

ALSO BY J. K. ROWLING

HARRY POTTER AND THE SORCERER'S STONE

YEAR ONE AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS

YEAR TWO AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE PRISONER OF AZKABAN

YEAR THREE AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE GOBLET OF FIRE

YEAR FOUR AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX

YEAR FIVE AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE

YEAR SIX AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER AND THE DEATHLY HALLOWS

YEAR SEVEN AT HOGWARTS

HARRY POTTER

AND THE DEATHLY HALLOWS

BY

J. K. ROWLING

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ARTHEUR A. LEVINE REEDS

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WE TRY TO PRODUCE THE MOST REALISTIC BOOKS POSSIBLE, AND WE ARE
ALSO EXTREMELY CONCERNED

ABOUT THE IMPACT OF OUR MANUFACTURING PROCESS ON THE FORESTS OF
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POST-CONSUMER RECYCLED FIBER, AND THAT EVERY 100% HAS BEEN CERTIFIED
AS COMING FROM FORESTS

THAT ARE MANAGED TO INSURE THE PROTECTION OF THE PEOPLE AND
WILDLIFE DEPENDENT UPON THEM.

THE

DEDICATION

OF THIS BOOK

IS SPLIT

SEVEN WAYS:

THE FIRST,

THE JESSICA,
THE DAVID,
THE DENZIE,
THE DI,
THE ANNE,
AND THE PELL,
IF PELL HAVE
STUCK
WITH F-HARRY
UNTIL THE
VERY
END.

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EPilogue

xxx

END, THE TORMENT KID IN THE RACE,

THE GRINDING SCREAM OF DEATH
AND THE STRIKE THAT HITS THE VEIN,
THE HAMMERSHOCK NEENE CAN STANCH, THE GRIEF,
THE CURSE NE MAN CAN BEAR,
BUT THERE IS A CLUE IN THE FLOOD
AND NEET ELTISIDE IT, NE,
NEET FROM EITHER'S BUT FROM THEM,
THEIR BLEEDY STRIFE, WE SING THE YELL,
DARK GEDS BENEATH THE EARTH,
NEEN HEAR, YELL BLISSFUL PHENERS LINDERGHELD
ANSWER THE CALL, SEND HELP,
BLESS THE CHILDREN, GIVE THEM TRIUMPH NEEN,
AESTHOLLS, THE LKATHEEN BEARERS

DEATH IS BUT CROSSING THE WORLD, AS FRIENDS ON THE SEAS; THEY LIVE
IN ONE ANOTHER STILL, FOR THEY MUST NEEDS BE PRESENT, THAT LIVE
AND LIVE IN THAT WHICH IS ETERNIPRESENT. IN THIS DIVINE GLASS THEY
SEE FACE THE FACE; AND THEIR CONVERSE IS FREE, AS WELL AS PURE. THIS IS
THE COMFORT OF FRIENDS, THAT THOUGH THEY MAY BE SAID TO DIE, YET
THEIR FRIENDSHIP AND SOCIETY ARE, IN THE BEST SENSE, EVER PRESENT,
BECAUSE IMMORTAL.

WILLIAM PENN, MORE FRUITS OF SOLITUDE

HARRY PETER

AND THE DEATHLY HALLELUIHS

CHAPTER ONE

1

THE DARK LORD ASCENDING

THE TWO MEN APPEARED BLITZ UP NEARLY HERE, A FEW YARDS APART IN THE NARROW, MIMMELT LANE. FOR A SECOND THEY STOOD BLITZ STILL, HANDS DIRECTED AT EACH OTHER'S CHESTS; THEN, RECOGNIZING EACH OTHER, THEY STEWED THEIR HANDS BENEATH THEIR CHADS AND STARTED WALKING BRIEFLY IN THE SAME DIRECTION.

NEWS? ASKED THE TALLER OF THE TWO.

THE BEST, REPLIED SEVERUS Snape.

THE LANE WAS BORDERED ON THE LEFT BY WILD, WILLY-GROWING BRAMBLES, ON THE RIGHT BY A HIGH, NEATLY MANICURED HEDGE. THE MEN'S LONG CHADS FLAPPED AROUND THEIR ANKLES AS THEY MARCHED.

THOUGH I MIGHT BE LATE, SAID JAXLEY, HIS BLUNT FEATURES SLID-
ING IN AND BLITZ UP SIGHT AS THE BRANCHES OF OVERHANGING TREES
BROKE

THE MIMMELT. IT WAS A LITTLE TRICKIER THAN I EXPECTED, BUT I
HOPED

HE WILL BE SATISFIED. JELLY SEEMING CONFIDENT THAT JELLY RECEPTION WILL
BE GOOD?

Snape NEEDED, BUT DID NOT ELABORATE. THEY TURNED RIGHT, INTO A

T

CHAPTER END

2

WIDE DRIVEWAY THAT LED OFF THE LANE. THE HIGH HEDGE CLIMBED WITH THEM, RUNNING OFF INTO THE DISTANCE BEYOND THE PAIR OF IMPRESSIVE WREIGHT-IRON GATES BARRING THE MEN'S WAY. NEITHER OF THEM BREKE STEP! IN SILENCE BOTH RAISED THEIR LEFT ARMS IN A KIND OF SALUTE AND PASSED STRAIGHT THROUGH, AS THOUGH THE DARK METAL WERE SMOKE. THE YEW HEDGES MILED THE SILENCE OF THE MEN'S FOOTSTEPS. THERE WAS A RUSTLE SOMEWHERE TO THEIR RIGHT! JAXLEY DREW HIS WAND AGAIN,

POINTING IT OVER HIS COMPANION'S HEAD, BUT THE SILENCE OF THE NIGHT

PROVED THERE NOTHING MORE THAN A POLAR-WHITE PEACOCK, STRUTTING MAJESTICALLY ALONG THE TOP OF THE HEDGE.

HE ALWAYS DID HIMSELF WELL, BUKILIS, PEACOCKS ... JAXLEY THREW HIS WAND BACK UNDER HIS CHIN WITH A SMILE.

A HANDSOME MANER FELLS GREW BUILT OF THE DARKNESS AT THE END OF THE STRAIGHT DRIVE, LIGHTS GLINTING IN THE DIAMOND-PANED BELLINSTAIRS

WINDOWS. SOMEWHERE IN THE DARK GARDEN BEYOND THE HEDGE A FOUNTAIN WAS PLAYING. GRAVEL CRACKLED BENEATH THEIR FEET AS SNAPE AND

JAXLEY SPED TOWARD THE FRONT DOOR, WHICH SWUNG INWARD AT THEIR

APPROACH, THOUGH NEHEM had visibly opened it,

THE HALLWAY WAS LARGE, DIMLY LIT, AND SIMPLY DECORATED,
WITH A MAGNIFICENT CARPET COVERING MOST OF THE STONE FLOOR. THE
EYES

OF THE PALE-FACED PORTRAITS ON THE WALLS FOLLOWED SNAPE AND
JAXLEY

AS THEY STRODE PAST. THE TWO MEN HALTED AT A HEAVY WOODEN DOOR
LEADING INTO THE NEXT ROOM, HESITATED FOR THE SPACE OF A HEARTBEAT,
THEN SNAPE TURNED THE BRONZE HANDLE.

THE DRAWING ROOM WAS FULL OF SILENT PEOPLE, SITTING AT A LONG AND
ORNATE TABLE. THE ROOM'S USUAL FURNITURE HAD BEEN POLISHED
CARELESSLY

UP AGAINST THE WALLS. ILLUMINATION CAME FROM A BURNING FIRE
BENEATH

A HANDSOME MARBLE MANTELPIECE SURMOUNTED BY A GILDED MIRROR.

SNAPE AND JAXLEY LINGERED FOR A MOMENT ON THE THRESHOLD, AS
THEIR

THE DARK LORD

ASCENDING

B

EYES GREW ATTRACTED TO THE LACK OF LIGHT, THEY WERE DRAWN UPWARD

TO THE STRANGEST FEATURE OF THE SCENE: AN APPARENTLY LINCOLNSHIRE
HILL-

MAN FIGURE HANGING UPSIDE DOWN OVER THE TABLE, REVOLVING SLOWLY
AS

IF SUSPENDED BY AN INVISIBLE ROPE, AND REFLECTED IN THE MIRROR AND
IN THE BARE, POLISHED SURFACE OF THE TABLE BEHIND. NONE OF THE
PEOPLE

SEATED UNDERNEATH THIS SINGULAR SIGHT WAS LOOKING AT IT EXCEPT
HER A

PALE YOUNG MAN SITTING ALMOST DIRECTLY BEHIND IT. HE SEEMED UNABLE
TO PREVENT HIMSELF FROM GLANCING UPWARD EVERY MINUTE FOR HER.

WAXLEY, SNAPE, SAID A HIGH, CLEAR VOICE FROM THE HEAD OF THE
TABLE.

THEY ARE VERY NEARLY LATE.

THE SPEAKER WAS SEATED DIRECTLY IN FRONT OF THE FIREPLACE, SHE THAT
IT WAS DIFFICULT, AT FIRST, FOR THE NEW ARRIVALS TO MAKE HER MORE
THAN

HIS SILHOUETTE. AS THEY DREW NEARER, HOWEVER, HIS FACE SEEMED
THROUGH

THE GLEAM, HAIRLESS, SNARL-LIKE, WITH SLITS FOR NOSTRILS AND
GLEAMING

RED EYES WHOSE PUPILS WERE VERTICAL. HE WAS SHE PALE THAT HE SEEMED
TO EMIT A PEARLY GLEAM.

SEVERUS, HERE, SAID VINDICATIVELY, INDICATING THE SEAT BY HIS IM-
MEDIATE RIGHT. WAXLEY RESIDE DEEPLY.

THE TWO MEN TOOK THEIR ALLOTTED PLACES, MOST OF THE EYES AREHIND
THE TABLE FOLLOWED SNAPE, AND IT WAS TO HIM THAT VINDICATIVELY SPoke
FIRST.

SHE?

MY LORD, THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX INTENDS TO MOVE HARRY POTTER FROM HIS CURRENT PLACE OF SAFETY ON SATURDAY NEXT, AT NIGHTFALL.

THE INTEREST AROUND THE TABLE SHARPENED PALPABLY: SOME STIFFENED, OTHERS FIDGETED, ALL GAZING AT SNAPE AND VERDERBERT.

SATURDAY . . . AT NIGHTFALL, REPEATED VERDERBERT. HIS RED EYES FASTENED UPON SNAPE'S BLACK EYES WITH SUCH INTENSITY THAT SOME OF THE

WATCHERS LEANED AWAY, APPARENTLY FEARFUL THAT THEY THEMSELVES WOULD

CHAPTER NINE

29

BE SCORCHED BY THE PERECITY OF THE GAZE. SNAPE, HOWEVER, LEANED

CALMLY BACK INTO VERDERBERT'S FACE AND, AFTER A MOMENT OF TIME, VER-

DERBERT'S LIPLESS MOUTH CURVED INTO SOMETHING LIKE A SMILE.

GOOD, VERY GOOD, AND THIS INFORMATION COMES

FROM THE SOURCE WE DISCUSSED, SAID SNAPE.

MY LORD.

PARKLEY HAD LEANED FORWARD THE SEEDS DOWN THE LONG TABLE AT VERDER-
MERT AND SNAPE. ALL FACES TURNED TOWARD HIM.

MY LORD, I HAVE HEARD DIFFERENTLY.

PARKLEY WAITED, BUT VERDERMERT DID NOT SPEAK, SO HE WENT ON.

DALGLISH, THE ALDER, LET SLIP THAT PETER WILL NOT BE MOVED UNTIL
THE

THIRTIETH, THE NIGHT BEFORE THE KEY TURNS SEVENTEEN.

SNAPE WAS SMILING.

MY SEVERUS TOLD ME THAT THERE ARE PLANTS THE LAY A FALSE TRAIL; THIS
MIST

BE IT. NOW BELIEVE A CHENPLINDER CHARM HAS BEEN PLACED UPON DALGLISH.

IT WOULD NOT BE THE FIRST TIME; HE IS KNOWN TO BE SUSCEPTIBLE.

I ASSURE YOU, MY LORD, DALGLISH SEEMED WHITE CERTAIN, SAID
PARKLEY.

IF HE HAS BEEN CHENPLINDED, NATURALLY HE IS CERTAIN, SAID SNAPE.

I ASSURE YOU, PARKLEY, THE ALDER OFFICE WILL PLAY NO FURTHER
PART IN

THE PROTECTION OF HARRY PETER. THE ORDER BELIEVES THAT WE HAVE
INFILTRATED THE MINISTRY.

THE ORDER IS GETTING THIS THING RIGHT, THEN, YES SAID A SEVERAL MAN
SIT-

TING A SHORT DISTANCE FROM PARKLEY; HE GAVE A WHISPERY GIGGLE THAT
WAS

HEARD HERE AND THERE ALONG THE TABLE.

VEHEMENT DID NOT LAUGH. HIS GAZE HAD WANDERED UPWARD THE
THE KEY REVOLVING SILENTLY OVERHEAD, AND HE SEEMED TO BE LOST IN
THOUGHT.

THE DARK LORD
ASCENDING

5

MY LORD, JAXLEY WENT ON, DAWKISH BELIEVES AN ENTIRE PARTY OF
SLAVES WILL BE USED TO TRANSFER THE KEY
VEHEMENT HELD UP A LARGE WHITE HAND, AND JAXLEY SLIDED AT
ONCE, WATCHING RESSENTFULLY AS VEHEMENT TURNED BACK THE SNAP.
WHERE ARE THEY GOING TO HIDE THE KEY NEXT?

AT THE HOME OF ONE OF THE HERD, SAID SNAP. THE PLACE,
ACCORD-
ING TO THE SHERIFF, HAS BEEN GIVEN EVERY PROTECTION THAT THE HERD
AND MINISTRY TOGETHER COULD PROVIDE. I THINK THAT THERE IS LITTLE
CHANCE OF TAKING HIM ONCE HE IS THERE, MY LORD, UNLESS, OF COURSE,
THE MINISTRY HAS FALLEN BEFORE NEXT SATURDAY, WHICH MIGHT GIVE
US
THE OPPORTUNITY TO DISCOVER AND LINGER ENOUGH OF THE
ENCHANTMENTS
THE READ THROUGH THE REST.
WELL, JAXLEY? VEHEMENT CALLED DOWN THE TABLE, THE FIRELIGHT

GLINTING STRANGELY IN HIS RED EYES. WILL THE MINISTRY HAVE FALLEN BY

NEXT SATURDAY?

HENCE AGAIN, ALL HEADS TURNED, YAKLEY SEHARED HIS SEHOLDERS,

MY LORD, I HAVE GHEED NEWS HEN THAT SCHEE, I HAVE WITH DIFFICULTY, AND AFTER GREAT EFFERT SUCCEEDED IN PLACING AN IMPERILIS

CURSE UPON PILIS THICKNESS.

MANY OF THESE SITTING AROUND YAKLEY WHEEED IMPRESSED; HIS NEIGH-

HER, DEEH-HEY, A MAN WITH A LONG, TWISTED FACE, CLAPPED HIM HEN THE

BACK,

IT IS A START, SAID VEHEDEMENT, BUT THICKNESS IS ONLY HENK MAN, SCRINGHELR MUST BE SLIRHEUNDED BY HLIR PEOPLE BEFORE I ACT, HENK FAILED ATTEMPT HEN THE MINISTER S LIFE WILL SET ME BACK A LONG WAY,

YES MY LORD, THAT IS TRUE BUT YELI DNEEL, AS HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT, THICKNESS HAS REGULAR CONTACT NEET ONLY WITH THE MINISTER HIMSELF, BUT ALSO WITH THE HEADS

CHAPTER HENK

☒

OF ALL THE OTHER MINISTRY DEPARTMENTS, IT WILL, I THINK, BE EASY NEEL

THAT WE HAVE SUCH A HIGH-RANKING OFFICIAL UNDER OUR CONTROL, THE
SUBVERT THE OTHERS, AND THEN THEY CAN ALL WORK TOGETHER THE
KING

STINGING HIM DEEN.

AS LONG AS OUR FRIEND THICKNESS IS NOT DISCOVERED BEFORE HE HAS
CONVERTED THE REST, SAID VERDEMENT, AT ANY RATE, IT REMAINS
UNLIKELY THAT THE MINISTRY WILL BE MINE BEFORE NEXT SATURDAY. IF
WE

CANNOT TRICK THE KING AT HIS DESTINATION, THEN IT MUST BE DONE
WHILE

HE TRAVELS.

WE ARE AT AN ADVANTAGE THERE, MY LORD, SAID YARLEY, WHO SEEMED
DETERMINED THE RECEIVE SOME PORTION OF APPROVAL. WE NEED HAVE

SEVERAL PEOPLE PLANTED WITHIN THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL TRANS-
PORT. IF BETTER APPARATES ARE USED THE FLEE NETWORK, WE SHALL
KNOW

IMMEDIATELY.

HE WILL NOT BE EITHER, SAID SNAPE. THE ORDER IS ESTABLISHING AND
FORM OF TRANSPORT THAT IS CONTROLLED AND REGULATED BY THE
MINISTRY;

THEY MISTRUST EVERYTHING THEY DO WITH THE PLACE.

ALL THE BETTER, SAID VERDEMENT. HE WILL HAVE THE MOVE IN THE
OPEN, EASIER TO TAKE, BY FAR.

AGAIN, VERDEMENT LOOKED UP AT THE SLEEKLY REVEALING KING AS HE
WENT ON. I SHALL ATTEND THE KING IN PERSON. THERE HAVE BEEN
THE

MANY MISTAKES WHERE HARRY POTTER IS CONCERNED, SOME OF THEM
HAVE BEEN MY OWN, THAT POTTER LIVES IS ONE MORE TH MY ERRORS
THAN
TH HIS TRIUMPHS.

THE COMPANY AROUND THE TABLE WATCHED VOLDEMORT APPREHEN-
SIVELY, EACH OF THEM, BY HIS OR HER EXPRESSION, AFRAID THAT THEY
MIGHT

BE BLAMED FOR HARRY POTTER'S CONTINUED EXISTENCE, VOLDEMORT, HOW-
EVER, SEEMED TO BE SPEAKING MORE OF HIMSELF THAN OF ANY OF THEM,

STILL ADDRESSING THE LINCENSTHILLS KID AS HE WENT HIM,

THE DARK LORD
ASCENDING

7

I HAVE BEEN CARELESS, AND SHE HAVE BEEN THWARTED BY LUCK AND

CHANCE, THESE WRECKERS OF ALL BUT THE BEST-LAID PLANS, BUT I KNOW
BET-

TER NOW, I UNDERSTAND THESE THINGS THAT I DID NOT UNDERSTAND
BEFORE.

I MUST BE THE ONE TO KILL HARRY POTTER, AND I SHALL BE.

AT THESE WORDS, SEEMINGLY IN RESPONSE TO THEM, A SUDDEN WAIL

SHOWN, A TERRIBLE, DRAWN-OUT CRY OF MISERY AND PAIN. MANY OF
THOSE AT THE TABLE LOOKED DOWNWARD, STARTLED, FOR THE SOUND HAD
SEEMED TO ISSUE FROM BEHIND THEIR FEET.

WHIRTAIL, SAID VELDMEERT, WITH NO CHANGE IN HIS EXPRESSION,
TELL ME, THEN, AND WITHOUT REMOVING HIS EYES FROM THE
REVOLVING

KNIFE ABOVE, HAVE I NOT SPOKEN THE TRUTH ABOUT KEEPING OUR
PRISONER
ALIVE?

YES, MY LORD, GASPED A SMALL MAN HALFWAY DOWN THE TABLE,
WHOM HAD BEEN SITTING SEVERAL IN HIS CHAIR THAT IT HAD APPEARED, AT
FIRST GLANCE, TO BE UNOCCUPIED. WHEN HE STRAGGLED FROM HIS SEAT AND
SCURRIED FROM THE ROOM, LEAVING NOTHING BEHIND HIM BUT A CLASHING
GLEAM OF SILVER.

AS I WAS SAYING, CONTINUED VELDMEERT, LOOKING AGAIN AT THE
TENSE FACES OF HIS FOLLOWERS, I UNDERSTAND BETTER NOW, I SHALL NEED,
FOR INSTANCE, THE KNIFE A HAND FROM HERE OF THE KNIFE I CAN THE WILL
PUTTER.

THE FACES AROUND HIM DISPLAYED NOTHING BUT STUNNED; HE MIGHT HAVE
ANNOUNCED THAT HE WANTED THE KNIFE HERE OF THEIR ARMS.

NO VOLUNTEERS? SAID VELDMEERT. LET US SEE . . . LIKE, I SEE NO
REASON FOR THE HAVE A HAND ANYMORE.

LIKE, MALCOLM LOOKED UP. HIS SKIN APPEARED YELLOWISH AND WAXY
IN THE FIRELIGHT, AND HIS EYES WERE SUNKEN AND SHADOWED. WHEN HE
SPoke, HIS VOICE WAS HARSH.

MY LORD?

CHAPTER XXX

8

MY OWN WAND, LUCILIS, I REQUIRE MY OWN WAND,

I...

MALPHEUS GLANCED SIDELWAYS AT HIS WIFE. SHE WAS STARING STRAIGHT
AHEAD, WHITE AS PALE AS HE WAS, HER LONG BLONDE HAIR HANGING DOWN
HER BACK, BUT BENEATH THE TABLE HER SLIM FINGERS CLOSED BRIEFLY ON
HIS

WRIST. AT HER TOUCH, MALPHEUS PUT HIS HAND INTO HIS REEKS, WITH-DREW
A WAND, AND PASSED IT ALONG THE VEILDERBERT, WHOSE FINGER HE HELD UP IN FRONT
OF HIS RED EYES, EXAMINING IT CLOSELY.

WHAT IS IT?

WELL, MY LORD, WHISPERED MALPHEUS,

AND THE CHIEF?

DRAGON DRAGON HEARTSTRING.

GOOD, SAID VEILDERBERT. HE DREW OUT HIS OWN WAND AND COM-
PARED THE LENGTHS, LUCILIS MALPHEUS MADE AN INVOLUNTARY MOVEMENT;

AFTER A FRACTION OF A SECOND, IT SEEMED HE EXPECTED THE RECIPROCAL VEILDE-
BERT'S WAND IN EXCHANGE FOR HIS OWN. THE GESTURE WAS NOT MISSED

BY VEILDERBERT, WHOSE EYES WIDENED MALICIOUSLY.

GIVE ME MY WAND, LUCILIS? MY WAND?

SOME OF THE THING SMUGGLED.

I HAVE GIVEN YOU YOUR LIBERTY, LILILIS, IS THAT NOT ENOUGH FOR
YOU? BUT I HAVE NOTICED THAT YOU AND YOUR FAMILY SEEM LESS THAN
HAPPY OF LATE. . . . WHAT IS IT ABOUT MY PRESENCE IN YOUR HOME THAT
DISPLEASURES YOU, LILILIS?

NOTHING NOTHING, MY LORD!

SUCH LIES, LILILIS . . .

THE SILENT VOICE SEEMED TO HISS HIM EVEN AFTER THE CROAK MOUTH HAD

STOPPED MOVING. THEN FOR TWO OF THE LIZARDS BARELY REPPRESSED A
SHLD-

DER AS THE HISSING GREW LOUDER, SOMETHING HEAVY COULD BE HEARD

SLIDING ACROSS THE FLOOR BENEATH THE TABLE.

THE DARK LORD

ASCENDING

7

THE HUGE SNAKE EMERGED THE CLINK SILENTLY UP VERDMEERT'S CHAIR.

IT ROSE, SEEMINGLY ENDLESSLY, AND CAME THE REST ACROSS VERDMEERT'S
SHOULDERS: ITS NECK THE THICKNESS OF A MAN'S THIGH; ITS EYES, WITH
THEIR

VERTICAL SLITS AND PUPILS, LINKLINKING. VERDMEERT STROOKED THE
CREATURE

ABSENTLY WITH LONG THIN FINGERS, STILL LINKING AT LILILIS MALPHEE.

WHY DO THE MALPHEES SEEM SO LINK-HAPPY WITH THEIR LENT? IS MY RE-

TURN, MY RISE THE PHEWER, MEET THE VERY THING THEY PROFESSED THE
DESIRE

HER SEE MANY YEARS?

HE CHURCH, MY LORD, SAID BLINDLY MALTHEY, HIS HAND STOOD AS HE
WIPED SWEAT FROM HIS UPPER LIP, WE DID DESIRE IT WE SEE,

THE MALTHEY'S LEFT, HIS WIFE MADE AN END, STIFF NEED, HER EYES AVERTED
FROM VERDEMENT AND THE SNARE, THE HIS RIGHT, HIS SHEN, DRACH, WITH
HAD BEEN GAZING UP AT THE INERT BODY HYPERHEAD, GLANCED QUICKLY AT
VERDEMENT AND AWAY AGAIN, TERRIFIED THE MADE EYE CONTACT,

MY LORD, SAID A DARK WOMAN HALFWAY DOWN THE TABLE, HER VOICE
CONSTRICTED WITH EMOTION, IT IS AN FEELER THE HAVE BEEN HERE, IN
ELIA

FAMILY'S FEELER, THERE CAN BE NO HIGHER PLEASURE,

SHE SAT BESIDE HER SISTER, AS LINKED HER IN ARMS, WITH HER DARK
HAIR

AND HEAVILY LIDDED EYES, AS SHE WAS IN REARING AND DEMEANOR; WHERE
NARCISSE SAT RIGID AND IMPASSIVE, BELLATRIX LEANED TOWARD
VERDEMENT,

HER MORE WORDS COULD NOT DEMONSTRATE HER LONGING FOR CLOSURE,

NO HIGHER PLEASURE, REPEATED VERDEMENT, HIS HEAD TILTED A LITTLE
THE ONE SIDE AS HE CONSIDERED BELLATRIX, THAT MEANS A GREAT DEAL,
BELLATRIX, FROM WELL,

HER FACE FLEWED WITH CHEER; HER EYES WELLED WITH TEARS OF
DELIGHT,

MY LORD KNOWS I SPEAK NOTHING BUT THE TRUTH;

NO HIGHER PLEASURE . . . EVEN COMPARED WITH THE HAPPY EVENT
THAT, I HEAR, HAS TAKEN PLACE IN YOUR FAMILY THIS WEEK?

CHAPTER ENNE

10

SHE STARED AT HIM, HER LIPS PARTED, EVIDENTLY CHERVISED.

I DENN T DENNE WHAT YELL MEAN, MY LEIRD.

I M TALKING ABELIT YELLER NICE, BELLATRIX, AND YELLER, BLIKILIS AND
NARCISSE. SHE HAS ILST MARRIED THE WEREWOLF, REMUS LUPIN. YELL
MUST BE SHE PREHED.

THERE WAS AN ERUPTION OF IRERING LAUGHTER FROM AROUND THE
TABLE.

MANY LEANED FORWARD THE EXCHANGE GLEEFUL BEERS; A FEW THUMPED
THE TABLE WITH THEIR FISTS. THE GREAT SNAKE, DISLIKING THE
DISTURBANCE,

HEPENDED ITS MOUTH WIDE AND HISSED ANGRILY, BUT THE DEATH EATERS DID

NEET HEAR IT, SHE ILKILANT WERE THEY AT BELLATRIX AND THE MALFOYS
HIL-

MILATION. BELLATRIX S FACE, SHE RECENTLY FLISHED WITH HAPPINESS, HAD

TURNED AN LELY, BLETTED RED.

SHE IS NEH NICE OF ELIER, MY LEIRD. SHE CRIED EVER THE HILTPHEURING
OF MIRTH. WE NARCISSE AND I HAVE NEVER SET EYES EN ELIER
SISTER

SINCE SHE MARRIED THE MLDREHED. THIS BRAT HAS NEETHING THE DEN WITH
EITHER OF US, NEER ANY REAST SHE MARRIES.

WHAT SAY YELL, DRACHER? ASKED VELDREHED, AND THOUGH HIS VOICE

WAS ELIPT, IT CARRIED CLEARLY THROUGH THE CATALLS AND IERS. WILL
YELL

BARST THE CLKS?

THE HILARITY MELINTED; GRACE MALPHY LEEDED IN TERNER AT HIS
FATHER,

WHEN WAS STARING DEEN INTH HIS ELN LAP, THEN CALGT HIS
MEETTER \$

EYE. SHE SEEMED HER HEAD ALMOST IMPERCEPTIBLY, THEN RESUMED HER
ELN DEADPAN STARE AT THE OPPOSITE WALL.

ENELGH, SAID VERDEMEERT, STRIKING THE ANGRY SNAKE.

ENELGH.

AND THE LAUGHTER DIED AT ENCE.

MANY OF ELN ELDEST FAMILY TREES BECAME A LITTLE DISEASED EVER
TIME. HE SAID AS BELLATRIX GAZED AT HIM, BREATHLESS AND IMPLERING.

THE DARK LEED

ASCENDING

11

YELL MUST PROVE YELRS, MUST YELL NEET, THE DEEP IT HEALTHY? CLT
ALAY

THESE PARTS THAT THREATEN THE HEALTH OF THE REST.

YES, MY LEED, WHISPERED BELLATRIX, AND HER EYES SHAM WITH TEARS
OF GRATITUDE AGAIN. AT THE FIRST CHANCE?

YELL SHALL HAVE IT, SAID VERDEMEERT, AND IN YELN FAMILY, SHE IN
THE WORLD . . . WE SHALL CLT AWAY THE CANDER THAT INFECTS US UNTIL
ENLY

THESE OF THE TRUE BLEED REMAIN, . . .

VERDEMORET RAISED LUCIUS MALFOY'S WAND, POINTED IT DIRECTLY AT THE
SILENTLY REVEALING FIGURE SUSPENDED OVER THE TABLE, AND GAVE IT A
TINY

FLICK. THE FIGURE CAME TO LIFE WITH A GRIMACE AND BEGAN THE STRUGGLE
AGAINST INVISIBLE HANDS.

DID YOU RECOGNIZE YOUR GUEST, SEVERUS? ASKED VERDEMORET.

SNAPE RAISED HIS EYES TO THE UPSIDE-DOWN FACE. ALL OF THE DEATH
EATERS WERE LEERING UP AT THE CAPTIVE NOW, AS THOUGH THEY HAD
BEEN

GIVEN PERMISSION THE SHELL CLICHÉDITY, AS SHE REVEALED THE FACE THE
FIRE-

LIGHT, THE WOMAN SAID IN A CRACKED AND TERRIFIED VOICE, SEVERUS?

HELP ME?

AH, YES, SAID SNAPE AS THE PRISONER TURNED SILENTLY AWAY AGAIN.

AND YOU, DRACHE? ASKED VERDEMORET, STROKING THE SNAPE'S SHOULDER
WITH HIS WAND-FREE HAND. DRACHE SHOOK HIS HEAD IRRITABLY. WHEN THAT
THE WOMAN HAD WOKEN, HE SEEMED UNABLE TO LOOK AT HER ANYMORE.

BUT YOU WOULD NOT HAVE TAKEN HER CLASSES, SAID VERDEMORET. FOR
THESE OF YOU WHO DO NOT KNOW, WE ARE JOINED HERE TONIGHT BY
CLARITY

COURAGE WHEN, UNTIL RECENTLY, TAUGHT AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF
WITCH-

WITCH AND WIZARDRY.

THERE WERE SMALL NOISES OF COMPREHENSION AROUND THE TABLE. A BREAD-FLUNCHED WOMAN WITH POINTED TEETH LAUGHED.

YES . . . PROFESSOR KLUDGE TAUGHT THE CHILDREN OF WITCHES AND

CHAPTER FOUR

12

WIZARDS ALL ABILIT MUGGLES . . . HOW THEY ARE NOT SO DIFFERENT FROM US . . .

ONE OF THE DEATH EATERS SPAT IN THE FLOOR. CLARITY KLUDGE REVEELED THE FACE SNARE AGAIN.

SEVERUS . . . PLEASE . . . PLEASE . . .

SILENCE, SAID VERDERBERT, WITH ANOTHER TWITCH OF MALFOY'S WAND, AND CLARITY FELL SILENT AS IF GAGGED. NOT CONTENT WITH CHIRLIPPING AND PHILLING THE MINDS OF WIZARDING CHILDREN, LAST WEEK PROFESSOR

KLUDGE WROTE AN IMPASSIONED DEFENSE OF MUGGLEHOODS IN THE DAILY

PROPHET. WIZARDS, SHE SAYS, MUST ACCEPT THESE THIRVES OF THEIR OWN-

EDGE AND MAGIC. THE DOWDLING OF THE PLEURPLEHOODS IS, SAYS PROFESSOR

KLUDGE, A MOST DESIRABLE CIRCUMSTANCE. . . . SHE WOULD HAVE US ALL MATE WITH MUGGLES . . . ER, NO BELLET, WEREWEAVES. . . .

DEREDY LAUGHED THIS TIME! THERE WAS NO MISTAKING THE ANGER AND
CONTUMPT IN VOLDENHART'S VOICE. FOR THE THIRD TIME, CLARITY
BURST

REVEALED THE FACE SNAPE. TEARS WERE POURING FROM HER EYES INTO
HER

HAIR. SNAPE LOOKED BACK AT HER, BLITHE IMPASSIVE, AS SHE TURNED
SLIGHTLY

AWAY FROM HIM AGAIN.

AVADA KEDAVRA.

THE FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT ILLUMINATED EVERY CORNER OF THE ROOM.

CLARITY FELL, WITH A RESOUNDING CRASH, BENT THE TABLE BEHIND, WHICH
TREMBLED AND CREAKED. SEVERAL OF THE DEATH EATERS LEAPT BACK IN
THEIR

CHAIRS. DRACE FELL FLAT ON HIS BENT THE FLOOR.

DINNER, NAGINI, SAID VOLDENHART SEFTLY, AND THE GREAT SNAKE
SLAYED AND SLITHERED FROM HIS SHOULDERS BENT THE POLISHED WOOD.

CHAPTER TWEE

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IN MEMORIAM

ARRY WAS BLEEDING. CLUTCHING HIS RIGHT HAND IN HIS LEFT
AND SWEARING UNDER HIS BREATH, HE SHOULDERS OPEN HIS

REDREDDY DEER. THERE WAS A CRUNCH OF CRACKING CHINA! HE HAD TROD-
DEN ON A CUP OF CHINA TEA THAT HAD BEEN SITTING ON THE FLOOR BESIDE

HIS BODILY DEER.

WHAT THE ?

HE WHEELED AROUND; THE LANDING OF NUMBER SEVEN, PRIVATE DRIVE, WAS
DESERTED. POSSIBLY THE CLIP OF TEA WAS DUDLEY'S IDEA OF A CLEVER KITCHEN

TRAP. KEEPING HIS BLEEDING HAND ELEVATED, HARRY SCRAPED THE FRAG-
MENTS OF CLIP TOGETHER WITH THE OTHER HAND AND THREW THEM INTO THE

ALREADY CRAMPED KIN JUST VISIBLE INSIDE HIS BODILY DEER. THEN HE
TRAMPED ACROSS THE THE BATHROOM THE RIN HIS FINGER UNDER THE TAP.
IT WAS STUPID, PAINFUL, IRRITATING BEYOND BELIEF THAT HE STILL HAD

SEVEN DAYS LEFT OF BEING LIABLE THE PERFORM MAGIC . . . BUT HE HAD THE
AD-

MIT THE HIMSELF THAT THIS LAGGED CLIP IN HIS FINGER WOULD HAVE
DEFEATED

HIM. HE HAD NEVER LEARNED HOW TO REPAIR WHEELS, AND NOW HE CAME
H

CHAPTER TWO

19

THE THING OF IT PARTICULARLY IN LIGHT OF HIS IMMEDIATE PLANS
THIS

SEEMED A SERIOUS FLAW IN HIS MAGICAL EDUCATION, MAKING A MENTAL
NOTE THE ASK HERMIONE WHEN IT WAS DONE, HE USED A LARGE WAD OF
TENSLET

PAPER THE MORE UP AS MUCH OF THE TEA AS HE COULD, BEFORE RETURNING
THE

HIS BEDROOM AND SLAMMING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

HARRY HAD SPENT THE MORNING COMPLETELY EMPTYING HIS SCHEM
TRUNK FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE HE HAD PACKED IT SIX YEARS AGO. AT
THE

START OF THE INTERVENING SEVEN YEARS, HE HAD MERELY SKIMMED OFF
THE TOPMOST THREE QUARTERS OF THE CONTENTS AND REPLACED HER
UPDATED

THEM, LEAVING A LAYER OF GENERAL DEBRIS AT THE BOTTOM. OLD BILLS,

DESICCATED BUTTERFLY EYES, SINGLE SHOES THAT NO LONGER FIT, MINUTES
PREVI-

ELISLY, HARRY HAD PLUNGED HIS HAND INTO THIS MESS, EXPERIENCED A

STABBING PAIN IN THE FOURTH FINGER OF HIS RIGHT HAND, AND
WITHDRAWN

IT THE SEE A LOT OF BLEED.

HE NOW PROCEEDED A LITTLE MORE CAUTIOUSLY, KNEELING DOWN BESIDE

THE TRUNK AGAIN, HE GRIPPED AROUND IN THE BOTTOM AND, AFTER
RETRIEV-

ING AN OLD BADGE THAT FLICKERED FEEBLY BETWEEN SLIPPERY COBBLER

DIGGERY AND BETTER STINGS, A CRACKED AND WORN-OUT
SNEAK-

ESCAPE, AND A CHILD LOCKET INSIDE WHICH A WHITE SIGNED RAB, HAD

BEEN HIDDEN, HE FINALLY DISCOVERED THE SHARP EDGE THAT HAD DONE

THE DAMAGE. HE RECOGNIZED IT AT ONCE. IT WAS A TWO-INCH-LENG FRAG-
MENT OF THE ENCHANTED MIRROR THAT HIS DEAD GODFATHER, SIRILIS, HAD

GIVEN HIM. HARRY LAID IT ASIDE AND FELT CALMTHLISLY AROUND THE
TRUNK

AER THE REST, BUT NOTHING MORE REMAINED OF HIS GODFATHER'S LAST
GIFT

EXCEPT POWDERED GLASS, WHICH FLLING THE DEEPEST LAYER OF DERRIS
LIKE GLITTERING GRIT.

HARRY SAT UP AND EXAMINED THE JAGGED PIECE IN WHICH HE HAD
LIT HIMSELF, SEEING NOTHING BUT HIS OWN BRIGHT GREEN EYE REFLECTED
BACK AT HIM. THEN HE PLACED THE FRAGMENT IN THE OF THAT
MORNING'S

IN MEMORIAM

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DAILY PROPHECY, WHICH LAY UNREAD IN THE BED, AND ATTEMPTED THE STEM
THE SUDDEN UPSURGE OF BITTER MEMORIES, THE STARS OF REGRET AND OF

LENGING THE DISCOVERY OF THE BROKEN MIRROR HAD OCCASIONED, BY AT-
TACKING THE REST OF THE BLISS IN THE TRUNK.

IT THUD ANOTHER FLOOR THE EMPTY IT COMPLETELY, THREW AWAY THE
USE-

LESS ITEMS, AND SHOT THE REMAINDER IN PILES ACCORDING THE WHETHER HE

NEED HE WOULD NEED THEM FROM NOW ON, HIS SCHEMEL AND FLUIDITY
REELS, CALIBRE, PARCHMENT, ELLIPS, AND MOST OF HIS TEXTBOOKS WERE
PILED IN A CORNER, THE HE LEFT BEHIND, HE WONDERED WHAT HIS ALIVE AND

WILL WOULD BE WITH THEM; KNEW THEM IN THE DEAD OF NIGHT, PRECA-
RILY, AS IF THEY WERE THE EVIDENCE OF SOME DREADFUL CRIME. HIS MUGGLE

CLOTHING, INVISIBILITY CLOAK, POTION-MAKING KIT, CERTAIN BOOKS, THE
PENTHEGRAPH ALUMI FLAGRANT HAD HERE GIVEN HIM, A STACK OF LETTERS,
AND

HIS WAND HAD BEEN REPAKED INTO AN OLD RUCKSACK, IN A FRONT
POCKET

WERE THE MARALDER'S MAP AND THE LOCKET WITH THE NOTE SIGNED
R.A.B.

INSIDE IT, THE LOCKET WAS ACCORDED THIS PLACE OF HONOR NOT BECAUSE
IT

WAS VALUABLE IN ALL USUAL SENSES IT WAS WORTHLESS BUT
BECAUSE

OF WHAT IT HAD COST THE ATTAIN IT.

THIS LEFT A SIZABLE STACK OF NEWSPAPERS SITTING ON HIS DESK BESIDE
HIS SLEEPING BAG, FREDWIG: HERE FOR EACH OF THE DAYS HARRY HAD SPENT
AT PRIVET DRIVE THIS SUMMER.

HE GOT UP OFF THE FLOOR, STRETCHED, AND MOVED ACROSS THE HIS DESK,

LUDWIG MADE NO MOVEMENT AS HE BEGAN TO FLICK THROUGH THE NEWSPAPERS, THROWING THEM INTO THE RUBBISH PILE ONE BY ONE. THE MAN WAS

ASLEEP, HIS EYES FADING; SHE WAS ANGRY WITH HARRY ABOUT THE LIMITED AMOUNT OF TIME SHE WAS ALLOWED OUT OF HER CAGE AT THE MOMENT.

AS HE NEARED THE BOTTOM OF THE PILE OF NEWSPAPERS, HARRY SLEWED DOWN, SEARCHING FOR ONE PARTICULAR ISSUE THAT HE KNEW HAD ARRIVED

SHORTLY AFTER HE HAD RETURNED THE PRIVATE DRIVE FOR THE SUMMER; HE

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REMEMBERED THAT THERE HAD BEEN A SMALL MENTION IN THE FRONT ABOUT

THE RESIGNATION OF CLARITY BLURAGE, THE MUSIC STUDIES TEACHER AT HOGWARTS. AT LAST HE FOUND IT. TURNING THE PAGE TEN, HE SANK INTO HIS

DESK CHAIR AND REREAD THE ARTICLE HE HAD BEEN LOOKING FOR.

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE REMEMBERED

BY RUFIAS DICE

I MET ALBUS DUMBLEDORE AT THE AGE OF

ELEVEN, ON HIS FIRST DAY AT HOGWARTS.

THEIR MUTUAL ATTRACTION WAS UNDISPUTEDLY

DO TO THE FACT THAT WE BOTH FELT

THEMSELVES THE REBELS, I HAD CON-
TRACTED DRAGON PHEX SHORTLY BEFORE ARRIVING AT SCHEER,

AND WHILE I WAS NO LONGER CONTAGIOUS, MY PHEX-
MARKED VISAGE AND GREENISH-HUE DID NOT ENCOUR-
AGE MANY TO APPROACH ME. FOR HIS PART, AELIS HAD

ARRIVED AT FIEGLARTS UNDER THE BURDEN OF UNWANTED
NEITHERY. SCARCELY A YEAR PREVIOUSLY, HIS FATHER,

PERCIVAL, HAD BEEN CONVICTED OF A SAVAGE AND WELL-
PUBLICIZED ATTACK UPON THREE YELING MUGGLES.

AELIS NEVER ATTEMPTED TO DENY THAT HIS FATHER
WHOM WAS THE DUE IN AZERAN! HAD COMMITTED THIS
CRIME; ON THE CONTRARY, WHEN I PICKED UP CHELACE
THE ASK HIM, HE ASSURED ME THAT HE KNEW HIS FATHER THE
RE GUILTY. BEYOND THAT, DUMBLEDORE REFUSED TO SPEAK
OF THE SAD BUSINESS, THOUGH MANY ATTEMPTED TO MAKE
HIM DO SO. SOME, INDEED, WERE DISPOSED TO PRAISE
HIS FATHER'S ACTION AND ASSUMED THAT AELIS THEM WAS A
MUGGLE-HATER. THEY COULD NOT HAVE BEEN MORE MIS-

IN MEMORIAM

TAKEN; AS ANYBODY WHO KNEW ARLIS WOULD ATTEST, HE NEVER REVEALED THE REMOTEST ANTI-MUGGLE TENDENCY. INDEED, HIS DETERMINED SUPPORT FOR MUGGLE RIGHTS GAINED HIM MANY ENEMIES IN SUBSEQUENT YEARS. IN A MATTER OF MONTHS, HOWEVER, ARLIS'S NEW FAME HAD REFINED THE ECLIPSE THAT OF HIS FATHER. BY THE END OF HIS FIRST YEAR HE WOULD NEVER AGAIN BE KNOWN AS THE SON OF A MUGGLE-HATER, BUT AS NOTHING MORE OR LESS THAN THE MOST BRILLIANT STUDENT EVER SEEN AT THE SCHOOL.

THOSE OF US WHO WERE PRIVILEGED TO BE HIS FRIENDS BENEFITED FROM HIS EXAMPLE, NOT TO MENTION HIS HELP AND

ENCOURAGEMENT, WITH WHICH HE WAS ALWAYS GENEROUS.

HE CONFESSED TO ME IN LATER LIFE THAT HE KNEW EVEN THEN THAT HIS GREATEST PLEASURE LAY IN TEACHING.

HE NOT ONLY WON EVERY PRIZE HE WENT FOR AT THE SCHOOL OFFERED, HE WAS KEEN IN REGULAR CORRESPONDENCE WITH THE MOST NOTABLE MAGICAL NAMES OF THE DAY, INCLUDING NICHOLAS FLAMEL, THE CELEBRATED ALCHEMIST; RUTHILDA

RAGSHEE, THE NOTED HISTORIAN; AND ADALBERT WAFLING, THE MAGICAL THEORETICIAN. SEVERAL OF HIS PAPERS

FIND THEIR WAY INTO LEARNED PUBLICATIONS SUCH AS TRANSFIGURATION TODAY, CHALLENGES IN CHARMING, AND

THE PRACTICAL PETITIONER, DUMFRIES'S FUTURE CAREER SEEMED LIKELY TO BE METEORIC, AND THE ONLY QUESTION THAT REMAINED WAS WHEN HE WOULD BECOME MINISTER OF MAGIC. THOUGH IT WAS OFTEN PREDICTED IN LATER YEARS THAT HE WAS ON THE POINT OF TAKING THE JOB, HOWEVER, HE NEVER HAD MINISTERIAL AMBITIONS.

THREE YEARS AFTER WE HAD STARTED AT FISHGARDENS,

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ALAN'S SISTER, ANNE, ARRIVED AT SCHOOL. THEY WERE NOT ALIKE; ANNE WAS NEVER BOLD AND,

UNLIKE ALAN, PREFERRED TO SETTLE ARGUMENTS BY BURLING RATHER THAN THOROUGH REASONED DISCUSSION. HOWEVER, IT IS WHITE WASHING THE SUGGEST, AS SOME HAVE, THAT

THE SISTERS WERE NOT FRIENDS. THEY MIXED ALONG AS COMFORTABLY AS TWO SUCH DIFFERENT KINDS COULD BE. IN FAIRNESS TO ANNE, IT MUST BE ADMITTED THAT

LIVING IN ALAN'S SHADOWS CANNOT HAVE BEEN AN ALTOGETHER COMFORTABLE EXPERIENCE. BEING CONTINUALLY

ELBOWED WAS AN UNCOMFORTABLE HAZARD OF BEING HIS

FRIEND AND CANNIBAL HAVE BEEN AND MORE PLEASURABLE
AS A BROTHER.

WHEN ARLIS AND I LEFT EHEWARTS WE INTENDED TO
TAKE THE THEN-TRADITIONAL TOUR OF THE WORLD TOGETHER,

VISITING AND RESERVING FOREIGN WIZARDS, BEFORE PUR-
SUING OUR SEPARATE CAREERS. HOWEVER, TRAGEDY INTER-
VENED. IN THE VERY EVE OF OUR TRIP, ARLIS'S MOTHER,

XENDRA, DIED, LEAVING ARLIS THE HEAD, AND SHELL

READLINER, OF THE FAMILY. I POSTPONED MY DEPAR-
TURE LONG ENOUGH TO PAY MY RESPECTS AT XENDRA'S

Funeral, THEN LEFT HER WHAT WAS THEN THE RE A SOLITARY
JOURNEY, WITH A YOUNGER BROTHER AND SISTER TO CARE
FOR, AND LITTLE CHILD LEFT THEM, THERE CHILD WOULD LONGER
BE AND ELDEST OF ARLIS ACCOMPANYING ME.

THAT WAS THE PERIOD OF OUR LIVES WHEN WE HAD LEAST

CONTACT. I WROTE THE ARLIS, DESCRIBING, PERHAPS INSEN-
SITIVELY, THE WONDERS OF MY JOURNEY, FROM NARROW ES-
CAPES FROM CHIMERAS IN GREECE TO THE EXPERIMENTS

IN MEXICO

OF THE EGYPTIAN ALCHEMISTS, HIS LETTERS TOLD ME LITTLE

OF HIS DAY-TO-DAY LIFE, WHICH I GUESSED TO BE FRUSTRAT-
INGLY DULL FOR SUCH A BRILLIANT WIZARD, IMMERSED IN

MY OWN EXPERIENCES, IT WAS WITH HORROR THAT I HEARD,
TOWARD THE END OF MY YEAR'S TRAVELS, THAT YET ANOTHER
TRAGEDY HAD STRUCK THE DUMKLEDHRES: THE DEATH OF
HIS SISTER, ARIANA.

THOUGH ARIANA HAD BEEN IN POOR HEALTH FOR A LONG
TIME, THE BLEED, COMING SO SOON AFTER THE LOSS OF THEIR

MOTHER, HAD A PROFOUND EFFECT ON BOTH OF HER BROTHER-
S. ALL THESE CHEST THOUGHTS AND I COULD NOT MY-
SELF FORGET THAT BLACK NUMBER AGREE THAT ARIANA'S

DEATH, AND ALEIS'S FEELING OF PERSONAL RESPONSIBILITY
FOR IT (THOUGH, OF COURSE, HE WAS GUILTLESS), LEFT THEIR
MARK UPON HIM PERMANENTLY.

I RETURNED HOME TO FIND A YOUNG MAN WHO HAD
EXPERIENCED A MUCH OLDER PERSON'S SUFFERING. ALEIS

WAS MORE RESERVED THAN BEFORE, AND MUCH LESS LIGHT-
HEARTED. THE ADD TO HIS MISERY, THE LOSS OF ARIANA

HAD LED, NOT TO A REVISED CLOSENESS BETWEEN ALEIS

AND APOORTEH, BLIT THE AN ESTRANGEMENT. (IN TIME
THIS WOULD BLIT IN LATER YEARS THEY REESTABLISHED,
IF NOT A CLOSE RELATIONSHIP, THEN CERTAINLY A CORDIAL
ONE.) HOWEVER, HE RARELY SPoke OF HIS PARENTS OR OF
ARIANA FROM THEN ON, AND HIS FRIENDS LEARNED NOT TO
MENTION THEM.

ETHER HILLS WILL DESCRIBE THE TRIUMPHS OF THE FEEL-
ING YEARS, DUMBLEDORE'S INNUMERABLE CONTRIBU-
TIONS TO THE STATE OF WIZARDING KNOWLEDGE, INCLUDING

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HIS DISCOVERY OF THE TWELVE LIVES OF DRAGON'S BLOOD,
WILL BENEFIT GENERATIONS TO COME, AS WILL THE WISDOM
HE DISPLAYED IN THE MANY JUDGMENTS HE MADE WHILE
CHIEF WARLOCK OF THE WIZENGAMMOT. THEY SAY, STILL,
THAT NO WIZARDING DUEL EVER MATCHED THAT BETWEEN
DUMBLEDORE AND GRINDELWALD IN 1945. THOSE WHO
WITNESSED IT HAVE WRITTEN OF THE TERROR AND THE AWE
THEY FELT AS THEY WATCHED THESE TWO EXTRAORDINARY
WIZARDS DUE BATTLE, DUMBLEDORE'S TRIUMPH, AND ITS

CONSEQUENCES FOR THE WIZARDING WORLD, ARE CONSID-
ERED A TURNING POINT IN MAGICAL HISTORY THE MATCH THE

INTRODUCTION OF THE INTERNATIONAL STATUTE OF SECRECY
OF THE DEEDS OF THE LOST-DEED-RE-NAMED,
ALIAS DUMBLEDOORE WAS NEVER PROUD OF VAIN; HE
COULD FIND SOMETHING THE VALUE IN ANYONE, HOWEVER
APPARENTLY INSIGNIFICANT OR WRETCHED, AND I BELIEVE

THAT HIS EARLY LESSES ENDED HIM WITH GREAT HUMAN-
ITY AND SYMPATHY. I SHALL MISS HIS FRIENDSHIP MORE

THAN I CAN SAY, BUT MY LOSS IS AS NOTHING COMPARED TO

THE WIZARDING WORLD'S, THAT HE WAS THE MOST INSPIR-
ING AND THE BEST LOVED OF ALL HOGWARTS HEADMASTERS

CANNOT BE IN EXISTENCE, HE DIED AS HE LIVED: WORKING
ALWAYS FOR THE GREATER GOOD AND, TO HIS LAST BREATH, AS
WILLING TO STRETCH OUT A HAND TO A SMALL KID WITH
DRAGON PINK AS HE WAS ON THE DAY THAT I MET HIM.

HARRY FINISHED READING BUT CONTINUED THE GAZE AT THE PICTURE AC-
COMPANYING THE HERITAGE. DUMBLEDOORE WAS WEARING HIS FAMILIAR,

IN MEMORIAM

KINDLY SMILE, BUT AS HE PEERED OVER THE TOP OF HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES, HE GAVE THE IMPRESSION, EVEN IN NEWSPRINT, OF X-RAYING HARRY,

WHOSE SADNESS MINGLED WITH A SENSE OF HUMILIATION.

HE HAD THOUGHT HE KNEW DUMBLEDORE WELL, BUT EVER SINCE READING THIS HEATILY HE HAD BEEN FORCED TO RECOGNIZE THAT HE HAD BARELY KNOWN HIM AT ALL. NEVER HENCE HAD HE IMAGINED DUMBLEDORE'S CHILDHOOD OR YOUTH; IT WAS AS THOUGH HE HAD SPUN IN THE KING AS

HARRY HAD KNOWN HIM, VENERABLE AND SILVER-HAIRED AND OLD. THE IDEA

OF A TEENAGE DUMBLEDORE WAS SIMPLY HED, LIKE TRYING TO IMAGINE A STUPID HERMION OR A FRIENDLY BLAST-ENDED SKRINT.

HE HAD NEVER THOUGHT THE OLD DUMBLEDORE ABOUT HIS PAST. WHY SHOULD IT HAVE FELT STRANGE, IMPERTINENT EVEN, BUT AFTER ALL, IT HAD BEEN COMMON KNOWLEDGE THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD TAKEN PART IN THAT LEGENDARY BUEL WITH GRINDELWALD, AND HARRY HAD NOT THOUGHT THE OLD DUMBLEDORE WHAT THAT HAD BEEN LIKE, NOR ABOUT ANY OF HIS OTHER FAMOUS ACHIEVEMENTS. WHY, THEY HAD ALWAYS DISCUSSED HARRY, HARRY'S PAST, HARRY'S FUTURE, HARRY'S PLANS . . . AND IT SEEMED THE HARRY NOW, DESPITE THE FACT THAT HIS FUTURE WAS SO DANGEROUS AND SO UNCERTAIN, THAT HE HAD MISSED IRREPLACEABLE OPPORTUNITIES WHEN

HE HAD FAILED THE OLD DUMBLEDORE MORE ABOUT HIMSELF, EVEN THOUGH THE ONLY PERSONAL QUESTION HE HAD EVER ASKED HIS HEADMASTER WAS ALSO THE ONLY ONE HE SUSPECTED THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD NOT ANSWERED HONESTLY:

WHAT DO YOU SEE WHEN YOU LOOK IN THE MIRROR?

IF I SEE MYSELF HOLDING A PAIR OF THICK, WHEEKEN SHEARS,

AFTER SEVERAL MINUTES' THOUGHT, HARRY TOOK THE HEFTIEST BLIT OF THE

PROPHET, HELD IT CAREFULLY, AND TUCKED IT INSIDE THE FIRST VOLUME OF

PRACTICAL DEFENSIVE MAGIC AND ITS USE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, THEN HE

CHAPTER TWO

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THREW THE REST OF THE NEWSPAPER INTO THE RUBBISH PILE AND TURNED THE

FACE THE OTHER WAY. IT WAS MUCH QUIETER. THE ONLY THINGS LEFT BLIT OF PLACE

WERE TODAY'S DAILY PROPHET, STILL LYING IN THE BED, AND IN THE CORNER OF IT, THE PILE OF BROKEN MIRROR.

HARRY MOVED ACROSS THE ROOM, SLID THE MIRROR FRAGMENT OFF TODAY'S

PROPHET, AND UNFOLDED THE NEWSPAPER. HE HAD MERELY GLANCED AT THE

HEADLINE WHEN HE HAD TAKEN THE REELLED-UP PAPER FROM THE DELIVERY MAN EARLY THAT MORNING AND THROWN IT ASIDE, AFTER NOTING THAT IT SAID

NOTHING ABOUT VULDERMORT. HARRY WAS SURE THAT THE MINISTRY WAS LEADING HIM THE WRONG WAY. THE SUPPRESS NEWS ABOUT VULDERMORT. IT WAS

ONLY NOW, THEREFORE, THAT HE SAW WHAT HE HAD MISSED,
ACROSS THE BOTTOM HALF OF THE FRONT PAGE A SMALLER HEADLINE WAS
SET OVER A PICTURE OF DUMBLEDOORE STRIDING ALONG LOOKING HARRIED:

DUMBLEDOORE THE TRUTH AT LAST?

COMING NEXT WEEK, THE SHOCKING STORY OF THE FLAWED
GENIUS CONSIDERED BY MANY TO BE THE GREATEST WIZARD
OF HIS GENERATION. STRIPPING AWAY THE POPULAR IMAGE
OF SERENE, SILVER-BEARDED WISDOM, RITA SKEETER REVEALS

THE DISTURBED CHILDHOOD, THE LONELY YOUTH, THE LIFE-
LONG FELDS, AND THE GUILTY SECRETS THAT DUMBLEDOORE

CARRIED TO HIS GRAVE. WHO WAS THE MAN TIPPED TO BE

MINISTER OF MAGIC CONTENT TO REMAIN A MERE HEAD-
MASTER? WHAT WAS THE REAL PURPOSE OF THE SECRET

ORGANIZATION KNOWN AS THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX?
HOW DID DUMBLEDOORE REALLY MEET HIS END?

THE ANSWERS TO THESE AND MANY MORE QUESTIONS
ARE EXPLORED IN THE EXCLUSIVE NEW BIOGRAPHY, 'THE
LIFE AND LIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDOORE, BY RITA SKEETER,

IN MEMORIAM

EXCLUSIVELY INTERVIEWED BY BETTY BRAITHWAITE, PAGE

18, INSIDE.

HARRY RIPPED OPEN THE PAPER AND FOUND PAGE THIRTEEN. THE ARTICLE

WAS TOPPED WITH A PICTURE SHOWING ANOTHER FAMILIAR FACE: A WOMAN

WEARING JEWELLED GLASSES WITH ELABORATELY CURLLED BLONDE HAIR, HER TEETH

BARED IN WHAT WAS CLEARLY SUPPRESSED THE BE A WINNING SMILE, WIGGLING

HER FINGERS UP AT HIM, DOING HIS BEST TO IGNORE THIS REALISING IM-

AGE, HARRY READ ON.

IN PERSON, RITA SKEETER IS MUCH WARMER AND
SHEETER THAN HER FAMOUSLY PERECUTIOUS ELEGANT PORTRAITS
MIGHT SUGGEST. GREETING ME IN THE HALLWAY OF HER
CHEZY HOME, SHE LEADS ME STRAIGHT INTO THE KITCHEN
FOR A CUP OF TEA, A SLICE OF PEELING CAKE AND, IT GOES
WITHOUT SAYING, A STEAMING VAT OF FRESHEST CHESSEP.

WELL, OF COURSE, DUMBLEDORE IS A KINERAPHIC S
DREAM, SAYS SKEETER. SUCH A LONG, FULL LIFE. I'M SURE
MY BOOKS WILL BE THE FIRST OF VERY, VERY MANY.

SKEETER WAS CERTAINLY ELICED OFF THE MARK. HER
NINE-HUNDRED-PAGE BOOK WAS COMPLETED A MERE FEW
WEEKS AFTER DUMBLEDORE'S MYSTERIOUS DEATH IN JUNE.
I ASK HER HOW SHE MANAGED THIS SUPERFAST FEAT.

HEY, WHEN YOU'VE BEEN A JOURNALIST AS LONG AS
I HAVE, WORKING THE DEADLINE IS SECOND NATURE. I
KNEW THAT THE WIZARDING WORLD WAS CLAMORING FOR
THE FULL STORY AND I WANTED TO BE THE FIRST TO MEET
THAT NEED.

I MENTIONED THE RECENT, WIDELY PUBLICIZED REMARKS

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MR ELPHIAS DUFFLE, SPECIAL ADVISER TO THE WIZEN-
GAMUT AND LONGSTANDING FRIEND OF ALBUS DUMBLE-
DORE'S, THAT SKEETER'S BOOK CONTAINS LESS FACT THAN A

COMPLIMENTARY FREE CARD.

SKEETER TURNS BACK HER HEAD AND LAUGHS.

DARLING DUFFLE? I REMEMBER INTERVIEWING HIM
A FEW YEARS BACK ABOUT MERPEOPLE RIGHTS, BLESS HIM.
COMPLETELY GAGA, SEEMED TO THINK WE WERE SITTING
AT THE BATHHOUSE OF LAKE WINDERMERE, KEPT TELLING ME
THE WATCH HELLT FOR TRELLT.

AND YET ELPHIAS DUFFLE'S ACCUSATIONS OF INACCURACY

HAVE BEEN ECHOED IN MANY PLACES, DOES SKEETER RE-
ALLY FEEL THAT THEIR SHORT WEEKS HAVE BEEN ENOUGH TO

GAIN A FULL PICTURE OF DUMKLEBHERE'S LIFE AND EXTRAORDINARY LIFE?

HEY, MY DEAR, BEAMS SKEETER, RAPPING ME APPROPRIATELY ACROSS THE KNICKLES, YELL DOWN AS WELL AS

I DO FEEL MUCH INFORMATION CAN BE GENERATED BY A FAT BAG OF CALLIONS, A REFLISAL THE HEAR THE WEIRD NEE, AND A NICE SHARP FLICK-FLUTES FLIM! PEOPLE WERE FOLLOWING THE DISH THE DIRT HEN DUMKLEBHERE ANYWAY, MEET EVERYONE TELLIGHT HE WAS SEE WHENDERFLIK, YELL DOWN HE TRIED HEN AN ALPLI LET OF IMPERTANT THES, BUT HED DEEDY DEER CAN GET OFF HIS HIGH HIPPOCRISY,

BECAUSE I VE HAD ACCESS TH A SEELICE MEET INJURIALISTS WOULD SWAP THEIR HANDS PER, HENK WE-EE HAS NEVER

SPEEREN IN PUBLIC REPERE AND WE-EE WAS CLISE TH DUMKLEBHERE DURING THE MEET TURBULENT AND DISTURBING

PHASE OF HIS YELTHE,

IN MEMORIAM

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THE ADVANCE PUBLICITY PER SKEETER'S BIOGRAPHY HAS

CERTAINLY SUGGESTED THAT THERE WILL BE SHIELDS IN STORE
FOR THOSE WHO BELIEVE OLMPLEDERE THE HAVE LED A
BLAMELESS LIFE. WHAT WERE THE BIGGEST SURPRISES SHE
UNCOVERED, I ASK?

WELL, HERE IT IS, BETTY, I M NOT GIVING AWAY ALL
THE HIGHLIGHTS BEFORE ANYBODY S RELIGHT THE REEDS!
LAWREN SKEETER. BUT I CAN PROMISE THAT ANYBODY
WHO STILL THINKS OLMPLEDERE WAS WHITE AS HIS BEARD
IS IN FOR A RUDE AWAKENING! LET S JUST SAY THAT NEEDY
HEARING HIM RAGE AGAINST YELI-KNEEL-WHEE WOULD
HAVE DREAMED THAT HE DABBLED IN THE DARK ARTS
HIMSELF IN HIS YOUTH! AND FOR A WIZARD WHO SPENT

HIS LATER YEARS PLEADING FOR TOLERANCE, HE WASN T EX-
ACTLY BROAD-MINDED WHEN HE WAS YOUNGER! YES, AL-
THO OLMPLEDERE HAD AN EXTREMELY MURDERY PAST, NOT

THE MENTION THAT VERY FISHY FAMILY, WHICH HE WORKED
SHE HAD THE DEEP FULFILLED LIP,

I ASK WHETHER SKEETER IS REFERRING THE OLMPLEDERE S

BROTHER, ARRWORTH, WHOSE CONVICTION BY THE WIZEN-
CAMEET FOR MISUSE OF MAGIC CALLED A MINOR SCANDAL

FIFTEEN YEARS AGO.

EH, ARRWORTH IS JUST THE TIP OF THE BLIND HEAP,
LAWREN SKEETER. NO, NO, I M TALKING ABOUT MUCH

WHERE THAN A BROTHER WITH A KINDNESS FOR FIDDLING

ARLIT WITH CHATS, WHERE EVEN THAN THE MUGGLE-
MAIMING FATHER DUMBLEDORE COULD NOT KEEP EITHER

OF THEM QUIET ANYWAY, THEY WERE BOTH CHARGED BY
THE WIZENGAMUT. NOW, IT IS THE MOTHER AND THE SISTER

CHAPTER TWO

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THAT INTRIGUED ME, AND A LITTLE DIGGING UNCOVERED A
POSITIVE NEST OF NAUGHTINESS BUT, AS I SAY, YOU WILL HAVE
TO WAIT FOR CHAPTERS NINE TO TWELVE FOR FULL DETAILS. ALL
I CAN SAY NOW IS, IT IS NOT WHEN DUMBLEDORE NEVER
TALKED ABOUT HIS HIS NEAR GET KIDNED.

FAMILY SKELETONS NOTWITHSTANDING, DOES SKEETER
DENY THE BRILLIANCE THAT LED THE DUMBLEDORE'S MANY
MAGICAL DISCOVERIES?

HE HAD BRAINS, SHE CONCEDES, ALTHOUGH MANY
NOW QUESTION WHETHER HE COULD REALLY TAKE FULL CREDIT
FOR ALL OF HIS SUPPOSED ACHIEVEMENTS. AS I REVEAL IN

CHAPTER SIXTEEN, IVER DILLHURST CLAIMS HE HAD AL-
READY DISCOVERED EIGHT USES OF DRAGON'S BLOOD WHEN

OLMKEDEHE REHEHEED HIS PAPERS,

BUT THE IMPORTANCE OF SOME OF OLMKEDEHE'S
ACHIEVEMENTS CANNOT, I VENTURE, BE DENIED. WHAT OF
HIS FAMOUS DEFEAT OF GRINDEWALD?

EH, WELL, I'M GLAD YOU MENTIONED GRINDEWALD,
SAYS SKEETER WITH A TANTALIZING SMILE. I'M AFRAID THESE
WELL-GH-DEED-EDD EVER OLMKEDEHE'S SPECTACULAR
VICTORIES MUST BRACE THEMSELVES FOR A RETORT. FOR
PERHAPS A DINGDONG. VERY DIRTY BUSINESS INDEED.
ALL I'LL SAY IS, DON'T BE SO SURE THAT THERE REALLY WAS
THE SPECTACULAR DEED OF LEGEND. AFTER THEY'VE READ MY

BOOK, PEOPLE MAY BE FORCED TO CONCLUDE THAT GRIN-
DEWALD SIMPLY CONQUERED A WHITE HANDKERCHIEF FROM

THE END OF HIS HAND AND CAME AWAY WITH IT.

SKEETER REFUSES TO GIVE ANY MORE AWAY THAN THIS
INTRIGUING SLICKET, SHE WE TURN INSTEAD TO THE RELA-

IN MEMORIAM

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THINKING THAT WILL UNDOUBTEDLY FASCINATE HER READERS
MORE THAN ANY OTHER.

EH YES, SAYS SKEETER, NODDING BRISKLY. I DEVOTE
AN ENTIRE CHAPTER TO THE LITTLE PETER-OLMKEDEHE

RELATIONSHIP, IT'S BEEN CALLED UNHEALTHY, EVEN SINISTER. AGAIN, YOUR READERS WILL HAVE TO KNOB MY REAS-

FOR THE WHOLE STORY, BUT THERE IS ONE QUESTION THAT
DUMFRIESHERE THINKS AN UNNATURAL INTEREST IN PETER
FROM THE WORD GO. WHETHER THAT WAS REALLY IN THE
KID'S BEST INTERESTS. WELL, WE'LL SEE. IT'S CERTAINLY
AN OPEN SECRET THAT PETER HAS HAD A MOST TROUBLED
ADOLESCENCE.

I ASK WHETHER SKEETER IS STILL IN TOUCH WITH HARRY
PETER, WHEN SHE'S FAMILIARLY INTERVIEWED LAST YEAR:

A BREADTHFUL PIECE IN WHICH PETER SPEAKS EXCEL-
LENTLY OF HIS CONVICTION THAT SHE-KNEW-WHEN HAD

RETURNED.

EH, YES, WE'VE DEVELOPED A CLOSE KNOB, SAYS
SKEETER. PETER PETER HAS FEW REAL FRIENDS, AND WE
MET AT ONE OF THE MOST TESTING MOMENTS OF HIS LIFE

THE TRIUNZARD TRIUNZAMENT. I AM PROBABLY ONE
OF THE ONLY PEOPLE ALIVE WHEN CAN SAY THAT THEY KNEW
THE REAL HARRY PETER.

WHICH LEADS US NEATLY TO THE MANY RUMORS STILL
CIRCULATING ABOUT DUMFRIESHERE'S FINAL FEELINGS. DOES

SKEETER BELIEVE THAT PETER WAS THERE WHEN DUMBLE-

DIED?

WELL, I DIDN'T WANT TO SAY THE MURDER IT'S ALL IN
THE BOOK BUT EVIDENCES INSIDE HOGWARTS CASTLE

CHAPTER TWO

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SAN PETER RUNNING AWAY FROM THE SCENE MOMENTS

AFTER DUMBLEDORE FELL, LIMPED, HE WAS PUSHED. PETER
LATER GAVE EVIDENCE AGAINST SEVERUS Snape, A MAN

AGAINST WHOM HE HAS A PERSONAL GRUDGE. IS EVERY-
THING AS IT SEEMS? THAT IS FOR THE WIZARDING COM-
MUNITY TO DECIDE. HENCE THEY'VE READ MY BOOK.

IN THAT INTRIGUING NOTE, I TAKE MY LEAVE. THERE
CAN BE NO DOUBT THAT SPECTER HAS ENLIVENED AN INSTANT

BESTSELLER, DUMBLEDORE'S LEGIONS OF ADMIRERS, MEAN-
WHILE, MAY WELL BE TREMBLING AT WHAT IS SEEN TO

EMERGE ABOUT THEIR HEADS.

HARRY REACHED THE BOTTOM OF THE ARTICLE, BUT CONTINUED TO STARE

BLANDLY AT THE PAGE. REVULSION AND FURY RISE IN HIM LIKE VOMIT;
HE

ROLLED UP THE NEWSPAPER AND THREW IT, WITH ALL HIS FORCE, AT THE
WALL,

WHERE IT HIT THE REST OF THE BLUESH-HEADED ARMY HIS
EVERGREEN-

ING KIN,

HE BEGAN THE STRIDE BLINDLY AMONG THE ROOMS, OPENING EMPTY DRAW-
ERS AND PICKING UP BOOKS ONLY TO REPLACE THEM IN THE SAME PLACES,

BARELY CONSCIOUS OF WHAT HE WAS DOING, AS RANDOM PHRASES FROM

rita's ARTICLE REEMERGED IN HIS HEAD: AN ENTIRE CHAPTER THE THE WHOLE
PITTER-

CLUMBERING RELATIONSHIP . . . IT'S BEEN CALLED LINE-HEATHY, EVEN
SINISTER, . . .

HE DABBLED IN THE DARK ARTS HIMSELF IN HIS YOUTH . . . I'VE HAD ACCESS
THE

A SEVERE MOST JOURNALISTS WOULD SLAP THEIR HANDS FOR . . .

LIES! HARRY BELIEVED, AND THROUGH THE WINDOW HE SAW THE
NEXT-DOOR NEIGHBOR, WHO HAD PAUSED THE RESTART HIS LAWN MOWER,
WENT UP NERVOUSLY,

HARRY SAT DOWN HARD IN THE BED. THE BREDEN KIT OF MIRROR DANCED
AWAY FROM HIM; HE PICKED IT UP AND TURNED IT OVER IN HIS FINGERS,

IN MEMORIAM

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THINKING, THINKING OF DUMBLEDORE AND THE LIES WITH WHICH RITA
SKEETER WAS DEAMING HIM, . . .

A FLASH OF BRIGHTEST BLUE, HARRY FREEZE, HIS CLIT FINGER SLIPPING IN
THE JAGGED EDGE OF THE MIRROR AGAIN, HE HAD IMAGINED IT, HE MUST
HAVE DONE, HE GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER, BUT THE WALL WAS A SILENT
PARCHMENT OF ALINT PETLINIA'S CHESSING: THERE WAS NOTHING
BLUE

THERE FOR THE MIRROR TO REFLECT, HE PEERED INTO THE MIRROR
FRAGMENT

AGAIN, AND SAW NOTHING BUT HIS OWN BRIGHT GREEN EYE LOOKING BACK
AT HIM.

HE HAD IMAGINED IT, THERE WAS NO OTHER EXPLANATION; IMAGINED IT,
BECAUSE HE HAD BEEN THINKING OF HIS DEAD HEADMASTER, IF ANYTHING
WAS CERTAIN, IT WAS THAT THE BRIGHT BLUE EYES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE
WOULD NEVER PIERCE HIM AGAIN.

CHAPTER THREE

KK

THE DURSLEYS
DEPARTING

HE FELT THE FRONT DOOR SLAMMING BEHIND HIM UP THE STAIRS
AND A VOICE YELLED, "HEY, PHIL!"

SIXTEEN YEARS OF BEING ADDRESSED THATS LEFT HARRY IN THE DILEMMA WHEN
HIS UNCLE WAS CALLING; NEVERTHELESS, HE DID NOT IMMEDIATELY RESPOND.
HE WAS STILL GAZING AT THE MIRROR FRAGMENT IN WHICH, FOR A SPLIT
SECOND,

HE HAD THE LIGHT HE SAW DUMBLEDORE'S EYE. IT WAS NOT UNTIL HIS
UNCLE

REMARKED, "HEY!" THAT HARRY GOT HIMSELF TO HIS FEET AND HEADED FOR
THE BEDROOM DOOR, PALISING THE ADD THE PIECE OF BROKEN MIRROR THE
THE

RUCKSACK FILLED WITH THINGS HE WOULD BE TAKING WITH HIM.

"PHIL, THEIR TIME!" HEARD VERNON DURSLEY WHEN HARRY AP-
PEARED AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS. "GET DOWN HERE, I WANT A WORD!"

HARRY STRETTLED DOWNSTAIRS, HIS HANDS DEEP IN HIS JEANS POCKETS.
WHEN HE REACHED THE LIVING ROOM HE FELT ALL THREE DURSLEYS.
THEY

WERE DRESSED FOR TRAVELING: UNCLE VERNON IN A FAWN ZIP-UP JACKET,
AUNT PETUNIA IN A NEAT SALMON-COLOURED COAT, AND DUDLEY, HARRY'S
LARGE, BLENDED, MUSCULAR COUNSELIN, IN HIS LEATHER JACKET.

T

THE DURSLEYS
DEPARTING

YES? ASKED HARRY.

SIT DOWN! SAID UNCLE VERNON, HARRY RAISED HIS EYEBROWS.

PLEASE! ADDED UNCLE VERNON, WINKING SLIGHTLY AS THOUGH THE

WORD

WAS SHARP IN HIS TONGUE.

HARRY SAT, HE THOUGHT HE KNEW WHAT WAS COMING. HIS UNCLE

BEGAN THE PACE UP AND DOWN, ALINT PETLINIA AND DUDLEY FOLLOWING

HIS MOVEMENTS WITH ANXIOUS EXPRESSIONS, FINALLY, HIS LARGE

PLUMP

FACE CRUMPLED WITH CONCENTRATION, UNCLE VERNON STOPPED IN

FRONT

OF HARRY AND SPEAK.

I VE CHANGED MY MIND, HE SAID.

WHAT A SURPRISE, SAID HARRY,

DONT YOU TAKE THAT THERE BEGAN ALINT PETLINIA IN A SHRILL

VOICE, BUT VERNON DURSLEY WAVED HER DOWN.

IT S ALL A LEFT OF CLAPTRAP, SAID UNCLE VERNON, GLARING AT HARRY

WITH PIGGY LITTLE EYES. I VE DECIDED I DONT BELIEVE A WORD OF IT.

MENT HAD BEEN THE ONE WHEN LITTLE VERNON, UNAWARE THAT DUDLEY HAD ADDED HIS DUMBBELLS TO HIS CASE SINCE THE LAST TIME IT HAD

BEEN UNPACKED, HAD ATTEMPTED TO PUSH IT BACK INTO THE SHEET AND COLLAPSED WITH REARS OF PAIN AND MUCH SWEARING.

ACCORDING TO YELL, VERNON DURSLEY SAID NEH, RESUMING HIS PAILING UP AND DOWN THE LIVING ROOM, WE PETUNIA, DUDLEY, AND I

ARE IN DANGER, FROM FROM

SOME OF MY LEFT, RIGHT, SAID HARRY,

WELL, I DON'T BELIEVE IT, REPEATED LITTLE VERNON, COMING TO A HALT

CHAPTER THREE

BY

IN FRONT OF HARRY AGAIN. I WAS AWAKE HALF THE NIGHT THINKING IT ALL

EVER, AND I BELIEVE IT'S A PLOT TO GET THE FELLOWS.

THE FELLOWS? REPEATED HARRY. WHAT FELLOWS?

THIS FELLOW? STRUCK LITTLE VERNON, THE VEIN IN HIS FOREHEAD STARTING TO PULSE. HOW FELLOWS? FELLOW PRICES ARE SPYING DETECTING ARELAND

HERE? YELL WANT US OUT OF THE WAY AND THEN YELL'RE GOING TO BE A KIT

OF FELLOWS-FELLOWS AND BEFORE WE KNOW IT THE DEEDS WILL BE IN YOUR NAME AND

ARE YOU BLIT HY YOUR MIND? DEMANDED HARRY, A PLANT THE GET THIS
FEELISE? ARE YOU ACTUALLY AS STUPID AS YOU LOOK?

DEN T YOU DARE ♪ SHEWALKED ALINT PETLINIA, BLIT AGAIN, VERNEN
WAVED HER DEHN: SLIGHTS HEN HIS PERSONAL APPEARANCE WERE, IT
SEEMED,

AS NOTHING THE THE DANGER HE HAD SPENTED,

JUST IN CASE YOU VE FORGOTTEN, SAID HARRY, I VE ALREADY GET A
FEELISE, MY GODFATHER LEFT ME HEN, SEE WHY WOULD I WANT THIS HEN?
ALL THE HAPPY MEMORIES?

THERE WAS SILENCE, HARRY THELIGHT HE HAD RATHER IMPRESSED HIS
UNCLE WITH THIS ARGUMENT,

YOU CLAIM, SAID UNCLE VERNEN, STARTING THE PACE YET AGAIN, THAT
THIS LEHD THING

VERHEMERT, SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY, AND WE VE BEEN THROUGH

THIS AKHIT A HUNDRED TIMES ALREADY, THIS ISN T A CLAIM, IT S FACT,
BLIM-

BLEDHIRE TELD YOU LAST YEAR, AND KINGSLEY AND MR, WEASLEY

VERNEN BLIRLEY FLINCHED HIS SEHLIDERS ANGRILY, AND HARRY
GRESSED

THAT HIS UNCLE WAS ATTEMPTING THE WARD HY REHELECTIONS OF THE
LINAN-

NEHLINCE VISIT, A FEW DAYS INTEH HARRY S SLIMPER FEHLIDAYS, HY THE
FLILY

GREEN WIZARDS, THE ARRIVAL IN THE DEERSTEP OF KINGSLEY
SHACKLEHOLT

AND ARTHUR WEASLEY HAD COME AS A MOST UNPLEASANT SURPRISE TO THE

THE DURSLEYS

DEPARTING

KK

DURSLEYS, HARRY HAD TO ADMIT, HOWEVER, THAT AS MR. WEASLEY HAD
HENCE DEMOLISHED HALF OF THE LIVING ROOM, HIS REAPPEARANCE COULD
NOT

HAVE BEEN EXPECTED TO DELIGHT UNCLE VERNON.

KINGSLEY AND MR. WEASLEY EXPLAINED IT ALL AS WELL, HARRY
PRESSED HIM REMORSELESSLY, HENCE I'M SEVENTEEN, THE PROTECTIVE
CHARM

THAT KEEPS ME SAFE WILL BREAK, AND THAT EXPOSES ME AS WELL AS MR.

THE ORDER IS SURE VERMONT WILL TARGET ME, WHETHER THE THUNDER
ME

THE TRY AND FIND ME WHERE I AM, HE REALISE HE THINKS BY HOLDING
ME

HESTAGE I'D COME AND TRY TO RESCUE ME.

UNCLE VERNON'S AND HARRY'S EYES MET, HARRY WAS SURE THAT IN
THAT

INSTANT THEY WERE BOTH CONSIDERING THE SAME THING, THEN UNCLE
VER-

NON WALKED ON AND HARRY RESUMED, ME WE GOT THE GO INTO THE HIDING

AND THE ORDER WANTS THE HELP, THEY'RE BEING OFFERED SERIOUS
PROTECTION,

THE BEST THERE IS,

WHILE VERNON SAID NOTHING, BUT CONTINUED THE PACE UP AND DOWN,
OUTSIDE THE SUN HUNG LOW OVER THE PRIVET HEDGES. THE NEXT-DAY
NEIGHBOR'S LAWN MOWER STALLED AGAIN.

I THOUGHT THERE WAS A MINISTRY OF MAGIC? ASKED VERNON DURS-
LEY ABRUPTLY.

THERE IS, SAID HARRY, SURPRISED.

WELL, THEN, WHY CAN'T THEY PROTECT US? IT SEEMS TO ME THAT, AS
INNOCENT VICTIMS, GUILTY OF NOTHING MORE THAN HARBORING A
MURDER

MAN, WE ENJOY THE ELIQUITY FOR GOVERNMENT PROTECTION?

HARRY LAUGHED; HE COULD NOT HELP HIMSELF. IT WAS SO VERY TYPICAL
OF HIS UNCLE THE PUT HIS FEET IN THE ESTABLISHMENT, EVEN WITHIN
THIS

WORLD THAT HE DESPISED AND MISTRUSTED.

THEY HEARD WHAT MR. WEASLEY AND DINGSLEY SAID, HARRY REPLIED.

WE THINK THE MINISTRY HAS BEEN INFILTRATED.

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R4

WHILE VERNON STRODE THE THE FIREPLACE AND BACK, BREATHING THE
FRAY-

ILY THAT HIS GREAT BLACK MUSTACHE RIPPLED, HIS FACE STILL PURPLE WITH

CONCENTRATION.

ALL RIGHT, HE SAID, STEPPING IN FRONT OF HARRY YET AGAIN. ALL RIGHT, LET S SAY, FOR THE SAKE OF ARGUMENT, WE ACCEPT THIS PROTECTION.

I STILL DONT SEE WHY WE CANT HAVE THAT KINGSLEY BLADE.

HARRY MANAGED NOT TO REEL HIS EYES, BUT WITH DIFFICULTY. THIS BLADE-

THEN HAD ALREADY BEEN ADDRESSED HALF A DOZEN TIMES.

AS I VE TOLD YOU, HE SAID THROUGH GRITTED TEETH, KINGSLEY IS PROTECTING THE MUG I MEAN, YOUR PRIME MINISTER.

EXACTLY HE S THE BEST! SAID LITTLE VERNON, POINTING AT THE BLANK TELEVISION SCREEN. THE DURSLEYS HAD SPOTTED KINGSLEY ON THE NEWS, WALKING ALONG DISCREETLY BEHIND THE MUGGLE PRIME MINISTER AS

HE VISITED A HOSPITAL. THIS, AND THE FACT THAT KINGSLEY HAD MASTERED

THE knack OF DRESSING LIKE A MUGGLE, NOT TO MENTION A CERTAIN REAS-

URING SOMETHING IN HIS SLEEVES, DEEP VOICE, HAD CALLED THE DURSLEYS

THE TAKE THE KINGSLEY IN A WAY THAT THEY HAD CERTAINLY NOT DONE WITH

AND EITHER WIZARD, ALTHOUGH IT WAS TRUE THAT THEY HAD NEVER SEEN HIM

WITH HIS KARRING IN,

WELL, HE'S TAKEN, SAID HARRY, BUT HESTIA JONES AND DEBALLIS BIGGLE ARE MORE THAN UP TO THE JOB

IF WE'D EVEN SEEN TV'S ... BEGAN UNCLE VERNON, BUT HARRY LOST

PATIENCE, GETTING TO HIS FEET, HE ADVANCED ON HIS UNCLE, NOW POINTING AT THE TV SET HIMSELF,

THESE ACCIDENTS AREN'T ACCIDENTS THE CRASHES AND EXPLOSIONS AND DERAILMENTS AND WHATEVER ELSE HAS HAPPENED SINCE WE LAST

WATCHED THE NEWS, PEOPLE ARE DISAPPEARING AND DYING AND HE'S RE-
FIND IT VERMONT, I'VE TOLD YOU THIS EVER AND EVER AGAIN, HE
KILLS

THE DURSLEYS
DEPARTING

RS

MUGGLES ARE FLIN, EVEN THE MUGS THEY'RE CALLED BY DEMENTERS, AND
IF YOU CAN'T REMEMBER WHAT THEY ARE, ASK YOUR SISTER

DUDLEY'S HANDS REACHED UPWARD TO COVER HIS EYES. WITH HIS PAR-
ENTS AND HARRY'S EYES UPON HIM, HE SILENTLY BELIEVED THEM AGAIN
AND

ASKED, THERE ARE . . . MORE OF THEM?

MORE? LAUGHED HARRY, MORE THAN THE TREE THAT ATTACKED US, YELL

MEAN? OF COURSE THERE ARE, THERE ARE HUNDREDS, MAYBE THOUSANDS BY THIS TIME, SEEING AS THEY FEED OFF FEAR AND DESPAIR

ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, BLUSTERED VERNON DURSLEY, YELL VE MADE YOUR POINT

I HOPE SO, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE SINCE I'M SEVENTEEN, ALL OF THEM

DEATH EATERS, DEMENTORS, MAYBE EVEN INFERI WHICH MEANS DEAD BODIES ENCHANTED BY A DARK WIZARD WILL BE ABLE TO FIND YELL AND WILL CERTAINLY ATTACK YELL, AND IF YELL REMEMBER THE LAST TIME YELL TRIED

THE MOUTHWORN WIZARDS, I THINK YELL LL AGREE YELL NEED HELP,

THERE WAS A BRIEF SILENCE IN WHICH THE DISTANT ECHOES OF HARRY SMASHING DOWN A WHEDEN FRONT DOOR SEEMED TO REVERBERATE THROUGH

THE INTERVENING YEARS, ALIST PETUNIA WAS LEEDING AT LITTLE VERNON,

DUDLEY WAS STARING AT HARRY, FINALLY LITTLE VERNON BLURTED OUT, BUT

WHAT ARELT MY WORDS? WHAT ARELT DUDLEY'S SCREAMS? I DON'T SUPPOSE

THESE THINGS MATTER TO A CLUNCH OF LADARELT WIZARDS

DON'T YELL UNDERSTAND? SHOUTED HARRY, THEY WILL TORTURE AND KILL YELL LIKE THEY DID MY PARENTS!

DAD, SAID DUDLEY IN A LETH VICE, DAD I'M GOING WITH THESE HARDER PEOPLE,

DUDLEY, SAID F-HARRY, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN THEIR LIFE, THEY'RE TAKING SENSE.

HE KNEW THAT THE BATTLE WAS WON. IF DUDLEY WAS FRIGHTENED

CHAPTER THREE

KE

ENOUGH TO ACCEPT THE HERDER'S HELP, HIS PARENTS WOULD ACCOMPANY

HIM: THERE COULD BE NO QUESTION OF BEING SEPARATED FROM THEIR DIDDYBINS. F-HARRY GLANCED AT THE CARRIAGE CLOCK ON THE MANTELPIECE.

THEY'LL BE HERE IN ABOUT FIVE MINUTES, HE SAID, AND WHEN NONE

OF THE DURSLEYS REPLIED, HE LEFT THE ROOM. THE PROSPECT OF PARTING PERMANENTLY FROM HIS AUNT, UNCLE, AND CHRISTIN WAS

ONE THAT HE WAS ABLE TO CONTEMPLATE WITH CHEERFULNESS, BUT THERE WAS

NEVERTHELESS A CERTAIN ALDWARDNESS IN THE AIR. WHAT DID THEY SAY TO

ONE ANOTHER AT THE END OF SIXTEEN YEARS' SILENT DISLIKE?

BACK IN HIS BEDROOM, F-HARRY FIDDED AIMLESSLY WITH HIS RICKSACK,

THEN PEEKED A CHIMP OF HAW NUTS THROUGH THE BARS OF F-EDWIG'S CAGE.

THEY FELL WITH DULL THUDS THE THE BETTER, WHERE SHE IGNORED THEM.

WE'RE LEAVING SHEN, REALLY SHEN, HARRY TOLD HER. AND THEN
WELL

BE ABLE TO FLY AGAIN.

THE DINNERELL RANG, HARRY HESITATED, THEN HEADED BACK TOWARD HIS
ROOM AND DOWNSTAIRS. IT WAS THEN MUCH THE EXPECT FRESTIA AND
DEBALLIS

THE CHIEF WITH THE DURSLEYS IN THEIR HALL.

HARRY PETER? SHELEADED AN EXCITED VOICE, THE MOMENT HARRY
HAD OPENED THE DOOR, A SMALL MAN IN A MALVE TIE HAT WAS
SWEEPING

HIM A DEEP BELL. AN FINDER, AS EVER?

THANKS, DEBALLIS, SAID HARRY, RESTING A SMALL AND EM-
BARRASSED SMILE UPON THE DARK-HAIRED FRESTIA. IT'S REALLY GOOD TO

WELL THE DEE THIS, . . . THEY'RE THROUGH HERE, MY AUNT AND UNCLE AND
Cousin, . . .

GOOD DAY TO WELL, HARRY PETER'S RELATIVES? SAID DEBALLIS HAP-
PILY, STRIDING INTO THE LIVING ROOM. THE DURSLEYS DID NOT LOOK AT
ALL

HAPPY TO BE ADDRESSED THIS, HARRY HAD EXPECTED ANOTHER CHANGE
OF

MIND, DUBLY STANDING NEARER TO HIS MOTHER AT THE SIGHT OF THE
WITCH

AND LIZARD.

THE DURSLEYS

DEPARTING

BY

I SEE VEHLS ARE PACKED AND READY, EXCELLENT! THE PLAN, AS HARRY HAS TOLD VEHLS, IS A SIMPLE ONE, SAID DEDALLIS, PULLING AN IMPENSE POCKET WATCH FORTH OF HIS WAISTCOAT AND EXAMINING IT. WE SHALL BE LEAVING BEFORE HARRY DEES, BUT THE THE DANGER OF USING MAGIC IN VEHLS

BEHOLD HARRY BEING STILL UNDERAGE, IT COULD PROVIDE THE MINISTRY

WITH AN EXCUSE TO ARREST HIM WE SHALL BE DRIVING, SAY, TEN MILES

SEE, BEFORE DISAPPEARING THE THE SAFE LOCATION WE HAVE PICKED FORTH

VEHLS, VEHLS KNOW HOW TO DRIVE, I TAKE IT? HE ASKED LITTLE VERNON POLITELY.

KNOW HOW TO ? OF COURSE I SHOULD WELL KNOW HOW TO DRIVE? SPLATTERED LITTLE VERNON.

VERY CLEVER OF VEHLS, SIR, VERY CLEVER, I PERSONALLY WOULD BE LITTERALLY BAMBLED BY ALL THESE CLUTTERS AND DEETS, SAID DEDALLIS.

HE WAS CLEARLY UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT HE WAS FLATTERING VERNON

DURSLEY, WHO WAS VISIBLY LOSING CONFIDENCE IN THE PLAN WITH EVERY

WHERE DEDALLIS SPHERE.

CAN'T EVEN DRIVE, HE MUTTERED UNDER HIS BREATH, HIS MUSTACHE RIBBLING INDIGNANTLY, BUT FORTUNATELY NEITHER DEDALLIS NOR HESTIA SEEMED TO HEAR HIM.

WELL, HARRY, DEDALLIS CONTINUED, WILL WAIT HERE FOR YOUR CLARK. THERE HAS BEEN A LITTLE CHANGE IN THE ARRANGEMENTS

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? SAID HARRY AT ONCE. I THOUGHT MAD-EYE WAS GOING TO COME AND TAKE ME BY SIDE-ALONG-APPARITION?

CAN'T DO IT, SAID HESTIA TERSELY. MAD-EYE WILL EXPLAIN. THE DURSLEYS, WHO HAD LISTENED TO ALL OF THIS WITH DEEPS OF LITTLE UNDERSTANDING IN THEIR FACES, JUMPED AS A NOISE SCREECHED, HURRY UP! HARRY LOOKED ALL AROUND THE ROOM BEFORE REALIZING THAT

THE VOICE HAD ISSUED FROM DEDALLIS'S POCKET WATCH.

EXACTLY RIGHT, WE ARE OPERATING TO A VERY TIGHT SCHEDULE, SAID

CHAPTER THREE

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DEDALLIS, READING AT HIS WATCH AND TUCKING IT BACK INTO HIS WAIST-COAT. WE ARE ATTEMPTING THE TIME YOUR DEPARTURE FROM THE HOUSE

WITH YOUR FAMILY'S DISAPPEARITION, HARRY; THAT, THE CLARK BREAKS AT

THE MOMENT YOU ALL HEAD FOR SAFETY. HE TURNED TO THE DURSLEYS.

WELL, ARE WE ALL PACKED AND READY TO GO?

NEVER IF THEY ANSWERED HIM, UNCLE VERNON WAS STILL STARING, APPALLED, AT THE BLUR IN DEDALLIS'S WAISTCOT POCKET.

PERHAPS WE SHOULD WAIT OUTSIDE IN THE HALL, DEDALLIS, MURMURED HESTIA. SHE CLEARLY FELT THAT IT WOULD BE TACTLESS FOR THEM TO REMAIN

IN THE ROOM WHILE HARRY AND THE DURSLEYS EXCHANGED LEAVING, PRESSINGLY TEARFUL FAREWELLS.

THERE'S NO NEED, HARRY MUTTERED, BUT UNCLE VERNON MADE ANY FURTHER EXPLANATION UNNECESSARY BY SAYING BOLDLY,

WELL, THIS IS GOOD-BYE, THEN, BHP.

HE SWUNG HIS RIGHT ARM UPWARD TO SHAKE HARRY'S HAND, BUT AT THE

LAST MOMENT SEEMED UNABLE TO FACE IT, AND MERELY CLOSED HIS FIST AND BEGAN SWINGING IT BACKWARD AND FORWARD LIKE A METRONOME.

READY, DIDDY? ASKED AUNT PETUNIA, FLIPPING CHECKING THE CLASP OF HER HANDS AS SHE AVOIDED LOOKING AT HARRY ALTOGETHER.

DUDLEY DID NOT ANSWER, BUT STOOD THERE WITH HIS MOUTH SLIGHTLY Ajar, REMINDING HARRY A LITTLE OF THE GIANT, GRAMP.

COME ALONG, THEN, SAID UNCLE VERNON.

HE HAD ALREADY REACHED THE LIVING ROOM WHEN DUDLEY MURMURED, I DON'T UNDERSTAND.

WHAT DOESN'T SHE UNDERSTAND, PEEPING? ASKED ALINT PETLINIA,
WHICH-

ING UP AT HER SON.

BLUBLEY RAISED A LARGE, HAMLIKE HAND THE POINT AT HARRY.

WHY ISN'T HE COMING WITH US?

THE BLUBLEYS
DEPARTING

BY

UNCLE VERNON AND ALINT PETLINIA FREEZE WHERE THEY STAND, STAR-
ING AT BLUBLEY AS THOUGH HE HAD JUST EXPRESSED A DESIRE TO BECOME

A BALLERINA.

WHAT? SAID UNCLE VERNON LAUDLY.

WHY ISN'T HE COMING THEN? ASKED BLUBLEY.

WELL, HE HE DOESN'T WANT TO, SAID UNCLE VERNON, TURNING THE
GLARE AT HARRY AND ADDING, SHE DOESN'T WANT TO, DOES SHE?

NOT IN THE SLIGHTEST, SAID HARRY.

THERE SHE IS, UNCLE VERNON TOLD BLUBLEY. NOW COME ON,
WE'RE OFF.

HE MARCHED OUT OF THE ROOM. THEY HEARD THE FRONT DOOR OPEN.

BUT BLUBLEY DID NOT MOVE AND AFTER A FEW FALTERING STEPS ALINT PE-
TLINIA STOPPED THEM.

WHAT NEXT? BARKED UNCLE VERNON, REAPPEARING IN THE
BEERLAW.

IT SEEMED THAT DUDLEY WAS STRUGGLING WITH CONCEPTS THAT DIFFICULT
THE PLIT INTO WORDS. AFTER SEVERAL MOMENTS OF APPARENTLY PAINFUL
INTERNAL STRUGGLE HE SAID, BUT WHERE IS HE GOING THE CAR?

ALINT PETLINIA AND UNCLE VERNON BEHEDED AT EACH OTHER. IT WAS
CLEAR THAT DUDLEY WAS FRIGHTENING THEM. HESTIA JONES BROKE THE
SILENCE.

BUT ... SURELY YOU KNOW WHERE YOUR NEPHEW IS GOING? SHE
ASKED, BEHEADING REWILDERED.

CERTAINLY WE KNOW, SAID VERNON DURSLEY, HE IS OFF WITH SOME
OF YOUR LEFT, ISN'T HE? RIGHT, DUDLEY, LET US GET IN THE CAR, YOU HEARD
THE MAN, WE ARE IN A HURRY.

AGAIN, VERNON DURSLEY MARCHED AS FAR AS THE FRONT DOOR, BUT
DUDLEY DID NOT FOLLOW.

CHAPTER THREE

OFF WITH SOME OF YOUR LEFT?

HESTIA BEHEDED ELTRAGED. HARRY HAD MET THIS ATTITUDE BEFORE!

WITCHES AND WIZARDS SEEMED STUNNED THAT HIS CLOSEST LIVING
RELATIVES

THEY SEE LITTLE INTEREST IN THE FAMILIAR HARRY POTTER.

IT'S FINE, HARRY ASSURED HER. IT DOESN'T MATTER, HONESTLY.

DOESN'T MATTER? REPEATED ESTIA, HER VOICE RISING EMINENTLY.

DON'T THESE PEOPLE REALIZE WHAT YOU'VE BEEN THROUGH? WHAT DANGER

YOU ARE IN? THE UNWELIKE POSITION YOU FIND IN THE HEARTS OF THE ANTI-

VEHEMENT MOVEMENT?

ER... NEH, THEY DON'T, SAID HARRY. THEY THINK I'M A WASTE OF SPACE, ACTUALLY, BUT I'M USED TO

I DON'T THINK YOU'RE A WASTE OF SPACE.

IF HARRY HAD NOT SEEN DUDLEY'S LIPS MOVE, HE MIGHT NOT HAVE BELIEVED IT. AS IT WAS, HE STARED AT DUDLEY FOR SEVERAL SECONDS BEFORE ACCEPTING THAT IT MUST HAVE BEEN HIS CHLUSIN WHO HAD SPOKEN; FOR ONE THING, DUDLEY HAD TURNED RED. HARRY WAS EMBARRASSED AND ASTONISHED HIMSELF.

WELL... ER... THANKS, DUDLEY.

AGAIN, DUDLEY APPEARED THE GRAPPLE WITH THE LIGHTS THEN UNWIKELY FOR EXPRESSION BEFORE MURKING, YOU SAVED MY LIFE.

NOT REALLY, SAID HARRY. IT WAS YOURSELF THE DEMENTER WOULD HAVE TAKEN...

HE LOOKED CLUTELISLY AT HIS CHLUSIN. THEY HAD HAD VIRTUALLY NO CHEN-

TACT DURING THIS SUMMER HER LAST, AS HARRY HAD COME BACK THE PRIVET

DRIVE SHE BRIEFLY AND KEPT THE HIS REEFER SHE MUCH. IT NEW DAWNED HER
HARRY, HOWEVER, THAT THE CLIP HE HELD TOA HER WHICH HE HAD THROBEN
THAT MORNINE MIGHT NOT HAVE BEEN A BERRY TRAP AT ALL. ALTHOUGH

RATHER THICKED, HE WAS NEVERTHELESS ELITE RELIEVED THAT DUDLEY AP-
PEARED THE HAVE EXHAUSTED HIS ABILITY THE EXPRESS HIS FEELINGS. AFTER

THE DUDSELYS
DEPARTING

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OPENING HIS MOUTH HERCE HER TWICE MORE, DUDLEY SLIDED INTO
STARLET-

FACED SILENCE.

ALINT PETLINIA BURST INTO TEARS, HESTIA JONES GAVE HER AN
APPROHY-

ING LEED THAT CHANGED THE ELITRAGE AS ALINT PETLINIA RAN FORWARD
AND

EMBRACED DUDLEY RATHER THAN HARRY,

S-SHE SWEET, DUDDEBS . . . SHE SHERED INTO HIS MASSIVE CHEST,

S-SUCH A BEVERLY B-BER . . . S-SAYING THAND YELI . . .

BUT HE HASN T SAID THAND YELI AT ALL? SAID HESTIA INDIGNANTLY,
HE

ONLY SAID HE DIDN T THINK HARRY WAS A WASTE OF SPACE?

YEAH, BUT CHEMING FROM DUDLEY THAT S LIKE I LOVE YELI, SAID

HARRY, TEEN BETWEEN APPREHENSION AND A DESIRE TO LAUGH AS ALINT PETLINIA CONTINUED THE CLUTCH AT DUDLEY AS IF HE HAD JUST SAVED HARRY

FROM A BURNING BUILDING.

ARE WE GOING FOR NEXT? HEARD LITTLE VERNON, REAPPEARING YET AGAIN

AT THE LIVING ROOM DOOR. I THINK WE WERE IN A TIGHT SCHEDULE?

YES YES, WE ARE, SAID DEDALLIS DIGGLE, WHO HAD BEEN WATCHING THESE EXCHANGES WITH AN AIR OF REMISEMENT AND NOW SEEMED TO

PULL HIMSELF TOGETHER. WE REALLY MUST BE GO, HARRY

HE TRIPPED FORWARD AND GRABBING HARRY'S HAND WITH BOTH OF HIS ELBOWS.

GOOD LUCK, I HOPE WE MEET AGAIN. THE MEMBERS OF THE WIZARDING WORLD REST UPON YOUR SHOULDERS.

EH, SAID HARRY, RIGHT, THANKS.

FAREWELL, HARRY, SAID FLESTIA, ALSO CLASPING HIS HAND. ELIN THOUGHTS GO WITH YOU.

I HOPE EVERYTHING'S OKAY, SAID HARRY WITH A GLANCE TOWARD ALINT

PETLINIA AND DUDLEY.

EH, I'M SURE WE SHALL END UP THE BEST OF FILMS, SAID DIGGLE BRIGHTLY, WAVING HIS HAT AS HE LEFT THE ROOM. FLESTIA FOLLOWED HIM.

CHAPTER THREE

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DLIDLEY GENTLY RELEASED HIMSELF FROM HIS MOTHER'S CLUTCHES AND WALKED TOWARD HARRY, WHO HAD THE REPRESS AN LARGE THE THREATEN HIM

WITH MAGIC. THEN DLIDLEY HELD UP HIS LARGE, PINK HAND,

KLIMEY, DLIDLEY, SAID HARRY EVER ALINT PETLONIA'S REVELED SHE'S,

DID THE DEMENTHRS BLEND A DIFFERENT PERSONALITY INTO YOU?

DLIDLEY, MUTTERED DLIDLEY. SEE YOU, HARRY,

YES... SAID HARRY, TAKING DLIDLEY'S HAND AND SHAKING IT,

MAYBE, TAKE CARE, BIG D,

DLIDLEY NEARLY SMILED, THEN LINGERED FROM THE ROOM. HARRY

HEARD HIS HEAVY FEETFALLS ON THE GRAVELED DRIVE, AND THEN A CAR ENGINE

SLAMMED,

ALINT PETLONIA, WHOSE FACE HAD BEEN BURIED IN HER HANDKERCHIEF,

LOOKED AROUND AT THE SOUND. SHE DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE EXPECTED THE

FIND HERSELF ALONE WITH HARRY, HASTILY STEALING HER WET HANDKERCHIEF

INTO HER POCKET, SHE SAID, WELL GOOD-BYE, AND MARCHED TOWARD THE ENGINE WITHOUT LOOKING AT HIM,

GOOD-BYE, SAID HARRY,

SHE STOPPED AND LOOKED BACK, FOR A MOMENT HARRY HAD THE

STRANGEST FEELING THAT SHE WANTED TO SAY SOMETHING TO HIM: SHE

GAVE HIM AN EYE, TREMBLINGLY LOOK AND SEEMED TO TITTER ON THE EDGE

OF SPEECH, BUT THEN, WITH A LITTLE JERK OF HER HEAD, SHE LISTENED BUT
NOT

THE ROOM AFTER HER HUSBAND AND SON.

CHAPTER FOUR

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THE SEVEN PEETERS

HARRY RAN BACK UPSTAIRS TO HIS BEDROOM, ARRIVING AT THE
WINDOW JUST IN TIME TO SEE THE DURSLEYS' CAR SWINGING
OUT OF THE DRIVE AND OFF UP THE ROAD. DEADALLIS'S THOMPSON HAT WAS VISIBLE
BETWEEN ALINT PETLONIA AND DUDLEY IN THE BACKSEAT. THE CAR TURNED
RIGHT AT THE END OF PRIVET DRIVE, ITS WINDOWS TURNED SCARLET FOR A
MOMENT IN THE NEW SETTING SUN, AND THEN IT WAS GONE.

HARRY PICKED UP HERMIE'S CASE, HIS FIREHORN, AND HIS RUCKSACK,
GAVE HIS UNNATURALLY TIDY BEDROOM ONE LAST SLEEPING LOOK, AND
THEN

MADE HIS UNCAINLY WAY BACK DOWNSTAIRS TO THE HALL, WHERE HE
DROPPED-

THE CASE, BROOMSTICK, AND BAG NEAR THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS. THE
LIGHT

WAS FADING RAPIDLY NOW, THE HALL FULL OF SHADOWS IN THE EVENING
LIGHT.

IT FELT MOST STRANGE TO STAND HERE IN THE SILENCE AND KNOW THAT HE

WAS ABOUT TO LEAVE THE HOUSE FOR THE LAST TIME, LONG AGO, WHEN HE
HAD BEEN LEFT ALONE WHILE THE DURSLEYS WENT OUT THE FRONT
THEMSELVES.

THE FEELING OF SOLITUDE HAD BEEN A RARE TREAT! PALING ONLY THE
SNEAK

SOMETHING TASTY FROM THE FRIDGE, HE HAD ENJOYED UPSTAIRS THE PLAY
HIS

—

CHAPTER FOUR

DUDLEY'S COMPUTER, HE PUT ON THE TELEVISION AND FLICKED THROUGH
THE

CHANNELS THE HIS HEART'S CONTENT. IT GAVE HIM AN EERILY EMPTY FEELING
THE

REMEMBER THESE TIMES! IT WAS LIKE REMEMBERING A FAMILIAR STREET-
WHICH HE HAD LOST.

DON'T YOU WANT TO TAKE A LAST LOOK AT THE PLACE? HE ASKED FRED-
WICK, WHO WAS STILL SLIPPING WITH HER HEAD UNDER HER WING. WE'LL

NEVER BE HERE AGAIN, DON'T YOU WANT TO REMEMBER ALL THE GOOD
TIMES?

I MEAN, LOOK AT THIS DEERHAT. WHAT MEMORIES . . . DUDLEY PLUCKED
HIS IT AFTER I SAVED HIM FROM THE DEMENTHES. . . , TURNS OUT HE WAS

GRATEFUL AFTER ALL, CAN YOU BELIEVE IT? . . . AND LAST SUMMER, DUMBLE-
DORE WALKED THROUGH THAT FRONT DOOR, . . .

HARRY LOST THE THREAD OF HIS THOUGHTS FOR A MOMENT AND HERMIE
DID NOTHING TO HELP HIM RETRIEVE IT, BUT CONTINUED THE SIT WITH HER
HEAD UNDER HER WING. HARRY TURNED HIS BACK ON THE FRONT DOOR.

AND UNDER HERE, HERMIE HARRY PULLED OPEN A DOOR UNDER
THE STAIRS IS WHERE I USED TO SLEEP! YOU NEVER KNEW ME THEN

KLIMEX, IT'S SMALL, I'D FORGOTTEN, . . .

HARRY LOOKED AROUND AT THE STACKED SHEETS AND UMBRELLAS, RE-
MEMBERING HOW HE USED TO WAKE EVERY MORNING LOOKING UP AT THE

UNDERSIDE OF THE STAIRCASE, WHICH WAS MORE OFTEN THAN NOT ADORNED
WITH A SPIDER OR TWO. THESE HAD BEEN THE DAYS BEFORE HE HAD KNOWN
ANYTHING ABOUT HIS TRUE IDENTITY; BEFORE HE HAD FOUND OUT HOW
HIS

PARENTS HAD DIED AND WHY SUCH STRANGE THINGS OFTEN HAPPENED
AROUND

HIM. BUT HARRY COULD STILL REMEMBER THE DREAMS THAT HAD HIGGED
HIM, EVEN IN THESE DAYS: CHAOTIC DREAMS INVOLVING FLASHES OF
GREEN

LIGHT AND HEAR UNCLE VERNON HAD NEARLY CRASHED THE CAR WHEN
HARRY HAD RECALCITRATED IT A FLYING METERMETER, . . .

THERE WAS A SUDDEN, DRAVENING RUMOR FROM SOMEWHERE NEARBY.

HARRY STRAIGHTENED UP WITH A JERK AND SMACKED THE TOP OF HIS
HEAD

THE SEVEN PEETTERS

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WHEN THE LEAD DEER FRAMZ, PALISING ONLY THE EMPLOY A FEW OF LINDLE
VERNEEN'S CHEEKEST SWEAR WORDS, HE STAGGERED BACK INTO THE
KITCHEN,

CLUTCHING HIS HEAD AND STARING BLIT OF THE WINDHILL INTO THE BACK
GARDEN.

THE DARKNESS SEEMED TO BE RIPPLING, THE AIR ITSELF BULYERING.
THEN,

ONE BY ONE, FIGURES BEGAN TO PEER INTO SIGHT AS THEIR
DISILLUSIONMENT

CHARMS LIFTED, DEMINATING THE SCENE WAS FLAGRID, WEARING A HELMET
AND GOGGLES AND SITTING ASTRIDE AN ENHIRMELIS MEETHEKID WITH A
BLACK

SIDELAR ATTACHED. ALL AROUND HIM OTHER PEOPLE WERE DISMELLING
FROM KREHMIS AND, IN TWO CASES, SKELETAL, BLACK WINGED HORSES.

WRENCHING OPEN THE BACK DEER, HARRY FLIRTLED INTO THEIR MIDST.

THERE WAS A GENERAL CRY OF GREETING AS HERMIEKE FLING HER ARMS
AROUND HIM, BEN CLAPPED HIM ON THE BACK, AND FLAGRID SAID, ALL
RIGHT, HARRY? READY FOR THE HPP?

DEFINITELY, SAID HARRY, BEAMING AROUND AT THEM ALL. BUT I
WASN'T EXPECTING THIS MANY OF YELLY

CHANGE OF PLAN, GRIELED MAD-LYE, WHO WAS HOLDING TWO ENHIRMELIS,
KILGING SACKS, AND WHOSE MAGICAL EYE WAS SPINNING FROM

DARKENING SKY THE FLOODS THE GARDEN WITH DIZZING RAPIDITY. LET S
GET

LINDERCHER BEHRE WE TALK WELL THROUGH IT.

HARRY LED THEM ALL BACK INTO THE KITCHEN WHERE, LAUGHING AND
CHATTERING, THEY SETTLED IN CHAIRS, SAT THEMSELVES UPON ALINT
PETLINIA S

GLAMING WERE SLIPACES, HER LEANED UP AGAINST HER SPOTLESS
APPLIANCES:

REEN, LEUNG AND LANDY; HERMINE, HER BLISSY HAIR TIED BACK IN A
LEUNG

PLAIT; FRED AND GEORGE, GRINNING IDENTICALLY; BILL, RABLY SCARRED AND
LEUNG-HAIRED; MR. WEASLEY, BIRD-FACED, BALDING, HIS SPECTACLES A LITTLE
ALRY; MAD-EYE, RATTLE-WEIRD, HINE-LEGGED, HIS BRIGHT BLUE MAGICAL
EYE WHIZZING IN ITS SOCKET; TENDS, WEHSE SHEET HAIR WAS HER
FAVORITE

SHADE OF BRIGHT PINK; LUPIN, GRAYER, MORE LINED; FLEUR, SLENDER AND

CHAPTER FELLER

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BEAUTIFUL, WITH HER LEUNG SILVERY BLONDE HAIR; KINGLEY, BALD, BLACK,
BROAD-SHOULDERED; JACOB, WITH HIS WILD HAIR AND BEARD, STANDING

BLINK-BACKED THE AYHID HITTING HIS HEAD ON THE CEILING; AND MIN-
DLINGS FLETCHER, SMALL, DIRTY, AND HANGING, WITH HIS DREDDY BASSSET

FEELING HIS EYES AND MATTED HAIR, HARRY'S HEART SEEMED TO EXPAND AND

GLOW AT THE SIGHT! HE FELT INCREDIBLY PLEASANT TO ALL OF THEM, EVEN
MURDO-

WINGS, WHOM HE HAD TRIED TO STRANGLE THE LAST TIME THEY HAD MET.

KINGSLEY, I THOUGHT YOU WERE LOOKING AFTER THE MUGGLE PRIME
MINISTER? HE CALLED ACROSS THE ROOM.

HE CAN GET ALONG WITHOUT ME FOR ONE NIGHT, SAID KINGSLEY,
YOU'RE MORE IMPORTANT.

HARRY, GLASS WHAT? SAID THINGS FROM HER PERCH ON TOP OF THE

WASHING MACHINE, AND SHE WIGGLED HER LEFT HAND AT HIM; A RING
GLIT-

TERED THERE.

YOU GET MARRIED? HARRY YELPED, LEAVING FROM HER THE SLIP IN.

I'M SORRY YOU COULDN'T BE THERE, HARRY, IT WAS VERY QUIET.

THAT'S BRILLIANT, CONGRAT

ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, WE'LL HAVE TIME FOR A CHEERY CATCH-UP LATER!

HEARD MURDO OVER THE FENCE, AND SILENCE FELL IN THE KITCHEN.

MURDO DROPPED HIS SACKS AT HIS FEET AND TURNED TO HARRY. AS
DEDA-

WAS PROBABLY TOLD YOU, WE HAD THE ABANDONED PLAN A, PILLS THICKNESS

HAS GONE AWAY, WHICH GIVES US A BIG PROBLEM. HE'S MADE IT AN
IMPRIS-

ENABLE OFFENSE TO COUNTER THIS THREAT TO THE BLUE NETWORK, PLACE A

PORTAL HERE, AND APPARATE IN THE HILL, ALL DONE IN THE NAME OF
YELL

PROTECTION, TO PREVENT YELL-DONALD-LEIGH GETTING IN AT YELL,
ABSOLUTELY

POINTLESS, SEEING AS YELL'S MOTHER'S CHARM DOES THAT ALREADY, WHAT
HE'S REALLY DONE IS THE STEP YELL GETTING HILT OF HERE SAFELY.

SECOND PROBLEM: YELL IS LINGERING, WHICH MEANS YELL IS STILL ON
THE TRACE IN YELL.

THE SEVEN PETERS

???

I DON'T

THE TRACE, THE TRACE! SAID MAD-EYE IMPATIENTLY. THE CHARM
THAT DETECTS MAGICAL ACTIVITY AROUND LINGER-SEVENTEENS, THE WAY
THE

MINISTRY FINDS HILT AROUND LINGERAGE MAGIC! IF YELL, OR ANYONE
AROUND

YELL, CASTS A SPELL TO GET YELL HILT OF HERE, THICKNESS IS GOING TO
KNOW

ABOUT IT, AND SHE WILL BE DEATH RATHER.

WE CAN'T WAIT FOR THE TRACE TO BREAK, BECAUSE THE MOMENT YELL
TURNS SEVENTEEN YELL WILL LOSE ALL THE PROTECTION YELL'S MOTHER GAVE
YELL.

IN SHORT: POOR THICKNESS THINKS HE'S GOT YELL CORNERED GOOD AND

PROPER,

HARRY COULD NOT HELP BUT AGREE WITH THE LONDONIAN THICKNESS.

SEE WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO?

WE'RE GOING TO USE THE ONLY MEANS OF TRANSPORT LEFT TO US, THE ONLY MEANS THE TRACE CAN'T DETECT, BECAUSE WE DON'T NEED THE LAST SPELLS

THE USE THEM: GHOSTS, THESTRALS, AND HAGRID'S METERIDGE.

HARRY COULD SEE FLAWS IN THIS PLAN; HOWEVER, HE HELD HIS TONGUE

GIVE MAD-EYE THE CHANCE TO ADDRESS THEM.

WELL, YOUR METERIDGE'S CHARM WILL ONLY BREAK UNDER TWO CONDITIONS:

WHEN YOU COME OF AGE, OR WHEN MURDER IS COMMITTED WITHIN THE PRISTINE KITCHEN. YOU NO LONGER CALL THIS PLACE HOME. YOU AND YOUR ALONE

AND LIKE ARE GOING YOUR SEPARATE WAYS TONIGHT, IN THE FULL LIGHT-

STANDING THAT YOU'RE NEVER GOING TO LIVE TOGETHER AGAIN, CORRECT?

HARRY NEEDED,

SEE THIS TIME, WHEN YOU LEAVE, THERE WILL BE NO GOING BACK, AND THE

CHARM WILL BREAK THE MOMENT YOU GET OUTSIDE ITS RANGE. WE'RE CHAS-

ING TO BREAK IT EARLY, BECAUSE THE ALTERNATIVE IS WAITING FOR YOU TO

WHEN THE CHARM AND SEIZE YOU THE MOMENT YOU TURN SEVENTEEN.

THE ONE THING WE'VE GOT ON OUR SIDE IS THAT YELL-DWELL-WHIE
DIDN'T KNOW WE'RE MOVING YELL TONIGHT. WE'VE LEAVED A FAKE TRAIL

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

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THE THE MINISTRY! THEY THINK YELL ARE NOT LEAVING UNTIL THE
THIRTIETH.

HOWEVER, THIS IS YELL-DWELL-WHIE WE'RE DEALING WITH, SEE WE CAN'T
JUST

RELY ON HIM GETTING THE DATE WRONG; HE'S BEHIND THE HAVY A CHURCH
OF

DEATH EATERS PATROLLING THE STREETS IN THIS GENERAL AREA, JUST IN
CASE, SEE.

WE'VE GIVEN A DOZEN DIFFERENT LIES EVERY PRETEXT WE CAN
THINK

AT THEM. THEY ALL SOUND LIKE THEY COULD BE THE PLACE WE'RE GOING TO
HIDE YELL. THEY'VE ALL GOT SOME CONNECTION WITH THE ORDER: MY
HOUSE,

KINGSLEY'S PLACE, MERRY'S AUNTIE MURIEL'S YELL GOT THE IDEA.

Yeah, said Harry, not entirely truthfully, because he could still
spot a gaping hole in the plan.

YELL WILL BE GOING TO THE TOWN'S PARENTS, SINCE YELL ARE WITHIN THE
BOUNDARIES OF THE PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS WE'VE PUT ON THEIR
HOUSE,

YELL WILL BE ABLE TO USE A PORTKEY TO THE BURIAL AND BURIALS?

Oh yes, said Harry. Maybe they won't know which OF THE

TWELVE SECURE HELICES I'M HEADING FOR AT FIRST, BUT WHEN T IT BE SHORT
OF

HEAVILY ENCE HE PERFORMED A HELIX HEADCLINT FOURTEEN OF
LIS FLY OFF TOWARD THENDS S PARENTS ?

AH, SAID MEEH, I MIGHT MENTION THE KEY POINT, FOURTEEN
OF LIS WHEN T BE FLYING THE THENDS S PARENTS , THERE WILL BE SEVEN
HARRY

PITTERS MOVING THROUGH THE SKIES TONIGHT, EACH OF THEM WITH A
CHEM-

PARTHEN, EACH PAIR HEADING FOR A DIFFERENT SAFE HELICE.

FROM INSIDE HIS CHAM MEEH NOW WITHDREW A GLASS OF WHAT
LOOKED LIKE MILK. THERE WAS NO NEED FOR HIM TO SAY ANOTHER WORD;
HARRY UNDERSTOOD THE REST OF THE PLAN IMMEDIATELY.

NO! HE SAID LOUDLY, HIS VOICE RINGING THROUGH THE KITCHEN. NO
WAY!

I TOLD THEM YOU'D TAKE IT LIKE THIS, SAID HERMINE WITH A HINT
OF COMPLACENCY.

IF YOU THINK I'M GOING TO LET SIX PEOPLE RISK THEIR LIVES :

THE SEVEN PITTERS

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BECAUSE IT'S THE FIRST TIME FOR ALL OF LIS, SAID BEN.

THIS IS DIFFERENT, PRETENDING TO BE ME

WELL, NONE OF LIS REALLY FANCY IT, HARRY, SAID FRED EARNESTLY.

IMAGINE IF SOMETHING WENT WRONG AND WE WERE STUCK AS SPECKS,
STRAWING GITS FOREVER.

HARRY DID NOT SMILE.

YOU CAN'T DO IT IF I DON'T COOPERATE, YOU NEED ME TO GIVE YOU
SOME HAIR.

WELL, THAT'S THAT PLAN SLIPPED, SAID GEORGE. HEAVILY
THERE'S NO CHANCE AT ALL OF HIS GETTING A BIT OF YOUR HAIR UNLESS
YOU
COOPERATE.

Yeah, THIRTEEN OF HIS AGAINST ONE BLEED WITH A NOT ALLOWED THE USE
MAGIC, WE'VE GOT NO CHANCE, SAID FRED.

FLINDY, SAID HARRY, REALLY AMUSING.

IF IT HAS THE CHANCE TO WIN, THEN IT WILL, GROWLED MURDOX, HIS
MAGICAL EYE NOW BELIEVING A LITTLE IN ITS SECRET AS HE GLARED AT
HARRY.

EVERYONE HERE'S BEYOND, BETTER, AND THEY'RE ALL PREPARED TO
TAKE

THE RISK.

MURDOX'S SHRIEKED AND GRIMACED, THE MAGICAL EYE STARED
SIDELWAYS TO GLARE AT HIM FROM THE SIDE OF MURDOX'S HEAD.

LET'S HAVE NO MORE ARGUMENTS, TIME'S WEARING ON, I WANT A FEW
OF YOUR HAIRS, NOW, NOW.

BUT THIS IS MAD, THERE'S NO NEED

NO NEED! SNARLED MURDOX, WITH YOUR OWN EYES YOU KNOW THERE
AND HALF THE MINISTRY ON HIS SIDE? BETTER, IF WE'RE LUCKY HE'LL
HAVE

SWALLOWED THE BAIT AND HE'LL BE PLANNING THE AMERICAN YOU ON
THE THIRTIETH, BUT HE'D BE MAD NOT TO HAVE A DEATH LATER FOR THEM

KEEPING AN EYE HLIT, IT S WHAT I D DEE, THEY MIGHT NOT BE ABLE TH GET
AT YELL HER THIS HOUSE WHILE YELLER MEET-HER S CHARM FIELDS, BUT IT S
ABEHLIT

CHAPTER FELLER

SO

THE BREAD AND THEY KNOW THE RIGHT POSITION OF THE PLACE, FELLER
ONLY

CHANCE IS THE LIKE DEEDS, EVEN YELL-KNEEL-WH CAN T SPLIT HIMSELF
INTE SEVEN,

HARRY CALIGHT HERMINE S EYE AND LEEDED AWAY AT HENCE,

SEE, PETER SOME OF YELLER HAIR, IF YELL PLEASE,

HARRY GLANCED AT REIN, WH GRIMACED AT HIM IN A ILST-DE-IT SEET
OF WAY,

NEEL: KARKED MHHOY,

WITH ALL OF THEIR EYES LIPEN HIM, HARRY REACHED UP THE THE THP OF
HIS HEAD, GRABED A HAND OF HAIR, AND PULLED,

CHHO, SAID MHHOY, LIMPING FORWARD AS HE PULLED THE STEPPER
HLIT OF THE PLASD OF PETIEN, STRAIGHT IN HERE, IF YELL PLEASE,

HARRY DREPPED THE HAIR INTE THE MLBLIKE LIHLID, THE MEMENT IT
MADE CONTACT WITH ITS SURFACE, THE PETIEN BEGAN THE PRETH AND
SMHKE,

THEN, ALL AT HENCE, IT TURNED A CLEAR, KRIGHT CHHO,

HEH, YELL LEEDS MUCH TASTIER THAN CRACK AND CHOLE, HARRY, SAID
HERMINE, BEFORE CATCHING SIGHT OF REIN S RAISED EYEBRELS,
BLUSHING

SLIGHTLY, AND SAYING, EH, YELL KNOW WHAT I MEAN. PEOPLE'S
PETITION

MINDED LIKE KEGS.

RIGHT THEN, FIVE PETERS LINE UP OVER HERE, PLEASE, SAID MEEDY,
HEN, HERMINE, FRED, GEORGE, AND FLEUR LINE UP IN FRONT OF
ALICE PETLINIA'S CLEANING SINK.

WE'RE HERE SHORT, SAID LUPIN.

HERE, SAID HAGRID GRUFFLY, AND HE LIFTED MUNDLING'S BY THE

SCUFF OF THE NECK AND DROPPED HIM DOWN BESIDE FLEUR, WHO WRIN-
KLED HER NOSE PHINTEDLY AND MOVED ALONG THE STAND BETWEEN FRED

AND GEORGE INSTEAD.

I'VE TOLD YOU, I'D SHOWER BE A PROTECTOR, SAID MUNDLING'S.

SHE IT, GRIELED MEEDY, AS I'VE ALREADY TOLD YOU, YOU SPINELESS

THE SEVEN PETERS

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WHEN, AND DEATH EATERS WE RUN INTO WILL BE AIMING THE CAPTURE
PET-

TER, NOT KILL HIM. DUMKLEHORE ALWAYS SAID YOU-KNOW-WHEN WE'D

WANT THE FINISH PETER IN PERSON. IT'LL BE THE PROTECTORS WHO HAVE
GET

THE MOST THE WHOLEY ABOUT, THE DEATH EATERS WILL WANT THE KILL THEM.

MUNDLING'S DID NOT SEEM PARTICULARLY REASSURED, BUT MEEDY WAS

ALREADY PULLING HALF A DOZEN EGGLIP-SIZED GLASSES FROM INSIDE HIS
COAT, WHICH HE HANDED OUT, BEFORE POURING A LITTLE PEACHY
PETTIN

INTO EACH ONE.

TOGETHER, THEN . . .

RENN, HERMINE, FRED, GEORGE, FELIX, AND MINDLIN'S BRAND.

ALL OF THEM GASPED AND GRIMACED AS THE PETTIN HIT THEIR THROATS:

AT ONCE, THEIR FEATURES BECAME THE BLUE AND DISTANT LIKE FET LAX.

HERMINE AND MINDLIN WERE SWEETING UPWARD; RENN, FRED, AND

GEORGE WERE SHRINKING; THEIR HAIR WAS DARKENING, HERMINE'S
AND

FELIX'S APPEARING TO SWEET BACKWARD INTO THEIR SKULLS.

MENDY, WHITE LINCINNED, WAS NOW LOOSENING THE TIES OF THE
LARGE SACKS HE HAD BRUGHT WITH HIM. WHEN HE STRAIGHTENED UP
AGAIN, THERE WERE SIX HARRY PETERS GASPING AND PANTING IN
FRONT

OF HIM.

FRED AND GEORGE TURNED TO EACH OTHER AND SAID TOGETHER, WHEN

WE'RE IDENTICAL?

I DON'T, THOUGH, I THINK I'M STILL BETTER-LOOKING, SAID FRED,
EXAMINING HIS REFLECTION IN THE KETTLE.

RAH, SAID FELIX, CHECKING HERSELF IN THE MICROWAVE OVEN. KILL,
DON'T LOOK AT ME I'M IDEAL.

THESE WHITE CLOTHES ARE A BIT BUNCHY, I'VE GOTT SMALLER HERE, SAID
MENDY, INDICATING THE FIRST SACK, AND VICE VERSA. DON'T FORGET THE
GLASSES, THERE'S SIX PAIRS IN THE SIDE POCKET. AND WHEN YOU'RE
DRESSED,

THERE'S LUGGAGE IN THE OTHER SACK.

CHAPTER FELLER

52

THE REAL HARRY THOUGHT THAT THIS MIGHT JUST BE THE MOST BIZARRE THING HE HAD EVER SEEN, AND HE HAD SEEN SOME EXTREMELY odd THINGS.

HE WATCHED AS HIS SIX DUFFELCANGERS RUMMAGED IN THE SACKS, PULLING OUT SETS OF CLOTHES, PUTTING ON GLASSES, STOPPING THEIR OWN THINGS

AWAY. HE FELT LIKE ASKING THEM TO SHOW A LITTLE MORE RESPECT FOR HIS

PRIVACY AS THEY ALL BEGAN STRIPPING OFF WITH IMPUNITY, CLEARLY MUCH

MORE AT EASE WITH DISPLAYING HIS BODY THAN THEY WOULD HAVE BEEN WITH THEIR OWN.

I KNOW GINNY WAS LYING ABOUT THAT TATTOO, SAID RICH, LEERING DOWN AT HIS BARE CHEST.

HARRY, YOUR EYESIGHT REALLY IS AWFUL, SAID FERMINE, AS SHE PUT ON GLASSES.

THEN DRESSED, THE PAIR HARRYS THEN ROLLSACKS AND HILL BAGS, EACH CONTAINING A STUFFED SNELLY HILL, FROM THE SECOND SACK.

GOOD, SAID MERRY, AS AT LAST SEVEN DRESSED, RESPECTABLE, AND LUGGAGE-LOADED HARRYS FACED HIM. THE PAIRS WILL BE AS FOLLOWS:

MURDUNGLIS WILL BE TRAVELING WITH ME, BY BRRRR

WELL I WITH VERN GRANTED THE HARRY NEAREST THE BACK DOOR.

BECAUSE THEY'RE THE ONE THAT NEEDS WATCHING, GROWLED MURPHY,
AND SURPRISE ENOUGH, HIS MAGICAL EYE DID NOT WAVER FROM MUNDLING'S
AS HE CONTINUED, ARTHUR AND FRED

I'M GEORGE, SAID THE TWIN AT WHOM MURPHY WAS POINTING, CAN'T
THEY EVEN TELL US APART WHEN WE'RE HARRY?

SHRUG, GEORGE

I'M ONLY HANDLING THEIR WAND, I'M FRED REALLY

ENOUGH MESSING AROUND? SPARKED MURPHY, THE EITHER ONE
GEORGE OR FRED OR WHATEVER THEY ARE THEY'RE WITH REMUS, MISS
BLAKE

THE SEVEN PETERS

SE

I'M TAKING FLEUR ON A THEATRICAL, SAID BILL, SHE'S NOT THAT KIND
OF KIDNEY,

FLEUR WALKED OVER THE STAND BESIDE HIM, GIVING HIM A SHY, SLAV-
ISH SMILE THAT HARRY HOPED WITH ALL HIS HEART WOULD NEVER
APPEAR ON

HIS FACE AGAIN,

MISS GRANGER WITH KINGSLEY, AGAIN BY THEATRICAL

HERMIONE SMILED REASSURED AS SHE ANSWERED KINGSLEY'S SMILE,
HARRY

KNEW THAT HERMIONE THEN LACKED CONFIDENCE IN A KIDNEY,

WHICH LEAVES YELL AND MR. RENN: SAID THINGS RIGHTLY, KNOWING
EVER A MILE TREE AS SHE WAVED AT HIM.

RENN DID NOT LEAVE WHITE AS PLEASED AS FERMINE.

AND YELL BE WITH MR. HARRY, THAT ALL RIGHT? SAID LACED,
LOOKING

A LITTLE ANXIOUS. WE LL BE IN THE RIDE, KREMS AND TERSTRALS CAN T
TAKE ME WEIGHT, SEE. NOT A LIT IN THEM IN THE SEAT WITH ME IN IT,
THOUGH, SEE YELL LL BE IN THE SIDECAR.

THAT S GREAT, SAID HARRY, NOT ALTOGETHER TRULY-LY.

WE THINK THE DEATH EATERS WILL EXPECT YELL TH BE IN A KREMS,
SAID MERRY, WE SEEMED THE GLASS YELL HARRY WAS FEELING. SNARE S

HAD PLENTY OF TIME TO TELL THEM EVERYTHING ABOUT YELL HE S NEVER
MEN-

THINKED BEHIND, SEE IF WE BE IN IN THE AND DEATH EATERS, WE BE GETTING

THEY LL CHASE ME OF THE PITTERS WE SEEM AT HOME IN A
KREMSSTICK.

ALL RIGHT THEN, HE WENT IN, TYING UP THE SACK WITH THE FINE
PITTERS

CLOTHES IN IT AND LEADING THE WAY BACK TO THE DEER. I MADE IT THREE
MINUTES UNTIL WE BE SLIPPED THE LEAVE. NOT PHANT LOOKING THE BACK
DEER, IT WENT T KEEP THE DEATH EATERS OUT WHEN THEY CAME LOOKING.
... CAME IN, ...

HARRY HURRIED INTO THE HALL TO FETCH HIS RUCKSACK, FIREWEED, AND
FEDWIG S CAGE BEFORE JOINING THE OTHERS IN THE DARK BACK GARDEN.

CHAPTER FELLER

ON EVERY SIDE KNEEMSTICKS WERE LEAPING INTO HANDS; FERMINEK HAD ALREADY BEEN HELPED UP INTO A GREAT BLACK THESTRAL BY KINGSLY, FLEW INTO THE OTHER BY KILL. HAGRID WAS STANDING READY BESIDE THE METERCYCLE, CHECKS HIM.

IS THIS IT? IS THIS SIRILIS S KID?

THE VERY SAME, SAID HAGRID, BEAMING DOWN AT HARRY. ON THE LAST TIME YOU WAS IN IT, HARRY, I COULD FIT YOU IN ONE HAND!

HARRY COULD NOT HELP BUT FEEL A LITTLE HUMILIATED AS HE GOT INTO THE SIDELAR. IT PLACED HIM SEVERAL FEET BELOW EVERYBODY ELSE: BEN SMIRKED AT THE SIGHT OF HIM SITTING THERE LIKE A CHILD IN A KIMPER CAR, HARRY STUFFED HIS RUCKSACK AND KNEEMSTICK DOWN BY HIS FEET AND RAMMED FREDIE S CASE BETWEEN HIS KNEES. IT WAS EXTREMELY UNCOMFORTABLE.

ARTHUR S BENE A KIT EE TINDERIN, SAID HAGRID, WHITE EYESHEDS THE HARRY S DISCOMFORT. HE SETTLED HIMSELF ASTRIDE THE METERCYCLE, WHICH CREAKED SLIGHTLY AND SANK INCHES INTO THE GRIND. IT S GOT A

FEW TRICKS UP ITS HANDLEBARS NEH. THE ONE WAS MY IDEA.

HE POINTED A THICK FINGER AT A PURPLE BLOTCH NEAR THE SPEED-METER.

PLEASE BE CAREFUL, HAGRID, SAID MR. WEASLEY, WHO WAS STANDING BESIDE THEM, HOLDING HIS KNEEMSTICK. I M STILL NOT SURE THAT WAS

ADVISABLE AND IT IS CERTAINLY ONLY TO BE USED IN EMERGENCIES.

ALL RIGHT THEN, SAID MURPHY. EVERYONE READY, PLEASE? I WANT US ALL TO LEAVE AT EXACTLY THE SAME TIME ON THE WHEEL POINT OF THE DIVERSITY'S LIST.

EVERYBODY MOUNTED THEIR BIKES.

HOLD TIGHT NOW, BEN, SAID TERRY, AND HARRY SAW BEN THROW A FLUTTER, GUILTY LOOK AT LUPIN BEFORE PLACING HIS HANDS ON EITHER SIDE

THE SEVEN PETERS

SS

ON HER WAIST, HARRY KICKED THE METERKICK INTO LIFE! IT REARED LIKE A

DRAGON, AND THE SIDEAR BEGAN TO VIBRATE.

GOOD LUCK, EVERYONE, SHOUTED MURPHY. SEE YOU ALL IN ABOUT AN HOUR AT THE BURNING, ON THE POINT OF THREE, FIVE . . . TWO . . . THREE.

THERE WAS A GREAT RUMOR FROM THE METERKICK, AND HARRY FELT THE SIDEAR GIVE A NASTY BUNCH: HE WAS RISING THROUGH THE AIR FAST, HIS

EYES WATERING SLIGHTLY, HAIR WHIPPED BACK OFF HIS FACE, AROUND HIM BIKES WERE SHARING UPWARD THEM: THE LONG BLACK TAIL OF A TERSTRAL FLICKED PAST, HIS LEGS, LAMMED INTO THE SIDEAR BY FRED'S LACE AND HIS RUCKSACK, WERE ALREADY THERE AND STARTING TO GO NUTS. SEE GREAT WAS HIS DISCOMFORT THAT HE ALMOST FORGOT TO TAKE A LAST GLIMPSE OF NIMMER AILIN, PRIVET DRIVE; BY THE TIME HE LOOKED OVER THE EDGE OF

THE SIDELAR HE COULD NO LONGER TELL WHICH ONE IT WAS, FASTER AND FASTER THEY CLIMBED INTO THE SKY

AND THEN, BLIT HE NEELHERE, BLIT HE NETHING, THEY WERE SURROUNDED, AT LEAST THIRTY HUNDRED FIGURES, SUSPENDED IN MIDAIR, FORMED A VAST CIRCLE IN THE MIDST OF WHICH THE ORDER MEMBERS HAD RISEN, HELIVIELIS

SCREAMS, A BLAZE OF GREEN LIGHT ON EVERY SIDE: HAGRID GAVE A YELL AND THE MEETHERIDE REELLED BACK, HARRY LOST ANY SENSE OF WHERE THEY WERE: STREETLIGHTS ABOVE HIM, YELLS AROUND HIM, HE WAS CLINGING TO

THE SIDELAR FOR DEAR LIFE, HEDWIG'S CAGE, THE FIREHAT, AND HIS RUCKSACK SLIPPED FROM BENEATH HIS KNEES

NO HEDWIG!

THE BREMMSTICK SPUN THE EARTH, BLIT HE JUST MANAGED TO SEIZE THE STRAP OF HIS RUCKSACK AND THE TOP OF THE CAGE AS THE MEETHERIDE

SWUNG THE RIGHT WAY UP AGAIN, A SECOND'S RELIEF, AND THEN ANOTHER

CHAPTER FELLER

SE

BLIT OF GREEN LIGHT, THE HELL SCREECHED AND FELL TO THE FLOOR OF THE CAGE,

NO NEE!

THE MOTHERKIDZ ZOOMED FORWARD; HARRY GLIMPSED HUNDRED DEATH-
EATERS SCATTERING AS HAGRID BLASTED THROUGH THEIR CIRCLE.

FREDWIG FREDWIG

BUT THE HULL LAY MENTIONLESS AND PATHETIC AS A THING IN THE FLAMES OF
HER CAGE. HE COULD NOT TAKE IT IN, AND HIS TERROR FOR THE OTHERS
WAS

PARAMOUNT. HE GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER AND SAW A MASS OF
PEOPLE

MOVING, FLARES OF GREEN LIGHT, TWO PAIRS OF PEOPLE IN ROBES
SHARING

OFF INTO THE DISTANCE, BUT HE COULD NOT TELL WHO THEY WERE

HAGRID, WE'VE GOT THEM BACK, WE'VE GOT THEM BACK! HE YELLED

OVER THE THUNDEROUS ROAR OF THE ENGINE, PULLING OUT HIS WAND,
RAM-

MING FREDWIG'S CAGE BENT THE FLAME, REFUSING THE BELIEF THAT SHE
WAS

DEAD. HAGRID, TURN AROUND!

MY JOB IS TO GET THEM THERE SAFE, HARRY! REPLIED HAGRID, AND
HE OPENED THE THROTTLE.

STEP STEP! HARRY SHOUTED, BUT AS HE LEANED BACK AGAIN
TWO BOTS OF GREEN LIGHT FLEW PAST HIS LEFT EAR: FLEW DEATH EATERS
HAD

BROKEN AWAY FROM THE CIRCLE AND WERE PURSUING THEM, AIMING FOR
HAGRID'S BREAST BACK. HAGRID SWERVED, BUT THE DEATH EATERS WERE
KEEPING UP WITH THE KID; MORE CURSES SENT AFTER THEM, AND HARRY
HAD THE SINK LEEV INTO THE SIDELAR THE AVOID THEM, WRIGGLING AROUND

HE CRIED, 'STUPID!' AND A RED BOLT OF LIGHT SHOT FROM HIS WAND,

CREATING A GAP BETWEEN THE FLEET PURSUING DEATH EATERS AS THEY

ENTERED THE AVHID IT.

HEARD HIM, HARRY, THIS LL BE FOR YOU! HEARD HARRY, AND HARRY
LOOKED UP JUST IN TIME TO SEE HARRY SLAMMING A THICK FINGER INTO
A GREEN BUTTON NEAR THE FLIGHT GEAR.

THE SEVEN PETERS

BY

A WALL, A SHED BRICK WALL, ERUPTED OUT OF THE EXHAUST PIPE. CRAN-
ING HIS NECK, HARRY SAW IT EXPAND INTO A RING IN MIDAIR. THREE OF
THE

DEATH EATERS SWERVED AND AVOIDED IT, BUT THE FLEET WAS NOT SEE
LIDY!

HE VANISHED FROM VIEW AND THEN DROPPED LIKE A BOMBER FROM
BEHIND

IT, HIS BOMBSTICK CRACKED INTO PIECES, ONE OF HIS FELLIES SHOOK UP
THE

SAVE HIM, BUT THEY AND THE AIRBORNE WALL WERE SWALLOWED BY
DARKNESS

AS HARRY LEANED WELL OVER THE HANDLES AND SPED UP.

MORE KILLING CURSES FLEW PAST HARRY'S HEAD FROM THE TWO REMAINING DEATH EATERS' HANDS; THEY WERE AIMING FOR HAGRID. HARRY

RESPONDED WITH FURTHER STUNNING SPELLS: RED AND GREEN COLLIDED IN MIDAIR IN A SHOWER OF MULTICOLOURED SPARKS, AND HARRY THREATENED WILDLY

THE FIREWORKS, AND THE MUGGLES BEHIND THEM WOULD HAVE NO IDEA WHAT WAS HAPPENING

HERE WE GO AGAIN, HARRY, HOLD ON! YELLED HAGRID, AND HE LAUNCHED

AT A SECOND KITTEN. THIS TIME A GREAT NET BURST FROM THE RIDGE'S EXHAUST, BUT THE DEATH EATERS WERE READY FOR IT. NOT ONLY DID THEY

SWERVE TO AVOID IT, BUT THE COMPANION WHO HAD SHOWN THEM SAW THEIR

WITCHENSTEWART'S FRIEND HAD CALLED UP. HE BLINKED SUDDENLY OUT OF THE DARKNESS AND WHEN THREE OF THEM WERE PURSUING THE MOTHERKID, ALL SHOOTING CURSES AFTER IT.

THIS IS IT, HARRY, HOLD ON TIGHT! YELLED HAGRID, AND HARRY SAW HIM SLAM HIS WHOLE HAND BENTH THE PURPLE KITTEN BESIDE THE SPEEDOMETER.

WITH AN UNMISTAKABLE BELLEWING ROAR, DRAGON FIRE BURST FROM THE EXHAUST, WHITE-HEAT AND BLUE, AND THE MOTHERKID SHOT FORWARD LIKE A

BULLET WITH A SWING OF WRENCHING METAL. HARRY SAW THE DEATH EATERS SWERVE OUT OF SIGHT TO AVOID THE DEADLY TRAIL OF FLAME, AND AT THE

SAME TIME FELT THE SIDELAR SLAY HEMISELSLY: ITS METAL CONNECTIONS
THE

THE RIDE HAD SPLINTERED WITH THE FORCE OF ACCELERATION.

CHAPTER FELLER

XX

IT S ALL RIGHT , HARRY? BELIEVED HAGRID, NEW THREEIN PLAT HENTH HIS
BACK BY THE SLURGE OF SPEED; NERKED WAS STEERING NEW, AND THE
SIDELAR

WAS STARTING THE TWIST VIOLENTLY IN THE RIDE S SLIPSTREAM.

I M EN IT, HARRY, DEN WHIRRY? HAGRID YELLED, AND FROM INSIDE
HIS JACKET PHECKET HE PULLED HIS FLEHVERY PINK UMBRELLA.

HAGRID? DEN? LET ME?

REPAIRS?

THERE WAS A DEAFENING BANG AND THE SIDELAR BROKE AWAY FROM THE
RIDE COMPLETELY: HARRY SPED FORWARD, PREPULLED BY THE IMPETUS OF
THE RIDE S FLIGHT, THEN THE SIDELAR BEGAN THE LONG HEIGHT

IN DESPERATION HARRY POINTED HIS WAND AT THE SIDELAR AND SHOUTED,

WINGARDIUM LEVIOSA?

THE SIDELAR ROSE LIKE A CHORD, UNSTEERABLE BUT AT LEAST STILL
AIRBORNE:

HE HAD BUT A SPLIT SECOND S RELIEF, HOWEVER, AS MORE CLUSTERS STREAKED
PAST HIM: THE THREE DEATH EATERS WERE CLOSING IN.

I M GEMIN , HARRY? HAGRID YELLED FROM BLIT OF THE DARKNESS, BUT

HARRY COULD FEEL THE SIDECAR BEGINNING THE SINK AGAIN! CREEPING AS

WELL AS HE COULD, HE POINTED AT THE MIDDLE OF THE HUNCHING FIGURES AND YELLED, IMPEDIMENTA!

THE HUNK HIT THE MIDDLE DEATH-LATER IN THE CHEST! FOR A MOMENT THE MAN WAS ABSURDLY SPREAD-EAGLED IN MIDAIR AS THOUGH HE HAD HIT AN INVISIBLE BARRIER: ONE OF HIS PELLELS ALMOST COLLIDED WITH HIM

THEN THE SIDECAR BEGAN THE FALL IN EARNEST, AND THE REMAINING DEATH-LATER SEEMED A CLIPSE SEE CLIPSE THE HARRY THAT HE HAD THE BLICK BELIEF

THE RIM OF THE CAR, DROPPING HELT A THETHEN THE EDGE OF HIS SEAT

I M CHIN, HARRY, I M CHIN !

A FLICK HAND SEIZED THE BACK OF HARRY'S REEKS AND WHISTLED HIM HELT OF THE PLUMMETING SIDECAR; HARRY PULLED HIS RICKSACK WITH HIM

AS HE DROGGED HIMSELF BENTH THE METHERIDGE'S SEAT AND PHIND HIMSELF

THE SEVEN PETHERS

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BACK-TH-BACK WITH HAGRID, AS THEY SHARED UPWARD, AWAY FROM THE TWO REMAINING DEATH-LATERS, HARRY SPAT BLEED HELT OF HIS MELTH, POINTED HIS HAND AT THE FALLING SIDECAR, AND YELLED, CHENRINGH!

HE KNEW A DREADFUL, GLIT-WRENCHING PANG FOR FREDIE AS IT EX-

PLEADED: THE DEATH EATER NEAREST IT WAS BLASTED OFF HIS KNEES AND FELL

FROM SIGHT: HIS COMPANIONS FELL BACK AND VANISHED.

HARRY, I M SHARRY, I M SHARRY, MEANED HAGRID, I SHOULDNTA TRIED
TER REPAIR IT MYSELF YEH YE GHT NEH RHEEM

IT S NOT A PROBLEM, JUST KEEP FLYING! HARRY SMILTED BACK, AS THREE
MORE DEATH EATERS EMERGED HLT OFF THE DARKNESS, DRAWING CLOSER,
AS THE CURSES CAME SMITTING ACROSS THE INTERVENING SPACE AGAIN,
HAGRID SWERVED AND ZIGZAGGED: HARRY KNEW THAT HAGRID DID NOT

DARE USE THE DRAGON-FIRE BLITZES AGAIN, WITH HARRY SEATED SEE INSE-
CLURELY, HARRY SENT STUNNING SPELL AFTER STUNNING SPELL BACK AT
THEIR

PURSUEES, BARELY HOLDING THEM OFF, HE SAW ANOTHER BLEEDING INK
AT THEM: THE CLOSEST DEATH EATER SWERVED TO AVOID IT AND HIS HAND
SLIPPED, AND BY THE RED LIGHT OF HIS NEXT STUNNING SPELL, HARRY
SAW

THE STRANGELY BLANK FACE OF STANLEY SHLIMPIKE STAN

EXPPELLIARMUS! HARRY YELLED.

THAT S HIM, IT S HIM, IT S THE REAL ONE!

THE BLEEDING DEATH EATER S SMILT REACHED HARRY EVEN ABOVE THE
TOWER OF THE MEETHEKIDE S ENGINE: NEXT MOMENT, BOTH PURSUERS
HAD FALLEN BACK AND DISAPPEARED FROM VIEW.

HARRY, WHAT S HAPPENED? BELLEWD HAGRID, WHERE YE THEY
GONE?

I DONT KNOW!

BUT HARRY WAS AFRAID! THE REDDED DEATH RATER HAD SEEMED IT S

THE REAL ONE! ; HE HAD HE BEEN HE GAZED AROUND AT THE
APPAR-

ENTLY EMPTY DARKNESS AND FELT ITS MENACE. WHERE WERE THEY?

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

HE CLAMBERED AROUND IN THE SEAT THE FACE FORWARD AND SEIZED HOLD
OF THE BACK OF HAGRID S JACKET.

HAGRID, DO THE DRAGON-FIRE THING AGAIN, LET S GET OUT OF HERE!

HOLD ON TIGHT, THEN, HARRY!

THERE WAS A DRAPENING, SCREECHING REAR AGAIN AND THE WHITE-BLUE
FIRE SHEET FROM THE EXHAUST! HARRY FELT HIMSELF SLIPPING BACKWARD
OFF

WHAT LITTLE OF THE SEAT HE HAD, HAGRID FELL BACKWARD WITHIN HIM,
BARELY MAINTAINING HIS GRIP IN THE HANDLES

I THINK WE VE LOST EM HARRY, I THINK WE VE DONE IT! YELLED
HAGRID,

BUT HARRY WAS NOT CONVINCED! FEAR LAPPED AT HIM AS HE LEANED
LEFT AND RIGHT FOR PURSUERS HE WAS SURE WOULD COME. . . . WHY HAD
THEY FALLEN BACK? HENCE HE THEM HAD STILL HAD A HAND. . . . IT S HIM
. . . IT S THE REAL ONE. . . . THEY HAD SAID IT RIGHT AFTER HE HAD TRIED THE
DISARM STUN. . . .

WE RE NEARLY THERE, HARRY, WE VE NEARLY MADE IT! SEEMED

ELAGRID,

HARRY FELT THE RIDE DREIF A LITTLE, THOUGH THE LIGHTS DOWN IN THE
GROUNDS STILL SEEMED REMOTE AS STARS.

THEN THE STAR IN HIS THREE-HEAD BLAZED LIKE FIRE; AS A DEATH EATER
APPEARED IN EITHER SIDE OF THE RIDE, TWO KILLING CURSES MISSED
HARRY

BY MILLIMETERS, LAST FROM BEHIND

AND THEN HARRY SAW HIM. VEILDEMEERT WAS FLYING LIKE SPEED IN

THE WIND, WITH EIGHT BREEMSTICKS FOR THESTRAL HE HELD HIM, HIS SNAKE-
LIKE FACE GLEAMING OUT OF THE BLACKNESS, HIS WHITE FINGERS RAISING
HIS

WAND AGAIN

ELAGRID LET OUT A RELLER OF FEAR AND STEERED THE MEETHEKIDE INTO A
VERTICAL DIVE. CLINGING IN FOR DEAR LIFE, HARRY SENT STUNNING
SPELLS

FLYING AT RANDOM INTO THE WHIRLING NIGHT, HE SAW A BIRD FLY PAST

THE SEVEN FEETTERS

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HIM AND KNEW HE HAD HIT ONE OF THEM, BUT THEN HE HEARD A BANG
AND SAW SPARKS FROM THE ENGINE; THE MEETHEKIDE SPIRALED THROUGH THE
THE

AIR, COMPLETELY OUT OF CONTROL

GREEN LETS OF LIGHT SEEMT PAST THEM AGAIN, HARRY HAD NO IDEA WHICH

WAY WAS UP, WHICH DOWN: HIS SCAR WAS STILL BURNING: HE EXPECTED THE

DIE AT ANY SECOND, A BEEHIVED FIGURE HEN A KREHMSTICK WAS FEET FROM HIM, HE SAW IT RAISE ITS ARM

NEE:

WITH A SEEMT OF FLRY HJAGRID LAUNCHED HIMSELF OFF THE RIDE AT THE DEATH: LATER, TH HIS HORROR, HARRY SAW BOTH HJAGRID AND THE DEATH: LATER FALLING OUT OF SIGHT, THEIR COMBINED WEIGHT THEE MUCH FOR THE KREHMSTICK

BARELY GRIPPING THE PLUMMETING RIDE WITH HIS KNEES, HARRY HEARD VEHDENHRT SCREAM, MINE:

IT WAS EVER: HE COULD NOT SEE OR HEAR WHERE VEHDENHRT WAS: HE GLIMPSED ANOTHER DEATH: LATER SWEEPING OUT OF THE WAY AND HEARD, AVADA

AS THE PAIN FROM HARRY S SCAR FORCED HIS EYES SHUT, HIS WAND ACTED OF ITS OWN ACCORD, HE FELT IT DRAG HIS HAND AROUND LIKE SOME GREAT MAGNET, SAW A SPURT OF GILDED FIRE THROUGH HIS HALF-CLOSED EYELIDS, HEARD A CRACK AND A SCREAM OF FLRY, THE REMAINING DEATH: LATER YELLED: VEHDENHRT SCREAMED, NEE: ; SEEMT-HEN, HARRY FEELING HIS NECK AN INCH FROM THE DRAGON-FIRE BLITZEN, HE PUNCHED IT WITH HIS

WAND-FREE HAND AND THE RIDE SEEMT MORE FLAMES INTO THE AIR, FLIRTLING

STRAIGHT TOWARD THE GRHLING,

HJAGRID: HARRY CALLED, HOLDING HEN TH THE RIDE FOR DEAR LIFE,

HJAGRID ACKIE HJAGRID:

THE METERKIND SPED UP, SLIDED TOWARD THE EARTH, FACE LEVEL WITH THE HANDLEBARS, HARRY COULD SEE NOTHING BUT DISTANT LIGHTS GRIMING

CHAPTER FOUR

XX

NEARER AND NEARER! HE WAS GOING TO CRASH AND THERE WAS NOTHING HE

COULD DO ABOUT IT. BEHIND HIM CAME ANOTHER SCREAM, VELIA WAND, SELLON, GIVE ME VELIA WAND!

HE FELT VEIDEMERT BEHIND HIM, LEANING SIDEWAYS, HE STARED INTO THE RED EYES AND WAS SURE THEY WOULD BE THE LAST THING HE EVER SAW: VEIDEMERT PREPARING TO CLASP HIM BEHIND NECK

AND THEN VEIDEMERT VANISHED. HARRY LEANED DOWN AND SAW

HAGRID SPREAD-EAGLED WHEN THE GRILING REELT HIM. HE PULLED HARD AT THE HANDLEBARS TO AVOID HITTING HIM, CREEPED OVER THE BRACK, BUT WITH AN EARSPLITTING, GRILING-TREMELING CRASH, HE SMASHED INTO A MUDDY POND.

CHAPTER FIVE

XX

FALLEN WARRIOR

ACRID?

HARRY STRUGGLED TO RAISE HIMSELF OUT OF THE DEBRIS OF METAL AND LEATHER THAT SURROUNDED HIM; HIS HANDS SANK INTO

THE Muddy WATER AS HE TRIED TO STAND. HE COULD NOT UNDERSTAND WHERE VERBEMERT HAD GONE AND EXPECTED HIM TO STAY OUT OF THE DARKNESS AT ANY MOMENT. SOMETHING HOT AND WET WAS TRICKLING DOWN HIS CHIN AND FROM HIS FOREHEAD. HE CRAWLED OUT OF THE POND AND STUMBLED TOWARD THE GREAT DARK MASS IN THE GROUND THAT WAS

ACRID. ACRID, TALK TO ME

BUT THE DARK MASS DID NOT STIR.

WHO IS THERE? IS IT BETTER? ARE YOU HARRY BETTER? HARRY DID NOT RECOGNIZE THE MAN'S VOICE. THEN A WOMAN SPEAKED, THEY'VE CRASHED, THEY'VE CRASHED IN THE GARDEN!

HARRY'S HEAD WAS SWIMMING.

ACRID, HE REPEATED STUPIDLY, AND HIS KNEES CLICKED.

H

CHAPTER FIVE

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THE NEXT THING HE KNEW, HE WAS LYING ON HIS BACK ON WHAT FELT LIKE CUSHIONS, WITH A BURNING SENSATION IN HIS RIBS AND RIGHT ARM. HIS MISSING TEETH HAD BEEN RECOVERED. THE STAR ON HIS FOREHEAD WAS

STILL TREKING.

HARRY

HE OPENED HIS EYES AND SAW THAT HE WAS LYING IN A SHA IN AN UN-
FAMILIAR, LAMPLIT SITTING ROOM. HIS RUCKSACK LAY IN THE CORNER A
SHORT

DISTANCE AWAY, WET AND MUDDY. A FAIR-HAired, BIG-BELLIED MAN WAS
WATCHING HARRY ANXIOUSLY.

HARRY S FINE, SEN, SAID THE MAN, THE WIFE S SEEING TH HIM NOW.
HOW ARE YOU FEELING? ANYTHING ELSE BROKEN? I VE FIXED YOUR RIBS,
YOUR TEETH, AND YOUR ARM. I M TED, BY THE WAY, TED THOMAS
DEER S

FATHER.

HARRY SAT UP THEN SUDDENLY! LIGHTS FLASHED IN FRONT OF HIS EYES AND
HE FELT SICK AND GIDDY.

WHEW

EASY, NOW, SAID TED THOMAS, PLACING A HAND ON HARRY S SHOUL-
DER AND PUSHING HIM BACK AGAINST THE CUSHIONS. THAT WAS A
NASTY

CRASH YOU JUST HAD. WHAT HAPPENED, ANYWAY? SOMETHING GO
WRONG

WITH THE RIDE? ARTHUR WEASLEY EVERSTRETCHED HIMSELF AGAIN, HIM AND
HIS MULES CONTRAPTIONS?

NO, SAID HARRY, AS HIS SCAR PULSED LIKE AN OPEN WOUND. DEATH
EATERS, WHADS OF THEM WE WERE CHASED

DEATH EATERS? SAID TED SHARPLY. WHAT DO YOU MEAN, DEATH
EATERS? I THOUGHT THEY DIDN'T KNOW YOU WERE BEING MOVED TONIGHT,
I THOUGHT

THEY KNOW, SAID HARRY.
TED TENDS LOOKED UP AT THE CEILING AS THOUGH HE COULD SEE
THROUGH
IT TO THE SKY ABOVE.

FALLEN WARRIOR

AS

WELL, WE KNOW OUR PROTECTIVE CHARMS HOLD, THEN, DON'T WE? THEY
SHOULDN'T BE ABLE TO GET WITHIN A HUNDRED YARDS OF THE PLACE IN ANY
DIRECTION.

YOU HARRY UNDERSTOOD WHY VERDREHT HAD VANISHED? IT HAD
BEEN AT THE POINT WHEN THE MOTHERKID CRASHED THE BARRIER OF THE
ORDER'S CHARMS, HE ONLY HOPED THEY WOULD CONTINUE TO WORK. HE
IMAGINED VERDREHT, A HUNDRED YARDS ABOVE THEM AS THEY SPED,
LOOKING FOR A WAY TO PENETRATE WHAT HARRY VISUALIZED AS A GREAT
TRANSPARENT BUBBLE.

HE SWUNG HIS LEGS OFF THE SEAT. HE NEEDED TO SEE HAGRID WITH
HIS OWN EYES BEFORE HE WOULD BELIEVE THAT HE WAS ALIVE. HE HAD
BARELY STEPPED UP, HOWEVER, WHEN A DEER OPENED AND HAGRID SLIPPED
THROUGH IT, HIS FACE COVERED IN MUD AND BLOOD, LIMPING A LITTLE BUT
MIRACULOUSLY ALIVE.

HARRY?

BRUSHING OVER THE DELICATE TABLES AND AN ASPIDISTRA, HE COVERED THE FLOOR BETWEEN THEM IN TWO STRIDES AND PULLED HARRY INTO A HUG

THAT NEARLY CRACKED HIS NEWLY REPAIRED RIBS. KIMMY, HARRY, THEN DID

YOU GET HIT IN THAT? I THOUGHT WE WERE BOTH CHINNERS.

Yeah, Mr. Then, I CAN'T BELIEVE

HARRY BREKE OFF, HE HAD JUST NOTICED THE WOMAN WHO HAD ENTERED THE ROOM BEHIND HAGRID.

Well? HE SMILTED, AND HE THIRST HIS HAND INTO HIS POCKET, BUT IT WAS EMPTY.

WELL, WARD S HERE, THEN, SAID TED, TAPPING IT ON HARRY S ARM.

IT FELL RIGHT BESIDE WELL, I PICKED IT UP, AND THAT S MY WIFE WELL RE SMILTING AT.

Oh, I M I M SORRY.

AS SHE MOVED FORWARD INTO THE ROOM, MRS. TENDS S RESEMBLANCE

CHAPTER FIVE

XX

THE HER SISTER BELLATRIX BECAME MUCH LESS FRIENDLY: HER HAIR WAS A

LIGHT, SHORT KROWN AND HER EYES WERE WIDER AND KINDER. NEVERTHELESS, SHE BEHEED A LITTLE HALIGHTY AFTER HARRY S EXCLAMATION.

WHAT HAPPENED THE ELIR DALIGHTER? SHE ASKED. HAGRID SAID WELL WERE AMPLISHED; WHERE IS DUMPHADDER?

I DIN T KNOW, SAID HARRY. WE DIN T KNOW WHAT HAPPENED THE

ANYONE ELSE.

SHE AND TED EXCHANGED LOOKS. A MIXTURE OF FEAR AND GUILT GRIPPED HARRY AT THE SIGHT OF THEIR EXPRESSIONS; IF ANY OF THE OTHERS HAD DIED,

IT WAS HIS FAULT, ALL HIS FAULT. HE HAD CONSENTED TO THE PLAN, GIVEN THEM HIS FAIR, . . .

THE PERTNEY, HE SAID, REMEMBERING ALL OF A SUDDEN. WE'VE GOTTEN BACK TO THE CLIMBER AND FIND OUT THEN WE'LL BE ABLE TO SEND

WELL, WELL, HER THINGS WILL, SINCE SHE'S

DEBRA'LL BE HERE, DREYDA, SAID TED. SHE KNOWS HER STUFF, SHE'S BEEN IN PLENTY OF TIGHT SPOTS WITH THE ALPHAS. THE PERTNEY'S THROUGH

HERE, HE ADDED TO HARRY. IT'S SLIPPED THE LEAVE IN THREE MINUTES, IF YOU WANT TO TAKE IT.

Yeah, we do, said HARRY. HE SEIZED HIS RUCKSACK, SLINGING IT OVER HIS SHOULDERS. I

HE LOOKED AT MRS. THINGS, WANTING TO APOLOGIZE FOR THE STATE OF

FEAR IN WHICH HE LEFT HER AND FOR WHICH HE FELT SHE TERRIBLY RESPONSIBLE, BUT NEW WORDS HIGHLIGHTED TO HIM THAT DID NOT SEEM HELPFUL AND

INSINCERE.

I'LL TELL THINGS DEBRA THE SEND WORD, WHEN SHE . . . THANKS FOR PATCHING US UP, THANKS FOR EVERYTHING. I

HE WAS GLAD TO LEAVE THE ROOM AND FOLLOW TED THINGS ALONG A SHORT

HALLWAY AND INTO A BEDROOM. JAGRID CAME AFTER THEM, SENDING HER

THE AVIAD HITTING HIS HEAD ON THE DINNER LINTEL.

FALLON WARRIERS

BY

THERE WILL BE, THEN, THAT'S THE PERTINENT.

MR. THOMAS WAS PRINTING THE A SMALL, SILVER-KAYED FAIRERLISH LYING
ON THE DRESSING TABLE.

THANKS, SAID HARRY, REACHING OUT THE PLACE A FINGER ON IT, READY
THE LEAVE.

WAIT A MOMENT, SAID HAGRID, LEAVING AROUND. HARRY, WHERE'S
HEDWIG?

SHE ... SHE GOT HIT, SAID HARRY.

THE REALIZATION CRASHED OVER HIM: HE FELT ASHAMED OF HIMSELF AS
THE TEARS STUNG HIS EYES. THE HUK HAD BEEN HIS COMPANION, HIS ONE
GREAT LINK WITH THE MAGICAL WORLD WHENEVER HE HAD BEEN FORCED TO
RETURN TO THE DURSLEYS.

HAGRID REACHED OUT A GREAT HAND AND PATTED HIM PAINFULLY ON
THE SHOULDER.

NEVER MIND, HE SAID GRUFFLY. NEVER MIND, SHE HAD A GREAT OLD
LIFE

HAGRID SAID TO THOMAS WARNINGLY, AS THE FAIRERLISH GLEWED
BRIGHT BLUE, AND HAGRID ONLY JUST GOT HIS THREDFINGER TO IT IN TIME.
WITH A KICK BEHIND THE NAVEL AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE HOOK AND
LINE

HAD DRAGGED HIM FORWARD, HARRY WAS PULLED INTO NOTHINGNESS,
SPIN-

NING UNCONTROLLABLY, HIS FINGER GRIPPED THE THE PORTKEY AS HE AND
HAGRID

HURTTLED AWAY FROM MR. TENDS. SECONDS LATER HARRY'S FEET SLAMMED
DOWN THE HARD CEMENT AND HE FELL DOWN HIS HANDS AND KNEES IN THE
YARD OF

THE KITCHEN. HE HEARD SCREAMS, THROWING ASIDE THE ONE WHOM HE
WAS

HAIRBRUSH, HARRY STOOD UP, SWAYING SLIGHTLY, AND SAW MRS.
WEASLEY

AND GINNY RUNNING DOWN THE STAIRS BY THE BACK DOOR AS HAGRID,
WHO

HAD ALSO COLLAPSED ON LANDING, CLAMBERED LABORIOUSLY TO HIS FEET.

HARRY? WHO ARE THE REAL HARRY? WHAT HAPPENED? WHERE ARE THE
OTHERS? CRIED MRS. WEASLEY.

CHAPTER FIVE

XX

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? ISN'T ANYONE ELSE BACK? HARRY PANTED.

THE ANSWER WAS CLEARLY ETCHED IN MRS. WEASLEY'S PALE FACE.

THE DEATH EATERS WERE WAITING FOR US, HARRY TOLD HER. WE

WERE SURROUNDED THE MOMENT WE THEM OF THEY KNEW IT WAS THE

NIGHT I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HAPPENED OR ANYONE ELSE, FEELING OF
THEM

CHASED US, IT WAS ALL WE COULD DO TO GET AWAY, AND THEN VERBEMMENT
CALLED UP WITH US

HE COULD HEAR THE SELF-JUSTIFYING NOTE IN HIS VOICE, THE PLEA FOR
HER TO UNDERSTAND WHY HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT HAD HAPPENED TO HER
SENS, BUT

"THANK GOODNESS YOU'RE ALL RIGHT," SHE SAID, PULLING HIM INTO A
HUG HE DID NOT FEEL HE DESERVED.

"HAVEN'T YOU ANY BRANDY, HAVE YOU, MOTHER?" ASKED HAGRID A LITTLE
SHARPLY. FOR MEDICINAL PURPOSES?

SHE COULD HAVE SLIMMERED IT BY MAGIC, BUT AS SHE HURRIED BACK
TOWARD THE CRACKED HEEL, HARRY KNEW THAT SHE WANTED TO HIDE
HER

FACE. HE TURNED TO GINNY AND SHE ANSWERED HIS UNSPOKEN PLEA FOR
INFORMATION AT ONCE.

JOHN AND THOMAS SHOULD HAVE BEEN BACK FIRST, BUT THEY MISSED
THEIR PORTKEY, IT CAME BACK WITHOUT THEM, SHE SAID, POINTING AT
A RUSTY HIL CAN LYING ON THE GRASS NEARBY. AND THAT ONE, SHE
POINTED AT AN ANCIENT SNEAKER, SHOULD HAVE BEEN DAD AND FRED'S,
THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO BE SECOND, YOU AND HAGRID WERE THIRD AND,
SHE CHECKED HER WATCH, IF THEY MADE IT, GEORGE AND KLIPIN WOULD
BE BACK IN ABOUT A MINUTE.

MRS. WEASLEY REAPPEARED CARRYING A KETTLE OF BRANDY, WHICH SHE
HANDS TO HAGRID. HE LINGERED IT AND DRANK IT STRAIGHT DOWN IN
ONE.

MUM SHOULD GINNY, POINTING TO A SPOT SEVERAL FEET AWAY,

FALLEN WARRIOR

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A BLUE LIGHT HAD APPEARED IN THE DARKNESS: IT GREW LARGER AND BRIGHTER, AND LUPIN AND GEORGE APPEARED, SPINNING AND THEN FALLING.

HARRY KNEW IMMEDIATELY THAT THERE WAS SOMETHING WRONG: LUPIN WAS SLIPPING GEORGE, WHO WAS UNCONSCIOUS AND WHOSE FACE WAS COVERED IN BLOOD.

HARRY RAN FORWARD AND SEIZED GEORGE'S LEGS. TOGETHER, HE AND LUPIN CARRIED GEORGE INTO THE HALL AND THROUGH THE KITCHEN THE

SITTING ROOM, WHERE THEY LAID HIM ON THE SOFA. AS THE LAMPLIGHT FELL

ACROSS GEORGE'S HEAD, GINNY GASPED AND HARRY'S STOMACH CLUTCHED: ONE OF GEORGE'S EARS WAS MISSING. THE SIDE OF HIS HEAD AND NECK WERE DRENCHED IN WET, SHOCKINGLY SCARLET BLOOD.

NONE SHORTER HAD MRS. WEASLEY RENT EVER BEEN SEEN THAN LUPIN GRABBED HARRY BY THE UPPER ARM AND DRAGGED HIM, NEARLY THEN GENTLY, BACK INTO THE KITCHEN, WHERE Hagrid WAS STILL ATTEMPTING THE TASK HIS

BLIND THROUGH THE BACK DOOR.

"HI!" SAID Hagrid INDIGNANTLY. "LEAVE HIM! LEAVE HIM! LEAVE HARRY!" LUPIN IGNORED HIM.

WHAT CREATURE SAT IN THE CORNER THE FIRST TIME THAT HARRY PETER

VISITED MY OFFICE AT F-HEGARTY'S? HE SAID, GIVING F-HARRY A SMALL
SHAKE.

ANSWER ME?

A GRINDYHEEL IN A TANK, WASN'T IT?

LUPIN RELEASED F-HARRY AND FELL BACK AGAINST A KITCHEN CLIPBOARD.

WHAT WAS THE RESULT? REHARD F-HARRY.

I'M SURE, F-HARRY, BUT I HAD THE CHECK, SAID LUPIN TERSELY. WE'VE
BEEN BETRAYED. VERMONT KNEW THAT WE WERE BEING MOVED TONIGHT
AND THE ONLY PEOPLE WHO COULD HAVE TOLD HIM WERE DIRECTLY
INVOLVED

IN THE PLAN. WE MIGHT HAVE BEEN AN IMPOSTER.

SEE WHY AREN'T WE CHECKING ME? PANTED F-HARRY, STILL STRUGGLING
THE FIT THROUGH THE DEER.

CHAPTER FIVE

NO

WE'RE HALF-GIANT, SAID LUPIN, LEANING UP AT F-HARRY. THE
PHYSICAL PARTITION IS DESIGNED FOR HUMAN USE ONLY.

NONE OF THE ORDER WOULD HAVE TOLD VERMONT WE WERE MOV-
ING TONIGHT, SAID F-HARRY. THE IDEA WAS DREADFUL TO HIM, HE COULD

NOT BELIEVE IT OF ANY OF THEM. VERMONT ONLY CALLED UP WITH ME
TOWARD THE END, HE DIDN'T KNOW WHICH ONE I WAS IN THE BEGINNING.
IF HE'D BEEN IN ON THE PLAN HE'D HAVE KNOWN FROM THE START I WAS

THE HIRE WITH FLAGRID.

VERDERBERT CALLED UP WITH THEM? SAID LUPIN SHARPLY, WHAT HAPPENED? WHEN DID YOU ESCAPE?

HARRY EXPLAINED BRIEFLY WHEN THE DEATH EATERS PURSUING THEM HAD

SEEMED TO RECOGNIZE HIM AS THE TRUE HARRY, WHEN THEY HAD ABANDONED THE CHASE, WHEN THEY MUST HAVE SLIPPED VERDERBERT, WHEN

HAD APPEARED JUST BEFORE HE AND FLAGRID HAD REACHED THE SANCTUARY OF THEIR PARENTS.

THEY RECOGNIZED YOU? BUT WHEN? WHAT HAD YOU DONE?

I... HARRY TRIED TO REMEMBER; THE WHOLE JOURNEY SEEMED LIKE A BLUR OF PANIC AND CONFUSION. I SAW STAN SHUNPICK... YOU KNOW,

THE BLUR WHEN WAS THE CRUCIATEX AND THE KNIGHT BLISS? AND I TRIED TO

DISARM HIM INSTEAD OF... WELL, HE DOESN'T KNOW WHAT HE'S DOING, DOES HE? HE MUST BE IMPERILED?

LUPIN LEANED AGAINST.

HARRY, THE TIME FOR DISARMING IS PAST! THESE PEOPLE ARE TRYING TO

CAPTURE AND KILL YOU! AT LEAST STILL IF YOU AREN'T PREPARED TO KILL!

WE WERE HUNDREDS OF FEET UP! STAN'S NEXT HIMSELF, AND IF I STRUCK HIM AND HE'D FALLEN, HE'D HAVE DIED THE SAME AS IF I'D USED AVADA KEDAVRA! EXPELLIARMIS SAVED ME FROM VERDERBERT TWO YEARS AGO, HARRY ADDED DEFIANTLY. LUPIN WAS REMINDING HIM OF THE SNEERING

FALLON WARRIORS

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ELPHINSTON ZACHARIAS SMITH, WHO HAD LOOKED AT HARRY FOR WANTING THE

TEACH DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY FOR THE DISARM,

YES, HARRY, SAID LUPIN WITH PAINFUL RESTRAINT, AND A GREAT NLM-

HER HP DEATH EATERS WITNESSED THAT HAPPENING! FORGIVE ME, BUT IT

WAS A VERY UNUSUAL MOVE THEN, UNDER IMMINENT THREAT OF DEATH,

REPEATING IT TONIGHT IN FRONT OF DEATH EATERS WHO EITHER WITNESSED

HE HEARD ABOUT THE FIRST OCCASION WAS CLOSE THE SUICIDAL?

SEE WHY THINK I SHOULD HAVE KILLED STAN SHIMPICK? SAID HARRY ANGRILY,

HP CHURCH MEET, SAID LUPIN, BUT THE DEATH EATERS FRANKLY,

MOST PEOPLE? WOULD HAVE EXPECTED WHY THE ATTACK BACK? EXPELLIAR-

MIS IS A USEFUL SPELL, HARRY, BUT THE DEATH EATERS SEEM TO THINK IT IS

THEIR SIGNATURE MOVE, AND I WOULD WHY NOT LET IT BECOME SEE?

LUPIN WAS MAKING HARRY FEEL IDIOTIC, AND YET THERE WAS STILL A GRAIN OF DEFIANCE INSIDE HIM.

I WHEN THE LAST PEOPLE FELT HE WAS JUST REALISE THEY'RE THERE,
SAID HARRY, THAT'S VERDICT THAT'S IT.

LUPIN'S RETORT WAS BEST: FINALLY SLEEPING IN SLEEPING THROUGH
THE DEER, HARRY STAGGERED TO A CHAIR AND SAT DOWN; IT COLLAPSED

BENEATH HIM, IGNORING HIS MINGLED PAINS AND APPEALS, HARRY AD-
DRESSED LUPIN AGAIN.

WILL GEORGE BE HARRY?

ALL LUPIN'S FRUSTRATION WITH HARRY SEEMED TO DRAIN AWAY AT THE
MOMENT.

I THINK YES, ALTHOUGH THERE'S NO CHANCE OF REPLACING HIS EAR, NOT
WHEN IT'S BEEN LOST.

THERE WAS A SLIPPER FROM HILLSIDE, LUPIN DIVED FOR THE BACK DEER;
HARRY LEAPT OVER HARRY'S LEGS AND SPRINTED INTO THE YARD.

CHAPTER FIVE

THE

TWO FIGURES HAD APPEARED IN THE YARD, AND AS HARRY RAN TOWARD
THEM HE REALIZED THEY WERE HERMIONE, NOW RETURNING TO HER
NORMAL

APPEARANCE, AND KINGSLY, BOTH CLUTCHING A BENT CHAIR HANGER.
HERMI-

ONE FLYING HERSELF INTO HARRY'S ARMS, BUT KINGSLY SEEMED NOT
PLEASED

AT THE SIGHT OF ANY OF THEM. EVER HERMINIE'S STELLER HARRY SAW
HIM RAISE HIS HAND AND POINT IT AT LUPIN'S CHEST.

THE LAST WORDS ALAS DUMPLEDORE SPoke THE THE PAIR OF LIPS

HARRY IS THE BEST FEEF WE HAVE. TRUST HIM, SAID LUPIN
CALMLY.

KINGSLEY TURNED HIS HAND ON HARRY, BUT LUPIN SAID, IT'S HIM,
I'VE CHECKED!

ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT! SAID KINGSLEY, STEALING HIS HAND BACK BE-
NEATH HIS CHAIR. BUT SOMEHOW BETRAYED LIPS! THEY KNEW, THEY KNEW

IT WAS TONIGHT!

SEE IT SEEMS, REPLIED LUPIN, BUT APPARENTLY THEY DID NOT REALIZE
THAT THERE WOULD BE SEVEN HARRYS.

SMALL CONFERT! SNARLED KINGSLEY. WHO ELSE IS BACK?

ONLY HARRY, HAGRID, GEORGE, AND ME.

HERMINIE STOLE A LITTLE MEAN BEHIND HER HAND.

WHAT HAPPENED THE YEAR? LUPIN ASKED KINGSLEY.

FOLLOWED BY FIVE, INJURED TWO, MIGHT'VE KILLED ONE, KINGSLEY
REELED OFF, AND WE SAW YELL-KNEEL-WITH AS WELL, HE THOUGHT THE CHASE
HALFWAY THROUGH BUT VANISHED PRETTY QUICKLY. REMINDS, HE CAN
FLY, SLIPPERED HARRY. I SAW HIM THEN, HE CAME AFTER HAGRID AND
ME.

SEE THAT'S WHY HE LEFT, THE FELLOW YELL! SAID KINGSLEY. I COULDN'T
WIN-

UNDERSTAND WHY HE'D VANISHED, BUT WHAT MADE HIM CHANGE TARGETS?

HARRY REJAYED A LITTLE THEN KINDLY THE STAN SHLINDLE, SAID
SLIPIN.

STAN? REPEATED HERMIONE, BUT I THOUGHT HE WAS IN AZKABAN?

PAULIN WARRIERS

OR

DINGSLEY LET OUT A MIRTHLESS LAUGH.

HERMIONE, THERE'S HEAVILY BEEN A MASS BREACHLET WHICH THE
MINISTRY HAS FILISHED UP, TRAVERS'S FEELING FELL OFF WHEN I CLASSED
HIM,

HE'S SLIPPED THE RE INSIDE THEM, BUT WHAT HAPPENED THE YELL, REMILY?
WHERE'S GEORGE?

HE LEFT AN EAR, SAID SLIPIN.

LEFT AN ? REPEATED HERMIONE IN A HIGH VOICE.

SNAPE'S WEIRD, SAID SLIPIN.

SNAPE? SMILTED HARRY, YELL DIDN'T SAY

HE LEFT HIS FEELING DURING THE CHASE, SETLINGSMPRA WAS ALWAYS A
SPECIALITY OF SNAPE'S, I WISH I COULD SAY I'D PAID HIM BACK IN KIND,
BUT IT WAS ALL I COULD DO THE DEEP GEORGE HEN THE BROTHER AFTER HE WAS
INJURED, HE WAS MISSING SEE MUCH BLEED.

SILENCE FELL BETWEEN THE FEELER OF THEM AS THEY BLEEDED UP AT THE SKY,
THERE WAS NO SIGN OF MOVEMENT; THE STARS STARED BACK,
LINKINGING,

INDIFFERENT, LINKINGING BY FLYING FRIENDS, WHERE WAS RING? WHERE

WERE FRED AND MR. WEASLEY? WHERE WERE BILL, FLEUR, THUNDERS, MAD-EYE, AND MUNDLINGUS?

HARRY, GIVE US A HAND! CALLED HAGRID HEARSELY FROM THE DEER, IN WHICH HE WAS STUCK AGAIN. GLAD HE SOMETHING THE DEER, HARRY PULLED HIM FREE, THEN HEADED THROUGH THE EMPTY KITCHEN AND BACK INTO THE SITTING ROOM, WHERE MRS. WEASLEY AND GINNY WERE STILL TENDING THE GEORGE. MRS. WEASLEY HAD STALNCHED HIS BLEEDING NECK, AND BY THE LAMPLIGHT HARRY SAW A CLEAN, GAPING WOUND WHERE GEORGE'S EAR HAD BEEN.

HOW IS HE?

MRS. WEASLEY WHINED AROUND AND SAID, I CAN'T MAKE IT GROW BACK, NOT WHEN IT'S BEEN REMOVED BY DARK MAGIC, BUT IT COULD HAVE BEEN SO MUCH WORSE. . . . HE'S ALIVE.

CHAPTER FIVE

ggg

YEAH, SAID HARRY, THANKS CHD.

DID I HEAR SOMEONE ELSE IN THE YARD? GINNY ASKED.

HERMIONE AND KINGSLEY, SAID HARRY.

THANK GOODNESS, GINNY WHISPERED, THEY WHINED AT EACH OTHER; HARRY WANTED TO HUG HER, HOLD HER, HEED HER; HE DID NOT EVEN CARE MUCH

THAT MRS. WEASLEY WAS THERE, BUT BEFORE HE COULD ACT ON THE IMPULSE

THERE WAS A GREAT CRASH FROM THE KITCHEN.

I'LL PROVE WHAT I AM, DINGSLEY, AFTER I'VE SEEN MY SHIN, NEEL KAD
HFF IF YELL KNOW WHAT I'VE DONE FOR YELL!

HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD MR. WEASLEY SPEAK LIKE THAT BEFORE. HE
BURST INTO THE LIVING ROOM, HIS BALD PATCH GLEAMING WITH SWEAT,
HIS

SPECTACLES ASKED, FRED RIGHT BEHIND HIM, BOTH PALE BUT UNINJURED.

ARTHUR! SHRIED MRS. WEASLEY. HER HANDS CLOUTERED!

HOW IS HE?

MR. WEASLEY DROPPED TO HIS KNEES BESIDE GEORGE, FOR THE FIRST
TIME SINCE HARRY HAD KNOWN HIM, FRED SEEMED TO BE LIST FOR WORDS.
HE GAZED OVER THE BACK OF THE SHIN AT HIS TWIN & WHINED AS IF HE
WAS

NOT BELIEVE WHAT HE WAS SEEING.

PERHAPS RELEASSED BY THE SOUND OF FRED AND THEIR FATHER'S ARRIVAL,
GEORGE STIRRED.

HOW DO YOU FEEL, GEORGE? WHISPERED MRS. WEASLEY.

GEORGE'S FINGERS CREEPED OVER THE SIDE OF HIS HEAD.

SAINTELY, HE MURMURED.

WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM? CRIED FRED, LOOKING TERRIFIED. IS
HIS MIND AFFECTED?

SAINTELY, REPEATED GEORGE, OPENING HIS EYES AND LOOKING UP AT
HIS BROTHER. YOU SEE... I'M FINE, FINE, FRED, CREDIT?

MRS. WEASLEY SHRIED HARDER THAN EVER. CLOUTERED FRED'S PALE
FACE.

FALLING WARRIOR

AS

PATNETIC, HE TOLD GEORGE. PATNETIC! WITH THE WIDE WIDE WORLD
HE CAN-RELATED HIMSELF BEFORE YOU, YOU CAN SEE HIMSELF?

AS WELL, SAID GEORGE, GRINNING AT HIS TEAR-SHAKED MOTHER,
YOU LL

BE ABLE TO TELL US APART NOW, ANYWAY, MUM.

HE WHISPERED ANEW.

HI, HARRY YOU ARE HARRY, RIGHT?

YEAS, I AM, SAID HARRY, MOVING CLOSER TO THE SHIP.

WELL, AT LEAST WE GET YOU BACK HOME, SAID GEORGE. WHY AREN'T
JOHN AND BILL HIDDEN BEHIND MY SICKBED?

THEY'RE NOT BACK YET, GEORGE, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. GEORGE'S GRIN
FADDED.

HARRY GLANCED AT GINNY AND MENTIONED TO HER TO ACCOMPANY HIM
BACK HILTSIDE. AS THEY WALKED THROUGH THE KITCHEN SHE SAID IN A
LOW VOICE, JOHN AND THOMAS SHOULD BE BACK BY NOW. THEY DIDN'T
HAVE A LONG JOURNEY; ALTHOUGH MURIEL'S NOT THAT FAR FROM HERE.
HARRY SAID NOTHING. HE HAD BEEN TRYING TO KEEP FEAR AT BAY EVER
SINCE REACHING THE BLURRY, BUT NOW IT ENVELOPED HIM, SEEMING TO
CRAWL OVER HIS SKIN, THRUMMING IN HIS CHEST, CLOGGING HIS THROAT.
AS

THEY WALKED DOWN THE BACK STEPS INTO THE DARK YARD, GINNY TOOK
HIS HAND.

DINGSLEY WAS STRIDING BACKWARD AND FORWARD, GLANCING UP AT THE
SKY

EVERY TIME HE TURNED, HARRY WAS REMINDED OF LITTLE VERNON
PACING

THE LIVING AMONG A MILLION YEARS AGO, HAGRID, HERMIONE, AND LUPIN
STOOD SHOULDER TO SHOULDER, GAZING UPWARD IN SILENCE, HEAR-
ING

THEIR OWN HEARTS WHEN HARRY AND GINNY JOINED THEIR SILENT VIGIL.
THE MINUTES STRETCHED INTO WHAT MIGHT AS WELL HAVE BEEN YEARS.
THE SLIGHTEST BREATH OF WIND MADE THEM ALL JUMP AND TURN TOWARD
THE WHISPERING BUSH OR TREE IN THE HOPE THAT ONE OF THE MISSING
ORDER MEMBERS MIGHT LEAP UNSCATHED FROM ITS LEAVES

CHAPTER FIVE

THE

AND THEN A GREEN MATERIALIZED DIRECTLY ABOVE THEM AND STREAKED
TOWARD THE GROUND

IT'S THEM! SCREAMED HERMIONE.

THEY LANDED IN A LONG SKID THAT SENT EARTH AND ROCKS
EVERYWHERE.

REMY! THEY CRIED AS SHE STAGGERED OFF THE GREEN INTO LUPIN'S
ARMS. HIS FACE WAS SET AND WHITE; HE SEEMED UNABLE TO SPEAK. THEN
TRIPPED DAZZLED TOWARD HARRY AND HERMIONE.

WELL BE HONOR, HE MUMBLED, BEFORE HERMIONE FLEW AT HIM AND
HUGGED HIM TIGHTLY.

I THOUGHT I THOUGHT

M ALL RIGHT, SAID Remy, PATTING HER ON THE BACK. M FINE.

Remy WAS GREAT, SAID THEY WARMLY, RELINEALIZING HER HOLD ON
LUPIN. UNEXPECTED, STUNNED ONE OF THE DEATH EATERS, STRAIGHT THE

THE HEAD, AND WHEN THEY'RE AIMING AT A MOVING TARGET FROM A
FLYING

CRASH

THEY DID? SAID HERMIONE, GLAZING UP AT RON WITH HER ARMS STILL
AROUND HIS NECK.

ALWAYS THE TIME OF SURPRISE, HE SAID A LITTLE GRUMPILY, BREASTING
FREE. ARE WE THE LAST BACK?

NO, SAID GINNY, WE'RE STILL WAITING FOR KILL AND FLEET AND MAD-
EYE AND MUNDLINGIS. I'M GOING TO TELL MUM AND DAD THEY'RE HERE,

RON

SHE RAN BACK INSIDE.

SHE WHAT KEPT THEM? WHAT HAPPENED? LUPIN SEEMED ALMOST
ANGRY AT THEM.

BELLATRIX, SAID THEM. SHE WANTS ME WHITE AS MUCH AS SHE
WANTS

HARRY, REMUS, SHE TRIED VERY HARD TO KILL ME, I JUST WISH I'D GET
HER.

I HATE BELLATRIX, BUT WE DEFINITELY INJURED REDHEADS. . . THEN WE

FALLEN WARRIOR

??

GET THE RON'S ALITTLE MURIEL'S AND WE'D MISSED HER PERTNEY AND
SHE

WAS MISSING EVERY LIS

A MUSCLE WAS LIMPING IN LUPIN'S TAIL, HE NEEDED, BUT SEEMED
UNABLE TO SAY ANYTHING ELSE.

SEE WHAT HAPPENED TO YOU LEFT? THENDS ASKED, TURNING TO HARRY,
HERMIONE, AND KINGSLY.

THEY RECALLED THE STORIES OF THEIR OWN JOURNEYS, BUT ALL THE
TIME

THE CONTINUED ABSENCE OF BILL, FLEW, MAD-EYE, AND MURDERER
SEEMED TO BE WITHIN THEM LIKE A FIRE, ITS ICE KITE HARDER AND HARDER
TO IGNORE.

I'M GOING TO HAVE TO GET BACK TO DOWLING STREET, I SHOULD HAVE
BEEN THERE AN HOUR AGO, SAID KINGSLY FINALLY, AFTER A LAST
SLEEPING

GLANCE AT THE SKY. LET ME KNOW WHEN THEY'RE BACK.

LUPIN NEEDED, WITH A WAVE TO THE OTHERS, KINGSLY WALKED AWAY
INTO THE DARKNESS TOWARD THE GATE, HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD THE
FAINTEST PEEP AS KINGSLY DISAPPEARED JUST BEYOND THE BARRIERS
OF THE

MRS. AND MRS. WEASLEY CAME RACING DOWN THE BACK STEPS, GINNY
BEHIND THEM, BOTH PARENTS HURRIED TO TURNING TO LUPIN
AND THENDS.

THANK YOU, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, FOR YOUR SHOTS.

DON'T BE SILLY, MUM, SAID THENDS AT ONCE.

HE'S GREEN? ASKED LUPIN.

WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM? PIPED UP GINNY.

HE'S LOST

BUT THE END OF MRS. WEASLEY'S SENTENCE WAS DROPPED IN A GEN-

ERAL FLUTTER: A THESTRAL HAD JUST SHARED THE SIGHT AND LANDED A FEW

FEET FROM THEM, BILL AND FLEUR SLID FROM ITS BACK, WINDSWEEP BLT
LINE-LIFT.

CHAPTER FIVE

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BILL: THANK GOOD, THANK GOOD

MRS. LEASLEY RAN FORWARD, BLT THE FILE BILL RESTORED WHEN HER
WAS PERCUSSION, LEADING DIRECTLY AT HIS FATHER, HE SAID, MAD-
EYE S

DEAD,

NEEDY SPEED, NEEDY MOVE, JARRY FELT AS THOUGH SOMETHING
INSIDE HIM WAS FALLING, FALLING THROUGH THE EARTH, LEAVING HIM
FOREVER.

WE SAW IT, SAID BILL; FLEUR NEEDED, TEAR TRACKS GLITTERING IN
HER CHEEKS IN THE LIGHT FROM THE KITCHEN WINDOW. IT HAPPENED
JUST

AFTER WE KNEW BLT OF THE CIRCLE: MAD-EYE AND DLING WERE CLOSE BY
US, THEY WERE HEADING NORTH THE, VERDIMENT HE CAN FLY WENT
STRAIGHT FOR THEM, DLING PANICKED, I HEARD HIM CRY BLT, MAD-EYE

TRIED TO STOP HIM, BLT HE DISAPPEARED, VERDIMENT S CLASH HIT MAD-
EYE FULL IN THE FACE, HE FELL BACKWARD OFF HIS KNEES AND THERE

WAS NOTHING WE COULD DO, NOTHING, WE HAD HALF A DOZEN OF THEM IN

HELD HIS TAIL

WILL I HAVE KNOWN,

HE CHASED THEM CHILDREN TO HAVE BEEN ANYTHING, SAID LUPIN,

THEY ALL STOOD LOOKING AT EACH OTHER, HARRY COULD NOT EVEN COM-
PREHEND IT, MAD-EYE DEAD, IT COULD NOT BE, ... MAD-EYE, THE THING,

THE BRAVE, THE UNSLAIN SURVIVOR ...

AT LAST IT SEEMED THE DAWN IN EVERYONE, THE THING NEARLY SAID IT, THAT
THERE WAS NO POINT WAITING IN THE YARD ANYMORE, AND IN SILENCE
THEY

WALKED MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY BACK INTO THE KITCHEN, AND INTO THE
LIVING ROOM, WHERE FRED AND GEORGE WERE LAUGHING TOGETHER.

WHAT IS WRONG? SAID FRED, SCANNING THEIR FACES AS THEY ENTERED.

WHAT IS HAPPENING? WHY IS ?

MAD-EYE, SAID MR. WEASLEY, DEAD.

THE TWINS GRINS TURNED THE GRIMACES OF SHOCK, NEARLY SEEMED

FALLING WARRIOR

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THE DREAM WHAT THE DREAM, TENDERS WAS CRYING SILENTLY INTO A
HANDKERCHIEF!

SHE HAD BEEN CLOSE TO MAD-EYE, HARRY KNEW, HIS FAVORITE AND HIS
FIRST & LAST AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, HARRY, WHO HAD SAT DOWN IN
THE CORNER IN THE CORNER WHERE HE HAD MOST SPACE, WAS DASHING AT
HIS

EYES WITH HIS TABLET-SIZED HANDBERCHER,

KILL WALKED OVER THE SIDEBOARD AND PULLED OUT A KETTLE OF FIRE-
WHISKY AND SOME GLASSES.

HERE, HE SAID, AND WITH A WAVE OF HIS HAND HE SENT TWELVE FULL
GLASSES SHARING THROUGH THE ROOM, ONE EACH OF THEM, FILLING THE
THIR-
TEENTH ALBERT. MAD-EYE.

MAD-EYE, THEY ALL SAID, AND DRANK.

MAD-EYE, REPLIED HAGRID, A LITTLE LATE, WITH A HICUP.
THE FIREWHISKY SEARED HARRY'S THROAT. IT SEEMED THE BLIND FEELING
BACK INTO HIM, DISPELLING THE DREAMINESS AND SENSE OF UNREALITY, FIR-
ING HIM WITH SOMETHING THAT WAS LIKE COURAGE.

THE MINDLINESS DISAPPEARED? SAID LUPIN, WHO HAD DRAINED HIS
OWN GLASS IN ONE.

THE ATMOSPHERE CHANGED AT ONCE. EVERYBODY LOOKED TENSE, WATCH-
ING LUPIN, BOTH WANTING HIM TO GO ON, IT SEEMED THE HARRY, AND
SLIGHTLY AFRAID OF WHAT THEY MIGHT HEAR.

I KNOW WHAT YOU'RE THINKING, SAID KILL, AND I WONDERED THAT
THEY,

WHEN THE WAY BACK HERE, BECAUSE THEY SEEMED TO BE EXPECTING US, DIDN'T THEY? BUT MUNDLINGUS CAN'T HAVE BETRAYED US. THEY DIDN'T KNOW THERE

WOULD BE SEVEN HARRYS, THAT CONVINCED THEM THE MOMENT WE APPEARED,

AND IN CASE YOU'VE FORGOTTEN, IT WAS MUNDLINGUS WHO SUGGESTED THAT

LITTLE BIT OF SKILLBEGGER, WHY WOULDN'T HE HAVE TOLD THEM THE ESSENTIAL

POINT? I THINK DUNE PANICKED, IT'S AS SIMPLE AS THAT. HE DIDN'T WANT THE

CHIEF IN THE FIRST PLACE, BUT MAD-EYE MADE HIM, AND YOU-KNOW-WHO WENT STRAIGHT FOR THEM. IT WAS ENOUGH TO MAKE ANYONE PANIC.

CHAPTER FIVE

YOU-KNOW-WHO ACTED EXACTLY AS MAD-EYE EXPECTED HIM TO, SNIPPED THINGS. MAD-EYE SAID HE'D EXPECT THE REAL HARRY TO BE WITH THE BRIGHTEST, MOST SKILLED ALIENS. HE CHASED MAD-EYE FIRST, AND WHEN MUNDLINGUS GAVE THEM AWAY HE SWITCHED TO DINGSLEY. . . .

YES, AND THAT WAS ALL VERY GOOD, SNAPPED FLEET, BUT STILL LET THEM NOT EXPLAIN HOW THEY KNEW WE WERE MOVING AWAY TONIGHT, DOESN'T IT?

SOMEONE MUST HAVE BEEN CARELESS. SOMEONE LET SLIP THE DATE THE ANCHORS. IT IS THE ONLY EXPLANATION FOR THEM KNOWING THE DATE BUT NOT

THE PLAN.

SHE GLARED AROUND AT THEM ALL, TEAR TRACKS STILL ETCHED IN HER
REAL-

TIFUL FACE, SILENTLY DARING ANY OF THEM TO CONTRADICT HER. NOBODY
DID.

THE ONLY SOUND THE BREAK THE SILENCE WAS THAT OF HAGRID HICCLING
FROM BEHIND HIS HANDKERCHIEF. HARRY GLANCED AT HAGRID, WHO HAD
JUST RISKED HIS OWN LIFE TO SAVE HARRY & HAGRID, WHEN HE LEAVED,
WHEN HE TRUSTED, WHO HAD ONCE BEEN TRICKED INTO GIVING
VERBEMERT

CRUCIAL INFORMATION IN EXCHANGE FOR A DRAGON'S EGG. . .

NO, HARRY SAID ALOUD, AND THEY ALL LOOKED AT HIM, SURPRISED:

THE FIREWHISKY SEEMED TO HAVE AMPLIFIED HIS VOICE. I MEAN . . . IF
SOMEONE MADE A MISTAKE, HARRY WENT ON, AND LET SOMETHING SLIP,
I KNOW THEY DIDN'T MEAN TO DO IT. IT'S NOT THEIR FAULT, HE REPEATED,
AGAIN A LITTLE LOUDER THAN HE WOULD USUALLY HAVE SPOKEN. WE'VE
GOT

THE TRUST EACH OTHER. I TRUST ALL OF YOU, I DON'T THINK ANYONE IN
THIS

ROOM WOULD EVER SELL ME THE VERBEMERT.

MORE SILENCE FOLLOWED HIS WORDS. THEY WERE ALL LOOKING AT HIM;
HARRY FELT A LITTLE BETT AGAIN, AND DROVE SOME MORE FIREWHISKY FOR
SOMETHING TO DO. AS HE DROVE, HE THOUGHT OF MAD-EYE. MAD-EYE
HAD ALWAYS BEEN SCATHING ABOUT DUMBLEDORE'S WILLINGNESS TO TRUST
PEOPLE.

FALLON LARRIER

WELL SAID, HARRY, SAID FRED LINEXPECTEDLY.

YEAH, EAR, EAR, SAID GEORGE, WITH HALF A GLANCE AT FRED, THE CORNER OF HIS MOUTH TWITCHED.

BLIPIN WAS WEARING AN EDD EXPRESSION AS HE LOOKED AT HARRY. IT WAS LIKE THE PITYING.

WELL THINK I M A FFFF? DEMANDED HARRY.

NO, I THINK YOU RE LIKE JAMES, SAID BLIPIN, WHO WOULD HAVE REGARDED IT AS THE RIGHT OF DISHONOR THE MISTRUST HIS FRIENDS. HARRY KNEW WHAT BLIPIN WAS GETTING AT: THAT HIS FATHER HAD BEEN BETRAYED BY HIS FRIEND, PETER PETTIGREW. HE FELT IRRATIONALLY ANGRY. HE

WANTED THE ANSWER, BUT BLIPIN HAD TURNED AWAY FROM HIM, SET DOWN HIS GLASS UPON A SIDE TABLE, AND ADDRESSED BILL. THERE S WHERE THE DEE. I CAN ASK KINGSLEY WHETHER

NO, SAID BILL AT ONCE. I LL DEE IT, I LL CHME.

WHERE ARE YOU GOING? SAID THOMAS AND FLEW TOGETHER.

MAD-EYE S EDDY, SAID BLIPIN. WE NEED THE RECHYER IT.

CAN T IT ? BEGAN MRS. WEASLEY WITH AN APPEALING LOOK AT BILL.

WAIT? SAID BILL. NOT UNLESS YOU D RATHER THE DEATH EATERS THEE IT?

NEEDY SPEER, BLIPIN AND BILL SAID GOOD-BYE AND LEFT.

THE REST OF THEM NOW DROPPED INTO CHAIRS, ALL EXCEPT FOR HARRY, WHO REMAINED STANDING. THE SUDDENNESS AND COMPLETENESS OF DEATH WAS WITH THEM LIKE A PRESENCE.

I'VE GOT TO GO THEN, SAID HARRY.
TEN PAIRS OF STARTLED EYES LOOKED AT HIM.

DON'T BE SILLY, HARRY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT?

CHAPTER FIVE

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I CAN'T STAY HERE.
HE RUBBED HIS FOREHEAD; IT WAS PRICKLING AGAIN. IT HAD NOT FELT LIKE THIS FOR MORE THAN A YEAR.
YOU'RE ALL IN DANGER WHILE I'M HERE. I DON'T WANT
BUT DON'T BE SO SILLY! SAID MRS. WEASLEY. THE LITTLE PRINT OF
TONIGHT WAS TO GET YOU HERE SAFELY, AND THANK GOODNESS IT WORKED.
AND FLEW AS AGREED TO GET MARRIED HERE RATHER THAN IN FRANCE,
WE'VE
ARRANGED EVERYTHING SO THAT WE CAN ALL STAY TOGETHER AND LIVE
AFTER
YOU
SHE DID NOT UNDERSTAND; SHE WAS MAKING HIM FEEL WORSE, NOT
BETTER.
IF VERMONT FINDS OUT I'M HERE

BUT WHY SHOULD HE? ASKED MRS. WEASLEY.

THERE ARE A DOZEN PLACES WHERE HE MIGHT BE NOW, HARRY, SAID MR. WEASLEY. HE'S GOT NO WAY OF KNOWING WHICH SIDE HE'LL BE IN.

IT'S NOT ME I'M WORRIED ABOUT! SAID HARRY.

WE KNOW THAT, SAID MR. WEASLEY QUIETLY, BUT IT WOULD MAKE OUR EFFORTS TONIGHT SEEM RATHER POINTLESS IF HE'LL LEFT.

PERHAPS HE'LL SHOW UP SOMEWHERE, GRIELED HAGRID. BLIMPY, HARRY, AFTER ALL WE WERE THROUGH TO GET HIM HERE?

YES, WHAT ABOUT MY BLEEDING EAR? SAID GEORGE, HOLDING HIMSELF UP ON HIS KNUCKLES.

I KNOW THAT

MAD-LYR WOULDNT WANT

I KNOW! HARRY REPLIED.

HE FELT RELEGATED AND BLACKMAILED! DID THEY THINK HE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT THEY HAD DONE FOR HIM, DIDN'T THEY UNDERSTAND THAT IT WAS FOR PRECISELY THAT REASON THAT HE WANTED THE CHIMNEY, BECAUSE THEY

FALLN WARRIOR

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HAD THE SLIPPER AND MORE ON HIS BEHALF? THERE WAS A LONG AND AWKWARD

SILENCE IN WHICH HIS SCAR CONTINUED THE PRICKLE AND TITCLE, AND WHICH

WAS BROKEN AT LAST BY MRS. WEASLEY,

WHERE'S HERMIE, HARRY? SHE SAID CHAMINGLY. WE CAN PUT HER UP WITH PIGWIDGEM AND GIVE HER SOMETHING TO EAT.

HIS INSIDES CLENCHED LIKE A FIST. HE COULD NOT TELL HER THE TRUTH. HE BRANDS THE LAST OF HIS FIREWHISKY THE AVOID ANSWERING.

WAIT TILL IT GETS HOT YEH DID IT AGAIN, HARRY, SAID HERMIE. ESCAPED HIM, FELT HIM OFF WHEN HE WAS RIGHT IN THE MIDDLE OF YEH!

IT WASN'T ME, SAID HARRY FLATLY. IT WAS MY WAND. MY WAND ACTED UP IT'S BEEN ACCORD.

AFTER A FEW MOMENTS, HERMIE SAID GENTLY, BUT THAT'S IMPOSSIBLE, HARRY, YEH MEAN THAT YEH DID MAGIC WITH-OUT MEANING THE YEH!

REACTED INSTINCTIVELY.

NO, SAID HARRY. THE RIDE WAS FALLING, I COULDN'T HAVE TOLD YEH WHERE VERBEMBERT WAS, BUT MY WAND SPUN IN MY HAND AND FELT HIM AND SENT A SPELL AT HIM, AND IT WASN'T EVEN A SPELL I RECOGNIZED.

I VE NEVER MADE CHILD FLAMES APPEAR BEFORE.

HEN, SAID MR. WEASLEY, WHEN YEH RE IN A PRESSURED SITUATION YEH CAN PRODUCE MAGIC YEH NEVER DREAMED OF. SMALL CHILDREN HEN FIND, BEFORE THEY RE TRAINED

IT WASN'T LIKE THAT, SAID HARRY THROUGH GRITTED TEETH. HIS SCAR

WAS BURNING; HE FELT ANGRY AND FRUSTRATED; HE HATED THE IDEA THAT THEY WERE ALL IMAGINING HIM THE HAVE FEELER THE MATCH VEEDMENT S, NEH HENK SAID ANYTHING, HE KNEW THAT THEY DID NOT BELIEVE HIM,

NEED THAT HE CAME THE THINK OF IT, HE HAD NEVER HEARD OF A WAND PER-

FORMING MAGIC HEN ITS HENK REPERE,

HIS STAR SEARED WITH PAIN; IT WAS ALL HE COULD BE NOT THE MEAN ALHED,

MUTTERING ABHUT FRESH AIR, HE SET DOWN HIS GLASS AND LEFT THE REHET,

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AS HE CROSSED THE DARK YARD, THE GREAT SKELETAL THESTRAL WHIRLED UP, RUSTLED ITS ENHYPHILIS KATHIXE WINGS, THEN RESUMED ITS GRAZING, HARRY

STEPPED AT THE GATE INTO THE GARDEN, STARING BLIT AT ITS EVERGREEN PLANTS,

BLINKING HIS PEELING AIRK-HEAD AND THINKING OF DUMBLEDORE,

DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE BELIEVED HIM, HE KNEW IT, DUMBLEDORE

WOULD HAVE KNOWN BEEN AND WHY HARRY S WAND HAD ACTED INDEPENDENTLY, BECAUSE DUMBLEDORE ALWAYS HAD THE ANSWERS; HE HAD KNOWN

ARHIT WANDS, HAD EXPLAINED THE FARRY THE STRANGE CONNECTION THAT
EXISTED BETWEEN HIS WAND AND VERDEMERT S. . . . BUT DUMKEDERE,
LIKE MAD-LYE, LIKE SIRILIS, LIKE HIS PARENTS, LIKE HIS OTHER HELL, ALL
WERE

GONE WHERE FARRY COULD NEVER TAKE THEM AGAIN. HE FELT A
BURNING

IN HIS THROAT THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH FIRE-FLIES . . .

AND THEN, HEIT HE NOWHERE, THE PAIN IN HIS STAR PEAKED. AS HE
CLUTCHED HIS FOREHEAD AND CLOSED HIS EYES, A VOICE SCREAMED INSIDE
HIS HEAD.

YELL TOLD ME THE PROBLEM WOULD BE SOLVED BY LISTING ANOTHER S
WAND:

AND IN THE MIND FIRST THE VISION OF AN EMACIATED OLD MAN LYING
IN RAGS WITHIN A STONE FLINT, SCREAMING, A TERRIBLE, DRAIN-HEIT
SCREAM,

A SCREAM OF UNENDING AGONY. . . .

NEE! NEE! I KEE YELL, I KEE YELL. . . .

YELL LIED THE LORD VERDEMERT, HILLIVANDER:

I DID NOT. . . . I SWEAR I DID NOT. . . .

YELL SOUGHT THE HELP BETTER, THE HELP HIM ESCAPE ME:

I SWEAR I DID NOT. . . . I BELIEVED A DIFFERENT WAND WOULD
WORK. . . .

EXPLAIN, THEN, WHAT HAPPENED, LILILIS S WAND IS DESTROYED:

I CANNOT UNDERSTAND. . . . THE CONNECTION . . . EXISTS ONLY . . . BE-
TWEEN YELL'S TWO WANDS. . . .

FALLEN WARRIOR

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LIES?

PLEASE . . . I REG YELL . . .

AND HARRY SAW THE WHITE HAND RAISE ITS HAND AND FELT VERDERBERT'S SURGE OF VICIOUS ANGER, SAW THE PALE OLD MAN IN THE FLEET WRITHE IN

AGONY

HARRY?

IT WAS EVER AS SWIFTLY AS IT HAD CAME: HARRY STOOD SHAKING IN THE DARKNESS, CLUTCHING THE GATE INTO THE GARDEN, HIS HEART RACING, HIS SKIN STILL TINGLING. IT WAS SEVERAL MOMENTS BEFORE HE REALIZED THAT

REIN AND HERMINE WERE AT HIS SIDE.

HARRY, CAME BACK IN THE HOUSE, HERMINE WHISPERED, YELL AREN'T STILL THINKING OF LEAVING?

YEAH, YELL WE GOT THE STAY, MATE, SAID REIN, THUMPING HARRY ON THE BACK.

ARE YELL ALL RIGHT? HERMINE ASKED, CLOSE ENOUGH WHEN THE WHISK INTO HARRY'S FACE. YELL WHISK AWAY!

WELL, SAID HARRY SHABILY, I PREFERABLY WHISK BETTER THAN FILL-YARDER . . .

WHEN HE HAD FINISHED TELLING THEM WHAT HE HAD SEEN, REIN WHISKED APPALLED, BUT HERMINE BELNRIGHT TERRIFIED,

BUT IT WAS SUPPOSED THEY WERE STOPPED! THEIR STAR IT WASN'T
SLIP-

PEESED THE DEE THIS ANYMORE? THEY MUSTN'T LET THAT CONNECTION OPEN
UP

AGAIN DUMBLEDORE WANTED THEM TO CLOSE THEIR MINDS!

WHEN HE DID NOT REPLY, SHE GRIPPED HIS ARM.

HARRY, HE'S TAKING OVER THE MINISTRY AND THE NEWSPAPERS AND
HALF

THE WIZARDING WORLD! DON'T LET HIM INSIDE THEIR HEADS!

CHAPTER SIX

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THE GHIIL IN PALMAMAS

HE STOOD UP LEAVING MAD-LYR FLYING OVER THE HOUSE IN THE DAYS
THAT FOLLOWED! HARRY KEPT EXPECTING TO SEE HIM STUMPING IN
THROUGH THE BACK DOOR LIKE THE OTHER ORDER MEMBERS, WHEN PASSED
IN AND HEARD THE RELAY NEWS, HARRY FELT THAT NOTHING BUT ACTION
WOULD

ASSUAGE HIS FEELINGS OF GUILT AND GRIEF AND THAT HE MIGHT THE SET
HELD HIM

HIS MISSION TO FIND AND DESTROY THE DARK LORDS AS SOON AS POSSIBLE.

WELL, THEY CAN'T DO ANYTHING ABOUT THE DARK LORDS THE

WHERE HERCULES TILL YOU'RE SEVENTEEN, YOU'VE STILL GOT THE
TRACE

AND YOU, AND WE CAN PLAN HERE AS WELL AS ANYWHERE, CAN'T WE? HE
HE DROPPED HIS VOICE TO A WHISPER, & YOU REMEMBER YOU ALREADY
KNOW

WHERE THE YOU-KNOW-WHATS ARE?

OH, HARRY ADMITTED,

I THINK HERMIONE'S BEEN DOING A BIT OF RESEARCH, SAID RON. SHE
SAID SHE WAS SAYING IT FOR WHEN YOU GET HERE.

THEY WERE SITTING AT THE BREAKFAST TABLE; MR. WEASLEY AND BILL HAD
T

THE GIBBS IN PALMERS

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JUST LEFT FOR WORK. MRS. WEASLEY HAD GONE UPSTAIRS TO MAKE
HERMIONE

AND GINNY, WHILE FLEUR HAD DRIFTED OFF TO TAKE A BATH.

THE TRACE IS BACK IN THE THIRTY-FIRST, SAID HARRY. THAT
MEANS

I ONLY NEED TO STAY HERE FIVE DAYS. THEN I CAN

FIVE DAYS, RON CORRECTED HIM FIRMLY. WE'VE GOT TO STAY FOR THE
WEDDING. THEY'LL KILL US IF WE MISS IT.

HARRY UNDERSTOOD THEY MEAN FLEUR AND MRS. WEASLEY.

IT'S ONE EXTRA DAY, SAID RON, WHEN HARRY NODDED MULTITUDES.

DON'T THEY REALIZE HOW IMPORTANT ?

CHURCH THEY DIDN'T, SAID RON. THEY HAVEN'T GOT A CLUE, AND
NEED

WE'LL MENTION IT, I WANTED TO TALK TO HER ABOUT THAT,

RON GLANCED TOWARD THE DOOR INTO THE HALL THE CHECK THAT MRS.
WEASLEY WAS NOT RETURNING YET, THEN LEANED IN CLOSER TO HARRY,

MUM'S BEEN TRYING TO GET IT OUT OF HERMIONIE AND ME, WHAT
WE'RE UP TO THE DEE. SHE'LL TRY HER NEXT, SHE BRACE HERSELF, DAD AND
LUPIN WE BOTH ASKED AS WELL, BUT WHEN WE SAID DUMBLEDORE TOLD HER
NOT TO TELL ANYONE EXCEPT US, THEY DROPPED IT, NOT MUM, THOUGH,
SHE'S DETERMINED,

RON'S PREDICTIONS CAME TRUE WITHIN HOURS, SHORTLY BEFORE LUNCH,
MRS. WEASLEY DETACHED HARRY FROM THE OTHERS BY ASKING HIM THE
HELP

IDENTIFY A LONE MAN'S CHECK THAT SHE THOUGHT MIGHT HAVE COME OUT
OF HIS BACKPACK, SINCE SHE HAD HIM CORNERED IN THE TINY SCULLERY
OFF

THE KITCHEN, SHE STARTED,

RON AND HERMIONIE SEEM TO THINK THAT THE THREE OF THEM ARE
DUMB-

ING OUT OF HERMIONIE, SHE BEGAN IN A LIGHT, CASUAL TONE,

HEH, SAID HARRY, WELL, YEAH, WE ARE,

THE MANGLE TURNED UP ITS HEAVY ACHE IN A CORNER, WRINGING OUT
WHAT LOOKED LIKE ONE OF MR. WEASLEY'S VESTS,

CHAPTER SIX

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MAY I ASK WHY YOU ARE ABANDONING YOUR EDUCATION? SAID MRS. WEASLEY.

WELL, DUMBLEDORE LEFT ME . . . STUFF THE DEE, MUMBLED HARRY.

RON AND HERMIONE DON'T BELIEVE IT, AND THEY WANT TO CHEER THEM.
WHAT SORT OF STUFF?

I'M SORRY, I CAN'T

WELL, FRANKLY, I THINK ARTHUR AND I HAVE A RIGHT TO KNOW, AND
I'M SURE MR. AND MRS. GRANGER WOULD AGREE! SAID MRS. WEASLEY.
HARRY HAD BEEN AFRAID OF THE CONCERNED PARENT ATTACK, HE FORCED
HIMSELF TO LEAN DIRECTLY INTO HER EYES, NOTICING AS HE DID SHE THAT
THEY WERE PRECISELY THE SAME SHADE OF GREEN AS GINNY'S. THIS DID
NOT HELP.

DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T WANT ANYONE ELSE TO KNOW, MRS. WEASLEY, I'M
SORRY, RON AND HERMIONE DON'T HAVE TO CHEER, IT'S THEIR CHOICE

I DIDN'T SEE THAT YOU HAVE TO CHOOSE! SHE SNAPPED, DROPPING
ALL

PRETENSE NOW. YOU'RE EARLY OF AGE, AND OF COURSE IT'S LITTLE
SENSIBLE.

IF DUMBLEDORE NEEDED WARD DING, HE HAD THE WIZARD HORDER AT HIS
COMMAND! HARRY, YOU MUST HAVE MISUNDERSTOOD HIM. PROBABLY HE
WAS TELLING YOU SOMETHING HE WANTED DING, AND YOU THOUGHT IT MEAN

THAT HE WANTED YOU

I DIDN'T MISUNDERSTAND, SAID HARRY FLATLY. IT'S GET THE DEE ME.

HE HANDED HER BACK THE SINGLE SHEET HE WAS SUPPOSED TO BE IDEN-

TIPPING, WHICH WAS PATTERNED WITH GOLDEN KLIMSHES.

AND THAT'S NEET MINE, I DENN'T SUPPERT PLOBBEMERE LIMITED.

HEH, HEH CHLORSE NEET, SAID MRS. WEASLEY WITH A SLIDEN AND RATHER LINGERING RETURN THE HER CASUAL THINK. I SHOULD HAVE REALIZED, WELL,

HARRY, WHILE WE'RE STILL GET WELL HERE, WELL WHEN'T MIND HELPING WITH

THE PREPARATIONS FOR BILL AND FLEER'S WEDDING, WILL WELL? THERE'S STILL

SEE MUCH THE DEE.

THE CHILL IN PAIAMS

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NEH I HE CHLORSE NEET, SAID HARRY, DISCHOKERTED BY THIS SLIDEN CHANGE HE SUBJECT.

SWEET HE WELL, SHE REPLIED, AND SHE SMILED AS SHE LEFT THE STILLERY.

FROM THAT MOMENT ON, MRS. WEASLEY KEPT HARRY, PERN, AND HER-MINEE SEE KISS WITH PREPARATIONS FOR THE WEDDING THAT THEY HARDLY

HAD ANY TIME THE THINK. THE KINDEST EXPLANATION HE THIS BEHAVIOR WOULD HAVE BEEN THAT MRS. WEASLEY WANTED THE DISTRACT THEM ALL

FROM THE LIGHTS OF MAD-EYE AND THE TERRORS OF THEIR RECENT
MILITARY,

AFTER TWO DAYS OF NEARLY CLUTTER CLEANING, OF CLOTH-MATCHING PA-
VERS, RICKERS, AND PLEASERS, OF DE-CHEMING THE GARDEN AND HELPING

MRS. LEASLEY CHECK VAST BATCHES OF CANNAS, HOWEVER, HARRY
STARTED

THE SUSPECT HER OF A DIFFERENT MOTIVE. ALL THE IDEAS SHE HANDED HIM
SEEMED TO KEEP HIM, RICH, AND DETERMINE ALAS FROM ONE ANOTHER;
HE HAD NOT HAD A CHANCE TO SPEAK TO HER TWO OF THEM ALONE SINCE
THE FIRST NIGHT, WHEN HE HAD TOLD THEM ABOUT VERMONT
THIRTLING

ELLIVANDER,

I THINK MUM THINKS THAT IF SHE CAN STOP THE THREE OF THEM
GETTING

TOGETHER AND PLANNING, SHE WILL BE ABLE TO DELAY THEM LEAVING, GINNY
TOLD HARRY IN AN UNDERSTANDING, AS THEY LAID THE TABLE FOR DINNER AND
THE

THIRD NIGHT OF HIS STAY,

AND THEN WHAT DOES SHE THINK IS GOING TO HAPPEN? HARRY MILIT-
TERED. SOMEONE ELSE MIGHT KILL HER VERMONT WHILE SHE IS HOLDING

US HERE MAKING WH-ALL-VENTS?

HE HAD SPOKEN WITHOUT THINKING, AND SAW GINNY'S FACE WHITEN.

IS IT TRUE? SHE SAID, THAT IS WHAT WE'RE TRYING TO DO?

I NOT I WAS THINKING, SAID HARRY EVASIVELY.

THEY STARED AT EACH OTHER, AND THERE WAS SOMETHING MORE THAN
SHOCK IN GINNY'S EXPRESSION. SUDDENLY HARRY BECAME AWARE THAT

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THIS WAS THE FIRST TIME THAT HE HAD BEEN ALONE WITH HER SINCE
THESE

STEVEN FEELS IN SECLUDED CORNERS OF THE HOGWARTS GREENHOUSE, HE
WAS

SURE SHE WAS REMEMBERING THEM TOO, BOTH OF THEM ILLEGITIMATE AS THE
DOOR OPENED, AND MR. WEASLEY, KINGSLEY, AND KILL WALKED IN.

THEY WERE OFTEN JOINED BY OTHER ORDER MEMBERS FOR DINNER NOW,
BECAUSE THE BLURRY HAD REPLACED NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINAL PLACE
AS THE HEADQUARTERS. MR. WEASLEY HAD EXPLAINED THAT AFTER THE
DEATH

OF DUMBLEDORE, THEIR SECRET-KEEPER, EACH OF THE PEOPLE WHO WERE
DUMBLEDORE HAD CHOSEN CRIMINAL PLACE'S LOCATION HAD BECOME
A SECRET-KEEPER IN TURN.

AND AS THERE ARE ABOUT TWENTY OF US, THAT GREATLY DILUTES THE
POWER OF THE FIDELITY CHARM. TWENTY TIMES AS MANY OPPORTUNITIES
FOR THE DEATH EATERS TO GET THE SECRET OUT OF SOMEONE. WE CAN'T
EXPECT IT TO HOLD MUCH LONGER.

BUT SURELY SNAPE WILL HAVE TOLD THE DEATH EATERS THE ADDRESS BY
NOW? ASKED HARRY.

WELL, MARY-POPE SET UP A CHAIN OF CLUES AGAINST SNAPE IN CASE

HE TURNS UP THERE AGAIN, WE HOPE THEY'LL BE STRONG ENOUGH WITH THE

KEEP HIM HURT AND TELL HIM HIS THOUGHTS IF HE TRIES TO TALK ABOUT THE

PLACE, BUT WE CAN'T BE SURE. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN INSANE TO KEEP LISTENING TO THE PLACE AS HEADQUARTERS WHEN THAT ITS PROTECTION HAS BECOME

SEE STARRY.

THE KITCHEN WAS SHE CRIEDED THAT EVENING IT WAS DIFFICULT TO MANAGE THE DENIVES AND THINGS, HARRY FEELING HIMSELF CRAMPED BESIDE

GINDY; THE LIES SAID THINGS THAT HAD JUST PASSED BETWEEN THEM MADE HIM WISH THEY HAD BEEN SEPARATED BY A FEW MORE PEOPLE. HE WAS TRYING SHE HAD THE AVOID BRUSHING HER ARM HE COULD BARELY CLUT HIS CHICKEN.

THE NEWS ABOUT MAD-EYE? HARRY ASKED BILL.

THE CROWD IN PALMERS

91

NOTHING, REPLIED BILL.

THEY HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO FIND A PLURAL FOR MURDER, BECAUSE BILL AND LUPIN HAD FAILED TO RECOVER HIS BODY. IT HAD BEEN DIFFICULT TO KNOW WHERE HE MIGHT HAVE FALLEN, GIVEN THE DARKNESS AND THE COMPLICATIONS OF THE BATTLE.

THE DAILY PROPHET HADN'T SAID A WORD ABOUT HIM DYING OR ABOUT FINDING THE BODY. BILL WENT ON. BUT THAT DOESN'T MEAN MUCH. IT'S KEEPING A LOW PROFILE THESE DAYS.

AND THEY STILL HAVEN'T CALLED A HEARING ABOUT ALL THE LINGERAGE MAGIC I USED ESCAPING THE DEATH EATERS? HARRY CALLED ACROSS THE TABLE TO MR. WEASLEY, WHO SHOOK HIS HEAD.

BECAUSE THEY KNOW I HAD NO CHOICE OR BECAUSE THEY DON'T WANT ME TO TELL THE WORLD VERDERBENT ATTACKED ME?

THE LATTER, I THINK. SCRIMGEWORM DOESN'T WANT TO ADMIT THAT VERDERBENT IS AS POWERFUL AS HE IS, NOR THAT AZKABAN'S BEEN A MASS

EXECUTION.

YES, WHY TELL THE PUBLIC THE TRUTH? SAID HARRY, CLENCHING HIS KNIFE SO TIGHTLY THAT THE PAINT SCARS ON THE BACK OF HIS RIGHT HAND

STOOD OUT, WHITE AGAINST HIS SKIN. I MUST NOT TELL LIES.

ISN'T ANYONE AT THE MINISTRY PREPARED TO STAND UP TO HIM? ASKED

RON ANGRILY.

OF COURSE, RON, BUT PEOPLE ARE TERRIFIED. MR. WEASLEY REPLIED, TERRIFIED THAT THEY WILL BE NEXT TO DISAPPEAR, THEIR CHILDREN THE NEXT

TO BE ATTACKED! THERE ARE NASTY RUMORS GOING AROUND. I HAVE HAD BEEN

BELIEVE THE MAGIC STUDIES PROFESSOR AT HOGWARTS RESIGNED. SHE HADN'T BEEN SEEN FOR WEEKS NOW. MEANWHILE SCRIMGEWORM REMAINS

SPLIT LIP IN HIS OFFICE ALL DAY! I JUST HOPE HE'S WORKING ON A PLAN.
THERE WAS A PALATE IN WHICH MRS. LEASLEY MAGICKED THE EMPTY
PLATES INTO THE WOOD SURFACE AND SERVED APPLE TART.

CHAPTER SIX

22

WE MUST DECIDE HOW MUCH WILL BE DISCLOSED, ARRY, SAID FLEUR,
HENCE EVERYONE HAD PLUDDING. FOR THE WEDDING, SHE ADDED, WHEN HE
WISHED CHNULSED. OF COURSE, NONE OF HER GUESTS ARE DEATH EATERS,
BUT WE CANNOT GUARANTEE THAT THEY WILL NOT LET SOMETHING SLIP AFTER
THEY ARE AD CHAMPAGNE.

FROM THIS, HARRY GATHERED THAT SHE STILL SUSPECTED HAGRID.

YES, GOOD POINT, SAID MRS. LEASLEY FROM THE TOP OF THE TABLE,

WHERE SHE SAT, SPECTACLES PERCHED ON THE END OF HER NOSE, SCAN-
NING AN IMMENSE LIST OF THINGS THAT SHE HAD SCRIBBLED ON A VERY LONG

PIECE OF PARCHMENT. NOW, BEN, HAVE YOU CLEANED UP YOUR ROOM
YET?

WHY? EXCLAIMED BEN, SLAMMING HIS SPEECH DOWN AND GLARING
AT HIS MOTHER. WHY DOES MY ROOM HAVE TO BE CLEANED UP? HARRY
AND I ARE FINE WITH IT THE WAY IT IS!

WE ARE HOLDING YOUR BROTHER'S WEDDING HERE IN A FEW DAYS' TIME,
YOUNG MAN

AND ARE THEY GETTING MARRIED IN MY BEDROOM? ASKED RICH FLIR-
TULOUSLY. NO! SHE LIES IN THE NAME OF MERLIN'S SAGE'S LEFT

DON'T TALK TO ME LIKE THAT, SAID MR. WEASLEY FIRMLY,
AND BE AS YOU'RE TOLD.

RICH STUMBLED AT BOTH HIS PARENTS, THEN PICKED UP HIS SPEECH AND
ATTACKED THE LAST FEW MEMENTOS OF HIS APPLE TART.

I CAN HELP, SOME OF IT'S MY MESS, HARRY TOLD RICH, BUT MRS.
WEASLEY CUT ACROSS HIM.

NO, HARRY, DEAR, I'D MUCH RATHER YOU HELPED ARTHUR MUCK WITH
THE CHICKENS, AND HERMIONE, I'D BE EVER SO GRATEFUL IF YOU'D CHANGE
THE SHEETS FOR MISSIE AND MADAME DEACON; YOU KNOW THEY'RE
ARRIVING AT ELEVEN THIRTY THIS MORNING.

BUT AS IT TURNED OUT, THERE WAS VERY LITTLE TO DO FOR THE CHICKENS.

THE GELIN IN PAJAMAS

RE

THERE'S NO NEED TO, ER, MENTION IT TO ME, MR. WEASLEY TOLD
HARRY, BLENDING HIS ACCENT TO THE CHIEF, BUT, ER, TED THINKS SENT
ME

MOST OF WHAT WAS LEFT OF SIRIL'S SKELETON AND, ER, I'M HIDING THAT'S

THE SAY, KEEPING IT IN HERE, FANTASTIC STUFF! THERE'S AN EXPERT
CASE-

YES, AS I BELIEVE IT'S CALLED, THE MOST MAGNIFICENT BATTERY, AND IT'LL

BE A GREAT OPPORTUNITY TO FIND OUT HOW THINGS WERE, I'M GOING TO
TRY AND PUT IT ALL BACK TOGETHER AGAIN WHEN MARY'S HERE. I
MEAN,

WHEN I GET TIME.

WHEN THEY RETURNED TO THE HOUSE, MRS. WEAVER WAS NOWHERE TO
BE SEEN, SO HARRY SLIPPED UPSTAIRS TO JOHN'S ATTIC BEDROOM.

I'M DOING IT, I'M DOING IT! HEY, IT'S HERE, SAID JOHN IN RELIEF, AS
HARRY ENTERED THE ROOM. JOHN LAY BACK DOWN ON THE BED, WHICH HE
HAD EVIDENTLY JUST VACATED. THE ROOM WAS JUST AS MESSY AS IT HAD
BEEN ALL WEEK; THE ONLY CHANGE WAS THAT FERMINE WAS NOW
SITTING

IN THE FAR CORNER, HER FLUFFY GINGER CAT, CREAMSHANKS, AT HER FEET,
SHEDDING FEATHERS, SOME OF WHICH HARRY RECOGNIZED AS HIS OWN, IN THE
TWO ENORMOUS PILES.

HI, HARRY, SHE SAID, AS HE SAT DOWN ON HIS CAMP BED.

AND HOW DID YOU MANAGE TO GET AWAY?

HEY, JOHN'S MOM FORGET THAT SHE ASKED GINNY AND ME TO CHANGE
THE SHEETS YESTERDAY, SAID FERMINE. SHE THREW OLIVER TWIST AND
GRAMMATICA INTO THE FIRE AND THE RISE AND FALL OF THE DARK ARTS
INTO THE BATH.

WE WERE JUST TALKING ABOUT MAD EYE, JOHN TOLD HARRY. I REMEMBER
HE MIGHT HAVE SURVIVED.

BUT BILL SAW HIM HIT BY THE KILLING CURSE, SAID HARRY.

YEAH, BUT BILL WAS UNDER ATTACK THEN, SAID JOHN. HOW CAN HE BE
SURE WHAT HE SAW?

EVEN IF THE KILLING CURSE MISSED, MAD EYE STILL FELL ABOUT A

CHAPTER SIX

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THOUSAND FEET, SAID HERMIONE, NEW WEIGHING ELUDITCH TEAMS OF
BRITAIN AND IRELAND IN HER HAND.

HE COULD HAVE USED A SHIELD CHARM

FLUR SAID HIS HAND WAS BLASTED OUT OF HIS HAND, SAID HARRY.

WELL, ALL RIGHT, IF YOU WANT HIM THEN BE DEAD, SAID RON GRUMPILY,
PUNCHING HIS PILLER INTO A MORE COMFORTABLE SHAPE.

HE COULD BE DEN'T WANT HIM THEN BE DEAD? SAID HERMIONE, LEERING
SMILED. IT'S DREADFUL THAT HE'S DEAD? BUT WE'RE BEING REALISTIC?
FOR THE FIRST TIME, HARRY IMAGINED MAD-EYE'S EYES, BRIGHTEN AS
DUMBLEDORE'S HAD BEEN, YET WITH THAT HENRY EYE STILL WHIZZING IN ITS
SHEATH, HE FELT A STAB OF REVULSION MIXED WITH A BIZARRE DESIRE TO
LAUGH.

THE DEATH EATERS PRECARIOUSLY TIDIED UP AFTER THEMSELVES, THAT'S WHY
NOW HE'S FINDING HIM, SAID RON WISPLY.

Yeah, SAID HARRY. LIKE KARTY COLEMAN, TURNED INTO A BONE AND
BURIED IN HAGRID'S FRONT GARDEN. THEY PRECARIOUSLY TRANSFIGURED
MURDER
AND STUFFED HIM

DEN'T? SNEAKED HERMIONE. STARTLED, HARRY LEANED OVER INSTANTLY
IN TIME TO SEE HER BURST INTO TEARS OVER HER COPY OF SPELLMAN'S
SYLLABARY.

HEY NEE, SAID HARRY, STRUGGLING TO GET UP FROM THE HED CAMP

RED, HERMINE, I WASN'T TRYING THE LIPSET

BUT WITH A GREAT CREAKING OF RUSTY BEDSPRINGS, REN ROLLED OFF THE BED AND GOT THERE FIRST. HEW ARM AROUND HERMINE, HE FISHED IN HIS JEANS POCKET AND WITHDREW A REVEALING-LOOKING HANDKERCHIEF

THAT HE HAD USED THE CLEAN HLT THE EVEN EARLIER. FASTLY PULLING HLT

HIS HAND, HE POINTED IT AT THE RAG AND SAID, 'THEREH.

THE HAND SIPPENED OFF MOST OF THE GREASE, LOOKING RATHER PLEASED

THE GHELL IN PALAMAS

AS

WITH HIMSELF, REN HANDED THE SLIGHTLY SMOKING HANDKERCHIEF THE HERMINE.

EH... THANKS, REN... I'M SORRY... SHE BLEW HER NOSE AND HICCUPEH. IT'S JUST SHE ALW-PLA, ISN'T IT? R-RIGHT AFTER DUMKLEBERH... ,

I I-ILST N-NEVER IMAGINED MAD-EYE DYING, SHERM-HEH, HE SEEMED SHE TELIGH?

YEAH, I KNOW, SAID REN, GIVING HER A SHELPEZE. BUT YELL KNOW WHAT HE'D SAY THE LIS IF HE WAS HERE?

CONSTANT VIGILANCE, SAID HERMINE, MIPPING HER EYES.

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID REN, NODDING. HE'D TELL LIS THE LEARN FROM WHAT HAPPENED THE HIM, AND WHAT I'VE LEARNED IS NHT THE TRULST THAT CHEARDLY LITTLE SHLIT, MINDBLINGLIS.

HERMINE GAVE A SHADY LAUGH AND LEANED FORWARD THE PICK UP THE

MORE BOOKS. A SECOND LATER, RON HAD SNATCHED HIS ARM BACK FROM
AROUND HER SHOULDERS; SHE HAD DROPPED THE MINSTER BOOK OF
MINISTERS

ON HIS FEET. THE BOOK HAD BOUNDED FREE FROM ITS RESTRAINING BELT
AND

SNAPPED VIOLENTLY AT RON'S ANKLE.

I'M SORRY, I'M SORRY! HERMIONE CRIED AS HARRY WRENCHED THE
BOOK FROM RON'S LEG AND RETIED IT SHIT.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING WITH ALL THESE BOOKS ANYWAY? RON ASKED,
LIMPING BACK TO HIS BED.

JUST TRYING TO DECIDE WHICH ONES TO TAKE WITH US, SAID HERMIONE.
WHEN WE'RE LOOKING FOR THE HEURLOCKES.

EH, OF COURSE, SAID RON, CLAPPING A HAND TO HIS FOREHEAD. I
MIGHT WE BE HUNTING DOWN VERBEMPT IN A MOBILE LIBRARY.

HA HA, SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING DOWN AT SPELLMAN'S SYLLABARY. I
WONDER... WILL WE NEED TO TRANSLATE ALINES? IT'S POSSIBLE... I
THINK

WE'D BETTER TAKE IT, THEN BE SAFE.

CHAPTER SIX

THE

SHE DROPPED THE SYLLABARY BENTH THE LARGER OF THE TWO PILES AND
PICKED UP HEGHARTS, A HISTORY.

LISTEN, SAID HARRY.

HE HAD SAT UP STRAIGHT. RON AND HERMIONE LOOKED AT HIM WITH
SIMILAR MIXTURES OF RESIGNATION AND DEFIANCE.

I KNOW YOU SAID AFTER DUMBLEDORE'S FUNERAL THAT YOU WANTED THE
CAMP WITH ME, HARRY BEGAN.

HERE HE GOES, RON SAID TO HERMION, ROLLING HIS EYES.

AS WE KNOW HE WOULD, SHE SIGHED, TURNING BACK THE OTHER BOOKS.

YOU KNOW, I THINK I WILL TAKE HOGWARTS, A HISTORY, EVEN IF
WE'RE

NOT GOING BACK THERE, I DON'T THINK I'D FEEL RIGHT IF I DIDN'T HAVE IT
WITH

LISTER? SAID HARRY AGAIN.

NO, HARRY, YOU LISTEN, SAID HERMION. WE'RE CAMPING WITH YOU.
THAT WAS DECIDED MONTHS AGO YEARS, REALLY.

BUT

SPLIT UP, RON ADVISED HIM.

ARE YOU SURE YOU'VE THOUGHT THIS THROUGH? HARRY
PERSISTED.

LET'S SEE, SAID HERMION, SLAPPING TRAVELS WITH TREES INTO
THE DISCARDED PILE WITH A RATHER FIERCE LOOK. I'VE BEEN PACKING FOR
DAYS, SO WE'RE READY TO LEAVE AT A MOMENT'S NOTICE, WHICH FOR YOUR
INFORMATION HAS INCLUDED DOING SOME PRETTY DIFFICULT MAGIC, NOT TO
MENTION SMOGGING MAD-EYE'S WHEEL STICK OF PHOSPHORUS PENTHER
RIGHT

UNDER RON'S FILM'S NOSE.

I'VE ALSO MEDDLED MY PARENTS' MEMORIES SO THAT THEY'RE CON-
VINCED THEY'RE REALLY CALLED WENDELL AND MERICA WILKINS, AND THAT

THEIR LIFE'S ADVENTURE IS THE MOVE TO AUSTRALIA, WHICH THEY HAVE
NEED

DEEN, THAT'S THE MAKE IT MORE DIFFICULT FOR VERDERBERT THE TRACK
THEM

THE CHILD IN PALMIS

??

DEEN AND INTERPRETATE THEM ABOUT ME HER YELL, BECAUSE UNFORTU-
NATELY, I'VE TOLD THEM ABOUT A BIT ABOUT YELL.

ASSUMING I SURVIVE HER FIRST FOR THE FIERCEWORKS, I'LL FIND MOM
AND DAD AND LIFT THE ENCHANTMENT. IF I DON'T WELL, I THINK I'VE
LOST A GOOD ENOUGH CHANCE TO KEEP THEM SAFE AND HAPPY. WENDY
AND MENICA WILKINS DON'T KNOW THAT THEY'VE GOTTEN A DAUGHTER, YELL
SEE.

HERMINE'S EYES WERE SWIMMING WITH TEARS AGAIN. DEN GET BACK
OFF THE BED, PUT HIS ARM AROUND HER NECK THERE, AND FREELAND AT
HARRY AS TELLING REPROACHING HIM FOR LACK OF TACT. HARRY COULD
NOT

THINK OF ANYTHING TO SAY, NOT LEAST BECAUSE IT WAS HIGHLY
UNUSUAL FOR

DEN THE BE TEACHING ANYONE ELSE TACT.

I HERMINE, I'M SORRY I DIDN'T
DIDN'T REALIZE THAT DEN AND I KNOW PERFECTLY WELL WHAT MIGHT
HAPPEN IF WE COME WITH YELL? WELL, WE DO, DEN, STILL HARRY WHAT
YELL'VE DONE.

NAH, HE'S JUST EATEN, SAID DEN.

SEE DEN, HE NEEDS THE KNOW

HEY, ALL RIGHT, HARRY, COME HERE.

FOR THE SECOND TIME REIN WITHDREW HIS ARM FROM ARIEL'S GRASP AND STUMPED OVER TO THE DEER.

[MNN.

WHAT? HARRY ASKED, FEELING REIN HURT BY THE ROOM ENTERED THE TINY LANDING.

DESCENDING, MUTTERED REIN, POINTING HIS HAND AT THE LOW CEILING. A HATCH OPENED RIGHT OVER THEIR HEADS AND A LADDER SLID DOWN THE THEIR

FEET. A TERRIBLE, HALF-SLICKING, HALF-MEANING SOUND CAME OUT OF THE

SHARP HISS, ALONG WITH AN UNPLEASANT SMELL LIKE OPEN DRAINS.

CHAPTER SIX

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THAT SOUNDS GROSS, DOESN'T IT? ASKED HARRY, WHO HAD NEVER ACTUALLY

MET THE CREATURE THAT SOMETIMES DISRUPTED THE NIGHTLY SILENCE.

Yeah, IT IS, SAID REIN, CLIMBING THE LADDER. COME AND HAVE A LOOK AT HIM.

HARRY FOLLOWED REIN UP THE FEW SHORT STEPS INTO THE TINY ATTIC SPACE. HIS HEAD AND SHOULDERS WERE IN THE ROOM BEFORE HE COULD GET SIGHT OF THE CREATURE CRAWLED UP A FEW FEET FROM HIM, FAST ASLEEP IN THE GLEAM WITH ITS LARGE MOUTH WIDE OPEN.

BUT IT . . . IT LOOKS . . . OH GHEHLS NORMALLY WEAR PALAMAS?

OH, SAID RENN. WHEN HAVE THEY USUALLY GOTTEN RED HAIR FOR THAT
ALM-

FOR THE PLEISTOCENE.

HARRY CONTEMPLATED THE THING, SLIGHTLY REVOLTED. IT WAS HUMAN IN
SHAPE AND SIZE, AND WAS WEARING WHAT, WHEN THAT HARRY'S EYES
BECAME

USED THE THE DARKNESS, WAS CLEARLY AN OLD PAIR OF RENN'S PALAMAS. HE
WAS ALSO SURE THAT GHEHLS WERE GENERALLY RATHER SLIM AND BALD,
RATHER

THAN DISTINCTLY HAIRY AND COVERED IN ANGRY PURPLE BLISTERS.

HE'S ME, SEE? SAID RENN.

OH, SAID HARRY. I DON'T.

I'LL EXPLAIN IT BACK IN MY ROOM, THE SPELL'S GETTING THE ME, SAID
RENN. THEY CLIMBED BACK DOWN THE LADDER, WHICH RENN RETURNED THE
THE CEILING, AND REMAINED HERMINE, WHO WAS STILL SHUTTING EYES.

SINCE WE'VE LEFT, THE GHEHL'S GOING THE HOME AND LIVE DOWN HERE IN
MY ROOM, SAID RENN. I THINK HE'S REALLY LOOKING FORWARD TO IT
WELL.

IT'S HARD TO TELL, BECAUSE ALL HE CAN DO IS MEAN AND DRONE. BUT HE
NEEDS A LITTLE WHEN YOU MENTION IT. ANYWAY, HE'S GOING TO BE ME WITH
SPATTERHEAD, GHEH, EH

HARRY MERELY LAUGHED HIS CHELISHLY.

IT IS? SAID RENN, CLEARLY FRUSTRATED THAT HARRY HAD NOT GRASPED
THE BRILLIANCE OF THE PLAN. LAUGH, WHEN WE THREE DON'T TURN UP AT

THE GHEUL IN PALMAMAS

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FINGLARTS AGAIN, EVERYONE'S GOING TO THINK HERMINE AND I MUST BE

WITH YEL, RIGHT? WHICH MEANS THE DEATH EATERS WILL GO STRAIGHT FOR

HER FAMILIES TO SEE IF THEY'VE GOTT INFORMATION ON WHERE YEL ARE.

BUT HAPPILY IT'LL BE LIKE I'VE GONE AWAY WITH MUM AND DAD; A LOT OF MUGGLE-BORN ARE TALKING ABOUT GOING INTO HIDING AT THE MOMENT, SAID HERMINE.

WE CAN'T HIDE MY WHOLE FAMILY, IT'LL BE LIKE THE FISH AND THEY CAN'T ALL LEAVE THEIR HOPS, SAID BEN. SHE WAS GOING TO PUT OUT THE STORY

THAT I'M SERIOUSLY ILL WITH SPATTERGHEIT, WHICH IS WHY I CAN'T GO BACK

THE SCHOOL. IF ANYONE COMES CALLING TO INVESTIGATE, MUM OR DAD CAN SHOW THEM THE GHEUL IN MY EYE, COVERED IN PLISTLES. SPATTERGHEIT'S

REALLY CONTAGIOUS, SHE THEY'RE NOT GOING TO WANT TO BE NEAR HIM. IT

DON'T MATTER THAT HE CAN'T SAY ANYTHING, EITHER, BECAUSE APPARENTLY

YEL CAN'T HEAR THE FLINGLES HAS SPREAD THE YELER LYOLA.

AND YELER MUM AND DAD ARE IN ON THIS PLAN? ASKED HARRY.

DAD IS, HE HELPED FRED AND GEORGE TRANSFORM THE GHEUL.

MUM... WELL, YEL'VE SEEN WHAT SHE'S LIKE. SHE WON'T ACCEPT WE'RE GOING TILL WE'VE GONE.

THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE ROOM, BROKEN ONLY BY GENTLE THUDS AS HERMIONE CONTINUED THE THREE BOOKS UNTIL HER PILE WAS THE EITHER, THEN SAT WATCHING HER, AND HARRY LEANED FROM HER THE THE EITHER, UNABLE TO SAY ANYTHING. THE MEASURES THEY HAD TAKEN TO PROTECT THEIR FAMILIES MADE HIM REALIZE, MORE THAN ANYTHING ELSE COULD HAVE DONE, THAT THEY REALLY WERE GOING TO COME WITH HIM AND THAT THEY KNEW EXACTLY HOW DANGEROUS THAT WOULD BE. HE WANTED TO TELL THEM WHAT THAT MEANT TO HIM, BUT HE SIMPLY COULD NOT FIND WORDS IMPORTANT ENOUGH.

THROUGH THE SILENCE CAME THE MUFFLED SOUNDS OF MRS. WEASLEY SPEAKING FROM HER ROOMS BELOW.

CHAPTER SIX

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GINNY'S PROBABLY LEFT A SPECK OF BUTTER ON A PEACH NAPKIN RING, SAID REN. I DON'T KNOW WHY THE DELACOURS HAVE GOTTEN THE COME TWO DAYS BEFORE THE WEDDING.

FLOR'S SISTER'S A BRIDESMAID, SHE NEEDS TO BE HERE FOR THE REHEARSAL,

AND SHE'S THE ONLY ONE THE COME IN HER OWN, SAID HERMIONE, AS SHE PHEED INDECISIVELY OVER BREAK WITH A BANISH.

WELL, GUESTS AREN'T GOING TO HELP WITH MY STRESS LEVELS, SAID REN.

WHAT WE REALLY NEED TO DECIDE, SAID HERMIONE, TESTING DEFENSIVE MAGICAL THEORY INTO THE RIN WITHOUT A SECOND GLANCE AND PICKING

UP AN APPRAISAL OF MAGICAL EDUCATION IN EUROPE, IS WHERE WE'RE
GOING AFTER WE LEAVE HERE. I KNOW YOU SAID YOU WANTED THE GO THE
GODRIC & HELENA FIRST, HARRY, AND I UNDERSTAND WHY, BUT ... WELL ...
SHOULDN'T WE MAKE THE FURCULONES OUR PRIORITY?

IF WE KNOW WHERE ANY OF THE FURCULONES WERE, I'D AGREE WITH
YOU,

SAID HARRY, WHO DID NOT BELIEVE THAT HERMIONE REALLY UNDERSTOOD
HIS

DESIRE TO RETURN TO GODRIC & HELENA. HIS PARENTS' GRAVES WERE
ONLY

PART OF THE ATTRACTION: HE HAD A STRONG, THOUGH UNEXPLICABLE,
FEELING

THAT THE PLACE HELD ANSWERS FOR HIM. PERHAPS IT WAS SIMPLY
BECAUSE IT

WAS THERE THAT HE HAD SURVIVED VOLDMORT'S KILLING CURSE; NOW
THAT

HE WAS FACING THE CHALLENGE OF REPEATING THE FEAT, HARRY WAS
DRAWN

TO THE PLACE WHERE IT HAD HAPPENED, WANTING TO UNDERSTAND.

DIDN'T YOU THINK THERE'S A POSSIBILITY THAT VOLDMORT'S KEEPING

A WATCH ON GODRIC & HELENA? HERMIONE ASKED. HE MIGHT EXPECT

YOU TO GO BACK AND VISIT YOUR PARENTS' GRAVES SINCE YOU'RE FREE TO
GO

WHEREVER YOU LIKE?

THIS HAD NOT OCCURRED TO HARRY. WHILE HE STRUGGLED TO FIND A
COUNTERARGUMENT, SHE SPED UP, EVIDENTLY FOLLOWING HIS OWN
TRAIN

OF THOUGHT.

THE GHELU IN PALAMAS

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THIS RAB, PERSON, HE SAID, WILL KNOW, THE ONE WHO STEAL THE REAL LOCKET?

HERMINEE NEEDED.

HE SAID IN HIS MIND HE WAS GOING TO DESTROY IT, DIDN'T HE?

HARRY DRAGGED HIS RUCKSACK TOWARD HIM AND PULLED OUT THE FAKE LOCKET IN WHICH RAB, S MIND WAS STILL HELD.

I HAVE STOLEN THE REAL LOCKET AND INTEND TO DESTROY IT AS SOON AS

I CAN, HARRY READ OUT.

WELL, WHAT IF HE DID FINISH IT NOW? SAID REIN.

HE SHE, INTERPOSED HERMINEE.

WHICHEVER, SAID REIN, IT DOESN'T MATTER LESS FOR US TO DO.

YES, BUT WE'RE STILL GOING TO HAVE TO TRY AND TRACE THE REAL LOCKET, AREN'T WE? SAID HERMINEE, THE FIND OUT WHETHER HE MEET IT'S

DESTROYED.

AND SINCE WE GET HOLD OF IT, HOW DO YOU DESTROY A LOCKET? ASKED REIN.

WELL, SAID HERMINEE, I'VE BEEN RESEARCHING THAT.

WELL? ASKED HARRY, I DIDN'T THINK THERE WERE ANY BOOKS ON LOCKETS IN THE LIBRARY?

THERE WEREN'T, SAID HERMINEE, WHO HAD TURNED PINK. DUMBLE-

THEY REMOVED THEM ALL, BUT HE HE DIDN'T DESTROY THEM.

REIN SAT UP STRAIGHT, WIDE-EYED.

HOW IN THE NAME OF MERLIN'S PANTS HAVE YOU MANAGED TO GET YOUR HANDS ON THESE HERCULES BOOKS?

IT IT WASN'T STEALING! SAID HERMINE, LEERING FROM HARRY THE REIN WITH A KIND OF DESPERATION. THEY WERE STILL LIBRARY BOOKS, EVEN

IF DUMBLEDORE HAD TAKEN THEM OFF THE SHELVES. ANYWAY, IF HE REALLY DIDN'T WANT ANYONE TO GET AT THEM, I'M SURE HE WOULD HAVE MADE IT MUCH HARDER TO

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GET THE POINT? SAID REIN.

WELL... IT WAS EASY, SAID HERMINE IN A SMALL VOICE. I JUST DID A SLIGHTLY CHARM. YOU KNOW ALICE, AND THEY ZOOMED OUT OF DUMBLEDORE'S STUDY WINDOW RIGHT INTO THE GIRLS' DORMITORY.

BUT WHEN DID YOU DO THIS? HARRY ASKED, REGARDING HERMINE WITH A MIXTURE OF ADMIRATION AND INCREDULITY.

JUST AFTER HIS DUMBLEDORE'S FUNERAL, SAID HERMINE IN AN EVEN SMALLER VOICE. RIGHT AFTER WE AGREED WE'D LEAVE SCHOOL AND GO AND LIVE FOR THE HERCULES. WHEN I WENT BACK UPSTAIRS TO GET MY THINGS IT IT JUST OCCURRED TO ME THAT THE MORE WE KNEW ABOUT THEM, THE BETTER IT WOULD BE... AND I WAS ALONE IN THERE...

SHE TRIED . . . AND IT WORKED. THEY FLEW STRAIGHT IN THROUGH THE
OPEN

WINDOWS AND I I PACKED THEM.

SHE STALLED AND THEN SAID IMPLORINGLY, I CAN'T BELIEVE DIM-
BLENDRE WOULD HAVE BEEN ANGRY, IT'S NOT AS THOUGH WE'RE GIVING THE
LIFE

THE INFORMATION THE MADE A FIERCELY, IS IT?

CAN YOU HEAR HIS COMPLAINING? SAID REN. WHERE ARE THESE
KINDS ANYWAY?

BERMINE RUMAGED FOR A MOMENT AND THEN EXTRACTED FROM
THE PILE A LARGE VOLUME, BOUND IN FADED BLACK LEATHER. SHE LOOKED

A LITTLE NERVOUS AND HELD IT AS GINGERLY AS IF IT WERE SOMETHING
RE-

CENTLY DEAD.

THIS IS THE ONE THAT GIVES EXPLICIT INSTRUCTIONS FOR HOW THE MADE
A FIERCELY. SECRETS OF THE DARKEST ART IT'S A FIERCELY KIND,
REALLY

ALSO, FULL OF EVIL MAGIC. I WONDER WHEN DIMBLENDRE REMOVED IT
FROM THE LIBRARY. . . . IF HE DIDN'T DO IT UNTIL HE WAS HEADMASTER, I GET
VANDERBILT GET ALL THE INSTRUCTIONS HE NEEDED FROM HERE.

WHY DID HE HAVE THE ASK SULLY-THORN HOW THE MADE A FIERCELY, THEN,
IF HE'D ALREADY READ THAT? ASKED REN.

THE CHILD IN PAJAMAS

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HE ONLY APPROXIMATED SLUGGISHLY THE FIND FELT WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF
WELL SPLIT THEIR SKIN INTO SEVEN, SAID HARRY, DUMBLEDORE WAS SURE
RIDDLE ALREADY KNEW HOW THEY MADE A FURROW BY THE TIME HE ASKED
SLUGGISHLY ABOUT THEM, I THINK WELL ARE RIGHT, DETERMINE, THAT CHILD
EASILY HAVE BEEN WHERE HE GOT THE INFORMATION.

AND THE MORE I VE READ ABOUT THEM, SAID DETERMINE, THE MORE
HORRIBLE THEY SEEM, AND THE LESS I CAN BELIEVE THAT HE ACTUALLY MADE
SIX, IT WARNS IN THIS BOOK HOW UNSTABLE WELL MADE THE REST OF
THEIR

SKIN BY RIPPING IT, AND THAT S ILST BY MAKING ONE FURROW?
HARRY REMEMBERED WHAT DUMBLEDORE HAD SAID ABOUT VILDEMENT
MOVING BEYOND USUAL PAIN.

ISN T THERE ANY WAY OF PUTTING THEMSELVES BACK TOGETHER? REEN
ASKED.

YES, SAID DETERMINE WITH A HELPLESS SMILE, BUT IT WOULD BE EX-
CRUCIATINGLY PAINFUL.

HOW? HOW DO THEY DO IT? ASKED HARRY.

REMEMBER, SAID DETERMINE, WELL VE GOT THE REALLY FEEL WHAT WELL VE
DOING, THERE S A FEETNOTE, APPARENTLY THE PAIN OF IT CAN DESTROY
WELL.

I CAN T SEE VILDEMENT ATTEMPTING IT THEMSELVES, CAN WELL?

NO, SAID REEN, BECAUSE HARRY COULD ANSWER, SHE DOES IT SAY HOW

THE DESTROYED FURCULINES IN THAT BLOOD?

YES, SAID HERMIONE, NOW TURNING THE FRAGILE PAGES AS IF EXAMINING BOTTLED ENTRAILS, BECAUSE IT WARNS DARK WIZARDS FEEL STRONG THEM

HAVE THE MADE THE ENCHANTMENTS FOR THEM, FROM ALL THAT I VE READ, WHAT HARRY DID THE RIDDLE S DIARY WAS HERE IF THE FEEL REALLY FEEL THEM

WAYS OF DESTROYING A FURCULINE,

WHAT, STABBING IT WITH A BASILISK FANG? ASKED HARRY,

WELL, UNLESS WE VE GOT SUCH A LARGE SUPPLY OF BASILISK FANGS, THEN,

SAID REEN. I WAS WONDERING WHAT WE WERE GOING TO DO WITH THEM.

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IT DOESN'T HAVE THE OF A BASILISK FANG, SAID HERMIONE PATIENTLY,

IT HAS THE OF SOMETHING SO DESTRUCTIVE THAT THE FURCULINE CAN'T REPAIR ITSELF, BASILISK VENOM ONLY HAS ONE ANTIDOTE, AND IT'S INCREDIBLY

RARE

PHENIX TEARS, SAID HARRY, NODDING.

EXACTLY, SAID HERMIONE, HER PROBLEM IS THAT THERE ARE VERY FEW

SUBSTANCES AS DESTRUCTIVE AS BASILISK VENOM, AND THEY'RE ALL DANGEROUS-

HOW DO WE CARRY AROUND WITH US? THAT'S A PROBLEM WE'RE GOING TO HAVE

THE SKELETON, THE LEG, BECAUSE RIPPING, SMASHING, OR CRUSHING A FURROW

WHEN IT DOES THE TRICK. YOU'VE GOT TO PUT IT BEYOND MAGICAL REPAIR.

BUT EVEN IF WE WORKED THE THING IT LIVES IN, SAID RON, WHY CAN'T WE PUT THE SKELETON IN IT JUST GO AND LIVE IN SOMETHING ELSE?

BECAUSE A FURROW IS THE COMPLETE OPPOSITE OF A HUMAN BEING.

SEEING THAT HARRY AND RON LOOKED TERRIBLY CONFUSED, HERMIONIE HURRIED ON, WELL, IF I PICKED UP A SWORD RIGHT NOW, RON, AND

RAN THROUGH WITH IT, I WOULDN'T DAMAGE YOUR SKELETON AT ALL.

WHICH WOULD BE A REAL COMFORT TO ME, I'M SURE, SAID RON. HARRY LAUGHED.

IT SHOULD BE, ACTUALLY! BUT MY POINT IS THAT WHATEVER HAPPENS TO YOUR BODY, YOUR SKELETON WILL SURVIVE, UNTHINKED, SAID HERMIONIE.

BUT IT'S THE OTHER WAY AROUND WITH A FURROW. THE FRAGMENT OF SKELETON

INSIDE IT DEPENDS ON ITS CONTAINER, ITS ENCHANTED BODY, FOR SURVIVAL. IT CAN'T EXIST WITHOUT IT.

THAT DIARY SHEET HE DIED WHEN I STABBED IT, SAID HARRY, REMEMBERING HOW FEELING LIKE BLEED FROM THE PUNCTURED PAGES, AND THE

SCREAMS OF THE PIECE OF VERDIMENT & SHELL AS IT VANISHED.

AND SINCE THE DIARY WAS PROPERLY DESTROYED, THE KIT OF SHELL
TRAPPED IN IT COULD NO LONGER EXIST. GINNY TRIED TO GET RID OF THE
THE GEM IN PALAMAS

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DIARY BEFORE SHE DID, FLUSHING IT AWAY, BUT MIRACULOUSLY IT CAME BACK
GOOD AS NEW.

HANG ON, SAID RHN, FROWNING. THE KIT OF SHELL IN THAT DIARY WAS
POSSESSING GINNY, WASN'T IT? HOW DOES THAT WORK, THEN?

WHILE THE MAGICAL CONTAINER IS STILL INTACT, THE KIT OF SHELL INSIDE
IT CAN FLIT IN AND FLIT OF SOMEONE IF THEY GET TOO CLOSE TO THE
OBJECT. I

DON'T MEAN HOLDING IT FOR TOO LONG, IT'S NOTHING TO DO WITH
TELEKINESIS

IT, SHE ADDED BEFORE RHN COULD SPEAK. I MEAN CLOSE EMOTIONALLY.

GINNY FELT HER HEART FLIT INTO THAT DIARY, SHE MADE HERSELF
INCRED-

IBLY VULNERABLE. SHE WAS IN TROUBLE IF SHE GOT TOO CLOSE TO HER
DEPENDENT

ON THE BENCH.

I WONDER HOW DIMPLEHERE DESTROYED THE RING? SAID HARRY.

WHY DIDN'T I ASK HIM? I NEVER REALLY ...

HIS VEHICLE TAILED AWAY! HE WAS THINKING OF ALL THE THINGS HE SHOULD

HAVE ASKED DUMBLEDORE, AND HE FELT, SINCE THE HEADMASTER HAD DIED, IT SEEMED TO HIM THAT HE HAD WASTED SO MANY OPPORTUNITIES WHEN DUMBLEDORE HAD BEEN ALIVE, THE FINE HUNT HERE . . . THE FINE HUNT EVERYTHING, . . .

THE SILENCE WAS SHATTERED AS THE REDHEADS BEER FLEW OPEN WITH A WALL-SHAKING CRASH. HERMIONE SHRIEKED AND DROPPED SECRETS OF THE

DARKEST ART! CREEDS-LANDS STREAKED UNDER THE RED, HISSING INDIGNANTLY; RON JUMPED OFF THE RED, SKIDDED ON A DISCARDED CHOCOLATE

FREE WRAPPER, AND SMACKED HIS HEAD ON THE OPPOSITE WALL; AND HARRY

INSTINCTIVELY DIVED FOR HIS WAND BEHIND REALIZING THAT HE WAS BLENDING

UP AT MRS. WEASLEY, WHOSE HAIR WAS DISHEVELED AND WHOSE FACE WAS CENTERTED WITH RAGE.

I'M SEE SHIRRY THE KREAK UP THIS CHIZY LITTLE GATHERING, SHE SAID, HER VEHICLE TREMBLING. I'M SURE YELL ALL NEED YELLER REST . . . BUT THERE ARE

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WEDDING PRESENTS STACKED IN MY ROOM THAT NEED SORTING OUT AND I WAS UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT YELL HAD AGREED THE FIELD.

HEY YES, SAID HERMIONE, BLENDING TERRIFIED AS SHE LEAPT THE HER

FEET, SENDING KNEES FLYING IN EVERY DIRECTION. WE WILL . . . WE'RE
SHIRRY . . .

WITH AN ANGLISHED LEER AT HARRY AND RON, HERMIONE FLURRIED
HELT UP THE ROOM AFTER MRS. WEASLEY.

IT'S LIKE BEING A FELLSE-Elf, COMPLAINED RON IN AN UNDERTONE,
STILL MASSAGING HIS HEAD AS HE AND HARRY FELLOWED. EXCEPT
WITHHELT

THEIR THE SATISFACTION. THE SWEETER THIS WEDDING'S EVER, THE HAPPIER
I'M
BE.

YEAAH, SAID HARRY, THEN WE'LL HAVE NOTHING TO DO EXCEPT FIND
HERCULES. . . IT'LL BE LIKE A HOLIDAY, WON'T IT?

RON STARTED TO LAUGH, BUT AT THE SIGHT OF THE ENORMOUS PILE OF
WEDDING PRESENTS WAITING FOR THEM IN MRS. WEASLEY'S ROOM,
STAPPED

BLITHE ABRUPTLY.

THE DELACELIRS ARRIVED THE FOLLOWING MORNING AT ELEVEN O'CLOCK.

HARRY, RON, HERMIONE, AND GINNY WERE FEELING BLITHE RESSENTFUL THE-
WARD FLEUR'S FAMILY BY THIS TIME, AND IT WAS WITH ILL GRACE THAT RON

STUMPED BACK UPSTAIRS TO PUT ON MATCHING SHEDS, AND HARRY AT-
TEMPTED TO FLATTEN HIS HAIR. SINCE THEY HAD ALL BEEN DEEMED SMART

ENOUGH, THEY TREMPED HEIT INTO THE SUNNY BACKYARD TO AWAIT THE
VISITERS.

HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN THE PLACE LOOKING SO TIDY. THE RUSTY CAIL-

BRENS AND OLD WELLINGTON BENTS THAT USUALLY LITTERED THE STEPS BY THE

BACK DEER WERE GONE, REPLACED BY TWO NEW FLUTTERY BISHES
STANDING

EITHER SIDE OF THE DEER IN LARGE PETS; THOUGH THERE WAS NO BREEZE,
THE

LEAVES WAVED LAZILY, GIVING AN ATTRACTIVE RIBBLING EFFECT. THE
CHICKENS

HAD BEEN SHUT AWAY, THE YARD HAD BEEN SWEEPED, AND THE NEARBY GARDEN

THE GIBBS IN PAIAMS

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HAD BEEN PRUNED, POLISHED, AND GENERALLY SPOLISHED UP, ALTHOUGH
HARRY,

WHEN LOOKED IT IN ITS EVERGREEN STATE, THOUGHT THAT IT LOOKED
RATHER FIER-

LYING WITHOUT ITS USUAL CONTINGENT OF CAPERING CREMERS.

HE HAD LOST TRACK OF HOW MANY SECURITY ENCHANTMENTS HAD BEEN
PLACED UPON THE BLINDS BY BOTH THE ORDER AND THE MINISTRY; ALL
HE KNEW WAS THAT IT WAS NO LONGER POSSIBLE FOR ANYBODY TO TRAVEL
BY MAGIC DIRECTLY INTO THE PLACE. MR. LEASLEY HAD THEREFORE GONE
TO MEET THE DELACHURS IN THE OF A NEARBY HILL, WHERE THEY WERE TO

ARRIVE BY PERTNEY, THE FIRST SOUND OF THEIR APPROACH WAS AN UNUSU-

ALLY HIGH-PITCHED LAUGH, WHICH TURNED OUT TO BE COMING FROM MR.

WEASLEY, WHO APPEARED AT THE GATE MOMENTS LATER, LADEN WITH
LUGGAGE

AND LEADING A BEAUTIFUL BLONDE WOMAN IN LONG, LEAF-GREEN DRESS,
WHO COULD ONLY BE FLEUR'S MOTHER.

MAMAN? CRIED FLEUR, RUSHING FORWARD TO EMBRACE HER. PAPA?
MONSIEUR DELACOUR WAS NOWHERE NEAR AS ATTRACTIVE AS HIS WIFE; HE
WAS A HEAD SHORTER AND EXTREMELY PLUMP, WITH A LITTLE, POINTED
BEARD.

HOWEVER, HE SEEMED GOOD-NATURED, REACHING TOWARD MRS.
WEASLEY AND HIGH-PEELED SHEETS, HE KISSED HER TWICE ON EACH CHEEK,
LEAVING HER FLUSTERED.

WELL YOU'VE BEEN THE MOST TREMBLE, HE SAID IN A DEEP VOICE. FLEUR
TELLS US WELL YOU'VE BEEN WORKING VERY HARD.

OH, IT'S BEEN NOTHING, NOTHING? TRILLED MRS. WEASLEY. NOT TREMB-
LE AT ALL?

HEEN RELIEVED HIS FEELINGS BY AIMING A DICK AT A Gnome WHO WAS
PEERING OUT FROM BEHIND ONE OF THE NEW FLUTTERBY BLISHES.

DEAR LADY? SAID MONSIEUR DELACOUR, STILL HOLDING MRS. WEASLEY'S
HAND BETWEEN HIS OWN TWO PLUMP FINGERS AND BEAMING. WE ARE MOST

HONORED AT THE APPROACHING UNION OF OUR TWO FAMILIES! LET ME
PRES-

ENT MY WIFE, APPELLINE.

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MADAME DELACHELLE GLIDED FORWARD AND STEERED THE KISS MRS. WEASLEY TOWARD HER.

ENCHANTED? SHE SAID. YOUR HUSBAND AS BEEN TELLING US SUCH AMUSING STORIES?

MR. WEASLEY GAVE A MANIACAL LAUGH; MRS. WEASLEY THREW HIM A LOOK, UPON WHICH HE BECAME IMMEDIATELY SILENT AND ASSUMED AN EXPRESSION APPROPRIATE TO THE SICKED OF A CLOSE FRIEND.

AND, OF COURSE, YOU ARE MET MY LITTLE DAUGHTER, GABRIELLE? SAID MRS. DELACHELLE. GABRIELLE WAS FLEET IN MINIATURE; ELEVEN YEARS

OLD, WITH WAIST-LENGTH HAIR OF PURE, SILVERY BLOND, SHE GAVE MRS.

WEASLEY A DAZZLING SMILE AND FLICED HER, THEN THREW HER A GLANCE

ING LOOK, BATTING HER EYELASHES, GINNED CLEARED HER THROAT LUDICROUSLY.

WELL, COME IN, THEN? SAID MRS. WEASLEY BRIGHTLY, AND SHE USHERED THE DELACHELLES INTO THE HOUSE, WITH MANY OH, PLEASE? S AND AFTER

PHILIP AND NEET AT ALL?

THE DELACHURS, IT SEEMED TRANSPIRED, WERE HELPFUL, PLEASANT GUESTS.

THEY WERE PLEASED WITH EVERYTHING AND KEEN TO ASSIST WITH THE PREPARATIONS FOR THE WEDDING.

MENSTELIA DELACHUR PREPARED EVERYTHING FROM THE SEATING PLAN TO THE BRIDESMAIDS' STORIES. CHARMANT!

MADAME DELACHUR WAS MOST ACCOMPLISHED AT HOUSEHOLD SPELLS AND HAD THE HIVE PROPERLY CLEANED IN A TRICE. GABRIELLE FOLLOWED HER ELDER

SISTER AROUND, TRYING TO ASSIST IN ANY WAY SHE COULD AND JABBERING AWAY IN RAPID FRENCH.

IN THE DINING ROOM, THE BUREAU WAS NOT QUITE THE ACCOMMODATE SHE

MANY PEOPLE. MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY WERE NOW SLEEPING IN THE SITTING ROOM, HAVING SETTLED DOWN MENSTELIA AND MADAME DELACHUR'S

PRETEXTS AND INSISTED THEY TAKE THEIR BEDROOM. GABRIELLE WAS SLEEPING

WITH FLEUR IN PERCY'S OLD ROOM, AND BILL WOULD BE SHARING WITH CHAR-

THE CHILD IN PALMERS

LIE, HIS BEST MAN, HENCE CHARLIE ARRIVED FROM ROMANIA,
OPPORTUNITIES

THEir MAJOR PLANS TOGETHER BECAME VIRTUALLY NONEXISTENT, AND IT WAS
IN

DESPERATION THAT HARRY, RENE, AND HERMINE THREW THE
VOLUNTEERING

THEY FEED THE CHILDREN JUST THE ESCAPE THE OVERCROWDED HOUSE.

BUT SHE STILL WON'T LEAVE US ALONE? SNARLED RENE, AS THEIR SECOND
ATTEMPT AT A MEETING IN THE YARD WAS FOILED BY THE APPEARANCE OF
MRS. WEASLEY CARRYING A LARGE BASKET OF LAUNDRY IN HER ARMS.

HEY, GROSS, WHY DO YOU FEED THE CHILDREN, SHE CALLED AS SHE APPROACHED
THEM. WE'D BETTER SHUT THEM AWAY AGAIN BEFORE THE MEN ARRIVE
THEMSELVES . . . THE PUT UP THE TENT FOR THE WEDDING, SHE EXPLAINED,

PALISING THE LEAN AGAINST THE HEN-HOUSE. SHE LOOKED EXHAUSTED,
MIL-

LOVANT'S MAGIC MARSHMALLOWES . . . THEY'RE VERY GOOD, BILL'S EXCLAIMING

THEM. . . . YOU'D BETTER STAY INSIDE WHILE THEY'RE HERE, HARRY, I MUST

SAY IT DOES COMPLICATE ORGANIZING A WEDDING, HAVING ALL THESE SECU-
RITY SPELLS AROUND THE PLACE.

I'M SORRY, SAID HARRY FLIMELY.

HEY, DON'T BE SILLY, DEAR! SAID MRS. WEASLEY AT HENCE. I DIDN'T
MEAN WELL, YOUR SAFETY'S MUCH MORE IMPORTANT! ACTUALLY, I'VE
BEEN WANTING THE ASD YOU KNOW YOU WANT TO CELEBRATE YOUR
BIRTHDAY,

HARRY, SEVENTEEN, AFTER ALL, IT'S AN IMPORTANT DAY, . . .

I DON'T WANT A FLISS, SAID HARRY EMBOLDLY, ENVISAGING THE ADDITIONAL STRAIN THIS WOULD PUT ON THEM ALL. REALLY, MRS. WEASLEY, JUST A NORMAL DINNER WOULD BE FINE. . . . IT'S THE DAY BEFORE THE WEDDING. . . .

EH, WELL, IF YOU'RE SURE, DEAR, I'LL INVITE REMUS AND TENDS, SHALL I? AND HOW ABOUT HAGRID?

THAT'D BE GREAT, SAID HARRY, BUT PLEASE DON'T GIVE THEM HEADS UP THERE. . . .

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NOT AT ALL, NOT AT ALL. . . . IT'S NOT THERE. . . .

SHE LOOKED AT HIM, A LONG, SEARCHING LOOK, THEN SMILED A LITTLE SADLY, STRAIGHTENED UP, AND WALKED AWAY. HARRY WATCHED AS SHE WAVED HER HAND NEAR THE WASHING LINE, AND THE DAMP CLOTHES RISE INTO THE AIR THE LONG THEMSELVES UP, AND SUDDENLY HE FELT A GREAT WAVE OF REMORSE FOR THE INCONVENIENCE AND THE PAIN HE WAS GIVING HER.

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE WILL OF ARLIS DUMBLEDORE

HE WAS WALKING ALONG A MOUNTAIN ROAD IN THE CHELSEA LIGHT OF DAWN, FAR AWAY, SHROUDS IN MIST, WAS THE SHADE OF A SMALL TOWN. WAS THE MAN HE SAW THERE, THE MAN HE NEEDED SEE EARLY HE COULD THINK OF LITTLE ELSE, THE MAN WHO HELD THE ANSWER, THE ANSWER TO HIS PROBLEM . . . ?

HI, WAKE UP,

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES. HE WAS LYING AGAIN IN THE CAMP BED IN RON'S DINGY ATTIC ROOM. THE SUN HAD NOT YET RISEN AND THE ROOM WAS STILL SHADY. PIGWIDGEE was ASLEEP WITH HIS HEAD UNDER HIS TINY WING. THE STAR ON HARRY'S FOREHEAD WAS PRICKLING.

THEY WERE MUTTERING IN THEIR SLEEP,

WAS IT

YEAH, GREGORYVITCH, THEY KEPT SAYING GREGORYVITCH,

HARRY WAS NOT WEARING HIS GLASSES; RON'S FACE APPEARED SLIGHTLY BLURRED.

WHO'S GREGORYVITCH?

HI

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I DUNNED, DID I? WELL WERE THEY HENCE SAYING IT.

HARRY BLINKED HIS FOREHEAD, THINKING. HE HAD A VAGUE IDEA HE HAD
HEARD THE NAME BEFORE, BUT HE COULD NOT THINK WHERE.

I THINK VERMOREL IS LOOKING FOR HIM.

JOHN BLAKE, SAID JOHN PERVENTLY.

HARRY SAT UP, STILL BLINKING HIS STAR, WELL WIDE AWAKE. HE TRIED TO
REMEMBER EXACTLY WHAT HE HAD SEEN IN THE DREAM, BUT ALL THAT CAME
BACK WAS A MOUNTAINOUS HORIZON AND THE SILHOUETTE OF THE LITTLE
VILLAGE

CRADLED IN A DEEP VALLEY.

I THINK HE IS AHEAD.

WELL, GREGORYVITCH?

VERMOREL, I THINK HE IS SOMEWHERE AHEAD, LOOKING FOR GREG-
ORYVITCH. IT DIDN'T LOOK LIKE ANYWHERE IN BRITAIN.

WELL RECOGNIZED WELL WERE SEEING INTO HIS MIND AGAIN?

JOHN SHOOKED HIS HEAD.

DON'T ME A FATHER AND DON'T TELL HERMIONE, SAID HARRY. ALTHOUGH
SHE EXPECTS ME TO STOP SEEING STUFF IN MY SLEEP ...

HE GAZED UP AT LITTLE PIGWIDGEN'S FACE, THINKING ... WHY WAS
THE NAME GREGORYVITCH FAMILIAR?

I THINK, HE SAID SILENTLY, HE'S GOT SOMETHING TO DO WITH ELID-
ITCH. THERE'S SOME CONNECTION, BUT I CAN'T I CAN'T THINK WHAT
IT

IS.

BLIDDITCH SAID THEN. SURE YOU'RE NOT THINKING OF GERGEVITCH?

WHEN?

DRAGMIR GERGEVITCH, CHASER, TRANSFERRED THE THE CHUDLEY CANDLES FOR A RECORD FIVE YEARS AGO. RECORD HOLDER FOR MOST ENJAMBLE

DREPS IN A SEASON.

NO, SAID HARRY. I'M DEFINITELY NOT THINKING OF GERGEVITCH.

THE WILL OF
ALLIS OLYMPIANS

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I TRY NOT THE EITHER, SAID THEN. WELL, HAPPY BIRTHDAY ANYWAY.

WHEN THAT'S RIGHT, I MIGHT! I'M SEVENTEEN!

HARRY SEIZED THE WAND LYING BESIDE HIS CAMP BED, POINTED IT AT THE CLUTTERED DESK WHERE HE HAD LEFT HIS GLASSES, AND SAID, ALLIE GLASSES!

ALTHOUGH THEY WERE ONLY ABOUT A FEET AWAY, THERE WAS SOMETHING

IMMENSELY SATISFYING ABOUT SEEING THEM ZOOM TOWARD HIM, AT LEAST

UNTIL THEY PEEKED HIM IN THE EYE.

SLICK, SMIRKED RON.

REVELING IN THE REMOVAL OF HIS TRACE, HARRY SENT RON'S PHOENIXES-
STONES FLYING AROUND THE ROOM, CAUSING PIGWIDGEEEN TO WAKE UP AND

FLUTTER EXCITEDLY AROUND HIS CAGE. HARRY ALSO TRIED TYING THE LACES
OF HIS TRAINERS BY MAGIC (THE RESULTANT KNOTS TOOK SEVERAL MINUTES
TO

UNTIE BY HAND) AND, PURELY FOR THE PLEASURE OF IT, TURNED THE
STRANGE

BOOKS INTO RON'S CHILDISH CANNONS OF BRIGHT BLUE.

I'D BE HELD BY HAND, HOWEVER, RON ADVISED HARRY, SMUGGLING
WHEN HARRY IMMEDIATELY CHECKED IT. HERE'S YOUR PRESENT. UNWRAP
IT UP HERE, IT'S NOT FOR MY MOTHER'S EYES.

A KID? SAID HARRY AS HE TOOK THE RECTANGULAR PARCEL. KIT OF A
DEPARTURE FROM TRADITION, ISN'T IT?

THIS ISN'T YOUR AVERAGE KID, SAID RON. IT'S PURE GOLD! TWELVE
FALL-SAFE DAYS THE CHARM WITCHES, EXPLAINS EVERYTHING YOU NEED
TO

KNOW ABOUT GIRLS. IF ONLY I'D HAD THIS LAST YEAR I'D HAVE KNOWN
EXACTLY

HOW TO GET RID OF LAVENDER AND I WOULD'VE KNOWN HOW TO GET
GONE

WITH... WELL, FRED AND GEORGE GAVE ME A COPY, AND I'VE LEARNED A
LOT. YOU'D BE SURPRISED, IT'S NOT ALL ABOUT HANDSHAKES, EITHER.

WHEN THEY ARRIVED IN THE KITCHEN THEY FOUND A PILE OF PRESENTS
WAITING ON THE TABLE. BILL AND MUNDICUS DELACOUR WERE FINISHING

THEIR BREAKFASTS, WHILE MRS. WEASLEY STEAD CHATTING TO THEM OVER THE FRYING PAN.

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ARTHUR TOLD ME THE WISH YOU A HAPPY SEVENTEENTH, HARRY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, BEAMING AT HIM. HE HAD THE LEAVE EARLY FOR WORK, BUT HE WOULD BE BACK FOR DINNER, THAT SHE WOULD PRESENT HIM THEN.

HARRY SAT DOWN, THEN THE SILVER PARCEL SHE HAD INDICATED, AND UNWRAPPED IT. INSIDE WAS A WATCH VERY LIKE THE ONE MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY HAD GIVEN REIN FOR HIS SEVENTEENTH; IT WAS GOLD, WITH STARS

CIRCLING AROUND THE FACE INSTEAD OF HANDS.

IT IS TRADITIONAL TO GIVE A WIZARD A WATCH WHEN HE REACHES HIS AGE, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, WATCHING HIM ANXIOUSLY FROM BESIDE THE CHURCH.

I'M AFRAID THAT THERE ISN'T NEW LIKE REIN'S, IT WAS ACTUALLY MY BROTHER

PARIAN'S AND HE WASN'T TERRIBLY CAREFUL WITH HIS POSSESSIONS, IT'S A BIT

DENTED ON THE BACK, BUT

THE REST OF HER SPEECH WAS LOST; HARRY HAD GOTTEN UP AND FLEGGED HER.

HE TRIED TO PUT A LIE OF UNSAID THINGS INTO THE FILE AND PERHAPS SHE

UNDERSTOOD THEM, BECAUSE SHE PATTED HIS CHEEK GENTLY WHEN HE

RELEASED HER, THEN WAVED HER HAND IN A SLIGHTLY RANDOM WAY,
CAUSING

HALF A DOZEN OF BAKED TEA ROLLS OUT OF THE FRYING PAN INTO THE
FLYER.

HAPPY BIRTHDAY, HARRY? SAID HERMIONE, FLIRTING INTO THE
KITCHEN AND ADDING HER OWN PRESENT TO THE TOP OF THE PILE. IT'S
NOT

MUCH, BUT I HOPE YOU'LL LIKE IT. WHAT DID YOU GET HIM? SHE ADDED THE
RIBBON, WHICH SEEMED NOT TO HEAR HER.

COME ON, THEN, OPEN HERMIONE'S? SAID RITA.

SHE HAD BUGHT HIM A NEW SNARFLESCHE. THE OTHER PACKAGES CON-
TAINED AN ENCHANTED RAZOR FROM BILL AND FLEUR / AND YES, HIS WILL
GIVE

YOU'LL BE SMOTHERED BY THE WAY YOU'LL EVER SEE, MENDELIA DELACOUR
AS-

SHRED HIM, BUT YOU MUST TELL IT CLEARLY WHAT YOU WANT ...
HAPPENING

YOU MIGHT FIND YOU'VE A LITTLE LESS FAIR THAN YOU WOULD LIKE ... I,
CIRCLES FROM THE DELACOURS, AND AN ENORMOUS BOX OF THE LATEST
WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEASELS MERCHANDISE FROM FRED AND GEORGE.

THE WILL OF

ALL IS DIVERGENT

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE DID NOT LINGER AT THE TABLE, AS THE ARRIVAL OF MADAME DELACOUR, FILIP, AND GABRIELLE MADE THE KITCHEN LINCHPINARTABLY CROWDED.

I'LL PACK THESE FOR YOU, HERMIONE SAID BRIGHTLY, TAKING HARRY'S PRESENTS AWAY FROM HIS ARMS AS THE THREE OF THEM HEADED BACK UPSTAIRS.

I'M NEARLY DONE, I MUST WAITING FOR THE REST OF YOUR UNDERPANTS

THE CHIME FROM THE LASH, RON

RON'S WHISTLE WAS INTERRUPTED BY THE OPENING OF A DOOR ON THE FIRST-FLOOR LANDING.

HARRY, WILL YOU COME IN HERE A MOMENT?

IT WAS GINNY. RON CAME TO AN ABRUPT HALT, BUT HERMIONE THREW HIM BY THE ELBOW AND TUGGED HIM UP THE STAIRS, FEELING NERVOUS. HARRY FOLLOWED GINNY INTO HER ROOM.

HE HAD NEVER BEEN INSIDE IT BEFORE. IT WAS SMALL, BUT BRIGHT. THERE WAS A LARGE POSTER OF THE WIZARDING BOND THE WEIRD SISTERS HAD HAD

WALL, AND A PICTURE OF GLENNEE JONES, CAPTAIN OF THE ALL-WITCH FIGHT-

ING TEAM THE FLY-HEAD HARPIES, ON THE OTHER. A DESK STOOD FACING

THE OPEN WINDOW, WHICH LOOKED OUT OVER THE GARDEN WHERE HE AND

GINNY HAD ENCE PLAYED TEN-A-SIDE FLIDDITCH WITH RICH AND HER-
MIENE, AND WHICH NOW FELT A LARGE, PEARLY WHITE MARBLE. THE

GOLDEN FLAG HAD BEEN WAS LEVEL WITH GINNY'S EYES.

GINNY LEMBED UP INTO HARRY'S FACE, TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AND SAID,
HAPPY SEVENTEENTH.

YES... THANKS.

SHE WAS LOOKING AT HIM STEADILY; HE, HOWEVER, FELT IT DIFFICULT TO
LOOK BACK AT HER; IT WAS LIKE GAZING INTO A BRILLIANT LIGHT.

NICE VIEW, HE SAID FREELY, POINTING TOWARD THE WINDOW.

SHE IGNORED THIS. HE COULD NOT BLAME HER.

I COULDN'T THINK WHAT TO GET YOU, SHE SAID.

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YOU DIDN'T HAVE TO GET ME ANYTHING.

SHE DISREGARDED THIS THEN.

I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT WOULD BE USEFUL. NOTHING TOO BIG, BECAUSE
YOU WOULDN'T BE ABLE TO TAKE IT WITH YOU.

HE GLANCED A GLANCE AT HER. SHE WAS NOT TALKING; THAT WAS ONE OF
THE MANY WONDERFUL THINGS ABOUT GINNY, SHE WAS RARELY SILENT. HE

HAD SOMETIMES THOUGHT THAT HAVING SIX BROTHERS MUST HAVE
THOUGHT

ENDED HER LIP.

SHE THREW A STEP CLOSER TO HIM.

SHE THEN I THOUGHT, I'D LIKE YOU TO HAVE SOMETHING TO REMEMBER ME BY, YOU KNOW, IF YOU MEET SOME GIRL WHEN YOU'RE NOT DOING WHATEVER YOU'RE DOING.

I THINK DATING OPPORTUNITIES ARE GOING TO BE PRETTY THIN FOR THE GIRL, SHE BE HONEST.

THERE'S THE SILVER LINING I'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR, SHE WHISPERED, AND THEN SHE WAS KISSING HIM AS SHE HAD NEVER KISSED HIM BEFORE, AND HARRY WAS KISSING HER BACK, AND IT WAS BLISSFUL ECSTASY, BETTER THAN FIREWORKS; SHE WAS THE ONLY REAL THING IN THE WORLD, GINNY,

THE FEEL OF HER, HER HAND AT HER BACK AND HER IN HER LONG, SWEET-SMELLING HAIR

THE DOOR BANGED OPEN BEHIND THEM AND THEY JUMPED APART.

HE, SAID THEN POINTEDLY. SHERRY.

THEN: FERMINE WAS JUST BEHIND HIM, SLIGHTLY BLT OF BREATH.

THERE WAS A STRAINED SILENCE, THEN GINNY SAID IN A FLAT LITTLE VOICE,

WELL, HAPPY BIRTHDAY ANYWAY, HARRY.

THEN'S EARS WERE SCARLET; FERMINE WHISPERED NERVOUSLY. HARRY WANTED TO SLAM THE DOOR IN THEIR FACES, BUT IT FELT AS THOUGH A CHILD DRAFT

HAD ENTERED THE ROOM WHEN THE DOOR OPENED, AND HIS SHINING MENT HAD POPOPPED LIKE A SOAP BUBBLE. ALL THE REASONS FOR ENDING HIS

THE WILL OF ARLIS OLYMPIOS

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RELATIONSHIP WITH CINDY, HER STAYING WELL AWAY FROM HER, SEEMED
THE

HAVE SLUNK INSIDE THE ROOM WITH REN, AND ALL HAPPY
PERCEPTUALNESS

WAS GONE.

HE LOOKED AT CINDY, WANTING TO SAY SOMETHING, THOUGH HE HARDLY
KNEW WHAT, BUT SHE HAD TURNED HER BACK ON HIM. HE THOUGHT THAT
SHE MIGHT HAVE SLIPPED, HER EYES, THE TEARS. HE COULD NOT DO
ANYTHING TO COMFORT HER IN FRONT OF REN.

I'LL SEE YOU LATER, HE SAID, AND REMEMBERED THE EITHER TIME HE'D OF THE
BEDROOM.

REN MARCHED DOWNSTAIRS, THOUGH THE STILL-CROWDED KITCHEN AND
INTO THE YARD, AND HARRY KEPT PACE WITH HIM ALL THE WAY,
HERMINE

TRETTING ALONG BEHIND THEM LOOKING SCARED.

WHEN HE REACHED THE SLOTTING OF THE FRESHLY MOWN LAWN, REN
REINDED HIM HARRY.

YOU DITCHED HER. WHAT ARE YOU DOING NOW, MESSING HER
AROUND?

I'M NOT MESSING HER AROUND, SAID HARRY, AS HERMINE CALLED
UP WITH THEM.

REN

BUT REN HELD UP A HAND TO SILENCE HER.

SHE WAS REALLY CLIT UP WHEN VELL ENDED IT

SHE WAS I, VELL KNEW WHY I STOPPED IT, AND IT WASN'T BECAUSE I
WANTED THE.

YEAH, BUT VELL SHE SNEGGING HER NECK AND SHE'S JUST GOING TO GET
HER KEEPS UP AGAIN

SHE'S NOT AN IDIOT, SHE KNOWS IT CAN'T HAPPEN, SHE'S NOT
EXPECTING

LIES THE THE END UP MARRIED, HER

AS HE SAID IT, A VIVID PICTURE FORMED IN HARRY'S MIND OF GINNY
IN A WHITE DRESS, MARRYING A TALL, FACELESS, AND UNPLEASANT
STRANGER.

CHAPTER SEVEN

118

IN ONE SPIRALING MOMENT IT SEEMED THE HIT HIM: HER FUTURE WAS FREE

AND UNENCLIMBERED, WHEREAS HIS . . . HE COULD SEE NOTHING BUT VELL-
BEHIND AHEAD.

IF VELL KEEP GRIPPING HER EVERY CHANCE VELL GET

IT WON'T HAPPEN AGAIN, SAID HARRY HARSHLY. THE DAY WAS CHILD-
LESS, BUT HE FELT AS THOUGH THE SUN HAD GONE IN. TODAY?

HEEN LOOKED HALF RESSENTFUL, HALF SHEEPISH; HE REVERSED BACKWARD

AND FORWARD ON HIS FEET FOR A MOMENT, THEN SAID, RIGHT THEN, WELL, THAT'S . . . YES.

GINNY DID NOT SEEK ANOTHER ONE-THREE MEETING WITH HARRY FOR THE REST OF THE DAY, NEAR BY ANY MEANS HER GESTURE DID SHE SHOW THAT

THEY HAD SHARED MORE THAN POLITE CONVERSATION IN HER ROOM. NEVERTHELESS, CHARLIE'S ARRIVAL CAME AS A RELIEF TO HARRY. IT PROVIDED A

DISTRACTION, WATCHING MRS. WEASLEY FORCE CHARLIE INTO A CHAIR, RAISE

HER HAND THREATENINGLY, AND ANNOUNCING THAT HE WAS ABOUT TO GET A PROPER HAIRCUT.

AS HARRY'S BIRTHDAY DINNER WOULD HAVE STRETCHED THE KITCHEN'S DITCHEN THE BREAKING POINT EVEN BEFORE THE ARRIVAL OF CHARLIE, LUPIN,

THEIRS, AND HAGRID, SEVERAL TABLES WERE PLACED END TO END IN THE GARDEN. FRED AND GEORGE BLENCHED A NUMBER OF PURPLE LANTERNS, ALL EMBLAZONED WITH A LARGE NUMBER 19, THE FLAG IN MIDAIR OVER THE GUESTS. THANKS TO MRS. WEASLEY'S MINISTRATIONS, GEORGE'S WHEEL WAS

NEAT AND CLEAN, BUT HARRY WAS NOT YET USED TO THE DARK FEEL IN THE SIDE OF HIS HEAD, DESPITE THE TWIN'S MANY INDEXES ABOUT IT.

HERMIONIE MADE PURPLE AND GOLD STREAMERS FLIPT FROM THE END OF HER HAND AND DRAPE THEMSELVES ARTISTICALLY OVER THE TREES AND BUSHES.

NICE, SAID RON, AS WITH ONE FINAL FLICK OF HER HAND, HERMIONIE

THE WILL OF ARLIS DUMBLEDOORE

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TURNED THE LEAVES IN THE CRACKLE TREE THE CHILD. SHE'VE REALLY
GOTTEN AN

IDEA FOR THAT SORT OF THING.

THANK YOU, RON? SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING BOTH PLEASED AND A
LITTLE CONFUSED. HARRY TURNED AWAY, SMILING TO HIMSELF. HE HAD A
FLIMSY NOTION THAT HE WOULD FIND A CHAPTER IN COMPLIMENTS WHEN
HE FOUND TIME TO PERUSE HIS COPY OF TWELVE FALSAFEA WAYS TO
CHARM

WITCHES; HE CAUGHT GINNY'S EYE AND GRINNED AT HER BEFORE REMEM-
BERING HIS PROMISE TO RON AND HURRIEDLY STRIKING UP A
CONVERSATION

WITH MINESTER DELACOUR.

HE'LL BE THE WAY, HE'LL BE THE WAY? SANG MRS. WEASLEY, CHIMING
THROUGH THE GATE WITH WHAT APPEARED TO BE A GIANT, BEACH-BALL-
SIZED

SMITH PLACING IN FRONT OF HER. SECONDS LATER HARRY REALIZED
THAT IT

WAS HIS BIRTHDAY CAKE, WHICH MRS. WEASLEY WAS SUSPENDING WITH
HER

HAND, RATHER THAN RISK CARRYING IT OVER THE LINEEN GREENING,
WHEN

THE CAKE HAD FINALLY LANDED IN THE MIDDLE OF THE TABLE, HARRY SAID,

THAT LOOKS AMAZING, MRS. WEASLEY,

EH, IT'S NOTHING, DEAR, SHE SAID FRIENDLY, EVER HER SHOULDERS, THEN
GAVE HARRY THE THUMB-UP AND MOUTHED, GOOD ONE.

BY SEVEN HE CHECKED ALL THE GUESTS HAD ARRIVED, LED INTO THE HALL BY
FRED AND GEORGE, WHO HAD WAITED FOR THEM AT THE END OF THE LANE.
Hagrid had enhanced the occasion by wearing his best, and horrible,
hairy knee-lengths. ALTHOUGH LUPIN SMILED AS HE SEEN HARRY'S
HAND,

HARRY THOUGHT HE LOOKED RATHER UNHAPPY. IT WAS ALL VERY EDDY;
THANKS,

BESIDE HIM, LOOKED SIMPLY RADIANT.

HAPPY BIRTHDAY, HARRY, SHE SAID, HUGGING HIM TIGHTLY.

SEVENTEEN, EH? SAID HAGRID AS HE ACCEPTED A GLASS-SIZED GLASS
OF WINE FROM FRED. SIX YEARS FOR THE DAY SINCE WE MET, HARRY, DON'T
REMEMBER IT?

CHAPTER SEVEN

120

WELL, SAID HARRY, GRINNING UP AT HIM. DIDN'T YOU SMASH
DOWN THE FRONT DOOR, GIVE DUDLEY A PIE & TAIL, AND TELL ME I WAS A
WIZARD?

I FORGET THE DETAILS, HAGRID CHEERED. ALL RIGHT, THEN,
HERMION?

WE'RE FINE, SAID HERMION. THEY ARE THEY?

OH, NOT BAD, KIN KISS, WE GOT SOME NEWBORN WITCHES, I'LL SHOW

YES WHEN YOU GET BACK HARRY AVOIDED REEN'S AND HERMIONE'S
Gazes AS HAGRID REMAINED IN HIS POCKET. HERE, HARRY CHILDREN
THINK WHAT TO GET YOU, BUT THEN I REMEMBERED THIS. HE PULLED OUT
A SMALL, SLIGHTLY FLIRTY DRAWSTRING POUCH WITH A LONG STRING,
EVIDENTLY

INTENDED TO BE WORN AROUND THE NECK. MEANS, HIDE ANYTHING IN
THERE AND NO ONE BUT THE OWNER CAN GET IT OUT. THEY'RE RARE,
THEM.

HAGRID, THANKS!

SOMETHING, SAID HAGRID WITH A WAVE OF A DUSTY-LID-SIZED HAND.
AND THERE'S CHARLIE! ALWAYS LIKED HIM HEY! CHARLIE!
CHARLIE APPROACHED, RUNNING HIS HAND SLIGHTLY REPELLENTLY OVER HIS
NEW, EXOTICALLY SHORT HAIRCUT. HE WAS SHORTER THAN REEN, THICKSET,
WITH

A NUMBER OF KLIPS AND SCRATCHES UP HIS MUSCULAR ARMS.

HI, HAGRID, HOW'S IT GOING?

FIN MEANING TO WRITE FOR AGES. HOW'S NERBERT DOING?

NERBERT? CHARLIE LAUGHED. THE NORWEGIAN RIDGEBACK? WE
CALL HER NERBERTA NOW.

WHAT NERBERT'S A GIRL?

HEY, YEAH, SAID CHARLIE.

HOW CAN YOU TELL? ASKED HERMIONE.

THEY'RE A BIT MORE VICIOUS, SAID CHARLIE. HE LEANED OVER HIS
SHOULDER AND DROPPED HIS VOICE. WISH DAD WOULD FLIRTY UP AND
GET HERE. MOM'S GETTING OLD.

THE WILL OF

ALL'S DUMBLEDOR

THEY ALL BEHEADED HER AT MRS. WEASLEY. SHE WAS TRYING THE TALK THE MADAME DELACOUR WHILE GLANCING REPEATEDLY AT THE GATE.

I THINK WE'D BETTER START WITH HELL! ARTHEUR, SHE CALLED THE THE CAR-
DEN AT LARGE AFTER A MOMENT HER TIME. HE MUST HAVE BEEN HELD UP

AT THE

THEY ALL SAW IT AT THE SAME TIME: A STREAK OF LIGHT THAT CAME FLY-
ING ACROSS THE YARD AND HIT THE TABLE, WHERE IT RESOLVED ITSELF
INTO A

BRIGHT SILVER WEASEL, WHICH STOOD ON ITS HIND LEGS AND SPoke WITH
MR. WEASLEY'S VOICE.

MINISTER OF MAGIC COMING WITH ME.

THE PATRONUS DISSOLVED INTO THIN AIR, LEAVING FLEUR'S FAMILY
PEER-

ING IN ASTONISHMENT AT THE PLACE WHERE IT HAD VANISHED.

WE SHOULDN'T BE HERE, SAID LUPIN AT ONCE. HARRY I'M SORRY

I'LL EXPLAIN ANOTHER TIME

HE GRABBED THERESA'S WRIST AND PULLED HER AWAY; THEY REACHED THE
FENCE, CLIMBED OVER IT, AND VANISHED FROM SIGHT. MRS. WEASLEY BEHEADED

REWILDERED.

THE MINISTER BUT WHY ? I DON'T UNDERSTAND
BUT THERE WAS NO TIME TO DISCUSS THE MATTER; A SECOND LATER, MR.
WEASLEY HAD APPEARED BUILT UP THIN AIR AT THE GATE, ACCOMPANIED BY
RUFUS SCRIMEGHEAR, INSTANTLY RECOGNIZABLE BY HIS MANK OF GRIZZLED
HAIR.

THE TWO NEWCOMERS MARCHED ACROSS THE YARD TOWARD THE GARDEN
AND THE LANTERN-LIT TABLE, WHERE EVERYBODY SAT IN SILENCE, WATCHING
THEM DRAW CLOSER. AS SCRIMEGHEAR CAME WITHIN RANGE OF THE
LANTERN

LIGHT, HARRY SAW THAT HE LOOKED MUCH OLDER THAN THE LAST TIME
THEY

HAD MET, SCRAGGY AND GRIM.

SHRUG THE INTERLOPER, SAID SCRIMEGHEAR, AS HE LIMPED TO A HALT BEFORE
THE TABLE. ESPECIALLY AS I CAN SEE THAT I AM GATE-CRASHING A
PARTY.

CHAPTER SEVEN

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HIS EYES LINGERED FOR A MOMENT ON THE GIANT SNITCH CAGE.

MANY HAPPY RETURNS.

THANKS, SAID HARRY.

I REQUIRE A PRIVATE WORD WITH YOU, SCRIMEGHEAR WENT ON, ALTHO
WITH MR. RENEALD WEASLEY AND MISS HERMIENE GRANGER.

YES SAID RHN, SOUNDING SURPRISED. WHY YES?

I SHALL TELL YOU THAT WHEN WE ARE SOMEWHERE MORE PRIVATE, SAID

SCRIMPKEHLIN. IS THERE SUCH A PLACE? HE DEMANDED OF MR. WEASLEY,

MRS. OF COURSE, SAID MR. WEASLEY, WITH UNHIDDEN NERVOUSNESS. THE TWO, SITTING TOGETHER, WHY DIDN'T YOU LIKE THAT?

YOU CAN LEAD THE WAY, SCRIMPKEHLIN SAID TO THEM. THERE WILL BE NO NEED FOR YOU TO ACCOMPANY US, ARTHEUR,

HARRY SAW MR. WEASLEY EXCHANGE A WORRIED GLANCE WITH MRS. WEASLEY AS HE, RON, AND HERMIONIE STEPPED UP, AS THEY LED THE WAY BACK TO THE HOUSE IN SILENCE, HARRY KNEW THAT THE OTHER TWO WERE THINKING THE SAME AS HE WAS: SCRIMPKEHLIN MUST, SOMEHOW, HAVE LEARNED THAT THE THREE OF THEM WERE PLANNING THE DREPP HUNT OF THE HOGWARTS.

SCRIMPKEHLIN DID NOT SPEAK AS THEY ALL PASSED THROUGH THE MESSY KITCHEN AND INTO THE HALLWAY & SITTING ROOM, ALTHOUGH THE GARDEN

HAD BEEN FULL OF SOFT GILDEN EVENING LIGHT, IT WAS ALREADY DARK IN HERE: HARRY FLICKED HIS WAND AT THE HALL LAMPS AS HE ENTERED AND THEY

ILLUMINATED THE SHABBY KILT CHAIR TOGETHER, SCRIMPKEHLIN SAT HIMSELF IN THE SAGGING ARMCHAIR THAT MR. WEASLEY NORMALLY OCCUPIED, LEAVING

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE TO SHUTTER SIDE BY SIDE BESIDE THE SEAT. SINCE THEY HAD DONE SO, SCRIMPKEHLIN SPoke,

I HAVE SOME QUESTIONS FOR THE THREE OF YOU, AND I THINK IT WILL BE BEST IF WE DO IT INDIVIDUALLY, IF YOU TWO HE POINTED AT HARRY AND

HERMIONIE CAN WAIT UPSTAIRS, I WILL START WITH RONALD,

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ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

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WE'RE NOT GOING ANYWHERE, SAID HARRY, WHILE HERMIONE NEEDED
VIGILANCE. YOU CAN SPREAD THEM TOGETHER, BUT NOT AT ALL.

STRONGHOLD GAVE HARRY A GLANCE, APPRAISING HIM. HARRY HAD THE

IMPRESSION THAT THE MINISTER WAS WONDERING WHETHER IT WAS
WORTH

WHILE OPENING HOSTILITIES THIS EARLY.

VERY WELL THEN, TOGETHER, HE SAID, SWALLOWING. HE CLEARED HIS

THROAT. I AM HERE, AS I'M SURE YOU KNOW, BECAUSE OF ALBUS DUM-
BLEDORE'S WILL.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE LOOKED AT ONE ANOTHER.

A SURPRISE, APPARENTLY? YOU WERE NOT AWARE THEN THAT DUMBLE-
DORE HAD LEFT YOU ANYTHING?

ALL OF US? SAID RON. ME AND HERMIONE TOO?

YES, ALL OF

BUT HARRY INTERRUPTED.

DUMBLEDORE DIED OVER A MONTH AGO. WHY HAS IT TAKEN THIS LONG
TO GIVE US WHAT HE LEFT US?

ISN'T IT HEAVILY? SAID HERMIONE, BEHOLD SCRIMGEOR CHILD ANSWER. THEY WANTED TO EXAMINE WHATEVER HE LEFT US. YELL HAD BEEN

RIGHT TO DO THAT? SHE SAID, AND HER VEHICLE TREMBLED SLIGHTLY.

I HAD EVERY RIGHT, SAID SCRIMGEOR DISMISSIVELY. THE DECREE FOR ILLEGIBLE CONFISCATION GIVES THE MINISTRY THE POWER TO CONFISCATE

THE CONTENTS OF A WILL

THAT LAW WAS CREATED TO STOP WIZARDS PASSING ON DARK ARTIFACTS, SAID HERMIONE, AND THE MINISTRY IS SUPPOSED TO HAVE SUFFICIENT EVIDENCE THAT THE DECEASED'S POSSESSIONS ARE ILLEGAL BEFORE SEIZING THEM? ARE YOU TELLING ME THAT YOU THOUGHT DUMBLEDORE WAS TRYING

TO PASS US SOMETHING CURSED?

ARE YOU PLANNING TO FOLLOW A CAREER IN MAGICAL LAW, MISS GRANGER? ASKED SCRIMGEOR.

CHAPTER SEVEN

129

NO, I'M NOT, RETORTED HERMIONE. I'M HELPING TO DO SOME GOOD IN THE WORLD!

THEN LAUGHED, SCRIMGEOR'S EYES FLICKERED TOWARD HIM AND AWAY AGAIN AS HARRY SPEAKED.

SHE WHY HAVE YOU DECIDED TO LET US HAVE OUR THINGS NOW? CAN'T

THINK OF A PRETEXT TO KEEP THEM?

WELL, IT MIGHT BE BECAUSE THE THIRTY-NINE DAYS ARE UP, SAID HERMIONE AT ONCE. THEY CAN'T KEEP THE BRIBES LONGER THAN THAT UNLESS THEY

CAN PROVE THEY'RE DANGEROUS, RIGHT?

WOULD YOU SAY YOU WERE CLOSE TO DUMBLEDORE, RONALD? ASKED SCRIMPGEUR, IGNORING HERMIONE. RON LAUGHED STARTLED.

MR? NOT NOT REALLY ... IT WAS ALWAYS HARRY WHO ... RON LAUGHED AROUND AT HARRY AND HERMIONE, THEN SAW HERMIONE GIVING HIM A STOP-TALKING-NOW! SHUT UP LAUGH, BUT THE DAMAGE WAS DONE: SCRIMPGEUR LAUGHED AS THOUGH HE HAD HEARD EXACTLY WHAT HE HAD EXPECTED, AND WANTED, TO HEAR. HE SMILED LIKE A BIRD OF PREY UPON RON'S ANSWER.

IF YOU WERE NOT VERY CLOSE TO DUMBLEDORE, WHY DID YOU ACCIDENT

ALLY FIND PERSONAL REQUESTS, THE VAST MAJORITY OF HIS POSSESSIONS HIS

PRIVATE LIBRARY, HIS MAGICAL INSTRUMENTS, AND OTHER PERSONAL EFFECTS

WERE LEFT TO THE FLEGGHARTS, WHY DID YOU THINK YOU WERE SINGLED OUT?

I ... BLIND, SAID RON. I ... WHEN I SAY WE WEREN'T CLOSE ... I MEAN, I THINK HE LIKED ME ...

YOU'RE BEING MODEST, RON, SAID HERMIONE. DUMBLEDORE WAS VERY KIND OF YOU.

THIS WAS STRETCHING THE TRUTH THE BREAKING POINT; AS FAR AS
HARRY

KNEW, BEN AND DUMBLEDORE HAD NEVER BEEN ALONE TOGETHER, AND

THE WILL OF

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

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DIRECT CONTACT BETWEEN THEM HAD BEEN NEGLIGIBLE. HOWEVER, STRING-
GELAR DID NOT SEEM TO BE LISTENING. HE PUT HIS HAND INSIDE HIS
COAT

AND DREW OUT A DRAWSTRING POUCH MUCH LARGER THAN THE ONE
HARRY

HAD GIVEN HARRY. FROM IT, HE REMOVED A SCROLL OF PARCHMENT WHICH
HE UNROLLED AND READ ALOUD.

THE LAST WILL AND TESTAMENT OF ALBUS PERCIVAL WILFRID BRIAN
DUMBLEDORE . . . YES, HERE WE ARE. . . THE RONALD BILLY WEASLEY, I
LEAVE MY DEDICATOR, IN THE HOPE THAT HE WILL REMEMBER ME WHEN
HE USES IT.

STRINGGELAR TOOK FROM THE BAG AN OBJECT THAT HARRY HAD SEEN RE-
CENTLY: IT LOOKED SOMETHING LIKE A SILVER CIGARETTE LIGHTER, BUT IT
HAD, HE

KNEW, THE POUCH THE SLID ALL LIGHT FROM A PLACE, AND RESTORE IT,
WITH

A SIMPLE CLICK. SCRIMGEEHLR LEANED FORWARD AND PASSED THE DILLMI-
NATHER TO REHN, WHO THICK IT AND TURNED IT OVER IN HIS FINGERS,
MEEKING

STUNNED.

THAT IS A VALUABLE OBJECT, SAID SCRIMGEEHLR, WATCHING REHN. IT
MAY EVEN BE LINDHELE. CERTAINLY IT IS OF DUMKLEBHERE'S OWN DESIGN.
WHY WOULD HE HAVE LEFT SUCH AN ITEM SO RARE?
REHN SHOOK HIS HEAD, MEEKING BEMILDERED.

DUMKLEBHERE MUST HAVE TAUGHT THOUSANDS OF STUDENTS, SCRIM-
GEEHLR PERSERVERED. YET THE ONLY ONES HE REMEMBERED IN HIS WILL ARE

SUCH THREE. WHY IS THAT? THE WHAT LIKE DID HE THINK SUCH WOULD PUT
HIS DILLMINATHER, MR. WEASLEY?

PUT BLIT LIGHTS, I S PHESE, MUMKLED REHN. WHAT ELSE COULD I DO
WITH IT?

EVIDENTLY SCRIMGEEHLR HAD NO SUGGESTIONS. AFTER SHILTING AT
REHN

FOR A MOMENT OR TWO, HE TURNED BACK TO DUMKLEBHERE'S WILL.

THE MISS HERMIONE IRAN GRANGER, I LEAVE MY COPY OF THE TALES

CHAPTER SEVEN

OF REEDEL THE BARD, IN THE HOPPE THAT SHE WILL FIND IT ENTERTAINING
AND

INSTRUITIVE.

SCRINGEHLIN NEW PULLED OUT OF THE BAG A SMALL BOOK THAT LOOKED AS
ANCIENT AS THE CRYPT OF SECRETS OF THE DARKEST ART UPSTAIRS. ITS
BINDING

WAS STAINED AND PEELING IN PLACES. HERMIENE TOOK IT FROM SCRING-
EHLIN WITH A WHIRL. SHE HELD THE BOOK IN HER LAP AND GAZED AT
IT.

HARRY SAW THAT THE TITLE WAS IN RUNES; HE HAD NEVER LEARNED TO
READ

THEM. AS HE LOOKED, A TEAR SPLASHED INTO THE EMBOSSED SYMBOLS.

WHY DID YOU THINK DUMBLEDORE LEFT YOU THAT BOOK, MISS
GRANGER? ASKED SCRINGEHLIN.

HE ... HE KNEW I LIKED BOOKS, SAID HERMIENE IN A THICK VOICE,
WIPING HER EYES WITH HER SLEEVE.

BUT WHY THAT PARTICULAR BOOK?

I DIDN'T KNOW, HE MUST HAVE THOUGHT I'D ENJOY IT.

DID YOU EVER DISCUSS BOOKS, HER ANY MEANS OF PASSING SECRET MES-
SAGES, WITH DUMBLEDORE?

NO, I DIDN'T, SAID HERMIENE, STILL WIPING HER EYES ON HER SLEEVE.
AND IF THE MINISTRY HASN'T FOUND ANY HIDDEN BOOKS IN THIS BOOK
IN

THIRTY-THREE DAYS, I BELIEVE THAT I WILL.

SHE SLIPPRESSED A SHE. THEY WERE WEDGED TOGETHER SHE TIGHTLY THAT
WHEN HAD DIFFICULTY EXTRACTING HIS ARM THE PLUT IT AROUND
HERMIONE'S

SEHLIDERS, SCRIMEHELR TURNED BACK THE THE WILL.

THE HARRY JAMES PITTER, HE READ, AND HARRY'S INSIDES
CONTRACTED

WITH A SLIDEN EXCITEMENT, I LEAVE THE SNITCH HE CALIGHT IN HIS
FIRST

BLIDDITCH MATCH AT HEGWARTS, AS A REMINDER OF THE REWARDS OF
PERSE-

VERANCE AND SKILL.

AS SCRIMEHELR PLUCKED OUT THE TINY, WALNUT-SIZED GOLDEN BALL, ITS
SILVER WINGS FLITTERED RATHER FEELY, AND HARRY COULD NOT HELP
FEELING

A DEFINITE SENSE OF ANTICIPAX.

THE WILL OF

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

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WHY DID DUMBLEDORE LEAVE MEH THIS SNITCH? ASKED SCRIMEHELR.

NO IDEA, SAID HARRY. FOR THE REASONS MEH ILST READ OUT, I SLIP-
PENSE . . . THE REMIND ME WHAT MEH CAN GET IF MEH . . . PERSEVERE AND

WHATEVER IT WAS.

WELL THINK THIS A MORE SYMBOLIC DEEDSACK, THEN?

I SUPPOSE SHE, SAID HARRY. WHAT ELSE COULD IT BE?

I'M ASKING THE ELDESTIENS, SAID SCRIMPGEHLER, SHIFTING HIS CHAIR A

LITTLE CLOSER TO THE SEAT. DUSK WAS REALLY FALLING ELTISIDE NOW; THE MAR-

BLEE BEYOND THE WINDMILLS TWINKED GHOSTLY WHITE OVER THE HEDGE.

I NOTICE THAT YOUR BIRTHDAY CAKE IS IN THE SHAPE OF A SNITCH,
SCRIMPGEHLER SAID TO HARRY. WHY IS THAT?

HERMIONE LAUGHED DERISIVELY.

EH, IT CAN'T BE A REFERENCE TO THE FACT HARRY'S A GREAT SEEKER,
THAT'S

WAS THE REVEALING, SHE SAID. THERE MUST BE A SECRET MESSAGE FROM
SOMEBODY HIDDEN IN THE ICING!

I DON'T THINK THERE'S ANYTHING HIDDEN IN THE ICING, SAID SCRIMP-
GHEHLER, BUT A SNITCH WOULD BE A VERY GOOD HIDING PLACE FOR A SMALL

OBJECT, WELL DONE WHY, I'M SURE?

HARRY SMILED. HERMIONE, HOWEVER, ANSWERED: HARRY THOUGHT
THAT ANSWERING ELDESTIENS CORRECTLY WAS SUCH A DEEPLY INGRAINED
HABIT

SHE COULD NOT SUPPRESS THE LAUGH.

BECAUSE SNITCHES HAVE FLESH MEMORIES, SHE SAID.

WHAT? SAID HARRY AND RON TOGETHER; BOTH CONSIDERED HERMI-

HIS S EVIDENCE KNOWLEDGE NEGLECTIBLE.

CORRECT, SAID STRINGER. A SNITCH IS NOT THICKED BY RARE SKIN BEFORE IT IS RELEASED, NOT EVEN BY THE MAKER, WHO WEARS GLOVES. IT CARRIES AN ENCHANTMENT BY WHICH IT CAN IDENTIFY THE FIRST HUMAN THE

LAST HANDS WORN IT, IN CASE OF A DISPLACED CAPTURE. THIS SNITCH HE

HOLD UP THE TINY CHILDEN BALL WILL REMEMBER YOUR THICK, PETER.

CHAPTER SEVEN

128

IT HILLS THE ME THAT DUMBLEDORE, WHO HAD PRODIGIOUS MAGICAL SKILL, WHATEVER HIS OTHER FALLS, MIGHT HAVE ENCHANTED THIS SNITCH SEE THAT

IT WILL OPEN ONLY FOR YOU.

HARRY'S HEART WAS BEATING RATHER FAST. HE WAS SURE THAT STRINGER WAS RIGHT. HOW COULD HE AVOID TAKING THE SNITCH WITH HIS RARE

HAND IN FRONT OF THE MINISTER?

YOU DON'T SAY ANYTHING, SAID STRINGER. PERHAPS YOU ALREADY KNOW WHAT THE SNITCH CONTAINS?

NO, SAID HARRY, STILL WONDERING HOW HE COULD APPEAR THE THICK THE SNITCH WITHOUT REALLY BEING SEE. IF ONLY HE KNEW LEGITIMACY,

REALLY KNEW IT, AND COULD READ HERMIONE'S MIND; HE COULD PRACTICALLY HEAR HER BRAIN WHIRRING BESIDE HIM.

TAKE IT, SAID SCRIMGEOR, QUIETLY.

HARRY MET THE MINISTER'S YELLOW EYES AND KNEW HE HAD NOT EIGHTEN BUT TEN YEARS, HE HELD UP HIS HAND, AND SCRIMGEOR LEANED FORWARD AGAIN AND PLACED THE SNITCH, SLEEKLY AND DELIBERATELY, INTO HARRY'S PALM.

NOTHING HAPPENED, AS HARRY'S FINGERS CLOSED AROUND THE SNITCH,

ITS TIRED WINGS FLUTTERED AND WERE STILL, SCRIMGEOR, RON, AND HERMIONE CONTINUED THE GAME VIVIDLY AT THE NEW PARTIALLY CONCEALED BALL,

AS IF STILL HOPING IT MIGHT TRANSFORM IN SOME WAY.

THAT WAS DRAMATIC, SAID HARRY CHEERILY, BOTH RON AND HERMIONE LAUGHED.

THAT'S ALL, THEN, IS IT? ASKED HERMIONE, MAKING THE PRIZE HERSELF FOR THE SEPA.

NOT WHITE, SAID SCRIMGEOR, WHO LOOKED BAD-TEMPERED NOW.

OLIVERPOKE LEFT WITH A SECOND REELIST, BETTER.

WHAT IS IT? ASKED HARRY, EXCITEMENT REKINDLING.

SCRIMGEOR DID NOT EITHER TRY TO READ FROM THE WILL THIS TIME.

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THE SWORD OF GORRIK GORFFINDOR, HE SAID,
HERMIONE AND RON BOTH STIFFENED. HARRY LOOKED AROUND FOR A
SIGN OF THE RUBY-ENCASED HILT, BUT STRINGER DID NOT PULL THE
SWORD FROM THE LEATHER POUCH, WHICH IN ANY CASE LOOKED MUCH THE
SMALLER CERTAIN IT.

SEE WHERE IS IT? HARRY ASKED SUSPICIOUSLY.

UNFORTUNATELY, SAID STRINGER, THAT SWORD WAS NOT DUMBLE-
DORE'S TO GIVE AWAY. THE SWORD OF GORRIK GORFFINDOR IS AN
IMPORTANT

HISTORICAL ARTIFACT, AND AS SUCH, REMAINS

IT REMAINS THE HARRY? SAID HERMIONE BENTLY. IT CAME HIM, HE WAS
THE ONE WHO FOUND IT, IT CAME TO HIM FIRST OF THE SORTING HAT

ACCORDING TO RELIABLE HISTORICAL SOURCES, THE SWORD MAY PRESENT
ITSELF TO ANY WORTHY GORFFINDOR, SAID STRINGER. THAT DOES
NOT

MAKE IT THE EXCLUSIVE PROPERTY OF MR. PEETER, WHATEVER
DUMBLEDOORE

MAY HAVE DECIDED. STRINGER SCRATCHED HIS BADLY SHAVEN CHEEK,
STUTTERING HARRY. WHY DO YOU THINK ?

DUMBLEDOORE WANTED TO GIVE ME THE SWORD? SAID HARRY,
STRUGGLING TO KEEP HIS TEMPER. MAYBE HE THOUGHT IT WOULD LOOK
NICE ON MY WALL.

THIS IS NOT A Joke, PETER! GROWLED SCRIMPHELR. WAS IT BECAUSE DUMBLEDORE BELIEVED THAT ONLY THE SWORD OF GODRIC GOFFINDOR COULD DEFEAT THE FORCE OF SLYTHERIN? DID HE WISH THE GIVE THEM THAT SWORD, PETER, BECAUSE HE BELIEVED, AS SO MANY, THAT THEY ARE THE ONE DESTINED THE DESTINED FOR-LOST-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED?

INTERESTING THEORY, SAID HARRY. HAS ANYONE EVER TRIED STICKING A SWORD IN VULDERMORT? MAYBE THE MINISTRY SHOULD PUT SOME PEOPLE

THAT, INSTEAD OF WASTING THEIR TIME STRIPPING DOWN BELLINIA-

THESE ARE CHIPPING UP BREADCRUMBS FROM AZKABAN, SHE IS THIS WHAT THEY VE

BEEN DOING, MINISTER, SHIT UP IN YOUR OFFICE, TRYING THE BREAD OPEN

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A SNITCH? PEOPLE ARE DYING I WAS NEARLY ONE OF THEM VULDERMORT CHASED ME ACROSS THREE COUNTIES, HE KILLED MAD-EYE MURDER,

BUT THERE'S BEEN ONE WHO'D ABELT AND OF THAT FROM THE MINISTRY, HAS THERE? AND THEY STILL EXPECT US TO COOPERATE WITH THEM?

THEY GO THEN FAR? SHOUTED SCRIMPHELR, STANDING UP; HARRY LIMPED

THE HIS FEET THEN, SCRIMPHELR LIMPED TOWARD HARRY AND LAPPED HIM

HARD IN THE CHEST WITH THE POINT OF HIS WAND! IT STINGED A HOLE IN
HARRY'S T-SHIRT LIKE A LIT CIGARETTE.

HE SAID THEN, LIMPING UP AND RAISING HIS OWN WAND, BUT HARRY
SAID,

WELL I WANT TO GIVE HIM AN EXCLUSIVE THE ARREST LIST?

REMEMBERED WELL HE MET AT SCHOOL, HAVE WELL? SAID STRINGPULP,

BREATHING HARD INTO HARRY'S FACE. REMEMBERED THAT I AM NOT DUM-
BLEDORE, WITH MYGAVE YOUR INTELLIGENCE AND INSUBORDINATION? YOU
MAY

WEAR THAT SCAR LIKE A CROWN, BETTER, BUT IT IS NOT UP TO A
SEVENTEEN-

YEAR-OLD KID TO TELL ME HOW TO DO MY JOB? IT'S TIME YOU LEARNED SOME

RESPECT!

IT'S TIME YOU EARNED IT, SAID HARRY.

THE FLOOR TREMBLED; THERE WAS A SOUND OF RUNNING FEETSTEPS, THEN
THE DOOR TO THE SITTING ROOM FIRST OPENED AND MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY
RAN IN.

WE WE THOUGHT WE HEARD BEGAN MR. WEASLEY, LEERING

TEHRREGLY ALARMED AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY AND THE MINISTER
VIRTU-

ALLY NEESE TO NEESE.

RAISED VOICES, PANTED MRS. WEASLEY.

STRINGPULP TOOK A CHUPLER OF STEPS BACK FROM HARRY, GLANCING AT

THE HOLE HE HAD MADE IN HARRY'S T-SHIRT, HE SEEMED TO REGRET HIS
LESSER TEMPER.

IT WAS NOTHING, HE GROWLED. I... REGRET YOUR ATTITUDE, HE

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ALLIS DUMBLEDORE

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SAID, WHIPPING HARRY FULL IN THE FACE ONCE MORE. YOU SEEM TO
THINK

THAT THE MINISTRY DOES NOT DESIRE WHAT YOU WANT DUMBLEDORE
DESIRED, WE MIGHT BE WORKING TOGETHER.

I DON'T LIKE YOUR METHODS, MINISTER, SAID HARRY. REMEMBER?
FOR THE SECOND TIME, HE RAISED HIS RIGHT FIST AND DISPLAYED THE
SCRIMGEOR'S SCARS THAT STILL SHOWED WHITE ON THE BACK OF IT,
SPELLING I MUST NOT TELL LIES. SCRIMGEOR'S EXPRESSION HARDENED,
HE

TURNED AWAY WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD AND LIMPED FROM THE ROOM.
MRS.

WEASLEY HURRIED AFTER HIM; HARRY HEARD HER STEP AT THE BACK
DOOR.

AFTER A MINUTE OR SO SHE CALLED, HE'S GONE?

WHAT DID HE WANT? MR. WEASLEY ASKED, LOOKING AROUND AT
HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE AS MRS. WEASLEY CAME HURRYING BACK
TO THEM.

THEY GIVE US WHAT DUMBLEDORE LEFT US, SAID HARRY. THEY'RE ONLY
JUST RELEASED THE CONTENTS OF HIS WILL.

ELTISIDE IN THE GARDEN, OVER THE DINNER TABLES, THE THREE SUBJECTS

STRINGERHURST HAD GIVEN THEM WERE PASSED FROM HAND TO HAND, EVERYONE EXCLAIMED OVER THE DEDICATOR AND THE TALE OF REEDER THE

AND LAMENTED THE FACT THAT STRINGERHURST HAD REFUSED TO PASS HIM THE SWORD, BUT NONE OF THEM COULD OFFER ANY SUGGESTION AS TO WHY

BLUNDERBELLER WOULD HAVE LEFT HARRY AN OLD SMITH. AS MR. WEASLEY EXAMINED THE DEDICATOR FOR THE THIRD OR FOURTH TIME, MRS.

WEASLEY SAID TENTATIVELY, "HARRY, DEAR, EVERYONE'S AWFULLY HUNGRY, WE

DON'T LIKE TO START WITHOUT YOU, . . . SHALL I SERVE DINNER NOW?"

THEY ALL ATE RATHER FLURRIEDLY AND THEN, AFTER A HASTY CHEERS OF

"HAPPY BIRTHDAY" AND MUCH GLIMPING OF LAKE, THE PARTY BROKE UP.

HARRY, WHO WAS INVITED TO THE WEDDING THE FOLLOWING DAY, WAS FAR FROM READY TO SLEEP IN THE OVERSTRETCHED CLOTHES, LEFT THE SET UP A

TENT FOR HIMSELF IN A NEIGHBORING FIELD.

CHAPTER SEVEN

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MEET HIS WIFE, HARRY WHISPERED TO HERMION, WHILE THEY

HELPED MRS. WEASLEY RESTORE THE GARDEN TO ITS NORMAL STATE.

AFTER

EVERYTHING WAS DONE THE RED,

UP IN THE ATTIC ROOM, RON EXAMINED HIS DEDIMINATOR, AND HARRY FILLED HARRY'S MEDICINE POUCH, NOT WITH CHOC, BUT WITH THESE ITEMS

HE MOST PRIZED, APPARENTLY WORTHLESS THOUGH SOME OF THEM WERE: THE

MARALDER'S MAP, THE SWORD OF SIRILUS'S ENCHANTED MIRROR, AND RAB'S

WICKET. HE PULLED THE STRINGS TIGHT AND SLIPPED THE POUCH AROUND HIS

NECK, THEN SAT HOLDING THE RED SNITCH AND WATCHING ITS WINGS FLUTTER

FREELY. AT LAST, HERMIONE TAPPED HIM ON THE SHOULDER AND TIPPED INSIDE.

MULIATE, SHE WHISPERED, WAVING HER HAND IN THE DIRECTION OF THE STAIRS.

THE LIGHT WILL NOT APPROVE OF THAT SPELL? SAID RON.

TIMES CHANGE, SAID HERMIONE. NOW, SHOW US THAT DEDIMINATOR.

RON CLICKED AT ONCE, HOLDING IT UP IN FRONT OF HIM. HE CLICKED IT.

THE SOLITARY LAMP THEY HAD LIT WENT OUT AT ONCE.

THE THING IS, WHISPERED HERMIONE THROUGH THE DARK, WE COULD HAVE ACHIEVED THAT WITH PERUVIAN INSTANT DARKNESS POWDER.

THERE WAS A SMALL CLICK, AND THE BALL OF LIGHT FROM THE LAMP FLEW BACK TO THE CEILING AND ILLUMINATED THEM ALL ONCE MORE.

STILL, IT'S CHEER, SAID REIN, A LITTLE DEFENSIVELY, AND FROM WHAT THEY SAID, DUMKLEDBORE INVENTED IT HIMSELF?

I KNOW, BUT SURELY HE WOULDN'T HAVE SINGLED YOU OUT IN HIS WILL JUST TO HELP US TURN OUT THE LIGHTS?

D YOU THINK HE KNEW THE MINISTRY WOULD CONFISCATE HIS WILL AND EXAMINE EVERYTHING HE'D LEFT US? ASKED HARRY.

DEFINITELY, SAID HERMIONE. HE WOULDN'T TELL US IN THE WILL WHY HE WAS LEAVING US THESE THINGS, BUT THAT STILL DOESN'T EXPLAIN...

THE WILL OF

ALBUS DUMKLEDBORE

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... WHY HE WOULDN'T HAVE GIVEN US A HINT WHEN HE WAS ALIVE? ASKED REIN.

WELL, EXACTLY, SAID HERMIONE, NOW FLICKING THROUGH THE PAGES OF NEEDLE THE BARD. IF THESE THINGS ARE IMPORTANT ENOUGH TO PASS ON

RIGHT UNDER THE NOSE OF THE MINISTRY, YOU'D THINK HE'D HAVE LET US

KNOW WHY... UNLESS HE THOUGHT IT WAS OBVIOUS?

THOUGHT WRITING, THEN, DIDN'T HE? SAID REIN. I ALWAYS SAID HE WAS MENTAL, BRILLIANT AND EVERYTHING, BUT CRACKED, LEAVING HARRY AN OLD SNITCH. WHAT THE HELL WAS THAT ABILITY?

I'VE NO IDEA, SAID HERMIONE. WHEN STRINGBELLOW MADE YOU TAKE IT, HARRY, I WAS SO SURE THAT SOMETHING WAS GOING TO HAPPEN?

Yeah, well, said Harry, his pulse quickening as he raised the Snitch in his fingers. I wasn't going to try too hard in front of Stringfellow, was I?

What did you mean? asked Hermione.

The Snitch I caught in my first ever Quidditch match? said Harry. Don't you remember?

Hermione looked simply confused, then, however, gasped, pointing frantically from Harry to the Snitch and back again until he

found his voice.

That was the one you nearly swallowed?

Exactly, said Harry, and with his heart beating fast, he pressed his mouth to the Snitch.

It did not open. Frustration and bitter disappointment welled up inside him: he held the golden sphere, but then Hermione cried out.

Writing! There's writing on it, quick, look!

He nearly dropped the Snitch in surprise and excitement. Hermione was quite right. Engraved upon the smooth golden surface,

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Where seconds before there had been nothing, were five words

WRITTEN IN THE THIN, SLANTING HANDWRITING THAT HARRY RECOGNIZED AS

DUMBLEDORE'S:

I HOPEN AT THE CLESE.

HE HAD BARELY READ THEM WHEN THE WORDS VANISHED AGAIN.

I HOPEN AT THE CLESE . . . WHAT'S THAT SUPPOSED TO MEAN?
HERMIONE AND RON SHOOK THEIR HEADS, LOOKING BLANK.

I HOPEN AT THE CLESE . . . AT THE CLESE . . . I HOPEN AT THE CLESE . . .
BUT NO MATTER HOW OFTEN THEY REPEATED THE WORDS, WITH MANY
DIFFERENT INFLECTIONS, THEY WERE UNABLE TO WORK OUT THEIR MEANING
FROM THEM.

AND THE SWORD, SAID RON FINALLY, WHEN THEY HAD AT LAST ABAN-
DONED THEIR ATTEMPTS TO DIVINE MEANING IN THE SNITCH'S
INSCRIPTION.

WHY DID HE WANT HARRY TO HAVE THE SWORD?
AND WHY COULDN'T HE JUST HAVE TOLD ME? HARRY SAID BRISKLY, IT
WAS THERE, IT WAS RIGHT THERE ON THE WALL OF HIS OFFICE DURING ALL
HIS
TALKS LAST YEAR! IF HE WANTED ME TO HAVE IT, WHY DIDN'T HE JUST GIVE
IT TO ME THEN?

HE FELT AS THOUGH HE WERE SITTING IN AN EXAMINATION WITH A LIES-
TELLER HE HADN'T BEEN ABLE TO ANSWER IN FRONT OF HIM, HIS
BRAIN

STILL AND UNRESPONSIVE. WAS THERE SOMETHING HE HAD MISSED IN THE LONG TALKS WITH DUMBLEDORE LAST YEAR? HEIGHT HE THEN KNEW WHAT IT ALL

MEANT? HAD DUMBLEDORE EXPECTED HIM THEN UNDERSTAND?

AND AS FOR THIS BOOK, SAID HERMIONE, THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE BARD ... I VE NEVER EVEN HEARD OF THEM!

WELL VE NEVER HEARD OF THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE BARD? SAID RON INCREDULOUSLY. WELL RE KIDDING, RIGHT?

THE WILL OF

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

YES

OH, I M NOT! SAID HERMIONE IN SURPRISE. OH WELL KNEW THEM, THEN?

WELL, OF COURSE I DO!

HARRY LEDDED UP, DIVERTED. THE CIRCUMSTANCE OF RON HAVING READ A BOOK THAT HERMIONE HAD NOT WAS UNPRECEDENTED. RON, HOWEVER, LEDDED REPLIED BY THEIR SURPRISE.

OH COME ON! ALL THE OLD KIDS STORIES ARE SUPPOSED TO BE BEEDLE S, AREN T THEY? THE FOUNTAIN OF FAIR FORTUNE ... THE WIZARD AND THE

HOPPING POT ... RABBITTY RABBITTY AND HER CACKLING STUMP ...

EXCUSE ME? SAID HERMIONE, GIGGLING. WHAT WAS THAT LAST ONE?

COME OFF IT! SAID RENN, LEANING IN DISBELIEF FROM HARRY THE HER-
MIONE. YOU MUST VE HEARD OF RABBITTY RABBITTY

RENN, YOU KNOW FULL WELL HARRY AND I WERE BRUGHT UP BY
MUGGLES!

SAID HERMIONE. WE DIDN'T HEAR STORIES LIKE THAT WHEN WE WERE
LITTLE,

WE HEARD SNOW WHITE AND THE SEVEN DWARFS AND CINDERELLA

WHAT'S THAT, AN ILLNESS? ASKED RENN.

SEE THESE ARE CHILDREN'S STORIES? ASKED HERMIONE, BENDING AGAIN
OVER THE RILNES.

YEAH, SAID RENN UNCERTAINLY, I MEAN, THAT'S JUST WHAT YOU HEAR,
YOU KNOW, THAT ALL THESE OLD STORIES CAME FROM BEDDIE. I DON'T
KNOW

THEY'RE LIKE IN THE ORIGINAL VERSIONS.

BUT I WONDER WHY DUMBLEDORE THOUGHT I SHOULD READ THEM?
SOMETHING CREAKED DOWNSTAIRS.

PROBABLY JUST CHARLIE, NEW MUM'S ASLEEP, SNEAKING OFF THE REGGIES
HIS HAIR, SAID RENN NERVOUSLY.

ALL THE SAME, WE SHOULD GET THE BED, WHISPERED HERMIONE. IT
WOULDN'T BE THE EVER-SLEEP THEMSELVES.

CHAPTER SEVEN

LEE

NE, AGREED RENN. A BRUTAL TRIPLE MURDER BY THE BRIDEGROOM'S

WHETHER MIGHT PUT A BIT OF A DAMPER ON THE WEDDING, I'LL GET THE LIGHTS.

AND HE CLICKED THE REMOVATOR ONCE MORE AS HERMIONE LEFT THE ROOM.

CHAPTER EIGHT

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THE WEDDING

THEY WERE IN THE FOLLOWING AFTERNOON FINDING HARRY, RON, FRED, AND GEORGE STANDING BESIDE THE GREAT WHITE MARBLE IN THE GARDEN, AWAITING THE ARRIVAL OF THE WEDDING GUESTS. HARRY HAD

TAKEN A LARGE DOSE OF PHOSPHORUS POTION AND WAS NOW THE DOCTOR OF A

RED-HEADED MUGGLE BOY FROM THE LOCAL VILLAGE, HETTERY ST. CATHERINE, FROM WHOM FRED HAD STOLEN HAIRS USING A SLEEPING CHARM. THE PLAN WAS TO INTRODUCE HARRY AS CHRISTIN BARRY AND TRUST THE GREAT NUMBER OF WEASLEY RELATIVES TO CAMELBACK HIM.

ALL FOUR OF THEM WERE CLUTCHING SEATING PLANS, SEE THAT THEY COULD HELP SHOW PEOPLE TO THE RIGHT SEATS. A HOST OF WHITE-BEKKED WAITERS

HAD ARRIVED AN HOUR EARLIER, ALONG WITH A GOLDEN-JACKETED BAND, AND

ALL OF THESE WIZARDS WERE CURRENTLY SITTING A SHORT DISTANCE AWAY
UNDER A TREE; HARRY COULD SEE A BLUE HAZE OF PIPE SMOKE ISSUING FROM

THE SMOKE.

BEHIND HARRY, THE ENTRANCE TO THE MARBLE REVEALED ROWS AND
ROWS OF FRAGILE GILDED CHAIRS SET ON EITHER SIDE OF A LONG PURPLE
CARPET.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

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THE SUPPORTING PILES WERE ENTWINED WITH WHITE AND GOLD FLOWERS.

FRED AND GEORGE HAD FASTENED AN ENORMOUS KNOT OF GILDED RAL-
PHENS OVER THE EXACT POINT WHERE BILL AND MELBA WOULD SHORTLY RE-
MEET HUSBAND AND WIFE. ELTISE, KLITTERLIES AND KEES WERE FEVERING

LAZILY OVER THE GRASS AND HEDGEROW. HARRY WAS RATHER
UNCOMFORTABLE.

THE MUGGLE WHOSE APPEARANCE HE WAS AFFECTING WAS SLIGHTLY
FAT-

TER THAN HIM, AND HIS DRESS REELS FELT HOT AND TIGHT IN THE FULL
GLARE

OF A SLIMPER S DAY.

WHEN I GET MARRIED, SAID FRED, TUGGING AT THE COLLAR OF HIS HORN
RINGS, I WEN'T BE BOTHERING WITH ANY OF THIS NONSENSE. YELL CAN
ALL

WEAR WHAT YELL LIKE, AND I LL PUT A FULL BODY-KIND CURSE ON YIM
UNTIL IT S ALL OVER.

SHE WASN'T TOO BAD THIS MORNIN, CONSIDERING, SAID GEORGE.

CRIED A BIT ABOUT PERCY NOT BEING HERE, BUT WE'LL WANT HIM? EH
BLIMEY, BRACE YOURSELVES HERE THEY COME, LEEED.

BRIGHTLY COLOURED FIGURES WERE APPEARING, ONE BY ONE, UNTIL THEY WERE
WHERE AT THE DISTANT BOUNDARY OF THE YARD, WITHIN MINUTES A
PACKES-

STEEN HAD FORMED, WHICH BEGAN THE SNAKE ITS WAY UP THROUGH THE
GARDEN

THROUGH THE MARSHES, EXOTIC FLOWERS AND BOWTIED KIDS FLUTTERED
ON

THE WITCHES HATS, WHILE PRECIOUS GEMS GLITTERED FROM MANY OF THE
WIZARDS CRAVATS; A FLOW OF EXCITED CHATTER GREW LOUDER AND LOUDER,
DRENNING THE SOUND OF THE KEES AS THE CREED APPROACHED THE TENT.

EXCELLENT, I THINK I SEE A FEW VEEA CHLISINS, SAID GEORGE, CRAN-
ING HIS NECK FOR A BETTER VIEW. THEY LL NEED HELP UNDERSTANDING
ELIA

ENGLISH CLUSTERS, I LL WATCH AFTER THEM, . . .

NOT SO FAST, YELLIA FEELEYNES, SAID FRED, AND DARTING PAST THE

GAGGLE OF MIDDLE-AGED WITCHES HEADING THE PROCESSION, HE SAID,

HERE PERMITTED-MEET THE ASSISTANT VEHICLES, THE A PAIR OF PRETTY FRENCH

GIRLS, WHO GIGGLED AND ALLOWED HIM TO ESCORT THEM INSIDE. GEORGE

THE WEDDING

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WAS LEFT THE DEAL WITH THE MIDDLE-AGED WITCHES AND THEN THEIR CHARGE OF MR. WEASLEY'S OLD MINISTRY COLLEAGUE PERKINS, WHILE A RATHER DRAPE

HAD CHURCH FELL THE HARRY'S LEFT.

WHETHER, SAID A FAMILIAR VOICE AS HE CAME OUT OF THE MARSHES AGAIN AND FEELING THINGS AND LUPIN AT THE FRONT OF THE BELIEVE, SHE HAD TURNED BLIND FOR THE OCCASION. AFTERWARD THIS WAS WHEN THE HEN WITH THE CURLY HAIR, SHIRAZ ABELT LAST NIGHT, SHE ADDED IN A WHISPER AS HARRY LED THEM UP THE AISLE. THE MINISTRY'S BEING VERY

ANTI-WEREWOLVES AT THE MOMENT AND WE THOUGHT HER PRESENCE MIGHT NOT BE WELL AND FAYERS.

IT'S FINE, I UNDERSTAND, SAID HARRY, SPEAKING MORE TO LUPIN THAN THINGS. LUPIN GAVE HIM A SWIFT SMILE, BUT AS THEY TURNED AWAY,

HARRY SAW LUPIN'S FACE FALL AGAIN INTO LINES OF MISERY. HE DID NOT UNDERSTAND IT, BUT THERE WAS NO TIME TO DWELL ON THE MATTER: HARRY

WAS CAUSING A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF DISRUPTION, HAVING
MISUNDERSTOOD

FRED'S DIRECTIONS HE HAD SAT HIMSELF, NOT UPON THE MAGICALLY
ENLARGED

AND REINFORCED SEAT SET ASIDE FOR HIM IN THE BACK ROW, BUT FIVE
SEATS THAT NOW RESEMBLED A LARGE PILE OF GOLDEN MATCHSTICKS.

WHILE MR. WEASLEY REPAIRED THE DAMAGE AND HAGRID SPELLED
APPLESIES THE ANKEDY WHO WOULD LISTEN, HARRY HURRIED BACK TO THE
ENTRANCE THE FIND THEM FACE-TO-FACE WITH A MOST ECCENTRIC-LOOKING

WIZARD, SLIGHTLY CROSS-EYED, WITH SHOULDER-LENGTH WHITE HAIR THE
TEXT-

THAT OF CANDYFLIES, HE WORE A CAP WHOSE TASSEL DANGLED IN FRONT OF

HIS NOSE AND BEARS OF AN EYE-WATERING SHADE OF EC-YELLOW YELLOW,
AN

HDD SYMBOL, RATHER LIKE A TRIANGULAR EYE, GLISTENED FROM A GOLDEN
CHAIN AROUND HIS NECK.

WENDEPHILIS LIVED, HE SAID, EXTENDING A HAND TO HARRY, MY
DAUGHTER AND I LIVE JUST OVER THE HILL, SEE KIND OF THE GOOD
WEASLEYS

THE INVITE US, BUT I THINK YOU KNOW MY LUNA? HE ADDED THE OTHER.

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YES, SAID OTHER, ISN'T SHE WITH YOU?

SHE LINGERED IN THAT CHARMING LITTLE GARDEN THE DAY BEFORE THE THE

Gnomes, such a cheerful infestation! Few few wizards realize just how much we can learn from the wise little Gnomes. No, we give them their correct name, the Gnomish Gardens.

How do know a lot of excellent swear words, said Ben, but I think Fred and George taught them these.

He led a party of warriors into the marshes as Lina rushed up.

Hello Harry! she said.

Oh my name is Lina, said Harry, flustered.

Oh, have you changed that then? she asked brightly.

How did you know?

Oh, just your expression, she said.

Like her father, Lina was wearing bright yellow robes, which she had accessorized with a large sunflower in her hair. Hence you get even the brightness of it all, the general effect was quite pleasant. At

least there were no radishes dangling from her ears.

Remphill, who was deep in conversation with an acquaintance,

had missed the exchange between Lina and Harry. Kidding the wizard farewell, he turned to his daughter, who held up her finger and said, Daddy, when one of the Gnomes actually bit me?

How wonderful! Gnome saliva is enormously beneficial! said Mr. Leverage, seizing Lina's outstretched finger and examining the bleeding puncture marks. Lina, my love, if you should feel any burgeoning talent today perhaps an unexpected urge to sing

opera or the declaim in Mermish. Do not repress it! You may have

BEEN CITED BY THE GERMANKELIES?

THEN, PASSING THEM IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION, LET MEET A BEILD
SNEERT.

THE WEDDING

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THEN CAN LAUGH, SAID LLINA SERENELY AS HARRY LED HER AND XENH-
PHILILIS TOWARD THEIR SEATS, BUT MY FATHER HAS BEEN A LITTLE OF
RESEARCH.

HEIN GERMANKELI MAGIC.

REALLY? SAID HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN SINCE DECIDED MEET THE CHALLENGE
LLINA HER FATHER'S PECULIAR VIEWS. ARE YOU SURE YOU DON'T
WANT THE

PLUT ANYTHING HEIN THAT RITE, THEELLYN?

HEH, IT'S FINE, SAID LLINA, SLICKING HER FINGER IN A DREAMY FASHION
AND LEERLING HARRY UP AND DOWN. YOU KNOW SMART, I TOLD DADDY
MOST PEOPLE WOULD PREFERABLY WEAR DRESS RINGS, BUT HE BELIEVES YOU
MIGHT THE WEAR SUN CROWN THE A WEDDING, FOR LUCK, YOU KNOW.

AS SHE DRIFTED OFF AFTER HER FATHER, THEN REAPPEARED WITH AN ELDERLY
WITCH CLUTCHING HIS ARM, HER BRADY NOSE, RED-RIMMED EYES, AND
FEATHERY PINK HAT GAVE HER THE LOOK OF A BAD-TEMPERED FLAMINGO.

... AND YOUR HAIR'S MUCH THE LONG, RICHARD, FOR A MOMENT I
THOUGHT YOU WERE GINEVRA. MERLIN'S BEARD, WHAT IS XENH-
PHILILIS LHYGHEED WEARING? HE LOOKS LIKE AN EMPELET, AND WHO ARE YOU?

SHE GAZED AT HARRY.

OH DEAR, AUNTIE MURIEL, THIS IS MISS CHRISTIN BARRY,

ANOTHER LEASLEY? YOU SPEAK LIKE ENEMIES. ISN'T HARRY BETTER
HERE? I WAS HOPING TO MEET HIM. I THOUGHT HE WAS A FRIEND OF
YOURS,

REYNOLD, HE HAD YOU MERELY BEEN JEASTING?

NO HE COULDN'T COME

HEM, MADE AN EXCUSE, DID HE? NOT AS CHERMLESS AS HE LOOKS IN
PRESS PHOTOGRAPHS, THEN. I VE JUST BEEN INSTRUCTING THE BRIDE HER
SELF

BEST TO WEAR MY TIARA, SHE SMILED AT HARRY. CHERLIN-MADE, YOU
KNOW, AND BEEN IN MY FAMILY FOR CENTURIES. SHE'S A GOOD-LOOKING
GIRL, BUT STILL FRENCH. WELL, WELL, FIND ME A GOOD SEAT, REYNOLD,
I AM A HUNDRED AND SEVEN AND I MIGHT NOT BE IN MY FEET THIS
MORN.

CHAPTER EIGHT

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REYN GAVE HARRY A MEANINGFUL LOOK AS HE PASSED AND DID NOT REAP-
PEAR FOR SOME TIME. WHEN NEXT THEY MET AT THE ENTRANCE, HARRY
HAD

SEEN A DOZEN MORE PEOPLE TO THEIR PLACES. THE MARQUEE WAS
NEARLY

FULL NOW, AND FOR THE FIRST TIME THERE WAS NO EMPTY OUTSIDE.

NIGHTMARE, MURIEL IS, SAID REYN, SHIPPING HIS FOREHEAD IN HIS

SLEEVE. SHE USED THE CUFF FOR CHRISTMAS EVERY YEAR, THEN, THAND

GOD, SHE THEM OFFENSE BECAUSE FRED AND GEORGE SET UP A DUNG-
BERRY UNDER HER CHAIR AT DINNER. DAD ALWAYS SAYS SHE LL HAVE WRIT-
TEN THEM ABOUT IF HER WILL LIKE THEY CARE, THEY RE GOING THE END
LIP

RICHER THAN ANYONE IN THE FAMILY, RATE THEY RE GOING. . . . WELL, HE
ADDED, BLINKING RATHER RAPIDLY AS HERMINEE CAME FLIRTING TOWARD
THEM. YELL THEM GREAT!

ALWAYS THE TIME OF SURPRISE, SAID HERMINEE, THOUGH SHE SMILED.
SHE WAS WEARING A PLEATY, LILAC-COLORED DRESS WITH MATCHING HIGH
HEELS; HER HAIR WAS SLEEK AND SHINY. YELL GREAT-GRAND MURIEL
DEESN T

AGREE, I JUST MET HER UPSTAIRS WHILE SHE WAS GIVING FLEUR THE
TIARA.

SHE SAID, HEN DEAR, IS THIS THE MUGGLE-BERRY? AND THEN, BAD
PESTLE

AND SPINNY ANDLES.

DEN T TAKE IT PERSONALLY, SHE S BLAME THE EVERYONE, SAID REEN.

TALKING ABOUT MURIEL? INQUIRED GEORGE, REEMERGING FROM THE
MARBLE WITH FRED. YEAH, SHE S JUST TOLD ME MY EARS ARE UPSIDED.
HOLD ON, I WISH HOLD LITTLE BILLY WAS STILL WITH US, THOUGH; HE WAS A
RIGHT LAUGH AT WEDDINGS.

WASN T HE THE ONE WHO SAW A GRIM AND DIED TWENTY-FLEUR FEELERS
LATER? ASKED HERMINEE.

WELL, YEAH, HE WENT A BIT MAD TOWARD THE END, CHUCKLED
GEORGE.

BUT BEFORE HE WENT HOME HE WAS THE LIFE AND SOUL OF THE PARTY,
SAID FRED. HE USED THE DOLBY AN ENTIRE BOTTLE OF FIREWATER, THEN
RAN

THE WEDDING

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BUT THE DANCE FLOOR, HEIST UP HIS REEKS, AND START PULLING
CLINKERS

HE FLOWERS HEIT OF HIS

YES, HE SEEMS A REAL CHARMER, SAID FERMINE, WHILE HARRY
BEHARD WITH LAUGHTER.

NEVER MARRIED, FOR SOME REASON, SAID RICH.

WELL AMAZE ME, SAID FERMINE.

THEY WERE ALL LAUGHING SO MUCH THAT WHEN HE THEM NOTICED THE
LATECHER, A DARK-HAIRED YOUNG MAN WITH A LARGE, CLAYED NOSE AND
THICK BLACK EYEBROWS, UNTIL HE HAD HEIT HIS INVITATION THE RICH AND
SAID, WITH HIS EYES ON FERMINE, WELL WELL GLORIOUS.

WITHER? SHE SHRIEKED, AND DROPPED HER SMALL BEADED BAG, WHICH

MADE A BEUD FLUMP HEITE DISPROPORTIONATE THE ITS SIZE. AS SHE
SCRAM-

LED, ELLISHING, THE PICK IT UP, SHE SAID, I DIDN T KNOW YOU WERE

GENUINE IT S BEVELY THE SEE FEEL ARE YOU?

RICH S EARS HAD TURNED BRIGHT RED AGAIN. AFTER GLANCING AT EDWIN S
INVITATION AS IF HE DID NOT BELIEVE A WORD OF IT, HE SAID, MUCH THE

WELL, I'VE COME HERE ARE HERE?

ALAN INVITED ME, SAID ORLIN, EYEBROWS RAISED.

HARRY, WHO HAD NO GRUDGE AGAINST ORLIN, STOOD HANDS; THEN,

FEELING THAT IT WOULD BE PRUDENT TO REMOVE ORLIN FROM REEN'S
VICIN-

ITY, OFFERED TO SHOW HIM HIS SEAT.

THEIR FRIEND IS NOT PLEASED TO SEE ME, SAID ORLIN AS THEY ENTERED
THE NEW PACKED MARQUEE. HE IS HE A RELATIVE? HE ASKED WITH A
GLANCE AT HARRY'S RED CURLY HAIR.

WHEN, HARRY MUTTERED, BUT ORLIN WAS NOT REALLY LISTENING.
HIS APPEARANCE WAS CAUSING A STIR, PARTICULARLY AMONGST THE
PEOPLE

WHEN: HE WAS, AFTER ALL, A FAMOUS HILDDITCH PLAYER. WHILE
PEOPLE

WERE STILL CRANING THEIR NECKS TO GET A GOOD LOOK AT HIM, REEN,
HER-

MINNE, FRED, AND GEORGE WERE FLIPPING DOWN THE AISLE.

CHAPTER EIGHT

1999

TIME TO SIT DOWN, FRED TOLD HARRY, HE WE'RE GOING TO GET RUN
OVER BY THE BRIDE.

HARRY, REEN, AND HERMINNE TOOK THEIR SEATS IN THE SECOND ROW

BEHIND FRED AND GEORGE, HERMIONE BLEEHED RATHER PINK AND HER EARS WERE STILL SCARLET. AFTER A FEW MOMENTS HE MUTTERED THE HARRY, DID YOU SEE HE'S GREEN A STUPID LITTLE BEARD? HARRY GAVE A NUNCHENMITTAL GRUNT.

A SENSE OF LITTEY ANTICIPATION HAD FILLED THE WARM TENT, THE GENERAL MURMURING BREEDEN BY ECCLESIAL SPLITS OF EXCITED LAUGHTER.

MRS. WEASLEY STRETTLED UP THE AISLE, SMILING AND WAVING AT RELATIVES; MRS. WEASLEY WAS WEARING A BRAND-NEW SET OF ANTI-POST-CELESTIAL DRESSES WITH A MATCHING HAT.

A MOMENT LATER BILL AND CHARLIE STOOD UP AT THE FRONT OF THE MARBLE, BOTH WEARING DRESS DRESSES, WITH LARGE WHITE DRESSES IN THEIR EYES-

THEY WERE; FRED WHIP-LEISTLED AND THERE WAS AN ELLTEREAD OF GIGGLING

FROM THE VERY CELESTIALS. THEN THE CREED FELL SILENT AS MUSIC SWELLED FROM WHAT SEEMED THE BE THE CELESTIALS.

HEHEHE! SAID HERMIONE, SWIVELING AROUND IN HER SEAT THE BLEED AT THE ENTRANCE.

A GREAT COLLECTIVE SIGH ISSUED FROM THE ASSEMBLED WITCHES AND WIZARDS AS MENSTELIA DELACELIA AND FLEW CAME WALKING UP THE AISLE.

FLEW GLIDING, MENSTELIA DELACELIA REELING AND REAMING, FLEW WAS WEARING A VERY SIMPLE WHITE DRESS AND SEEMED THE BE EMITTING A

SHINE, SILVERY GLEES, WHILE HER RADIANCE USUALLY DIMMED EVERYONE ELSE BY COMPARISON, TODAY IT REALITIFIED EVERYBODY IT FELL UPON, GINNY

AND GABRIELLE, BOTH WEARING GOLDEN DRESSES, LOOKED EVEN PRETTIER THAN USUAL, AND WHEN FLEW HAD REACHED HIM, KILL DID NOT LOOK AS THOUGH HE HAD EVER MET FERRIS GREYBACK.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, SAID A SLIGHTLY SINGING VOICE, AND WITH THE WEDDING

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A SLIGHT SMILE, HARRY SAW THE SAME SMALL, TWIFTY-FAIRED WIZARD WHO HAD PRESIDED AT DUMBLEDORE'S FUNERAL, NOW STANDING IN FRONT OF KILL AND FLEW. WE ARE GATHERED HERE TODAY TO CELEBRATE THE WEDDING OF TWO FAITHFUL SHELS . . .

YES, MY TIARA SETS OFF THE WHOLE THING NICELY, SAID ALUNTIE MURIEL

IN A RATHER CARRYING WHISPER. BUT I MUST SAY, GINEVRA'S DRESS IS FAR

THEE WELL CUT,

GINNY GLANCED AROUND, GRINNING, WINKED AT HARRY, THEN BLINKED FACED THE FRONT AGAIN. HARRY'S MIND WANDERED A LONG WAY FROM THE MARILIZE, BACK THE AFTERNOONS SPENT ALONE WITH GINNY IN LONELY PARTS

OF THE SCHEER GREENLANDS. THEY SEEMED SO LONG AGO; THEY HAD ALWAYS

SEEMED THEE GOOD THEE TRULY, AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN STEALING SHIN-

ING FEELING FROM A NORMAL PERSON'S LIFE, A PERSON WITHOUT A
LIGHTNING-

SHAPED STAR ON HIS FOREHEAD, . . .

DEE YELL, WILLIAM ARTHUR, TAKE FLEUR ISABELLE . . . ?

IN THE FRONT ROW, MRS. LEASLEY AND MADAME DELACHAIR WERE BOTH
SHRINKING QUIETLY INTO SCRAPS OF LACE. TRUMPETLIKE SOUNDS FROM THE
BACK OF THE MARQUEE TOLD EVERYONE THAT HARRY HAD TAKEN HOLD OF
OF HIS OWN TABLET-SIZED HANDKERCHIEFS. FERMINE TURNED AND
BEAMED AT HARRY; HER EYES THEN WERE FULL OF TEARS.

. . . THEN I DECLARE YELL BEHIND HER LIFE.

THE TWIFTY-FAIRED WIZARD WAVED HIS HAND HIGH OVER THE HEADS OF
BILL AND FLEUR AND A SHOWER OF SILVER STARS FELL UPON THEM,
SPIRALING

AROUND THEIR NOW ENTWINED FIGURES. AS FRED AND GEORGE LED A
ROUND

OF APPLAUSE, THE GOLDEN BALLEONS OVERHEAD BURST! BIRDS OF PARADISE
AND TINY GOLDEN BELLS FLEW AND CHEATED OUT OF THEM, ADDING THEIR
SINGS AND CHIMES TO THE DIN.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN! CALLED THE TWIFTY-FAIRED WIZARD. IF YELL
WOULD PLEASE STAND UP!

CHAPTER EIGHT

1998

THEY ALL DID SEE, ALTHOUGH MURIEL CROUCHING ALIDILY; HE WAVED HIS

WAND AGAIN. THE SEATS IN WHICH THEY HAD BEEN SITTING RISE GRACE-
FULLY INTO THE AIR AS THE CANVAS WALLS OF THE MARQUEE VANISHED, SH-

THAT THEY STOOD BENEATH A CANOPY SUPPORTED BY CHILDEN POLES, WITH
A GLORIOUS VIEW OF THE SUNNY HILL AND SURROUNDING
COUNTRY.

NEXT, A POLE OF MOUNTAIN CLOTH SPREAD FROM THE CENTER OF THE TENT TO

FORM A GLAMOROUS DANCE FLOOR; THE HEAVY CHAIRS GROUNDED THEM-
SELVES AROUND SMALL, WHITE-CLOTHED TABLES, WHICH ALL RISE GRACE-
FULLY BACK THE EARTH AROUND IT, AND THE CHILDEN-LOVED BAND
TRUMPETED

THEIR OWN MUSIC.

SMITH, SAID REIN APPROVINGLY AS THE WAITERS PEEPED UP IN ALL
SIDES, SOME BEARING SILVER TRAYS OF PLUMPOIN JUICE, BUTTER, AND
FIREW-HISKEY, OTHERS TITTERING PILES OF TARTS AND SANDWICHES.

WE SHOULD GO AND CONGRATULATE THEM! SAID FERMINE, STANDING
IN THE TEE SEE THE PLACE WHERE KILL AND FLEW HAD VANISHED AMID
A CLOUD OF WELL-WISHERS.

WE LL HAVE TIME LATER, SUGGESTED REIN, SNATCHING THREE BUTTER-
PERS FROM A PASSING TRAY AND HANDING ONE TO FERRY, FERMINE,
AND

WELL, LET US GRAB A TABLE. . . . NOT THERE! NOWHERE NEAR MURIEL

REIN LED THE WAY ACROSS THE EMPTY DANCE FLOOR, GLANCING LEFT AND

RIGHT AS HE WENT: HARRY FELT SURE THAT HE WAS KEEPING AN EYE ONT
HER

DURING. BY THE TIME THEY HAD REACHED THE OTHER SIDE OF THE MARBLE,
MOST OF THE TABLES WERE OCCUPIED: THE EMPTYEST WAS THE ONE WHERE
LUNA SAT ALONE.

ALL RIGHT IF WE IMIN YELLY? ASKED RENN.

HEY YES, SHE SAID HAPPILY. DADDY S ILST GENE TH GIVE BILL AND
FLEUR ELIN PRESENT.

WHAT IS IT, A LIFETIME S SUPPLY OF GLINDYREETS? ASKED RENN.

HERMIONE AIMED A BIDE AT HIM UNDER THE TABLE, BUT CALIGHT HARRY

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INSTEAD, EYES WATERING IN PAIN, HARRY LOST TRACK OF THE
CONVERSATION

AFTER A FEW MOMENTS,

THE BAND HAD BEGUN THE PLAY, BILL AND FLEUR THEN THE DANCE FLEER

FIRST, THE GREAT APPALISE; AFTER A WHILE, MR. WEASLEY LED MADAME
DELA-

CELIA HENTH THE FLEER, FOLLOWED BY MRS. WEASLEY AND FLEUR S FATHER.

I LIKE THIS SONG, SAID LUNA, SWAYING IN TIME THE THE WALTZLIKE
TUNE, AND A FEW SECONDS LATER SHE STEPPED UP AND GLIDED HENTH THE
DANCE

FLEER, WHERE SHE REVEALED HER THE SPOT, WHITE ALONE, EYES CLOSED AND

LAYING HER ARMS.

SHE IS GREAT, ISN'T SHE? SAID RICH ADMIRINGLY. ALWAYS GOOD
VALER.

BUT THE SMILE VANISHED FROM HIS FACE AT ONCE: YETTER DORUM HAD

DROPPED INTO LINA'S VACANT SEAT. HERMINEE LOOKED PLEASURABLY
ALLIS-

TERED, BUT THIS TIME DORUM HAD NOT COME TO COMPLEMENT HER. WITH A

STERN LOOK ON HIS FACE HE SAID, WHO IS THAT MAN IN THE YELLOW?

THAT'S XENOPHILUS LEVEGHEE, HE'S THE FATHER OF A FRIEND OF
MINE.

SAID RICH. HIS PLEASURES THERE INDICATED THAT THEY WERE NOT ABOUT
THE LAUGH AT XENOPHILUS, DESPITE THE CLEAR PRESENTATION. COME
AND

DANCE. HE ADDED ABRUPTLY TO HERMINEE.

SHE LOOKED TAKEN ABACK, BUT PLEASED THEM, AND GOT UP. THEY VAN-
ISHED TOGETHER INTO THE GRILLING THRONG IN THE DANCE FLOOR.

AH, THEY ARE TOGETHER NOW? ASKED DORUM, MOMENTARILY
DISTRACTED.

OR NOT? SAID HARRY.

WHO ARE YOU? DORUM ASKED.

BARRY LEASLEY.

THEY SHOOK HANDS.

WELL, BARRY WHO KNOWS THIS MAN LEVEGHEE WELL?

NO, I ONLY MET HIM TODAY, WHO?

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DRUM GLEERED OVER THE TOP OF HIS DRINK, WATCHING XENOPHILIUS, WHO WAS CHATTING THE SEVERAL WARRIORS ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE

DANCE FLOOR.

BECAUSE, SAID DRUM, IF HE WERE MEET A GUEST OF FLEET'S, I WOULD BLAME

HIM, HERE AND NOW, FOR WEARING THAT FILTHY SIGN UPON HIS CHEST.

SIGN? SAID HARRY, LEERING OVER AT XENOPHILIUS THEN. THE STRANGE

TRIANGULAR ONE WAS GLAMING HIM HIS CHEST. WHY? WHAT'S WRONG WITH IT?

GRINDYALD, THAT IS GRINDYALD'S SIGN.

GRINDYALD . . . THE DARK WIZARD DUMBLEDORE DEFEATED?

EXACTLY.

DRUM'S JAW MUSCLES WERRED AS IF HE WERE CHEWING, THEN HE SAID,

GRINDYALD KILLED MANY PEOPLE, MY GRANDFATHER, FOR INSTANCE. OF COURSE, HE WAS NEVER POWERFUL IN THIS COUNTRY, THEY SAID HE FEARED DUMBLEDORE AND RIGHTLY, SEEING HOW HE WAS FINISHED, BUT THIS

HE POINTED A FINGER AT XENOPHILIUS THIS IS HIS SYMBOL, I RECOGNIZED

IT AT A GLANCE! GRINDELWALD CARRIED IT INTO A WALL AT BLUMSTRANG WHEN HE

WAS A PUPIL THERE. SOME BOYS COPIED IT WITH THEIR KNIVES AND

KNIVES, MADE THEMSELVES IMPRESSIVE UNTIL THEY HAD

WHEN HAD LEFT FAMILY MEMBERS THE GRINDELWALD TAUGHT THEM BETTER.

GRIM CRACKED HIS KNIVES MENACINGLY AND GLEARED AT XENOPHILUS. HARRY FELT PERPLEXED. IT SEEMED INCREDIBLY UNLIKELY THAT

FATHER WAS A SUPPORTER OF THE DARK ARTS, AND NOBODY ELSE IN THE

SEEMED TO HAVE RECOGNIZED THE TRIANGULAR, RINGLIKE SHAPE.

ARE YOU SURE IT'S GRINDELWALD'S ?

I AM NOT MISTAKEN, SAID GRIM GRIMLY. I WALKED PAST THAT SIGN

WELL, THERE'S A CHANCE, SAID HARRY, THAT XENOPHILUS DOESN'T

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UNUSUAL. HE COULD EASILY HAVE PICKED IT UP SOMEWHERE AND THOUGHT

A CROSS SECTION OF THE HEAD OF A CRUMPLE-HEADED SNAKE

SOMETHING.

THE CROSS SECTIONS OF A VEET?

WELL, I DONT KNOW WHAT THEY ARE, BUT APPARENTLY HE AND HIS DAUGHTER CHEN HEN HOLIDAY LEAVING FOR THEM. . . .

HARRY FELT HE WAS DOING A BAD JOB EXPLAINING LLINA AND HER FATHER.

THAT S HER, HE SAID, POINTING AT LLINA, WHO WAS STILL DANCING ALONE, WAVING HER ARMS AROUND HER HEAD LIKE SOMEONE ATTEMPTING THE GREAT MUDGLES.

IS SHE DOING THAT? ASKED DURLIN.

PROBABLY TRYING TO GET RID OF A WRACKSPLINT, SAID HARRY, WHO RECOGNIZED THE SYMPTOMS.

DURLIN DID NOT SEEM TO KNOW WHETHER OR NOT HARRY WAS MAKING FUN OF HIM. HE DREW HIS HAND FROM INSIDE HIS REEKS AND TAPPED IT MENACINGLY ON HIS THIGH. SPARKS FLEW OUT OF THE END.

GREGHEVITCH? SAID HARRY LEHLY, AND DURLIN STARTED, BUT HARRY WAS THEN EXCITED THE CARE; THE MEMORY HAD COME BACK TO HIM AT THE

SIGHT OF DURLIN S HAND; HILLVANDER TAKING IT AND EXAMINING IT CARE-

FULLY BEFORE THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT.

HE KNOWS HIM? ASKED DURLIN SUSPICIOUSLY.

HE S A HANDMAKER?

I KNOW THAT, SAID DURLIN.

HE MADE YOUR HAND? THAT S WHY I THOUGHT HILLVITCH

DURLIN WAS LEAVING MORE AND MORE SUSPICIOUS.

HOW DO YOU KNOW GREGORYVITCH MADE MY YARD?

I... I READ IT SOMEWHERE, I THINK, SAID HARRY, IN A A FAN
MAGAZINE, HE IMPROVISED WILDLY AND DRUM BEHEADED MELLIFIED.

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I HAD NOT REALIZED I EVER DISCUSSED MY YARD WITH FANS, HE
SAID.

HE... ER... WHERE IS GREGORYVITCH THESE DAYS?

DRUM BEHEADED PLIZZLED.

HE RETIRED SEVERAL YEARS AGO, I WAS HERE AT THE LAST THE PURCHASE A
GREGORYVITCH YARD, THEY ARE THE BEST ALTHOUGH I KNOW OF
CHURCH,

THAT YOU BRITHENS SET MUCH STONE BY HILLIANDER.

HARRY DID NOT ANSWER, HE PRETENDED TO WATCH THE DANCERS, LIKE
DRUM, BUT HE WAS THINKING HARD. HE VERDMENT WAS BEHINDING HER
A CELEBRATED WARDMAKER, AND HARRY DID NOT HAVE THE SEARCH FOR HER
A

REASON: IT WAS SURELY BECAUSE OF WHAT HARRY'S LAND HAD DONE IN
THE

NIGHT THAT VERDMENT HAD PURSUED HIM ACROSS THE SKIES, THE
HELLY

AND PHENIX FEATHER LAND HAD CHENELIERED THE BEHINDED LAND,
SOME-

THING THAT HILLIANDER HAD NOT ANTICIPATED HER UNDERSTOOD, WHICH

GREGOROVITCH KNOW BETTER? WAS HE TRULY MORE SKILLED THAN HELLIVANDER, DID HE KNOW SECRETS OF WANDS THAT HELLIVANDER DID NOT?

THIS GIRL IS VERY NICE-LOOKING, DORUM SAID, RECALLING HARRY THE SLURPBLINDING. DORUM WAS POINTING AT GINNY, WHO HAD JUST JOINED LUNA. SHE IS ALSO A RELATIVE OF YELORS?

YEAH, SAID HARRY, SLIDENLY IRRITATED, AND SHE'S SEEING SOMEONE, ISRAELIS TYPE, BIG KNEE, WHO WOULDN'T WANT TO CROSS HIM.

DORUM GRINLED.

YET, HE SAID, DRAINING HIS CUPLET AND GETTING THE HIS FEET AGAIN, IS THE POINT OF BEING AN INTERNATIONAL FLUIDDITCH PLAYER IF ALL THE

GOOD-LOOKING GIRLS ARE TAKEN?

AND HE STRODE OFF, LEAVING HARRY TO TAKE A SANDWICH FROM A PASSING WAITER AND MAKE HIS WAY AROUND THE EDGE OF THE CROWDED DANCE

FLOOR. HE WANTED TO FIND RHEIN, TO TELL HIM ABOUT GREGOROVITCH, BUT RHEIN WAS DANCING WITH FERMINE HOLT IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FLOOR.

THE WEDDING

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HARRY LEANED UP AGAINST ONE OF THE GOLDEN PILLARS AND WATCHED

GINNY, WHO WAS NOW DANCING WITH FRED AND GEORGE'S FRIEND LEE
JORDAN, TRYING NOT TO FEEL RESENTFUL ABOUT THE PROMISE HE HAD
GIVEN

HERN.

HE HAD NEVER BEEN TO A WEDDING BEFORE, SO HE COULD NOT JUDGE
HOW WIZARDING CELEBRATIONS DIFFERED FROM MUGGLE ONES, THOUGH HE
WAS PRETTY SURE THAT THE LATTER WOULD NOT INVOLVE A WEDDING CAKE
TOPPED WITH TWO MEERLOPPHENS THAT THUD FLIGHT WHEN THE CAKE
WAS CUT, OR BOTTLES OF CHAMPAGNE THAT FLEATED UNSUPPRESSED
THROUGH

THE CROWD. AS EVENING DREW IN, AND MEETHS BEGAN TO SLEEP UNDER
THE CANOPY, NOW LIT WITH FLEATING GILDED LANTERNS, THE REVELRY
BECAME

MORE AND MORE UNCERTAIN. FRED AND GEORGE HAD LONG SINCE DIS-
APPEARED INTO THE DARKNESS WITH A PAIR OF FLEIA'S HELMETS;
CHARLIE,

LAGRID, AND A SEELAT WIZARD IN A PURPLE PHOXPUR HAT WERE SINGING
FROM THE BALCONY IN A CORNER.

WANDERING THROUGH THE CROWD HE AS THE ESCAPE A DRUNKEN UNCLE OF
HERN'S WHO SEEMED UNSURE WHETHER HIS NIECE HARRY WAS HIS SON,
HARRY

SPOTTED AN OLD WIZARD SITTING ALONE AT A TABLE. HIS HAIR OF WHITE
HAIR

MADE HIM LOOK RATHER LIKE AN AGED DANDELION CLOTH AND WAS TOPPED
BY A MEETH-EATEN FEZ. HE WAS VAGUELY FAMILIAR: RACKING HIS BRAINS,
HARRY SUDDENLY REALIZED THAT THIS WAS EUPHIAS DEER, MEMBER OF THE

EDITOR OF THE PROPHECY AND THE WRITER OF DUMBLEDORE'S HEITLIARY,
HARRY APPROACHED HIM.

MAY I SIT DOWN?

OF COURSE, OF COURSE, SAID DECE; HE HAD A RATHER HIGH-PITCHED,
WHEEZY VOICE.

HARRY LEANED IN.

MR. DECE, I'M HARRY POTTER.

DECE GASPED.

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MY DEAR KID! ARTHUR TOLD ME YOU WERE HERE, DISGUISED, . . . I AM
SO GLAD, SO FORTUNED!

IN A FLUTTER OF NERVOUS PLEASURE DECE PHURED HARRY A GLASS OF
CHAMPAGNE.

I THOUGHT OF WRITING TO YOU, HE WHISPERED, AFTER DUMBLEDORE
. . . THE SCHOOL . . . AND FOR YOU, I AM SURE . . .

DECE'S TINY EYES FILLED WITH SUDDEN TEARS.

I SAW THE HEITLIARY YOU WRITE FOR THE DAILY PROPHECY, SAID
HARRY.

I DIDN'T REALIZE YOU KNEW PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE SO WELL.

AS WELL AS ANYONE, SAID DECE, DABBLING HIS EYES WITH A NAPKIN.

CERTAINLY I KNEW HIM LONGEST, IF YOU DIDN'T COUNT ALBUSWORTH
AND

SOMEHOW, PEOPLE NEVER SEE THEM THE COUNT ALBUSWORTH.

SPREADING OF THE DAILY PROPHET . . . I DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER SHE
SAW, MR. DEER ?

EH, PLEASE CALL ME ELPHIAS, DEAR HEN.

ELPHIAS, I DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER SHE SAW THE INTERVIEW RITA
SKEETER

GAVE ABOUT DUMBLEDORE?

DEER'S FACE FLEETED WITH ANGRY CHEER.

EH YES, HARRY, I SAW IT. THAT WOMAN, HER VULGARE MIGHT BE A MORE
ACCURATE TERM, POSITIVELY PESTERED ME THE TIME THE HER, I AM ASHAMED
THE

SAY THAT I BECAME RATHER RUDE, CALLED HER AN INTERFERING TROLL, WHICH

RESULTED, AS SHE MAY HAVE SEEN, IN ASPERSIONS LAST UPON MY
SANITY.

WELL, IN THAT INTERVIEW, HARRY WENT ON, RITA SKEETER HINTED
THAT PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WAS INVOLVED IN THE DARK ARTS WHEN HE
WAS YOUNG.

DIDN'T BELIEVE A WORD OF IT? SAID DEER AT ONCE. NOT A WORD,
HARRY?

LET NOTHING TARNISH YOUR MEMORIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE?

HARRY LEANED INTO DEER'S EARNEST, PAINED FACE AND FELT, NOT REAS-
SURED, BUT FRUSTRATED, DID DEER REALLY THINK IT WAS THAT EASY, THAT

THE WEDDING

HARRY COULD SIMPLY CHOOSE NOT TO BELIEVE? DIDN'T DEGE UNDERSTAND
HARRY'S NEED TO BE SURE, TO KNOW EVERYTHING?

PERHAPS DEGE SUSPECTED HARRY'S FEELINGS, FOR HE LOOKED CONCERNED
AND HURRIED HIM. HARRY, RITA SKEETER IS A DREADFUL
BUT HE WAS INTERRUPTED BY A SHRILL CACOPHONY.

RITA SKEETER? EH, I LOVE HER, ALWAYS READ HER!

HARRY AND DEGE LOOKED UP TO SEE ALINTIE MURIEL STANDING THERE,
THE PUMPS DANCING ON HER HAT, A GLASS OF CHAMPAGNE IN HER
HAND.

SHE'S WRITTEN A BOOK ABOUT DUMBLEDORE, YOU KNOW!

HELLO, MURIEL, SAID DEGE. YES, WE WERE JUST DISCUSSING

YOU THERE? GIVE ME YOUR CHAIR, I'M A HUNDRED AND SEVEN!

ANOTHER RED-HEADED WEASLEY CHASING HIMSELF OFF HIS SEAT, LOOK-
ING ALARMED, AND ALINTIE MURIEL SWUNG IT AROUND WITH SURPRISING

STRENGTH AND PLOPPED HERSELF DOWN BETWEEN IT BETWEEN DEGE AND
HARRY.

HELLO AGAIN, HARRY, FOR WHATEVER YOUR NAME IS, SHE SAID TO
HARRY.

WELL, WHAT WERE YOU SAYING ABOUT RITA SKEETER, RUPERT? YOU
KNOW

SHE'S WRITTEN A BIOGRAPHY OF DUMBLEDORE? I CAN'T WAIT TO READ IT, I
MUST REMEMBER THE PLACE AN ORDER AT FLEMISH AND BLETTS!

DEGE LOOKED STIFF AND SILENT AT THIS, BUT ALINTIE MURIEL DRAINED

HER CHEELET AND CLICKED HER BENDY FINGERS AT A PASSING WAITER FOR A
RE-

PLACEMENT, SHE THREW ANOTHER LARGE GLIP OF CHAMPAGNE, BELCHED,
AND

THEN SAID, 'THERE I NOW NEED THEM LIKE A PAIR OF STIFFED PANTS;
BEFORE

HE BECAME SHE RESPECTED AND RESPECTABLE AND ALL THAT THESE, THERE
WERE

SOME MIGHTY FLINDY RUMORS ABOUT ARLIS;

ILL-INFORMED SNIPING, SAID DEER, TURNING RADISH-COLOURED
AGAIN,

YELL WOULD SAY THAT, EUPHIA, CACKLED ALINTIE MURIEL. I REMEMBERED
HOW YELL SKATED OVER THE STICKY PATCHES IN THAT HETTERLY OF
YELLERS;

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I'M SURE YELL THINK SHE, SAID DEER, MORE COLDLY STILL. I ASSURE
YELL I WAS WRITING FROM THE HEART.

HEY, WE ALL KNOW YELL WERE-SHIPPED DUMKLEBERG; I DARE SAY YELL LL
STILL THINK HE WAS A SAINT EVEN IF IT DOES TURN OUT THAT HE DID
AWAY

WITH HIS SELLIE SISTER;

MURIEL ? EXCLAIMED DEER.

A CHILL THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THE ICED CHAMPAGNE WAS

STEALING THROUGH HARRY'S CLOSET.

WHAT DID YOU MEAN? HE ASKED MIRIEL. WHEN SAID HIS SISTER WAS A SHELL? I THOUGHT SHE WAS ILL?

THOUGHT WHEN, THEN, DIDN'T YOU, HARRY? SAID AUNTIE MIRIEL, SMILING DELIGHTED AT THE EFFECT SHE HAD PRODUCED. ANYWAY, YOU COULD YOU EXPECT TO KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT IT? IT ALL HAPPENED YEARS

AND YEARS BEFORE YOU WERE EVEN THOUGHT OF, MY DEAR, AND THE TRUTH

IS THAT THESE OF US WHEN WERE ALIVE THEN NEVER KNEW WHAT REALLY

HAPPENED. THAT'S WHY I CAN'T WAIT TO FIND OUT WHAT SECRETER'S

DISCOVERY KEPT THAT SISTER OF HIS HIDEOUT FOR A LONG TIME?

INTRIGUE? WHIZZED DICK. ABSOLUTELY INTRIGUE?

HE NEVER TOLD ME HIS SISTER WAS A SHELL, SAID HARRY, WITHOUT THINKING, STILL CHILD INSIDE.

AND WHY HADN'T YOU TOLD ME? STUTTERED MIRIEL, SWAYING A LITTLE IN HER SEAT AS SHE ATTEMPTED TO FOLLOW UPON HARRY.

THE REASON ALWAYS NEVER SPEAK ABOUT ARIANA, BEGAN EUPHIA IN A VOICE STIFF WITH EMOTION. IS, I SHOULD HAVE THOUGHT, WHITE CLEAR, HE WAS SO DEVASTATED BY HER DEATH

WHY DID NOBODY EVER SEE HER, EUPHIA? DEMANDS MIRIEL.

WHY DID HADN'T YOU NEVER EVEN KNOW SHE EXISTED, UNTIL THEY CARRIED THE COFFIN OUT OF THE HOUSE AND HELD A FUNERAL FOR HER? WHERE

WAS SAINTLY ARIANA WHILE ARIANA WAS LOCKED IN THE CELLAR? HARRY
BEING

THE WEDDING

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BRILLIANT AT FIEGLHARTS, AND NEVER MIND WHAT WAS GOING ON IN HIS
OWN HOUSE?

WHAT DO YOU MEAN, LOCKED IN THE CELLAR? ASKED HARRY. WHAT
IS THIS?

DECE LOOKED WRETCHED. AUNTIE MURIEL LAUGHED AGAIN AND AN-
SWERED HARRY.

OLIMPEHERE'S MOTHER WAS A TERRIFYING WOMAN, SIMPLY TERRIFYING.
MUGGLE-BORN, THOUGH I HEARD SHE PRETENDED OTHERWISE

SHE NEVER PRETENDED ANYTHING OF THE SORT! KENDRA WAS A FINE
WOMAN, WHISPERED DECE MISERABLY, BUT AUNTIE MURIEL IGNORED
HIM.

PRELID AND VERY DEMONSTRATING, THE SORT OF WITCH WHO WOULD
HAVE BEEN MORTIFIED THE PRELID & SHELIK

ARIANA WAS NOT A SHELIK! WHISPERED DECE.

SHE YOU SAY, EUPHIAS, BUT EXPLAIN, THEN, WHY SHE NEVER ATTENDED
FIEGLHARTS? SAID AUNTIE MURIEL. SHE TURNED BACK TO HARRY. IN
HIS

DAY, SHELIKS WERE OFTEN FLISHED UP, THOUGH THEY TAKE IT THE THE
EXTREME

HE ACTUALLY IMPRISONING A LITTLE GIRL IN THE HELLIS AND PRETENDING SHE

DIDN'T EXIST

I TELL YOU, THAT'S NOT WHAT HAPPENED! SAID DICE, BUT ALTHOUGH MURIEL STEAMROLLED HIM, STILL ADDRESSING HARRY,

SHEWAS WERE USUALLY SHIPPED OFF THE MUGGLE SCHOOLS AND ENCOURAGED TO INTEGRATE INTO THE MUGGLE COMMUNITY . . . MUCH KINDER THAN

TRYING TO FIND THEM A PLACE IN THE WIZARDING WORLD, WHERE THEY MUST

ALWAYS BE SECOND CLASS; BUT NATURALLY DENDRA DUMBLEDOORE WOULDN'T HAVE DREAMED OF LETTING HER DAUGHTER GO TO A MUGGLE SCHOOL

ARIANA WAS DELICATE! SAID DICE DESPERATELY. HER HEALTH WAS ALWAYS THE PROBLEM TO PERMIT HER

TO PERMIT HER TO LEAVE THE HELLIS? CACKLED MURIEL, AND YET

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SHE WAS NEVER TAKEN TO ST. MUNGUS AND THE HEALER WAS EVER SUMMONED TO SEE HER!

Really, MURIEL, HOW YOU CAN POSSIBLY KNOW WHETHER

HER YOUR INFORMATION, EUPHIAS, MY CHLORIS LANCELOT WAS A HEALER

AT ST. MUNGEE'S AT THE TIME, AND HE TOLD MY FAMILY IN STRICTEST CONFIDENCE THAT ARIANA HAD NEVER BEEN SEEN THERE. ALL MOST SUSPICIOUS.

LANCELOT THELIGHT:

DECE LOOKED THE BE HEN THE VERGE OF TEARS. AUNTIE MIRIEL, WHO SEEMED THE BE ENJOYING HERSELF HIGHLY, SNAPPED HER FINGERS FOR MORE CHAMPAGNE. NORMALLY LARRY THELIGHT OF WHEN THE DURSLEYS HAD ENCE SLIT HIM UP, KICKED HIM AWAY, KEPT HIM OUT OF SIGHT, ALL FOR THE CRIME OF BEING A WIZARD. HAD DUMBLEDORE'S SISTER SUFFERED THE SAME FATE IN REVERSE: IMPRISONED FOR HER LACK OF MAGIC? AND HAD DUMBLEDORE TRULY LEFT HER THE HER FATE WHILE HE WENT OFF THE HIGGLARTS,

THE PROVE HIMSELF BRILLIANT AND TALENTED?

WELL, IF DENDRA HADN'T DIED FIRST, MIRIEL RESUMED, I'D HAVE SAID THAT IT WAS SHE WHO FINISHED OFF ARIANA

WHEN CAN YOU, MIRIEL? GRANTED DECE. A MOTHER KILL HER OWN DAUGHTER? THINK WHAT YOU ARE SAYING!

IF THE MOTHER IN HOLSTERN WAS CAPABLE OF IMPRISONING HER DAUGHT-

TER FOR YEARS AND END, WHY NOT? SERLEGGED AUNTIE MIRIEL. BUT AS

I SAY, IT DOESN'T FIT, BECAUSE DENDRA DIED BEFORE ARIANA OF WHAT, NOBODY EVER SEEMED SURE

HE, NEI BELIST ARIANA MURDERED HER, SAID DECE WITH A BRAVE ATTEMPT AT SCORN. WHY NOT?

YES, ARIANA MIGHT HAVE MADE A DESPERATE BID FOR FREEDOM AND

KILLED KENDRA IN THE STRUGGLE, SAID ALINTIE MURIEL THOUGHTFULLY.

SHADE YOUR HEAD ALL YOUR LIKE, EUPHIA? YOU WERE AT ARIANA'S
FUNERAL,

WERE YOU NOT?

THE WEDDING

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YES I WAS, SAID DECE, THROUGH TREMBLING LIPS, AND A MORE
DESPER-

ATELY SAD OCCASION I CANNOT REMEMBER, ARLIS WAS HEARTBROKEN

HIS HEART WASN'T THE ONLY THING, DIDN'T AKEWORTHY BREAK ARLIS'S
NECK HALFWAY THROUGH THE SERVICE?

IF DECE HAD BEEN MORE FERRISIED BEFORE THIS, IT WAS NOTHING THE FEEL HE
BEHOLD NOW, MURIEL MIGHT HAVE STABBED HIM, SHE LAUGHED HEEDLESSLY AND
THREW ANOTHER SLUG OF CHAMPAGNE, WHICH DRIPPED DOWN HER CHIN,

FEEL DE YOU ? CREATED DECE,

MY MOTHER WAS FRIENDLY WITH HER KATHILDA RAGSHEET, SAID ALINTIE
MURIEL HAPPILY, KATHILDA DESCRIBED THE WHOLE THING THE MOTHER
WHILE

I WAS LISTENING AT THE DEER, A CHIFFIN-SIDE CRANK! THE WAY KATHILDA
TELD IT, AKEWORTHY SHELLED THAT IT WAS ALL ARLIS'S FAULT THAT
ARIANA

WAS DEAD AND THEN PUNCHED HIM IN THE FACE, ACCORDING TO KATHILDA,
ARLIS DID NOT EVEN DEFEND HIMSELF, AND THAT S HAD ENOUGH IN ITSELF,
ARLIS COULD HAVE DESTROYED AKEWORTHY IN A DUEL WITH BOTH HANDS

TIED BEHIND HIS BACK.

MURIEL SWIGGED YET MORE CHAMPAGNE. THE RECITATION OF THESE OLD SCANDALS SEEMED TO PLATE HER AS MUCH AS THEY TERRIFIED DECE. HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHAT TO THINK, WHAT TO BELIEVE: HE WANTED THE TRUTH, AND YET ALL DECE DID WAS SIT THERE AND BEAT FEELY THAT ARIANA HAD BEEN ILL. HARRY COULD HARDLY BELIEVE THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD NOT HAVE INTERVENED IF SUCH CRUELTY WAS HAPPENING INSIDE HIS OWN HOUSE.

AND YET THERE WAS UNDOUBTEDLY SOMETHING HAD ABOUT THE STORY.

AND I LL TELL YOU SOMETHING ELSE, MURIEL SAID, HICCUPIING SLIGHTLY AS SHE WHISPERED HER GIBBLET. I THINK RATHILDA HAS SPILLED THE BEANS THE

RITA SKEETER. ALL THESE HINTS IN SKEETER'S INTERVIEW ABOUT AN IMPER-

TANT SHIRAZ CLUSE THE THE DUMBLEDORES GOODNESS KNOWS SHE WAS

THERE ALL THROUGH THE ARIANA BUSINESS, AND IT WOULD FIT?

RATHILDA WOULD NEVER TALK THE RITA SKEETER? WHISPERED DECE.

CHAPTER EIGHT

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RATHILDA RAGSHEIT? HARRY SAID. THE ALTHOUGH OF A HISTORY OF MAGIC?

THE NAME WAS PRINTED IN THE FRONT OF ONE OF HARRY'S TEXT-

REMEMBER, THOUGH ADMITTEDLY NOT ONE OF THE BOOKS HE HAD READ MOST ATTENTIVELY.

YES, SAID DEER, CLUTCHING AT HARRY'S ELDEST SON LIKE A DROWNING MAN AT A LIFE BELT. A MOST GIFTED MAGICAL HISTORIAN AND AN OLD FRIEND OF ALBUS'S.

WHITE GAGA THESE DAYS, I'VE HEARD, SAID AUNTIE MURIEL CHEERFULLY.

IF THAT IS SHE, IT IS EVEN MORE DISHONORABLE FOR SKEETER TO HAVE TAKEN ADVANTAGE OF HER, SAID DEER, AND NO RELIANCE CAN BE PLACED ON ANYTHING KATHILDA MAY HAVE SAID.

EH, THERE ARE WAYS OF BRINGING BACK MEMORIES, AND I'M SURE RITA SKEETER KNOWS THEM ALL, SAID AUNTIE MURIEL. BUT EVEN IF KATHILDA'S

COMPLETELY CLICHEE, I'M SURE SHE'D STILL HAVE HAD PHOTOGRAPHS, MAPS

EVEN LETTERS. SHE KNOWS THE DUMPERBERRIES FOR YEARS. . . . WELL WORTH A TRIP TO GENDRIK'S HOUSE, I'D HAVE THOUGHT.

HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN TAKING A SIP OF KLUTTERKEER, CHUCKED. DEER

RANGED HIM ON THE BACK AS HARRY CHUCKED, LEERING AT AUNTIE MURIEL THROUGH STREAMING EYES, SINCE HE HAD CENTRED HIS VEHICLE AGAIN.

HE ASKED, RATHILDA RAGSHEIT LIVES IN CEDRIC'S BUILDING?

HE YES, SHE'S BEEN THERE HOWEVER? THE DUMBLEDOORES MOVED THERE AFTER PERCIVAL WAS IMPRISONED, AND SHE WAS THEIR NEIGHBOR.

THE DUMBLEDOORES LIVED IN CEDRIC'S BUILDING?

YES, RARRY, THAT'S WHAT I JUST SAID, SAID ALUNTIE MURIEL TESTILY.

HARRY FELT DRAINED, EMPTY. NEVER SINCE, IN SIX YEARS, HAD DUMBLEDOORE TOLD HARRY THAT THEY HAD EITHER LIVED AND BEST BEYOND HENCE

IN CEDRIC'S BUILDING, WHY? WERE LILY AND JAMES BURIED THERE THE

THE WEDDING

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DUMBLEDOORE'S MOTHER AND SISTER? HAD DUMBLEDOORE VISITED THEIR GRAVES, PERHAPS WALKED PAST LILY'S AND JAMES'S TOMB STONE? AND HE HAD

NEVER SINCE TOLD HARRY . . . NEVER EITHERED THE SAY . . .

AND WHY IT WAS SO IMPORTANT, HARRY COULD NOT EXPLAIN EVEN TO HIMSELF, YET HE FELT IT HAD BEEN TANTALIZING THAT A LIE NOT TO TELL HIM THAT THEY HAD THIS PLACE AND THESE EXPERIENCES IN COMMON. HE STARED

AHEAD OF HIM, BARELY NOTICING WHAT WAS GOING ON AROUND HIM, AND DID NOT REALIZE THAT HERMIONE HAD APPEARED UNTIL HE HEARD UNTIL SHE DREW UP A CHAIR BESIDE HIM.

I SIMPLY CAN'T DANCE ANYMORE, SHE PANTED, SLIPPING OFF ONE OF

HER SHOES AND RUBBING THE SOLE OF HER FOOT. THEN I HEARD WHISTLING
THE

FIND MORE CLUTTERERS. IT'S A BIT LATE, I'VE JUST SEEN VICTOR STORMING
AWAY FROM LUNA'S FATHER. IT LOOKED LIKE THEY'D BEEN ARGUING
SHE

DROPPED HER VEIL, STARING AT HIM. HARRY, ARE YOU DEAD?

HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHERE THE BEGIN, BUT IT DID NOT MATTER. AT
THAT MOMENT, SOMETHING LARGE AND SILVER CAME FALLING THROUGH
THE

CANOPY OVER THE DANCE FLOOR. CRACKLE AND CLAMOR, THE DANCE
LANDED

LIGHTLY IN THE MIDDLE OF THE ASTONISHED DANCERS. HEADS TURNED, AS
THESE NEAREST IT FREEZE ABLY IN MID-DANCE. THEN THE PATRON'S
MOUTH OPENED WIDE AND IT SPARK IN THE HEAV, DEEP, SILENT VEIL OF
KINGSLEY SHACKLEHOLT.

THE MINISTRY HAS FALLEN. SCRIMGEOR IS DEAD. THEY ARE COMING.

C H A P T E R N I N E

1888

A PLACE TO HIDE

EVERYTHING SEEMED FLIZZY, SILENT. HARRY AND HERMIONE LIMPED
THE THEIR FEET AND DREW THEIR HANDS. MANY PEOPLE WERE ONLY
JUST REALIZING THAT SOMETHING STRANGE HAD HAPPENED; HEADS WERE
STILL

TURNING TOWARD THE SILVER CAT AS IT VANISHED, SILENCE SPREAD
ELTWARD

IN CHLD RIPPLES FROM THE PLACE WHERE THE PATRONUS HAD LANDED,
THEN

SEMEREDY SCREAMED,

HARRY AND HERMIONE THREW THEMSELVES INTO THE PANICKING CROWD,

GUESTS WERE SPRINTING IN ALL DIRECTIONS; MANY WERE
DISAPPEARING;

THE PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS AROUND THE BLURPLE HAD BROKEN,

WHEN? HERMIONE CRIED, WHEN, WHERE ARE THEY?

AS THEY PUSHED THEIR WAY ACROSS THE DANCE FLOOR, HARRY SAW
CLOAKED AND MASKED FIGURES APPEARING IN THE CROWD; THEN HE SAW
LUPIN AND TONKS, THEIR HANDS RAISED, AND HEARD BOTH OF THEM
SHOUT,

PROTECTOR, A CRY THAT WAS HEARD ON ALL SIDES

WHEN? WHEN? HERMIONE CALLED, HALF SHAKING AS SHE AND HARRY
WERE KIFFETED BY TERRIFIED GUESTS; HARRY SEIZED HER HAND THE MADE
R

A PLACE TO HIDE

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SURE THEY WEREN'T SEPARATED AS A STREAK OF LIGHT WHIZZED OVER
THEIR

HEADS, WHETHER A PROTECTIVE CHARM OR SOMETHING MORE SINISTER HE
DID NOT KNOW

AND THEN WHEN WAS THERE, HE CALGHT HOLD OF HERMIONE'S FREE

ARM, AND HARRY FELT HER TURN HIM THE SPOT; SIGHT AND SOUND WERE EX-

TINGLISHED AS DARKNESS PRESSED IN UPON HIM; ALL HE COULD FEEL WAS

HERMIONE'S HAND AS HE WAS SWEPT THROUGH SPACE AND TIME, AWAY FROM THE BLURRY, AWAY FROM THE DESCENDING DEATH PATERS, AWAY, PERHAPS, FROM VOLDERMORT HIMSELF. . . .

WHERE ARE WE? SAID RON'S VOICE.

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES. FOR A MOMENT HE THOUGHT THEY HAD NOT LEFT THE WEDDING AFTER ALL: THEY STILL SEEMED TO BE SURROUNDED BY PEOPLE.

THEATRICAL LIGHT BEAM, PANTED HERMIONE. WALK, JUST WALK, WE NEED TO FIND SOMEWHERE FOR THE CHANGE.

HARRY DID AS SHE ASKED. THEY HALF WALKED, HALF RAN UP THE WIDE DARK STREET THROGGED WITH LATE-NIGHT REVELERS AND LINED WITH CLOSED

SHOPS, STARS TWINKLING ABOVE THEM. A DOUBLE-DECKER BUS RUMBLER BY AND A CRUEL OF MERRY PUB-CHERS HELED THEM AS THEY PASSED; HARRY AND RON WERE STILL WEARING DRESS ROBES.

HERMIONE, WE HAVEN'T GOTT ANYTHING THE CHANGE INTO, RON TOLD HER,

AS A YELING WOMAN BURST INTO RALPH'S GIGGLES AT THE SIGHT OF HIM.

WHY DIDN'T I MAKE SURE I HAD THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK WITH ME?

SAID HARRY, INWARDLY CURSING HIS OWN STUPIDITY. ALL LAST YEAR I KEPT

IT ON ME AND

IT'S HERE, I'VE GOTT THE CLOAK, I'VE GOTT CLOTHES FOR BOTH OF US,

SAID HERMINE. JUST TRY AND ACT NATURALLY UNTIL THIS WILL BE.

SHE LED THEM DOWN A SIDE STREET, THEN INTO THE SHELTER OF A SHAD-
DOW ALLEYWAY.

CHAPTER NINE

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WHEN YOU SAY YOU'VE GOT THE LEAD, AND CLOTHES . . . SAID HARRY,
PRELIMINARILY AT HERMINE, WHO WAS CARRYING NOTHING EXCEPT HER
SMALL

LEADED HANDBAG, IN WHICH SHE WAS NOW CLIMBING.

YES, THEY'RE HERE, SAID HERMINE, AND THE HARRY AND BEN'S LIT-
TER ASTONISHMENT, SHE PULLED OUT A PAIR OF JEANS, A SWEATSHIRT,
SOME

MARSHMALLOW SEEDS, AND FINALLY THE SILVER INVISIBILITY LEAD.

WELL THE RUDDY HELL ?

UNDETECTABLE EXTENSIBLE CHARM, SAID HERMINE. TRICKY, BUT I
THINK I'VE DONE IT BEFORE; ANYWAY, I MANAGED TO FIT EVERYTHING WE
NEED

IN HERE. SHE GAVE THE FRAGILE-LOOKING BAG A LITTLE SHAKE AND IT
CRACKED

LIKE A LARGE FIELD AS A NUMBER OF HEAVY OBJECTS ROLLED AROUND
INSIDE

IT. EH, DAMN, THAT LL BE THE RINGS, SHE SAID, PEERING INTO IT, AND I

HAD THEM ALL STACKED BY SUBJECT. . . . EH WELL. . . . HARRY, YELL D BETTER TAKE THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, RHN, HURRY UP AND CHANGE. . . .

WHEN DID YELL DO ALL THIS? HARRY ASKED AS RHN STRIPPED OFF HIS RINGS.

I TOLD YELL AT THE BIRTHDAY, I VE HAD THE ESSENTIALS PACKED FOR DAYS, YELL KNOWS, IN CASE WE NEEDED THEM MAKE A QUICK GETAWAY. I PACKED YOUR RINGSACK THIS MORNIN, HARRY, AFTER YELL CHANGED, AND PUT IT IN HERE. . . . I JUST HAD A FEELING. . . .

YELL RE AMAZING, YELL ARE, SAID RHN, HANDING HER HIS RINGBOX-LIP RINGS.

THANK YELL, SAID HERMIONE, MANAGING A SMALL SMILE AS SHE PUSHED THE RINGS INTO THE BAG. PLEASE, HARRY, GET THAT CLOAK HEN? HARRY THREW THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AROUND HIS SHOULDERS AND PULLED IT UP OVER HIS HEAD, VANISHING FROM SIGHT. HE WAS ONLY JUST BEGINNING TO APPRECIATE WHAT HAD HAPPENED.

THE OTHERS EVERYONE AT THE WEDDING

A PLACE THE END

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WE CAN T WHISPER ABOUT THAT NOW, WHISPERED HERMIONE. IT S YELL

THEY'RE AFTER HARRY, AND WE'LL JUST PUT EVERYONE IN EVEN MORE DANGER

BY GOING BACK.

SHE'S RIGHT, SAID RON, WHO SEEMED TO KNOW THAT HARRY WAS ABLE TO HEAR HER, EVEN IF HE COULD NOT SEE HIS FACE. MUST BE THE HURDER

WAS THERE, THEY'LL LEAVE AFTER EVERYONE.

HARRY NEEDED, THEN REMEMBERED THAT THEY COULD NOT SEE HIM, AND SAID, YES. BUT HE THOUGHT OF GINNY, AND FEAR BUBBLED LIKE ACID IN HIS STOMACH.

COME ON, I THINK WE SHOULD KEEP MOVING, SAID HERMION. THEY MOVED BACK UP THE SIDE STREET AND ENTERED THE MAIN ROAD AGAIN, WHERE A GROUP OF MEN ON THE OPPOSITE SIDE WAS SINGING AND WEAVING ACROSS THE PAVEMENT.

JUST AS A MATTER OF INTEREST, WHY THUNDERBOLT LIGHTNING? RON ASKED HERMION.

I'VE NO IDEA, IT JUST POPOPED INTO MY HEAD, BUT I'M SURE WE'RE SAFER HIDE IN THE MUGGLE WORLD, IT'S NOT WHERE THEY'LL EXPECT US TO BE.

TRUE, SAID RON, LEAVING AROUND, BUT DON'T YOU FEEL A BIT EXPOSED?

WHERE ELSE IS THERE? ASKED HERMION, CRINGING AS THE MEN ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE ROAD STARTED WHISPER-WHISTLING AT HER. WE CAN HARDLY KIDNAP THEM AT THE LEADY CALIBREIN, CAN WE? AND CRIMINALS PLACE IS NOT IF SNAPE CAN GET IN THERE. . . I SUPPOSE WE COULD TRY MY

PARENTS' HOUSE, THOUGH I THINK THERE'S A CHANCE THEY MIGHT CHECK THERE. . . EH, I WISH THEY'D SPLIT UP!

ALL RIGHT, DARLING? THE DRINDEST OF THE MEN IN THE OTHER PAYMENT WAS YELLING. FANCY A DRINK? DITCH GINGER AND LIME AND HAVE A PINT?

CHAPTER NINE

1899

LET S SIT DOWN SOMEWHERE. HERMIENE SAID HASTILY AS RICH OPENED HIS MOUTH THE SHELT RACK ACROSS THE ROAD. LEEDS, THIS WILL BE IN HERE?

IT WAS A SMALL AND SPARKY ALL-NIGHT CAR . A LIGHT LAYER OF GREASE LAY ON ALL THE FORMICA-TOPPED TABLES, BUT IT WAS AT LEAST EMPTY. HARRY SLIPPED INTO A SEAT FIRST AND RICH SAT NEXT TO HIM OPPOSITE

HERMIENE, WHO HAD HER BACK TO THE ENTRANCE AND DID NOT LIKE IT! SHE GLANCED OVER HER SHOULDER SHE FREQUENTLY SHE APPEARED TO HAVE A

TWITCH. HARRY DID NOT LIKE BEING STATUARY; WALKING HAD GIVEN THE

ILLUSION THAT THEY HAD A CHASE. BENEATH THE CHAIR HE COULD FEEL THE LAST VESTIGES OF PHYSIQUE LEAVING HIM, HIS HANDS RETURNING THE THEIR

USUAL LENGTH AND SHAPE. HE PULLED HIS GLASSES OUT OF HIS POCKET AND

PLUT THEM ON AGAIN.

AFTER A MINUTE OR TWO, REN SAID, 'WELL KNOW, WE'RE NOT FAR FROM THE LEADY CALIBREIN HERE, IT'S ONLY IN CHAIRING CROSS

REN, WE CAN'T, SAID HERMINE AT ENCE.

NOT THE STAY THERE, BUT THE FIND OUT WHAT'S GOING ON?

WE KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON? VERMONT IS TAKEN OVER THE MINISTRY,

WHAT ELSE DO WE NEED TO KNOW?

HEY, HEY, IT WAS JUST AN IDEA!

THEY RELAPSED INTO A PROUDLY SILENCE. THE GLIM-CHEWING WAITRESS SLIPPED OVER AND HERMINE ORDERED TWO CAPPUCCINOS. AS HARRY WAS INVISIBLE, IT WOULD HAVE BEEN HIS ORDER HIMSELF. A PAIR OF BURLY WARDEN MEN ENTERED THE CAFÉ AND SHEEZED INTO THE NEXT SHEET. HERMINE DROPPED HER VEIL IN A WHISPER.

I SAY WE FIND A QUIET PLACE TO DISAPPEAR AND HEAD FOR THE CHLINTONSIDE. SINCE WE'RE THERE, WE COULD SEND A MESSAGE TO THE ORDER.

CAN YOU DO THAT TALKING PATRONS THING, THEN? ASKED REN.

I'VE BEEN PRACTICING AND I THINK SO, SAID HERMINE.

A PLACE TO HIDE

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WELL, AS LONG AS IT DOESN'T GET THEM INTO TROUBLE, THOUGH THEY MIGHT'VE BEEN ARRESTED ALREADY. GOOD, THAT'S REVEALING, REN ADDED AFTER ONE SIP OF THE THAW, GRAYISH CHIFFER. THE WAITRESS HAD HEARD:

SHE SEET RENN A NASTY BLEED AS SHE SLIPPED OFF THE TABLE THE NEW
CLIS-

THEMERS HANDS, THE LARGER OF THE TWO WERDPMEN, WHO WAS BLEND
AND

ELITE FLICE, WHEN THAT HARRY CAME THE BLEED AT HIM, WAVED HER AWAY,
SHE STARED, APPREHENDED,

LET S GET GOING, THEN, I DONT WANT THE DRINK THIS MUCH, SAID RENN,
HERMINE, HAVE YOU GET MUGGLE MONEY THE PAY FOR THIS?

YES, I THINK HLT ALL MY BUILDING SOCIETY SAVINGS BEHRE I CAME THE

THE BLURREN, I LL GET ALL THE CHANGE IS AT THE BHTTER, SIGHED HERMI-
NE, REACHING FOR HER BEADED BAG,

THE TWO WERDPMEN MADE IDENTICAL MEVEMENTS, AND HARRY MIR-
RERED THEM WITH HLT CONSCIOUS THUGHT: ALL THREE OF THEM DREW

THEIR HANDS, RENN, A FEW SECONDS LATE IN REALIZING WHAT WAS GOING
ON, LUNGED ACROSS THE TABLE, PUSHING HERMINE SIDEWAYS BHTH HER
BENCH, THE FORCE OF THE DEATH EATERS SPELLS SHATTERED THE TILED
WALL

WHERE RENN S HEAD HAD ILST BEEN, AS HARRY, STILL INVISIBLE, YELLED,
STUPID!

THE GREAT BLEND DEATH EATER WAS HIT IN THE FACE BY A JET OF RED
LIGHT: HE SLUMPED SIDEWAYS, UNCONSCIOUS, HIS COMPANION, UNABLE
THE SEE WHO HAD CAST THE SPELL, FIRED ANOTHER AT RENN: SHINING BLACK
RIPES FLEW FROM HIS HAND-TIP AND BEHND RENN HEAD THE SHEET THE

WAITRESS SCREAMED AND RAN TOWARD THE DEER. HARRY SENT ANOTHER
STUN-

NING SPELL AT THE DEATH EATER WITH THE TWISTED FACE WHO HAD TIED
UP

REIN, BUT THE SPELL MISSED, RECOILED IN THE WINDS, AND HIT THE
WAITRESS, WHO COLLAPSED IN FRONT OF THE DEER.

EXPLOSION! KILLED THE DEATH EATER, AND THE TABLE BEHIND WHICH
HARRY WAS STANDING BLEW UP! THE FORCE OF THE EXPLOSION SLAMMED

CHAPTER NINE

1888

HIM INTO THE WALL AND HE FELT HIS HAND LEAVE HIS HAND AS THE CHAIR
SLIPPED OFF HIM.

PETRIFICUS TITILLIS! SCREAMED HERMIONE FROM BEHIND HIM, AND THE

DEATH EATER FELL FORWARD LIKE A STATUE TO THE GROUND WITH A CRUNCHING
THUD

IN THE MESS OF BROKEN CHINA, TABLE, AND CHAIR. HERMIONE CRAWLED
BEHIND UNDERNEATH THE BENCH, SHAKING KITS OF GLASS ASTRAY BEHIND
HER

HER HAIR AND TREMBLING ALL OVER.

DIFFIDENT, SHE SAID, POINTING HER HAND AT REIN, WHO REARED IN
PAIN AS SHE SLASHED OPEN THE BUCKLE OF HIS LEADS, LEAVING A DEEP CUT.

OH, I'M SORRY, REIN, MY HAND IS SHAKING! DIFFIDENT!

THE SEVERED WHIPS FELL AWAY, RON GET THE HIS FEET, SHAKING HIS ARMS
THE REGAIN FEELING IN THEM, HARRY PICKED UP HIS WAND AND CLIMBED
EVER ALL THE DEBRIS THE WHERE THE LARGE BLEND DEATH EATER WAS
SPRAWLED
ACROSS THE BENCH.

I SHOULD VE RECOGNIZED HIM, HE WAS THERE THE NIGHT DUMBLEDORE
DIED, HE SAID, HE TURNED OVER THE DARKER DEATH EATER WITH HIS FEET;
THE MAN S EYES MOVED RAPIDLY BETWEEN HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE.
THAT S DUMBLEDORE, SAID RON, I RECOGNIZE HIM FROM THE OLD WANTED
POSTERS, I THINK THE BIG ONE S THIRTIEN REWAL.

NEVER MIND WHAT THEY RE CALLED, SAID HERMIONE A LITTLE HYSTERI-
CALLY, WHEN DID THEY FIND US? WHAT ARE WE DOING THE DEE?

SHAKING HER PANIC SEEMED THE CLEAR HARRY S HEAD.

BEHIND THE DEER, HE TOLD HER, AND RON, TURN FOLT THE LIGHTS.
HE WHISKED DOWN AT THE PARALYZED DUMBLEDORE, THINKING FAST AS THE
WHEELS CLICKED AND RON USED THE DEDIMINATHEE THE PULLING THE CAP IN THE
DARKNESS, HARRY COULD HEAR THE MEN WHO HAD IRRED AT HERMIONE
EARLIER, YELLING AT ANOTHER GIRL IN THE DISTANCE.

WHAT ARE WE DOING THE DEE WITH THEM? RON WHISPERED THE HARRY

A PLACE THE HIDE

THROUGH THE DARK, THEN, EVEN MORE QUIETLY, KILL THEM? THEY'D
KILL

US. THEY HAD A GOOD CHANCE NOW.

HERMIONE SLIDDERED AND TOOK A STEP BACKWARD, HARRY STOOD
HIS HEAD.

WE JUST NEED TO WIPE THEIR MEMORIES, SAID HARRY. IT'S BETTER
LIKE THAT, IT'LL THROW THEM OFF THE SCENT. IF WE KILLED THEM IT'D BE
EVIDENCE WE WERE HERE.

WELL BE THE BEST, SAID RON, SOUNDING PROFOUNDLY RELIEVED, BUT
I'VE NEVER DONE A MEMORY CHARM.

NEVER HAVE I, SAID HERMIONE, BUT I KNOW THE THEORY.

SHE TOOK A DEEP, CALMING BREATH, THEN POINTED HER WAND AT DEATH-
EY'S FOREHEAD AND SAID, OBIVIATE.

AT ONCE, DEATH-EY'S EYES BECAME UNFOCUSED AND DREAMY.

BRAVANT! SAID HARRY, CLAPPING HER ON THE BACK. TAKE CARE OF
THE OTHER ONE AND THE WAITRESS WHILE RON AND I CLEAR UP.

CLEAR UP? SAID RON, LEERING AROUND AT THE PARTLY DESTROYED
CAR. WHY?

DON'T YOU THINK THEY MIGHT WONDER WHAT'S HAPPENED IF THEY
WAKE UP AND FIND THEMSELVES IN A PLACE THAT LOOKS LIKE IT'S JUST
BEEN

BOMBED?

OH RIGHT, YES...

RON STRUGGLED FOR A MOMENT BEFORE MANAGING TO EXTRACT HIS WAND
FROM HIS POCKET.

IT'S NOT WONDER I CAN'T GET IT HELT, HERMINNE, WHEN PACKED MY HILD
IRANS, THEY'RE TIGHT.

HEI, I'M SORRY, HISSED HERMINNE, AND AS SHE DRAGGED THE

WAITRESS HELT HER SIGHT OF THE WINDMILLS, HARRY HEARD HER MUTTER A
SLUG-

GESTURE AS THE WHERE RICH CHILD STUCK HIS HAND INSTEAD.

CHAPTER NINE

1888

BEFORE THE CAR WAS RESTORED TO ITS PREVIOUS CONDITION, THEY HEAVED

THE DEATH EATERS BACK INTO THEIR SEETH AND PREPARED THEM UP FAC-
ING EACH OTHER.

BUT WHEN DID THEY FIND US? HERMINNE ASKED, LEERING FROM HER
INERT MAN TO THE OTHER. WHEN DID THEY KNOW WHERE WE WERE?
SHE TURNED TO HARRY.

WELL, WELL DON'T THINK WELL WE STILL GET YOUR TRACE AND WELL, DEE
WELL, HARRY?

HE CAN'T HAVE, SAID RICH. THE TRACE BREAKS AT SEVENTEEN, THAT'S
WIZARDING LAW, WELL CAN'T PLIT IT AND AN ADULT.

AS FAR AS WELL KNOW, SAID HERMINNE. WHAT IF THE DEATH EATERS
HAVE FOUND A WAY TO PLIT IT AND A SEVENTEEN-YEAR-OLD?

BUT HARRY HADN'T BEEN NEAR A DEATH EATER IN THE LAST TWENTY-
FIVE

HOURS, WHEN S SUGGESTED THEY HAVE PUT A TRACE BACK ON HIM?

HERMIONIE DID NOT REPLY, HARRY FELT CONTAMINATED, TAINTED: WAS
THAT REALLY HOW THE DEATH EATERS HAD FELT THEM?

IF I CAN'T USE MAGIC, AND YOU CAN'T USE MAGIC NEAR ME, WITHOUT
US GIVING AWAY OUR POSITION HE BEGAN,

WE'RE NOT SPLITTING UP! SAID HERMIONIE FIRMLY,

WE NEED A SAFE PLACE TO HIDE, SAID RON, GIVE US TIME TO THINK
THINGS THROUGH,

GRIMMALT PLACE, SAID HARRY,

THE OTHER TWO GASED,

DON'T BE SILLY, HARRY, SNAPE CAN GET IN THERE!

RON'S DAD SAID THEY'VE PUT UP INDEXES AGAINST HIM AND EVEN IF
THEY HAVEN'T WORKED, HE PRESSED HIM AS HERMIONIE BEGAN TO ARGUE,

SEE WHAT? I SWEAR, I'D LIKE NOTHING BETTER THAN TO MEET SNAPE!

BUT

HERMIONIE, WHERE ELSE IS THERE? IT'S THE BEST CHANCE WE'VE GOT,

A PLACE TO HIDE

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SNAPE'S ONLY ONE DEATH EATER, IF I'VE STILL GOT THE TRACE ON ME,
WE'LL

HAVE WHILE THERE'S ANY OF THEM AND US WHEREVER ELSE WE GO,

SHE COULD NOT ARGUE, THOUGH SHE WHINED AS IF SHE WOULD HAVE LIKED

THE WHILE SHE UNLOCKED THE CAR DOOR, RON CLICKED THE ILLUMINATION THE RELEASE THE CAR'S LIGHT. THEN, FOR HARRY'S COMFORT OF THREE, THEY

REVERSED THE SPELLS UPON THEIR THREE VICTIMS, AND BEFORE THE WAITRESS

FOR EITHER OF THE DEATH EATERS COULD BE MORE THAN SLUR SLEEPILY, HARRY,

RON, AND HERMIONIE HAD TURNED HIM THE SPOT AND VANISHED INTO THE COMPELLING DARKNESS BACK THERE.

SECONDS LATER HARRY'S LINGS EXPANDED GRATEFULLY AND HE OPENED HIS EYES: THEY WERE NOW STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF A FAMILIAR SMALL AND SHAGGY SHED. TALL, DILAPIDATED BUILDINGS LINED DOWN HIM THEM FROM EVERY SIDE. NUMBER TWELVE WAS VISIBLE TO THEM, FOR THEY HAD BEEN TOLD OF ITS EXISTENCE BY DUMBLEDORE, ITS SECRET-KEEPER, AND THEY

ALIGNED THEMSELVES IT, CHECKING EVERY FEW YARDS THAT THEY WERE NOT BEING FOLLOWED OR OBSERVED. THEY RACED UP THE STONE STEPS, AND HARRY

TAPPED THE FRONT DOOR BACK WITH HIS HAND. THEY HEARD A SERIES OF METALLIC CLIPS AND THE CLATTER OF A CHAIN, THEN THE DOOR SWUNG OPEN

WITH A CREAK AND THEY FLURRIED OVER THE THRESHOLD.

AS HARRY CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND THEM, THE OLD-FASHIONED GAS LAMPS SPRANG INTO LIFE, CASTING FLICKERING LIGHT ALONG THE LENGTH OF THE

HALLWAY. IT LOOKED JUST AS HARRY REMEMBERED IT: Eerie, cheerless,

THE OUTLINES OF THE HOUSE-ELF HEADS ON THE WALL TWINKLING AND
SHED-

HEW UP THE STAIRCASE. LONG DARK CURTAINS CONCEALED THE PORTRAIT
OF

STIRLIS & MEETHEN. THE ONLY THING THAT WAS LEFT OF PLACE WAS THE
TRELLIS

AND UMBRELLA STAND, WHICH WAS LYING ON ITS SIDE AS IF THINGS HAD
JUST

SHOOKED IT OVER AGAIN.

I THINK SOMEONE'S BEEN IN HERE, HERMIONE WHISPERED, POINT-
ING TOWARD IT.

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THAT COULD VE HAPPENED AS THE ORDER LEFT, RON MURMURED
BACK.

SEE WHERE ARE THESE INDICES THEY PUT UP AGAINST SNAPS? HARRY
ASKED.

MAYBE THEY RE ONLY ACTIVATED IF HE STAYS UP? SUGGESTED RON.
BUT THEY REMAINED CLOSE TOGETHER ON THE DORMER, BACKS AGAINST
THE DORM, SCARED THE MOVIE FARTHER INTO THE HOUSE.

WELL, WE CAN'T STAY HERE FOREVER, SAID HARRY, AND HE TOOK A STEP

FORWARD,

SEVERUS Snape?

MAD-EYE Moody's voice whispered out of the darkness, making all three of them limp back in fright. We're not Snape! shrieked Harry, before something whisked over him like cold air and his tongue curled backward in itself, making it impossible to speak. Before he had time to feel inside his mouth, however, his tongue had unraveled again.

The other two seemed to have experienced the same unpleasant sensation. Ron was making retching noises; Hermione stamped, that must have been the T-Tongue-Tying Curse Mad-Eye set up for Snape!

Gingerly Harry took another step forward. Something shifted in the shadows at the end of the hall, and before any of them could

say another word, a figure had risen up out of the carpet, tall, list-

less, and terrible! Hermione screamed and so did Mrs. Black,

her curtains flying open; the gray figure was sliding toward them,

faster and faster, its waist-length hair and beard streaming behind it,

its face slender, fleshless, with empty eye sockets! Horrifiedly familiar,

dreadfully altered, it raised a wasted arm, pointing at Harry,

A PLACE THE END

NO! HARRY STEELTED, AND THOUGH HE HAD RAISED HIS WAND THE SPELL
HURLLED THE HIM. NO! IT WASN'T LI! WE DIDN'T KILL THE!

THE THE WARD KILL, THE FIGURE EXPLODED IN A GREAT CLOUD OF DUST!

CHUCKLING, HIS EYES WATERING, HARRY WHISKED AROUND THE SEE
HERMIONE

CRUELLED HIM THE FLEER BY THE DEER WITH HER ARMS OVER HER HEAD,
AND

THEN, WHEN WAS SHAKING FROM HEAD THE FEET, PATTING HER CLOMELY IN
THE SHOULDER AND SAYING, IT'S ALL R-RIGHT, ... IT'S E-CHINE, ...

DUST SWIRLED AROUND HARRY LIKE MIST, CATCHING THE BLUE GASLIGHT,
AS MRS. BLACK CONTINUED THE SCREAM.

MURDERERS, FILTH, STAINS OF DISHONOR, TAIN OF SHAME IN THE HEEL OF
OF

MY FATHERS

STILL LIP! HARRY BELLEVED, DIRECTING HIS WAND AT HER, AND
WITH A BANG AND A CLUST OF RED SPARKS, THE CURTAINS SWINGING SHUT
AGAIN, SILENCING HER.

THAT ... THAT WAS ... HERMIONE WHIMPERED, AS RON HELPED
HER THE HER FEET.

YEAH, SAID HARRY, BUT IT WASN'T REALLY HIM, WAS IT? JUST SOME-
THING THE SCARE SNAPE.

HAD IT WORKED, HARRY WHISPERED, HE HAD SNAPE ALREADY ELASTED

THE CHORUS-FIGURE ASIDE AS CASUALLY AS HE HAD KILLED THE REAL
DUMBLE-

DEER? NERVES STILL TINGLING, HE LED THE OTHER TWO UP THE HALL, HALF-
EXPECTING SOME NEW TERROR TO REVEAL ITSELF, BUT NOTHING CAME
EXCEPT

A FINE SWITTING ALONG THE SWITTING BOARD,

BEFORE WE GO ANY FARTHER, I THINK WE'D BETTER CHECK, WHISPERED
HERMINE, AND SHE RAISED HER HAND AND SAID, HERMINE REVELED,
NOTHING HAPPENED,

WELL, WELL YE ILST HAD A BIG SHECK, SAID RICH KINDLY, WHAT WAS
THAT SLIPPERED THE DEE?

CHAPTER NINE

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IT DID WHAT I MEANT IT TO DO, SAID HERMINE RATHER CRISPLY,
THAT WAS A SPELL THE REVEAL HUMAN PRESENCE, AND THERE'S NOTHING
HERE EXCEPT US:

AND WHO DUSTY, SAID RICH, GLANCING AT THE PATCH OF CARPET FROM
WHICH THE CHORUS-FIGURE HAD RISEN,

LET'S GO UP, SAID HERMINE WITH A FRIGHTENED LOOK AT THE SAME
SPOT, AND SHE LED THE WAY UP THE CREAKING STAIRS TO THE DRAWING
ROOM

IN THE FIRST PLACE,

HERMINE WAVED HER HAND TO IGNITE THE TWO GAS LAMPS, THEN,

SHIVERING SLIGHTLY IN THE DRAFTY ROOM, SHE PERCHED ON THE SEAT,
HER

ARMS WRAPPED TIGHTLY AROUND HER, THEN CROSSED THE WINDOW AND
MOVED THE HEAVY VELVET CURTAIN ASIDE AN INCH.

CAN'T SEE ANYONE OUT THERE, HE REPORTED. AND YET I THINK, IF
HARRY STILL HAD A TRACE OF HIM, THEY'D HAVE FOLLOWED US HERE. I
KNOW

THEY CAN'T GET IN THE HOUSE, BUT WHAT'S UP, HARRY?

HARRY HAD GIVEN A CRY OF PAIN: HIS SCAR HAD BURNED AGAIN AS
SOME-

THING FLASHED ACROSS HIS MIND LIKE A BRIGHT LIGHT IN WATER. HE SAW
A

LARGE SHADE AND FELT A FLURY THAT WAS NOT HIS OWN FEELING
THROUGH

HIS BODY, VIOLENT AND BRIEF AS AN ELECTRIC SHOCK.

WHAT DID YOU SEE? THEN ASKED, ADVANCING ON HARRY. DID YOU
SEE HIM AT MY PLACE?

NO, I JUST FELT ANGER HE'S REALLY ANGRY

BUT THAT CHILD BE AT THE CURTAIN, SAID THEN WHISPERING. WHAT ELSE?
DIDN'T YOU SEE ANYTHING? WAS HE CURSING SOMEONE?

NO, I JUST FELT ANGER I COULDN'T TELL

HARRY FELT BAGERED, CONFUSED, AND SOMEONE DID NOT HELP AS SHE
SAID IN A FRIGHTENED VOICE. YOUR SCAR, AGAIN? BUT WHAT'S GOING
ON? I

THOUGHT THAT CONNECTION HAD CLOSED:

IT DID, FOR A WHILE, MUTTERED HARRY; HIS SCAR WAS STILL PAINFUL,

A PLACE TO HIDE

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WHICH MADE IT HARD TO CONCENTRATE. I I THINK IT'S STARTED
HAPPENING

AGAIN WHENEVER HE LIES DOWN, THAT'S WHY IT USED TO

BUT THEN WHEN WE GOT THE CLUES FROM MIND? SAID HERMIONE SHRILLY,
HARRY, DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T WANT WHEN THE USE THAT CONNECTION, HE
WANTED WHEN THE SPLIT IT OPEN, THAT'S WHY WHEN WE WERE SUPPOSED TO USE
ILLUMINATIO? OTHERWISE VERBEMERT CAN PLANT FALSE IMAGES IN YOUR
MIND, REMEMBER

Yeah, I DO REMEMBER, THANKS, SAID HARRY THROUGHO CRITTED TEETH;
HE DID NOT NEED HERMIONE TO TELL HIM THAT VERBEMERT HAD ONCE
USED

THIS SAME CONNECTION BETWEEN THEM TO LEAD HIM INTO A TRAP,
NEED

THAT IT HAD RESULTED IN SIRIUS'S DEATH, HE WISHED THAT HE HAD NOT
TOLD

THAT WHAT HE HAD SEEN AND FELT; IT MADE VERBEMERT MORE THREATEN-
ING, AS THOUGH HE WERE PRESSING AGAINST THE WINDSHIELD OF THE RHYTHM,

AND STILL THE PAIN IN HIS SCAR WAS BUILDING AND HE FELT IT! IT WAS
LIKE RESISTING THE FORCE OF THE SICK,

HE TURNED HIS BACK ON RON AND HERMIONE, PRETENDING THE EXAM-

IN THE OLD TAPESTRY OF THE BLACK FAMILY TREE ON THE WALL. THEN
HER-

MIND STRICKEN: HARRY DREW HIS HAND AGAIN AND SPUN AROUND THE
SEE

A SILVER PATRIOT'S SHIP THROUGH THE DRAWING ROOM WINDOW AND
LAND

UPON THE FLOOR IN FRONT OF THEM, WHERE IT COLLIDED INTO THE
WEASEL

THAT SPED WITH THE VEHICLE OF REN'S FATHER.

FAMILY SAFE, SHE DID NOT REPLY, WE ARE BEING WATCHED.

THE PATRIOT'S DISSOLVED INTO NOTHINGNESS. REN LET OUT A NOISE BE-
TWEEN A WHIMPER AND A GRIAN AND DROPPED INTO THE SEAT:
HERMINE

THINK HIM, GRIPPING HIS ARM.

THEY ARE ALL RIGHT, THEY ARE ALL RIGHT! SHE WHISPERED, AND REN
HALL

LAUGHED AND HUGGED HER.

HARRY, HE SAID EVER HERMINE'S SHOULDERS, I

IT IS NOT A PROBLEM, SAID HARRY, SICKENED BY THE PAIN IN HIS HEAD.

CHAPTER NINE

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IT IS YOUR FAMILY, CHLOE'S YOU ARE WORRIED, I DO FEEL THE SAME WAY,
HE

THE LIGHT OF GINN, I DO FEEL THE SAME WAY,

THE PAIN IN HIS STOMACH WAS REACHING A PEAK, BURNING AS IT HAD DONE
IN THE GARDEN OF THE KILN. FAINTLY HE HEARD FERMINE SAY, I
DON'T

WANT TO BE IN MY HAND, CHILD WE USE THE SLEEPING BAGS I'VE BROUGHT
AND CAMP IN HERE TONIGHT?

HE HEARD BEN AGREE, HE COULD NOT FIGHT THE PAIN MUCH LONGER:

HE HAD THE SICKLE,

SATISFIED, HE MUTTERED, AND HE LEFT THE ROOM AS FAST AS HE COULD
WITHHOLD RUNNING.

HE BARELY MADE IT: KICKING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM WITH TREMBLING
HANDS, HE GRASPED HIS POUNDING HEAD AND FELL TO THE FLOOR, THEN IN
AN EXPLOSION OF AGONY, HE FELT THE RAGE THAT DID NOT RELEASE HIM
POSSESS HIS SENSE, SAW A LONG ROOM LIT ONLY BY FIRELIGHT, AND THE
GREAT

BLIND DEATH LATER THAN THE FLOOR, SCREAMING AND WRITHING, AND A
SLIGHTER FIGURE STANDING OVER HIM, HANDS OUTSTRETCHED, WHILE
HARRY

SPROKE IN A HIGH, COLD, MERCILESS VOICE.

MERE, WHILE, HE SHALL WE END IT AND FEEL THE DRAIN? LORD
VILDEBERT IS NOT SURE THAT HE WILL FORGIVE THIS TIME. . . . SHE
CALLED

HE RAN FOR THIS, HE TELL ME THAT HARRY POTTER HAS ESCAPED AGAIN?
DRACH, GIVE WHILE ANOTHER TASTE OF HIS DISPLEASURE. . . . DO IT, HE
FEEL MY WRATH YOURSELF?

A LONG FELL IN THE FIRE! FLAMES REARED, THEIR LIGHT DARTING ACROSS A
TERRIFIED, PAINTED WHITE FACE WITH A SENSE OF EMERGING FROM DEEP
WATER, HARRY DREW HEAVING BREATHS AND OPENED HIS EYES.

HE WAS SPREAD-EAGLED WHEN THE CHILD BLACK MARKLE FLEW, HIS NECK
INCHES FROM WHEN THE SILVER SERPENT TAILS THAT SUPPORTED THE
LARGE

BATTLE. HE SAT UP, MALFOY'S CALM, PETRIFIED FACE SEEMED BRANDED

A BLACK TREE TRUNK

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WHEN THE INSIDE OF HIS EYES, HARRY FELT SICKENED BY WHAT HE HAD SEEN,
BY THE LIKE THE WHICH DRAGON WAS NOW BEING PLIT BY VERMEMENT.

THERE WAS A SHARP RAP WHEN THE DRAGON, AND HARRY JUMPED AS HERMI-
ONE'S WHEEL RANG HILT.

HARRY, BE WELL WANT YOUR THUNDERBOLTS I VE GOT IT HERE.

YES, GREAT, THANKS, HE SAID, FIGHTING THE DRAGON HIS WHEEL CASUAL
AS HE STOOD UP THE LET HER IN.

C H A P T E R T E N

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DRAGON'S TAIL

ARRY WAKE EARLY NEXT MORNING, WRAPPED IN A SLEEPING

RAG IN THE DRAWING ROOM FLOOR. A CHINK OF SKY WAS VISIBLE BETWEEN THE HEAVY CURTAINS: IT WAS THE COLD, CLEAR BLUE OF WATERED

IND, SOMEWHERE BETWEEN NIGHT AND DAWN, AND EVERYTHING WAS QUIET EXCEPT FOR REN AND FERMINE'S SLOW, DEEP BREATHING. HARRY GLANCED

EVER AT THE DARK SHAPES THEY MADE IN THE FLOOR BESIDE HIM. REN HAD HAD A FIT OF GALLANTRY AND INSISTED THAT FERMINE SLEEP IN THE CUSHIONS FROM THE SOFA, SEE THAT HER SILHETTE WAS RAISED ABOVE HIS.

HER ARM CLYVED TO THE FLOOR, HER FINGERS INCHES FROM REN'S. HARRY

WONDERED WHETHER THEY HAD FALLEN ASLEEP HOLDING HANDS. THE IDEA MADE HIM FEEL STRANGELY LONELY.

HE LOOKED UP AT THE SHADELY CEILING, THE CHECKERED CHANDLIER, LESS THAN TWENTY-FOUR HOURS AGO, HE HAD BEEN STANDING IN THE

SLIGHT AT THE ENTRANCE TO THE MARQUEE, WAITING TO SEE IN WEDDING GUESTS. IT SEEMED A LIFETIME AWAY. WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN

NOW? HE LAY IN THE FLOOR AND HE THOUGHT OF THE FURCLOWS, OF THE

H

DEACON & TALL

DALNTINE, CEMPLEX MISSIHN DUMKLEDHRE HAD LEFT HIM. . . . DUMKLE-
DHRE . . .

THE GRIEF THAT HAD POSSESSED HIM SINCE DUMKLEDHRE'S DEATH FELT
DIFFERENT NOW. THE ACCUSATIONS HE HAD HEARD FROM MURIEL AT THE
WEDDING SEEMED TO HAVE NESTED IN HIS BRAIN LIKE DISEASED THINGS,

INFECTING HIS MEMORIES OF THE WIZARD HE HAD IDEALIZED. COULD DUM-
KLEDHRE HAVE LET SUCH THINGS HAPPEN? HAD HE BEEN LIKE DUDLEY,

CONTENT TO WATCH NEGLECT AND ABUSE AS LONG AS IT DID NOT AFFECT
HIM?

COULD HE HAVE TURNED HIS BACK WHEN A SISTER WHO WAS BEING IMPRIS-
ONED AND HIDDEN?

HARRY THOUGHT OF CEMRIK'S FATHER, OF GRAVES DUMKLEDHRE HAD

NEVER MENTIONED THERE; HE THOUGHT OF MYSTERIOUS ERIKTS LEFT
WITH-

OUT EXPLANATIONS IN DUMKLEDHRE'S WILL, AND RESENTMENT SWELLED IN

THE DARKNESS. WHY HADN'T DUMKLEDHRE TOLD HIM? WHY HADN'T HE
EXPLAINED? HAD DUMKLEDHRE ACTUALLY CARED ABOUT HARRY AT ALL? HER

HAD HARRY BEEN NOTHING MORE THAN A THING HE HAD FORGOTTEN AND
FORGOTTEN,

HE HAD NOT TRUSTED, NEVER TRUSTED IN?

HARRY COULD NOT STAND LYING THERE WITH NOTHING BUT BITTER

THOUGHTS FOR COMPANY, DESPERATE FOR SOMETHING TO DO, FOR DISTRACTION,
HE SLIPPED OUT OF HIS SLEEPING BAG, PICKED UP HIS WAND, AND

CREPT OUT OF THE ROOM, IN THE LANDING HE WHISPERED, "Lumos," AND
STARTED THE CLIMB THE STAIRS BY WANDLIGHT.

IN THE SECOND LANDING WAS THE BEDROOM IN WHICH HE AND RON

HAD SLEPT LAST TIME THEY HAD BEEN HERE; HE GLANCED INTO IT. THE
WARD-

ROBE DRESSER STOOD OPEN AND THE BEDCLOTHES HAD BEEN RIPPED BACK,

HARRY REMEMBERED THE HEAVY-THROATED TRILL OF DOWNSTAIRS, SOMEONE
HAD SEARCHED THE HOUSE SINCE THE ORDER HAD LEFT, SNAPE? OR
PERHAPS

MURDERING, WHO HAD PILFERED PLenty FROM THIS HOUSE BOTH BEFORE
AND AFTER SIRIUS DIED? HARRY'S GAZE WANDERED TO THE PORTRAIT THAT

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SOMETIMES CONTAINED PHINEAS NIGELLUS BLACK, SIRIUS'S GREAT-GREAT-
GRANDFATHER, BUT IT WAS EMPTY, FEELING NOTHING BUT A STRETCH OF

MOODY BACKDROPP, PHINEAS NIGELLUS WAS EVIDENTLY SPENDING THE NIGHT

IN THE HEADMASTER'S STUDY AT HOGWARTS.

HARRY CONTINUED UP THE STAIRS UNTIL HE REACHED THE THIRDMOST LANDING, WHERE THERE WERE ONLY TWO DOORS. THE ONE FACING HIM BEHOLD A NAMEPLATE READING SIRILUS. HARRY HAD NEVER ENTERED HIS GODFATHER'S BEDROOM BEFORE. HE PUSHED OPEN THE DOOR, HOLDING HIS WAND HIGH TO CAST LIGHT AS WIDELY AS POSSIBLE. THE ROOM WAS SPACIOUS AND MUST ONCE HAVE BEEN HANDSOME. THERE WAS A LARGE BED WITH A CARVED WOODEN HEADBOARD, A TALL WINDOW ENCLOSED BY HEAVY VELVET CURTAINS, AND A CHANDELIER THICKLY LADEN IN BLISS WITH CANDLE STICKS STILL RESTING IN ITS SHEETS, WHICH WAS HANGING IN FREESTYLE DRIPS. A FINE FILM OF BLISS COVERED THE PICTURES ON THE WALLS AND THE BED'S HEADBOARD; A SPIDER'S WEB STRETCHED BETWEEN THE CHANDELIER AND THE TOP OF THE LARGE WOODEN WARDROBE, AND AS

HARRY MOVED DEEPER INTO THE ROOM, HE HEARD A SLURRYING OF DISTURBED MICE.

THE TEENAGE SIRILUS HAD PLASTERED THE WALLS WITH SO MANY POSTERS AND PICTURES THAT LITTLE OF THE WALLS' SILVERY-GRAY STONE WAS VISIBLE.

HARRY COULD ONLY ASSUME THAT SIRILUS'S PARENTS HAD BEEN UNABLE TO

REMOVE THE PERMANENT STICKING CHARM THAT KEPT THEM ON THE WALL.

BECAUSE HE WAS SURE THEY WOULD NOT HAVE APPRECIATED THEIR ELDEST SON'S TASTE IN DECORATION, SIRIUS SEEMED TO HAVE GONE HURT BY HIS WAY

TO ANSWER HIS PARENTS. THERE WERE SEVERAL LARGE GRYFFINDOR BANNERS,

FADED SCARLET AND GOLD, JUST THE UNDERLINE HIS DIFFERENCE FROM ALL THE REST OF THE SLYTHERIN FAMILY. THERE WERE MANY PICTURES OF MUGGLE MOTORCYCLES, AND ALSO (HARRY HAD TO ADMIRE SIRIUS'S NERVE) SEVERAL

DEATH-EATERS'S TALL

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POSTERS OF RIXINI-CLAD MUGGLE GIRLS; HARRY COULD TELL THAT THEY WERE

MUGGLES BECAUSE THEY REMAINED ELITE STATUARY WITHIN THEIR PICTURES, FADED SMILES AND GLAZED EYES FROZEN IN THE PAPER. THIS WAS IN

CONTRAST TO THE ONLY WIZARDING PHOTOGRAPH ON THE WALLS, WHICH WAS

A PICTURE OF PHILIP FLEGGWARTS STUDENTS STANDING ARM IN ARM, LAUGHING

AT THE CAMERA.

WITH A LEAP OF PLEASURE, HARRY RECOGNIZED HIS FATHER; HIS UNTIDY BLACK HAIR STICK UP AT THE BACK LIKE HARRY'S, AND HE THEM WORE GLASSES.

BESIDE HIM WAS SIRILIS, CARELESSLY HANDSOME, HIS SLIGHTLY ARROGANT FACE

SEE MUCH YOUNGER AND HAPPIER THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN IT ALIVE. THE

SIRILIS'S RIGHT STEADY PETTIGREW, MORE THAN A HEAD SHORTER, PLUMP AND

WATERY-EYED, FLASHED WITH PLEASURE AT HIS INCLINATION IN THIS CHEERFUL
OF GAMES, WITH THE MUCH-ADMIRED REELS THAT JAMES AND SIRILIS HAD
BEEN. WHEN JAMES'S LEFT WAS BLIMPY, EVEN THEN A LITTLE SHAKY-LOOKING,
BUT HE HAD THE SAME AIR OF DELIGHTED SURPRISE AT FINDING HIMSELF
LIKED

AND INCLUDED . . . HE WAS IT SIMPLY BECAUSE HARRY KNOWS WELL IT HAD
BEEN, THAT HE SAW THESE THINGS IN THE PICTURE? HE TRIED TO TAKE IT
FROM

THE WALL; IT WAS HIS NEED, AFTER ALL, SIRILIS HAD LEFT HIM EVERYTHING,
BUT

IT WOULD NOT DO. SIRILIS HAD TAKEN NEAR CHANCES IN PREVENTING
HIS

PARENTS FROM REDETERMINING HIS FUTURE.

HARRY LOOKED AROUND AT THE FLOOR. THE SKY OUTSIDE WAS GROW-
ING BRIGHTER; A SLANT OF LIGHT REVEALED BITS OF PAPER, BOOKS, AND

SMALL OBJECTS SCATTERED OVER THE CARPET. EVIDENTLY SIRILIS'S BEDROOM
HAD BEEN SEARCHED THOROUGHLY, ALTHOUGH ITS CONTENTS SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN
ILLEGED MOSTLY, IF NOT ENTIRELY, WORTHLESS. A FEW OF THE BOOKS HAD
BEEN SHAKEN RELIGIOUSLY ENOUGH THE PART COMPANY WITH THEIR LEAVES,
AND SLINDRY PAGES LITTERED THE FLOOR.

HARRY BENT DOWN, PICKED UP A FEW OF THE PIECES OF PAPER, AND

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EXAMINED THEM, HE RECOGNIZED ONE AS PART OF AN OLD EDITION OF
A HISTORY OF MAGIC, BY RUTHILDA BACCHETT, AND ANOTHER AS
RELATING

TO A MOTORCYCLE MAINTENANCE MANUAL. THE THIRD WAS HANDWRITTEN
AND CRUMPLED. HE SMOTHERED IT IN IT.

DEAR PADMEET,

THANK YOU, THANK YOU, FOR HARRY'S BIRTHDAY PRESENT! IT
WAS HIS FAVORITE BY FAR. FINE YEAR OLD AND ALREADY ZIPPING
ALONG ON A NEW BROOMSTICK, HE BEAMED SO PLEASED WITH HIMSELF,
I'M ENCLOSING A PICTURE YOU WILL CAN SEE. YOU KNOW IT ONLY
RISES ABOUT TWO FEET OFF THE GROUND, BUT HE NEARLY KILLED THE
CAT AND HE SMASHED A TERRIBLE VASE PETLINIA SENT ME FOR
CHRISTMAS (SEE COMPLAINTS THERE). OF COURSE, JAMES THOUGHT IT
WAS SO FLINDY, SAYS HE'S GETTING THE RE A GREAT FLIBBITCH PLAYER,
BUT WE'VE HAD THE PACK AWAY ALL THE ORNAMENTS AND MADE SURE
WE DON'T TAKE HIS EYES OFF HIM WHEN HE GETS GOING.

WE HAD A VERY QUIET BIRTHDAY TEA, JUST US AND OLD

RUTHILDA, WHO HAS ALWAYS BEEN SWEET TO US AND WHO DOTES ON
HARRY. WE WERE SO SHY YOU CHILDREN T CAME, BUT THE ORDER'S

GET THE CUP FIRST, AND HARRY'S NEET OLD ENOUGH TO KNOW

IT'S HIS BIRTHDAY ANYWAY! JAMES IS GETTING A BIT FRUSTRATED

SPLIT LIP HERE, HE TRIES NOT TO SHOW IT BUT I CAN TELL ALSE,

OLIVEREDORE'S STILL GET HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK, SHE NEE CHANCE
HIS LITTLE EXCLUSIVENESS. IF SHE'LL BEHOLD VISIT, IT WOULD CHEER HIM
UP SHE THINK. WHERBY WAS HERE LAST WEEKEND, I TRULIGHT HE
SEEMED DEHN, BUT THAT WAS PROBABLY THE NEWS ABOUT THE
MCDONNENS; I CRIED ALL EVENING WHEN I HEARD.

KATHILDA DREAMS IN MOST DAYS, SHE'S A FASCINATING OLD THING
WITH THE MOST AMAZING STORIES ABOUT OLIVEREDORE, I'M NOT

DEARER'S TALK

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SURE HE'D BE PLEASED IF HE KNEW; I DIDN'T KNOW HOW MUCH TO
BELIEVE, ACTUALLY, BECAUSE IT SEEMS INCREDIBLE THAT OLIVEREDORE
HARRY'S EXTREMITIES SEEMED TO HAVE GONE ALIVE. HE STOOD ELITE
STILL, HOLDING THE MIRACULOUS PAPER IN HIS NERVELESS FINGERS WHILE
INSIDE HIM A KIND OF ELITE ERLIPTHEN SENT HIM AND GRIEF THUNDERING
IN FINAL MEASURE THROUGH HIS VEINS. BLINKING TO THE RED, HE SAT
DOWN.

HE READ THE LETTER AGAIN, BUT COULD NOT TAKE IN ANY MORE MEANING
THAN HE HAD DONE THE FIRST TIME, AND WAS REDUCED TO STARING AT THE
HANDWRITING ITSELF. SHE HAD MADE HER C'S THE SAME WAY HE DID; HE
SEARCHED THROUGH THE LETTER FOR EVERY ONE OF THEM, AND EACH FELT
LIKE

A FRIENDLY LITTLE WAVE GLIMPSED FROM BEHIND A VEIL. THE LETTER WAS
AN

INCREDIBLE TREASURE, PROOF THAT LILY BETTER HAD LIVED, REALLY LIVED,
THAT

HIS WARM HAND HAD SINCE MOVED ACROSS THIS PARCEMENT, TRACING INDENTURES
IN THESE LETTERS, THESE WORDS, WORDS ABLE TO HIM, HARRY, HER SON,
IMPATIENTLY BRUSHING AWAY THE WETNESS IN HIS EYES, HE REREAD THE
LETTER, THIS TIME CONCENTRATING ON THE MEANING. IT WAS LIKE
LISTENING

TO A HALF-REMEMBERED VOICE.

THEY HAD HAD A CAT . . . PERHAPS IT HAD PERISHED, LIKE HIS PARENTS, AT
GRIFFIN & BULLOCK . . . HER ELSE ATE WHEN THERE WAS NOTHING LEFT TO FEED
IT . . . SIRIUS HAD BUGHT HIM HIS FIRST BROOMSTICK . . . HIS PARENTS
HAD KNOWN KATHLEEN RAGSWORTH; HAD DUMBLEDORE INTRODUCED THEM?
DUMBLEDORE & STILL GET HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK . . . THERE WAS
SOMETHING

FLINNY THERE . . .

HARRY PAUSED, Pondering HIS MOTHER & WORDS. WHY HAD DUM-
BLEDORE TAKEN JAMES & INVISIBILITY CLOAK? HARRY DISTINCTLY REMEM-
BERED HIS HEADMASTER TELLING HIM YEARS BEFORE, I DON'T NEED A CLOAK

TO BECOME INVISIBLE. PERHAPS SOME LESS GIFTED ORDER MEMBER HAD

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NEEDED ITS ASSISTANCE, AND DUMBLEDORE HAD ACTED AS CARRIER? HARRY
PASSED ON . . .

WHEN WAS HERE . . . PETTIGREW, THE TRAITOR, HAD SEEMED DEAD,

HAD HE? WAS HE AWARE THAT HE WAS SEEING JAMES AND LILY ALIVE AFTER THE LAST TIME?

AND FINALLY RATHILDA AGAIN, WITH THOSE INCREDIBLE STORIES ABOUT DUMKLEBERRY. IT SEEMS INCREDIBLE THAT DUMKLEBERRY

THAT DUMKLEBERRY WHAT? BUT THERE WERE AND NUMBER OF THINGS THAT WOULD SEEM INCREDIBLE ABOUT DUMKLEBERRY; THAT HE HAD ONCE RECEIVED BATTERY MARKS IN A TRANSFIGURATION TEST, FOR INSTANCE, HE HAD TAKEN UP CHEAT-CHARMING LIKE ABERCROMBIE, . . .

HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET AND SCANNED THE FLOOR: PERHAPS THE REST OF THE LETTER WAS HERE SOMEWHERE. HE SEIZED PAPERS, TREATING THEM, IN HIS EAGERNESS, WITH AS LITTLE CONSIDERATION AS THE ORIGINAL SEARCHER;

HE PULLED OPEN DRAWERS, SEARCHED UNTIL REDDS, STEPPED ON A CHAIR THE ALIVE HIS HAND OVER THE TOP OF THE WARDROBE, AND CRAWLED UNDER THE BED AND ARMCHAIR.

AT LAST, LYING FACEDOWN ON THE FLOOR, HE SPOTTED WHAT LOOKED LIKE A THIN PIECE OF PAPER UNDER THE FIRST OF DRAWERS. WHEN HE PULLED IT

OUT, IT PROVED TO BE MOST OF THE PHOTOGRAPH LILY HAD DESCRIBED IN

HER LETTER. A BLACK-HAIRED BABY WAS ZIPPING IN AND OUT OF THE PICTURE ON A TINY GREEN, BEARING WITH LAUGHTER, AND A PAIR OF LEGS THAT

MUST HAVE BELONGED TO JAMES WAS CHASING AFTER HIM. HARRY TUCKED THE PHOTOGRAPH INTO HIS POCKET WITH LILY'S LETTER AND CONTINUED THE

LOOK FOR THE SECOND STREET.

AFTER ANOTHER GLANCE AT AN EELER, HOWEVER, HE WAS FORCED TO
CONCLUDE THAT THE REST OF HIS MOTHER'S LETTER WAS GONE. HAD IT SIM-
PLY BEEN LOST IN THE SIXTEEN YEARS THAT HAD ELAPSED SINCE IT HAD
BEEN WRITTEN, OR HAD IT BEEN TAKEN BY WHOMEVER HAD SEARCHED THE
DEACON'S TABLE

188

REALLY? HARRY READ THE FIRST SHEET AGAIN, THIS TIME LOOKING FOR
CLUES
AS TO WHAT MIGHT HAVE MADE THE SECOND SHEET VALUABLE. HIS THEO-
CRISTIAN CHILD HARDLY BE CONSIDERED INTERESTING TO THE DEATH-
EATERS. . . . THE ONLY POTENTIALLY USEFUL THING HE COULD SEE HERE
WAS POSSIBLE INFORMATION ON DUMBLEDORE. IT SEEMS INCREDIBLE THAT
DUMBLEDORE WHAT?

HARRY? HARRY? HARRY?

I'M HERE! HE CALLED. WHAT'S HAPPENED?

THERE WAS A CLATTER OF FEETSTEPS OUTSIDE THE DEER, AND HERMIONE
RUSHED INSIDE.

WE WERE UP AND DIDN'T KNOW WHERE YOU WERE! SHE SAID BREATH-
LESSLY. SHE TURNED AND SHOOKED EVERY HER SHOULDER. THEN I'VE
FOUND

HIM?

THEN A ANNOYED VOICE RANGED DISTANTLY FROM SEVERAL FEETERS BEHIND.

GEORGE: TELL HIM FROM ME HE'S A GIT!

HARRY, WHEN IT JUST DISAPPEARED, PLEASE, WE WERE TERRIFIED! WHY DID YOU COME UP HERE ANYWAY? SHE GAZED AROUND THE RANSACKED ROOM.
WHAT HAVE YOU BEEN DOING?

LENN: WHAT I'VE JUST FEELING.

HE HELD OUT HIS MOTHER'S LETTER, HERMINIE TOOK IT AND READ IT WHILE HARRY WATCHED HER. WHEN SHE REACHED THE END OF THE PAGE SHE LOOKED UP AT HIM.

HE, HARRY ...

AND THERE'S THIS THEN.

HE HANDED HER THE THIN PHOTOGRAPH, AND HERMINIE SMILED AT THE BABY ZIPPING IN AND OUT OF SIGHT IN THE TINY ROOM.

I'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR THE REST OF THE LETTER, HARRY SAID, BUT IT'S NOT HERE.

HERMINIE GLANCED AROUND.

CHAPTER TEN

1899

DID YOU MAKE ALL THIS MESS, HE WAS SURE OF IT WHEN YOU GOT HERE?

SOMEONE HAD SEARCHED EVERYWHERE ME, SAID HARRY.

I THOUGHT SEE, EVERY ROOM I LOOKED INTO THE WAY YOU HAD BEEN DISTURBED. WHAT WERE THEY AFTER, DID YOU THINK?

INFORMATION IN THE ORDER, IF IT WAS SNAPE.

BUT YOU'D THINK HE'D ALREADY HAVE ALL HE NEEDED, I MEAN, HE WAS IN THE ORDER, WASN'T HE?

WELL THEN, SAID HARRY, DEEN TEE DISCUSS HIS THEORY, WHAT ABOUT INFORMATION IN DUMBLEDORE? THE SECOND PAGE OF THIS LETTER, FOR INSTANCE, YOU KNOW THIS RATHILDA MY MUM MENTIONS, YOU KNOW WHERE SHE IS?

WHERE?

RATHILDA RACSTENT, THE AUNTIE OF

A HISTORY OF MAGIC, SAID HERMIONE, SOUNDING INTERESTED. SHE KNOWS

PARENTS KNOW HER? SHE WAS AN INCREDIBLE MAGICAL HISTORIAN,

AND SHE'S STILL ALIVE, SAID HARRY, AND SHE LIVES IN GEDRIC'S TOWN-
HALL, THEN AUNTIE MURIEL WAS TALKING ABOUT HER AT THE WEDDING.

SHE KNOWS DUMBLEDORE'S FAMILY THEN, BE PRETTY INTERESTING TALK
THAT, WOULDN'T SHE?

THERE WAS A LITTLE MORE MUCH UNDERSTANDING IN THE SMILE HERMI-
ONE GAVE HIM FOR HARRY'S LISTING, HE THEN RACD THE LETTER AND THE

PHOTOGRAPH AND TICKED THEM INSIDE THE POUCH ABOUT HIS NECK, SEE
AS NEET TEE HAVE TEE LOOK AT HER AND GIVE HIMSELF AWAY.

I UNDERSTAND WHY YOU'D HAVE TALK TEE HER ABOUT YOUR MUM AND

DAD, AND DUMBLEDORE THEN, SAID HERMIONE. BUT THAT WOULDN'T RE-

ALLY HELP US IN OUR SEARCH FOR THE FATHERS, WOULD IT? HARRY
DID

NOT ANSWER, AND SHE BLISHED HIM, HARRY, I KNOW YOU REALLY WANT
THE

THE CHORUS & FATHERS, BUT I'M SCARED, I'M SCARED AT THEM EASILY
THESE

DEATHS & TALK

188

DEATH EATERS FEELING US YESTERDAY, IT JUST MAKES ME FEEL MORE THAN
EVER THAT WE MIGHT BE AHEAD THE PLACE WHERE YOUR PARENTS ARE
KLINED,

I'M SURE THEY'D BE EXPECTING YOU TO VISIT IT,

IT'S NOT JUST THAT, HARRY SAID, STILL AVOIDING LOOKING AT HER,
MUR-

HE SAID STUFF ABOUT DUMBLEDORE AT THE WEDDING, I WANT THE KNOW THE

TRUTH...

HE TOLD HERMIONE EVERYTHING THAT MURIEL HAD TOLD HIM, WHEN
HE HAD FINISHED, HERMIONE SAID, HE' CHOOSE, I CAN SEE WHY THAT'S
WISER YOU, HARRY

I'M NOT WISER, HE LIED, I'D JUST LIKE THE KNOW WHETHER OR NOT IT'S
TRUE OR

HARRY, DO YOU REALLY THINK YOU'LL GET THE TRUTH FROM A
MALIKIHLIS

HOLD UP! MAN LIKE MURIEL, HER FROM RITA SKEETON? HOW CAN YOU
BELIEVE

THEY? YOU KNOW DUMBLEDORE?

I THOUGHT I DID, HE MUTTERED.

BUT YOU KNOW HOW MUCH TRUTH THERE WAS IN EVERYTHING RITA
WROTE ABOUT YOU? DECE IS RIGHT, HOW CAN YOU LET THESE PEOPLE
TARNISH

YOUR MEMORIES OF DUMBLEDORE?

HE WHISPERED AWAY, TRYING NOT TO BETRAY THE RESENTMENT HE FELT.
THERE

IT WAS AGAIN! CHOOSE WHAT TO BELIEVE, HE WANTED THE TRUTH. WHY
WAS EVERYBODY SO DETERMINED THAT HE SHOULD NOT GET IT?

SHALL WE GO DOWN TO THE KITCHEN? HERMIONE SUGGESTED AFTER A
LITTLE PAUSE. FIND SOMETHING FOR BREAKFAST?

HE AGREED, BUT GRUDGINGLY, AND FOLLOWED HER OUT INTO THE LAND-
ING AND PAST THE SECOND DOOR THAT LED OFF IT. THERE WERE DEEP
SCRATCHES

MARKS IN THE PAINTWORK REVEAL A SMALL SIGN THAT HE HAD NOT
NOTICED

IN THE DARK, HE PAUSED AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS TO READ IT. IT WAS A
POMPHREY'S LITTLE SIGN, NEATLY LETTERED BY HAND, THE SORT OF THING
THAT

PERCY WEASLEY MIGHT HAVE STUCK IN HIS BEDROOM DOOR:

CHAPTER TEN

188

DEE NEET ENTER

WITHEHUT THE EXPRESS PERMISSION EF

REGILLIS ARCTURILIS BLACK

EXCITEMENT TRICKLED THROUGH HARRY, BUT HE WAS NOT IMMEDIATELY
SURE WHY. HE READ THE SIGN AGAIN. HERMIENE WAS ALREADY A FLIGHT
OF

STAIRS BELOW HIM.

HERMIENE, HE SAID, AND HE WAS SURPRISED THAT HIS VOICE WAS SO
CALM. COME BACK UP HERE.

WHAT IS THE MATTER?

WELL, I THINK I VE FOUND HIM.

THERE WAS A GASP, AND THEN HERMIENE RAN BACK UP THE STAIRS.

IN YOUR MIND IS BETTER? BUT I DIDN T SEE

HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, POINTING AT REGILLIS S SIGN. SHE READ IT,
THEN

CLUTCHED HARRY S ARM SO TIGHTLY THAT HE WINCED.

SIRILIS S BROTHER? SHE WHISPERED.

HE WAS A DEATH EATER, SAID HARRY. SIRILIS TOLD ME ABOUT HIM.
HE THINKED UP WHEN HE WAS REALLY DYING AND THEN GOT CHILD FEET AND
TRIED TO LEAVE SO THEY KILLED HIM.

THAT FITS! GASPED HERMIENE. IF HE WAS A DEATH EATER HE HAD
ACCESS TO THE VEILMANT, AND IF HE BECAME DISSENT-ANTED, THEN HE WOULD
HAVE WANTED THE KING VEILMANT DEAD!

SHE RELEASED HARRY, LEANED OVER THE BANISTER, AND SCREAMED. RUN!

RENN: GET UP HERE, ELIJAH!

RENN APPEARED, PANTING, A MINUTE LATER, HIS HAND READY IN HIS HAND.

WHAT'S UP? IF IT'S MASSIVE SPIDERS AGAIN I WANT BREAKFAST BEFORE I

DETRACTOR'S TAIL

189

HE FREEMAN AT THE SIGN IN REELIUS'S DEER, THE WHICH HERMINE WAS SILENTLY PRINTING.

WHAT? THAT WAS SIRILUS'S BROTHER, WASN'T IT? REELIUS' ARTWORKS . . .

REELIUS . . . RAB: THE LOCKET YELL DEN'T REDEEN ?

LET'S FIND OUT, SAID HARRY, HE PUSHED THE DEER: IT WAS LOCKED, HERMINE PRINTED HER HAND AT THE HANDLE AND SAID, ALLELUHRA, THERE WAS A CLICK, AND THE DEER SWING OPEN.

THEY MOVED OVER THE THRESHOLD TOGETHER, GAZING AROUND, REELIUS'S

REDHEM WAS SLIGHTLY SMALLER THAN SIRILUS'S, THOUGH IT HAD THE SAME

SENSE OF FIERCE GRADUAL, WHEREAS SIRILUS HAD SEEMED TO ADVERTISE HIS DIFFERENCE FROM THE REST OF THE FAMILY, REELIUS HAD STRIVEN TO EMPHASIZE THE OPPOSITE. THE SLOTHFUL CHIEFS OF EMERALD AND SILVER

WERE EVERYWHERE, DRAPING THE BED, THE WALLS, AND THE WINDOWS. THE BLACK FAMILY CREST WAS PAINSTAKINGLY PAINTED OVER THE BED, ALONG

WITH ITS MOUTH, THE WHEELS PLIN. BENEATH THIS WAS A COLLECTION OF

YELLOW NEWSPAPER CLIPPINGS, ALL STUCK TOGETHER TO MAKE A RAGGED
CEL-

LAGE. HERMIONE CROSSED THE ROOM TO EXAMINE THEM.

THEY ARE ALL ABOUT VERBEMERT, SHE SAID. REGULUS SEEMS TO HAVE
BEEN A FAN FOR A FEW YEARS BEFORE HE JOINED THE DEATH EATERS. . . .
A LITTLE PLIP OF BLIST RESE FROM THE BEDCOVERS AS SHE SAT DOWN TO

READ THE CLIPPINGS. HARRY, MEANWHILE, HAD NOTICED ANOTHER PHOTO-
GRAPH: A HOGWARTS HOLIDAY TEAM WAS SMILING AND WAVING OUT

OF THE FRAME. HE MOVED CLOSER AND SAW THE SNAKES ENLARGED IN
THEIR CHISTS: SLYTHERINS. REGULUS WAS INSTANTLY RECOGNIZABLE AS THE
THE

BOY SITTING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FRONT ROW: HE HAD THE SAME DARK
HAIR AND SLIGHTLY HAUGHTY LOOK OF HIS BROTHER, THOUGH HE WAS
SMALLER,

SLIGHTER, AND RATHER LESS HANDSOME THAN SIRIUS HAD BEEN.

HE PLAYED SEEKER, SAID HARRY.

CHAPTER TEN

1888

WHAT? SAID HERMIONE VAGUELY; SHE WAS STILL IMMERSED IN VER-
BEMERT & PRESS CLIPPINGS.

HE'S SITTING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FRONT REAR, THAT'S WHERE THE
SENDER... NEVER MIND, SAID HARRY, REALIZING THAT NEHEMUS WAS
LISTENING: REIN WAS IN HIS HANDS AND KNEES, SEARCHING UNDER THE
WARDROBE, HARRY LEANED AROUND THE ROOM FOR LIKELY HIDING PLACES
AND APPROACHED THE DESK. YET AGAIN, NEHEMUS HAD SEARCHED BEFORE
THEM. THE DRAWERS' CONTENTS HAD BEEN TURNED OVER RECENTLY, THE

BLIST DISTURBED, BUT THERE WAS NOTHING OF VALUE THERE: TWO BILLS,
FIFT-

OF DATE TEXTBOOKS THAT WERE EVIDENCE OF BEING RELEGALLY HANDLED, A

RECENTLY SMASHED INDEX RING, ITS STICKY RESIDUE COVERING THE
CONTENTS

OF THE DRAWER.

THERE'S AN EASIER WAY, SAID HERMIONE, AS HARRY WIPED HIS INDEX
FINGERS ON HIS JEANS. SHE RAISED HER WAND AND SAID, ACCIO LOCKET!
NOTHING HAPPENED. REIN, WHO HAD BEEN SEARCHING THE FOLDS OF
THE PAVED CURTAINS, LEANED DISAPPOINTED.

IS THAT IT, THEN? IT'S NOT HERE?

OH, IT COULD STILL BE HERE, BUT UNDER CHLISTER-ENCHANTMENTS,
SAID HERMIONE. CHARM'S TO PREVENT IT BEING SUMMONED MAGICALLY,
SHE KNOWS.

LIKE VERDAMPT PUT IN THE STONE BASIN IN THE CAVE, SAID HARRY,
RE-

MEMBERING HOW HE HAD BEEN UNABLE TO SUMMON THE PAVE LOCKET.

"HOW ARE WE SUPPOSED TO FIND IT THEN?" ASKED RENN.

"WE SEARCH MANUALLY," SAID HERMINE.

"THAT'S A GOOD IDEA," SAID RENN, ROLLING HIS EYES, AND HE RESUMED HIS EXAMINATION OF THE CURTAINS.

THEY CHECKED EVERY INCH OF THE ROOM FOR MORE THAN AN HOUR, BUT WERE FORCED, FINALLY, TO CONCLUDE THAT THE LOCKET WAS NOT THERE.

DEACON'S TALK

187

THE SUN HAD RISEN NOW; ITS LIGHT DAZZLED THEM EVEN THROUGH THE GRIMY LANDING WINDOWS.

"IT COULD BE SOMEWHERE ELSE IN THE HOUSE, THOUGH," SAID HERMINE IN A RALLYING TONE AS THEY WALKED BACK DOWNSTAIRS; AS HARRY

AND RENN HAD BECOME MORE DISCOURAGED, SHE SEEMED TO HAVE BECOME MORE DETERMINED. WHETHER HE'D MANAGED TO DESTROY IT OR NOT, HE'D WANT TO KEEP IT HIDDEN FROM VILDEMEHT, WOULDN'T HE? REMEMBER ALL THESE AWFUL THINGS WE HAD TO GET RID OF WHEN WE WERE HERE LAST TIME? THAT CLOCK THAT SHOT SHOTS AT EVERYONE AND THESE OLD BOOKS THAT TRIED TO STRANGLE RENN; REGILLIS MIGHT HAVE PUT THEM THERE TO

PROTECT THE LOCKET'S HIDING PLACE, EVEN THOUGH WE DIDN'T REALIZE IT AT ... AT ...

HARRY AND RENN LOOKED AT HER. SHE WAS STANDING WITH HER FEET IN

MIDAIR, WITH THE DUMESTRIK LINDS OF HINE WE-H HAD ILST BEEN EXLIVT-
ATED; HER EYES HAD EVEN DRIFTED BLT OF PHCLIS.

... AT THE TIME, SHE FINISHED IN A WHISPER.

SOMETHING WREING? ASKED REIN.

THERE WAS A WHISPER.

WHAT? SAID HARRY AND REIN TOGETHER.

IN THE CABINET IN THE DRAWING ROOM, NOBODY COULD OPEN IT, AND
WE ... WE ...

HARRY FELT AS THOUGH A BRICK HAD SLID DOWN THROUGH HIS CHEST
INTO

HIS STOMACH. HE REMEMBERED: HE HAD EVEN HANDLED THE THING AS
THEY PASSED IT AROUND, EACH TRYING IN TURN TO PRIZE IT OPEN. IT HAD

BEEN THESSED INTO A SACK OF ALKISH, ALONG WITH THE SNLPPERS OF
WART-

LAP PHUNDER AND THE MUSIC BOX THAT HAD MADE EVERYONE SLEEPY, ...

DRACHER NICKED HEADS OF THINGS BACK FROM US, SAID HARRY. IT
WAS THE ONLY CHANCE, THE ONLY SLENDER FINGER LEFT TO THEM, AND HE
WAS

CHAPTER TEN

GIVING THE CLING THE IT UNTIL PERCEIVED THE LET GO. HE HAD A WHOLE STASH
OF

STUFF IN HIS CLOSET IN THE KITCHEN, I MEAN.

HE RAN DOWN THE STAIRS TAKING TWO STEPS AT A TIME, THE EITHER TWO
THUNDERING ALONG IN HIS WAKE. THEY MADE SEE MUCH WORSE THAT THEY
WERE THE PORTRAIT OF SIRIL'S SISTER AS THEY PASSED THROUGH THE
HALL.

FILTHY MURDERERS! SLIM! SHE SCREAMED AFTER THEM AS THEY DASHED
DOWN INTO THE BASEMENT KITCHEN AND SLAMMED THE DOOR BEHIND
THEM.

HARRY RAN THE LENGTH OF THE ROOM, SKIDDED TO A HALT AT THE DOOR
OF DREACHER'S CLOSET, AND WRENCHED IT OPEN. THERE WAS THE NEST
OF DIRTY OLD BLANKETS IN WHICH THE FELLOW-HAD HENCE SLEPT, BUT

THEY WERE NO LONGER GLITTERING WITH THE TRINKETS DREACHER HAD
SAID-

VAGUE. THE ONLY THING THERE WAS AN OLD COPY OF NATURE'S
DEBILITY: A

WIZARDING GENEALOGY. REFUSING TO BELIEVE HIS EYES, HARRY SNATCHED
UP THE BLANKETS AND SEARCHED THEM. A DEAD MURDER FELL FLAT AND ROLLED
DISMALLY ACROSS THE FLOOR. THEN GRIMACED AS HE THREW HIMSELF INTO A
KITCHEN CHAIR. FERMINE CLOSED HER EYES.

IT'S NOT OVER YET, SAID HARRY, AND HE RAISED HIS VOICE AND CALLED,
DREACHER!

THERE WAS A LOUD CRACK AND THE FELLOW-HAD THAT HARRY HAD SEEN RE-

SLIGHTLY INHERITED FROM SIRILIS APPEARED BUT HE NOWHERE IN
PRESENT OF

THE CHILD AND EMPTY FIREPLACE! TINY, HALF ELFGAN-SIZED, HIS PALE SKIN
HANGING OFF HIM IN FLEDS, WHITE HAIR SPARKLING CRUELLY FROM
HIS

BATLIKE EARS, HE WAS STILL WEARING THE FILTHY RAG IN WHICH THEY HAD
FIRST MET HIM, AND THE CONTEMPTFUL LOOK HE SENT LIPEN HARRY
SHOWED THAT HIS ATTITUDE TO HIS CHANGE OF OWNERSHIP HAD ALTERED
NOT

MORE THAN HIS BELTIT.

MASTER, CREATED DREACHER IN HIS KILLING S VEHICLE, AND HE KEENED

DREACHER S TALL

191

WELL, MUTTERING TO HIS KNEES, BACK IN MY MISTRESS S OLD HOUSE WITH
THE BLEED-TRAITER LEASLEY AND THE MURDERER

I SHOULD YELL TO CALL ANYONE BLEED TRAITER OR MURDERER,
GROWLED HARRY, HE WOULD HAVE FELT DREACHER, WITH HIS
SNELTLIKE

NEED AND BLEED-SEE EYES, A DISTINCTLY UNPLEASANT EFFECT EVEN IF THE
ELF HAD NOT BETRAYED SIRILIS TO VILDEMEET.

I VE GOT A BELIEF IN THE YELL, SAID HARRY, HIS HEART BEATING
RATHER

FAST AS HE LEAPED DOWN AT THE ELF, AND I HARDER YELL THE ANSWER IT
TRULY-

FULLY, UNDERSTAND?

YES, MASTER, SAID DRACHER, CHWING WELL AGAIN: HARRY SAW HIS
LIPS MOVING SILENTLY, UNHEEDINGLY FRAMING THE INSULTS HE WAS
NOW PERKIDEN THE LITTER.

TWO YEARS AGO, SAID HARRY, HIS HEART NOW HAMMERING AGAINST
HIS RIBS, THERE WAS A BIG GOLD LOCKET IN THE DRAWING ROOM
UPSTAIRS.

WE THREW IT AWAY. DID YOU STEAL IT BACK?

THERE WAS A MOMENT'S SILENCE, DURING WHICH DRACHER STRAIGHT-
ENED UP THE BACK OF HARRY FULL IN THE FACE. THEN HE SAID, YES.

WHERE IS IT NOW? ASKED HARRY ILLEGITIMATELY AS BEN AND FERMINE
LEAPED GLEEFUL.

DRACHER CLOSED HIS EYES AS THOUGH HE COULD NOT BEAR TO SEE THEIR
REACTIONS TO HIS NEXT WORD.

CHUNK.

CHUNK? EXCLAIMED HARRY, PLATINUM BLEEDING AWAY FROM HIM. WHAT DID
YOU MEAN, IT'S CHUNK?

THE ELF SHIVERED. HE SWAYED.

DRACHER, SAID HARRY FIERCELY, I HARDER YELL

MURDERING FLETCHER, CREATED THE ELF, HIS EYES STILL TIGHT SHUT.

MURDERING FLETCHER STEAL IT ALL: MISS BELLA'S AND MISS LISSY'S

CHAPTER TEN

192

PICTURES, MY MISTRESS'S GLOVES, THE HORN OF MERLIN, FIRST CLASS,
THE

COATS WITH THE FAMILY CREST, AND AND

DRACONER WAS CLIPPING HER AIR: HIS HEAVEN CHEST WAS RISING AND

FALLING RAPIDLY, THEN HIS EYES FLEW OPEN AND HE UTTERED A BLENDING-
BLIND STREAM.

AND THE HEART, MASTER REGILLIS'S HEART, DRACONER DID WRING,
DRACONER FAILED IN HIS HANDS?

HARRY REACTED INSTINCTIVELY: AS DRACONER LINGERED FOR THE POKER

STANDING IN THE GRATE, HE LAUNCHED HIMSELF UPON THE ELF, FLATTEN-
ING HIM. HERMIONE'S SCREAM MINGLED WITH DRACONER'S, BUT HARRY

REMEMBERED BOLDER THAN BOTH OF THEM: DRACONER, I ORDER YOU TO STAY
STILL?

HE FELT THE ELF FREEZE AND RELEASED HIM. DRACONER LAY FLAT ON THE
FLOOR STUNNED FLAT, TEARS GLISTENING FROM HIS SAGGING EYES.

HARRY, LET HIM UP? HERMIONE WHISPERED.

SEE HE CAN BEAT HIMSELF UP WITH THE POKER? SNEERED HARRY,
KNEEL-

ING BESIDE THE ELF, I DERN T THINK SHE RIGHT, DREACHER, I WANT THE

TRUTH: FHEW DEE YELL DNEEL MINDLINGIS FLETCHER STEAL THE LOCKET?

DREACHER SAW HIM? GASPED THE ELF AS TEARS FLOWED OVER HIS
SMILE

AND IN THE HIS MOUTH FULL OF GRAYING TEETH, DREACHER SAW HIM CHIN-
ING HIMSELF DREACHER'S CLIPBOARD WITH HIS HANDS FULL OF DREACHER'S

TREASURES, DREACHER THOUGHT THE SNEAK THIEF THE STEEP, BUT MINDLINGIS
FLETCHER LAUGHED AND R-RAN. . .

YELL CALLED THE LOCKET MASTER REGILLIS S, SAID HARRY, WHY?

WHERE DID IT COME FROM? WHAT DID REGILLIS HAVE THE DEE WITH IT?

DREACHER, SIT UP AND TELL ME EVERYTHING YELL DNEEL ABOUT THAT
LOCKET,

AND EVERYTHING REGILLIS HAD THE DEE WITH IT?

THE ELF SAT UP, CRAWLED INTO A BALL, PLACED HIS WET FACE BETWEEN
HIS KNEES, AND BEGAN THE RHEE BACKWARD AND FORWARD, WHEN HE

DREACHER'S TALK

193

SPEAKER, HIS VOICE WAS MUFFLED BUT WHITE DISTINCT IN THE SILENT, ECH-
ING KITCHEN,

MASTER SIRILIS RAN AWAY, CHEED RIDDANCE, FOR HE WAS A BAD KID AND

BROKE MY MISTRESS'S HEART WITH HIS LAZINESS DAYS, BUT MASTER
REGILL-

LLIS HAD PROPER PRIDE; HE KNEW WHAT WAS DUE TO THE NAME OF BLACK

AND THE DIGNITY OF HIS PURE BLEED, FEW YEARS HE TALKED OF THE DARK
LORD, WHO WAS GOING TO BRING THE WIZARDS OUT OF HIDING THE LIKE
THE

MUGGLES AND THE MUGGLE-BORN . . . AND WHEN HE WAS SIXTEEN YEARS
OLD, MASTER REGILLIS THOUGHT THE DARK LORD, SHE PRELUD, SHE PRELUD, SHE
HAPPY TO SERVE . . .

AND ONE DAY, A YEAR AFTER HE HAD THOUGHT, MASTER REGILLIS CAME
DOWN THE KITCHEN TO SEE DREACHER. MASTER REGILLIS ALWAYS LIKED
DREACHER, AND MASTER REGILLIS SAID . . . HE SAID . . .

THE OLD ELF RECKED FASTER THAN EVER.

. . . HE SAID THAT THE DARK LORD REQUIRED AN ELF.

YELDMERT NEEDED AN ELF? HARRY REPEATED, LEANING AROUND AT
RON AND HERMION, WHO LOOKED JUST AS PLAZZED AS HE DID.

HE YES, MHAED DREACHER, AND MASTER REGILLIS HAD VOLUN-
TEERED DREACHER. IT WAS AN FINDER, SAID MASTER REGILLIS, AN FINDER
HER

HIM AND HER DREACHER, WHO MUST BE SURE TO DO WHATEVER THE DARK
LORD ORDERED HIM TO DO . . . AND THEN TO COME HOME.

DREACHER RECKED STILL FASTER, HIS BREATH COMING IN SIPS.

SHE DREACHER WENT TO THE DARK LORD, THE DARK LORD DID NOT TELL
DREACHER WHAT THEY WERE TO DO, BUT THREW DREACHER WITH HIM TO A

CAVE BESIDE THE SEA, AND BEYOND THE CAVE THERE WAS A CAVERN, AND IN THE CAVERN WAS A GREAT BLACK LAKE . . .

THE HAIRS ON THE BACK OF FARRY'S NECK STOOD UP, BREAKER'S CRIES-

ING WHICH SEEMED TO COME TO HIM FROM ACROSS THAT DARK WATER, HE

SAW WHAT HAD HAPPENED AS CLEARLY AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN PRESENT.

CHAPTER TEN

179

. . . THERE WAS A KEAT . . .

IF ONLY THERE HAD BEEN A KEAT; FARRY KNEW THE KEAT, CHESTLY GREEN AND TINY, FLITCHED SEE AS THE CARRY HINE LIZARD AND HINE VICTIM TOWARD THE ISLAND IN THE CENTER. THIS, THEN, WAS FINE YHDEMENT HAD TESTED THE DEFENSES SURROUNDING THE FHERCULX; BY KHRRELING A DISPENSABLE CREATURE, A FHELE-ELF . . .

THERE WAS A E-BASIN FULL OF PETITION ON THE ISLAND. THE D-DARK LORD MADE BREAKER DRINK IT. . . .

THE ELF ENLARGED FROM HEAD TO FEET.

BREAKER DRANK, AND AS HE DRANK, HE SAW TERRIBLE THINGS. . . .

BREAKER'S INSIDES BURNED. . . . BREAKER CRIED FOR MASTER REGILLIS TO SAVE HIM, HE CRIED FOR HIS MISTRESS BLACK, BUT THE DARK LORD ONLY

LAUGHED. . . . HE MADE BREAKER DRINK ALL THE PETITION. . . . HE DROPPED A LICKET INTO THE EMPTY BASIN. . . . HE FILLED IT WITH MORE PETITION.

AND THEN THE DARK LORD SAILED AWAY, LEAVING KREACHER IN THE ISLAND, . . .

HARRY COULD SEE IT HAPPENING, HE WATCHED VERMOREL'S WHITE,

SNAKE-LIKE FACE VANISHING INTO DARKNESS, THESE RED EYES FIXED PITILESSLY ON THE THRASHING ELF WHOSE DEATH WOULD OCCUR WITHIN MINUTES,

WHENEVER HE SLICKERED THE DESPERATE THIRST THAT THE BURNING PHE-

THEN CALLED ITS VICTIM, . . . BUT HERE, HARRY'S IMAGINATION COULD GO

NO FURTHER, FOR HE COULD NOT SEE HOW KREACHER HAD ESCAPED,

KREACHER NEEDED WATER, HE CRAWLED TO THE ISLAND'S EDGE AND HE DROVE FROM THE BLACK LAKE . . . AND HANDS, DEAD HANDS, CAME OUT OF THE WATER AND DRAGGED KREACHER UNDER THE SURFACE, . . .

HOW DID PHIL GET AWAY? HARRY ASKED, AND HE WAS NOT SURPRISED TO HEAR HIMSELF WHISPERING,

KREACHER RAISED HIS UGLY HEAD AND LOOKED AT HARRY WITH HIS GREAT, BLOODSHOT EYES,

KREACHER'S TAIL

125

MASTER REGULUS TOLD KREACHER THE SAME RACE, HE SAID,

I KNOW BUT HOW DID PHIL ESCAPE THE INFERI?

DREACHER DID NOT SEEM TO UNDERSTAND.

MASTER REGILLIS TOLD DREACHER THE SAME BACK. HE REPEATED,

I KNOW, BUT

WELL, IT'S HEAVENLY, ISN'T IT, HARRY? SAID RHN. HE DISAP-
PEARED.

BUT . . . WHEN CHILDREN APPARATE IN AND OUT OF THAT CAVE, SAID
HARRY, OTHERWISE DUMBLEDORE

THE MAGIC ISN'T LIKE WIZARD'S MAGIC, IS IT? SAID RHN. I MEAN,
THEY CAN APPARATE AND DISAPPARATE IN AND OUT OF HOGWARTS WHEN
WE CAN'T.

THERE WAS SILENCE AS HARRY DIGESTED THIS. WHEN COULD VERMOREL
HAVE MADE SUCH A MISTAKE? BUT EVEN AS HE THOUGHT THIS, HERMIONE
SPROKE, AND HER VOICE WAS IT.

HE CHOICE, VERMOREL WOULD HAVE CONSIDERED THE WAYS OF HOGWARTS-
ELVES FAR BEYOND HIS NOTICE, JUST LIKE ALL THE POLYMERASES WE
TREAT

THEM LIKE ANIMALS. . . . IT WOULD NEVER HAVE OCCURRED TO HIM THAT
THEY MIGHT HAVE MAGIC THAT HE DIDN'T.

THE HOGWARTS'S HIGHEST LAW IS HIS MASTER'S KIDDING, INTENDED
DREACHER. DREACHER WAS TOLD THE SAME BEFORE, SEE DREACHER CAME
HERE. . . .

WELL, THEN, WHEN DID WHAT WHEN WERE TOLD, DIDN'T WHEN? SAID HER-

PLEASE KINDLY, YOU DIDN'T DISOBEY ORDERS AT ALL!

DRACHER SHOOK HIS HEAD, RECKING AS FAST AS EVER.

SEE WHAT HAPPENED WHEN YOU GET BACK? HARRY ASKED, WHAT DID REGILLIS SAY WHEN YOU TOLD HIM WHAT HAD HAPPENED?

MASTER REGILLIS WAS VERY WORRIED, VERY WORRIED, CRIED DRACHER. MASTER REGILLIS TOLD DRACHER TO STAY HIDDEN AND MEET THE

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LEAVE THE FEELING, AND THEN . . . IT WAS A LITTLE WHILE LATER . . . MASTER

REGILLIS CAME TO FIND DRACHER IN HIS CLIPBOARD ONE NIGHT, AND MAS-

TER REGILLIS WAS STRANGE, NOT AS HE USUALLY WAS, DISTURBED IN HIS MIND,

DRACHER COULD TELL . . . AND HE ASKED DRACHER TO TAKE HIM TO THE CAVE, THE CAVE WHERE DRACHER HAD GONE WITH THE DARK LORD, . . . AND SEE THEY HAD SET OFF, HARRY COULD VISUALIZE THEM WHITE CLEARLY,

THE FRIGHTENED OLD ELF AND THE THIN, DARK SEEKER WHO HAD SEEN RESEMBLED SIRILIS, . . . DRACHER KNEW HE HAD TO OPEN THE CONCEALED ENTRANCE

TO THE LINDERGHEIM CAVES, KNEW HE HAD TO RAISE THE TINY BEAT; THIS

TIME IT WAS HIS RELIEVED REGILLIS WHO SAILED WITH HIM TO THE ISLAND
WITH ITS BASIN OF POISON, . . .

AND HE MADE YELI DRINK THE POISON? SAID FARRY, DISGUSTED.
BUT DREACHER SHOOK HIS HEAD AND WEPT. FERMINE'S HANDS LEAPT
TO HER MOUTH: SHE SEEMED TO HAVE UNDERSTOOD SOMETHING.

M-MASTER REGILLIS TOOK FROM HIS POCKET A LOCKET LIKE THE ONE
THE DARK LORD HAD, SAID DREACHER, TEARS FLOWING DOWN EITHER SIDE
OF HIS SNOUTLIKE NOSE. AND HE TOLD DREACHER TO TAKE IT AND, WHEN
THE BASIN WAS EMPTY, TO SWITCH THE LOCKETS, . . .

DREACHER'S SHES CAME IN GREAT RASPS NOW; FARRY HAD THE CONVIN-
CENTE HARD TO UNDERSTAND HIM.

AND HE ORDERED DREACHER TO LEAVE WITHOUT HIM, AND
HE TOLD DREACHER TO GO HOME AND NEVER TO TELL MY MISTRESS
WHAT HE HAD DONE BUT THE DESTINY OF THE FIRST LOCKET, AND HE
DROPPED ALL THE POISON AND DREACHER SWAPPED THE LOCKETS
AND WATCHED . . . AS MASTER REGILLIS . . . WAS DRAGGED BENEATH THE
WATER . . . AND . . .

HEY, DREACHER! Wailed FERMINE, WHO WAS CRYING. SHE DROPPED
TO HER KNEES BESIDE THE ELF AND TRIED TO HUG HIM. AT ONCE HE WAS ON
HIS FEET, CRINGING AWAY FROM HER, WHITE HEAVILY REPLIED.

DREACHER'S TAIL

THE MUDKNEED THICKER DREAFTER, HE WILL NOT ALLOW IT, WHAT
WOULD HIS MISTRESS SAY?

I TOLD YOU NOT TO CALL HER MUDKNEED! SNARLED HARRY, BUT THE
ELF WAS ALREADY PLUNISHING HIMSELF; HE FELT THE THE GRUELING AND
RANGED

HIS THREE-HEAD IN THE FLICKER.

STEP HIM STEP HIM! HERMIONE CRIED, WHY DON'T YOU SEE
HOW HOW SICK IT IS, THE WAY THEY VE GET THE HKEY?

DREAFTER STEP, STEP! SCHELTED HARRY.

THE ELF LAY IN THE FLICKER, PANTING AND SHIVERING, GREEN MUCKS
GLIS-

TENING AROUND HIS SNELT, A BRUISE ALREADY BLEEDING IN HIS PALLID

THREE-HEAD WHERE HE HAD STRUCK HIMSELF, HIS EYES SWELLEN AND BLEED-
SHOT AND SWIMMING IN TEARS, HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING SO

PITIFUL.

SEE YOU BRILLIANT THE WICKET HOME, HE SAID RELENTLESSLY, FOR HE WAS
DETERMINED TO KNOW THE FULL STORY. AND YOU TRIED TO DESTROY IT?

NOTHING DREAFTER DID MADE ANY MARK UPON IT, MEANED THE
ELF. DREAFTER TRIED EVERYTHING, EVERYTHING HE KNEW, BUT NOTHING,
NOTHING WOULD WORK. . . . SEE MANY POWERFUL SPELLS UPON THE
CASINE,

DREAFTER WAS SURE THE WAY TO DESTROY IT WAS TO GET INSIDE IT, BUT IT
WOULD NOT OPEN. . . . DREAFTER PLUNISHED HIMSELF, HE TRIED AGAIN, HE
PLUNISHED HIMSELF, HE TRIED AGAIN. DREAFTER FAILED THE HKEY HORDERS,
DREAFTER COULD NOT DESTROY THE WICKET! AND HIS MISTRESS WAS MAD

WITH GRIEF, BECAUSE MASTER REGILLIS HAD DISAPPEARED, AND DREACHER
COULD NOT TELL HER WHAT HAD HAPPENED, NEH, BECAUSE MASTER REGILLIS
HAD P-P-PERMITTED HIM TO TELL ANY OF THE P-P-FAMILY WHAT HAD HAPPENED
IN THE C-CAVE. . . .

DREACHER BEGAN TO SEE SHE HAD THAT THERE WERE NEH MORE CHER-
ENT WORDS. TEARS FLEW DOWN HERMIONE'S CHEEKS AS SHE WATCHED

DREACHER, BUT SHE DID NOT DARE TOUCH HIM AGAIN. EVEN THEN, WHEN
WAS

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NEH CAN HE DREACHER'S, WHINED THUNDERED. HARRY SAT BACK ON HIS HEELS
AND STOOD HIS HEAD, TRYING TO CLEAR IT.

I DON'T UNDERSTAND WHY, DREACHER, HE SAID FINALLY. VOLDMORT
TRIED TO KILL WHY, REGILLIS DIED TO BRING VOLDMORT DOWN, BUT WHY
WERE STILL HAPPY TO BETRAY SIRIUS TO VOLDMORT? WHY WERE HAPPY
TO

SEE THE NARCISSE AND BELATRIX, AND PASS INFORMATION TO VOLDMORT
THROUGH THEM. . . .

HARRY, DREACHER DOESN'T THINK LIKE THAT, SAID HERMIONE, WIP-
ING HER EYES ON THE BACK OF HER HAND. HE'S A SLAVE; HIS EYES
ARE

USED THE BAD, EVEN BRUTAL TREATMENT; WHAT VERDEMERT DID THE
DREACHER

WASN'T THAT FAR FROM THE COMMON WAY, WHAT THE WIZARD WARS
MEAN

THE AN ELF LIKE DREACHER? HE'S A MAN THE PEOPLE WHO ARE KIND TO HIM,
AND MRS. BLACK MUST HAVE BEEN, AND REGILLIS CERTAINLY WAS, SHE HE
SERVED THEM WILLINGLY AND PROMPTED THEIR RELIEFS, I KNOW WHAT
SHE IS

WHEN THE SAY, SHE WENT ON AS HARRY BEGAN THE PROTEST, THAT
REGILLIS

CHANGED HIS MIND . . . BUT HE DOESN'T SEEM TO HAVE EXPLAINED THAT THE
DREACHER, DOES HE? AND I THINK I KNOW WHY, DREACHER AND
REGILLIS'S

FAMILY WERE ALL SAFE IF THEY KEPT THE THE OLD FINE-OLD LINE,
REGILLIS

WAS TRYING TO PROTECT THEM ALL,

SIRILIS

SIRILIS WAS TERRIBLE THE DREACHER, HARRY, AND IT'S NOT GOOD
LOOKING

LIKE THAT, SHE KNOWS IT'S TRUE, DREACHER HAD BEEN ALONE FOR A LONG
TIME

WHEN SIRILIS CAME TO LIVE HERE, AND HE WAS PROBABLY STARVING FOR A
BIT OF AFFECTION, I'M SURE MISS LISSY AND MISS BELLA WERE
PERFECTLY

HEAVELY THE DREACHER WHEN HE TURNED UP, SHE HE DID THEM A FAVOR AND
TOLD THEM EVERYTHING THEY WANTED TO KNOW, I'VE SAID ALL ALONG
THAT

WIZARDS WOULD PAY FOR THEM THEY TREAT HOUSE-ELVES, WELL,
VERDEMERT

DID . . . AND SHE DID SIRILIS.

FARRY HAD NO RETORT, AS HE WATCHED DREACHER SHAKING HIS THE

DREACHER S TALL

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ALREADY, HE REMEMBERED WHAT DUMKLEBERG HAD SAID TO HIM, MORE FEELINGS
AFTER SIRILIS S DEATH: I DO NOT THINK SIRILIS EVER SAW DREACHER AS A
BEING

WITH FEELINGS AS ACUTE AS A HUMAN S. . .

DREACHER, SAID FARRY AFTER A WHILE, WHEN YOU FEEL LIKE IT, ER
. . . PLEASE SIT UP.

IT WAS SEVERAL MINUTES BEFORE DREACHER HICCUPED HIMSELF INTO SI-
LENCE. THEN HE PUSHED HIMSELF INTO A SITTING POSITION AGAIN,
ALIKING

HIS KNUCKLES INTO HIS EYES LIKE A SMALL CHILD.

DREACHER, I AM GOING TO ASK YOU TO DO SOMETHING, SAID FARRY.
HE GLANCED AT DERMINE FOR ASSISTANCE. HE WANTED TO GIVE THE
ORDER

KINDLY, BUT AT THE SAME TIME, HE COULD NOT PRETEND THAT IT WAS NOT
AN ORDER. HOWEVER, THE CHANGE IN HIS TONE SEEMED TO HAVE GAINED
HER APPROVAL: SHE SMILED ENCOURAGINGLY.

DREACHER, I WANT YOU, PLEASE, TO GO AND FIND MINDLING S FLETCHER.
WE NEED TO FIND OUT WHERE THE LOCKET WHERE MASTER REGILLIS S
LOCKET IS. IT S REALLY IMPORTANT. WE WANT TO FINISH THE WORK
MASTER

REGULUS STARTED, WE WANT THE ER ENSURE THAT HE DIDN'T DIE IN VAIN.

DRACHER DROPPED HIS FISTS AND LEANED UP AT HARRY.

FIND MURDERING FLETCHER? HE CRIED.

AND BRING HIM HERE, THE CRIMINALS PLACE, SAID HARRY. DID YOU THINK YOU COULD BE THAT FUR LUS?

AS DRACHER NEEDED AND GUT THE HIS FEET, HARRY HAD A SUDDEN INSPIRATION, HE PULLED OUT HAGRID'S PURSE AND TOOK OUT THE FAKE FURCULON, THE SUBSTITUTE LEOPARD IN WHICH REGULUS HAD PLACED THE NOTE

THE VERDICT.

DRACHER, I'D, ER, LIKE YOU TO HAVE THIS, HE SAID, PRESSING THE LEOPARD INTO THE ELF'S HAND. THIS BELONGED TO REGULUS AND I'M SURE HE'D WANT YOU TO HAVE IT AS A TOKEN OF GRATITUDE FOR WHAT YOU

CHAPTER TEN

EVERKILL, MATE, SAID REIN AS THE ELF TOOK HIM LEANED AT THE LEOPARD, LET HIM FEEL OF SORROW AND MISERY, AND THREW HIMSELF BACK INTO THE GRILL.

IT TOOK THEM NEARLY HALF AN HOUR TO CALM DOWN DRACHER, WHO WAS SO OVERCOME HE WAS PRESENTED WITH A BLACK FAMILY MEMORIAL FOR HIS VERY OWN THAT HE WAS THE LEAD AT THE DUNES THE STAND PROPERLY.

WHEN FINALLY HE WAS ABLE TO TETHER A FEW STEPS THEY ALL
ACCOMPANIED

HIM TO HIS CLIPBOARD, WATCHED HIM TUCK UP THE SHEET SLEELY IN HIS

DIRTY BLANKETS, AND ASSURED HIM THAT THEY WOULD MAKE ITS PROTECT-
TION THEIR FIRST PRIORITY WHILE HE WAS AWAY, HE THEN MADE TWO MORE

HEELS TO HARRY AND REEN, AND EVEN GAVE A FLINDY LITTLE SPASM IN
HER-

MINUTE'S DIRECTION THAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN AN ATTEMPT AT A RESPECTFUL

SALUTE, BEFORE DISAPPEARING WITH THE USUAL MILD CRACK.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE

THE STRIKE

IF DRACONER COULD ESCAPE A LAKE FULL OF INVERI, HARRY WAS CONFIDENT
THAT THE CAPTURE OF MINDLINGUS WOULD TAKE A FEW HOURS AT MOST,
AND HE PRELIMED THE FLEET ALL MORNING IN A STATE OF HIGH
ANTICIPATION.

HOWEVER, DRACONER DID NOT RETURN THAT MORNING OR EVEN THAT
AFTER-

NEEN, BY NIGHTFALL, HARRY FELT DISCOURAGED AND ANXIOUS, AND A
SLIPPER

COMPOSED LARGELY OF MILDLY KNEAD, LIPHEN WHICH FERMINE HAD TRIED A VARIETY OF UNSUCCESSFUL TRANSFIGURATIONS, DID NOTHING THE FIELD, BREAHER DID NOT RETURN THE FOLLOWING DAY, NOR THE DAY AFTER THAT.

HOWEVER, TWO CHARGED MEN HAD APPEARED IN THE SHLARE HILLSIDE NLM-

BER TWELVE, AND THEY REMAINED THERE INTO THE NIGHT, GAZING IN THE

DIRECTION OF THE FIELDS THAT THEY COULD NOT SEE.

DEATH EATERS, FOR SLIRE, SAID BEN, AS HE, HARRY, AND FERMINE WATCHED FROM THE DRAWING ROOM WINDOWS. RECOGN THEY KNOW WE ARE IN HERE?

I DON'T THINK SO, SAID FERMINE, THOUGH SHE LOOKED FRIGHTENED, FOR THEY D HAVE SENT SNAPE IN AFTER US, WOULDNT THEY?
I

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D WHY RECOGN HE S BEEN IN HERE AND HAD HIS THINGIE TIED BY MENDY S CLARE? ASKED BEN.

YES, SAID FERMINE, OTHERWISE HE D HAVE BEEN ABLE TO TELL THAT LEFT THEM TO GET IN, WOULDNT HE? BUT THEY ARE PROBABLY WATCHING THE SEE

WHETHER WE TURN UP, THEY KNOW THAT HARRY HELDS THE FIELDS, AFTER

ALL,

WELL DID THEY ? REGAN HARRY,

WIZARDING WILLS ARE EXAMINED BY THE MINISTRY, REMEMBER?

THEY LL KNOW SIRILS LEFT WELL THE PLACE.

THE PRESENCE OF THE DEATH EATERS ELTISIDE INCREASED THE EMINENCE

MENTH INSIDE NIMMER TWELVE. THEY HAD NOT HEARD A WORD FROM ANY-
ONE BEYOND CRIMINALS PLACE SINCE MR. WEASLEY S PATRONUS, AND
THE

STRAIN WAS STARTING TO TELL. RESTLESS AND IRRITABLE, REGAN HAD
DEVELOPED

AN ANNOYING HABIT OF PLAYING WITH THE DEDIMINATOR IN HIS
POCKET;

THIS PARTICULARLY IRRITATED HERMIONE, WHO WAS WAITING AWAY
THE

WAIT FOR DREACHER BY STUDYING THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE BARD AND DID
NOT APPRECIATE THE WAY THE LIGHTS KEPT FLASHING ON AND OFF.

WILL YOU STOP IT? SHE CRIED ON THE THIRD EVENING OF DREACHER S
ABSENCE, AS ALL LIGHT WAS SLICKED FROM THE DRAWING ROOM YET AGAIN.

SHRRY, SHRRY? SAID REGAN, CLICKING THE DEDIMINATOR AND RESTORING
THE LIGHTS. I DIDN T KNOW I M DOING IT?

WELL, CAN T YOU FIND SOMETHING USEFUL TO OCCUPY YOURSELF?

WHAT, LIKE READING KIDS STORIES?

ANYWHERE LEFT ME THIS ROOM, REGAN

AND HE LEFT ME THE DEDIMINATOR, MAYBE I M SUPPOSED TO
USE IT?

UNABLE TO STAND THE KIDDERING, HARRY SLIPPED OUT OF THE ROOM
UNNOTICED BY EITHER OF THEM. HE HEADED DOWNSTAIRS TOWARD THE

KITCHEN, WHICH HE KEPT VISITING BECAUSE HE WAS SURE THAT WAS
WHERE

THE STRIKE

THE

DEATHEN WAS MOST LIKELY TO REAPPEAR. HALFWAY DOWN THE FLIGHT OF
STAIRS INTO THE HALL, HOWEVER, HE HEARD A TAP ON THE FRONT DOOR,
THEN

METALLIC CLIKES AND THE GRINDING OF THE CHAIN.

EVERY NERVE IN HIS BODY SEEMED TO TALTEN: HE PULLED OUT HIS
WAND, MOVED INTO THE SHADOWS BESIDE THE DECAPITATED ELF HEADS, AND
WAITED. THE DOOR OPENED: HE SAW A GLIMPSE OF THE LAMPLIT SHELARE
HILLSIDE, AND A CLOAKED FIGURE EDGED INTO THE HALL AND CLOSED THE
DOOR BEHIND IT. THE INTRUDER TOOK A STEP FORWARD, AND MERRY'S
VOICE

ASKED, SEVERAL SNAPS? THEN THE DUST FIGURE ROSE FROM THE END
OF

THE HALL AND GLARED HIM, RAISING ITS DEAD HAND,

IT WAS NOT I WHO KILLED YOU, ARIUS, SAID A HELIX VEHICLE.

THE DARK KNEE: THE DUST-FIGURE EXPLODED AGAIN, AND IT WAS IM-
POSSIBLE TO MAKE OUT THE NEWCOMER THROUGH THE DENSE GRAY CLOUD

IT LEFT BEHIND,

HARRY POINTED HIS WAND INTO THE MIDDLE OF IT,

DON'T MOVE!

HE HAD FORGOTTEN THE PORTRAIT OF MRS. BLACK! AT THE SOUND OF HIS
YELL, THE CURTAINS HIDING HER FLEW OPEN AND SHE BEGAN THE SCREAM,

MURDERED AND FILTH DISFATHERING MY FEELING

REHN AND HERMIONE CAME CRASHING DOWN THE STAIRS BEHIND HARRY,
HANDS POINTING, LIKE HIS, AT THE LONELY MAN NOW STANDING WITH
HIS ARMS RAISED IN THE HALL BEHIND.

HELD YOUR FIRE, IT'S ME, REMUS!

HE, THANK GOODNESS, SAID HERMIONE WEABLY, POINTING HER HAND
AT MRS. BLACK INSTEAD! WITH A BANG, THE CURTAINS SWISHED SHUT
AGAIN

AND SILENCE FELL. REHN THEN LOWERED HIS HAND, BUT HARRY DID NOT.

STILL YOURSELF? HE CALLED BACK.

LUPIN MOVED FORWARD INTO THE LAMPLIGHT, HANDS STILL HELD HIGH
IN A GESTURE OF SURRENDER.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

I AM REMUS JOHN LUPIN, WEREWOLF, SOMETIMES KNOWN AS MOONY,

ONE OF THE FEWER CREATORS OF THE MARAUDER'S MAP, MARRIED THE
DUMFRIES-

DIRT, USUALLY KNOWN AS TONKS, AND I TAUGHT YOU FEEL THE PRODIGE
A

PATRICKS, HARRY, WHICH TAKES THE FORM OF A STAG,

HE, ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY, LOWERING HIS HAND, BUT I HAD THE

CHIEF, DIDN'T I?

SPREADING AS YELLER EX-DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER, I
ELITE AGREE THAT YELL HAD THE CHIEF, REEN, FERMINE, YELL S-HILLON T
BE ELITE SEE ELITE THE LELER YELLER DEFENSES.

THEY RAN DOWN THE STAIRS TOWARD HIM, WRAPPED IN A THICK BLACK
TRAVELING CLOAK, HE LOOKED EXHAUSTED, BUT PLEASED TO SEE THEM.

THE SIGN OF SEVERUS, THEN? HE ASKED.

THE, SAID HARRY, WHAT'S GOING ON? IS EVERYONE DEAD?

YES, SAID LUPIN, BUT WE'RE ALL BEING WATCHED. THERE ARE A COUPLE
OF DEATH EATERS IN THE SELLAR ELITIDE

WE KNOW

I HAD THE APPARATE VERY PRECISELY BENTH THE TOP STEP ELITIDE THE
FRONT DOOR THE BE SURE THAT THEY WOULD NOT SEE ME. THEY CAN'T
KNOW

YELL ARE IN HERE AND I'M SURE THEY'D HAVE MORE PEOPLE ELIT THERE;
THEY'RE

STAYING ELIT EVERYWHERE THAT'S GET ANY CONNECTION WITH YELL,
HARRY,

LET'S GO DOWNSTAIRS, THERE'S A LOT TO TELL YELL, AND I WANT TO KNOW
WHAT HAPPENED AFTER YELL LEFT THE BLURRY.

THEY DESCENDED INTO THE KITCHEN, WHERE FERMINE POINTED HER
HAND AT THE GRATE. A FIRE SPRANG UP INSTANTLY! IT GAVE THE
ILLUSION OF

HEATNESS TO THE STARK STONE WALLS AND GLISTENED OFF THE LONG
WOODEN

TABLE. LUPIN PULLED A FEW BUTTERKNIVES FROM BENEATH HIS TRAVELING
CLOAK AND THEY SAT DOWN.

I'D HAVE BEEN HERE THREE DAYS AGO BUT I NEEDED THE SHADE OFF THE

THE BIRK

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DEATH EATER TAILING ME, SAID LUPIN. SHE, YELL CAME STRAIGHT HERE AFTER THE WEDDING?

NO, SAID HARRY, ONLY AFTER WE RAN INTO A COUPLE OF DEATH EATERS

IN A CAR ON TOTTENHAM COURT ROAD.

LUPIN SNEEZED MOST OF HIS CLITTERER DOWN HIS FRONT.

WHAT?

THEY EXPLAINED WHAT HAD HAPPENED; WHEN THEY HAD FINISHED, LUPIN LEANED AGAINST.

BUT HOW DID THEY FIND SHE ENJOYED? IT'S IMPOSSIBLE THE TRACK ANYONE WITH APPARATES, UNLESS SHE GRAB HOLD OF THEM AS THEY DISAPPEAR?

AND IT DOESN'T SEEM LIKELY THEY WERE JUST STROLLING DOWN TOTTENHAM COURT ROAD AT THE TIME, DOES IT? SAID HARRY.

WE WONDERED, SAID HERMIONE TENTATIVELY, WHETHER HARRY COULD STILL HAVE THE TRACK IN HIM?

IMPOSSIBLE, SAID LUPIN, THEN LEANED SMILE, AND HARRY FELT HIGHLY RELIEVED. APART FROM ANYTHING ELSE, THEY'D KNOWN HER SINCE HARRY WAS

HERE IF HE STILL HAD THE TRACK IN HIM, WOULDN'T THEY? BUT I CAN'T SEE

HOW THEY COULD HAVE TRACKED THEM THE THIRTIEN-THIRTY ROAD,
THAT IS

WHIRRYING, REALLY WHIRRYING.

HE LOOKED DISTURBED, BUT AS FAR AS HARRY WAS CONCERNED, THAT
ELDESTHIE COULD WAIT.

TELL US WHAT HAPPENED AFTER HE LEFT, WE HAVEN'T HEARD A THING
SINCE THEN. IS DAD TELL US THE FAMILY WERE SAFE.

WELL, KINGSLY SAVED US, SAID LUPIN. THANKS TO HIS WARNING
MIST

IF THE WEDDING GUESTS WERE ABLE TO DISAPPEAR BEFORE THEY
ARRIVED.

WERE THEY DEATH EATERS OR MINISTRY PEOPLE? INTERJECTED
HERMIONIE.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

~~THE~~

A MIXTURE, BUT THE ALL INTENTS AND PURPOSES THEY ARE THE SAME
THING

NEH, SAID LUPIN. THERE WERE ABOUT A DOZEN OF THEM, BUT THEY
DIDN'T

KNOW THEM WERE THERE, HARRY. ARTHEUR HEARD A RUMOR THAT THEY
TRIED

THE THIRTLIE THEM UNREARABLES BUT OF STRINGERER BEFORE THEY
KILLED

HIM, IF IT IS TRUE, HE DIDN'T GIVE THEM AWAY.

HARRY LOOKED AT RON AND HERMIONIE, THEIR EXPRESSIONS REFLECTED

THE MINGLED SORROW AND GRATITUDE HE FELT, HE HAD NEVER LIKED SCIMP-
GHELMER MUCH, BUT IF WHAT LUPIN SAID WAS TRUE, THE MAN'S FINAL ACT
HAD BEEN TO TRY TO PROTECT HARRY.

THE DEATH EATERS SEARCHED THE CLOSET FROM THE OTHER SIDE, LUPIN
WENT IN. THEY FOUND THE GHELMER, BUT DIDN'T WANT TO GET THEM
CLOSE

AND THEN THEY INTERROGATED THESE OF US WHO REMAINED FOR
HOURS.

THEY WERE TRYING TO GET INFORMATION FROM THEM, HARRY, BUT OF
COURSE

NOBODY APART FROM THE ORDER KNEW THAT THEY HAD BEEN THERE.

AT THE SAME TIME THAT THEY WERE SMASHING UP THE WEDDING, MORE
DEATH EATERS WERE MAKING THEIR WAY INTO EVERY ORDER-CONNECTED
HOUSE IN THE COUNTRY. THE DEATHS, HE ADDED QUICKLY, ARRESTING
THE MURDERER, BUT THEY WERE RIGHT. THEY KNEW EVERY DETAIL OF
DICKLE'S HOUSE, BUT AS THEY KNEW HE WASN'T THERE, AND THEY USED THE
CRUCIAL CLUE IN THE HOUSE'S FAMILY, AGAIN, TRYING TO FIND OUT
WHERE

THEY WENT AFTER THEM VISITED THEM. THEY'RE ALL RIGHT SHAKEN,
HEAVY-

HEAVY, BUT OTHERWISE OKAY.

THE DEATH EATERS GOT THROUGH ALL THESE PROTECTIVE CHARMES?
HARRY ASKED, REMEMBERING HOW EFFECTIVE THESE HAD BEEN IN THE

NIGHT HE HAD CRASHED IN THENDS S PARENTS GARDEN.

WHAT THEY VE GET THE REALIZE, HARRY, IS THAT THE DEATH EATERS HAVE
GET THE FULL MIGHT OF THE MINISTRY ON THEIR SIDE NOW, SAID LUPIN.

THEY VE GET THE POWER THE PERFORM CRITICAL SPELLS WITHOUT FEAR OF
THE BRIBE

END

IDENTIFICATION FOR ARREST. THEY MANAGED TO PENETRATE EVERY
DEFENSIVE

SPELL WE D CAST AGAINST THEM, AND ENCE INSIDE, THEY WERE COMPLETELY
OPEN ABOUT WHY THEY D COME.

AND ARE THEY EITHERING TO GIVE AN EXCUSE FOR THEFTING HARRY S
WHEREABOUTS LEFT OF PEOPLE? ASKED HERMIONE, AN EDGE TO HER
VOICE.

WELL, SAID LUPIN, HE HESITATED, THEN PULLED OUT A FOLDED SHEET
OF THE DAILY PROPHET.

HERE, HE SAID, PUSHING IT ACROSS THE TABLE TO HARRY, THEY LL
KNOW

SEEMER FOR LATER ANYWAY, THAT S THEIR PRETEXT FOR GOING AFTER
THEY.

HARRY SPENTED OUT THE PAPER, A HUGE PHOTOGRAPH OF HIS OWN
FACE FILLED THE FRONT PAGE, HE READ THE HEADLINE OVER IT:

WANTED FOR ELDESTING ABOUT

THE DEATH OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

AND HERMIONE GAVE SIGNS OF INTEREST, BUT HARRY SAID NOTHING

ING. HE PUSHED THE NEWSPAPER AWAY; HE DID NOT WANT TO READ ANY

MORE! HE KNEW WHAT IT WOULD SAY. NOBODY BUT THOSE WHO HAD BEEN
IN THE OF THE TOWER WHEN DUMBLEDORE DIED KNEW WHO HAD REALLY
KILLED HIM AND, AS RITA SKEETER HAD ALREADY TOLD THE WIZARDING
WORLD, HARRY HAD BEEN SEEN RUNNING FROM THE PLACE MOMENTS AFTER
DUMBLEDORE HAD FALLEN.

I'M SORRY, HARRY, LUPIN SAID.

SINCE DEATH EATERS HAVE TAKEN OVER THE DAILY PROPHET THEY' ASKED
HERMIONE ANXIOUSLY.

LUPIN NEEDED.

BUT SURELY PEOPLE REALIZE WHAT'S GOING ON?

THE CHURCH HAS BEEN SILENT AND VIRTUALLY SILENT, SAID LUPIN.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

~~THE~~

THE OFFICIAL VERSION OF SCRIMGEOUR'S MURDER IS THAT HE RESIGNED;
HE

HAS BEEN REPLACED BY PIVUS THICKNESS, WHO IS UNDER THE IMPERILUS
CURSE.

WHY DIDN'T VOLDERMORT DECLARE HIMSELF MINISTER OF MAGIC?
ASKED RON.

LUPIN LAUGHED.

HE DOESN'T NEED THEM, RON. EFFECTIVELY HE IS THE MINISTER, BUT WHY

SHOULD HE SIT BEHIND A DESK AT THE MINISTRY? HIS PLUMMET, THICKNESS,

IS TAKING CARE OF EVERYDAY BUSINESS, LEAVING VERDEMEERT FREE TO EXTEND

HIS POWER BEYOND THE MINISTRY.

NATURALLY MANY PEOPLE HAVE DEDUCED WHAT HAS HAPPENED! THERE HAS BEEN SUCH A DRAMATIC CHANGE IN MINISTRY POLICY IN THE LAST FEW DAYS, AND MANY ARE WHISPERING THAT VERDEMEERT MUST BE BEHIND IT. HOWEVER, THAT IS THE POINT! THEY WHISPER, THEY DAREN'T CONVINCE IN

EACH OTHER, NOT DREAMING OF THEM THE TRUTH! THEY ARE SCARED TO SPEAK OUT, IN CASE THEIR SUSPICIONS ARE TRUE AND THEIR FAMILIES ARE TARGETED.

YES, VERDEMEERT IS PLAYING A VERY CLEVER GAME, DECLARING HIMSELF

MIGHT HAVE PREVENTED OPEN REBELLION! REMAINING MASKED HAS CREATED CONFUSION, UNCERTAINTY, AND FEAR.

AND THIS DRAMATIC CHANGE IN MINISTRY POLICY, SAID HARRY, INVOLVES

WARNING THE WIZARDING WORLD AGAINST ME INSTEAD OF VERDEMEERT?

THAT'S CERTAINLY PART OF IT, SAID LUPIN, AND IT IS A MASTERSTROKE.

WELL THAT DUMBLEDORE IS DEAD, WELL THE RED WORMS LIVED WERE

SURE TO BE THE SYMBOL AND RALLYING POINT FOR ANY RESISTANCE TO VERDE-

MEERT, BUT BY SUGGESTING THAT WELL HAD A HAND IN THE OLD MAN'S DEATH,

VHLDENHRT HAS NEET ENLY SET A PRICE UPON THEIR HEAD, BUT SEEN
DEHKT

AND FEAR AMONGST MANY WHO WOULD HAVE DEFENDED THE,

MEANWHILE, THE MINISTRY HAS STARTED MOVING AGAINST MUGGLE-
KHOONS,

THE BRIKE

2007

LUPIN PRINTED AT THE DAILY PROPHET,

LEEDS AT PAGE TWO.

HERMIONE TURNED THE PAGES WITH MUCH THE SAME EXPRESSION OF
DISTASTE SHE HAD WHEN WHEN HANDLING SECRETS OF THE DARKEST ART.

MUGGLE-KHOON REGISTER, SHE READ AHEAD. THE MINISTRY OF
MAGIC

IS UNDERTAKING A SURVEY OF SHE-CALLED MUGGLE-KHOONS, THE BETTER THE
WIN-

DERSTAND HOW THEY CAN THE POSSESS MAGICAL SECRETS.

RECENT RESEARCH UNDERTAKEN BY THE DEPARTMENT OF MYSTERIES
REVEALS

THAT MAGIC CAN ONLY BE PASSED FROM PERSON TO PERSON WHEN
WIZARDS

REPRODUCE, WHERE NO PROVEN WIZARDING ANCESTRY EXISTS, THEREFORE,
THE

SEE-CALLED MUGGLE-BORN IS LIKELY THEY HAVE OBTAINED MAGICAL POWER BY
THEFT

HER POWER.

THE MINISTRY IS DETERMINED THEY MUST ELIMINATE SUCH DISGRACERS OF MAGI-
CAL POWER, AND TO THIS END HAS ISSUED AN INVITATION TO EVERY SEE-
CALLED

MUGGLE-BORN TO PRESENT THEMSELVES FOR INTERVIEW BY THE NEWLY
APPOINTED

MUGGLE-BORN REGISTRATION COMMISSION.

PEOPLE WON'T LET THIS HAPPEN, SAID RON.

IT IS HAPPENING, RON, SAID LUPIN. MUGGLE-BORNS ARE BEING
RECORDED UP AS WE SPEAK.

BUT HOW ARE THEY SUPPOSED TO HAVE STEALING MAGIC? SAID RON.

IT'S MENTAL, IF YOU COULD STEAL MAGIC THERE WOULDN'T BE ANY SPELLS,
WOULD THERE?

I KNOW, SAID LUPIN. NEVERTHELESS, UNLESS YOU CAN PROVE THAT
YOU HAVE AT LEAST ONE CLOSE WIZARDING RELATIVE, YOU ARE NOW
DEEMED

THEY HAVE OBTAINED THEIR MAGICAL POWER ILLEGALLY AND MUST SUFFER THE
PUNISHMENT.

RON GLANCED AT HERMION, THEN SAID, WHAT IF PUREBLOODS AND

HALF-BLOODS SWEAR A MUGGLE-BORN IS PART OF THEIR FAMILY? I'LL TELL
YOU-

ERMIONE HERMION IS MY CHILDS

CHAPTER ELEVEN

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HERMIONE COVERED RON'S HAND WITH HERS AND SQUEEZED IT.

THANK YOU, RON, BUT I COULDN'T LET YOU

YOU WOULDN'T HAVE A CHANCE, SAID RON FIERCELY, GRIPPING HER HAND BACK. I'LL TEACH YOU MY FAMILY TREE SEE YOU CAN ANSWER QUESTIONS ON IT.

HERMIONE GAVE A SHAKY LAUGH.

RON, AS WE'RE IN THE RAIN WITH HARRY POTTER, THE MOST WANTED PERSON IN THE COUNTRY, I DON'T THINK IT MATTERS. IF I WAS GOING BACK

THE SCHOOL IT WOULD BE DIFFERENT. WHAT'S VOLDMORT PLANNING FOR HOGWARTS? SHE ASKED BLINDLY.

ATTENDANCE IS NOW COMPULSORY FOR EVERY WELSH WITCH AND WIZARD, HE REPLIED. THAT WAS ANNOUNCED YESTERDAY. IT'S A CHANGE, BECAUSE IT WAS NEVER MANDATORY BEFORE. HE COULDN'T, NEARLY EVERY WITCH

AND WIZARD IN BRITAIN HAS BEEN EDUCATED AT HOGWARTS, BUT THEIR PARENTS HAD THE RIGHT TO TRACK THEM AT HOME OR SEND THEM AHEAD IF

THEY PREFERRED. THIS WAY, VOLDMORT WILL HAVE THE WELSH WIZARDING

POPULATION UNDER HIS EYE FROM A YOUNG AGE. AND IT'S ALSO ANOTHER

WAS HE WEEDING OUT MUGGLE-BORN, BECAUSE STUDENTS MUST BE GIVEN
BLOOD STATUS MEANING THAT THEY HAVE PROVEN TO THE MINISTRY
THAT

THEY ARE OF WIZARD DESCENT BEFORE THEY ARE ALLOWED TO ATTEND.

HARRY FELT SICKENED AND ANGRY! AT THIS MOMENT, EXCITED ELEVEN-
YEAR-OLDS WOULD BE PERUSING NEW STACKS OF NEWLY PURCHASED SPELL-
BOOKS, UNAWARE THAT THEY WOULD NEVER SEE HOGWARTS, PERHAPS
NEVER

SEE THEIR FAMILIES AGAIN EITHER.

IT S... IT S... HE MUTTERED, STRUGGLING TO FIND WORDS THAT DID
JUSTICE TO THE HORROR OF HIS THOUGHTS, BUT LUPIN SAID QUICKLY,

I KNOW.

LUPIN HESITATED.

THEY STRIKE

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I DO UNDERSTAND IF YOU CAN'T CONFIRM THIS, HARRY, BUT THE ORDER IS
UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT DUMBLEDORE LEFT YOU A MESSAGE.

HE DID, HARRY REPLIED, AND RON AND HERMION ARE IN WITH IT
AND THEY'RE HELPING WITH ME.

CAN YOU CLARIFY IN ME WHAT THE MESSAGE IS?

HARRY WINCEED INTO THE PREMATURELY LINED FACE, FRAMED IN THICK BUT
GRAYING HAIR, AND WISHED THAT HE COULD RETURN A DIFFERENT ANSWER.

I CAN'T, REMUS, I'M SORRY, IF DUMKLEBREE DIDN'T TELL YOU I DIDN'T
THINK I CAN.

I THOUGHT YOU'D SAY THAT, SAID LUPIN, LOOKING DISAPPOINTED,
BUT

I MIGHT STILL BE OF SOME USE TO YOU, YOU KNOW WHAT I AM AND WHAT
I

CAN DO. I COULD COME WITH YOU TO PROVIDE PROTECTION. THERE WOULD
BE NO NEED TO TELL ME EXACTLY WHAT YOU WERE UP TO.

HARRY HESITATED. IT WAS A VERY TEMPTING OFFER, THOUGH HEY THEY
WOULD BE ABLE TO KEEP THEIR MISSION SECRET FROM LUPIN IF HE WERE
WITH THEM ALL THE TIME HE COULD NOT IMAGINE.

HERMIONE, HOWEVER, LOOKED PLAZZED.

BUT WHAT ABOUT TENDS? SHE ASKED.

WHAT ABOUT HER? SAID LUPIN.

WELL, SAID HERMIONE, FREQUENTLY, YOU'RE MARRIED! SHE'D BET SHE
FEEL ABOUT YOU GOING AWAY WITH US?

TENDS WILL BE PERFECTLY SAFE, SAID LUPIN. SHE'LL BE AT HER PAR-
ENTS HOUSE.

THERE WAS SOMETHING STRANGE IN LUPIN'S TONE; IT WAS ALMOST CHILD.

THERE WAS ALSO SOMETHING HED IN THE IDEA OF TENDS REMAINING HID-
DEN AT HER PARENTS HOUSE; SHE WAS, AFTER ALL, A MEMBER OF THE
ORDER

AND, AS FAR AS HARRY KNEW, WAS LIKELY TO WANT TO BE IN THE THICK OF
THE ACTION.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

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REPLIS, SAID HERMIONE TENTATIVELY, IS EVERYTHING ALL RIGHT ...
YELL KNOWS ... BETWEEN YELL AND

EVERYTHING IS FINE, THANKS YELL, SAID LUPIN FEINTLY,
HERMIONE TURNED PINK. THERE WAS ANOTHER PALSE, AN AWARD
AND EMBARRASSED HER, AND THEN LUPIN SAID, WITH AN AIR OF PERKING
HIMSELF TO ADMIT SOMETHING UNPLEASANT, THANKS IS GOING TO HAVE
A
BABY,

OH, HOW WONDERFUL! EXCLAIMED HERMIONE,

EXCELLENT! SAID RON ENTHUSIASTICALLY,

CONGRATULATIONS, SAID HARRY,

LUPIN GAVE AN ARTIFICIAL SMILE THAT WAS MORE LIKE A GRIMACE, THEN
SAID, SHE ... OH YELL ACCEPT MY OFFER? WILL THERE BECOME FELLRY? I

CANNOT BELIEVE THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE DISAPPROVED, HE AP-
PEINTE ME YELL'S DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER, AFTER ALL,

AND I MUST TELL YELL THAT I BELIEVE THAT WE ARE FACING MAGIC MAND
OF

US HAVE NEVER ENCOUNTERED HER IMAGINED,

RON AND HERMIONE BOTH LOOKED AT HARRY,

JUST JUST THE BE CLEAR, HE SAID, YELL WANT THE LEAVE THANKS AT
HER

PARENTS FEELISE AND CHEER AWAY WITH LIZ?

SHE'LL BE PERFECTLY SAFE THERE, THEY'LL LOOK AFTER HER, SAID LUPIN.
HE SPEAKS WITH A FINALITY BEHINDING HIS INDIFFERENCE. HARRY, I'M
SURE

JAMES WOULD HAVE WANTED ME THE STICK WITH YELL.

WELL, SAID HARRY SLEEKLY, I'M NOT, I'M PRETTY SURE MY FATHER
WOULD HAVE WANTED THE KNIFE WE'VE YELL AREN'T STICKING WITH YELLIN
EVEN

DID, ACTUALLY.

LUPIN'S FACE DRAINED OF COLOR. THE TEMPERATURE IN THE KITCHEN
MIGHT HAVE DROPPED TEN DEGREES. DEN STARED AROUND THE ROOM AS
THOUGH HE HAD BEEN KIDNAPED THE MEMORIZE IT, WHILE HERMIONE'S EYES
SWIVELED BACKWARD AND FORWARD FROM HARRY TO LUPIN.

THE BIRK

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YELL DEN'T UNDERSTAND, SAID LUPIN AT LAST.

EXPLAIN, THEN, SAID HARRY.

LUPIN SWALLOWED.

I I MADE A GRAVE MISTAKE IN MARRYING THEM. I DID IT AGAINST
MY BETTER JUDGMENT AND I HAVE REGRETTED IT VERY MUCH EVER SINCE.

I SEE, SAID HARRY, SEE YELL'RE JUST GIVING THE BUMP HER AND THEN DID
AND RUN OFF WITH LIZ?

LUPIN SPRANG THE HIS FEET: HIS CHAIR TOPPLED OVER BACKWARD, AND
HE GLARED AT THEM SEE FIRCELY THAT HARRY SAW, FOR THE FIRST TIME
EVER,

THE SHADOWS OF THE WOLF WERE HIS HUMAN FACE.

DIDN'T YOU UNDERSTAND WHAT I'VE DONE TO MY WIFE AND MY LITTLE
CHILD? I SHOULD NEVER HAVE MARRIED HER, I'VE MADE HER AN OUTCAST!
LUPIN KICKED ASIDE THE CHAIR HE HAD OVERTURNED.

YOU HAVE ONLY EVER SEEN ME AMONGST THE HERBES, THE LITTLE
BLENDING OF PROTECTION AT HOGWARTS? YOU DIDN'T KNOW HOW MOST OF
THE

WIZARDING WORLD SEES CREATURES LIKE ME? WHEN THEY KNOW OF MY
AFFLICTION, THEY CAN BARELY TALK TO ME? DIDN'T YOU SEE WHAT I'VE
DONE?

EVEN HER OWN FAMILY IS DISGUSTED BY HER MARRIAGE, WHAT PARENTS
WANT THEIR ONLY DAUGHTER TO MARRY A WEREWOLF? AND THE CHILD
THE
CHILD

LUPIN ACTUALLY SEIZED HANDFULS OF HIS OWN HAIR; HE WHISKED HER
AWAY.

MY KIND DIDN'T USUALLY KNEED IT. IT WILL BE LIKE ME, I AM CONVINCED
OF IT. HOW CAN I FORGIVE MYSELF, WHEN I KNOWINGLY RISKED
PASSING
ON MY OWN CONDITION TO AN INNOCENT CHILD? AND IF, BY SOME MIRACLE,
IT IS NOT LIKE ME, THEN IT WILL BE BETTER OFF, A HUNDRED TIMES BETTER,
WITH
A FATHER OF WHOM IT MUST ALWAYS BE ASKED?

REMUS? WHISPERED HERMIONE, TEARS IN HER EYES. DIDN'T SAY
THAT HOW COULD ANY CHILD BE ASKED OF YOU?

CHAPTER ELEVEN

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"EH, I DERN'T KNOW, HERMIONE," SAID HARRY. "I'D BE PRETTY ASHAMED OF HIM."

HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHERE HIS RAGE WAS COMING FROM, BUT IT HAD PROPELLED HIM TEN FEET THEN, LUPIN LOOKED AS THOUGH HARRY HAD HIT HIM.

"IF THE NEW REGIME THINKS MUGGLE-BORN'S ARE BAD," HARRY SAID, "WHAT WILL THEY DO TO A HALF-WEREWOLF WHOSE FATHER'S IN THE ORDER?"

"MY FATHER DIED TRYING TO PROTECT MY MOTHER AND ME, AND YELL RECKON

HE'D TELL YELL THE ARABIAN YELL'D DID THE GIBBON AN ADVENTURE WITH HIS?

"HELL, HOW DARE YELL?" SAID LUPIN. "THIS IS NOT ABOUT A DESIRE FOR DANGER OR PERSONAL GLORY. HOW DARE YELL SUGGEST SUCH

A

"I THINK YELL'RE FEELING A BIT OF A DAREDEVIL," HARRY SAID. "HELL PARDY

STEPPING INTO STRIPS & STOPS

HARRY, NOW? HERMIONE BEGGED HIM, BUT HE CONTINUED TO GLARE INTO LUPIN'S LIVID FACE.

"I'D NEVER HAVE BELIEVED THIS," HARRY SAID. "THE MAN WHO TAUGHT ME THE FIGHT DEMENTHRS A CHLARD,

LUPIN DREW HIS WAND SO FAST THAT HARRY HAD BARELY REACHED FOR

HIS HEAD, THERE WAS A BLIND RAGE AND HE FELT HIMSELF FLYING BACKWARD AS IF PUNCHED, AS HE SLAMMED INTO THE KITCHEN WALL AND SLID THE THE FLOOR, HE GLIMPSED THE TAIL OF LUPIN'S HEAD DISAPPEARING AROUND THE DOOR.

REMUS, REMUS, COME BACK! HERMIONE CRIED, BUT LUPIN DID NOT RESPOND, A MOMENT LATER THEY HEARD THE FRONT DOOR SLAM.

HARRY? WAILED HERMIONE. JOHN CHILD WHY?

IT WAS EASY, SAID HARRY, HE STOOD UP, HE COULD FEEL A LUMP SWELLING WHERE HIS HEAD HAD HIT THE WALL, HE WAS STILL SEE FLICK OF ANGER HE

WAS SHAKING.

THE BRIKE

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DON'T LOOK AT ME LIKE THAT! HE SNAPPED AT HERMIONE.

DON'T YOU START ME HERE! SNARLED RON.

NEH NEH WE MUSTN'T FIGHT! SAID HERMIONE, LAUNCHING HERSELF BETWEEN THEM.

YOU SHOULD'VE SAID THAT STUFF THE LUPIN, RON TOLD HARRY.

HE HAD IT COMING TO HIM, SAID HARRY, BRIGHT IMAGES WERE RAC-

ING EACH OTHER THROUGH HIS MIND: STIRILS FALLING THROUGH THE
VEIL;

BUMPLEDIERE SUSPENDED, KNEELEN IN MIDAIR; A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT
AND HIS MOTHER'S VEHICLE, BEGGING FOR MERCY . . .

PARENTS, SAID HARRY, SHOULDNT LEAVE THEIR KIDS UNLESS
UNLESS

THEY VE GOTTEN THEM.

HARRY SAID HERMIONE, STRETCHING OUT A CENSURING HAND, BUT
HE SHRUGGED IT OFF AND WALKED AWAY, HIS EYES ON THE FIRE HERMIONE
HAD CHILDED. HE HAD HENCE SPOKEN THE LUPIN OUT OF THAT FIREPLACE,
SEEKING REASSURANCE ABOUT JAMES, AND LUPIN HAD CENSURED HIM.
NOW LUPIN'S THUNDERED WHITE FACE SEEMED TO SWIM IN THE AIR BEFORE

HIM. HE FELT A SICKENING SURGE OF REMORSE. NEITHER RON NOR
HERM-

HENCE SPED, BUT HARRY FELT SURE THAT THEY WERE LEEDING AT EACH
OTHER

BEHIND HIS BACK, COMMUNICATING SILENTLY.

HE TURNED AROUND AND CALLED THEM TURNING FLURRIEDLY AWAY FROM
EACH OTHER.

I KNOW I SHOULDNT HAVE CALLED HIM A CHILDER.

NO, WELL SHOULDNT, SAID RON AT ONCE.

BUT HE'S ACTING LIKE ONE.

ALL THE SAME . . . SAID HERMIONE.

I KNOW, SAID HARRY. BUT IF IT MAKES HIM GO BACK TO THE TENDERS, IT LL
BE WORTH IT, WONT IT?

HE COULD NOT KEEP THE PLEA OUT OF HIS VOICE, HERMIONE LOOKED SYMPATHETIC, REEN UNCERTAIN, HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT HIS FEET, THINKING

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OF HIS FATHER, WOULD JAMES HAVE BACKED HARRY IN WHAT HE HAD SAID TO SLIPIN, OR WOULD HE HAVE BEEN ANGRY AT HOW HIS SON HAD TREATED HIS OLD FRIEND?

THE SILENT KITCHEN SEEMED TO FILL WITH THE SENSE OF THE RECENT SCENE AND WITH REEN AND HERMIONE'S UNSPOKEN REPROACHES. THE DAILY

PROPHET SLIPIN HAD BROUGHT WAS STILL LYING ON THE TABLE, HARRY'S EYES

WERE STARRING UP AT THE CEILING FROM THE FRONT PAGE. HE WALKED OVER TO IT AND SAT DOWN, OPENED THE PAPER AT RANDOM, AND PRETENDED TO READ. HE COULD NOT TAKE IN THE WORDS; HIS MIND WAS STILL FULL OF THE ENCOUNTER WITH SLIPIN. HE WAS SURE THAT REEN AND HERMIONE

HAD RESUMED THEIR SILENT COMMUNICATIONS ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE PROPHET. HE TURNED A PAGE LILABLY, AND DUMBLEDORE'S NAME LEAPT OUT

AT HIM. IT WAS A MOMENT OR TWO BEFORE HE THOUGHT IN THE MEANING OF THE

PHOTOCOPY, WHICH SHOWED A FAMILY GROUP, BENEATH THE PHOTOCOPY

WERE THE WERDS: THE DUMBLEDORE FAMILY, LEFT TO RIGHT: ALBUS,
PERCIVAL,

HOLDING NEWBORN ARIANA; KENDRA; AND ARKENTHUS.

His attention caught, Harry examined the picture more care-
fully. DUMBLEDORE'S FATHER, PERCIVAL, WAS A GOOD-LOOKING MAN WITH

EYES THAT SEEMED TO TWINKLE EVEN IN THIS FADED OLD PHOTOGRAPH.
THE

BABY, ARIANA, WAS LITTLE LONGER THAN A LEAF OF BREAD AND SHE MORE
DISTINCTIVE-LOOKING. THE MOTHER, KENDRA, HAD jet-black hair pulled
INTO A HIGH BUN. Her face had A CARVED QUALITY ABOUT IT. Harry
RECALLED THE PHOTOS OF NATIVE AMERICANS HE'D SEEN AS HE STUDIED
HER

DARK EYES, HIGH CHEEKBONES, AND STRAIGHT NOSE, NORMALLY COMPOSED
ABOUT A HIGH-COLLARED SILK GOWN. ALBUS AND ARKENTHUS WERE
MATCHING

LACY COLLARED JACKETS AND HAD IDENTICAL, SHOULDER-LENGTH HAIRSTYLES.
ALBUS LOOKED SEVERAL YEARS OLDER, BUT OTHERWISE THE TWO BOYS
LOOKED

VERY ALIKE, FOR THIS WAS BEFORE ALBUS'S NOSE HAD BEEN BROKEN AND
BEFORE HE STARTED WEARING GLASSES.

THE BIRTH

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THE FAMILY LOOKED ELITE HAPPY AND NORMAL, SMILING SERENELY UP

HELT IN THE NEWSPAPER, RARY ARIANA S ARM WAVED VAGUELY HELT IN
HER

SHALL, HARRY LEEKED ABOVE THE PICTURE AND SAW THE HEADLINE:

EXCLUSIVE EXTRACT FROM THE LITCHFIELD

BIOGRAPHY OF ARLIS DUMBLEDORE

BY RITA SKEETER

THINKING THAT IT COULD HARDLY MAKE HIM FEEL ANY WORSE THAN HE
ALREADY DID, HARRY BEGAN TO READ:

PRELUDE AND EPILOGUE, DENDRA DUMBLEDORE COULD NOT

SEAR THE REMAIN IN MURDER-IN-THE-WOOD AFTER HER HUSBAND
PERCYAL S WELL-PUBLICIZED ARREST AND IMPRISONMENT
IN AZKABAN. SHE THEREFORE DECIDED TO REWIND

THE FAMILY AND REHEAT THE CHORIC S FATHER, THE VIL-
LAGE THAT WAS LATER THE GAIN FAME AS THE SCENE OF HARRY

POTTER S STRANGE ESCAPE FROM MURDER-IN-THE-WOOD.

LIKE MURDER-IN-THE-WOOD, CHORIC S FATHER WAS

FROM THE A NUMBER OF WIZARDING FAMILIES, BUT AS

DENDRA KNEW NONE OF THEM, SHE WOULD BE SPARED

THE CURIOUSITY ABOUT HER HUSBAND S CRIME SHE HAD

FACED IN HER FORMER VILLAGE. BY REPEATEDLY REWINDING

THE FRIENDLY ADVANCES OF HER NEW WIZARDING NEIGH-

BORS, SHE SURELY ENSURED THAT HER FAMILY WAS LEFT WELL

ALONE.

SLAPPED THE DEER IN MY FACE WHEN I WENT
AROUND THE WELCOME HER WITH A BATCH OF HOMEMADE
CALABRESE CAKES, SAYS KATHILDA RAGSHEIT. THE FIRST

CHAPTER ELEVEN

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YEAR THEY WERE THERE I ONLY EVER SAW THE TWO BOYS.
WOULDN'T HAVE KNOWN THERE WAS A DAUGHTER IF I
HADN'T BEEN PICKING PLACENTINES BY MIDDLELIGHT THE
WINTER AFTER THEY MOVED IN, AND SAW KENDRA LEADING
ARIANA OUT INTO THE BACK GARDEN, WALKED HER AROUND
THE LAWN FENCE, KEEPING A FIRM GRIP ON HER, THEN THREW
HER BACK INSIDE. DIDN'T KNOW WHAT SHE MADE OF IT.

IT SEEMS THAT KENDRA THOUGHT THE MOVE THE GOOD-
RICKS FELLOWS WAS THE PERFECT OPPORTUNITY TO HIDE

ARIANA AWAY AND FOR ALL, SOMETHING SHE HAD PROBABLY
BEEN PLANNING FOR YEARS. THE TIMING WAS SIGNIFICANT.
ARIANA WAS EARLY SEVEN YEARS OLD WHEN SHE VANISHED

FROM SIGHT, AND SEVEN IS THE AGE BY WHICH MOST EX-
PERTS AGREE THAT MAGIC WILL HAVE REVEALED ITSELF, IF

PRESENT. NOBODY NEW ALIVE REMEMBERS ARIANA EVER
DEMONSTRATING EVEN THE SLIGHTEST SIGN OF MAGICAL
ABILITY. IT SEEMS CLEAR, THEREFORE, THAT KENDRA MADE
A DECISION TO HIDE HER DAUGHTER'S EXISTENCE RATHER

THAN SLIPPER THE SHAME OF ADMITTING THAT SHE HAD PRO-
DUCED A SON. MOVING AWAY FROM THE FRIENDS AND

NEIGHBORS WHO KNEW ARIANA WOULD, OF COURSE, MAKE
IMPRISONING HER ALL THE EASIER. THE TINY NUMBER OF
PEOPLE WHO HENCEFORTH KNEW OF ARIANA'S EXISTENCE
COULD BE CHAINED UPON THE DEEP THE SECRET, INCLUDING
HER TWO BROTHERS, WHO DEFLECTED ALEXANDER'S QUESTIONS
WITH THE ANSWER THEIR MOTHER HAD TAUGHT THEM: MY
SISTER IS THE PRINCESS OF THE SKY.

NEXT WEEK: ALEXIS DUMBLEDOORE AT THE GLAVERS THE
PRIZES AND THE PRETENSE.

THE BIRTH

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HARRY HAD BEEN WRITING: WHAT HE HAD READ HAD INDEED MADE HIM
FEEL WORSE. HE LOOKED BACK AT THE PHOTOGRAPH OF THE APPARENTLY
HAPPY FAMILY. WAS IT TRUE? COULD HE FIND OUT? HE WANTED TO
SEE THE CHILD'S FATHER, EVEN IF RUTHLESS WAS IN THE FIT STATE TO TALK

THE HIM; HE WANTED THE VISIT THE PLACE WHERE HE AND DIMPLEDINE HAD

KEITH LEFT LEVED HERS. HE WAS IN THE PROCESS OF LEAVING THE
NELSPA-

PER, THE ASK BEEN S AND FERMINE S EPINIENTS, WHEN A DRAVENING
CRACK

ECHEED AROUND THE DITCHEN.

FOR THE FIRST TIME IN THREE DAYS FARRY HAD FORGOTTEN ALL ABOUT
DREACHER. HIS IMMEDIATE THOUGHT WAS THAT LUPIN HAD BURST BACK
INTO THE ROOM, AND FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HE DID NOT TAKE IN THE MASS
OF STRUGGLING LIMBS THAT HAD APPEARED OUT OF THE AIR RIGHT BESIDE
HIS CHAIR. HE FLURRIED THE HIS FEET AS DREACHER DISENTANGLED HIMSELF
AND, WHILING AWAY THE FARRY, CRASHED. DREACHER HAS RETURNED WITH
THE THIEF MUNDLINGIS FLETCHER, MASTER.

MUNDLINGIS SCRAMBLED UP AND PULLED OUT HIS WARD; FERMINE,
HOWEVER, WAS THEE HELD FOR HIM.

EXPELLIAMUS!

MUNDLINGIS S WARD SHARED INTO THE AIR, AND FERMINE CALIGHT IT.
WILD-EYED, MUNDLINGIS DIVED FOR THE STAIRS! BEEN RICKY-TACKLED HIM
AND MUNDLINGIS HIT THE STONE FLOOR WITH A MUFFLED CRUNCH.

WHAT? HE BELIEVED, WRITHING IN HIS ATTEMPTS TO FREE HIMSELF
FROM BEEN S GRIP. WHAT YE I DENY? SETTING A BLEEDIN' HOUSE-FLY ON
ME, WHAT ARE YEEN PLAYING AT, WHAT YE I DENY, LETME GO, LETME GO,
HER

YEEEN RE NOT IN MUCH OF A POSITION TO MAKE THREATS, SAID FARRY.
HE

THREW ASIDE THE NEWSPAPER, CROSSED THE KITCHEN IN A FEW STRIDES,
AND

DROPPED TO HIS KNEES BESIDE MUNDLINGIS, WHO STOPPED STRUGGLING
AND LOOKED TERRIFIED. RON GET UP, PANTING, AND WATCHED AS HARRY

CHAPTER ELEVEN

POINTED HIS HAND DELICATELY AT MUNDLINGIS'S NECK. MUNDLINGIS
STAND UP STALE SWEAT AND TERRIBLE SMELL: HIS HAIR WAS MATTED AND
HIS REEKS STAINED.

KREACHER APPEALIZES FOR THE DELAY IN BRINGING THE THIEF, MASTER,
CREATED THE ELF. FLETCHER KNOWS HOW THE AVOID CAPTURE, HAS MANY
HIDEY-PLACES AND ALIBIS. NEVERTHELESS, KREACHER CORNERED THE
THIEF IN THE END.

WELL YOU DINE REALLY WELL, KREACHER, SAID HARRY, AND THE ELF KEELER
WELL.

RIGHT, WE VE GET A FEW QUESTIONS FOR YOU, HARRY TOLD MUNDLINGIS,
WHO SMILED AT HIM.

I PANICKED, HARRY? I NEVER WANTED TO CHASE ALONG, NOT OFFENSE,
MATE, BUT I NEVER VOLUNTEERED TO DIE FOR YOU, AND THAT WAS BLEEDING
YOU-KNEW-WHEN CHASE FLYING AT ME, ANYONE WOULD GET HITTA
THREE,

I SAID ALL ALONG I DIDN'T WANNA DIE IT

HER YELLOW INFORMATION, NONE OF THE REST OF US DISAPPEARED, SAID
HERMIONE.

WELL, YOU'RE A SLICK OF BLEEDING KNEES THEN, AREN'T YOU, BUT I
NEVER PRETENDED I WAS UP FOR KILLING MURDER

WE'RE NOT INTERESTED IN WHY YOU RAN OUT FOR MAD-EYE, SAID
HARRY, MOVING HIS HAND A LITTLE CLOSER TO MURDERING'S & RAGEY,
BLOODSHOT EYES. WE ALREADY KNOW YOU WERE AN UNRELIABLE BIT OF
SLIM.

WELL THEN, WHY THE HELL AM I BEING WANTED DOWN BY HOUSE-ELVES?
IS THIS ABOUT THEM GHOSTS AGAIN? I AIN'T GOT NONE OF 'EM LEFT,
HARRY

YOU COULD AVE 'EM

IT'S NOT ABOUT THE GHOSTS EITHER, ALTHOUGH YOU'RE GETTING
WARMER,

SAID HARRY, SHUT UP AND LISTEN.

IT FELT WONDERFUL TO HAVE SOMETHING TO DO, SOMETHING OF WHICH HE

THE BRICK

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COULD DEMAND SOME SMALL PORTION OF TRUTH. HARRY'S HAND WAS NOW
SO CLOSE TO THE BRIDGE OF MURDERING'S NEAR THAT MURDERING'S HAD
GONE CROSS-EYED TRYING TO KEEP IT IN VIEW.

WHEN YOU CARED ABOUT THIS FELICE OF ANYTHING VALUABLE, HARRY
BEGAN, BUT MURDERING'S INTERRUPTED HIM AGAIN.

SIRIUS NEVER CARED ABOUT ANY OF THE ILLEG

THERE WAS THE SOUND OF PATTING FEET, A BLAZE OF SHINING CHOPPERS,
AN EERING CLANG, AND A STRIDE OF AGONY! BREAKER HAD TAKEN A
RUN

AT MUNDLINGIS AND HIT HIM OVER THE HEAD WITH A SALICPAN,

CALL IM HFF, CALL IM HFF, I SHOULD BE WHIPPED LIP? SCREAMED
MUNDLINGIS, COWERING AS BREAKER RAISED THE HEAVY-BETTERED PAN
AGAIN,

BREAKER, NEH? SHOUTED FARRY,

BREAKER'S THIN ARMS TREMBLED WITH THE WEIGHT OF THE PAN, STILL
HELD ALERT,

PERHAPS I'LL HIRE THERE, MASTER FARRY, HEH LICK?
REHN LAUGHED,

WE NEED HIM CHRISTMAS, BREAKER, BUT IF HE NEEDS PERSUADING
WE'LL CAN DO THE FEATHERS, SAID FARRY,

THANK YOU VERY MUCH, MASTER, SAID BREAKER WITH A BELL, AND
HE RETREATED A SHORT DISTANCE, HIS GREAT PALE EYES STILL FIXED UPON
MUNDLINGIS WITH LEATHING,

WHEN YOU STRIPPED THIS FEELER OF ALL THE VARIABLES YOU COULD
FIND, FARRY BEGAN AGAIN, YOU THINK A CLINK OF STUFF FROM THE
KITCHEN CLIPBOARD, THERE WAS A WHISKET THERE, FARRY'S MOUTH WAS

SUDDENLY DRY: HE COULD SENSE REHN AND FERMINE'S TENSION AND EX-
CITEMENT THERE, WHAT DID YOU DO WITH IT?

HEY? ASKED MUNDLINGIS, IS IT VARIABLE?

YOU'VE STILL GOT IT? CRIED FERMINE,

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Well, he hasn't, said Ron shrilly. He's wondering whether he should have asked more money for it.

More? said Mumblegus. That wouldn't have been offing difficult... bleeding gave it away, did it? Well, choice.

What did you mean?

I was selling in Diagon Alley and she came up to me and asks if I've got a license for trading in magical artifacts, bleeding snore, she

was gonna fine me, but she thinks a fancy to the lookout and told me she'd take it and let me off that time, and then finds me out bloody.

Well was this woman? asked Harry.

I don't, she's Ministry hag.

Mumblegus considered her a moment, eyes wrinkled.

Little woman, she's in the of her head.

He frowned and then added, looked like a head.

Harry dropped his wand: it hit Mumblegus in the neck and sent red sparks into his eyebrows, which ignited.

Agliament! screamed Hermione, and a jet of water streamed from her wand, engulfing a spluttering and bleeding Mumblegus. Harry looked up and saw his own shock reflected in Ron's and

HERMINE'S FACES. THE SCARS ON THE BACK OF HIS RIGHT HAND SEEMED
THE

BE TINGLING AGAIN.

CHAPTER TWELVE

MAGIC IS MIGHT

S ALIGHT WHERE HE, THE SEHJARE OF UNDEPT GRASS IN THE
MIDDLE OF CRIMMALLD PLACE SHRIVELLED IN THE SUN UNTIL IT
WAS BRITTLE AND CRACKED. THE INHABITANTS OF NUMBER TWELVE WERE
NEVER

SEEN BY ANYBODY IN THE SURROUNDING HILLS, AND NEAR WAS NUMBER
TWELVE ITSELF. THE MUGGLES WHO LIVED IN CRIMMALLD PLACE HAD LONG
SINCE ACCEPTED THE AMUSING MISTAKE IN THE NUMBERING THAT HAD
CAUSED NUMBER ELEVEN TO SIT BESIDE NUMBER THIRTEEN.

AND YET THE SEHJARE WAS NOW ATTRACTING A TRICKLE OF VISITORS WHO
SEEMED TO FIND THE ANIMAL MOST INTRIGUING. RARELY A DAY PASSED
WITHOUT ONE OR TWO PEOPLE ARRIVING IN CRIMMALLD PLACE WITH ONE
EITHER PURPOSE, OR SEE IT SEEMED, THAN TO LEAN AGAINST THE RAILINGS
FACING NUMBERS ELEVEN AND THIRTEEN, WATCHING THE HILL BETWEEN THE
TWO HILLS. THE WALKERS WERE NEVER THE SAME TWO DAYS RUNNING,
ALTHOUGH THEY ALL SEEMED TO SHARE A DISLIKE FOR NORMAL CLOTHING.
MOST OF THE WANDERERS WHO PASSED THEM WERE USED TO ECCENTRIC
DRESSERS AND TOOK LITTLE NOTICE, THOUGH OCCASIONALLY ONE OF THEM

☆

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MIGHT GLANCE BACK, WONDERING WHY ANYONE WOULD WEAR SUCH LONG
CLOAKS IN THIS HEAT.

THE WATCHERS SEEMED TO BE GLEANING LITTLE SATISFACTION FROM THEIR
VIGIL. OCCASIONALLY ONE OF THEM STARTED FORWARD EXCITEDLY, AS IF
THEY

HAD SEEN SOMETHING INTERESTING AT LAST, ONLY TO FALL BACK LOOKING
DISAPPOINTED.

ON THE FIRST DAY OF SEPTEMBER THERE WERE MORE PEOPLE WORKING IN
THE SHELTER THAN EVER BEFORE. HALF A DOZEN MEN IN LONG CLOAKS
STOOD

SILENT AND WATCHFUL, GAZING AS EVER AT BUILDINGS ELEVEN AND THIRTEEN,
BUT THE THING FOR WHICH THEY WERE WAITING STILL APPEARED ELUSIVE.
☆

EVENING DREW IN, BRINGING WITH IT AN UNEXPECTED GLIST OF CHILLY
RAIN

FOR THE FIRST TIME IN WEEKS, THERE ECLIPSED ONE OF THESE
INEXPLICABLE

MOMENTS WHEN THEY APPEARED TO HAVE SEEN SOMETHING INTERESTING.

THE MAN WITH THE TWISTED FACE PHINTED AND HIS CLOSEST COMPANION,
A PUDGY, PALLID MAN, STARTED FORWARD, BUT A MOMENT LATER THEY HAD
RELAXED INTO THEIR PREVIOUS STATE OF INACTIVITY, LOOKING
FRUSTRATED AND

DISAPPOINTED,

MEANWHILE, INSIDE NUMBER TWELVE, HARRY HAD JUST ENTERED THE HALL. HE HAD NEARLY LOST HIS BALANCE AS HE APPARATED INTO THE

STEP JUST BESIDE THE FRONT DOOR, AND THOUGHT THAT THE DEATH EATERS

MIGHT HAVE CAUGHT A GLIMPSE OF HIS MOMENTARILY EXPOSED KNEE.

SLITTING THE FRONT DOOR CAREFULLY BEHIND HIM, HE PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, DRAPED IT OVER HIS ARM, AND HURRIED ALONG THE GLEAMY HALLWAY TOWARD THE DOOR THAT LED TO THE BASEMENT, A STEEL COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHET CLUTCHED IN HIS HAND.

THE USUAL LOW WHISPER OF SEVERUS Snape? GREETED HIM, THE CHILL WIND SWIFT HIM, AND HIS THROAT ROLLED UP FOR A MOMENT.

I DIDN'T KILL YOU, HE SAID, SINCE IT HAD UNROLLED, THEN HELD HIS BREATH AS THE DUSTY INK-FIGURE EXPLODED. HE WAITED UNTIL HE WAS

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HALLWAY BEHIND THE STAIRS TO THE KITCHEN, HEAT OF EARSHEET OF MRS. BLACK

AND CLEAR OF THE DUST CLOUD, BEHIND CALLING, I'VE GOT NEWS, AND YOU WON'T LIKE IT.

THE KITCHEN WAS ALMOST UNRECOGNIZABLE. EVERY SURFACE NOW SHINE! CHOPPER POTS AND PANS HAD BEEN SHINISHED TO A BRISK GLEAM; THE WOODEN TABLETOP GLEAMED; THE CUPSETS AND PLATES ALREADY LAID FOR

DINNER GLINTED IN THE LIGHT FROM A MERRILY BLAZING FIRE, IN WHICH A CALABROSE WAS SIMMERING. NOTHING IN THE ROOM, HOWEVER, WAS MORE DRAMATICALLY DIFFERENT THAN THE HOUSE-ELF WHO NOW CAME FLYING TOWARD HARRY, DRESSED IN A SHINY-WHITE TUNIC, HIS EAR HAIR AS CLEAN

AND FLUFFY AS COTTON WOE, REGULUS S MURDERED GULPING HIM HIS THIN CHEST.

STEPS OFF, IF YOU PLEASE, MASTER HARRY, AND HANDS WASHED BEFORE DINNER. CREATED DREADER, SEIZING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND

SHEDDING OFF THE HANG IT ON A HOOK ON THE WALL, BESIDE A NUMBER OF

OLD-FASHIONED SHOES THAT HAD BEEN FRESHLY POLISHED.

WHAT IS HAPPENING? BEEN ASKED APPREHENSIVELY. HE AND HERMIONINE HAD BEEN PIERING OVER A SHEAF OF SCRIBBLED NOTES AND HAND-DRAWN

MAPS THAT LITTERED THE END OF THE LONG KITCHEN TABLE, BUT NOW THEY

WATCHED HARRY AS HE STRODE TOWARD THEM AND THREW DOWN THE NEWS-

PAPER ON THE OF THEIR SCATTERED PARCEMENT.

A LARGE PICTURE OF A FAMILIAR, HOOK-NEESED, BLACK-HAIRED MAN STARED UP AT THEM ALL, BENEATH A HEADLINE THAT READ:

SEVERUS Snape confirmed as Hogwarts
Headmaster

He said Ron and Hermione loudly,

Hermione was quickest; she snatched up the newspaper and began to read the accompanying story with held.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Severus Snape, long-standing Potions Master at Hogwarts
School of

Witchcraft and Wizardry, was today appointed Headmaster in the
most

important of several staffing changes at the ancient school,
following

the resignation of the previous Muggle Studies teacher, Albus
Lemon

will take over the post while her brother, Amos, fills the
position of

defense against the Dark Arts professor.

I welcome the opportunity to uphold our finest wizarding
tradi-

tions and values like committing murder and cutting off peo-
ple's ears, I suppose; Snape, Headmaster; Snape in Grimmauld's

study Merlin's pants; she shrieked, making both Harry and

DOWN JUMP, SHE LEAPT UP FROM THE TABLE AND FLIRTLED FROM THE ROOM,
SHOUTING AS SHE WENT, I LL BE BACK IN A MINUTE!

MERLIN S PANTS ? REPEATED RENN, LOOKING AMUSED, SHE MUST
BE LIPSIT, HE PULLED THE NEWSPAPER TOWARD HIM AND PERUSED THE
ARTICLE ABOUT SNAPE.

THE OTHER TEACHERS WENT T STAND AER THIS, MCGONAGALL AND FLIT-
WICK AND SPRELLT ALL KNEW THE TRUTH, THEY KNEW FELL DUMBLEDORE

DIED, THEY WENT T ACCEPT SNAPE AS HEADMASTER, AND WHO ARE THESE
CARRIERS?

DEATH EATERS, SAID HARRY, THERE ARE PICTURES OF THEM INSIDE,
THEY WERE AT THE TOP OF THE TOWER WHEN SNAPE KILLED DUMBLEDORE,
SEE IT S ALL FRIENDS TOGETHER, AND, HARRY WENT ON BITTERLY, DRAWING
UP A CHAIR, I CAN T SEE THAT THE OTHER TEACHERS HAVE GHT ANY
CHIEF

BLT THE STAY, IF THE MINISTRY AND VERDMENT ARE BEHIND SNAPE IT LL
BE

A CHIEF BETWEEN STAYING AND TEACHING, FOR A NICE FEW YEARS IN AZ-
KABAN AND THAT S IF THEY RE LUCKY, I RECKON THEY LL STAY THE TRY
AND

PROTECT THE STUDENTS.

DRACONER CAME BUSTLING THE THE TABLE WITH A LARGE TROOP IN HIS

MAGIC IS MIGHT

HANDS, AND LADLED HOT STEEP INTO PRISTINE CUPS, WHISTLING BETWEEN HIS TEETH AS HE DID SO.

THANKS, DREACHER, SAID HARRY, FLIPPING OVER THE PROPHECY SHE AS NIFTY HE HAD THE LOOK AT SNAPE'S FACE. WELL, AT LEAST WE KNOW EXACTLY

WHERE SNAPE IS NOW.

HE BEGAN TO SPEAK STEADILY INTO HIS MOUTH. THE QUALITY OF DREACHER'S

COOKING HAD IMPROVED DRAMATICALLY EVER SINCE HE HAD BEEN GIVEN REGILL'S SECRET: TODAY'S FRENCH BREAD WAS AS GOOD AS HARRY HAD EVER TASTED.

THERE ARE STILL A LOT OF DEATH EATERS WATCHING THE HOUSE, HE TOLD RON AS HE ATE, MORE THAN USUAL. IT'S LIKE THEY'RE KEEPING US IN

MARCH HEAT CARRYING THEIR SCREAMING TRUCKS AND HEAD OFF FOR THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS.

RON GLANCED AT HIS WATCH.

I'VE BEEN THINKING ABOUT THAT ALL DAY. IT LEFT NEARLY SIX HOURS AGO.

WEIRD, NOT BEING IN IT, ISN'T IT?

IN HIS MIND'S EYE HARRY SEEMED TO SEE THE SCARLET STEAM ENGINE AS HE AND RON HAD ONCE FOLLOWED IT BY AIR, SHIMMERING BETWEEN FIELDS AND HILLS, A RIPPLING SCARLET CATERPILLAR. HE WAS SURE GINNY, DEVLIN,

AND LUNA WERE SITTING TOGETHER AT THIS MOMENT, PERHAPS WONDERING WHERE HE, RON, AND HERMION WERE, HER DEKATING FEEL BEST TH LINDERMINE SNAPE S NEW REGIME.

THEY NEARLY SAW ME COMING BACK IN ILIST NEEL, HARRY SAID. I LANDED BADLY BEN THE THEP STEP, AND THE CLEAD SLIPPED.

I DEE THAT EVERY TIME, EH, HERE SHE IS, RON ADDED, CRANING AROUND IN HIS SEAT THE WATCH HERMION REENTERING THE KITCHEN. AND WHAT IN

THE NAME OF MERLIN S MOST SACRED & FREINTS WAS THAT ABELTY?

I REMEMBERED THIS, HERMION PANTED.

CHAPTER TWELVE

SHE WAS CARRYING A LARGE, FRAMED PICTURE, WHICH SHE NOW BELIEVED THE THE FLEHER BEFORE SEIZING HER SMALL, BEADED BAG FROM THE KITCHEN SIDEBARD. OPENING IT, SHE PROCEEDED THE FORCE THE PAINTING INSIDE, AND DESPITE THE FACT THAT IT WAS PATENTLY THREE LARGER THE FIT INSIDE THE TINY BAG, WITHIN A FEW SECONDS IT HAD VANISHED, LIKE SHE MUCH ELSE, INTO THE BAG S CAPACIOUS DEPTHS.

PHINEAS NIGELLUS, HERMION EXPLAINED AS SHE THREW THE BAG BENTHE THE KITCHEN TABLE WITH THE USUAL SHOWERBELLIS, CLANKING CRASH.

SHERRO? SAID RON, BUT HARRY LINDERSTEED, THE PAINTED IMAGE OF PHINEAS NIGELLUS BLACK WAS ABLE THE FLIT BETWEEN HIS PORTRAIT IN

CRIMINAL PLACE AND THE ONE THAT HUNG IN THE HEADMASTER'S OFFICE
AT HOGWARTS: THE CIRCULAR TABLES WHERE SNAPE WAS NOW
DESECT

SITTING RIGHT NOW, IN TRIUMPHANT POSSESSION OF DUMBLEDORE'S
CHURCH-

THEN OF DELICATE, SILVER MAGICAL INSTRUMENTS, THE STONE PENSIVE,
THE

SHIRTING THAT AND, UNLESS IT HAD BEEN MOVED ELSEWHERE, THE SWORD OF
GRYFFINDOR.

SNAPE COULD SEND PHINEAS NIGELLUS THE LETTER INSIDE THIS HOUSE FOR
HIM. HERMIONE EXPLAINED THE PLAN AS SHE RESUMED HER SEAT. BUT LET
HIM TRY IT NOW, ALL PHINEAS NIGELLUS WILL BE ABLE TO SEE IS THE
INSIDE
OF MY HANDBAG.

CHILD THINKING? SAID RON, LOOKING IMPRESSED.

THANK YOU, SMILED HERMIONE, PULLING HER SHOULDER TOWARD HER.

SEE, HARRY, WHAT ELSE HAPPENED TODAY?

NOTHING, SAID HARRY, WATCHED THE MINISTRY ENTRANCE FOR SEVEN
HOURS. DID NOT SEE HER, SAW HER DAD, HOWEVER, RON, HE LOOKS
FINE.

RON NEEDED HIS APPRECIATION OF THIS NEWS. THEY HAD AGREED THAT
IT WAS FAR TOO DANGEROUS TO TRY AND COMMUNICATE WITH MR.
WEASLEY

WHILE HE WALKED IN AND OUT OF THE MINISTRY, BECAUSE HE WAS ALWAYS
SURROUNDED BY EITHER MINISTRY WORKERS. IT WAS, HOWEVER,
REASSURING

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THE CATCH THESE GLIMPSES OF HIM, EVEN IF HE DID LOOK VERY STRAINED AND ANXIOUS.

DAD ALWAYS TOLD US MOST MINISTRY PEOPLE USE THE FLEET NETWORK TO GET THE WORD, RON SAID. THAT'S WHY WE HAVEN'T SEEN LUMBRIDGE, SHE'D NEVER WALK, SHE'D THINK SHE'S TOO IMPORTANT.

AND WHAT ABOUT THAT FLINDY OLD WITCH AND THAT LITTLE WIZARD IN THE NAVY BOOKS? HERMIONIE ASKED.

HEY, YEAH, THE BOOKS FROM MAGICAL MAINTENANCE, SAID RON.

WELL, DO YOU KNOW HE LOOKS FOR MAGICAL MAINTENANCE? HERMIONIE ASKED, HER SLIPSPINN SLIDDED IN MIDAIR.

DAD SAID EVERYONE FROM MAGICAL MAINTENANCE WEARS NAVY BLUE BOOKS,

BUT YOU NEVER TOLD US THAT!

HERMIONIE DROPPED HER SPINN AND PULLED TOWARD HER THE SHEAF OF NOTES AND MAPS THAT SHE AND RON HAD BEEN EXAMINING WHEN HARRY HAD ENTERED THE KITCHEN.

THERE'S NOTHING IN HERE ABOUT NAVY BLUE BOOKS, NOTHING! SHE SAID, FLIPPING FEVERISHLY THROUGH THE PAGES.

WELL, DOES IT REALLY MATTER?

RON, IT ALL MATTERS! IF WE'RE GOING TO GET INTO THE MINISTRY AND

NEET GIVE OURSELVES AWAY WHEN THEY RE BEHIND THE RE IN THE WOODS
FOR

INTRUDERS, EVERY LITTLE DETAIL MATTERS! WE VE BEEN HERE AND HERE
THIS, I

MEAN, WHAT S THE POINT OF ALL THESE RECONNAISSANCE TRIPS IF WE
AREN T

EVEN BOTHERING TO TELL US

KLIMY, HERMIONE, I FORGET ONE LITTLE THING

WE DNT REALIZE, DONT WE, THAT THERE S PROBABLY ONE MORE DAN-
GEROUS PLACE IN THE WHOLE WORLD FOR US TO BE RIGHT NOW THAN THE

MINISTRY OF

I THINK WE SHOULD BE IT THEMSELVES, SAID HARRY.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE

HERMIONE STOPPED DEAD, HER JAW HANGING; RON CHECKED A LITTLE
OVER HIS SHOULDER.

THEMSELVES? REPEATED HERMIONE, WE AREN T SERIOUS, HARRY?

I AM, SAID HARRY. I DONT THINK WE RE GOING TO BE MUCH BETTER
PREPARED THAN WE ARE NOW EVEN IF WE SINK AROUND THE MINISTRY
ENTRANCE FOR ANOTHER MONTH. THE LONGER WE PUT IT OFF, THE
FARTHER

AWAY THAT LOCKET COULD BE. THERE S ALREADY A GOOD CHANCE LONGBRIDGE
HAS CHECKED IT AWAY; THE THING DONT HAPPEN.

UNLESS, SAID RON, SHE'S FINDING A WAY OF OPENING IT AND SHE'S
NOW POSSESSED.

WHICHN'T MAKE ANY DIFFERENCE TO HER, SHE WAS SEE EVIL IN THE FIRST
PLACE, HARRY STRUGGLED.

HERMIONIE WAS BITING HER LIP, DEEP IN THOUGHT.

WE KNOW EVERYTHING IMPORTANT, HARRY WENT ON, ADDRESSING
HERMIONIE. WE KNOW THEY'VE STOPPED APPARITION IN AND OUT OF
THE

MINISTRY. WE KNOW ONLY THE MOST SENIOR MINISTRY MEMBERS ARE AL-
LOWED TO CONNECT THEIR HOMES TO THE FLEET NETWORK NOW, BECAUSE

RON HEARD THESE TWO UNSPEAKABLES COMPLAINING ABOUT IT. AND WE
KNOW EXACTLY WHERE LAMORDE'S OFFICE IS, BECAUSE OF WHAT WE
HEARD

THAT BEARDED BLEND SAYING TO HIS MATE

I'LL BE UP IN LEVEL ONE, DUMBLEDORE WANTS TO SEE ME, HERMIONIE RE-
LITED IMMEDIATELY.

EXACTLY, SAID HARRY, AND WE KNOW WE'LL GET IN USING THESE
FLIND

CHINS, HER THICKENS, HER WHATEVER THEY ARE, BECAUSE I SAW THAT WITCH-
HER-

REELING ONE FROM HER FRIEND

BUT WE HAVEN'T GOTTEN ANY!

IF THE PLAN WORKS, WE WILL HAVE, HARRY CONTINUED CALMLY,
I DIDN'T KNEEL, HARRY, I DIDN'T KNEEL, . . . THERE ARE AN ALGOL LITTLE
THINGS THAT CHILD CAN WRITE, SEE MUCH RELIES ON CHANCE, . . .

MAGIC IS MIGHT

ZK1

THAT IS BE TRUE EVEN IF WE SPEND ANOTHER THREE MONTHS PREPAR-
ING, SAID HARRY, IT'S TIME THE ACT.

HE CHILD TELL FROM RON'S AND HERMIONE'S FACES THAT THEY WERE
STARTED; HE WAS NOT PARTICULARLY CONFIDENT HIMSELF, AND YET HE WAS
SURE THE TIME HAD COME TO PUT THEIR PLAN INTO OPERATION.
THEY HAD SPENT THE PREVIOUS FEW WEEKS TAKING IT IN TURNS THE
DOWN

THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND SPY ON THE OFFICIAL ENTRANCE TO THE
MINIS-

TRY, WHICH RON, THANKS TO MR. WEASLEY, HAD KNOWN SINCE
CHILDHOOD.

THEY HAD TAILED MINISTRY WORKERS ON THEIR WAY IN, EAVESDROPPED
ON

THEIR CONVERSATIONS, AND LEARNED BY CAREFUL OBSERVATION WHICH OF
THEM CHILD BE RELIED UPON TO APPEAR, ALONE, AT THE SAME TIME EVERY
DAY. OCCASIONALLY THERE HAD BEEN A CHANCE TO SNEAK A DAILY
PROPHET

HELT UP SHEPHERD'S BRIEFCASE. SILENTLY THEY HAD UNZIPPED THE SHEPHERD'S
MAPS AND NOTES NOW STACKED IN FRONT OF HERMIONE.

ALL RIGHT, SAID RON SILENTLY, LET'S SAY WE GO FOR IT TOMORROW. . .
I THINK IT SHOULD JUST BE ME AND HARRY.

HEH, DIDN'T START THAT AGAIN? SIGHED HERMIONE. I THOUGHT WE'D
SETTLED THIS.

IT'S THE THING HANGING AROUND THE ENTRANCES UNDER THE CHAIR,
BUT THIS IS DIFFERENT, HERMIONE. RON TAPPED A FINGER AT A COPY OF
THE DAILY PROPHET DATED TEN DAYS PREVIOUSLY. WELL BE IN THE LIST
OF

MUGGLE-BORN WHO DIDN'T PRESENT THEMSELVES FOR INTERVIEW?

AND WELL BE SUPPOSED TO BE DYING OF SPATTERCREEP AT THE BURIAL?
IF ANYONE SHOULDN'T GO, IT'S HARRY, HE'S GOT A TEN-THOUSAND-
GALLON

PRICE ON HIS HEAD

FINE, I'LL STAY HERE, SAID HARRY. LET ME KNOW IF YOU EVER DEFEAT
Voldemort, WHEN? YOU?

AS RON AND HERMIONE LAUGHED, PAIN SHOT THROUGH THE STAR ON
HARRY'S FOREHEAD. HIS HAND CLUTCHED IT: HE SAW HERMIONE'S EYES

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NARROW, AND HE TRIED TO PASS OFF THE MOVEMENT BY BRUSHING HIS
HAIR

HELT UP HIS EYES.

WELL, IF ALL THREE OF US GO WE'LL HAVE THE DISAPPEARATE SEPARATELY,

REIN WAS SAYING. WE CAN'T ALL FIT UNDER THE CURTAIN ANYMORE.
HARRY'S SCAR WAS BECOMING MORE AND MORE PAINFUL. HE STOOD UP,
AT ONCE, BREACHER HURRIED FORWARD.

MASTER HAS NOT FINISHED HIS SHIP, WOULD MASTER PREFER THE
SAVING
STEW, OR ELSE THE TREADLE TART THE WHICH MASTER IS SHE PARTIAL?

THANKS, BREACHER, BUT I'LL BE BACK IN A MINUTE ER BATH-
ROOM.

AWARE THAT FERMINE WAS WATCHING HIM SUSPICIOUSLY, HARRY
HUR-
RIED UP THE STAIRS THE THE HALL AND THEN THE FIRST LANDING, WHERE
HE

DASHED INTO THE BATHROOM AND KIELT THE DEER AGAIN, GRUNTING
WITH
PAIN, HE SLUMPED OVER THE BLACK BASIN WITH ITS TAPS IN THE FORM OF
OPEN-MOUTHED SERPENTS AND CLOSED HIS EYES. . . .

HE WAS GLIDING ALONG A TWILIT STREET. THE BUILDINGS ON EITHER SIDE
OF HIM HAD HIGH, TIMBERED GABLES; THEY LOOKED LIKE GINGERBREAD
HILLS.

HE APPROACHED ONE OF THEM, THEN SAW THE WHITENESS OF HIS ELBOW

LONG-FINGERED HAND AGAINST THE DEER. HE DROVE, HE FELT A
MOMENT-
ING EXCITEMENT. . . .

THE DEER OPENED: A LAUGHING WOMAN STOOD THERE, HER FACE FELL AS
SHE LEANED INTO HARRY'S FACE: HER GREEN, TERRIBLE REPLACING IT, . . .

GREGOROVITCH SAID A HIGH, COLD VOICE,

SHE SHOOK HER HEAD: SHE WAS TRYING TO CLASP THE DEER, A WHITE
HAND HELD IT STEADY, PREVENTED HER SHUTTING HIM OUT, . . .

I WANT GREGOROVITCH,

ER WERNT HER NICKT MEIN? SHE CRIED, SHAKING HER HEAD, HE NE
LIVE HERE? HE NE LIVE HERE? I KNOW HIM NOT?

MAGIC IS MIGHT

ZKZ

ABANDONING THE ATTEMPT TO CLASP THE DEER, SHE BEGAN TO BACK
AWAY DOWN THE DARK HALL, AND HARRY FOLLOWED, GLIDING TOWARD HER,
AND HIS LONG-FINGERED HAND HAD DRAWN HIS WAND,

WHERE IS HE?

DAS WEI ICH NICHT? HE MOVE? I KNOW NOT, I KNOW NOT?

HE RAISED THE WAND, SHE SCREAMED, TWO YOUNG CHILDREN CAME
RUNNING INTO THE HALL, SHE TRIED TO SHIELD THEM WITH HER ARMS,
THERE

WAS A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT

HARRY? HARRY?

HE OPENED HIS EYES: HE HAD SLID TO THE FLOOR, HERMION WAS
PHELDING HIM THE DEER AGAIN,

HARRY, OPEN UP?

HE HAD SHUTTED OUT, HE KNEW IT, HE GOT UP AND UNSHUTTED THE DEER,

HERMINE THIPPED INSIDE AT ONCE, REGAINED HER BALANCE, AND LEANED
AROUND SUSPICIOUSLY. RON WAS RIGHT BEHIND HER, LEANING UNNERTYED
AS

HE POINTED HIS HAND INTO THE CORNERS OF THE CILLY BATHROOM.

WHAT WERE YOU DOING? ASKED HERMINE STERNLY.

WHAT DO YOU THINK I WAS DOING? ASKED HARRY WITH FEELER
BRAYADE.

YOU WERE YELLING YOUR HEAD OFF? SAID RON.

OH YES... I MUST VE BEEN OFFER

HARRY, PLEASE DON'T INSULT OUR INTELLIGENCE, SAID HERMINE, TAK-
ING DEEP BREATHS. WE KNOW YOUR SCAR FLIRT DOWNSTAIRS, AND
YOU'RE

WHITE AS A SHEET.

HARRY SAT DOWN ON THE EDGE OF THE BAT.

FINE, I VE JUST SEEN VOLDEMORT MURDERING A WOMAN, BY NOW
HE'S PROBABLY KILLED HER WHOLE FAMILY, AND HE DIDN'T NEED THEM. IT WAS
LEON ALL OVER AGAIN, THEY WERE JUST THERE...

HARRY, YOU AREN'T SUPPOSED TO LET THIS HAPPEN ANYMORE?

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HERMINE CRIED, HER VOICE ECHOING THROUGH THE BATHROOM. DUM-
BLEDORE WANTED YOU THE LIE ELLUMENCY? HE THOUGHT THE
CONNECTION

WAS DANGEROUS. VILDEMERT CAN USE IT, HARRY? WHAT GOOD IS IT THE
WATCH HIM KILL AND TORTURE, HOW CAN IT HELP?

BECAUSE IT MEANS I KNOW WHAT HE'S DOING, SAID HARRY.

SEE WHY HE NEET EVEN GOING THE TRY THE SHUT HIM OUT?

HERMIONE, I CAN'T. WHY KNOW I'M HELD AT HELLMONEY, I NEVER
GET THE HAND OF IT.

WHY NEVER REALLY TRIED? SHE SAID HEETLY. I DIDN'T GET IT, HARRY
DO WHY LIKE HAVING THIS SPECIAL CONNECTION HER RELATIONSHIP HER
WHAT. WHATEVER

SHE FALTERED UNDER THE LOOK HE GAVE HER AS HE STOOD UP.

LIKE IT? HE SAID HEETLY. WOULD WHY LIKE IT?

I. NO. I'M SORRY, HARRY, I DIDN'T MEAN

I HATE IT, I HATE THE FACT THAT HE CAN GET INSIDE ME, THAT I HAVE THE
WATCH HIM WHEN HE'S MOST DANGEROUS, BUT I'M GOING THE USE IT.

BLUNDERBIRE

FORGET BLUNDERBIRE. THIS IS MY CHOICE, NOBODY ELSE'S. I WANT THE
KNOW WHY HE'S AFTER GREGORYVITCH.

WHY?

HE'S A FOREIGN HANDMAKER, SAID HARRY. HE MADE DRUM'S HAND
AND DRUM BELIEVES HE'S BRILLIANT.

BUT ACCORDING THE WHY, SAID REEN, VILDEMERT'S GET ELLIVANDER
LOCKED UP SOMEWHERE. IF HE'S ALREADY GET A HANDMAKER, WHAT DOES
HE NEED ANOTHER ONE FOR?

MAYBE HE AGREES WITH DRUM, MAYBE HE THINKS GREGORYVITCH
IS BETTER... OR ELSE HE THINKS GREGORYVITCH WILL BE ABLE THE EXPLAIN
WHAT MY HAND DID WHEN HE WAS CHASING ME, BECAUSE ELLIVANDER

DIDN'T KNOW.

MAGIC IS MIGHT

ZKS

HARRY GLANCED INTO THE CRACKED, DUSTY MIRROR AND SAW RON AND HERMIONE EXCHANGING SKEPTICAL LOOKS BEHIND HIS BACK.

HARRY, WHO KEPT TALKING ABOUT WHAT THEIR WAND DID, SAID HERMIONE, BUT WHO MADE IT HAPPEN? WHO ARE YOU SO DETERMINED NOT

TO TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR YOUR OWN POWER?

BECAUSE I KNOW IT WASN'T ME? AND SHE DOES VULDERBERT, HERMIONE? WE BOTH KNOW WHAT REALLY HAPPENED?

THEY GLARED AT EACH OTHER: HARRY KNEW THAT HE HAD NOT CONVINCED HERMIONE AND THAT SHE WAS MARSHALLING COUNTERARGUMENTS,

AGAINST BOTH HIS THEORY AND HIS WAND AND THE FACT THAT HE WAS PERMITTING HIMSELF TO GET INTO VULDERBERT'S MIND. THEN HIS RELIEF, RON

INTERVENED.

DROPPED IT, HE ADVISED HER. IT'S UP TO HIM, AND IF WE'RE GOING TO THE MINISTRY TOMORROW, DON'T YOU REMEMBER WE SHOULD GO OVER THE PLAN?

RELUCTANTLY, AS THE OTHER TWO CHILD TELL, HERMIONE LET THE MAT-
TER REST, THOUGH HARRY WAS WHITE SURE SHE WOULD ATTACK AGAIN AT
THE

FIRST OPPORTUNITY. IN THE MEANTIME, THEY RETURNED TO THE BASEMENT
KITCHEN, WHERE BREAKER SERVED THEM ALL STEW AND TREACLE TART.
THEY DID NOT GET TO BED UNTIL LATE THAT NIGHT, AFTER SPENDING
HOURS

GOING OVER AND OVER THEIR PLAN UNTIL THEY COULD RECITE IT, WORD
PER-

FECT, TO EACH OTHER. HARRY, WHO WAS NOW SLEEPING IN SIRIUS'S
ROOM, LAY

IN BED WITH HIS WANDLIGHT TRAINED ON THE OLD PHOTOGRAPH OF HIS
FA-

THER, SIRIUS, LUPIN, AND PETTIGREW, AND MUTTERED THE PLAN TO
HIMSELF

FOR ANOTHER TEN MINUTES. AS HE EXTINGUISHED HIS WAND, HOWEVER,
HE

WAS THINKING NOT OF PERILIOUS POTION, POISONING PASTILLES, OR THE
NAVY

BLUE BOOKS OF MAGICAL MAINTENANCE; HE THOUGHT OF GREGOROVITCH
THE

WANDMAKER, AND HOW LONG HE COULD KEEP THEM REMAIN HIDDEN WHILE
VOLDEMORT SIGHT HIM SO DETERMINEDLY.

CHAPTER TWELVE

222

DAWN SEEMED THE FALLEEN MIDNIGHT WITH INDICENT FASTE.

YELL WHEE TERRIBLE, WAS REEN S GREETING AS HE ENTERED THE REEM
THE WAKE FARRY.

NEET PER WERE, SAID FARRY, PALNING.

THEY FELND FERMINE DELNSTAIRS IN THE KITCHEN. SHE WAS BEING
SERVED CHEPP AND FET REELS BY KREACHER AND WEARING THE SLIGHTLY
MANIC EXPRESSTEN THAT FARRY ASSOCIATED WITH EXAM REVIEW.

REES, SHE SAID LINDER HER BREATH, ACKNOWLEDGING THEIR PRESENCE
WITH A NERVELIS NED AND CHENTINLING THE PERKE ARELND IN HER READED
BAG, PERYLICE PERTIEN ... INVISIBILITY CLEAD ... DECHY DETERNATERS
... YELL SEELND EACH TAKE A CHELPLE ILST IN CASE ... PLIXING
PASTILLES.

NEESKEED NEHLEAT, EXTENDABLE PARS ...

THEY CLIMPED DELND THEIR BREAKFAST, THEN SET HFF LIPSTAIRS, KREACHER
KEHLING THEM ELT AND PREMISING THE HAVE A STEAD-AND-KIDNEY PIE
READY PER THEM WHEN THEY RETLRND.

BLESS HIM, SAID REEN FENDLY, AND WHEN YELL THIND I LIKED THE PAN-
TASIZR ARELT CLITTING HFF HIS HEAD AND STICKING IT HEN THE WALL.

THEY MADE THEIR WAY HENTH THE FREENT STEP WITH IMPENSE CALTIEN:
THEY CHELD SEE A CHELPLE HF PLIPPY-EYED DEATH EATERS WATCHING THE
FELISE PERM ACRESS THE MISTY SEELARE.

FERMINE DISAPPARATED WITH REEN FIRST, THEN CAME BACK PER

HARRY,

AFTER THE USUAL BRIEF SPELL OF DARKNESS AND NEAR SUFFOCATION,
HARRY

FOUND HIMSELF IN THE TINY ALLEYWAY WHERE THE FIRST PHASE OF THEIR
PLAN WAS SCHEDULED TO TAKE PLACE. IT WAS AS YET DESERTED, EXCEPT FOR
A COUPLE OF LARGE BINS; THE FIRST MINISTRY WORKERS DID NOT USUALLY
APPEAR HERE UNTIL AT LEAST EIGHT O'CLOCK.

RIGHT THEN, SAID HERMIONE, CHECKING HER WATCH. SHE THOUGHT THE
BE HERE IN ABOUT FIVE MINUTES. WHEN I'VE STUNNED HER

MAGIC IS MIGHT

ZZZ

HERMIONE, WE KNOW, SAID RON STERNLY. AND I THOUGHT WE WERE
SUPPOSED TO OPEN THE DOOR BEFORE SHE GOT HERE?

HERMIONE SNEEZED.

I NEARLY FORGOT! STAND BACK

SHE POINTED HER WAND AT THE PABLOCKED AND HEAVILY GRAFFITIED FIRE
DOOR BESIDE THEM, WHICH FIRST OPENED WITH A CRASH. THE DARK
CORRIDOR

BEHIND IT LED, AS THEY KNEW FROM THEIR CAREFUL SCOUTING TRIPS, INTO
AN

EMPTY THEATER. HERMIONE PULLED THE DOOR BACK TOWARD HER, THE MAKE
IT LOOK AS THOUGH IT WAS STILL CLOSED.

AND NOW, SHE SAID, TURNING BACK THE FACE THE OTHER TWO IN THE
ALLEYWAY, WE PUT ON THE MASKS AGAIN

AND WE WAIT, RON FINISHED, THROWING IT OVER HERMIONE'S HEAD

LIKE A BLANKET OVER A FIREPLACE AND ROLLING HIS EYES AT FARRY,
LITTLE MORE THAN A MINUTE LATER, THERE WAS A TINY PEEP AND A LITTLE
MINISTRY WITCH WITH SILVER GRAY HAIR APPARATED FEET FROM THEM,
BLINKING A LITTLE IN THE SUDDEN BRIGHTNESS; THE SLIN HAD JUST COME
HELT
FROM BEHIND A CHAIR. SHE BARELY HAD TIME TO ENJOY THE UNEXPECTED
WARMTH, HOWEVER, BEFORE HERMINE'S SILENT STUNNING SPELL HIT
HER
IN THE CHEST AND SHE TOPPLED OVER.

NICELY DONE, HERMINE, SAID RENN, EMERGING FROM BEHIND A
KIN BESIDE THE THEATER DEER AS FARRY THREW OFF THE INVISIBILITY
LEAD.

TOGETHER THEY CARRIED THE LITTLE WITCH INTO THE DARK PASSAGEWAY
THAT
LED BACKSTAGE. HERMINE PLUCKED A FEW HAIRS FROM THE WITCH'S HEAD
AND ADDED THEM TO A PILE OF MILDLY PEBBLY PENTHIN SHE HAD TAKEN
FROM THE BEADED BAG. RENN WAS RUMMAGING THROUGH THE LITTLE
WITCH'S
HANDS.

SHE'S MARALDA HEMLOCK, HE SAID, READING A SMALL CARD THAT IDENTIFIED THEIR VICTIM AS AN ASSISTANT IN THE IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC.

WELL, I BETTER TAKE THIS, HERMINE, AND HERE ARE THE TREASURES.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE

HE PASSED HER SEVERAL SMALL CHILDEN CHINS, ALL EMBESSED WITH THE LETTERS M.E.M., WHICH HE HAD TAKEN FROM THE WITCH'S PURSE.

HERMINE BRAND THE PERSILICE POTION, WHICH WAS NOW A PLEASANT MELTHEREE CUP, AND WITHIN SECONDS STEED BEHRE THEM, THE DELKE OF MARALDA HERDERS. AS SHE REMOVED MARALDA'S SPECTACLES AND PUT THEM ON, HARRY CHECKED HIS WATCH.

WE'RE RUNNING LATE, MR. MAGICAL MAINTENANCE WILL BE HERE ANY SECOND.

THEY FLURRIED THE CHESE THE DEER ON THE REAL MARALDA; HARRY AND

REN THREW THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK OVER THEMSELVES BUT HERMINE REMAINED IN VIEW, WAITING. SECONDS LATER THERE WAS ANOTHER PEEP, AND

A SMALL, FRETTY-LOOKING WIZARD APPEARED BEHRE THEM.

HI, HELLO, MARALDA.

HELLO? SAID HERMINE IN A HILAYERY VOICE. HOW ARE YOU TODAY?

NOT SO GOOD, ACTUALLY, REPLIED THE LITTLE WIZARD, WHO LOOKED TEHRRELYLY DEHNICAST.

AS HERMINE AND THE WIZARD HEADED FOR THE MAIN ROAD, HARRY AND REN CREEPT ALONG BEHIND THEM.

I'M SORRY THE HEAR YOU'RE UNDER THE WEATHER, SAID HERMINE, TALKING FIRMLY EVER THE LITTLE WIZARD AS HE TRIED THE EXPELLING UPON HIS PROBLEMS; IT WAS ESSENTIAL TO STOP HIM FROM REACHING THE STREET.

HERE, HAVE A SWEET,

EEK EEE, NEH THANKS

I INSIST! SAID HERMINEE AGGRESSIVELY, SHAKING THE BAG OF
PASTILLES

IN HIS FACE, BEHINDING RATHER ALARMED, THE LITTLE WIZARD THREW ONE.
THE EFFECT WAS INSTANTANEOUS, THE MOMENT THE PASTILLE TOUCHED
HIS TONGUE, THE LITTLE WIZARD STARTED VOMITING SHE HAD THAT HE DID

MAGIC IS MIGHT

ZKZ

NOT EVEN NOTICE AS HERMINEE YANKED A HANDFUL OF HAIRS FROM THE
THEP

OF HIS HEAD,

EEH DEAR! SHE SAID, AS HE SPLATTERED THE ALLEY WITH SICK. PERHAPS
YELL D BETTER TAKE THE DAY OFF?

NEH NEH! HE CHOKED AND RETCHED, TRYING TO CONTINUE IN HIS
WAY DESPITE BEING UNABLE TO WALK STRAIGHT. I MUST TODAY
MUST

EEH

BUT THAT'S JUST SILLY! SAID HERMINEE, ALARMED, YELL CAN'T GO TO
WORK IN THIS STATE I THINK YELL MIGHT GO TO ST. MUNGUS
AND

GET THEM THE SHIRT YELL WENT!

THE WIZARD HAD COLLAPSED, HEAVING, WITHOUT ALL FEELING, STILL TRYING TO
CRAWL TOWARD THE MAIN STREET,

YELL SIMPLY CAN'T GO TO WORK LIKE THIS! CRIED HERMINEE,

AT LAST HE SEEMED TO ACCEPT THE TRUTH OF HER WORDS, LINGERING A RE-
PULSED HERMIONE THE CLAW HIS WAY BACK INTO A STANDING POSITION,
HE

TURNED ON THE SPOT AND VANISHED, LEAVING NOTHING BEHIND BUT THE
BAG REEN HAD SNATCHED FROM HIS HAND AS HE WENT AND SOME FLYING
CLINGS OF VOMIT.

WELL, SAID HERMIONE, PULLING UP THE SKIRTS OF HER DRESS TO AVOID
THE PROBLEMS OF SIZE. IT WOULD HAVE MADE MUCH LESS MESS TO STUN
HIM THERE.

YEAH, SAID REEN, EMERGING FROM UNDER THE CLOAK HOLDING THE
WIZARD'S BAG, BUT I STILL THINK A WHOLE PILE OF LINCHSKIN'S REEDS
WOULD HAVE DRAWN MORE ATTENTION, BEEN ON HIS MIND, THOUGH, ISN'T
HE? CLING TO THE HAIR AND THE POSITION, THEN.

WITHIN TWO MINUTES, REEN STOOD BEFORE THEM, AS SMALL AND FURTHER
AS THE SICK WIZARD, AND WEARING THE NAVY BLUE DRESS THAT HAD BEEN
HIDDEN IN HIS BAG.

CHAPTER TWELVE

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WELL HE WASN'T WEARING THEM TODAY, WASN'T IT, SEEING HOW MUCH
HE WANTED THE GIFT ANYWAY, I'M REG LATTERMERE, ACCORDING TO THE
LABEL IN THE BAG.

NEED WAIT HERE, HERMIONE TOLD HARRY, WHO WAS STILL UNDER THE

INVISIBILITY CLOAK, AND WE'LL BE BACK WITH SOME HAIRS FOR YOU.

HE HAD TO WAIT TEN MINUTES, BUT IT SEEMED MUCH LONGER TO

HARRY, STANDING ALONE IN THE SICK-SPLATTERED ALLEYWAY BESIDE THE
DEER CHUCKLING THE STUNNED MAFALDA. FINALLY REEN AND FERMINE
REAPPEARED.

WE DON'T KNOW WHO HE IS, FERMINE SAID, PASSING HARRY SEVERAL
CURLY BLACK HAIRS, BUT HE'S GONE HOME WITH A DREADFUL NECKLACE;
HERE, HE'S PRETTY TALL, YOU'LL NEED BIGGER RINGS, . . .

SHE PULLED OUT A SET OF THE OLD RINGS REACHER HAD LINGERED FOR
THEM, AND HARRY RETIRED TO TAKE THE POTION AND CHANGE.

SINCE THE PAINFUL TRANSFORMATION WAS COMPLETE HE WAS MORE THAN
SIX FEET TALL AND, FROM WHAT HE COULD TELL FROM HIS WELL-MUSCLED
ARMS,

POWERFULLY BUILT, HE ALSO HAD A BEARD. STEALING THE INVISIBILITY
CLOAK

AND HIS GLASSES INSIDE HIS NEW RINGS, HE REFINED THE OTHER TWO.

KLIMPY, THAT'S SCARY, SAID REEN, LEERING UP AT HARRY, WHO NOW
THELDERED OVER HIM.

TAKE ONE OF MAFALDA'S THINGS, FERMINE TOLD HARRY, AND LET'S
GO, IT'S NEARLY NINE.

THEY STOPPED OUT OF THE ALLEYWAY TOGETHER, FIFTY YARDS ALONG THE
CRACKED PAVEMENT THERE WERE SPIDED BLACK RAILINGS FLANKING THE
FLIGHTS OF STEPS, ONE LABELED GENTLEMEN, THE OTHER LADIES.

SEE YOU IN A MOMENT, THEN, SAID FERMINE NERVOUSLY, AND SHE

THELDERED OFF DOWN THE STEPS THE LADIES, HARRY AND REEN HEARD A NUM-
BER OF NOBLY DRESSED MEN DESCENDING INTO WHAT APPEARED TO BE AN HR-

DINARY LINDERGHEIM PUBLIC THEATRE, TILED IN GRIMY BLACK AND WHITE.

MAGIC IS MIGHT

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MORNING, REG? CALLED ANOTHER WIZARD IN NAVY BLUE ROBES AS HE
LET HIMSELF INTO A CLOSET BY INSERTING HIS CHILDEN TROUSERS INTO A SLEET
IN THE DOOR. BLEEMING PAIN IN THE ELM, THIS, EH? FEELING LIS ALL
THE GET THE WHERS THIS WAY? WHEN ARE THEY EXPECTING THE TOWN WIP,
HARRY

PETTER?

THE WIZARD BEHAVED WITH LAUGHTER AT HIS OWN WIT, THEN GAVE A
PHELED

CHUCKLE.

YEAH, HE SAID, STUPID, ISN'T IT?

AND HE AND HARRY LET THEMSELVES INTO ADJOINING CLOSETS.

THE HARRY'S LEFT AND RIGHT CAME THE SOUND OF FLOSSING, HE
CRACKLED

DOWN AND PEERED THROUGH THE GAP AT THE BENTHEM OF THE CLOSET,
LIST

IN TIME THE SAW A PAIR OF BENTHEM FEET CLIMBING INTO THE THEATRE NEXT
DOOR.

HE BENDED LEFT AND SAW REG BLINKING AT HIM.

WE HAVE THE FLOSSI THEMSELVES IN? HE WHISPERED.

SEEMS LIKE IT, HARRY WHISPERED BACK, HIS VOICE CAME OUT DEEP
AND GRAVELLY.

THEY BOTH STOOD UP, FEELING EXCEPTIONALLY FOOLISH. HARRY CLAM-
BERED INTO THE THICKET.

HE KNEW AT ONCE THAT HE HAD DONE THE RIGHT THING; THOUGH HE AP-
PEARED TO BE STANDING IN WATER, HIS SHOES, FEET, AND REEFS REMAINED

BLISTE DRY. HE REACHED UP, PULLED THE CHAIN, AND NEXT MOMENT HAD
ZOOMED DOWN A SHORT CHUTE, EMERGING OUT OF A FIREPLACE INTO THE
MINISTRY OF MAGIC.

HE GOT UP CLIMBLY; THERE WAS A LOT MORE OF HIS BODY THAN HE
WAS ACCUSTOMED TO. THE GREAT ATRIUM SEEMED DARKER THAN HARRY
REMEMBERED IT. PREVIOUSLY A GILDEN CHLINTAIN HAD FILLED THE CENTER
OF

THE HALL, CASTING SHIMMERING SPEETS OF LIGHT OVER THE POLISHED
WOODEN

FLOOR AND WALLS. NOW A GIGANTIC STATUE OF BLACK STONE DOMINATED THE
SCENE.

IT WAS RATHER FRIGHTENING, THIS VAST SCULPTURE OF A WITCH
AND

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE

A WIZARD SITTING IN ELABORATELY CARVED THRONES, LEERING DOWN AT THE
MINISTRY WORKERS TROOPING OUT OF FIREPLACES BEHIND THEM.
ENGRAVED

IN FOOT-HIGH LETTERS AT THE BASE OF THE STATUE WERE THE WORDS MAGIC

IS MIGHT.

HARRY RECEIVED A HEAVY BLOW ON THE BACK OF THE LEGS; ANOTHER
WIZARD HAD JUST FLEWN OUT OF THE FIREPLACE BEHIND HIM.

OUT OF THE WAY, CAN'T YOU SEE, SHIRAZ, RUNCERN?

CLEARLY FRIGHTENED, THE BALDING WIZARD FLURRIED AWAY. APPAR-
ENTLY THE MAN WITH WHOM HARRY WAS IMPERSONATING, RUNCERN, WAS
INTIMIDATING.

PAST? SAID A VOICE, AND HE WHISKED AROUND TO SEE A WISPY LITTLE
WITCH AND THE FERRETY WIZARD FROM MAGICAL MAINTENANCE GESTURING
TOWARD HIM FROM OVER BESIDE THE STATUE. HARRY HASTENED TO JOIN THEM.

YOU GET IN ALL RIGHT, THEN? HERMIONE WHISPERED TO HARRY.

NO, HE'S STILL STUCK IN THE KICK, SAID RON.

HE'S VERY FLINDY . . . IT'S TERRIBLE, ISN'T IT? SHE SAID TO HARRY, WHO
WAS STARING UP AT THE STATUE. HAVE YOU SEEN WHAT THEY'RE
SITTING

ON?

HARRY WHISKED MORE CLOSERLY AND REALIZED THAT WHAT HE HAD THOUGHT
WERE DECORATIVELY CARVED THRONES WERE ACTUALLY THOUSANDS OF CARVED
FILMSTARS! HUNDREDS AND HUNDREDS OF NAKED KIDIES, MEN, WOMEN,
AND CHILDREN, ALL WITH RATHER STUPID, UGLY FACES, TWISTED AND PRESSED
TOGETHER TO SUPPORT THE WEIGHT OF THE HANDSOMELY BEHEADED WIZARDS.

MURKINS, WHISPERED HERMIONE. IN THEIR RIGHTFUL PLACE, THEY
SHOULD BE GETTING ON.

THEY JOINED THE STREAM OF WITCHES AND WIZARDS MOVING TOWARD

THE GILDED GATES AT THE END OF THE HALL, LEERING AROUND AS
SLURPETY-

TIDILY AS POSSIBLE, BUT THERE WAS NO SIGN OF THE DISTINCTIVE FIGURE
OF

DELMER LIMERIDGE. THEY PASSED THROUGH THE GATES AND INTO A
SMALLER

MAGIC IS MIGHT

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HALL, WHERE ELEVATORS WERE FORMING IN FRONT OF TWENTY GILDED GRILLES
FEELING AS MANY LIFTS. THEY HAD BARELY THOUGHT THE NEAREST ONE
WHEN

A VOICE SAID, CATTERMERE?

THEY LOOKED AROUND: HARRY'S STOMACH TURNED OVER. ONE OF THE
DEATH EATERS WHO HAD WITNESSED DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH WAS STRIDING
TOWARD THEM. THE MINISTRY WORKERS BESIDE THEM FELL SILENT, THEIR
EYES DOWNCAST; HARRY COULD FEEL FEAR RIPPLING THROUGH THEM. THE
MAN'S SNEERING, SLIGHTLY BRUTISH FACE WAS SHYPTENED AT HODS WITH
HIS

MAGNIFICENT, SLEEPING REEKS, WHICH WERE EMBROIDERED WITH MUCH

GOLD THREAD. SOMEONE IN THE CROWD AROUND THE LIFTS CALLED
STEPHAN-

TICALLY, MERRING, JAXLEY? JAXLEY IGNORED THEM.

I REQUESTED SOMEONE FROM MAGICAL MAINTENANCE THE SHORT ELIT
MY OFFICE, CATTERMERE. IT'S STILL RAINING IN THERE.

RENN LOOKED AROUND AS THOUGH HOPING SOMEONE ELSE WOULD IN-
TERVENE, BUT NOBODY SPoke.

RAINING . . . IN YOUR OFFICE? THAT'S . . . THAT'S NOT GOOD, IS IT?
RENN GAVE A NERVOUS LAUGH. JAXLEY'S EYES WIDENED.

YOU THINK IT'S FLIRTY, CATTERMERE, DO YOU?
A PAIR OF WITCHES BROKE AWAY FROM THE BELLEVUE FOR THE LIFT AND
BLISTLED OFF.

NEH, SAID RENN, NEH, OF COURSE

YOU REALIZE THAT I AM ON MY WAY DOWNSTAIRS TO INTERVIEW
YOUR

WIFE, CATTERMERE? IN FACT, I'M WHITE SURPRISED YOU'RE NOT DOWN
THERE

HOLDING HER HAND WHILE SHE WAITS, ALREADY GIVEN HER UP AS A BAD
JOK, HAVE YOU? PROBABLY WISE. BE SURE AND MARRY A POLICEWOMAN NEXT
TIME.

BERMINE HAD LET ELIT A LITTLE SEALAD OF HERSELF. JAXLEY LOOKED AT
HER. SHE CHUCKLED FREELY AND TURNED AWAY.

I I STAMMERED RENN.

CHAPTER TWELVE

BUT IF MY WIFE WERE ACCUSED OF BEING A MURDERER, SAID YAKLEY,
NEET THAT AND LIEMAN I MARRIED WOULD EVER BE MISTAKEN FOR
SUCH-

FIFTH AND THE HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCE-
MENT NEEDED A JOB DOING, I WOULD MAKE IT MY PRIORITY TO SEE THAT

THE, CATTERMERE, DID FEEL UNDERSTAND ME?

YES, WHISPERED REIN,

THEN ATTEND TO IT, CATTERMERE, AND IF MY OFFICE IS NOT COMPLETELY
DRY WITHIN AN HOUR, YOUR WIFE'S LEGAL STATUS WILL BE IN EVEN
GRAYER

DEEPER THAN IT IS NOW,

THE GILDED GRILLE BEFORE THEM CLATTERED OPEN, WITH A RING AND

UNPLEASANT SMILE THE HARRY, WHO WAS EVIDENTLY EXPECTED THE
APPRECI-

ATE THIS TREATMENT OF CATTERMERE, YAKLEY SWIFT AWAY THEWARD
ANOTHER

LIFT, HARRY, REIN, AND HERMIONE ENTERED THEIRS, BUT NEITHER FELLED
THEM: IT WAS AS IF THEY WERE INEFFECTUAL. THE GRILLES SHUT WITH A
CLANG

AND THE LIFT BEGAN TO MOVE UPWARD,

WHAT AM I GOING TO DO? REIN ASKED THE OTHER TWO AT ONCE; HE
LOOKED STRICKEN. IF I DON'T TURN UP, MY WIFE I MEAN,
CATTERMERE'S
WIFE

WE'LL COME WITH YOU, WE SHOULD STICK TOGETHER BEGAN
HARRY, BUT THEN SHOOK HIS HEAD FEVERISHLY.

THAT'S MENTAL, WE HAVEN'T GOT MUCH TIME. YOU TWO FIND LIM-
BRIDGE, I'LL GO AND SORT OUT PAXLEY'S OFFICE BUT WHEN DO I STOP IT

RAINING?

TRY FINITE INCANTATIONS, SAID HERMIONE AT ONCE, THAT SHOULD
STOP

THE RAIN IF IT'S A HEX OR CURSE; IF IT DOESN'T, SOMETHING'S GOING
WRONG

WITH AN ATMOSPHERIC CHARM, WHICH WILL BE MORE DIFFICULT TO FIX, SEE
AS AN INTERIM MEASURE TRY IMPERVIOUS TO PROTECT HIS BELONGINGS

SAY IT AGAIN, SILENCE SAID RON, SEARCHING HIS POCKETS DES-
PERATELY FOR A HULL, BUT AT THAT MOMENT THE LIFT JOLTERED TO A HALT.

MAGIC IS MIGHT

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A DISMEMBERED FEMALE VOICE SAID, LEVEL FLOOR, DEPARTMENT FOR THE
REGULATION AND CONTROL OF MAGICAL CREATURES, INTERPRETING
BEAST,

KING, AND SPIRIT DIVISIONS, CHIEFLY LIAISON OFFICE, AND PEST ADVI-

SEEN BY REAL, AND THE GRILLES SLID OPEN AGAIN, ADMITTING A CLOUD OF
OF

WIZARDS AND SEVERAL PALE VIOLET PAPER AIRPLANES THAT FLUTTERED
AROUND

THE LAMP IN THE CEILING OF THE LIFT.

MORNING, ALBERT, SAID A SLIGHTLY WHISKERED MAN, SMILING AT
HARRY. HE GLANCED OVER AT RON AND HERMION AS THE LIFT CREAKED

UPWARD ONCE MORE; HERMION WAS NOW WHISPERING FRANTIC
INSTRUCTIONS-

THINGS TO RON. THE WIZARD LEANED TOWARD HARRY, LEERING, AND MUT-
TERED, DIRTY CRESSWELL, IT'S FROM GRIFFIN BLOODSUCKER NICE ONE, ALBERT.

I'M PRETTY CONFIDENT I'LL GET HIS ONE NOW.

HE WINCED, HARRY SMILED BACK, HOPING THAT THIS WOULD SUFFICE.

THE LIFT STOPPED; THE GRILLES OPENED ONCE MORE.

LEVEL TWO, DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT, INCLUDING
THE IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC OFFICE, ALBION HEADQUARTERS, AND

WIZENGAMPT ADMINISTRATIVE SERVICES, SAID THE DISMEMBERED WITCH'S
VOICE.

HARRY SAW HERMION GIVE RON A LITTLE PUSH AND HE HURRIED OUT
OF

THE LIFT, FOLLOWED BY THE OTHER WIZARDS, LEAVING HARRY AND
HERMION

ALONE. THE MOMENT THE GILDED DOOR HAD CLOSED HERMION SAID, VERY

FAST, ACTUALLY, HARRY, I THINK I'D BETTER GO AFTER HIM, I DON'T
THINK HE

KNOWS WHAT HE'S DOING AND IF HE GETS CAUGHT THE WHOLE THING

LEVEL ONE, MINISTER OF MAGIC AND SLIPPERY STAFF,

THE GILDED GRILLES SLID APART AGAIN AND HERMIONE GASPED, FEELING

PEOPLE STOOD BEFORE THEM, TWO OF THEM DEEP IN CONVERSATION: A
LONG-

HAired WIZARD WEARING MAGNIFICENT RINGS OF BLACK AND GOLD, AND A

SENIOR, THUNDER WITCH WEARING A VELVET RING IN HER SHORT HAIR AND
CLUTCHING A CLIPBOARD TO HER CHEST,

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

THE

THE MUGGLE-BORN

REGISTRATION

COMMISSION

“MAYBE,” SAID LAMBERT, LOOKING AT HERMIONE. “TRAY-
ERS SENT YOU, DID HE?”

“YES,” SHE SAID HERMIONE.

“GOOD, YOU’LL BE PERFECTLY WELL,” LAMBERT SAID TO THE WIZARD

IN BLACK AND GOLD. THAT'S THAT PROBLEM SOLVED, MINISTER, IF MAFALDA CAN BE SPARED HER RECORD-KEEPING WE SHALL BE ABLE TO START

STRAIGHTAWAY. SHE CONSULTED HER CLIPBOARD. TEN PEOPLE TODAY AND ONE OF THEM THE WIFE OF A MINISTRY EMPLOYEE? TLT, TLT... EVEN HERE, IN THE HEART OF THE MINISTRY? SHE STEPPED INTO THE LIFT BESIDE HERMIONE, AS DID THE TWO WIZARDS WHO HAD BEEN LISTENING TO LIMPURGE'S CONVERSATION WITH THE MINISTER. WE'LL GO STRAIGHT DOWN, MAFALDA, YOU'LL FIND EVERYTHING YOU NEED IN THE CHLWTRHEEM. GOOD MORNING, ALBERT, AREN'T YOU GETTING HEAT?

YES, HE CHIRPED, SAID HARRY IN BLINCHER'S DEEP VOICE. HARRY STEPPED OUT OF THE LIFT. THE GOLDEN GRILLES CHANGED SLIT BEHIND HIM. GLANCING OVER HIS SHOULDER, HARRY SAW HERMIONE'S

☆

THE MUGGLE-BORN REGISTRATION COMMISSION

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ANDREWS'S FACE SINKING BACK OUT OF SIGHT, A TALL WIZARD ON EITHER SIDE OF

HER, LIMPURGE'S VELVET HAIR-HEELS LEVEL WITH HER SHOULDER.

WHAT BRINGS YOU UP HERE, BLINCHER? ASKED THE NEW MINISTER OF MAGIC. HIS LONG BLACK HAIR AND BEARD WERE STREAKED WITH SILVER, AND A GREAT OVERHANGING FOREHEAD SHADOWED HIS GLINTING EYES, PLUTTING HARRY IN MIND OF A CRAB LEEDING OUT FROM BENEATH A ROCK.

NEEDED A HELICOPTER WITH. HARRY HESITATED FOR A FRACTION OF A SECOND. ARTHUR WEASLEY, SOMEONE SAID HE WAS UP AND LEVEL HERE.

HE SAID PILES THICKNESS. HAS HE BEEN CAUGHT HAVING CONTACT WITH AN UNDESIRABLE?

NO, SAID HARRY, HIS THERMIST DRY. NO, NOTHING LIKE THAT.

HE, WELL, IT'S ONLY A MATTER OF TIME, SAID THICKNESS. IF YOU ASK ME, THE BLEED TRAITERS ARE AS BAD AS THE MURDERERS, GOOD DAY, BLINCHER.

GOOD DAY, MINISTER.

HARRY WATCHED THICKNESS MARCH AWAY ALONG THE THICKLY CARPETED CORRIDOR. THE MOMENT THE MINISTER HAD PASSED OUT OF SIGHT, HARRY

TUGGED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK OUT FROM UNDER HIS HEAVY BLACK CLOAK,

THREW IT OVER HIMSELF, AND SET OFF ALONG THE CORRIDOR IN THE OPPOSITE

DIRECTION. BLINCHER WAS SO TALL THAT HARRY WAS FORCED TO STEEPEN THE MAKE SURE HIS BIG FEET WERE HIDDEN.

PANIC PULSED IN THE PIT OF HIS STOMACH. AS HE PASSED GLAMING WHEDEN DEER AFTER GLAMING WHEDEN DEER, EACH BEARING A SMALL PLaque WITH THE OWNER'S NAME AND OCCUPATION UPON IT, THE MIGHT OF THE MINISTRY, ITS COMPLEXITY, ITS IMPENETRABILITY, SEEMED TO SMACK ITSELF UPON HIM SO THAT THE PLAN HE HAD BEEN CAREFULLY CONSTRUCTING WITH RON AND HERMIONIE OVER THE PAST FEW WEEKS SEEMED LAUGHABLY

CHILDISH. THEY HAD CONCENTRATED ALL THEIR EFFORTS ON GETTING INSIDE WITHOUT BEING DETECTED! THEY HAD NOT GIVEN A MOMENT'S THOUGHT TO

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WHAT THEY WOULD DO IF THEY WERE FORCED TO SEPARATE. NOW HERMION WAS STUCK IN COURT PROCEEDINGS, WHICH WOULD UNDOUBTEDLY LAST

HOURS; BEEN WAS STRUGGLING TO DO MAGIC THAT HARRY WAS SURE WAS BEYOND HIM, A WIZARD'S LIBERTY PHOTICALLY DEPENDING ON THE MUTE; AND HE, HARRY, WAS WANDERING AROUND ON THE TOP FLOOR WHEN HE KNEW PERFECTLY WELL THAT HIS HARRY HAD JUST GONE DOWN IN THE LIFT.

HE STOPPED WALKING, LEANED AGAINST A WALL, AND TRIED TO DECIDE WHAT TO DO. THE SILENCE PRESSED UPON HIM; THERE WAS NO WHISTLING OR TALK OR SWIFT FEETSTEPS HERE; THE PURPLE-CARPETED HALLWAYS WERE

AS FLUSHED AS THOUGH THE MUFFLIATE CHARM HAD BEEN CAST EVERYWHERE.

HIS OFFICE MUST BE UP HERE, HARRY THOUGHT.

IT SEEMED MOST UNLIKELY THAT LAMBRIDGE WOULD KEEP HER JEWELRY IN HER OFFICE, BUT ON THE OTHER HAND IT SEEMED ABSOLUTELY NOT THE SEARCH

IT TO MAKE SURE. HE THEREFORE SET OFF ALONG THE HALLWAY AGAIN, PASS-

ING NEARBY BUT A FROTHING WIZARD WHO WAS MURMURING INSTRUCT-

THENS THE A HILL THAT APPEARED IN FRONT OF HIM, STRIKING HIM A TRAIL
OF

PARCHMENT.

WHEN PAYING ATTENTION THE THE NAMES IN THE BOOKS, HARRY TURNED
A CORNER. FOLLOWING ALONG THE NEXT CORRIDOR HE EMERGED INTO A WIDE,
OPEN SPACE WHERE A DOZEN WITCHES AND WIZARDS SAT IN ROWS AT SMALL
DESKS NOT LIKE SCHOOL DESKS, THOUGH MUCH MORE HIGHLY FINISHED
AND FREE FROM GRAFFITI. HARRY PAUSED TO WATCH THEM, FOR THE EFFECT
WAS

ELITE MESMERIZING. THEY WERE ALL WAVING AND TWIDDLING THEIR
WANDS

IN UNISON, AND SHEETS OF COLORED PAPER WERE FLYING IN EVERY
DIREC-

TION LIKE LITTLE PINK DARTS. AFTER A FEW SECONDS, HARRY REALIZED
THAT

THERE WAS A RHYTHM TO THE PROCEEDINGS, THAT THE PAPERS ALL FORMED
THE SAME PATTERN, AND AFTER A FEW MORE SECONDS HE REALIZED THAT
WHAT

HE WAS WATCHING WAS THE CREATION OF PAMPHLETS THAT THE PAPER

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SEALARDS WERE PAGES, WHICH, WHEN ASSEMBLED, FOLDED, AND MAGICKED
INTO PLACE, FELL INTO NEAT STACKS BESIDE EACH WITCH OR WIZARD.
HARRY CROPT CLOSER, ALTHOUGH THE WORKERS WERE SEE INTENT MEN
WHAT

THEY WERE DOING THAT HE BELIEVED THEY WOULD NOTICE A CARPET-
MAPPED

FEETSTEP, AND HE SLID A COMPLETED PAMPHLET FROM THE PILE BESIDE A
YELING WITCH. HE EXAMINED IT BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. ITS
PINK

COVER WAS EMBLAZONED WITH A GILDEN TITLE:

MILDBREEDS

AND THE DANGERS THEY FLEE THE
A PEACEFUL PURE-BLOOD SOCIETY

BENEATH THE TITLE WAS A PICTURE OF A RED ROSE WITH A SIMPERING FACE
IN THE MIDDLE OF ITS PETALS, BEING STRANGLED BY A GREEN WEED WITH
FANGS AND A SNEER. THERE WAS NO ALTHOUGH'S NAME UPON THE
PAMPHLET.

BUT AGAIN, THE SCARS ON THE BACK OF HIS RIGHT HAND SEEMED TO TINGLE
AS HE EXAMINED IT. THEN THE YELING WITCH BESIDE HIM CONFIRMED HIS
SUSPICION AS SHE SAID, STILL WAVING AND TWIRLING HER WAND. WILL
THE

HELD HAD BE INTERROGATING MILDBREEDS ALL DAY, DOES ANYONE KNOW?

CAREFUL, SAID THE WIZARD BESIDE HER, GLANCING AROUND NERVOUSLY;
ONE OF HIS PAGES SLIPPED AND FELL TO THE FLOOR.

WHAT, HAS SHE GOTT MAGIC EARS AS WELL AS AN EYE, NEIGH?

THE WITCH GLANCED TOWARD THE SHINING MARENGARD BEHIND FACING THE
SPACE FULL OF PAMPHLET-MAKERS; HARRY LEERED THEM, AND RAGE REARED

IN HIM LIKE A SNARE, WHERE THERE MIGHT HAVE BEEN A DEEP-FLEETING HEN
A MUSCLE FRONT DEER, A LARGE, BELLING EYE WITH A BRIGHT BLUE IRIS HAD
BEEN SET INTO THE WOOD AN EYE THAT WAS STERKINGLY FAMILIAR TO
ANYBODY WHO HAD KNOWN ALASTER MEEDY,
FOR A SPLIT SECOND HARRY FORGET WHERE HE WAS AND WHAT HE WAS

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BEING THERE: HE EVEN FORGET THAT HE WAS INVISIBLE, HE STRODE
STRAIGHT
EVER THE THE DEER THE EXAMINE THE EYE, IT WAS NOT MOVING: IT GAZED
BLINDLY UPWARD, FROZEN, THE PLANKLE BENEATH IT READ:
DELMERES LIMERIDGE

SENIOR UNDERSECRETARY TO THE MINISTER
BELIEV THAT, A SLIGHTLY SENIOR NEW PLANKLE READ:
HEAD OF THE MUSCLE-BURN
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HARRY WHEEDED BACK AT THE DIZZEN PAMPHLET-MAKERS: THOUGH THEY
WERE INTENT UPON THEIR WORK, HE COULD HARDLY SUPPOSE THAT THEY
WOULD
NOT NOTICE IF THE DEER OF AN EMPTY OFFICE OPENED IN FRONT OF THEM,
HE
THEREFORE WITHDREW FROM AN INNER POCKET AN EDD BRIGHT WITH LITTLE
WAVING LEGS AND A BLINKER-BLINKED BURN FOR A BIDDY, CRACKLING DOWN

BENEATH THE CHAIR, HE PLACED THE DEEDS DETERMINATELY IN THE CRIBING.

IT SLUTTLED AWAY AT ONCE THROUGH THE LEGS OF THE WITCHES AND WIZ-
ARDS IN FRONT OF HIM. A FEW MOMENTS LATER, DURING WHICH F-HARRY

WAITED WITH HIS HAND UPON THE DEERDOOR, THERE CAME A HEAVY BANG
AND A GREAT DEAL OF ACID BLACK SMOKE KILLED FROM A CORNER. THE
YELLOW WITCH IN THE FRONT ROW SHRIEKED: PINK PAGES FLEW
EVERYWHERE

AS SHE AND HER FELLOWS JUMPED UP, LEAVING AROUND HER THE SHELTER

OF THE COMMITTEES, F-HARRY TURNED THE DEERDOOR, STEPPED INTO LYM-
BRIDGE'S OFFICE, AND CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

HE FELT HE HAD STEPPED BACK IN TIME. THE ROOM WAS EXACTLY LIKE
LYMBRIDGE'S OFFICE AT F-HOLWARTS: LACE DRAPERIES, BEHINDS, AND DRIED
FLOWERS COVERED EVERY AVAILABLE SURFACE. THE WALLS WERE THE SAME

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ORNAMENTAL PLATES, EACH FEATURING A HIGHLY COLORED, PERIPHERAL
BIT-

TEN, GAMBLING AND PRISING WITH SICKENING CLUTENESS. THE DESK WAS

COVERED WITH A FLIMSY, FLEEWORN CLOTH. BEHIND MAD-EYE'S EYE, A TELESCOPIC ATTACHMENT ENABLED LUMBRIDGE TO SPY ON THE WORKERS ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE DEER. HARRY TOOK A LEWD TWIRL OF IT AND SAW THAT THEY WERE ALL STILL GATHERED AROUND THE DEER'S DEATH. HE WRENCHED THE TELESCOPE OUT OF THE DEER, LEAVING A HOLE BEHIND, PULLED

THE MAGICAL EYEBALL OUT OF IT, AND PLACED IT IN HIS POCKET. THEN HE TURNED THE FACE THE OTHER WAY AGAIN, RAISED HIS HAND, AND MURMURED, ACCIDENTAL.

NOTHING HAPPENED, BUT HE HAD NOT EXPECTED IT THEN. HE BELIEVED LUMBRIDGE KNEW ALL ABOUT PROTECTIVE CHARMS AND SPELLS. HE THEREFORE

HURRIED BEHIND HER DESK AND BEGAN PULLING OPEN THE DRAWERS. HE SAW BILLS AND NOTICES AND SPELLBOOKS; ENCHANTED PAPER CLIPS THAT COILED SNARL LIKE FROM THEIR DRAWER AND HAD THE BE BEATEN BACK; A FLIMSY LITTLE BOX FULL OF SPARE HAIR RINGS AND CLIPS; BUT NO SIGN OF A LOCK.

THERE WAS A FILING CABINET BEHIND THE DESK. HARRY SET THE SEARCHING IT. LIKE FILCH'S FILING CABINETS AT HOGWARTS, IT WAS FULL OF FOLDERS, EACH LABELED WITH A NAME. IT WAS NOT UNTIL HARRY REACHED THE

SEVENTH-DRAWER THAT HE SAW SOMETHING TO DISTRACT HIM FROM HIS

SEARCH: MR. WEASLEY'S FILE.

HE PULLED IT OUT AND OPENED IT.

ARTHUR WEASLEY

KNOWN STATUS: UNKNOWN, BUT WITH UNACCEPTABLE PRO-
MISCULE LEANINGS, KNOWN MEMBER OF THE

ORDER OF THE PHOENIX.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

END

FAMILY: WIFE (UNKNOWN), SEVEN CHILDREN, TWO
YOUNGEST AT HOGWARTS, UK; YOUNGEST SON
CURRENTLY AT HOME, SERIOUSLY ILL, MINISTRY
INSPECTORS HAVE CONFIRMED.

SECURITY STATUS: TRACKED, ALL MOVEMENTS ARE BEING
MONITORED, STRONG LIKELIHOOD UNDESIRABLE
NEE, 1 WILL CONTACT (HAS STAYED WITH
WEASLEY FAMILY PREVIOUSLY)

UNDESIRABLE NUMBER FIVE, HARRY MUTTERED UNDER HIS BREATH
AS HE REPLACED MR. WEASLEY'S PICTURE AND SHUT THE DRAWER. HE HAD AN
IDEA HE KNEW WELL THAT WAS, AND SURE ENOUGH, AS HE STRAIGHTENED
UP AND GLANCED AROUND THE OFFICE FOR FRESH HIDING PLACES, HE SAW A
POSTER OF HIMSELF ON THE WALL, WITH THE WORDS UNDESIRABLE NEE, 1

EMBLAZONED ACROSS HIS CHEST. A LITTLE PINK NOTE WAS STUCK THROUGH IT WITH A

PICTURE OF A BITTEN IN THE CORNER. HARRY MOVED ACROSS THE ROAD IT AND

SAW THAT LUMBRIDGE HAD WRITTEN, "THE RE PLINISHED."

ANGRIER THAN EVER, HE PROCEEDED TO GRAB IN THE CRUTCHES OF THE VASES AND BASKETS OF DRIED FLOWERS, BUT WAS NOT AT ALL SURPRISED THAT THE

BOOKLET WAS NOT THERE. HE GAVE THE OFFICE ONE LAST SLEEPING KISS, AND

HIS HEART SKIPPED A BEAT. DUMBLEDORE WAS STARING AT HIM FROM A SMALL

RECTANGULAR MIRROR, PREPARED UP IN A KITCHEN CASE BESIDE THE DESK.

HARRY CROSSED THE ROOM AT A RUN AND SNATCHED IT UP, BUT REALIZED

THE MOMENT HE THOUGHT IT THAT IT WAS NOT A MIRROR AT ALL. DUMBLEDORE WAS SMILING WISTFULLY BUT OF THE FRONT COVER OF A GLASSY KITCHEN.

HARRY HAD NOT IMMEDIATELY NOTICED THE CLARLY GREEN WRITING ACROSS HIS HAT. THE LIFE AND LIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. NEAR THE SLIGHTLY

SMALLER WRITING ACROSS HIS CHEST: BY RITA SKEETER, BESTSELLING AUTHOR

OF ARMANDO DIPPET: MASTER OF MURDER

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HARRY OPENED THE BOOK AT RANDOM AND SAW A FULL-PAGE PHOTOGRAPH OF TWO TEENAGE BOYS, BOTH LAUGHING IMMODERATELY WITH THEIR

ARMS AROUND EACH OTHER'S SHOULDERS. DUMBLEDORE, NEARLY EIGHT-LENGTH HAIR, HAD GROWN A TINY WISPY BEARD THAT RECALLED THE ONE

FROM A BOY THAT HAD BEEN ANSWERED FOR. THE BOY WHO HAD BEEN IN SILENT AMUSEMENT BESIDE DUMBLEDORE HAD A GLEEFUL, WILD LOOK ABOUT

HIM. HIS CHILDEN HAIR FELL IN CURLS OVER HIS SHOULDERS. HARRY WONDERS

WHETHER IT WAS A STELLING DEER, BUT BEFORE HE COULD CHECK THE CAPTION,

THE COVER OF THE BOOK OPENED.

IF THICKNESS HAD NOT BEEN LOOKING OVER HIS SHOULDERS AS HE ENTERED, HARRY WOULD NOT HAVE HAD TIME TO PULL THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK

OVER HIMSELF. AS IT WAS, HE THOUGHT THICKNESS MIGHT HAVE CAUGHT

A GLIMPSE OF MOVEMENT, REALISE FOR A MOMENT FOR THEN HE REMAINED BLINDLY STILL, STARING CURIOUSLY AT THE PLACE WHERE HARRY HAD JUST VANISHED, PERHAPS DECIDING THAT ALL HE HAD SEEN WAS DUMBLEDORE

SCRATCHING HIS NOSE ON THE FRONT OF THE KNEE, AND HARRY HAD
HASTILY

REPLACED IT UPON THE SHELF, THICKNESSES FINALLY WALKED TO THE DESK
AND POINTED HIS HAND AT THE HULLI STANDING READY IN THE INK POT.
IT

SPRANG UP AND BEGAN SCREEKING A NOTE THE LINGERER, VERY SILENTLY,
HARDLY DARING THE BREATH, HARRY BACKED UP THE OFFICE INTO THE
OPEN AREA BEYOND.

THE PAMPHLET-MAKERS WERE STILL CLUSTERED AROUND THE REMAINS OF
THE DEEP DETERMINATION, WHICH CONTINUED THE PHEET FEELY AS IT SMOKED,
HARRY HURRIED OFF UP THE CORRIDOR AS THE YELING WITCH SAID, I GET
IT SNEAKED UP HERE FROM EXPERIMENTAL CHAIRS, THEY ARE SO CARELESS,
REMEMBER THAT PHEISHNEELS BLED?

SPEEDING BACK TOWARD THE LITS, HARRY REVIEWED HIS HOPELESS. IT HAD
NEVER BEEN LIKELY THAT THE WICKET WAS HERE AT THE MINISTRY, AND
THERE

WAS NO HOPE OF REWITCHING ITS WHEREABOUTS UNTIL THE LINGERER WHILE

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SHE WAS SITTING IN A CROWDED CHAIR, THEIR PRIORITY NEED HAD THE
THE

LEAVE THE MINISTRY BEFORE THEY WERE EXPOSED, AND TRY AGAIN
ANOTHER

DAY, THE FIRST THING SHE WAS TO FIND THEM, AND THEN THEY COULD
WHERE

HELT A WAY OFF EXTRACTING FERMINE FROM THE CHELSTREEM.

THE LIFT WAS EMPTY WHEN IT ARRIVED. HARRY JUMPED IN AND PULLED
OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AS IT STARTED ITS DESCENT. THE HIS
ENORMOUS

RELIEF, WHEN IT RATTLED TO A HALT AT LEVEL TWO, A SHADING-LIFT AND
WILD-

EVERYONE GET IN.

M-MORNING, HE STAMMERED TO HARRY AS THE LIFT SET OFF AGAIN.

THEN, IT'S ME, HARRY?

HARRY? BLIMEY, I FORGOT WHAT YOU LOOKED LIKE WHY ISN'T FER-
MINE WITH YOU?

SHE HAD TO GO DOWN THE CHELSTREEMS WITH LAMBRIDGE, SHE
COULDN'T REPLY, AND

BUT BEFORE HARRY COULD FINISH THE LIFT HAD STOPPED AGAIN. THE

DOORS OPENED AND MR. WEASLEY WALKED INSIDE, TALKING TO AN EL-
DERLY LADY WHOSE BLONDE HAIR WAS TEASED SO HIGH IT RESEMBLED AN

ANTHILL.

... I DON'T UNDERSTAND WHAT YOU'RE SAYING, WANDERER, BUT I'M
AFRAID I CAN'T BE PART OF THE

MR. WEASLEY KNEW HER; HE HAD NOTICED HARRY. IT WAS VERY STRANGE
THE WAY MR. WEASLEY GLARED AT HIM WITH THAT MUCKY DISLIKE. THE LIFT

DOORS CLOSED AND THE FEEL OF THEM TRUNDLED DOWNWARD HENCE MORE.

HI, HELLO, REG, SAID MR. WEASLEY, LEANING AROUND AT THE SOUND

OF STEADY DRIPPING FROM ROOF'S EYES. ISN'T YOUR WIFE IN HER
ELDESTHER-

ING TODAY? ER WHAT'S HAPPENED THE OTHER WAY ARE YOU SEE LATE?

YAKLEY'S OFFICE IS RAINING, SAID ROBIN. HE ADDRESSED MR. WEASLEY'S

SHOULDER, AND HARRY FELT SURE HE WAS SCARED THAT HIS FATHER MIGHT
REK-

RECOGNIZE HIM IF THEY LOOKED DIRECTLY INTO EACH OTHER'S EYES. I
CHILDREN T

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ZSS

STEP IT, SEE THEY'VE SENT ME THE GET BERNIE PILLSBURY, I THINK
THEY

SAID

YES, A LOT OF OFFICES HAVE BEEN RAINING LATELY, SAID MR. WEASLEY,

DID YOU TRY METEOROLOGICAL RESEARCH? IT WORKED FOR KETCHER,

METEOROLOGICAL RESEARCH? WHISPERED ROBIN. NO, I DIDN'T. THANKS,

O I MEAN, THANKS, ARTHUR,

THE LIFT DOORS OPENED; THE OLD WITCH WITH THE ANTI-HILL HAIR LEFT,
AND ROBIN DARTED PAST HER WITHOUT HIS SIGHT. HARRY MADE THE FEELING HIM,

BLIT FELT HIS PATH BLOCKED AS PERCY WEASLEY STRIDE INTO THE LIFT,
HIS

NECK BURIED IN SOME PAPERS HE WAS READING.

NOT UNTIL THE DOORS HAD CLOSED SHUT AGAIN DID PERCY REALIZE HE
WAS IN A LIFT WITH HIS FATHER. HE GLANCED UP, SAW MR. WEASLEY,
TURNED

PALE RED, AND LEFT THE LIFT THE MOMENT THE DOORS OPENED AGAIN.
HE

THE SECOND TIME, HARRY TRIED TO GET BLIT, BUT THIS TIME FELT HIS
WAY

BLOCKED BY MR. WEASLEY'S ARM.

THE MOMENT, BLINDLY.

THE LIFT DOORS CLOSED AND AS THEY CLANKED DOWN ANOTHER FLOOR, MR.
WEASLEY SAID, I HEAR YOU'VE Laid INFORMATION ABOUT DICK CRESSWELL.
HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT MR. WEASLEY'S ANGER WAS NO LESS
BECAUSE OF THE TALK WITH PERCY. HE DECIDED HIS BEST CHANCE WAS
TO ACT STUPID.

SHRUG HE SAID.

DON'T PRETEND, BLINDLY, SAID MR. WEASLEY FIERCELY. YOU TRACKED
DOWN THE WIZARD WHO RAN HIS FAMILY TREE, DIDN'T YOU?

I SEE WHAT IF I DID? SAID HARRY.

SEE DICK CRESSWELL IS TEN TIMES THE WIZARD YOU ARE, SAID MR.

WEASLEY QUIETLY, AS THE LIFT SANK EVER LOWER. AND IF HE SURVIVES
AT-

DON'T, YOU'LL HAVE THE ANSWER TO HIM, NOT TO MENTION HIS WIFE, HIS

SEEN, AND HIS FRIENDS

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ARTHUR, HARRY INTERRUPTED, WELL KNOWN WELL BE BEING TRACKED, DIDN'T YOU?

IS THAT A THREAT, BUNKERN? SAID MR. WEASLEY HEEDILY.

NO, SAID HARRY, IT'S A FACT! THEY'RE WATCHING YOU EVERY MOVE

THE LIFT DOORS OPENED, THEY HAD REACHED THE ATRIUM, MR. WEASLEY GAVE HARRY A SCATHING LOOK AND SLIPPED FROM THE LIFT, HARRY STOOD THERE, SHAKEN, HE WISHED HE WAS IMPERSONATING SOMEONE OTHER THAN BUNKERN, ... THE LIFT DOORS CLANGED SHUT.

HARRY PULLED OUT THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND PUT IT BACK ON, HE WOULD TRY TO EXTRICATE HERMIONE ON HIS OWN WHILE RON WAS DEALING

WITH THE RAISING OFFICE. WHEN THE DOORS OPENED, HE STEPPED OUT INTO

A THICK-LIT STONE PASSAGELAY ELITE DIFFERENT FROM THE WOOD-PANELED

AND CARPETED HALLWAYS ABOVE, AS THE LIFT RATTLED AWAY AGAIN, HARRY

SHIVERED SLIGHTLY, LEEDING TOWARD THE DISTANT BLACK DOOR THAT MARKED

THE ENTRANCE TO THE DEPARTMENT OF MYSTERIES.

HE SET OFF, HIS DESTINATION NEAR THE BLACK DOOR, BUT THE DOORWAY

HE REMEMBERED ON THE LEFT-HAND SIDE, WHICH OPENED INTO THE FLIGHT

HE STAIRS DOWN THE THE CHURCH CHAMBERS, HIS MIND GRAPPLED WITH POSSIBILITIES AS HE CREEPT DOWN THEM: HE STILL HAD A COUPLE OF DEEP

DETERMINATIONS, BUT PERHAPS IT WOULD BE BETTER TO SIMPLY KNEEL IN THE CHURCHTOWN DEER, ENTER AS RICHARD, AND ASK FOR A HELIX WARD WITH

MARALDA? HE CHURCH, HE DID NOT KNOW WHETHER RICHARD WAS SUFFICIENTLY IMPORTANT TO GET AWAY WITH THIS, AND EVEN IF HE MANAGED

IT, HERMINE'S REAPPEARANCE MIGHT TRIGGER A SEARCH BEFORE THEY

WERE CLEAR OF THE MINISTRY, . . .

BEST IN THE LIGHT, HE DID NOT IMMEDIATELY REGISTER THE UNNATURAL CHILL THAT WAS CREEPING OVER HIM, AS IF HE WERE DESCENDING INTO THE. IT WAS REACHING COLDER AND COLDER WITH EVERY STEP HE TOOK: A CHILD

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THAT REACHED RIGHT DOWN INTO HIS THROAT AND THERE AT HIS KLINGS,
AND

THEN HE FELT THAT STEALING SENSE OF DESPAIR, OF HELPLESSNESS, FILLING HIM, EXPANDING INSIDE HIM, . . .

DEMENTERS, HE THOUGHT,

AND AS HE REACHED THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS AND TURNED TO HIS RIGHT HE

SAW A DREADFUL SCENE. THE DARK PASSAGE OUTSIDE THE CHURCHDOORS WAS

PACKED WITH TALL, BLACK-HEADED FIGURES, THEIR FACES COMPLETELY HIDDEN, THEIR RAGGED BREATHING THE ONLY SOUND IN THE PLACE. THE PETRIFIED

MUSCLE-BURNS BRIGHT IN THE HURSTING SAT Huddled AND SHIVERING

ON HARD WOODEN BENCHES, MOST OF THEM WERE HIDING THEIR FACES IN THEIR HANDS, PERHAPS IN AN INSTINCTIVE ATTEMPT TO SHIELD THEMSELVES

FROM THE DEMONSTRATIONS GREEDY MIGHTS, SOME WERE ACCOMPANIED BY FAMILIES, OTHERS SAT ALONE. THE DEMONSTRATIONS WERE GLIDING UP AND DOWN

IN FRONT OF THEM, AND THE CHILD, AND THE HELPLESSNESS, AND THE DESPAIR

OF THE PLACE LAID THEMSELVES UPON JARRY LIKE A CLASP. . . .

FIGHT IT, HE TOLD HIMSELF, BUT HE KNEW THAT HE COULD NOT CONJURE A PATRONUS HERE WITHOUT REVEALING HIMSELF INSTANTLY. SO HE MOVED

FORWARD AS SILENTLY AS HE COULD, AND WITH EVERY STEP HE THOUGHT NIMBLENESS SEEMED TO STEAL OVER HIS BRAIN, BUT HE FORCED HIMSELF TO THINK

OF HERMINE AND OF BEN, WHO NEEDED HIM.

MOVING THROUGH THE THUNDERING BLACK FIGURES WAS TERRIFYING! THE

EYELESS FACES HIDDEN BENEATH THEIR HEEHS TURNED AS HE PASSED, AND HE

FEELT SURE THAT THEY SENSED HIM, SENSED, PERHAPS, A HUMAN PRESENCE THAT STILL HAD SOME HOPE, SOME RESILIENCE. . . .

AND THEN, ABRUPTLY AND SHOCKINGLY AMID THE FROZEN SILENCE, HEAR THE DINGEDEN DINGERS IN THE LEFT OF THE CORRIDOR WAS FALLING OPEN AND

SCREAMS ECCHED OUT OF IT.

NO, NO, I M HALF-BLEED, I M HALF-BLEED, I TELL YELL! MY FATHER WAS A WIZARD, HE WAS, BLEED HIM UP, ARDIE ALBERTIN, HE S A WELL-KNOWN

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CRYSTIC DESIGNER, BLEED HIM UP, I TELL YELL GET YELLR HANDS OFF ME, GET YELLR HANDS OFF

THIS IS YELLR FINAL WARNING, SAID LIMERIDGE S SEET VEHICLE, MAGI- CALLY MAGNIFIED SEE THAT IT SHOUNED CLEARLY EVER THE MAN S DESPERATE

SCREAMS. IF YELL STRUGGLE, YELL WILL BE SUBJECTED THE THE DEMENTHER S DASS.

THE MAN S SCREAMS SLKSIDED, BLIT DRY SEKS ECCHED THROUGH THE CORRIDOR.

TAKE HIM AWAY, SAID LIMERIDGE.

TWEE DEMENTHERS APPEARED IN THE DINGELAY OF THE CHELITREEM, THEIR

HITTING, STARKED HANDS CLUTCHING THE UPPER ARMS OF A WIZARD WHO
APPEARED TO BE FAINTING. THEY GLIDED AWAY DOWN THE CORRIDOR WITH
HIM, AND THE DARKNESS THEY TRAILED BEHIND THEM SWALLOWED HIM
FROM SIGHT.

NEXT MARY LATTERMERE, CALLED LIMERIDGE.

A SMALL WOMAN STOOD UP; SHE WAS TREMBLING FROM HEAD TO FEET.
HER DARK HAIR WAS SWEPTED BACK INTO A KNOT AND SHE WORE LONG,
PLAIN DRESS. HER FACE WAS COMPLETELY featureless. AS SHE PASSED THE
DEMENTERS, HARRY SAW HER SHOULDER.

HE DID IT INSTINCTIVELY, WITHOUT ANY SORT OF PLAN, BECAUSE HE HATED
THE SIGHT OF HER WALKING ALONE INTO THE DUNGEON. AS THE DOOR
BEGAN

TO SWING CLOSED, HE SLIPPED INTO THE CORRIDOR BEHIND HER.

IT WAS NOT THE SAME ROOM IN WHICH HE HAD ONCE BEEN INTERROGATED
FOR IMPROPER USE OF MAGIC. THIS ONE WAS MUCH SMALLER, THOUGH
THE

CEILING WAS WHITE AS HIGH; IT GAVE THE CALISTOPHOREAN SENSE OF
BEING

STUCK AT THE BOTTOM OF A DEEP WELL.

THERE WERE MORE DEMENTERS IN HERE, CASTING THEIR FREEZING ALRA

EVER THE PLACE; THEY STOOD LIKE FACELESS SENTINELS IN THE CORNERS
FAR-

TEST FROM THE HIGH, RAISED PLATFORM. HERE, BEHIND A BALUSTRADE, SAT

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LIMBRIDGE, WITH JAKLEY ON ONE SIDE OF HER, AND HERMIENE, AS WHITE AS MRS. LATTERMELE, ON THE OTHER. AT THE FOOT OF THE PLATFORM, A BRIGHT-SILVER, LONG-HAired CAT PRAWLED UP AND DOWN, UP

AND DOWN, AND HARRY REALIZED THAT IT WAS THERE THE PROTECT THE PRES-

ELTERS FROM THE DESPAIR THAT EMANATED FROM THE DEMENTERS: THAT

WAS FOR THE ALLISED THE FEEL, NOT THE ALLISERS.

SIT DOWN, SAID LIMBRIDGE IN HER SIFT, SILKY VOICE.

MRS. LATTERMELE STIMBLED TO THE SINGLE SEAT IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PLANTER BENEATH THE RAISED PLATFORM. THE MOMENT SHE HAD SAT DOWN, CHAINS CLINKED AROUND THE ARMS OF THE CHAIR AND BEHIND HER THERE.

WELL ARE MARY ELIZABETH LATTERMELE? ASKED LIMBRIDGE.

MRS. LATTERMELE GAVE A SINGLE, SHADY NOD.

MARRIED THE REGINALD LATTERMELE OF THE MAGICAL MAINTENANCE DEPARTMENT?

MRS. LATTERMELE BLURST INTO TEARS.

I DON'T KNOW WHERE HE IS, HE WAS SUPPOSED TO MEET ME HERE?

LIMBRIDGE IGNORED HER.

MEETHER THE MAISIE, ELIE, AND ALFRED LATTERMELE?

MRS. LATTERMELE SHOOK HARDER THAN EVER.

THEY ARE FRIGHTENED, THEY THINK I MIGHT NOT COME HOME

SPARK US, SPAT JAKLEY. THE KRATS OF MLDREHDS DO NOT STIR FOR

SYMPATHIES.

MRS. LATTERMELE'S SHES MASKED HARRY'S FEETSTEPS AS HE MADE HIS WAY CAREFULLY TOWARD THE STEPS THAT LED UP TO THE RAISED PLATFORM. THE

MOMENT HE HAD PASSED THE PLACE WHERE THE PATRONUS CAT PATROLLED, HE

FEELT THE CHANGE IN TEMPERATURE! IT WAS WARM AND COMFORTABLE HERE.

THE PATRONUS, HE WAS SURE, WAS LIMERIDGE'S, AND IT GLOWED BRIGHTLY BECAUSE SHE WAS SO HAPPY HERE, IN HER ELEMENT, UNFOLDING THE TWISTED

LAWS SHE HAD HELPED TO WRITE. SILENTLY AND VERY CAREFULLY HE EDGED

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HIS WAY ALONG THE PLATFORM BEHIND LIMERIDGE, JAXLEY, AND HERMINE, TAKING A SEAT BEHIND THE LATTER. HE WAS WHIRLED ABOUT MAKING

HERMINE JUMP. HE THOUGHT OF CASTING THE MUFFLATE CHARM UPON LIMERIDGE AND JAXLEY, BUT EVEN MURMURING THE WORD MIGHT CAUSE HERMINE ALARM. THEN LIMERIDGE RAISED HER VOICE TO ADDRESS MRS. LATTERMELE, AND HARRY SEIZED HIS CHANCE.

IN THE MOMENT, HE WHISPERED INTO HERMINE'S EAR.

AS HE HAD EXPECTED, SHE JUMPED SO VIOLENTLY SHE NEARLY OVERTURNED THE KETTLE OF IND WITH WHICH SHE WAS SUPPLIED TO BE REHEARDING THE INTERVIEW, BUT BOTH LIMERIDGE AND JAXLEY WERE CONCENTRATING UPON

MRS. LATTERMELE, AND THIS WENT UNNOTICED.

A WAND WAS TAKEN FROM THE LIP OF HER ARRIVAL AT THE MINISTRY

TODAY, MRS. LATTERMELE, LAMBRIDGE WAS SAYING. RIGHT-AND-THREE-
EIGHTHARTER INCHES, CHERRY, LINDICORN-HAIR THERE, DID THE RECOGNIZE THAT

DESCRIPTION?

MRS. LATTERMELE NEEDED, MEEPING HER EYES IN HER SLEEVE.

CHILD THE PLEASE TELL US FROM WHICH WITCH HER WIZARD THE THAT
THAT WAND?

T-THAT? SHEKED MRS. LATTERMELE. I DIDN T T-TAKE IT FROM ANY-
BODY, I R-RELIGHT IT WHEN I WAS ELEVEN YEARS OLD. IT IT IT

CHISE ME.

SHE CRIED HARDER THAN EVER.

LAMBRIDGE LAUGHED A SIFT GIRLISH LAUGH THAT MADE HARRY WANT THE
ATTACK HER. SHE LEANED FORWARD OVER THE BARRIER, THE BETTER THE
HERSELF

HER VICTIM, AND SOMETHING CHILD SWING FORWARD THE, AND DANGLED
OVER THE VOID: THE WICKET.

HERMIONE HAD SEEN IT; SHE LET OUT A LITTLE SHOUT, BUT LAMBRIDGE
AND PARKER, STILL INTENT UPON THEIR PREY, WERE DEAF TO EVERYTHING
ELSE.

THE MUGGLE-BORN

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NEE, SAID LIMERIDGE, NEE, I DEEN T THINK SHE, MRS. CATTERMERE.
LANDS ONLY CHEESE WITCHES AND WIZARDS, SHELL ARE NOT A WITCH, I
HAVE
THEIR RESPONSES TO THE QUESTIONNAIRE THAT WAS SENT THE SHELL HERE
MARALDA, PASS THEM THE MR.
LIMERIDGE HELD OUT A SMALL HAND: SHE LOOKED SHE THOUGHT AT THAT
MOMENT THAT HARRY WAS WHITE SURPRISED NOT THE SEE WERE BETWEEN
THE STUCKY FINGERS, HERMINE'S HANDS WERE SHAKING WITH SHOCK.
SHE
FLUMLED IN A PILE OF DOCUMENTS BALANCED ON THE CHAIR BESIDE HER,
FINALLY WITHDRAWING A SHEAF OF PARCHMENT WITH MRS. CATTERMERE'S
NAME ON IT.

THAT'S THAT'S PRETTY, DEERES, SHE SAID, POINTING AT THE PEN-
DANT GLAMING IN THE RUFFLED PLEDS OF LIMERIDGE'S KNEELER.

WHAT? SNAPPED LIMERIDGE, GLANCING DOWN. YES AN OLD
FAMILY HEIRLOOM, SHE SAID, PATTING THE BROOCH LYING ON HER LARGE
KNEE-
SEAT. THE S STANDS FOR SELLON, ... I AM RELATED TO THE SELLONS, ...
INDEED, THERE ARE FEW PURE-BLOOD FAMILIES TO WHICH I AM NOT RELATED,
... A PITY, SHE CONTINUED IN A MILDLY VEXED, PLUCKING THROUGH MRS.

LATTERMERE'S ELDEST DAUGHTER, THAT THE SAME CANNOT BE SAID FOR
HER.

PARENTS PROTESTING: GREENGLASS.

PARLEY LAUGHED IRRINGLY, BEHEW, THE ALIVE SILVER CAT PATROLLED UP
AND DOWN, AND THE DEMONSTRATIONS STOOD WAITING IN THE CORNERS.

IT WAS LAMBRIDGE'S LIE THAT BRILLIANT THE BLEED SURGING INTO
HARRY'S

BRAIN AND ILLITERATED HIS SENSE OF CALIBER THAT THE MURDERER SHE

HAD TAKEN AS A BRIBE FROM A PETTY CRIMINAL WAS BEING USED TO RE-
STER HER OWN PURE-BLOOD CREDENTIALS. HE RAISED HIS HAND, NOT EVEN

TRICKLING THE DEEP IT CONCEALED BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, AND
SAID, STUPID!

THERE WAS A FLASH OF RED LIGHT; LAMBRIDGE CRUMPLED AND HER FIRE-
HEAD HIT THE EDGE OF THE BALUSTRADE: MRS. LATTERMERE'S PAPERS SLID

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE

OFF HER LAP BENTH THE FLEET AND, DOWN BELOW, THE PURRING SILVER
CAT

VANISHED. ICE-COLD AIR HIT THEM LIKE AN ENCHURING WIND: PARLEY,
DOWN-

FLISHED, WHIRLED AROUND FOR THE SHELTER OF THE TREE-LIKE AND SAW
HARRY'S

DISMEMBERED HAND AND WAND POINTING AT HIM. HE TRIED TO DRAW HIS
ELBOW WAND, BUT TOO LATE: STUPEFY!

PARLEY SLID THE TREE-GROUND THE LIE CLIMBED HIM THE FLEWER.

HARRY:

HERMIONE, IF YOU THINK I WAS GOING TO SIT HERE AND LET HER
PRETEND

HARRY, MRS. LATTERMEER:

HARRY WHIRLED AROUND, THROWING OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK; DOWN
BELOW, THE DEMENTORS HAD MOVED OUT OF THEIR CORNERS; THEY WERE
GLIDING TOWARD THE WOMAN CHAINED TO THE CHAIR; UNEXPECTED BECAUSE
THE PATRONUS HAD VANISHED HER BECAUSE THEY SENSED THAT THEIR
MASTERS

WERE NO LONGER IN CONTROL, THEY SEEMED TO HAVE ABANDONED
RESTRAINT.

MRS. LATTERMEER LET OUT A TERRIBLE SCREAM OF FEAR AS A SLIMY, SKINNED
HAND GRASPED HER CHIN AND FORCED HER FACE BACK.

EXPECT THE PATRONUS:

THE SILVER STAG SHARED FROM THE TIP OF HARRY'S WAND AND LEAPED
TOWARD THE DEMENTORS, WHICH FELL BACK AND MELTED INTO THE DARK
SHADOWS AGAIN. THE STAG'S LIGHT, MORE POWERFUL AND MORE WARMING
THAN THE CAT'S PROTECTION, FILLED THE WHOLE DARKNESS AS IT CANTERED
AROUND AND AROUND THE ROOM.

GET THE HERCULES, HARRY TOLD HERMIONE.

HE RAN BACK DOWN THE STEPS, STOPPING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK BACK
INTO HIS BAG, AND APPROACHED MRS. LATTERMEER.

YELL SHE WHISPERED, GAZING INTO HIS FACE. BUT BUT REG SAID
WELL WERE THE ONE WHO SUBMITTED MY NAME FOR CONSIDERATION?

DID IT MENTIONED HARRY, TUGGING AT THE CHAINS BINDING HER ARMS.

THE MUGGLE-BORN
REGISTRATION COMMISSION

THE

WELL, I VE HAD A CHANGE OF HEART, DIFFICULT? NOTHING HAPPENED.

HERMIONE, HOW DO I GET RID OF THESE CHAINS?

WAIT, I M TRYING SOMETHING UP HERE

HERMIONE, WE RE SURROUNDED BY DEMENTORS?

I KNOW THAT, HARRY, BUT IF SHE WAKES UP AND THE LOCKET S GONE

I NEED TO DUPLICATE IT COMING! THERE ... THAT SHOULD HELP
HER. ...

HERMIONE CAME RUNNING DOWNSTAIRS.

LET S SEE. ... RELEASE!

THE CHAINS CLINKED AND WITHDREW INTO THE ARMS OF THE CHAIR, MRS.
LATTERMERE BEHEADED LIST AS FRIGHTENED AS EVER BEFORE.

I DON T UNDERSTAND, SHE WHISPERED.

WELL BE GOING TO LEAVE HERE WITH US, SAID HARRY, PULLING HER TO
HER FEET. COME HERE, GRAB YOUR CHILDREN, AND GET OUT, GET OUT OF THE
COUNTRY IF YOU VE GOT TO, DISGUISE YOURSELVES AND RUN. YOU VE
SEEN

HOW IT IS, YOU WON T GET ANYTHING LIKE A FAIR HEARING HERE.

HARRY, SAID HERMIONE, HOW ARE WE GOING TO GET OUT OF HERE

WITH ALL THESE DEMENTERS HLTSIDE THE DEER?

PATRENLISE, SAID FARRY, POINTING HIS HAND AT HIS ELIN: THE
STAG

SHEDD AND WALKED, STILL GLEAMING BRIGHTLY, TOWARD THE DEER, AS
MANY AS WE CAN MUSTER; DE VELURS, FERMINE.

EXPECT EXPECTE PATRENLIM, SAID FERMINE, NOTHING HAP-
PENED.

IT S THE ONLY SPELL SHE EVER HAS TROUBLE WITH, FARRY TOLD A COM-
PLETLY REMLISE MRS. CATTERMELE, KIT UNFORTUNATE, REALLY ... COME

HN, FERMINE ...

EXPECTE PATRENLIM

A SILVER BTTER BLIST FROM THE END OF FERMINE S HAND AND SLAM
GRACEFULLY THROUGH THE AIR THE HIN THE STAG.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

???

[HEN, SAID FARRY, AND HE LED FERMINE AND MRS. CATTERMELE
THE THE DEER.

WHEN THE PATRENLISES GLIDED HLIT OF THE DLINGEN THERE WERE CRIES
OF SHEDD FROM THE PEOPLE WAITING HLTSIDE, FARRY WHEDD ARELIND;
THE

DEMENTERS WERE FALLING BACK HN BOTH SIDES OF THEM, MELDING INTO

THE DARKNESS, SCATTERING BEFORE THE SILVER CREATURES.

IT IS BEEN DECIDED THAT THEY SHOULD ALL GO HOME AND GO INTO HIDING WITH THEIR FAMILIES. HARRY TOLD THE WAITING MUGGLE-BORN, WHO WERE

DAZZLED BY THE LIGHT OF THE PATRONUSES AND STILL CHEWING SLIGHTLY,

GO AHEAD IF YOU CAN, JUST GET WELL AWAY FROM THE MINISTRY, THAT IS

THE NEW OFFICIAL POSITION. NOW, IF YOU DO JUST FOLLOW THE PAT-

RONALDES, YOU WILL BE ABLE TO LEAVE FROM THE ATRIUM.

THEY MANAGED TO GET UP THE STONE STEPS WITHOUT BEING INTERCEPTED,

BUT AS THEY APPROACHED THE LIFT HARRY STARTED TO HAVE MISGIVINGS.

IF THEY EMERGED INTO THE ATRIUM WITH A SILVER STAG, AN EATER SHARING

ALONGSIDE IT, AND TWENTY OR SO PEOPLE, HALF OF THEM ACCUSED MUGGLE-

BORN, HE COULD NOT HELP FEELING THAT THEY WOULD ATTRACT UNWANTED

ATTENTION. HE HAD JUST REACHED THIS UNWELCOME CONCLUSION WHEN THE

LIFT CHANGED TO A HALL IN FRONT OF THEM.

REG! SCREAMED MRS. LATIMER, AND SHE THREW HERSELF INTO RON'S ARMS. RON LET ME HEAR, HE ATTACKED LAMERIDGE AND PAXLEY,

AND HE S THLD ALL HP LIS TH LEAVE THE COUNTRY, I THINK WE D BETTER DH
IT,

REG, I REALLY DH, LET S HARRY HME AND FETCH THE CHILDREN AND
WE-D

ARE YELL SEE WET?

LATER, MUTTERED DHEN, DISENGAGING HIMSELF, HARRY, THEY KNEL
THERE ARE INTRUDERS INSIDE THE MINISTRY, SOMETHING ABOUT A HELL
IN

LMRIDGE S OFFICE DHEN, I RECDEN WE VE GHT FIVE MINUTES IF THAT

HERMIONE S PATRONUS VANISHED WITH A POOP AS SHE TURNED A
HERRER-

STRIKE FACE TH HARRY,

THE MUGGLE-BORN

REGISTRATION COMMISSION

THE

HARRY, IF WE RE TRAPPED HERE ;

WE WHN T BE IF WE MOVE FAST, SAID HARRY, HE ADDRESSED THE SILENT
CROWD BEHIND THEM, WHO WERE ALL GAWPING AT HIM,

WHO S GET WANDS?

ABOUT HALF HP THEM RAISED THEIR HANDS,

HARRY, ALL HP YELL WHO HAVEN T GET WANDS NEED TH ATTACH THEMSELF
THE SHORTEST WHO HAS, WE LL NEED TH BE FAST BEFORE THEY STOP LIS.
COME HN,

THEY MANAGED THE CROWD THEMSELVES INTO TWO LISTS, HARRY S PATRON-

WAS STEAD SENTINEL BEHIND THE GOLDEN GRILLES AS THEY SHUT AND THE
LIFTS

BEGAN THE RISE.

LEVEL EIGHT, SAID THE WITCH'S CHEEL VOICE, ATRILIM.

HARRY KNEW AT ONCE THAT THEY WERE IN TROUBLE. THE ATRILIM WAS
FULL OF PEOPLE MOVING FROM FIREPLACE TO FIREPLACE, SEALING THEM OFF.

HARRY'S SHEPHERD HERMIONE. WHAT ARE WE GOING TO ?

STEAD? HARRY THUNDERED, AND THE PEELING VOICE OF RUMBLE
ECHOED THROUGH THE ATRILIM: THE WIZARDS SEALING THE FIREPLACES

FREEZE. FELLER ME, HE WHISPERED TO THE GROUP OF TERRIFIED MUGGLE-
BORN, WHO MOVED FORWARD IN A Huddle, SHEPHERDED BY DEAN AND

HERMIONE.

WHAT'S UP, ALBERT? SAID THE SAME BALDING WIZARD WHO HAD FEL-
LOWED HARRY HURT IN THE FIREPLACE EARLIER. HE LOOKED NERVOUS.

THIS LOT NEED TO LEAVE BEFORE WE'LL SEAL THE EXITS, SAID HARRY WITH
ALL THE AUTHORITY HE COULD MUSTER.

THE GROUP OF WIZARDS IN FRONT OF HIM LOOKED AT ONE ANOTHER.

WE'VE BEEN TOLD TO SEAL ALL EXITS AND NOT LET ANYONE

ARE YOU CONTRADICTING ME? HARRY BELLERED. WOULD YOU LIKE ME
TO HAVE YOUR FAMILY TREE EXAMINED, LIKE I HAD DICK CRESSWELL'S?

SHRUG? GASPED THE BALDING WIZARD, BACKING AWAY. I DIDN'T MEAN

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE

NOTHING, ALBERT, BUT I THOUGHT . . . I THOUGHT THEY WERE IN THE
HILLS-

THINKING AND . . .

THEIR BLEND IS PURE, SAID HARRY, AND HIS DEEP VOICE RUMBLING IM-
PRESSIVELY THROUGH THE HALL. PURER THAN MANY OF THEM, I
DARE SAY.

OFF THEY GO, HE RUMBLERED THE MUGGLE-KINDS, WHO SLURPED
FORWARD

INTO THE FIREPLACES AND BEGAN TO VANISH IN PAIRS. THE MINISTRY
WIZ-

ARDS FILING BACK, SOME BLENDING CONFUSED, OTHERS SCARED AND RESENT-
FUL. THEN:

MARY?

MRS. LATTERMERE LOOKED OVER HER SHOULDER. THE REAL REG LATTER-
MERE, NO LONGER VOMITING BUT PALE AND WORN, HAD JUST COME
RUNNING

BLIT BY A LIFT.

R-REG?

SHE LEAPED FROM HER HUSBAND THE ROON, WITH SWIFT LEADY,

THE BALDING WIZARD GAZED, HIS HEAD TURNING UNWITTINGLY FROM HER

REG CATTERTHURP THE THE EITHER,

HEY WHAT'S GOING ON? WHAT IS THIS?

SEAL THE EXIT! SEAL IT!

YAKLEY HAD FIRST FELT HE ANOTHER LIFT AND WAS RUNNING TOWARD THE
GRILLING BESIDE THE FIREPLACES, INTO WHICH ALL OF THE MUGGLE-BORN
WENT

MRS. CATTERTHURP HAD BEEN VANISHED, AS THE BALDING WIZARD LIFTED
HIS WAND, HARRY RAISED AN UNWITTING FIST AND PUNCHED HIM, SENDING
HIM FLYING THROUGH THE AIR.

HE'S BEEN HELPING MUGGLE-BORN ESCAPE, YAKLEY! HARRY
SHOUTED.

THE BALDING WIZARD'S COLLEAGUES SET UP AN UPROAR, UNDER COVER OF
WHICH ROON GRABBED MRS. CATTERTHURP, PULLED HER INTO THE STILL-OPEN
FIREPLACE, AND DISAPPEARED. CONFUSED, YAKLEY LEAPED FROM HARRY THE

THE MUGGLE-BORN

REGISTRATION COMMISSION

END

THE PUNCHED WIZARD, WHILE THE REAL REG CATTERTHURP SCREAMED, MY
WIFE! WHAT WAS THAT WITH MY WIFE? WHAT'S GOING ON?

HARRY SAW YAKLEY'S HEAD TURN, SAW AN INKLING OF THE TRUTH BURN
IN THAT BRITISH FACE.

COME ON! HARRY SHOUTED AT HERMIONIE! HE SEIZED HER HAND AND

THEY JUMPED INTO THE FIREPLACE TOGETHER AS VAXLEY'S CURSE SAILED
EVER

HARRY'S HEAD. THEY SPUN AROUND A FEW SECONDS BEFORE SHEETING UP
BLITZ

A THICKET INTO A CLUTTER. HARRY ALONE OPENED THE DOOR; REIN WAS
STANDING

THERE BESIDE THE STOPS, STILL WRESTLING WITH MRS. CATTERRMERE.

REG, I DON'T UNDERSTAND

LET GO, I'M NOT YOUR HUSBAND, YOU'VE GOT THE GO HOME!

THERE WAS A NOISE IN THE CLUTTER BEHIND THEM; HARRY WHIRLED
AROUND; VAXLEY HAD JUST APPEARED.

LET'S GO! HARRY YELLED. HE SEIZED FERMINE BY THE HAND
AND REIN BY THE ARM AND TURNED HER THE OTHER WAY.

DARKNESS ENVELOPED THEM, ALONG WITH THE SENSATION OF COMPRESSING
HANDS, BUT SOMETHING WAS WRITHING. . . . FERMINE'S HAND SEEMED TO
BE SLIDING OUT OF HIS GRIP. . . .

HE WONDERED WHETHER HE WAS GOING TO SUFFocate; HE COULD NOT
BREATHE AND SEE AND THE ONLY SENSIBLE THINGS IN THE WORLD WERE REIN'S
ARM

AND FERMINE'S FINGERS, WHICH WERE SLOWLY SLIPPING AWAY. . . .

AND THEN HE SAW THE DOOR OF NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINALS PLACE,
WITH ITS SERPENT DOOR KNOCKER, BUT BEFORE HE COULD DRAW BREATH,
THERE

WAS A SCREAM AND A FLASH OF PURPLE LIGHT; FERMINE'S HAND WAS
SLID-

ONLY VIBRATING UNDER HIS AND EVERYTHING WENT DARK AGAIN.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE TREE

HARRY OPENED HIS EYES AND WAS DAZZLED BY GOLD AND GREEN;
HE HAD NO IDEA WHAT HAD HAPPENED, HE ONLY KNEW THAT
HE WAS LYING IN WHAT SEEMED THE LEAVES AND TWIGS, STRUGGLING THE
DRAIN BREATH INTO HIS LUNGS THAT FELT FLATTENED, HE BLINKED AND REALIZED
THAT THE CALID CLARE WAS SUNLIGHT STREAMING THROUGH A CANOPY
OF
LEAVES FAR ABOVE HIM. THEN AN INSECT TWITCHED CLOSE TO HIS FACE. HE
PUSHED HIMSELF UP WITH HIS HANDS AND KNEES, READY THE FACE SOME SMALL,
PIERCE CREATURE, BUT SAW THAT THE INSECT WAS BEEN A FEET, LEEDING
AROUND, HARRY SAW THAT THEY AND HERMIONE WERE LYING IN A
FOREST
ALONE, APPARENTLY ALONE.

HARRY'S FIRST THOUGHT WAS OF THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, AND FOR A MOMENT,
EVEN THOUGH HE KNEW HOW FOOLISH AND DANGEROUS IT WOULD

BE FOR THEM TO APPEAR IN THE GROUNDS OF HOGWARTS, HIS HEART
LEAPT

AT THE THOUGHT OF SNEAKING THROUGH THE TREES THE HAGRID'S MOUNT,
HEW-

EVER, IN THE FEW MOMENTS IT TOOK FOR THEM TO GIVE A WELL-GROOMED AND

AS HARRY THE START CRAWLING TOWARD HIM, HE REALIZED THAT THIS WAS NOT THE

HE

THE THIR

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FORBIDDEN FOREST! THE TREES LOOKED YOUNGER, THEY WERE MORE WIDELY
SPACED, THE GREENING CLEARER.

HE MET HERMIONE, ALSEEN HER HANDS AND KNEES, AT RON'S HEAD.

THE MOMENT HIS EYES FELL UPON RON, ALL OTHER CONCERNS FLEW
HARRY'S

MIND, AND BLEED DRENCHED THE WHOLE OF RON'S LEFT SIDE AND HIS FACE
STOOD BLUT, GRAYISH-WHITE, AGAINST THE LEAF-STREWN EARTH. THE
PAINFUL

WHEN WAS WEARING OFF NOW! RON WAS HALFWAY BETWEEN CATERPILLAR
AND HIMSELF IN APPEARANCE, HIS HAIR TURNING REDDER AND REDDER AS
HIS FACE DRAINED OF THE LITTLE COLOR IT HAD LEFT.

WHAT'S HAPPENED TO HIM?

SPLINCHED, SAID HERMIONE, HER FINGERS ALREADY CLASP AT RON'S
SLEEVE, WHERE THE BLEED WAS WETTEST AND DARKEST.

HARRY WATCHED, HORRIFIED, AS SHE THERE OPENED RON'S SHIRT. HE HAD
ALWAYS THOUGHT OF SPLINCHING AS SOMETHING CHEMICAL, BUT THIS...

HIS INSIDES CRAWLED UNPLEASANTLY AS HERMIONE LAID BARE RON'S LIP-

PER ARM, WHERE A GREAT CHUNK OF FLESH WAS MISSING, SCHEEPED
CLEANLY

ALAS AS THOUGH BY A KNIFE.

HARRY, QUICKLY, IN MY BAG, THERE'S A SMALL BOTTLE LABELED ESSENCE
OF DITTANY

BAG RIGHT

HARRY SPED THE THE PLACE WHERE FERMINE HAD LANDED, SEIZED THE
TINY BEADED BAG, AND THrust HIS HAND INSIDE IT. AT ONCE, BRIST AFTER
BRIST BEGAN PRESENTING ITSELF TO HIS TOUCH: HE FELT THE LEATHER
SPINES

OF BOOKS, WOOLLY SLEEVES OF LIMBERS, FEELS OF SHIRTS

QUICKLY!

HE GRABBED HIS HAND FROM THE GRILING AND PEINTED IT INTO THE
DEPTH'S OF THE MAGICAL BAG.

ALL THE DITTANY!

A SMALL GREEN BOTTLE ZIMMED OUT OF THE BAG; HE CALIGHT IT AND

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

THE

HASTENED BACK TO FERMINE AND RHN, WHOSE EYES WERE NOW HALF-
CLOSED, STRIPS OF WHITE EYEBALL ALL THAT WERE VISIBLE BETWEEN HIS LIPS.

HE'S FAINTED, SAID FERMINE, WHO WAS ALSO RATHER PALE; SHE NOW
LINGERED BEHIND LIKE MARALDA, THOUGH HER HAIR WAS STILL GRAY IN
PLACES.

UNSTOPPER IT FOR ME, HARRY, MY HANDS ARE SHAKING.

HARRY WRENCHED THE STOPPER OFF THE LITTLE BOTTLE, DETERMINED TO
IT AND PULSED THREE DROPS OF THE POTION INTO THE BLEEDING WOUND.
GREENISH SMOKE RISES UPWARD AND WHEN IT HAD CLEARED, HARRY
SAW THAT THE BLEEDING HAD STOPPED. THE WOUND NOW HEALED SEVERAL
DAYS OLD; NEW SKIN STRETCHED OVER WHAT HAD JUST BEEN OPEN FLESH.

WELL, SAID HARRY.

IT'S ALL I FEEL SAFE DOING, SAID DETERMINED SHARPLY. THERE ARE
SPELLS

THAT WOULD PUT HIM COMPLETELY RIGHT, BUT I DAREN'T TRY IN CASE I DO
THEM WRONG AND CAUSE MORE DAMAGE. . . . HE'S BEST SEE MUCH BLOOD
ALREADY. . . .

HOW DID HE GET HURT? I MEAN HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, TRYING
TO CLEAR IT, TO MAKE SENSE OF WHATEVER HAD JUST TAKEN PLACE
WHY

ARE WE HERE? I THOUGHT WE WERE GOING BACK TO CRIMINALM PLACE?

DETERMINED TOOK A DEEP BREATH. SHE HEALED CLOSE THE TEARS.

HARRY, I DON'T THINK WE'RE GOING TO BE ABLE TO GO BACK THERE.

WHAT DO YOU ?

AS WE DISAPPEARED, SAKLEY CALLED HIMSELF UP ME AND I COULDN'T
GET RID OF HIM, HE WAS TOO STRONG, AND HE WAS STILL HOLDING ME
WHEN

WE ARRIVED AT CRIMINALM PLACE, AND THEN WELL, I THINK HE MUST
HAVE SEEN THE DEER, AND THOUGHT WE WERE STOPPING THERE, SO HE
SLACKENED HIS GRIP AND I MANAGED TO SHAKE HIM OFF AND I REELT
LIS

HERE INSTEAD.

BUT THEN, WHERE'S HE? FANG HIM, . . . WHY DOESN'T HE GET AT GRIM-
MALD PLACE? HE CAN'T GET IN THERE?

THEY THEIR

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HER EYES SPARKLED WITH LUSHED TEARS AS SHE NEEDED.

HARRY, I THINK HE CAN. I I FORCED HIM TO LET GO WITH A REVUL-
SION INDEX, BUT I'D ALREADY TAKEN HIM INSIDE THE FIDELITY CHARM'S

PROTECTION. SINCE DUMBLEDORE DIED, WE'RE SECRET-KEEPERS, SHE'D WE
GIVEN HIM THE SECRET, HAVEN'T I?

THERE WAS NO PRETENDING; HARRY WAS SURE SHE WAS RIGHT. IT WAS
A SERIOUS RISK. IF PARSLEY COULD NOW GET INSIDE THE HELLER, THERE WAS
NO WAY THAT THEY COULD RETURN. EVEN NOW, HE COULD BE BRINGING
EITHER DEATH EATERS IN THERE BY APPARITION, CLEVER AND
IMPRESSIVE

THOUGH THE HELLER WAS, IT HAD BEEN THEIR ONE SAFE REFUGE: EVEN
NOW

THAT REACHER WAS SHE MUCH HAPPIER AND FRIENDLIER, A KIND OF HOME.
WITH A TWINGE OF REGRET THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THEM, HARRY
IMAGINED THE HELLER-ER ELUSING HIMSELF EVERY THE STEAD-AND-DIDN'T
PIE THAT HARRY, RON, AND HERMION WOULD NEVER EAT.

HARRY, I'M SURE, I'M SHE SURE?

DOESN'T BE STUPID, IT WASN'T PARSLEY'S FAULT! IF ANYTHING, IT WAS

MINE. . .

HARRY PUT HIS HAND IN HIS POCKET AND DREW OUT MAD-EYE'S EYE.

HERMIONE RECOILED, LOOKING FRIGHTENED.

LUMBRIDGE HAD STUCK IT TO HER OFFICE DESK, THE SPY HAD PEOPLE. I
COULDN'T

LEAVE IT THERE . . . BUT THAT'S HOW THEY KNEW THERE WERE INTRUDERS.

BEFORE HERMIONE COULD ANSWER, RON CREANED AND OPENED HIS
EYES. HE WAS STILL GRAY AND HIS FACE GLISTENED WITH SWEAT.

HOW DO YOU FEEL? HERMIONE WHISPERED.

HELLS, CREANED RON, WINKING AS HE FELT HIS INJURED ARM. WHERE
ARE WE?

IN THE WOODS WHERE THEY HAD THE SLIDITCH WORLD CUP, SAID
HERMIONE. I WANTED SOMEWHERE ENCLOSED, UNDERCOVER, AND THIS
WAS

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE

THE FIRST PLACE YOU THOUGHT OF, HARRY FINISHED FOR HER,
GLANCE-

ING AROUND AT THE APPARENTLY DESERTED GLADE. HE COULD NOT HELP RE-
MEMBERING WHAT HAD HAPPENED THE LAST TIME THEY HAD APPEARED

THE FIRST PLACE HERMIONE HAD THOUGHT OF HOW DEATH EATERS
HAD FOUND THEM WITHIN MINUTES. HAD IT BEEN LEGITIMACY? DID
Voldemort and his henchmen know, even now, where HERMIONE HAD

TAKEN THEM?

D YOU REMEMBER WE SHOULD MOVE HIM? RENN ASKED HARRY, AND HARRY COULD TELL BY THE LEER IN RENN'S FACE THAT HE WAS THINKING THE SAME.

I DUNNED.

RENN STILL LOOKED PALE AND CLAMMY. HE HAD MADE ONE ATTEMPT TO SIT UP AND IT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS THEN LEAD TO THE SEE. THE PROSPECT

OF MOVING HIM WAS DAILINTING.

LET'S STAY HERE FOR NOW, HARRY SAID.

LOOKING RELIEVED, HERMIONE SPRANG TO HER FEET.

WHERE ARE YOU GOING? ASKED RENN.

IF WE'RE STAYING, WE SHOULD PUT SOME PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS AROUND THE PLACE, SHE REPLIED, AND RAISING HER HAND, SHE BEGAN

THE WALK IN A WIDE CIRCLE AROUND HARRY AND RENN, MURMURING INCANTATIONS AS SHE WENT. HARRY SAW LITTLE DISTURBANCES IN THE SURROUNDING AIR: IT WAS AS IF HERMIONE HAD CAST A HEAT HAZE UPON THEIR

CLEARING.

SALVIE HEXIA . . . PROTEGE TETALLIM . . . REPELLE MUGGLETLIM . . . MURPLIATE . . . YOU COULD GET HIT THE TENT, HARRY, . . .

TENT?

IN THE BAG?

IN THE . . . HE CHUCKLED, SAID HARRY.

HE DID NOT ENTER THE GROPE INSIDE IT THIS TIME, BUT USED ANOTHER

THE THREE

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SLEEPING CHARM. THE TENT EMERGED IN A LUMPY MASS OF CANVAS, REEF, AND POLES. HARRY RECOGNIZED IT, PARTLY BECAUSE OF THE SMELL OF CATS, AS THE SAME TENT IN WHICH THEY HAD SLEPT ON THE NIGHT OF THE ELWIDITCH WERLD CLIP.

I THOUGHT THIS BELONGED TO THAT BLENDY PERKINS AT THE MINISTRY? HE ASKED, STARTING TO DISENTANGLE THE TENT PEGS.

APPARENTLY HE DIDN'T WANT IT BACK, HIS LIMBAGE SHE HAD, SAID HERMIONE, NEARLY PERFORMING COMPLICATED FIGURE-OF-EIGHT MOVEMENTS WITH HER WAND. SHE THEN SAID I COULD REPAIR IT. PROBABLY SHE ADDED, POINTING HER WAND AT THE MISMADE CANVAS, WHICH IN ONE FLUID MOTION ROSE INTO THE AIR AND SETTLED, FULLY CONSTRUCTED, BENEATH THE

GRILING BEFORE HARRY, WHOSE STARTLED HANDS A TENT PEG SHARED,

THE LAND WITH A FINAL THUD AT THE END OF A GLY REEF.

CAVE INIMICLY, HERMIONE FINISHED WITH A SPOYARD FLICKRISH.

THAT'S AS MUCH AS I CAN DO. AT THE VERY LEAST, WE SHOULD KNOW THEY'RE COMING. I CAN'T GUARANTEE IT WILL KEEP HIMT VEE

DON'T SAY THE NAME! RON CLUT ACROSS HER, HIS VOICE HARSH. HARRY AND HERMIONE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

I'M SORRY, RON SAID, MEANING A LITTLE AS HE RAISED HIMSELF THE
LEND

AT THEM, BUT IT FEELS LIKE A A HINGE FOR SOMETHING. CAN'T WE CALL HIM

PHIL-DONNELL-WHITE PLEASE?

OLIMPEDERE SAID FEAR OF A NAME BEGAN FARRY.

IN CASE PHIL HADN'T NOTICED, MAYBE, CALLING PHIL-DONNELL-WHITE BY HIS NAME DIDN'T DO OLIMPEDERE MUCH GOOD IN THE END. REIN SNAPPED BACK. MUST MUST SHOW PHIL-DONNELL-WHITE SOME RESPECT, WILL PHIL? RESPECT? FARRY REPEATED, BUT FERMINE SENT HIM A WARNING LOOK; APPARENTLY HE WAS NOT THE ANGEL WITH REIN WHILE THE LATTER WAS

IN SUCH A WEAKENED CONDITION.

FARRY AND FERMINE HALF CARRIED, HALF DRAGGED REIN THROUGH

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THE ENTRANCE OF THE TENT. THE INTERIOR WAS EXACTLY AS FARRY REMEM-

BERED IT: A SMALL FLAT, COMPLETE WITH BATHROOM AND TINY KITCHEN. HE

SHOVED ASIDE AN OLD ARMCHAIR AND LOWERED REIN CAREFULLY INTO THE LOWER BERTH OF A BLIND BED. EVEN THIS VERY SHORT JOURNEY HAD TURNED

REIN WHITER STILL, AND SINCE THEY HAD SETTLED HIM IN THE MATTRESS HE CLOSED HIS EYES AGAIN AND DID NOT SPEAK FOR A WHILE.

I'LL MAKE SOME TEA, SAID FERMINE BREATHLESSLY, PULLING BOTTLE AND

MILES FROM THE DEPTHS OF HER BAG AND HEADING TOWARD THE KITCHEN,
HARRY FEELING THE FEET DRINK AS WELCOME AS THE FIREW-HISSEY HAD
BEEN IN THE NIGHT THAT MAD-LYR HAD DIED; IT SEEMED THE BLIND AWAY
A LITTLE OF THE FEAR FLUTTERING IN HIS CHEST. AFTER A MINUTE OR TWO,
THEN
BROKE THE SILENCE.

WHAT DO YOU RECKON HAPPENED TO THE LATTERMELES?

WITH ANY LUCK, THEY LL HAVE GET AWAY, SAID HERMINE, CLUTCHING
HER FEET MILE FOR COMFORT. AS LONG AS MR. LATTERMELE HAD HIS WITS

ABOUT HIM, HE LL HAVE TRANSPORTED MRS. LATTERMELE BY SIDE-ALONG-
APPARITION AND THEY LL BE FLEEING THE COUNTRY RIGHT NOW WITH
THEIR

CHILDREN. THAT S WHAT HARRY TOLD HER THE DEE.

BLIMEY, I HOPE THEY ESCAPED, SAID REIN, LEANING BACK IN HIS
PILLOWS. THE TEA SEEMED TO BE DOING HIM GOOD; A LITTLE OF HIS CHEER
HAD RETURNED. I DIDN T GET THE FEELING REG LATTERMELE WAS ALL THAT
WIND-BITTEN, THOUGH, THE WAY EVERYONE WAS TALKING TO ME WHEN I

WAS HIM. GOOD, I HOPE THEY MADE IT. . . . IF THEY BOTH END UP IN AZ-
KABAN BECAUSE OF US . . .

HARRY LOOKED OVER AT HERMINE AND THE ELDEST SON HE HAD BEEN
ABOUT THE AGE ABOUT WHETHER MRS. LATTERMELE S LACK OF A HAND
WOULD PREVENT HER APPARATING ALONGSIDE HER HUSBAND DIED IN
HIS

THREAT, HERMINE WAS WATCHING REIN FRET OVER THE FATE OF THE

CATTERMILES, AND THERE WAS SUCH TENDERNESS IN HER EXPRESSION
THAT

THEY THIRP

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HARRY FELT ALMOST AS IF HE HAD SURPRISED HER IN THE ACT OF KISSING
HIM.

SHE HAD YELL GET IT? HARRY ASKED HER, PARTLY TO REMIND HER
THAT

HE WAS THERE.

GET GET WHAT? SHE SAID WITH A LITTLE START.

WHAT DID WE JUST GO THROUGH ALL THAT FOR? THE LOCKET? WHERE'S
THE LOCKET?

YELL GET IT? SPELLED RHEIN, RAISING HIMSELF A LITTLE HIGHER THAN HIS

PILLARS. SHE HAD TELLS ME ANYTHING? BLIMEY, YELL CHILD HAD MEN-
TIONED IT?

WELL, WE WERE RUNNING FOR OUR LIVES FROM THE DEATH EATERS,
WEREN'T WE? SAID HERMIONE. HERE.

AND SHE PULLED THE LOCKET OUT OF THE POCKET OF HER PANTS AND
HANDS IT TO RHEIN.

IT WAS AS LARGE AS A CHICKEN'S EGG, AN ORNATE LETTER S, INLAIN WITH
MANY SMALL GREEN STONES, GLINTED DIMLY IN THE DIMMED LIGHT
SHINING

THROUGH THE TENT'S CANVAS SHEET.

THERE ISN'T ANY CHANCE SOMEONE'S DESTROYED IT SINCE DREACHER HAD IT? ASKED BEN HOPEFULLY. I MEAN, ARE WE SURE IT'S STILL A ~~HERCULES~~?

I THINK SHE SAID JERMIENE, TAKING IT BACK FROM HIM AND LOOKING AT IT CLOSELY. THERE'D BE SOME SIGN OF DAMAGE IF IT HAD BEEN MAGICALLY DESTROYED.

SHE PASSED IT TO HARRY, WHO TURNED IT OVER IN HIS FINGERS. THE THING

LOOKED PERFECT, PRISTINE. HE REMEMBERED THE MANGLED REMAINS OF THE DIARY, AND HOW THE STONE IN THE ~~HERCULES~~ RING HAD BEEN CRACKED

OPEN WHEN DUMBLEDORE DESTROYED IT.

I RECKON DREACHER'S RIGHT, SAID HARRY. WE'RE GOING TO HAVE TO WORK OUT HOW TO OPEN THIS THING BEFORE WE CAN DESTROY IT.

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THE

SLIDEN AWARENESS OF WHAT HE WAS HOLDING, OF WHAT LIVED BEHIND THE LITTLE CHILDREN DOORS, HIT HARRY AS HE SPHERE. EVEN AFTER ALL THEIR EFFORTS TO FIND IT, HE FELT A VIOLENT LONG TO FLING THE LOCKET FROM HIM.

MASTERING HIMSELF AGAIN, HE TRIED TO PRIZE THE LOCKET APART WITH HIS

FINGERS, THEN ATTEMPTED THE CHARM JERMIENE HAD USED TO OPEN

REGULUS & REBRHEM DHEH, NEITHER WORKED, HE HANDED THE LOCKET BACK TO RHN AND HERMINE, EACH OF WHOM DID THEIR BEST, BUT WERE NOT MORE SUCCESSFUL AT OPENING IT THAN HE HAD BEEN.

CAN YOU FEEL IT, THOUGH? RHN ASKED IN A FLUSTERED VOICE, AS HE HELD IT TIGHT IN HIS CLENCHED FIST.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN?

RHN PASSED THE LOCKET TO HARRY, AFTER A MOMENT HER TWO, HARRY

THOUGHT HE KNEW WHAT RHN MEANT, WAS IT HIS HEAVY BLEED PULSING THROUGH HIS VEINS THAT HE COULD FEEL, OR WAS IT SOMETHING BEATING INSIDE THE LOCKET, LIKE A TINY METAL HEART?

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO WITH IT? HERMINE ASKED.

KEEP IT SAFE TILL WE WORK OUT HOW TO DESTROY IT, HARRY REPLIED, AND, LITTLE THOUGH HE WANTED TO, HE HUNG THE CHAIN AROUND HIS NECK.

NEED, DROPPING THE LOCKET INTO HIS SIGHT BEHIND HIS BACKS, WHERE IT RESTED AGAINST HIS CHEST BESIDE THE POUCH HARRY HAD GIVEN HIM.

I THINK WE SHOULD TAKE IT IN TURNS TO KEEP WATCH OUTSIDE THE TENT,

HE ADDED TO HERMINE, STANDING UP AND STRETCHING. AND WE'LL NEED TO THINK ABOUT SOME FOOD AS WELL, YOU STAY THERE, HE ADDED SHARPLY,

AS RHN ATTEMPTED TO SIT UP AND TURNED A NAUZY SHADE OF GREEN.

WITH THE SNACKS SHE HAD GIVEN HARRY FOR HIS BIRTHDAY SET CAREFULLY UPON THE TABLE IN THE TENT, HARRY AND HERMINE

SPENT THE REST OF THE DAY SHARING THE RICE OF LUNCH. HOWEVER,

THE SNEAKESHOPE REMAINED SILENT AND STILL UPON ITS POINT ALL DAY,
AND WHETHER BECAUSE OF THE PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS AND MISCLE-

THE THEIR

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REPELLING CHARMS HERMIONE HAD SPREAD AROUND THEM, HER BECAUSE

PEOPLE RARELY VENTURED THIS WAY, THEIR PATCH OF WOOD REMAINED DE-
SERTE, APART FROM ECCASTHIAL BIRDS AND SEELIRRELS, EVENING BRIGHT

THE CHANGE; HARRY LIT HIS HAND AS HE SLAPPED PLACES WITH
HERMIONE

AT TEN HE CHECK, AND WISHED HEIT UPON A DESERTED SCENE, MEETING THE
BATS

ALLITERING HIGH ABOVE HIM ACROSS THE SINGLE PATCH OF STARRY SKY
VISIBLE

FROM THEIR PROTECTED CLEARING,

HE FELT HUNGRY NOW, AND A LITTLE LIGHT-HEADED, HERMIONE HAD
NEET PACKED AND MEED IN HER MAGICAL BAG, AS SHE HAD ASSUMED THAT
THEY WOULD BE RETURNING THE CRIMINALS PLACE THAT NIGHT, SHE THEY

HAD HAD NOTHING THE BAT EXCEPT SOME WILD MIST-IRREMS THAT HERMI-
ONE HAD COLLECTED FROM AMONGST THE NEAREST TREES AND STEWED IN A

KILLYCAN, AFTER A COUPLE OF MONTHS HIS REIN HAD POLISHED HIS
PHENTIEN

ALAY, WHISKING AWAY; HARRY HAD ONLY PERSEVERED SHE AS NEET THE FLIRT

TERMINING S FEELINGS.

THE SURROUNDING SILENCE WAS BROKEN BY HED RUSTLING AND WHAT SOUNDED LIKE CRACKING OF TWIGS; HARRY THOUGHT THAT THEY WERE CAUSED BY ANIMALS RATHER THAN PEOPLE, YET HE KEPT HIS HAND HELD TIGHT AT THE READY, HIS INSIDES, ALREADY UNCOMFORTABLE DUE THE THEIR INADEQUATE HELPING OF RICKERY MUSCLES, TINGLED WITH UNEASE. HE HAD THOUGHT THAT HE WOULD FEEL ELATED IF THEY MANAGED THE STEAL

BACK THE THIEVES, BUT SOMEHOW HE DID NOT; ALL HE FELT AS HE SAT

ING OUT AT THE DARKNESS, OF WHICH HIS HAND LIT ONLY A TINY PART, WAS

WHY HE HAD NO IDEA WHAT WOULD HAPPEN NEXT. IT WAS AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN

FLUTTERING TOWARD THIS POINT FOR WEEKS, MONTHS, MAYBE EVEN YEARS, BUT

NOW HE HAD COME THE AN ABRUPT HALT, ALIN OUT OF REACH.

THERE WERE EITHER THIEVES OUT THERE SOMEWHERE, BUT HE DID NOT HAVE THE FAINTEST IDEA WHERE THEY WOULD BE. HE DID NOT EVEN KNOW WHAT ALL OF THEM WERE. MEANWHILE HE WAS AT A LOSS TO KNOW WHEN THE

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DESTINED THE ONLY ONE THAT THEY HAD FOUND, THE FATHERLY THAT CURRENTLY LAY AGAINST THE BARE FLESH OF HIS CHEST. CURIOUSLY, IT HAD NOT

TAKEN HEAT FROM HIS BODY, BUT LAY SHE HELD AGAINST HIS SKIN IT MIGHT JUST HAVE EMERGED FROM ITS WATER, FROM TIME TO TIME FLASHING THOUGHT,

HE PERHAPS IMAGINED, THAT HE COULD FEEL THE TINY HEARTBEAT TICKING IRREGULARLY ALONGSIDE HIS OWN,

NAMELESS PERSEVERANCES CREEPT UPON HIM AS HE SAT THERE IN THE DARK:

HE TRIED TO RESIST THEM, PUSH THEM AWAY, YET THEY CAME AT HIM RELENT-

LESSLY, NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE OTHER SURVIVES, THEN AND FORTHWITH,

WHEN TALKING SEFTLY BEHIND HIM IN THE TENT, COULD WALK AWAY IF THEY WANTED TO: HE COULD NOT, AND IT SEEMED TO FLASH AS HE SAT THERE TRYING TO MASTER HIS OWN FEAR AND EXHAUSTION, THAT THE FATHERLY AGAINST HIS CHEST WAS TICKING AWAY THE TIME HE HAD LEFT. . . . STUPID IDEA, HE TOLD HIMSELF, DON'T THINK THAT. . . .

HIS SKIN WAS STARTING TO PRICKLE AGAIN, HE WAS AFRAID THAT HE WAS MAKING IT HAPPEN BY HAVING THESE THOUGHTS, AND TRIED TO DIRECT THEM INTO ANOTHER CHANNEL, HE THOUGHT OF THEIR ORIGIN, WHEN HAD

EXPECTED THEM FROM AND HAD RECEIVED THEM INSTEAD, WOULD THE

HE DEEP SILENT HE WOULD HE TELL THE DEATH EATER EVERYTHING HE
KNEW?

HARRY WANTED TO BELIEVE THAT CRACKER HAD CHANGED TOWARD HIM IN
THE PAST MONTH, THAT HE WOULD BE Loyal NOW, BUT WHEN HE WOULD WHAT

WOULD HAPPEN? WHAT IF THE DEATH EATERS THRTLRED THE HE? SICK IM-
AGES SWARMED INTO HARRY'S HEAD AND HE TRIED TO PUSH THEM AWAY
THEM,

AND THERE WAS NOTHING HE COULD DO AND CRACKER: HE AND
HERMION

HAD ALREADY DECIDED AGAINST TRYING TO SLIP HIM; WHAT IF SOME-
ONE FROM THE MINISTRY CAME THEM? THEY COULD NOT COUNT ON ELISH

APPARITION BEING FREE FROM THE SAME FLAW THAT HAD TAKEN JAXLEY
THE

CRIMINAL PLACE IN THE HAND OF HERMION'S SLEEVE.

HARRY'S SCAR WAS BURNING NOW, HE THOUGHT THAT THERE WAS SOMETHING
MUCH

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THEY DID NOT KNOW: LUPIN HAD BEEN RIGHT ABOUT MAGIC THEY HAD
NEVER ENCOUNTERED HE IMAGINED, WHY HADN'T DUMBLEDORE EXPLAINED

MERE? HAD HE THOUGHT THAT THERE WOULD BE TIME; THAT HE WOULD LIVE

FOR YEARS, FOR CENTURIES PERHAPS, LIKE HIS FRIEND NICHOLAS FLAME? IF
SEE, HE HAD BEEN WRONG. . . . SNAPE HAD SEEN THE TRUTH. . . . SNAPE, THE
SLEEPING SNAPE, WHO HAD STRUCK AT THE THROAT OF THE THIEF . . .
AND DUMBLEDORE HAD FALLEN . . . FALLEN . . .

GIVE IT TO ME, GREGOROVITCH.

HARRY'S VEIL WAS HIGH, CLEAR, AND COLD, HIS HAND HELD IN FRONT
OF HIM BY A LONG-FINGERED WHITE HAND. THE MAN AT WHOM HE WAS
POINTING WAS SUSPENDED UPSIDE DOWN IN MIDAIR, THOUGH THERE WERE
NO ROPES HOLDING HIM; HE SWUNG THERE, INVISIBLY AND TERRIBLY QUIET,
HIS LIMBS WRAPPED ABOUT HIM, HIS TERRIFIED FACE, HIS A LIP WITH
HARRY'S, RUDDY BUT THE SAME COLOR THAT HAD RUINED THE HIS HEAD. HE
HAD PURE-WHITE HAIR AND A THICK, BRISTLY BEARD; A TRILLED-LIP FATHER
CHRISTMAS.

I HAVE IT NOT, I HAVE IT NOT MORE? IT WAS, MANY YEARS AGO, STOLEN
FROM ME?

DO NOT BE THE LORD VOLDEMORT, GREGOROVITCH, HE KNOWS. . . . HE
ALWAYS KNOWS.

THE HANGING MAN'S PUPILS WERE WIDE, DILATED WITH FEAR, AND THEY
SEEMED TO SWELL, BIGGER AND BIGGER UNTIL THEIR BLACKNESS SWALLOWED
HARRY WHOLE

AND WHEN HARRY WAS HURRYING ALONG A DARK CORRIDOR IN STEALTH
LITTLE

GREGOROVITCH'S LAKE AS HE HELD A LANTERN AHEAD; GREGOROVITCH
FIRST

INTO THE ROOM AT THE END OF THE PASSAGE AND HIS LANTERN
ILLUMINATED

WHAT LOOKED LIKE A WERDST-HP; WHEN STAYING AND CHILD CLAMORED
IN THE SWINGING PINK OF LIGHT, AND THERE ON THE WINDING LEDGE SAT
PERCHED, LIKE A GIANT BIRD, A YOUNG MAN WITH GOLDEN HAIR. IN THE

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SPLIT SECOND THAT THE LANTERN'S LIGHT ILLUMINATED HIM, HARRY SAW
THE

DELIGHT UPON HIS HANDSOME FACE, THEN THE INTRUDER SEET A
STUNNING

SPELL FROM HIS WAND AND LUMPED NEATLY BACKWARD OUT OF THE
WINDING

WITH A CRASH OF BALLETTER.

AND HARRY WAS FLUTTERING BACK OUT OF THESE WIDE, TUNNELLIKE
PUPILS

AND GREGOROVITCH'S FACE WAS STRICKEN WITH TERROR.

WHEN WAS THE TIME, GREGOROVITCH SAID THE HIGH CHILD VOICE.

I DO NOT KNOW, I NEVER KNOW, A YOUNG MAN NE PLEASE
PLEASE;

A SCREAM THAT WENT ON AND ON AND THEN A BURST OF GREEN LIGHT
HARRY;

HE OPENED HIS EYES, PANTING, HIS FOREHEAD TREMBLING. HE HAD
PASSED OUT AGAINST THE SIDE OF THE TENT, HAD SLID SIDEWAYS DOWN THE

CANVAS, AND WAS SPRAWLED ON THE GRASS. HE LOOKED UP AT HERMI-

HEN, WHENSE KUSHY HAIR REVEALED THE TINY PATCH OF SKIN VISIBLE
THROUGH

THE DARK BRANCHES HIGH ABOVE THEM.

DREAM, HE SAID, SITTING UP QUICKLY AND ATTEMPTING THE MEET
HERMIONE'S GLEAMER WITH A LOOK OF INDIFFERENCE. MUST WE DRIZZLE OFF,
SHERRY.

I KNOW IT WAS YOUR SCAR? I CAN TELL BY THE LOOK IN YOUR FACE? YOU
WERE LOOKING INTO THE VEIL

DIDN'T SAY HIS NAME? CAN'T BEEN'S ANGRY VOICE FROM THE DEPTHS
OF THE TENT.

FINE, RETORTED HERMIONE. YOU KNOW WHAT'S MIND, THEN?
I DIDN'T MEAN IT TO HAPPEN? HARRY SAID. IT WAS A DREAM? CAN
YOU CONTROL WHAT YOU DREAM ABOUT, HERMIONE?
IF YOU JUST LEARNED THE ART OF FOCUSING

BUT HARRY WAS NOT INTERESTED IN BEING TOLD OFF? HE WANTED THE DIS-
CUSS WHAT HE HAD JUST SEEN.

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HE'S ARLAND GREGORYVITCH, HERMIONE, AND I THINK HE'S KILLED
HIM, BUT BEFORE HE KILLED HIM HE READ GREGORYVITCH'S MIND AND I
SAW

I THINK I'D BETTER TAKE OVER THE WATCH IF YOU'RE SO TIRED YOU'RE

FALLING ASLEEP, SAID FERMINE CHILLY,

I CAN FINISH THE WATCH:

THEY WERE HEAVILY EXHAUSTED, SHE AND HER DEER.

SHE DROPPED DOWN IN THE MIDDLE OF THE TENT, LOOKING STRAIGHT,

ANGRY, BUT WISHING THE WORLD A WELL, HARRY CLOSED BACK INSIDE.

THEY'S STILL-PALE FACE WAS PEEKING OUT FROM THE LOWER BLIND; HARRY

CLIMBED INTO THE HOLE ABOVE HIM, LAY DOWN, AND LOOKED UP AT THE

CANVAS CEILING. AFTER SEVERAL MOMENTS, THEY SPoke IN A VOICE SHE

THAT IT WOULD NOT CARRY THE FERMINE, HIDDEN IN THE ENTRANCE.

WHAT'S YOUR OWN-OWN DEED?

HARRY SQUEEZED UP HIS EYES IN THE EFFORT TO REMEMBER EVERY DETAIL,

THEN WHISPERED INTO THE DARKNESS.

HE FELT GREGORYVITCH. HE HAD HIM TIED UP, HE WAS TORTURING

THEY'S GREGORYVITCH SUGGESTED THE MAKE HIM A NEW WAND IF HE'S

I BLAME... IT'S WEIRD, ISN'T IT?

HARRY CLOSED HIS EYES, THINKING OF ALL HE HAD SEEN AND HEARD. THE

NOTHING ABOUT HARRY'S WAND, NOTHING ABOUT THE TWIN CHIPS,

ING ABOUT GREGORYVITCH MAKING A NEW AND MORE POWERFUL WAND THE

REAT HARRY'S...

HE WANTED SOMETHING FROM GREGORYVITCH, HARRY SAID, EYES STILL

CLOSED TIGHT. HE ASKED HIM THE HAND IT HAD, BUT GREGORIEVITCH SAID
IT HAD BEEN STEALEN FROM HIM . . . AND THEN . . . THEN . . .

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HE REMEMBERED HOW HE, AS VIKTOR, HAD SEEMED THE FLUTTER
THROUGH GREGORIEVITCH'S EYES, INTO HIS MEMORIES. . . .

HE READ GREGORIEVITCH'S MIND, AND I SAW THIS YELING BIRD PERCHED
ON A WINDMILL, AND HE FIRED A CLASP AT GREGORIEVITCH AND LUMPED
BUT HE SIGHT. HE STEAL IT, HE STEAL WHATEVER YEL-DOWN-WHIS
AFTER.

AND I . . . I THINK I VE SEEN HIM SOMEWHERE. . . .

HARRY WISHED HE COULD HAVE ANOTHER GLIMPSE OF THE LAUGHING
BIRD'S FACE. THE THEFT HAD HAPPENED MANY YEARS AGO, ACCORDING TO
GREGORIEVITCH. WHY DID THE YELING THING SEEM FAMILIAR?

THE WHISSES OF THE SLURRING WINDS WERE MUFFLED INSIDE THE
TENT; ALL HARRY COULD HEAR WAS REIN'S BREATHING. AFTER A WHILE,
REIN

WHISPERED, COULDN'T YOU SEE WHAT THE THING WAS HOLDING?

NO . . . IT MUST VE BEEN SOMETHING SMALL.

HARRY?

THE WOODEN SLATS OF REIN'S BLIND CREAKED AS HE REPEATED HIM-
SELF IN BED.

HARRY, WHO DIDN'T RECOGNISE WHO'D DONE WHAT AFTER SOMETHING ELSE
THEY TURN INTO A CHICKEN?

I DIDN'T KNOW, SAID HARRY SLEAZELY. MAYBE, BUT WOULDNT IT BE
DANGEROUS FOR HIM THE MORE ANOTHER ONE? DIDN'T HERMIONE SAY HE
HAD PUSHED HIS SKILL THE VERY LIMIT ALREADY?

YES, BUT MAYBE HE DOESN'T KNOW THAT,

YES... MAYBE, SAID HARRY,

HE HAD BEEN SURE THAT VERMOREL HAD BEEN LOOKING FOR A WAY
AROUND THE PROBLEM OF THE TWIN CHAIRS, SURE THAT VERMOREL
WOULD

A SOLUTION FROM THE OLD WANDMAKER... AND YET HE HAD KILLED HIM,
APPARENTLY WITHOUT ASKING HIM A SINGLE QUESTION ABOUT
WANDS.

WHAT WAS VERMOREL TRYING TO FIND? WHY, WITH THE MINISTRY OF
MAGIC AND THE WIZARDING WORLD AT HIS FEET, WAS HE FAR AWAY, INTENT

THEY

THE

IN THE PURSUIT OF AN OBJECT THAT GREGOROVITCH HAD NEVER HAD,
AND

WHICH HAD BEEN STOLEN BY THE LINDHELM THIEF?

HARRY COULD STILL SEE THE BLOOD-HAIRED WHO'D'S FACE; IT WAS MERRY,
WILD; THERE WAS A FROD AND GINGER-ISH AIR OF TRIUMPHANT TRICKERY
ABOUT HIM. HE HAD ESCAPED FROM THE WINDMILL LIKE A BIRD, AND
HARRY HAD SEEN HIM BEFORE, BUT HE COULD NOT THINK WHERE...

WITH GREGOROVITCH DEAD, IT WAS THE MERRY-FACED THIEF WHO WAS

IN DANGER NOW, AND IT WAS THEN THAT HARRY'S TEHLIGHTS DWELLED,
AS

THEY'S SNIRES BEGAN TO RUMBLE FROM THE LOWER CLIMB AND AS HE
HIMSELF

DRIFTED SLEEPLY INTO SLEEP ONCE MORE.

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THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

EARLY NEXT MORNING, BEFORE THE EITHER TWO WERE AWAKE, HARRY LEFT
THE TENT TO SEARCH THE WOODS AROUND THEM FOR THE ELDEST, MEET
ENABLED, AND RESILIENT-LOOKING TREE HE COULD FIND. THERE IN ITS
SHADES

HE CLIMBED MAD-LY MERRY'S EYE AND MARKED THE SPOT BY CHISELING A
SMALL CROSS IN THE BARK WITH HIS WAND. IT WAS NOT MUCH, BUT HARRY
FELT THAT MAD-LY WOULD HAVE MUCH PREFERRED THIS TO BEING STUCK
IN

DEEPER LIMERIDGE'S DEER. THEN HE RETURNED TO THE TENT TO WAIT FOR
THE

EITHERS TO WAKE, AND DISCUSS WHAT THEY WERE GOING TO DO NEXT.

HARRY AND HERMIONE FELT THAT IT WAS BEST NOT TO STAY ANYWHERE
THEY WERE, AND THEN AGREED, WITH THE SAME PROVISION THAT THEIR NEXT
MOVE

THEY WOULD WITHIN REACH OF A BAKED SANDWICH. HERMIONE THEREFORE
RE-

MOVED THE ENCHANTMENTS SHE HAD PLACED AROUND THE CLEARING, WHILE

HARRY AND REN ELITERATED ALL THE MARKS AND IMPRESSIONS ON THE

GROUND THAT MIGHT SHOW THEY HAD CAMPED THERE. THEN THEY DISAP-
PEARED THE ELITEXIRTS OF A SMALL MARKET TOWN.

SINCE THEY HAD PITCHED THE TENT IN THE SHELTER OF A SMALL CLUMP OF
T

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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TREES AND SURROUNDED IT WITH FRESHLY CAST DEFENSIVE ENCHANTMENTS,
HARRY VENTURED OUT UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CHARM TO FIND
SUSTENANCE.

THIS, HOWEVER, DID NOT GO AS PLANNED. HE HAD BARELY ENTERED THE
TOWN WHEN AN UNNATURAL CHILL, A DESCENDING MIST, AND A SUDDEN
DARKENING OF THE SKIES MADE HIM FREEZE WHERE HE STOOD.

BUT THEN CAN MAKE A BRILLIANT PATRIOTIST? PROTESTED REN, WHEN
HARRY ARRIVED BACK AT THE TENT EMPTY-HANDED, OUT OF BREATH, AND
MELTING THE SINGLE WIND, DEMENTERS.

I CHILDN T . . . MAKE ONE, HE PANTED, CLUTCHING THE STITCH IN HIS
SIDE. CHILDN T . . . ONE.

THEIR EXPRESSIONS OF CONSTERNATION AND DISAPPOINTMENT MADE
HARRY FEEL ASHAMED. IT HAD BEEN A NIGHTMARISH EXPERIENCE, SEEING

THE DEMENTHRS GLIDING HLT IN THE MIST IN THE DISTANCE AND
REALIZING,

AS THE PARALYZING CHILD C-HECKED HIS LINGS AND A DISTANT SCREAMING
FILLED HIS EARS, THAT HE WAS NOT GOING TO BE ABLE TO PROTECT HIMSELF.
IT HAD TAKEN ALL HARRY S WILLPOWER TO LIPROHEET HIMSELF FROM THE
SPHET

AND RLIN, LEAVING THE EYELSS DEMENTHRS TO GLIDE AMONGST THE
MUGGLES

WHEN MIGHT NOT BE ABLE TO SEE THEM, BUT WOULD ASSUREDLY FEEL THE
DESPAIR THEY CAST WHEREVER THEY WENT.

SEE WE STILL HAVEN T GHT ANY ANSW.

SHUT UP, REIN, SNAPPED HERMIONE. HARRY, WHAT HAPPENED?
WHY DO YOU THINK YOU CHILDEN T MAKE YOUR PATRONUS? YOU
MANAGED

PERFECTLY YESTERDAY?

I DONT KNOW.

HE SAT DOWN IN ONE OF PERKINS S OLD ARMCHAIRS, FEELING MORE HUMILI-
ATED BY THE MOMENT. HE WAS AFRAID THAT SOMETHING HAD GONE WRONG

INSIDE HIM. YESTERDAY SEEMED A LONG TIME AGO! TODAY HE MIGHT HAVE
BEEN THIRTEEN YEARS OLD AGAIN, THE ONLY ONE WHO COLLAPSED ON THE
HOGWARTS EXPRESS.

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JOHN KICKED A CHAIR LEG.

WHAT? HE SNARLED AT FERMINE. I'M STARVING! ALL I'VE HAD SINCE
I KID HALF THE DEATH IS A CHLIPLE OF THADSTHELS!

WELL GEE AND FIGHT WELLER WAS THROUGH THE DEMENTHRS, THEN, SAID
FARRY, SLING.

I WOULD, BUT MY ARM'S IN A SLING, IN CASE WELL HADN'T NOTICED!

THAT'S CONVENIENT.

AND WHAT'S THAT SLIPPERS THE ?

OF COURSE! CRIED FERMINE, CLAPPING A HAND TO HER FOREHEAD
AND STARTLING BOTH OF THEM INTO SILENCE. FARRY, GIVE ME THE
MICKET!

COME ON, SHE SAID IMPATIENTLY, CLICKING HER FINGERS AT HIM WHEN
HE

DID NOT REACT, THE FERRICUS, FARRY, WELL HE STILL WEARING IT!

SHE HELD OUT HER HANDS, AND FARRY LIFTED THE CHILDEN CHAIN OVER
HIS HEAD. THE MOMENT IT PARTED CONTACT WITH FARRY'S SKIN HE FELT
FREE AND EDDY LIGHT. HE HAD NOT EVEN REALIZED THAT HE WAS CLAMPY
HER THAT THERE WAS A HEAVY WEIGHT PRESSING ON HIS STOMACH UNTIL
BOTH

SENSATIONS LIFTED.

BETTER? ASKED FERMINE.

YEAH, LEADS BETTER!

FARRY, SHE SAID, CREEKING DOWN IN FRONT OF HIM AND LISING THE
KIND OF VOICE HE ASSOCIATED WITH VISITING THE VERY SICK, WELL BEEN T
THINK WELL'VE BEEN POSSESSED, OH WELL?

WHAT? NO? HE SAID DEPRESSIVELY. I REMEMBER EVERYTHING WE'VE
DONE WHILE I'VE BEEN WEARING IT. I WOULDN'T KNOW WHAT I'D DONE IF
I'D BEEN POSSESSED, WOULD I? GINNY TELLS ME THERE WERE TIMES WHEN

SHE COULDN'T REMEMBER ANYTHING.

“HMM, SAID FERMINE, LEANING DOWN AT THE HEAVY CHILD LOCKET,
WELL, MAYBE WE MIGHT NOT TOO WEAR IT. WE CAN JUST KEEP IT IN THE
TENT.

THE CHILIN'S REVENGE

WE ARE NOT LEAVING THAT FIERCELY LYING AROUND, HARRY STATED
FIRMLY. IF WE LOSE IT, IF IT GETS STEALEN

“EH, ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, SAID FERMINE, AND SHE PLACED IT AROUND
HER NECK AND TUCKED IT INTO HER SIGHT DOWN THE FRONT OF HER
SHIRT.

BUT WE WILL TAKE TURNS WEARING IT, SHE NEARLY KEEPS IT IN THE LEAD.

GREAT, SAID BENN IRRITABLY, AND WHEN WE VE STARTED THAT HLT, CAN
WE PLEASE GET SOME MORE?

FINE, BUT WE WILL GO SOMEWHERE ELSE TO FIND IT, SAID FERMINE WITH
HALF A GLANCE AT HARRY. THERE'S NO POINT STAYING WHERE WE
KNOW

DEMENTERS ARE SLEEPING AROUND.

IN THE END THEY SETTLED DOWN FOR THE NIGHT IN A FAR-FLUNG FIELD RE-
SEMBLING THE A LONELY FARM, FROM WHICH THEY HAD MANAGED TO ESCAPE

EGGS AND KRAID.

IT'S NOT STEALING, IS IT? ASKED FERMINE IN A TROUBLED VOICE, AS

THEY DEVOURED SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH THAST, BUT IF I LEFT SOME MONEY
UNDER THE CHICKEN CHIMP?

RON WINKED HIS EYES AND SAID, WITH HIS CHEEKS BLINKING, ER-MY-
NEE, THE WHOLEY THE MUCK, BLANK?

AND, INDEED, IT WAS MUCH EASIER TO RELAX WHEN THEY WERE COM-
FORTABLY WELL FED: THE ARGUMENT ABOUT THE DEMENTORS WAS
FORGOTTEN

IN LAUGHTER THAT NIGHT, AND HARRY FELT CHEERFUL, EVEN HEDFUL, AS
HE

THINK THE FIRST OF THE THREE NIGHT WATCHES.

THIS WAS THEIR FIRST ENCOUNTER WITH THE FACT THAT A FULL STOMACH
MEANT GOOD SPIRITS; AN EMPTY ONE, KICKING AND GLENN, HARRY
WAS LEAST SURPRISED BY THIS, BECAUSE HE HAD SUFFERED PERIODS OF NEAR
STARVATION AT THE DURSLEYS, HERMIONE HAD LIVED REASONABLY WELL IN
THESE NIGHTS WHEN THEY MANAGED THE SLAYING NOTHING BUT BERRIES
AND

STALE BISCUITS, HER TEMPER PERHAPS A LITTLE SHORTER THAN USUAL AND
HER

SILENCE RATHER DEEP, RON, HOWEVER, HAD ALWAYS BEEN USED TO THREE

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

XXX

DELICIOUS MEALS A DAY, COURTESY OF HIS MOTHER AND OF THE FAMILIARS

HELLER-EYES, AND FLINGER MADE HIM BOTH UNREASONABLE AND IRASCIBLE.

WHenever LACK OF FOOD COINCIDED WITH RAIN & TURN THE WIND THE
FIER-

COLD, HE BECAME DOWNRIGHT UNPLEASANT.

THE WHERE NEXT? WAS HIS CONSTANT REFRAIN. HE DID NOT SEEM TO
HAVE ANY IDEAS HIMSELF, BUT EXPECTED HARRY AND HERMIONE TO COME
UP WITH PLANS WHILE HE SAT AND BROODED OVER THE WELL FOOD
SUPPLIES.

ACCORDINGLY HARRY AND HERMIONE SPENT FRUITLESS HOURS TRYING TO

DECIDE WHERE THEY MIGHT FIND THE EITHER HERCULES, AND FEEL THE DE-
STRESS THE MORE THEY HAD ALREADY GOTT, THEIR CONVERSATIONS BECOMING

INCREASINGLY REPETITIVE AS THEY HAD NO NEW INFORMATION.

AS DUMBLEDORE HAD TOLD HARRY THAT HE BELIEVED VOLDEMORT HAD

HIDDEN THE HERCULES IN PLACES IMPORTANT TO HIM, THEY BEPT RECIT-
ING, IN A SORT OF DREARY LITANY, THESE LOCATIONS THEY KNEW THAT
VOLDE-

MORT HAD LIVED OR VISITED. THE HOSPITALS WHERE HE HAD BEEN BORN

AND RAISED; HOGWARTS, WHERE HE HAD BEEN EDUCATED; BURGON AND

BLURDES, WHERE HE HAD WORKED AFTER COMPLETING SCHOOL; THEN ALBA-
NIA, WHERE HE HAD SPENT HIS YEARS OF EXILE: THESE FORMED THE BASIS

OF THEIR SPECULATIONS.

PLEASE, LET'S GO TO ALBANIA. SHELLDON T'ADDER MORE THAN AN AFTERNOON

THE SEARCH AN ENTIRE COUNTRY, SAID BEN SARCASTICALLY.

THERE CAN'T BE ANYTHING THERE. HE'D ALREADY MADE FIVE OF HIS
FINGERLINGS BEFORE HE WENT INTO EXILE, AND DUMKEDORE WAS CERTAIN
THE SNAKE IS THE SIXTH, SAID FERMINE. WE KNOW THE SNAKE'S NEST
IN ALBANIA, IT'S USUALLY WITH THE

DIDN'T I ASK YOU THE STEP SAYING THAT?

FINE! THE SNAKE IS USUALLY WITH THE DUMKEDORE-WE-HAPPY?
NEET PARTICULARLY.

I CAN'T SEE HIM HIDING ANYTHING AT BIRGIN AND BIRKES, SAID

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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HARRY, WHO HAD MADE THIS POINT MANY TIMES BEFORE, BUT SAID IT
AGAIN

SIMPLY THE READ THE NASTY SILENCE. BIRGIN AND BIRKES WERE EXPERTS
AT

DARK HEIKETS, THEY WOULD BE RECOGNIZED A FINGERLIX STRAIGHTAWAY.

BEN PALMED PHINTEDLY, REPRESSING A STRONG LURE THE THREE SOMETHING
AT HIM, HARRY PLEADED HIM, I STILL RECKON HE MIGHT HAVE
HIDDEN

SOMETHING AT FINGLARTS.

HERMIONNE SIGHED.

BUT DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE HEARD IT, HARRY?

HARRY REPEATED THE ARGUMENT HE KEPT BRINGING UP IN FAVOR OF THIS THEORY.

DUMBLEDORE SAID IN FRONT OF ME THAT HE NEVER ASSUMED HE KNEW ALL OF HOGWARTS'S SECRETS. I'M TELLING YOU, IF THERE WAS ONE PLACE YOU

W-

YOU-KNOW-ONE, THEN? HARRY STEELTED, CHASED PAST EN-DURANCE. IF THERE WAS ONE PLACE THAT WAS REALLY IMPORTANT TO YOU-

KNOW-ONE, IT WAS HOGWARTS?

HE, COME ON, STOPPED THEN. HIS SCHOOL?

YES, HIS SCHOOL! IT WAS HIS FIRST REAL HOME, THE PLACE THAT MEANT HE

WAS SPECIAL; IT MEANT EVERYTHING TO HIM, AND EVEN AFTER HE LEFT

THIS IS YOU-KNOW-ONE WE'RE TALKING ABOUT, RIGHT? NOT YOU? INJURED THEN, HE WAS TUGGING AT THE CHAIN OF THE FIERCELY AROUND

HIS NECK! HARRY WAS VISITED BY A DESIRE TO SEIZE IT AND THREATEN HIM.

YOU TOLD US THAT YOU-KNOW-ONE ASKED DUMBLEDORE TO GIVE HIM A HUG AFTER HE LEFT, SAID HERMIONNE.

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID HARRY.

AND DUMBLEDORE THOUGHT HE ONLY WANTED TO COME BACK TO TRY AND FIND SOMETHING, PROBABLY ANOTHER MEMBER'S OBJECT, TO MAKE INTO ANOTHER FIERCELY?

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

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Yeah, said Harry.

But he didn't get the ink, did he? said Hermione. See he never got the chance to find a cylinder & erect there and hide it in the school?

Er, then, said Harry, defeated. Forget the charts.

Without any other leads, they traveled into London and, hidden beneath the invisibility cloak, searched for the hideout in which

Voldemort had been raised. Hermione stole into a library and discovered from their records that the place had been demolished many

years before. They visited its site and found a rather bleak set of offices.

We could try digging in the foundations? Hermione suggested half-heartedly.

He wouldn't have hidden a secret here, Harry said. He had known it all along! The hideout had been the place Voldemort had been determined to escape; he would never have hidden a part of his self there. Dumbledore had shown Harry that Voldemort sought grandeur and mystery in his hiding places; this dismal

CORNER OF LONDON WAS AS FAR REMOVED AS YETI CHILD IMAGINE THEM

HEGLARTS FOR THE MINISTRY FOR A BUILDING LIKE CRINGETTS, THE
WIZARD-

ING RARE, WITH ITS GOLDEN DEERS AND MARKLE FLEERS,

EVEN WITHHOUT ANY NEW IDEAS, THEY CONTINUED TO MOVE THROUGH
THE COUNTRYSIDE, PITCHING THE TENT IN A DIFFERENT PLACE EACH NIGHT
FOR

SECURITY. EVERY MORNING THEY MADE SURE THAT THEY HAD REMOVED ALL

CLUES TO THEIR PRESENCE, THEN SET OFF TO FIND ANOTHER LONELY AND SE-
CLUDED SPOT, TRAVELING BY APPARITION TO MORE WOODS, TO THE
SHADES

CREVICES OF CLIFFS, THE PURPLE MOORS, GHOST-COVERED MOUNTAINSIDES,
AND ONCE A SHELTERED AND PEKKY CRY. EVERY TWELVE HOURS FOR SEE
THEY

PASSED THE BARRIERS BETWEEN THEM AS THOUGH THEY WERE PLAYING
HIDE

PERVERSE, SILENTLY CAME BY PASS-THE-PARCEL, WHERE THEY DREADED

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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THE MUSIC STOPPING BECAUSE THE REWARD WAS TWELVE HOURS OF
INCREASED

FEAR AND ANXIETY.

HARRY'S SKIN KEPT PRICKLING. IT HAPPENED MOST OFTEN, HE NOTICED, WHEN HE WAS WEARING THE HURDLIX. SOMETIMES HE COULD NOT STOP HIMSELF REACTING TO THE PAIN.

WHAT? WHAT DID YOU SEE? DEMANDED RICH, WHENEVER HE NOTICED HARRY Wince.

A FACE, MUTTERED HARRY, EVERY TIME. THE SAME FACE. THE THIEF WHO STEAL FROM GREGOROVITCH.

AND RICH WOULD TURN AWAY, MAKING NO EFFORT TO HIDE HIS DISAPPOINTMENT. HARRY KNEW THAT RICH WAS TRYING TO HEAR NEWS OF HIS

FAMILY OR OF THE REST OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX, BUT AFTER ALL, HE,

HARRY, WAS NOT A TELEVISION ARIAL; HE COULD ONLY SEE WHAT VERDEMENT

WAS THINKING AT THE TIME, NOT LONG IN THE WHATEVER THING HIS FANCY, AD-

PARENTLY VERDEMENT WAS DWELLING ENDLESSLY ON THE LONDONER WITH

WITH THE GLEAMING FACE, WHOSE NAME AND WHEREABOUTS, HARRY FELT SURE,

VERDEMENT KNEW BETTER THAN HE DID. AS HARRY'S SKIN CONTINUED TO BURN AND THE MERRY, BLIND-EAIED KID SWAM TANTALIZINGLY IN HIS MEMORY, HE LEARNED THE SLIPPERY AND SIGN OF PAIN OR DISCOMFORT, AND

THE EITHER TWO SHOWED NOTHING BUT IMPATIENCE AT THE MENTION OF
THE

THEIR. HE COULD NOT ENTIRELY BLAME THEM, WHEN THEY WERE SO DESPER-
ATE FOR A LEAD IN THE MURDER CASES.

AS THE DAYS STRETCHED INTO WEEKS, HARRY BEGAN TO SUSPECT THAT
JOHN AND HERMIONE WERE HAVING CONVERSATIONS WITH HIM, AND
ALONE,

HIM. SEVERAL TIMES THEY STOPPED TALKING ABRUPTLY WHEN HARRY EN-
TERED THE TENT, AND TWICE HE CAME ACCIDENTALLY UPON THEM, HIDDEN

A LITTLE DISTANCE AWAY, HEADS TOGETHER AND TALKING FAST; BOTH TIMES
THEY WERE SILENT WHEN THEY REALIZED HE WAS APPROACHING THEM AND
HASTENED TO APPEAR BUSY CHECKING THEIR WATER.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

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HARRY COULD NOT HELP WONDERING WHETHER THEY HAD ONLY AGREED

THE CAMP IN WHAT NOW FELT LIKE A PAINFUL AND RAMBLING MANNER
RE-

CAUSE THEY THOUGHT HE HAD SOME SECRET PLAN THAT THEY WOULD
LEARN

IN BLUE CHELWSE, REHN WAS MAKING NEH EFFERT THE HIDE HIS BAD MIND,
AND HARRY WAS STARTING THE FEAR THAT HERMIONE THEE WAS
DISAPPOINTED

BY HIS PEER LEADERSHIP, IN DESPERATION HE TRIED THE THING OF
FLIRTER

HERCULES LOCATIONS, BUT THE ONLY ONE THAT CONTINUED THE HECLAIR THE
HIM

WAS HERWARTS, AND AS NEITHER OF THE OTHERS THEUGHT THIS AT ALL
LIKELY,

HE STEPPED SUGGESTING IT.

AUTUMN ROLLED OVER THE COUNTRYSIDE AS THEY MOVED THROUGH IT:

THEY WERE NOW PITCHING THE TENT IN PLACES OF FALLEN LEAVES,
NATURAL

MISTS BEING THESE LAST BY THE DEMENTERS' WIND AND RAIN ADDED THE

THEIR TROUBLES, THE FACT THAT HERMIONE WAS GETTING BETTER AT IDEN-
TIFYING EIBLE FLINGI COULD NOT ALTOGETHER COMPENSATE FOR THEIR
CHEN-

TIDLING ISOLATION, THE LACK OF OTHER PEOPLE'S COMPANY, FOR THEIR
TENTAL

IGNORANCE OF WHAT WAS GOING ON IN THE WAR AGAINST VILDEMENT.

MY MOTHER, SAID REHN ONE NIGHT, AS THEY SAT IN THE TENT IN A
RIVERBANK IN WALES, CAN MAKE GOOD FEED APPEAR OUT OF THIN AIR.
HE PROCEEDED MEEKLY AT THE LUMPS OF CHARRD GRAY FISH IN HIS
PLATE, HARRY GLANCED ALTERNATIVELY AT REHN'S NEED AND SAW, AS HE
HAD EXPECTED, THE CHILDEN CHAIN OF THE HERCULES GLINTING THERE. HE
MANAGED THE FIGHT DOWN THE IMPULSE THE SWEAR AT REHN, WHOSE
ATTITUDE

WHILE, HE KNOW, IMPROVE SLIGHTLY WHEN THE TIME CAME TO TAKE OFF THE HOOKET.

YELLER MOTHER CAN'T PRODUCE FEED HLT OF THIN AIR, SAID HERMINE.
NIE HNR CAN, FEED IS THE FIRST OF THE FIVE PRINCIPAL EXCEPTIONS THE CAMP'S LAW OF ELEMENTAL TRANSFER

HE, SPEAK ENGLISH, CAN'T YELL? BEN SAID, PRISING A FISH FROM HLT FROM BETWEEN HIS TEETH.

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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IT'S IMPOSSIBLE TO MAKE GOOD FEED HLT OF NOTHING? YELL CAN SLIP-
MIND IT IF YELL KNOW WHERE IT IS, YELL CAN TRANSFER IT, YELL CAN INCREASE

THE HILANTITY IF YELL VE ALREADY GET SOME

WELL, BEN'T EITHER INCREASING THIS, IT'S DISGUSTING, SAID BEN.

HARRY CALLED THE FISH AND I DID MY BEST WITH IT? I NOTICE I'M AL-
WAYS THE HNR WHEN ENDS UP SHITTING HLT THE FEED, BECAUSE I'M A GIRL,

I SLIPPED?

NIE, IT'S BECAUSE YELL'RE SLIPPED THERE THE BEST AT MAGIC? SHEET
BACK BEN.

HERMINE JUMPED UP AND KITS OF REAST PINE SLID OFF HER TIN PLATE
ENTER THE FLEER.

YELL CAN SEE THE CHEEKING THEMSELVES, THEN, YELL CAN FIND THE INGREDIENTS AND TRY AND CHARM THEM INTO SOMETHING WORTH EATING, AND

I'LL SIT HERE AND PULL FACES AND MEAN AND YELL CAN SEE FEEL YELL

SPLIT LIP? SAID HARRY, LEAPING TO HIS FEET AND HOLDING UP BOTH HANDS. SPLIT LIP NELL?

HERMIONE WHISKED AWAY.

YELL CAN YELL SIDE WITH HIM, HE HARDLY EVER SEES THE CHEEK

HERMIONE, BE BELIEVE, I CAN HEAR SOMETHING?

HE WAS LISTENING HARD, HIS HANDS STILL RAISED, WARNING THEM NOT TO TALK. THEN, EVER THE RUSH AND GLISH OF THE DARK RIVER BESIDE THEM,

HE HEARD VEHICLES AGAIN. HE WHISKED AROUND AT THE SNEAKERSHIP. IT WAS

NOT MOVING.

YELL CAST THE MULTIPLY CHARM EVER LIS, RIGHT? HE WHISPERED TO HERMIONE,

I DID EVERYTHING, SHE WHISPERED BACK, MULTIPLY, MISCARREPELLING AND DISILLUSIONMENT CHARMS, ALL OF IT. THEY SHOULDNT BE

ABLE TO HEAR OR SEE LIS, WHEREVER THEY ARE.

HEAVY SLIPPING AND SCRAPING NOISES, POLLS THE SOUND OF DISMOUNTED

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

STONES AND TWIGS, TOLD THEM THAT SEVERAL PEOPLE WERE CLAMBERING
DOWN THE STEEP, WHEEDED SLOPE THAT DESCENDED THE THE NARROW BANK
WHERE THEY HAD PITCHED THE TENT. THEY DREW THEIR WANDS, WAITING.

THE ENCHANTMENTS THEY HAD CAST AROUND THEMSELVES ELIGHT THE BE
SLIP-

FICIENT, IN THE NEAR TOTAL DARKNESS, THE SHIELD THEM FROM THE NOTICE

OF MUGGLS AND NORMAL WITCHES AND WIZARDS. IF THESE WERE DEATH-
EATERS, THEN PERHAPS THEIR DEFENSES WERE ABLE TO BE TESTED BY DARK
MAGIC FOR THE FIRST TIME.

THE VEHICLES BECAME LOUDER BUT NOT MORE INTELLIGIBLE AS THE GROUP OF
MEN REACHED THE BANK. HARRY ESTIMATED THAT THEIR OWNERS WERE
FEWER

THAN TWENTY FEET AWAY, BUT THE CASCADING RIVER MADE IT IMPOSSIBLE
TO

TELL FOR SURE. HERMIONE SNATCHED UP THE LEADED BAG AND STARTED THE
RITUAL; AFTER A MOMENT SHE DREW OUT THREE EXTENDABLE EARS AND
THREW ONE EACH TO HARRY AND RON, WHO HASTILY INSERTED THE ENDS
OF

THE FLESH-COLOURED STRINGS INTO THEIR EARS AND FED THE OTHER ENDS
OUT

OF THE TENT ENTRANCE.

WITHIN SECONDS HARRY HEARD A WEARY MALE VOICE.

THERE WOULD BE A FEW SALMON IN HERE, AND YOU'LL RECKON IT'S THE
EARLY IN THE SEASON? ALL THE SALMON?

THERE WERE SEVERAL DISTINCT SPLASHES AND THEN THE SLAPPING
SOUNDS

OF FISH AGAINST FLESH. SHEPHERD GRINDED APPRECIATIVELY. HARRY
PRESSED

THE EXTENDABLE EAR DEEPER INTO HIS EAR: EVER THE MURMUR OF THE
RIVER HE COULD MAKE OUT MORE VOICES, BUT THEY WERE NOT SPEAKING
ENGLISH AND HUMAN LANGUAGE HE HAD EVER HEARD. IT WAS A
RHYTHM

AND UNMELLOUS THROB, A STRING OF RATTING, GLITTERAL NOISES,
AND

THERE SEEMED TO BE TWO SPEAKERS, ONE WITH A SLIGHTLY LOWER, SLOWER
VOICE THAN THE OTHER.

A FIRE DANCED INTO LIFE ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE CANYON; LARGE SHAD-
DOWS PASSED BETWEEN TENT AND FLAMES. THE DELICIOUS SMELL OF BAKING

THE GIBBON'S REVENGE

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SALMON WAITED TANTALIZINGLY IN THEIR DIRECTION. THEN CAME THE
CLINK-

ING OF CUTLERY ON PLATES, AND THE FIRST MAN SPEAK AGAIN.

HERE, CRIPPLED, GIBBON.

GIBBON? HERMINE MOUTHED AT HARRY, WHO NODDED.

THANK YOU, SAID THE GIBBON TOGETHER IN ENGLISH.

SEE, YOU THREE HAVE BEEN ON THE RIVER FOR LONG? ASKED A NEW,

MELLOW, AND PLEASANT VOICE; IT WAS VAGUELY FAMILIAR THE F-HARRY, WHO
PICTURED A ROUNDBELLIED, CHEERFUL-FACED MAN.

SIX WEEKS . . . SEVEN . . . I FORGET, SAID THE TIRED MAN. MET UP
WITH GRIP-HAND IN THE FIRST CHURCH OF DAYS AND JOINED HERES WITH
CHURCH MEET LEAVE AFTER. NICE TO HAVE A BIT OF COMPANY. THERE
WAS

A PALACE, WHILE KNIVES SCRAPED PLATES AND TIN MUGS WERE PICKED UP

AND REPLACED IN THE CHURCH. WHAT MADE YOU LEAVE, TED? CONTIN-
UED THE MAN.

KNEW THEY WERE COMING FOR ME, REPLIED MELLOW-VOICED TED, AND
F-HARRY SLIDDERLY KNEW WHO HE WAS: THOMAS S FATHER. HEARD DEATH
EATERS WERE IN THE AREA LAST WEEK AND DECIDED I D BETTER RUN FOR IT.
REFUSED THE REGISTER AS A MUGGLE-BORN IN PRINCIPLE, SEE, SEE I KNEW
IT WAS A MATTER OF TIME, KNEW I D HAVE THE LEAVE IN THE END. MY WIFE
SHOULD BE DEAD, SHE S PURE-BLOOD, AND THEN I MET DEAN HERE, WHAT,
A FEW DAYS AGO, THEN

Yeah, SAID ANOTHER VOICE, AND F-HARRY, DEAN, AND F-HARRY STARTED
AT EACH OTHER, SILENT BUT BESIDE THEMSELVES WITH EXCITEMENT, SURE
THEY

RECOGNIZED THE VOICE OF DEAN THOMAS, THEIR FELLOW GRIP-HAND.

MUGGLE-BORN, THEN ASKED THE FIRST MAN.

NOT SURE, SAID DEAN. MY DAD LEFT MY MOM WHEN I WAS A KID.
I VE GET THE FEELING HE WAS A LIZARD, THOUGH.

THERE WAS SILENCE FOR A WHILE, EXCEPT FOR THE SOUNDS OF MUNCHING;
THEN TED SPOKE AGAIN.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

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I VE GET THE SAY, DIRD, I M SURPRISED THE RLVN INTEH YELL. PLEASED, BUT SURPRISED. WHERD WAS YELL D BEEN CALIGHT.

I WAS, SAID DIRD. I WAS HALFWAY THE AZERABAN WHEN I MADE A BREAK FOR IT, STUNNED DAWLISH, AND NICKED HIS KNEEM. IT WAS EASIER THAN YELL D THIND; I DENN T RECKEN HE S BLITE RIGHT AT THE MEMENT. MIGHT BE CHNPLINDED. IF SEE, I D LIKE THE SHADKE THE HAND OF THE WITCH HER WIZARD WHEN DID IT, PREHABLY SAVED MY LIFE.

THERE WAS ANOTHER PALISE IN WHICH THE FIRE CRACKLED AND THE RIVER RUSHED HEN. THEN TED SAID, AND WHERE DEE YELL TWEE FIT IN? I, ER, HAD THE IMPRESSIHN THE GHEKLINS WERE FOR YELL-DONNEN-WHEN HEN THE WHEEL.

YELL HAD A FALSE IMPRESSIHN, SAID THE HIGHER-VEICED OF THE GHEKLINS.

WE TAKE NEH SIDES. THIS IS A WIZARDS WAR.

HEH CHME YELL RE IN HIDING, THEN?

I DEEMED IT PRUDENT, SAID THE DEEPER-VEICED GHEKLIN. HAVING REFUSED WHAT I CONSIDERED AN IMPERTINENT REQUEST, I COULD SEE THAT MY PERSONAL SAFETY WAS IN JEOPARDY.

WHAT DID THEY ASK YELL THE DEN? ASKED TED.

DUTIES UN-FITTING THE DIGNITY OF MY RACE, REPLIED THE GHEKLIN, HIS VOICE REHLGHER AND LESS FILMAN AS HE SAID IT. I AM NOT A FHELSE-ER.

WHAT ABOUT YOU, CRIPPLEHEAD?

SIMILAR REASONS, SAID THE HIGHLY-VEILED GIBLIN. CRINGETTS IS NO LONGER UNDER THE FIRM CONTROL OF MY RACE. I RECOGNIZE NO WIZARDING

MASTER.

HE ADDED SOMETHING UNDER HIS BREATH IN GIBBLING, AND GIBBLER LAUGHED.

WHAT IS THE ISSUE? ASKED DEAN.

HE SAID, REPLIED GIBBLER, THAT THERE ARE THINGS WIZARDS DON'T RECOGNIZE, EITHER.

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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THERE WAS A SHORT PAUSE.

I DON'T GET IT, SAID DEAN.

I HAD MY SMALL REVENGE BEFORE I LEFT, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD IN ENGLISH.

GOOD MAN GIBLIN, I SHOULD SAY, AMENDED TED HASTILY.

DIDN'T MANAGE TO LOCK A DEATH LATER UP IN ONE OF THE OLD HIGH-SECURITY VAULTS, I SUPPOSE?

IF I HAD, THE SWORD WOULD NOT HAVE HELPED HIM BREAK OUT, REPLIED CRIPPLEHEAD. GIBBLER LAUGHED AGAIN AND EVEN GIBBLER GAVE A DRY

CHUCKLE.

DEAN AND I ARE STILL MISSING SOMETHING HERE, SAID TED.

HE IS SEVERUS Snape, THOUGH HE DOES NOT KNOW IT, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD.

AND THE TWO GHEKINS BEAMED WITH MALICIOUS LAUGHTER. INSIDE THE TENT

HARRY'S BREATHING WAS SHALLOWS WITH EXCITEMENT. HE AND HERMIONNE STARED AT EACH OTHER, LISTENING AS HARD AS THEY COULD.

DIDN'T YOU HEAR ABOUT THAT, TED? ASKED DICK. ABOUT THE KIDS WHO TRIED TO STEAL CRIPPLEHEAD'S SWORD OUT OF Snape's OFFICE AT HOGWARTS?

AN ELECTRIC CURRENT SEEMED TO COURSE THROUGH HARRY, JANGLING HIS

EVERY NERVE AS HE STOOD RIGHTED TO THE SPOT.

NEVER HEARD A WORD, SAID TED. NOT IN THE PROPHECY, WAS IT?

HARDLY, CHORTLED DICK. CRIPPLEHEAD HERE TOLD ME, HE HEARD ABOUT IT FROM BILL WEASLEY WHO WINKS FOR THE BAND. ONE OF THE KIDS WHO TRIED TO TAKE THE SWORD WAS BILL'S YOUNGER SISTER.

HARRY GLANCED TOWARD HERMIONNE AND RON, BOTH OF WHOM WERE CLUTCHING THE EXTENDABLE PARS AS TIGHTLY AS LIFELINES.

SHE AND A COUPLE OF FRIENDS GET INTO Snape's OFFICE AND SMASHED OPEN THE GLASS CASE WHERE HE WAS APPARENTLY KEEPING THE SWORD. Snape CALLED THEM AS THEY WERE TRYING TO SNEAK IT DOWN THE STAIRCASE.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

“Ah, God bless em, said Ted, what did they think, that they’d be able to use the sword and yell-Knew-Weh? For he snare himself?”

Well, whatever they thought they were going to do with it, snare

decided the sword wasn’t safe where it was, said Bird. Couple of days later, once he’d got the say-so from yell-Knew-Weh, I imagine,

he sent it down the Linneth he kept in Gringotts instead. The Goblins started the laugh again.

I’m still not seeing the humor, said Ted.

It’s a fake, rasped Griphook.

The sword of Gryffindor?

“Yes, it is a copy. An excellent copy, it is true. But it was Wizard-made. The original was forged centuries ago by Goblins and had certain properties only Goblin-made armor possesses. Wherever

the genuine sword of Gryffindor is, it is not in a vault at Gringotts

and,

I see, said Ted. And I take it you didn’t bother telling the Death Eaters this?

I saw no reason to trouble them with the information, said Griphook smugly, and now Ted and Dean grinned in Gherkin and Bird’s laughter.

Inside the tent, Harry closed his eyes, willing someone to ask the question he needed answered, and after a minute that seemed

TEN, DEAN BELIEVED; HE WAS HARRY REMEMBERED WITH A HEAT! AN EX-
FRIEND OF GINNY'S THEN.

WHAT HAPPENED TO GINNY AND THE OTHERS? THE HENS WERE TRIED TO
STEAL IT?

OH, THEY WERE PUNISHED, AND CRUELLY, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD INDIF-
FERENTLY.

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

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THEY'RE DEAD, THOUGH? ASKED TED BELICIOUSLY. I MEAN, THE WEASLEYS
DON'T NEED ANY MORE OF THEIR KIDS INJURED, DO THEY?

THEY SUFFERED NO SERIOUS INJURY, AS FAR AS I AM AWARE, SAID
CRIPPLEHEAD.

LUCKY FOR THEM, SAID TED. WITH SNAPE'S TRACK RECORD I SUPPOSE
WE SHOULD JUST BE GLAD THEY'RE STILL ALIVE.

YOU BELIEVE THAT STORY, THEN, DO YOU, TED? ASKED DICK. YOU
BELIEVE SNAPE KILLED DUMBLEDORE?

COURSE I DO, SAID TED. YOU'RE NOT GOING TO SIT THERE AND TELL
ME YOU THINK PETER HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH IT?

HARD TO KNOW WHAT YOU BELIEVE THESE DAYS, MUTTERED DICK.

I KNOW HARRY PETER, SAID DEAN. AND I RECKON HE'S THE REAL
THING THE CHIEFS HIRE, OR WHATEVER YOU WANT TO CALL IT.

Yeah, there's a left wheel like the right, he said, then, said Bird, me included, but where is he? Run for it, by the looks of things, well I think, if he knew anything we didn't, he had something special

Going for him, he'd be left there with fighting, rallying resistance, instead of hiding, and well know, the prophet made a pretty good case against him

The prophet? skipped Ted, well deserve the lie if well be still

Reading that book, Bird, well want the facts, try the healer, there was a sudden explosion of cheering and retching, plus a good deal of thumping; by the sound of it, Bird had swallowed a fish bone, at last he spluttered, the healer? that lunatic rag

Ken Leverage?

It's not the lunatic these days, said Ted, well want to give it a look, Ken is printing all the stuff the prophet is ignoring, not

a single mention of Crumple-Horned Snurfaloes in the last issue, well hope they'll let him get away with it, mind, I don't know, but

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Ken

Ken says, front page of every issue, that any wizard who's against

WELL-KNEW-WHEN HEUGHT THE MADE HELPING HARRY BETTER THEIR
MILKER-

HEN PRIORITY.

HARD THE HELP A KEY WHEN S VANISHED OFF THE FACE OF THE EARTH,
SAID DICK.

LISTEN, THE FACT THAT THEY HAVEN T CALIGHT HIM YET S HEN FELL OF
AN ACHIEVEMENT, SAID TED. I D TAKE TIPS FROM HIM GLADLY; IT S WHAT
WE RE TRYING THE DEE, STAY FREE, ISN T IT?

YEAS, WELL, WELL YE GET A POINT THERE, SAID DICK HEAVILY. WITH
THE WHOLE OF THE MINISTRY AND ALL THEIR INFORMERS LOOKING FOR
HIM

I D HAVE EXPECTED HIM THE BE CALIGHT BY NEEL, MIND, WHEN S THE SAY THEY
HAVEN T ALREADY CALIGHT AND KILLED HIM WITHHELT PUBLICIZING IT?

AH, DENN T SAY THAT, DICK, MURMURED TED.

THERE WAS A LONG PAUSE FILLED WITH MORE CLATTERING OF KNIVES AND
FORKS. WHEN THEY SPOKE AGAIN IT WAS TO DISCUSS WHETHER THEY
HEUGHT

THE SLEEP ON THE BANK HER RETREAT BACK UP THE WOODED SLOPE. DECIDING
THE TREES WOULD GIVE BETTER COVER, THEY EXTINGUISHED THEIR FIRE,
THEN

CLAMBERED BACK UP THE INCLINE, THEIR VEHICLES FADING AWAY.

HARRY, RICH, AND HERMINE REELLED IN THE EXTENDABLE CARS. HARRY,
WHEN HAD FEELING THE NEED TO REMAIN SILENT INCREASINGLY DIFFICULT THE
LONGER THEY RAVESDROPPED, NEEL FEELING HIMSELF UNABLE TO SAY MORE
THAN, GINNY THE SWORD

I KNOW! SAID HERMINE.

SHE LUNGED FOR THE TINY LEADED BAG, THIS TIME SINKING HER ARM IN

IT RIGHT UP THE THE AMPIT.

HERE . . . WE . . . ARE . . . SHE SAID BETWEEN GRITTED TEETH, AND SHE
PULLED AT SOMETHING THAT WAS EVIDENTLY IN THE DEPTHS OF THE BAG.

SURELY THE EDGE OF AN EMBROIDERED PICTURE FRAME CAME INTO SIGHT.
HARRY

HURRIED THE HELP HER. AS THEY LIFTED THE EMPTY PORTRAIT OF PHINEAS

THE GERLIN'S REVENGE

RM1

NIGELLIS FREE OF HERMINE'S BAG, SHE KEPT HER HAND POINTING AT IT,
READY THE LAST A SPELL AT ANY MOMENT.

IF SOMEHOW SWAPPED THE REAL SWORD FOR THE FAKE WHILE IT WAS
IN OLIVEROS'S OFFICE, SHE PANTED, AS THEY PREPARED THE PAINTING
AGAINST THE SIDE OF THE TENT, PHINEAS NIGELLIS WOULD HAVE SEEN IT
HAPPEN, HE HANGS RIGHT BESIDE THE CASE?

UNLESS HE WAS ASLEEP, SAID HARRY, BUT HE STILL HELD HIS BREATH
AS HERMINE BENT DOWN IN FRONT OF THE EMPTY CANVAS, HER HAND
DIRECTED AT ITS CENTER, CLEARED HER THROAT, THEN SAID:

OR PHINEAS? PHINEAS NIGELLIS?

NOTHING HAPPENED.

PHINEAS NIGELLIS? SAID HERMINE AGAIN. PROFESSOR BLACK?
PLEASE

WOULD WE TALK THE YELLY PLEASE?

PLEASE ALWAYS HELPS, SAID A CHILD, SNIDE VOICE, AND PHINEAS NI-

GELLIS SLID INTO HIS PORTRAIT. AT ONCE, HERMIONE CRIED:

HEALURE!

A BLACK BLINDFOLD APPEARED OVER PHINEAS NIGELLUS'S CLEVER, DARK EYES, CALISING HIM THE CLIMP INTO THE FRAME AND SHRIED WITH PAIN.

WHAT FEEL DARK WHAT ARE YOU ?

I'M VERY SORRY, PROFESSOR BLACK, SAID HERMIONE, BUT IT'S A NECESSARY PRECAUTION!

REMOVE THIS FEEL ADDITION AT ONCE! REMOVE IT, I SAY! YOU ARE RUINING A GREAT WORK OF ART! WHERE AM I? WHAT IS GOING ON?

NEVER MIND WHERE WE ARE, SAID HARRY, AND PHINEAS NIGELLUS FREEZE, ABANDONING HIS ATTEMPTS TO PEEL OFF THE PAINTED BLINDFOLD. CAN THAT POSSIBLY BE THE VEHICLE OF THE ELUSIVE MR. POTTTER?

MAKER, SAID HARRY, KNOWING THAT THIS WOULD KEEP PHINEAS NIGELLUS'S INTEREST. WE'VE GOT A COUPLE OF HILISTIONS TO ASK YOU ABOUT

THE SWORD OF GRAYFINDER.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

END

AH, SAID PHINEAS NIGELLUS, NOW TURNING HIS HEAD THIS WAY AND THAT IN AN EFFORT TO CATCH SIGHT OF HARRY, YES, THAT SILLY GIRL ACTED

MOST UNWISELY THERE

SHE'LL LIVE TO REGRET MY SISTER, SAID BEN REVERENDLY. PHINEAS NIGELLUS RAISED SUPERCILIOUS EYEBROWS.

WHERE ELSE IS HERE? HE ASKED, TURNING HIS HEAD FROM SIDE TO SIDE. WHERE THEN DISPLEASES ME? THE GIRL AND HER FRIENDS WERE APPALLED IN THE EXTREME, THIEVING FROM THE HEADMASTER?

THEY WEREN'T THIEVING, SAID HARRY. THAT SNEAK ISN'T SNAPE'S. IT BELONGS TO PROFESSOR SNAPE'S SECRET, SAID PHINEAS NIGELLUS. EXACTLY WHAT CLAIM DID THE WEASLEY GIRL HAVE UPON IT? SHE DESERVED

HER PUNISHMENT, AS DID THE IDIOT LONGBOTTOM AND THE LITWITCH HEDDITY?

NEVILLE IS NOT AN IDIOT AND LUNA IS NOT AN HEDDITY? SAID HERMION.

WHERE AM I? REPEATED PHINEAS NIGELLUS, STARTING THE WRESTLE WITH

THE BLINDFOLD AGAIN. WHERE HAVE YOU BRUGHT ME? WHY HAVE YOU REMOVED ME FROM THE FEELING OF MY PRESENCE?

NEVER MIND THAT? HOW DID SNAPE PUNISH GINNY, NEVILLE, AND LUNA? ASKED HARRY URGENTLY.

PROFESSOR SNAPE SENT THEM INTO THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, THE DEEP SHIRAZ WHERE FOR THE HAF, HAGRID.

HAGRID'S NOT AN HAF? SAID HERMION SHRILLY.

AND SNAPE MIGHT BE THOUGHT THAT WAS A PUNISHMENT, SAID HARRY, BUT GINNY, NEVILLE, AND LUNA PROBABLY HAD A GOOD LAUGH

WITH F-JAGRID, THE FERRIDDEN FERRIST . . . THEY VE FACED PLENTY WHERSE
THAN THE FERRIDDEN FERRIST, BIG DEAL!

HE FELT RELIEVED; HE HAD BEEN IMAGINING FERRERS, THE COLICATLS
CURSE AT THE VERY LEAST.

THE GERRIN S REVENGE

RRR

WHAT WE REALLY WANTED THE DNNEL, PROFESSOR BLACK, IS WHETHER
ANYONE ELSE HAS, LM, TAKEN HLIT THE SWEED AT ALL? MAYBE IT S BEEN
TAKEN AWAY FOR CLEANING HER HER SOMETHING?

PHINEAS NIGELLIS PALSED AGAIN IN HIS STRUGGLES THE FREE HIS EYES
AND SNIGGERED.

MUGGLE-BURNS, HE SAID, GERRIN-MADE ARMOR DOES NOT REQUIRE
CLEANING, SIMPLE GIRL, GERRINS SILVER REPELS MUNDANE DIRT, IMKING
ONLY THAT WHICH STRENGTHENS IT.

DEN T CALL HERMINEE SIMPLE, SAID HARRY.

I GRRR WEARY OF CONTRADICTION, SAID PHINEAS NIGELLIS, PERHAPS
IT IS TIME FOR ME TO RETURN TO THE HEADMASTER S OFFICE?

STILL BLINDHELD, HE BEGAN CREEPING THE SIDE OF HIS FRAME, TRYING
TO FEEL HIS WAY HLIT OF HIS PICTURE AND BACK INTO THE HOLE AT
F-JEGLARTS.

HARRY HAD A SUDDEN INSPIRATION.

DUMBLEDORE? CAN T YOU BRING US DUMBLEDORE?

I SEE YOUR PARDON? ASKED PHINEAS NIGELLIS.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE S PORTRAIT HELDON T YOU BRING HIM

ALONG, HERE, INTO THE VELURS?

PHINEAS NIGELLUS TURNED HIS FACE IN THE DIRECTION OF HARRY'S
VEHICLE.

EVIDENTLY IT IS NOT ONLY MUGGLE-THINGS WHICH ARE IGNORANT, BETTER,
THE PORTRAITS OF FREDWARTS MAY COMMUNE WITH EACH OTHER, BUT
THEY

CANNOT TRAVEL OUTSIDE THE CASTLE EXCEPT THE VISIT A PAINTING OF
THEM-

SELVES HANGING ELSEWHERE, DUMBLEDORE CANNOT COME HERE WITH ME,

AND AFTER THE TREATMENT I HAVE RECEIVED AT THEIR HANDS, I CAN
ASSURE

THEY THAT I SHALL NOT BE MAKING A RETURN VISIT!

SLIGHTLY CRESTFALLEN, HARRY WATCHED PHINEAS REDOUBLE HIS ATTEMPTS
TO LEAVE HIS FRAME.

PROFESSOR BLACK, SAID FERMINE, CHILDEN T THEY JUST TELL US,
PLEASE,

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

RM

WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME THE SWORD WAS TAKEN OUT OF ITS CASE? BEFORE
GINNY TOOK IT OUT, I MEAN?

PHINEAS SNEEZED IMPATIENTLY.

I BELIEVE THAT THE LAST TIME I SAW THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER LEAVE
ITS CASE WAS WHEN PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE USED IT THE BREAK WHEN A

RING.

HERMIONE WHIPPED AROUND THE CORNER AT HARRY, NEITHER OF THEM

DARED SAY MORE IN FRONT OF PHINEAS NIGELLUS, WHO HAD AT LAST MANAGED THE DECADE THE EXIT.

WELL, GOOD NIGHT THE TWO, HE SAID A LITTLE WASPISHLY, AND HE BEGAN THE MOVE AWAY FROM SIGHT AGAIN. ONLY THE EDGE OF HIS HAT BRIM REMAINED

IN VIEW WHEN HARRY GAVE A SUDDEN START.

WAIT! HAVE YOU TWO SNAPE YOU SAW THIS?

PHINEAS NIGELLUS STUCK HIS BLINDFOLDED HEAD BACK INTO THE PICTURE.

PROFESSOR SNAPE HAS MORE IMPORTANT THINGS ON HIS MIND THAN THE

MANY ECCENTRICITIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. GOOD-BYE, PETER!

AND WITH THAT, HE VANISHED COMPLETELY, LEAVING BEHIND HIM NOTHING BUT HIS MURKY BACKDROP.

HARRY? HERMIONE CRIED.

I KNOW! HARRY STARTLED. UNABLE TO CONTAIN HIMSELF, HE PUNCHED THE AIR; IT WAS MORE THAN HE HAD DARED THE BEFORE HER. HE STOOD UP AND

BEHIND THE TENT, FEELING THAT HE COULD HAVE RUN A MILE; HE DID NOT EVEN

FEEL HUNGRY ANYMORE. HERMIONE WAS SEELASHING PHINEAS NIGELLUS S

PORTRAIT BACK INTO THE LEADED BAG; WHEN SHE HAD FASTENED THE CLASP
SHE THREW THE BAG ASIDE AND RAISED A SHINING FACE TO HARRY,

THE SWORD CAN DESTROY HERCULES; GIBLIN-MADE BLADES IMBUE

ONLY THAT WHICH STRENGTHEN THEM HARRY, THAT SWORD IS IMPREG-
NATED WITH BASILISK VENOM;

THE GIBLIN'S REVENGE

YES

AND DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T GIVE IT TO ME BECAUSE HE STILL NEEDED IT,
HE WANTED THE LISK IT HAD THE LOCKET

AND HE MUST HAVE REALIZED THEY WOULDN'T LET THEM HAVE IT IF HE
PUT IT IN HIS WILL

SEE HE MADE A COPY

AND PUT A FAKE IN THE GLASS CASE

AND HE LEFT THE REAL ONE WHERE?

THEY GAZED AT EACH OTHER; HARRY FELT THAT THE ANSWER WAS
DANGLING

INVISIBLY IN THE AIR ABOVE THEM, TARTALIZINGLY CLOSE, WHY HADN'T
DUM-

DUMBLEDORE TOLD HIM? HE HAD HE, IN FACT, TOLD HARRY, BUT HARRY HAD NEET

REALIZED IT AT THE TIME?

THINK? WHISPERED FERMINE. THINK? WHERE WOULD HE HAVE

LEFT IT?

NHET AT HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY, RESUMING HIS PACING.

SOMEWHERE IN HOGSMEADE? SUGGESTED HERMIONE.

THE SHRIKING SHACK? SAID HARRY, NODDING EVER CLOSE IN THERE.

BUT SNAPE KNOWS HOW THEY GET IN, WOULDNT THAT BE A BIT RISKY?

DUMBLEDORE TRUSTED SNAPE, HARRY REMINDED HER.

NHET ENOUGH TO TELL HIM THAT HE HAD SWAPPED THE SWORDS, SAID HERMIONE.

YEAH, WELL BE RIGHT? SAID HARRY, AND HE FELT EVEN MORE CHERRED AT THE THOUGHT THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD HAD SOME RESERVATIONS, HOWEVER FAINT, ABOUT SNAPE'S TRUSTWORTHINESS. SEE, WOULD HE HAVE HIDDEN THE SWORD WELL AWAY FROM HOGSMEADE, THEN? WHAT D YOU RECKON, RON? RON?

HARRY LOOKED AROUND, FOR ONE RESEMBLED MOMENT THE THOUGHT THAT RON HAD LEFT THE TENT, THEN REALIZED THAT RON WAS LYING IN THE

SHADOW OF A WHEELER BLIND, LOOKING STONY.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

RON

HE REMEMBERED ME, HAVE YOU? HE SAID.

WHAT?

RON SMILED AS HE STARED UP AT THE UNDERSIDE OF THE UPPER BLIND.

WELL THEN CARRY ON, DONT LET ME SPILL YOUR PLAN.

PERPLEXED, F-JARRY LEANED THE F-JERMINNE OVER HELP, BUT SHE STOOD
HER HEAD, APPARENTLY AS DIMPLED AS HE WAS.

WHAT IS THE PROBLEM? ASKED F-JARRY.

PROBLEM? THERE IS NO PROBLEM, SAID REIN, STILL REPEATING THE WORD
AT

F-JARRY, NOT ACCORDING TO YOU, ANYWAY.

THERE WERE SEVERAL PLINDS ON THE CANVAS OVER THEIR HEADS. IT HAD
STARTED THE RAIN.

WELL, YOU'VE HEAVILY GOT A PROBLEM, SAID F-JARRY, SPIT IT OUT,
WILL YOU?

REIN SWUNG HIS LONG LEGS OFF THE BED AND SAT UP. F-JARRY MEAN,
UNLIKE HIMSELF.

ALL RIGHT, I'LL SPIT IT OUT. DON'T EXPECT ME TO SKIP UP AND DOWN
THE TENT BECAUSE THERE IS SOME OTHER DAMN THING WE'VE GOT THE FIND.
I'LL ADD IT TO THE LIST OF STUFF YOU DON'T KNOW.

I DON'T KNOW? REPEATED F-JARRY, I DON'T KNOW?

PLIND, PLIND, PLIND. THE RAIN WAS FALLING HARDER AND HEAVIER;
IT PATTERNED ON THE LEAF-STREWN BANK ALL AROUND THEM AND INTO THE
RIVER CHATTERING THROUGH THE DARK. DREAD BEHIND F-JARRY'S
ILLUSTRATION:

REIN WAS SAYING EXACTLY WHAT HE HAD SUSPECTED AND FEARED HIM THE
BE THINKING.

IT IS NOT LIKE I'M NOT HAVING THE TIME OF MY LIFE HERE, SAID REIN,
YOU KNOW, WITH MY ARM MANGLED AND NOTHING TO EAT AND FREEZING
MY BACKSIDE EVERY NIGHT. I'LL HELP, YOU KNOW, AFTER WE'VE BEEN
RUNNING AROUND A FEW WEEKS, WE'D HAVE ACHIEVED SOMETHING.

THE GIBLIN S REVENGE

END

REN, HERMINE SAID, BUT IN SUCH A QUIET VOICE THAT REN COULD PRETEND NOT TO HAVE HEARD IT OVER THE LOUD TATTERS THE RAIN WAS MAKING

EATING IN THE TENT.

I THINK YOU KNOW WHAT YOU'D SIGNED UP FOR, SAID HARRY,

YEAH, I THINK I DID THAT.

SEE WHAT PART OF IT ISN'T LIVING UP TO YOUR EXPECTATIONS? ASKED HARRY, ANGER WAS CRYING THROUGH HIS DEFENSE NOW. DID YOU THINK WE'D BE STAYING IN FIVE-STAR HOTELS? FINDING A FIERCELY EVERY OTHER DAY?

DID YOU THINK YOU'D BE BACK THE MOUNTAIN BY CHRISTMAS?

WE THINK YOU KNOW WHAT YOU WERE DOING! SMILED REN, STANDING UP, AND HIS WORDS PIERCED HARRY LIKE SCALDING KNIVES. WE

THINK DUMBLEDORE HAD TOLD YOU WHAT TO DO, WE THINK YOU HAD A REAL PLAN?

REN? SAID HERMINE, THIS TIME CLEARLY AUDIBLE OVER THE RAIN THUNDERING IN THE TENT NOW, BUT AGAIN, HE IGNORED HER.

WELL, SHUT THE LET YOU DOWN, SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE WHITE CALM EVEN THOUGH HE FELT FURIOUS, INADEQUATE. I'VE BEEN STRAIGHT WITH YOU

FROM THE START, I TOLD YOU EVERYTHING DUMBLEDORE TOLD ME, AND IN CASE YOU HAVEN'T NOTICED, WE'RE FEELING MORE FIERCELY

Yeah, and we're almost as near getting rid of it as we are the finding.

The rest of them were here, sitting near, in either words?

Take off the jacket, then, Hermione said, her voice unusually high. Please take it off, you wouldn't be talking like this if you hadn't been wearing it all day.

Yeah, he would, said Harry, who did not want excuses made for Ron. I don't think I haven't noticed the two of you whispering

behind my back? I don't think I didn't guess you were thinking this stuff?

Harry, we weren't

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

XXX

Don't lie! Ron glared at her. You said it then, you said you were

disappointed, you said you'd thought he had a kit more than he had

I didn't say it like that Harry, I didn't! she cried.

The rain was pounding the tent, tears were pouring down Hermione's face, and the excitement of a few minutes before had vanished

as if it had never been, a short-lived firework that had flared and

DIED, LEAVING EVERYTHING DARK, WET, AND CHILL. THE SWORD OF GRYPHIN-
DEER WAS HIDDEN THEY DON'T KNOW WHERE, AND THEY WERE THREE
TEENAGERS

IN A TENT WHERE ONLY ACHIEVEMENT WAS NOT, YET, THEY'RE DEAD.

THEY ARE STILL HERE? HARRY ASKED RON.

SEARCH ME, SAID RON.

GO HOME THEN, SAID HARRY.

PLEASE, MAYBE I WILL! SMILED RON, AND HE TOOK SEVERAL STEPS
TOWARD HARRY, WHO DID NOT BACK AWAY. DIDN'T YOU HEAR WHAT THEY
SAID ABOUT MY SISTER? BUT YOU DON'T GIVE A RAT'S PART, DO YOU, IT'S
ONLY

THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, HARRY I RE-PAID-WHAT BETTER DOESN'T CARE
WHAT HAPPENS THERE IN HERE WELL, I DO, ALL RIGHT, GIANT SPIDERS
AND MENTAL STUFF

I WAS ONLY SAYING SHE WAS WITH THE OTHERS, THEY WERE WITH
HARRY

PLEASE, I GET IT, YOU DON'T CARE! AND WHAT ABOUT THE REST OF MY
FAMILY, THE WEASLEYS DON'T NEED ANOTHER KID INJURED, DID YOU HEAR
THAT?

PLEASE, I

DON'T REMEMBER WHAT IT MEANT, THOUGH?

RON: SAID HERMION, PUNCHING HER WAY BETWEEN THEM. I DON'T
THINK IT MEANS ANYTHING NEW HAS HAPPENED, ANYTHING WE DON'T
KNOW ABOUT; THINK, RON, KILL'S ALREADY STARTED, PLenty OF PEOPLE

THE GRIPIN'S REVER

KNOW

MUST HAVE SEEN THAT GEORGE HAS LOST AN EAR BY NOW, AND YOU'RE
SLIP-

PERIOD THE RE HIS YOUR DEATH-REED WITH SPATTER-REED, I'M SURE THAT'S ALL

HE MEANT

HEY, YOU'RE SURE, ARE YOU? RIGHT THEN, WELL, I WON'T EITHER MY-
SELF ABOUT THEM. IT'S ALL RIGHT FOR YOU TWO, ISN'T IT, WITH YOUR
PARENTS

SURELY HEAT OF THE WAY

MY PARENTS ARE DEAD? HARRY BELIEVED.

AND MINE CHILD IS GOING THE SAME WAY? YELLED REIN.

THEN GEE? REARED HARRY. GO BACK TO THEM, PRETEND YOU'VE
GOT EVERY YOUR SPATTER-REED AND MUMMY'LL BE ABLE TO FEED YOU LIP
AND

REIN MADE A SUDDEN MOVEMENT! HARRY REACTED, BUT BEFORE RI-

TER HAND WAS CLEAR OF ITS OWNER'S POCKET, HERMIONE HAD RAISED
HER

WAND.

PROTECTOR! SHE CRIED, AND AN INVISIBLE SHIELD EXPANDED BETWEEN
HER AND HARRY ON THE ONE SIDE AND REIN ON THE OTHER; ALL OF THEM
WERE FORCED BACKWARD A FEW STEPS BY THE STRENGTH OF THE SPELL, AND

HARRY AND RON CLARED FROM EITHER SIDE OF THE TRANSPARENT BARRIER AS

THOUGH THEY WERE SEEING EACH OTHER CLEARLY FOR THE FIRST TIME.
HARRY

FELT A CHILLSOME HATRED TOWARD RON: SOMETHING HAD BREKEN
BETWEEN
THEM.

LEAVE THE HERCULES, HARRY SAID,

RON WRENCHED THE CHAIN FROM OVER HIS HEAD AND CAST THE LOCKET
INTO A NEARBY CHAIR. HE TURNED THE HERMION.

WHAT ARE YOU DOING?

WHAT DO YOU MEAN?

ARE YOU STAYING, OR WHAT?

I ... SHE BREKED ANGLISHED. YES YES, I M STAYING. RON, WE
SAID WE D GO WITH HARRY, WE SAID WE D HELP

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

RON

I GET IT. YOU CHASE HIM.

RON, NO PLEASE COME BACK, COME BACK!

SHE WAS IMPEDED BY HER HORN SHIELD CHARM; BY THE TIME SHE
HAD REMOVED IT HE HAD ALREADY STEPMED INTO THE NIGHT. HARRY STEED
ELITE STILL AND SILENT, LISTENING TO HER SHREKING AND CALLING RON S
NAME

AMONGST THE TREES.

AFTER A FEW MINUTES SHE RETURNED, HER SHIPPING HAIR PLASTERED TO
HER FACE.

HIS G-G-GHNE? DISAPPEARED?

SHE THREW HERSELF INTO A CHAIR, CLUNKED UP, AND STARTED THE CRY.
HARRY FELT DAZED, HE STEEPED, PICKED UP THE FERRULUS, AND PLACED
IT AROUND HIS ELBOW NECK. HE DRAGGED BLANKETS OFF REEN'S BLIND AND
THREW THEM OVER HERMINE. THEN HE CLIMBED INTO HIS ELBOW BED
AND STARED UP AT THE DARK CANVAS REEF, LISTENING TO THE POUNDING
OF
THE RAIN.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

R11

GEORGE'S FELLLOW

WHEN HARRY WOKED THE FOLLOWING DAY IT WAS SEVERAL SEC-
UNDS BEFORE HE REMEMBERED WHAT HAD HAPPENED. THEN

HE HOPED, CHILDISHLY, THAT IT HAD BEEN A DREAM, THAT REEN WAS STILL
THERE AND HAD NEVER LEFT. YET BY TURNING HIS HEAD ON HIS PILLOW HE
COULD SEE REEN'S DESERTED BLIND. IT WAS LIKE A DEAD BODY IN THE WAY
IT SEEMED TO DRAW HIS EYES. HARRY JUMPED DOWN FROM HIS ELBOW BED,
KEEPING HIS EYES AVERTED FROM REEN'S, HERMINE, WHO WAS ALREADY
BUSY IN THE KITCHEN, DID NOT WISH HARRY GOOD MORNING, BUT TURNED
HER FACE AWAY QUICKLY AS HE WENT BY.

HIS GHNE, HARRY TOLD HIMSELF, HIS GHNE, HE HAD THE DEEP THINK-

ING IT AS HE WASHED AND DRESSED, AS THOUGH REPETITION WOULD BULL

THE SENSE OF IT, HE S CAME AND HE S NOT COMING BACK, AND THAT WAS THE

SIMPLE TRUTH OF IT, HARRY KNEW, BECAUSE THEIR PROTECTIVE ENCHANT-
MENTS MEANT THAT IT WOULD BE IMPOSSIBLE, SINCE THEY VACATED THIS

SPOT, FOR THEM TO FIND THEM AGAIN.

HE AND HERMIONE ATE BREAKFAST IN SILENCE, HERMIONE S EYES WERE
W

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

R12

PLUFFY AND RED, SHE LOOKED AS IF SHE HAD NOT SLEPT. THEY PACKED UP
THEIR THINGS, HERMIONE DAWDLING, HARRY KNEW WHY SHE WANTED THE
SPIN AWAY THEIR TIME IN THE RIVERLANDS, SEVERAL TIMES HE SAW HER
LOOK

UP EAGERLY, AND HE WAS SURE SHE HAD DELLED HERSELF INTO THINKING
THAT SHE HEARD FOOTSTEPS THROUGH THE HEAVY RAIN, BUT NOT RED-
HAIR

FIGURE APPEARED BETWEEN THE TREES, EVERY TIME HARRY IMITATED HER,
LOOKED AWAY AND FOR HE COULD NOT HELP FEELING A LITTLE, HIMSELF AND
SAW NOTHING BUT RAIN-SOFT WHEELS, ANOTHER LITTLE PARCEL OF FLUFF
EXPLODED INSIDE HIM, HE COULD HEAR THEM SAYING, WE THOUGHT YOU
KNEW WHAT YOU WERE DOING, AND HE RESUMED PACKING WITH A HARD

DOWN IN THE PIT OF HIS STOMACH.

THE MUDGY RIVER BESIDE THEM WAS RISING RAPIDLY AND WOULD SOON
SPILL OVER BENTH THEIR BANK. THEY HAD LINGERED A GOOD WHILE AFTER
THEY

WOULD USUALLY HAVE DEPARTED THEIR CAMPSITE, FINALLY HAVING
ENTIRELY

REPACKED THE LEADED BAG THREE TIMES, FERMINE SEEMED UNABLE
TO FIND ANY MORE REASONS TO DELAY! SHE AND HARRY GRASPED HANDS
AND DISAPPEARED, REAPPEARING IN A WINDSWEEP HEATHER-COVERED
HILLSIDE.

THE INSTANT THEY ARRIVED, FERMINE DROPPED HARRY'S HAND AND
WALKED AWAY FROM HIM, FINALLY SITTING DOWN IN A LARGE ROCK, HER
FACE

IN HER KNEES, SHAKING WITH WHAT HER KNEES WERE SHES. HE WATCHED
HER, SLIPPINGING THAT HE MIGHT BE GOING TO THE CHURCH HER, BUT
SOMETHING

KEPT HIM REMEMBERED THE THE SPOT. EVERYTHING INSIDE HIM FELT COLD AND
TIGHT! AGAIN HE SAW THE CONTEMPTIBLE EXPRESSION IN REN'S FACE.
HARRY STOOD OFF THROUGH THE HEATHER, WALKING IN A LARGE CIRCLE
WITH

THE DISTRAUGHT FERMINE AT ITS CENTER, CASTING THE SPELLS SHE
USUALLY

PERFORMED TO ENSURE THEIR PROTECTION.

THEY DID NOT DISCUSS REN AT ALL EVER THE NEXT FEW DAYS. HARRY WAS
DETERMINED NEVER TO MENTION HIS NAME AGAIN, AND FERMINE SEEMED

GEORGE'S FELLOW

KLR

THE KNOW THAT IT WAS NOT LIKE PERKING THE ISSUE, ALTHOUGH SOMETIMES AT

NIGHT WHEN SHE THOUGHT HE WAS SLEEPING, HE WOULD HEAR HER CRYING.

MEANWHILE HARRY HAD STARTED BRINGING OUT THE MARAUDER'S MAP AND

EXAMINING IT BY WANDLIGHT. HE WAS WAITING FOR THE MOMENT WHEN RON'S LABELLED DUT WOULD REAPPEAR IN THE CORRIDORS OF HOGWARTS, PROVING THAT HE HAD RETURNED TO THE COMFORTABLE CASTLE, PROTECTED BY HIS STATUS OF PRINCE. HOWEVER, RON DID NOT APPEAR ON THE MAP, AND AFTER A WHILE HARRY FOUND HIMSELF TAKING IT OUT SIMPLY TO

STARE AT GINNY'S NAME IN THE GIRLS' DORMITORY, WONDERING WHETHER THE INTENSITY WITH WHICH HE GAZED AT IT MIGHT BLEND INTO HER SLEEP, THAT SHE WOULD SOMEHOW KNOW HE WAS THINKING ABOUT HER, HOPING

THAT SHE WAS ALL RIGHT.

BY DAY, THEY DEVOTED THEMSELVES TO TRYING TO DETERMINE THE POSSIBLE LOCATIONS OF GRYPFINDER'S SWORD, BUT THE MORE THEY TALKED ABOUT

THE PLACES IN WHICH DUMBLEDORE MIGHT HAVE HIDDEN IT, THE MORE DESPERATE AND FAR-FETCHED THEIR SPECULATION BECAME. CLUTCHING HIS BRAINS

THOUGH HE MIGHT, HARRY COULD NOT REMEMBER DUMBLEDORE EVER

MENTIONING A PLACE IN WHICH HE MIGHT HIDE SOMETHING. THERE WERE
MOMENTS WHEN HE DID NOT KNOW WHETHER HE WAS ANGRIER WITH REIN
HER WITH DUMKLEDHRE. WE THOUGHT THEY KNEW WHAT THEY WERE DOING. . .

WE THOUGHT DUMKLEDHRE HAD TOLD THEM WHAT THE DEE . . . WE THOUGHT
THEY

HAD A REAL PLAN

HE COULD NOT HIDE IT FROM HIMSELF; REIN HAD BEEN RIGHT. DUMKLE-
DRE HAD LEFT HIM WITH VIRTUALLY NOTHING. THEY HAD DISCOVERED HOW

HERCULES, BUT THEY HAD NO MEANS OF DESTROYING IT; THE OTHERS
WERE

AS UNATTAINABLE AS THEY HAD EVER BEEN. HELPLESSNESS THREATENED THE
ENGLISH HIM. HE WAS STAGGERED WHEN HE THOUGHT OF HIS OWN
PRESUMPTION

IN ACCEPTING HIS FRIENDS OFFERS TO ACCOMPANY HIM ON THIS
MEANDER-

ING, PAINLESS JOURNEY. HE KNEW NOTHING, HE HAD NO IDEAS, AND HE

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WAS CONSTANTLY, PAINFULLY ON THE ALERT FOR ANY INDICATION THAT
HE

WHEN SHE WAS ABOUT TO TELL HIM THAT SHE HAD FOUND OUT, THAT
SHE

WAS LEAVING,

THEY WERE SPENDING MANY EVENINGS IN NEAR SILENCE, AND HERMIONIE THREW THE BRINGING HOLT PHINEAS NIGELLUS'S PORTRAIT AND PROPPING

IT UP IN A CHAIR, AS THOUGH HE MIGHT FILL PART OF THE GAPING HOLE LEFT

BY RONN'S DEPARTURE, DESPITE HIS PREVIOUS ASSERTION THAT HE WOULD

NEVER VISIT THEM AGAIN, PHINEAS NIGELLUS DID NOT SEEM ABLE TO RESIST THE CHANCE TO FIND OUT MORE ABOUT WHAT HARRY WAS UP TO, AND

CONSENTED TO REAPPEAR, BLINDFOLDED, EVERY FEW DAYS FOR SEE. HARRY WAS EVEN GLAD TO SEE HIM, BECAUSE HE WAS COMPANY, ALTHOUGH A SNIDE AND TALANTING KIND. THEY RELISHED ANY NEWS ABOUT WHAT WAS HAPPENING AT

HEGLARTS, THOUGH PHINEAS NIGELLUS WAS NOT AN IDEAL INFORMER. HE

GENERATED SNAPE, THE FIRST SLYTHERIN HEADMASTER SINCE HE HIMSELF HAD

CONTROLLED THE SCHOOL, AND THEY HAD TO BE CAREFUL NOT TO CRITICIZE HIM

AND IMPERTINENT QUESTIONS ABOUT SNAPE, FOR PHINEAS NIGELLUS WOULD

INSTANTLY LEAVE HIS PAINTING.

HOWEVER, HE DID LET DROP CERTAIN SNIPPETS. SNAPE SEEMED TO BE

FACING A CONSTANT, LOW LEVEL OF MUTINY FROM A HARD CORE OF STUDENTS.

GINNY HAD BEEN BANNED FROM GOING INTO HOGSMEADE. SNAPE HAD REINSTATED LIMERIDGE'S OLD DEGREE FERRIDDING GATHERINGS OF THREE OR MORE STUDENTS OR ANY UNOFFICIAL STUDENT SOCIETIES.

FROM ALL OF THESE THINGS, HARRY DEDUCED THAT GINNY, AND PROBABLY NEVILLE AND LUNA ALONG WITH HER, HAD BEEN DOING THEIR BEST TO

CONTINUE DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY. THIS SCANT NEWS MADE HARRY WANT TO SEE GINNY SO BADLY IT FELT LIKE A STEPMOTHER; BUT IT ALSO MADE HIM THINK OF RON AGAIN, AND OF DUMBLEDORE, AND OF HOGWARTS ITSELF, WHICH HE MISSED NEARLY AS MUCH AS HIS EX-GIRLFRIEND. INDEED, AS PHINEAS NIGELLUS TALKED ABOUT SNAPE'S CRACKDOWN, HARRY EXPERIENCED

GEORGE'S FEELINGS

AND

EXPERIENCED A SPILT SECOND OF MADNESS WHEN HE IMAGINED SIMPLY GOING

BACK TO SCHOOL TO JOIN THE DESTABILIZATION OF SNAPE'S REGIME: BEING FED, AND HAVING A SHOT RED, AND OTHER PEOPLE BEING IN CHARGE,

SEEMED THE MOST WONDERFUL PROSPECT IN THE WORLD AT THAT MOMENT.

BUT THEN HE REMEMBERED THAT HE WAS UNDESIRABLE DUMBLEDORE

THAT THERE WAS A TEN-THOUSAND-GALLON PRICE ON HIS HEAD, AND
THAT

THE WALK INTO HOGWARTS THESE DAYS WAS JUST AS DANGEROUS AS
WALKING

INTO THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC. INDEED, PHINEAS NIGELLUS
INADVERTENTLY

EMPHASIZED THIS FACT BY SLIPPING IN LEADING ELIZABETHS ABELT HARRY
AND HERMIONE S WERREABLETS, HERMIONE SHOWED HIM BACK INSIDE

THE BEADED BAG EVERY TIME HE DID THIS, AND PHINEAS NIGELLUS INVARI-
ABLY REFUSED TO REAPPEAR FOR SEVERAL DAYS AFTER THESE
UNPLEASANT INCIDENTS

GOOD-BYES,

THE WEATHER GREW COLDER AND COLDER. THEY DID NOT DARE REMAIN IN

ANY ONE AREA TOO LONG, SHE RATHER THAN STAYING IN THE SHUTS OF
ONE-

LAND, WHERE A HARD COLD WIND WAS THE WORST OF THEIR WORRIES,
THEY

CONTINUED TO MEANDER UP AND DOWN THE COUNTRY, BRAVING A MILLIN-
TAINSIDE, WHERE SLEET FELL ON THE TENT; A WIDE, FLAT MARSH, WHERE
THE

TENT WAS FLEETED WITH CHILL WATER; AND A TINY ISLAND IN THE MIDDLE OF
A SCOTTISH LEECH, WHERE SNOW HAD BLINDED THE TENT IN THE NIGHT.

THEY HAD ALREADY SPOTTED CHRISTMAS TREES TWINKLING FROM SEVERAL
SITTING ROOM WINDOWS BEFORE THERE CAME AN EVENING WHEN HARRY

RESOLVED THE SLIGHTEST, AGAIN, WHAT SEEMED TO HIM THE ONLY
UNEXPLORED

AVENUE LEFT THEM. THEY HAD JUST EATEN AN UNUSUALLY GOOD MEAL;
HERMIONE HAD BEEN TO A SUPERMARKET UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK
(SCHEMATICALLY DROPPING THE MONEY INTO AN OPEN TILL AS SHE LEFT),
AND

HARRY THOUGHT THAT SHE MIGHT BE MORE PERSUADABLE THAN USUAL
IN A

STOMACH FULL OF SPAGHETTI Bolognese AND TINNED PEARS. HE HAD ALSO
HAD THE PRESIGHT THE SLIGHTEST THAT THEY TAKE A FEW HOURS' BREAK
FROM

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WEARING THE CHURCH, WHICH WAS HANGING OVER THE END OF THE
BLIND

RESIDE HIM.

HERMIONE?

HEY? SHE WAS CLIMBED UP IN ONE OF THE SAGGING ARMCHAIRS WITH
THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE BARD. HE COULD NOT IMAGINE HOW MUCH MORE
SHE COULD GET OUT OF THE BOOK, WHICH WAS NOT, AFTER ALL, VERY LONG;
BUT EVIDENTLY SHE WAS STILL DECRYPTING SOMETHING IN IT, BECAUSE
SPELLMAN'S SYLLABARY LAY OPEN ON THE ARM OF THE CHAIR.
HARRY CLEARED HIS THROAT. HE FELT EXACTLY AS HE HAD DONE IN THE

ELLASTERN, SEVERAL YEARS PREVIOUSLY, WHEN HE HAD ASKED PROFESSOR
MC-

CHENAGALL WHETHER HE COULD GO INTO THE HILLSIDE, DESPITE THE FACT
THAT

HE HAD NOT PERSUADED THE OLIVERYS TO SIGN HIS PERMISSION SLIP,

HERMINE, I'VE BEEN THINKING, AND

HARRY, COULD YOU HELP ME WITH SOMETHING?

APPARENTLY SHE HAD NOT BEEN LISTENING TO HIM. SHE LEANED

FORWARD AND HELD UP THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE LARD,

LOOK AT THAT SYMBOL, SHE SAID, POINTING TO THE TOP OF A PAGE.

BEFORE WHAT HARRY ASSUMED WAS THE TITLE OF THE STORY BEING
LINA

THE READ ALONGS, HE COULD NOT BE SURE, THERE WAS A PICTURE OF WHAT
LOOKED LIKE A TRIANGULAR EYE, ITS PUPIL CROSSED WITH A VERTICAL LINE.

I NEVER THOUGHT ANCIENT RINGS, HERMINE.

I KNOW THAT, BUT IT ISN'T A RING AND IT'S NOT IN THE SYLLABARY,
EITHER.

ALL ALONG I THOUGHT IT WAS A PICTURE OF AN EYE, BUT I DIDN'T THINK
IT

IS? IT'S BEEN INDEXED IN, LOOK, SOMEHOW'S DRAWN IT THERE, IT ISN'T
REALLY

PART OF THE BOOK. THINK, HAVE YOU EVER SEEN IT BEFORE?

NO... NO, WAIT A MOMENT, HARRY LOOKED CLOSER. ISN'T IT THE
SAME SYMBOL LINA'S DAD WAS WEARING BEHIND HIS NECK?

WELL, THAT'S WHAT I THOUGHT THEN

THEN IT'S GRINDWALD'S MARK.

GRINDWALD S MARK?

K19

SHE STARED AT HIM, HYPNOTIZED.

WHAT?

DRUM TOLD ME ...

HE RECALLED THE STORY THAT VICTOR DRUM HAD TOLD HIM AT THE WEDDING, HERMIONE LOOKED ASTONISHED.

GRINDWALD S MARK?

SHE LOOKED FROM HARRY TO THE WEIRD SYMBOL AND BACK AGAIN. I VE NEVER HEARD THAT GRINDWALD HAD A MARK. THERE S NO MENTION OF IT

IN ANYTHING I VE EVER READ ABOUT HIM.

WELL, LIKE I SAY, DRUM RECALLED THAT SYMBOL WAS CARVED IN A WALL AT DUMSTRANG, AND GRINDWALD PUT IT THERE.

SHE FELL BACK INTO THE OLD ARMCHAIR, SMILING.

THAT S VERY odd. IF IT S A SYMBOL OF DARK MAGIC, WHAT S IT DOING IN A BOOK OF CHILDREN S STORIES?

Yeah, IT IS WEIRD, SAID HARRY. AND YOU D THINK STRINGER WOULD HAVE RECOGNIZED IT. HE WAS MINISTER, HE SHOULD THE HAVE BEEN EXPERT IN DARK STUFF.

I KNOW, ... PERHAPS HE THOUGHT IT WAS AN EYE, JUST LIKE I DID. ALL THE OTHER STORIES HAVE LITTLE PICTURES OVER THE TITLES.

SHE DID NOT SPEAK, BUT CONTINUED TO STARE OVER THE STRANGE MARK.

HARRY TRIED AGAIN.

HERMIONE?

Hmm?

I'VE BEEN THINKING, I WANT THE GRIM THE CHORUS & HILLMAN.
SHE LOOKED UP AT HIM, BUT HER EYES WERE UNFOCUSSED, AND HE
WAS SURE SHE WAS STILL THINKING ABOUT THE MYSTERIOUS MARK ON
THE
BROW.

YES, SHE SAID, YES, I'VE BEEN WONDERING THAT TOO, I REALLY THINK
WE'LL HAVE THEM.

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R18

DID YOU HEAR ME RIGHT? HE ASKED.

OF COURSE I DID, YOU WANT THE GRIM THE CHORUS & HILLMAN, I AGREE, I
THINK WE SHOULD, I MEAN, I CAN'T THINK OF ANYWHERE ELSE IT COULD BE
EITHER, IT'LL BE DANGEROUS, BUT THE MORE I THINK ABOUT IT, THE MORE
LIKELY IT SEEMS IT'S THERE.

OR WHAT'S THERE? ASKED HARRY.

AT THAT, SHE LOOKED JUST AS REBUILT AS HE FELT.

WELL, THE SWORD, HARRY! DUMBLEDORE MUST HAVE KNOWN YOU'D
WANT THE GRIM BACK THERE, AND I MEAN, CHORUS & HILLMAN IS CHORUS
GRYFFINDOR'S BIRTHPLACE

REALLY? GRYFFINDOR CAME FROM CHORUS & HILLMAN?

HARRY, DID YOU EVER EVEN HEAR OF HISTORY OF MAGIC?

ERM, HE SAID, SMILING FOR WHAT FELT LIKE THE FIRST TIME IN MONTHS!
THE MUSCLES IN HIS FACE FELT HARDLY STIFF. I MIGHT'VE OPENED IT, YOU
KNOW, WHEN I RECALLED IT . . . JUST THE HENCE . . .

WELL, AS THE VILLAGE IS NAMED AFTER HIM I'D HAVE RECALLED YOU

MIGHT HAVE MADE THE CONNECTION, SAID FERMINE. SHE SEEMED MUCH MORE LIKE HER OLD SELF THAN SHE HAD BEEN BY LATE; HARRY HAD EXPECTED HER THE ANNOUNCEMENT THAT SHE WAS OFF THE THE LIBRARY.

THERE S A

RIT ABOUT THE VILLAGE IN A FISTERY OF MAGIC, WAIT ...

SHE OPENED THE BEADED BAG AND RUMMAGED FOR A WHILE, FINALLY

EXTRACTING HER COPY OF THEIR OLD SCHOOL TEXTBOOK, A FISTERY OF MAGIC

BY KATHILDA RAGSHEIT, WHICH SHE THUMBED THROUGH UNTIL FINDING THE PAGE SHE WANTED.

UPON THE SIGNATURE OF THE INTERNATIONAL STATUTE OF SECRECY IN 1887,

WIZARDS WENT INTO HIDING FOR GOOD. IT WAS NATURAL, PERHAPS, THAT THEY

FORMED THEIR OWN SMALL COMMUNITIES WITHIN A COMMUNITY. MANY SMALL

VILLAGES AND HAMLETS ATTRACTED SEVERAL MAGICAL FAMILIES, WHO Banded TOGETHER FOR MUTUAL SUPPORT AND PROTECTION. THE VILLAGES OF TINDWORTH

GEORGE S. HILLMAN

R19

IN CORNWALL, UPPER FLAGLEY IN YORKSHIRE, AND ETTERY ST. CATCHPOLE IN

THE SOUTHERN COAST OF ENGLAND WERE NOTABLE HOMES THE KNIGHTS OF WIZARDING

FAMILIES WHO LIVED ALONGSIDE TOLERANT AND SOMETIMES CHENGLINGED
MUG-

ELSE, MOST CELEBRATED OF THESE HALF-MAGICAL DWELLING PLACES IS,
PERHAPS,

CHORIC S FHELLH, THE WEST CHENLTRY VILLAGE WHERE THE GREAT WIZARD

CHORIC CROFFINDER WAS BORN, AND WHERE REWMAN WRIGHT, WIZARD-
ING SMITH, MERGED THE FIRST CHORDEN SMITH. THE GRAVEYARD IS FULL OF
THE

NAMES OF ANCIENT MAGICAL FAMILIES, AND THIS ACCHLINTS, NEE DELJET, FOR
THE STORIES OF FALNTINES THAT HAVE DEEGED THE LITTLE CHURCH BESIDE
IT FOR

MANY CENTLIRIES,

YELL AND YELLIR PARENTS AREN T MENTIONED, HERMINE SAID, CLESTING
THE REHED, BECAUSE PROFESSOR RAGSHTH DEEDEN T CHYER ANYTHING
LATER

THAN THE END OF THE NINETEENTH CENTLIRY, BUT YELL SEE? CHORIC S
FHEH-

WELL, CHORIC CROFFINDER, CROFFINDER S SLEHED, DEEN T YELL THINK DLYM-
BLEHRE WOULD HAVE EXPECTED YELL TO MAKE THE CHONNECTION?

HE PRAN...

HARRY DID NOT WANT TO ADMIT THAT HE HAD NOT BEEN THINKING

ABHUT THE SLEHED AT ALL WHEN HE SUGGESTED THEY GO TO CHORIC S FHEH-

WELL, FOR HIM, THE LURE OF THE VILLAGE LAY IN HIS PARENTS' GRAVES, THE

FEELING WHERE HE HAD NARROWLY ESCAPED DEATH, AND IN THE PERSON OF KATHILDA RAGSHEET.

REMEMBER WHAT MURIEL SAID? HE ASKED EVENTUALLY.

WELL?

WELL DENIED, HE HESITATED: HE DID NOT WANT TO SAY REEN'S NAME.

GINDY'S GREAT-GRANDFATHER, AT THE WEDDING, THE ONE WHO SAID WELL HAD SKINNY ANKLES.

HE, SAID HERMIONE, IT WAS A STICKY MOMENT: HARRY KNEW THAT SHE HAD SENSED REEN'S NAME IN THE HOPPING, HE BLISHED HIM;

SHE SAID KATHILDA RAGSHEET STILL LIVES IN CEDRIC'S FELLOWSHIP.

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END

KATHILDA RAGSHEET, MURMURED HERMIONE, BLINNING HER INDEX

FINGER OVER KATHILDA'S EMBOSSED NAME ON THE FRONT COVER OF A DIS-
TANT OF MAGIC. WELL, I SUPPOSE

SHE GASPED SHE DRAMATICALLY THAT HARRY'S INSIDES TURNED OVER; HE
DREW HIS HAND, WHIPPING AROUND AT THE ENTRANCE, HALF EXPECTING TO
SEE A HAND PIERCING ITS WAY THROUGH THE ENTRANCE FLAP, BUT THERE
WAS

NOTHING THERE.

WHAT? HE SAID, HALF ANGRY, HALF RELIEVED. WHAT DID SHE SEE
THAT HER? I THOUGHT SHE'D SEEN A DEATH EATER UNZIPPING THE TENT,
AT
LEAST

HARRY, WHAT IF RATHILDA'S GOT THE SWORD? WHAT IF DUMBLEDORE
ENTRUSTED IT TO HER?

HARRY CONSIDERED THIS POSSIBILITY. RATHILDA WOULD BE AN EXTREMELY
WILD WOMAN BY NOW, AND ACCORDING TO MURIEL, SHE WAS CRAZY. WAS
IT

LIKELY THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE HIDDEN THE SWORD OF GRAYFINDER
WITH HER? IF SHE, HARRY FELT THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD LEFT A GREAT DEAL THE
CHANCE! DUMBLEDORE HAD NEVER REVEALED THAT HE HAD REPLACED THE
SWORD WITH A FAKE, NOR HAD HE SHE MUCH AS MENTIONED A FRIENDSHIP
WITH RATHILDA. NOW, HOWEVER, WAS NOT THE MOMENT THE LAST DEBATE
BETWEEN HERMION'S THEORY, NOT WHEN SHE WAS SHE SURPRISINGLY WILLING
THE

FALL IN WITH HARRY'S DEAREST WISH.

YES, HE MIGHT HAVE DONE! SHE, ARE WE GOING TO GET THE CHURCH'S
FAMILY?

YES, BUT WE'LL HAVE TO THINK IT THROUGH CAREFULLY, HARRY. SHE

WAS SITTING UP NOW, AND HARRY COULD TELL THAT THE PROSPECT OF
HAV-

ING A PLAN AGAIN HAD LIFTED HER MOOD AS MUCH AS HIS. WE'LL NEED THE

PRACTICE DISAPPEARING TOGETHER UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK FOR
A

START, AND PERHAPS DISILLUSIONMENT CHARMS WOULD BE SENSIBLE THEN,
UNLESS YOU THINK WE SHOULD GO THE WHOLE HOG AND USE PERMANENT

GEORGE S. HILLMAN

KEA

PERHAPS? IN THAT CASE WE WOULD NEED THE CHELSEA FAIR FROM SOMEWHERE. I
ACTUALLY THINK WE'D BETTER DO THAT, HARRY, THE THICKER YOUR
DISGUISES

THE BETTER. . . .

HARRY LET HER TALK, NODDING AND AGREEING WHENEVER THERE WAS
A PAUSE, BUT HIS MIND HAD LEFT THE CONVERSATION. FOR THE FIRST TIME
SINCE HE HAD DISCOVERED THAT THE SHEEP IN CRINGETTS WAS A FAKE, HE
FELT EXCITED.

HE WAS ABOUT TO GO HOME, ABOUT TO RETURN TO THE PLACE WHERE HE
HAD HAD A FAMILY. IT WAS IN GEORGE S. HILLMAN THAT, BUT FOR
VANDERBILT,

HE WOULD HAVE GROWN UP AND SPENT EVERY SCHOOL HOLIDAY. HE COULD

HAVE INVITED FRIENDS TO HIS HOUSE. . . . HE MIGHT EVEN HAVE HAD
BROTHERS

AND SISTERS. . . . IT WOULD HAVE BEEN HIS MOTHER WHO HAD MADE

HIS SEVENTEENTH BIRTHDAY CAKE. THE LIFE HE HAD LOST HAD HARDLY
EVER

SEEMED SO REAL TO HIM AS AT THIS MOMENT, WHEN HE KNEW HE WAS
ABOUT

THE SEE THE PLACE WHERE IT HAD BEEN TAKEN FROM HIM. AFTER HERMIONE
HAD GONE THE RED THAT NIGHT, HARRY QUIETLY EXTRACTED HIS RINGSACK
FROM

HERMIONE'S BEADED BAG, AND FROM INSIDE IT, THE PHOTOGRAPH ALUMINUM
HAGRID HAD GIVEN HIM SEEN LONG AGO, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN MONTHS,
HE

PERUSED THE OLD PICTURES OF HIS PARENTS, SMILING AND WAVING UP AT
HIM

FROM THE IMAGES, WHICH WERE ALL HE HAD LEFT OF THEM NOW.

HARRY WOULD GLADLY HAVE SET OUT FOR CEDRIC'S BIRTHDAY THE FOLLOWING
DAY, BUT HERMIONE HAD OTHER IDEAS. CONVINCED AS SHE WAS THAT

VERBEMBERT WOULD EXPECT HARRY TO RETURN TO THE SCENE OF HIS
PARENTS

DEATHS, SHE WAS DETERMINED THAT THEY WOULD SET OFF ONLY AFTER THEY
HAD

ENSURED THAT THEY HAD THE BEST DISGUISES POSSIBLE. IT WAS THEREFORE
A

FULL WEEK LATER SINCE THEY HAD SURREPTITIOUSLY OBTAINED HAIRS
FROM

INNOCENT MUGGLES WHO WERE CHRISTMAS SHOPPING, AND HAD PRACTICED
APPEARING AND DISAPPEARING WHILE UNDERNEATH THE
INVISIBILITY

TOOK TOGETHER THAT HERMIONE AGREED TO MAKE THE JOURNEY,

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

XXX

THEY WERE THE APPARATE THE THE VILLAGE UNDER COVER OF DARKNESS,

SEE IT WAS LATE AFTERNOON WHEN THEY FINALLY SWALLOWED PERILIOUS
OF

THEN, HARRY TRANSFORMING INTO A BUILDING, MIDDLE-AGED MUSCLE MAN,

HERMIONE INTO HIS SMALL AND RATHER MEELY WIFE. THE BEADED BAG
CONTAINING ALL OF THEIR POSSESSIONS (APART FROM THE HURLOCK,
WHICH

HARRY WAS WEARING AROUND HIS NECK) WAS TUCKED INTO AN INSIDE

POCKET OF HERMIONE'S CLUTTERED-UP COAT. HARRY BELIEVED THE INVIS-
IBILITY CLOAK OVER THEM, THEN THEY TURNED INTO THE SLIPPERING
DARK-

NESS ONCE AGAIN.

HEART BEATING IN HIS THROAT, HARRY OPENED HIS EYES. THEY WERE
STANDING HAND IN HAND IN A STONY LANE UNDER A DARK BLUE SKY, IN

WHICH THE NIGHT'S FIRST STARS WERE ALREADY GLIMMERING FEELY. CHIT-
TAGS STOOD ON EITHER SIDE OF THE NARROW ROAD, CHRISTMAS
DECORATIONS

TWINKLING IN THEIR WINDOWS. A STREET LAY AHEAD OF THEM, A GLEAM OF
GOLDEN STREETLIGHTS INDICATED THE CENTER OF THE VILLAGE.

ALL THIS SNEEL? FERMINE WHISPERED BENEATH THE CLOAK. WHY
DIDN'T WE THINK OF SNEEL? AFTER ALL OUR PRECAUTIONS, WE'LL LEAVE
PRINTS?

WE'LL JUST HAVE TO GET RID OF THEM. WELL, GEE, IN FRONT, I'LL DO IT

FARRY DID NOT WANT TO ENTER THE VILLAGE LIKE A PANTHEMIC BEAST,
TRYING TO KEEP THEMSELVES CONCEALED WHILE MAGICALLY COVERING
THEIR
TRACES.

LET'S TAKE OFF THE CLOAK, SAID FARRY, AND WHEN SHE LOOKED
FRIGHTENED, HE, COME ON, WE DON'T LOOK LIKE LIS AND THERE'S NO ONE
AROUND.

HE STEWED THE CLOAK UNDER HIS JACKET AND THEY MADE THEIR WAY
FORWARD LINE-DAMPED, THE ICY AIR STINGING THEIR FACES AS THEY
PASSED

THREE CHATTAGES! AND ONE OF THEM MIGHT HAVE BEEN THE ONE IN WHICH
JAMES AND LILY HAD ONCE LIVED OR WHERE KATHILDA LIVED NOW. FARRY
GAZED AT THE FRONT DOORS, THEIR SNEEL-BURDENED ROOFS, AND THEIR
FRONT

GEORIC S. FEELEW

EEK

PERCHES, WONDERING WHETHER HE REMEMBERED ANY OF THEM, DREAMING
DEEP INSIDE THAT IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE, THAT HE HAD BEEN LITTLE MORE
THAN

A YOUNG MAN WHEN HE HAD LEFT THIS PLACE FOREVER, HE WAS NOT EVEN
SURE

WHETHER HE WOULD BE ABLE TO SEE THE CHURCH AT ALL; HE DID NOT KNOW
WHAT HAPPENED WHEN THE SUBJECTS OF A FIDELITY CHARM DIED. THEN
THE LITTLE LANE ALONG WHICH THEY WERE WALKING CURVED TO THE LEFT
AND

THE HEART OF THE VILLAGE, A SMALL SQUARE, WAS REVEALED TO THEM.
STILLING ALL AROUND WITH CHERISHED LIGHTS, THERE WAS WHAT LOOKED
LIKE

A WAR MEMORIAL IN THE MIDDLE, PARTLY ENCLOSED BY A WINDMILL
CHRISTMAS TREE. THERE WERE SEVERAL SHOPS, A POST OFFICE, A PUB, AND
A

LITTLE CHURCH WHOSE STAINED-GLASS WINDOWS WERE GLOWING IRRES-
BRIGHT

ACROSS THE SQUARE.

THE SNOW HERE HAD BEEN IMPACTED: IT WAS HARD AND SLIPPERY
WHERE PEOPLE HAD TRODDEN IN IT ALL DAY. VILLAGERS WERE
CRISPCRESSING

IN FRONT OF THEM, THEIR FIGURES BRIEFLY ILLUMINATED BY STREETLAMPS.
THEY HEARD A SNATCH OF LAUGHTER AND POP MUSIC AS THE PUB DOOR
OPENED AND CLOSED; THEN THEY HEARD A CARRIAGE START UP INSIDE THE
LITTLE
CHURCH.

HARRY, I THINK IT'S CHRISTMAS EVE! SAID HERMIONE.

IS IT?

HE HAD LOST TRACK OF THE DATE; THEY HAD NOT SEEN A NEWSPAPER FOR
WEEKS.

I'M SURE IT IS, SAID HERMIONE, HER EYES UPON THE CHURCH. THEY
... THEY WILL BE IN THERE, WHEN? THEY? YOUR MUM AND DAD? I CAN SEE
THE GRAVEYARD BEHIND IT.

HARRY FELT A THRILL OF SOMETHING THAT WAS BEYOND EXCITEMENT,
MORE LIKE FEAR. WHEN THAT HE WAS SO NEAR, HE WONDERED WHETHER HE
WANTED TO SEE AFTER ALL. PERHAPS JERMYNE KNEW HOW HE WAS FEEL-
ING, BECAUSE SHE REACHED FOR HIS HAND AND TOOK THE LEAD FOR THE
FIRST

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RAY

TIME, PULLING HIM FORWARD, HALFWAY ACROSS THE SQUARE, HOWEVER,
SHE

STOPPED DEAD.

HARRY, WHEN?

SHE WAS POINTING AT THE WAR MEMORIAL. AS THEY HAD PASSED IT,
IT HAD TRANSFORMED. INSTEAD OF AN ARCADE COVERED IN NAMES, THERE
WAS A STATUE OF THREE PEOPLE: A MAN WITH UNTIDY HAIR AND GLASSES,
A

WOMAN WITH LONG HAIR AND A KIND, PRETTY FACE, AND A BABY WHO SIT-
TING IN HIS MOTHER'S ARMS. SHEEN LAY UPON ALL THEIR HEADS, LIKE
ALFIE

WHITE CAPS.

HARRY DREW CLOSER, GAZING UP INTO HIS PARENTS' FACES. HE HAD
NEVER

IMAGINED THAT THERE WOULD BE A STATUE. . . . HOW STRANGE IT WAS THE

SEE HIMSELF REPRESENTED IN STONE, A HAPPY BABY WITHOUT A SCAR ON
HIS THREE-HEAD, . . .

[THEN, SAID HARRY, WHEN HE HAD BREWED HIS FILL, AND THEY TURNED
AGAIN TOWARD THE CHURCH. AS THEY CROSSED THE ROAD, HE GLANCED
EVER

HIS SHOULDERS; THE STATUE HAD TURNED BACK INTO THE WAR MEMORIAL.
THE SINGING GREW LOUDER AS THEY APPROACHED THE CHURCH. IT MADE
HARRY'S THREAT CONSTRUCT, IT REMINDED HIM SHE FEROCIOUSLY OF
FUGLEHARTS,

HE PERVES BELIEVING RUDE VERSIONS OF CAROLS FROM INSIDE SLITS OF
AIR-

MENT, OF THE GREAT HALL'S TWELVE CHRISTMAS TREES, HE DUMPKED

WEARING A KENNET HE HAD WORN IN A CRACKER, HE POKE IN A HAND-
KNITTED

SWEATER, . . .

THERE WAS A MISSING GATE AT THE ENTRANCE TO THE GRAVEYARD,
FIRMI-

HE PUSHED IT OPEN AS QUIETLY AS POSSIBLE AND THEY EDGED THROUGH

IT, ON EITHER SIDE OF THE SLIPPERY PATH TO THE CHURCH DOORS, THE
SNOW

LAY DEEP AND UNTHAWED. THEY MOVED OFF THROUGH THE SNOW, CARV-
ING DEEP TRENCHES BEHIND THEM AS THEY WALKED AROUND THE BUILDING,

KEEPING THE SHADES BENEATH THE BRILLIANT WINDOWS,
BEHIND THE CHURCH, NOW WHEN NOW HE SPOKE THEMSELVES FROM

GEORGE S. FILLER

KPS

TRUDGED FROM A BLANKET OF PALE BLUE THAT WAS FLECKED WITH DAZZLING
RED, GOLD, AND GREEN WHEREVER THE REFLECTIONS FROM THE STAINED
GLASS

HIT THE SNOW, KEEPING HIS HAND CLASPED TIGHTLY AROUND THE HORN IN HIS
JACKET POCKET, HARRY MOVED TOWARD THE NEAREST GRAVE.

LOOKING AT THIS, IT WAS AN ARKITT, COULD BE SOME LONG-LOST RELATIVE OF
HARRISON'S?

KEEP YOUR VOICE DOWN, HERMINE BEGGED HIM.

THEY WADED DEEPER AND DEEPER INTO THE GRAVEYARD, CHISELING DARK
TRACKS INTO THE SNOW BEHIND THEM, STEERING THE POOR AT THE WEEDS
AND

OLD HEADSTONES, EVERY NOW AND THEN SWERVING INTO THE
SURROUNDING

DARKNESS THE MADE ABSOLUTELY SURE THAT THEY WERE UNACCOMPANIED.

HARRY, HERE?

HERMINE WAS TWO FEET AWAY FROM THEMSELVES ALREADY; HE HAD THE WAD BACK
TO HER, HIS HEART POSITIVELY RANGING IN HIS CHEST.

IS IT ?

NO, BUT LOOK?

SHE POINTED TO THE DARK STONE, HARRY STEPPED DOWN AND SAW,

UPON THE FREEZEN, LICHEN-SPOTTED GRANITE, THE WORDS KENDRA DUM-
BLEDBERE AND, A SHEET WAS REELLED HER DATES OF BIRTH AND DEATH, AND

HER DAUGHTER ARIANA. THERE WAS ALSO A ELLEGATION:

WHERE YOUR TREASURE IS, THERE WILL YOUR HEART BE ALSO.

SEE RITA SKEETER AND MURIEL HAD GET SOME OF THEIR FACTS RIGHT.

THE DUMBLEDBERE FAMILY HAD INDEED LIVED HERE, AND PART OF IT HAD
DIED HERE.

SEEKING THE GRAVE WAS WORSE THAN HEARING ABOUT IT. HARRY COULD
NOT

HELP THINKING THAT HE AND DUMBLEDBERE BOTH HAD DEEP ROOTS IN THIS
GRAVEYARD, AND THAT DUMBLEDBERE MIGHT BE HAVE TOLD HIM SO, YET HE

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

HAD NEVER THOUGHT TO SHARE THE CONNECTION. THEY COULD HAVE
VISITED

THE PLACE TOGETHER; FOR A MOMENT HARRY IMAGINED CHIMING HERE
WITH

DUMBLEDBERE, OF WHAT A KIND THAT WOULD HAVE BEEN, HE FELT MUCH IT
WOULD HAVE MEANT TO HIM. BUT IT SEEMED THAT THE DUMBLEDBERE, THE
FACT THAT THEIR FAMILIES LAY SIDE BY SIDE IN THE SAME GRAVEYARD HAD
BEEN AN UNIMPORTANT COINCIDENCE, IRRELEVANT, PERHAPS, THE TIME HE
HE

WANTED HARRY TO DIE.

HERMIONE WAS WATCHING AT HARRY, AND HE WAS GLAD THAT HIS FACE WAS

HIDDEN IN SHADELS, HE READ THE WORDS AND THE THINGSTHINK AGAIN,
WHERE

WHERE TREASURE IS, THERE WILL YOUR HEART BE ALSO, HE DID NOT
UNDERSTAND

WHAT THESE WORDS MEANT, SURELY OLIMPEDEHE HAD CHOSEN THEM, AS
THE ELDEST MEMBER OF THE FAMILY SINCE HIS FATHER HAD DIED.

ARE YOU SURE HE NEVER MENTIONED ? HERMINE BEGAN,

NO, SAID HARRY CLUTLY, THEN, LET S KEEP LOOKING, AND HE TURNED
AWAY, WISHING HE HAD NOT SEEN THE STONE: HE DID NOT WANT HIS
EXCITED

TREPIDATION TAINED WITH RESENTMENT,

HERE? CRIED HERMINE AGAIN A FEW MOMENTS LATER FROM HILT OF
THE DARKNESS, EH NO, SHIRY? I THOUGHT IT SAID BETTER,

SHE WAS RUBBING AT A CRUMBLING, MESSY STONE, GAZING DOWN AT IT,
A LITTLE FROWN ON HER FACE,

HARRY, CAME BACK A MOMENT,

HE DID NOT WANT TO BE SIDETRACKED AGAIN, AND ONLY GRUDGINGLY
MADE HIS WAY BACK THROUGH THE SNOW TOWARD HER,

WHAT?

LOOK AT THIS?

THE GRAVE WAS EXTREMELY OLD, WEATHERED SO THAT HARRY COULD

HARDLY MAKE HILT THE NAME, HERMINE SHOWED HIM THE SYMBOL BE-
NEATH IT,

HARRY, THAT S THE MARK IN THE KNEE?

GEORGE S HELLEN

REY

HE PEERED AT THE PLACE SHE INDICATED: THE STONE WAS SHE WHERN THAT IT WAS HARD TO MAKE OUT WHAT WAS ENGRAVED THERE, THOUGH THERE DID

SEEM TO BE A TRIANGULAR MARK BENEATH THE NEARLY ILLEGIBLE NAME.

YES... IT COULD BE...

HERMIONE HIT HER HAND AND POINTED IT AT THE NAME ON THE HEADSTONE.

IT SAYS IG... IGENIUS, I THINK...

I'M GOING TO KEEP LOOKING FOR MY PARENTS, ALL RIGHT? HARRY TOLD HER, A SLIGHT EDGE TO HIS VOICE, AND HE SET OFF AGAIN, LEAVING HER

CRUELLED BESIDE THE OLD GRAVE.

EVERY NEW AND THEN HE RECOGNIZED A SURNAME THAT, LIKE ASKEW, HE HAD MET AT HOGWARTS. SOMETIMES THERE WERE SEVERAL GENERATIONS

OF THE SAME WIZARDING FAMILY REPRESENTED IN THE GRAVEYARD: HARRY

COULD TELL FROM THE DATES THAT IT HAD EITHER DIED OUT, OR THE CURRENT MEMBERS HAD MOVED AWAY FROM GORIC & HILL, DEEPER AND

DEEPER AMONGST THE GRAVES HE WENT, AND EVERY TIME HE REACHED A NEW

HEADSTONE HE FELT A LITTLE LURCH OF APPREHENSION AND ANTICIPATION.

THE DARKNESS AND THE SILENCE SEEMED TO BECOME, ALL OF A SUDDEN,

MUCH DEEPER, HARRY LOOKED AROUND, WHIRLED, THINKING OF DEMON-
TERS, THEN REALIZED THAT THE CARRIAGES HAD FINISHED, THAT THE CHATTER

AND ALL THE CHURCHGERS WERE FADING AWAY AS THEY MADE THEIR
WAY

BACK INTO THE SHELTER, SOMEHOW INSIDE THE CHURCH HAD JUST TURNED
OFF THE LIGHTS.

THEN HERMIONE'S VEHICLE CAME OUT OF THE BLACKNESS FOR THE THIRD
TIME, SHARP AND CLEAR FROM A FEW YARDS AWAY.

HARRY, THEY'RE HERE . . . RIGHT HERE.

AND HE KNEW BY HER TONE THAT IT WAS HIS MOTHER AND FATHER THIS
TIME! HE MOVED TOWARD HER, FEELING AS IF SOMETHING HEAVY WERE
PRESSING HIM HIS CHEST, THE SAME SENSATION HE HAD HAD RIGHT AFTER

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

XXX

BLUMENBERG HAD DIED, A GRIEF THAT HAD ACTUALLY WEIGHED HIM HIS
HEART AND LUNGS.

THE HEADSTONE WAS ONLY TWO FEET BEHIND KENDRA AND ARIANA'S.
IT WAS MADE OF WHITE MARBLE, JUST LIKE BLUMENBERG'S TOMB, AND THIS
MADE IT EASY TO READ, AS IT SEEMED TO SHINE IN THE DARK. HARRY DID
NOT NEED TO BOW OR EVEN APPROACH VERY CLOSE TO IT TO MAKE OUT
THE

WORDS ENGRAVED UPON IT.

G ICP~M~~~~~ I TV~M~~~~~

~~THE LAST ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH.~~
~~THE LAST ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH.~~

THE LAST ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH.

HARRY READ THE WORDS SILENTLY, AS THOUGH HE WOULD HAVE HAD
HIS CHANCE TO TAKE IN THEIR MEANING, AND HE READ THE LAST OF THEM
ALONE.

THE LAST ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH... A TERRIBLE
THOUGHT CAME TO HIM, AND WITH IT A KIND OF PANIC. ISN'T THAT A
DEATH

LATER IDEA? WHY IS THAT THERE?

IT DOESN'T MEAN DEFEATING DEATH IN THE WAY THE DEATH EATERS
MEAN IT, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE, HER VOICE GENTLE. IT MEANS... WELL
KNOW... LIVING BEYOND DEATH. LIVING AFTER DEATH.

BUT THEY WERE NOT LIVING, THOUGHT HARRY: THEY WERE GONE. THE
EMPTY WORDS COULD NOT DISGUISE THE FACT THAT HIS PARENTS
MURDERING

REMAINS LAY BENEATH SNOW AND STONE, INDIFFERENT, UNMOVING, AND
TEARS CAME BEFORE HE COULD STOP THEM, BRILLING HOT THEN INSTANTLY
FREEZING ON HIS FACE, AND WHAT WAS THE POINT IN WIPING THEM OFF
HIS

PRETENDING? HE LET THEM FALL, HIS LIPS PRESSED HARD TOGETHER,
WHISKING

GEORGE S HELLER

END

DOWN AT THE THICK SNOW HIDING FROM HIS EYES THE PLACE WHERE THE

LAST OF LILY AND JAMES LAY, KNEES NEAR, SURELY, HER BLIST, NOT KNOWING
HER CARING THAT THEIR LIVING SHEN STOOD SO NEAR, HIS HEART STILL
BEATING,

ALIVE BECAUSE OF THEIR SACRIFICE AND THESE THE WISHING, AT THIS
MOMENT,

THAT HE WAS SLEEPING UNDER THE SNOW WITH THEM.

BERMINE HAD TAKEN HIS HAND AGAIN AND WAS GRIPPING IT TIGHTLY,

HE COULD NOT LOOK AT HER, BUT RETURNED THE PRESSURE, NOW TAKING
DEEP, SHARP GLIPS OF THE NIGHT AIR, TRYING THE STEADY HIMSELF,
TRYING

THE REGAIN CONTROL, HE SHOULD HAVE REALIZED SOMETHING THE GIVE
THEM,

AND HE HAD NOT THOUGHT OF IT, AND EVERY PLANT IN THE GRAVEYARD
WAS

LEAFLESS AND FROZEN, BUT BERMINE RAISED HER HAND, MOVED IT IN A
CIRCLE THROUGH THE AIR, AND A WREATH OF CHRISTMAS REES BLESSED
BEFORE THEM, HARRY CAUGHT IT AND LAID IT ON HIS PARENTS GRAVE,

AS SOON AS HE STOOD UP HE WANTED THE LEAVE: HE DID NOT THINK HE

COULD STAND ANOTHER MOMENT THERE, HE PUT HIS ARM AROUND BERMINE
S SHOULDERS, AND SHE PUT HER ARROUND HIS WAIST, AND THEY
TURNED

IN SILENCE AND WALKED AWAY THROUGH THE SNOW, PAST DUMKEDORE S
MOTHER AND SISTER, BACK TOWARD THE DARK CHURCH AND THE BLIT-OF-
SIGHT

KISSING GATE.

C H A P T E R S E V E N T E E N

KKK

RATEILDA \$ SECRET

ARRY, STEP,

WHAT \$ WRENG?

THEY HAD ONLY JUST REACHED THE GRAVE OF THE LINDENHILL ARKETT.

THERE \$ SOMEONE THERE, SOMEONE WATCHING US, I CAN TELL. THERE
EVER BY THE BLISHES.

THEY STOOD WHITE STILL, HOLDING EACH OTHER, GAZING AT THE
DENSE

BLACK BOUNDARY OF THE GRAVEYARD, HARRY COULD NOT SEE ANYTHING.
ARE YOU SURE?

I SAW SOMETHING MOVE, I COULD HAVE SWORN I DID, . . .

SHE BROKE FROM HIM THE FREE HER WAND ARM.

WE WERE LIKE MUGGLES, HARRY POINTED OUT.

MUGGLES WHO VE JUST BEEN LAYING FLOWERS ON THEIR PARENTS
GRAVE?

HARRY, I M SURE THERE \$ SOMEONE OVER THERE?

HARRY THOUGHT OF A HISTORY OF MAGIC; THE GRAVEYARD WAS
SLIPPED

THE HE FAINTED: WHAT IF ? BUT THEN HE HEARD A RUSTLE AND SAW A
H

RATEILDA \$ SECRET

KK1

LITTLE BOY HE DISMISSED SNEEL IN THE BLISH TH WHICH FERMINE HAD
PRINTED. GHOSTS CHILD NEET MEVE SNEEL.

IT S A CAT, SAID HARRY, AFTER A SECOND HE TWE, HE A KIRD, IF IT WAS
A DEATH LATER WE D BE DEAD BY NEEL. BUT LET S GET ELIT HE HERE, AND
WE CAN PUT THE CHAD BACK IN.

THEY GLANCED BACK REPEATEDLY AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY ELIT HE THE
GRAVEYARD. HARRY, WHEN DID NEET FEEL AS SANGLINE AS HE HAD PRETENDED

WHEN REASSURING FERMINE, WAS GLAD TO REACH THE GATE AND THE
SLIP-

PERRY PAVEMENT. THEY PULLED THE INVISIBILITY CHAD BACK OVER THEM-
SELVES. THE PLIE WAS FLICKER THAN BEFORE: MANY VEHICLES INSIDE IT WERE

NEEL SINGING THE CAMEL THAT THEY HAD HEARD AS THEY APPROACHED THE
THE

CHURCH. FOR A MOMENT HARRY CONSIDERED SUGGESTING THEY TAKE
RELIEF

INSIDE IT, BUT BEFORE HE COULD SAY ANYTHING FERMINE MURMURED,

LET S GO THIS WAY, AND PULLED HIM DOWN THE DARK STREET LEADING
ELIT

HE THE VILLAGE IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION FROM WHICH THEY HAD
ENTERED.

HARRY COULD MAKE ELIT THE POINT WHERE THE COTTAGES ENDED AND THE
LANE TURNED INTO OPEN COUNTRY AGAIN. THEY WALKED AS QUICKLY AS
THEY

DARED, PAST MORE WINDOWS SPARKLING WITH MULTICOLORED LIGHTS, THE

OUTLINES OF CHRISTMAS TREES DARK THROUGH THE CURTAINS.

"HOW ARE WE GOING TO FIND RATHILDA'S HELMS?" ASKED FERMINE,
WHO WAS SHIVERING A LITTLE AND KEPT GLANCING BACK OVER HER
SHOULDER.

"HARRY? WHAT DO YOU THINK?" HARRY?

SHE TUGGED AT HIS ARM, BUT HARRY WAS NOT PAYING ATTENTION. HE
WAS LEERING TOWARD THE DARK MASS THAT STOOD AT THE VERY END OF
THIS

ROW OF HELMS. NEXT MOMENT HE HAD SPED UP, DRAGGING FERMINE
ALONG WITH HIM; SHE SLIPPED A LITTLE ON THE ICE.

"HARRY"

"LOOK, . . . LOOK AT IT, FERMINE, . . ."

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

KEE

"I DON'T . . . HE?"

HE COULD SEE IT; THE FIDELIS CHARM MUST HAVE DIED WITH JAMES
AND LILY. THE HEDGE HAD GROWN WILD IN THE SIXTEEN YEARS SINCE
HAGRID

HAD TAKEN HARRY FROM THE RUCKLE THAT LAY SCATTERED AMONGST THE
WAIST-HIGH GRASS. MOST OF THE HUTTAGE WAS STILL STANDING, THOUGH
ENTIRELY COVERED IN DARK IVY AND SNEL, BUT THE RIGHT SIDE OF THE
THRO

ATHEIR HAD BEEN BLOWN APART; THAT, HARRY WAS SURE, WAS WHERE THE
CURSE HAD BACKFIRED. HE AND FERMINE STOOD AT THE GATE, GAZING UP

AT THE WRECK OF WHAT MUST HAVE BEEN A CHITTAGER ILIST LIKE
THESE

THAT FLANKED IT.

I WONDER WHY ANYBODY'S EVER REBUILT IT? WHISPERED HERMIONE.

MAYBE YOU CAN'T REBUILD IT? HARRY REPLIED. MAYBE IT'S LIKE THE
INJURIES FROM DARK MAGIC AND YOU CAN'T REPAIR THE DAMAGE?

HE SLIPPED A HAND FROM BENEATH THE LEAD AND GRASPED THE SPOKE
AND THICKLY RUSTED GATE, NOT WISHING TO OPEN IT, BUT SIMPLY TO HOLD
SOME PART OF THE FENCE.

YOU'RE NOT GOING TO GO INSIDE? IT LOOKS UNSAFE, IT MIGHT BE,
HARRY, LOOK?

HIS THOUGHTS ON THE GATE SEEMED TO HAVE DONE IT. A SIGN HAD RISEN
BUT OF THE GRASS IN FRONT OF THEM, UP THROUGH THE TANGLES OF
NETTLES

AND WEEDS, LIKE SOME RIZARR, FAST-GROWING FLEWER, AND IN CHILDEN
LET-

TERS WHEN THE WIND IT SAID:

ON THIS SPOT, ON THE NIGHT OF 31 OCTOBER 1981,

LILY AND JAMES POTTER LOST THEIR LIVES.

THEIR SON, HARRY, REMAINS THE ONLY WIZARD
EVER TO HAVE SURVIVED THE KILLING CURSE.

THIS FENCE, INVISIBLE TO MUGGLES, HAS BEEN LEFT
IN ITS RUINED STATE AS A MONUMENT TO THE POTTERS

RATHEILDA'S SECRET

KKK

AND AS A REMINDER OF THE VIOLENCE
THAT THERE APART THEIR FAMILY.

AND ALL AROUND THESE NEATLY LETTERED WORDS, SCRIBBLES HAD BEEN
ADDED BY EITHER WITCHES AND WIZARDS WHO HAD COME TO SEE THE PLACE
WHERE THE RED WHO LIVED HAD ESCAPED, SOME HAD MERELY SIGNED
THEIR NAMES IN EVERLASTING INK; OTHERS HAD CARVED THEIR INITIALS
INTO

THE WOOD, STILL OTHERS HAD LEFT MESSAGES, THE MOST RECENT OF THESE,
SHINING BRIGHTLY OVER SIXTEEN YEARS WORTH OF MAGICAL GRAFFITI, ALL
SAID

SIMILAR THINGS.

GOOD LUCK, HARRY, WHEREVER YOU ARE.

IF YOU READ THIS, HARRY, WE'RE ALL BEHIND YOU!

LONG LIVE HARRY POTTER.

THEY SHOULDN'T HAVE WRITTEN IN THE SIGN! SAID HERMIONE,
INDIGNANT.

BUT HARRY BEAMED AT HER.

IT'S BRILLIANT. I'M GLAD THEY DID. I...

HE BROKE OFF. A HEAVILY MUFFLED FIGURE WAS PEEKING UP THE LANE
TOWARD THEM, SILHOUETTED BY THE BRIGHT LIGHTS IN THE DISTANT
SQUARE.

HARRY THOUGHT, THOUGH IT WAS HARD TO JUDGE, THAT THE FIGURE WAS
A

WHEN SHE WAS MOVING SILENTLY, POSSIBLY FRIGHTENED BY SLIPPING ON THE SLEET-COVERED GROUND, HER STEADY, HER STEALTHINESS, HER SLIPPING GAIT ALL

GAVE AN IMPRESSION OF EXTREME AGE. THEY WATCHED IN SILENCE AS SHE DREW NEARER. HARRY WAS WAITING TO SEE WHETHER SHE WOULD TURN INTO

ANY OF THE CREATURES SHE WAS PASSING, BUT HE KNEW INSTINCTIVELY THAT

SHE WOULD NOT. AT LAST SHE CAME TO A HALT A FEW YARDS FROM THEM AND

SIMPLY STOOD THERE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FROZEN ROAD, FACING THEM.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

KKK

HE DID NOT NEED HERMIONE'S PINCH TO HIS ARM. THERE WAS NEXT TO NO CHANCE THAT THIS WOMAN WAS A MUGGLE! SHE WAS STANDING THERE GAZING AT A HOUSE THAT MIGHT BE HAVE BEEN COMPLETELY INVISIBLE TO HER,

IF SHE WAS NOT A WITCH. EVEN ASSUMING THAT SHE WAS A WITCH, HOWEVER,

IT WAS EDD RE-JAY-HER THE CAMP FELT ON A NIGHT THIS CHILD, SIMPLY THE

AT AN OLD BLIND. BY ALL THE RULES OF NORMAL MAGIC, MEANWHILE, SHE MIGHT NOT BE ABLE TO SEE HERMIONE AND HIM AT ALL. NEVERTHELESS, HARRY HAD THE STRANGEST FEELING THAT SHE KNEW THAT THEY WERE THERE.

AND ALSO WHEN THEY WERE. JUST AS HE HAD REACHED THIS UNEASY
CHUCKLE-

THEN, SHE RAISED A GLEEVED HAND AND RECKONED,

HERMINEE MOVED CLOSER TO HIM UNDER THE CLOAK, HER ARM PRESSED
AGAINST HIS,

HOW DOES SHE KNOW?

HE SHOOK HIS HEAD. THE WOMAN RECKONED AGAIN, MORE VIGOR-
OUSLY. HARRY COULD THINK OF MANY REASONS NOT TO BEYOND THE SLIM-
MINDS, AND YET HIS SUSPICIONS ABOUT HER IDENTITY WERE GROWING

STRONGER EVERY MOMENT THAT THEY STOOD FACING EACH OTHER IN THE
DESERTED STREET.

WAS IT POSSIBLE THAT SHE HAD BEEN WAITING FOR THEM ALL THESE LONG
MONTHS? THAT DUMKEDORE HAD TOLD HER TO WAIT, AND THAT HARRY
WOULD COME IN THE END? WAS IT NOT LIKELY THAT IT WAS SHE WHO HAD
MOVED IN THE SHADOWS IN THE GRAVEYARD AND HAD FOLLOWED THEM TO
THIS

SPOT? EVEN HER ABILITY TO SENSE THEM SUGGESTED SOME DUMKEDORE-
ISH

POWER THAT HE HAD NEVER ENCOUNTERED BEFORE.

FINALLY HARRY SPOKE, CALLING HERMINEE TO GASP AND ILMP,

ARE YOU KATHILDA?

THE MUFFLED FIGURE NODDED AND RECKONED AGAIN,

BEHIND THE CLOAK HARRY AND HERMINEE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

HARRY RAISED HIS EYEBROWS; HERMINEE GAVE A TINY, NERVOUS NOD.

RATHILDA'S SECRET

KKK

THEY STEPPED TOWARD THE WHIMAN AND, AT ONCE, SHE TURNED AND
FEBBLED OFF BACK THE WAY THEY HAD COME, LEADING THEM PAST SEVERAL
FEBBLES, SHE TURNED IN AT A GATE. THEY FOLLOWED HER UP THE FRONT
PATH

THROUGH A GARDEN NEARLY AS EVERGREEN AS THE ONE THEY HAD JUST
LEFT.

SHE FLUMBED FOR A MOMENT WITH A KEY AT THE FRONT DOOR, THEN
OPENED

IT AND STEPPED BACK TO LET THEM PASS.

SHE SMELLED BAD, OR PERHAPS IT WAS HER FEBBLE! HARRY WRINKLED
HIS NOSE AS THEY SIDLED PAST HER AND PULLED OFF THE CHAIR. WHEN THAT
HE WAS BESIDE HER, HE REALIZED HOW TINY SHE WAS; BUILT DOWN WITH
AGE, SHE CAME BARELY LEVEL WITH HIS CHEST. SHE CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND
THEM, HER KNUCKLES BUMP AND MOTTLED AGAINST THE PEELING PAINT,
THEN

TURNED AND PEERED INTO HARRY'S FACE. HER EYES WERE THICK WITH
CATAR-

RACTS AND SLIDEN IN THE FIELDS OF TRANSPARENT SKIN, AND HER WHEE
FACE

WAS DOTTED WITH BROWN VEINS AND LIVER SPOTS. HE WONDERED
WHETHER

SHE COULD MAKE HIM BLIT AT ALL; EVEN IF SHE COULD, IT WAS THE BALDING
MUSCLE WHERE IDENTITY HE HAD STEALN THAT SHE WOULD SEE.

THE MORE HE HAD AGE, HE BLIST, HE UNWASHED CLOTHES AND STALE FOOD
INTENSIFIED AS SHE UNWOUND A MOUTH-EATEN BLACK SIALI, REVEALING A
HEAD OF SCANT WHITE HAIR THROUGH WHICH THE SCALP SHOWED CLEARLY.

RATHILDA? HARRY REPEATED.

SHE NODDED AGAIN. HARRY BECAME AWARE OF THE TICKET AGAINST HIS
SKIN; THE THING INSIDE IT THAT SOMETIMES TICKED HER BEAT HAD WEAKEN;
HE COULD FEEL IT PULSING THROUGH THE CHILD CHILD. DID IT KNOW, COULD
IT SENSE, THAT THE THING THAT WOULD DESTROY IT WAS NEAR?

RATHILDA SLIPPED PAST THEM, PUSHING HERMIONE ASIDE AS THOUGH
SHE HAD NOT SEEN HER, AND VANISHED INTO WHAT SEEMED TO BE A
SITTING

ROOM.

HARRY, I'M NOT SURE ABOUT THIS, BREATHED HERMIONE.

LOOK AT THE SIZE OF HER; I THINK WE COULD OVERPOWER HER IF WE
HAD

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

THE

THE, SAID HARRY. LISTEN, I SHOULD HAVE TOLD YOU, I KNOW SHE WASN'T
ALL THERE. MURIEL CALLED HER CACA.

COME? CALLED RATHILDA FROM THE NEXT ROOM.

HERMIONE LIMPED AND CLUTCHED HARRY'S ARM.

IT'S OKAY, SAID HARRY REASSURINGLY, AND HE LED THE WAY INTO THE
SITTING ROOM.

RATHILDA WAS TITTERING AROUND THE PLACE LIGHTING CANDLES, BUT

IT WAS STILL VERY DARK, NOT THE MENTIONED EXTREMELY DIRTY, THICK DUST
CRUNCHED BENEATH THEIR FEET, AND HARRY'S NOSE DETECTED, UNDERNEATH
THE DARK AND MILDRED SPELL, SOMETHING WORSE, LIKE MEAT CHESE
BAD. HE WONDERED WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME ANYONE HAD BEEN INSIDE
RATHILDA'S HOUSE THE CHECK WHETHER SHE WAS LIVING. SHE SEEMED TO
HAVE FORGOTTEN THAT SHE COULD DO MAGIC, THEN, FOR SHE LIT THE
CANDLES

CLIMBING BY HAND, HER TRAILING LACE CLIP IN CONSTANT DANGER OF
CATCH-
ING FIRE.

LET ME DO THAT, OFFERED HARRY, AND HE TOOK THE MATCHES FROM HER.
SHE STOOD WATCHING HIM AS HE FINISHED LIGHTING THE CANDLE STICKS
THAT

STOOD ON SALICERS AROUND THE ROOM, PERCHED PRECARIOUSLY ON
STACKS OF

BOOKS AND ON SIDE TABLES CRAMPED WITH CRACKED AND MELODY CLIPS.

THE LAST SURFACE ON WHICH HARRY SPENT A CANDLE WAS A SHELF-
FRONTED CHEST OF DRAWERS ON WHICH THERE STOOD A LARGE NUMBER OF

PHOTOGRAPHS. WHEN THE FLAME DANCED INTO LIFE, ITS REFLECTION
WAVED

ON THEIR DUSTY GLASS AND SILVER. HE SAW A FEW TINY MOVEMENTS FROM
THE PICTURES. AS RATHILDA FUMLED WITH LEGS FOR THE FIRE, HE
MUTTERED

TERREN : THE DUST VANISHED FROM THE PHOTOGRAPHS, AND HE SAW
AT

HENCE THAT HALF A DOZEN WERE MISSING FROM THE LARGEST AND MOST ORNATE FRAMES. HE WONDERED WHETHER KATHILDA OR SOMEONE ELSE HAD

REMOVED THEM. THEN THE SIGHT OF A PHOTOGRAPH NEAR THE BACK OF THE

COLLECTION CAUGHT HIS EYE, AND HE SNATCHED IT UP.

KATHILDA'S SECRET

XXX

IT WAS THE GOLDEN-HAired, MERRY-FACED THING, THE YOUNG MAN WHO HAD PERCHED ON GREGORYVITCH'S WINDMILL, SMILING LAZILY UP AT HARRY

HELD UP THE SILVER FRAME, AND IT CAME TO HARRY INSTANTLY WHERE HE HAD

SEEN THE RED BEARD: IN THE LIFE AND LIPS OF ALEXIS DUMKEDORE, ARM IN ARM WITH THE TEENAGE DUMKEDORE, AND THAT MUST BE WHERE ALL THE MISSING PHOTOGRAPHS WERE: IN RITA'S ROOM.

MRS. MISS RAGSHEE? HE SAID, AND HIS VEHICLE STOPPED SLIGHTLY, WHO IS THIS?

KATHILDA WAS STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM WATCHING HER-MINEE LIGHT THE FIRE FOR HER.

MISS RAGSHEE? HARRY REPEATED, AND HE ADVANCED WITH THE PICTURE IN HIS HANDS AS THE FLAMES BURST INTO LIFE IN THE FIREPLACE. KATHILDA

LEERED UP AT HIS VEHICLE, AND THE FERRARI BEAT FASTER UPON HIS CHEST.

WHO IS THIS PERSON? HARRY ASKED HER, PUSHING THE PICTURE FORWARD.

SHE PEERED AT IT SILENTLY, THEN UP AT HARRY.

DID YOU KNOW WHO THIS IS? HE REPEATED IN A MUCH SLOWER AND HEEDER VOICE THAN USUAL. THIS MAN? DID YOU KNOW HIM? WHAT IS HE CALLED?

KATHILDA MERELY LEERED VAGUE. HARRY FELT AN AWFUL FRUSTRATION. HAD RITA SKEETER LINKED KATHILDA'S MEMORIES?

WHO IS THIS MAN? HE REPEATED HEEDLY.

HARRY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING? ASKED HERMIONE.

THIS PICTURE, HERMIONE, IT'S THE THIEF, THE THIEF WHO STEAL FROM GREGOROVITCH? PLEASE? HE SAID TO KATHILDA. WHO IS THIS? BUT SHE ONLY STARED AT HIM.

WHO DID YOU ASK US THE NAME WITH YOU, MRS. MISS BAG-SHIT? ASKED HERMIONE, RAISING HER EYEBROW. WAS THERE SOMETHING YOU WANTED TO TELL US?

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

GIVING HER SIGN THAT SHE HAD HEARD HERMIONE, KATHILDA THEN SHUFFLED A FEW STEPS CLOSER TO HARRY, WITH A LITTLE TUCK OF HER HEAD SHE

LEERED BACK INTO THE HALL.

WELL WANT US THE LEAVE? HE ASKED.

SHE REPEATED THE GESTURE, THIS TIME POINTING FIRSTLY AT HIM, THEN AT

HERSELF, THEN AT THE CEILING.

EH, RIGHT . . . FERMINE, I THINK SHE WANTS ME THE GO UPSTAIRS WITH HER.

ALL RIGHT, SAID FERMINE, LET S GO.

BUT WHEN FERMINE MOVED, KATHILDA SHOOK HER HEAD WITH SURPRISING VIGOR, ONCE MORE POINTING FIRST AT FARRY, THEN THE HERSELF.

SHE WANTS ME THE GO WITH HER, ALONE.

WHY? ASKED FERMINE, AND HER VOICE RANG BELL SHARP AND CLEAR IN THE CANDLELIT ROOM; THE OLD LADY SHOOK HER HEAD A LITTLE AT THE MILD NOISE.

MAYBE DUMBLEDORE TOLD HER THE GIVE THE SWORD THE ME, AND ONLY THE ME?

DO YOU REALLY THINK SHE KNOWS WE TH YOU ARE?

YES, SAID FARRY, LEERING DOWN INTO THE MILD EYES FIXED UPON HIS ELIN, I THINK SHE DOES.

WELL, HESAY THEN, BUT BE BELIEVE, FARRY.

LEAD THE WAY, FARRY TOLD KATHILDA.

SHE SEEMED THE UNDERSTAND, BECAUSE SHE SHUFFLED AROUND HIM THE-
WARD THE DOOR. FARRY GLANCED BACK AT FERMINE WITH A REASSURING

SMILE, BUT HE WAS NOT SURE SHE HAD SEEN IT; SHE STOOD FLINGING
HERSELF

IN THE MIST OF THE CANDLELIT SHELTER, LEADING TOWARD THE
BEDCASE.

AS HARRY WALKED OUT OF THE ROOM, LINGERED BY BOTH FERMINE AND
KATHILDA, HE SLIPPED THE SILVER-FRAMED PICTOGRAPH OF THE
LINDWELM
THIEF INSIDE HIS JACKET.

KATHILDA'S SECRET

KEY

THE STAIRS WERE STEEP AND NARROW; HARRY WAS HALF-TEMPTED THE
PLACE

HIS HANDS WERE STEADY KATHILDA'S BACKSIDE TO ENSURE THAT SHE DID NOT
TUMBLE EVER BACKWARD INTO HIM, WHICH SEEMED ONLY TOO LIKELY.
SILENTLY, WHEEZING A LITTLE, SHE CLIMBED TO THE UPPER LANDING, TURNED
IMMEDIATELY RIGHT, AND LED HIM INTO A LOW-CEILINGED BEDROOM.

IT WAS PITCH-BLACK AND SMELLED HORRIBLE; HARRY HAD JUST MADE OUT
A CHAIR PENT PROTRUDING FROM UNDER THE BED BEFORE KATHILDA
CLOSED

THE DOOR AND EVEN THAT WAS SWALLOWED BY THE DARKNESS.

FLAMES, SAID HARRY, AND HIS HAND IGNITED, HE GAVE A START;
KATHILDA HAD MOVED CLOSE TO HIM IN THESE FEW SECONDS OF DARKNESS,
AND HE HAD NOT HEARD HER APPROACH.

WELL ARE YOU? SHE WHISPERED.

YES, I AM.

SHE NEEDED SILENCE, SERENITY, HARRY FELT THE FIERCELY BEATING
FAST, FASTER THAN HIS OWN HEART: IT WAS AN UNPLEASANT, AGITATING
SENSATION.

HAVE YOU GOT ANYTHING FOR ME? HARRY ASKED, BUT SHE SEEMED
DISTRACTED BY HIS LIT WAND-TIP.

HAVE YOU GOT ANYTHING FOR ME? HE REPEATED.

THEN SHE CLOSED HER EYES AND SEVERAL THINGS HAPPENED AT ONCE:

HARRY'S SKIN PRICKLED PAINFULLY; THE FIERCELY TWITCHED SHE THAT
THE

FRONT OF HIS SWEATER ACTUALLY MOVED; THE DARK, FETID REICH DISINTEGRATED
MENTALLY, HE FELT A LEAD OF ICE AND STONE IN A HIGH, CHILD VOICE:
HELD HIM.

HARRY STAYED WHERE HE STOOD: THE DARK, FILLING-SPREADING REICH
SEEMED TO CLOSE AROUND HIM AGAIN; HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT HAD JUST
HAPPENED.

HAVE YOU GOT ANYTHING FOR ME? HE ASKED HER A THIRD TIME, MUCH
LOUDER.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

END

EVER HERE, SHE WHISPERED, POINTING THE THE CORNER, HARRY RAISED
HIS WAND AND SAW THE OUTLINE OF A CLUTTERED DRESSING TABLE BENEATH
THE CURTAINED WINDOW.

THIS TIME SHE DID NOT LEAD HIM, HARRY EDGED BETWEEN HER AND
THE UNMADE BED, HIS WAND RAISED, HE DID NOT WANT TO LEAVE AWAY

FROM HER,

WHAT IS IT? HE ASKED AS HE REACHED THE DRESSING TABLE, WHICH WAS
HEAPED HIGH WITH WHAT LOOKED AND SMELLED LIKE DIRTY LAUNDRY.

THERE, SHE SAID, POINTING AT THE SHAPELESS MASS,

AND IN THE INSTANT THAT HE LOOKED AWAY, HIS EYES RAKING THE TAN-
GLED MESS FOR A SWORD HILT, A RUBY, SHE MOVED WEIRDLY: HE SAW IT HILT

OF THE CORNER OF HIS EYE; PANIC MADE HIM TURN AND FURTHER
PARALYZED

HIM AS HE SAW THE HILD BODY COLLAPSING AND THE GREAT SNAKE
PEELING

FROM THE PLACE WHERE HER NECK HAD BEEN,

THE SNAKE STRUCK AS HE RAISED HIS WAND: THE FORCE OF THE BITE THE
HIS THREARM SENT THE WAND SPINNING UP TOWARD THE CEILING; ITS
LIGHT

SWUNG DIZZILY AROUND THE ROOM AND WAS EXTINGUISHED: THEN A
PHEW! RUSH FROM THE TAIL THE HIS MIDRIF? DENIED THE BREATH HILT
OF HIM: HE FELL BACKWARD INTO THE DRESSING TABLE, INTO THE MOUND
OF FILTHY CLOTHING

HE ROLLED SIDELWAYS, NARROWLY AVOIDING THE SNAKE'S TAIL, WHICH
THRASHED BEHIND UPON THE TABLE WHERE HE HAD BEEN A SECOND EARLIER:
FRAGMENTS OF THE GLASS SURFACE RAINED UPON HIM AS HE HIT THE
FLOOR,

FROM BEHIND HE HEARD FERMINE CALL, JARRY?

HE COULD NOT GET ENOUGH BREATH INTO HIS LUNGS THE CALL BACK: THEN
A HEAVY SMOOTH MASS SMASHED HIM THE THE FLOOR AND HE FELT IT SLIDE
OVER HIM, PHEW! PHEW! PHEW!

AND HE GASPED, PINNED TO THE FLOOR.

YES, WHISPERED THE VOICE. PRESS . . . HOLD STILL . . . HOLD STILL . . .

RATEILDA'S SECRET

891

ACCE . . . ACCE WAND . . .

BUT NOTHING HAPPENED AND HE NEEDED HIS HANDS TO TRY TO PULL THE
SNAKE FROM HIM AS IT CHILED ITSELF AROUND HIS THROAT, SQUEEZING THE
AIR

FROM HIM, PRESSING THE FIERCELY HARD INTO HIS CHEST, A CIRCLE OF ICE
THAT TREMBLED WITH LIFE, INCHES FROM HIS BEATING FRANTIC HEART, AND HIS
BRAIN WAS FLASHING WITH CHILD, WHITE LIGHT, ALL THE LIGHT ILLUMINATED,
HIS BEATING BREATH BREATHED, DISTANT FOOTSTEPS, EVERYTHING GOING . . .

A METAL HEART WAS BEATING OUTSIDE HIS CHEST, AND NOW HE WAS FLY-
ING, FLYING WITH TRIUMPH IN HIS HEART, WITHOUT NEED OF BREASTSTICK

HER THESTRAL . . .

HE WAS ABRUPTLY AWAKE IN THE SILENT-SPELLING DARKNESS; NAGINI
HAD

RELEASED HIM. HE SCRAMBLED UP AND SAW THE SNAKE OUTLINED AGAINST
THE LANDING LIGHT: IT STRUCK, AND FERMINE DIVERGED ASIDE WITH A
SHRIEK;

HER DEFLECTED CLASH HIT THE CURTAINED WINDOW, WHICH SHATTERED, FREE-
ZEN AIR FILLED THE ROOM AS HARRY BLINKED THE AWKWARD ANOTHER SILENCE
OF

KREKEN GLASS AND HIS FEET SLIPPED ON A PENCIL-LIKE SOMETHING
HIS

WAND

HE KENT AND SNATCHED IT UP, BUT WHEN THE ROOM WAS FULL OF THE
SNAKE, ITS TAIL THRASHING; HERMIONE WAS NOWHERE TO BE SEEN AND
HER

A MOMENT HARRY REALIZED THE WORST, BUT THEN THERE WAS A LOUD
BANG

AND A FLASH OF RED LIGHT, AND THE SNAKE FLEW INTO THE AIR, SMACKING
HARRY HARD IN THE FACE AS IT WENT, THEN AFTER HEAVY THUD RISING UP
THE

THE CEILING. HARRY RAISED HIS WAND, BUT AS HE DID SEE HIS SCAR SEARED
MORE PAINFULLY, MORE POWERFULLY THAN IT HAD DONE IN YEARS.

HE SCREAMED! HERMIONE, HE SCREAMED!

AS HE FELT THE SNAKE FALL, HISsing WILDLY, EVERYTHING WAS CHAOS!

IT SMASHED AGAINST THE WALL, AND SPLINTERED CHINA FLEW EVERY-
WHERE AS HARRY LIMPED OVER THE RED AND SEIZED THE DARK SHAPE HE

KNOW THE HE HERMIONE

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

END

SHE SCRIEDED WITH PAIN AS HE PULLED HER BACK ACROSS THE RED; THE

SNAKE REARED AGAIN, BUT HARRY KNEW THAT WORSE THAN THE SNAKE
WAS

CHIMING, WAS PERHAPS ALREADY AT THE GATE, HIS HEAD WAS GOING THE
SPLIT

OPEN WITH THE PAIN FROM HIS SCAR

THE SNAKE LUNGED AS HE TOOK A RUNNING LEAP, DRAGGING HERMIONE
WITH HIM; AS IT STRUCK, HERMIONE SCREAMED, 'CHVRINGH!' AND HER
SPELL

WENT AROUND THE ROOM, EXPLODING THE WARDROBE MIRROR AND
RICHIE-RT-

ING BACK AT THEM, SHOOTING FROM ABOVE THE CEILING; HARRY FELT THE
HEAT

OF IT SEAR THE BACK OF HIS HAND, GLASS CUT HIS CHEEK AS, PULLING
HERMI-

ONE WITH HIM, HE LEAPT FROM BED THE BREDEN DRESSING TABLE AND THEN

STRAIGHT INTO THE SMASHED WINDOW INTO NOTHINGNESS, HER SCREAM
REVERBERATING THROUGH THE NIGHT AS THEY TWISTED IN MIDAIR, . . .

AND THEN HIS SCAR FIRST OPEN AND HE WAS VULNERABLE AND HE WAS
RUNNING ACROSS THE FETID BEDROOM, HIS LONG WHITE HANDS CLUTCHING
AT THE WINDOW SILL AS HE GLIMPSED THE OLD MAN AND THE LITTLE WOMAN
TWIST AND VANISH, AND HE SCREAMED WITH RAGE, A SCREAM THAT MINGLED
WITH THE GIRL'S, THAT ECHOED ACROSS THE DARK GARDENS OVER THE
CHURCH

BELLS RINGING IN CHRISTMAS DAY, . . .

AND HIS SCREAM WAS HARRY'S SCREAM, HIS PAIN WAS HARRY'S PAIN . . .
THAT IT COULD HAPPEN HERE, WHERE IT HAD HAPPENED BEFORE . . . HERE,

WITHIN SIGHT OF THAT HOUSE WHERE HE HAD COME SEE CLARE THE
KNOWING

WHAT IT WAS THE DIE . . . THE DIE . . . THE PAIN WAS SO TERRIBLE . . . RIPPED
FROM HIS BODY . . . BUT IF HE HAD NO BODY, WHY DID HIS HEAD HURT SO
BADLY? IF HE WAS DEAD, HOW COULD HE FEEL SO UNREPAIRABLY, DIDN'T PAIN
CEASE WITH DEATH, DIDN'T IT GO . . .

THE NIGHT WAS WET AND WINDY, TWO CHILDREN DRESSED AS PLIMPTONS WAD-
DLING ACROSS THE SQUARE, AND THE STIFF WINDMILLS COVERED IN PAPER
SPIDERS,

ALL THE TAWDRY MISCLE TRAPPINGS OF A WORLD IN WHICH THEY DID NOT
BELIEVE . . . AND HE WAS GLIDING ALONG, THAT SENSE OF PURPOSE AND
POWER

RATHILDA'S SECRET

RAR

AND RIGHTNESS IN HIM THAT HE ALWAYS KNEW WHEN THESE OCCASIONS . . .
WENT

ANGER . . . THAT WAS HER WEAKER SIDE THAN HE . . . BUT TRIUMPH, YES . . .
..

HE HAD WAITED FOR THIS, HE HAD HELPED HER IT . . .

NICE CLOTHING, MISTER?

HE SAW THE SMALL BODY'S SMILE FAULTER AS HE RAN NEAR ENOUGH TO SEE
RE-

NEATH THE HIND OF THE CHAIR, SAW THE FEAR CHILD HIS PAINTED FACE!
THEN

THE CHILD TURNED AND RAN AWAY, . . . BENEATH THE REE HE FINGERED THE
HANDLE OF HIS WAND, . . . ONE SIMPLE MOVEMENT AND THE CHILD WOULD
NEVER REACH HIS MOTHER, . . . BUT UNNECESSARY, WHITE UNNECESSARY, . . .

AND ALONG A NEW AND DARKER STREET HE MOVED, AND NOW HIS DESTINA-
TION WAS IN SIGHT AT LAST, THE FIDELIS CHARM BROKEN, THOUGH THEY
DID

HAD KNOWN IT YET, . . . AND HE MADE LESS NOISE THAN THE DEAD LEAVES
SLITH-

ERING ALONG THE PAVEMENT AS HE DREW LEVEL WITH THE DARK HEDGE,
AND

STARED OVER IT, . . .

THEY HAD NOT DRAWN THE CURTAINS; HE SAW THEM WHITE CLEARLY IN
THEIR

LITTLE SITTING ROOM, THE TALL BLACK-HAired MAN IN HIS GLASSES,
MAKING PLAYS

HE CHIEFED SMOKER ERUPT FROM HIS WAND FOR THE AMUSEMENT OF THE
SMALL

BLACK-HAired BOY IN HIS BLUE PYJAMAS, THE CHILD WAS LAUGHING AND
TRY-

ING TO CATCH THE SMOKE, TO GRAB IT IN HIS SMALL FIST, . . .

A DOOR OPENED AND THE MOTHER ENTERED, SAYING WORDS HE COULD NOT

HEAR, HER LONG DARK-RED HAIR FALLING OVER HER FACE, WHEN THE FATHER
STEEPED

LIFT THE SHIN AND HANDED HIM THE THE MEET-HER, HE THREW HIS WAND
DOWN

LIFTEN THE SHIN AND STRETCHED, YALNING, . . .

THE GATE CREAKED A LITTLE AS HE PUSHED IT OPEN, BUT JAMES POTTTER DID
NOT HEAR, HIS WHITE HAND PULLED OUT THE WAND BENEATH HIS CLOAK
AND

POINTED IT AT THE DOOR, WHICH BURST OPEN.

HE WAS OVER THE THRESHOLD AS JAMES CAME SPRINTING INTO THE HALL.
IT

WAS EASY, THEN EASY, HE HAD NOT EVEN PICKED UP HIS WAND, . . .

LILY, TAKE HARRY AND GO! IT'S HIM! GO! RUN! I'LL HOLD HIM OFF!

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

~~~~~

HELD HIM OFF, WITH ONLY A WAND IN HIS HAND! . . . HE LAUGHED BEFORE  
LASTING THE CURSE, . . .

AVADA KEDAVRA!

THE GREEN LIGHT FILLED THE CRAMPED HALLWAY, IT HIT THE FRAM PUSHED  
AGAINST THE WALL, IT MADE THE BANISTERS GLARE LIKE LIGHTNING BOLTS,  
AND

JAMES POTTTER FELL LIKE A MARIONETTE WHOSE STRINGS WERE CUT, . . .

HE COULD HEAR HER SCREAMING FROM THE UPPER FLOOR, TRAPPED, BUT  
AS LONG AS SHE WAS SENSIBLE, SHE, AT LEAST, HAD NOTHING TO FEAR, . . .  
HE

CLIMBED THE STEPS, LISTENING WITH FAINT AMUSEMENT THE HER ATTEMPTS  
THE

BARRICADE HERSELF IN. . . SHE HAD NO HAND UPON HER EITHER. . . SHE  
STUPID THEY WERE, AND SHE TRUSTING, THINKING THAT THEIR SAFETY  
LAY IN

FRIENDS, THAT WEAPONS COULD BE DISCARDED EVEN FOR MOMENTS. . .

SHE FORCED THE DOOR OPEN, CAST ASIDE THE CHAIR AND BOOKS HASTILY  
PILED

AGAINST IT WITH ONE LAZY WAVE OF HIS HAND . . . AND THERE SHE STOOD,  
THE

CHILD IN HER ARMS. AT THE SIGHT OF HIM, SHE DROPPED HER SEEN INTO  
THE CRIB

BEHIND HER AND THREW HER ARMS WIDE, AS IF THIS WOULD HELP, AS IF IN  
SHIELDING HIM FROM SIGHT SHE HOPED THE BE CHOSEN INSTEAD. . .

NEET HARRY, NEET HARRY, PLEASE NEET HARRY?

STAND ASIDE, WHY SILLY GIRL . . . STAND ASIDE, NEET.

NEET HARRY, PLEASE NEET, TAKE ME, KILL ME INSTEAD

THIS IS MY LAST WARNING

NEET HARRY? PLEASE . . . HAVE MERCY . . . HAVE MERCY. . . NEET HARRY?

NEET HARRY? PLEASE I LL DO ANYTHING

STAND ASIDE, STAND ASIDE, GIRL?

HE COULD HAVE FORCED HER AWAY FROM THE CRIB, BUT IT SEEMED MORE  
PRUDENT THE FINISH THEM ALL. . .

THE GREEN LIGHT FLASHED AROUND THE ROOM AND SHE DROPPED LIKE HER

HUSBAND. THE CHILD HAD NEET CRIED ALL THIS TIME: HE COULD STAND,  
CLUTCH-

ING THE BARS OF HIS CRIB, AND HE BURSTED UP INTO THE INTRUDER'S FACE  
WITH A

RATHILDA'S SECRET

RAT

KIND OF BRIGHT INTEREST, PERHAPS THINKING THAT IT WAS HIS FATHER  
WHEN HID

BENEATH THE CHAIR, MAKING MORE PRETTY LIGHTS, AND HIS MOTHER  
WHILE

PEEP UP AND MOMENT, LAUGHING

HE POINTED THE WAND VERY CAREFULLY INTO THE KING'S FACE! HE WANTED  
TO SEE IT HAPPEN, THE DESTRUCTION OF THIS KING, INEXPLICABLE DANGER,  
THE

CHILD BEGAN TO CRY: IT HAD SEEN THAT HE WAS NOT JAMES, HE DID NOT  
LIKE

IT CRYING, HE HAD NEVER BEEN ABLE TO STEAL THE SMALL KINGS  
WHINING IN

THE HOSPITAL

AVADA KEDAVRA!

AND THEN HE BREED: HE WAS NOTHING, NOTHING BUT PAIN AND TER-  
ROR, AND HE MUST HIDE HIMSELF, NOT HERE IN THE RICKLE OF THE BLIND

HOUSE, WHERE THE CHILD WAS TRAPPED AND SCREAMING, BUT FAR AWAY . . .

FAR AWAY, . . .

NO, HE MEANT,

THE SNAKE RUSTLED IN THE FILTHY, CLUTTERED FLOOR, AND HE HAD KILLED  
THE

KID, AND YET HE WAS THE KID, . . .

NIE . . .

AND NOW HE STOOD AT THE BROKEN WINDOW OF KATHILDA'S HOUSE, IM-  
MERSED IN MEMORIES OF HIS GREATEST LOSS, AND AT HIS FEET THE GREAT  
SNAKE

SLITHERED OVER BROKEN CHINA AND GLASS, . . . HE LOOKED DOWN AND SAW  
SOMETHING . . . SOMETHING INCREDIBLE, . . .

NIE . . .

HARRY, IT'S ALL RIGHT, YOU'RE ALL RIGHT!

HE STEPPED DOWN AND PICKED UP THE SMASHED PHOTOGRAPH. THERE  
HE

WAS, THE WINDMILL THIEF, THE THIEF HE WAS SEEKING, . . .

NIE . . . I DROPPED IT, . . . I DROPPED IT, . . .

HARRY, IT'S OKAY, WAKE UP, WAKE UP!

HE WAS HARRY, . . . HARRY, NOT VERBODEN . . . AND THE THING THAT  
WAS RUSTLING WAS NOT A SNAKE, . . . HE OPENED HIS EYES,

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

THE

HARRY, HERMIONE WHISPERED, DO YOU FEEL ALL      ALL RIGHT?

YES, HE LIED,

HE WAS IN THE TENT, LYING AWAY FROM THE LOWER BLINDS BENEATH A  
HAP



HE BLANKETS. HE COULD TELL THAT IT WAS ALMOST DAWN BY THE STILLNESS  
AND

THE QUALITY OF THE LIGHT, FLAT LIGHT BEYOND THE CANVAS CEILING. HE  
WAS

DRENCHED IN SWEAT; HE COULD FEEL IT EVEN THE SHEETS AND BLANKETS.

WE GET AWAY.

YES, SAID FERMINE. I HAD THE LIKE A FEVER CHARM THE GET WELL  
INTO YOUR BLIND, I COULDN'T LIFT WELL. WELL WE BEEN ... WELL, WELL  
HAVEN'T

BEEN WHITE ...

THERE WERE PURPLE SHADOWS UNDER HER BROWN EYES AND HE NOTICED  
A SMALL SPONGE IN HER HAND: SHE HAD BEEN WIPING HIS FACE.

WELL WE BEEN ILL, SHE FINISHED. WHITE ILL.

FEEL LONG AGO DID WE LEAVE?

FEELS AGO. IT'S NEARLY MORNING.

AND I WE BEEN ... WHAT, LINDENSHILLS?

NOT EXACTLY, SAID FERMINE UNCOMFORTABLY. WELL WE BEEN SHUT-  
TING AND MEANING AND ... THINGS, SHE ADDED IN A TONE THAT MADE

HARRY FEEL UNEASY. WHAT HAD HE DONE? SCREAMED CURSES LIKE CHILD-  
MURDER, CRIED LIKE THE BABY IN THE CRY?

I COULDN'T GET THE FURROW OF HIS WELL, FERMINE SAID, AND HE KNEW  
SHE WANTED THE CHANGE THE SUBJECT. IT WAS STUCK, STUCK THE OTHER  
CHEST.

WELL WE GOT A MARK; I'M SURE, I HAD THE LIKE A SEVERING CHARM THE  
GET

IT AWAY, THE SNAKE BIT YELL THEM, BUT I VE CLEANED THE WOUND AND PUT  
SOME DITTANY ON IT. . . .

HE PULLED THE SWEATY T-SHIRT HE WAS WEARING AWAY FROM HIMSELF  
AND LEEKED DOWN, THERE WAS A SCARLET HVAL OVER HIS HEART WHERE  
THE

WICKET HAD KLINED HIM, HE COULD ALSO SEE THE HALF-HEALED PUNCTURE  
MARKS ON HIS FOREARM.

RATHILDA S SECRET

RAY

WHERE VE YELL PUT THE BHERCLIX?

IN MY BAG, I THINK WE SHOULD KEEP IT OFF FOR A WHILE.

HE LAY BACK ON HIS PILLOWS AND LEEKED INTO HER PINCHED GRAY  
FACE.

WE SHOULDNT HAVE GIVEN THE GEDRIC S BHERCLIX, IT S MY FAULT, IT S ALL  
MY FAULT, HERMINE, I M SORRY.

IT S NOT YOUR FAULT, I WANTED THE GED THEM, I REALLY THOUGHT DUMBLE-  
DORE MIGHT HAVE LEFT THE SWORD THERE FOR YELL.

YEAH, WELL . . . WE GET THAT WRING, DIDN T WE?

WHAT HAPPENED, HARRY? WHAT HAPPENED WHEN SHE THREW YELL  
UPSTAIRS? WAS THE SNAKE HIDING SOMEWHERE? DID IT ILST COME OUT  
AND KILL HER AND ATTACK YELL?

NO, HE SAID, SHE WAS THE SNAKE . . . HER THE SNAKE WAS HER . . .  
ALL ALONE.

W-WHAT?

HE CLOSED HIS EYES, HE COULD STILL FEEL KATHILDA'S FINGER ON HIM;

IT MADE THE WHOLE THING TERRIBLY VIVID.

KATHILDA MUST'VE BEEN DEAD A WHILE. THE SNAKE WAS . . . WAS INSIDE HER. SHELL-DONNELL-WH-HE PUT IT THERE IN CEDRIC'S F-HALLS, THE WAIT.

SHE WAS RIGHT, HE KNEW I'D GO BACK.

THE SNAKE WAS INSIDE HER?

HE OPENED HIS EYES AGAIN: HERMIONE LOOKED REVELED,

REALISED.

LUPIN SAID THERE WOULD BE MAGIC WE'D NEVER IMAGINED, HARRY SAID. SHE DIDN'T WANT THE TALK IN FRONT OF SHELL, BECAUSE IT WAS PARSELTONGUE, ALL PARSELTONGUE, AND I DIDN'T REALIZE, BUT HE COULDN'T

UNDERSTAND HER. SINCE WE WERE UP IN THE ROOM, THE SNAKE SENT

A MESSAGE THE SHELL-DONNELL-WH-HE, I HEARD IT HAPPEN INSIDE MY HEAD, I FELT HIM GET EXCITED, HE SAID THE KEEP ME THERE . . . AND THEN . . .

## CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

R<sup>428</sup>

HE REMEMBERED THE SNAKE COMING BEHIND HER KATHILDA'S NECK: HERMIONE DIDN'T NEED THE KNOW THE DETAILS.

... SHE CHANGED, CHANGED INTO THE SNAKE, AND ATTACKED.  
HE LUNGED DOWN AT THE PUNCTURE MARKS.

IT WASN'T SUPPOSED THE BILL ME, JUST KEEP ME THERE TILL YELL-KNELL-  
WELL CAME.

IF HE HAD ONLY MANAGED THE BILL THE SNAKE, IT WOULD HAVE BEEN  
WORTH IT, ALL OF IT, ... SIDE AT HEART, HE SAT UP AND THREW BACK THE  
COVERS.

HARRY, NO, I'M SURE YELL WOULD GET THE REST!

YELL BE THE ONE WELL NEEDS SLEEP, NO OFFENSE, BUT YELL WOULD  
TERRIBLE.

I'M FINE, I'LL KEEP WATCH FOR A WHILE, WHERE'S MY WAND?

SHE DID NOT ANSWER, SHE MERELY LUNGED AT HIM.

WHERE'S MY WAND, HERMION?

SHE WAS BITING HER LIP, AND TEARS SWAM IN HER EYES.

HARRY ...

WHERE'S MY WAND?

SHE REACHED DOWN BESIDE THE BED AND FELD IT FELT THE HIM.

THE HILLY AND PHENIX WAND WAS NEARLY SEVERED IN TWO, ONE FRAG-  
ILE STRAND OF PHENIX FEATHER KEPT BOTH PIECES HANGING TOGETHER.  
THE

WAND HAD SPLINTERED APART COMPLETELY, HARRY THREW IT INTO HIS  
HANDS

AS THOUGH IT WAS A LIVING THING THAT HAD SUFFERED A TERRIBLE  
INJURY.

HE COULD NOT THINK PROPERLY! EVERYTHING WAS A BLUR OF PANIC AND FEAR. THEN HE HELD UP THE WAND THE HERMIONNE,

MEND IT, PLEASE.

HARRY, I DONT THINK, WHEN IT S BROKEN LIKE THIS

PLEASE, HERMIONNE, TRY?

R-REPAIR.

THE DANGLING HALF OF THE WAND RESEALD ITSELF. HARRY HELD IT UP.

BATHILDA S SECRET

END

LUMES?

THE WAND SPARKED FEELY, THEN WENT BLIT. HARRY POINTED IT AT HERMIONNE.

EXPPELLIARMLIS?

HERMIONNE S WAND GAVE A LITTLE JERK, BUT DID NOT LEAVE HER HAND.

THE FEELY ATTEMPT AT MAGIC WAS THEN MUCH FOR HARRY S WAND, WHICH SPLIT INTO TWO AGAIN. HE STARED AT IT, AGHAST, UNABLE TO TAKE IN WHAT

HE WAS SEEING . . . THE WAND THAT HAD SURVIVED SE MUCH . . .

HARRY, HERMIONNE WHISPERED SE QUIETLY HE COULD HARDLY HEAR HER.

I M SE, SE SHRY, I THINK IT WAS ME. AS WE WERE LEAVING, WELL KNOWN, THE SNAKE WAS CHING FOR US, AND SE I CAST A BLASTING CURSE, AND IT REEHLINED EVERYWHERE, AND IT MUST HAVE MUST HAVE HIT

IT WAS AN ACCIDENT, SAID HARRY MECHANICALLY. HE FELT EMPTY,

STUNNED, WE LL WE LL FIND A WAY TO REPAIR IT.

HARRY, I DONT THINK WE RE GOING TO BE ABLE TO, SAID HERMIONE,  
THE TEARS TRICKLING DOWN HER FACE. REMEMBER... REMEMBER WHEN  
WHEN HE BROKE HIS WAND, CRASHING THE CAR? IT WAS NEVER THE SAME  
AGAIN, HE HAD TO GET A NEW ONE.

HARRY THOUGHT OF HELLVANDER, KIDNAPPED AND HELD HOSTAGE BY  
VOLDERMORT; OF CROOKSHAW, WHO WAS DEAD. THEN WAS HE SUPPOSED  
TO FIND HIMSELF A NEW WAND?

WELL, HE SAID, IN A FAULTY MATTER-OF-FACT VOICE, WELL, I LL JUST  
KEEP ON TRYING FOR NOW, THEN, WHILE I KEEP WATCH.  
HER FACE GLAZED WITH TEARS, HERMIONE HANDED OVER HER WAND,  
AND HE LEFT HER SITTING BESIDE HIS BED, DESIRING NOTHING MORE THAN  
TO GET AWAY FROM HER.

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

END

THE LIFE AND LIES OF  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

THE SUN WAS COMING UP! THE PURE, ENDLESS VASTNESS OF THE  
SKY STRETCHED OVER HIM, INDIFFERENT TO HIM AND HIS SLIPPING.  
HARRY SAT DOWN IN THE TENT ENTRANCE AND TOOK A DEEP BREATH OF  
CLEAN  
AIR. SIMPLY TO BE ABLE TO WATCH THE SUN RISE OVER THE SPARKLING  
SNOW

HILLSIDE MIGHT THE HAVE BEEN THE GREATEST TREASURE ON EARTH, YET HE  
COULD NOT APPRECIATE IT: HIS SENSES HAD BEEN SPICED BY THE CALAMITY  
OF LOSING HIS WAND, HE HEARD BUT NEVER A VALLEY BLANKETED IN SNOW,  
DISTANT CHURCH BELLS CHIMING THROUGH THE GLITTERING SILENCE.

WITHOUT REALIZING IT, HE WAS DIGGING HIS FINGERS INTO HIS ARMS AS IF

HE WERE TRYING TO RESIST PHYSICAL PAIN, HE HAD SPILLED HIS BLOOD  
BLOOD

MORE TIMES THAN HE COULD COUNT; HE HAD LOST ALL THE BONES IN HIS  
RIGHT ARM BRACE; THIS INJURY HAD ALREADY GIVEN HIM SCARS TO HIS  
CHEST

AND THEREFORE THE WHOLE OF HIS HAND AND FOREHEAD, BUT NEVER,  
UNTIL

THIS MOMENT, HAD HE FELT HIMSELF TO BE FATALLY WEAKENED, VULNERABLE,  
AND NAKED, AS THOUGH THE BEST PART OF HIS MAGICAL POWER HAD BEEN  
TORN FROM HIM, HE KNEW EXACTLY WHAT HERMIONE WOULD SAY IF HE  
T

THE LIE AND LIES OF  
ALLS OLYMPIAN

RS1

EXPRESSED ANY OF THIS: THE WAND IS ONLY AS GOOD AS THE WIZARD, BUT  
SHE WAS WRONG, HIS CASE WAS DIFFERENT, SHE HAD NOT FELT THE WAND  
SPIN

LIKE THE NEEDLE OF A COMPASS AND SHEET GOLDEN FLAMES AT HIS ENEMY,

HE HAD LOST THE PROTECTION OF THE TWIN CHIEFS, AND ONLY NOW THAT IT

WAS GONE DID HE REALIZE HOW MUCH HE HAD BEEN COUNTING UPON IT.

HE PULLED THE PIECES OF THE BROKEN WAND OUT OF HIS POCKET AND, WITHOUT LOOKING AT THEM, THREW THEM AWAY IN JAGGED SHELLS

AROUND HIS NECK. THE SHELL WAS NOW THE FULL OF BROKEN AND USELESS FRAGMENTS THE TARD AND MORE. JARRY'S HAND GRABBED THE OLD SNITCH

THROUGH THE MEREKIN AND FOR A MOMENT HE HAD THE SIGHT THE TEMP-

TATION THE FULL IT OUT AND THREW IT AWAY. IMPENETRABLE, UNKINDLY,

USELESS, LIKE EVERYTHING ELSE DUMKEDDRE HAD LEFT BEHIND

AND HIS FLURY AT DUMKEDDRE BROKE OVER HIM NOW LIKE LAVA,

SEARCHING HIM INSIDE, WIPING OUT EVERY OTHER FEELING, OUT OF SIGHT

DESPERATION THEY HAD TAKEN THEMSELVES INTO BELIEVING THAT GERRIC'S

SHALLER HAD ANSWERS, CONVINCED THEMSELVES THAT THEY WERE SLIPPED

THE GO BACK, THAT IT WAS ALL PART OF SOME SECRET PATH LAD OUT FOR THEM

BY DUMKEDDRE; BUT THERE WAS NO MAP, NO PLAN. DUMKEDDRE HAD

LEFT THEM THE GROUP IN THE DARKNESS, THE WRESTLE WITH UNKNOWNS AND

UNDREAMED-OF TERRORS, ALONE AND UNAIDED: NOTHING WAS EXPLAINED,

NOTHING WAS GIVEN FREELY, THEY HAD NO SWORD, AND NOW, JARRY HAD

NO WAND, AND HE HAD DROPPED THE PHOTOGRAPH OF THE THREE, AND IT



WOULD SURELY BE EASY NOW FOR VERMONT THE FIND OUT WHO HE WAS. . .

,

VERMONT HAD ALL THE INFORMATION NOW. . .

HARRY?

HERMIONE LOOKED FRIGHTENED THAT HE MIGHT CLOSE HER WITH HER  
MAGIC WAND. HER FACE STREAKED WITH TEARS, SHE CRAWLED DOWN BESIDE  
HIM, TWO CUPS OF TEA TREMBLING IN HER HANDS AND SOMETHING BLOODY  
UNDER HER ARM.

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

ESP

THANKS, HE SAID, TAKING ONE OF THE CUPS.

DO YOU MIND IF I TAKE THE OTHER?

NO, HE SAID BECAUSE HE DID NOT WANT TO HURT HER FEELINGS.

HARRY, YOU WANTED TO KNOW WHO THAT MAN IN THE PICTURE WAS.

WELL. . . I'VE GOT THE ANSWER.

TIMIDLY SHE PLUSHED IT INTO HIS LAP, A PRISTINE COPY OF THE LIFE  
AND

LIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE.

WHERE WAS IT?

IT WAS IN RATHBURN'S SITTING ROOM, JUST LYING THERE. . . THIS NOTE  
WAS STICKING OUT OF THE TOP OF IT.

HERMIONE READ THE FEW LINES OF SPIDY, ACID-GREEN WRITING ALoud.

DEAR RATTY, THANKS FOR YOUR HELP. HERE'S A COPY OF THE ANSWER  
BOOK

YOU LIKE IT, YOU SAID EVERYTHING, EVEN IF YOU DON'T REMEMBER IT.  
RITA.

I THINK IT MUST HAVE ARRIVED WHILE THE REAL RATHILDA WAS ALIVE, BUT  
PERHAPS SHE WASN'T IN ANY FIT STATE TO READ IT?

NO, SHE PROBABLY WASN'T.

HARRY LEECHES DOWN UPON DUMBLEDORE'S FACE AND EXPERIENCED A  
SURGE OF SAVAGE PLEASURE! NOW HE WOULD KNOW ALL THE THINGS THAT

DUMBLEDORE HAD NEVER THOUGHT IT WORTH TELLING HIM, WHETHER DUM-  
BLEDORE WANTED HIM TO OR NOT.

YOU'RE STILL REALLY ANGRY AT ME, AREN'T YOU? SAID HERMIONA; HE  
LEECHES UP TO SEE FRESH TEARS LEAVING HOLE IN HER EYES, AND KNEW  
THAT

HIS ANGER MUST HAVE SHOWN IN HIS FACE.

NO, HE SAID QUIETLY. NO, HERMIONA, I KNOW IT WAS AN ACCIDENT.  
YOU WERE TRYING TO GET HIS HOLE IN THERE ALIVE, AND YOU WERE  
INCREDIBLE.

I'D BE DEAD IF YOU HADN'T BEEN THERE TO HELP ME.

HE TRIED TO RETURN HER WATERY SMILE, THEN TURNED HIS ATTENTION TO  
THE BOOK. ITS SPINE WAS STIFF; IT HAD CLEARLY NEVER BEEN OPENED  
BEFORE.

HE RIPPED THROUGH THE PAGES, LEAVING HER PHOTOGRAPHS. HE CAME

THE LIFE AND LIES OF  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

EEK

ACROSS THE HOLE HE THOUGHT ALMOST AT ONCE, THE YELING DUMBLEDORE

AND HIS HANDSOME COMPANION, REHARING WITH LAUGHTER AT SOME  
THING-

FORGOTTEN HERE, HARRY DROPPED HIS EYES TO THE CAPTION,

ALBUS DUMBLEDORE, SHORTLY AFTER HIS FATHER'S DEATH,  
WITH HIS FRIEND GELLERT GRINDELWALD.

HARRY GAZED AT THE LAST WORD FOR SEVERAL LONG MOMENTS, GRINDEL-  
WALD, HIS FRIEND GRINDELWALD, HE LOOKED SIDELWAYS AT HERMIONE,

WHEN WAS STILL CONTEMPLATING THE NAME AS THOUGH SHE COULD NOT  
RE-

LIVE HER EYES. SILENTLY SHE LOOKED UP AT HARRY,

GRINDELWALD?

IGNORING THE REMAINDER OF THE PHOTOGRAPHS, HARRY SEARCHED THE

PAGES AROUND THEM FOR A RECURRENCE OF THAT FATAL NAME, HE THEN  
DIS-

COVERED IT AND READ GREEDILY, BUT BECAME LOST: IT WAS NECESSARY TO GO

FLURTHER BACK TO MAKE SENSE OF IT ALL, AND EVENTUALLY HE FOUND  
HIMSELF

AT THE START OF A CHAPTER ENTITLED 'THE GREATER GOOD. TOGETHER,  
HE

AND HERMIONE STARTED TO READ:

WHEN APPROACHING HIS EIGHTEENTH BIRTHDAY, DUMBLEDORE LEFT

HOGWARTS IN A BLAZE OF GLORY HEAD KEEPER, PREFECT, WINNER  
 OF THE KARNARUS FINLEY PRIZE FOR EXCEPTIONAL SPELL-CASTING,  
 BRITISH YOUTH REPRESENTATIVE TO THE WIZENGAMBIT, GOLD MEDAL-  
 WINNER FOR GRIELING-BREAKING CONTRIBUTION TO THE INTERNATIONAL  
 ALCHEMICAL CONFERENCE IN CAIRO, DUMBLEDORE INTENDED, NEXT,  
 TO TAKE A GRAND TOUR WITH RUFIOUS DEGREATH DEER, THE  
 DIM-WITTED BUT DEVOTED SIDEKICK HE HAD PICKED UP AT SCHOOL.  
 THE TWO YOUNG MEN WERE STAYING AT THE LADY CALDERN IN  
 LONDON, PREPARING TO DEPART FOR GREECE THE FOLLOWING MORNING,  
 WHEN AN HELL ARRIVED BEARING NEWS OF DUMBLEDORE'S MOTHER'S

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

RS4

DEATH. DEGREATH DEER, WHO RECALLED THE HE INTERVIEWED FOR  
 THIS BOOK, HAS GIVEN THE PUBLIC HIS OWN SENTIMENTAL VERSION OF  
 WHAT HAPPENED NEXT. HE REPRESENTS DENDRA'S DEATH AS A TRAGIC  
 EVENT, AND DUMBLEDORE'S DECISION TO GIVE UP HIS EXPEDITION AS  
 AN ACT OF NERVOUS SELF-SACRIFICE.

CERTAINLY DUMBLEDORE RETURNED THE GHOST'S FELLOWSHIP AT ONCE,  
 SUPPOSEDLY TO CARE FOR HIS YOUNGER BROTHER AND SISTER, BUT  
 HOW MUCH CARE DID HE ACTUALLY GIVE THEM?

HE WERE A HEAD CASE, THAT APPARENTLY, SAYS END SPOKE,  
 WHOSE FAMILY LIVED IN THE BELTSHIRTS OF GHOST'S FELLOWSHIP AT THAT

TIME. RAN WILD, CHELSEA, WITH HIS MOM AND DAD GENE WOULD  
HAVE FELT SHAME FOR HIM, ONLY HE KEPT CHUCKING SHIT BLIND AT MY  
HEAD. I DIDN'T THINK ARLIS WAS FLISHED ABOUT HIM, I NEVER SAW  
THEM TOGETHER, ANYWAY.  
SEE WHAT WAS ARLIS DOING, IF NOT COMPARTING HIS WILD FEELING

KNOWLEDGE? THE ANSWER, IT SEEMS, IS ENSURING THE CONTINUED IM-  
PRISONMENT OF HIS SISTER, FOR, THOUGH HER FIRST JAILER HAD DIED,

THERE WAS NO CHANGE IN THE PITIFUL CONDITION OF ARIANA DUMBLE-  
DORE, HER VERY EXISTENCE CONTINUED TO BE KNOWN ONLY TO THESE

FEW ELITISTS WHO, LIKE DEGREATH DEER, COULD BE CHAINED  
UPON THE BELIEF IN THE STORY OF HER ILL HEALTH.

ANOTHER SUCH EASILY SATISFIED FRIEND OF THE FAMILY WAS  
RATHILDA BAGSHOT, THE CELEBRATED MAGICAL HISTORIAN WHO HAD  
LIVED IN GENDRI'S HOUSE FOR MANY YEARS. KENDRA, OF CHELSEA,  
HAD REJECTED RATHILDA WHEN SHE FIRST ATTEMPTED THE WELCOME THE  
FAMILY TO THE VILLAGE. SEVERAL YEARS LATER, HOWEVER, THE ALTHOR

SENT AN HILL TO ARLIS AT BEECHWARTS, HAVING BEEN FAVORABLY IM-  
PRESSED BY HIS PAPER ON TRANS-SPECIES TRANSFORMATION IN TRANS-  
FIGURATION TODAY. THIS INITIAL CONTACT LED THE ACQUAINTANCE WITH

THE LIFE AND LIES OF  
ARLIS DUMBLEDORE

KSS

THE ENTIRE DUMBLEDORE FAMILY. AT THE TIME OF KENDRA'S DEATH, KATHILDA WAS THE ONLY PERSON IN CEDRIC'S FAMILIAL LINE WHO WAS ON SPEAKING TERMS WITH DUMBLEDORE'S MOTHER.

UNFORTUNATELY, THE BRILLIANCE THAT KATHILDA EXHIBITED EARLIER IN HER LIFE HAS NOW DIMMED. THE FIRE'S LIT, BUT THE CALIBRENS'S EMPTY, AS IVER DILLHENSBY PUT IT THE ME, HER, IN KIND SPEECH'S

SLIGHTLY EARTHIER PHRASE, SHE'S SLUTTY AS SQUIRREL PHEE. NEVERTHELESS, A COMBINATION OF TRIED-AND-TESTED REPORTING TECHNIQUES

ENABLED ME TO EXTRACT ENOUGH NUANCES OF HARD FACT TO STRING TOGETHER THE LITTLE SCANDALOUS STORY.

LIKE THE REST OF THE WIZARDING WORLD, KATHILDA PUTS KENDRA'S PREMATURE DEATH DOWN TO A BACKFIRING CHARM, A STORY REPEATED BY AELIS AND ABERNETHY IN LATER YEARS. KATHILDA ALSO PARENTS THE FAMILY LINE WITH ARIANA, CALLING HER PRIL AND DELICATE. WITH ONE SLICKET, HOWEVER, KATHILDA IS WELL WORTH THE EFFORT I PUT INTO PRECLURING VERITASERUM, FOR SHE, AND SHE ALONE, KNOWS THE FULL STORY OF THE BEST-KEPT SECRET OF AELIS DUMBLEDORE'S LIFE. NOW REVEALED FOR THE FIRST TIME, IT CALLS INTO QUESTION EVERYTHING THAT HIS ADMIRERS BELIEVED OF DUMBLEDORE: HIS SUPPOSED HATRED OF THE DARK ARTS, HIS HYPOTHESIS OF THE HYPOTHESIS OF MUGGLES, EVEN HIS DEVOTION TO HIS OWN FAMILY.

THE VERY SAME SUMMER THAT DUMBLEDORE WENT HOME TO CEDRIC'S FAMILIAL, NOW AN ORPHAN AND HEAD OF THE FAMILY,

RATHILDA BAGSHOTT AGREED TO ACCEPT INTO HER HOME HER GREAT-NEPHEW, GELLERT GRINDELLWALD.

THE NAME OF GRINDELLWALD IS ILUSTLY FAMOUS: IN A LIST OF MOST DANGEROUS DARK WIZARDS OF ALL TIME, HE WOULD MISS OUT ON

THE TOP SPOT ONLY BECAUSE YELL-KNEEL-WHE ARRIVED, A GENERATION LATER, TO STEAL HIS CROWN, AS GRINDELLWALD NEVER EXTENDED

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

END

HIS CAMPAIGN OF TERROR THROUGH BRITAIN, HOWEVER, THE DETAILS OF HIS RISE TO POWER ARE NOT WIDELY KNOWN HERE.

EDUCATED AT DUMSTRANG, A SCHOOL FAMOUS EVEN THEN FOR ITS UNFORTHUNATE TOLERANCE OF THE DARK ARTS, GRINDELLWALD SHOWED HIMSELF ELITE AS PRECISELY AS BRILLIANT AS DUMBLEDORE. RATHER THAN CHANNEL HIS ABILITIES INTO THE ATTAINMENT OF AWARDS AND PRIZES, HOWEVER, GELLERT GRINDELLWALD DEVOTED HIMSELF TO OTHER PURSUITS. AT SIXTEEN YEARS OLD, EVEN DUMSTRANG FELT IT COULD NO LONGER TURN A BLIND EYE TO THE TWISTED EXPERIMENTS OF GELLERT GRINDELLWALD, AND HE WAS EXPELLED.

HERETOFOR, ALL THAT HAS BEEN KNOWN OF GRINDELLWALD'S NEXT MOVEMENTS IS THAT HE TRAVELED AHEAD FOR SOME MONTHS. IT CAN NOW BE REVEALED THAT GRINDELLWALD CHOSE TO VISIT HIS GREAT-UNCLE

IN GERRIK'S F-HELLHEN, AND THAT THERE, INTENSELY S-HOCKING T-HLLGH  
IT WILL BE FOR MANY THE HEAR IT, HE STRUCK UP A CLOSE FRIENDSHIP  
WITH NEENE EITHER THAN ARLIS DUMBLEDORE.

HE SEEMED A CHARMING KID THE MR. BARBLES KATHILDA,  
WHATEVER HE BECAME LATER. NATURALLY I INTRODUCED HIM THE OTHER  
ARLIS, WHO WAS MISSING THE COMPANY HE LADS HIS OWN AGE. THE  
KIDS THEM THE EACH EITHER AT HOME.

THEY CERTAINLY DID. KATHILDA SENDS ME A LETTER, KEPT BY HER,  
THAT ARLIS DUMBLEDORE SENT GILBERT GRINDLEWALD IN THE DEAD  
OF NIGHT.

YES, EVEN AFTER THEY'D SPENT ALL DAY IN DISCUSSION KEITH  
SUCH BRILLIANT YELING KIDS, THEY GHT HIM LIKE A CALIBREIN HIM  
FIRE I'D SOMETIMES HEAR AN HELL TAPPING AT GILBERT'S BEDROOM  
WINDOW, DELIVERING A LETTER FROM ARLIS? AN IDEA WOULD HAVE  
STRUCK HIM, AND HE HAD THE LET GILBERT KNOW IMMEDIATELY?  
AND WHAT IDEAS THEY WERE. PROFOUNDLY S-HOCKING T-HLLGH

THE LIP AND LIPS OF  
ARLIS DUMBLEDORE

END

ARLIS DUMBLEDORE'S FANS WILL FIND IT, HERE ARE THE T-HLLGH'S OF  
THEIR SEVENTEEN-YEAR-OLD HERO, AS RELATED THE HIS NEW BEST FRIEND.

(A COPY OF THE ORIGINAL LETTER MAY BE SEEN ON PAGE 422.)

GILBERT

WELLER POINT ABOUT LIZARD DOMINANCE BEING FOR



THE MUGGLES HAD GOTTEN THIS, I THINK, IS THE CRUCIAL POINT. YES, WE HAVE BEEN GIVEN POWER AND YES,

THAT POWER GIVES US THE RIGHT TO RULE, BUT IT ALSO GIVES US RESPONSIBILITIES OVER THE RULED. WE MUST STRESS THIS POINT, IT WILL BE THE FOUNDATION STONE UPON WHICH WE BUILD, WHERE WE ARE OPPOSED, AS WE SOON WILL BE, THIS MUST BE THE BASIS OF ALL OUR NEGOTIATIONS. WE SEIZE CONTROL FOR THE GREATER GOOD, AND FROM THIS IT FOLLOWS THAT WHERE WE MEET RESISTANCE, WE MUST USE ONLY THE FORCE THAT IS NECESSARY AND NO MORE. THIS WAS YOUR MISTAKE AT DUMSTRANG! BUT I DO NOT COMPLAIN, BECAUSE IF YOU HAD NOT BEEN EXPELLED, WE WOULD NEVER HAVE MET.

ALBUS

ASTONISHED AND APPALLED THOUGH HIS MANY ADMIRERS WILL BE, THIS LETTER CONSTITUTES PROOF THAT ALBUS DUMBLEDORE ONCE

DREAMED OF OVERTHROWING THE STATE OF SECRECY AND ESTABLISHING WIZARD RULE OVER MUGGLES. WHAT A BLIND FOR THESE WHO HAVE

ALWAYS PORTRAYED DUMBLEDORE AS THE MUGGLE-BORN'S GREATEST CHAMPION! HOW FOLLOWS THESE SPEECHES PROMOTING MUGGLE RIGHTS SEEN IN THE LIGHT OF THIS DAMNING NEW EVIDENCE? HOW DESPICABLE DOES ALBUS DUMBLEDORE APPEAR, ELUSIPLY PLETTING HIS

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

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RISE THE POWER WHEN HE SHOULD HAVE BEEN MELTING HIS MOTHER  
AND CARING FOR HIS SISTER?

NIE BELIEVE THESE DETERMINED THE DEEP DIMPLEDNESS IN HIS  
CRUMBLING PEDestal WILL BEAT THAT HE DID NOT, AFTER ALL, PUT  
HIS PLANS INTO ACTION, THAT HE MUST HAVE SUFFERED A CHANGE OF  
HEART, THAT HE LOST HIS SENSES, HOWEVER, THE TRUTH SEEMS  
TOGETHER MORE SHOCKING.

RARELY TWO MONTHS INTO THEIR GREAT NEW FRIENDSHIP, DIM-  
PLEDNESS AND GRINDLEWALL PARTED, NEVER TO SEE EACH OTHER AGAIN

UNTIL THEY MET FOR THEIR LEGENDARY DUEL (SEE MORE, SEE CHAPTER  
22). WHAT CAUSED THIS ABRUPT RUPTURE? HAD DIMPLEDNESS LOST  
HIS SENSES? HAD HE TOLD GRINDLEWALL HE WANTED NIE MORE PART  
IN HIS PLANS? ALAS, NIE.

IT WAS POOR LITTLE ARIANA DYING, I THINK, THAT DID IT, SAYS  
KATHILDA. IT CAME AS AN AWFUL SHOCK. GELLERT WAS THERE IN THE  
HALL WHEN IT HAPPENED, AND HE CAME BACK TO MY HALL ALL OF  
A SUDDEN, TOLD ME HE WANTED TO SEE NIE THE NEXT DAY. TERRIBLY  
DISTRESSED, VERY DOWN. SO I ARRANGED A PARTY AND THAT WAS  
THE LAST I SAW OF HIM.

ALAS WAS BESIDE HIMSELF AT ARIANA'S DEATH. IT WAS THE DREAD-

ALL FOR THESE TWO BROTHERS. THEY HAD LOST EVERYBODY EXCEPT

EACH OTHER. NEW WINDY TEMPER RAN A LITTLE HIGH. ABERNETHY

BLAMED ALKIS, WHO DIED, AS PEOPLE WILL UNDER THESE DREAD-

FUL CIRCUMSTANCES. BUT ABERNETHY ALWAYS TALKED A LITTLE MADLY,

WHEN HEY, ALL THE SAME, BREAKING ALKIS'S NEWS AT THE FUNERAL  
WAS NOT DECENT. IT WOULD HAVE DESTROYED KENDRA THE SEE HER SONS  
FIGHTING LIKE THAT, ACROSS HER DAUGHTER'S BODY. A STAGE GELBERT  
COULD NOT HAVE STAYED FOR THE FUNERAL. . . . HE WOULD HAVE BEEN  
A COMFORT TO ALKIS, AT LEAST. . . .

THE LIFE AND LIES OF  
ALKIS DUMBLEDORE

END

THIS DREADFUL CHIFFIN-SIDE BRAIN, DURING ONLY THE THESE FEW

WHEN ATTENDED ARIANA DUMBLEDORE'S FUNERAL, RAISES SEVERAL QUESTIONS. WHY EXACTLY DID ABERNETHY DUMBLEDORE BLAME ALKIS

FOR HIS SISTER'S DEATH? WAS IT, AS RATTY PRETENDS, A MERE PULL-  
STAIN OF GRIEF? OR COULD THERE HAVE BEEN SOME MORE CONCRETE

REASON FOR HIS FLIGHT? GRINDLEWALD, EXPELLED FROM DUMBLEDORE

HER NEAR-FATAL ATTACKS LIPHEEN FELLOW STUDENTS, FLED THE COUNTRY  
HOURS AFTER THE GIRL'S DEATH, AND ALKIS FELT HE SHAME HER FEAR?  
NEVER SAW HIM AGAIN, NOT UNTIL FORCED TO SEE HER BY THE PLEAS OF  
THE WIZARDING WORLD.

NEITHER DUMBLEDORE NOR GRINDELWALD EVER SEEMS TO HAVE

REFERRED TO THIS BRIEF BROTHERHOOD FRIENDSHIP IN LATER LIFE, HOW-  
EVER, THERE CAN BE NO DOUBT THAT DUMBLEDORE DELAYED, FOR

SOME FIVE YEARS OF TORMENT, FATALITIES, AND DISAPPEARANCES, HIS  
ATTACK LIPHEEN GILBERT GRINDELWALD. WAS IT LINGERING AFFECTION  
FOR THE MAN HER FEAR OF EXPOSURE AS HIS ONCE BEST FRIEND THAT  
CAUSED DUMBLEDORE TO HESITATE? WAS IT ONLY RELUCTANTLY THAT

DUMBLEDORE SET OUT TO CAPTURE THE MAN HE WAS ONCE SO DE-  
LIGHTED HE HAD MET?

AND HOW DID THE MYSTERIOUS ARIANA DIE? WAS SHE THE IN-  
ADVERTENT VICTIM OF SOME DARK RITE? DID SHE STUMBLE ACROSS

SOMETHING SHE SHOULD NOT HAVE SEEN, AS THE TWO YOUNG MEN  
SAT PRACTISING FOR THEIR ATTEMPT AT GLORY AND DOMINATION? IS IT  
POSSIBLE THAT ARIANA DUMBLEDORE WAS THE FIRST PERSON TO DIE  
FOR THE GREATER GOOD ?

THE CHAPTER ENDED HERE AND HARRY LEANED UP, HERMIONE HAD  
REACHED THE BOTTOM OF THE PAGE BEFORE HIM, SHE TOOK THE BOOK  
OUT OF HARRY'S HANDS, LEANING A LITTLE ALARMED BY HIS EXPRESSION,

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

XXX

AND CLESED IT WITH-HELT LEEDING AT IT, AS TEEHUGH HIDING SOMETHING  
INDECENT.

HARRY

BUT HE SH-HEED HIS HEAD, SOME INNER CERTAINTY HAD CRASHED DEEWN  
INSIDE HIM; IT WAS EXACTLY AS HE HAD FELT AFTER DEEN LEFT, HE HAD  
TRUSTED DUMBLEDORE, BELIEVED HIM THE EMBODIMENT OF GOODNESS  
AND WISDOM, ALL WAS ASHES! HOW MUCH MORE COULD HE LIESE? DEEN,  
DUMBLEDORE, THE PHOENIX LAND . . .

HARRY. SHE SEEMED TO HAVE HEARD HIS TEEHUGHTS. LISTEN TO ME,  
IT IT DEESN T MAKE VERY NICE READING

YES, SHE COULD SAY THAT

BUT DEEN T FORGET, HARRY, THIS IS RITA SKEETER WRITING.

SHE DID READ THAT LETTER TO GRINDLEWALD, DIDN T SHE?

YES, I I DID. SHE HESITATED, LEEDING LIPSET, CRADLING HER TEA  
IN HER CHILD HANDS. I THINK THAT S THE WORST BIT, I DEEN KATHILDA  
T-HEHUGHT IT WAS ALL ILST TALK, BUT FOR THE GREATER GOOD BECAME

GRINDLEWALD S SLEGAN, HIS ILSTIFICATION FOR ALL THE ATROCITIES HE  
HEM-

MITTED LATER, AND . . . FROM THAT . . . IT LEEDS LIKE DUMBLEDORE GAVE

HIM THE IDEA. THEY SAY FOR THE GREATER GOOD WAS EVEN CARVED  
EVER

THE ENTRANCE TO NIRMENGARD.

WHAT IS NIRMENGARD?

THE PRISON GRINDWALD HAD KNIT THE FIELD HIS OPPONENTS, HE

ENDED UP IN THERE HIMSELF, SINCE DUMBLEDORE HAD CAUGHT HIM. ANY-  
WAY, IT IS IT IS AN AWFUL THOUGHT THAT DUMBLEDORE'S IDEAS HELPED

GRINDWALD RISE THE POWER, BUT EVEN THE OTHER HAND, EVEN RITA CAN'T  
PRETEND THAT THEY KNOW EACH OTHER FOR MORE THAN A FEW MONTHS  
HENCE

SUMMER WHEN THEY WERE BOTH REALLY YOUNG, AND

I THOUGHT YOU'D SAY THAT, SAID HARRY, HE DID NOT WANT TO LET HIS  
ANGER SPILL OUT AT HER, BUT IT WAS HARD TO KEEP HIS VOICE STEADY. I

THE LIE AND LIES OF  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE

KK1

THOUGHT YOU'D SAY THEY WERE YOUNG. THEY WERE THE SAME AGE AS  
WE

ARE NOW, AND HERE WE ARE, RISKING OUR LIVES TO FIGHT THE DARK  
ARTS,

AND THERE HE WAS, IN A FLIBBLE WITH HIS NEW BEST FRIEND, PLETTING  
THEIR

RISE THE POWER OVER THE MUGGLES.

HIS TEMPER WOULD NOT REMAIN IN CHECK MUCH LONGER! HE STOOD UP AND WALKED AROUND, TRYING TO WORK SOME OF IT OFF,

I'M NOT TRYING TO DEFEND WHAT DUMBLEDORE WROTE, SAID HERMIONINE. ALL THAT RIGHT THE BLUE BOOKS, IT'S MAGIC IS MIGHT ALL OVER

AGAIN. BUT HARRY, HIS MOTHER HAD JUST DIED, HE WAS STUCK ALONE IN THE HOUSE

ALONE? HE WASN'T ALONE? HE HAD HIS BROTHER AND SISTER FOR COMPANY, HIS SEULIE SISTER HE WAS KEEPING LOCKED UP

I DON'T BELIEVE IT, SAID HERMIONINE. SHE STOOD UP THEN. WHATEVER

WAS GOING WITH THAT GIRL, I DON'T THINK SHE WAS A SEULIE. THE DUM-

DLEDORE WE KNOW WOULD NEVER, EVER HAVE ALLOWED

THE DUMBLEDORE WE THOUGHT WE KNOW DIDN'T WANT THE CHINESE MUGGLES BY FORCE? HARRY SHOUTED, HIS VOICE ECHOING ACROSS THE EMPTY HALLS, AND SEVERAL BLACKBIRDS ROSE INTO THE AIR, SWIRLING AND SPIRALING AGAINST THE PEARLY SKY.

HE CHANGED, HARRY, HE CHANGED? IT'S AS SIMPLE AS THAT? MAYBE HE DID BELIEVE THESE THINGS WHEN HE WAS SEVENTEEN, BUT THE WHILE OF THE

REST OF HIS LIFE WAS DEVOTED TO FIGHTING THE DARK ARTS? DUMBLEDORE

WAS THE ONE WHO STOPPED GRINDWALD, THE ONE WHO ALWAYS VOTED  
FOR

MUGGLE PROTECTION AND MUGGLE-BORN RIGHTS, WHO WOULD VOTE  
DOWN-

WHO FROM THE START, AND WHO DID TRYING TO BRING HIM DOWN?

RITA S EYES LAY ON THE GRINDWALD BETWEEN THEM, SHE THAT THE FACE OF  
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE SMILED DEEPLY AT HER.

HARRY, I'M SORRY, BUT I THINK THE REAL REASON WHY HE IS ANGRY IS  
THAT DUMBLEDORE NEVER TOLD YOU ANY OF THIS HIMSELF.

## CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

THE

MAYBE I AM? HARRY BELIEVED, AND HE FELLING HIS ARMS OVER HIS  
HEAD, HARDLY KNOWING WHETHER HE WAS TRYING TO HOLD IN HIS ANGER  
OR

PROTECT HIMSELF FROM THE WEIGHT OF HIS OWN DISILLUSIONMENT.  
THE

WHAT HE ASKED FROM ME, DETERMINED? RISK YOUR LIFE, HARRY? AND  
AGAIN? AND AGAIN? AND THEN I EXPECT ME TO EXPLAIN EVERYTHING,  
JUST

TRUST ME BLINDLY, TRUST THAT I KNOW WHAT I'M DOING, TRUST ME EVEN  
THOUGH I DON'T TRUST YOU? NEVER THE WHOLE TRUTH? NEVER?  
HIS VOICE CRACKED WITH THE STRAIN, AND THEY STOOD LOOKING AT EACH



EITHER IN THE WHITENESS AND THE EMPTINESS, AND HARRY FELT THEY WERE

AS INSIGNIFICANT AS INSECTS BENEATH THAT WIDE SKY.

HE LEVED WELL, HERMIONE WHISPERED. I KNOW HE LEVED WELL.  
HARRY DROPPED HIS ARMS.

I DON'T KNOW WHEN HE LEVED, HERMIONE, BUT IT WAS NEVER ME. THIS ISN'T LOVE, THE MESS HE'S LEFT ME IN. HE SHARED A DAMN SIGHT MORE OF WHAT HE WAS REALLY THINKING WITH GELLERT GRINDWALD THAN HE EVER SHARED WITH ME.

HARRY PICKED UP HERMIONE'S HAND, WHICH HE HAD DROPPED IN THE SNOW, AND SAT BACK DOWN IN THE ENTRANCE OF THE TENT.

THANKS FOR THE TEA. I'LL FINISH THE WATCH. WELL GET BACK IN THE WARM.

SHE HESITATED, BUT RECOGNIZED THE DISMISSAL. SHE PICKED UP THE BUNDLE AND THEN WALKED BACK PAST HIM INTO THE TENT, BUT AS SHE DID SEE, SHE BRUSHED THE TOP OF HIS HEAD LIGHTLY WITH HER HAND. HE CLOSED

HIS EYES AT HER TOUCH, AND HATED HIMSELF FOR WISHING THAT WHAT SHE SAID WAS TRUE: THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD REALLY CARED.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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### THE SILVER DEER

IT WAS SNOWING BY THE TIME HERMIONE THREW OVER THE WATCH

AT MIDNIGHT, HARRY'S DREAMS WERE CHENGLISHED AND DISTURBING:

NAGINI WHEVE IN AND HILT HF THEM, FIRST THROUGH A GIGANTIC, CRACKED

RING, THEN THROUGH A WREATH HF CHRISTMAS REESES. HE WHEKE REPEAT-  
EDLY, PANICKED, CHENVINCED THAT SHEPKEEDY HAD CALLED HILT THE HIM IN

THE DISTANCE, IMAGINING THAT THE WIND WHIPPING AROUND THE TENT  
WAS WHETSTEPS HF VEHICLES.

FINALLY HE GET UP IN THE DARKNESS AND WHINED HERMIENE, WHEE WAS  
HIDDEN IN THE ENTRANCE THE THE TENT READING A HISTORY HF MAGIC BY  
THE

LIGHT HF HER HAND. THE SNOW WAS STILL FALLING THICKLY, AND SHE  
GREETED

WITH RELIEF HIS SUGGESTIEN HF PACKING UP EARLY AND MOVING HF.

WE LL GO SOMEWHERE MORE SHELTERED, SHE AGREED, SHIVERING AS SHE  
PULLED HF A SWEATSHIRT OVER HER PALAMAS. I KEPT THINKING I CHULD  
HEAR PEOPLE MOVING HILTSIDE. I EVEN THOUGHT I SAW SHEPKEEDY HENCE  
HF TWICE.

I

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

REMY

HARRY PALSED IN THE ACT HF PULLING HF A ILIMPER AND GLANCED AT  
THE SILENT, MEETHEELESS SNEAKHSCHEPE HF THE TABLE.

I M SURE I IMAGINED IT, SAID HERMIENE, WHEDDING NERVEELIS. THE

SNOW IN THE DARK, IT PLAYS TRICKS ON YOUR EYES, . . . BUT PERHAPS WE  
MIGHT BE DISAPPEARING UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, JUST IN CASE?

A HALF AN HOUR LATER, WITH THE TENT PACKED, HARRY WEARING THE  
HIS-

COAT, AND HERMIONE CLUTCHING THE BEADED BAG, THEY DISAPPEARED.

THE USUAL TIGHTNESS ENVELOPED THEM; HARRY'S FEET PARTED COMPANY  
WITH THE SILENTLY CRUNCHING, THEN SLAMMED HARD ON THE LEAT FELT LIKE  
FROZEN EARTH COVERED WITH LEAVES.

WHERE ARE WE? HE ASKED, PEERING AROUND AT A FRESH MASS OF  
TREES AS HERMIONE OPENED THE BEADED BAG AND BEGAN TUGGING OUT  
TENT POLES.

THE FINEST OF DEAN, SHE SAID. I CAME CAMPING HERE ONCE WITH  
MY MOM AND DAD.

HERE THE SILENT LAY AMONG THE TREES ALL AROUND AND IT WAS BITTERLY COLD,  
BUT THEY WERE AT LEAST PROTECTED FROM THE WIND. THEY SPENT MOST  
OF THE DAY INSIDE THE TENT, FLOODED WITH WARMTH AROUND THE LITTLE  
BRIGHT BLUE FLAMES THAT HERMIONE WAS SO ADEPT AT FUELING, AND  
WHICH COULD BE SQUEEZED UP AND CARRIED AROUND IN A JAR. HARRY FELT  
AS THOUGH HE WAS RECOVERING FROM SOME KIND OF SEVERE ILLNESS,  
AND

IMPRESSION REINFORCED BY HERMIONE'S SILENTNESS. THAT  
AFTERNOON

FRESH FLAKES DRIFTED DOWN UPON THEM, SHE THAT EVEN THEIR SHELTERED  
CLEARING HAD A FRESH GLISTENING OF FINEST SNOW.

AFTER TWO NIGHTS OF LITTLE SLEEP, HARRY'S SENSES SEEMED MORE ALERT

THAN USUAL. THEIR ESCAPE FROM GEDRIK'S FOLLOWERS HAD BEEN SO  
NARROW

THAT VERDUGERT SEEMED SOMEHOW CLOSER THAN BEFORE, MORE  
THREATEN-

ING. AS DARKNESS DREW IN AGAIN HARRY REPLIED FIRMLY & OFFERED THE

KEEP WATCH AND TOLD HER THE GO THE BED.

THE SILVER DEER

WAS

HARRY MOVED AN OLD CUSHION INTO THE TENT MOUTH AND SAT DOWN,

WEARING ALL THE SWEATERS HE HADN'T PUT EVEN ON, STILL SHIVERING. THE  
DARK-

NESS DEEPENED WITH THE PASSING HOURS UNTIL IT WAS VIRTUALLY  
IMPEN-

ETRABLE. HE WAS ON THE POINT OF TAKING OUT THE MARAUDER'S MAP,  
SEE AS

THE WATCH GINN'S DEET FOR A WHILE, BEFORE HE REMEMBERED THAT IT WAS  
THE CHRISTMAS HOLIDAYS AND THAT SHE WOULD BE BACK AT THE BURROWS.

EVERY TINY MOVEMENT SEEMED MAGNIFIED IN THE VASTNESS OF THE

FOREST. HARRY KNEW THAT IT MUST BE FULL OF LIVING CREATURES, BUT HE

WISHED THEY WOULD ALL REMAIN STILL AND SILENT SO THAT HE COULD  
SEPA-

RATE THEIR INNOCENT SLURRYINGS AND PREELINGS FROM NOISES THAT  
MIGHT

PRECLAIM EITHER, SINISTER MOVEMENTS, HE REMEMBERED THE SOUND OF  
A CHIAS SLITHERING OVER DEAD LEAVES MANY YEARS AGO, AND AT ONCE  
THOUGHT HE HEARD IT AGAIN BEFORE MENTALLY SHAKING HIMSELF. THEIR  
PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS HAD WORKED FOR WEEKS; WHY SHOULD THEY

BEAR NOISE? AND YET HE COULD NOT THROW OFF THE FEELING THAT SOME-  
THING WAS DIFFERENT TONIGHT.

SEVERAL TIMES HE JERKED UPRIGHT, HIS NECK ACHING BECAUSE HE HAD  
FALLEN ASLEEP, SLUMPED AT AN ALKWARD ANGLE AGAINST THE SIDE OF THE  
TENT. THE NIGHT REACHED SUCH A DEPTH OF VELVETY BLACKNESS THAT HE  
MIGHT HAVE BEEN SUSPENDED IN LIMBO BETWEEN DISAPPEARITION AND  
APPARITION. HE HAD INST HELD UP A HAND IN FRONT OF HIS FACE TO SEE  
WHETHER HE COULD MAKE OUT HIS FINGERS WHEN IT HAPPENED.

A BRIGHT SILVER LIGHT APPEARED RIGHT AHEAD OF HIM, MOVING  
THROUGH

THE TREES. WHATEVER THE SOURCE, IT WAS MOVING SLENDRELESSLY. THE  
LIGHT

SEEMED SIMPLY TO DRIFT TOWARD HIM.

HE JUMPED ON HIS FEET, HIS VOICE FROZEN IN HIS THROAT, AND RAISED

HERMINE'S WAND. HE SCREWED UP HIS EYES AS THE LIGHT BECAME BLIND-  
ING, THE TREES IN FRONT OF IT PITCH-BLACK IN SILHOUETTE, AND STILL THE

THING CAME CLESER, . . .

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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AND THEN THE SOURCE OF THE LIGHT STEPPED OUT FROM BEHIND AN  
HEDGE. IT WAS A SILVER-WHITE DEER, MOTHER-BRIGHT AND DAZZLING, PICKING  
HER WAY OVER THE GRASSLAND, STILL SILENT, AND LEAVING NO FOOTPRINTS  
IN

THE FINE POWDERING OF SNOW. SHE STEPPED TOWARD HIM, HER BEAUTIFUL  
HEAD WITH ITS WIDE, LONG-LASHED EYES HELD HIGH.

HARRY STARED AT THE CREATURE, FILLED WITH WONDER, NOT AT HER  
STRANGENESS, BUT AT HER INEXPLICABLE FAMILIARITY. HE FELT THAT HE  
HAD

BEEN WAITING FOR HER THE LONG, BUT THAT HE HAD FORGOTTEN, UNTIL  
THIS

MOMENT, THAT THEY HAD ARRANGED THE MEET. HIS IMPULSE TO SEARCH FOR  
HERMINE, WHICH HAD BEEN SET STRONG A MOMENT AGO, HAD GONE. HE  
KNEW, HE WOULD HAVE STAKED HIS LIFE ON IT, THAT SHE HAD COME FOR  
HIM, AND HIM ALONE.

THEY GAZED AT EACH OTHER FOR SEVERAL LONG MOMENTS AND THEN SHE  
TURNED AND WALKED AWAY.

NEE, HE SAID, AND HIS VOICE WAS CRACKED WITH LACK OF USE. COME  
BACK!

SHE CONTINUED THE STEP DELIBERATELY THROUGH THE TREES, AND SEEN  
HER

BRIGHTNESS WAS STRIPED BY THEIR THICK BLACK TRUNKS. HER HIND  
TREMBLING

SECOND HE HESITATED, CALTHERN MURMURED IT COULD BE A TRICK, A LURE,  
A TRAP, BUT INSTINCT, OVERWHELMING INSTINCT, TOLD HIM THAT THIS  
WAS

NOT DARK MAGIC. HE SET OFF IN PURSUIT.

SNELLS CRUNCHING BENEATH HIS FEET, BUT THE DEER MADE NO NOISE AS  
SHE PASSED THROUGH THE TREES, FOR SHE WAS NOTHING BUT LIGHT,  
DEEPER

AND DEEPER INTO THE FOREST SHE LED HIM, AND HARRY WALKED BELICIOUSLY,  
SURE THAT WHEN SHE STOPPED, SHE WOULD ALLOW HIM TO APPROACH HER  
PROPERLY, AND THEN SHE WOULD SPEAK AND THE VOICE WOULD TELL HIM  
WHAT HE NEEDED TO KNOW.

AT LAST, SHE CAME TO A HALT. SHE TURNED HER BEAUTIFUL HEAD TOWARD

THE SILVER DEER

AND

HIM ONCE MORE, AND HE BROKE INTO A RUN, A BLISTERING RUNNING IN  
HIM,

BUT AS HE OPENED HIS LIPS TO ASK IT, SHE VANISHED.

THOUGH THE DARKNESS HAD SHALLOWED HER WHITE, HER BLURRIED  
IMAGE WAS STILL IMPRINTED ON HIS RETINAS; IT OBSCURED HIS VISION,  
BRIGHTENING WHEN HE WINKED HIS EYELIDS, DISORIENTING HIM. NOW  
FEAR CAME: HER PRESENCE HAD MEANT SAFETY.

FLAMES! HE WHISPERED, AND THE WAND-TIP IGNITED.

THE IMPRINT OF THE DEER FADED AWAY WITH EVERY BLINK OF HIS EYES AS

HE STOOD THERE, LISTENING TO THE SOUNDS OF THE FOREST, THE DISTANT  
CRACK-

LES OF TWIGS, SOFT SWISHES OF SNOW. WAS HE ABOUT TO BE ATTACKED?  
HAD

SHE ENTICED HIM INTO AN AMBUSH? WAS HE IMAGINING THAT SOMEONE  
STOOD BEYOND THE REACH OF THE WANDLIGHT, WATCHING HIM?

HE HELD THE WAND HIGHER. SOMEONE RAN HEAT AT HIM, A FLASH OF  
GREEN LIGHT BURST FROM BEHIND A TREE. WHY, THEN, HAD SHE LED HIM  
TO THIS SPOT?

SOMETHING GLEAMED IN THE LIGHT OF THE WAND, AND HARRY SPUN  
ABOUT, BUT ALL THAT WAS THERE WAS A SMALL, FROZEN POOL, ITS CRACKED  
BLACK SURFACE GLITTERING AS HE RAISED THE WAND HIGHER TO EXAMINE  
IT.

HE MOVED FORWARD RATHER CAUTIOUSLY AND LOOKED DOWN. THE ICE  
REFLECTED HIS DISTORTED SHADOW AND THE BEAM OF WANDLIGHT, BUT DEEP  
BELOW THE THICK, MISTY GRAY CANOPACE, SOMETHING ELSE GLINTED. A  
GREAT

SILVER CROSS . . .

HIS HEART SKIPPED INTO HIS MOUTH: HE DROPPED THE HIS KNIVES AT THE  
POOL'S EDGE AND ANGLED THE WAND SO AS TO FLARE THE BRIGHTNESS OF THE  
POOL WITH AS MUCH LIGHT AS POSSIBLE. A GLINT OF DEEP RED . . . IT WAS  
A

SWORD WITH GLITTERING BLADES IN ITS HILT. . . THE SWORD OF  
GRYFFINDOR

WAS LYING AT THE BRIGHTNESS OF THE FROSTY POOL.

BARELY BREATHING, HE STARED DOWN AT IT. HOW WAS THIS POSSIBLE?



## CHAPTER NINETEEN

\*\*\*

HOW COULD IT HAVE COME TO BE LYING IN A FOREST POOL, THIS CREEPY THE  
THE

PLACE WHERE THEY WERE CAMPING? HAD SOME UNKNOWN MAGIC DRAWN  
HERMIONE TO THIS SPOT, OR WAS THE DEER, WHICH HE HAD TAKEN TO BE A  
PATRONUS, SOME KIND OF GUARDIAN OF THE POOL? HE HAD THE SWORD  
BEEN

PLUT INTO THE POOL AFTER THEY HAD ARRIVED, PRECISELY BECAUSE THEY  
WERE

HERE? IN WHICH CASE, WHERE WAS THE PERSON WHO HAD WANTED THE  
PASS

IT TO HARRY? AGAIN HE DIRECTED THE WAND AT THE SURROUNDING TREES  
AND BUSHES, SEARCHING FOR A FLEET-FOOTED, FOR THE GLINT OF AN  
EYE,

BUT HE COULD NOT SEE ANYONE THERE. ALL THE SAME, A LITTLE MORE FEAR  
LESSENED HIS EXHILARATION AS HE RETURNED HIS ATTENTION TO THE  
SWORD

REPOSING UPON THE BENCH OF THE FROZEN POOL.

HE POINTED THE WAND AT THE SILVERY SHAPE AND MURMURED, ALL THE  
SWORD.

IT DID NOT STIR. HE HAD NOT EXPECTED IT TO. IF IT HAD BEEN THAT EASY,  
THE SWORD WOULD HAVE LAIN ON THE GROUND FOR HIM TO PICK UP, NOT  
IN THE DEPTHS OF A FROZEN POOL. HE SET OFF AROUND THE CIRCLE OF ICE,  
THINKING HARD ABOUT THE LAST TIME THE SWORD HAD DELIVERED ITSELF TO

HIM. HE HAD BEEN IN TERRIBLE DANGER THEN, AND HAD ASKED FOR HELP.

HELP, HE MURMURED, BUT THE SWORD REMAINED LUPEN THE POOL  
BETTER, INDIFFERENT, MENTHELESS.

WHAT WAS IT, HARRY ASKED HIMSELF (WALKING AGAIN), THAT DUMBLE-  
DORE HAD TOLD HIM THE LAST TIME HE HAD RETRIEVED THE SWORD? ONLY A

TRUE GRYFFINDOR CHILD HAD PLUCKED THAT HILT OF THE HAT, AND WHAT  
WERE THE

QUALITIES THAT DEFINED A GRYFFINDOR? A SMALL VOICE INSIDE HARRY'S  
HEAD

ANSWERED HIM: THEIR DARING, NERVE, AND CHIVALRY SET GRYFFINDORS  
APART.

HARRY STOPPED WALKING AND LET HILT A LONG SIGH, HIS SMOOXY BREATH  
DISPERSING RAPIDLY UPEN THE FREEZEN AIR. HE KNEW WHAT HE HAD THE  
DEE.

IF HE WAS HONEST WITH HIMSELF, HE HAD THOUGHT IT MIGHT COME THE  
THIS

FROM THE MOMENT HE HAD SPOTTED THE SWORD THROUGH THE ICE.

THE SILVER DEE

KEE

HE GLANCED AROUND AT THE SURROUNDING TREES AGAIN, BUT WAS CON-  
VINCED NOW THAT NOBODY WAS GOING TO ATTACK HIM. THEY HAD HAD  
THEIR

CHANCE AS HE WALKED ALONE THROUGH THE FOREST, HAD HAD PLenty OF OPPOR-

TUNITY AS HE EXAMINED THE POOL. THE ONLY REASON THE DELAY AT THIS POINT

WAS BECAUSE THE IMMEDIATE PROSPECT WAS SO DEEPLY UNINVITING.

WITH FUMBLING FINGERS HARRY STARTED TO REMOVE HIS MANY LAYERS OF CLoTHING. WHERE CHIVALRY ENTERED INTO THIS, HE THOUGHT RELUCTantly,

HE WAS NOT ENTIRELY SURE, UNLESS IT COUNTED AS CHIVALROUS THAT HE WAS

NOT CALLING FOR HERMIONE TO DO IT IN HIS STEAD.

AN EMBL EMBLED SOMEWHERE AS HE STRIPPED OFF, AND HE THOUGHT

WITH A PANG OF FRODING, HE WAS SHIVERING NOW, HIS TEETH CHATTERING FURIOUSLY, AND YET HE CONTINUED TO STRIP OFF UNTIL AT LAST HE STOOD

THERE IN HIS UNDERWEAR, EMBEZZLED IN THE SNOW. HE PLACED THE POOL

CONTAINING HIS WAND, HIS MOTHER'S LETTER, THE SWORD OF SIRILIS'S MIRROR,

AND THE OLD SNITCH AND THEN OF HIS CLoTHES, THEN HE POINTED HERMIONE'S

WAND AT THE ICE.

DISAPPEAR.

IT CRACKED WITH A SOUND LIKE A BULLET IN THE SILENCE! THE SURFACE

OF THE POOL BROKE AND CLoUDS OF DARK ICE RECKED AND THE RUFFLED WA-

TER, AS FAR AS HARRY COULD JUDGE, IT WAS NOT DEEP, BUT THE RETRIEVE  
THE

SWOON HE WOULD HAVE THE SWIMMER HIMSELF COMPLETELY.

CONTEMPLATING THE TASK AHEAD WOULD NOT MAKE IT EASIER FOR THE  
WATER WARMER, HE STEPPED THE THE POOL'S EDGE AND PLACED  
TERMINING S

WAND FOR THE GRILLING, STILL HOT, THEN, TRYING NOT TO IMAGINE HOW  
MUCH

CHILDER HE WAS ABOUT THE RECTOR FOR FEEL VIOLENTLY HE WOULD SHED BE  
SHIVERING, HE LIMPED.

EVERY PORE OF HIS BODY SCREAMED IN PROTEST! THE VERY AIR IN HIS  
LUNGS SEEMED TO FREEZE WHILE AS HE WAS SWIMMERED THE HIS SHOULDERS  
IN THE FROZEN WATER, HE COULD HARDLY BREATHE; TREMBLING BE  
VIOLENTLY

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

END

THE WATER LAPPED OVER THE EDGES OF THE POOL, HE FELT FOR THE BLADE  
WITH

HIS NINE FEET, HE ONLY WANTED THE DIVE HENCE.

HARRY PLUT OFF THE MOMENT OF TOTAL SWIMMERED FROM SECOND THE  
SECOND, GASPING AND SHAKING, UNTIL HE TOLD HIMSELF THAT IT MUST BE  
DONE, GATHERED ALL HIS COURAGE, AND DIVER.

THE CHILD WAS AGONY! IT ATTACKED HIM LIKE FIRE, HIS BRAIN ITSELF

SEEMED TO HAVE FROZEN AS HE PUSHED THROUGH THE DARK WATER THE  
THE

BETTER AND REACHED HILT, GRIPPING AROUND THE SCABRD. HIS FINGERS CLOSED  
AROUND THE HILT; HE PULLED IT UPWARD.

THEN SOMETHING CLOSED TIGHT AROUND HIS NECK. HE THOUGHT OF WA-  
TER WEEDS, THOUGH NOTHING HAD GRASPED HIM AS HE DIVED, AND RAISED

HIS EMPTY HAND TO FREE HIMSELF. IT WAS NOT WEED! THE CHAIN OF THE  
SKELETON HAD TIGHTENED AND WAS SLOWLY CONSTRICTING HIS WINDPIPE.

HARRY KICKED HILT WILDLY, TRYING TO PUSH HIMSELF BACK TO THE SUR-  
FACE, BUT MERELY PROPELLED HIMSELF INTO THE RECKLESS SIDE OF THE POND.

THRASHING, SUFFOCATING, HE STRUGGLED AT THE STRANGLING CHAIN, HIS

FROZEN FINGERS UNABLE TO LOOSEN IT, AND WHEN LITTLE LIGHTS WERE PEEP-  
ING INSIDE HIS HEAD, AND HE WAS GOING TO DROWN, THERE WAS  
NOTHING

LEFT, NOTHING HE COULD DO, AND THE ARMS THAT CLOSED AROUND HIS  
CHEST

WERE SURELY DEATH'S . . .

CHOKING AND RETCHING, SHAKING AND COLDER THAN HE HAD EVER BEEN  
IN HIS LIFE, HE CAME TO FACEDOWN IN THE SNEL. SOMEWHERE CLOSE BY,  
ANOTHER PERSON WAS PANTING AND CHUCKLING AND STAGGERING  
AROUND.

HERMIONNE HAD COME AGAIN, AS SHE HAD COME WHEN THE SNAKE ATTACKED, . . . Yet it did not shield like her, not with these deep curls,

not bulging by the weight of the footsteps, . . .

HARRY HAD NO STRENGTH TO LIFT HIS HEAD AND SEE HIS Saviour's IDENTITY,

ALL HE COULD DO WAS RAISE A SHAKING HAND TO HIS THROAT AND FEEL THE

PLACE WHERE THE LOCKET HAD CLUT TIGHTLY INTO HIS FLESH. IT WAS GONE!

THE SILVER DEER

BY

SHERMONE HAD CLUT HIM FREE, THEN A PANTING VEHICLE SPEEDED FROM OVER HIS HEAD,

ARE YOU MENTAL?

NOTHING CLUT THE SENSE OF HEARING THAT VEHICLE COULD HAVE GIVEN HARRY THE STRENGTH TO GET UP. SHIVERING VIOLENTLY, HE STAGGERED THE

HIS FEET. THERE BEFORE HIM STOOD RON, FULLY DRESSED BUT DRENCHED TO THE SKIN, HIS HAIR PLASTERED TO HIS FACE, THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER IN ONE HAND AND THE FIERCELY DANGLING FROM ITS BROKEN CHAIN IN THE OTHER,

WHY THE HELL, PANTED RON, HOLDING UP THE FIERCELY, WHICH SWUNG BACKWARD AND FORWARD IN ITS SHORTENED CHAIN IN SOME PARADOX

HE HYPNOSIS, DIDN'T YELL TAKE THIS THING OFF BEFORE YELL DIED?  
HARRY COULD NOT ANSWER. THE SILVER DEER WAS NOTHING, NOTHING

COMPARED WITH RICH'S REAPPEARANCE; HE COULD NOT BELIEVE IT. STUN-  
DERING WITH CHLOE, HE CALLED UP THE PILE OF CLOTHES STILL LYING AT  
THE

WATER'S EDGE AND BEGAN TO PULL THEM OFF. AS HE DRAGGED SWEATER  
AFTER

SWEATER OVER HIS HEAD, HARRY STARED AT RICH, HALF EXPECTING HIM TO  
HAVE DISAPPEARED EVERY TIME HE LOST SIGHT OF HIM, AND YET HE HAD THE  
BE REAL: HE HAD JUST DIED INTO THE POND, HE HAD SAVED HARRY'S LIFE.

IT WAS Y-YELL? HARRY SAID AT LAST, HIS TEETH CHATTERING, HIS VOICE  
WEAKER THAN USUAL DUE TO HIS NEAR-STRANGULATION.

WELL, YEAH, SAID RICH, BLENDING SLIGHTLY CONFUSED.

Y-YELL LAST THAT DEER?

WHAT? NO, HE CHIRPED NOT; I THOUGHT IT WAS YELL DOING IT?

MY PATRONS IS A STAG.

OH YEAH, I THOUGHT IT LOOKED DIFFERENT, NO ANTLERS.

HARRY PUT HARRY'S PINK RACK AROUND HIS NECK, PULLED ON A  
FINAL SWEATER, STEPPED TO PICK UP HERMINE'S WAND, AND FACED RICH  
AGAIN.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

BYE

YELL COME YELL BE HERE?

APPARENTLY REIN HAD HOPED THAT THIS POINT WOULD COME UP LATER, IF AT ALL.

WELL, I'VE YELL DONEW I'VE COME BACK, IF HE CLEARED HIS THROAT, YELL DONEW, YELL STILL WANT ME.

THERE WAS A PALISE, IN WHICH THE SUBJECT OF REIN'S DEPARTURE SEEMED THE RISE LIKE A WALL BETWEEN THEM, YET HE WAS HERE, HE HAD RETURNED, HE HAD JUST SAVED HARRY'S LIFE.

REIN LOOKED DOWN AT HIS HANDS, HE SEEMED MOMENTARILY SURPRISED TO SEE THE THINGS HE WAS HOLDING.

HEY YEAH, I GOT IT EMT, HE SAID, RATHER UNNECESSARILY, HOLDING UP THE SWORD FOR HARRY'S INSPECTION. THAT'S WHY YELL LUMPED IN, RIGHT?

YEAH, SAID HARRY, BUT I DIDN'T UNDERSTAND, HEEL DID YELL GET HERE? HEEL DID YELL FIND US?

LONG STORY, SAID REIN, I'VE BEEN LOOKING FOR YELL FOR FEELS, IT'S A BIG FEELST, EN'T IT? AND I WAS JUST THINKING I'D HAVE THE KIP UNDER A

TREE AND WAIT FOR MORNING WHEN I SAW THAT DEER CHIMING AND YELL FELLINGING.

YELL DIDN'T SEE ANYONE ELSE?

NEH, SAID REIN, I

BUT HE HESITATED, GLANCING AT THE TREES GROWING CLOSE TOGETHER SOME YARDS AWAY.

I DID THINK I SAW SOMETHING MOVE OVER THERE, BUT I WAS RUNNING THE THE PHEE AT THE TIME, BECAUSE YELL'D GONE IN AND YELL HADN'T COME UP, SEE I WASN'T GOING TO MAKE A DETAILER THE HEY?

HARRY WAS ALREADY HURRYING THE THE PLACE REIN HAD INDICATED. THE



TWO HANDS GREW CLOSE TOGETHER; THERE WAS A GAP OF ONLY A FEW INCHES

BETWEEN THE TRUNKS AT EYE LEVEL, AN IDEAL PLACE THE SEE BLIT NEET BE SEEN.

THE SILVER DEER

FOR

THE GRIND AROUND THE REETS, HOWEVER, WAS FREE OF SNOW, AND HARRY

COULD SEE NO SIGN OF FOOTPRINTS. HE WALKED BACK TO WHERE REIN STOOD

WAITING, STILL HOLDING THE SWORD AND THE HERCULES.

ANYTHING THERE? REIN ASKED.

NO, SAID HARRY.

SEE HOW DID THE SWORD GET IN THAT POOL?

WHETHER LAST THE PATRONS MUST HAVE PUT IT THERE.

THEY BOTH LOOKED AT THE ORNATE SILVER SWORD, ITS POLISHED HILT GLINTING A LITTLE IN THE LIGHT FROM HERMINE'S HAND.

WELL RECOGNIZE THIS IS THE REAL ONE? ASKED REIN.

HERE WAS THE FIND BLIT, ISN'T THERE? SAID HARRY.

THE HERCULES WAS STILL SLINGING FROM REIN'S HAND. THE WECKET WAS TWITCHING SLIGHTLY. HARRY KNEW THAT THE THING INSIDE IT WAS AGITATED AGAIN. IT HAD SENSED THE PRESENCE OF THE SWORD AND HAD TRIED TO KILL HARRY RATHER THAN LET HIM POSSESS IT. NOW WAS NOT

THE TIME HER LONG DISCUSSIONS; NOW WAS THE MOMENT HE DESTROYED THE  
MURDER HERE AND FOR ALL. HARRY LEANED AROUND, HOLDING HERMIONE'S  
WAND HIGH, AND SAW THE PLACE: A FLATTISH REED LYING IN THE SHADE  
OF A SYCAMORE TREE.

COME HERE, HE SAID, AND HE LED THE WAY, BRUSHED SNOW FROM THE  
REED'S SURFACE, AND HELD OUT HIS HAND FOR THE HERCULEAN. WHEN RON  
HOPPED THE SWORD, HOWEVER, HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD.

NO, YOU SHOULD DO IT.

ME? SAID RON, LOOKING SHOCKED. WHY?

BECAUSE YOU GOT THE SWORD OUT OF THE POOL. I THINK IT'S SLIPPED  
THE RE YOU.

HE WAS NOT BEING KIND OR GENEROUS. AS CERTAINLY AS HE HAD KNOWN  
THAT THE DEE WAS BENIGN, HE KNEW THAT RON HAD THE RE THE END THE  
WIELD THE SWORD. SOMEWHERE HAD AT LEAST TAUGHT HARRY SOMETHING

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

RM

ABOUT CERTAIN KINDS OF MAGIC, OF THE INCALCULABLE POWER OF CERTAIN  
ACTS.

I'M GOING TO OPEN IT, SAID HARRY, AND YOU STAY IT,  
STRAIGHTAWAY.

HOW? BECAUSE WHATEVER'S IN THERE WILL PUT UP A FIGHT. THE KIT OF  
RIDDLE IN THE DIARY TRIED TO KILL ME.

YOU ARE YOU GOING TO OPEN IT? ASKED RON, HE LEANED TERRIFIED,

I M GOING TO ASK IT THE MPMEN, LISTING PARSELTUNGLE, SAID HARRY,  
THE

ANSWER CAME SHE READILY THE HIS LIPS THAT HE TRILLIGHT THAT HE HAD  
ALWAYS

KNOWEN IT DEEP DOWN: PERHAPS IT HAD TAKEN HIS RECENT ENCOUNTER  
WITH

MACINI THE MADE HIM REALIZE IT, HE WHISKED AT THE SERPENTINE S,  
INLAD

WITH GLITTERING GREEN STONES: IT WAS EASY THE VISUALIZE IT AS A  
MINUSCLE

SNAKE, CUNLED WPMEN THE CHILD RECK,

NEE? SAID REIN, NEE, DEEN T MPMEN IT? I M SERIEHLIS?

WHY NEE? ASKED HARRY, LET S GET RID OF THE DAMN THING, IT S  
KEEN MPMENIS

I CAN T, HARRY, I M SERIEHLIS YELL DEE IT

BLIT WHY?

BECAUSE THAT THING S BAD FOR ME? SAID REIN, BACKING AWAY FROM  
THE WHISKET MEN THE RECK, I CAN T HANDLE IT? I M NEE MAKING EXCLISES,  
HARRY, FOR WHAT I WAS LIKE, BLIT IT AFFECTS ME WHERSE THAN IT AFFECTED  
YELL AND HERMIONE, IT MADE ME THINK STUFF STUFF I WAS THINKING  
ANYWAY, BLIT IT MADE EVERYTHING WHERSE, I CAN T EXPLAIN IT, AND THEN  
I D TAKE IT OFF AND I D GET MY HEAD MEN STRAIGHT AGAIN, AND THEN I D  
HAVE THE PLIT THE EPPING THING BACK MEN I CAN T DEE IT, HARRY?  
HE HAD BACKED AWAY, THE SWORD DRAGGING AT HIS SIDE, SHAKING HIS  
HEAD,

YELL CAN DEE IT, SAID HARRY, YELL CAN? YELL VE ILIST GET THE SWORD,  
I KNOW IT S SLIPPHESD THE RE YELL WHEH LIVES IT, PLEASE, ILIST GET RID OF  
IT, REIN,

## THE SILVER DEER

KYS

THE SOUND OF HIS NAME SEEMED TO ACT LIKE A STIMULANT. JOHN SWALLOWED, THEN, STILL BREATHING HARD THROUGH HIS LONG NOSE, MOVED BACK

TOWARD THE REED.

TELL ME WHEN, HE CREAMED.

END THREE, SAID HARRY, LEANING BACK DOWN AT THE LOCKET AND NARROWING HIS EYES, CONCENTRATING ON THE LETTER S, IMAGINING A SERPENT,

WHILE THE CONTENTS OF THE LOCKET RATTLED LIKE A TRAPPED CHECKMATE. IT

WOULD HAVE BEEN EASY TO PITY IT, EXCEPT THAT THE CLUT AROUND HARRY'S

NECK STILL BURNED.

ONE ... TWO ... THREE ... OPEN.

THE LAST WORD CAME AS A HISS AND A SNARL AND THE GILDED DEERS OF THE LOCKET SWUNG WIDE WITH A LITTLE CLICK.

BEHIND EACH OF THE GLASS WINDOWS WITHIN GLIMMERED A LIVING EYE, DARK AND HANDSOME AS THEM RIDDLE'S EYES HAD BEEN BEFORE HE TURNED THEM SCARLET AND SLIT-PUPILED.

STAR, SAID HARRY, HOLDING THE LOCKET STEADY IN THE REED.

RON RAISED THE SWORD IN HIS SHAKING HANDS! THE POINT DANCED  
OVER THE FRANTICALLY SWIVELING EYES, AND HARRY GRIPPED THE HILT  
TIGHTLY, BRACING HIMSELF, ALREADY IMAGINING BLEED POURING FROM THE  
EMPTY WOUNDS.

THEN A VOICE HISSED FROM HILT OF THE SWORD.

I HAVE SEEN YOUR HEART, AND IT IS MINE.

DON'T LISTEN TO IT! HARRY SAID HARSHLY. STAB IT!

I HAVE SEEN YOUR DREAMS, RONALD WEASLEY, AND I HAVE SEEN YOUR  
FEARS.

ALL YOU DESIRE IS POSSIBLE, BUT ALL THAT YOU DREAD IS ALSO POSSIBLE. . .

,

STAB! SCREAMED HARRY; HIS VOICE ECHOED OFF THE SURROUNDING  
TREES, THE SWORD POINT TREMBLED, AND RON GAZED DOWN INTO RIDDLE'S  
EYES.

LEAST LIVED, ALWAYS, BY THE MOTHER WHO CRAVED A DAUGHTER . . .  
LEAST

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

THE

LIVED, NEAR, BY THE GIRL WHO PREFERS YOUR FRIEND . . . SECOND BEST,  
ALWAYS,

ETERNALLY EVERSHADENED . . .

RON, STAB IT NOW! HARRY BELLEWED! HE COULD FEEL THE HILT  
SLIDDERING IN HIS GRIP AND WAS STARTED BY WHAT WAS CHIMING. RON  
RAISED THE SWORD STILL HIGHER, AND AS HE DID SO, RIDDLE'S EYES GLEAMED  
SCARLET.

HELT UP THE WICKET & THE WINDMILLS, HELT UP THE EYES, THERE BLENDED,  
LIKE TWO GREATESTLY BLISSFUL, THE HEADS OF FARRY AND FERMINE,  
WINDY DISTORTED.

THEY WERE IN SHOCK AND RAN AWAY AS THE FIGURES BLENDED HELT  
UP THE WICKET, FIRST CHESTS, THEN WAISTS, THEN LEGS, UNTIL THEY STOOD  
IN

THE WICKET, SIDE BY SIDE LIKE TREES WITH A CERTAIN RHYTHM, SWAYING  
EVER

THEY AND THE REAL FARRY, WHO HAD SNATCHED HIS FINGERS AWAY FROM  
THE WICKET AS IT TURNED, SUDDENLY, WHITE-FEET.

THEY: HE SMILED, BUT THE RIDDLE-FARRY WAS NOW SPREADING WITH  
VILDEBERT & VILDE AND THEY WAS GAZING, MESMERIZED, INTO ITS FACE.

WE RETURN? WE WERE BETTER WITH-OUT YOU, HAPPIER WITH-OUT YOU,  
GLAD OF YOUR ABSENCE. . . . WE LAUGHED AT YOUR STUPIDITY, YOUR  
CHLARDICE,

YOUR PRESUMPTION

PRESUMPTION? KNEW THE RIDDLE-FERMINE, WHO WAS MORE  
BEAUTIFUL AND YET MORE TERRIBLE THAN THE REAL FERMINE: SHE  
SWAYED,

LAUGHING, BEFORE THEY, WHO WERE HORRIFIED YET TRANSFIXED, THE  
SWAYED

HANGING PHANTOM-LIKE AT HIS SIDE. WHO COULD LOOK AT YOU, WHO  
COULD

EVER LOOK AT YOU, BESIDE FARRY BETTER? WHAT HAVE YOU EVER DONE,  
HE-

PAID WITH THE CHESSEBERRY? WHAT ARE YOU, COMPARED WITH THE KEY

WHO LIVED?

DEEN, STAR IT, STAR IT! HARRY YELLED, BUT DEEN DID NOT MOVE!  
HIS EYES WERE WIDE, AND THE RIDDLE-HARRY AND THE RIDDLE-HERMIONE

THE SILVER DEER

BY

WERE REFLECTED IN THEM, THEIR HAIR SWIRLING LIKE FLAMES, THEIR EYES  
SHINING RED, THEIR VEHICLES LIFTED IN AN EVIL BLITZ.

THEIR MOUTHS CHUCKLED, SNEERED RIDDLE-HARRY, WHILE RIDDLE-  
HERMIONE REERED, THAT SHE WOULD HAVE PREFERRED ME AS A SON,  
WOULD

BE GLAD THE EXCHANGE . . .

WHEN WOULD I PREFER HIM, WHAT WOMAN WOULD TAKE ME, ME ARE  
NOTHING, NOTHING, NOTHING THE HIM, CRIEDED RIDDLE-HERMIONE, AND

SHE STRETCHED LIKE A SNAKE AND ENTWINED HERSELF AROUND RIDDLE-  
HARRY, WRAPPING HIM IN A CHISEL EMBRACE! THEIR LIPS MET,

THEN THE GRIELING IN FRONT OF THEM, DEEN'S FACE FILLED WITH ANGLISH.  
HE RAISED THE SWORD HIGH, HIS ARMS SPARKING,

DEE IT, DEEN! HARRY YELLED,

DEEN WHISKED TOWARD HIM, AND HARRY THOUGHT HE SAW A TRACE OF  
SCARLET IN HIS EYES,

DEEN ?

THE SWORD FLASHED, COLLINGED! HARRY THREW HIMSELF OUT OF THE WAY, THERE WAS A CLANG OF METAL AND A LONG, DRAINING SCREAM. HARRY WHIRLED AROUND, SLIPPING IN THE SNEL, HAND HELD READY TO DEFEND HIMSELF: BUT THERE WAS NOTHING TO FIGHT.

THE MINSTRELS VERSIONS OF HIMSELF AND HERMIONE WERE GONE!

THERE WAS ONLY REEN, STANDING THERE WITH THE SWORD HELD SLACKLY IN

HIS HAND, LOOKING DOWN AT THE SHATTERED REMAINS OF THE WICKET ON THE FLAT REED.

SILENTLY, HARRY WALKED BACK TO HIM, HARDLY KNOWING WHAT HE SAID FOR DEE. REEN WAS BREATHING HEAVILY: HIS EYES WERE NO LONGER RED AT ALL, BUT THEIR NORMAL BLUE; THEY WERE ALSO WET.

HARRY STEPPED, PRETENDING HE HAD NOT SEEN, AND PICKED UP THE BROKEN HERCULES. REEN HAD PIERCED THE GLASS IN BOTH WINDOWS!

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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RIDDLE'S EYES WERE GONE, AND THE STAINED SILK LINING OF THE WICKET WAS SMOKING SLIGHTLY. THE THING THAT HAD LIVED IN THE HERCULES HAD

VANISHED; THREATENING REEN HAD BEEN ITS FINAL ACT.

THE SWORD CLANGED AS REEN DROPPED IT. HE HAD SLUNK TO HIS KNEES, HIS HEAD IN HIS ARMS. HE WAS SHAKING, BUT NOT, HARRY REALIZED, FROM

CHILD. HARRY CRAMMED THE BROKEN WICKET INTO HIS POCKET, DROPT DOWN



RESIDE REEN, AND PLACED A HAND CALTHERLISLY INN HIS ST-THULDER. F-HE THHEK  
IT AS A CHHD SIGN THAT REEN DID NEET THHEW IT HPP.

AFTER YELI LEFT, HE SAID IN A LHHN VEHIC, GRATEPLK PHER THE FACT THAT  
REEN S FACE WAS HIDDEN, SHE CRIED PHER A WEEK. PRHEKARLY LHHNGER, HENLY  
SHE DIDN T WANT ME THE SEE, THERE WERE LEADS HF NIGHTS WHEN WE  
NEVER

EVEN SPHEKE THE EACH EETHER, WITH YELI CHNE ...

F-HE CHULD NEET FINISH; IT WAS HENLY NEEN THAT REEN WAS HERE AGAIN  
THAT

F-JARRY FLILY REALIZED FHEW MUCH HIS ABSENCE HAD CHST THEM,

SHE S LIKE MY SISTER, HE WENT INN, I LHYE HER LIKE A SISTER AND I  
RECKEN SHE FEELS THE SAME WAY ABHELT ME, IT S ALWAYS BEEN LIKE THAT,  
I THELIGHT YELI DNEL,

REEN DID NEET RESPOND, KLIT TURNED HIS FACE AWAY FROM F-JARRY AND  
WIPED HIS NOSE NEHISTLY INN HIS SLEEVE, F-JARRY GET THE HIS FEET AGAIN  
AND

WALKED THE WHERE REEN S ENHHEMELIS RICKSACK LAY YARDS AWAY,  
DISCARDED

AS REEN HAD RLIN THEWARD THE PHEH THE SAVE F-JARRY FROM DREHWINING,  
F-HE

HELISTED IT HENTHE HIS HELIN BACK AND WALKED BACK THE REEN, WITH CLAM-  
BERED THE HIS FEET AS F-JARRY APPREHACHED, EYES BLEHDS-HEET KLIT  
EETHEHRLISE

CHMPHSED,

I M SHRRY, HE SAID IN A THICK VEHIC, I M SHRRY I LEFT, I DNEN I  
WAS A     A

HE LEANED AHEAD AT THE DARKNESS, AS IF FEELING A RAD PULSE  
WHICH WOULD SLIP DEEP WITHIN HIM AND CLAIM HIM.

## THE SILVER DEE

ETA

WELL YOU SHIRT ME MADE UP FOR IT TONIGHT, SAID HARRY. GETTING THE  
SWORD, FINISHING OFF THE HERCULES, SAVING MY LIFE.

THAT MAKES ME FEEL A LOT CHEERIER THAN I WAS, REEN MUMURED.  
STUFF LIKE THAT ALWAYS FEELS CHEERIER THAN IT REALLY WAS, SAID  
HARRY. I VE BEEN TRYING TO TELL YOU THAT FOR YEARS.

SIMULTANEOUSLY THEY WALKED FORWARD AND FLICED, HARRY GRIPPING  
THE STILL-SLEEPING BACK OF REEN S JACKET.

AND WELL, SAID HARRY AS THEY BREKE APART, ALL WE VE GOT TO DO  
IS FIND THE TENT AGAIN.

BUT IT WAS NOT DIFFICULT, THOUGH THE WALK THROUGH THE DARK  
FOREST

WITH THE DEE HAD SEEMED LENGTHY, WITH REEN BY HIS SIDE THE JOURNEY  
BACK SEEMED TO TAKE A SURPRISINGLY SHORT TIME. HARRY COULD NOT  
WAIT

TO MAKE HERMIONE, AND IT WAS WITH FLICKERING EXCITEMENT THAT HE  
ENTERED THE TENT, REEN LAGGING A LITTLE BEHIND HIM.

IT WAS GLORIOUSLY WARM AFTER THE FUEL AND THE FOREST, THE ONLY  
ILLUMINATION THE BLIZZARD FLAMES STILL SHIMMERING IN A BEAM ON THE  
FLOOR. HERMIONE WAS FAST ASLEEP, CURLED UP UNDER HER BLANKETS, AND  
DID NOT MOVE UNTIL HARRY HAD SAID HER NAME SEVERAL TIMES.

HERMIONE?

SHE STIRRED, THEN SAT UP QUICKLY, PUSHING HER HAIR OUT OF HER FACE.

WHAT'S WRONG? HARRY? ARE YOU ALL RIGHT?

IT'S OKAY, EVERYTHING'S FINE. MORE THAN FINE, I'M GREAT. THERE'S SOMEONE HERE.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? WHO?

SHE SAW RON, WHO STOOD THERE HOLDING THE SWORD AND DRIPPING BLOOD

THE THREADBARE CARPET. HARRY BACKED INTO A SHADY CORNER, SLIPPED

OFF RON'S BACK, AND ATTEMPTED TO BLEND IN WITH THE CANVAS.

HERMIONE SLID OUT OF HER BLIND AND MOVED LIKE A SLEEPWALKER

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

XXX

THEYARD RON, HER EYES WIDEN HIS PALE FACE. SHE STOPPED RIGHT IN FRONT

OF HIM, HER LIPS SLIGHTLY PARTED, HER EYES WIDE. RON GAVE A WEAK, HESITANT SMILE AND HALF-RAISED HIS ARMS.

HERMIONE LAUNCHED HERSELF FORWARD AND STARTED PUNCHING EVERY INCH OF HIM THAT SHE COULD REACH.

WHICH HOW GROSS? WHAT THE? HERMIONE HOW?

YOU COMPLETE ARSE RONALD WEASLEY?

SHE PUNCTUATED EVERY WORD WITH A KICK. RON BACKED AWAY, SHIELD-

ING HIS HEAD AS HERMINE ADVANCED,

YELL CRAWL BACK HERE AFTER WEEKS AND  
WEEKS EH, WHERE S MY LAND?

SHE LUNGED AS THOUGH READY TO WRESTLE IT BUT HE HARRY S HANDS  
AND

HE REACTED INSTINCTIVELY,

POWTECH!

THE INVISIBLE SHIELD ERUPTED BETWEEN REIN AND HERMINE! THE  
FORCE OF IT BOUNDED HER BACKWARD INTO THE AIR, SPITTING HAIR  
OUT

OF HER MOUTH, SHE LEAPT UP AGAIN,

HERMINE! SAID HARRY, CALM

I WILL NOT CALM DOWN! SHE SCREAMED, NEVER BEFORE HAD HE SEEN  
HER LIKE THIS! SHE LUNGED WHITE DEMENTED, GIVE ME  
BACK

MY LAND! GIVE IT BACK TO ME!

HERMINE, WILL YOU PLEASE

DOEN T YOU TELL ME WHAT THE DE, HARRY PITTER! SHE SCREAMED,

DOEN T YOU DARE! GIVE IT BACK NOW! AND YOU!

SHE WAS POINTING AT REIN IN DIRE ACCUSATION! IT WAS LIKE A MALEDIC-  
TION, AND HARRY COULD NOT BLAME REIN FOR RETREATING SEVERAL STEPS,

I CAME RUNNING AFTER YOU! I CALLED YOU! I BEGGED YOU TO COME  
BACK!

I KNOW, REIN SAID, HERMINE, I M SORRY, I M REALLY

## THE SILVER DEER

XXXI

"HE, YELL RE SHRRY?"

SHE LAUGHED, A HIGH-PITCHED, HILT-UP-CENTREED SHLIND; REIN LEERED AT  
FARRY FOR HELP, BUT FARRY MERELY GRIMACED HIS HELPLESSNESS.

"YELL COME BACK AFTER WEEKS WEEKS AND YELL THIND IT S ALL  
BEING THEE RE ALL RIGHT IF YELL ILIST SAY SHRRY?"

"WELL, WHAT ELSE CAN I SAY?" REIN SHELTED, AND FARRY WAS GLAD  
THAT REIN WAS FIGHTING BACK.

"HE, I DEEN T DNEEL!" YELLED FERMINE WITH AWWL SARCASTIC. RACK  
YELLER BRAINS, REIN, THAT SHOULD ONLY TAKE A CHUPLE OF SECONDS  
FERMINE, INTERRUPTED FARRY, WHEN CONSIDERED THIS A LEEW BLEW,  
HE ILIST SAVED MY

"I DEEN T CARE!" SHE SCREAMED. "I DEEN T CARE WHAT HE S DEEN!" WEEKS  
AND WEEKS, WE CHULD HAVE BEEN DEAD FOR ALL HE DNEEL

"I DNEEL YELL WEREN T DEAD!" RELIEVED REIN, DRILLING HER VEHICLE  
FOR THE FIRST TIME, AND APPROACHING AS CLOSE AS HE CHULD WITH THE  
SHIELD CHARM BETWEEN THEM. FARRY S ALL EVER THE PROPHET, ALL  
EVER

THE RADIO, THEY RE WHISKING FOR YELL EVERYWHERE, ALL THESE RUMORS  
AND

MENTAL STORIES, I DNEEL I D HEAR STRAIGHT OFF IF YELL WERE DEAD, YELL  
DEEN T DNEEL WHAT IT S BEEN LIKE

"WHAT IT S BEEN LIKE FOR YELL?"

FER VEHICLE WAS NEEL SHE SHILL ONLY RATS WOULD BE ABLE THE HEAR IT

SEEN, BUT SHE HAD REACHED A LEVEL OF INDIGNATION THAT RENDERED HER TEMPORARILY SPEECHLESS, AND REN SEIZED HIS OPPORTUNITY.

I WANTED THE CHIEF BACK THE MINUTE I'D DISAPPEARED, BUT I WALKED STRAIGHT INTO A GANG OF SNATCHERS, FERMINE, AND I CHILDREN

GO ANYWHERE?

A GANG OF WHAT? ASKED HARRY, AS FERMINE THREW HERSELF DOWN

INTO A CHAIR WITH HER ARMS AND LEGS CROSSED SO TIGHTLY IT SEEMED UN-

LIKELY THAT SHE WOULD UNRAVEL THEM FOR SEVERAL YEARS.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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SNATCHERS, SAID REN. THEY'RE EVERYWHERE. GANGS TRYING TO EARN CASH BY REWRINDING UP MUGGLE-BORN AND BLOOD TRAITORS, THERE'S

A REWARD FROM THE MINISTRY FOR EVERYONE CAPTURED. I WAS IN MY ELN AND I LOOKED LIKE I MIGHT BE SOMEONE AGO; THEY GOT REALLY EXCITED, THOUGHT I WAS A MUGGLE-BORN IN HIDING. I HAD THE TALK FAST THE GET OUT

OF BEING DRAGGED TO THE MINISTRY.

WHAT DID YOU SAY TO THEM?

TOLD THEM I WAS STAN SHLIMPEX, FIRST PERSON I COULD THINK OF.

AND THEY BELIEVED THAT?

THEY WEREN'T THE BRIGHTEST, NONE OF THEM WAS DEFINITELY PART  
TRELL,

THE SMELL OFF HIM. . .

REN GLANCED AT HERMINE, CLEARLY EXPECTING SHE MIGHT SEIZURE AT  
THIS

SMALL INSTANCE OF FLIMMER, BUT HER EXPRESSION REMAINED STEADY ABOVE  
HER TIGHTLY KNITTEN LIPS.

ANYWAY, THEY HAD A REEL ABOUT WHETHER I WAS STAYING WITH THEM. IT WAS  
A BIT PATHETIC THE RE HONEST, BUT THERE WERE STILL FIVE OF THEM AND  
ONLY

ONE OF ME AND THEY'D TAKEN MY HAND, THEN TWO OF THEM GET INTO A  
FIGHT AND WHILE THE OTHERS WERE DISTRACTED I MANAGED TO HIT THE  
ONE

HOLDING ME IN THE STOMACH, GRABBED HIS HAND, DISARMED THE OTHER

HOLDING ME, AND DISAPPEARED. I DIDN'T SEE IT TOO WELL, SPLINCHED

MYSELF AGAIN. REN HELD UP HIS RIGHT HAND TO SHOW THE MISSING

FINGERNAILS. HERMINE RAISED HER EYEBROWS COLDLY AND I CAME

ABOUT FIFTY FEET FROM WHERE THEY WERE. BY THE TIME I GOT BACK TO THAT BIT  
OF

RIVERBANK WHERE WE'D BEEN. . . THEY'D GONE.

GOSH, WHAT A GRIPPING STORY, HERMINE SAID IN THE LEFTY VEHICLE

SHE ADOPTED WHEN WISHING TO WHINE. THEY MUST HAVE BEEN SIMPLY

TERRIFIED. MEANWHILE WE WENT TO CHURCH & HILL AND, LET'S THINK,

THE SILVER DOLL

XXX

WHAT HAPPENED THERE, HARRY? HEY YES, YELL-DONNEL-WH-EE S SNAKE  
TURNED UP, IT NEARLY KILLED BOTH OF US, AND THEN YELL-DONNEL-WH-EE  
HIMSELF ARRIVED AND MISSED US BY ABOUT A SECOND.

WHAT? RENN SAID, CAVING FROM HER THE HARRY, BUT HERMIONE  
IGNORED HIM.

IMAGINE MISSING FINGERNAILS, HARRY? THAT REALLY PUTS OUR  
SLIPPERINGS

INTO PERSPECTIVE, DOESN'T IT?

HERMIONE, SAID HARRY QUIETLY, RENN JUST SAVED MY LIFE.  
SHE APPEARED NEET THE HAVE HEARD HIM.

ONE THING I WOULD LIKE TO KNOW, THOUGH, SHE SAID, FIXING HER  
EYES ON A SPOT A FEET OVER RENN'S HEAD. HOW EXACTLY DID YELL FIND  
US TONIGHT? THAT'S IMPORTANT. BECAUSE WE KNOW, WE WILL BE ABLE TO  
MAKE

SURE WE'RE NOT VISITED BY ANYONE ELSE WE DON'T WANT TO SEE.

RENN GLARED AT HER, THEN PULLED A SMALL SILVER OBJECT FROM HIS TRANS  
POCKET.

THIS,

SHE HAD THE LOOK AT RENN TO SEE WHAT HE WAS SHOWING THEM.

THE DETERMINATION? SHE ASKED, SHE SURPRISED SHE MIGHT THE LOOK  
CHILD AND FIERCE.

IT DOESN'T JUST TURN THE LIGHTS ON AND OFF, SAID RENN. I DON'T  
KNOW HOW IT WORKS OR WHY IT HAPPENED THEN AND NOT ANY OTHER  
TIME, BECAUSE I'VE BEEN WANTING THE CHAIR BACK EVER SINCE I LEFT, BUT  
I WAS LISTENING TO THE RADIO REALLY EARLY ON CHRISTMAS MORNING  
AND

I HEARD . . . I HEARD YELL.

HE WAS LOOKING AT HERMIONE.



YELL HEARD ME IN THE RADIO? SHE ASKED INCREDULOUSLY.  
NO, I HEARD YELL CHIMING BELT OF MY POCKET, YELLER VOICE, HE HELD  
UP THE DEDIMINATOR AGAIN, CAME BELT OF THIS.

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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AND WHAT EXACTLY DID I SAY? ASKED HERMINE, HER TONE SOME-  
WHERE BETWEEN SKEPTICISM AND CLARITY.

MY NAME, REN, AND YELL SAID ... SOMETHING ABOUT A  
HAND, ...

HERMINE TURNED A FIERY SHADE OF SCARLET, HARRY REMEMBERED: IT  
HAD BEEN THE FIRST TIME REN'S NAME HAD BEEN SAID ALOUD BY EITHER OF  
THEM SINCE THE DAY HE HAD LEFT; HERMINE HAD MENTIONED IT WHEN  
TALKING ABOUT REPAIRING HARRY'S HAND.

SEE I THINK IT BELT, REN WENT ON, LOOKING AT THE DEDIMINATOR,  
AND

IT DIDN'T SEEM DIFFERENT OR ANYTHING, BUT I WAS SURE I'D HEARD YELL.  
SEE

I CLICKED IT, AND THE LIGHT WENT BELT IN MY REAR, BUT ANOTHER LIGHT  
APPEARED RIGHT BELTSIDE THE WINDMILL.

REN RAISED HIS EMPTY HAND AND POINTED IN FRONT OF HIM, HIS EYES  
FOCUSED ON SOMETHING NEITHER HARRY NOR HERMINE COULD SEE.

IT WAS A BALL OF LIGHT, KIND OF PULSING, AND BUBBLY, LIKE THAT LIGHT  
YELL GOT ABOUT A PERTURB, YELL BOWEL?

Yeah, said Harry and Hermione together alternately,  
I knew this was it, said Ron. I grabbed my stuff and packed it,  
then I put in my rucksack and went out into the garden.

The little ball of light was hovering there, waiting for me, and  
when I came out it zipped along a bit and I followed it behind the  
shed and then it . . . well, it went inside me.

Shhrrr? said Harry, sure he had not heard correctly.

It sort of floated toward me, said Ron, illustrating the move-  
ment with his free index finger, right to my chest, and then it

just went straight through. It was here, he thought a faint  
chase

to his heart, I could feel it, it was hot, and hence it was inside me  
I knew what I was supposed to do, I knew it would take me where

the silver deer

was

I needed the car. So I disappeared and came out on the side of a hill.  
There was snow everywhere. . . .

We were there, said Harry. We spent two nights there, and the  
second night I kept thinking I could hear someone moving  
around

in the dark and calling out?

Yeah, well, that would've been me, said Ron. Your protective

SPELLS WERE, ANYWAY, BECAUSE I COULDN'T SEE YELL AND I COULDN'T  
HEAR

YELL, I WAS SURE YELL WERE AROUND, THOUGH, SO IN THE END I GOT IN  
MY

SLEEPING BAG AND WAITED FOR ONE OF YELL TO APPEAR. I THOUGHT YELL'D  
HAVE THE SEEN THEMSELVES WHEN YELL PACKED UP THE TENT.

OH, ACTUALLY, SAID HERMIONE. WE'VE BEEN DISAPPEARING UNDER  
THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AS AN EXTRA PRECAUTION. AND WE LEFT REALLY  
EARLY.

BECAUSE, AS HARRY SAYS, WE'D HEARD SOMEBODY RUMBLING AROUND.

WELL, I STAYED ON THAT HILL ALL DAY, SAID RON. I KEPT HOPEING  
YELL'D

APPEAR, BUT WHEN IT STARTED TO GET DARK I KNEW I MUST HAVE MISSED  
YELL, SO I CLICKED THE DEDIMINATOR AGAIN, THE BLUE LIGHT CAME OUT  
AND WENT INSIDE ME, AND I DISAPPEARED AND ARRIVED HERE IN THESE  
WOODS. I STILL COULDN'T SEE YELL, SO I JUST HAD THE HOPE ONE OF YELL  
WOULD

SEEN THEMSELVES IN THE END AND HARRY DID. WELL, I SAW THE DEER  
FIRST, HEAVENLY.

YELL SAW THE WHAT? SAID HERMIONE SHARPLY.

THEY EXPLAINED WHAT HAD HAPPENED, AND AS THE STORY OF THE SILVER  
DEER AND THE SWORD IN THE PEARL LINCOLD, HERMIONE FREWED FROM  
BENEATH THE OTHER OF THEM, CONCENTRATING SHE HAD SHE RECENT THE  
DEEP

HER LIMBS LOCKED TOGETHER.

BUT IT MUST HAVE BEEN A PATRONUS! SHE SAID. COULDN'T YELL SEE  
WHAT WAS CARRYING IT? DIDN'T YELL SEE ANYTHING? AND IT LED YELL TO THE  
SWORD! I CAN'T BELIEVE THIS! THEN WHAT HAPPENED?

## CHAPTER NINETEEN

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REIN EXPLAINED WHEN HE HAD WATCHED HARRY JUMP INTO THE POOL

AND HAD WAITED FOR HIM TO RESURFACE; WHEN HE HAD REALIZED THAT  
SOME-

THING WAS WRONG, DIVED IN, AND SAVED HARRY, THEN RETURNED FOR THE

SWORD, HE GET AS FAR AS THE OPENING OF THE LOCKET, THEN HESITATED,  
AND HARRY CLUT IN,

AND REIN STABBED IT WITH THE SWORD,

AND . . . AND IT WENT? JUST LIKE THAT? SHE WHISPERED,

WELL, IT IT SCREAMED, SAID HARRY WITH HALF A GLANCE AT REIN,  
HERE,

HE THREW THE LOCKET INTO HER LAP; GINGERLY SHE PICKED IT UP AND  
EXAMINED ITS PUNCTURED WINDSHIELD,

DECIDING THAT IT WAS AT LAST SAFE TO SEE, HARRY REMOVED THE  
SHIELD

CHARM WITH A WAVE OF HERMIONE'S WAND AND TURNED TO REIN,

DID YOU JUST SAY YOU GET AWAY FROM THE SNATCHERS WITH A SPARE  
WAND?

WHAT? SAID REIN, WHO HAD BEEN WATCHING HERMIONE EXAMINING  
THE LOCKET. EH EH YEAS,

HE TUGGED OPEN A KLIDLE IN HIS RUCKSACK AND PULLED A SHEET,

DARK LAND HLT IF ITS PECKET. HERE, I FIGURED IT S ALWAYS HANDY THE  
HAVE A BACKUP.

THEY WERE RIGHT, SAID HARRY, HOLDING UP HIS HAND. MINE S  
KREIDEN.

ARE YOU KIDDING? BEN SAID, BLIT AT THAT MOMENT HERMINE GET  
THE HER FEET, AND HE LOOKED APPREHENSIVE AGAIN.

TERMININE PUT THE VANDERLISHED THERCULX INTO THE LEADED BAG,  
THEN CLIMBED BACK INTO HER BED AND SETTLED DOWN WITH HEART ANOTHER  
WEED.

REIN PASSED HARRY THE NEW WAND.

ABOUT THE BEST YOU COULD HAVE HER, I THINK, MURMURED EDDY.

# THE SILVER DEER

YEAH, SAID BEN. WOULD VE BEEN WORSE. REMEMBER THESE KIDS  
THEY SET HIM ON FIRE?

I STILL HAVEN'T ROLLED IT UP, I AME DETERMINED I PULLED VEHICLE FROM  
BENEATH HER BLANKETS, BUT HARRY SAW REEN SMILING SLIGHTLY AS HE  
PULLED HIS MARTIN PALMAS UP BY HIS ROLLSACKS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY

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JARRY HAD NOT EXPECTED HERMINE'S ANGER THE ARATE EVEN-  
NIGHT, AND WAS THEREFORE UNDISAPPOINTED THAT SHE COM-  
MUNICATED MAINLY BY DIRTY LOOKS AND PHINTED SILENCES THE NEXT  
MORNING. REN RESPONDED BY MAINTAINING AN UNNATURALLY STUBBORN  
BEHAVIOUR IN HER PRESENCE AS AN EVIDENT SIGN OF CONTINUING RE-  
MORSE. IN FACT, WHEN ALL THREE OF THEM WERE TOGETHER JARRY FELT  
LIKE THE ONLY NON-MILLIONAIRE AT A SOCIALLY ATTENDED FUNERAL. DURING  
THESE FEW MOMENTS HE SPENT ALONE WITH JARRY, HOWEVER (COLLECT-  
ING WATER AND SEARCHING THE UNDERGROUNDS FOR MISFORTHES), REN  
BECAME SHAMELESSLY CHEERFUL.

HERMINE HELPED US. HE KEPT SAYING. HERMINE SENT THAT ONE.  
HERMINE'S OWN OWN SIDE. ONE HERMINE'S OWN, MATE?  
EXHASTED BY THE DESTRUCTION OF THE LOCKET, THEY SET THE DEBATING  
THE POSSIBLE LOCATIONS OF THE OTHER HERMINE'S, AND EVEN THOUGH  
THEY

HAD DISCUSSED THE MATTER SEVERAL TIMES BEFORE, JARRY FELT OPTIMISTIC, CER-  
TAIN THAT MORE BREADTHFULNESS WOULD SLICE THE FIRST, HERMINE'S

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

XXX

SURPRISE COULD NOT MAR HIS ELATED SPIRITS: THE SUDDEN UPSWING  
IN

THEIR FORTUNES, THE APPEARANCE OF THE MYSTERIOUS DEER, THE  
RECOVERY

OF GRYPFINDER'S SWORD, AND ABOVE ALL, RON'S RETURN, MADE HARRY SEE  
HAPPY THAT IT WAS ELITE DIFFICULT TO MAINTAIN A STRAIGHT FACE.

LATE IN THE AFTERNOON HE AND RON ESCAPED HERMION'S RALPH  
PRESENCE AGAIN, AND UNDER THE PRETEXT OF SEARCHING THE BARE  
HEDGES

FOR NONEXISTENT BLACKBERRIES, THEY CONTINUED THEIR ENGAGING  
EXCHANGE

OF NEWS. HARRY HAD FINALLY MANAGED TO TELL RON THE WHOLE STORY  
OF

HIS AND HERMION'S VARIOUS WANDERINGS, RIGHT UP TO THE FULL  
STORY

OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED AT CEDRIC'S FUNERAL; RON WAS NOW FILLING

HARRY IN ON EVERYTHING HE HAD DISCOVERED ABOUT THE WIDER WIZARD-  
ING WORLD DURING HIS WEEKS AWAY.

... AND HOW DID YOU FIND OUT ABOUT THE TALKING? HE ASKED HARRY  
AFTER EXPLAINING THE MANY DESPERATE ATTEMPTS OF MUGGLE-BOSS TO  
EVIL THE MINISTRY.

THE WHAT?

YELL AND HERMIONE HAVE STOPPED SAYING YELL-KNEW-WHICH S NAME?

HEH, YEAH, WELL, IT S ILST A BAD HABIT WE VE SLIPPED INTO, SAID HARRY. BUT I HAVEN T GHT A PROBLEM CALLING HIM Y

NEH? HEARD RON, CALSING HARRY THE ILMP INTO THE HEDGE AND HERMIONE INESE BLIRIED IN A BHEX AT THE TENT ENTRANCE! THE SCHOOL EVER AT THEM. SHRRY, SAID RON, WRENCHING HARRY BACK HEHT HP THE

BRAMBLES, BUT THE NAME S BEEN LINKED, HARRY, THAT S WHEN THEY TRACK

PEOPLE? USING HIS NAME BREAKS PROTECTIVE ENCHANTMENTS, IT CAUSES

SOME KIND HP MAGICAL DISTURBANCE IT S WHEN THEY FEELND LIS IN THE-

TENHAM CHLRT READ?

BECAUSE WE USED HIS NAME?

EXACTLY? YELL VE GHT THE GIVE THEM CREDIT, IT MAKES SENSE. IT WAS

## CHAPTER TWENTY

END

ONLY PEOPLE WHO WERE SERIOUS ABOUT STANDING UP TO HIM, LIKE DUMBLEDORE, WHO EVER DARED USE IT, WHEN THEY VE PLT A TARKEN HEN IT, AND-

END WHO SAYS IT IS TRACKABLE ELLID-AND-EASY WAY THE FIND HENDER



MEMBERS? THEY NEARLY GET DINGSLEY

YELL RE KIDDING?

YEAH, A BLINK OF DEATH PATERS CORNERED HIM, BILL SAID, BUT HE  
THOUGHT HIS WAY OUT. HE'S BEEN THE BLIN NEW, JUST LIKE US. BEEN  
STRATCHED

HIS CHIN TIGHTLY WITH THE END OF HIS HAND, YELL BEEN T  
RECKEN

DINGSLEY COULD HAVE SENT THAT DEER?

HIS PATRONS IS A LYON, WE SAW IT AT THE WEDDING, REMEMBER?

HE YEAH...

THEY MOVED FARTHER ALONG THE HEDGE, AWAY FROM THE TENT AND  
HERMINE.

HARRY... YELL BEEN T RECKEN IT COULD VE BEEN DUMBLEDORE?

DUMBLEDORE WHAT?

BEEN LOOKED A LITTLE EMBARRASSED, BUT SAID IN A LOW VOICE, DUM-  
BLEDORE... THE DEER? I MEAN, BEEN WAS WATCHING HARRY OUT OF THE

CORNERS OF HIS EYES, HE HAD THE REAL SWORD LAST, DIDN'T HE?

HARRY DID NOT LAUGH AT BEEN, BECAUSE HE UNDERSTOOD THEM WELL THE

BEINGING BEHIND THE HILSTERN. THE IDEA THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD MAN-  
AGED TO COME BACK TO THEM, THAT HE WAS WATCHING OVER THEM, WOULD

HAVE BEEN INEXPRESSIBLY COMFORTING. HE SHOOK HIS HEAD.

DUMBLEDORE'S DEAD, HE SAID. I SAW IT HAPPEN, I SAW THE BODY.

HE'S DEFINITELY GONE. ANYWAY, HIS PATRONS WAS A PHOENIX, NOT A

DHE.

PATRONLISES CAN CHANGE, TEHLICH, CAN T THEY? SAID RHN. THNKS S  
CHANGED, DIDN T IT?

YEAH, BUT IF DUMBLEDORE WAS ALIVE, WHY WOULDN T HE STEAL HIM-  
SELF? WHY WOULDN T HE JUST HAND US THE SWORD?

~~XXXXXXXXXXXXX~~

BY

SEARCH ME, SAID RHN. SAME REASON HE DIDN T GIVE IT THE YELL WHILE  
HE WAS ALIVE? SAME REASON HE LEFT YELL AN OLD SNITCH AND  
HERMIONE

A BUNCH OF KIDS STORIES?

WHICH IS WHAT? ASKED HARRY, TURNING THE BUNCH RHN AROUND IN THE  
FACE, DESPERATE FOR THE ANSWER.

I DUNNO, SAID RHN. SOMETIMES I VE THOUGHT, WHEN I VE BEEN  
A BIT HACKED OFF, HE WAS HAVING A LAUGH AT ME HE HE JUST WANTED TO  
MAKE IT MORE DIFFICULT, BUT I DIDN T THINK SEE, NOT ANYMORE, HE KNOWS  
WHAT HE WAS DOING WHEN HE GAVE ME THE DEDIMINATOR, DIDN T HE?  
HE WELL, RHN S EARS TURNED BRIGHT RED AND HE BECAME ENGROSSSED  
IN A TUFT OF GRASS AT HIS FEET, WHICH HE PRETENDED WITH HIS TIE, HE  
MUST VE KNOWN I D BLIN BLT HEN YELL.

NO, HARRY CORRECTED HIM. HE MUST VE KNOWN YELL D ALWAYS  
WANT THE CHAMP BACK.

RENN SMILED GRATEFUL, BUT STILL ALREADY, PARTLY THE CHARGE THE SUBJECT, HARRY SAID, SPEAKING OF DUMBLEDORE, HAVE YOU HEARD WHAT

SKEETER WROTE ABOUT HIM?

OH YES, SAID RENN AT ONCE, PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT IT ALL

A LOT. HOWEVER, IF THINGS WERE DIFFERENT, IT WOULD BE LIKE NEWS, DUMBLEDORE BEING PAIS WITH GRINDLEWALD, BUT WHEN IT IS JUST SOMETHING THE

LARGE ABOUT FOR PEOPLE WHO DIDN'T LIKE DUMBLEDORE, AND A BIT OF A SLAP IN THE FACE FOR EVERYONE WHO THOUGHT HE WAS SUCH A GOOD MAN.

I DIDN'T KNOW THAT IT WAS SUCH A BIG DEAL, THOUGH. HE WAS REALLY

WHEN THEY

HOW AGE, SAID HARRY, JUST AS HE HAD RETORTED THE JEREMY, AND SOMETHING IN HIS FACE SEEMED TO DECIDE RENN AGAINST PURSUING THE SUBJECT.

A LARGE SPIDER SAT IN THE MIDDLE OF A FROSTED WEB IN THE CRACKS.

HARRY THEN AIM AT IT WITH THE WAND RENN HAD GIVEN HIM THE PREVIOUS

## CHAPTER TWENTY

END

NIGHT, WHICH JEREMY HAD SINCE CHANDERED THE EXAMINE, AND HAD DECIDED WAS MADE OF BLACKTHORN.

ENLARGED.

THE SPIDER GAVE A LITTLE SHIVER, BELLING SLIGHTLY IN THE WEE.  
HARRY

TRIED AGAIN. THIS TIME THE SPIDER CRAW SLIGHTLY LARGER.

STEP THAT, SAID RENN SHARPLY. I'M SURE I SAID DIMPLEDHERE WAS  
WELLING, HARRY?

HARRY HAD FORGOTTEN RENN'S HATRED OF SPIDERS.

SURE? REDUCED.

THE SPIDER DID NOT SHRINK. HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE BLACKTHORN  
WAND. EVERY MINOR SPELL HE HAD CAST WITH IT SINCE THAT DAY HAD  
SEEMED LESS PERVERSE THAN THESE HE HAD PRODUCED WITH HIS PHOENIX  
WAND. THE NEW ONE FELT INSTINCTIVELY UNFAMILIAR, LIKE HAVING  
SOMEONE

ELSE'S HAND SEW THE END OF HIS ARM.

WELL I'VE GOT THE PRACTICE, SAID HERMIONE, WHEN HAD APPROACHED  
THEM NEARLY FROM BEHIND AND HAD STOPPED WATCHING ANXIOUSLY AS  
HARRY TRIED TO ENLARGE AND REDUCE THE SPIDER. IT'S ALL A MATTER OF  
CONFIDENCE, HARRY.

HE KNEW WHY SHE WANTED IT TO BE ALL RIGHT! SHE STILL FELT CLINTY  
ABOUT BREAKING HIS WAND. HE HIT BACK THE RETORT THAT SPRANG TO  
HIS

LIPS, THAT SHE COULD TAKE THE BLACKTHORN WAND IF SHE THOUGHT IT  
MADE

THE DIFFERENCE, AND HE WOULD HAVE HER'S INSTEAD. BEEN FOR THEM ALL

THEIR FRIENDS AGAIN, HOWEVER, HE AGREED; BUT WHEN RENN GAVE HERMI-  
ONE A TENTATIVE SMILE, SHE STALKED OFF AND VANISHED BEHIND HER

HENCE MORE.

ALL THREE OF THEM RETURNED THE TENT WHEN DARKNESS FELL, AND HARRY TOOK FIRST WATCH. SITTING IN THE ENTRANCE, HE TRIED THE MAGIC THE BLACKTHERN HAD LEVITATE SMALL STONES AT HIS FEET, BUT HIS

MAGIC STILL SEEMED CLUMSIER AND LESS POWERFUL THAN IT HAD BEEN BEFORE.

~~XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX~~

KK

HERMIONE WAS LYING IN HER BED READING, WHILE RON, AFTER MANY NERVIOUS GLANCES UP AT HER, HAD TAKEN A SMALL WHEDEN WIRELESS OUT OF HIS RUCKSACK AND STARTED TO TRY AND TUNE IT.

THERE'S THIS NEW PROGRAM, HE TOLD HARRY IN A LOW VOICE, THAT TELLS THE NEWS LIKE IT REALLY IS. ALL THE OTHERS ARE IN THE DARK-ROOMS

SIDE AND ARE FOLLOWING THE MINISTRY LINE, BUT THIS ONE... YOU WAIT TILL YOU HEAR IT, IT'S GREAT. ONLY THEY CAN'T DO IT EVERY NIGHT, THEY HAVE

TO KEEP CHANGING LOCATIONS IN CASE THEY'RE RAIDED, AND YOU NEED A PASSWORD TO TUNE IN... PROBABLY IS, I MISSED THE LAST ONE...

HE DRUMMED LIGHTLY ON THE TOP OF THE RADIO WITH HIS HAND, MUTTERING RANDOM WORDS UNDER HIS BREATH. HE THREW HERMIONE MANY

COVERT GLANCES, PLAINLY FEARING AN ANGRY REPLY, BUT FOR ALL THE

TILL SHE THOUGHT OF HIM HE MIGHT NOT HAVE BEEN THERE, FOR TEN MINUTES

HER SHE WHEN TAPPED AND MUTTERED, HERMINE TURNED THE PAGES OF HER BOOK, AND JARRY CONTINUED THE PRACTICE WITH THE BLACKTHERN WAND. FINALLY HERMINE CLIMBED DOWN FROM HER KLIND, WHEN CEASED HIS TAPPING AT ONCE.

IF IT'S ANNOYING YOU, I'LL STOP! HE TOLD HERMINE NERVOUSLY, HERMINE DID NOT DEIGN TO RESPOND, BUT APPROACHED JARRY.

WE NEED TO TALK, SHE SAID.

HE LOOKED AT THE BOOK STILL CLUTCHED IN HER HAND, IT WAS THE LIFE AND LIES OF ALEXIS DUMBLEDORE.

WHAT? HE SAID APPREHENSIVELY, IT FLEW THROUGH HIS MIND THAT THERE WAS A CHAPTER ON HIM IN THERE; HE WAS NOT SURE HE FELT UP TO

HEARING RITA'S VERSION OF HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH DUMBLEDORE, HERMI-

NE'S ANSWER, HOWEVER, WAS COMPLETELY UNEXPECTED.

I WANT TO GO AND SEE XENOPHILIUS LOVEGOOD.

HE STARED AT HER.

SERIOUS?

CHAPTER TWENTY

“XENOPHILIUS LOVEGOOD, LUNA’S FATHER, I WANT TO SEE AND TALK TO HIM!”

“ER... WHY?”

SHE TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AS THOUGH BRACING HERSELF, AND SAID, “IT’S THAT MARK, THE MARK IN BLOOD THE BARD, LOOK AT THIS!”

SHE THROUST THE LIFE AND LIES OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE UNDER HARRY’S UNWILLING EYES AND HE SAW A PHOTOGRAPH OF THE ORIGINAL LETTER THAT

DUMBLEDORE HAD WRITTEN GRINDLEWALD, WITH DUMBLEDORE’S FAMILIAR THIN, SLANTING HANDWRITING, HE HATED SEEING ARTHURITE PROOF THAT

DUMBLEDORE REALLY HAD WRITTEN THESE WORDS, THAT THEY HAD NOT BEEN RITA’S INVENTION.

“THE SIGNATURE,” SAID HERMION, “LOOK AT THE SIGNATURE, HARRY!” HE HESITED, FOR A MOMENT HE HAD NO IDEA WHAT SHE WAS TALKING ABOUT, BUT, LEANING MORE CLOSELY WITH THE AID OF HIS LIT HAND, HE SAW

THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD REPLACED THE  OF ALBUS WITH A TINY VERSION OF THE SAME TRIANGULAR MARK INSCRIBED UPON THE TALES OF BLOOD THE BARD.

“ER... WHAT ARE YOU?” SAID RON TENTATIVELY, BUT HERMION REPLIED HIM WITH A LOOK AND TURNED BACK TO HARRY.

“IT KEEPS CREEPING UP, DOESN’T IT?” SHE SAID, “I KNOW VICTOR SAID IT WAS GRINDLEWALD’S MARK, BUT IT WAS DEFINITELY HIS THAT HAD GRAY IN

CHERIE'S FAMILIES, AND THE DATES ON THE HEADSTONE WERE LONG BEFORE

GRINDLEWALD CAME ALONG? AND NOW THIS? WELL, WE CAN'T ASK DUMBLE-  
DORE FOR GRINDLEWALD WHAT IT MEANS. I DON'T EVEN KNOW WHETHER

GRINDLEWALD IS STILL ALIVE. BUT WE CAN ASK MR. LEEVEGOOD, HE WAS  
WEARING THE SYMBOL AT THE WEDDING, I'M SURE THIS IS IMPORTANT,  
HARRY?

HARRY DID NOT ANSWER IMMEDIATELY, HE LOOKED INTO HER INTENSE,  
EAGER FACE AND THEN WENT INTO THE SURROUNDING DARKNESS, THINKING,

PROFESSOR LEEVEGOOD

YES

AFTER A LONG PAUSE HE SAID, HERMIONE, WE DON'T NEED ANOTHER  
ONE-

RIK'S FAMILIES, WE TALKED OURSELVES INTO GOING THERE, AND

BUT IT KEEPS APPEARING, HARRY? DUMBLEDORE LEFT ME THE TALES OF  
BLOOD THE BARD, HOW DID YOU KNOW WE'RE NOT SUPPOSED TO FIND OUT  
ABOUT THE SIGN?

HERE WE GO AGAIN? HARRY FELT SLIGHTLY EXHAUSTED, WE KEEP  
TRYING TO CONVINCE OURSELVES DUMBLEDORE LEFT HIS SECRET SIGNS AND  
CLUES

THE DEDUCTOR TURNED OUT TO BE PRETTY USEFUL, PIPED UP  
NOW, I THINK HERMIONE'S RIGHT, I THINK WE MIGHT TRY GOING AND SEE



LEVERCHED.

HARRY THREW HIM A DARK LOOK. HE WAS WHITE SLICE THAT REEN'S SLIP-  
PERT HE HERMIONE HAD LITTLE TO DO WITH A DESIRE TO KNOW THE  
MEANING

OF THE TRIANGULAR RING.

IT WENT TO BE LIKE CROOK'S FELLER, REEN ADDED, LEVERCHED'S MEN

WELL, SIDE, HARRY, THE FELLER'S BEEN FOR WELL ALL ALONG, IT KEEPS  
TELL-

ING EVERYONE THEY'RE GET THE HELP WELL?

I'M SURE THIS IS IMPORTANT! SAID HERMIONE EARNESTLY.

BUT THEN I WELL THINK IF IT WAS, DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE TOLD ME  
ABOUT IT BEFORE HE DIED?

MAYBE . . . MAYBE IT'S SOMETHING WELL NEED TO FIND OUT FOR YOUR-  
SELF, SAID HERMIONE WITH A PAINT AIR OF CLUTCHING AT STRAWS.

Yeah, SAID REEN SYMPHANTICALLY, THAT MAKES SENSE.

NEH, IT DOESN'T, SNAPPED HERMIONE, BUT I STILL THINK WE MIGHT

THE TALK THE MR. LEVERCHED, A SYMPTOM THAT LINKS DUMBLEDORE, GRIN-  
DELLARD, AND CROOK'S FELLER? HARRY, I'M SURE WE MIGHT THE KNOW

ABOUT THIS?

I THINK WE SHOULD WRITE HIM IT, SAID RENN. THESE IN FAVOR OF  
GOING

THE SEE LEVEGHHH

## CHAPTER TWENTY

THE

HIS HAND FLEW INTO THE AIR BEFORE HERMIONE'S, HER LIPS DELIVERED  
SUSPICIOUSLY AS SHE RAISED HER EYEBROW.

DELIVERED, HARRY, SHIRAZ, SAID RENN, CLAPPING HIM ON THE BACK.

FINE, SAID HARRY, HALF AMUSED, HALF IRRITATED. FINALLY, SINCE WE'VE  
SEEN LEVEGHHH, LET'S TRY AND LEARN FROM SOME MORE EXPERIENCED, SHALL  
WE?

WHERE DO THE LEVEGHHHS LIVE, ANYWAY? DO EITHER OF YOU KNOW?

YES, THEY'RE NOT FAR FROM MY PLACE, SAID RENN. I DON'T EXACTLY  
KNOW, BUT MUM AND DAD ALWAYS POINT THEM TOWARD THE HILLS WHENEVER  
THEY MENTION THEM. SHOULDN'T BE HARD TO FIND.

WHEN HERMIONE HAD RETURNED TO HER ROOM, HARRY WHEELED HIS  
VEHICLE.

THEY ONLY AGREED TO TRY AND GET BACK IN HER GOOD BOOKS.

ALL'S FAIR IN LOVE AND WAR, SAID RENN BRIGHTLY, AND THIS IS A BIT  
OF

RIGHT. CHECK UP, IT'S THE CHRISTMAS HOLIDAYS, LUNA WILL BE HOME!

THEY HAD AN EXCELLENT VIEW OF THE VILLAGE OF ETTERTON ST. CATCHPOLE  
FROM THE BREEZY HILLSIDE TO WHICH THEY DISAPPEARED NEXT MORNING.  
FROM THEIR HIGH VANTAGE POINT THE VILLAGE LOOKED LIKE A  
COLLECTION OF

THEY FELLS IN THE GREAT SLANTING SHAFTS OF SUNLIGHT STRETCHING THE EARTH

IN THE BREAKS BETWEEN TREES. THEY STOOD FOR A MINUTE FOR THEM  
MOMENT

THEYARD THE BURNING, THEIR HANDS SHADING THEIR EYES, BUT ALL THEY  
COULD MAKE OUT WERE THE HIGH HEDGES AND TREES OF THE BACKYARD,  
WHICH

OFFERED THE CRIBBED LITTLE FELLS PROTECTION FROM MUGGLE EYES.

IT'S WEIRD, BEING THIS NEAR, BUT NOT GOING TO VISIT, SAID DEN.

WELL, IT'S NOT LIKE YOU HAVEN'T JUST SEEN THEM. YOU WERE THERE  
FOR

CHRISTMAS, SAID HERMIONE COLDLY.

I WASN'T AT THE BURNING! SAID DEN WITH AN INCREDULOUS LAUGH.

OH YOU THINK I WAS GOING TO GO BACK THERE AND TELL THEM ALL I'D  
WALKED OUT IN YOUR DRESS, FRED AND GEORGE WOULD'VE BEEN GREAT  
ABOUT IT, AND GINNY, SHE'D HAVE BEEN REALLY UNDERSTANDING.

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

END

BUT WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN, THEN? ASKED HERMIONE, SURPRISED.

BILL AND FLEET'S NEW PLACE. SMALL COTTAGE. BILL'S ALWAYS BEEN DE-  
CENT THE MR. FLEET HE WASN'T IMPRESSED WHEN HE HEARD WHAT I'D

BEEN, BUT HE DIDN'T GO ON ABOUT IT. FLEET KNEW I WAS REALLY SHY.

NONE OF THE REST OF THE FAMILY KNEW I WAS THERE. BILL TOLD MOM HE

AND FLEW WEREN'T GOING HOME FOR CHRISTMAS BECAUSE THEY WANTED  
TO SPEND IT ALONE. YULI KNEW, FIRST HOLIDAY AFTER THEY WERE MARRIED.  
I

DIDN'T THINK FLEW MINDED. YULI KNEW HOW MUCH SHE HATES CELESTINA  
WARRICK.

RENN TURNED HIS BACK ON THE BLURRY.

LET'S TRY UP HERE, HE SAID, LEADING THE WAY OVER THE TOP OF THE  
HILL.

THEY WALKED FOR A FEW FEET, HARRY, AT HERMIONE'S INSISTENCE,

HIDDEN BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. THE CLUSTER OF LOW HILLS AP-  
PEARED TO BE UNINHABITED APART FROM ONE SMALL COTTAGE, WHICH

SEEMED DESERTED.

DID YULI THINK IT'S THEIRS, AND THEY'VE GONE AWAY FOR CHRISTMAS?  
SAID HERMIONE, PEERING THROUGH THE WINDOW AT A NEAT LITTLE  
KITCHEN

WITH GERANIUMS ON THE WINDOWSILL, RENN SMILED.

LISTEN, I'VE GOT A FEELING YULI'D BE ABLE TO TELL WHO LIVED THERE IF  
YULI WALKED THROUGH THE LIVESHEDS WINDOW. LET'S TRY THE NEXT  
LEFT

OF HILLS.

SEE THEY DISAPPEARED A FEW MILES FARTHER NORTH.

AH! SHOUTED RENN, AS THE WIND WHIPPED THEIR HAIR AND CLOTHES.  
RENN WAS POINTING UPWARD, TOWARD THE TOP OF THE HILL ON WHICH  
THEY

HAD APPEARED, WHERE A MOST STRANGE-LOOKING FELISE ROSE  
VERTICALLY

AGAINST THE SKY, A GREAT BLACK CYLINDER WITH A GHOSTLY MOON  
HANGING

BEHIND IT IN THE AFTERNOON SKY. THAT I GET THE REELING & FEELING,  
WHICH

ELSE WOULD LIVE IN A PLACE LIKE THAT? IT LOOKS LIKE A GIANT REELING!

## CHAPTER TWENTY

THE

IT IS NOTHING LIKE A KID, SAID HERMIONE, PREPARING AT THE TOWER.  
I WAS TALKING ABOUT A CROSS REELING, SAID REEL. A CASTLE THE REEL.  
REEL'S LEGS WERE THE LONGEST AND HE REACHED THE TOP OF THE HILL  
FIRST. WHEN HARRY AND HERMIONE CALLED UP WITH HIM, PANTING  
AND

CLUTCHING STITCHES IN THEIR SIDES, THEY FOUND HIM GRINNING BROADLY,

IT IS THEIRS, SAID REEL. REELING.

THREE HAND-PAINTED SIGNS HAD BEEN TACKLED TO A CRACKEN-BROWN  
GATE. THE FIRST READ,

THE HILKILER, EITHER: X. LEVYCEMENT

THE SECOND,

PICK REELING HORN MISTLETHEE

THE THIRD,

DEEP OFF THE DIRTIER PLAINS

THE GATE CREAKED AS THEY OPENED IT. THE ZIGZAGGING PATH LEADING

THE THE FRONT DOOR WAS EVERGREENS WITH A VARIETY OF FOD PLANTS,  
INCLD-

ING A BUSH COVERED IN THE ORANGE RADISH-LIKE FRUIT LUNA SOMETIMES

WHERE AS EARRINGS, HARRY THOUGHT HE RECOGNIZED A SNAREBALL AND  
GAVE

THE WIZENED STUMP A WIDE BERTH. THE AGED CRAB APPLE TREES, BENT  
WITH THE WIND, STRIPPED OF LEAVES BUT STILL HEAVY WITH BERRY-SIZED  
RED

FRUITS AND BUSHY CREWELS OF WHITE-BEADED MISTLETOE, STOOD SENTINEL  
EON EITHER SIDE OF THE FRONT DOOR. A LITTLE HILL WITH A SLIGHTLY  
FLATTENED,

HANDLIKE HEAD PEERED DOWN AT THEM FROM ONE OF THE BRANCHES,

YOU'D BETTER TAKE OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HARRY, SAID HERMI-  
ENE. IT'S YOU MR. LEVECHEE WANTS THE HELP, NOT US.

HE DID AS SHE SUGGESTED, HANDING HER THE CLOAK THE STEEL IN THE  
LEADED BAG. SHE THEN RAPPED THREE TIMES ON THE THICK BLACK DOOR,

XXXXXXXXXXXX LEVECHEE

END

WHICH WAS STUDDED WITH IRON NAILS AND BEHE A BENCHER SHAPED LIKE AN EAGLE.

BARELY TEN SECONDS PASSED, THEN THE DOOR WAS FLING OPEN AND THERE STOOD XENOPHILUS LEVECHEE, KAREHEET AND WEARING WHAT APPEARED

TO BE A STAINED NIGHT-SHIRT, HIS LONG WHITE CANDY-LESS HAIR WAS DIRTY

AND UNDEPT, XENOPHILUS HAD BEEN POSITIVELY DAPPER AT BILL AND FLEUR'S WEDDING BY COMPARISON.

WHAT? WHAT IS IT? WE ARE YELL? WHAT DO YOU WANT? HE CRIED IN A HIGH-PITCHED, HILVERLILIS VOICE, LOOKING FIRST AT FERMINE, THEN

AT RICH, AND FINALLY AT FARRY, UPON WHICH HIS MOUTH FELL OPEN IN A

PERFECT, CHEMICAL EE.

HELLO MR. LEVECHEE, SAID FARRY, HOLDING UP HIS HAND, I'M FARRY, FARRY PETER.

XENOPHILUS DID NOT TAKE FARRY'S HAND, ALTHOUGH THE EYE THAT WAS

NOT POINTING INWARD AT HIS NOSE SLID STRAIGHT TO THE SCAR ON FARRY'S

FOREHEAD.

WOULD IT BE OKAY IF WE CAME IN? ASKED FARRY. THERE'S SOMETHING WE'D LIKE TO ASK YOU.

I... I'M NOT SURE THAT'S ADVISABLE, WHISPERED XENOPHILUS. HE STAMMERED AND CAST A GLANCE BEHIND THE GARDEN, RATHER A

SEEMED . . . MY WORD . . . I . . . I'M AFRAID I DIDN'T REALLY THINK I HUGHT  
THE

IT DIDN'T TAKE LONG, SAID HARRY, SLIGHTLY DISAPPOINTED BY THIS  
LESS-THAN-WARM WELCOME.

I HED, ALL RIGHT THEN, COME IN, HILICELY, HILICELY?

THEY WERE BARELY EVER THE THRESHOLD WHEN XENOPHILUS SLAMMED  
THE DOOR SHUT BEHIND THEM. THEY WERE STANDING IN THE MOST  
PECULIAR

KITCHEN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN. THE ROOM WAS PERFECTLY CIRCULAR, SHE  
THAT

IT FELT LIKE BEING INSIDE A GIANT PEPPER PENT. EVERYTHING WAS CURVED

## CHAPTER TWENTY

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THE FIT THE WALLS THE STOVE, THE SINK, AND THE CUPBOARDS AND  
ALL

HED IT HAD BEEN PAINTED WITH FLOWERS, INSECTS, AND BIRDS IN BRIGHT PRI-  
MARY COLORS. HARRY THOUGHT HE RECOGNIZED LUNA'S STYLE! THE  
EFFECT,

IN SUCH AN ENCLOSED SPACE, WAS SLIGHTLY OVERWHELMING.

IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FLOOR, A BRIGHT-IRON SPIRAL STAIRCASE LED THE  
THE

UPPER LEVELS. THERE WAS A GREAT DEAL OF CLATTERING AND RANGING  
CHIMING



FROM HYPER-HEAD! HARRY WONDERED WHAT LILNA COULD BE DOING.

YOU'D BETTER COME UP, SAID XENOPHILIUS, STILL BEHAVING EXTREMELY UNCOMFORTABLE, AND HE LED THE WAY.

THE ROOM ABOVE SEEMED TO BE A COMBINATION OF LIVING ROOM AND WORKPLACE, AND AS SUCH, WAS EVEN MORE CLUTTERED THAN THE KITCHEN.

THOUGH MUCH SMALLER AND ENTIRELY REAR, THE ROOM SOMEWHAT RESEMBLED THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT IN THE UNFORGETTABLE OCCASION

THAT IT HAD TRANSFORMED ITSELF INTO A GIGANTIC LABYRINTH COMPRISED OF CENTURIES OF HIDDEN HIKETS. THERE WERE PILES UPON PILES OF BOOKS

AND PAPERS IN EVERY SURFACE. DELICATELY MADE MODELS OF CREATURES

HARRY DID NOT RECOGNIZE, ALL FLAPPING WINGS OR SNAPPING JAWS, FINE

FROM THE CEILING.

LILNA WAS NOT THERE! THE THING THAT WAS MAKING SUCH A RACKET WAS A WOODEN HIKET COVERED IN MAGICALLY TURNING CHES AND WHEELS. IT BEHEVED LIKE THE BIZARRE OFFSPRING OF A WOODKENCH AND A SET OF

OLD SEELVES, BUT AFTER A MOMENT HARRY DECIDED THAT IT WAS AN OLD-FASHIONED PRINTING PRESS, BUT THE FACT THAT IT WAS TURNING

CLIKKERS.

EXCUSE ME, SAID XENOPHILIUS, AND HE STRODE OVER THE THE MACHINE, SEIZED A GRUBBY TABLET FROM BENEATH AN IMMENSE NUMBER

HE KICKED AND PAPERS, WHICH ALL TUMBLLED BENTH THE FLOOR, AND THREW IT

OVER THE PRESS, SOMEWHAT MUFFLING THE HELD RANGES AND CLATTERS, HE THEN FACED HARRY.

WENDPHILILIS LEVYCEHHH

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WHY HAVE YOU COME HERE?

BEFORE HARRY COULD SPEAK, HOWEVER, FERMINE LET OUT A SMALL CRY OF SURPRISE.

MR. LEVYCEHHH WHAT IS THAT?

SHE WAS POINTING AT AN ENORMOUS, GRAY SPIRAL HORN, NOT UNLIKE THAT OF A UNICORN, WHICH HAD BEEN MOUNTED ON THE WALL, PROJECTING

SEVERAL FEET INTO THE ROOM.

IT IS THE HORN OF A CRUMPLE-HORNED SNORRACK, SAID WENDPHILILIS.

OH IT ISN'T? SAID FERMINE.

FERMINE, MUTTERED HARRY, EMBARRASSED, WELL I MET THE MOMENT

BUT HARRY, IT IS AN ERLINPELT HORN! IT IS A CLASS B TRADEABLE MATERIAL AND IT IS AN EXTRAORDINARILY DANGEROUS THING TO HAVE IN A HOUSE!

"HOW DO YOU KNOW IT'S AN CRIMPENT HORN?" ASKED REIN, EDGING AWAY FROM THE HORN AS FAST AS HE COULD, GIVEN THE EXTREME CLITTER OF THE REIN.

THERE'S A DESCRIPTION IN FANTASTIC BEASTS AND WHERE TO FIND THEM:

MR. LEVEGHEED, YOU NEED TO GET RID OF IT STRAIGHTAWAY, DIDN'T YOU KNOW

IT CAN EXPLODE AT THE SLIGHTEST TOUCH?

THE CRIMPLE-HORNED SNORRACK, SAID XENOPHILUS VERY CLEARLY, A POLISH LEND UPON HIS FACE, IS A SHY AND HIGHLY MAGICAL CREATURE,

AND ITS HORN

MR. LEVEGHEED, I RECOGNIZE THE GRIEVED MARKINGS AROUND THE BASE, THAT'S AN CRIMPENT HORN AND IT'S INCREDIBLY DANGEROUS I DIDN'T KNOW WHERE YOU GOT IT

I REUGHT IT, SAID XENOPHILUS DEGOMATICALLY, TWO WEEKS AGO, FROM

A DELIGHTFUL YELING WIZARD WHO KNEW OF MY INTEREST IN THE EXHIBITS

## CHAPTER TWENTY

\*\*\*

SNORRACK, A CHRISTMAS SURPRISE FOR MY LUNA, NOW, HE SAID, TURNING

THE HARRY, WHY EXACTLY HAVE YOU COME HERE, MR. POTTER?

WE NEED SOME HELP, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE HERMIONE COULD START

AGAIN.

“AH, SAID XENOPHILUS, HELP, I AM.

HIS GOOD EYE MOVED AGAIN THE HARRY S STAR, HE SEEMED SIMULTANEOUSLY TERRIFIED AND MESMERIZED.

YES, THE THING IS . . . HELPING HARRY BETTER . . . RATHER DANGEROUS . . .

AREN T YOU THE ONE WHO KEEPS TELLING EVERYONE IT S THEIR FIRST DUTY

TO HELP HARRY? SAID RHN. IN THAT MAGAZINE OF YOURS?

XENOPHILUS GLANCED BEHIND HIM AT THE CONCEALED PRINTING PRESS, STILL RANGING AND CLATTERING BENEATH THE TABLETTS.

ER YES, I HAVE EXPRESSED THAT VIEW, HOWEVER

THAT S FOR EVERYONE ELSE THE ONE WHO PERSONALLY? SAID RHN. XENOPHILUS DID NOT ANSWER, HE KEPT STALLING, HIS EYES DARTING BETWEEN THE THREE OF THEM. HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT HE WAS UNDERGOING SOME PAINFUL INTERNAL STRUGGLE.

WHERE S LUNA? ASKED HERMIONE. LET S SEE WHAT SHE THINKS. XENOPHILUS GLIMPED, HE SEEMED TO BE STEELING HIMSELF, FINALLY HE SAID IN A SLEAZY VOICE DIFFICULT TO HEAR OVER THE NOISE OF THE PRINTING

PRESS, LUNA IS DOWN AT THE STREAM, FISHING FOR FRESH-WATER PLIMPIES.

SHE . . . SHE WILL LIKE TO SEE YOU, I LL GO AND CALL HER AND THEN YES,

VERY WELL, I SHALL TRY TO HELP YOU.

HE DISAPPEARED DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE AND THEY HEARD THE FRONT  
DOOR OPEN AND CLOSE. THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER.

LEONARDY HAD WART, SAID RENN. LINDA S GOT TEN TIMES HIS CLITS.

HE S PROBABLY WORRIED ABOUT WHAT LL HAPPEN THE THEM IF THE DEATH  
EATERS FIND OUT I WAS HERE, SAID HARRY.

~~XXXXXXXXXXXX~~

XXX

WELL, I AGREE WITH RENN, SAID HERMINE. ALPLI HAD HYPERITE,

TELLING EVERYONE ELSE THE HELP MEH AND TRYING THE WHOM OUT OF IT  
HIM-

SELF, AND FOR HEAVEN S SAKS KEEP AWAY FROM THAT FERN.

HARRY CROSSED THE THE WINDMILL ON THE FAR SIDE OF THE RIVER, HE  
COULD SEE A STREAM, A THIN, GLITTERING RIBBON LYING FAR BELOW THEM  
AT THE BASE OF THE HILL. THEY WERE VERY HIGH UP; A BIRD FLUTTERED  
PAST

THE WINDMILL AS HE STARED IN THE DIRECTION OF THE CLIFFS, NOW  
INVIS-

IBLE BEYOND ANOTHER LINE OF HILLS. GINNY WAS NEVER THERE  
SOMEWHERE.

THEY WERE CLOSER TO EACH OTHER TODAY THAN THEY HAD BEEN SINCE BILL

AND FLEW'S WEDDING, BUT SHE COULD HAVE NO IDEA HE WAS GAZING TOWARD HER NOW, THINKING OF HER. HE SUPPOSED HE MIGHT BE BE GLAD OF

IT; ANYONE HE CAME INTO CONTACT WITH WAS IN DANGER, XENOPHILUS'S

ATTITUDE PROVED THAT.

HE TURNED AWAY FROM THE WINDOW AND HIS GAZE FELL UPON ANOTHER PECULIAR BEIST STANDING UPON THE CLUTTERED, CLAYED SIDEPATH: A STONE LIST OF A BEAUTIFUL BUT ALISTERE-LOOKING LITTLE WEARING A

WIZARD-LOOKING HEADRESS. THE BEISTS THAT RESEMBLED CHILDEN EAR TRUMPETS CLAYED OUT FROM THE SIDES, A TINY PAIR OF GLITTERING BLUE WINGS WAS STUCK TO A LEATHER STRAP THAT RAN OVER THE TOP OF HER HEAD,

WHILE ONE OF THE STRANGE RADISHES HAD BEEN STUCK TO A SECOND STRAP AROUND HER THREE-HEAD.

LOOK AT THIS, SAID HARRY.

PETCHING, SAID BEN. SURPRISED HE DIDN'T WEAR THAT THE THE WEDDING.

THEY HEARD THE FRONT DOOR CLASH, AND A MOMENT LATER XENOPHILUS HAD CLIMBED BACK UP THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE INTO THE ROOM, HIS THIN

LEGS NOW ENCASED IN WELLINGTON BOOTS, BEARING A TRAY OF IL-ASSORTED

TEACUPS AND A STREAMING TRAPPEL.

“Ah, you have spotted my pet invention,” he said, showing the

## CHAPTER TWENTY

“Mm

tray into Fermine’s arms and leaning Harry at the statue’s side.

Modelled, fittingly enough, upon the head of the beautiful  
Rhena

Ravenclaw. Wit beyond measure is man’s greatest treasure!

He indicated the objects like ear trumpets.

These are the Wrackspurt siphons     to remove all sources of  
distraction from the thinker’s immediate area. Here, he pointed  
out

the tiny wings, a billywig propeller, the index and elevated frame  
of

mind. Finally, he pointed to the orange radish, the dirigible  
pump.

See as the enhance the ability to accept the extraordinary.

Xenophilus strode back to the tea tray, which Fermine had  
man-

aged the balance precariously on one of the cluttered side tables.

“May I offer you all an infusion of Glindwrights?” said Xenophil-  
us. We make it ourselves. As he started the phial out the drink,

which was as deeply purple as beetroot juice, he added, “Lina is

DOWN BEYOND BATTERY BRIDGE, SHE IS MOST EXCITED THAT YOU ARE HERE.

SHE MIGHT NOT BE THE LONG, SHE HAS GAINED NEARLY ENOUGH  
PUMP-

YES THE MAKE SURE FOR ALL OF US. SHE SIT DOWN AND HELP YOURSELVES THE

SURE.

WELL, HE REMOVED A TATTERED PILE OF PAPERS FROM AN ARMCHAIR  
AND SAT DOWN, HIS WELLINGTONED LEGS CROSSED, HOW MAY I HELP YOU,  
MR. PETER?

WELL, SAID HARRY, GLANCING AT HERMINE, WE NEED ENCLIN-  
ACINGLY, IT IS ABOUT THAT SOME OF YOU WERE WEARING ABOUT YOUR  
NECK

AT BILL AND FLEET'S WEDDING, MR. LEVEE, WE WONDERED WHAT IT  
MEANT.

GENEPIHILIS RAISED HIS EYEBROWS.

ARE YOU REFERRING TO THE SIGN OF THE DEATHLY HALLS?

## CHAPTER TWENTY - END

THE

THE TALL OF THE  
THREE BROTHERS



ARRY TURNED THE LEADS AT RENN AND HERMINE. NEITHER OF THEM SEEMED TO HAVE UNDERSTOOD WHAT XENOPHILUS HAD

SAID EITHER.

THE DEADLY FALLS?

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID XENOPHILUS. YELL HAVEN'T HEARD OF THEM?  
I'M

NOT SURPRISED, VERY, VERY FEW WIZARDS BELIEVE. WITNESS THAT  
DRAKLE-

HEADED YELLING MAN AT YELLER BROTHER'S WEDDING, HE NEEDED AT RENN,

WHEN ATTACKED BY HER SPORTING THE SYMBOL OF A WELL-KNOWN DARK  
WIZARD! SUCH IGNORANCE. THERE IS NOTHING DARK ABOUT THE  
FALLS

AT LEAST, NOT IN THAT CRUDE SENSE, HERE SIMPLY LIES THE SYMBOL THE  
REVEAL HIMSELF TO EITHER BELIEVERS, IN THE HOPE THAT THEY MIGHT  
HELP

HERE WITH THE ELDEST.

HE STIRRED SEVERAL LUMPS OF SUGAR INTO HIS CLARYNETT INFUSION  
AND DRANK SOME.

I'M SORRY, SAID HARRY, I STILL DON'T REALLY UNDERSTAND.  
THE BE PHILIP, HE TOOK A SIP FROM HIS CUP THEN, AND ALMOST GAGGED!  
H

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

THE

THE STUFF WAS WHITE DISGUSTING, AS THOUGH SOMEONE HAD LIQUIDIZED  
BEEFY-FLAVORED EVERY FLAVOR BEANS.

WELL, YOU SEE, BELIEVERS SEED THE DEATHLY FALLINGS, SAID XENOPHILUS, SMACKING HIS LIPS IN APPARENT APPRECIATION OF THE  
GLINDYRETT

INFLUENCE.

BUT WHAT ARE THE DEATHLY FALLINGS? ASKED HERMIONE.  
XENOPHILUS SET ASIDE HIS EMPTY TEACUP.

I ASSUME THAT YOU ARE ALL FAMILIAR WITH THE TALE OF THE THREE  
BROTHERS ?

HARRY SAID, NO, BUT RON AND HERMIONE BOTH SAID, YES. XENOPHILUS NEEDED GRAVELY.

WELL, WELL, MR. POTTER, THE WHOLE THING STARTS WITH THE TALE OF  
THE THREE BROTHERS ... I HAVE A COPY SOMEWHERE, ...  
HE GLANCED VAGUELY AROUND THE ROOM, AT THE PILES OF PARCHMENT  
AND BOOKS, BUT HERMIONE SAID, I VE GOT A COPY, MR. LEVERHEAD, I VE  
GOT IT RIGHT HERE.  
AND SHE PULLED OUT THE TALES OF BEEDLE THE BARD FROM THE SMALL,  
WEADED BAG.

THE ORIGINAL? INQUIRED XENOPHILUS SHARPLY, AND WHEN SHE  
NOD-

DED, HE SAID, WELL THEN, WHY DONT YOU READ IT ALLOUD? MUCH THE BEST

WAS THE MADE SURE WE ALL UNDERSTAND,

ER... ALL RIGHT, SAID HERMINE NERVELISLY, SHE OPENED THE BOOK,  
AND HARRY SAW THAT THE SYMBOL THEY WERE INVESTIGATING HEADED THE  
TOP OF THE PAGE AS SHE GAVE A LITTLE CUGH, AND BEGAN THE READ,

THERE WERE ENCE THREE BROTHERS WHO WERE TRAVELING ALONG A  
WINDING ROAD AT TWILIGHT

MIDNIGHT, ELIAH MAN ALWAYS TOLD US, SAID RICH, WHO HAD STRETCHED  
HIS, ARMS BEHIND HIS HEAD, THE LISTEN, HERMINE SENT HIM A LOOK OF  
ANNEDANCE,

THE TALL OF THE  
THREE BROTHERS

AND

SHRUG, I JUST THINK IT S A KIT SPEEDIER IF IT S MIDNIGHT? SAID RICH,

YEAH, BECAUSE WE REALLY NEED A KIT MORE FEAR IN ELIAH LIVES, SAID  
HARRY BEFORE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF, XENOPHILUS DID NOT SEEM THE  
BE PAYING MUCH ATTENTION, BUT WAS STARING OUT OF THE WINDOW AT THE

SEA, OH EN, HERMINE,

IN TIME, THE BROTHERS REACHED A RIVER THAT DEEP THE MADE THROUGH  
AND

THE DANGEROUS THE SWIM ACROSS, HOWEVER, THESE BROTHERS WERE  
LEARNED IN

THE MAGICAL ARTS, AND SEE THEY SIMPLY WAVED THEIR WANDS AND MADE A  
BRIDGE APPEAR ACROSS THE TREACHEROUS WATER. THEY WERE HALFWAY  
ACROSS IT

WHEN THEY FELT THEIR PATH BLOCKED BY A FLEETING FIGURE.

AND DEATH SPEAK TO THEM

SHRIMP, INTERRUPTED HARRY, BUT DEATH SPEAK TO THEM?

IT IS A FAIRY TALE, HARRY.

RIGHT, SHRIMP, GEE HEN.

AND DEATH SPEAK TO THEM, HE WAS ANGRY THAT HE HAD BEEN CHEATED  
BUT HE THREE NEW VICTIMS, THE TRAVELERS USUALLY DROWNED IN THE  
RIVER, BUT

DEATH WAS CUNNING, HE PRETENDED TO CONGRATULATE THE THREE  
BROTHERS

UPON THEIR MAGIC, AND SAID THAT EACH HAD EARNED A PRIZE FOR  
HAVING

BEEN CLEVER ENOUGH TO EVADE HIM.

SEE THE ELDEST BROTHER, WHO WAS A CREATIVE MAN, ASKED FOR A  
WAND

MORE POWERFUL THAN ANY IN EXISTENCE: A WAND THAT MUST ALWAYS  
WIN BILLS

FOR ITS OWNER, A WAND WORTHY OF A WIZARD WHO HAD CHALLENGED  
DEATH: SEE

DEATH CROSSED THE AN ELDER TREE ON THE BANKS OF THE RIVER, FASTENED  
A WAND

FROM A BRANCH THAT HUNG THERE, AND GAVE IT TO THE ELDEST BROTHER.

THEN THE SECOND BROTHER, WHO WAS AN ARROGANT MAN, DECIDED THAT  
HE WANTED TO HUMILIATE DEATH STILL FURTHER, AND ASKED FOR THE  
POWER TO

RECALL OTHERS FROM DEATH. SEE DEATH PICKED UP A STONE FROM THE  
RIVERBANK

AND GAVE IT TO THE SECOND BROTHER, AND TOLD HIM THAT THE STONE  
WOULD

HAVE THE POWER TO BRING BACK THE DEAD.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

\*\*\*

AND THEN DEATH ASKED THE THIRD AND YOUNGEST BROTHER WHAT HE  
WOULD LIKE. THE YOUNGEST BROTHER WAS THE SIMPLEST AND ALSO THE  
WISEST

OF THE BROTHERS, AND HE DID NOT TRUST DEATH. SO HE ASKED FOR  
SOMETHING

THAT WOULD ENABLE HIM TO GET AWAY FROM THAT PLACE WITHOUT BEING  
SEEN-

OFFERED BY DEATH. AND DEATH, MOST UNWILLINGLY, HANDED OVER HIS OWN

CLASH OF INVISIBILITY.

DEATH'S GIFT AN INVISIBILITY CLASH? HARRY INTERRUPTED AGAIN.

SO HE CAN SNEAK UP ON PEOPLE, SAID HE. SOMETIMES HE GETS  
BEHIND ME RUNNING AT THEM, FLAPPING HIS ARMS AND SHRIeking ...  
SHRIeking,

TERMININE.

THEN DEATH STEPPED ASIDE AND ALLOWED THE THREE BROTHERS TO  
CONTINUE

ON THEIR WAY, AND THEY DID SEE, TALKING WITH WHOMER OF THE  
ADVENTURE

THEY HAD HAD, AND ADMIRING DEATH'S GIFTS.

IN ONE CHURCH THE BROTHERS SEPARATED, EACH FOR HIS OWN  
DESTINATION.

THE FIRST BROTHER TRAVELED ON FOR A WEEK OR MORE, AND REACHING  
A

DISTANT VILLAGE, HE MET A FELLOW WIZARD WITH WHOM HE HAD A  
FRIEND-

REL. NATURALLY, WITH THE ELDER WARD AS HIS WEAPON, HE COULD NOT  
FAIL

THE WIN THE DUEL THAT FOLLOWED, LEAVING HIS ENEMY DEAD UPON THE  
FLOOR,

THE ELDEST BROTHER PROCEEDED TO AN INN, WHERE HE REJECTED HEAVILY OF  
THE

POWERFUL WARD HE HAD SNATCHED FROM DEATH HIMSELF, AND HE KNEW IT  
MADE HIM INVINCIBLE.

THAT VERY NIGHT, ANOTHER WIZARD CROPT UPON THE ELDEST BROTHER  
AS HE

LAY, WINE-DRUNKEN, UPON HIS BED, THE THREE THREW THE WARD AND, FOR  
GOOD

MEASURE, SLIT THE ELDEST BROTHER'S THROAT.

AND SO DEATH THREW THE FIRST BROTHER FOR HIS OWN.

MEANWHILE, THE SECOND BROTHER JOURNEYED TO HIS OWN HOME,  
WHERE

HE LIVED ALONE. THERE HE THREW OUT THE STONE THAT HAD THE POWER TO  
RECALL

THE DEAD, AND TURNED IT TRICE IN HIS HAND. TO HIS AMAZEMENT AND  
HIS

THE TALL OF THE

## THREE BROTHERS

\*\*\*

DELIGHT, THE FIGURE OF THE GIRL HE HAD ONCE LOVED THE MARRY, BEFORE  
HER

UNTIMELY DEATH, APPEARED AT ONCE BEFORE HIM.

BUT SHE WAS SAD AND COLD, SEPARATED FROM HIM AS BY A VEIL,  
THOUGH

SHE HAD RETURNED TO THE MORTAL WORLD, SHE DID NOT TRULY BELONG  
THERE AND

SUFFERED. FINALLY THE SECOND BROTHER, DRIVEN MAD WITH HELPLESS  
LONGING,

KILLED HIMSELF SEE AS TRULY THE IDOL HER,

AND SHE DIED THUS THE SECOND BROTHER FOR HIS LOVE.

BUT THOUGH DEATH SEARCHED FOR THE THIRD BROTHER FOR MANY  
YEARS, HE

WAS NEVER ABLE TO FIND HIM. IT WAS ONLY WHEN HE HAD ATTAINED A  
GREAT

AGE THAT THE YOUNGEST BROTHER FINALLY THREW OFF THE CHAIN OF  
INVISIBILITY

AND GAVE IT TO HIS SON. AND THEN HE GREETED DEATH AS AN OLD FRIEND,  
AND

WENT WITH HIM GLADLY, AND, FIDELIALLY, THEY DEPARTED THIS LIFE.

BERNARDINE CLOSED THE BOOK. IT WAS A MOMENT FOR THEM BEFORE  
PHILIP'S SEEMED TO REALIZE THAT SHE HAD STOPPED READING, THEN HE  
WITH-

DREW HIS GAZE FROM THE WINDOW AND SAID, WELL, THERE THEY ARE.

STORY? SAID FERMINE, SOUNDING CONFUSED.

THESE ARE THE DEATHLY FALLS, SAID XENOPHILUS.

HE PICKED UP A KNIFE FROM A PADDED TABLE AT HIS ELBOW, AND PULLED A THIN PIECE OF PARCHMENT FROM BETWEEN MORE BOOKS.

THE ELDER LORD, HE SAID, AND HE DREW A STRAIGHT VERTICAL LINE UPON THE PARCHMENT. THE RESURRECTION STONE, HE SAID, AND HE ADDED

A CIRCLE END OF THE LINE. THE CIRCLE OF INVISIBILITY, HE FINISHED, EN-

CLOSING BOTH LINE AND CIRCLE IN A TRIANGLE, HE MADE THE SYMBOL THAT SHE

INTRIGUED FERMINE. TOGETHER, HE SAID, THE DEATHLY FALLS.

BUT THERE IS NO MENTION OF THE WORDS DEATHLY FALLS IN THE STORY, SAID FERMINE.

WELL, OF COURSE NOT, SAID XENOPHILUS, MADDENINGLY SMILE. THAT IS A CHILDREN'S TALE, TELL THE AMUSE RATHER THAN THE INSTRUCT. THESE OF US

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

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WE UNDERSTAND THESE MATTERS, HOWEVER, RECOGNIZE THAT THE ANCIENT



STORY REFERS THE THREE OBJECTS, HER FALLINGS, WHICH, IF LIMITED, WILL  
MAKE

THE POSSESSOR MASTER OF DEATH.

THERE WAS A SHORT SILENCE IN WHICH XENOPHILUS GLANCED OUT OF  
THE

WINDOW. ALREADY THE SUN WAS LOW IN THE SKY.

LUNA MIGHT THE HAVE ENOUGH PLIMPS SEEN, HE SAID QUIETLY,

WHEN YOU SAY MASTER OF DEATH SAID RICH,

MASTER, SAID XENOPHILUS, HAVING AN AIRY HAND. CHERUBIM,  
VANGLISHIER, WHICHEVER TERM YOU PREFER.

BUT THEN . . . OH YOU MEAN . . . SAID FERMINE SLEELY, AND HARRY  
CHILD TELL THAT SHE WAS TRYING THE DEEP AND TRACE OF SKEPTICISM OUT  
OF

HER VIEW, THAT YOU BELIEVE THESE OBJECTS THESE FALLINGS  
ACTU-  
ALLY EXIST?

XENOPHILUS RAISED HIS EYEBROWS AGAIN.

WELL, OF COURSE.

BUT, SAID FERMINE, AND HARRY CHILD HEAR HER RESTRAINT  
STARTING

THE CRACK, MR. LEVERETT, HOW CAN YOU POSSIBLY BELIEVE ?

LUNA HAS TOLD ME ALL ABOUT YOU, YOUNG LADY, SAID XENOPHILUS.

YOU ARE, I GATHER, NOT UNINTELLIGENT, BUT PAINFULLY LIMITED.  
NARRATE,

CHEER-MINDED.

PERHAPS YOU MIGHT TRY ON THE HAT, FERMINE, SAID RICH,

NODDING TOWARD THE LUDICROUS HEADRESS, HIS VOICE SPOKE WITH THE STRAIN OF DEEP LAUGHING.

MR. LEVEEQUE, HERMIENE BEGAN AGAIN. WE ALL KNOW THAT THERE ARE SUCH THINGS AS INVISIBILITY CLOAKS. THEY ARE RARE, BUT THEY EXIST.

BUT

AH, BUT THE THIRD FALLER IS A TRUE CLOAK OF INVISIBILITY, MISS

GRANGER? I MEAN TO SAY, IT IS NOT A TRAVELING CLOAK IMBLED WITH A DIS-

ILLUSIONMENT CHARM, NOR CARRYING A BEDAZZLING PEARL, NOR ELSE WHEN

THE TALK OF THE

THREE BROTHERS

911

FROM DEMIGLISE HAIR, WHICH WILL HIDE ONE INITIALLY BUT FADE WITH THE

YEARS UNTIL IT TURNS GRAY. WE ARE TALKING ABOUT A CLOAK THAT REALLY

AND TRULY RENDERS THE WEARER COMPLETELY INVISIBLE, AND ENDURES ETERNALLY, GIVING CONSTANT AND IMPENETRABLE CONCEALMENT, NO MATTER

WHAT SPELLS ARE CAST AT IT. FEW MANY CLOAKS HAVE BEEN EVER SEEN LIKE

THAT, MISS GRANGER?

HERMIENE OPENED HER MOUTH TO ANSWER, THEN CLOSED IT AGAIN,

LOOKING MORE CONFUSED THAN EVER. SHE, HARRY, AND BEN GLANCED AT ONE ANOTHER, AND HARRY KNEW THAT THEY WERE ALL THINKING THE

SAME THING. IT SEEMED THAT A CLHAK EXACTLY LIKE THE ONE  
~~WENT~~

PHILIP HAD JUST DESCRIBED WAS IN THE ROOM WITH THEM AT THAT VERY

MOMENT.

EXACTLY, SAID ~~WENT~~PHILIP, AS IF HE HAD DEFEATED THEM ALL IN  
REASONED ARGUMENT. WHEN HE WOULD HAVE EVER SEEN SUCH A THING.  
THE

PRESSESSOR WOULD BE IMMEASURABLY RICH, WOULD HE NOT?

HE GLANCED OUT OF THE WINDOW AGAIN. THE SKY WAS NOW TINGED  
WITH THE FAINTEST TRACE OF PINK.

ALL RIGHT, SAID HERMINE, DISHONESTED. SAY THE CLHAK EXISTED  
... WHAT ABOUT THE STONE, MR. ~~WENT~~? THE THING YOU CALL THE  
RESURRECTION STONE?

WHAT OF IT?

WELL, HOW CAN THAT BE REAL?

PROVE THAT IT IS NOT, SAID ~~WENT~~PHILIP.

HERMINE LOOKED ELTRAGED.

BUT THAT'S I'M SORRY, BUT THAT'S COMPLETELY RIDICULOUS! HOW  
CAN I POSSIBLY PROVE IT DOESN'T EXIST? DO YOU EXPECT ME TO GET HOLD  
OF ALL THE PEBBLES IN THE WORLD AND TEST THEM? I MEAN, YOU  
WOULD CLAIM THAT ANYTHING IS REAL IF THE ONLY BASIS FOR BELIEVING IN  
IT

IS THAT NOBODY'S PROVED IT DOESN'T EXIST?

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

912

YES, YELL CHILD, SAID XENOPHILUS. I AM GLAD TO SEE THAT YOU ARE OPENING YOUR MIND A LITTLE.

SEE THE ELDER WAND, SAID HARRY BRISKLY, REHERE FERMINE CHILD RETERT, YOU THINK THAT EXISTS THEN?

EH, WELL, IN THAT CASE THERE IS ENDLESS EVIDENCE, SAID XENOPHILUS. THE ELDER WAND IS THE FALLER THAT IS MOST EASILY TRACED, BECAUSE OF THE WAY IN WHICH IT PASSES FROM HAND TO HAND.

WHICH IS WHAT? ASKED HARRY.

WHICH IS THAT THE POSSESSOR OF THE WAND MUST CAPTURE IT FROM

ITS PREVIOUS OWNER, IF HE IS THE TRULY MASTER OF IT, SAID XENOPHILUS.

SURELY YOU HAVE HEARD OF THE WAY THE WAND CAME TO ROBERT THE

RESCUEE, AFTER HIS SLAUGHTER OF EMERIL THE EVIL OF FINE GORRETT DIED IN HIS OWN CELLAR AFTER HIS SON, FERREARD, TOOK THE WAND FROM HIM OF THE DREADFUL LEMMAS, WHEN TOOK THE WAND FROM BARNABAS DEVERILL, WHEN HE HAD KILLED? THE BLOODY TRAIL OF THE ELDER WAND IS SPLATTERED ACROSS THE PAGES OF WIZARDING HISTORY.

HARRY GLANCED AT FERMINE. SHE WAS FROWNING AT XENOPHILUS,

BUT SHE DID NOT CONTRADICT HIM.

SEE WHERE SHE WOULD THINK THE ELDER LAND IS NOW? ASKED RICH.

ALAS, WE-KNOWS? SAID XENOPHILUS, AS HE GAZED OUT OF THE WINDOW. WE-KNOWS WHERE THE ELDER LAND LIES HIDDEN? THE TRAIL GOES ON WITH ARCLIS AND LIVILIS, WE-KN CAN SAY WHICH OF THEM REALLY

DEFEATED LEXIAS, AND WHICH THEM THE LAND? AND WE-KN CAN SAY WE-KN MAY HAVE DEFEATED THEM? FISTHERY, ALAS, SHE'S NOT TELL US.

THERE WAS A PAUSE. FINALLY FERMINE ASKED STIFFLY, MR. LEVE-GOOD, DOES THE PEYERELL FAMILY HAVE ANYTHING TO DO WITH THE DEATHLY

CHALLENGE?

XENOPHILUS LOOKED TAKEN ABACK AS SOMETHING SHIFTED IN HARRY'S

THE TALK OF THE  
THEIR BROTHERS

ALL

MEMORY, BUT HE COULD NOT LOCATE IT. PEYERELL . . . HE HAD HEARD THAT NAME BEFORE. . .

BUT SHE HAD BEEN MISLEADING ME, SAYING HERMAN? SAID XENOPHILUS, NOW SITTING UP MUCH STRAIGHTER IN HIS CHAIR AND GEEGLING AT

HERMINE, I THOUGHT YOU WERE NEW TO THE FALLENS HOUSE! MANY  
OF

THE GUESTS BELIEVE THAT THE PEVERELS HAVE EVERYTHING  
EVERYTHING!

THE ONE WITH THE FALLENS!

WHO ARE THE PEVERELS? ASKED BEN.

THAT WAS THE NAME ON THE GRAVE WITH THE MARK ON IT, IN  
GEOFF'S

HOUSE, SAID HERMINE, STILL WATCHING XENOPHILUS, IGNEUS  
PEVEREL.

EXACTLY! SAID XENOPHILUS, HIS FINGER RAISED DIGNIFIEDLY.

THE SIGN OF THE DEATHLY FALLENS ON IGNEUS'S GRAVE IS  
CONFIDENTIAL

RIGHT?

OF WHAT? ASKED BEN.

WELL, THAT THE THREE BROTHERS IN THE STORY WERE ACTUALLY THE  
THREE

PEVEREL BROTHERS, ANTHONY, CADMUS, AND IGNEUS! THAT THEY WERE  
THE ORIGINAL OWNERS OF THE FALLENS!

WITH ANOTHER GLANCE AT THE WINDOW HE GOT TO HIS FEET, PICKED UP  
THE TRAY, AND HEADED FOR THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE.

YOU WILL STAY FOR DINNER? HE CALLED, AS HE VANISHED DOWNSTAIRS  
AGAIN. EVERYBODY ALWAYS REQUESTS HIS RECIPE FOR FRESH-WATER  
PLUM

SHIRAZ.

PROBABLY TO SEE THE POLISHING DEPARTMENT AT ST. MUNG'S,  
SAID BEN UNDER HIS BREATH.

HARRY WAITED UNTIL THEY COULD HEAR XENOPHILUS MOVING AWAY

IN THE KITCHEN DOWNSTAIRS BEFORE SPREADING.

WHAT DO YOU THINK? HE ASKED HERMIONE.

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919

HE, HARRY, SHE SAID WEARILY, IT'S A PILE OF LITTER LIKEWISE. THIS CAN'T BE WHAT THE SIGN REALLY MEANS. THIS MUST JUST BE HIS WEIRD TAKE

ON IT. WHAT A WASTE OF TIME.

I'VE FEEL THIS IS THE MAN WHO BRILLIANTLY CRUMPLE-FOURNED SNEER-  
BACKS, SAID RON.

YOU DON'T BELIEVE IT EITHER? HARRY ASKED HIM.

NO, THAT STORY'S JUST ONE OF THESE THINGS YOU TELL KIDS THE TRICK-  
THERM LESSONS, ISN'T IT? DON'T GO WHEEDLING FOR TROUBLE, DON'T PICK  
FIGHTS,

DON'T GO MESSING AROUND WITH STUFF THAT'S BEST LEFT ALONE! JUST  
KEEP

YOUR HEAD DOWN, MIND YOUR OWN BUSINESS, AND YOU'LL BE OKAY. COME  
THE THINK OF IT, RON ADDED, MAYBE THAT STORY'S WHY ELDER WANDS ARE  
SUPPOSED TO BE UNLUCKY.

WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT?

ONE OF THESE SUPERSTITIONS, ISN'T IT? MAY-BEEN WITCHES WILL  
MARRY

MUGGLES. INK BY TWILIGHT, LINDEN BY MIDNIGHT. WAND OF ELDER,

NEVER PROSPER. YOU MUST VE HEARD THEM, MY MUM S FULL OF THEM.

HARRY AND I WERE RAISED BY MUGGLES, HERMIONE REMINDED HIM.

WE WERE TALKEHT DIFFERENT SUPERSTITIENS. SHE SIGHED DEEPLY AS A RATHER PLINGENT SMELL DRIFTED UP FROM THE KITCHEN. THE ONE GOOD THING ABELT HER EXASPERATIEN WITH ~~HERMION~~ HILIS WAS THAT IT SEEMED THE

HAVE MADE HER FORGET THAT SHE WAS ANNOYED AT RON. I THINK YOU RE

RIGHT, SHE TOLD HIM. IT S ILST A MORALITY TALE, IT S HERVEELS WHICH GIFT

IS BEST, WHICH ONE YOU D CHOOSE

THE THREE OF THEM SPoke AT THE SAME TIME: HERMIONE SAID, THE CLOAK, RON SAID, THE WAND, AND HARRY SAID, THE STONE.

THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, HALF SURPRISED, HALF AMUSED.

YOU RE SUPPOSED THE SAY THE CLOAK, RON TOLD HERMIONE, BUT YOU WOULDN T NEED THE BE INVISIBLE IF YOU HAD THE WAND, AN UNBREAKABLE WAND, HERMIONE, CAME ON:

THE TALE OF THE  
THREE BROTHERS

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WE VE ALREADY GIFT AN INVISIBILITY CLOAK, SAID HARRY.

AND IT S HELPED US RATHER A LOT, IN CASE YOU HADN T NOTICED: SAID HERMIONE. WHEREAS THE WAND WOULD BE BEHIND THE ATTRACT TRELLER

ONLY IF YOU SPELITED ABELT IT, ARGUED RON. ONLY IF YOU WERE



PRAT ENOUGH TH GH DANKING ARHLND, WAVING IT EVER YHLR HEAD, AND SINGING, I VE GHT AN UNKEATABLE WAND, CHEM AND HAVE A GH IF YHL THIND YHL RE HARD ENOUGH. AS LONG AS YHL DEPT YHLR TRAP SE-IT

YES, BUT COULD YHL DEPT YHLR TRAP SE-IT? SAID HERMIONE, SOUN-  
ING SKEPTICAL. YHL KNEL, THE ONLY TRUE THING HE SAID TH WAS  
THAT

THERE HAVE BEEN STORIES ABOUT EXTRA-PHEWFUL WANDS FOR HUNDREDS  
OF

YEARS.

THERE HAVE? ASKED HARRY.

HERMIONE SOUNDED EXASPERATED: THE EXPRESSION WAS SO ENDEARINGLY  
FAMILIAR THAT HARRY AND RON GRINNED AT EACH OTHER.

THE DEATHSTICK, THE WAND OF DESTINY, THEY CAME UP UNDER DIFFER-  
ENT NAMES THROUGH THE CENTURIES, USUALLY IN THE POSSESSION OF  
SOME

DARK WIZARD WHO S REASTING ABOUT THEM. PROFESSOR KINGS  
MENTIONED

SOME OF THEM, BUT HE, IT S ALL NONSENSE, WANDS ARE ONLY AS PHEW-  
FUL AS THE WIZARDS WHO USE THEM. SOME WIZARDS JUST LIKE THE REAST

THAT THEIRS ARE BIGGER AND BETTER THAN OTHER PEOPLE S.

BUT HEH DE YHL KNEL, SAID HARRY, THAT THESE WANDS THE

DEATHSTICK AND THE LAND OF DESTINY AREN'T THE SAME LAND, SUR-  
FACING EVERY THE CENTURIES UNDER DIFFERENT NAMES?

WHAT, AND THEY'RE ALL REALLY THE ELDER LAND, MADE BY DEATH?  
SAID REIN.

HARRY LAUGHED: THE STRANGE IDEA THAT HAD OCCURRED TO HIM WAS,  
AFTER ALL, RIDICULOUS. HIS LAND, HE REMINDED HIMSELF, HAD BEEN OF  
FOLLY, NOT ELDER, AND IT HAD BEEN MADE BY HELLIVANDER, WHATEVER IT  
HAD

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

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BEFORE THAT NIGHT VERDERMERT HAD PURSUED HIM ACROSS THE SKIES, AND  
IF IT HAD BEEN UNBEATABLE, HOW COULD IT HAVE BEEN BROKEN?

THE WHY WOULD YOU TAKE THE STONE? REIN ASKED HIM.

WELL, IF YOU COULD BRING PEOPLE BACK, WE COULD HAVE STRIUS ...  
MAD-LYR ... OLIMPEDEIRE ... MY PARENTS, ...

NEITHER REIN NOR HERMINE SMILED.

BUT ACCORDING TO REEDER THE CARD, THEY WOULDN'T WANT THE CHIEF  
BACK, WOULD THEY? SAID HARRY, THINKING ABOUT THE TALK THEY HAD

JUST HEARD. I DON'T SUPPOSE THERE HAVE BEEN LEADS OF EITHER STE-  
RIES ABOUT A STONE THAT CAN RAISE THE DEAD, HAVE THERE? HE ASKED

TERMINING.

NO, SHE REPLIED SADLY. I DON'T THINK ANYONE EXCEPT MR. LEVER-  
CHILD COULD DO THEMSELVES THAT POSSIBLE. PEOPLE PROBABLY THINK THE

IDEA FROM THE SCORPER'S STINK; WELL KNOWN, INSTEAD OF A STINK THE  
MADE

WELL IMMORTAL, A STINK THE REVERSE DEATH.

THE SMELL FROM THE KITCHEN WAS GETTING STRONGER! IT WAS SOME-  
THING LIKE BURNING UNDERPANTS. HARRY WONDERED WHETHER IT WOULD

BE POSSIBLE TO EAT ENOUGH OF WHATEVER SCORPERILIS WAS COOKING  
THE

SPARE HIS FEELINGS.

WHAT ABOUT THE CHAIR, THOUGH? SAID RICH SILENTLY. DON'T YOU  
REALIZE, HE'S RIGHT? I'VE GOTTEN USED TO HARRY'S CHAIR AND I'VE  
GOTTEN

IT IS, I NEVER STOPPED TO THINK. I'VE NEVER HEARD OF ONE LIKE  
HARRY'S.

IT'S IMPOSSIBLE. WE'VE NEVER BEEN SPOTTED UNDER IT

OF COURSE NOT WE'RE INVISIBLE WHEN WE'RE UNDER IT, RICH!

BUT ALL THE STUFF HE SAID ABOUT EITHER CHAIRS, AND THEY'RE NOT EX-  
ACTLY TEN A DOZEN, WELL KNOWN, IS TRUE? IT'S NEVER OCCURRED TO ME  
BEFORE.

BUT I'VE HEARD STUFF ABOUT CHARMS WEARING OFF LIPS WHEN THEY  
GET

HOLD, FOR THEM BEING RIPPED APART BY SPELLS SEE THEY'VE GOTTEN THEM IN.

THE TALL OF THE  
THEIR BRETTERS

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HARRY WAS HELD BY HIS DAD, SEE IT WASN'T EXACTLY NEW, IS IT, BUT IT WAS  
JUST . . . PERFECT?

YES, ALL RIGHT, BUT THEN, THE STONE . . .

AS THEY ARGUED IN WHISPERS, HARRY MOVED AROUND THE ROOM, ONLY  
HALF LISTENING. REACHING THE SPIRAL STAIR, HE RAISED HIS EYES  
ABSENTLY TO

THE NEXT LEVEL AND WAS DISTRACTED AT ONCE. HIS OWN FACE WAS  
LOOKING

BACK AT HIM FROM THE CEILING OF THE ROOM ABOVE.

AFTER A MOMENT'S REWILDERMENT, HE REALIZED THAT IT WASN'T A MIR-  
ROR, BUT A PAINTING. CURIOUS, HE BEGAN TO CLIMB THE STAIRS.

HARRY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING? I DON'T THINK YOU SHOULD LOOK  
AROUND

WHEN HE WASN'T HERE?

BUT HARRY HAD ALREADY REACHED THE NEXT LEVEL.

LUNA HAD DECORATED HER BEDROOM CEILING WITH FIVE BEAUTIFULLY  
PAINTED FACES: HARRY, RON, HERMION, GINNY, AND NEVILLE. THEY

WERE NOT MOVING AS THE PORTRAITS AT HOGWARTS MOVED, BUT THERE WAS A CERTAIN MAGIC ABOUT THEM ALL THE SAME! HARRY THOUGHT THEY BREATHED. WHAT APPEARED TO BE FINE GOLDEN CHAINS WERE AROUND THE PICTURES, LINKING THEM TOGETHER, BUT AFTER EXAMINING THEM FOR A MINUTE OR SO, HARRY REALIZED THAT THE CHAINS WERE ACTUALLY ONE WHOLE.

REPEATED A THOUSAND TIMES IN GOLDEN IND: FRIENDS ... FRIENDS ... FRIENDS ...

HARRY FELT A GREAT RUSH OF AFFECTION FOR LUNA. HE LOOKED AROUND THE ROOM. THERE WAS A LARGE PHOTOGRAPH BESIDE THE BED, OF A YOUNG

LUNA AND A WOMAN WHO LOOKED VERY LIKE HER. THEY WERE HUGGING. LUNA LOOKED RATHER BETTER-GROOMED IN THIS PICTURE THAN HARRY HAD

EVER SEEN HER IN LIFE. THE PICTURE WAS BLISTY. THIS STRUCK HARRY AS SLIGHTLY ODD. HE STARED AROUND.

SOMETHING WAS WRONG. THE PALE BLUE CARPET WAS ALSO THICK WITH

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

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BLIST. THERE WERE NO CLOTHES IN THE WARDROBE, WHOSE DOORS STOOD AJAR.

THE BED HAD A CHILD, UNFRIENDLY LOOK, AS THOUGH IT HAD NOT BEEN SLEPT

IN FOR WEEKS. A SINGLE CHAIR STRETCHED OVER THE NEAREST WINDOW, ACROSS A BLEARED SKY.

WHAT'S WRONG? FERMINE ASKED AS HARRY DESCENDED THE STAIRCASE, BUT BEFORE HE COULD RESPOND, XENOPHILUS REACHED THE TOP OF THE STAIRS FROM THE KITCHEN, NOW HOLDING A TRAY LOADED WITH BREADS. MR. LEVEEQUE, SAID HARRY, WHERE'S LINA? EXCUSE ME? WHERE'S LINA? XENOPHILUS HALTED ON THE TOP STEP.

I I'VE ALREADY TOLD YOU, SHE IS DOWN AT BETTERIDGE BRIDGE, FISHING FOR PLIMPIES.

SHE WOULDN'T HAVE YOU ONLY SAID THAT TRAY FOR FISH? XENOPHILUS TRIED TO SPEAK, BUT NO SOUND CAME OUT. THE ONLY NOISE WAS THE CONTINUED CHUGGING OF THE PRINTING PRESS, AND A SLIGHT RATTLE FROM THE TRAY AS XENOPHILUS'S HANDS SHAKED. I DON'T THINK LINA'S BEEN HERE FOR WEEKS, SAID HARRY. HER CLOTHES ARE GONE, HER BED HASN'T BEEN SLEPT IN, WHERE IS SHE? AND WHY DO YOU KEEP LOOKING OUT OF THE WINDOW? XENOPHILUS DROPPED THE TRAY! THE BREADS ROLLED AND SMASHED. HARRY, JOHN, AND FERMINE DREW THEIR HANDS; XENOPHILUS FREEZE, HIS HAND ABOUT TO ENTER HIS POCKET. AT THAT MOMENT THE PRINTING PRESS GAVE A BIG BANG AND NUMEROUS FLICKERS CAME STREAMING ACROSS THE FLOOR FROM UNDERNEATH THE TABLETS; THE PRESS FELL SILENT.

AT LAST,

HERMINE STEPPED DOWN AND PICKED UP ONE OF THE MAGAZINES,  
HER HAND STILL POINTING AT MR. LEVECHE.

HARRY, LEED AT THIS,

THE TALL OF THE  
THREE BROTHERS

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HE STRUCK HER THE HER AS HEAVILY AS HE COULD THROUGH ALL THE  
CLUT-

TER, THE FRONT OF THE FLICKER CARRIED HIS OWN PICTURE,  
EMBELLISHED

WITH THE WORDS UNDESIRABLE OLIVER HINE AND CAPTIONED WITH  
THE REWARD MONEY,

THE FLICKER IS GOING FOR A NEW ANGLE, THEN? HARRY ASKED CHILD,  
HIS MIND WORKING VERY FAST. IS THAT WHAT YOU WERE DOING WHEN  
YOU WENT INTO THE GARDEN, MR. LEVECHE? SENDING AN HAIL TO THE  
MINISTRY?

BERNARDILIS LICKED HIS LIPS,

THEY THINK MY LINA, HE WHISPERED, BECAUSE OF WHAT I VE BEEN  
WRITING, THEY THINK MY LINA AND I DONT KNOW WHERE SHE IS, WHAT  
THEY VE DONE TO HER, BUT THEY MIGHT GIVE HER BACK TO ME IF I IF  
I

HAND OVER HARRY? HERMINE FINISHED FOR HIM,

NO DEAL, SAID REN FLATLY. GET OUT OF THE WAY, WE'RE LEAVING.  
XENOPHILUS LUNGED GLASTLY, A CENTURY OLD, HIS LIPS DRAWN BACK  
INTO A DREADFUL LEER.

THEY WILL BE HERE AT ANY MOMENT, I MUST SAVE LINA, I CANNOT  
LEAVE LINA, SHE MUST NOT LEAVE.

HE SPREAD HIS ARMS IN FRONT OF THE STAIRCASE, AND HARRY HAD A SUD-  
DEN VISION OF HIS FATHER BEING THE SAME THING IN FRONT OF HIS CRIB.

DON'T MAKE US WAIT YELL, HARRY SAID. GET OUT OF THE WAY, MR.  
LHYEGHED.

HARRY: HERMINE SCREAMED.

FIGURES AND BRIMSTICKS WERE FLYING PAST THE WINDOWS, AS THE  
THREE

OF THEM LUNGED AWAY FROM HIM, XENOPHILUS DREW HIS HAND, HARRY  
REALIZED THEIR MISTAKE INSTANTLY: HE LAUNCHED HIMSELF SIDWAYS,

SHOVING REN AND HERMINE OUT OF HARM'S WAY AS XENOPHILUS'S  
STUN-

NINE SPELL STRUCK ACROSS THE ROOM AND HIT THE COLLAPSED MEN.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

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THERE WAS A CATASTROPHIC EXPLOSION. THE SOUND OF IT SEEMED TO BLEW  
THE ROOM APART: FRAGMENTS OF WOOD AND PAPER AND RUBBLE FLEW IN



ALL DIRECTIONS, ALONG WITH AN IMPENETRABLE CLOUD OF THICK WHITE  
DUST.

HARRY FLEW THROUGH THE AIR, THEN CRASHED TO THE FLOOR, UNABLE TO  
SEE

AS DEERIS RAINED UPON HIM, HIS ARMS OVER HIS HEAD. HE HEARD HER-  
MIONE'S SCREAM, RON'S YELL, AND A SERIES OF SICKENING METALLIC THUDS,

WHICH TOLD HIM THAT XENOPHILIUS HAD BEEN BLASTED OFF HIS FEET AND  
FALLEN BACKWARD DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRS.

HALF BLIND IN BLIND, HARRY TRIED TO RAISE HIMSELF. HE COULD  
BARELY BREATHE FOR THE DUST. HALF OF THE CEILING HAD FALLEN IN,  
AND

THE END OF LUNA'S BED WAS HANGING THROUGH THE FLOOR. THE DUST OF

REVERA RAVENCLAW LAY BESIDE HIM WITH HALF ITS FACE MISSING, FRAG-  
MENTS OF THORN PARCEMENT WERE FLEATING THROUGH THE AIR, AND NEAR

THE PRINTING PRESS LAY ON ITS SIDE, BLOCKING THE TOP OF THE  
STAIR-

CASE TO THE KITCHEN. THEN ANOTHER WHITE SHAPE MOVED CLOSE BY, AND

HERMIONE, CHAINED IN DUST LIKE A SECOND STATUE, PRESSED HER FINGER  
TO HER LIPS.

THE DEER DOWNSTAIRS CRASHED OPEN.

DIDN'T I TELL YOU THERE WAS NO NEED TO HURRY, TRAYERS? SAID A  
RELIGIOUS

VOICE. DIDN'T I TELL YOU THIS NOISE WAS JUST RAVING AS USUAL?

THERE WAS A BANG AND A SCREAM OF PAIN FROM XENOPHILIUS.

NEE . . . NEE . . . UPSTAIRS . . . PITTER!

I TOLD YELI LAST WEEK, BEYEGHEED, WE WEREN'T COMING BACK FOR ANY-  
THING LESS THAN SOME SERIOUS INFORMATION! REMEMBER LAST WEEK?  
WHEN

YELI WANTED THE SWAP YELIR DAUGHTER FOR THAT STUPID BLEEDING HEAD-  
DRESS? AND THE WEEK BEFORE ANOTHER BANG, ANOTHER SERIOUS

WHEN YELI THOUGHT WE'D GIVE HER BACK IF YELI OFFERED HIS PRISON  
THERE

ARE CRUMPLE BANG HEADS BANG SNORRACKS?

THE TALK OF THE  
THREE BROTHERS

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NEE NEE I KEE YELI! SHOOK XENOPHILIUS. IT REALLY IS PIT-  
TER! REALLY!

AND WHEN IT TURNS OUT YELI HAD CALLED HIS FATHER THE TRY AND KNEW HIS

UP! HEARD THE DEATH! LATER, AND THERE WAS A WHOLE OF BANGS  
INTER-

SPERSED WITH SERIOUS OF AGONY FROM XENOPHILIUS.

THE PLACE LOOKS LIKE IT'S ABOUT THE FALL IN, SELWYN, SAID A CHEER  
SECOND VOICE, CLIMBING UP THE MANGLED STAIRCASE. THE STAIRS ARE  
COMPLETELY BLOCKED. COULD TRY CLEARING IT? MIGHT BRING THE PLACE  
DOWN.

YELL LYING PIECE OF FILTH, SHOUTED THE WIZARD NAMED SELWYN.

YELL YOU NEVER SEEN BETTER IN YOUR LIFE, HAVE YOU? TELLIGHT  
YELL O

WHERE ARE HERE THE BILLS ARE, DID YOU? AND YOU THINK YOU'LL GET YOUR  
GIRL

BACK LIKE THIS?

I SWEAR . . . I SWEAR . . . BETTER'S UPSTAIRS!

HERMION GRUMBLED, SAID THE VOICE AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS.

HARRY HEARD HERMION GRUMBLED, AND HE HAD THE BODILY SENSATION THAT  
SOMETHING WAS SLEEPING OVER HIM, IMMERSED HIS BODY IN ITS  
SHADOWS.

THERE'S SOMETHING UP THERE ALL RIGHT, SELWYN, SAID THE SECOND  
MAN SHARPLY.

IT'S BETTER, I TELL YOU, IT'S BETTER! SHRIED XENOPHILUS. PLEASE . .  
,

PLEASE . . . GIVE ME LUNA, JUST LET ME HAVE LUNA. . .

YOU CAN HAVE YOUR LITTLE GIRL, HOWEVER, SAID SELWYN, IF YOU  
GET UP THESE STAIRS AND BRING ME DOWN HARRY POTTER. BUT IF THIS IS  
A PRANK, IF IT'S A TRICK, IF YOU'RE GET AN ACCOMPLICE WAITING UP THERE  
THE

AMERICAN ARE, WE'LL SEE IF WE CAN SPARE A BIT OF YOUR DAUGHTER FOR YOU  
THE BIRD.

XENOPHILUS GAVE A WAIL OF FEAR AND DESPAIR. THERE WERE  
SLURRYINGS

## CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

\*\*\*

AND SCRAPINGS! XENOPHILUS WAS TRYING TO GET THROUGH THE DOOR IN

THE STAIRS.

COME ON, HARRY WHISPERED, WE'VE GOT TO GET OUT OF HERE.

HE STARTED TO DIG HIMSELF OUT UNDER COVER OF ALL THE NOISE XENOPHILUS WAS MAKING IN THE STAIRCASE. THEN WAS ELATED DEEPEST! HARRY

AND HERMIONE CLIMBED, AS QUIETLY AS THEY COULD, OVER ALL THE WRECKAGE WHERE HE LAY, TRYING TO PRIZE A HEAVY CHEST OF DRAWERS OFF HIS

LEGS. WHILE XENOPHILUS'S SCRAPING AND SCRAPING DREW NEARER AND NEARER, HERMIONE MANAGED TO FREE THEN WITH THE USE OF A FEVER CHARM.

ALL RIGHT, BREATHED HERMIONE, AS THE CRACKEN PRINTING PRESS BLOOMING THE TOP OF THE STAIRS BEGAN TO TREMBLE; XENOPHILUS WAS FEET AWAY FROM THEM. SHE WAS STILL WHITE WITH DUST. OH WELL TRUST ME, HARRY?

HARRY NEEDED.

HEY THEN, HERMIONE WHISPERED, GIVE ME THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, THEN, WELL BE GOING TO PUT IT ON.

MR? BUT HARRY

PLEASE, THEN? HARRY, HOLD HIM TIGHT TO MY HAND, THEN, GRAB MY  
SHOULDER,

HARRY HOLD HIMT HIS LEFT HAND, THEN VANISHED BENEATH THE CURTAIN,

THE PRINTING PRESS BLOCKING THE STAIRS WAS VIBRATING!

XXXXXXXXXXXX

WAS TRYING TO SHIFT IT USING A FEVER CHARM, HARRY DID NOT KNOW  
WHAT HERMIONE WAS WAITING FOR,

HOLD TIGHT, SHE WHISPERED, HOLD TIGHT ... AND SECOND ...

XXXXXXXXXXXX'S PAPER-WHITE FACE APPEARED OVER THE TOP OF THE  
SIDEBAR,

RELIVATE? CRIED HERMIONE, POINTING HER WAND FIRST INTO HIS  
FACE, THEN AT THE FLOOR BENEATH THEM, DEPRIVED?

THE TALL OF THE

THREE BROTHERS

XXX

SHE HAD BLASTED A HOLE IN THE SITTING ROOM FLOOR, THEY FELL LIKE  
CHILDREN, HARRY STILL HOLDING ONTO HER HAND FOR DEAR LIFE; THERE  
WAS

A SCREAM FROM REMUS, AND HE GLIMPSED TWO MEN TRYING TO GET HIMT  
OF THE WAY AS VAST MOUNTAINS OF BOOKS AND CRACKED FURNITURE  
RAINED

ALL AROUND THEM FROM THE SHATTERED CEILING, HERMIONE TWISTED IN  
MIDAIR AND THE THUNDERING OF THE COLLAPSING FLOOR RANG IN  
HARRY'S

EARS AS SHE DRAGGED HIM HENCE MORE INTO DARKNESS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY - TWO

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### THE DEATHLY HALLS

ARRY FELL, PANTING, INTO THE GRASS AND SCRAMLED UP AT ONCE.

THEY SEEMED TO HAVE LANDED IN THE CORNER OF A FIELD AT

BLISS; HERMIONE WAS ALREADY RUNNING IN A CIRCLE AROUND THEM,  
WAY-

ING HER HAND.

PRETEND TITALLM... SALVIE HEXIA...

THAT TREACHEROUS HED BLEEDER? REN PANTED, EMERGING FROM BE-  
NEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND THROWING IT TO HARRY.  
HERMIONE,

WELL BE A GENIUS, A TITAN GENIUS, I CAN'T BELIEVE WE GOT HIT BY  
THAT?

LOVE INIMICUM... DIDN'T I SAY IT WAS AN ERLUMPENT HEIRN, DIDN'T  
I TELL HIM? AND WELL HIS FEELSE HAS BEEN BLEENN APART?

SERVES HIM RIGHT, SAID REN, EXAMINING HIS TORN IRONS AND THE  
CLUTS TO HIS LEGS. WHAT'D WELL RECKEN THEY'LL DO TO HIM?

EH, I HOPE THEY DEN'T KILL HIM? GRIANED HERMIONE. THAT'S WHY

I WANTED THE DEATH EATERS TO GET A GLIMPSE OF HARRY BEFORE WE LEFT,  
SEE THEY KNEW XENOPHILIUS HADN'T BEEN LYING?

WHY HIDE ME, THELGH? ASKED REIN.  
H

THE DEATHLY HALLS

YES

THEY'RE SUPPOSED TO BE IN BED WITH SPATTERGOAT, REIN? THEY'VE  
KIDNAPPED LLINA BECAUSE HER FATHER SUPPORTED HARRY? WHAT WOULD  
HAPPEN TO THE YELIN FAMILY IF THEY KNEW THEY'RE WITH HIM?

BUT WHAT ABOUT THEIR MOM AND DAD?

THEY'RE IN AUSTRALIA, SAID HERMIONE. THEY SHOULD BE ALL RIGHT.  
THEY DIDN'T KNOW ANYTHING.

THEY'RE A GENIUS, REIN REPEATED, LEERING AWAY.

YEAH, THEY ARE, HERMIONE, AGREED HARRY PERVENTLY. I DIDN'T KNOW  
WHAT WE'D DO WITH THEM.

SHE BEAMED, BUT BECAME SERIOUS AT ONCE.

WHAT ABOUT LLINA?

WELL, IF THEY'RE TELLING THE TRUTH AND SHE'S STILL ALIVE, REIN  
REIN.

DIDN'T SAY THAT, DIDN'T SAY IT? SHEARED HERMIONE. SHE MUST BE  
ALIVE, SHE MUST?

THEN SHE'LL BE IN AZKABAN, I EXPECT, SAID REIN. WHETHER SHE  
SURVIVES THE PLACE, THELGH... LEADS DIDN'T...

SHE WILL, SAID HARRY, HE COULD NEET REAR THE CHNTEMPLETE THE AL-  
TERNATIVE. SHE S TELUCH, LUNA, MLIK TELUCHER THAN VELL D THINK,  
SHE S

PREHABLY TEACHING ALL THE INMATES ABELT INRADESPURTS AND  
NARGLES.

I HEPPE VELL RE RIGHT, SAID HERMINE. SHE PASSED A HAND EVER HER  
EYES. I D FEEL SHE SHIRY PER XENHPHILIS IF

IF HE HADN T ILST TRIED THE SKL LIS THE THE DEATH EATERS, YEAK,  
SAID REIN.

THEY PLIT UP THE TENT AND RETREATED INSIDE IT, WHERE REIN MADE  
THEM TEA. AFTER THEIR NARRHEW ESCAPE, THE CHILLY, MLISTY HED PLACE  
FELT

LIKE HEPPE: SAFE, FAMILIAR, AND FRIENDLY.

EH, WHY DID WE GH THERE? GRHANE HERMINE AFTER A FEW MIN-  
UTES SILENCE. HARRY, VELL WERE RIGHT, IT WAS CHORIK S FHELLEN ALL  
EVER

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWEE

THE

AGAIN, A COMPLETE WASTE OF TIME? THE DEATHLY FALLHLS . . . SLICH  
RLKKISH . . . ALTHELICH ACTUALLY, A SLDDEN THELUGHT SEEMED THE HAVE  
STRICKED HER, HE MIGHT HAVE MADE IT ALL UP, MIGHTN T HE? HE  
PREHABLY



DIDN'T BELIEVE IN THE DEATHLY HALLOWS AT ALL, HE JUST WANTED THE DEEP

WAS TALKING UNTIL THE DEATH EATERS ARRIVED?

I DIDN'T THINK SO, SAID RON. IT'S A DAMN SIGHT HARDER MAKING STUFF UP WHEN YOU'RE UNDER STRESS THAN YOU'D THINK. I FELT THAT HE

WHEN THE SNATCHERS CALLED ME, IT WAS MUCH EASIER PRETENDING THE

STAY, BECAUSE I KNEW A BIT ABOUT HIM, THAN INVENTING A WHOLE NEW PERSON. HE'D LIVED UNDER LOADS OF PRESSURE, TRYING TO MAKE SURE WE STAYED ALIVE, I RECALLED HE TOLD US THE TRUTH, AND WHAT HE THINKS

IS THE TRUTH, JUST THE DEEP WAS TALKING.

WELL, I DIDN'T SUPPOSE IT MATTERS, SIGHED HERMION. EVEN IF HE WAS BEING HONEST, I NEVER HEARD SUCH A LOT OF NONSENSE IN ALL MY LIFE.

HANG ON, TELL ME, SAID RON. THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS WAS SLIPPED THE DEEP A MYTH, WASN'T IT?

BUT THE DEATHLY HALLOWS CAN'T EXIST, RON?

YOU'RE DEEP SAYING THAT, BUT HOW CAN THEY CAN, SAID RON. HARRY'S INVISIBILITY CLOAK

THE TALE OF THE THREE BROTHERS IS A STORY, SAID HERMION FIRMLY.

A STORY ABOUT HOW HUMANS ARE FRIGHTENED OF DEATH. IF SURVIVING WAS AS SIMPLE AS HIDING UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, WE'D HAVE EV-

EVERYTHING WE NEED ALREADY?

I DIDN'T KNOW, WE COULD BE WITH AN UNBREAKABLE WAND, SAID HARRY, TURNING THE BLACKTHORN WAND HE SHE DISLIKED EVER IN HIS FINGERS.

THERE'S NOT SUCH A THING, HARRY?

YELL SAID THERE HAVE BEEN LEADS OF WANDS THE DEATHSTICK AND WHATEVER THEY WERE CALLED

THE DEATHLY HALLS

AND

ALL RIGHT, EVEN IF YELL WANT TO DO YOURSELF THE ELDER WAND'S REAL, WHAT ABOUT THE RESURRECTION STONE? HER FINGERS SKETCHED ENLIGHTENMENT

MARKS AROUND THE NAME, AND HER TONE DRIPPED SARCASTIC. NOT MAGIC CAN RAISE THE DEAD, AND THAT'S THAT?

WHEN MY WAND CONNECTED WITH YELL-KNEW-WELL'S, IT MADE MY MOM AND DAD APPEAR... AND CEDRIC...

BUT THEY WEREN'T REALLY BACK FROM THE DEAD, WERE THEY? SAID HERMION. THESE KINDS OF... OF PALE IMITATIONS AREN'T THE SAME AS

TRULY BRINGING SOMEONE BACK TO LIFE.

BUT SHE, THE GIRL IN THE TALE, DIDN'T REALLY COME BACK, DID SHE? THE STORY SAYS THAT ONCE PEOPLE ARE DEAD, THEY BELONG WITH THE DEAD, BUT

THE SECOND BROTHER STILL GOT TO SEE HER AND TALK TO HER, DIDN'T HE? HE

EVEN LIVED WITH HER FOR A WHILE. . .

HE SAW CONCERN AND SOMETHING LESS EASILY DEFINABLE IN HERMIONE'S EXPRESSION. THEN, AS SHE GLANCED AT REIN, HARRY REALIZED THAT IT WAS

FEAR: HE HAD STARED HER WITH HIS TALK OF LIVING WITH DEAD PEOPLE.

SEE THAT PEPPERELL BLEND WITH A FLURRY IN GORDON'S FINGER, HE SAID HASTILY, TRYING THE SOUND REHELISTLY SAME, YET HEIN'T KNOWN ANYTHING

ABOUT HIM, THEN?

NO, SHE REPLIED, LOOKING RELIEVED AT THE CHANGE OF SUBJECT. I

LOOKED HIM UP AFTER I SAW THE MARK ON HIS GRAVE; IF HE'D BEEN ANY-  
ONE FAMOUS OR BEEN ANYTHING IMPORTANT, I'M SURE HE'D BE IN ONE  
OF

HER BOOKS. THE ONLY PLACE I'VE MANAGED TO FIND THE NAME  
PEPPERELL

IS NATLIE'S DEERITY: A WIZARDING GENEALOGY. I BORROWED IT FROM  
DREADER. SHE EXPLAINED AS REIN RAISED HIS EYEBROWS. IT LISTS THE  
PURE-BLOOD FAMILIES THAT ARE NOW EXTINCT IN THE MALE LINE,  
APPARENTLY

THE PEPPERELLS WERE ONE OF THE EARLIEST FAMILIES TO VANISH.

EXTINCT IN THE MALE LINE? REPEATED REIN.

IT MEANS THE NAME'S DIED OUT, SAID HERMIONE, CENTURIES AGO, IN

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

THE CASE OF THE PEVERELLS. THEY COULD STILL HAVE DESCENDANTS,  
THOUGH,

THEY MUST BE CALLED SOMETHING DIFFERENT.

AND THEN IT CAME THE HARRY IN HIS SHINING PIECE, THE MEMORY THAT  
HAD STIRRED AT THE SOUND OF THE NAME PEVERELL : A FILTHY OLD MAN  
BRANDISHING AN UGLY RING IN THE FACE OF A MINISTRY OFFICIAL, AND HE  
CRIED ALOUD, MARVELLUS GALINT!

SHRILL? SAID RHN AND HERMINNE TOGETHER.

MARVELLUS GALINT? WELL-KNOWN WERE HIS GRANDFATHER IN THE  
PENSIRES?

WITH DUMBLEDORE? MARVELLUS GALINT SAID HE WAS DESCENDED FROM THE  
PEVERELLS?

RHN AND HERMINNE LOOKED BEMUSED.

THE RING, THE RING THAT BECAME THE HEIRLOOM, MARVELLUS GALINT  
SAID IT HAD THE PEVERELL THAT HE ARMS IN IT? I SAW HIM WAVING IT IN  
THE

BLIND FROM THE MINISTRY'S FACE, HE NEARLY SHEWED IT UP HIS NECK?

THE PEVERELL THAT HE ARMS? SAID HERMINNE SHARPLY, COULD YOU  
SEE WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE?

NOT REALLY, SAID HARRY, TRYING TO REMEMBER. THERE WAS  
NOTHING

FANCY IN THERE, AS FAR AS I COULD SEE; MAYBE A FEW SCRATCHES, I ONLY  
EVER SAW IT REALLY CLOSE UP AFTER IT HAD BEEN CRACKED OPEN.

HARRY SAW HERMINNE'S COMPREHENSION IN THE SUDDEN WIDENING OF  
HER EYES, RHN WAS LOOKING FROM HER TO THE OTHER, ASTONISHED.

BLIMEY . . . YOU RECOGNISE IT WAS THIS SIGN AGAIN? THE SIGN OF THE  
FALLING?

WELL, WHY NOT? SAID HARRY EXCITEDLY, MARVELLUS CALINT WAS AN IGNORANT FELLOW WHO LIVED LIKE A PIG, ALL HE CARED ABOUT WAS HIS ANCESTRY.

IF THAT RING HAD BEEN PASSED DOWN THROUGH THE CENTURIES, HE MIGHT NOT HAVE KNOWN WHAT IT REALLY WAS. THERE WERE NO KEYS IN THAT HOUSE, AND TRUST ME, HE WASN'T THE TYPE TO READ FAIRY TALES TO HIS KIDS.

HE'D HAVE BEEN THE THING THE SCRATCHES ON THE STONE WERE A CLUE TO

## THE DEADLY HALLS

AND

ARMS, BECAUSE AS FAR AS HE WAS CONCERNED, HAVING PLUM BLEED MADE THEM PRACTICALLY DEAD.

YES . . . AND THAT'S ALL VERY INTERESTING, SAID FERMINE CALTILISLY.

BUT HARRY, IF YOU'RE THINKING WHAT I THINK YOU'RE THINKING

WELL, WHY NOT? WHY NOT? SAID HARRY, ABANDONING CALTILIS. IT WAS A STONE, WASN'T IT? HE LOOKED AT BEN FOR SUPPORT. WHAT IF IT

WAS THE RESURRECTION STONE?

BEN'S MOUTH FELL OPEN.

BLIMEY BUT WOULD IT STILL WORK IF DUMBLEDORE KNEW ?

WHERE? WHERE? BEN, IT NEVER WORKED! THERE'S NO SUCH THING AS A

RESURRECTION STONE?

HERMIONE HAD LEAPT THE HER FEET, BREATHING EXHAUSTED AND ANGRY.

HARRY, WILL HE TRYING TO FIT EVERYTHING INTO THE FALLS STORY

FIT EVERYTHING IN? HE REPEATED, HERMIONE, IT FITS IF ITS BEEN ACC-  
CIDENT? I KNOW THE SIGN OF THE DEATHLY FALLS WAS IN THAT STONE?

GALANT SAID HE WAS DESCENDED FROM THE DEVERILLS?

A MINUTE AGO WILL THOUGHT WAS WILL NEVER SAW THE MARK IN THE STONE  
PROPERLY?

WHERE D WILL RECOGN THE RING IS NEAR? BEEN ASKED HARRY, WHAT  
DID DUMBLEDORE DO WITH IT AFTER HE BROKE IT OPEN?

BUT HARRY S IMAGINATION WAS RACING AHEAD, FAR BEYOND BEEN AND  
HERMIONE S. . . .

THREE OBJECTS, THE FALLS, WHICH, IF UNITED, WILL MAKE THE  
POSSESSOR

MASTER OF DEATH . . . MASTER . . . UNDEAD . . . VANQUISH . . . THE  
LAST

ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH. . .

AND HE SAW HIMSELF, POSSESSOR OF THE FALLS, FACING VOLD-  
MORT, WHERE DEATHLY WERE NO MATCH . . . NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE

THE OTHER SURVIVES. . . WAS THIS THE ANSWER? FALLS VERSUS  
DEATH-

CRUISES? WAS THERE A WAY, AFTER ALL, TO ENSURE THAT HE WAS THE ONE

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WHE TRIUMPHED? IF HE WERE THE MASTER OF THE DEATHLY HALLS,  
WOULD HE BE SAFE?

HARRY?

BUT HE SCARCELY HEARD HERMIONE: HE HAD PULLED OUT HIS INVISIBIL-  
ITY CLOAK AND WAS RUNNING IT THROUGH HIS FINGERS, THE CLOTH  
SUPPLE

AS WATER, LIGHT AS AIR. HE HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING THE EQUAL IT IN

HIS NEARLY SEVEN YEARS IN THE WIZARDING WORLD. THE CLOAK WAS EX-  
ACTLY WHAT XENOPHILIUS HAD DESCRIBED: A CLOAK THAT REALLY AND  
TRULY

RENDERS THE WEARER COMPLETELY INVISIBLE, AND ENDURES ETERNALLY,  
GIVING

CONSTANT AND IMPENETRABLE CONCEALMENT, NO MATTER WHAT SPELLS ARE  
CAST

AT IT. . . .

AND THEN, WITH A GASP, HE REMEMBERED

DUMBLEDORE HAD MY CLOAK THE NIGHT MY PARENTS DIED!

HIS VOICE SPOKE AND HE COULD FEEL THE CLOAK IN HIS FACE, BUT HE DID  
NOT CARE.

MY MUM TOLD SIRIUS THAT DUMBLEDORE KNEW THE CLOAK? THIS

IS WHY? HE WANTED TO EXAMINE IT, BECAUSE HE THOUGHT IT WAS THE  
THIRD

HALLS? IGNATIUS PEVERELL IS KNOWN IN CHURCH & HALLS... HARRY  
WAS WALKING BLINDLY AROUND THE TENT, FEELING AS THOUGH GREAT NEW  
VISTAS OF TRUTH WERE OPENING ALL AROUND HIM. HE & MY ANCESTOR?  
I'M

DESCENDED FROM THE THIRD BROTHER? IT ALL MAKES SENSE?

HE FELT ARMED IN CERTAINTY, IN HIS RELIEF IN THE HALLS, AS IF THE  
MERE IDEA OF POSSESSING THEM WAS GIVING HIM PROTECTION, AND HE  
FELT

INDULGENT AS HE TURNED BACK TO THE OTHER TWO.

HARRY, SAID HERMIONIE AGAIN, BUT HE WAS BUSY LINDING THE  
PILCHER AROUND HIS NECK, HIS FINGERS STARKING HARD.

READ IT, HE TOLD HER, PUSHING HIS MOTHER'S LETTER INTO HER HAND.

READ IT? DUMBLEDOORE HAD THE CHAIR, HERMIONIE? WHY ELSE WOULD HE  
WANT IT? HE DIDN'T NEED A CHAIR, HE COULD PERFORM A  
DISILLUSIONMENT

THE DEATHLY HALLS

AK1

CHARM SEE PEVERELL THAT HE MADE HIMSELF COMPLETELY INVISIBLE WITH  
HIS HUNT?

SOMETHING FELL TO THE FLOOR AND ROLLED, GLITTERING, UNDER A CHAIR:

HE HAD DISLODGED THE SNITCH WHEN HE PULLED OUT THE LETTER. HE



STEPPED THE PICK IT UP, AND THEN THE NEWLY TAPPED SPRING HE  
FARLIGHIS

DISCOVERIES THREW HIM ANOTHER GIFT, AND SHEED AND WHENDER EXLPTED  
INSIDE HIM SEE THAT HE SHELTED ELIT.

IT S IN FERR; HE LEFT ME THE RING IT S IN THE SNITCH;

YELI YELI REEDER?

HE CHILD NOT UNDERSTAND WHY BEEN WHEDER TAKEN AWAY. IT WAS  
SEE HEYVILIS, SEE CLEAR THE FARRY; EVERYTHING FIT, EVERYTHING. . . HIS  
LEAD WAS THE THIRD FALLEH, AND WHEN HE DISCOVERED FELL THE OPEN  
THE SNITCH HE WOULD HAVE THE SECOND, AND THEN ALL HE NEEDED TO BE  
WAS FIND THE FIRST FALLEH, THE ELDER WAND, AND THEN

BUT IT WAS AS THOUGH A CURTAIN FELL IN A LIT STAGE: ALL HIS EXCITE-  
MENT, ALL HIS HOPE AND HAPPINESS WERE EXTINGUISHED AT A STROKE,  
AND

HE STOOD ALONE IN THE DARKNESS, AND THE GLEAMING SPELL WAS EXTERMINATED.

THAT S WHAT HE S AFTER.

THE CHANGE IN HIS VOICE MADE REIN AND HERMINEE WERE EVEN  
MORE SCARED.

YELI-DREH-WITH S AFTER THE ELDER WAND.

HE TURNED HIS BACK IN THEIR STRAINED, INCREDIBLE FACES. HE KNEW  
IT WAS THE TRUTH. IT ALL MADE SENSE. VEILDEMEHT WAS NOT SEEKING A NEW

WAND; HE WAS SEEKING AN OLD WAND, A VERY OLD WAND INDEED, FARRY

WALKED TO THE ENTRANCE OF THE TENT, FORGETTING ABOUT REIN AND  
HER-

MIND AS HE WENDED HLT INTO THE NIGHT, THINKING. . . .

VOLDMORT HAD BEEN RAISED IN A MUGGLE ORPHANAGE. NOBODY  
COULD HAVE TOLD HIM THE TALES OF REBEL THE BARD WHEN HE WAS A  
CHILD, AND MORE THAN HARRY HAD HEARD THEM. BARDLY AND WIZARDS

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THE

BEHEVED IN THE DEATHLY HALLOWS, WAS IT LIKELY THAT VOLDMORT  
KNEW

ABOUT THEM?

HARRY GAZED INTO THE DARKNESS. . . . IF VOLDMORT HAD KNOWN  
ABOUT THE DEATHLY HALLOWS, SURELY HE WOULD HAVE SEUGHT THEM,

DIDN'T ANYTHING HE POSSESS THEM: THREE OBJECTS THAT MADE THE POS-  
SESSOR MASTER OF DEATH? IF HE HAD KNOWN ABOUT THE DEATHLY HAL-  
LOWS, HE MIGHT NOT HAVE NEEDED HERCULES IN THE FIRST PLACE.  
DIDN'T

THE SIMPLE FACT THAT HE HAD TAKEN A HALLOW, AND TURNED IT INTO A

HERCULES, DEMONSTRATE THAT HE DID NOT KNOW THIS LAST GREAT WIZ-  
ARDING SECRET?

WHICH MEANT THAT VOLDMORT SEUGHT THE ELDER WAND WITHOUT

REALIZING ITS FULL POWER, WITHOUT UNDERSTANDING THAT IT WAS HERE  
OF

THERE . . . FOR THE LAND WAS THE FALLEN THAT COULD NOT BE HIDDEN,  
WHOSE EXISTENCE WAS BEST KNOWN. . . . THE BLOODY TRAIL OF THE ELDER  
LAND IS SPLATTERED ACROSS THE PAGES OF WIZARDING HISTORY . . .

HARRY WATCHED THE CLOUDY SKY, CLAYES OF SMOKE-GRAY AND SILVER  
SLIDING OVER THE FACE OF THE WHITE MOUNTAIN. HE FELT LIGHT-HEADED WITH  
AMAZEMENT AT HIS DISCOVERIES.

HE TURNED BACK INTO THE TENT. IT WAS A SHOCK TO SEE RON AND  
HERM-

ION STANDING EXACTLY WHERE HE HAD LEFT THEM, HERMION STILL  
HOLDING

LILY'S LETTER, RON AT HER SIDE LOOKING SLIGHTLY ANXIOUS. DIDN'T  
THEY

REALIZE HOW FAR THEY HAD TRAVELED IN THE LAST FEW MINUTES?

THIS IS IT, HARRY SAID, TRYING TO BRING THEM INSIDE THE CLOTH OF  
HIS

HIS ASTONISHED CERTAINTY. THIS EXPLAINS EVERYTHING. THE  
DEATHLY

FALLS ARE REAL, AND I'VE GOT ONE      MARK THE

HE HELD UP THE SNITCH.

AND PHIL-DAVE-DAVE IS CHASING THE THING, BUT HE DOESN'T REAL-  
IZE . . . HE JUST THINKS IT'S A POWERFUL WAND

HARRY, SAID HERMION, MOVING ACROSS TO HIM AND HANDING HIM

## THE DEATHLY HALLS

"KKK

BACK LILY'S LETTER, I'M SORRY, BUT I THINK YOU'VE GOT THIS WRONG,  
ALL

WRONG.

BUT DOESN'T YOU SEE? IT ALL FITS

NO, IT DOESN'T, SHE SAID. IT DOESN'T, HARRY, YOU'RE JUST GETTING  
CARRIED AWAY, PLEASE, SHE SAID AS HE STARTED THE SPEAK, PLEASE JUST

ANSWER ME THIS: IF THE DEATHLY HALLS REALLY EXISTED, AND DUM-  
BLEDORE KNEW ABOUT THEM, KNEW THAT THE PERSON WHO POSSESSED ALL

THREE OF THEM WOULD BE MASTER OF DEATH HARRY, WHY WOULDN'T  
HE HAVE TOLD YOU? WHY?

HE HAD HIS ANSWER READY.

BUT YOU SAID IT, HERMION! YOU'VE GOT THE FINGERPRINT ABOUT THEM  
FOR YOURSELF? IT'S A QUEST?

BUT I ONLY SAID THAT YOU TRY AND PERSUADE YOU THE CHIEF THE THE

SHYREHOODS : CRIED HERMION IN EXASPERATION, I DIDN'T REALLY BE-  
LIEVE IT?

HARRY THEN SHE NOTICE,

DUMBLEDORE USUALLY LET ME FIND OUT STUFF FOR MYSELF, HE LET ME TRY

MY STRENGTH, TAKE RISKS. THIS FEELS LIKE THE KIND OF THING HE'D DO.

HARRY, THIS ISN'T A GAME, THIS ISN'T PRACTICE! THIS IS THE REAL THING,

AND DUMBLEDORE LEFT YOU VERY CLEAR INSTRUCTIONS! FIND AND DESTROY THE FIERCECLONES! THAT SYMBOL DOESN'T MEAN ANYTHING, FORGET THE DEATHLY HALLS, WE CAN'T AFFORD TO GET SIDETRACKED

HARRY WAS BARELY LISTENING TO HER. HE WAS TURNING THE SNITCH OVER

AND OVER IN HIS HANDS, HALF EXPECTING IT TO BREAK OPEN, TO REVEAL THE

RESURRECTION STONE, TO PROVE THE FERMINE THAT HE WAS RIGHT, THAT

THE DEATHLY HALLS WERE REAL.

SHE APPEARED TO REIN,

YOU DON'T BELIEVE IN THIS, DO YOU?

HARRY LEANED UP, REIN HESITATED.

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I DON'T ... I MEAN ... IT'S AS IF IT SHIRT UP FIT TOGETHER, SAID REIN ALONGSIDELY. BUT WHEN YOU LOOK AT THE WHOLE THING ... HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH. I THINK WE'RE SUPPOSED TO GET RID OF FIERCECLONES, HARRY.

THAT'S WHAT DUMBLEDORE TOLD US THE DAY, MAYBE ... MAYBE WE SHOULD FORGET ABOUT THIS HALLS BUSINESS.

THANK YOU, REIN, SAID FERMINE. I'LL TAKE FIRST WATCH.

AND SHE STRIDE PAST HARRY AND SAT DOWN IN THE TENT ENTRANCE,  
BRINGING THE ACTION TO A FIERCE FULL STOP.

BUT HARRY HARDLY SLEPT THAT NIGHT. THE IDEA OF THE DEATHLY HAL-  
LEWS HAD TAKEN POSSESSION OF HIM, AND HE COULD NOT REST WHILE AGI-  
TATING THOUGHTS WHIRLED THROUGH HIS MIND: THE WAND, THE STONE,  
AND

THE CLOAK, IF HE COULD JUST POSSESS THEM ALL, . . .

I OPEN AT THE CLOAK, . . . BUT WHAT WAS THE CLOAK? WHY COULDN'T HE

HAVE THE STONE ONLY? IF ONLY HE HAD THE STONE, HE COULD ASK  
DUMBLE-

BIRE THESE QUESTIONS IN PERSON . . . AND HARRY MURMURED WORDS TO

THE SNITCH IN THE DARKNESS, TRYING EVERYTHING, EVEN  
PARSELTONGUE,

BUT THE CHILDEN BALL WOULD NOT OPEN, . . .

AND THE WAND, THE ELDER WAND, WHERE WAS THAT HIDDEN? WHERE  
WAS VERDERBERT SEARCHING ONLY? HARRY WISHED HIS SCAR WOULD BURN  
AND SHOW HIM VERDERBERT'S THOUGHTS, RECALISE HER THE FIRST TIME  
EVER,

HE AND VERDERBERT WERE UNITED IN WANTING THE VERY SAME THING, . . .

HERMIONE WOULD NOT LIKE THAT IDEA, OF COURSE, . . . BUT THEN, SHE DID  
NOT BELIEVE . . . RENEPHILUS HAD BEEN RIGHT, IN A WAY . . . LIMITED.  
NARROW, CLOSE-MINDED. THE TRUTH WAS THAT SHE WAS SCARED OF THE  
IDEA

OF THE DEATHLY HALLEWS, ESPECIALLY OF THE RESURRECTION STONE . . .

AND HARRY PRESSED HIS MOUTH AGAIN TO THE SNITCH, KISSING IT,  
NEARLY

SWALLOWING IT, BUT THE HARD METAL DID NOT YIELD, . . .

IT WAS NEARLY DAWN WHEN HE REMEMBERED LUNA, ALONE IN A CELL IN  
AZKABAN, SURROUNDED BY DEMENTERS, AND HE SUDDENLY FELT ASSAILED

THE DEADLY HALLS

YES

OF HIMSELF, HE HAD FORGOTTEN ALL ABOUT HER IN HIS FEVERISH  
CONTEMPLA-

TION OF THE HALLS. IF ONLY THEY COULD RESCUE HER; BUT DEMENTERS

IN THESE NUMBERS WOULD BE VIRTUALLY UNASSAILABLE. WHEN HE CAME  
TO THINK ABOUT IT, HE HAD NOT YET TRIED CASTING A PATRONUS WITH  
THE

BLACKTHORN WAND, . . . HE MUST TRY THAT IN THE MORNING, . . .

IF ONLY THERE WAS A WAY OF GETTING A BETTER WAND . . .

AND DESIRE FOR THE ELDER WAND, THE DEATHSTICK, UNBREAKABLE, IN-  
VINCIBLE, SWALLOWED HIM ONCE MORE, . . .

THEY PACKED UP THE TENT NEXT MORNING AND MOVED ON THROUGH  
A DREARY SHELVING OF RAIN. THE DEMENTERS PURSUED THEM TO THE  
COAST,

WHERE THEY PITCHED THE TENT THAT NIGHT, AND PERSISTED THROUGH THE

WHEELS WERE, THROUGH SHODDEN LANDSCAPES THAT HARRY FELT BLEAD  
AND

DEPRESSING, HE COULD THINK ONLY OF THE DEATHLY ELLIOTS. IT WAS AS  
THOUGH A FLAME HAD BEEN LIT INSIDE HIM THAT NOTHING, NOT  
HERMIONE'S

PLAT DISBELIEF NOR RON'S PERSISTENT BELIEFS, COULD EXTINGUISH. AND  
YET

THE FIERCER THE LONGING FOR THE ELLIOTS BURNED INSIDE HIM, THE LESS

IMPULS IT MADE HIM. HE BLAMED RON AND HERMIONE: THEIR DETER-  
MINED INDIFFERENCE WAS AS BAD AS THE RELENTLESS RAIN AND DAMPENING

HIS SPIRITS, BUT NEITHER COULD ERASE HIS CERTAINTY, WHICH REMAINED  
ABSOLUTE. HARRY'S BELIEF IN AND LONGING FOR THE ELLIOTS CONSUMED  
HIM SO MUCH THAT HE FELT ALONE ISOLATED FROM THE OTHER TWO AND  
THEIR

EXISTENCE WITH THE ELLIOTS.

HERMIONE SAID HERMIONE IN A LOW FIERCE VOICE, WHEN HARRY  
WAS CARELESS ENOUGH TO USE THE WORD ONE EVENING, AFTER HERMIONE  
HAD TOLD HIM OFF FOR HIS LACK OF INTEREST IN LOCATING MERE  
ELLIOTS.

WE'RE NOT THE ONES WITH AN EXISTENCE, HARRY! WE'RE THE ONES  
TRYING

THE ONE WHAT DUMBLEDORE WANTED US TO BE!

BUT HE WAS IMPERVIOUS TO THE VEILED CRITICISM. DUMBLEDORE

HAD LEFT THE SIGN OF THE ELLIOTS AND HERMIONE THE DECIPIER, AND HE

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ARE

HAD ALSE, HARRY REMAINED CONVINCED OF IT, LEFT THE RESURRECTION  
STONE HIDDEN IN THE GOLDEN SNITCH. NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE  
OTHER

SURVIVES. . . . MASTER OF DEATH. . . . WHY DIDN'T BEN AND HERMIONE  
UNDERSTAND?

THE LAST ENEMY THAT SHALL BE DESTROYED IS DEATH. HARRY BREATHED  
CALMLY.

I THOUGHT IT WAS YELL-KNEW-WHEN WE WERE SUPPOSED TO BE FIGHT-  
ING? HERMIONE RETORTED, AND HARRY GAVE UP ON HER.

EVEN THE MYSTERY OF THE SILVER DEER, WHICH THE OTHER TWO INSISTED  
ON

DISCUSSING, SEEMED LESS IMPORTANT TO HARRY NOW, A VAGUELY  
INTERESTING

SIDE-SHOW. THE ONLY OTHER THING THAT MATTERED TO HIM WAS THAT HIS  
SCAR

HAD REWOUND THE PRICKLE AGAIN, ALTHOUGH HE DID ALL HE COULD TO HIDE  
THIS

FACT FROM THE OTHER TWO. HE SHOULDNT SHOW IT WHENEVER IT  
HAPPENED.

BUT WAS DISAPPOINTED BY WHAT HE SAW. THE VISIONS HE AND  
VERDERBERT

WERE SHARING HAD CHANGED IN QUALITY; THEY HAD BECOME BLURRED,  
SHIFT-

ING AS THOUGH THEY WERE MOVING IN AND OUT OF FIELDS, HARRY WAS  
LIST

ABLE TO MAKE OUT THE INDISTINCT FEATURES OF AN OBJECT THAT BEHEDED  
LIKE

A SKULL, AND SOMETHING LIKE A MOUNTAIN THAT WAS MORE SHADED  
THAN

SUBSTANCE, USED THE IMAGES SHARP AS REALITY, HARRY WAS DISORIENTED  
BY THE CHANGE, HE WAS WORRIED THAT THE CONNECTION BETWEEN  
HIMSELF

AND VERDREHT HAD BEEN DAMAGED, A CONNECTION THAT HE KEENLY FEARED

AND, WHATEVER HE HAD THOUGHT FORTHWITH, PRIZED, SOMEHOW HARRY CON-  
NECTED THESE UNSATISFYING, VAGUE IMAGES WITH THE DESTRUCTION OF  
HIS

WAND, AS IF IT WAS THE BLACKTHERN WAND & FAULT THAT HE COULD NO  
LONGER

SEE INTO VERDREHT'S MIND AS WELL AS RETURN.

AS THE WEEKS CREEPT ON, HARRY COULD NOT HELP BUT NOTICE, EVEN  
THROUGH HIS NEW SELF-ABSORPTION, THAT JOHN SEEMED TO BE TAKING  
CHARGE, PERHAPS BECAUSE HE WAS DETERMINED TO MAKE UP FOR HAVING

THE DEADLY HALLS

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WALKED OUT HIM THEM, PERHAPS BECAUSE HARRY'S DESCENT INTO  
LISTLESS-

NESS GALVANIZED HIS DORMANT LEADERSHIP ABILITIES, REIN WAS THE  
ONE

NEW ENCOURAGING AND EXHORTING THE OTHER TWO INTO ACTION.

THREE HERCULES LEFT, HE KEPT SAYING, WE NEED A PLAN OF AC-  
TION, COME ON! WHERE HAVEN'T WE SEARCHED? LET'S GO THROUGH IT  
AGAIN.

THE ORPHANAGE...

DIAGON ALLEY, HOGWARTS, THE RIDDLE HOUSE, BURGON AND BURTON,  
ALBANIA, EVERY PLACE THAT THEY KNEW THE RIDDLE HAD EVER LIVED OR  
WORKED, VISITED OR MURDERED, REIN AND HERMIONE RANDED OVER THEM  
AGAIN, HARRY IMITING IN ONLY THE STEP HERMIONE PESTERING HIM, HE

WOULD HAVE BEEN HAPPY TO SIT ALONE IN SILENCE, TRYING TO READ  
VOLUME-

MIGHT BE THE LIGHTS, THE FIND HAD BEEN ABOUT THE ELDER LAND, BUT REIN

INSISTED ON EXPLORING THE EVER MORE UNLIKELY PLACES SIMPLY,  
HARRY

WAS ALONE, THE KEEP THEM MOVING.

HE NEVER KNEW, WAS REIN'S CONSTANT REFRAIN, LITTLE FLAGLEY  
IS

A WIZARDING VILLAGE, HE MIGHT BE WANTED TO LIVE THERE, LET'S GO AND  
HAVE A PEEK AROUND.

THESE FREQUENT FORAYS INTO WIZARDING TERRITORY BRING THEM  
WITHIN OCCASIONAL SIGHT OF SNATCHERS.

SOME OF THEM ARE SUPPOSED TO BE AS BAD AS DEATH EATERS, SAID  
JOHN. THE LOT THAT GOT ME WERE A BIT PATHETIC, BUT BILL BELIEVES  
SOME

OF THEM ARE REALLY DANGEROUS. THEY SAID HEN PETERWATCH  
HEN WHAT? SAID HARRY.

PETERWATCH, DIDN'T I TELL YOU THAT'S WHAT IT WAS CALLED? THE PRO-  
GRAM I KEEP TRYING TO GET HEN THE RADIO, THE ONLY ONE THAT TELLS  
THE

TRUTH ABOUT WHAT'S GOING ON? NEARLY ALL THE PROGRAMS ARE  
FALLING

YOU-KNOW-WHICH LINE, ALL EXCEPT PETERWATCH. I REALLY WANT YOU  
TO

HEAR IT, BUT IT'S TRICKY TUNING IN, . . .

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

THE

JOHN SPENT EVENING AFTER EVENING LISTING HIS HAND TO BEAT OUT  
VARI-

OUS RHYTHMS HEN THE WIRELESS WHILE THE DIALS WHIRLED. OCCA-  
SIONALLY THEY WOULD CATCH SNATCHES OF ADVICE HEN FEEL THE TREAT  
DRAGON

POOR, AND HENCE A FEW EARS OF A CALIBRE FULL OF LIGHT STRONG  
LIGHT.

WHILE HE TAPPED, REIN CONTINUED TO TRY TO HIT HIM THE CORRECT  
PASS-

WORDS, FLUTTERING STRINGS OF RANDOM WORDS UNDER HIS BREATH.

THEY ARE NORMALLY SOMETHING TO DO WITH THE ORDER, HE TOLD THEM.  
BILL HAD A REAL KNACK FOR GUESSING THEM. I'M BEHIND TO GET HERE IN  
THE END. . . .

BUT NOT UNTIL MARCH DID BILL SAY REIN AT LAST. HARRY WAS  
SITTING

IN THE TENT ENTRANCE, HIS EYES DRY, STARING IDLY AT A CLUMP OF  
GRASS

HYACINTHS THAT HAD FORCED THEIR WAY THROUGH THE CHILLY GROUND,  
WHEN

REIN SMILED EXCITEDLY FROM INSIDE THE TENT.

I'VE GOT IT, I'VE GOT IT! PASSWORD WAS AKAIS! GET IN HERE,  
HARRY!

REFUSED FOR THE FIRST TIME IN DAYS FROM HIS CONTEMPLATION OF THE  
DEATHLY HALLS, HARRY HURRIED BACK INSIDE THE TENT TO FIND REIN

AND HERMIONE KNEELING ON THE FLOOR BESIDE THE LITTLE RADIO. HERMI-  
ONE, WHO HAD BEEN PEEVISHING THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER JUST FOR  
SOME-

THING TO DO, WAS SITTING EYES-MILKED, STARING AT THE TINY  
SPEAKER,

FROM WHICH A MOST FAMILIAR VOICE WAS ISSUING.

. . . APOLOGIZE FOR OUR TEMPORARY ABSENCE FROM THE AIRWAYS,  
WHICH WAS DUE TO A NUMBER OF UNUSUAL CALLS IN OUR AREA BY THESE  
CHARMING DEATH EATERS.

BUT THAT'S LEE JORDAN? SAID HERMINE.

I KNOW? KEATED REIN. CHEER, EH?

... NEIL FEELING HIMSELF ANOTHER SECURE LOCATION, LEE WAS SAY-  
ING, AND I'M PLEASED TO TELL YOU THAT TWO OF OUR REGULAR

CONTRIBUTORS HAVE JOINED ME HERE THIS EVENING. EVENING, REYS?  
Hi,

THE DEADLY FALLS

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EVENING, RIVER.

RIVER, THAT'S LEE, REIN EXPLAINED. THEY'VE ALL GOTTEN NAMES,  
BUT YOU CAN USUALLY TELL

SEE? SAID HERMINE.

BUT BEFORE WE HEAR FROM REYAL AND REYLLIS, LEE WENT ON, LET'S  
TAKE A MOMENT TO REPORT THESE DEATHS THAT THE WIZARDING  
WIRELESS

NETHERS NEWS AND DAILY PROPHECY DON'T THINK IMPORTANT ENOUGH  
TO

MENTION. IT IS WITH GREAT REGRET THAT WE INFORM OUR LISTENERS OF  
THE

MURDERS OF TED TENDS AND DICK CRESSWELL.

HARRY FELT A SICK, SWEEPING IN HIS BELLY. HE, REIN, AND HERMINE  
GAZED AT EACH OTHER IN HORROR.

A GIRL BY THE NAME OF GERNOLD WAS ALSO KILLED. IT IS BELIEVED

THAT MUGGLE-KHORN DEAN THOMAS AND A SECOND GIBLIN, BOTH BELIEVED TO HAVE BEEN TRAVELING WITH TENDS, CRESSWELL, AND GIBLIN, MAY HAVE ESCAPED. IF DEAN IS LISTENING, HE IF ANYONE HAS ANY

KNOWLEDGE OF HIS WHEREABOUTS, HIS PARENTS AND SISTERS ARE DESPERATE

FOR NEWS.

MEANWHILE, IN GADDLEY, A MUGGLE FAMILY OF FIVE HAS BEEN FOUND DEAD IN THEIR HOME. MUGGLE AUTHORITIES ARE ATTRIBUTING THE DEATHS TO A GAS LEAK, BUT MEMBERS OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX INFORM ME THAT IT WAS THE KILLING CURSE MORE EVIDENCE, AS IF IT WERE NEEDED, OF THE FACT THAT MUGGLE SLAUGHTER IS BECOMING LITTLE MORE THAN A RECREATIONAL SPORT UNDER THE NEW REGIME.

FINALLY, WE REGRET TO INFORM OUR LISTENERS THAT THE REMAINS OF RUTHILDA RAGSWORTH HAVE BEEN DISCOVERED IN GIBLIN'S FILLING. THE

EVIDENCE IS THAT SHE DIED SEVERAL MONTHS AGO. THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX

INFORMS US THAT HER BODY SHOWED UNMISTAKABLE SIGNS OF INJURIES

INFlicted BY DARK MAGIC.

LISTENERS, I'D LIKE TO INVITE YOU NOW TO JOIN US IN A MINUTE'S

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

SILENCE IN MEMORY OF TED TONKS, DICK CRESSWELL, RUTHILDA BACCHETT, GERNOLD, AND THE LINDAMED, BUT NOT LESS REGRETTED, MUGGLES MURDERED BY THE DEATH EATERS.

SILENCE FELL, AND HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONIE DID NOT SPEAK. HALF OF HARRY YEARNS TO HEAR MORE, HALF OF HIM WAS AFRAID OF WHAT MIGHT

COME NEXT. IT WAS THE FIRST TIME HE HAD FELT FULLY CONNECTED TO THE MUGGLESIDE WORLD FOR A LONG TIME.

THANK YOU, SAID LEE'S VOICE. AND WHEN WE TURN THE REGULAR CENTRIKITCHEN REVEAL, FOR AN UPDATE WE FEEL THE NEW WIZARDING ORDER IS

AFFECTING THE MUGGLE WORLD.

THANKS, RIVER, SAID AN UNMISTAKABLE VOICE, DEEP, MEASURED, REASSURING.

KINGSLEY? FIRST MET RON.

WE KNOW? SAID HERMIONIE, FLASHING HIM.

MUGGLES REMAIN IGNORANT OF THE SEVERITY OF THEIR SLIPPING AS THEY CONTINUE TO SUSTAIN HEAVY CASUALTIES, SAID KINGSLEY, HOWEVER,

WE CONTINUE TO HEAR TRULY INSPIRATIONAL STORIES OF WIZARDS AND WITCHES

RISKING THEIR OWN SAFETY TO PROTECT MUGGLE FRIENDS AND NEIGHBORS, OFTEN WITHOUT THE MUGGLES KNOWLEDGE. I'D LIKE TO APPEAL TO ALL OUR

LISTENERS TO EMULATE THEIR EXAMPLE, PERHAPS BY CARRYING A PROTECTIVE



CHARM EVER AND MISCLE DWELLINGS IN THEIR STREET. MANY LIVES COULD BE SAVED IF SUCH SIMPLE MEASURES ARE TAKEN.

AND WHAT WOULD YOU SAY, REYAL, THE THESE LISTENERS WERE REPLY THAT

IN THESE DANGEROUS TIMES, IT SHOULD BE WIZARDS FIRST ? ASKED LEE.

I D SAY THAT IT S MORE SHORT STEP FROM WIZARDS FIRST THE PLUREREHDS

FIRST, AND THEN THE DEATH EATERS, REPLIED KINGSLY. WE RE ALL FILI-

MAN, AREN T WE? EVERY HUMAN LIFE IS WORTH THE SAME, AND WORTH

SAVING.

EXCELLENTLY PUT, REYAL, AND YOU VE GOT MY VOTE FOR MINISTER OF

THE DEATHLY HALLS

ggg1

MAGIC IF EVER WE GET HLT OF THIS MESS, SAID LEE. AND NOW, EVER THE REMLILLS FOR THEIR POPULAR FEATURE PALS OF PETER.

THANKS, RIVER, SAID ANOTHER VERY FAMILIAR VOICE; BEN STARTED THE

SPREAD, BUT HERMIONE PRESTALLED HIM IN A WHISPER.

WE KNOW IT S SLIPIN

REMLILLS, DID YOU MAINTAIN, AS YOU HAVE EVERY TIME YOU VE AP-  
PEARED IN YOUR PROGRAM, THAT HARRY PETER IS STILL ALIVE?

I DO, SAID LUPIN FIRMLY. THERE IS NO DOUBT AT ALL IN MY MIND THAT HIS DEATH WOULD BE PROCLAIMED AS WIDELY AS POSSIBLE BY THE DEATH EATERS IF IT HAD HAPPENED, BECAUSE IT WOULD STRIKE A DEADLY BLOW AT THE MORALE OF THOSE RESISTING THE NEW REGIME. THE RED WOLF

LIVED REMAINS A SYMBOL OF EVERYTHING FOR WHICH WE ARE FIGHTING: THE TRIUMPH OF GOOD, THE POWER OF INDIGNANCE, THE NEED TO KEEP RESISTING.

A MIXTURE OF GRATITUDE AND SHAME WELLED UP IN HARRY. HAD LUPIN FORGIVEN HIM, THEN, FOR THE TERRIBLE THINGS HE HAD SAID WHEN THEY HAD LAST MET?

AND WHAT WOULD SHE SAY TO HARRY IF SHE KNEW HE WAS LISTENING, REMILLY?

I'D TELL HIM WE'RE ALL WITH HIM IN SPIRIT, SAID LUPIN, THEN HESITATED SLIGHTLY. AND I'D TELL HIM THE FEELINGS HIS INSTINCTS, WHICH ARE GOOD AND NEARLY ALWAYS RIGHT.

HARRY LOOKED AT FERMINE, WHOSE EYES WERE FULL OF TEARS.

NEARLY ALWAYS RIGHT, SHE REPEATED.

HE DIDN'T I TELL YOU? SAID REN IN SURPRISE. WILL TELL ME LUPIN IS LIVING WITH THEM AGAIN? AND APPARENTLY SHE IS GETTING PRETTY BIG

THEH...

... AND HOW USUAL UPDATE FOR THESE FRIENDS OF HARRY PETER'S WHO ARE SUFFERING FOR THEIR ALLEGIANCE? SHE WAS SAYING.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

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WELL, AS REGULAR LISTENERS WILL KNOW, SEVERAL OF THE MORE HITSPE-  
KEN SLIPPERERS OF F-HARRY PETER HAVE NOW BEEN IMPRISONED,  
INCLUD-  
ING JENNIFERILIS LEVEGHH, FIRST-LIKE EDITOR OF THE FLICKER,  
SAID

LUPIN.

AT LEAST HE IS STILL ALIVE? MUTTERED RHH.

WE HAVE ALSO HEARD WITHIN THE LAST FEW HOURS THAT RIKELIS  
F-HARID ALL THREE OF THEM GASPED, AND SHE NEARLY MISSED THE REST  
OF THE SENTENCE WELL-KNOWN GAMEKEEPER AT F-HIGWARTS SCHOOL,  
HAS NARROWLY ESCAPED ARREST WITHIN THE GROUNDS OF F-HIGWARTS,  
WHERE  
HE IS ALIGNED THE HAVE HOSTED A SLIPPER F-HARRY PETER PARTY IN  
HIS

HOUSE, HOWEVER, F-HARID WAS NOT TAKEN INTO CUSTODY, AND IS, WE  
BELIEVE, IN THE RUN.

I SUPPOSE IT HELPS, WHEN ESCAPING FROM DEATH RATERS, IF YOU VE  
GOT A SIXTEEN-FOOT-HIGH HALF BROTHER? ASKED LEE.

IT WOULD TEND TO GIVE YOU AN EDGE, AGREED LUPIN GRAVELY. MAY  
I JUST ADD THAT WHILE WE HERE AT PETERWATCH APPALD F-HARID IS  
SPIRIT,

WE WOULD LIKE EVEN THE MOST DEVOTED OF HARRY'S SLIPPERERS  
AGAINST

FOLLOWING HAGRID'S LEAD. SLIPPER HARRY POTTER PARTIES ARE  
LONELY

IN THE PRESENT CLIMATE.

INDEED THEY ARE, REMULUS, SAID LEE, SHE WE SUGGEST THAT YOU  
CONTINUE THE SAME YOUR DEVOTION TO THE MAN WITH THE LIGHTNING  
SCAR

BY LISTENING TO POTTERWATCH? AND NOW LET'S MOVE THE NEWS  
CONCERNING

THE WIZARD WHO IS PROVEN JUST AS ELUSIVE AS HARRY POTTER. WE  
LIKE

THE REFER TO HIM AS THE CHIEF DEATH EATER, AND HERE WE GIVE HIS VIEWS  
AND SOME OF THE MORE INSANE RUMORS CIRCULATING ABOUT HIM. I'D LIKE  
TO INTRODUCE A NEW CORRESPONDENT: REDENT.

REDENT? SAID YET ANOTHER FAMILIAR VOICE, AND HARRY, REM, AND  
BERMIONE CRIED OUT TOGETHER:

FRED!

THE DEATHLY HALLS

\*\*\*

NEH IS IT GEORGE?

IT'S FRED, I THINK, SAID REM, LEANING IN CLOSER, AS WHICHEVER TWIN  
IT WAS SAID,

I'M NOT BEING REDENT, NEH WAS, I TOLD YOU I WANTED THE  
RAPID!

EH, ALL RIGHT THEN. RAPIER, WOULD YOU PLEASE GIVE US YOUR TAKE ON THE VARIOUS THEORIES WE'VE BEEN HEARING ABOUT THE CHIEF DEATH LATER?

YES, RIVER, I CAN, SAID FRED. AS OUR LISTENERS WILL KNOW, UNLESS THEY'VE TAKEN REFUGE AT THE KITCHEN OF A GARDEN FRIEND OR SOMEWHERE

SIMILAR, YOU-KNOW-WHICH'S STRATEGY OF REMAINING IN THE SHADOWS IS

CREATING A NICE LITTLE CLIMATE OF PANIC. MIND YOU, IF ALL THE ALLEGED

SIGHTINGS OF HIM ARE GENUINE, WE MUST HAVE A GOOD NINETEEN YOU-KNOW-WHICHES RUNNING AROUND THE PLACE.

WHICH SLITS HIM, OF COURSE, SAID KINGSLEY. THE AIR OF MYSTERY IS CREATING MORE TERROR THAN ACTUALLY SHOWING HIMSELF.

AGREED, SAID FRED. SEE, PEOPLE, LET'S TRY AND CALM DOWN A BIT. THINGS ARE BAD ENOUGH WITHOUT INVENTING STUFF AS WELL. FOR INSTANCE,

THIS NEW IDEA THAT YOU-KNOW-WHICH CAN KILL WITH A SINGLE GLANCE FROM

HIS EYES. THAT'S A BASILISK, LISTENERS. HERE SIMPLE TEST: CHECK WHETHER

THE THING THAT'S GLARING AT YOU HAS GIFT LEGS. IF IT HAS, IT'S SAFE TO

INTO ITS EYES, ALTHOUGH IF IT REALLY IS YOU-KNOW-WHICH, THAT'S STILL LIKELY TO BE THE LAST THING YOU EVER DO.

FOR THE FIRST TIME IN WEEKS AND WEEKS, HARRY WAS LAUGHING: HE COULD FEEL THE WEIGHT OF TENSION LEAVING HIM.

AND THE LISTENERS THAT HE DEEPS BEING SIGHTED AHEAD? ASKED  
LEE.

WELL, WEH WELLDN T WANT A NICE LITTLE HOLIDAY AFTER ALL THE HARD  
WHIRL HE S BEEN PLUTTING IN? ASKED FRED. PHINT IS, PEOPLE, DEN T  
ERT

## CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

\*\*\*

WILLED INTO A FALSE SENSE OF SECURITY, THINKING HE S HLT OF THE  
COUNTRY.

MAYBE HE IS, MAYBE HE ISN T, BUT THE FACT REMAINS HE CAN MOVE  
FASTER

THAN SEVERUS Snape COMMENTED WITH SHARPNESS WHEN HE WANTS THE  
SEE DEN T HLT HIM HIM BEING A LONG WAY AWAY IF YELL RE PLANNING  
HIM

TAKING ANY RISKS. I NEVER THOUGHT I D HEAR MYSELF SAY IT, BUT  
SAFETY

FIRST:

THANK YELL VERY MUCH FOR THESE WISE WORDS, RAPIER, SAID LEE.

LISTENERS, THAT BRINGS US THE END OF ANOTHER POTTERRATCH. WE  
DEN T

KNOW WHEN IT WILL BE POSSIBLE THE BROADCAST AGAIN, BUT YELL CAN BE  
SURE

WE SHALL BE BACK, KEEP TWIDDLING THESE DIALS! THE NEXT PASSWORD  
WILL

BE MAD-LYE. KEEP EACH OTHER SAFE! KEEP FAITH. GOOD NIGHT.

THE RADIO S DIAL TWIRLED AND THE LIGHTS BEHIND THE TUNING PANEL

WENT BLIT, HARRY, RHN, AND HERMIONE WERE STILL BEAMING, HEARING

FAMILIAR, FRIENDLY VEHICLES WAS AN EXTRAORDINARY THING; HARRY HAD  
BE-

COME SHE LIVED THE THEIR ISOLATION HE HAD NEARLY FORGOTTEN THAT  
EITHER

PEOPLE WERE RESISTING VIOLENCE. IT WAS LIKE WAKING FROM A LONG  
SLEEP.

GOOD, EH? SAID RHN HAPPILY.

BRILLIANT, SAID HARRY.

IT'S SO BRAVE OF THEM, SIGHED HERMIONE ADMIRINGLY. IF THEY  
WERE BLIND...

WELL, THEY KEEP HIM THERE, DON'T THEY? SAID RHN. LIKE US.

BUT DID YOU HEAR WHAT FRED SAID? ASKED HARRY EXCITEDLY; NOW

THE BROADCAST WAS OVER, HIS THOUGHTS TURNED AGAIN TOWARD HIS ALL-  
CONSUMING OBSESSION. HE'S AHEAD? HE'S STILL LOOKING FOR THE

WAND, I KNOW IT!

HARRY

COME ON, HERMIONE, WHY ARE YOU SO DETERMINED NOT TO ADMIT  
IT? YOU

THE DEATHLY HALLOWS

MS

HARRY, NEE!

DEMENT S AFTER THE ELDER LAND!

THE NAME S TAREEE! REIN BELLEVED, LEAPING THE HIS FEET AS A WILD  
CRACK SHLINDO ELTISIDE THE TENT. I TELL YOU, HARRY, I TELL YOU, WE  
CAN T SAY IT ANYMORE WE VE GOT THE PLIT THE PROTECTION BACK  
AREHIND

LIS ELICIDLY IT S BEEN THEY FIND  
BUT REIN STOPPED TALKING, AND HARRY KNEW WHY. THE SNEAKERSHOPE  
HEN THE TABLE HAD LIT UP AND BEGIN THE SPIN! THEY WOULD HEAR VEHICLES

CHIMING NEARER AND NEARER! REHICH, EXCITED VEHICLES. REIN PULLED THE  
DE-

ELIMINATOR ELT H HIS PHECKET AND CLICKED IT! THEIR LAMPS WENT ELT.

THEIR ELT H THERE WITH THEIR HANDS UP! CAME A RASPING VEHICLE  
THROUGH THE DARKNESS. WE KNOW YOU RE IN THERE! YOU VE GOT  
HALF A

DIZEN HANDS PHINTING AT YOU AND WE DONT CARE WHEN WE CLASH!

## CHAPTER TWENTY - THREE

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MALFEY MANNER

ARRY WHEEDD AREHIND AT THE EITHER TWO, NEW MORE ELTLINES  
IN THE DARKNESS. HE SAW HERMIONE PHINT HER LAND, NEE



THEARD THE HILTIDE, BUT INTH HIS FACE, THERE WAS A RAGE, A BURN OF  
WHITE LIGHT, AND HE BLINKED IN AGONY, UNABLE TO SEE, HE COULD FEEL

HIS FACE SWELLING RAPIDLY UNDER HIS HANDS AS HEAVY FEETFALLS SUR-  
ROUNDED HIM.

GET UP, VERMIN.

LINDENHORN HANDS DRAGGED HARRY RELUCTANTLY OFF THE GROUND, BEWARE  
HE COULD STEEL THEM, SOMEONE HAD RUMMAGED THROUGH HIS POCKETS

AND REMOVED THE BLACKTHORN WAND, HARRY CLUTCHED AT HIS EXCRUCI-  
ATINGLY PAINFUL FACE, WHICH FELT UNRECOGNIZABLE BENEATH HIS  
FINGERS,

TIGHT, SWOLLEN, AND PUFFY AS THOUGH HE HAD SUFFERED SOME VIOLENT  
ALLERGIC REACTION, HIS EYES HAD BEEN REPLACED THE SLITS THROUGH WHICH  
HE COULD BARELY SEE, HIS GLASSES FELL OFF AS HE WAS BLINDED HIT BY THE  
TENT, ALL HE COULD MAKE OUT WERE THE BURNED SHAPES OF PEOPLE AND  
FIRE

PEOPLE WRESTLING RON AND HERMIONE HILTIDE THEM.

HE

MALFLOY MANEER

gggg

GET OFF HER! RON SMILED, THERE WAS THE UNMISTAKABLE

FEELING THE KNIVES HITTING FLESH: BEN GRANTED IN PAIN AND  
PERMITS

SCREAMED, "DON'T LEAVE HIM ALONE, LEAVE HIM ALONE!"

WELL, MY FRIEND, I'VE BEEN THERE MORE THAN THAT BEFORE THE TIME IF  
HE'S ON MY LIST, SAID THE TERRIBLY FAMILIAR, RASPY VOICE,  
DELICIOUS

GIRL... WHAT A TREAT... I'VE ENJOYED THE SMOOTHNESS OF THE SKIN...

HARRY'S STOMACH TURNED OVER, HE KNEW WHERE THIS WAS: FERRIS  
GROVER, THE WEREWOLF WHO WAS PERMITTED TO WEAR DEATH LATER  
THAN IN RETURN FOR HIS FIRED SAVAGERY.

SEARCH THE TENT? SAID ANOTHER VOICE.

HARRY WAS TURNING BACKWARD INTO THE GRIND, A THIRD TOLD HIM

THAT BEN HAD BEEN LAST SEEN BESIDE HIM. THEY COULD HEAR FOOT-  
STEPS AND CRASHES; THE MEN WERE PUSHING OVER CHAIRS INSIDE THE  
TENT

AS THEY SEARCHED.

WELL, LET'S SEE WHERE WE'VE GOTTEN, SAID GROVER'S GHOSTLY VOICE  
FROM OVERHEAD, AND HARRY WAS PULLED OVER INTO HIS BACK, A BEAM  
OF LIGHT FELL INTO HIS FACE AND GROVER LAUGHED.

I'LL BE NEEDING BUTTER FOR THE WASH THIS MORNING, WHAT HAP-  
PENED THE WELL, WELL?

HARRY DID NOT ANSWER IMMEDIATELY.

I SAID, REPEATED GROVER, AND HARRY RECEIVED A BLOW TO THE  
DIAPHRAGM THAT MADE HIM BELIEVE OVER IN PAIN, WHAT HAPPENED

THE YELL?

STUNG, HARRY MUTTERED, BEEN STUNG.

YEAH, LOOKS LIKE IT, SAID A SECOND VEHICLE.

WHAT'S THEIR NAME? SPARKED GREYBACK.

DUDLEY, SAID HARRY.

AND THEIR FIRST NAME?

I VERNIEEN, VERNIEEN DUDLEY.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

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CHECK THE LIST, SCARTER, SAID GREYBACK, AND HARRY HEARD HIM MOVE SIDEWAYS THE WHEEL DOWN AT REIN, INSTEAD, AND WHAT ABOUT YELL,

GINGER?

STAN SHLINDICE, SAID REIN.

LIKE ALL YELL ARE, SAID THE MAN CALLED SCARTER, WE KNOW STAN SHLINDICE, & I PUT A KIT UP WHERE HE WAS.

THERE WAS ANOTHER THING.

I & RABBY, SAID REIN, AND HARRY COULD TELL THAT HIS MOUTH WAS FULL OF BLEED. RABBY WEADEY.

A WEASLEY? RASPED GREYBACK. SEE YELL RE RELATED THE BLEED TRAITHERS EVEN IF YELL RE NOT A MURDERER, AND LASTLY, THEIR PRETTY LITTLE

FRIEND... THE RELISH IN HIS VOICE MADE HARRY'S FLESH CRAWL.

PASS, GREYBACK, SAID SCARIER OVER THE IPERING OF THE HITHERS.

OH, I M NOT CHING THE RITE ILST YET, WE LL SEE IF SHE S A RIT HELICKER  
AT REMEMBERING HER NAME THAN KARRY, WEH ARE YELL, GIRLY?

PENKHEE CLEARWATER, SAID FERMINE, SHE SHOUNED TERRIFIED,  
BLIT CHNVINKING.

WHAT S YELLER BLEED STATLS?

HALF-BLEED, SAID FERMINE.

PASS ENOUGH THE CHECKS, SAID SCARIER, BLIT THE HLE LIT OF PM LEED  
LIKE THEY CHLD STILL BE HGLWARTS AGE

WE E LEFT, SAID REN.

LEFT, AVE YELL, GINGER? SAID SCARIER, AND YELL DECIDED THE GE  
CAMPING? AND YELL THELIGHT, ILST FHR A LAUGH, YELL D LSE THE DARK  
LEHD S NAME?

NED A LAUGH, SAID REN, ACCIDEN.

ACCIDENT? THERE WAS MORE IPERING LAUGHTER.

YELL DENED WEH LSED TE LIKE LISING THE DARK LEHD S NAME,

MALTED MANER

ggg

WEASLEY? GRILLED GREYBACK, THE HORDER OF THE PHENIX, MEAN  
ANYTHING THE YELL?

DEH.

WELL, THEY DEN T SEH THE DARK LEHD PROPER RESPECT, SE THE  
NAME S BEEN TAKENED, A FEW HORDER MEMBERS HAVE BEEN TRACKED TEAT  
WAY, WE LL SEE, KID THEM UP WITH THE HITHER TWO PRISONERS?

SHEPHERD YANKED HARRY UP BY THE HAIR, DRAGGED HIM A SHORT WAY, PUSHED HIM DOWN INTO A SITTING POSITION, THEN STARTED BINDING HIM BACK-TO-BACK WITH OTHER PEOPLE. HARRY WAS STILL HALF BLIND, BARELY ABLE TO SEE ANYTHING THROUGH HIS PLUMPED-UP EYES. WHEN AT LAST THE MAN TYING THEM HAD WALKED AWAY, HARRY WHISPERED TO THE OTHER PRISONERS.

ANYONE STILL GET A HAND?

NO, SAID REEN AND HERMINE FROM EITHER SIDE OF HIM.

THIS IS ALL MY FAULT. I SAID THE NAME, I'M SORRY

HARRY?

IT WAS A NEW, BUT FAMILIAR, VEHICLE, AND IT CAME FROM DIRECTLY BEHIND HARRY, FROM THE PERSON TIED TO HERMINE'S LEFT.

DEAN?

IT IS WELL! IF THEY FIND OUT WHEN THEY'RE GETTING : THEY'RE SNATCHERS.

THEY'RE ONLY LOOKING FOR TRIANTS TO SELL FOR CASH

WENT A BAD LITTLE FALLOUT FOR ONE NIGHT, GREYBACK WAS SAYING, AS A PAIR OF FINGERMAILED KNEETS MARCHED CLOSE BY HARRY AND THEY HEARD MORE CRASHES FROM INSIDE THE TENT. A MURDERED, A RUNAWAY GHELIN, AND THREE TRIANTS, WELL CHECKED THEIR NAMES IN THE LIST YET, SLAKING?

HE REARED.

YEAH, THERE'S NEW VERNON DUBLEY IN THE, GREYBACK.

INTERESTING, SAID GREYBACK, THAT'S INTERESTING.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

AND

HE CREELED DOWN BESIDE HARRY, WHO SAW, THROUGH THE INFINITE-  
TESTAL GAP LEFT BETWEEN HIS SWELLEN EYELIDS, A FACE COVERED IN MAT-  
TED GRAY HAIR AND WHISKERS, WITH POINTED GREEN TEETH AND SHES AT

THE CORNERS OF HIS MOUTH. GREYBACK SMELLED AS HE HAD BEEN AT THE  
TOP OF THE TOWER WHERE DUMBLEDORE HAD DIED: OF DIRT, SWEAT, AND  
BLOOD.

THEY AREN'T WANTED, THEN, VERNON? ARE THEY IN THAT LIST

UNDER A DIFFERENT NAME? WHAT HOUSE WERE THEY IN AT HOGWARTS?

SLYTHERIN, SAID HARRY ALTERNATIVELY.

FLINDER HEY THEY ALL THINKS WE WANTS THE EAR THAT, IRRER SCARIER

HELT OF THE SHADOWS, BUT NONE OF EM CAN TELL US WHERE THE CHAM-  
BERN ROOM IS.

IT'S IN THE DUNGEONS, SAID HARRY CLEARLY. THEY ENTER THROUGH THE

WALL. IT'S FULL OF SKULLS AND STUFF AND IT'S UNDER THE LAKE, SEE THE  
LIGHT'S

ALL GREEN.

THERE WAS A SHORT PAUSE.

WELL, WELL, LOOKS LIKE WE REALLY ARE CALIGHT A LITTLE SLYTHERIN,  
SAID

SLABBER, GIBB FOR YELL, VERNON, CALISE THERE AIN T A LIT OF  
MUDKING

SLOTTHERINS, WEE S YELLER FATHER?

HE WERDS AT THE MINISTRY, HARRY LID, HE DNEW THAT HIS WEELE  
STERY WELLD CHLLAPSE WITH THE SMALLEST INVESTIGATION, BUT EN THE  
ETHER

HAND, HE ENLY HAD UNTIL HIS FACE REGAINED ITS USUAL APPEARANCE  
BEFORE

THE GAME WAS UP IN ANY CASE. DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL ACCIDENTS  
AND CATASTROPHES.

YELL DNEW WHAT, GREYBACK, SAID SLABBER, I THINK THERE IS A  
DUDLEY IN THERE.

HARRY CHLLD BARELY BREATHE: CHLLD BLCK, SPEER BLCK, GET THEM  
SAFEY FELT OF THIS?

MALFEY MANNER

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WELL, WELL, SAID GREYBACK, AND HARRY CHLLD HEAR THE TINIEST  
NOTE OF TREPIDATION IN THAT CALLELS VEHICLE, AND DNEW THAT GREYBACK  
WAS WENDERING WHETHER HE HAD INDEED ILST ATTACKED AND BEHIND THE  
SEEN OF A MINISTRY OFFICIAL, HARRY S HEART WAS PHLINDING AGAINST THE

REDS AREHND HIS RIKS; HE WELLD NEET HAVE BEEN SLRPRISED TH DNEW  
THAT GREYBACK CHLLD SEE IT. IF YELL RE TELLING THE TRUTH, WEL, YELL VE

GET NOTHING THE FEAR FROM A TRIP TO THE MINISTRY, I EXPECT YOUR FATHER IS

REWARD US JUST FOR PICKING YOU UP,

BUT, SAID HARRY, HIS MOUTH DROOPED, IF YOU JUST LET US

HEY! CAME A SHOUT FROM INSIDE THE TENT, LOOK AT THIS, CROUCH-  
BACH!

A DARK FIGURE CAME BLISTING TOWARD THEM, AND HARRY SAW A GLINT  
OF SILVER IN THE LIGHT OF THEIR HANDS. THEY HAD FOUND CROUCHBACH'S  
SWORD.

VERY NICE, SAID CROUCHBACH APPRECIATIVELY, TAKING IT FROM HIS  
COMPANIONS. HE, VERY NICE INDEED, LOOKS GENUINE, THAT. WHERE  
DID YOU GET SOMETHING LIKE THIS?

IT'S MY FATHER'S, HARRY LIED, LEANING AGAINST HIM THAT IT WAS  
THEM

DARK AND CROUCHBACH THEN SAW THE NAME ETCHED JUST BELOW THE HILT. HE  
SHOOKED IT THE LAST FIREWIND

AND IN A MINUTE, CROUCHBACH'S LOOK AT THIS, IN THE PRESENT?  
AS SCARTH SAID IT, HARRY'S SCAR, WHICH WAS STRETCHED TIGHT ACROSS  
HIS DISTENDED FOREHEAD, BURNED SAVAGELY, MORE CLEARLY THAN HE COULD  
MAKE OUT ANYTHING AROUND HIM, HE SAW A TWINKLING BUILDING, A  
GRIM

WRETCH, IET-BLACK AND FRIGHTENING; VIBRANT'S TAILLIGHTS HAD SLID-  
DENLY BECOME RAZOR-SHARP AGAIN; HE WAS GLIDING TOWARD THE  
GIGANTIC



BUILDING WITH A SENSE OF CALMLY EUPHORIC PURPOSE. . .

SEE CLOSE . . . SEE CLOSE . . .

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

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WITH A FLICK EFFORT HE WILL HARRY CLOSED HIS MIND TO VOLDERMORT'S

THOUGHTS, PULLING HIMSELF BACK TO WHERE HE SAT, TIED THE ROPE,  
HERMI-

ONE, DEAN, AND GRIPPER IN THE DARKNESS, LISTENING TO GRAYBACK

AND SLARTER.

ERMINE GRANGER, SLARTER WAS SAYING, THE MILDRED WHO IS  
DOWN IN THE RE TRAVELING WITH ARRY PITTER.

HARRY'S SCAR FLARED IN THE SILENCE, BUT HE MADE A SUPREME EF-

FORT TO KEEP HIMSELF PRESENT, NOT TO SLIP INTO VOLDERMORT'S MIND.  
HE

HEARD THE CREAK OF GRAYBACK'S REEFS AS HE CREELED DOWN IN FRONT  
OF HERMINE.

WELL KNOW WHAT, LITTLE GIRL? THIS PICTURE LOOKS A LITTLE OF A LIT  
LIKE WELL.

IT ISN'T! IT ISN'T ME!

HERMINE'S TERRIFIED SILENCE WAS AS GOOD AS A CONFESSSION.

... KNOWN THE BE TRAVELING WITH HARRY POTTER, REPEATED GRAY-  
BACK QUIETLY,

A STILLNESS HAD SETTLED OVER THE SCENE, HARRY'S SCAR WAS  
EXHIBITING

PAINFUL, BUT HE STRUGGLED WITH ALL HIS STRENGTH AGAINST THE PULL  
OF

VERBEMERT'S THOUGHTS: IT HAD NEVER BEEN SO IMPORTANT THE REMAIN  
IN

HIS OWN RIGHT MIND,

WELL, THIS CHANGES THINGS, DOESN'T IT? WHISPERED GRAYBACK, NE-  
BODY SPoke: HARRY SENSED THE GANG OF SNATCHERS WATCHING, FREEZEN,

AND FELT HERMIONE'S ARM TREMBLING AGAINST HIS, GRAYBACK GET UP  
AND

TOOK A COUPLE OF STEPS THE WHERE HARRY SAT, CREEPING DOWN AGAIN  
THE

STARE CLOSELY AT HIS MISPLACED FEATURES,

WHAT IS THAT FOR YOUR THREE-HEAD, VERBEMERT? HE ASKED SEETLY, HIS  
BREATH

WELL IN HARRY'S RESTRITS AS HE PRESSED A FILTHY FINGER THE THE TALIT  
SCAR,

DON'T THINK IT? HARRY YELLED: HE COULD NOT STOP HIMSELF: HE  
THOUGHT HE MIGHT BE SICK FROM THE PAIN OF IT,

MALFEY MANER

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I THOUGHT YOU WERE GLASSES, PETER? BREATHED CROOKED.  
I FEEL GLASSES? HELPED HIM OF THE SNATCHERS SWIMMING IN THE  
BACKGROUNDS. THERE WAS GLASSES IN THE TENT, CROOKED, WAIT  
AND SECONDS LATER HARRY'S GLASSES HAD BEEN RAMMED BACK INTO HIS  
FACE. THE SNATCHERS WERE CHASING IN WHEN, PEERING AT HIM.

IT IS? RASPED CROOKED. WE'VE CAUGHT PETER?  
THEY ALL TOOK SEVERAL STEPS BACKWARD, STUNNED BY WHAT THEY HAD  
SEEN. HARRY, STILL FIGHTING THE REMAINS PRESENT INSIDE HIS HEAD SPLIT-  
TING HEAD, COULD THINK OF NOTHING THEY SAY! FRAGMENTED VISIONS WERE  
BREAKING ACROSS THE SURFACE OF HIS MIND

HE WAS GLIDING ABOVE THE HIGH WALLS OF THE BLACK MOUNTAINS  
NOW, HE WAS HARRY, TIED UP AND HANDLESS, IN GRAVE DANGER

WHEN HE WAS, UP THE THE TALLEST MOUNTAINS, THE HIGHEST TOWER  
HE WAS HARRY, AND THEY WERE DISCUSSING HIS FATE IN WHEN  
VEHICLES

TIME THEY SAY ...

... THE THE MINISTRY?

THE HELL WITH THE MINISTRY, GROANED CROOKED. THEY'LL TAKE  
THE CREDIT, AND WE WON'T GET A WORD IN. I SAY WE TAKE HIM STRAIGHT  
THE

WELL-KNOWN-ONE.

WILL YOU STOPPEN IN? ARE? SAID SCARIER, SOUNDING ALONE,  
TERRIFIED.

NEH, SNARLED GREYBACK, I HAVEN'T GOTT THEY SAY HE'S LISTING THE  
MAMMON'S PLACE AS A BASE. WE'LL TAKE THE KID THERE.

HARRY THOUGHT HE KNEW WHY GREYBACK WAS NOT CALLING VEILDE-  
MERT. THE WEREWOLF MIGHT BE ALLOWED TO WEAR DEATH LATER WEEKS

WHEN THEY WANTED TO USE HIM, BUT ONLY VEILDEMERT'S INNER CIRCLE  
WERE BRANDED WITH THE DARK MARK! GREYBACK HAD NOT BEEN GRANTED  
THIS HIGHEST HONOR.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

\*\*\*

HARRY'S STAR SCARED AGAIN

AND HE RISE INTO THE NIGHT, FLYING STRAIGHT UP TO THE WINDMILL  
AT

THE VERY TOP OF THE TOWER

... COMPLETELY SURE IT'S HIM? CALISE IF IT AIN'T, GREYBACK, WE'RE  
DEAD.

WHO'S IN CHARGE HERE? REARED GREYBACK, COVERING HIS MOUTH  
OF INADEQUACY. I SAY THAT'S BETTER, AND HIM PULLS HIS WAND, THAT'S  
THE

HUNDRED THOUSAND GALLEONS RIGHT THERE! BUT IF YOU'RE THE CLUTLESS  
THE

COME ALONG, AND IF YOU, IT'S ALL FOR ME, AND WITH ANY LUCK, I'LL GET  
THE GIRL THROWN IN!

THE WINDMILL WAS THE MEREST SLIT IN THE BLACK ROCK, NOT BIG  
ENOUGH

AND A MAN THEN ENTER, . . . A SKELETAL FIGURE WAS JUST VISIBLE THROUGH IT,

COILED BENEATH A BLANKET, . . . DEAD, OR SLEEPING . . . ?

ALL RIGHT? SAID SCARER. ALL RIGHT, WE'RE IN! AND WHAT ABOUT THE

REST OF EM, GREYBACK, WHAT LL WE DO WITH EM?

MIGHT AS WELL TAKE THE LEFT, WE'VE GOT TWO MURDERERS, THAT'S ANOTHER TEN GALLEONS, GIVE ME THE SWORD AS WELL, IF THEY'RE ROLERS, THAT'S ANOTHER SMALL FORTUNE RIGHT THERE.

THE PRISONERS WERE DRAGGED BY THEIR FEET, HARRY COULD HEAR FERMINE'S BREATHING, FAST AND TERRIFIED.

GRAB HIM AND MAKE IT TIGHT, I LL DO BETTER! SAID GREYBACK, SEIZING A FISTFUL OF HARRY'S HAIR; HARRY COULD FEEL HIS LONG YELLOW NAILS

SCRATCHING HIS SCALP, ONE THREE! ONE TWO THREE

THEY DISAPPEARED, PULLING THE PRISONERS WITH THEM, HARRY STOLE-

WARD, TRYING TO TWIST OFF GREYBACK'S HAND, BUT IT WAS USELESS; WHEN

AND FERMINE WERE SQUEEZED TIGHTLY AGAINST HIM ON EITHER SIDE, HE COULD NOT SEPARATE FROM THE GRASP, AND AS THE BREATH WAS SQUEEZED

OUT OF HIM HIS SCAR SCARED MORE PAINFULLY STILL

MALFEY MANNER

YES

AS HE PERCED HIMSELF THROUGH THE SLIT OF A WINDOW LIKE A SNAKE  
AND

LANDED, LIGHTLY AS VAMPIRE, INSIDE THE CELL-LIKE ROOM

THE PRISONERS GLANCED INTO ONE ANOTHER AS THEY LANDED IN A  
CHURN-

TRY LAND. HARRY'S EYES, STILL PLUMP, TOOK A MOMENT TO ACCLIMATE,  
THEN

HE SAW A PAIR OF WHEELIGHT-IRON GATES AT THE FOOT OF WHAT LOOKED  
LIKE A

LONG DRIVE. HE EXPERIENCED THE TINIEST TRICKLE OF RELIEF. THE WORST  
HAD

NOT HAPPENED YET! VERDREHT WAS NOT HERE. HE WAS, HARRY KNEW,  
AND HE WAS FIGHTING TO RESIST THE VISION, IN SOME STRANGE,  
AIRTRESSLIKE

PLACE, AT THE TOP OF A TOWER. WHEN LONG IT WOULD TAKE VERDREHT TO  
GET TO THIS PLACE, SINCE HE KNEW THAT HARRY WAS HERE, WAS ANOTHER  
MATTER. . . .

ONE OF THE SNATCHERS STOOD AT THE GATES AND STARED THEM.

WHEN WE GET IN? THEY'RE LOCKED, GREYBACK, I CAN'T  
CLIMB!

HE WHIPPED HIS HANDS AWAY IN FRIGHT. THE IRON WAS CHATTERING,

TWISTING ITSELF AMONG THE ABSTRACT FLIRTS AND CHILLS INTO A FRIGHTEN-  
ING FACE, WHICH SPED IN A CLANGING, RATTING VEHICLE: STATE VEHICLE  
PURPOSE?

WE'VE GOT BETTER! GREYBACK BEAMED TRIUMPHANTLY. WE'VE CAP-  
TURED HARRY POTTER!

THE GATES SWUNG OPEN.

COME ON! SAID GREYBACK TO HIS MEN, AND THE PRISONERS WERE  
SHUNTED THROUGH THE GATES AND UP THE DRIVE, BETWEEN HIGH HEDGES  
THAT MUFFLED THEIR FEETSTEPS. HARRY SAW A GHOSTLY WHITE SHAPE  
ABOVE

HIM, AND REALIZED IT WAS AN ALBINO PEACOCK. HE STUMBLERED AND WAS  
DRAGGED BEHIND HIS FEET BY GREYBACK! WHEN HE WAS STAGGERING ALONG  
SIDELWAYS, TIED BACK-TO-BACK TO THE OTHER OTHER PRISONERS, CLOSING  
HIS

BLIND EYES, HE ALLEVIATED THE PAIN IN HIS SCAR BY OVERCHARGE HIM WITH A

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

THE

MOMENT, WANTING TO KNOW WHAT VILDEMENT WAS DOING, WHETHER HE  
KNEW YET THAT HARRY WAS CAUGHT. . . .

THE EMACIATED FIGURE STIRRED BENEATH ITS THIN BLANKET AND ROLLED  
OVER

THEARD HIM, EYES OPENING IN A SKULL OF A FACE, . . . THE PALE MAN SAT UP,

GREAT STUNNEN EYES FIXED UPON HIM, UPON VERBEMERT, AND THEN HE SMILED,

MOST OF HIS TEETH WERE GONE, . . .

SEE, YELL HAVE COME, I THOUGHT YELL WOULD . . . HERE DAY, BUT YELLR ILLWANE WAS POINTLESS, I NEVER HAD IT,

YELL LIE?

AS VERBEMERT'S ANGER TREMBLED INSIDE HIM, HARRY'S SCAR THREAT- ENED THE ELDEST WITH PAIN, AND HE WRENCHED HIS MIND BACK TO HIS

ELIN BODY, FIGHTING THE REMAIN PRESENT AS THE PRISONERS WERE PULSED

EVER GRAVEL,

LIGHT SPILLED OUT EVER ALL OF THEM,

WHAT IS THIS? SAID A WOMAN'S CHILD VOICE,

WE RE HERE TO SEE THE-ONE-MUST-NOT-RE-NAMED? RASPED GRAY- BACK,

ONE ARE YELL?

YELL KNOW ME? THERE WAS RESSENTMENT IN THE WEREWOLF'S VOICE,

FERRIS GRAYBACK? WE VE CAUGHT HARRY PITTER?

GRAYBACK SEIZED HARRY AND DRAGGED HIM AROUND THE FACE THE LIGHT, PERCING THE OTHER PRISONERS THE SHUDDER AROUND THEM,

I KNOW IT'S SWELLEN, MA AM, BUT IT'S IN? PIPED UP SCARER, IF



WELL WHEN A KIT CLOSER, WELL LL SEE IS STAR, AND THIS ARE, SEE THE  
GIRL? THE

MURDERED WHEN S BEEN TRAVELING AROUND WITH IM, MA AM, THERE S  
NEH

DELET IT S IM, AND WE VE GET IS WAND AS WELL? ARE, MA AM

THROUGH HIS PLINY EYES HARRY SAW NARCISSE MALFOY SCRUTINIZ-  
ING HIS SWELLEN FACE, SCARIER THIRST THE BLACKTHORN WAND AT HER,  
SHE

RAISED HER EYEBROWS.

MALFOY MANNER

???

BRING THEM IN, SHE SAID.

HARRY AND THE OTHERS WERE SHEVED AND KICKED UP BEHAD STEER  
STEPS INTO A HALLWAY LINED WITH PORTRAITS.

FEELER ME, SAID NARCISSE, LEADING THE WAY ACROSS THE HALL. MY  
SEN, BRACH, IS HERE FOR HIS EASTER HOLIDAYS. IF THAT IS HARRY  
POTTER,

HE WILL KNEEL.

THE DRAWING ROOM DAZZLED AFTER THE DARKNESS HILLSIDE, EVEN WITH  
HIS EYES ALMOST CLOSED HARRY COULD MAKE OUT THE WIDE PROPORTIONS

OF THE ROOM, A CRYSTAL CHANDELIER HUNG FROM THE CEILING, MORE  
PER-

TRAITS AGAINST THE DARK PURPLE WALLS. THE FIGURES ROSE FROM  
CHAIRS IN

FRONT OF AN ORNATE MARBLE FIREPLACE AS THE PRISONERS WERE FORCED  
INTO

THE ROOM BY THE SNATCHERS.

WHAT IS THIS?

THE DREADFULLY FAMILIAR, DRINKING VICE OF LUCIUS MALPHY RELL HIM  
HARRY'S EARS. HE WAS PANICKING NOW; HE COULD SEE NO WAY OUT,  
AND

IT WAS EASIER, AS HIS FEAR MELTING, THE BLIND BLIT VILDERBERT'S  
TEHLIGHTS,

THOUGH HIS STAR WAS STILL BURNING.

THEY SAY THEY'VE GOT BETTER, SAID NARCISSE'S CHILD VICE, DRACH,  
COME HERE.

HARRY DID NOT DARE LOOK DIRECTLY AT DRACH, BUT SAW HIM INDISTINCTLY:

A FIGURE SLIGHTLY TALLER THAN HE WAS, RISING FROM AN ARMCHAIR, HIS  
FACE

A PALE AND PHINTED SKIN BENEATH WHITE-BLEND HAIR.

GREYBACK FORCED THE PRISONERS TO TURN AGAIN SEE AS THE PLACE HARRY  
DIRECTLY BENEATH THE CHANDELIER.

WELL, WHY? RASPED THE WEREWOLF.

HARRY WAS FACING A MIRROR OVER THE FIREPLACE, A GREAT GILDED THING  
IN AN INTRICATELY SCHEMLED FRAME. THROUGH THE SLITS OF HIS EYES HE  
SAW HIS OWN REFLECTION FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE LEAVING CRIMINAL  
PLACE.

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HIS FACE WAS HUGE, SHINY, AND PINK, EVERY FEATURE DISTORTED BY  
HERMINE'S LIPS. HIS BLACK HAIR REACHED HIS SHOULDERS AND THERE  
WAS A DARK SHADOW AROUND HIS EYES. HAD HE NOT KNOWN THAT IT WAS  
HE WHO STOOD THERE, HE WOULD HAVE WONDERED WHO WAS WEARING  
HIS GLASSES. HE RESOLVED NOT TO SPEAK, FOR HIS VOICE WAS SURE TO  
GIVE  
HIM AWAY. YET HE STILL AVOIDED EYE CONTACT WITH DRACE AS THE LATTER  
APPROACHED.

WELL, DRACE? SAID ELLIUS MALPHY. HE SHOOK HIS HEAD. IS IT? IS  
IT HARRY POTTER?

I CAN'T I CAN'T BE SURE, SAID DRACE. HE WAS KEEPING HIS DIS-  
TANCE FROM GREYBACK, AND SEEMED AS SCARED OF LOOKING AT HARRY AS  
HARRY WAS OF LOOKING AT HIM.

BUT LOOK AT HIM CAREFULLY, LOOK! COME CLOSER!  
HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD ELLIUS MALPHY SO EXCITED.  
DRACE, IF WE ARE THE MEN WHO HAD POTTER EVER THEN THE DARK LORD,  
EVERYTHING WILL BE ALL RIGHT  
WELL, WE WON'T BE FORGETTING WHO ACTUALLY CAUGHT HIM, I HOPE,  
MR. MALPHY? SAID GREYBACK MENACINGLY.

IF COURSE NOT, IF COURSE NOT? SAID ELLIUS IMPATIENTLY. HE AP-  
PROACHED HARRY HIMSELF, CAME SO CLOSE THAT HARRY COULD SEE THE

USUALLY LAMELID, PALE FACE IN SHARP DETAIL EVEN THOUGH HIS  
SHUTTEN

EYES, WITH HIS FACE A PLIFY MASK, HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE WAS  
PERF-

ING HLT FROM BETWEEN THE BARS OF A CAGE.

WHAT DID YOU DO THE HIN? BLIKILIS ASKED GREYBACK. HOW DID  
HE GET INTO THIS STATE?

THAT WASN'T US.

LEADS MORE LIKE A STINGING INK THE ME, SAID BLIKILIS.  
HIS GRAY EYES RAKED HARRY'S HEAD.

THERE'S SOMETHING THERE, HE WHISPERED. IT COULD BE THE SCAR.

MALFEY MANNER

457

STRETCHED TIGHT. . . . DRACHE, COME HERE, LEED PROPERLY? WHAT DO YOU  
THINK?

HARRY SAW DRACHE'S FACE UP CLOSE NOW, RIGHT BESIDE HIS FATHER'S.  
THEY WERE EXTRAORDINARILY ALIKE, EXCEPT THAT WHILE HIS FATHER  
LEADED

BESIDE HIMSELF WITH EXCITEMENT, DRACHE'S EXPRESSION WAS FULL OF RE-  
LUCTANCE, EVEN FEAR.

I HEN T KNEL, HE SAID, AND HE WALKED AWAY TOWARD THE FIREPLACE WHERE HIS MOTHER STOOD WATCHING.

WE HAD BETTER BE CERTAIN, LUCIUS, NARCISSA CALLED THE HER HUSBAND IN HER CHD, CLEAR VOICE. COMPLETELY SURE THAT IT IS PETER,

BEFORE WE SLIP THE DARK LEAD . . . THEY SAY THIS IS HIS SHE

WAS LEERING CLOSELY AT THE BLACKTHORN WARD BUT IT DOES NOT RE-

SEMBLE HELLIVANDER S DESCRIPTION. . . IF WE ARE MISTAKEN, IF WE CALL THE

DARK LEAD HERE FOR NOTHING . . . REMEMBER WHAT HE DID THE REBEL AND DEATH-HY?

WHAT ABOUT THE MURDER, THEN? GREENED GREYBACK, HARRY WAS NEARLY THROWN OFF HIS FEET AS THE SNATCHERS FORCED THE PRISONERS

THE SWIVEL AROUND AGAIN, SEE THAT THE LIGHT FELL ON HERMIONE INSTEAD,

WAIT, SAID NARCISSA SHARPLY. YES YES, SHE WAS IN MADAM MALKIN S WITH PETER? I SAW HER PICTURE IN THE PROPHECY LEAD, DRACH,

ISN T IT THE CRANGER GIRL?

I . . . MAYBE . . . YES,

BUT THEN, THAT S THE WEASLEY KID? SHOUTED LUCIUS, STRID-ING AROUND THE BEHIND PRISONERS THE FACE BEEN. IT S THEM, PETER S

FRIENDS DRACHE LOOKED AT HIM, THEN IT ARTHEUR WEASLEY'S SHEN,  
WHAT'S

HIS NAME ?

Yeah, said Drache again, his back the the prisoners. It could  
be.

The drawing room door opened behind Harry, a woman spoke,

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

AND

and the sound of the vehicle wheeling Harry's fear the an even higher  
pitch.

What is this? What's happened, Lissy?

Bellatrix Lestrange walked slowly around the prisoners, and  
stopped in Harry's right, staring at Hermione through her  
heavily

lidded eyes.

But surely, she said quickly, this is the Muggleborn girl? This is  
Granger?

Yes, yes, it's Granger! cried Lucius, and beside her, we think,  
Petter! Petter and his friends, caught at last!

Petter? shrieked Bellatrix, and she backed away, the better the  
take in Harry, are you sure? Well then, the Dark Lord must be  
informed at once!

She dragged back her left sleeve! Harry saw the Dark Mark

SLID INTO THE FLESH OF HER ARM, AND KNEW THAT SHE WAS ABOUT THE  
THICK IT, THE SUMMON HER BELIEVED MASTER

I WAS ABOUT THE CALL HIM? SAID LUKILIS, AND HIS HAND ACTUALLY  
CLOSED UPON BELLATRIX'S WRIST, PREVENTING HER FROM THICKING THE  
MARD. I SHALL SUMMON HIM, BELLA, BETTER HAS BEEN KNIGHT THE MY  
FELISE, AND IT IS THEREFORE UPON MY AUTHORITY

YOUR AUTHORITY? SHE SNEERED, ATTEMPTING THE WRENCH HER HAND  
FROM HIS GRASP. YOU LEST YOUR AUTHORITY WHEN YOU LEST YOUR  
WAND,

LUKILIS? HOW DARE YOU? TAKE YOUR HANDS OFF ME?

THIS IS NOTHING THE DO WITH YOU, YOU DID NOT CAPTURE THE  
KID

BEGGING YOUR PARDON, MR. MALFEY, INTERRUPTED GREYBACK,  
BUT IT IS US THAT CALLED BETTER, AND IT IS US THAT WE'RE CLAIMING THE  
CHILD

CHILD? LAUGHED BELLATRIX, STILL ATTEMPTING THE THREW OFF HER

MALFEY MANNER

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RIGHTER-IN-LAW, HER FREE HAND GRIPPING IN HER POCKET FOR HER  
WAND.

TAKE YOUR CHILD, FILTHY SLAVENGER, WHAT DO I WANT WITH CHILD? I  
SEEK

ONLY THE FINGER OF HIS

SHE STOPPED STRUGGLING, HER DARK EYES FIXED UPON SOMETHING

HARRY COULD NOT SEE, ILLEGANT AT HER CAPITULATION, LUKILIS THREW HER

HAND FROM HIM AND RIPPED UP HIS ELBOW SLEEVE

STEEP! SCRIEDED BELLATRIX. SHE NOT BELIEVE IT, WE SHALL ALL PERISH IF THE DARK LORD COMES NEAR!

LUKILIS FREEZE, HIS INDEX FINGER HEVERING OVER HIS ELBOW MARK. BELLATRIX STOOD HILT OF HARRY'S LIMITED LINE OF VISION.

WHAT IS THAT? HE HEARD HER SAY.

SWOON, GRUNTED AN HILT-OF-SIGHT SNATCHER.

GIVE IT TO ME.

IT'S NOT YOURS, MISSUS, IT'S MINE, I REMEMBER I FEELING IT.

THERE WAS A BANG AND A FLASH OF RED LIGHT: HARRY KNEW THAT THE

SNATCHER HAD BEEN STUNNED. THERE WAS A RHEAR OF ANGER FROM HIS FEEL-

INGS! SCARIER DREW HIS WAND.

WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE PLAYING AT, WHIMMY?

STUPID! SHE SCREAMED, STUPID!

THEY WERE NO MATCH FOR HER, EVEN THOUGH THERE WERE FEWER OF THEM

AGAINST HER OF HER: SHE WAS A WITCH, AS HARRY KNEW, WITH PREDIGIOUS SKILL AND NO CONSCIENCE. THEY FELL WHERE THEY STOOD, ALL EXCEPT



GREYBACK, WHO HAD BEEN FORCED INTO A KNEELING POSITION, HIS ARMS  
OUTSTRETCHED, BUT AT THE CORNERS OF HIS EYES HARRY SAW BELLATRIX  
BEARING DOWN UPON THE WEREWOLF, THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER GRIPPED  
TIGHTLY IN HER HAND, HER FACE LAXEN.

WHERE DID YOU GET THIS SWORD? SHE WHISPERED TO GREYBACK AS  
SHE PULLED HIS HAND OUT OF HIS UNRESISTING GRIP.

HELD DARK YOU? HE SNARLED, HIS MOUTH THE ONLY THING THAT MOVED

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

~~AND~~

MOVE AS HE WAS FORCED TO GAZE UP AT HER, HE BARED HIS POINTED  
TEETH.

RELEASE ME, LEMMY!

WHERE DID YOU FIND THIS SWORD? SHE REPEATED, BRANDISHING IT IN  
HIS FACE. SNARE SENT IT TO MY VAULT IN GRINGOTT'S!

IT WAS IN THEIR TENT, RASPED GREYBACK. RELEASE ME, I SAY!

SHE WAVED HER WAND, AND THE WEREWOLF SPRANG TO HIS FEET, BUT AP-  
PEARED THE WAY TO APPROACH HER, HE PREHELD BEHIND AN ARMCHAIR,

HIS FILTHY CLAWED NAILS CLUTCHING ITS BACK.

DRAGON, MOVE THIS SLIM OUTSIDE, SAID BELLATRIX, INDICATING THE  
LUNGENSTIEHL'S MEN. IF YOU HAVEN'T GOT THE CLUTS TO FINISH THEM,  
THEN

LEAVE THEM IN THE CEMETERY FOR ME.

DIDN'T YELL DARE SPEAK THE BRACE LIKE        SAID NARCISSA FLURRIEDLY,  
BUT BELLATRIX SCREAMED,

BE QUIET! THE SITUATION IS GRAVER THAN YELL CAN POSSIBLY IMAGINE,  
LISSY! WE HAVE A VERY SERIOUS PROBLEM!

SHE STEPPED, PANTING SLIGHTLY, LEANING DOWN AT THE SWORD, EXAMIN-  
ING ITS HILT. THEN SHE TURNED THE HEAD AT THE SILENT PRISONERS.

IF IT IS INDEED PETER, HE MUST NOT BE HARMED, SHE MUTTERED,

MORE TO HERSELF THAN TO THE OTHERS. THE DARK LORD WISHES THE DIS-  
POSAL OF PETER HIMSELF, . . . BUT IF HE FINDS HIM . . . I MUST . . . I MUST

KNEEL, . . .

SHE TURNED BACK TO HER SISTER AGAIN.

THE PRISONERS MUST BE PLACED IN THE CELLAR, WHILE I THINK WHAT  
TO DO!

THIS IS MY HOUSE, BELLA, YELL DIDN'T GIVE ORDERS IN MY

DEED! YELL HAVE NO IDEA OF THE DANGER WE ARE IN! STARTED BEL-  
LATRIX. SHE LOOKED FRIGHTENING, MAD! A THIN STREAM OF FIRE ISSUED  
FROM

HER HAND AND CLUNG A FIRE IN THE CARPET.

NARCISSA HESITATED FOR A MOMENT, THEN ADDRESSED THE WEREWOLF.

MALICE MANE

WERE

TAKE THESE PRISONERS DOWN THE CELLAR, CROUCH.

WAIT, SAID BELLATRIX SHARPLY. ALL EXCEPT ... EXCEPT FOR THE MURDERER.

CROUCH GAVE A GLINT OF PLEASURE.

NO! SHELLTED RON. YOU CAN HAVE ME, KEEP ME!

BELLATRIX HIT HIM ACROSS THE FACE; THE BELL RANG AROUND THE ROOM.

IF SHE DIES UNDER QUESTIONING, I LL TAKE YOU NEXT, SHE SAID. BLOOD TRAITOR IS NEXT THE MURDERER IN MY EYES. TAKE THEM DOWNSTAIRS, CROUCH, AND MAKE SURE THEY ARE SECURE, BUT DO NOTHING MORE TO THEM YET.

SHE THREW CROUCH'S HAND BACK TO HIM, THEN TOOK A SHORT SILVER KNIFE FROM UNDER HER ROBES. SHE CUT HERMIONE FREE FROM THE OTHER PRISONERS, THEN DRAGGED HER BY THE HAIR INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM.

WHILE CROUCH FORCED THE REST OF THEM THE SLIPPER ACROSS THE ANTHRAL

DOWN, INTO A DARK PASSAGEWAY, HIS HAND FELD HILT IN FRONT OF HIM, PROJECTING AN INVISIBLE AND IRRESISTIBLE FORCE.

BEFORE SHE LL LET ME HAVE A HIT OF THE GIRL WHEN SHE S FINISHED WITH HER? CROUCH CRIED AS HE FORCED THEM ALONG THE CORRIDOR.

I D SAY I LL GET A KITE FOR THEE, WOULDNT T YOU, GINGER?

HARRY COULD FEEL RON SHAKING. THEY WERE FORCED DOWN A STEEP

FLIGHT OF STAIRS, STILL TIED BACK-TO-BACK AND IN DANGER OF SLIPPING  
AND

BREAKING THEIR NECKS AT ANY MOMENT. AT THE BATTERED WAS A HEAVY  
DEER, GREYBACK UNLOCKED IT WITH A TAP OF HIS WAND, THEN FORCED  
THEM INTO A DARK AND MUSTY ROOM AND LEFT THEM IN TOTAL DARKNESS.  
THE ECHOING RANG OF THE SLAMMED CELLAR DEER HAD NOT DIED AWAY  
BEFORE THERE WAS A TERRIBLE, BRAIN-SPLIT SCREAM FROM DIRECTLY ABOVE  
THEM.

FORGIVEN? RHN BELLEVED, AND HE STARTED TO WRITHE AND

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

away

STRUGGLE AGAINST THE ROPES TYING THEM TOGETHER, SHE THAT HARRY  
STAG-

GERED. FORGIVEN?

BE HELIET? HARRY SAID, SPLIT LIP, RHN, WE NEED THE WOODS HELT A  
WAY

FORGIVEN? FORGIVEN?

WE NEED A PLAN, STOP YELLING WE NEED TO GET THESE ROPES  
OFF

HARRY? CAME A WHISPER THROUGH THE DARKNESS, RHN? IS THAT  
YELK?

RHN STOPPED SHOUTING. THERE WAS A SILENT OF MOVEMENT CLOSER BY  
THEM, THEN HARRY SAW A SHADOW MOVING CLOSER.

HARRY? REIN?

LUNA?

YES, IT'S ME! EH! NEH, I DIDN'T WANT YOU TO BE CALLED!

LUNA, CAN YOU HELP US GET THESE ROPES OFF? SAID HARRY.

EH! YES, I EXPECT SEE... THERE'S AN OLD NAIL WE USE IF WE NEED TO  
BREAK ANYTHING... JUST A MOMENT...

HERMIONE SCREAMED AGAIN FROM EVERYWHERE, AND THEY COULD HEAR  
BELLATRIX SCREAMING THEM, BUT HER WORDS WERE INAUDIBLE, AND REIN  
STILLTED AGAIN. F-R-O-M-I-N-E! F-R-O-M-I-N-E!

MR. HELLIVANDER? HARRY COULD HEAR LUNA SAYING, MR. HELLIVANDER,  
HAVE YOU GOT THE NAIL? IF YOU JUST MOVE OVER A LITTLE BIT...

I THINK IT WAS BESIDE THE WATER ILG...

SHE WAS BACK WITHIN SECONDS.

YOU WILL NEED TO STAY STILL, SHE SAID.

HARRY COULD FEEL HER DIGGING AT THE ROPE & THROUGH FIBERS THE WORDS  
THE KNIGHTS FREE, FROM UPSTAIRS THEY HEARD BELLATRIX'S VOICE.

I'M GOING TO ASK YOU AGAIN! WHERE DID YOU GET THIS SWORD?  
WHERE?

MALFEY MANNER

YES

WE FEELING IT WE FEELING IT PLEASE! HERMIONE SCREAMED  
AGAIN; REIN STRUGGLED HARDER THAN EVER, AND THE RUSTY NAIL SLIPPED

HEATH HARRY'S WRIST.

REHN, PLEASE STAY STILL! LUNA WHISPERED. I CAN'T SEE WHAT I'M  
DOING

MY POCKET? SAID REHN. IN MY POCKET, THERE'S A DELUMINATOR,  
AND IT'S FULL OF LIGHT!

A FEW SECONDS LATER, THERE WAS A CLICK, AND THE LUMINESCENT SPHERES  
THE DELUMINATOR HAD SLICKED FROM THE LAMPS IN THE TENT FLEW INTO  
THE CELLAR! UNABLE TO REIN IN THEIR SHOUTS, THEY SIMPLY FLEW  
THERE,

LIKE TINY SUNS, FLOODING THE UNDERGROUND REHN WITH LIGHT. HARRY  
SAW LUNA, ALL EYES IN HER WHITE FACE, AND THE MEETHESS FIGURE OF  
ELLIVANDER THE WANDMAKER, CLIMBED UP ON THE FLOOR IN THE CORNER.  
CRANING AROUND, HE CAUGHT SIGHT OF THEIR FELLOW PRISONERS: DEAN  
AND

GRIPHEED THE GRIFFIN, WHO SEEMED BARELY HUMAN, KEPT STANDING  
BY THE REDES THAT HELD HIM TO THE FLOORS.

HEY, THAT'S MUCH EASIER, THANKS, REHN, SAID LUNA, AND SHE BEGAN  
FUCKING AT THEIR BINDINGS AGAIN. HELLO, DEAN?

FROM ABOVE CAME BELLATRIX'S VOICE.

YOU ARE LYING, FILTHY MURDERER, AND I KNOW IT! YOU HAVE BEEN  
INSIDE MY VAULT AT GRINGOTTS! TELL THE TRUTH, TELL THE TRUTH!

ANOTHER TERRIBLE SCREAM

FROM THE

WHAT ELSE DID YOU TAKE? WHAT ELSE HAVE YOU GOTTEN? TELL ME THE  
TRUTH OR, I SWEAR, I SHALL KILL YOU TWELVE TIMES WITH THIS KNIFE!

THERE!

HARRY FELT THE REDES FALL AWAY AND TURNED, RUBBING HIS WRISTS, THE

SEE REIN RUNNING AROUND THE CELLAR, LEEDING UP AT THE NEW  
CEILING,

SEARCHING FOR A TRAPDOOR. DEAN, HIS FACE SWOONED AND BLEEDY, SAID

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\*\*\*

THANKS THE LUNA AND STOOD THERE, SHIVERING, BUT GRIPPED  
SAND

ENTER THE CELLAR FLOOR, LEEDING GREGGY AND DISORIENTED, MANY WELTS  
ACROSS HIS SWARTHY FACE.

REIN WAS NOW TRYING THE DISAPPARATE WITH-OUT A WAND.

THERE S NO WAY OUT, REIN, SAID LUNA, WATCHING HIS FRUITLESS EF-  
FERTS. THE CELLAR IS COMPLETELY ESCAPE-PROOF. I TRIED, AT FIRST. MR.  
EL-

LIVANDER HAS BEEN HERE FOR A LONG TIME, HE S TRIED EVERYTHING.

HERMIONE WAS SCREAMING AGAIN! THE SOUND WENT THROUGH HARRY  
LIKE PHYSICAL PAIN. BARELY CONSCIOUS OF THE PIERCE PRICKLING OF HIS  
SCAR, HE THEN STARTED THE RUN AROUND THE CELLAR, FEELING THE WALLS FOR  
HE

HARDLY KNOW WHAT, KNOWING IN HIS HEART THAT IT WAS USELESS.

WHAT ELSE DID YOU TAKE, WHAT ELSE? ANSWER ME! CRYED:

HERMIONE S SCREAMS ECHOED OFF THE WALLS UPSTAIRS, REIN WAS HALF  
SHRINKING AS HE POUNDED THE WALLS WITH HIS FISTS, AND HARRY IN LITTER

DESPERATELY SEIZED HARRY'S WELCH FROM AROUND HIS NECK AND  
GRIPPED

INSIDE IT! HE PULLED OUT DUMBLEDORE'S SNITCH AND SEIZED IT, HOPEING  
THAT HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT NOTHING HAPPENED HE WAVED THE  
BROKEN HALVES OF THE PHOENIX WAND, BUT THEY WERE LIFELESS THE  
MIRROR FRAGMENT FELL SPARKLING TO THE FLOOR, AND HE SAW A GLAM OF  
BRIGHTEST BLUE

DUMBLEDORE'S EYE WAS GAZING AT HIM OUT OF THE MIRROR.

HELP US! HE YELLED AT IT IN MAD DESPERATION. WE ARE IN THE CELLAR  
OF MALFOY MANOR, HELP US!

THE EYE BLINKED AND WAS GONE.

HARRY WAS NOT EVEN SURE THAT IT HAD REALLY BEEN THERE. HE TILTED  
THE

SHARD OF MIRROR THIS WAY AND THAT, AND SAW NOTHING REFLECTED  
THERE

BUT THE WALLS AND CEILING OF THEIR PRISON, AND UPSTAIRS HERMIONINE  
WAS

SCREAMING WORSE THAN EVER, AND NEXT TO HIM RON WAS SQUEALING,

HERMIONINE! HERMIONINE!

MALFOY MANOR

~~~~~

HOW DID YOU GET INTO MY VAULT? THEY HEARD BELLATRIX SCREAM.

DID THAT DIRTY LITTLE GEEK IN THE CELLAR HELP YOU?

WE ONLY MET HIM TONIGHT! HERMIONINE SCREAMED. WE VE NEVER

BEEN INSIDE YELLER VALLET. . . IT ISN'T THE REAL SWORD! IT'S A COPY, JUST
A

COPY!

A COPY? STREETCHED BELLATRIX. HEY, A LIKELY STORY?

BUT WE CAN FIND HOLT EASILY! TAKE BLUKIL'S VEHICLE. DRACHE, FETCH
THE GHEKIN, HE CAN TELL US WHETHER THE SWORD IS REAL OR NOT!

HARRY DASHED ACROSS THE CELLAR TOWARD WHERE CRIPPLEHEAD WAS FLOODED
BY THE FLOOD.

CRIPPLEHEAD, HE WHISPERED INTO THE GHEKIN'S POINTED EAR, YELL
LIST

TELL THEM THAT SWORD IS A FAKE, THEY MUSTN'T BELIEVE IT'S THE REAL ONE,
CRIPPLEHEAD, PLEASE

HE COULD HEAR SOMETHING SLUTTLING DOWN THE CELLAR STEPS! NEXT MOMENT,
DRACHE'S SHADING VEHICLE SPED FROM BEHIND THE DOOR.

STAND BACK, LINE UP AGAINST THE BACK WALL, DON'T TRY ANYTHING,
OR I'LL KILL YOU!

THEY DID AS THEY WERE BIDDED! AS THE VEHICLE TURNED, REIN CLICKED THE
DELLMINATOR AND THE LIGHTS WHISKED BACK INTO HIS POCKET,
RESTORING

THE CELLAR'S DARKNESS. THE DOOR FLEW OPEN! MALPHY MARCHED INSIDE,
HAND FELD HOLT IN FRONT OF HIM, PALE AND DETERMINED. HE SEIZED THE
LITTLE GHEKIN BY THE ARM AND KICKED HOLT AGAIN, DRAGGING CRIPPLEHEAD
WITH HIM. THE DOOR SLAMMED SHUT AND AT THE SAME MOMENT A LOUD
CRACK ECHOED INSIDE THE CELLAR.

REIN CLICKED THE DELLMINATOR. THREE BALLS OF LIGHT FLEW BACK INTO
THE AIR FROM HIS POCKET, REVEALING DEEPLY THE FLOOD-FLY, WHO HAD

ILUST APPARATED INTHE THEIR MIDST,

DEER :

HARRY HIT REIN ENH THE ARM TH STEEP HIM SFEHLTING, AND REIN LEEHED

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

XXX

TERRIFIED AT HIS MISTAKE, FEETSTEPS CRESSED THE CEILING EVERHEAD:
BRACH

MARCHING CRIP-HEED THE BELLATRIX.

DEEKY S ENHEMELIS, TENNIS-BALL-SHAPED EYES WERE WIDE; HE WAS
TREMELING FROM HIS FEET TH THE TIPS OF HIS EARS. HE WAS BACK IN THE
HEED OF HIS OLD MASTERS, AND IT WAS CLEAR THAT HE WAS PETRIFIED.

HARRY PETHER, HE SHELLEADED IN THE TINDEST ELIJVER OF A VEHICLE,

DEEKY HAS CHEE TH RESCUE YELI.

BUT HEEL DID YELI ?

AN ALPLI SCREAM DREHINED HARRY S WEHDS; HERMINEE WAS BEING
THETLIRED AGAIN. HE CLIT TH THE ESSENTIALS.

YELI CAN DISAPPARATE HLT OF THIS CELLAR? HE ASKED DEEKY, WE-EE
NEHDED, HIS EARS FLAPPING.

AND YELI CAN TAKE FILMANS WITH YELI?

DEEKY NEHDED AGAIN.

RIGHT, DEEKY, I WANT YELI TH GRAB LLINA, DEAN, AND MR. HILLI-
YARBER, AND TAKE THEM TAKE THEM TH

BILL AND FLELIA S, SAID THEN, SHELL CHITTAGH HEN THE ELITSEKITS HIF
TINDERTHIF

THE ELF NEEDED HER A THIRD TIME.

AND THEN CAME BACK, SAID HARRY, CAN YELL DHE THAT, DHEK?

HE CHLUSE, HARRY PETER, WHISPERED THE LITTLE ELF, HE FLURRIED
EVER THE MR. HILLVANDER, WHEN APPEARED THE BE RARELY CHNSTHELS, HE
THEED HENK HE THE WANDMAKER S HANDS IN HIS ELIN, THEN FELD HLT THE
ETHER THE LUNA AND DEAN, NEITHER HE WE-HEM MEVED.

HARRY, WE WANT TH FELD YELL? LUNA WHISPERED.

WE CAN T LEAVE YELL HERE, SAID DEAN.

GH, BETH HE YELL? WE LL SEE YELL AT BILL AND FLELIA S.

AS HARRY SPEKE, HIS STAR ELINED WHESE THAN EVER, AND HER A FEW

MALFEY MANNER

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SECONDS HE WHEDD DEHN, NHT WPHEN THE WANDMAKER, ELT HEN ANOTHER
MAN WHEN WAS ILST AS HED, ILST AS THIN, ELT LAUGHING SCHRNFLY.

KILL ME, THEN, VEHDERT, I WELCHME DEATH? ELT MY DEATH WILL

NHT BRING YELL WE-IAT YELL SEED, . . . THERE IS SE MUCH-YELL DHE NHT
LINDER-

STAND, . . .

HE FELT VEHDERT S FLRY, ELT AS F-ERMINE SCREAMED AGAIN HE S-ILT

IT HURT, RETURNING TO THE CELLAR AND THE HORROR OF HIS OWN
PRESENT.

OH! HARRY RESPECTED LUNA AND DEAN. OH! HE IS FEELING, JUST
OH!

THEY CALIGHT FELD OF THE ELF'S HURTSTRETCHED FINGERS. THERE WAS
ANOTHER LEAD CRACK, AND DEER, LUNA, DEAN, AND HILIVANDER
VANISHED.

WHAT WAS THAT? SEEMED LUCIUS MALFOY FROM OVER THEIR HEADS.
DID YOU HEAR THAT? WHAT WAS THAT NOISE IN THE CELLAR?
HARRY AND RON STARED AT EACH OTHER.

DRAKE NO, CALL WHIRTAIL! MAKE HIM GO AND CHECK!
FOOTSTEPS CROSSED THE ROOM OVERHEAD, THEN THERE WAS SILENCE.
HARRY KNEW THAT THE PEOPLE IN THE DRAWING ROOM WERE LISTENING
FOR
MORE NOISES FROM THE CELLAR.

WE ARE GOING TO HAVE TO TRY AND TACKLE HIM, HE WHISPERED TO
RON.

THEY HAD NO CHOICE! THE MOMENT ANYONE ENTERED THE ROOM AND
SAW
THE ABSENCE OF THREE PRISONERS, THEY WERE LOST. LEAVE THE LIGHTS
ON.

HARRY ADDED, AND AS THEY HEARD SOMEONE DESCENDING THE STAIRS HURT-
SIDE THE DEER, THEY BACKED AGAINST THE WALL ON EITHER SIDE OF IT.

STAND BACK, CALL WHIRTAIL'S VOICE. STAND AWAY FROM THE DEER.
I AM COMING IN.

THE DEER FLEW UPON, FOR A SPLIT SECOND WHIRTAIL GAZED INTO THE

APPARENTLY EMPTY CELLAR, ABLAZE WITH LIGHT FROM THE THREE
MINIATURE

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

SLIMS FLEETING IN MIDAIR, THEN HARRY AND REEN LAUNCHED
THEMSELVES

LIFEN HIM, REEN SEIZED WHERMTAIL'S WAND ARM AND FORCED IT UPWARD;
HARRY SLAPPED A HAND TO HIS MOUTH, MUFFLING HIS WHICE. SILENTLY
THEY

STRUGGLED; WHERMTAIL'S WAND EMITTED SPARKS; HIS SILVER HAND CLOSED
AROUND HARRY'S THREAT.

WHAT IS IT, WHERMTAIL? CALLED LUCILIS MALPHE FROM ABOVE.

NOTHING! REEN CALLED BACK, IN A PASSABLE IMITATION OF WHERMTAIL'S
WHEEZY VOICE. ALL FINE!

HARRY COULD BARELY BREATHE.

WELL ARE YOU GOING TO KILL ME? HARRY CHOKED, ATTEMPTING TO PRIZE OFF
THE

METAL FINGERS. AFTER I SAVED YOUR LIFE? WELL HOW ME, WHERMTAIL!

THE SILVER FINGERS SLACKENED, HARRY HAD NOT EXPECTED IT; HE

WRENCHED HIMSELF FREE, ASTHENSIFIED, KEEPING HIS HAND OVER WHERM-
TAIL'S MOUTH. HE SAW THE RATLIKE MAN'S SMALL WATERY EYES WIDEN
WITH

FEAR AND SURPRISE! HE SEEMED ILT AS SHOCKED AS HARRY AT WHAT HIS

HAND HAD BEEN, AT THE TIME, MERCIFULLY IMPLIRED IT HAD RETRAGED, AND HE CONTINUED THE STRUGGLE MORE PERSISTENTLY, AS THOUGH THE LINGER THAT

MOMENT OF WEARINESS.

AND HE HAD THAT, WHISPERED THEN, TUGGING WORMTAIL'S HAND FROM HIS OTHER HAND,

HANDLESS, HELPLESS, PETTIGREW'S PUPILS DILATED IN TERROR, HIS EYES HAD SLID FROM HARRY'S FACE TO SOMETHING ELSE, HIS LONG SILVER FINGERS

WERE MOVING INEXORABLY TOWARD HIS OWN THROAT.

NO

WITHOUT PAUSING THE THING, HARRY TRIED TO DRAG BACK THE HAND, BUT THERE WAS NO STOPPING IT. THE SILVER THING THAT VERMOREL HAD GIVEN

HIS MOST CHIEFLY SERVANT HAD TURNED UPON ITS DISARMED AND USELESS OWNER; PETTIGREW WAS REAPING HIS REWARD FOR HIS HESITATION, HIS

MOMENT OF PITY; HE WAS BEING STRANGLED BEFORE THEIR EYES.

MALFLOY MANEER

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NO

THEN HAD RELEASED WORMTAIL THEM, AND TOGETHER HE AND HARRY TRIED

THE PULL THE CRUSHING METAL FINGERS FROM ARIELAND WHIRMTAIL'S
THREAT,

BUT IT WAS NO USE. PETTIGREW WAS TURNING BLUE.

RELATIVELY SAID THEN, POINTING THE HAND AT THE SILVER HAND, BUT
NOTHING HAPPENED; PETTIGREW DROPPED TO HIS KNEES, AND AT THE
SAME

MOMENT, HERMIONE GAVE A DREADFUL SCREAM FROM OVERHEAD. WHIRM-
TAIL'S EYES ROLLED UPWARD IN HIS PURPLE FACE; HE GAVE A LAST TWITCH,

AND WAS STILL.

HARRY AND THEN LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, THEN LEAVING WHIRMTAIL'S
BODY

AND THE FLEET BEHIND THEM, RAN UP THE STAIRS AND BACK INTO THE
SHAD-

ELY PASSAGEWAY LEADING TO THE DRAWING ROOM. CALIBRILLY THEY
CREPT

ALONG IT UNTIL THEY REACHED THE DRAWING ROOM DOOR, WHICH WAS
ALIVE.

THEN THEY HAD A CLEAR VIEW OF BELLATRIX LOOKING DOWN AT
CRIPPLEHEAD,

WHICH WAS HOLDING CRIPPLEHEAD'S SWORD IN HIS LONG-FINGERED HANDS.
HER-

MIENE WAS LYING AT BELLATRIX'S FEET. SHE WAS BARELY STIRRING.

WELL? BELLATRIX SAID TO CRIPPLEHEAD. IS IT THE TRUE SWORD?

HARRY WAITED, HOLDING HIS BREATH, FIGHTING AGAINST THE PRICKLING
OF HIS SCAR.

NEH, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD. IT IS A PACE.

ARE YOU SURE? PANTED BELLATRIX. ELITE SURE?

YES, SAID THE GHEKIN.

RELIEF BREWED ACROSS HER FACE, ALL TENSION DRAINED FROM IT.

GOOD, SHE SAID, AND WITH A CASUAL FLICK OF HER HAND SHE SLASHED
ANOTHER DEEP CLIT INTO THE GHEKIN'S FACE, AND HE DROPPED WITH A YELL
AT HER FEET. SHE KICKED HIM ASIDE. AND NOW, SHE SAID IN A VOICE
THAT

BURST WITH TRIUMPH, WE CALL THE DARK LORD!

AND SHE PULSED BACK HER SLEEVE AND TWITCHED HER FINGERS THE
THE DARK MARK.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

WE

AT ONCE, HARRY'S SCAR FELT AS THOUGH IT HAD SPLIT OPEN AGAIN. HIS
TRUE SURROUNDINGS VANISHED: HE WAS VERDEMENT, AND THE SKELETAL
WIZARD BEFORE HIM WAS LAUGHING TEETHLESSLY AT HIM; HE WAS
ENRAGED

AT THE SLIMMENS HE FELT HE HAD WARNED THEM, HE HAD TOLD THEM

THE SLIMMENS HIM FOR NOTHING LESS THAN BETTER. IF THEY WERE MIS-
TAKEN...

KILL ME, THEN? DEMANDED THE OLD MAN. YOU WILL NOT WIN, YOU CANNOT WIN! THAT WAND WILL NEVER, EVER BE YOURS AND VOLDERMORT'S FLORY BROTHER! A BURST OF GREEN LIGHT FILLED THE PRISON ROOM AND THE PALE OLD BODY WAS LIFTED FROM ITS HARD BED AND THEN FELL BACK, LIFELESS, AND VOLDERMORT RETURNED TO THE WINDS, HIS WRATH BARELY CONTROLLABLE. . . . THEY WOULD SLIPPER HIS RETRIEVAL IF THEY HAD NOT CHIEF REASON FOR CALLING HIM BACK. . . .

AND I THINK, SAID BELLATRIX'S VOICE, WE CAN DISPOSE OF THE MUD-BLOOD, GREYBACK, TAKE HER IF YOU WANT HER.

~~~~~

REIN HAD BURST INTO THE DRAWING ROOM; BELLATRIX WHISKED AROUND, SEEMED; SHE TURNED HER WAND THE FACE REIN INSTEAD

EXPPELLIARMS! HE REARED, POINTING WHERMTAIL'S WAND AT BELLATRIX, AND HER'S FLEW INTO THE AIR AND WAS CAUGHT BY HARRY, WHO HAD

SPRINTED AFTER REIN. LILLY, NARCISSE, DRACO, AND GREYBACK WHEELED AROUND; HARRY YELLED, STUPEFY! AND LILLY MALFOY COLLAPSED INTO

THE HEARTH. ITS OF LIGHT FLEW FROM DRACO'S, NARCISSE'S, AND GREYBACK'S WANDS; HARRY THREW HIMSELF TO THE FLOOR, REHLING BEHIND A

SEPA TO AVOID THEM.

STEEP FOR SHE DIES!

PANTING, HARRY PEERED AROUND THE EDGE OF THE SEPA. BELLATRIX WAS

SUPPERING FERMINE, WHO SEEMED THE RE UNCHASTELIS, AND WAS  
HOLDING HER SHORT SILVER KNIFE TO FERMINE'S THROAT,

MALICE MANER

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DROP YOUR WANDS, SHE WHISPERED, DROP THEM, OR WE LL SEE EX-  
ACTLY HOW FILTHY HER BLOOD IS!

REIN STOOD RIGID, CLUTCHING WHIRTAIL'S WAND, HARRY STRAIGHTENED  
UP, STILL HOLDING BELLATRIX'S.

I SAID, DROP THEM! SHE SCREECHED, PRESSING THE BLADE INTO FERMI-  
NE'S THROAT! HARRY SAW BLOODS HE BLED APPEAR THERE.

ALL RIGHT! HE SHOUTED, AND HE DROPPED BELLATRIX'S WAND BENT THE  
KNEE AT HIS FEET, REIN DID THE SAME WITH WHIRTAIL'S, BOTH RAISED  
THEIR

HANDS TO SHOULDER HEIGHT.

GOOD! SHE LEERED, GRACE, PICK THEM UP! THE DARK LORD IS  
COMING, HARRY PETER! YOUR DEATH APPROACHES!

HARRY KNEW IT! HIS SCAR WAS BURNING WITH THE PAIN OF IT, AND HE  
COULD FEEL Voldemort FLYING THROUGH THE SKY FROM FAR AWAY, EVER  
A

DARK AND STORMY SEA, AND THEN HE WOULD BE LOST KNOWN THE  
APPARATE

THE THEM, AND HARRY COULD SEE NO WAY OUT.

“WELL, SAID BELLATRIX SMILY, AS DRACHE HURRIED BACK TO HER WITH THE WANDS, “LISSY, I THINK WE MIGHT TRY TO TIE THESE LITTLE HERMES UP AGAIN, WHILE CROOKACK TAKES CARE OF MISS MURDERER. I AM SURE THE DARK LORD WILL NOT RECOGNIZE THEM THE GIRL, CROOKACK, AFTER WHAT THEY HAVE DONE TONIGHT.”

AT THE LAST WORD THERE WAS A PECULIAR GRINDING NOISE FROM ABOVE. ALL OF THEM LOOKED UPWARD IN TIME TO SEE THE CRYSTAL CHANDELIER TREMBLE; THEN, WITH A CREAK AND AN EMINENTLY RINGING, IT BEGAN TO FALL. BELLATRIX WAS DIRECTLY BENEATH IT; DROPPING HERMIONE, SHE THREW

HERSELF ASIDE WITH A SCREAM. THE CHANDELIER CRASHED TO THE FLOOR IN AN EXPLOSION OF CRYSTAL AND CHAINS, FALLING BETWEEN HERMIONE AND

THE GIRL, WHO STILL CLUTCHED THE SWORD OF CRUICKSHANK. GLITTERING SHARDS OF CRYSTAL FLEW IN ALL DIRECTIONS; DRACHE BELIEVED HEAVEN, HIS HANDS

COVERING HIS BLEEDING FACE.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

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AS BEN RAN TO HELP HERMIONE OUT OF THE WRECKAGE, HARRY THREW HIS

STAFF; HE LEAPT OVER AN ARMCHAIR AND WRESTED THE THREE WANDS FROM

DRACHE'S GRIP, POINTED ALL OF THEM AT CROOKACK, AND YELLED, “STUPID!”

THE WEREWOLF WAS LIFTED OFF HIS FEET BY THE TRIPLE SPELL, FLEW UP THE  
THE

CEILING, AND THEN SMASHED THE THE GHEKIN.

AS NARCISSA DRAGGED DRACEE ELIT BY THE WAY OF FURTHER HARM, BEL-  
LATRIK SPRANG THE HER FEET, HER HAIR FLYING AS SHE BRANDISHED THE  
SILVER

KNIFE; BUT NARCISSA HAD DIRECTED HER WAND AT THE DHEERLAW,

DHEEKY! SHE SCREAMED, AND EVEN BELLATRIX FREEZE. YELI! YELI  
DROPPED THE CHANDELIER ?

THE TINY ELF TWEETED INTO THE RHEEM, HIS SHADING FINGER POINTING  
AT

HIS ELB MISTRESS.

YELI MUST NOT FLIRT HARRY PETER, HE SHELEADED.

KILL HIM, Cissy! SHRIEKED BELLATRIX, BUT THERE WAS ANOTHER LELD  
CRACK, AND NARCISSA S WAND THEE FLEW INTO THE AIR AND LANDED ON THE  
EITHER SIDE OF THE RHEEM.

YELI DIRTY LITTLE MEREKES! RAGED BELLATRIX. FHEE DARE YELI TAKE  
A WITCH S WAND, FHEE DARE YELI DEY YELI MASTERS?

DHEEKY HAS NEH MASTER! SHELEADED THE ELF. DHEEKY IS A FREE ELF, AND  
DHEEKY HAS COME TO SAVE HARRY PETER AND HIS FRIENDS!

HARRY S SCAR WAS BLINDING HIM WITH PAIN, DIMLY HE KNEW THAT  
THEY HAD MOMENTS, SECONDS BEFORE YHEDEMEHT WAS WITH THEM.

REHN, CATCH AND GEE! HE YELLED, THREWING ONE OF THE WANDS  
THE HIM; THEN HE KENT DOWN THE TIG GRIPHEED ELIT FROM UNDER THE  
CHANDELIER, FHEISTING THE GHEANING GHEKIN, WHO STILL CALLING THE THE  
SWORD, EVER ONE SHELEADER, HARRY SEIZED DHEEKY S HAND AND SPUN HIM

THE SPOT THE DISAPPEARATE.

AS HE TURNED INTO DARKNESS HE CAUGHT ONE LAST VIEW OF THE  
DRAWING

BEHIND: OF THE PALE, FROZEN FIGURES OF NARCISSE AND DRACE, OF THE  
STREETS

MALFEY MANNER

YES

HE REMEMBERED THAT WAS REIN'S HAIR, AND A BLUR OF FLYING SILVER, AS  
BELLATRIX'S

DUNGEON FLEW ACROSS THE BEHIND AT THE PLACE WHERE HE WAS VANISHING

KILL AND FLEW'S . . . SELL COTTAGE . . . KILL AND FLEW'S . . .

HE HAD DISAPPEARED INTO THE LINDENHILL; ALL HE COULD DO WAS RE-  
PEAT THE NAME OF THE DESTINATION AND HOPE THAT IT WOULD SUFFICE

THE TAKE HIM THERE. THE PAIN IN HIS FOREHEAD PIERCED HIM, AND THE  
WRIGHT OF THE GIBLIN HERE DOWN UPON HIM; HE COULD FEEL THE BLADE  
OF

GRYFFINDOR'S SWORD CLIPPING AGAINST HIS BACK; DEERY'S HAND IRRATED  
IN HIS; HE WONDERED WHETHER THE ELF WAS TRYING TO TAKE CHARGE, TO  
PULL THEM IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION, AND TRIED, BY SQUEEZING THE  
FINGERS,

THE INDICATE THAT THAT WAS FINE WITH HIM. . . .

AND THEN THEY HIT SOFT EARTH AND SMELLED SALTY AIR. HARRY FELL

HE HIS KNIFE, RELINQUISHED DEEKE'S HAND, AND ATTEMPTED THE LOWER  
GRIP-HEED GENTLY THE THE GRILLING.

ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? HE SAID AS THE GRILLING STIRRED, BUT GRIP-HEED  
MERELY WHIMPERED.

HARRY SHUNTED AROUND THROUGH THE DARKNESS. THERE SEEMED TO  
BE A CHITTY A SHORT WAY AWAY UNDER THE WIDE STARRY SKY, AND HE  
THOUGHT HE SAW MOVEMENT BESIDE IT.

DEEKE, IS THIS THE CHITTY? HE WHISPERED, CLUTCHING THE TWO  
HANDS HE HAD KNIGHT FROM THE MARCHES, READY THE FIGHT IF HE  
NEEDED

THE. HAVE WE COME TO THE RIGHT PLACE? DEEKE?

HE WHISPERED AROUND. THE LITTLE ELF STOOD FEET FROM HIM.

DEEKE:

THE ELF SMILED SLIGHTLY, STARS REFLECTED IN HIS WIDE, SHINING EYES.  
TOGETHER, HE AND HARRY WHISPERED DOWN AT THE SILVER HILT OF THE  
KNIFE

PROTRUDING FROM THE ELF'S HEAVING CHEST.

DEEKE NEH HELP! HARRY BELLEVED TOWARD THE CHITTY,  
TOWARD THE PEOPLE MOVING THERE. HELP!

## CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

THE

HE DID NOT KNOW HER CARE WHETHER THEY WERE WIZARDS OR MUGGLES,  
FRIENDS OR FEARS; ALL HE CARED ABOUT WAS THAT A DARK STAIN WAS  
SPREADING

ACROSS DEEKY'S FRONT, AND THAT HE HAD STRETCHED OUT HIS THIN ARMS  
THE

HARRY WITH A LEAD OF SUPPLICATION, HARRY CALLED HIM AND LAID  
HIM

SIDELWAYS IN THE CREEK GRASS.

DEEKY, NEE, DEEN T DIE, DEEN T DIE

THE ELF'S EYES FLEW HIM, AND HIS LIPS TREMBLED WITH THE EFFORT  
THE FIRM WORDS.

HARRY . . . PITTER . . .

AND THEN WITH A LITTLE SLIDDER THE ELF BECAME WHITE STILL, AND HIS  
EYES WERE NOTHING MORE THAN GREAT GLASSY EYES, SPRINKLED WITH  
LIGHT

FROM THE STARS THEY COULD NOT SEE.

## CHAPTER TWENTY - FELLER

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### THE LANDMAKER

IT WAS LIKE FINDING IN THE AN OLD NIGHTMARE; FOR AN INSTANT HARRY  
DROPT AGAIN BESIDE DUMBLEDORE'S BODY AT THE FEET OF THE TALLEST  
TOWER AT HOGWARTS, BUT IN REALITY HE WAS STARING AT A TINY BODY  
CRAWLED

UPON THE GRASS, PIERCED BY BELLATRIX'S SILVER KNIFE. HARRY'S VEHICLE  
WAS

STILL SAYING, DEEKY . . . DEEKY . . . EVEN THOUGH HE KNEW THAT THE  
ELF HAD GONE WHERE HE COULD NOT CALL HIM BACK.

AFTER A MINUTE HER SEE HE REALIZED THAT THEY HAD, AFTER ALL, CHOSE THE  
THE RIGHT PLACE, FOR HERE WERE BILL AND FLEW, DEAN AND LINDA, GATH-  
ERING AROUND HIM AS HE KNELT OVER THE ELF.

HERMIEEN? HE SAID SUDDENLY. WHERE IS SHE?

WHEN I TAKEN HER INSIDE, SAID BILL. SHE IS ALL RIGHT.

HARRY LEANED BACK DOWN AT DEEKE. HE STRETCHED OUT A HAND AND  
PULLED THE SHARP BLADE FROM THE ELF'S REED, THEN DRAGGED OFF HIS LEAN  
JACKET AND COVERED DEEKE IN IT LIKE A BLANKET.

THE SEA WAS RUSHING AGAINST ROCKS SOMEWHERE NEARBY; HARRY LIS-  
TENED TO IT WHILE THE OTHERS TALKED, DISCUSSING MATTERS IN WHICH HE

I

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

THE

CHILD TAKE AN INTEREST, MAKING DECISIONS. DEAN CARRIED THE INJURED  
GRIP-HEAD INTO THE HOUSE, FLEW FOLLOWING WITH THEM; NOW BILL  
WAS

MAKING SUGGESTIONS ABOUT KILLING THE ELF. HARRY AGREED WITHOUT  
REALLY KNOWING WHAT HE WAS SAYING. AS HE DID SEE, HE GAZED DOWN AT  
THE TINY REED, AND HIS SKIN PRICKLED AND BURNED, AND IN ONE PART OF



HIS MIND, VIEWED AS IF FROM THE LENSING END OF A LONG TELESCOPE, HE SAW

VEHDEMENT PLUNISHING THOSE THEY HAD LEFT BEHIND AT MALPHE MANNER.

HIS RAGE WAS DREADFUL AND YET HARRY'S GRIEF FOR DEERY SEEMED TO DIMINISH IT, SEE THAT IT BECAME A DISTANT STORM THAT REACHED HARRY FROM ACROSS A VAST, SILENT OCEAN.

I WANT TO SEE IT PROPERLY, WERE THE FIRST WORDS OF WHICH HARRY WAS FULLY CONSCIOUS OF SPEAKING. NOT BY MAGIC, HARRY FELT GET A SPADE?

AND SHORTLY AFTERWARD HE HAD SET THE WHEEL, ALONE, DIGGING THE GRAVE IN THE PLACE THAT BILL HAD SHOWN HIM AT THE END OF THE GARDEN.

BETWEEN BLISHES, HE DUG WITH A KIND OF FLURY, RELISHING THE MANUAL WORK, GLORIFYING IN THE NEEN-MAGIC OF IT, FOR EVERY DROP OF HIS SWEAT AND EVERY BLISTER FELT LIKE A GIFT TO THE ELF WHO HAD SAVED THEIR LIVES.

HIS SCAR BURNED, BUT HE WAS MASTER OF THE PAIN; HE FELT IT, YET WAS APART FROM IT. HE HAD LEARNED CONTROL AT LAST, LEARNED TO SHUT HIS MIND TO VEHDEMENT, THE VERY THING DUMBLEDORE HAD WANTED HIM

TO LEARN FROM SNAPE. JUST AS VEHDEMENT HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO PUNISH HARRY WHILE HARRY WAS CONSUMED WITH GRIEF FOR SIRIUS, SO HIS

THOUGHTS COULD NOT PENETRATE HARRY NOW, WHILE HE MOURNED DEERY.

GRIEF, IT SEEMED, DROVE VEHDEMENT AWAY . . . THOUGH DUMBLEDORE, OF

CHURCH, WOULD HAVE SAID THAT IT WAS LEVE, . . .

IN HARRY DUG, DEEPER AND DEEPER INTO THE HARD, CHILD EARTH,  
SUSLIMING HIS GRIEF IN SWEAT, DENYING THE PAIN IN HIS SCAR, IN THE  
DARKNESS, WITH NOTHING BUT THE SOUND OF HIS OWN BREATH AND THE  
THE LANDMAKER

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BLISHING SEA THE DEEP HIM COMPANY, THE THINGS THAT HAD HAPPENED  
AT

THE MALTHEY'S RETURNED THE HIM, THE THINGS HE HAD HEARD CAME BACK  
THE HIM, AND UNDERSTANDING BLESSED IN THE DARKNESS, . . .

THE STEADY RHYTHM OF HIS ARMS BEAT TIME WITH HIS THOUGHTS, FAL-  
LENS . . . FHEROLWES . . . FALLENS . . . FHEROLWES . . . YET HE NEH LONGER

BLAINED WITH THAT WEIRD, OBSESSIVE WHINGING, LESS AND FEAR HAD  
ENLAPPED

IT HURT: HE FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN SLAPPED AWAKE AGAIN,  
DEEPER AND DEEPER HARRY SANK INTO THE GRAVE, AND HE KNEW WHERE

VEHDEMENT HAD BEEN THINIGHT, AND WHEN HE HAD KILLED IN THE THP-  
MIST CALL OF DIRMINGARD, AND WEY, . . .

AND HE THOUGHT OF WHIRTAIL, DEAD BECAUSE HE HAD SMALL LINGER-  
STILLS IMPULSE OF MERCY, . . . DUMBLEDORE HAD FORESEEN THAT, . . .

HOW MUCH MORE HAD HE DONE?

HARRY LOST TRACK OF TIME. HE KNEW ONLY THAT THE DARKNESS HAD LIGHTENED A FEW DEGREES WHEN HE WAS REHINED BY REEN AND DEAN.

HE'S HERMINE?

BETTER, SAID REEN. FLEW'S LEAVING AFTER HER.

HARRY HAD HIS RETORT READY FOR WHEN THEY ASKED HIM WHY HE HAD NOT SIMPLY CREATED A PERFECT GRAVE WITH HIS WAND, BUT HE DID NOT NEED IT. THEY JUMPED DOWN INTO THE HOLE HE HAD MADE WITH SPADES OF THEIR OWN, AND TOGETHER THEY WORKED IN SILENCE UNTIL THE HOLE SEEMED DEEP ENOUGH.

HARRY WRAPPED THE ELF MORE SOFTLY IN HIS JACKET. REEN SAT ON THE EDGE OF THE GRAVE AND STRIPPED OFF HIS SHOES AND SOCKS, WHICH HE PLACED UPON THE ELF'S BARE FEET. DEAN PRODUCED A WOOLLEN HAT, WHICH HARRY PLACED CAREFULLY UPON DEEN'S HEAD, MUFFLING HIS RATLIKE EARS.

WE SHOULD CLOSE HIS EYES.

HARRY HAD NOT HEARD THE OTHERS COMING THROUGH THE DARKNESS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

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KILL WAS WEARING A TRAVELING COAT, FLEW A LARGE WHITE APRON, FROM

THE POCKET OF WHICH PROTRUDED A KETTLE OF WHAT HARRY RECOGNIZED THE ICE-SKEL-CRIM. HERMINE WAS WRAPPED IN A REVERSED DRESSING

GELIN, PALE AND UNSTEADY ON HER FEET; RON PUT AN ARM AROUND HER WHEN SHE REACHED HIM. LUNA, WHO WAS FLOODED IN ONE OF HER SWEATS, CREELED ON GELIN AND PLACED HER FINGERS TENDERLY UPON EACH OF THE ELF'S EYELIDS, SLIDING THEM OVER HIS GLASSY STARE.

THERE, SHE SAID SOFTLY. WHEN HE COULD BE SLEEPING, HARRY PLACED THE ELF INTO THE GRAVE, ARRANGED HIS TINY LIMBS SO THAT HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN RESTING, THEN CLIMBED AWAY AND GAZED AFTER THE LAST TIME UPON THE LITTLE BODY. HE FORCED HIMSELF NOT TO BREAK DOWN AS HE REMEMBERED DUMBLEDORE'S FUNERAL, AND THE RILLS AND RILLS OF CHILDEN CHAIRS, AND THE MINISTER OF MAGIC IN THE FRONT ROW, THE RECITATION OF DUMBLEDORE'S ACHIEVEMENTS, THE STATELINESS OF THE WHITE MARBLE TOMB. HE FELT THAT DEREK DESERVED JUST AS GRAND A FUNERAL, AND YET HERE THE ELF LAY BETWEEN BUSHES IN A NEGLIGENTLY DONE FIELD.

I THINK WE MIGHT BE SAY SOMETHING, PIPED UP LUNA. I'LL GO FIRST, SHALL I?

AND AS EVERYBODY LOOKED AT HER, SHE ADDRESSED THE DEAD ELF AT THE ENTRANCE OF THE GRAVE.

THANK YOU SO MUCH, DEREK, FOR RESCUING ME FROM THAT CELLAR. IT'S THE UNFAIR THAT YOU HAD TO DIE, WHEN YOU WERE SO GOOD AND BRAVE. I'LL

ALWAYS REMEMBER WHAT YOU DID FOR US. I HOPE YOU'RE HAPPY NOW.

SHE TURNED AND LOOKED EXPECTANTLY AT RON, WHO CLEARED HIS THROAT

AND SAID IN A THICK VOICE, Yeah . . . THANKS, DEREK.

THANKS, MUTTERED DREAM.

HARRY SWALLOWED.

GOOD-BYE, DEERY, HE SAID, IT WAS ALL HE COULD MANAGE, BUT  
LUNA HAD SAID IT ALL FOR HIM. BILL RAISED HIS WAND, AND THE PILE OF

THE WANDMAKER

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EARTH BESIDE THE GRAVE ROSE UP INTO THE AIR AND FELL NEATLY UPON  
IT, A

SMALL, REDDISH MOUND.

DID YOU MIND IF I STAY HERE A MOMENT? HE ASKED THE OTHERS.  
THEY MURMURED WORDS HE DID NOT CATCH; HE FELT GENTLE PATS UPON  
HIS BACK, AND THEN THEY ALL TRAIPSED BACK TOWARD THE CHITTAG, LEAVING

HARRY ALONE BESIDE THE ELF.

HE WENDED AROUND: THERE WERE A NUMBER OF LARGE WHITE STONES,  
SMOTHERED BY THE SEA, MARKING THE EDGE OF THE FLOWER BEDS. HE PICKED  
UP ONE OF THE LARGEST AND LAID IT, PILLBOW-LIKE, OVER THE PLACE WHERE  
DEERY'S HEAD NOW RESTED. HE THEN FELT IN HIS POCKET FOR A WAND.  
THERE WERE TWO IN THERE. HE HAD FORGOTTEN, LEIST TRACK; HE COULD

NOT NOW REMEMBER WHICH WANDS THESE WERE; HE SEEMED TO REMEM-  
BER WRENCHING THEM OUT OF SOMEONE'S HAND. HE SELECTED THE  
SHORTER

OF THE TWO, WHICH FELT FRIENDLIER IN HIS HAND, AND POINTED IT AT THE  
RICK.

SURELY, UNDER HIS MURMURED INSTRUCTIONS, DEEP CUTS APPEARED

UPON THE REED'S SURFACE, HE KNEW THAT FERMINE COULD HAVE DONE IT MORE NEATLY, AND PROBABLY MORE QUICKLY, BUT HE WANTED THE MARK THE SPOT AS HE HAD WANTED THE DIG THE GRAVE. WHEN HARRY STEPPED UP AGAIN, THE STONE READ:

HERE LIES DEERY, A FREE ELF,

HE LOOKED DOWN AT HIS HANDIWORK FOR A FEW MORE SECONDS, THEN WALKED AWAY, HIS SCAR STILL PRICKLING A LITTLE, AND HIS MIND FULL OF THOSE THINGS THAT HAD COME TO HIM IN THE GRAVE, IDEAS THAT HAD TAKEN

SHAPE IN THE DARKNESS, IDEAS BOTH FASCINATING AND TERRIBLE.

THEY WERE ALL SITTING IN THE LIVING ROOM WHEN HE ENTERED THE LITTLE

HALL, THEIR ATTENTION FOCUSED UPON BILL, WHO WAS TALKING, THE ROOM

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

AND

WAS LIGHT-CHEERED, PRETTY, WITH A SMALL FIRE OF DRIFTWOOD BURNING BRIGHTLY IN THE FIREPLACE. HARRY DID NOT WANT THE DRIFTWOOD UPON THE

CARPET, SO HE STEPPED IN THE DOORWAY, LISTENING.

... UNLIKE THAT GINNY'S HOLIDAY, IF SHE HAD BEEN AT HOGWARTS, THEY COULD HAVE TAKEN HER BEFORE WE REACHED HER. NOW WE KNOW SHE'S SAFE THEN.

HE WHEELED AROUND AND SAW HARRY STANDING THERE.

I'VE BEEN GETTING THEM ALL HURT UP THE RIVER, HE EXPLAINED.

MOVED THEM THE MURKIN'S. THE DEATH EATERS KNOW THEM WITH THEM  
NOW, THEY'RE BEHIND THE TARGET THE FAMILY DON'T ADMIT. HE  
ADDED AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY'S EXPRESSION. IT WAS ALWAYS A MATTER

OF TIME, DAD'S BEEN SAYING FOR MONTHS. WE'RE THE BIGGEST BLOOD-  
TRAITOR FAMILY THERE IS.

THEY ARE THEY PROTECTED? ASKED HARRY.

FIDELITY CHARM, DAD'S SECRET-KEEPER, AND WE'VE DONE IT FOR THIS  
CITY. I'M SECRET-KEEPER HERE. NONE OF US CAN SEE THE WORK,  
BUT

THAT'S HARDLY THE MOST IMPORTANT THING NOW. HENCE HILTYANDER  
AND

GRIP-HAND ARE WELL KNOWN, WE'LL MOVE THEM THE MURKIN'S THEN.  
THERE

ISN'T MUCH ROOM HERE, BUT SHE'S GOT PLENTY. GRIP-HAND'S LEGS ARE  
FOR

THE MEN, FLEW'S GIVEN HIM SKIN-CRACK. WE COULD PROBABLY MOVE  
THEM IN AN HOUR OR

NO, HARRY SAID, AND KILL WHEELED STARTLED. I NEED BOTH OF THEM  
HERE. I NEED TO TALK TO THEM. IT'S IMPORTANT.

HE HEARD THE AUTHORITY IN HIS OWN VOICE, THE CONVICTION, THE  
SENSE

OF PURPOSE THAT HAD COME TO HIM AS HE DUG DEEPLY'S GRAVE. ALL OF  
THEIR FACES WERE TURNED TOWARD HIM, LOOKING PLAZZED.

I'M GOING THE WAY, HARRY TOLD KILL, LOOKING DOWN AT HIS HANDS,

STILL COVERED IN MUD AND DERRY'S BLEED. THEN I'LL NEED TO SEE THEM,  
STRAIGHTAWAY.

## THE WANDMAKER

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HE WALKED INTO THE LITTLE KITCHEN, TO THE BASIN BENEATH A WINDOW  
OVERLOOKING THE SEA. DALIN WAS BREAKING OVER THE FHRIZEN, SHELL  
PIND

AND FAINTLY GELD, AS HE WASHED, AGAIN FEELING THE TRAIN OF  
TEHLIGHT

THAT HAD COME TO HIM IN THE DARK GARDEN, . . .

DERRY WOULD NEVER BE ABLE TO TELL THEM WHAT HAD SENT HIM TO THE  
CELLAR, BUT HARRY KNEW WHAT HE HAD SEEN. A PIERCING BLUE EYE HAD  
LOOKED OUT OF THE MIRROR FRAGMENT, AND THEN HELP HAD COME. HELP  
WILL ALWAYS BE GIVEN AT FHEGWARTS TO THOSE WHO ASK FOR IT.

HARRY DRIED HIS HANDS, IMPROVISED TO THE REALITY OF THE SCENE

OUTSIDE THE WINDOW AND THE MURMURING OF THE WATERS IN THE  
ST-

TING ROOM. HE LOOKED OUT OVER THE OCEAN AND FELT CLEER, THIS  
DALIN,

THAN EVER BEFORE, CLEER TO THE HEART OF IT ALL.

AND STILL HIS SCAR PRICKLED, AND HE KNEW THAT VILDEMEET WAS GET-  
TING THERE THEN. HARRY UNDERSTOOD AND YET DID NOT UNDERSTAND. HIS



INSTINCT WAS TELLING HIM ONE THING, HIS BRAIN ELITE ANOTHER, THE  
DUMBLEDORE IN HARRY'S HEAD SMILED, SURVEYING HARRY OVER THE TIPS  
OF HIS FINGERS, PRESSED TOGETHER AS IF IN PRAYER.

YELL GAVE RON THE DEDIMINATER, YELL UNDERSTOOD HIM, . . . YELL GAVE  
HIM A WAY BACK, . . .

AND YELL UNDERSTOOD WHIRTAIL TOO, . . . YELL KNEW THERE WAS A KIT  
OF

REGRET THERE, SOMEWHERE, . . .

AND IF YELL KNEW THEM, . . . WHAT DID YELL KNOW ABOUT ME, DUMBLE-  
DORE?

AM I MEANT TO KNOW, BUT NOT THE SECRET? DID YELL KNOW HOW HARD I'D  
FIND THAT? IS THAT WHY YELL MADE IT THIS DIFFICULT? SHE'D HAVE TIME  
TO

WHERE THAT FELT?

HARRY STOOD ELITE STILL, EYES GLAZED, WATCHING THE PLACE WHERE A  
BRIGHT GLOBE OF DAZZLING SUN WAS RISING OVER THE HORIZON.  
THEN HE

LOOKED DOWN AT HIS CLEAN HANDS AND WAS MOMENTARILY SURPRISED THE

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

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SEE THE CLOTH HE WAS HOLDING IN THEM, HE SET IT DOWN AND RETURNED

THE THE HALL, AND AS HE DID SEE, HE FELT HIS STOMACH PLUMSE ANGRILY, AND THERE

FLASHED ACROSS HIS MIND, SWIFT AS THE REFLECTION OF A DRACONICALLY HYPER WATER, THE OUTLINE OF A BUILDING HE KNEW EXTREMELY WELL.

KILL AND FLEUR WERE STANDING AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS.

I NEED THE SPEAK THE CRIPPLED AND HILLVANDER, HARRY SAID.

NEE, SAID FLEUR, THEY WILL AVE THE WAIT, AHH, THEY ARE BOTH ILL, TIRED

I M SORRY, HE SAID WITHOUT HEAT, BUT IT CAN T WAIT, I NEED THE TALK THE THEM NOW, PRIVATELY AND SEPARATELY, IT S URGENT.

HARRY, WHAT THE HELL S GOING ON? ASKED KILL. THEY TURN UP HERE WITH A DEAD FLEUR-ER AND A HALF-CONSCIOUS GIBLIN, HERMINE LOOKS AS THOUGH SHE S BEEN THRTLED, AND THEN S ILST REFUSED THE TELL ME ANYTHING

WE CAN T TELL THEM WHAT WE RE DOING, SAID HARRY FLATLY. THEY RE IN

THE ORDER, KILL, THEY KNOW DUMKEDDRE LEFT US A MESSAGE, WE RE NOT SUPPOSED THE TALK ABOUT IT THE ANYONE ELSE.

FLEUR MADE AN IMPATIENT NOISE, BUT KILL DID NOT LOOK AT HER; HE WAS STARING AT HARRY, HIS DEEPLY SCARRED FACE WAS HARD THE READ, FINALLY KILL SAID, ALL RIGHT, WHEN DO THEY WANT THE TALK THE FIRST?

HARRY HESITATED, HE KNEW WHAT HUNG ON HIS DECISION, THERE WAS HARDLY ANY TIME LEFT; NOW WAS THE MOMENT THE DECIDE: HERCULES HER FATHERS?

CRIPPLED, HARRY SAID, I LL SPEAK THE CRIPPLED FIRST.

HIS HEART WAS RACING AS IF HE HAD BEEN SPRINTING AND HAD ILST CLEARED AN ENORMOUS OBSTACLE.

UP HERE, THEN, SAID KILL, LEADING THE WAY,  
HARRY HAD WALKED UP SEVERAL STEPS BEFORE STOPPING AND LOOKING  
BACK.

THE LANDMAKER

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I NEED YOU TWO AS WELL! HE CALLED THE ROBIN AND HERMIONE, WHO  
HAD BEEN SQUEAKING, HALF CONCEALED, IN THE DIRECTION OF THE SITTING  
ROOM.

THEY BOTH MOVED INTO THE LIGHT, LOOKING HOPEFULLY RELIEVED.

YOU ARE YOU? HARRY ASKED HERMIONE, YOU WERE AMAZING  
COMING UP WITH THAT STORY WHEN SHE WAS FLIRTING WITH LIKE THAT

HERMIONE GAVE A WIDE SMILE AS ROBIN GAVE HER A ONE-ARMED  
SQUEEZE.

WHAT ARE WE DOING NOW, HARRY? HE ASKED.

YOU'LL SEE, COME ON.

HARRY, ROBIN, AND HERMIONE FOLLOWED KILL UP THE STEEP STAIRS INTO  
A SMALL LANDING. THREE DOORS LED OFF IT.

IN HERE, SAID KILL, OPENING THE DOOR INTO HIS AND FLEW'S ROOM.  
IT WAS A VIEW OF THE SEA, NOW FLECKED WITH GOLD IN THE SUNRISE.  
HARRY MOVED TO THE WINDOW, TURNED HIS BACK TO THE SPECTACULAR  
VIEW, AND WAITED, HIS ARMS FOLDED, HIS SCAR PRICKLING. HERMIONE  
THEIR

THE CHAIR BESIDE THE DRESSING TABLE; ROBIN SAT IN THE ARM.

KILL REAPPEARED, CARRYING THE LITTLE GHEKIN, WHEN HE SET DOWN CAREFULLY UPON THE BED, CRIPPLEHEAD GRINDED TEETHS, AND KILL LEFT, CLOSING THE DOOR UPON THEM ALL.

I'M SORRY THE TACK YELL HURT ME BED, SAID F-HARRY. F-HELL ARE YELLER LEGS?

PAINFUL, REPLIED THE GHEKIN, BUT MENDING.

HE WAS STILL CLUTCHING THE SWORD OF CROPPINDOOR, AND WHEN A STRANGER

LOOKED: HALF TRULLENT, HALF INTRIGUED, F-HARRY NEEDED THE GHEKIN'S SALUTE

SKIN, HIS LONG THIN FINGERS, HIS BLACK EYES, FELLER HAD REMOVED HIS SHOES: HIS LONG FEET WERE DIRTY, HE WAS LARGER THAN A F-HELLER-ELF, BUT

NEED BY MUCH, HIS DENSE HEAD WAS MUCH BIGGER THAN A HUMAN'S.

YELL PROBABLY DIDN'T REMEMBER F-HARRY BEGAN.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FELLER

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THAT I WAS THE GHEKIN WHEN SHOWED YELL THE YELLER VALLEY, THE FIRST

TIME YELL EVER VISITED CRINGHTTS? SAID CRIPPLEHEAD, I REMEMBER,

F-HARRY BETTER, EVEN AMONGST GHEKINS, YELL ARE VERY FAMOUS.

F-HARRY AND THE GHEKIN LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, SIZING EACH OTHER UP.

F-HARRY'S SCAR WAS STILL PRICKLING, HE WANTED TO GET THROUGH THIS IN-

INTERVIEW WITH CRIPPLEHEADS QUICKLY, AND AT THE SAME TIME WAS AFRAID OF

MAKING A FALSE MOVE. WHILE HE TRIED TO DECIDE HOW THE BEST WAY TO  
APPROACH HIS REQUEST, THE GHEKIN KEPT THE SILENCE.

YELL BLINKED THE ELF, HE SAID, SOUNDING UNEXPECTEDLY RATHER HELD.

I WATCHED YELL FROM THE WINDOW OF THE BEDROOM NEXT DOOR.

YES, SAID HARRY.

CRIPPLEHEADS LOOKED AT HIM FROM THE CORNERS OF HIS SLANTING BLACK  
EYES.

YELL ARE AN UNUSUAL WIZARD, HARRY POTTER.

IN WHAT WAY? ASKED HARRY, BLINKING HIS STAR ABSENTLY.

YELL DID THE GRAVE.

SEE?

CRIPPLEHEADS DID NOT ANSWER. HARRY RATHER THOUGHT HE WAS BEING  
SNEERED AT FOR ACTING LIKE A MUGGLE, BUT IT DID NOT MUCH MATTER TO

HIM WHETHER CRIPPLEHEADS APPROVED OF DEE'S GRAVE OR NOT. HE  
GATH-

ERED HIMSELF FOR THE ATTACK.

CRIPPLEHEADS, I NEED TO ASK

YELL ALSO RESCUED A GHEKIN.

WHAT?

YELL BROUGHT ME HERE. SAVED ME.

WELL, I TAKE IT YELL IS NOT SHY? SAID HARRY A LITTLE  
IMPATIENTLY.

NO, HARRY POTTER, SAID CRIPPLEHEADS, AND WITH ONE FINGER HE

TWISTED THE THIN BLACK BEARD UPON HIS CHIN, BUT THEY ARE A VERY  
GOOD WIZARD.

THE WANDMAKER

AND

RIGHT, SAID HARRY, WELL, I NEED SOME HELP, CRIPPLEHEAD, AND THEY  
CAN GIVE IT TO ME.

THE GRIFFIN MADE NO SIGN OF ENCOURAGEMENT, BUT CONTINUED THE  
STARE AT HARRY AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING LIKE HIM.

I NEED THE KEYS INTO A CRINGE'S VALVE.

HARRY HAD NOT MEANT TO SAY IT SO LOUDLY; THE WORDS WERE FORCED  
FROM HIM AS PAIN SEETHED THROUGH HIS LIGHTNING SCAR AND HE SAW,  
AGAIN,

THE HILLINE OF HOGWARTS. HE CLOSED HIS MIND FIRMLY, HE NEEDED THE  
DEAL WITH CRIPPLEHEAD FIRST, RON AND HERMION WERE STARING AT  
HARRY

AS THOUGH HE HAD GONE MAD.

HARRY SAID HERMION, BUT SHE WAS CUT OFF BY CRIPPLEHEAD.

KEYS INTO A CRINGE'S VALVE? REPEATED THE GRIFFIN, WINKING A  
LITTLE AS HE SHIFTED HIS POSITION UPON THE BED. IT IS IMPOSSIBLE.

NO, IT ISN'T, RON CONTRADICTED HIM. IT'S BEEN DONE.

YES, SAID HARRY. THE SAME DAY I FIRST MET THEM, CRIPPLEHEAD, MY  
BIRTHDAY, SEVEN YEARS AGO.

THE VALVE IN HOGWARTS WAS EMPTY AT THE TIME, SNAPPED THE GRIFFIN.

LIN, AND HARRY UNDERSTOOD THAT EVEN THOUGH CRIPPLEHEAD HAD LEFT

CRIPPLEHEADS, HE WAS OFFENDED AT THE IDEA OF ITS DEFENSES BEING  
BREACHED.

ITS PROTECTION WAS MINIMAL.

WELL, THE VALUET WE NEED TO GET INTO ISN'T EMPTY, AND I'M GUESS-  
ING ITS PROTECTION WILL BE PRETTY PIERCABLE, SAID HARRY. IT  
REMEMBERS

THE THE LESTRANGES.

HE SAW HERMIONE AND RON LOOK AT EACH OTHER, ASTONISHED, BUT  
THERE WOULD BE TIME ENOUGH TO EXPLAIN AFTER CRIPPLEHEAD HAD GIVEN  
HIS ANSWER.

WE'LL HAVE NO CHANCE, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD FLATLY. NO CHANCE AT ALL. IF  
WE'LL SEEK BENEATH OUR FEET, A TREASURE THAT WAS NEVER OURS

THEIR, WE'LL HAVE BEEN WARNED, BEWARE      YES, I KNOW, I REMEMBER,

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

\*\*\*

SAID HARRY, BUT I'M NOT TRYING TO GET MYSELF AND TREASURE, I'M  
NOT

TRYING TO TAKE ANYTHING FOR PERSONAL GAIN. CAN YOU BELIEVE  
THAT?

THE CHIEF LOOKED SLANTWISE AT HARRY, AND THE LIGHTNING STAR ON

HARRY'S THREE-HEAD PRICKLED, BUT HE IGNORED IT, REFUSING THE ACKNOWLEDGE ITS PAIN OR ITS INVITATION.

IF THERE WAS A WIZARD OF WHOM I WOULD BELIEVE THAT THEY DID NOT SEEK PERSONAL GAIN, SAID CRUPPIER FINALLY, IT WOULD BE YELL, HARRY

PITTER, GHEKINS AND ELVES ARE NOT USED TO THE PROTECTION OR THE RE-

SPECT THAT YELL HAVE SEEN THIS NIGHT, NOT FROM WAND-CARRIERS,

WAND-CARRIERS, REPEATED HARRY: THE PHRASE RELL EDDY UPON HIS

EARS AS HIS SCAR PRICKLED, AS VERDERBERT TURNED HIS THOUGHTS NORTH-

WARD, AND AS HARRY BLINDED THE ELDEST HELLIVANDER NEXT DOOR,

THE RIGHT TO CARRY A WAND, SAID THE GHEKIN ELLIPTLY, HAS LONG BEEN CONTESTED BETWEEN WIZARDS AND GHEKINS,

WELL, GHEKINS CAN DO MAGIC WITHOUT WANDS, SAID BEN,

THAT IS IMPERIAL! WIZARDS REFUSE TO SHARE THE SECRETS OF WAND-  
MERE WITH EITHER MAGICAL BEINGS, THEY DENY US THE POSSIBILITY OF EX-  
TENDING OUR POWERS!

WELL, GHEKINS WEN'T SHARE ANY OF THEIR MAGIC EITHER, SAID BEN,

YELL WEN'T TELL US HOW TO MAKE SWORDS AND ARMOR THE WAY YELL  
DO, GHEKINS KNOW HOW TO WORK METAL IN A WAY WIZARDS HAVE



NEVER

IT DOESN'T MATTER, SAID HARRY, NOTHING CRIPPLED HIS RISING CREEPER.

THIS ISN'T ABOUT WIZARDS VERSUS CREELING HIM AND EITHER SHORT OF  
MAGIC-

CAL CREATURE

CRIPPLED GAVE A NASTY LAUGH.

BUT IT IS, IT IS ABOUT PRECISELY THAT! AS THE DARK LORD BECOMES  
EVER MORE POWERFUL, YOUR RACE IS SET STILL MORE FIRMLY ABOVE MINE!

THE LANDMAKER

XX

CRINGING FALLS UNDER WIZARDING RULE, FALSE-ELVES ARE  
SLAUGHTERED,

AND WE AMONGST THE HAND-CARRIERS PROTESTS?

WE DIE? SAID HERMIONE. SHE HAD SAT UP STRAIGHT, HER EYES BRIGHT.

WE PROTEST! AND I'M HUNTED WHITE AS MUCH AS ANY CREELING HIM ELF,  
CRIPPLED! I'M A MURDERER!

DON'T CALL YOURSELF BEEN MURDERED.

WE SHOULDNT IT SAID HERMIONE. MURDERED, AND PROUD OF  
IT! I'VE GOT A HIGHER POSITION UNDER THIS NEW ORDER THAN YOU  
HAVE,

CRIPPLED! IT WAS ME THEY CHASE THE TURTLE, BACK AT THE MALFLOYS!  
AS SHE SPoke, SHE PULLED ASIDE THE NECK OF THE DRESSING GOWN TO  
REVEAL THE THIN CUT BELLAATRIX HAD MADE, SCARLET AGAINST HER THREAT,

DID YELL KNOW THAT IT WAS HARRY WHO SET DEERY FREE? SHE ASKED.  
DID YELL KNOW THAT WE VE WANTED ELVES THE BE FREED FOR YEARS? (WHEN  
FIDGETED UNCOMFORTABLY IN THE ARM OF HERMIONE S CHAIR.) YELL  
CAN T  
WANT YELL-KNOW-WHO DECEATED MORE THAN WE DO, GRIP-HOOD?  
THE GEEKIN GAZED AT HERMIONE WITH THE SAME CURIOUSITY HE HAD  
SEEN IN HARRY.

WHAT DO YELL SEEK WITHIN THE LESTRANGES VALI? HE ASKED  
ABRUPTLY. THE SWORD THAT LIES INSIDE IT IS A FAKE. THIS IS THE REAL  
ONE. HE LOOKED FROM ONE THE OTHER OF THEM. I THINK THAT YELL  
ALREADY KNOW THIS, YELL ASKED ME THE LIE FOR YELL BACK THERE.

BUT THE FAKE SWORD ISN T THE ONLY THING IN THAT VALI, IS IT?  
ASKED

HARRY. PERHAPS YELL VE SEEN THE OTHER THINGS IN THERE?

HIS HEART WAS POUNDING HARDER THAN EVER. HE REBELLED HIS EF-  
FERTS TO IGNORE THE PULSING OF HIS SCAR.

THE GEEKIN TWISTED HIS BEARD AROUND HIS FINGER AGAIN.

IT IS AGAINST OUR CODE THE SPREAD OF THE SECRETS OF GRINGITTS. WE  
ARE THE GUARDIANS OF FAMILIES TREASURES. WE HAVE A DUTY THE THE

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

THE

OBJECTS PLACED IN OUR CARE, WHICH WERE, SEE OFTEN, WRENGHT BY OUR

FINGERS.

THE GHEKIN STRUCK THE SWORD, AND HIS BLACK EYES REVED FROM  
HARRY THE HERMIONE THE REIN AND THEN RAN AGAIN.

SEE YELINE, HE SAID FINALLY, THE RE FIGHTING SEE MARY.

WILL YOU HELP US? SAID HARRY, WE HAVEN'T GET A FEEL OF BREAD-  
ING IN WITHHOUT A GHEKIN'S HELP, YOU RE ELIABINE CHANCE.

I SHALL . . . THINK ABOUT IT, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD MADDENINGLY.

BUT REIN STARTED ANGRILY; HERMIONE NUDGED HIM IN THE RIBS.

THANK YOU, SAID HARRY.

THE GHEKIN REINED HIS GREAT BEHEAD IN ACKNOWLEDGEMENT,  
THEN FLEXED HIS SHORT LEGS.

I THINK, HE SAID, SETTLING HIMSELF ESENTENTIALLY UPON KILL AND  
FLEW'S REE, THAT THE SKELE-CORE HAS FINISHED ITS WORK. I MAY BE  
ABLE

THE SLEEP AT LAST, FORGIVE ME . . .

YEAH, HE CHIRPED, SAID HARRY, BUT BEFORE LEAVING THE REIN HE  
LEANED FORWARD AND THREW THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER FROM BESIDE THE

GHEKIN. CRIPPLEHEAD DID NOT PROTEST, BUT HARRY THOUGHT HE SAW  
RESENT-

MENT IN THE GHEKIN'S EYES AS HE CLESED THE BEHEAD UPON HIM.

LITTLE GIT, WHISPERED REIN, HE'S ENJOYING KEEPING US  
HANGING.

HARRY, WHISPERED HERMIONE, PULLING THEM BOTH AWAY FROM

THE DEER, IN THE MIDDLE OF THE STILL-DARK LANDING, ARE THEY SAYING  
WHAT I THINK THEY'RE SAYING? ARE THEY SAYING THERE'S A FIERCE  
IN THE

LESTRANGE VALLEY?

YES, SAID HARRY. BELLATRIX WAS TERRIFIED WHEN SHE THOUGHT WE'D  
BEEN IN THERE, SHE WAS BESIDE HERSELF, WHY? WHAT DID SHE THINK WE'D  
SEEN, WHAT ELSE DID SHE THINK WE MIGHT HAVE TAKEN? SOMETHING SHE  
WAS PRETENDING SHE'D KNOWN WHEN WE'D FIND HER DEAD.

THE WANDMAKER

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BUT I THOUGHT WE WERE LOOKING FOR PLACES SHE'D KNOWN WHEN SHE  
WAS,

PLACES HE'S BEEN SOMETHING IMPORTANT? SAID RON, LOOKING RAPIDLY,

WAS HE EVER INSIDE THE LESTRANGE VALLEY?

I DON'T KNOW WHETHER HE WAS EVER INSIDE GRINGETTS, SAID HARRY.  
HE NEVER HAD CHILD THERE WHEN HE WAS YOUNGER, BECAUSE NEVER  
LEFT HIM ANYTHING. HE WOULD HAVE SEEN THE BANK FROM THE HILLSIDE,  
THOUGH, THE FIRST TIME HE EVER WENT THE DIAGON ALLEY,

HARRY'S SCAR THROBBED, BUT HE IGNORED IT; HE WANTED RON AND  
HERMIONIE TO UNDERSTAND ABOUT GRINGETTS BEFORE THEY SPENT THE  
HOLIDAYS.

I THINK HE WOULD HAVE KNOWN ANYONE WHO HAD A KEY TO A GRIN-  
GETTS VALLEY. I THINK HE'D HAVE SEEN IT AS A REAL SYMBOL OF  
BELONGING.

THE THE WIZARDING WORLD, AND THEN I FORGET, HE TRUSTED BELLATRIX AND  
HER HUSBAND, THEY WERE HIS MOST DEVOTED SERVANTS BEFORE HE FELL,  
AND

THEY WENT LOOKING FOR HIM AFTER HE VANISHED, HE SAID IT THE NIGHT  
HE

CAME BACK, I HEARD HIM,

HARRY RUBBED HIS EAR,

I DON'T THINK HE'D HAVE TOLD BELLATRIX IT WAS A FORTUNE, THOUGH.

HE NEVER TOLD LUCIUS MALFOY THE TRUTH ABOUT THE DIARY, HE PROBABLY  
TOLD HER IT WAS A TREASURED POSSESSION AND ASKED HER THE PLACE  
IT

IN HER WALLET, THE SAFEST PLACE IN THE WORLD FOR ANYTHING YOU  
WANT TO

HIDE, SAGRID TOLD ME . . . EXCEPT FOR HOGWARTS.

WHEN HARRY HAD FINISHED SPEAKING, RON SHOOK HIS HEAD,

YOU REALLY UNDERSTAND HIM.

KITS UP HIM, SAID HARRY, KITS . . . I JUST WISH I'D UNDERSTOOD DUM-  
BLEDORE AS MUCH, BUT WE'LL SEE, COME ON HILTYANDER NOW.

RON AND HERMIONE LOOKED BEMUSED BUT IMPRESSED AS THEY  
FOLLOWED HIM ACROSS THE LITTLE LANDING AND STOPPED LIPON THE DOOR  
OPPOSITE KILL AND FLEUR'S, A WEAIR COME IN? ANSWERED THEM.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

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THE WANDMAKER WAS LYING IN THE TWIN BED FARTHEST FROM THE  
WINDOW. HE HAD BEEN HELD IN THE CELLAR FOR MORE THAN A YEAR, AND  
THIRTILIED, HARRY KNEW, IN AT LEAST ONE OCCASION, HE WAS EMACIATED,  
THE BONES OF HIS FACE STICKING OUT SHARPLY AGAINST THE YELLOWISH  
SKIN.

HIS GREAT SILVER EYES SEEMED VAST IN THEIR SLINDEN SHEETS, THE  
HANDS

THAT LAY UPON THE BLANKET COULD HAVE BELONGED TO A SKELETON.  
HARRY

SAT DOWN IN THE EMPTY BED, BESIDE RON AND HERMIONE. THE RISING  
SUN WAS NOT VISIBLE HERE. THE ROOM FACED THE CLIFF-TOP GARDEN AND  
THE FRESHLY DUG GRAVE.

MR. ELLIVANDER, I'M SORRY THE DISTURB YOU, HARRY SAID.

MY DEAR BOY, ELLIVANDER'S VOICE WAS FEIBLE. YOU RESCUED US. I  
THOUGHT WE WOULD DIE IN THAT PLACE. I CAN NEVER THANK YOU...  
NEVER

THANK YOU... ENOUGH.

WE WERE GLAD TO SEE IT.

HARRY'S SCAR THROBBED, HE KNEW, HE WAS CERTAIN, THAT THERE WAS  
HARDLY ANY TIME LEFT IN WHICH THE GREAT VILDEMENTHED THE HIS CHAL, HE  
ELSE

THE ATTEMPT TO THREAT HIM, HE FELT A FLUTTER OF PANIC... YET HE HAD

MADE HIS DECISION WHEN HE CHOSE TO SPEAK THE CRIPPLED FIRST,  
FEIGN-

ING A CALM HE DID NOT FEEL, HE CREEPED IN THE POUCH AROUND HIS NECK

AND THEN HILT THE TWO HALVES OF HIS BROKEN WAND,

MR. HILLVANDER, I NEED SOME HELP,

ANYTHING, ANYTHING, SAID THE WANDMAKER WEARILY,

CAN YOU MEND THIS? IS IT POSSIBLE?

HILLVANDER HELD HILT A TREMBLING HAND, AND HARRY PLACED THE TWO  
BARELY CONNECTED HALVES INTO HIS PALM,

HELLY AND PHOENIX FEATHER, SAID HILLVANDER IN A TREMBLING  
VOICE, ELEVEN INCHES, NICE AND SUPPLE,

YES, SAID HARRY, CAN YOU ?

NO, WHISPERED HILLVANDER, I AM SORRY, VERY SORRY, BUT A WAND

THE WANDMAKER

THE

THAT HAS SUFFERED THIS DEGREE OF DAMAGE CANNOT BE REPAIRED BY ANY  
MEANS THAT I KNOW OF,

HARRY HAD BEEN BRACED TO HEAR IT, BUT IT WAS A BLOW NEVERTHELESS,

HE THEN TOOK THE WAND HALVES BACK AND REPLACED THEM IN THE POUCH

AROUND HIS NECK, HILLVANDER STARED AT THE PLACE WHERE THE SHAT-  
TERED WAND HAD VANISHED, AND DID NOT BUDGE AWAY UNTIL HARRY HAD

TAKEN FROM HIS POCKET THE TWO WANDS HE HAD BROUGHT FROM THE  
MALLETS ,

CAN YOU IDENTIFY THESE? HARRY ASKED.

THE WANDMAKER THUMB THE FIRST OF THE WANDS AND HELD IT CLOSE TO

HIS FADED EYES, REELING IT BETWEEN HIS KNICKLE-KNICKLED FINGERS,  
FLEX-

ING IT SLIGHTLY.

WALNUT AND DRAGON HEARTSTRING, HE SAID. TWELVE-AND-THREE-  
EIGHTH PART INCHES, LINDYBOLDING. THIS WAND BELONGED TO BELLATRIX

LESTRANGE.

AND THIS ONE?

ELLIVANDER PERFORMED THE SAME EXAMINATION.

HAUTEHORN AND LINICORN HAIR, TEN INCHES PRECISELY, REASONABLY  
SPRINGY. THIS WAS THE WAND OF DRACH MALFOY.

WAS? REPEATED HARRY. ISN'T IT STILL HIS?

PERHAPS NOT. IF YOU THUMB IT

I DID

THEN IT MAY BE YOURS, OF COURSE, THE MANNER OF TAKING MAT-  
TERS, MUCH ALSO DEPENDS UPON THE WAND ITSELF. IN GENERAL, HOWEVER,

WHERE A WAND HAS BEEN WHEN, ITS ALLEGIANCE WILL CHANGE.

THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE ROOM, EXCEPT FOR THE DISTANT RUSHING OF  
THE SEA.

YOU TALK ABOUT WANDS LIKE THEY VE GOT FEELINGS, SAID HARRY,  
LIKE



THEY CAN THINK FOR THEMSELVES.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

\*\*\*

THE WAND CHOOSES THE WIZARD, SAID HELLIVANDER. THAT MUCH HAS ALWAYS BEEN CLEAR THE MOMENT HP WAS WHEN HE HAD STUDIED WANDS HERE.

A PERSON CAN STILL USE A WAND THAT HASN'T CHOSEN THEM, THROUGH?

ASKED HARRY.

HE YES, IF YOU ARE ANY WIZARD AT ALL YOU WILL BE ABLE TO CHANNEL

YOUR MAGIC THROUGH ALMOST ANY INSTRUMENT. THE BEST RESULTS, HOWEVER-

EVER, MUST ALWAYS COME WHERE THERE IS THE STRONGEST AFFINITY BETWEEN

WIZARD AND WAND. THESE CONNECTIONS ARE COMPLEX, AN INITIAL ATTRACTION-

THEN, AND THEN A MUTUAL GROWING EXPERIENCE, THE WAND LEARNING

FROM THE WIZARD, THE WIZARD FROM THE WAND.

THE SEA GLIDED FORWARD AND BACKWARD; IT WAS A MELODIOUS SOUND.

I THINK THIS WAND FROM DRACHE MATCHES BY FORCE, SAID HARRY. CAN I USE IT SAFELY?

I THINK SHE SLEETLE LAWS GYVERN WAND OWNERSHIP, KLIT THE CHN-  
ELVERED WAND WILL USUALLY REND ITS WILL TH ITS NEW MASTER.

SHE I SHOULD USE THIS ONE? SAID REEN, PULLING WHORPTAIL'S WAND  
HOUT OF HIS POCKET AND HANDING IT TO ELLIVANDER.

CHESTNUT AND DRAGON HEARTSTRING, NINE-AND-A-QUARTER INCHES,  
BRITTLE. I WAS FORCED TO MAKE THIS SHORTLY AFTER MY KIDNAPPING, FOR

PETER PETTIGREW. YES, IF YOU WEND IT, IT IS MORE LIKELY TO BE YOUR  
KID-

DING, AND BE IT WELL, THAN ANOTHER WAND.

AND THIS FEELS TRUE FOR ALL WANDS, DOES IT? ASKED HARRY.

I THINK SHE, REPLIED ELLIVANDER, HIS PRETTERRANT EYES LOPEN HARRY'S  
FACE. YOU ARE DEEP ELUSTIENS, MR. PETTER. WANDHERE IS A  
COMPLEX

AND MYSTERIUS BRANCH OF MAGIC.

SHE, IT ISN'T NECESSARY TO KILL THE PREVIOUS OWNER TO TAKE TRUE  
POS-

SESSION OF A WAND? ASKED HARRY.

ELLIVANDER STALLED.

THE WANDMAKER

NECESSARY? NO, I SHOULD NOT SAY THAT IT IS NECESSARY THE DEED.

THERE ARE LEGENDS, HOWEVER, SAID HARRY, AND AS HIS HEART RATE  
 INCREASED, THE PAIN IN HIS SCAR BECAME MORE INTENSE; HE WAS SURE  
 THAT VOLDEMORT HAD DECIDED TO PUT HIS IDEA INTO ACTION. LEGENDS  
 ABOUT A WAND HER WANDS THAT HAVE PASSED FROM HAND TO HAND  
 BY MURDER.

HOLLIVANDER TURNED PALE. AGAINST THE SLEEK PILLOW HE WAS LIGHT  
 GRAY, AND HIS EYES WERE ENORMOUS, BLOODSHOT, AND GLING WITH  
 WHAT

LOOKED LIKE FEAR.

ONLY ONE WAND, I THINK, HE WHISPERED.

AND YELL-KNELL-WELL IS INTERESTED IN IT, ISN'T HE? ASKED HARRY.

I KNOW? CRIED HOLLIVANDER, AND HE LOOKED APPEALINGLY AT  
 RON AND HERMIONE FOR HELP. HOW DO YOU KNOW THIS?

HE WANTED YOU TO TELL HIM HOW THE EVERCHANGE THE CONNECTION  
 BETWEEN HER WANDS, SAID HARRY.

HOLLIVANDER LOOKED TERRIFIED.

HE THOUGHT OF ME, YOU MUST UNDERSTAND THAT? THE CRUCIATUS CURSE,

I I HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO TELL HIM WHAT I KNEW, WHAT I GUESSED?

I UNDERSTAND, SAID HARRY. YOU TOLD HIM ABOUT THE TWIN CURSES?

YOU SAID HE MUST HAVE THE OTHERS ANOTHER WIZARD'S WAND?

HOLLIVANDER LOOKED FRIGHTENED, TRANSFIXED, BY THE MOMENT THAT  
 HARRY

KNEW, HE NEEDED SILENCE.

BUT IT DIDN'T WORK, HARRY WENT ON, MINE STILL BEAT THE BIR-  
REHED WAND, DID YOU KNOW WHY THAT IS?

ELLIVANDER SHOOK HIS HEAD AS SLOWLY AS HE HAD JUST NEEDED.

I HAD . . . NEVER HEARD OF SUCH A THING, YOUR WAND PERFORMED  
SOMETHING UNUSUAL THAT NIGHT, THE CONNECTION OF THE TWIN CORES  
IS

INCREDIBLY RARE, YET WHY YOUR WAND SHOULD HAVE SNAPPED THE BIR-  
REHED WAND, I DO NOT KNOW. . .

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

THE

WE WERE TALKING ABOUT THE EITHER WAND, THE WAND THAT CHANGES  
HANDS BY MURDER, WHEN YOU-KNEW-WHICH REALIZED MY WAND HAD  
DONE SOMETHING STRANGE, HE CAME BACK AND ASKED ABOUT THAT EITHER  
WAND, DIDN'T HE?

THE DO YOU KNOW THIS?

HARRY DID NOT ANSWER.

YES, HE ASKED, WHISPERED ELLIVANDER, HE WANTED TO KNOW EV-  
ERYTHING I COULD TELL HIM ABOUT THE WAND VARIOUSLY KNOWN AS THE

DEATHSTICK, THE WAND OF DESTINY, OR THE ELDER WAND.

HARRY GLANCED SIDELWAYS AT HERMIONE, SHE LOOKED FLABBERGASTED.

THE DARK LORD, SAID ELLIVANDER IN FLUSHED AND FRIGHTENED TONES,  
HAD ALWAYS BEEN HAPPY WITH THE WAND I MADE HIM YEW AND  
PORPHIRY FEATHER, THIRTEEN-AND-A-HALF INCHES UNTIL HE  
DISCOVERED

THE CONNECTION OF THE TWIN CORES, WHEN HE SEES ANOTHER, MORE  
POWER-

FUL WAND, AS THE ONLY WAY THE CHAMBERLAIN FEELS,

BUT HE IS KNOWN WHEN, IF HE DOESN'T ALREADY, THAT MINE IS BROKEN  
BEYOND REPAIR, SAID HARRY QUIETLY,

NEE? SAID HERMIONE, SOUNDING FRIGHTENED. HE CAN'T KNOW THAT,  
HARRY, HOW COULD HE ?

PRIMUM INCANTATEM, SAID HARRY. WE LEFT YOUR WAND AND THE  
BLACKTHORN WAND AT THE MALFLOYS', HERMIONE. IF THEY EXAMINE THEM  
PROPERLY, MAKE THEM RE-CREATE THE SPELLS THEY VE CAST LATELY,  
THEY LL

SEE THAT YOURS BREAKS MINE, THEY LL SEE THAT YOU TRIED AND FAILED TO  
MEND IT, AND THEY LL REALIZE THAT I VE BEEN USING THE BLACKTHORN  
ONE

EVER SINCE.

THE LITTLE CHILD SHE HAD REGAINED SINCE THEIR ARRIVAL HAD DRAINED  
FROM HER FACE. THEN GAVE HARRY A REPROACHFUL LOOK, AND SAID,  
LET S

NOT Worry ABOUT THAT NOW

BUT MR. ELLIVANDER INTERVENED,

THE WANDMAKER

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THE DARK LORD NEH WINGER SEES THE ELDER WAND ONLY FOR THEIR  
DESTRUCTION, MR. POTTER, HE IS DETERMINED TO POSSESS IT BECAUSE HE  
BELIEVES IT WILL MAKE HIM TRULY INVULNERABLE.

AND WILL IT?

THE OWNER OF THE ELDER WAND MUST ALWAYS FEAR ATTACK, SAID  
HOLLIVANDER, BUT THE IDEA OF THE DARK LORD IN POSSESSION OF THE  
DEATHSTICK IS, I MUST ADMIT . . . FEARFUL.

HARRY WAS SUDDENLY REMINDED OF HOW HE HAD BEEN UNSURE, WHEN  
THEY FIRST MET, OF HOW MUCH HE LIKED HOLLIVANDER. EVEN NOW, HAVING  
BEEN THREATENED AND IMPRISONED BY VOLDERMORT, THE IDEA OF THE DARK  
WIZARD IN POSSESSION OF THIS WAND SEEMED TO ENTIRELY HIM AS MUCH  
AS IT REPELLED HIM.

WELL, WELL REALLY THINK THIS WAND EXISTS, THEN, MR.  
HOLLIVANDER?

ASKED HERMION.

OH YES, SAID HOLLIVANDER. YES, IT IS PERFECTLY POSSIBLE TO TRACE  
THE

WAND'S CHANGING FORTUNE HISTORY. THERE ARE CAPS, OF COURSE, AND  
LONG

ONES, WHERE IT VANISHES FROM VIEW, TEMPORARILY LEFT BE HIDDEN; BUT  
ALWAYS IT RESURFACES. IT HAS CERTAIN IDENTIFYING CHARACTERISTICS  
THAT

THESE WHO ARE LEARNED IN WANDLERY RECOGNIZE. THERE ARE WRITTEN  
AC-

CLIENTS, SHOW ME THEM HERE, THAT I AND OTHER HANDMAKERS HAVE  
MADE IT OUR BUSINESS THE STUDY. THEY HAVE THE RING OF  
AUTHENTICITY.

SEE WELL      WELL DIDN'T THINK IT CAN BE A FAIRY TALE OR A MYTH?  
HER-

MINE ASKED HOPEFULLY.

NO, SAID HELLIVANDER. WHETHER IT NEEDS THE PASS BY MURDER, I DO  
NOT KNOW. ITS HISTORY IS BLEEDY, BUT THAT MAY BE SIMPLY DUE THE THE  
FACT THAT IT IS SUCH A DESIRABLE OBJECT, AND ATTRACTS SUCH PASSIONS IN  
WIZARDS, IMMENSELY POWERFUL, DANGEROUS IN THE WRONG HANDS, AND  
AN OBJECT OF INCREDIBLE FASCINATION THE ALL OF US WHO STUDY THE  
POWER  
OF WANDS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

\*\*\*

MR. HELLIVANDER, SAID HARRY, WELL TOLD WELL-KNOWN-ONE THAT  
GREGOROVITCH HAD THE ELDER WAND, DIDN'T WELL?  
HELLIVANDER TURNED, IF POSSIBLE, EVEN PALER. HE BREATHED QUIETLY AS  
HE GLIMPED.

BUT WELL      HOW DO WELL      ?

NEVER MIND HOW I KNOW IT, SAID HARRY, CLOSING HIS EYES ME-

MENTARILY AS HIS STAR TURNED AND HE SAW, FOR MERE SECONDS, A VISION

OF THE MAIN STREET IN FINGERSHED, STILL DARK, BECAUSE IT WAS SO MUCH  
FARTHER NORTH. YELI THOUGHT YELI-KNEEL-WHEN THAT GREGORIEVITCH  
HAD

THE WAND?

IT WAS A RUMOUR, WHISPERED ELLIVANDER. A RUMOUR, YEARS AND  
YEARS AGO, LONG BEFORE YELI WERE BORN! I BELIEVE GREGORIEVITCH  
HIMSELF

STARTED IT, YELI CAN SEE HOW GOOD IT WOULD BE FOR BUSINESS! THAT HE  
WAS STUBBING AND DuplicATING THE REALITIES OF THE ELDER WAND!

YES, I CAN SEE THAT, SAID HARRY, HE STOOD UP. MR. ELLIVANDER,  
HERE LAST THING, AND THEN WE LL LET YELI GET SOME REST. WHAT DID YELI  
KNOW ABOUT THE DEATHLY HALLS?

THE THE WHAT? ASKED THE WANDMAKER, LOOKING LITTERLY  
REMBLED.

THE DEATHLY HALLS.

I M AFRAID I DONT KNOW WHAT YELI RE TALKING ABOUT. IS THIS STILL  
SOMETHING THE DID WITH WANDS?

HARRY LOOKED INTO THE SLINDEN FACE AND BELIEVED THAT ELLIVANDER  
WAS NOT ACTING. HE DID NOT KNOW ABOUT THE HALLS.

THANK YELI, SAID HARRY. THANK YELI VERY MUCH. WE LL LEAVE  
YELI TO GET SOME REST NOW.

ELLIVANDER LOOKED STRIDEN.

HE WAS TERTURING ME! HE GASPED. THE CRUCIATIS CURSE ... YELI  
HAVE NO IDEA ...



## THE WANDMAKER

\*\*\*

I DO, SAID HARRY. I REALLY DO. PLEASE GET SOME REST. THANK YOU  
FOR TELLING ME ALL OF THIS.

HE LED RON AND HERMIONIE DOWN THE STAIRCASE. HARRY CAUGHT A  
GLIMPSE OF BILL, FLEUR, LUNA, AND DEAN SITTING AT THE TABLE IN THE  
KITCHEN, CLIPS OF TEA IN FRONT OF THEM. THEY ALL LOOKED UP AT  
HARRY AS

HE APPEARED IN THE HALLWAY, BUT HE MERELY NEEDED THE THEM AND CON-  
TINUED INTO THE GARDEN, RON AND HERMIONIE BEHIND HIM. THE REDDISH

MOON OF EARTH THAT COVERED DEAN LAY AHEAD, AND HARRY WALKED  
BACK TO IT, AS THE PAIN IN HIS HEAD BUILT MORE AND MORE POWERFULLY.

IT WAS A HUGE EFFORT WHEN HE CAME DOWN THE STAIRS THAT WERE  
FURTHER-

ING THEMSELVES UPON HIM, BUT HE KNEW THAT HE WOULD HAVE THE  
RESIST

ONLY A LITTLE LONGER. HE WOULD YIELD VERY SOON, BECAUSE HE NEEDED THE  
KNOW THAT HIS THEORY WAS RIGHT. HE MUST MAKE ONLY ONE MORE  
EFFORT

EFFORT, SEE THAT HE COULD EXPLAIN TO RON AND HERMIONIE.

GREGORYVITCH HAD THE ELDER WAND A LONG TIME AGO, HE SAID.

I SAW YOU KNOW WHEN TRYING TO FIND HIM. WHEN HE TRACKED HIM

BELOW, HE FEELING THAT GREGORIEVITCH DIDN'T HAVE IT ANYMORE! IT WAS  
STOLEN FROM HIM BY GRINDLEWALD, ~~THE~~ GRINDLEWALD FEELING THAT THAT  
GREGORIEVITCH HAD IT, I DIDN'T KNOW BUT IF GREGORIEVITCH WAS  
STUPID

ENOUGH TO SPREAD THE RUMOR, IT CAN'T HAVE BEEN THAT DIFFICULT.  
VILDEMERT WAS AT THE GATES OF ~~THE~~ HOGWARTS; HARRY COULD SEE HIM

STANDING THERE, AND SEE THEM THE LAMP BURNING IN THE PRE-DAWN, COM-  
ING CLOSER AND CLOSER.

AND GRINDLEWALD USED THE ELDER WAND THE RECENT PHEWELL.  
AND AT THE HEIGHT OF HIS POWER, WHEN DUMBLEDORE KNEW HE WAS  
THE ONLY ONE WHO COULD STOP HIM, HE DUELLED GRINDLEWALD AND BEAT  
HIM, AND HE THREW THE ELDER WAND.

DUMBLEDORE HAD THE ELDER WAND? SAID RHN, BUT THEN WHERE  
IS IT NOW?

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

\*\*\*

AT ~~THE~~ HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY, FIGHTING THEM REMAIN WITH THEM IN THE  
CLIFF-TOP GARDEN.

BUT THEN, LET'S GO! SAID RHN URGENTLY, HARRY, LET'S GO AND GET IT  
BEFORE HE DOES!

IT'S TOO LATE FOR THAT, SAID HARRY, ~~THE~~ CHILD NEET HELP HIMSELF,  
BUT CLUTCHED HIS HEAD, TRYING TO HELP IT RESIST, ~~THE~~ DREAMS WHERE IT

IS, HE'S THERE NOW.

HARRY? REIN SAID FLIRTELISLY. FEEL LIKE HAVE YELL DOWNIN THIS  
WY HAVE WE BEEN WASTING TIME? WY DID YELL TAKE THE CRIPPLES  
FIRST? WE COULD HAVE GONE WE COULD STILL GO

NO, SAID HARRY, AND HE SAND THE HIS DOKES IN THE GRASS. HERMI-  
ONE'S RIGHT, DUMBLEDORE DIDN'T WANT ME TO HAVE IT, HE DIDN'T WANT

ME TO TAKE IT, HE WANTED ME TO GET THE FURCLES.

THE UNBEATABLE WAND, HARRY? MEANED REIN.

I'M NOT SLEEPING THE... I'M SLEEPING THE GET THE FURCLES...

AND NOW EVERYTHING WAS DARK AND DARK: THE SUN WAS BARELY VIS-  
IBLE OVER THE HORIZON AS HE GLIDED ALONGSIDE SNAPE, UP TOWARD THE  
THE

GRILINDS TOWARD THE LAKE.

I SHALL MEET YOU IN THE CASTLE SHORTLY, HE SAID IN HIS HIGH, CHILL  
VOICE. LEAVE ME NOW.

SNAPE KEWED AND SET OFF BACK UP THE PATH, HIS BLACK CLOAK KILLING  
BEHIND HIM. HARRY WALKED SILENTLY, WAITING FOR SNAPE'S FIGURE  
THE

DISAPPEAR. IT WOULD NOT BE FOR SNAPE, HE INDEED ANYONE ELSE, TO SEE  
WHERE HE WAS GOING. BUT THERE WERE NO LIGHTS IN THE CASTLE  
WINDOWS,

AND HE COULD THINK HIMSELF... AND IN A SECOND HE HAD LOST UPON

HIMSELF A DISILLUSIONMENT CHARM THAT HID HIM EVEN FROM HIS OWN EYES.

AND HE WALKED ON, AROUND THE EDGE OF THE LAKE, TAKING IN THE HILT-LINES OF THE BELIEVED CASTLE, HIS FIRST KINGDOM, HIS BIRTHRIGHT. . . .

## THE WANDMAKER

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AND HERE IT WAS, BESIDE THE LAKE, REFLECTED IN THE DARK WATERS, THE WHITE MARBLE TEMPLE, AN UNNECESSARY BLITZ IN THE FAMILIAR LANDSCAPE. HE FELT AGAIN THAT RUSH OF CENTRELESS EUPHORIA, THAT HEADY SENSE OF

PURPOSE IN DESTRUCTION. HE RAISED THE OLD YEW WAND! FEELING FITTING THAT THIS WOULD BE ITS LAST GREAT ACT.

THE TEMPLE SPLIT OPEN FROM HEAD TO FEET. THE SPINNING FIGURE WAS AS LONG AND THIN AS IT HAD BEEN IN LIFE. HE RAISED THE WAND AGAIN. THE WRAPPINGS FELL OPEN. THE FACE WAS TRANSLUCENT, PALE, SLIMED, YET ALMOST PERFECTLY PRESERVED. THEY HAD LEFT HIS SPECTACLES IN THE CRUMPLED NECK. HE FELT AMUSED DERISION. OLIVENDER'S HANDS WERE

HELD UPON HIS CHEST, AND THERE IT LAY, CLUTCHED BENEATH THEM, BLIND WITH HIM.

HAD THE OLD FEEBLY IMAGINED THAT MARBLE HER DEATH WOULD PROTECT THE WAND? HAD HE THOUGHT THAT THE DARK LORD WOULD BE SCARED THE

VIOLATE HIS TRUTH? THE SPIDERLIKE HAND SLIPPED AND PLUCKED THE  
HAND

FROM DUMKLEHIRE'S GRASP, AND AS HE THREW IT, A SHOWER OF SPARKS  
FLEW

FROM ITS TIP, SPARKLING OVER THE CORPSE OF ITS LAST OWNER, READY TO  
SERVE

A NEW MASTER AT LAST.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

SKIP

### SKILL CHITTAG

ILL AND FLEW'S CHITTAG STOOD ALONE ON A CLIFF OVERLOOKING THE  
SEA, ITS WALLS EMBEDDED WITH SHELLS AND WHITEWASHED. IT WAS  
A QUIET AND BEAUTIFUL PLACE. WHEREVER HARRY WENT INSIDE THE TINY  
CHITTAG OR ITS GARDEN, HE COULD HEAR THE CONSTANT RISE AND FALL OF  
THE

SEA, LIKE THE BREATHING OF SOME GREAT, SLUMBERING CREATURE. HE  
SPENT

MUCH OF THE NEXT FEW DAYS MAKING EXCUSES TO ESCAPE THE CRUEL  
CHITTAG, CRAVING THE CLIFF-TOP VIEW OF OPEN SKY AND WIDE, EMPTY SEA,  
AND THE FEEL OF COOL, SALTY WIND ON HIS FACE.

THE ENEMY OF HIS DECISIONS WAS THE RACE WHOSEMENT THE THE WARD  
STILL SCARED HARRY. HE COULD NOT REMEMBER, EVER BEFORE, CHEERING  
NOT THE ACT, HE WAS FULL OF DEBILTS, DEBILTS THAT EVEN COULD NOT HELP  
WHILE WHENEVER THEY WERE TOGETHER.

WHAT IF DUMBLEDORE WANTED US TO KNOW WHAT THE SYMBOL IN TIME  
THE GET THE WAND? WHAT IF WEIRDING HAD WHAT THE SYMBOL MEANT  
MADE

WELL WORTH IT TO GET THE FALLING? HARRY, IF THAT REALLY IS THE  
ELDER

WAND, THEN THE FELL ARE WE SUPPOSED TO FINISH OFF THE-  
WELL-

R

STILL LEFT A

FOR

HARRY HAD NO ANSWERS: THERE WERE MOMENTS WHEN HE WONDERED

WHETHER IT HAD BEEN ULTRICHT MADNESS NOT TO TRY TO PREVENT  
THE-

MUCH BREAKING OPEN THE TIME, HE COULD NOT EVEN EXPLAIN  
SATISFACTION-

RILY WHY HE HAD DECIDED AGAINST IT: EVERY TIME HE TRIED TO  
RECONSTRUCT

THE INTERNAL ARGUMENTS THAT HAD LED TO HIS DECISION, THEY SEEMED  
FEELER THE HIM.

THE GOOD THING WAS THAT HERMIONE'S SUPPORT MADE HIM FEEL JUST  
AS CONFUSED AS REM'S DELUSIONS. WHEN FORCED TO ACCEPT THAT THE ELDER  
WAND WAS REAL, SHE MAINTAINED THAT IT WAS AN EVIL OBJECT, AND THAT  
THE WAY VERBEMERT HAD TAKEN POSSESSION OF IT WAS REPELLENT, NOT  
THE

BE CONSIDERED.

THEY COULD NEVER HAVE DONE THAT, HARRY, SHE SAID AGAIN AND AGAIN. THEY COULDN'T HAVE KNEELEN INTO DUMBLEDORE'S GRAVE. BUT THE IDEA OF DUMBLEDORE'S CORPSE FRIGHTENED HARRY MUCH LESS THAN THE POSSIBILITY THAT HE MIGHT HAVE MISUNDERSTOOD THE LIVING DUMBLEDORE'S INTENTIONS. HE FELT THAT HE WAS STILL CREEPING IN THE DARK; HE HAD CHOSEN HIS PATH BUT KEPT LOOKING BACK, WONDERING WHETHER HE HAD MISREAD THE SIGNS, WHETHER HE SHOULD NOT HAVE TAKEN

THE OTHER WAY. FROM TIME TO TIME, ANGER AT DUMBLEDORE CRASHED OVER

HIM AGAIN, PUNY AS THE WAVES SLAMMING THEMSELVES AGAINST THE

CLIFF BENEATH THE CHITTAG, ANGER THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD NOT EXPLAINED BEFORE HE DIED.

BUT IS HE DEAD? SAID RHN, THREE DAYS AFTER THEY HAD ARRIVED AT THE CHITTAG, HARRY HAD BEEN STARING OUT OVER THE WALL THAT SEPARATED THE

CHITTAG GARDEN FROM THE CLIFF WHEN RHN AND HERMIONE HAD FOUND HIM; HE WISHED THEY HAD NOT, HAVING NOT WISH THEM IN WITH THEIR ARGUMENT.

YES, HE IS, RHN, PLEASE DON'T START THAT AGAIN!

LOOK AT THE FACTS, HERMIONE, SAID RHN, SPEAKING ACROSS HARRY,

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

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WHEN HE CONTINUED THE GAZE AT THE HORIZON. THE SILVER DEER, THE SWORD,  
THE EYE HARRY SAW IN THE MIRROR

HARRY ADMITS HE COULD HAVE IMAGINED THE EYE? THEN T YELL,  
HARRY?

I COULD HAVE, SAID HARRY WITHOUT LOOKING AT HER,

BUT YELL DIDN'T THINK YELL DID, DID YELL? ASKED REN,

NO, I DIDN'T, SAID HARRY,

THERE YELL GO? SAID REN QUICKLY, BEFORE DETERMINING COULD CARRY  
ON. IF IT WASN'T DUMBLEDORE, EXPLAIN HOW DERRY KNEW WE WERE IN  
THE CELLAR, DETERMINING?

I CAN'T BUT CAN YELL EXPLAIN HOW DUMBLEDORE SENT HIM THE LIS  
IF HE'S LYING IN A TOMB AT HOGWARTS?

I DUNNO, IT COULD VE BEEN HIS GHOST?

DUMBLEDORE WOULDN'T COME BACK AS A GHOST, SAID HARRY, THERE  
WAS LITTLE ABOUT DUMBLEDORE HE WAS SURE OF NOW, BUT HE KNEW THAT  
MUCH. HE WOULD HAVE GONE ON,

WHAT D YELL MEAN, GONE ON? ASKED REN, BUT BEFORE HARRY  
COULD SAY ANY MORE, A VOICE BEHIND THEM SAID, AHH?  
FLEUR HAD COME OUT OF THE CHITTAG, HER LONG SILVER HAIR FLYING IN  
THE BREEZE.

AHH, GRIP HEE WOULDN'T LIKE THE SPREAD THE YELL, I SEE IN THE SMALLEST  
BEDROOM, I SAYS I DOES NOT WANT THE BE EVER LARD,

HER DISLIKE OF THE GRIFFIN SENDING HER THE DELIVER MESSAGES WAS  
CLEAR; SHE LOOKED IRRITABLE AS SHE WALKED BACK AROUND THE HALLS.  
GRIP-HEE WAS WAITING FOR THEM, AS FLEUR HAD SAID, IN THE TINIEST  
OF THE CHITTAG & THREE BEDROOMS, IN WHICH DETERMINING AND LUNA  
SLEPT



BY NIGHT, HE HAD DRAWN THE RED COTTEN CURTAINS AGAINST THE BRIGHT,

CHILDY SKY, WHICH GAVE THE ROOM A FIERY GLOW AT EODS WITH THE REST OF THE AIRY, LIGHT COTTAGE.

STILL COTTAGE

SKY

I HAVE REACHED MY DECISION, HARRY POTTER, SAID THE GHEKIN, WHO WAS SITTING CROSS-LEGGED IN A WEL CHAIR, DRUMMING ITS ARMS WITH HIS

SPINDLY FINGERS. THOUGH THE GHEKINS OF GRINGETTS WILL CONSIDER IT

BASE TREACHERY, I HAVE DECIDED TO HELP YOU

THAT'S GREAT! SAID HARRY, RELIEF SURGING THROUGH HIM. GRIP-HEED,

THANK YOU, WE'RE REALLY

IN RETURN, SAID THE GHEKIN FIRMLY, PER PAYMENT, SLIGHTLY TAKEN ABACK, HARRY HESITATED,

HOW MUCH DO YOU WANT? I'VE GOT GOLD,

NOT GOLD, SAID GRIP-HEED. I HAVE GOLD,

HIS BLACK EYES GLITTERED; THERE WERE NO WHITES TO HIS EYES,

I WANT THE SWORD. THE SWORD OF GODRIC GOFFINDOR,

HARRY'S SPIRITS FLUMMETERED,

YOU CAN'T HAVE THAT, HE SAID, I'M SORRY,

THEN, SAID THE GHEKIN SLEETLY, WE HAVE A PROBLEM,

WE CAN GIVE YOU SOMETHING ELSE, SAID PEREEN EAGERLY, I'LL GET THE

LESTRANGES HAVE GOT KEADS OF STUFF, YELL CAN TAKE YELLER PICK SINCE  
WE

GET INTO THE VAULT.

HE HAD SAID THE WRONG THING. CRIPPLEHEAD ALLISED ANGERILY.

I AM NOT A THIEF, KEE? I AM NOT TRYING TO PRELURE TREASURES THE  
WHICH I HAVE NOT RIGHT?

THE SWORD S HELPS

IT IS NOT, SAID THE GHEKIN.

WE RE GRYFFINDERS, AND IT WAS CEDRIC GRYFFINDERS S

AND BEFORE IT WAS GRYFFINDERS S, WHOSE WAS IT? DEMANDED THE  
GHEKIN, SITTING UP STRAIGHT.

NOT HERE S, SAID REIN. IT WAS MADE FOR HIM, WASN T IT?

NOT? CRIED THE GHEKIN, BRISTLING WITH ANGER AS HE POINTED A LONG  
FINGER AT REIN. WIZARDING ARREGCANCE AGAIN? THAT SWORD WAS  
RACENLIX

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

THE

THE FIRST S, TAKEN FROM HIM BY CEDRIC GRYFFINDERS? IT IS A BEST  
TREASURE,

A MASTERPIECE OF GHEKINHEAD? IT BELONGS WITH THE GHEKINS? THE  
SWORD

IS THE PRICE OF MY HIRE, TAKE IT OR LEAVE IT?

CRIPPLEHEAD GLARED AT THEM. HARRY GLANCED AT THE OTHER TWO, THEN  
SAID, WE NEED TO DISCUSS THIS, CRIPPLEHEAD, IF THAT S ALL RIGHT. LEHLID  
YELL GIVE US A FEW MINUTES?

THE GRIFFIN NEEDED, LEERING SMUG.

DOWNSTAIRS IN THE EMPTY SITTING ROOM, HARRY WALKED TO THE FIRE-  
PLACE, KRELL FLOWELED, TRYING TO THINK WHAT HE DID, BEHIND HIM, RON

SAID, HE'S HAVING A LAUGH. WE CAN'T LET HIM HAVE THAT SWORD.

IT IS TRUE? HARRY ASKED HERMIONE. WAS THE SWORD STELEN BY  
GRYFFINDOR?

I DON'T KNOW, SHE SAID EMPHATICALLY. WIZARDING HISTORY OFTEN  
EXAGGERATES

EVER WHAT THE WIZARDS HAVE DONE THE OTHER MAGICAL RACES, BUT  
THERE'S

NEE ACCIDENT THAT I KNOW OF THAT SAYS GRYFFINDOR STEAL THE SWORD.

IT MIGHT BE ONE OF THESE GRIFFIN STORIES, SAID RON, ABOUT HOW THE  
WIZ-

ARDS ARE ALWAYS TRYING TO GET ONE UP ON THEM. I SUPPOSE WE  
SHOULD

THINK OURSELVES LUCKY HE HADN'T ASKED HER ONE OF HER HANDS.

GRIFFINS HAVE GOT GOOD REASONS TO DISLIKE WIZARDS, RON, SAID HER-  
MIONE. THEY'VE BEEN TREATED CRUELLY IN THE PAST.

GRIFFINS AREN'T EXACTLY FLUFFY LITTLE BUNNIES, THOUGH, ARE THEY?  
SAID RON. THEY'VE KILLED PLENTS OF US. THEY'VE BEEN DIRTY THEM.

BUT ARGUING WITH GRIP-HEAD ABOUT WHICH RACE IS MOST UNDER-

HANDS AND VIOLENT ISN'T GOING TO MAKE HIM MORE LIKELY TO HELP US,

IS IT?

THERE WAS A PAUSE WHILE THEY TRIED TO THINK OF A WAY AROUND THE PROBLEM. HARRY WHISPERED HINTS OF THE WINDMILL AT DEEPLY'S GRAVE. LUNA WAS ARRANGING SEA LAVENDER IN A JAR BESIDE THE HEADSTONE.

HEY, SAID RON, AND HARRY TURNED BACK TO FACE HIM. HEEN'S

STILL CHITTAC

SON

THIS? WE TELL GRIPHOOK WE NEED THE SWORD UNTIL WE GET INSIDE THE VAULT, AND THEN HE CAN HAVE IT. THERE'S A FADER IN THERE, ISN'T THERE?

WE SWITCH THEM, AND GIVE HIM THE FADER.

RON, HE'D KNOWN THE DIFFERENCE BETTER THAN WE WOULD! SAID HERMIONE. HE'S THE ONLY ONE WHO REALIZED THERE HAD BEEN A SWAP!

YEAH, BUT WE COULD SCARPER BEFORE HE REALIZES

HE WHISPERED BENEATH THE WOOD HERMIONE WAS GIVING HIM.

THAT, SHE SAID QUIETLY, IS DESPICABLE. ASK FOR HIS HELP, THEN BELIEVE-CROSS HIM? AND WHY WOULD WE? CHECKING BEEN'T LIKE WIZARDS, RON?

RON'S EARS HAD TURNED RED.

ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT! IT WAS THE ONLY THING I COULD THINK OF  
WHAT I

WELL, SELL IT, THEN?

WE NEED TO OFFER HIM SOMETHING ELSE, SOMETHING JUST AS  
VALUABLE.

BRILLIANT, I'LL GO AND GET ONE OF OUR BETTER ANCIENT GRIFFIN-MADE  
SWORDS AND WE'LL CAN GIFT WRAP IT.

SILENCE FELL BETWEEN THEM AGAIN. HARRY WAS SURE THAT THE GRIFFIN  
WOULD ACCEPT NOTHING BUT THE SWORD, EVEN IF THEY HAD SOMETHING  
AS VALUABLE TO OFFER HIM. YET THE SWORD WAS THEIR ONE,  
INDISPENSABLE

WEAPON AGAINST THE DEATH-EATERS.

HE CLOSED HIS EYES FOR A MOMENT FOR THE AND LISTENED TO THE RUSH  
OF THE SEA. THE IDEA THAT GRYPFINDER MIGHT HAVE STELEN THE SWORD  
WAS UNPLEASANT TO HIM; HE HAD ALWAYS BEEN PROUD TO BE A  
GRYPFINDER;

GRYPFINDER HAD BEEN THE CHAMPION OF MUGGLE-BOYS, THE WIZARD  
WHO HAD CLASHED WITH THE PURPLE-HEADED-DRAGON SLYTHERIN. . . .

MAYBE HE'S LYING, HARRY SAID, OPENING HIS EYES AGAIN.  
GRYPFINDER.

MAYBE GRYPFINDER DIDN'T TAKE THE SWORD, BUT THEN WE KNOW THE  
GRIFFIN VERSION OF HISTORY'S RIGHT?

## CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

XXX

DID IT MAKE A DIFFERENCE? ASKED HERMION.

CHANCES WHEN I FEEL ABLE TO IT, SAID HARRY.

HE TOOK A DEEP BREATH.

WE WILL TELL HIM HE CAN HAVE THE SWORD AFTER HE'S HELPED US GET INTO THAT VALLEY BUT WE WILL BE CAREFUL TO AVOID TELLING HIM EXACTLY

WHEN HE CAN HAVE IT.

A GRIN SPREAD SLOWLY ACROSS REIN'S FACE. HERMIONE, HOWEVER, LOOKED ALARMED.

HARRY, WE CAN'T

HE CAN HAVE IT, HARRY WENT ON, AFTER WE'VE USED IT FOR ALL OF THE FORTKNIVES, I WILL MAKE SURE HE GETS IT THEN. I WILL KEEP MY WORD, BUT THAT COULD BE YEARS! SAID HERMIONE.

I KNOW THAT, BUT HE NEEDS IT. I WON'T BE LYING . . . REALLY.

HARRY MET HER EYES WITH A MIXTURE OF DEFIANCE AND SHAME. HE REMEMBERED THE WORDS THAT HAD BEEN ENGRAVED OVER THE GATEWAY TO DUNMONGARD: FOR THE GREATER GOOD, HE POLISHED THE IDEA AWAY. WHAT CHOICE DID THEY HAVE?

I DON'T LIKE IT, SAID HERMIONE.

NEED BE I, MUCH, HARRY ADMITTED.

WELL, I THINK IT'S GENIUS, SAID REIN, STANDING UP AGAIN. LET'S GO AND TELL HIM.

BACK IN THE SMALLEST BEDROOM, HARRY MADE THE OFFER, CAREFUL TO PHRASE IT SO AS NOT TO GIVE ANY DEFINITE TIME FOR THE HANDOVER OF THE

SWORD. HERMIONE FROWNED AT THE PLEA WHILE HE WAS SPEAKING; HE FELT

IRRITATED AT HER, AFRAID THAT SHE MIGHT GIVE THE GAME AWAY, HOWEVER,

CRIPPLEHEAD HAD EYES FOR NEITHER BUT HARRY.

I HAVE NEVER HEARD, HARRY POTTTER, THAT YOU WILL GIVE ME THE SWORD  
OF GRYPFINDER IF I HELP YOU.

YES, SAID HARRY.

STILL BETTER

NOT

THEN SNAKE, SAID THE GRIFFIN, HOLDING UP HIS HAND.  
HARRY THOUGHT IT AND SNAKE. HE WONDERED WHETHER THESE BLACK EYES  
SAW ANY MISGIVINGS IN HIS MIND. THEN GRYPFINDER REINDETERMINED HIM,  
CLAPPED HIS HANDS TOGETHER, AND SAID, SEE, WE BEGIN!  
IT WAS LIKE PLANNING THE BREAK INTO THE MINISTRY ALL OVER AGAIN.

THEY SETTLED THE WHERE IN THE SMALLEST BEDROOM, WHICH WAS KEPT, AC-  
CORDING TO GRYPFINDER'S PREFERENCE, IN SEMIDARKNESS.

I HAVE VISITED THE LESTRANGES VAULT ONLY ONCE, GRYPFINDER TOLD  
THEM, ON THE OCCASION I WAS TOLD THE PLACE INSIDE IT THE FALSE SWORD.  
IT

IS ONE OF THE MOST ANCIENT CHAMBERS. THE ELDEST WIZARDING FAMILIES  
STORE THEIR TREASURES AT THE DEEPEST LEVEL, WHERE THE VAULTS ARE  
LARGEST

AND BEST PROTECTED, . . .

THEY REMAINED SILENT IN THE CLIPBOARDLIKE ROOM FOR FEELS AT A TIME.

SLEEWLY THE DAYS STRETCHED INTO WEEKS. THERE WAS PROBLEM AFTER PROBLEM-

LET THE EVERCHANGE, NOT LEAST OF WHICH WAS THAT THEIR STORE OF PERUVIAN

PEPPER WAS GREATLY DEPLETED.

THERE WAS REALLY ONLY ENOUGH LEFT FOR ONE OF US, SAID HERMINE, TILTING THE THICK MOUND OF PEPPER AGAINST THE LAMPLIGHT.

THAT WILL BE ENOUGH, SAID HARRY, WHO WAS EXAMINING GRIPPE'S HAND-DRAWN MAP OF THE DEEPEST PASSAGELAYS.

THE OTHER INHABITANTS OF SHELL COTTAGE COULD HARDLY FAIL TO NOTICE

THAT SOMETHING WAS GOING ON WHEN THAT HARRY, RON, AND HERMINE

ONLY EMERGED FOR MEALTIMES. NORMALLY ASKED QUESTIONS, ALTHOUGH

HARRY OFTEN FELT KILL'S EYES ON THE THREE OF THEM AT THE TABLE, THOUGH-

ALL, CONCERNED.

THE LONGER THEY SPENT TOGETHER, THE MORE HARRY REALIZED THAT HE

DID NOT MUCH LIKE THE GEEK. GRIPPE WAS UNEXPECTEDLY BLEED-THIRSTY, LAUGHED AT THE IDEA OF PAIN IN LESSER CREATURES, AND SEEMED

TO RELISH THE POSSIBILITY THAT THEY MIGHT HAVE THE FLIRT WITH LIZARDS



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THE REACH THE LESTRANGES' VAULT. HARRY COULD TELL THAT HIS DISTASTE WAS

SHARED BY THE OTHER TWO, BUT THEY DID NOT DISCUSS IT: THEY NEEDED CRYPTICUS.

THE CHELIN ATE ONLY GRUDGINGLY WITH THE REST OF THEM. EVEN AFTER HIS LEGS HAD MENDED, HE CONTINUED THE REEDEST TRAYS OF FOOD IN HIS REEF, LIKE THE STILL-FRAIL HELLIVANDER, UNTIL BILL (FEELING AN ANGRY

HELTERAST FROM FLEW) WENT UPSTAIRS TO TELL HIM THAT THE ARRANGEMENT

COULD NOT CONTINUE. THEREAFTER CRYPTICUS JOINED THEM AT THE EVER-

CRIBBED TABLE, ALTHOUGH HE REFUSED TO EAT THE SAME FOOD, INSISTING,

INSTEAD, ON LUMPS OF RAW MEAT, ROOTS, AND VARIOUS FLING.

HARRY FELT RESPONSIBLE: IT WAS, AFTER ALL, HE WHO HAD INSISTED THAT THE CHELIN REMAIN AT SHELL CHITTAGH SEE THAT HE COULD ELICIT THEM HIM; HIS FAULT THAT THE WHOLE WEASLEY FAMILY HAD BEEN DRIVEN INTO HIDING,

THAT BILL, FRED, GEORGE, AND MR. WEASLEY COULD NO LONGER WORK.

I'M SURE, HE TOLD FLEW, ONE ELLISTERY APRIL EVENING AS HE HELPED

HER PREPARE DINNER. I NEVER MEANT YOU TO HAVE TO DEAL WITH ALL OF

THIS,

SHE HAD JUST SET SOME KNIVES THE WOOD, CHIPPING UP STEAKS FOR  
GRIPHEAD AND KILL, WHO HAD PREFERRED HIS MEAT BLEEDY EVER SINCE  
HE HAD BEEN ATTACKED BY GREYBACK. WHILE THE KNIVES SLICED AWAY  
BEHIND HER, HER SOMETIMES IRRITABLE EXPRESSION SOFTENED.

ARRY, YOU SAVED MY SISTER'S LIFE, I DO NOT FORGET.

THIS WAS NOT, STRICTLY SPEAKING, TRUE, BUT HARRY DECIDED AGAINST  
REMINDING HER THAT GABRIELLE HAD NEVER BEEN IN REAL DANGER.

ANYWAY, FLEUR WENT ON, POINTING HER HAND AT A PILE OF SALVE ON  
THE STOVE, WHICH BEGAN TO BUBBLE AT ONCE. MR. HILLVANDER LEAVES  
FOR MURIEL'S THIS EVENING. THAT WILL MAKE THINGS EASIER. THE GHELIN,  
SHE

SMILED A LITTLE AT THE MENTION OF HIM. CAN THEY DOWNSTAIRS, AND  
YOU, JOHN, AND DEAN CAN TAKE THAT ROOM.

STILL BETTER

511

WE DON'T MIND SLEEPING IN THE LIVING ROOM, SAID HARRY, WHO  
KNEW THAT GRIPHEAD WOULD THINK POORLY OF HAVING THEM SLEEP IN  
THE

SEPA; KEEPING GRIPHEAD HAPPY WAS ESSENTIAL TO THEIR PLANS.  
DON'T

WHEN ASKED US. AND WHEN SHE TRIED THE PRETEXT HE WENT ON,  
WE'LL

BE OFF YOUR HANDS WHEN THE, JOHN, HERMINE, AND I. WE DON'T NEED  
THE BE HERE MUCH LONGER.

BLIT WHAT DE YELL MEAN? SHE SAID, FLEEING AT HIM, HER HAND  
POINTING AT THE CASSEROLE DISH NOW SUSPENDED IN MIDAIR. ~~HE~~  
~~CHLUSE~~

YELL MUST NOT LEAVE, YELL ARE SAFE PRE?

SHE BEHEDED RATHER LIKE MRS. WEASLEY AS SHE SAID IT, AND HE WAS  
GLAD THAT THE BAD DINNER HAPPENED AT THAT MOMENT. LUNA AND DEAN  
ENTERED, THEIR HAIR DAMP FROM THE RAIN OUTSIDE AND THEIR ARMS FULL  
OF DRIFTWOOD.

... AND TINY LITTLE EARS, LUNA WAS SAYING, A KIT LIKE A HIPPO S,  
DADDY SAYS, ONLY PURPLE AND FAIRY, AND IF YELL WANT TO CALL THEM,  
YELL HAVE TO FILM; THEY PREFER A WALTZ, NOTHING TOO FAST, ...

BEHIND UNCOMFORTABLE, DEAN SHRUGGED AT HARRY AS HE PASSED,  
PUSHING LUNA INTO THE CRINKLED DINING AND SITTING THEM WHERE  
RON AND HERMIONIE WERE LAYING THE DINNER TABLE. SEIZING THE  
CHANCE

THE ESCAPE FLEW S UNEXPECTEDLY, HARRY GRABBED THE ILCS OF PLIMPOIN  
ILICE AND PULLED THEM.

... AND IF YELL EVER COME TO THE FLEW FLEW I LL BE ABLE TO SHOW YELL

THE FLEW, DADDY WROTE THE ME ABOUT IT BLIT I HAVEN T SEEN IT YET, RE-  
CALISE THE DEATH EATERS THEM ME FROM THE FLEWARTS EXPRESS AND I

NEVER GET HOME FOR CHRISTMAS, LUNA WAS SAYING, AS SHE AND DEAN  
RELAID THE FIRE.

LUNA, WE TOLD YELL, HERMIONIE CALLED OVER TO HER, THAT FLEW  
EXPLODED. IT CAME FROM AN ERLUMPENT, NOT A CRUMPLE-FLEWED  
SNEEDACK

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NEE, IT WAS DEFINITELY A SNEERBACKE FERN, SAID LILNA SERENELY.  
DADDY TOLD ME, IT WILL PROBABLY HAVE RE-FERRED BY NEE, THEY MEND  
THEMSELVES, YELL DNEEL.

BERMINE SE-HEED HER HEAD AND CONTINUED LAYING DOWN FEELS AS

KILL APPEARED, LEADING MR. ELLIVANDER DOWN THE STAIRS. THE WAND-  
MAKER STILL LOOKED EXCEPTIONALLY PALE, AND HE CULING THE KILL S ARM  
AS

THE LATTER SLIPPED HIM, CARRYING A LARGE SLITCASE.

I M CHING THE MISS YELL, MR. ELLIVANDER, SAID LILNA, APPROACHING  
THE OLD MAN.

AND I YELL, MY DEAR, SAID ELLIVANDER, PATTING HER ON THE  
SHOULDER.

YELL WERE AN INEXPRESSIBLE COMFORT TO ME IN THAT TERRIBLE PLACE.  
SEE, ALL REVEIL, MR. ELLIVANDER, SAID FLEUR, KISSING HIM ON BOTH  
CHEEKS. AND I WONDER WHETHER YELL COULD HELP ME BY DELIVERING  
A PACKAGE THE KILL S ALINTIE MURIEL? I NEVER RETURNED ER TIARA.

IT WILL BE AN FERNER, SAID ELLIVANDER WITH A LITTLE GEL, THE VERY  
LEAST I CAN DO IN RETURN FOR YOUR GENEROUS HOSPITALITY.

FLEUR DREW OUT A GREEN VELVET CASE, WHICH SHE OPENED TO SHOW THE  
WANDMAKER. THE TIARA SAT GLITTERING AND TWINKLING IN THE LIGHT  
FROM

THE LILY-HANGING LAMP,

MINSTRELS AND DIAMONDS, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD, WHO HAD SIDLED INTO THE ROOM WITHOUT HARRY NOTICING. MADE BY GIBLINS, I THINK?

AND PAID FOR BY WIZARDS, SAID KILL QUIETLY, AND THE GIBLIN SENT HIM A LOOK THAT WAS BOTH FLIRTIVE AND CHALLENGING.

A STRONG WIND BLUSTED AGAINST THE COTTAGE WINDOWS AS KILL AND HILLVANDER SET OFF INTO THE NIGHT. THE REST OF THEM SHELTERED IN AROUND THE TABLE; ELEANOR THE ELDER AND WITH BARELY ENOUGH ROOM TO MOVE, THEY STARTED THE CAT. THE FIRE CRACKLED AND PIPED IN THE GRATE

BESIDE THEM. FLEUR, HARRY NOTICED, WAS MERELY PLAYING WITH HER FEET; SHE GLANCED AT THE WINDOWS EVERY FEW MINUTES; HOWEVER, KILL

STILL COTTAGE

SIX

RETURNED BEFORE THEY HAD FINISHED THEIR FIRST COURSE, HIS LONG HAIR TANGLED BY THE WIND.

EVERYTHING IS FINE, HE TOLD FLEUR. HILLVANDER SETTLED IN, MUM AND DAD SAY HELLO. GINNY SENDS LOVE ALL HER LOVE. FRED AND GEORGE ARE DRIVING MURIEL UP THE WALL, THEY'RE STILL OPERATING AN EMBROIDER

BUSINESS OUT OF HER BACK ROOM. IT CHEERED HER UP TO HAVE HER TIARA

BACK, THOUGH. SHE SAID SHE THOUGHT SHE'D STEAL IT.

AH, SHE'LL BE CHARMANTE, FLEUR ALIVE, SAID FLEUR CROSSLY, WAVING HER HAND AND CALLING THE DIRTY PLATES TO RISE AND FORM A STACK IN

MIDAIR, SHE CALIGHT THEM AND MARCHED OUT OF THE ROOM.

DADDY'S MADE A TIARA, PIPED UP LUNA, WELL, THERE HE'S A CREW,  
REALLY.

REIN CALIGHT HARRY'S EYE AND GRINNED; HARRY KNEW THAT HE WAS  
REMEMBERING THE LUDICROUS HEADRESS THEY HAD SEEN HIM THEIR VISIT  
THE XENOPHILUS.

YES, HE'S TRYING TO RE-CREATE THE BEST DIADEM OF RAVENCLAW. HE  
THINKS HE'S IDENTIFIED MOST OF THE MAIN ELEMENTS WELL, ADDING THE  
KILBYN WINGS REALLY MADE A DIFFERENCE

THERE WAS A BANG IN THE FRONT DOOR, EVERYONE'S HEAD TURNED THE-  
WARD IT, FELIX CAME RUNNING OUT OF THE KITCHEN, LOOKING  
FRIGHTENED.

KILL JUMPED ON HIS FEET, HIS HAND POINTING AT THE DOOR; HARRY, REIN,  
AND HERMIONE DID THE SAME. SILENTLY CRIPPLED SLIPPED BENEATH THE  
TABLE, OUT OF SIGHT.

WHAT IS IT? KILL CALLED.

IT IS I, REMUS JOHN LIVING! CALLED A VOICE OVER THE HOWLING  
WIND, HARRY EXPERIENCED A THRILL OF FEAR; WHAT HAD HAPPENED? I  
AM

A WEREWOLF, MARRIED THE NYMPHADORA THINGS, AND WELL, THE SECRET-  
KEEPER OF SHELL CHITTAG, TOLD ME THE ADDRESS AND MADE ME COME IN  
AN EMERGENCY.

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ELPIN, MUTTERED KILL, AND HE RAN TO THE DEER AND WRENCHED IT OPEN.

ELPIN FELL OVER THE THRESHOLD, HE WAS WHITE-FACED, WRAPPED IN A TRAVELING CLOAK, HIS GRAYING HAIR WINDSWEEP, HE STRAIGHTENED UP, BEEDED AROUND THE ROOM, MAKING SURE HE WAS THERE, THEN CRIED ALOUD, IT'S A BOY! WE'VE NAMED HIM TED, AFTER DEBRA'S FATHER! HERMINE SHRIEKED.

WHA ? THINGS THINGS HAS HAD THE BABY?

YES, YES, SHE'S HAD THE BABY! SHOUTED ELPIN, ALL AROUND THE TABLE LAUGH CRIES OF DELIGHT, SIGHS OF RELIEF! HERMINE AND FLEUR BOTH SHRIEKED, CONGRATULATIONS! AND BEN SAID, KIMMY, A BABY! AS IF HE HAD NEVER HEARD OF SUCH A THING BEFORE.

YES YES A BOY, SAID ELPIN AGAIN, HE SEEMED DAZED BY HIS OWN HAPPINESS, HE STOOD AROUND THE TABLE AND FLICKED HARRY, THE SCENE IN THE BASEMENT OF CRIMINALS PLACE MIGHT NEVER HAVE HAPPENED.

WELL BE GOODFATHER? HE SAID AS HE RELEASED HARRY.

M-MY? STAMMERED HARRY

WELL, YES, OF COURSE DEBRA WHITE AGREES, NEH HNE BETTER

I PRAY KIMMY

HARRY FELT OVERWHELMED, ASTONISHED, DELIGHTED! NOW KILL WAS FLIRTING THE PETCH WINE, AND FLEUR WAS PERSUADING ELPIN TO JOIN THEM

AFTER A DRINK,

I CAN'T STAY LONG, I MUST GET BACK, SAID LUPIN, BEAMING AROUND AT THEM ALL: HE LOOKED YEARS YOUNGER THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN HIM.

THANK YOU, THANK YOU, BILL.

BILL HAD SEEN FILLED ALL OF THEIR CUPS, THEY STOOD AND RAISED THEM HIGH IN A TOAST.

STILL CHATTING

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THE TERRY REMAINS LUPIN, SAID LUPIN, A GREAT WIZARD IN THE MAKING!

HE DOES LOOK LIKE? ALICE INQUIRED.

I THINK HE LOOKS LIKE DORA, BUT SHE THINKS HE IS LIKE ME, NOT MUCH HAIR. IT LOOKED BLACK WHEN HE WAS BORN, BUT I SWEAR IT'S TURNED

GINGER IN THE PAST SINCE. PROBABLY BE BORN BY THE TIME I GET BACK.

ANDREWS SAYS THINGS HIS HAIR STARTED CHANGING WHEN THE DAY THAT SHE

WAS BORN. HE DRAINED HIS CUP. HE, SHE THEN, JUST HERE MORE, HE ADDED, BEAMING, AS BILL MADE THE FILL IT AGAIN.

THE WIND WHISTLED THE LITTLE CHATGE AND THE FIRE LEAPT AND CRACKLED, AND BILL WAS SEEN OPENING ANOTHER BOTTLE OF WINE. LUPIN'S NEWS SEEMED TO HAVE TAKEN THEM OUT OF THEMSELVES, REMOVED THEM FOR A



WHILE FROM THEIR STATE OF SLEEP: THINGS OF NEW LIFE WERE EXHILARATING.

ONLY THE GHEKIN SEEMED UNTHRILLED BY THE SUDDENLY FESTIVE ATMOSPHERE, AND AFTER A WHILE HE SLID BACK THE THE BEDROOM HE WENT BACK TO HIS ROOM. HARRY THOUGHT HE WAS THE ONLY ONE WHO HAD NOTICED

THIS, UNTIL HE SAW BILL'S EYES FOLLOWING THE GHEKIN UP THE STAIRS.

NEH... NEH... I REALLY MUST GET BACK, SAID LUPIN AT LAST, DECLINING YET ANOTHER GHEKLET OF WINE. HE GOT TO HIS FEET AND PULLED HIS

TRAVELING CLOAK BACK AROUND HIMSELF.

GHEH-KYE, GHEH-KYE I'LL TRY AND BRING SOME PICTURES IN A FEW DAYS TIME. THEY'LL ALL BE SO GLAD TO KNOW THAT I'VE BEEN WELL. HE FASTENED HIS CLOAK AND MADE HIS FAREWELLS, HUGGING THE WOMEN AND GRASPING HANDS WITH THE MEN, THEN, STILL BEAMING, RETURNED INTO THE WILD NIGHT.

GHEDFATHER, HARRY? SAID BILL AS THEY WALKED INTO THE KITCHEN TOGETHER, HELPING CLEAR THE TABLE. A REAL FATHER? CONGRATULATIONS?

AS HARRY SET DOWN THE EMPTY GHEKLETS HE WAS CARRYING, BILL PULLED

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THE DOOR BEHIND HIM CLOSED, SLUTTING OUT THE STILL-VEHICLE VEHICLES  
OF THE

BETTERS, WHO WERE CELEBRATING THE CELEBRATE EVEN IN SLIPIN'S ABSENCE.

I WANTED A PRIVATE WORD, ACTUALLY, HARRY. IT HASN'T BEEN EASY TO  
GET AN OPPORTUNITY WITH THE COTTAGE THIS FULL OF PEOPLE.

KILL HESITATED.

HARRY, YOU'RE PLANNING SOMETHING WITH CRIPPLEHEAD.

IT WAS A STATEMENT, NOT A QUESTION, AND HARRY DID NOT EITHER THE  
DENY IT. HE MERELY LOOKED AT KILL, WAITING.

I KNOW GRIFFINS, SAID KILL. I'VE WORKED FOR CRINGETTS EVER SINCE  
I LEFT HOGWARTS. AS FAR AS THERE CAN BE FRIENDSHIP BETWEEN WIZARDS  
AND GRIFFINS, I HAVE GRIFFIN FRIENDS. HER, AT LEAST, GRIFFINS I KNOW  
WELL, AND LIKE. AGAIN, KILL HESITATED.

HARRY, WHAT DO YOU WANT FROM CRIPPLEHEAD, AND WHAT HAVE YOU  
PROMISED HIM IN RETURN?

I CAN'T TELL YOU THAT, SAID HARRY. SURE, KILL.

THE KITCHEN DOOR OPENED BEHIND THEM; FLEUR WAS TRYING TO BRING  
THROUGH MORE EMPTY CHAIRS.

WAIT, KILL TOLD HER. JUST A MOMENT.

SHE BACKED OUT AND HE CLOSED THE DOOR AGAIN.

THEN I HAVE TO SAY THIS, KILL WENT ON. IF YOU HAVE STRUCK ANY

DEAL OF BARGAIN WITH CRIPPLEHEAD, AND MOST PARTICULARLY IF THAT  
BARGAIN INVOLVES TREASURE, YOU MUST BE EXCEPTIONALLY CAREFUL. GRIFFIN

NOTIONS OF OWNERSHIP, PAYMENT, AND REPAYMENT ARE NOT THE SAME AS

HUMAN ONES.

HARRY FELT A SLIGHT FEELING OF DISCOMFORT, AS THOUGH A SMALL SPARK HAD STIRRED INSIDE HIM.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? HE ASKED.

WE ARE TALKING ABOUT A DIFFERENT BREED OF BEING, SAID BILL.

STILL CETTAGE

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DEALINGS BETWEEN WIZARDS AND GRIFFINS HAVE BEEN FRAGMENT FOR CENTURIES BUT YOU WILL KNOW ALL THAT FROM HISTORY OF MAGIC. THERE HAS

BEEN FIGHT FOR BOTH SIDES, I WOULD NEVER CLAIM THAT WIZARDS HAVE BEEN

INNOCENT. HOWEVER, THERE IS A RELIEF AMONG SOME GRIFFINS, AND THESE AT GRINGotts ARE PERHAPS MOST PRONE TO IT, THAT WIZARDS CANNOT BE

TRUSTED IN MATTERS OF GOLD AND TREASURE, THAT THEY HAVE NO RESPECT FOR GRIFLIN OWNERSHIP.

I RESPECT HARRY BEGAN, BUT BILL SHOOK HIS HEAD.

YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND, HARRY, NOBODY COULD UNDERSTAND UNLESS

THEY HAVE LIVED WITH GRIFFINS. TO A GRIFLIN, THE RIGHTFUL AND TRUE MAS-

TER HE AND HIRKIS IS THE MAKER, NOT THE PURCHASER. ALL GHEKIN-MADE

HIRKIS ARE, IN GHEKIN EYES, RIGHTFULLY THEIRS.

BUT IF IT WAS EHLIGHT

THEN THEY WOULD CONSIDER IT RENTED BY THE ONE WHO HAD  
PAID THE MONEY. THEY HAVE, HOWEVER, GREAT DIFFICULTY WITH THE IDEA  
OF GHEKIN-MADE HIRKIS PASSING FROM WIZARD TO WIZARD. YELI SAW

GRIP-HEED'S FACE WHEN THE TIARA PASSED UNDER HIS EYES. HE DISAP-  
PROVES, I BELIEVE HE THINKS, AS DO THE FIERCEST OF HIS KIND, THAT IT

EHLIGHT TH HAVE BEEN RETURNED TO THE GHEKINS SINCE THE ORIGINAL  
PUR-

CHASER DIED. THEY CONSIDER ELUR HABIT OF KEEPING GHEKIN-MADE  
HIRKIS,

PASSING THEM FROM WIZARD TO WIZARD WITHOUT FURTHER PAYMENT,  
LITTLE

MORE THAN THAT.

HARRY HAD AN EMINENTLY FEELING YELI; HE WONDERED WHETHER KILL  
GUESSED MORE THAN HE WAS LETTING HIM.

ALL I AM SAYING, SAID KILL, SETTING HIS HAND ON THE OTHER BACK INTO  
THE SITTING ROOM, IS THE BE VERY CAREFUL WHAT YELI PROMISE GHEKINS,  
HARRY. IT WOULD BE LESS DANGEROUS TO BRING INTO GRINGETTS THAN  
THE

RENCE HIM A PROMISE TO A GHEKIN.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

RIGHT, SAID HARRY AS KILL HOPKED THE DEER, YEAH, THANKS, I LL  
 REAR THAT IN MIND,

AS HE PHELLED KILL BACK THE THE EITHER A WAY THELIGHT CAME THE HIM,  
 KERN NEE DEHJET HF THE WINE HE HAD DRUNK, HE SEEMED SET HEN CHLUSE  
 THE BECHME ILST AS RECKLESS A CHDFAHER THE TEDDY KLIPIN AS SIRILIS  
 BLACK  
 HAD BEEN THE HIM,

## CHAPTER TWENTY - SIX

### CRINGETTS

HEIR PLANS WERE MADE, THEIR PREPARATIENS COMPLETE; IN THE  
 SMALLEST REBHEEM A SINGLE LING, CHARSE BLACK HAIR POLLOCKED  
 FROM THE SWEATER HERMINEE HAD BEEN WEARING AT MALPHY MANER/  
 LAY CLURLED IN A SMALL GLASS PHIAL HEN THE MANTELPIECE,

AND YELL LL BE USING HER ACTUAL WAND, SAID HARRY, NEDDING THE-  
 WARD THE WALNUT WAND, SHE I RECKEN YELL LL BE PRETTY CERVINKING,

HERMINEE WHEDD FRIGHTENED THAT THE WAND MIGHT STING HER BITE  
 HER AS SHE PICKED IT UP,

I HATE THIS THING, SHE SAID IN A LOW VOICE. I REALLY HATE IT. IT FEELS

ALL WRONG, IT DOESN'T WORK PROPERLY FOR ME. . . . IT'S LIKE A KIT OF

HARRY CHILD NEET HELP BUT REMEMBER FEEL HERMIONE HAD DIS-  
MISSED HIS BEATING OF THE BLACKTHERN WAND, INSISTING THAT HE WAS

IMAGINING THINGS WHEN IT DID NOT WORK AS WELL AS HIS OWN, TELLING  
HIM TO SIMPLY PRACTICE. HE COULD NOT REPEAT HER OWN ADVICE  
BACK

TO HER, HOWEVER; THE EVE OF THEIR ATTEMPTED ASSAULT ON GRINGETTS  
FELT

LIKE THE WRONG MOMENT TO ANTAGONIZE HER.

T

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

END

IT WILL PROBABLY HELP YOU GET IN CHARACTER, THOUGH, SAID BEN.

THINK WHAT THAT WAND IS DONE?

BUT THAT'S MY POINT! SAID HERMIONE. THIS IS THE WAND THAT  
THRTLRED NEVILLE'S MUM AND DAD, AND WHICH KNOWS FEEL MANY OTHER  
PEOPLE? THIS IS THE WAND THAT KILLED SIRIUS!

HARRY HAD NOT THOUGHT OF THAT! HE LOOKED DOWN AT THE WAND AND

WAS VISITED BY A BRUTAL LURGE THE SNAP IT, THE SLICE IT IN HALF WITH  
CRYP-

FINDER'S SWORD, WHICH WAS PROPPED AGAINST THE WALL BESIDE HIM.

I MISS MY WAND, HERMIONE SAID MISERABLY. I WISH MR. ELLI-  
VANDER HAD MADE ME ANOTHER ONE THEN.

MR. ELLIVANDER HAD SENT LUNA A NEW WAND THAT MORNING. SHE  
WAS OUT IN THE BACK GARDEN AT THAT MOMENT, TESTING ITS CAPABILITIES  
IN

THE LATE AFTERNOON SUN. DEAN, WHO HAD LOST HIS WAND TO THE  
SNATCHERS,

WAS WATCHING RATHER CLOSERLY.

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE FALUTHERN WAND THAT HAD SINCE RE-  
PLACED THE DRACHE MALFOY. HE HAD BEEN SURPRISED, BUT PLEASED, THE

DISCOVER THAT IT WORKED FOR HIM AT LEAST AS WELL AS HERMIONE'S HAD  
BEEN. REMEMBERING WHAT ELLIVANDER HAD TOLD THEM OF THE SECRET

WORKINGS OF WANDS, HARRY THOUGHT HE KNEW WHAT HERMIONE'S PROB-  
LEM WAS: SHE HAD MET WITH THE WANDLIT WAND'S ALLEGIANCE BY TAKING

IT PERSONALLY FROM BELLATRIX.

THE DOOR OF THE BEDROOM OPENED AND CRUPPE ENTERED. HARRY  
REACHED INSTINCTIVELY FOR THE HILT OF THE SWORD AND DREW IT CLOSE THE

HIM, BUT REGRETTED HIS ACTION AT ONCE: HE COULD TELL THAT THE GIRL  
HAD NOTICED. SPENDING THE GLASS OVER THE STICKY MEMENT, HE SAID,

WE VE JUST BEEN CHECKING THE LAST-MINUTE STUFF, CRIPPERHEAD. WE VE  
TOLD BILL AND FLEUR WE RE LEAVING THEM HERE, AND WE VE TOLD THEM  
NOT

TO GET UP THE SEE US OFF.

THEY HAD BEEN FIRM ON THIS POINT, BECAUSE HERMIONE WOULD NEED

CRINGETTS

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TO TRANSFORM INTO BELLATRIX BEFORE THEY LEFT, AND THE LESS THAT BILL  
AND

FLEUR KNEW HER SUSPECTED ABOUT WHAT THEY WERE ABOUT TO DO, THE  
BETTER. THEY HAD ALSO EXPLAINED THAT THEY WOULD NOT BE RETURNING.

AS THEY HAD LEFT PERKINS S HAD TOLD HIM THE NIGHT THAT THE  
SNATCHERS

CUGHT THEM, BILL HAD LENT THEM ANOTHER ONE. IT WAS NOW PACKED

INSIDE THE BEADED BAG, WHICH, HARRY WAS IMPRESSED TO LEARN, HER-  
MIONE HAD PROTECTED FROM THE SNATCHERS BY THE SIMPLE EXPEDIENT OF

STUFFING IT DOWN HER SLEEVE.

THOUGH HE WOULD MISS BILL, FLEUR, LUNA, AND DEAN, NOT THE MEN-  
TIONED THE FEW MOMENTS THEY HAD ENJOYED OVER THE LAST FEW WEEKS,



HARRY WAS LEEDING FORWARD THE ESCAPING THE CONFINEMENT OF SHELL  
CELTAGE. HE WAS TIRED OF TRYING THE MAKE SURE THAT THEY WERE NOT  
EVERYWHERE, TIRED OF BEING STILT IN THE TINY, DARK ROOMS. MOST OF  
ALL,

HE HUNGED THE RE RID OF CRIPPLEHEAD. HOWEVER, PRECISELY WHEN AND WHEN  
THEY WERE THE PART FROM THE GHELIN WITHHELT HANDING EVER  
CRIPPLEHEAD S

SWARD REMAINED A BELIEF THAT THE WHICH HARRY HAD NOT ANSWER. IT HAD  
BEEN IMPOSSIBLE THE DECIDE WHEN THEY WERE GOING TO SEE IT, BECAUSE THE  
GHELIN RARELY LEFT HARRY, REN, AND HERMIONE ALONE TOGETHER FOR  
MORE

THAN FIVE MINUTES AT A TIME. HE COULD GIVE MY MOTHER LESSONS,  
GROWED REN, AS THE GHELIN S LONG FINGERS KEPT APPEARING AROUND  
THE

EDGES OF THEIRS. WITH KILL S WARNING IN MIND, HARRY COULD NOT HELP  
SUSPECTING THAT CRIPPLEHEAD WAS IN THE WATCH FOR POSSIBLE  
SLIDING.

HERMIONE DISAPPROVED SHE HEARTILY OF THE PLANNED DOUBLE-CROSS  
THAT

HARRY HAD GIVEN UP ATTEMPTING THE PICK HER BRAINS AND WHEN BEST THE  
SEE IT; REN, IN THE RARE OCCASIONS THAT THEY HAD BEEN ABLE TO  
SNATCH

A FEW CRIPPLEHEAD-FREE MOMENTS, HAD COME UP WITH NOTHING BETTER  
THAN WE LL JUST HAVE TO LIVE IT, MATE.

HARRY SLEPT BADLY THAT NIGHT, LYING AWAKE IN THE EARLY HOURS,  
HE THOUGHT BACK THE WAY HE HAD FELT THE NIGHT BEFORE THEY HAD

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

XXX

INFILTRATED THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC AND REMEMBERED A DETERMINATION,  
ALMOST AN EXCITEMENT, WHEN HE WAS EXPERIENCING MOMENTS OF ANXIETY,  
NAGGING DOUBTS: HE COULD NOT SHAKE OFF THE FEELING THAT IT WAS ALL  
GOING

THE WAY WRONG, HE KEPT TELLING HIMSELF THAT THEIR PLAN WAS GOOD,  
THAT

GRIPHOOKS KNEW WHAT THEY WERE FACING, THAT THEY WERE WELL-  
PREPARED

FOR ALL THE DIFFICULTIES THEY WERE LIKELY TO ENCOUNTER, YET STILL HE  
FELT

UNEASY, BECAUSE HE TWICE HE HEARD RONNIE STIR AND WAS SURE THAT HE THEM  
WAS AWAKE, BUT THEY WERE SHARING THE SITTING ROOM WITH DEAN, SHE  
HARRY DID NOT SPEAK.

IT WAS A RELIEF WHEN SIX HOURS ARRIVED AND THEY COULD SLIP OUT OF  
THEIR SLEEPING BAGS, DRESS IN THE SEMIDARKNESS, THEN CREEP OUT INTO  
THE GARDEN, WHERE THEY WERE TO MEET HERMIONE AND GRIPHOOK. THE  
EVENING WAS CHILLY, BUT THERE WAS LITTLE WIND WHEN IT WAS MAY,

HARRY LOOKED UP AT THE STARS STILL GLIMMERING FAIRLY IN THE DARK  
SKY

AND LISTENED TO THE SEA WASHING BACKWARD AND FORWARD AGAINST THE  
CLIFF: HE WAS GOING TO MISS THE SOUND.

SMALL GREEN SPECKLES WERE PIERCING THEIR WAY UP THROUGH THE RED  
EARTH OF DEAN'S GRAVE WHEN, IN A YEAR'S TIME THE MOUND WOULD BE

COVERED IN FLOWERS, THE WHITE STONE THAT BORE THE ELF'S NAME HAD AL-

READY ACQUIRED A WEATHERED LOOK. HE REALIZED NOW THAT THEY COULD

HARDLY HAVE LAID DEERY THE REST IN A MORE BEAUTIFUL PLACE, BUT HARRY  
ACHED WITH SADNESS THE THOUGHT OF LEAVING HIM BEHIND. LEARNING DEER  
IN THE GRAVE, HE WANDERED YET AGAIN HOW THE ELF HAD KNOWN WHERE  
THEY WERE THE REST OF THEM. HIS FINGERS MOVED UNCONSCIOUSLY TO THE  
LITTLE POCKET STILL STUCK AROUND HIS NECK, THROUGH WHICH HE  
COULD

FEEL THE JAGGED MIRROR FRAGMENT IN WHICH HE HAD BEEN SURE HE HAD  
SEEN DUMBLEDORE'S EYE. THEN THE SOUND OF A DEER OPENING MADE  
HIM LOOK AROUND.

BELLATRIX LESTRANGE WAS STRIDING ACROSS THE LAWN TOWARD THEM,

GRINGHITS

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ACCOMPANIED BY GRIPPER. AS SHE WALKED, SHE WAS TUCKING THE  
SMALL, BEADED BAG INTO THE INSIDE POCKET OF ANOTHER SET OF THE OLD  
BOOTS THEY HAD TAKEN FROM CRIMMOLD PLACE. THOUGH HARRY KNEW  
PERFECTLY WELL THAT IT WAS REALLY HERMIONE, HE COULD NOT SUPPRESS  
A SHIVER OF DREAD. SHE WAS TALLER THAN HE WAS, HER LONG BLACK  
HAIR RIPPLING DOWN HER BACK, HER HEAVILY LIDDED EYES DISDAINFUL AS  
THEY RESTED UPON HIM, BUT THEN SHE SPOKE, AND HE HEARD HERMIONE  
THROUGH BELLATRIX'S VOICE.

SHE TASTED DISGUSTING, WORSE THAN CLIMBING: HEAVY, RICH, CHEE  
HERE SHE I CAN BE WELL. . . .

RIGHT, BUT REMEMBER, I DON'T LIKE THE BEARD THE LONG

HE, FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, THIS ISN'T ABOUT BEING HANDSOME

IT'S NOT THAT, IT GETS IN THE WAY! BUT I LIKED MY NECK A BIT SHORTER,  
TRY AND DO IT THE WAY YOU DID LAST TIME.

HERMION GRINNED AND SET THE WORDS, MUTTERING UNDER HER BREATH  
AS SHE TRANSFORMED VARIOUS ASPECTS OF RON'S APPEARANCE. HE WAS  
THE BE GIVEN A COMPLETELY FAKE IDENTITY, AND THEY WERE TRUSTING THE  
THE MALEFICENT ALMA CAST BY BELLATRIX TO PROTECT HIM. MEANWHILE  
HARRY AND CRUICKSHANK WERE THE BE CONCEALED UNDER THE INVISIBILITY  
CLASH.

THERE, SAID HERMION, HOW DOES HE LOOK, HARRY?

IT WAS JUST POSSIBLE TO DISCERN RON UNDER HIS DISGUISE, BUT ONLY,  
HARRY THOUGHT, BECAUSE HE KNEW HIM SO WELL. RON'S HAIR WAS NEAR  
LONG AND WAVY; HE HAD A THICK BRUNNEN BEARD AND MUSTACHE, NO FRECK-  
LES, A SHORT, BROAD NECK, AND HEAVY EYEBROWS.

WELL, HE'S NOT MY TYPE, BUT HE'LL DO, SAID HARRY. SHALL WE GO  
THEN?

ALL THREE OF THEM GLANCED BACK AT SPELL CHITTAG, LYING DARK AND  
SILENT UNDER THE FADING STARS, THEN TURNED AND BEGAN THE WALK  
TOWARD

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

THE POINT, JUST BEYOND THE BOUNDARY WALL, WHERE THE FIDELIS CHARM STOPPED WORKING AND THEY WOULD BE ABLE TO DISAPPEAR. HENCE PAST THE GATE, CRIPPLEHEAD SPEAK.

I SHOULD CLIMB UP NOW, HARRY POTTER, I THINK?

HARRY KENT DOWN AND THE CHELIN CLAMBERED MONT HIS BACK, HIS HANDS LINKED IN FRONT OF HARRY'S THREAT, HE WAS NOT HEAVY, BUT HARRY

DISLIKED THE FEELING OF THE CHELIN AND THE SURPRISING STRENGTH WITH

WHICH HE CULING HIM, HERMIONE PULLED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK MONT OF THE LEADED BAG AND THREW IT OVER THEM BOTH.

PERFECT, SHE SAID, BENDING DOWN TO CHECK HARRY'S FEET. I CAN'T SEE A THING. LET'S GO.

HARRY TURNED MONT THE SPOT, WITH CRIPPLEHEAD MONT HIS SHOULDERS, CONCENTRATING WITH ALL HIS MIGHT MONT THE LEADY CALIBREIN, THE INN THAT

WAS THE ENTRANCE TO DIAGON ALLEY. THE CHELIN CULING EVEN TIGHTER AS THEY MOVED INTO THE COMPRESSING DARKNESS, AND SECONDS LATER HARRY'S FEET FELT PAVEMENT AND HE OPENED HIS EYES MONT CHARING CROSS ROAD. MUGGLES KLITLED PAST WEARING THE HANGING EXPRESSIONS

OF EARLY MORNING, WHITE LINCENSCHELS OF THE LITTLE INN'S EXISTENCE. THE BAR OF THE LEADY CALIBREIN WAS NEARLY DESERTED. THEN, THE STEEPED AND TEETHLESS LANDLORD, WAS POLISHING GLASSES BEHIND THE

EAR CHELINTER, A GROUP OF WARRIORS HAVING A MUTTERED  
CONVERSATION

IN THE FAR CORNER GLANCED AT HERMINE AND DREW BACK INTO THE  
SHADOWS.

MADAM LESTRANGE, MURMURED THEM, AND AS HERMINE PASSED  
HE INCLINED HIS HEAD SLIGHTLY.

GOOD MORNING, SAID HERMINE, AND AS HARRY CREEPT PAST, STILL  
CARRYING CRIPPLED PIGGYBACK UNDER THE CLOAK, HE SAW THEM LOOK  
SURPRISED.

THEY FELT, HARRY WHISPERED IN HERMINE'S EAR AS THEY PASSED

CRINGETTS

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HELT OF THE INN INTO THE TINY BACKYARD. YOU NEED THE TREAT PEOPLE  
LIKE

THEY'RE SLIM

HEY, HEY!

HERMINE DREW HEAT BELLATRIX'S HAND AND TAPPED A BRICK IN THE  
UNDESIRABLE WALL IN FRONT OF THEM. AT ONCE THE BRICKS BEGAN TO  
WHIRL

AND SPIN! A HOLE APPEARED IN THE MIDDLE OF THEM, WHICH GREW WIDER  
AND WIDER, FINALLY FORMING AN ARCH-WAY BENTH THE NARROW CHECKED  
STREET THAT WAS DIAGONAL ALLEY.

IT WAS QUIET, EARLY TIME FOR THE SHEEPS TO OPEN, AND THERE WERE  
HARDLY ANY SHEPHERDS AROUND. THE CRIMINAL, CHECKED STREET WAS MUCH  
ALTERED NOW FROM THE BUSTLING PLACE HARRY HAD VISITED BEFORE HIS

FIRST TERM AT HOGWARTS SEH MANY YEARS BEFORE. MORE STEPS THAN  
EVER

WERE REWARDED UP, THOUGH SEVERAL NEW ESTABLISHMENTS DEDICATED TO  
THE DARK ARTS HAD BEEN CREATED SINCE HIS LAST VISIT. HARRY S HELD  
FACE

GLARED DOWN AT HIM FROM POSTERS PLASTERED EVERY MANDY WINDOWS, AL-  
WAYS CAPTIONED WITH THE WORDS UNDESIRABLE NUMBER ONE.

A NUMBER OF RAGGED PEOPLE SAT Huddled IN DIRTWAYS. HE HEARD  
THEM MEANING THE THE FEW PASSERSBY, PLEADING FOR CHILD, INSISTING  
THAT THEY WERE REALLY WIZARDS. ONE MAN HAD A BLEEDY BANDAGE OVER  
HIS EYE.

AS THEY SET OFF ALONG THE STREET, THE REGGARS GLIMPSED HERMIONE.  
THEY SEEMED TO MELT AWAY BEFORE HER, DRAWING HANDS OVER THEIR  
FACES AND FLEEING AS FAST AS THEY COULD. HERMIONE LOOKED AFTER THEM

CLIMBILY, UNTIL THE MAN WITH THE BLEEDING BANDAGE CAME STAGGER-  
ING RIGHT ACROSS HER PATH.

MY CHILDREN? HE BELLEED, POINTING AT HER. HIS VOICE WAS  
CRACKED, HIGH-PITCHED. HE SEEMED DISTRAUGHT. WHERE ARE MY CHIL-  
DREN? WHAT HAS HE DONE WITH THEM? WELL KNOWN, WELL KNOWN?

I I REALLY STAMMERED HERMIONE.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

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THE MAN LUNGED AT HER, REACHING FOR HER THROAT! THEN, WITH A BANG

AND A FLURRY OF RED LIGHT HE WAS THROWN BACKWARD INTO THE GROUND, LUNCHSTICKS, BEEN STOOD THERE, HIS HAND STILL HILTSTRETCHED AND A

HE STOOD VISIBLE BEHIND HIS BEARD, FACES APPEARED AT THE WINDOWS ON EITHER SIDE OF THE STREET, WHILE A LITTLE BUNCH OF PROSPERITY-SEEKING

PASSERSBY GATHERED THEIR BIKES AROUND THEM AND BROKE INTO GENTLE TREATS, BEEN THE VACATE THE SCENE.

THEIR ENTRANCE INTO DIAGON ALLEY COULD HARDLY HAVE BEEN MORE CONSPICUOUS; FOR A MOMENT F-JARRY WANDERED WHETHER IT MIGHT NOT BE BETTER TO LEAVE NOW AND TRY TO THINK OF A DIFFERENT PLAN. BEFORE THEY COULD MOVE FOR CONSULT ONE ANOTHER, HOWEVER, THEY HEARD A CRY

FROM BEHIND THEM.

WHY, MADAM LESTRANGE?

F-JARRY WHIRLED AROUND AND GRIP-HEED TIGHTENED HIS HAND AROUND F-JARRY'S NECK: A TALL, THIN WIZARD WITH A CREW OF BLISSY GRAY HAIR

AND A LONG, SHARP NOSE WAS STRIDING TOWARD THEM.

IT'S TRAVERS, HISSED THE GHELIN INTO F-JARRY'S EAR, BUT AT THAT



MENT HARRY COULD NOT THINK LIKE TRIVERS WAS. HERMIONE HAD  
DROWN

HERSELF UP THE HER FULLEST FRIGHT AND SAID WITH AS MUCH CONTEMPT  
AS

SHE COULD MUSTER:

AND WHAT DO YOU WANT?

TRIVERS STEPPED IN HIS TRACKS, CLEARLY APPREHENDED,

HE'S ANOTHER DEATH EATER? BREADED CRIPPLED, AND HARRY SIDED  
SIDELWAYS THE REPEAT THE INFORMATION INTO HERMIONE'S EAR,

I MERELY SUGGEST THE GREAT YOU, SAID TRIVERS CHEERLY, BUT IF MY  
PRESENCE IS NOT WELCOME ...

HARRY RECOGNIZED HIS VOICE NOW; TRIVERS WAS ONE OF THE DEATH-  
EATERS WHO HAD BEEN SUMMONED THE MURDERER'S HOUSE.

GRINGETTS

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NO, NO, NOT AT ALL, TRIVERS, SAID HERMIONE FLICKED, TRYING THE  
COVER UP HER MISTAKE. YOU ARE YOU?

WELL, I CONFESS I AM SURPRISED TO SEE YOU HERE AND ABOUT,  
BELLATRIX.

Really? Why? ASKED HERMIONE.

WELL, TRIVERS CHEERED, I HEARD THAT THE INHABITANTS OF MALFOY  
MANSION WERE CHAINED TO THE HOUSE, AFTER THE ... AH ... ESCAPE.  
HARRY WILLED HERMIONE TO KEEP HER HEAD, IF THIS WAS TRUE, AND

BELLATRIX WAS NOT SLIPPED THE EE HLT IN PUBLIC

THE DARK LORD FORGIVES THOSE WHO HAVE SERVED HIM MOST FAITH-  
FULLY IN THE PAST, SAID HERMIONE IN A MAGNIFICENT IMITATION OF  
REL-

LATRIX'S MOST CONTEMPTUOUS MANNER. PERHAPS YOUR CREDIT IS NOT  
AS

GOOD WITH HIM AS MINE IS, TRAVERS.

THOUGH THE DEATH RATER HAD HAPPEDED, HE ALSO SEEMED LESS  
SUSPICIOUS. HE GLANCED DOWN AT THE MAN WHO HAD JUST STUNNED.  
HOW DID IT HAPPEN YET?

IT DOES NOT MATTER, IT WILL NOT BE SHOWN AGAIN, SAID HERMIONE  
COLDLY.

SOME OF THESE WANDLESS CAN BE TRICKLESTHE, SAID TRAVERS.

WHILE THEY DO NOTHING BUT SEE I HAVE NO OBJECTION, BUT HOW OF  
THEM

ACTUALLY ASKED ME TO PLEAD HER CASE AT THE MINISTRY LAST WEEK. I'M  
A WITCH, SIR, I'M A WITCH, LET ME PROVE IT TO YOU! HE SAID IN A  
SHELLY

IMPERSONATION. AS IF I WAS GOING TO GIVE HER MY WAND BUT  
WHESE

WAND, SAID TRAVERS COLDLY, ARE YOU LISTING AT THE MOMENT, REL-  
LATRIX? I HEARD THAT YOUR HUSBAND WAS

I HAVE MY WAND HERE, SAID HERMIONE COLDLY, HOLDING UP BELLA-

TRICK S LAND. I DEEN T DENEEH WHAT RUMORS YELL HAVE BEEN LISTENING  
TEE,

TRAYERS, BUT YELL SEEM SADLY MISINFORMED.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

\*\*\*

TRAYERS SEEMED A LITTLE TAKEN ABACK AT THAT, AND HE TURNED INSTEAD  
THE REIN.

WHO IS YOUR FRIEND? I DEE NEET RECOGNIZE HIM.

THIS IS DRACHEMIR DESPARD, SAID HERMINE; THEY HAD DECIDED  
THAT A FICTIONAL FOREIGNER WAS THE SAFEST COVER FOR REIN THE ASSUME.

HE SPEAKS VERY LITTLE ENGLISH, BUT HE IS IN SYMPATHY WITH THE  
DARD

LEADS S AIMS. HE HAS TRAVELED HERE FROM TRANSYLVANIA TO SEE YOUR  
NEW  
REGIME.

INDEED? HOW DEE YELL DEE, DRACHEMIR?

HE YELL? SAID REIN, HOLDING UP HIS HAND.

TRAYERS EXTENDED TWO FINGERS AND SHOOK REIN S HAND AS THOUGH  
FRIGHTENED BY DIRTYING HIMSELF.

SEE WHAT BRINGS YELL AND YOUR A-SYMPATHETIC FRIEND THE  
DIAGEN ALLEY THIS EARLY? ASKED TRAYERS.

I NEED THE VISIT GRINGETTS, SAID HERMINE.

ALAS, I ALSO, SAID TRAYERS. CHILD, FILTHY CHILD! WE CANNOT LIVE

WITHHELT IT, YET I CONFESS I DEPIRE THE NECESSITY OF CONSORTING  
WITH

ELIX LONG-FINGERED FRIENDS,

HARRY FELT CRIPPLEHEAD'S CLASPED HANDS TIGHTEN MOMENTARILY  
AROUND

HIS NECK.

SHALL WE? SAID TRAVERS, GESTURING HERMIONE FORWARD.

HERMIONE HAD NO CHOICE BUT TO FALL INTO STEP BESIDE HIM AND HEAD

ALONG THE CROOKED, CROOKED STREET TOWARD THE PLACE WHERE THE  
SNEEZY-

WHITE CRINGETTS STOOD TINKERING OVER THE OTHER LITTLE SHEEPS. THEN

SLEPT ALONG BESIDE THEM, AND HARRY AND CRIPPLEHEAD FOLLOWED.

A WATCHFUL DEATH EATER WAS THE VERY LAST THING THEY NEEDED, AND  
THE WORST OF IT WAS, WITH TRAVERS MARCHING AT WHAT HE BELIEVED THE  
BE BELLATRIX'S SIDE, THERE WAS NO MEANS FOR HARRY TO COMMUNICATE  
WITH HERMIONE OR THEN. ALL THIS WHEN THEY ARRIVED AT THE FOOT OF  
THE

CRINGETTS

ST

MARBLE STEPS LEADING UP THE GREAT KITCHEN DOORS. AS CRIPPLEHEAD  
HAD

ALREADY WARNED THEM, THE LIVERIED GROOMS WHO USUALLY FLANKED THE  
ENTRANCE HAD BEEN REPLACED BY TWO WIZARDS, BOTH OF WHOM WERE

CLUTCHING LONG THIN CHILDEN REEDS,

AH, PRETTY PRETTY, SIGHED TRAVERS THEATRICALY, SHE COULDE  
BLIT

EFFECTIVE!

AND HE SET OFF UP THE STEPS, NODDING LEFT AND RIGHT TO THE WIZ-  
ARDS, WHO RAISED THE CHILDEN REEDS AND PASSED THEM UP AND DOWN HIS

BODY. THE PRETTY, HARRY KNEW, DETECTED SPELLS OF CHARMAMENT AND  
HIDDEN MAGICAL EFFECTS. KNOWING THAT HE HAD ONLY SECONDS, HARRY  
POINTED DRAGON S LAND AT EACH OF THE GUARDS IN TURN AND MURMURED,  
CHAMPLING TWICE. UNNOTICED BY TRAVERS, WHO WAS LEADING  
THROUGH

THE GREENE DOORS AT THE INNER HALL, EACH OF THE GUARDS GAVE A  
LITTLE

START AS THE SPELLS HIT THEM.

HERMIONE S LONG BLACK HAIR RIPPLED BEHIND HER AS SHE CLIMBED  
THE STEPS.

ONE MOMENT, MADAM, SAID THE GUARD, RAISING HIS PRETTY.

BUT WHY YE ILST DERE THAT? SAID HERMIONE IN BELLATRIX S COM-  
MANDING, ARROGANT VOICE. TRAVERS SMILED AWEILING, EYEBROWS RAISED.

THE GUARD WAS CHASTISED. HE STARED DOWN AT THE THIN CHILDEN PRETTY  
AND THEN AT HIS COMPANION, WHO SAID IN A SLIGHTLY DAZED VOICE,

YEAH, WHY YE ILST CHASTISED THEM, MARILIS.

HERMIONE SWIFT FORWARD, BEEN BY HER SIDE, HARRY AND GRIPPER  
TROTTERING INVISIBLY BEHIND THEM. HARRY GLANCED BACK AS THEY CROSSED

THE THRESHOLD! THE WIZARDS WERE BOTH SCRATCHING THEIR HEADS.  
TWO GHEKINS STOOD BEHIND THE INNER DOORS, WHICH WERE MADE OF  
SILVER AND WHICH CARRIED THE PERM WARNING OF DIRE RETRIBUTION THE  
POTENTIAL THIEVES. HARRY LOOKED UP AT IT, AND ALL OF A SUDDEN A  
KNIFE-  
SHARP MEMORY CAME TO HIM: STANDING HERE THIS VERY SPOT HERE THE DAY

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THAT HE HAD TURNED ELEVEN, THE MOST WONDERFUL BIRTHDAY OF HIS LIFE,  
AND HAGRID STANDING BESIDE HIM SAYING, LIKE I SAID, YOU'D BE MAD  
TO TRY AND DO IT. GRINGETTS HAD SEEMED A PLACE OF WONDER THAT  
DAY,

THE ENCHANTED REPOSITORIES OF A THIEF OF GOLD HE HAD NEVER KNOWN  
HE

POSSESSED, AND NEVER FOR AN INSTANT COULD HE HAVE DREAMED THAT HE  
WOULD RETURN THE STEAL. . . . BUT WITHIN SECONDS THEY WERE STANDING  
IN THE VAST MARBLE HALL OF THE BANK.

THE LONG CHURCH WAS MANNED BY GHEKINS SITTING ON HIGH SEATLS,  
SERVING THE FIRST CUSTOMERS OF THE DAY. HERMIONE, RON, AND  
TRAVERS

HEADED TOWARD AN OLD GHEKIN WHO WAS EXAMINING A THICK GOLD CHAIN  
THROUGH AN EYEGLASS. HERMIONE ALLOWED TRAVERS THE STEP AHEAD OF  
HER

ON THE PRETEXT OF EXPLAINING FEATURES OF THE HALL TO RON.

THE GEEKLIN THESSED THE CHIN HE WAS HOLDING ASIDE, SAID THE NERKEDY IN PARTICULAR, LEPRECHALIN, AND THEN GREETED TRAYERS, WHO PASSED EVER

A TINY CHILDEN KEY, WHICH WAS EXAMINED AND GIVEN BACK TO HIM.  
HERMINE STEPPED FORWARD.

MADAM LESTRANGE? SAID THE GEEKLIN, EVIDENTLY STARTLED, DEAR ME? HELLO HELLO MAY I HELP YOU TODAY?

I WISH TO ENTER MY WALLET, SAID HERMINE.

THE OLD GEEKLIN SEEMED TO RECHIN A LITTLE, HARRY GLANCED AROUND, NOT ONLY WAS TRAYERS HANGING BACK, WATCHING, BUT SEVERAL OTHER GEEKLINS HAD WHEEDED UP FROM THEIR WHEELS TO STARE AT HERMINE.

YOU HAVE . . . IDENTIFICATION? ASKED THE GEEKLIN.

IDENTIFICATION? I I HAVE NEVER BEEN ASKED FOR IDENTIFICATION BEFORE? SAID HERMINE.

THEY KNOW? WHISPERED GRINGEEDS IN HARRY'S EAR. THEY MUST HAVE

BEEN WARNED THERE MIGHT BE AN IMPESTER?

YOUR WAND WILL DIE, MADAM, SAID THE GEEKLIN, HE FELT HIS A SLIGHTLY TREMBLING HAND, AND IN A DREADFUL BLAST OF REALIZATION HARRY

GRINGEEDS

SR1

KNOW THAT THE GEEKLINS OF GRINGEEDS WERE AWARE THAT BELLATRIX'S WAND

HAD BEEN STEALING.

ACT NELL, ACT NELL, WHISPERED CRIPPLEHEAD IN HARRY'S EAR, THE IMPERILIS CLUSE?

HARRY RAISED THE FALTY-HORN WAND BENEATH THE CHAIR, POINTED IT AT THE OLD GHELIN, AND WHISPERED, FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE, IMPERILIS?

A CLIRIELIS SENSATION SEETH DOWN HARRY'S ARM, A FEELING OF TINGLING WARMTH THAT SEEMED TO FLEW FROM HIS MIND, DOWN THE SINELIS AND VEINS CONNECTING HIM TO THE WAND AND THE CLUSE IT HAD JUST CAST. THE

GHELIN THEN BELLATRIX'S WAND, EXAMINED IT CLOSER, AND THEN SAID, AH,

WELL HAVE HAD A NEW WAND MADE, MADAM LESTRANGE?

WHAT? SAID HERMIONE, NEH, NEH, THAT'S MINE

A NEW WAND? SAID TRAVERS, APPROACHING THE CHAIR AGAIN, STILL

THE GHELINS ALL AROUND WERE WATCHING. BUT HOW COULD WELL HAVE DONE, WHICH WANDMAKER DID WELL LIKE?

HARRY ACTED WITHOUT THINKING: POINTING HIS WAND AT TRAVERS, HE MUTTERED, IMPERILIS? HENCE MORE.

EH YES, I SEE, SAID TRAVERS, LEANING DOWN AT BELLATRIX'S WAND,

YES, VERY HANDSOME. AND IS IT WORKING WELL? I ALWAYS THINK WANDS REQUIRE A LITTLE BREAKING IN, DON'T THEY?

HERMIONE LOOKED LITTERLY BEMUSED, BUT THE HARRY'S ENORMOUS RELIEF SHE ACCEPTED THE BIZARRE TURN OF EVENTS WITHOUT COMMENT.

THE OLD GHELIN BEHIND THE CHAIR CLAPPED HIS HANDS AND A YOUNGER GHELIN APPROACHED.



I SHALL NEED THE CLANKERS, HE TOLD THE GHEKIN, WHO DASHED AWAY  
AND RETURNED A MOMENT LATER WITH A LEATHER BAG THAT SEEMED TO BE  
FULL OF JINGLING METAL, WHICH HE HANDED TO HIS SENIOR. GHEED, GHEED!  
SEE, IF YOU WILL PLEASE ME, MADAM LESTRANGE, SAID THE OLD GHEKIN,

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SEE

HIPPING DOWN OFF HIS STEEL AND VANISHING FROM SIGHT, I SHALL  
TAKE

YOU THE OTHER VALIET.

HE APPEARED AROUND THE END OF THE CHLINTER, JIGGING HAPPILY TOWARD  
THEM, THE CONTENTS OF THE LEATHER BAG STILL JINGLING. TRAVERS

WAS NOW STANDING BLITZ STILL WITH HIS MOUTH HANGING WIDE OPEN.  
HEEN WAS DRAWING ATTENTION TO THIS AND PERCEIVING BY REGARDING  
TRAVERS WITH CONFLUSION.

WAIT RECHRED!

ANOTHER GHEKIN CAME SLURPING AROUND THE CHLINTER.

WE HAVE INSTRUCTIONS, HE SAID WITH A ROLL OF THE TONGUE. PEE-  
GIVE ME, MADAM, BUT THERE HAVE BEEN SPECIAL ORDERS REGARDING THE

VALIET OF LESTRANGE.

HE WHISPERED URGENTLY IN RECHRED'S EAR, BUT THE IMPERILISED GHEKIN

SEEMED HIMSELF,

I AM AWARE OF THE INSTRUCTIONS, MADAM LESTRANGE WISHES TO VISIT HER VAULT, . . . VERY OLD FAMILY . . . OLD CLIENTS . . . THIS WAY, PLEASE . . .

AND, STILL CLANKING, HE FLURRIED TOWARD ONE OF THE MANY DOORS LEADING OFF THE HALL. HARRY LOOKED BACK AT TRAVERS, WHO WAS STILL

REHEATED THE THE SPOT LOOKING ABNORMALLY VACANT, AND MADE HIS DECISION: WITH A FLICK OF HIS HAND HE MADE TRAVERS COME WITH THEM,

WALKING MEEDLY IN THEIR WAKE AS THEY REACHED THE DOOR AND PASSED

INTO THE NEIGH STONE PASSAGELAY BEYOND, WHICH WAS LIT WITH FLAMING TORCHES.

WE'RE IN TROUBLE; THEY SUSPECT, SAID HARRY AS THE DOOR SLAMMED BEHIND THEM AND HE PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. CRIPPLED HIMSELF ILMPED DOWN FROM HIS SHOULDERS; NEITHER TRAVERS NOR KEGRED SHOWED THE SLIGHTEST SURPRISE AT THE SUDDEN APPEARANCE OF HARRY PUTTER IN THEIR MIDST. THEY'RE IMPERILED, HE ADDED, IN RESPONSE

CRINGETTS

XXX

THE HERMIONIC AND REIN S CONVLISED HILKIES ABELT TRAVERS AND KEGRED,

WHICH WERE BOTH NOW STANDING THERE LOOKING BLANK. I DIDN'T THINK  
I

DID IT STRONGLY ENOUGH, I DIDN'T KNOW, . . .

AND ANOTHER MEMORY DARTED THROUGH HIS MIND, OF THE REAL BEL-  
LATRIK LESTRANGE SMILING AT HIM WHEN HE HAD FIRST TRIED THE LISP  
AND

UNINTENTIONAL CURSE: YOU NEED THE MEAN THEM, BETTER?

WHAT DO WE DO? ASKED REIN. SHALL WE GET HIT NOW, WHILE WE  
CAN?

IF WE CAN, SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING BACK TOWARD THE DEER IN THE  
THE MAIN HALL, BEYOND WHICH THEY KNEW WHAT WAS HAPPENING.

WE'VE GOT THIS FAR, I SAY WE GO ON, SAID HARRY.

GOOD! SAID CRUPPE. SEE, WE NEED REGRIND THE CENTRAL THE CART;  
I NO LONGER HAVE THE AUTHORITY, BUT THERE WILL NOT BE ROOM FOR  
THE

WIZARD.

HARRY POINTED HIS HAND AT TRAVERS.

IMPERIO!

THE WIZARD TURNED AND SET OFF ALONG THE DARK TRACK AT A SMART  
PACE.

WHAT ARE YOU MAKING HIM DO?

HIDE, SAID HARRY AS HE POINTED HIS HAND AT REGRIND, WHICH  
WHISTLED THE SLIMEST A LITTLE CART THAT CAME TRUNDLING ALONG THE  
TRACKS TOWARD THEM OUT OF THE DARKNESS. HARRY WAS SURE HE COULD  
HEAR SHOUTING BEHIND THEM IN THE MAIN HALL AS THEY ALL CLAMORED

INTO IT, BEHIND IN FRONT WITH GRIP-HHHH, HARRY, RON, AND  
HERMION

CRAMPED TOGETHER IN THE BACK.

WITH A LEAP THE CART MOVED OFF, GATHERING SPEED! THEY FLUTTERED  
PAST TRAYERS, WHO WAS WRIGGLING INTO A CRACK IN THE WALL, THEN  
THE

CART BEGAN TWISTING AND TURNING THROUGH THE LABYRINTHINE  
PASSAGES,

SLEEPING DOWNWARD ALL THE TIME. HARRY COULD NOT HEAR ANYTHING  
EVER

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THE RATTLING OF THE CART ON THE TRACKS! HIS HAIR FLEW BEHIND HIM  
AS

THEY SLURVED BETWEEN STALACTITES, FLYING EVER DEEPER INTO THE EARTH,  
BUT HE KEPT GLANCING BACK. THEY MIGHT AS WELL HAVE LEFT ENORMOUS  
FOOTPRINTS BEHIND THEM! THE MORE HE THOUGHT ABOUT IT, THE MORE  
FOOLISH IT SEEMED THEY HAD DISGUISED HERMION AS BELLATRIX, THEY HAD  
BRIGHTENED BELLATRIX'S NAME, WHEN THE DEATH EATERS KNEW WHO  
HAD STOLEN IT

THEY WERE DEEPER THAN HARRY HAD EVER PENETRATED WITHIN GRIN-  
GUTTS! THEY HEARD A HAIRPIN BEND AT SPEED AND SAW AHEAD OF THEM,  
WITH

SECONDS THE SPARK, A WATERFALL PHUDDING OVER THE TRACK. HARRY  
HEARD

CRIPPLED SILENT, BUT THERE WAS NO BRADING. THEY ZHEMED  
THROUGH IT. WATER FILLED HARRY'S EYES AND MOUTH. HE COULD NOT SEE  
HER BREATH. THEN, WITH AN AWFUL LURCH, THE CART FLIPPED OVER AND  
THEY

WERE ALL THROWN OUT OF IT. HARRY HEARD THE CART SMASH INTO PIECES  
AGAINST THE PASSAGE WALL, HEARD HERMIONE SHRIEK SOMETHING, AND  
FELT

HIMSELF GLIDE BACK TOWARD THE GROUND AS THOUGH WEIGHTLESS,  
LANDING

PAINLESSLY IN THE ROCKY PASSAGE FLOOR.

CLUSTERING CLAM, HERMIONE SPLUTTERED, AS RON PULLED HER

THE HER FEET, BUT THE HARRY'S FURROW HE SAW THAT SHE WAS NO LONGER  
KELLA-

TRIX. INSTEAD SHE STOOD THERE IN OVERLARGE SHOES, SHEDDING WET AND  
CHM-

PLETLY HERSELF. RON WAS RED-HAIRED AND BEARLESS AGAIN. THEY WERE

REALIZING IT AS THEY LEERED AT EACH OTHER, FEELING THEIR BLIND FACES.

THE THIEF'S DEEPFALL! SAID CRIPPLED, CLANKING THE HIS FEET  
AND LEERED BACK AT THE DELUGE BENTH THE TRACKS, WHICH HARRY  
KNEW

NEED, HAD BEEN MORE THAN WATER. IT WASHES AWAY ALL ENCHANTMENT,

ALL MAGICAL ENCHANTMENT. THEY KNEW THERE ARE IMPESTERS IN GRIN-  
GETTS, THEY HAVE SET UP DEFENSES AGAINST US.

HARRY SAW HERMIONE CHECKING THAT SHE STILL HAD THE LEADED BAG,  
AND HURRIEDLY THrust HIS LEFT HAND UNDER HIS JACKET TO MAKE SURE  
HE

GRINGETTS

SEE

HAD NOT LEST THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. THEN HE TURNED TO SEE REGARD  
SHAKING HIS HEAD IN BEMUDERMENT! THE THREE S DOWNFALL SEEMED TO  
HAVE LIFTED THE IMPERILS CURSE.

WE NEED HIM, SAID CRIPPLEHEAD, WE CANNOT ENTER THE VAULT WITH-  
OUT A GRINGETTS CUCKLIN, AND WE NEED THE CLANDERS!

IMPERIUS! HARRY SAID AGAIN! HIS VOICE ECHOED THROUGH THE STONE  
PASSAGE AS HE FELT AGAIN THE SENSE OF HEADY CONFUSION THAT FLEWED  
FROM

BRAIN THE WAND, REGARD SLURMITTED SINCE MORE TO HIS WILL, HIS RE-  
FLEDED EXPRESSION CHANGING THE ONE OF POLITE INDIFFERENCE, AS WHEN

HURRIED TO PICK UP THE LEATHER BAG OF METAL THINGS.

HARRY, I THINK I CAN HEAR PEOPLE CHIMING! SAID HERMIONE, AND  
SHE POINTED BELLATRIX S WAND AT THE WATERFALL AND CRIED, PROTECTOR!  
THEY SAW THE SHIELD CHARM BREAK THE FLOW OF ENCHANTED WATER AS  
IT

FLOW UP THE PASSAGEWAY.

CEASED THINKING, SAID HARRY, LEAD THE WAY, CRIPPLEHEAD!

HOW ARE WE GOING TO GET OUT AGAIN? WHEN ASKED AS THEY HURRIED  
DOWN THE STAIRS INTO THE DARKNESS AFTER THE GHEULIN, REEGRAD PARTING IN  
THEIR

WALKED LIKE AN ELD BEG.

LET'S WHISPER ABOUT THAT WHEN WE HAVE THEM, SAID HARRY, HE WAS  
TRYING TO LISTEN! HE THOUGHT HE COULD HEAR SOMETHING CLANKING  
AND

MOVING ABOUT NEARBY, CRIPPLEHEAD, HOW MUCH FARTHER?

NOT FAR, HARRY BETTER, NOT FAR . . .

AND THEY TURNED A CORNER AND SAW THE THING FOR WHICH HARRY HAD  
BEEN PREPARED, BUT WHICH STILL BRIGHTENED ALL OF THEM TO A HALT.

A GIGANTIC DRAGON WAS TETHERED TO THE GHEULIN IN FRONT OF THEM,  
BARRING ACCESS TO THE FLOOR FOR FIVE OF THE DEEPEST VAULTS IN THE PLACE.  
THE

BEAST'S SCALES HAD TURNED PALE AND FLAKY DURING ITS LONG INCARCERA-  
TION UNDER THE GHEULIN; ITS EYES WERE MILKILY PINK; BOTH REAR LEGS

WERE HEAVY CLIPS FROM WHICH CHAINS LED TO ENORMOUS PEGS DRIVEN

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

SEE

DEEP INTO THE REDDY FLESH, ITS GREAT SPIKED WINGS, FOLDED CLOSE TO  
ITS

BODY, WOULD HAVE FILLED THE CHAMBER IF IT SPREAD THEM, AND WHEN IT

TURNED ITS LELY HEAD TOWARD THEM, IT REARED WITH A NOISE THAT MADE THE ROCK TREMBLE, OPENED ITS MOUTH, AND SPAT A LOT OF FIRE THAT SENT THEM RUNNING BACK UP THE PASSAGEWAY.

IT IS PARTIALLY BLIND, PANTED GRIFFIN, BUT EVEN MORE SAVAGE FOR THAT, HOWEVER, WE HAVE THE MEANS TO CONTROL IT. IT HAS LEARNED WHAT TO EXPECT WHEN THE CLANKERS COME. GIVE THEM THE ME.

REIN PASSED THE BAG TO GRIFFIN, AND THE GIBLIN PULLED OUT A NUMBER OF SMALL METAL INSTRUMENTS THAT WHEN SHAKEN MADE A LULL, RINGING NOISE LIKE MINIATURE HAMMERS ON ANVILS. GRIFFIN HANDED

THEM OUT: REINHOLD ACCEPTED HIS MEEDLY.

YELL DOWN WHAT TO DO, GRIFFIN TOLD HARRY, REIN, AND HERMINE. IT WILL EXPECT PAIN WHEN IT HEARS THE NOISE: IT WILL RETREAT, AND

REINHOLD MUST PLACE HIS PALM UPON THE OTHER OF THE VALVE.

THEY ADVANCED AROUND THE CORNER AGAIN, SHAKING THE CLANKERS, AND THE NOISE ECHOED OFF THE ROCKY WALLS, GROSSLY MAGNIFIED, SO THAT

THE INSIDE OF HARRY'S SKULL SEEMED TO VIBRATE WITH THE DIN. THE DRAGON LET OUT ANOTHER HARSH ROAR, THEN RETREATED, HARRY COULD SEE

IT TREMBLING, AND AS THEY DREW NEARER HE SAW THE STARS MADE BY VIBRANT SLASHES ACROSS ITS FACE, AND GUESSED THAT IT HAD BEEN TALKING TO



FEAR HIT SWORDS WHEN IT HEARD THE SOUND OF THE CLANKERS.

MAKE HIM PRESS HIS HAND TO THE DOOR? CRIPPLED LINED HARRY,  
WHEN TURNED HIS HAND AGAIN UPON REED, THE OLD GELIN MOVED,  
PRESSING HIS PALM TO THE WOOD, AND THE DOOR OF THE VAULT MELTED  
AWAY

THE REVEAL A CAVE-LIKE OPENING CRAMPED FROM ABOVE THE CEILING WITH  
GOLDEN CHAINS AND CHAINS, SILVER ARMOR, THE SKINS OF STRANGE  
CREATURES

SOME WITH LONG SPINES, OTHERS WITH DRIPPING WINGS  
PETHENS

IN JEWELLED GLASSES, AND A SKULL STILL WEARING A CROWN.

CRINGETTS

SEE

SEARCH, FAST? SAID HARRY AS THEY ALL HURRIED INSIDE THE VAULT.  
HE HAD DESCRIBED CRIPPLED'S CLIP THE DOOR AND HERMINE, BUT IF  
IT WAS THE OTHER, LINDENHILL HERSELF THAT RESIDED IN THIS VAULT, HE  
DID

NOT KNOW WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE. HE RARELY HAD TIME TO GLANCE  
AROUND,

HOWEVER, BEFORE THERE WAS A MUFFLED CLUNK FROM BEHIND THEM: THE  
DOOR HAD REAPPEARED, SEALING THEM INSIDE THE VAULT, AND THEY WERE  
PULGED INTO TOTAL DARKNESS.

NO MATTER, REED WILL BE ABLE TO RELEASE US? SAID CRIPPLED AS  
REED GAVE A SMILE OF SURPRISE. LIGHT YOUR HANDS, CAN'T YOU? AND  
HARRY, WE HAVE VERY LITTLE TIME?

CLIMBS!

HARRY STROKE HIS LIT WAND AROUND THE VALVE: ITS BEAM FELL UPON GLITTERING JEWELS: HE SAW THE PINK SWORD OF GRYPFINDER LYING ON A HIGH SHELF AMONGST A JUMBLE OF CHAINS. REEN AND HERMIONE HAD LIT THEIR WANDS TOO, AND WERE NOW EXAMINING THE PILES OF BRICKS SURROUNDING THEM.

HARRY, COULD THIS BE ? AARGH!

HERMIONE SCREAMED IN PAIN, AND HARRY TURNED HIS WAND ON HER IN TIME TO SEE A JEWELLED CHALET TUMBLING FROM HER GRIP, BUT AS IT FELL,

IT SPLIT, BECAME A SHOWER OF CHALETs, SEE THAT A SECOND LATER, WITH A GREAT CLATTER, THE FLOOR WAS COVERED IN IDENTICAL CLIPS ROLLING IN EVERY

DIRECTION, THE ORIGINAL IMPOSSIBLE TO DISCERN AMONGST THEM.

IT CLANGED ME! MEANED HERMIONE, SLICKING HER BLISTERED FINGERS.

THEY HAVE ADDED GEMINE AND FLAGRANT CLIPs! SAID GRYPHINDER.

EVERYTHING WILL THICKEN WILL CLANG AND MULTIPLY, BUT THE CLIPS ARE WORTHLESS AND IF YOU CONTINUE TO HANDLE THE TREASURE, YOU WILL EVENTUALLY BE CRUSHED TO DEATH BY THE WEIGHT OF EXPANDING CHALETs!

HEY, DON'T THINK ANYTHING! SAID HARRY DESPERATELY, BUT EVEN AS

HE SAID IT, REEN ACCIDENTALLY NUDGED ONE OF THE FALLEN CHALETs WITH HIS

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FEET, AND TWENTY MORE EXPLODED INTO KING WHILE RON HOPPED ON THE

SPOT, PART OF HIS SKIN SLID AWAY BY CONTACT WITH THE HOT METAL.

STAND STILL, DON'T MOVE! SAID HERMION, CLUTCHING AT RON.

JUST BEHIND AHEAD! SAID HARRY. REMEMBER, THE CLIP IS SMALL AND  
CHILD, IT IS SET A BADGER ENGRAVED ON IT, TWO HANDLES OTHERWISE SEE  
IF YOU CAN SPOT RAVENCLAW'S SYMBOL ANYWHERE, THE EAGLE

THEY DIRECTED THEIR HANDS INTO EVERY NOOK AND CRVICE, TURNING  
CAUTIOUSLY ON THE SPOT. IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE NOT TO BRUSH UP AGAINST  
ANYTHING; HARRY SENT A GREAT CASCADE OF PAPER GALLEONS INTO THE  
GRILLING WHERE THEY HUNG THE CHIBLITS, AND NOW THERE WAS SCARCELY  
ROOM FOR THEIR FEET, AND THE GLOWING CHILD BLAZED WITH HEAT,  
SO THAT THE WALLS FELT LIKE A FURNACE. HARRY'S HANDLIGHT PASSED  
OVER

SHIELDS AND GRIFFIN-MADE HELMETS SET ON SHELVES RISING TO THE  
CEILING;

HIGHER AND HIGHER HE RAISED THE BEAM, UNTIL SUDDENLY IT FOUND AN  
OBJECT THAT MADE HIS HEART SKIP AND HIS HAND TREMBLE.

IT IS THERE, IT IS UP THERE!

RON AND HERMION POINTED THEIR HANDS AT IT THEN, SO THAT THE  
LITTLE

GOLDEN CLIP SPARKLED IN A THREE-WAY SPOTLIGHT: THE CLIP THAT HAD  
BE-

LONGED THE FLEA FLOPPY, WHICH HAD PASSED INTO THE POSSESSION  
OF

HERPZIRAH SMITH, FROM WHICH IT HAD BEEN STEALEN BY THEM RIDDLE.

AND WHEN THE FELL ARE WE GOING TO GET UP THERE WITHOUT  
THINKING

ANYTHING? ASKED REEN.

ACHEE CLIP? CRIED HERMIONE, WHO HAD EVIDENTLY FORGOTTEN IN HER  
DESPERATION WHAT GRIP-THUD HAD TOLD THEM DURING THEIR PLANNING  
SESSIONS.

NEE LEE, NEE LEE? SNARLED THE GHEKIN.

THEN WHAT DO WE DO? SAID HARRY, GLARING AT THE GHEKIN. IF YOU  
WANT THE SWORD, GRIP-THUD, THEN YOU WILL HAVE THE HELP OF MORE  
THAN

WAIT! CAN I THINK STUFF WITH THE SWORD? HERMIONE, GIVE IT HERE!

GRINGEYTT'S

SKY

HERMIONE FUMLED INSIDE HER REEKS, DREW OUT THE BEADED BAG,

FLUMMAGED FOR A FEW SECONDS, THEN REMOVED THE SHINING SWORD.

HARRY SEIZED IT BY ITS RUSTY HILT AND THICKED THE TIP OF THE BLADE  
THE

A SILVER FLASHIN NEARBY, WHICH DID NOT MULTIPLY.

IF I CAN JUST PEEK THE SWORD THROUGH A HANDLE BUT WHEN AM I  
GOING TO GET UP THERE?

THE SHIP MEN WHICH THE CLIP REPESED WAS OUT OF REACH FOR ANY  
OF THEM, EVEN REEN, WHO WAS TALLEST. THE HEAT FROM THE ENCHANTED  
TREASURE RESE IN WAVES, AND SWEAT RAN DOWN HARRY'S FACE AND BACK

AS HE STRUGGLED THE THING OF A WAY UP THE TREE CLIP, AND THEN HE  
HEARD

THE DRAGON REAR END THE EITHER SIDE OF THE VALLEY DEER, AND THE  
SHLIND

HE CLANKING GROWING BEHOLD AND BEHOLD.

THEY WERE TRULY TRAPPED NOW! THERE WAS NO WAY OUT EXCEPT

THROUGH THE DEER, AND A HERD OF GELINS SEEMED TO BE APPROACH-  
ING FROM THE EITHER SIDE. HARRY LOOKED AT RON AND HERMION AND SAW

TERROR IN THEIR FACES.

HERMION, SAID HARRY AS THE CLANKING GROW BEHOLD, I VE GOT TO  
GET UP THERE, WE VE GOT TO GET RID OF IT

SHE RAISED HER WAND, POINTED IT AT HARRY, AND WHISPERED, LEVI-  
CORPUS.

HELISTED INTO THE AIR BY HIS ANKLE, HARRY HIT A SLIT OF ARMOR AND  
REPLICAS FIRST HIT OF IT LIKE WHITE-FEET BODIES, FILLING THE CRAMPED  
SPACE. WITH SCREAMS OF PAIN RON, HERMION, AND THE TWO GELINS  
WERE BOUNDED ASIDE INTO EITHER BRICKS, WHICH ALSO BEGAN THE  
REPLICATE.

HAVE BURIED IN A RISING TIDE OF RED-FEET TREASURE, THEY STRUGGLED AND  
YELLED AS HARRY THROST THE SWORD THROUGH THE HANDLE OF  
FLAPFLAP S

CLIP, PUNCHING IT INTO THE BLADE.

IMPERVIOUS! SCREAMED HERMION IN AN ATTEMPT TO PROTECT  
HERSELF,

DOWN, AND THE GRIFFIN FROM THE CLIPPING METAL.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

THE

THEN THE WHEIST SCREAM YET MADE HARRY WHIRL DOWN! DOWN AND HER-  
MIONE WERE WAIST-DEEP IN TREASURE, STRUGGLING THE DEEP BEHIND  
FROM

SLIPPING BENEATH THE RISING TIDE, BUT GRIFFIN HAD SLUNK OUT OF  
SIGHT

AND NOTHING BUT THE TIPS OF A FEW LONG FINGERS WERE LEFT IN VIEW.  
HARRY SEIZED GRIFFIN'S FINGERS AND PULLED. THE BLISTERED GRIFFIN  
EMERGED BY DEGREES, HEAVING.

LIBERACHPUS! YELLED HARRY, AND WITH A CRASH HE AND GRIFFIN  
LANDED IN THE SURFACE OF THE SWELLING TREASURE, AND THE SWORD FLEW  
OUT OF HARRY'S HAND.

GET IT! HARRY YELLED, FIGHTING THE PAIN OF THE HEAT METAL IN HIS  
SKIN, AS GRIFFIN CLAMBERED UPON HIS SHOULDERS AGAIN, DETERMINED  
TO AVOID THE SWELLING MASS OF RED-HEAT BRICKS. WHERE'S THE SWORD?  
IT HAD THE CLIP IN IT!

THE CLANKING ON THE EITHER SIDE OF THE DEER WAS GROWING DEAFEN-  
ING IT WAS THEN LATE

THERE!

IT WAS CRIPPLEHEAD WHO HAD SEEN IT AND CRIPPLEHEAD WHO LINGERED, AND IN THAT INSTANT HARRY KNEW THAT THE GHEKIN HAD NEVER EXPECTED THEM

THEY KEPT THEIR WORD, ONE HAND HOLDING TIGHTLY THE A PISTOL OF HARRY'S

HAIR, THE OTHER SURE HE DID NOT FALL INTO THE HEAVING SEA OF BURNING GOLD, CRIPPLEHEAD SEIZED THE HILT OF THE SWORD AND SWUNG IT HIGH JUST OF HARRY'S REACH.

THE TINY CHILDEN CLIP, DISLOVERED BY THE HANDLE AND THE SWORD'S BLADE, WAS FALLING INTO THE AIR. THE GHEKIN STILL ASTRIDE HIM, HARRY DIVED AND

CATCHED IT, AND ALTHOUGH HE COULD FEEL IT SCALDING HIS FLESH HE DID NOT

RELINQUISH IT, EVEN WHILE UNCEASING FLAPFLAP CLIPS BURST FROM HIS

FIST, RAINING DOWN UPON HIM AS THE ENTRANCE OF THE VAULT OPENED UP

AGAIN AND HE FELT HIMSELF SLIDING UNCONTROLLABLY IN AN EXPANDING

CRINGETTS

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AVAILANCE OF FIERY GOLD AND SILVER THAT KNEW HIM, KNEW, AND DETERMINE

INTO THE HILTER CHAMBER.

HARDLY AWARE OF THE PAIN FROM THE BURNS COVERING HIS BODY, AND

STILL KEEPER ALONG HIM THE SWELL OF REPLICATING TREASURE, HARRY  
SHIVED

THE CLIP INTO HIS POCKET AND REACHED UP TO RETRIEVE THE SWORD, BUT  
CRIPPLED WAS GONE, SLIDING FROM HARRY'S SHOULDERS THE MOMENT  
HE

HELD, HE HAD SPRINTED FOR COVER AMONGST THE SLURRLING  
GIRLINS,

BRANDISHING THE SWORD AND CRYING, THIEVES! THIEVES! HELP!  
THIEVES!

HE VANISHED INTO THE MIST OF THE ADVANCING CREED, ALL OF WHOM  
WERE HOLDING DAGGERS AND WERE ALERTED HIM WITHOUT DELAY.  
SLIPPING ON THE HOT METAL, HARRY STRUGGLED TO HIS FEET AND KNEW  
THAT THE ONLY WAY OUT WAS THROUGH.

STUPID! HE BELIEVED, AND BEN AND HERMIONE THOUGHT IN: LETS  
HE RED LIGHT FLEW INTO THE CREED OF GIRLINS, AND SOME THOUGHT EVER,  
BUT OTHERS ADVANCED, AND HARRY SAW SEVERAL WIZARD GUARDS  
RUNNING

AROUND THE CORNER.

THE TETHERED DRAGON LET OUT A ROAR, AND A GLISH OF FLAME FLEW OVER  
THE GIRLINS! THE WIZARDS FLED, DUCKED-LIP, BACK THE WAY THEY HAD  
CAME, AND INSPIRATION, HIS MADNESS, CAME TO HARRY, POINTING HIS  
WAND AT THE THICK CLIFFS CHAINING THE BEAST TO THE FLOOR, HE YELLED,  
RELEASE!

THE CLIFFS BROKE OPEN WITH LUDIC RAGES.

THIS WAY! HARRY YELLED, AND STILL SHOOTING STUNNING SPELLS AT  
THE ADVANCING GIRLINS, HE SPRINTED TOWARD THE BLIND DRAGON.

HARRY HARRY WHAT ARE YOU DOING? CRIED HERMIONE.

GET UP, CLIMB UP, COME ON



THE DRAGON HAD NOT REALIZED THAT IT WAS FREE! HARRY'S FEET FELT THE CRACK OF ITS HIND LEG AND HE PULLED HIMSELF UP BENTH ITS BACK,

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

542

THE SCALES WERE HARD AS STEEL; IT DID NOT EVEN SEEM TO FEEL HIM. HE STRETCHED OUT AN ARM; HERMIONE HUNGLED HERSELF UP; RON CLIMBED ON BEHIND THEM, AND A SECOND LATER THE DRAGON BECAME AWARE THAT IT WAS UNTETHERED.

WITH A REAR IT REARED; HARRY DUG IN HIS KNEES, CLUTCHING AS TIGHTLY

AS HE COULD TO THE JAGGED SCALES AS THE WINGS SPUN, KICKING THE SPARKING GEBLINS ASIDE LIKE SKITTLES, AND IT SPUN INTO THE AIR, HARRY,

RON, AND HERMIONE, FLAT ON ITS BACK, SCRAPED AGAINST THE CEILING AS IT DIVED TOWARD THE PASSAGE OPENING, WHILE THE PURSUING GEBLINS FLUNG DAGGERS THAT GLANCED OFF ITS PLATES.

WE LL NEVER GET OUT, IT'S THEE RIG! HERMIONE SCREAMED, BUT THE DRAGON OPENED ITS MOUTH AND BELCHED FLAME AGAIN, BLASTING THE TUNNEL, WHERE FLIERS AND CEILING CRACKED AND CRUMPLED. BY THEE THE DRAGON CLAWED AND FLIGHT ITS WAY THROUGH. HARRY'S EYES

WERE SHUT TIGHT AGAINST THE HEAT AND BLIST; DEAFENED BY THE CRASHING OF ROCK AND THE DRAGON'S REARS, HE COULD ONLY CLING TO ITS BACK,

EXPECTING THEM TO SHAKEN OFF AT ANY MOMENT; THEN HE HEARD  
TERMINAL

YELLING, DEADEND!

SHE WAS HELPING THE DRAGON ENLARGE THE PASSAGEWAY, CARVING AWAY  
THE CEILING AS IT STRUGGLED UPWARD TOWARD THE FRESHER AIR, AWAY  
FROM

THE SHRIEKING AND CLANKING GHEKINS; HARRY AND RON HELPED HER,  
BLASTING THE CEILING APART WITH MORE GELICING SPELLS. THEY PASSED  
THE

LINGERING LARK, AND THE GREAT CRAWLING, SNARLING BEAST SEEMED  
THE

SENSE FREEDOM AND SPACE AHEAD OF IT, AND BEHIND THEM THE PASSAGE  
WAS FULL OF THE DRAGON'S THRASHING, SPIKED TAIL, OF GREAT LUMPS OF  
ROCK, GIGANTIC FRACTURED STALACTITES, AND THE CLANKING OF THE  
GHEKINS

SEEMED TO BE GROWING MORE MUFFLED, WHILE AHEAD, THE DRAGON'S FIRE  
KEPT THEIR PROGRESS CLEAR

GRINGETTS

THE

AND THEN AT LAST, BY THE COMBINED FORCE OF THEIR SPELLS AND THE  
DRAGON'S BRUTE STRENGTH, THEY HAD BLASTED THEIR WAY AWAY FROM THE  
PASSAGE

INTO THE MARBLE HALLWAY, GHEKINS AND WIZARDS SHRIEKED AND RAN FOR  
COVER, AND FINALLY THE DRAGON HAD THEM THE STRETCH ITS WINGS!  
TURNING

ITS HORNED HEAD TOWARD THE COLD OUTSIDE AIR IT COULD SMELL BEYOND

THE ENTRANCE, IT THREW HIM, AND WITH HARRY, REN, AND HERMIONE STILL

CLINGING TO ITS BACK, IT FORCED ITS WAY THROUGH THE METAL DOORS,  
LEAVING

THEY CLIMBED AND HANGING FROM THEIR HINGES, AS IT STAGGERED

INTO DIAGEN ALLEY AND LAUNCHED ITSELF INTO THE SKY,

## CHAPTER TWENTY - SEVEN

\*\*\*

THE FINAL

HIDING PLACE

THERE WAS NO MEANS OF STEERING; THE DRAGON COULD NOT SEE WHERE  
IT WAS GOING, AND HARRY KNEW THAT IF IT TURNED SHARPLY HER WHEELS  
IN MIDAIR THEY WOULD FIND IT IMPOSSIBLE TO CLING ONTO ITS BREAST  
BACK,

NEVERTHELESS, AS THEY CLIMBED HIGHER AND HIGHER, LONDON  
UNFURLING

BELOW THEM LIKE A GRAY-AND-GREEN MAP, HARRY'S OVERWHELMING  
FEELING

WAS OF GRATITUDE FOR AN ESCAPE THAT HAD SEEMED IMPOSSIBLE,  
RELIEFING

HOWEVER THE BEAST'S NEED, HE CLUNG TIGHT TO THE METALLIC SCALES,  
AND

THE CHILL BREEZE WAS SHEETING HIM HIS CLANKED AND KLISTERED SKIN, THE  
DRAGON'S WINGS BEATING THE AIR LIKE THE SAILS OF A WINDMILL, BEHIND  
HIM,

WHETHER THEY DELIGHT OR FEAR HE COULD NOT TELL, RON KEPT SWEARING AT

THE TOP OF HIS VEIL, AND HERMIONE SEEMED TO BE SHAKING,

AFTER FIVE MINUTES HE SAW HARRY LEIST SOME OF HIS IMMEDIATE DREAD THAT THE DRAGON WAS GOING TO THROW THEM OFF, AND IT SEEMED INTENT ON NOTHING BUT GETTING AS FAR AWAY FROM ITS UNDERGROUND PRISON

AS POSSIBLE; BUT THE ELDEST OF THEM AND WHEN THEY WERE THE DIS-  
MOUNT REMAINED RATHER FRIGHTENING, HE HAD NO IDEA HOW LONG

T

THE FINAL HIDING PLACE

545

DRAGON'S COULD FLY WITHOUT LANDING, AND HOW THIS PARTICULAR DRAGON,

WHICH COULD BARELY SEE, WOULD LOCATE A GOOD PLACE TO PUT THEM, HE GLANCED AROUND CONSTANTLY, IMAGINING THAT HE COULD FEEL HIS SCAR PRICKLING, . . .

HOW LONG WOULD IT BE BEFORE VOLDEMORT KNEW THAT THEY HAD BROKEN INTO THE LESTRANGES' VAULT? HOW SOON WOULD THE GRIFFINDORS

GRINGOTTS NOTIFY BELLATRIX? HOW SOON WOULD THEY REALIZE WHAT HAD BEEN TAKEN? AND THEN, WHEN THEY DISCOVERED THAT THE CHILDEN CLIP WAS MISSING? VOLDEMORT WOULD KNOW, AT LAST, THAT THEY WERE HUNTING HERCULES, . . .

THE DRAGON SEEMED THE CRAVE COLDER AND FRESHER AIR! IT CLIMBED STEADILY UNTIL THEY WERE FLYING THROUGH WISPS OF CHILLY CLOUD, AND HARRY COULD NO LONGER MAKE OUT THE LITTLE CHERUBED DEETS WHICH WERE CARS PHLEWING IN AND OUT OF THE CAPITAL. THEN AND THEN THEY FLEW, EVER COUNTRYSIDE PARCELED OUT IN PATCHES OF GREEN AND BROWN, EVER READS AND RIVERS WINDING THROUGH THE LANDSCAPE LIKE STRIPS OF MATTE AND GLOSSY RIBBON.

WHAT DID THEY RECKON IT WAS HUNGRING FOR? RICH YELLED AS THEY FLEW FARTHER AND FARTHER NORTH.

NO IDEA, HARRY REMEMBERED BACK. HIS HANDS WERE NUMB WITH COLD BUT HE DID NOT DARE ATTEMPT TO SHIFT HIS GRIP. HE HAD BEEN WONDERING FOR SOME TIME WHAT THEY WOULD DO IF THEY SAW THE CHAST SAIL BENEATH THEM, IF THE DRAGON HEADED FOR OPEN SEA; HE WAS COLD AND NUMB, NOT TO MENTION DESPERATELY HUNGRY AND THIRSTY. WHEN, HE WONDERED, HAD THE BEAST ITSELF LAST EATEN? SURELY IT WOULD NEED SUSTENANCE BEFORE LONG? AND WHAT IF, AT THAT POINT, IT REALIZED IT HAD

THREE HIGHLY EDIBLE HUMANS SITTING ON ITS BACK?

THE SUN SLIPPED LOWER IN THE SKY, WHICH WAS TURNING INDIGO; AND STILL THE DRAGON FLEW, CITIES AND TOWNS GLIDING OUT OF SIGHT BENEATH

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

THEM, ITS ENORMOUS SHADOW SLIDING OVER THE EARTH LIKE A GREAT  
DARK

CHILD. EVERY PART OF HARRY ACHED WITH THE EFFORT OF HOLDING ON THE  
THE DRAGON'S BACK.

IS IT MY IMAGINATION, SHELLED REIN AFTER A CONSIDERABLE STRETCH  
OF SILENCE. ARE WE LEAVING HEIGHT?

HARRY LOOKED DOWN AND SAW DEEP GREEN MOUNTAINS AND LAKES,  
CHIPPERS IN THE SUNSET. THE LANDSCAPE SEEMED THE GREEN LARGER AND  
MORE DETAILED AS HE SWUNTED OVER THE SIDE OF THE DRAGON, AND HE  
WONDERED WHETHER IT HAD DIVINED THE PRESENCE OF FRESH WATER BY THE  
FLASHES OF REFLECTED SUNLIGHT.

LOWER AND LOWER THE DRAGON FLEW, IN GREAT SPIRALING CIRCLES, FIN-  
ING IN, IT SEEMED, UPON ONE OF THE SMALLER LAKES.

I SAY WE JUMP WHEN IT GETS LOW ENOUGH! HARRY CALLED BACK THE  
THE OTHERS. STRAIGHT INTO THE WATER BEFORE IT REALIZES WE'RE  
HERE!

THEY AGREED, HERMIONE A LITTLE FAINTLY, AND WHEN HARRY COULD SEE  
THE

DRAGON'S WIDE YELLOW UNDERBELLY RIPPLING IN THE SURFACE OF THE  
WATER.

DOWN!

HE SLITHERED OVER THE SIDE OF THE DRAGON AND PLUMMETED FEETFIRST  
TOWARD THE SURFACE OF THE LAKE. THE DROP WAS GREATER THAN HE HAD  
ESTIMATED AND HE HIT THE WATER HARD, COLLAPSING LIKE A STONE INTO A  
FREEZING, GREEN, REED-FILLED WORLD. HE KICKED TOWARD THE SURFACE AND

EMERGED, PANTING, THE SEE ENORMOUS RIPPLES EMANATING IN CIRCLES FROM

THE PLACES WHERE REIN AND HERMIENE HAD FALLEN. THE DRAGON DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE NOTICED ANYTHING: IT WAS ALREADY FIFTY FEET AWAY, SWEEPING LOW OVER THE LAKE THE SCHEEP UP WATER IN ITS SCARRED SNOUT.

AS REIN AND HERMIENE EMERGED, SPLOTTING AND GASPING, FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE LAKE, THE DRAGON FLEW ON, ITS WINGS BEATING HARD, AND LANDED AT LAST ON A DISTANT BANK.

HARRY, REIN, AND HERMIENE STRUCK OUT FOR THE OPPOSITE SHORE. THE

## THE FINAL HIDING PLACE

599

LAKE DID NOT SEEM TO BE DEEP: SEEN IT WAS MORE A COLLECTION OF FIGHTING

THEIR WAY THROUGH REEDS AND MUD THAN SWIMMING, AND AT LAST THEY ALIGNED, SHEDDING, PANTING, AND EXHAUSTED, ON THE SLIPPERY GRASS,

HERMIENE COLLAPSED, CRAWLING AND SLIDDERING. THOUGH HARRY COULD HAVE HAPPILY LAIN DOWN AND SLEPT, HE STAGGERED TO HIS FEET, DREW OUT HIS WAND, AND STARTED CASTING THE USUAL PROTECTIVE SPELLS AROUND THEM.

WHEN HE HAD FINISHED, HE THOUGHT THE OTHERS. IT WAS THE FIRST TIME THAT HE HAD SEEN THEM PROPERLY SINCE ESCAPING FROM THE VAULT, REITH

HAD ANGRY RED BLURS ALL OVER THEIR FACES AND ARMS, AND THEIR CLOTHING WAS SINGED AWAY IN PLACES. THEY WERE WINKING AS THEY DABBED

ESSENCE OF DITTANY BENTH THEIR MANY INJURIES. HERMIONE HANDED HARRY

THE KETTLE, THEN PULLED OUT THREE KETTLES OF PLUMPOIN ILIKE SHE HAD BRIGHT FROM SHELL LEFTAGE AND CLEAN, DRY REEKS FOR ALL OF THEM. THEY CHANGED AND THEN CLIMBED DOWN THE ILIKE.

WELL, ON THE UPSIDE, SAID RON FINALLY, WHO WAS SITTING WATCHING THE SKIN ON HIS HANDS REGREIL, WE GOT THE HERCULES. ON THE

BELOWSIDE

THE SWORD, SAID HARRY THROUGH GRITTED TEETH, AS HE DRIPPED DITTANY THROUGH THE SINGED FLEECE IN HIS IRONS BENTH THE ANGRY BLURS

BEWATH.

THE SWORD, REPEATED RON, THAT DELICATE-CRESSING LITTLE SCAR . . . HARRY PULLED THE HERCULES FROM THE POCKET OF THE WET JACKET HE HAD JUST TAKEN OFF AND SET IT DOWN ON THE GRASS IN FRONT OF THEM. GLINTING IN THE SUN, IT DREW THEIR EYES AS THEY SWIGGED THEIR KETTLES OF ILIKE.

AT LEAST WE CAN'T WEAR IT THIS TIME, THAT'S A BIT WEIRD HANGING AROUND OUR NECKS, SAID RON, WIPING HIS MOUTH ON THE BACK OF HIS HAND.



## CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

548

HERMIONE LOOKED ACROSS THE LAKE TO THE FAR BANK, WHERE THE DRAGON WAS STILL DRINKING.

WHAT IS HAPPENING TO IT, DO YOU THINK? SHE ASKED. WILL IT BE ALL RIGHT?

YOU SHOULD LIKE HARRY, SAID RON. IT'S A DRAGON, HERMIONE, IT CAN LOOK AFTER ITSELF. IT'S LIKE WE NEED THE WHIPPY ARHAT.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN?

WELL, I DON'T KNOW HOW THE BRACK THIS TO YOU, SAID RON, BUT I THINK THEY MIGHT HAVE NOTICED WE BRECK INTO CRINGETTS.

ALL THREE OF THEM STARTED TO LAUGH, AND WHEN IT STARTED, IT WAS DIFFICULT TO STOP. HARRY'S RISK ASKED, HE FELT LIGHT-HEADED WITH FLINGER,

BUT HE LAY BACK IN THE GRASS BENEATH THE REDDENING SKY AND LAUGHED

UNTIL HIS THROAT WAS RAW.

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO, THOUGH? SAID HERMIONE FINALLY, PICKING HERSELF BACK TO SERIOUSNESS. HE IS KNOWN, WHEN IS HE? YOU KNOW WHEN WILL YOU KNOW WE KNOW ARHAT HIS FATHERS?

MAYBE THEY WILL BE TOO SCARED TO TELL HIM? SAID RON HOPEFULLY.

MAYBE THEY'LL NEVER LIP

THE SMOKE, THE SMELL OF LAKE WATER, THE SOUND OF RON'S VOICE WERE EXTINGUISHED: PAIN CLEAVED HARRY'S HEAD LIKE A SWORD STROKE. HE WAS

STANDING IN A DIMLY LIT ROOM, AND A SEMICIRCLE OF WIZARDS FACED HIM, AND ON THE FLOOR AT HIS FEET EXISTED A SMALL, HILARIOUS FIGURE.

WHAT DID YELL SAY TO ME? HIS VOICE WAS HIGH AND CHILD, BUT FLAT AND FEAR EJECTED INSIDE HIM. THE ONE THING HE HAD DREADED BUT IT COULD NOT BE TRUE, HE COULD NOT SEE FLEW...

THE GIBLIN WAS TREMBLING, UNABLE TO MEET THE RED EYES HIGH ABOVE HIS.

SAY IT AGAIN! MURMURED VERMILION. SAY IT AGAIN!

## THE FINAL HIDING PLACE

547

M-MY LORD, STAMMERED THE GIBLIN, ITS BLACK EYES WIDE WITH TERROR, M-MY LORD... WE TRIED TO STOP THEM... IM-IMPESTERS,

MY LORD... KROCK KROCK INTO THE INTO THE LESTRANGES V-VALLT...

IMPESTERS? WHAT IMPESTERS? I THOUGHT CRINGHITS HAD WAYS OF REVEALING IMPESTERS? WHEN WERE THEY?

IT WAS... IT WAS... THE P-PETTER B-BEE AND T-THE ALCHY-PLICES...

AND THEY THEM? HE SAID, HIS VOICE RISING, A TERRIBLE FEAR  
GRIPPING

HIM. TELL ME! WHAT DID THEY TAKE?

A . . . A S-SMALL CHILDEN C-CLIP, M-MY LORD . . .

THE SCREAM OF RAGE, OF DENIAL LEFT HIM AS IF IT WERE A STRANGER'S:

HE WAS CRAZED, FRENZIED, IT COULD NOT BE TRUE, IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE, NE-  
BODY HAD EVER KNOWN! THEN WAS IT POSSIBLE THAT THE KEY COULD HAVE

DISCOVERED HIS SECRET?

THE ELDER WAND SLASHED THROUGH THE AIR AND GREEN LIGHT ERUPTED  
THROUGH THE ROOM; THE KNEELING GELFIN ROLLED OVER, DEAD; THE  
WATCHING

WIZARDS SCATTERED BEFORE HIM, TERRIFIED; BELLATRIX AND LUCIUS MALFOY  
THREW ETHERS BEFORE THEM IN THEIR RACE FOR THE DOOR, AND AGAIN  
AND

AGAIN HIS WAND FELL, AND THOSE WHO WERE LEFT WERE SLAIN, ALL OF  
THEM,

FOR BRINGING HIM THIS NEWS, FOR HEARING ABOUT THE CHILDEN CLIP

ALONE AMONGST THE DEAD HE STORMED UP AND DOWN, AND THEY

PASSED BEFORE HIM IN VISION: HIS TREASURES, HIS SAPPWARDS, HIS  
ANCHORS

THE IMMORTALITY THE DIARY WAS DESTROYED AND THE CLIP WAS STOLEN:

WHAT IF, WHAT IF, THE KEY KNEW ABOUT THE ETHERS? COULD HE KNOW,

HAD HE ALREADY ACTED, HAD HE TRACED MORE OF THEM? WAS DUMBLEDORE

AT THE ROOT OF THIS? DUMBLEDORE, WHO HAD ALWAYS SUSPECTED HIM;

DUMBLEDORE, DEAD IN HIS HANDS; DUMBLEDORE, WHOSE WAND WAS

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

SSS

HIS NOSE, YET WHEN REACHED FELT FROM THE IGNOMINY OF DEATH  
THROUGH

THE BODY, THE BODY

BUT SURELY IF THE BODY HAD DESTROYED ANY OF HIS FINGERLINGS, HE, LORD  
VILDEMEHT, WOULD HAVE KNOWN, WOULD HAVE FELT IT? FOR THE  
GREATEST

WIZARD OF THEM ALL; HE, THE MOST POWERFUL; HE, THE KILLER OF DUMBLE-  
DORE AND OF FEW MANY OTHER WORTHLESS, NAMELESS MEN; FEW COULD

LORD VILDEMEHT NOT HAVE KNOWN, IF HE, HIMSELF, MOST IMPORTANT  
AND PRECIOUS, HAD BEEN ATTACKED, MUTILATED?

TRUE, HE HAD NOT FELT IT WHEN THE DIARY HAD BEEN DESTROYED, BUT  
HE HAD THEUGHT THAT WAS BECAUSE HE HAD NOT KNOWN THE FEEL, BEING LESS

THAN GHOST, . . . YES, SURELY, THE REST WERE SAFE, . . . THE OTHER FINGER-  
LINGS MUST BE INTACT, . . .

BUT HE MUST KNOW, HE MUST BE SURE, . . . HE PACED THE ROOM,  
KICKING ASIDE THE GIBLIN'S CORPSE AS HE PASSED, AND THE PICTURES  
BLURRED AND TURNED IN HIS WHIRLING BRAIN: THE LADY, THE SHARK, AND  
FINGWARTS

A MEDIUM HE CALM CHECKED HIS RAGE WHEN: HEW CHILD THE KEY  
KNOW THAT HE HAD HIDDEN THE RING IN THE GALANT ST-ACK? NO ONE  
HAD

EVER KNOWN HIM THE HE RELATED THE THE GALANTS, HE HAD HIDDEN THE  
CONNECTION, THE BILLINGS HAD NEVER BEEN TRACED THE HIM: THE RING,  
SURELY, WAS SAFE.

AND HEW CHILD THE KEY, FOR ANYBODY ELSE, KNOWN ABOUT THE CASE FOR  
PENETRATE ITS PROTECTION? THE IDEA OF THE SECRET BEING STELEN WAS  
ABSURD, . . .

AS FOR THE SECRET: HE ALONE KNEW WHERE IN HEWARTS HE HAD  
STELEN THE SECRET, BECAUSE HE ALONE HAD PLUNKED THE DEEPEST  
SECRETS OF THAT PLACE, . . .

AND THERE WAS STILL NAGINI, WHO MUST REMAIN CLOSE WHEN, NO  
LONGER

SENT THE DE HIS KIDDING, UNDER HIS PROTECTION, . . .

## THE FINAL HIDING PLACE

SS1

BUT THE HE SURE, THE HE LITTERLY SURE, HE MUST RETURN THE EACH OF HIS

HIDING PLACES, HE MUST REDUBLE PROTECTION AROUND EACH OF HIS  
SECRET-

CRUISES, . . . A HE, LIKE THE ELDEST FOR THE ELDER WARD, THAT HE MUST

UNDERSTAND ALONE . . .

WHICH SHOULD HE VISIT FIRST, WHICH WAS IN MOST DANGER? AN OLD

LINEAGE FLICKERED INSIDE HIM. DUMBLEDOORE HAD KNOWN HIS MIDDLE NAME. . . . DUMBLEDOORE MIGHT HAVE MADE THE CONNECTION WITH THE GALINTS. . . . THEIR ABANDONED HOME WAS, PERHAPS, THE LEAST SECURE OF HIS HIDING PLACES, IT WAS THERE THAT HE WOULD GO FIRST. . . .

THE LACK, SLURRY IMPOSSIBLE . . . THOUGH WAS THERE A SLIGHT POSSIBILITY THAT DUMBLEDOORE MIGHT HAVE KNOWN SOME OF HIS PAST MISDEEDS, THROUGH THE MURDER.

AND HIGGARTS . . . BUT HE KNEW THAT HIS FATHERLINE THERE WAS SAFE;

IT WOULD BE IMPOSSIBLE FOR PETER THE ENTER FUGITIVE WITHOUT DETEC-

THEM, LET ALONE THE SEARCH. NEVERTHELESS, IT WOULD BE PRUDENT THE ALERT

SNAPE THE THE FACT THAT THE KEY MIGHT TRY THE REENTER THE CASTLE. . . . THE

TELL SNAPE WHY THE KEY MIGHT RETURN WOULD BE FORTH, OF COURSE; IT

HAD BEEN A GRAVE MISTAKE THE TRUST BELLATRIX AND MALFOY: DIDN'T THEIR

STUPIDITY AND CARELESSNESS PROVE WELL ENOUGH IT WAS EVER THE TRUST? HE WOULD VISIT THE GALINT SHACK FIRST, THEN, AND TAKE NAGINI WITH HIM: HE WOULD NOT BE PARTED FROM THE SNAKE ANYMORE . . . AND HE

STRODE FROM THE ROOM, THROUGH THE HALL, AND INTO THE DARK CAR-

BEN WHERE THE HILINTAIN PLAYED, HE CALLED THE SNAKE IN  
PARSELTHENGWE

AND IT SLITHERED HEUT TE IHIN HIM LIKE A LONG SHADEN, . . .

HARRY'S EYES ALEW OPEN AS HE WRENCHED HIMSELF BACK TE THE PRES-  
ENT: HE WAS LYING HEN THE BANK OF THE LAKE IN THE SETTING SUN, AND

RON AND HERMIONE WERE LOOKING DOWN AT HIM, IDLING BY THEIR

WHIRLED HEADS, AND BY THE CONTINUED PEELING OF HIS SCAR, HIS SLID-  
DEN EXCURSION INTO VEEDMENT'S MIND HAD NEET PASSED UNNOTICED,  
HE

## CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

SSZ

STREGGLED LIP, SHIVERING, VAGUELY SURPRISED THAT HE WAS STILL WET  
TE HIS

SKIN, AND SAW THE CLIP LYING INNOCENTLY IN THE GRASS BEHIND HIM,  
AND

THE LAKE, DEEP BLUE SHEET WITH GOLD IN THE FADING SUN,

HE KNEELS, HIS HEWN VEHICLE BEHIND STRANGER AND LEL AFTER VEEL-  
DEMENT'S HIGH STREAMS, HE KNEELS, AND HE'S GOING TE CHECK WHERE

THE OTHERS ARE, AND THE LAST HEN, HE WAS ALREADY HEN HIS FEET, IS AT

“HOGWARTS, I KNOW IT, I KNOW IT.

WHAT?”

RON WAS GAWPING AT HIM; HERMIONE SAT UP, LOOKING WORRIED.

BUT WHAT DID THEY SEE? HOW DID THEY KNOW?

I SAW HIM FIND HOLT ABOUT THE CLIP, I I WAS IN HIS HEAD, HE &  
HARRY REMEMBERED THE KILLINGS HE & SERIOUSLY ANGRY, AND  
SCARED

THE, HE CAN'T UNDERSTAND HOW WE KNOW, AND NOW HE'S CHING THE  
CHICK

THE OTHERS ARE SAFE, THE RING FIRST, HE THINKS THE HOGWARTS ONE IS  
SAFEST, BECAUSE SNAPE'S THERE, BECAUSE IT LL BE THE HARD NEXT THE BE SEEN  
GETTING IN, I THINK HE LL CHICK THAT ONE LAST, BUT HE COULD STILL BE  
THERE WITHIN FEWRS

DID THEY SEE WHERE IN HOGWARTS IT IS? ASKED RON, NOW SCRAM-  
BLING THE HIS FEET THE.

NO, HE WAS CONCENTRATING ON WARNING SNAPE, HE DIDN'T THINK  
ABOUT EXACTLY WHERE IT IS

WAIT, WAIT! CRIED HERMIONE AS RON CALLED UP THE HOGWARTS AND  
HARRY PULLED OUT THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AGAIN. WE CAN'T JUST GO,  
WE

HAVEN'T GOT A PLAN, WE NEED THE

WE NEED THE GET GOING, SAID HARRY FIRMLY, HE HAD BEEN KEEP-  
ING THE SLEEP, LOOKING FORWARD THE GETTING INTO THE NEW TENT, BUT  
THAT



WAS IMPOSSIBLE NOW. CAN YOU IMAGINE WHAT HE'S GOING TO DO SINCE  
HE REALIZES THE RING AND THE LOCKET ARE GONE? WHAT IF HE MOVES  
THE

HOGWARTS FIREWORKS, DECIDES IT ISN'T SAFE ENOUGH?

## THE FINAL HIDING PLACE

SSS

BUT HOW ARE WE GOING TO GET IN?

WE'LL GO TO THE HOGSMEAD, SAID HARRY, AND TRY TO WORK SOMETHING  
OUT SINCE WE SEE WHAT THE PROTECTIONS AROUND THE SCHOOL'S LIKE, GET  
UNDER THE CLOAK, HERMION, I WANT THE STICK TOGETHER THIS TIME.

BUT WE DON'T REALLY FIT

IT'LL BE DARK, NOW SINCE I'M GOING TO NOTICE YOUR FEET.

THE FLAPPING OF ENORMOUS WINGS REACHED ACROSS THE BLACK WATER:

THE DRAGON HAD DRUNK ITS FILL AND RISEN INTO THE AIR. THEY PAUSED  
IN

THEIR PREPARATIONS TO WATCH IT CLIMB HIGHER AND HIGHER, NOW  
BLACK

AGAINST THE RAPIDLY DARKENING SKY, UNTIL IT VANISHED EVER A  
MOMENT

TO MAINTAIN. THEN HERMION WALKED FORWARD AND TOOK HER PLACE BE-  
TWEEN THE OTHER TWO. HARRY PULLED THE CLOAK DOWN AS FAR AS IT

WOULD GO, AND TOGETHER THEY TURNED IN THE SPOT INTO THE  
CRUSHING

DARKNESS.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

559

### THE MISSING MIRROR

HARRY'S FEET THICKENED AHEAD, HE SAW THE ACHINGLY FAMILIAR

EDGEWATER HIGH STREET: DARK STREET FRONTS, AND THE BLIT-  
LINE OF BLACK MOUNTAINS BEYOND THE VILLAGE, AND THE CLAY IN THE

ROAD AHEAD THAT LED HIM TOWARD THE GLASS, AND LIGHT SPILLING FROM  
THE WINDOWS OF THE THREE GREENSTICKS, AND WITH A LURCH OF THE  
HEART

HE REMEMBERED, WITH PIERCING ACCURACY, HOW HE HAD LANDED HERE  
NEARLY A YEAR BEFORE, SLIPPERING A DESPERATELY WEAK DUMPKEDDIE;  
ALL THIS IN A SECOND, UPON LANDING AND THEN, EVEN AS HE RELAXED  
HIS GRIP UPON BEN'S AND JERMYNE'S ARMS, IT HAPPENED.

THE AIR WAS RENT BY A SCREAM THAT SOUNDED LIKE VILDBERHRT'S WHEN  
HE HAD REALIZED THE CLIP HAD BEEN STOLEN! IT THREW AT EVERY NERVE IN  
HARRY'S BODY, AND HE KNEW IMMEDIATELY THAT THEIR APPEARANCE HAD  
CAUSED IT. EVEN AS HE LOOKED AT THE EITHER TWIN BENEATH THE CHAIR,  
THE

DOOR OF THE THREE GREENSTICKS FLUNG OPEN AND A DOZEN CREAKED AND  
WHINNED DEATH-LATERS DASHED INTO THE STREET, THEIR HANDS ALIFT.

HARRY SEIZED BEN'S WRIST AS HE RAISED HIS HAND; THERE WERE THREE

## THE MISSING MIRROR

SSS

MANY OF THEM THE STUN! EVEN ATTEMPTING IT WOULD GIVE AWAY THEIR POSITION. ONE OF THE DEATH EATERS WAVED HIS HAND AND THE SCRAM STOPPED, STILL ECHOING AROUND THE DISTANT MOUNTAINS.

ACROSS AHEAD! HEARD ONE OF THE DEATH EATERS.

HARRY SEIZED ITS FEELS, BUT IT MADE NO ATTEMPT TO ESCAPE! THE SLIPPERING CHARM HAD NOT WORKED ON IT.

NOT UNDER YOUR WRAPPER, THEN, PETER? YELLED THE DEATH EATER WHO HAD TRIED THE CHARM, AND THEN TO HIS FELLOWS, SPREAD OUT. HE'S HERE.

SIX OF THE DEATH EATERS RAN TOWARD THEM! HARRY, BEN, AND FERMINE RAN AS QUICKLY AS POSSIBLE DOWN THE NEAREST SIDE STREET,

AND THE DEATH EATERS MISSED THEM BY INCHES. THEY WAITED IN THE DARKNESS, LISTENING TO THE FOOTSTEPS RUNNING UP AND DOWN, BEAMS OF LIGHT FLYING ALONG THE STREET FROM THE DEATH EATERS SEARCHING HANDS.

LET'S JUST LEAVE! FERMINNE WHISPERED. DISAPPEARATE NOW!

GREAT IDEA, SAID BEN, BUT BEFORE HARRY COULD REPLY A DEATH EATER SCHELTED,

WE KNOW YOU'RE HERE, PETER, AND THERE'S NO GETTING AWAY! WE'LL FIND YOU!

THEY WERE READY FOR US, WHISPERED HARRY. THEY SET UP THAT SPELL TO TELL THEM WE'D COME. I RECKON THEY'VE DONE SOMETHING TO KEEP US HERE, TRAP US.

WHAT ABOUT DEMENTORS? CALLED ANOTHER DEATH EATER. LET EM HAVE FREE REIN, THEY'D FIND HIM MUCH EASIER!

THE DARK LORD WANTS PETER DEAD BY HIS HAND BUT HIS

AND DEMENTORS WON'T KILL HIM! THE DARK LORD WANTS PETER'S LIFE, NOT HIS SKIN. HE'LL BE EASIER TO KILL IF HE'S BEEN KISSED FIRST! THERE WERE NUANCES OF AGREEMENT, DREAD FILLED HARRY! THE REPEL

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

SSSS

DEMENTORS THEY WOULD HAVE THE PRODIGE PATRONUSES, WHICH WOULD GIVE THEM AWAY IMMEDIATELY.

WE'RE GOING TO HAVE TO TRY TO DISAPPEAR, HARRY! HERMIONE WHISPERED.

EVEN AS SHE SAID IT, HE FELT THE UNNATURAL CHILL BEGIN TO SEAL OVER THE STREET. LIGHT WAS SUCKED FROM THE ENVIRONMENT RIGHT UP THE

STARS, WHICH VANISHED. IN THE PITCH-BLACKNESS, HE FELT HERMIONE TAKE

HOLD OF HIS ARM AND TOGETHER, THEY TURNED IN THE SPOT.

THE AIR THROUGH WHICH THEY NEEDED TO MOVE SEEMED TO HAVE

BEHIND THEM! THEY COULD NOT DISAPPEAR! THE DEATH EATERS HAD  
LOST THEIR CHARMS WELL. THE CHILD WAS BITING DEEPER AND DEEPER INTO  
HARRY'S FLESH. HE, RON, AND HERMIONE RETREATED DOWN THE SIDE  
STREET.

GRIPPING THEIR WAY ALONG THE WALL, TRYING NOT TO MAKE A SOUND.  
THEN,

AROUND THE CORNER, GLIDING NEARLY SILENTLY, CAME DEMENTORS, TEN OR  
MORE

OF THEM, VISIBLE BECAUSE THEY WERE IN A DENSE DARKNESS THAN THEIR

SHRILL WHISTLES, WITH THEIR BLACK CLOAKS AND THEIR SCARRED AND REET-  
TING HANDS. COULD THEY SENSE FEAR IN THE VICINITY? HARRY WAS SURE

OF IT! THEY SEEMED TO BE CREEPING MORE SILENTLY NOW, TAKING THESE  
DRAGGING, RATTLING BREATHS HE DETESTED, TASTING DESPAIR EVEN THE AIR,  
CLOSING IN

HE RAISED HIS HAND: HE COULD NOT, WOULD NOT, STOP THE DEMENT-  
ORS'S KISS, WHATEVER HAPPENED AFTERWARD. IT WAS HE, RON AND  
HERMI-

ONE THAT HE FELT AS HE WHISPERED, EXPECTED PATRONUS!

THE SILVER STAG BURST FROM HIS HAND AND CHARGED! THE DEMENTORS  
SCATTERED AND THERE WAS A TRIUMPHANT YELL FROM SOMEWHERE OUT OF  
SIGHT.

IT'S HIM, DOWN THERE, DOWN THERE, I SAW HIS PATRONUS, IT WAS A  
STAG!

THE DEMENTORS HAD RETREATED, THE STARS WERE PEPPING OUT AGAIN,

## THE MISSING MIRROR

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AND THE FEETSTEPS OF THE DEATH PATERS WERE ECHOING BEHIND; BUT BEFORE HARRY IN HIS PANIC COULD DECIDE WHAT TO DO, THERE WAS A GRINDING

OF WHEELS NEARBY, A DOOR OPENED ON THE LEFT-HAND SIDE OF THE NARROW STREET, AND A SMALL VOICE SAID, "GETTER, IN HERE, QUICK!"

HE MOVED WITHOUT HESITATION; THE THREE OF THEM FLUTTERED THROUGH

THE OPEN DOORWAY,

UPSTAIRS, KEEP THE LEAD ON, KEEP QUIET! MUTTERED A TALL FIGURE, PASSING THEM ON HIS WAY INTO THE STREET AND SLAMMING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

HARRY HAD HAD NO IDEA WHERE THEY WERE, BUT WHEN HE SAW, BY THE FLUTTERING LIGHT OF A SINGLE CANDLE, THE GRAY, SALADIST-STRENGTH BAR OF THE DOOR LEAD IN. THEY RAN BEHIND THE CLOSET AND THROUGH A SECOND DOORWAY, WHICH LED TO A RICKETY WOODEN STAIRCASE THAT THEY

CLIMBED AS FAST AS THEY COULD. THE STAIRS OPENED INTO A SITTING ROOM

WITH A THREADBARE CARPET AND A SMALL FIREPLACE, ABOVE WHICH HUNG A

SINGLE LARGE OIL PAINTING OF A BLONDE GIRL WHO GAZED BLIND AT THE ROOM

WITH A KIND OF VACANT SWEETNESS.

SHULTS REACHED THEM FROM THE STREET BEHIND. STILL WEARING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, THEY CREEPT TOWARD THE GRIMY WINDOW AND LOOKED DOWN. THEIR SAVIOR, WHOM HARRY NEW RECOGNIZED AS THE KING'S HEAD & BARMAN, WAS THE ONLY PERSON NOT WEARING A HIDE.

SEE WHAT? HE WAS BELLEWING INTO ONE OF THE HIDEED FACES. SEE WHAT? YOU SEND DEMENTHES DOWN MY STREET, I LL SEND A PATRENLIS BACK AT EM! I M NOT HAVING EM NEAR ME, I VE TOLD YOU THAT, I M NOT HAVING IT!

THAT WASN T YOUR PATRENLIS! SAID A DEATH LATER. THAT WAS A STAG, IT WAS BETTER!

STAG! REARED THE BARMAN, AND HE PULLED OUT A WAND. STAG! YOU DONT EXPECT PATRENLIS!

## CHAPTER TWENTY EIGHT

SSSS

SOMETHING FLICK AND FIZZED ERUPTED FROM THE WAND! HEAD DOWN, IT CHARGED TOWARD THE HIGH STREET AND OUT OF SIGHT.

THAT S NOT WHAT I SAW SAID THE DEATH LATER, THOUGH WITH LESS CERTAINTY.

CLIFF'S BEEN KIDNED, YOU HEARD THE NOISE, ONE OF HIS COMPANIONS TOLD THE BARMAN. SOMEONE WAS OUT IN THE STREET AGAINST

REGULATIONS

IF I WANT THE PLUT MY CAT HLT, I WILL, AND BE DAMNED THE YELIR  
CLIRPLEY!

YELI SET OFF THE CATERWALLING CHAIR?

WHAT IF I DID? CHINE THE CART ME OFF THE AZDARAK? WILL ME FEEL  
STICKING MY NECK HLT MY HLTIN FRONT DEER? DEE IT, THEN, IF YELI WANT  
THE? BUT I HOPE FOR YELIR SACKS YELI HAVEN T PRESSED YELIR LITTLE  
DARK

MARDS AND SLITTHEND HIM, HE S NEET CHINE THE LIKE BEING CALLED HERE  
FOR ME AND MY HED CAT, IS HE, NEEL?

DEEN T YELI WHIRRY ARHIT LIS, SAID HINE OF THE DEATH EATERS, WHIRRY  
ARHIT YELIRSELF, BREAKING CLIRPLEY!

AND WHERE WILL YELI LEFT TRAFFICK PETITIONS AND PHISHINS WHEN MY  
PLK S CLESED DEEN? WHAT LL HAPPEN THE YELIR LITTLE SIDELINES THEN?  
ARE YELI THREATENING ?

I DEEP MY MHLTH SHLT, IT S WHY YELI CAME HERE, ISN T IT?

I STILL SAY I SAW A STAG PATRHLIS? SHHLTED THE FIRST DEATH EATER,  
STAG? REHARD THE BARMAN, IT S A CHEAT, IDIET?

ALL RIGHT, WE MADE A MISTAKE, SAID THE SECOND DEATH EATER,

BREAD CLIRPLEY AGAIN AND WE WHEN T BE SH LENIENT?

THE DEATH EATERS STRODE BACK TOWARD THE HIGH STREET, HERMI-  
HNE MEANED WITH RELIEF, WHEVE HLT FROM UNDER THE CHAD, AND SAT

DEEN HEN A WHEKLE-LEGGED CHAIR, FARRY DREW THE CURTAINS TIGHT  
SHLT,

THEN PULLED THE CHAD OFF HIMSELF AND REEN, THEY CHULD HEAR THE



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KARMAN OPENED SEVERAL, RECKLING THE DEER OF THE BAR, THEN CLIMBING THE STAIRS,

HARRY'S ATTENTION WAS CALLED BY SOMETHING ON THE MANTELPIECE: A SMALL, RECTANGULAR MIRROR PERCHED ON TOP OF IT, RIGHT BENEATH THE

PORTRAIT OF THE GIRL.

THE KARMAN ENTERED THE ROOM.

YELL BLINDLY FEELS, HE SAID GRUFFLY, LEERING FROM ONE TO THE OTHER

OF THEM. WHAT WERE YOU THINKING, COMING HERE?

THANK YOU, SAID HARRY. WE CAN'T THANK YOU ENOUGH. YOU SAVED

OUR LIVES.

THE KARMAN GRINDED, HARRY APPROACHED HIM, LEERING UP INTO THE FACE, TRYING TO SEE PAST THE LONG, STRINGY, WIRE-GRAY HAIR AND BEARD.

HE WORE SPECTACLES. BEHIND THE DIRTY LENSES, THE EYES WERE A PIERCING, BRILLIANT BLUE.

IT'S YOUR EYE I'VE BEEN SEEING IN THE MIRROR.

THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE ROOM. HARRY AND THE KARMAN LEERED AT EACH OTHER.

YOU SENT DEEKE.

THE BARMAN NEEDED AND LEANED AROUND FOR THE ELF.

THOUGHT HE D BE WITH YELL, WHERE YE YELL LEFT HIM?

HE S DEAD, SAID HARRY, BELLATRIX LESTRANGE KILLED HIM.

THE BARMAN S FACE WAS IMPASSIVE. AFTER A FEW MOMENTS HE SAID,

I M SORRY THE HEAR IT, I LIKED THAT ELF.

HE TURNED AWAY, LIGHTING LAMPS WITH PEEDS OF HIS WAND, NOT LOOK-  
ING AT ANY OF THEM.

YELL RE ASKED, SAID HARRY THE THE MAN S BACK.

HE NEITHER CONFIRMED NOR DENIED IT, BUT SENT THE LIGHT THE FIRE.

HOW DID YELL GET THIS? HARRY ASKED, WALKING ACROSS THE STIRLIS S  
MIRROR, THE TWIN OF THE ONE HE HAD BROKEN NEARLY THREE YEARS  
BEFORE.

## CHAPTER TWENTY EIGHT

SEE

RELIGHT IT FROM DUNE BEHUT A YEAR AGO, SAID ASKED, ASKED  
TOLD ME WHAT IT WAS, BEEN TRYING THE DEEP AN EYE BEHUT FOR YELL.  
THEN GASPED.

THE SILVER DEER? HE SAID EXCITEDLY, WAS THAT YELL THEN?

WHAT ARE YELL TALKING ABOUT? SAID ASKED.

SOMEONE SENT A DEER PATRONS THE LIST

BRAINS LIKE THAT, YELL COULD BE A DEATH LATER, THEN, HAVEN T I JUST  
PROVED MY PATRONS IS A CHEAT?

HEH, SAID REIN. YEAH... WELL, I'M HUNGRY! HE ADDED DEFENSIVELY AS HIS STOMACH GAVE AN ENERGETIC RUMBLE.

I GET FEED, SAID ABERNETHY, AND HE SLEPT UNTIL THE MORNING, RE-APPEARING MOMENTS LATER WITH A LARGE LOAF OF BREAD, SOME CHEESE,

AND A PLENTYFUL OF MEAD, WHICH HE SET UPON A SMALL TABLE IN FRONT OF THE FIRE. RATHERLY, THEY ATE AND DRANK, AND FOR A WHILE THERE WAS

SILENCE BUT FOR THE CRACKLE OF THE FIRE, THE CLINK OF CUPS, AND THE SOUND OF CHIRPING.

RIGHT THEN, SAID ABERNETHY WHEN THEY HAD EATEN THEIR FILL, AND HARRY AND REIN SAT SLUMPED DIZZILY IN THEIR CHAIRS. WE NEED TO THINK OF THE BEST WAY TO GET THEM OUT OF HERE. CAN'T BE DONE BY NIGHT,

THEY HEARD WHAT HAPPENS IF ANYONE MOVES UNTHINKING DURING DARKNESS! CATERWALKING CHARM'S SET OFF, THEY'LL BE HEARD LIKE BELL-TROTTLES AND BEEY EGGS. I DON'T RECKON I'LL BE ABLE TO PASS OFF A STAG

AS A GOAT A SECOND TIME. WAIT FOR DAWN WHEN CURTAINS LIFT, THEN THEY CAN PUT THEIR CLOAKS BACK ON AND SET OUT ON FEET. GET RIGHT OUT

OF THE SPREAD, UP INTO THE MOUNTAINS, AND THEY'LL BE ABLE TO DISAPPEAR THERE. MIGHT SEE HAGRID. HE'S BEEN HIDING IN A CAVE UP THERE

WITH GRAMP EVER SINCE THEY TRIED TO ARREST HIM.

WE'RE NOT LEAVING, SAID HARRY. WE NEED TO GET INTO HOGWARTS.

DON'T BE STUPID, KID, SAID ABERCORTHY.

## THE MISSING MIRROR

SEE

WE'VE GOT THEM, SAID HARRY.

WHAT YOU'VE GOT THEM DO, SAID ABERCORTHY, LEANING FORWARD, IS TO GET AS FAR FROM HERE AS YOU CAN.

YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND. THERE ISN'T MUCH TIME. WE'VE GOT TO GET INTO THE CASTLE, DUMBLEDORE I MEAN, YOUR BROTHER WANTED US

THE FIRELIGHT MADE THE GRIM LENSES OF ABERCORTHY'S GLASSES MOMENTARILY OPACULE, A BRIGHT FLAT WHITE, AND HARRY REMEMBERED THE BLIND

EYES OF THE GIANT SPIDER, CRACKING.

MY BROTHER ALWAYS WANTED A LOT OF THINGS, SAID ABERCORTHY, AND PEOPLE HAD A HABIT OF GETTING FLIRT WHILE HE WAS CARRYING OUT HIS GRAND PLANS. YOU GET AWAY FROM THIS SCHOOL, BETTER, AND OUT OF THE

COUNTRY IF YOU CAN, FORGET MY BROTHER AND HIS CLEVER SCHEMES, HE'S GONE WHERE NONE OF THIS CAN HURT HIM, AND YOU DON'T HURT HIM ANYTHING.

YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND, SAID HARRY AGAIN.

HE'D BEEN TOLD SAID ARKENTH. HE'D BEEN TOLD I UNDER-  
STOOD MY OWN BROTHER. THINK YOU KNOW ALAS BETTER THAN I DID?

I DIDN'T MEAN THAT, SAID HARRY, WHOSE BRAIN FELT SLUGGISH WITH  
EXHAUSTION AND FROM THE SLURPET OF FOOD AND WINE. IT'S... HE LEFT  
ME A LIE.

DID HE MEAN? SAID ARKENTH. NICE LIE, I HOPE? PLEASANT? EASY?  
SHORT OF THING YOU'D EXPECT AN UNQUALIFIED WIZARD DID THEN BE ABLE TO  
DO WITHOUT OVERSTRETCHING THEMSELVES?

HEEN GAVE A RATHER GRIM LAUGH. HERMIONE WAS LOOKING STRAINED.

IT'S NOT EASY, NEH, SAID HARRY, BUT I'VE GOT TO

GET TO? WHY GET TO? HE'S DEAD, ISN'T HE? SAID ARKENTH  
RELIGIOUSLY. LET IT GO, KID, BECAUSE YOU'VE HELPED HIM. SAVE YOURSELF.  
I CAN'T.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

SEE

WHY NOT?

I HARRY FELT OVERWHELMED; HE COULD NOT EXPLAIN, SEE HE THOUGHT  
THE OFFENSIVE INSTEAD. BUT YOU'RE FIGHTING THEM, YOU'RE IN THE  
ORDER

OF THE PHOENIX

I WAS, SAID ARKENTH. THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX IS FINISHED.

YELL-KNEEL-WITH S WHEN, IT S EVER, AND ANYONE WITH S PRETENDING  
DIP-

PERENT S KIDDING THEMSELVES, IT LL NEVER BE SAFE FOR YELL HERE,  
PHTTER,

HE WANTS YELL TOO BADLY, SHE GO AHEAD, GO INTO HIDING, SAVE  
YELLERSELF,

BEST TAKE THESE TWO WITH YELL. HE LOOKED A THUMB AT JOHN AND HER-  
MINE. THEY LL BE IN DANGER WHEN AS THEY LIVE WITH EVERYONE  
KNOWS

THEY VE BEEN WORKING WITH YELL.

I CAN T LEAVE, SAID HARRY, I VE GOT A JOB

GIVE IT TO SOMEONE ELSE!

I CAN T, IT S GOT TO BE ME, DUMKEDERE EXPLAINED IT ALL

HE, DID HE NOT? AND DID HE TELL YELL EVERYTHING, WAS HE HONEST  
WITH YELL?

HARRY WANTED WITH ALL HIS HEART TO SAY YES, BUT SOMEHOW THE  
SIMPLE WORD WOULD NOT RISE TO HIS LIPS, APPARENTLY SOMEONE SEEMED TO KNOW  
WHAT HE WAS THINKING.

I KNOW MY BROTHER, PHTTER, HE LEARNED SECRETLY AT HIS MOTHER S  
KNEE, SECRETS AND LIES, THAT S HOW WE GROW UP, AND ALAS . . . HE WAS  
A NATURAL.

THE OLD MAN S EYES TRAVELED TO THE PAINTING OF THE GIRL OVER THE  
MANTELPIECE. IT WAS, WHEN HARRY LOOKED AROUND PROPERLY, THE ONLY

PICTURE IN THE ROOM. THERE WAS NO PHOTOGRAPH OF ALAS DUMKED-

HERE, NEAR IF ANYWHERE ELSE.

MR. OLIMPEDERE? SAID HERMINE RATHER TIMIDLY. IS THAT YOUR  
SISTER? ARIANA?

THE MISSING MIRROR

SEE

YES, SAID ABERNETHY TERSELY. BEEN READING RITA SKEETER, HAVE  
YOU, MISS?

EVEN BY THE DIM LIGHT OF THE FIRE IT WAS CLEAR THAT HERMINE HAD  
TURNED RED.

ELPHIAS DEER MENTIONED HER TOO, SAID HARRY, TRYING THE SPARE  
HERMINE.

THAT HAD BEEN, MUTTERED ABERNETHY, TAKING ANOTHER SWIG OF  
MEAD. THE LIGHT THE SUN SHINE HILT OF MY BROTHER'S EVERY EFFORT,  
HE DID, WELL, SHE DID PLENTY OF PEOPLE, WELL THREE INCLUDED, BY THE  
LOOKS OF IT.

HARRY KEPT SILENT. HE DID NOT WANT THE EXPRESS THE DETAILS AND  
UNCERTAINTIES ABOUT OLIMPEDERE THAT HAD RIDDLED HIM FOR MONTHS  
NOW. HE HAD MADE HIS CHOICE WHILE HE DUG DEER'S GRAVE. HE HAD  
DECIDED THE CONTINUOUS ALONG THE WINDING, DANGEROUS PATH INDICATED  
FOR HIM BY ALEXIS OLIMPEDERE, THE ACCEPT THAT HE HAD NOT BEEN TOLD  
EVERYTHING THAT HE WANTED TO KNOW, BUT SIMPLY THE TRUTH. HE HAD  
NOT

DESIRE THE DUEL? AGAIN? HE DID NOT WANT TO HEAR ANYTHING THAT  
WOULD

DEFLECT HIM FROM HIS PURPOSE. HE MET ARBERTH'S GAZE, WHICH WAS  
SEE STRIKINGLY LIKE HIS BROTHER'S: THE BRIGHT BLUE EYES GAVE THE  
SAME

IMPRESSION THAT THEY WERE X-RAYING THE HEART OF THEIR SCOUTING,  
AND

HARRY THOUGHT THAT ARBERTH KNEW WHAT HE WAS THINKING AND  
DE-

SPISED HIM FOR IT.

PROFESSOR DIMLEDORF CARED ABOUT HARRY, VERY MUCH, SAID FERMINE  
IN A LOW VOICE.

DID HE NOT? SAID ARBERTH. PLANNED THING, HOW MANY OF THE  
PEOPLE MY BROTHER CARED ABOUT VERY MUCH ENDED UP IN A WORSE  
STATE

THAN IF HE'D LEFT THEM WELL ALONE.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN? ASKED FERMINE BREATHLESSLY.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

SEE

NEVER YOU MIND, SAID ARBERTH.

BUT THAT'S A REALLY SERIOUS THING TO SAY! SAID FERMINE. ARE  
YOU ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT YOUR SISTER?

ARBERTH GLARED AT HER: HIS LIPS MOVED AS IF HE WERE CHEWING THE



WORDS HE WAS HOLDING BACK. THEN HE BURST INTO SPEECH.

WHEN MY SISTER WAS SIX YEARS OLD, SHE WAS ATTACKED, SET LIPON, BY THREE MISCLE KIDS. THEY'D SEEN HER DOING MAGIC, SPYING THROUGH THE BACK GARDEN HEDGE! SHE WAS A KID, SHE COULDN'T CONTROL IT, NOT WITH HER WIZARD CAN AT THAT AGE. WHAT THEY SAW SCARED THEM, I EXPECT. THEY FORCED THEIR WAY THROUGH THE HEDGE, AND WHEN SHE COULDN'T SHOW THEM THE TRICK, THEY GOT A KIT CARRIED AWAY TRYING THE STEP THE LITTLE FREAK DOING IT.

HERMIONE'S EYES WERE FLICK IN THE FIRELIGHT! BEEN WOUNDED SLIGHTLY SICK. ABERFORTH STOOD UP, TALL AS A KILN, AND SUDDENLY TERRIBLE IN HIS

ANGER AND THE INTENSITY OF HIS PAIN.

IT DESTROYED HER, WHAT THEY DID! SHE WAS NEVER RIGHT AGAIN. SHE COULDN'T USE MAGIC, BUT SHE COULDN'T GET RID OF IT! IT TURNED INWARD AND DROVE HER MAD, IT EXPLODED OUT OF HER WHEN SHE COULDN'T CONTROL

IT, AND AT TIMES SHE WAS STRANGE AND DANGEROUS, BUT MOSTLY SHE WAS SWEET AND SCARED AND HARMLESS.

AND MY FATHER WENT AFTER THE KASTARDS THAT DID IT, SAID ABERFORTH, AND ATTACKED THEM. AND THEY WOUNDED HIM UP IN AZKABAN

AFTER IT. HE NEVER SAID WHY HE'D DONE IT, BECAUSE IF THE MINISTRY HAD KNOWN WHAT ARIANA HAD BECOME, SHE'D HAVE BEEN WOUNDED UP IN ST. MUNGUS'S SHOP. THEY'D HAVE SEEN HER AS A SERIOUS THREAT TO THE INTERNATIONAL TREATY OF SECRECY, UNBALANCED LIKE SHE WAS, WITH

MAGIC EXPLODING HIT HER AT MOMENTS WHEN SHE COULDN'T KEEP IT  
IN ANY LONGER.

WE HAD TO KEEP HER SAFE AND QUIET, WE MOVED HER, PUT IT AWAY

## THE MISSING MIRROR

SEE

SHE WAS ILL, AND MY MOTHER LOOKED AFTER HER, AND TRIED TO KEEP HER  
CALM AND HAPPY.

I WAS HER FAVORITE, HE SAID, AND AS HE SAID IT, A GRIMLY SCHEMER  
SEEMED TO LEEDS HIT THROUGH ARBERTH'S WRINKLES AND TANGLED  
BEARD.

NEET ALKS, HE WAS ALWAYS UP IN HIS BEDROOM WHEN HE WAS HOME,  
READING HIS BOOKS AND CHEATING HIS PRIZES, KEEPING UP WITH HIS  
CORRESPONDENCE WITH THE MOST NOTABLE MAGICAL NAMES OF THE DAY,

ARBERTH SNEEZED. HE DIDN'T WANT TO BE BOTHERED WITH HER. SHE  
LIKED ME BEST, I COULD GET HER THE CAT WHEN SHE COULDN'T SEE IT FOR MY  
MOTHER, I COULD GET HER THE CALM DOWN WHEN SHE WAS IN ONE OF HER  
RAGES, AND WHEN SHE WAS QUIET, SHE USED TO HELP ME FEED THE GOATS.

THEN, WHEN SHE WAS FORTYTHREE . . . SEE, I WASN'T THERE, SAID AR-  
BERTH. IF I'D BEEN THERE, I COULD HAVE CALMED HER DOWN, SHE HAD

ONE OF HER RAGES, AND MY MOTHER WASN'T AS YOUNG AS SHE WAS, AND . . .

,

IT WAS AN ACCIDENT, ARIANA COULDN'T CONTROL IT, BUT MY MOTHER WAS

KILLED.

HARRY FELT A TERRIBLE MIXTURE OF PITY AND REPULSION; HE DID NOT

WANT TO HEAR ANY MORE, BUT ALBERTHARTS KEPT TALKING, AND HARRY  
WHEN-

DETERMINED FEELING IT HAD BEEN SINCE HE HAD SPOKEN ABOUT THIS;  
WHETHER,

IN FACT, HE HAD EVER SPOKEN ABOUT IT.

SEE THAT PLUT PAID THE ALKIS'S TRIP AROUND THE WORLD WITH LITTLE  
DECE.

THE PAIR OF EM CAME HOME FOR MY MOTHER'S FUNERAL AND THEN DECE

WENT OFF ON HIS OWN, AND ALKIS SETTLED DOWN AS HEAD OF THE FAM-  
ILY, HAY.

ALBERTHARTS SPAT INTO THE FIRE.

I'D HAVE LIKED AFTER HER, I TOLD HIM SEE, I DIDN'T CARE ABOUT SCHEM,  
I'D HAVE STAYED HOME AND DONE IT. HE TOLD ME I HAD THE FINISH MY  
EDUCATION AND HE'D TAKE OVER FROM MY MOTHER. BUT HE A CHEMIST  
FOR MR. BRILLIANT, THERE'S NO PRIZES FOR LIKING AFTER YOUR HALF-  
MAD

## CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

SEE

SISTER, STEPPING HER KNEELING UP THE HOUSE EVERY OTHER DAY, BUT HE

DID ALL RIGHT FOR A FEW WEEKS . . . TILL HE CAME.

AND WHEN A POSITIVELY DANGEROUS LIEKE CROPT OVER ABERNETHY'S  
FACE.

GRINDLEWALD, AND AT LAST, MY BROTHER HAD AN IDEA THE TALK THE  
SOMEONE JUST AS BRIGHT AND TALENTED AS HE WAS, AND LEAVING AFTER  
ARIANA THREW A BACKSEAT THEN, WHILE THEY WERE HATCHING ALL THEIR  
PLANS

FOR A NEW WIZARDING ORDER, AND LEAVING FOR HALLS, AND  
WHATEVER

ELSE IT WAS THEY WERE SHE INTERESTED IN, GRAND PLANS FOR THE BENEFIT  
OF

ALL WIZARDING, AND IF ONE YOUNG GIRL GET NEGLECTED, WHAT DID THAT  
MATTER, WHEN ALEXIS WAS WORKING FOR THE GREATER GOOD?

BUT AFTER A FEW WEEKS OF IT, I'D HAD ENOUGH, I HAD. IT WAS NEARLY  
TIME FOR ME TO GO BACK TO HOGWARTS, SHE TOLD ME, BOTH OF ME,  
FACE-TO-FACE, LIKE I AM THE ONLY, NOW, AND ABERNETHY LOOKED DOWN AT  
HARRY, AND IT THREW LITTLE IMAGINATION THE SEE HIM AS A TEENAGER,  
WINDY

AND ANGRY, CONFRONTING HIS ELDER BROTHER. I TOLD HIM, YOU'D BETTER  
GIVE IT UP NOW, YOU CAN'T MOVE HER, SHE'S IN NO FIT STATE, YOU  
CAN'T

TALK HER WITH YOU, WHEREVER IT IS YOU'RE PLANNING TO GO, WHEN  
YOU'RE

MAKING YOUR CLEVER SPEECHES, TRYING TO WHIP YOURSELVES UP A  
FEELING-

ING, HE DIDN'T LIKE THAT, SAID ABERNETHY, AND HIS EYES WERE BRIEFLY

ILLUMINATED BY THE FIRELIGHT IN THE LENSES OF HIS GLASSES! THEY SHINE

WHITE AND BLIND AGAIN. GRINDELWALD DIDN'T LIKE THAT AT ALL, HE GOT ANGRY, HE TOLD ME WHAT A STUPID LITTLE KID I WAS, TRYING TO STAND IN

THE WAY OF HIM AND MY BRILLIANT BROTHER. . . . DIDN'T I UNDERSTAND, MY POOR SISTER WOULDN'T HAVE THEM HIDDEN SINCE THEY'D CHANGED THE WORLD, AND LET THE WIZARDS GET OF HIDING, AND TAKE THE MUGGLES THEIR PLACE?

AND THERE WAS AN ARGUMENT . . . AND I PULLED OUT MY HAND, AND HE PULLED OUT HIS, AND I HAD THE CRUCIATUS CURSE USED ON ME BY MY BROTHER'S BEST FRIEND AND ALBUS WAS TRYING TO STOP HIM, AND THEN

## THE MISSING MIRROR

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ALL THREE OF US WERE DYING, AND THE FLASHING LIGHTS AND THE RANGING SET HER OFF, SHE WOULDN'T STAND IT

THE CURSE WAS DRAINING FROM HER FATHER'S FACE AS THOUGH HE HAD SUFFERED A MENTAL COLLAPSE.

AND I THINK SHE WANTED THE HELP, BUT SHE DIDN'T REALLY KNOW WHAT SHE WAS DOING, AND I DIDN'T KNOW WHICH OF US DID IT, IT COULD HAVE BEEN ANY OF US AND SHE WAS DEAD.

HIS VOICE RANG ON THE LAST WORD AND HE DROPPED DOWN INTO THE NEAREST CHAIR. HERMIONE'S FACE WAS WET WITH TEARS, AND PENELOPE WAS ALMOST AS PALE AS HER FATHER. JARRY FELT NOTHING BUT REVULSION: HE

WISHED HE HAD NEET HEARD IT, WISHED HE COULD WASH HIS MIND CLEAN

OF IT.

I M SEE . . . I M SEE SHINY, HERMIONE WHISPERED,

GENE, CREAMED ABERNETHY, GENE THEREVER,

HE WIPED HIS NOSE ON HIS CLOTH AND CLEARED HIS THROAT.

CHURCH, GRINDENWALD STAMPERED, HE HAD A KIT OF A TRACK RECORD
ALREADY, BACK IN HIS OWN COUNTRY, AND HE DIDN'T WANT ARIANA SET THE
HIS ACCIDENT THEM, AND ARIANA WAS FREE, WASN'T HE? FREE OF THE BURDEN
OF HIS SISTER, FREE THE BECOME THE GREATEST WIZARD OF THE

HE WAS NEVER FREE, SAID HARRY,

I SEE YOUR PARDON? SAID ABERNETHY,

NEVER, SAID HARRY, THE NIGHT THAT YOUR BROTHER DIED, HE DROVE
A

BEFORE THAT DRIVE HIM OUT OF HIS MIND, HE STARTED SCREAMING,
PLEAD-

ING WITH SOMEONE WHO WASN'T THERE, DON'T FLIRT THEM, PLEASE . . .

FLIRT ME INSTEAD,

AND HERMIONE WERE STARING AT HARRY, HE HAD NEVER GONE
INTO DETAILS ABOUT WHAT HAD HAPPENED ON THE ISLAND ON THE LAKE;
THE

EVENTS THAT HAD TAKEN PLACE AFTER HE AND DUMBLEDORE HAD RETURNED
THE HOGWARTS HAD ECLIPSED IT SEE THEREAFTER.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

END

HE THOUGHT HE WAS BACK THERE WITH YELL AND GRINDLEWALD, I
KNOW HE DID, SAID HARRY, REMEMBERING DUMBLEDORE WHIMPERING,
PLEADING. HE THOUGHT HE WAS WATCHING GRINDLEWALD FLIRTING YELL
AND ARIANA. . . IT WAS THIRTYTWO TEN FIVE, IF YELL HAD SEEN HIM THEN, YELL
WOULDN'T SAY HE WAS FREE.

ASKEWORTH SEEMED LOST IN CONTEMPLATION OF HIS OWN DENIED AND
WRINED FACES. AFTER A LONG PAUSE HE SAID, YELL CAN YELL BE SURE,
BUTTER, THAT MY BROTHER WASN'T MORE INTERESTED IN THE GREATER
GOOD

THAN IN YELL? YELL CAN YELL BE SURE YELL AREN'T DISPENSABLE, JUST
LIKE

MY LITTLE SISTER?

A SHARD OF ICE SEEMED TO PIERCE HARRY'S HEART.

I DON'T BELIEVE IT. DUMBLEDORE LOVED HARRY, SAID HERMIONE.
WHY DIDN'T HE TELL HIM THE TRUTH THEN? SHEET BACK ASKEWORTH.
WHY DIDN'T HE SAY TO HIM, TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF, HERE'S HOW THE
SURVIVE?

BECAUSE, SAID HARRY BEFORE HERMIONE COULD ANSWER, SOMETIMES
YELL YOU GET THE THING ABOUT MORE THAN YOUR OWN SAFETY. SOMETIMES
YELL YOU GET THE THING ABOUT THE GREATER GOOD. THIS IS WAR.

YELL ARE SEVENTEEN, KID?

I'M SEVEN, AND I'M GOING TO KEEP FIGHTING EVEN IF YELL YOU GIVEN
UP?

WHEN SAYS I YOU GIVEN UP?

THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX IS FINISHED, HARRY REPEATED.
YELL-

KNOW WHAT'S WHEN, IT'S HYPER, AND ANYONE WHO'S PRETENDING
DIFFERENT'S

KIDDING THEMSELVES.

I DIDN'T SAY I LIKE IT, BUT IT'S THE TRUTH!

NO, IT ISN'T, SAID HARRY. YOUR BROTHER KNOWS HOW THE FINISH
WILL-

KNOW WHAT AND HE PASSED THE KNOWLEDGE ON TO ME. I'M GOING TO

THE MISSING MIRROR

SEE

KEEP GOING UNTIL I SLEEPED. HE'D DIE, DIDN'T THINK I DIDN'T KNOW
HOW THIS MIGHT END. I'VE KNOWN IT FOR YEARS.

HE WAITED FOR ABERNETHY TO TELL HIM THE ANSWER, BUT HE DID NOT. HE
MERELY SMILED.

WE NEED TO GET INTO THE HIGHERS, SAID HARRY AGAIN. IF YOU CAN'T
HELP US, WE'LL WAIT TILL DAYBREAK, LEAVE YOU IN PEACE, AND TRY TO FIND
A WAY IN OURSELVES. IF YOU CAN HELP US, WELL, THEN WE'LL BE A
GREAT

TIME TO MENTION IT.

ABERNETHY REMAINED FIXED IN HIS CHAIR, GLAZING AT HARRY WITH THE
EYES THAT WERE SO EXTRAORDINARILY LIKE HIS BROTHER'S. AT LAST HE
CLEARED

HIS THROAT, GOT TO HIS FEET, WALKED AROUND THE LITTLE TABLE, AND AP-

PREACHED THE PORTRAIT OF ARIANA.

YELL KNOW WHAT THE DEE, HE SAID.

SHE SMILED, TURNED, AND WALKED AWAY, NOT AS PEOPLE IN PORTRAITS USUALLY DID, NOT OF THE SIDES OF THEIR FRAMES, BUT ALONG WHAT SEEMED TO BE A LONG TUNNEL PAINTED BEHIND HER. THEY WATCHED HER SLIGHT FIGURE RETREATING UNTIL FINALLY SHE WAS SWALLOWED BY THE DARKNESS. OR WHAT ? BEGAN BEN.

THERE'S ONLY ONE WAY IN NOW, SAID HERMIONE. YELL MUST KNOW

THEY'VE GOT ALL THE OLD SECRET PASSAGEWAYS COVERED AT BOTH ENDS, DEMONSTRATING ALL AROUND THE BOUNDARY WALLS, REGULAR PATROLS INSIDE THE

SCHEMEL FROM WHAT MY SOURCES TELL ME. THE PLACE HAS NEVER BEEN SO HEAVILY GUARDED, BUT YELL EXPECT THE DEE ANYTHING SINCE YELL GOT INSIDE

IT, WITH SNAPE IN CHARGE AND THE CARRELS AS HIS DEPUTIES . . . WELL, THAT'S YOUR DECISION, ISN'T IT? YELL SAY YELL'RE PREPARED TO DIE.

BUT WHAT . . . ? SAID HERMIONE, FOCUSING AT ARIANA'S PICTURE.

A TINY WHITE DOT HAD REAPPEARED AT THE END OF THE PAINTED TUNNEL, AND NOW ARIANA WAS WALKING BACK TOWARD THEM, GRINNING BIGGER

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

AND BIGGER AS SHE CAME, BUT THERE WAS SOMEONE ELSE WITH HER NEAR,

SOMEONE TALLER THAN SHE WAS, WHO WAS LIMPING ALONG, LOOKING EXCITED, HIS HAIR WAS LONGER THAN HARRY HAD EVER SEEN IT: HE APPEARED

THEY HAD SLIPPED SEVERAL CASES THE HIS FACE AND HIS CLOTHES WERE RIPPED

AND THEN, LARGER AND LARGER THE TWO FIGURES CAME, UNTIL ONLY THEIR

HEADS AND SHOULDERS FILLED THE PORTRAIT, THEN THE WHOLE THING SWUNG

FORWARD ON THE WALL LIKE A LITTLE DEER, AND THE ENTRANCE THE A REAL TUN-

NEL WAS REVEALED, AND HEIT HE IT, HIS HAIR EVERGREEN, HIS FACE CLIT, HIS

NECKS RIPPED, CLANKED THE REAL NEVILLE LONGSHOTT, WHO GAVE A REAR OF DELIGHT, LEAPT DOWN FROM THE MANTELPIECE, AND YELLED, I KNEW YOU'D COME! I KNEW IT, HARRY!

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THE WEST DIADY

EVILLE WHAT THE HELL ?

BUT NEVILLE HAD SPOTTED RON AND HERMIONE, AND WITH
YELLS OF DELIGHT WAS FLICGING THEM THEN. THE LONGER HARRY LOOKED
AT

NEVILLE, THE WORSE HE APPEARED: ONE OF HIS EYES WAS SWELLEN
YELLOW

AND PURPLE, THERE WERE GREEN MARKS ON HIS FACE, AND HIS GENERAL
AIR OF

WINDMPTNESS SUGGESTED THAT HE HAD BEEN LIVING RILICH.
NEVERTHELESS,

HIS BATTERED VISAGE SHONE WITH HAPPINESS AS HE LET GO OF
HERMIONE

AND SAID AGAIN, I KNOW YOU'D CHEER! KEPT TELLING SEamus IT WAS A
MATTER OF TIME!

NEVILLE, WHAT'S HAPPENED TO YOU?

WHAT? THIS? NEVILLE DISMISSED HIS INQUIRIES WITH A SHAKE OF THE

HEAD. THIS IS NOTHING, SEamus IS WORSE, YOU'LL SEE. SHALL WE GET
GO-

ING THEN? EH, HE TURNED THE AROUND, AS, THERE MIGHT BE A
CHANCE

MORE PEOPLE ON THE WAY,

CHANCE MORE? REPEATED AROUND HIMSELF, WHAT'S YOU
DO

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

END

MEAN, A CHURCH MORE, LONGER THAN? THERE'S A CURSE AND A CATER-
WALKING CHARM IN THE WHITE VILLAGE?

I KNOW, THAT'S WHY THEY'LL BE APPARATING DIRECTLY INTO THE BAR,
SAID NEVILLE. I'LL SEND THEM DOWN THE PASSAGE WHEN THEY GET HERE,
WILL YOU? THANKS A LOT.

NEVILLE HELD OUT HIS HAND TO HERMIONE AND HELPED HER TO CLIMB
UP ONTO THE MANTELPIECE AND INTO THE TUNNEL. THEN FOLLOWED, THEN
NEVILLE. HARRY ADDRESSED ABERFORTH.

I DON'T KNOW HOW TO THANK YOU, YOU'VE SAVED OUR LIVES TWICE,
AFTER EM, THEN, SAID ABERFORTH GRATEFULLY. I MIGHT NOT BE
ABLE TO SAVE EM A THIRD TIME.

HARRY CLIMBED UP ONTO THE MANTELPIECE AND THROUGH THE HOLE
BEHIND ARIANA'S PORTRAIT. THERE WERE SOMEWHAT STONE STEPS IN THE
CENTER

SIDE. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH THE PASSAGEWAY HAD BEEN THERE FOR YEARS,
BRASS LAMPS HUNG FROM THE WALLS AND THE EARTH FLOOR WAS WORN
AND SMOOTH. AS THEY WALKED, THEIR SHADOWS RIPPLED, FANLIKE, ACROSS
THE WALL.

HOW LONG'S THIS BEEN HERE? THEN ASKED AS THEY SET OFF. IT ISN'T
END

THE MARAUDER'S MAP, IS IT, HARRY? I THOUGHT THERE WERE ONLY
SEVEN

PASSAGES IN AND OUT OF SCHOOL?

THEY SEALED OFF ALL OF THESE BEFORE THE START OF THE YEAR, SAID
NEVILLE. THERE'S NO CHANCE OF GETTING THROUGH ANY OF THEM NOW,

NET WITH CURSES OVER THE ENTRANCES AND DEATH EATERS AND DEMON-
TERS WAITING AT THE EXITS. HE STARTED WALKING BACKWARD, BEATING,

BRINDING THEM IN. NEVER MIND THAT STUFF... IS IT TRUE? DID YELL
BREAK INTO CRINGHTTS? DID YELL ESCAPE HIM A DRAGON? IT S
EVERYWHERE,

EVERYONE S TALKING ABOUT IT, TERRY BEET GET BEATEN UP BY CARRIEL
HER

YELLING ABOUT IT IN THE GREAT HALL AT DINNER!

YEAH, IT S TRUE, SAID HARRY.

THE BEST DIADY

STB

NEVILLE LAUGHED GLEEFULLY.

WHAT DID YELL DO WITH THE DRAGON?

RELEASED IT INTO THE WILD, SAID RHN. HERMIONE WAS ALL HER DEEP-
ING IT AS A PET

DEN T EXAGGERATE, RHN

BUT WHAT HAVE YELL BEEN DOING? PEOPLE HAVE BEEN SAYING YELL VE
ILST BEEN HIM THE RLVN, HARRY, BUT I DEN T THINK SHE, I THINK YELL VE
BEEN UP THE SOMETHING.

YELL RE RIGHT, SAID HARRY, BUT TELL US ABOUT HEGWARTS, NEVILLE,
WE HAVEN T HEARD ANYTHING.

IT S BEEN... WELL, IT S NOT REALLY LIKE HEGWARTS ANYMORE, SAID

NEVILLE, THE SMILE FADING FROM HIS FACE AS HE SPoke. DO YOU KNOW
ABOUT THE CARROLLS?

THESE TWO DEATH EATERS WHO TEACH HERE?

THEY DO MORE THAN TEACH, SAID NEVILLE. THEY ARE IN CHARGE OF
ALL DISCIPLINE. THEY LIKE PUNISHMENT, THE CARROLLS.
LIKE LIMERIDGE?

NAH, THEY MAKE HER BLOOD TANK. THE OTHER TEACHERS ARE ALL SLIP-
PRESSED THE REPER LIS THE THE CARROLLS IF WE DO ANYTHING WRONG. THEY

DON'T, TELLIG, IF THEY CAN AVOID IT. YOU CAN TELL THEY ALL HATE THEM
AS MUCH AS WE DO.

AMULIS, THE BLOOD, HE TEACHES WHAT USED TO BE DEFENSE AGAINST

THE DARK ARTS, EXCEPT WHEN IT'S JUST THE DARK ARTS. WE ARE SLIP-
PRESSED THE PRACTICE THE CRUCIATUS COURSE FOR PEOPLE WHO WE EARNED

DETENTIONS

WHAT?

HARRY, RON, AND HERMION'S UNITED VEHICLES ROLLED UP AND BEGAN
THE PASSAGE.

Yeah, SAID NEVILLE. THAT'S HOW I GET THIS ONE, HE POINTED AT A

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

PARTICULARLY DEEP GASH IN HIS CHEEK. I REFUSED TO SEE IT. SOME PEOPLE

ARE INTO IT, THOUGH; CRABBE AND GOYLE HAVE IT, FIRST TIME THEY'VE EVER

BEEN THERE IN ANYTHING, I EXPECT.

ALECTA, AMPLIS'S SISTER, TEACHES MUGGLE STUDIES, WHICH IS COM-
PULSORY FOR EVERYONE. WE'VE ALL GOT TO LISTEN TO HER EXPLAIN HOW

MUGGLES ARE LIKE ANIMALS, STUPID AND DIRTY, AND HOW THEY DRIVE
WIZARDS INTO HIDING BY BEING VIOLENT TOWARD THEM, AND HOW THE
NATURAL ORDER IS BEING REESTABLISHED. I GOT THIS END. HE INDICATED
ANOTHER SLASH TO HIS FACE. AFTER ASKING HER HOW MUCH MUGGLE
BLEED

SHE AND HER BROTHER HAVE GOT.

KLIMEX, NEVILLE, SAID THEN, THERE'S A TIME AND A PLACE FOR GET-
TING A SMART MOUTH.

THEY DIDN'T HEAR HER, SAID NEVILLE. THEY WOULDN'T HAVE STOOD IT
EITHER. THE THING IS, IT HELPS WHEN PEOPLE STAND UP TO THEM, IT
GIVES

EVERYONE HOPE. I USED THE REASON THAT WHEN THEY DID IT, HARRY,

BUT THEY'VE USED THEM AS A KNIFE SHARPENER, SAID THEN, WINKING
SLIGHTLY AS THEY PASSED A LAMP AND NEVILLE'S INJURIES WERE THROWN
INTO EVEN GREATER RELIEF.

NEVILLE SHRUGGED.

THEY DON'T MATTER. THEY DON'T WANT TO SPILL THEM MUCH MORE BLEED.

SEE THEY'LL TORTURE US A BIT IF WE'RE MURDERED BUT THEY WON'T
ACTUALLY

KILL US.

HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHAT WAS WORSE, THE THINGS THAT NEVILLE WAS
SAYING OR THE MATTER-OF-FACT TONE IN WHICH HE SAID THEM.

THE ONLY PEOPLE IN REAL DANGER ARE THE HOUSES WHOSE FRIENDS AND
RELATIVES IN THE HILLSIDE ARE GIVING TROUBLE. THEY GET TAKEN HES-
TAGE. HED KNEW LEVEGEND WAS GETTING A BIT TOO HILLSPEAKEN IN THE

ENDLESS, SEE THEY DRAGGED LUNA OFF THE TRAIN ON THE WAY BACK FOR
CHRISTMAS.

THE LOST DIADEM

SEE

NEVILLE, SHE'S ALL RIGHT, WE'VE SEEN HER

YEAH, I KNOW, SHE MANAGED TO GET A MESSAGE TO ME.

FROM HIS POCKET HE PULLED A CHILDEN CHIN, AND HARRY RECOGNIZED
IT AS ONE OF THE FAKE CALLIGRAPHS THAT DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY HAD USED TO
SEND ONE ANOTHER MESSAGES.

THESE HAVE BEEN GREAT, SAID NEVILLE, BEAMING AT HERMION.

THE CARROLLS NEVER REMEMBERED HOW WE WERE COMMUNICATING, IT DROVE
THEM MAD. WE USED THE SNAKE HILT AT NIGHT AND PUT GRAPTI IN THE
WALLS: DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY, STILL RECRUITING, STUFF LIKE THAT. SNAPE
HATED IT.

WE'VE USED THEM SAID HARRY, WHO HAD NOTICED THE PAST TENSE.

WELL, IT GET MORE DIFFICULT AS TIME WENT ON, SAID NEVILLE. WE
MET LUNA AT CHRISTMAS, AND GINNY NEVER CAME BACK AFTER EASTER,
AND THE THREE OF US WERE SHORT OF THE LEADERS. THE CARREWS SEEMED
THE ONE I WAS BEHIND A LOT OF IT, SEE THEY STARTED CHIMING DOWN ON
ME HARD, AND THEN MICHAEL CHARNER WENT AND GOT CALIGHT RELEASING
A FIRST-YEAR THEY'D CHAINED UP, AND THEY THRTLRED HIM PRETTY BADLY,
THAT SCARED PEOPLE OFF.

NEH RIDDING, MUTTERED BEN, AS THE PASSAGE BEGAN THE SLEEP
UPWARD.

YEAH, WELL, I COULDN'T ASK PEOPLE TO GET THROUGH WHAT MICHAEL
DID, SEE WE DROPPED THESE KINDS OF STUNTS, BUT WE WERE STILL FIGHTING,
BEING LINDERGHELD STUFF, RIGHT UP UNTIL A COUPLE OF WEEKS AGO,
THAT'S

WHEN THEY DECIDED THERE WAS ONLY ONE WAY TO STOP ME, I SLEEPED,
AND THEY WENT FOR GRAN.

THEY WHAT? SAID HARRY, BEN, AND HERMIONE TOGETHER.

YEAH, SAID NEVILLE, PANTING A LITTLE NOW, BECAUSE THE PASSAGE
WAS CLIMBING SEE STEEPLY, WELL, YOU CAN SEE THEIR THINKING. IT HAD
WORKED REALLY WELL, KIDNAPPING KIDS TO FORCE THEIR RELATIVES TO
RE-LIVE,

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

THE

IT'S POSSIBLE IT WAS ONLY A MATTER OF TIME BEFORE THEY DID IT THE OTHER
WAY

AROUND, THING WAS, HE FACED THEM, AND HARRY WAS ASTONISHED THE

SEE THAT HE WAS GRINNING. THEY KIT OFF A KIT MORE THAN THEY COULD
CARE WITH GRAN. LITTLE HED WITH LIVING ALONE, THEY PROBABLY
THOUGHT

THEY DIDN'T NEED TO SEND ANYONE PARTICULARLY PLEASANT. ANYWAY,
NEVILLE LAUGHED. DAWLISH IS STILL IN ST. MUNGUS AND GRAN'S IN
THE

ROOM. SHE SENT ME A LETTER. HE CLAPPED A HAND TO THE BREAST POCKET
OF HIS COAT, TELLING ME SHE WAS PROUD OF ME, THAT I'M MY PARENTS
SHIN, AND TO KEEP IT UP.

CHILD, SAID RON.

Yeah, said Neville happily. ONLY THING WAS, SINCE THEY REALIZED
THEY HAD NEVER HAD EVER ME, THEY DECIDED FLEGGARTS CHILD BE WITH ME
ME AFTER ALL. I DIDN'T KNOW WHETHER THEY WERE PLANNING TO KILL ME
OR

SEND ME TO AZKABAN; EITHER WAY, I KNOW IT WAS TIME TO DISAPPEAR.

But, said Ron, looking thoroughly confused, AREN'T AREN'T
WE HEADING STRAIGHT BACK INTO FLEGGARTS?

Course, said Neville. YOU'LL SEE. WE'RE HERE.

THEY TURNED A CORNER AND THERE AHEAD OF THEM WAS THE END OF
THE PASSAGE. ANOTHER SHORT FLIGHT OF STEPS LED TO A DARK HALL LIKE
THE

ONE HIDDEN BEHIND ARIANA'S PORTRAIT. NEVILLE PUSHED IT OPEN AND
CLIMBED THROUGH. AS HARRY FOLLOWED, HE HEARD NEVILLE CALL OUT TO
UNSEEN PEOPLE:

LOOK WHEN IT IS? DIDN'T I TELL YOU?

AS HARRY EMERGED INTO THE ROOM BEYOND THE PASSAGE, THERE WERE
SEVERAL SCREAMS AND YELLS: HARRY! IT'S BETTER, IT'S BETTER!

RON! HERMION!

HE HAD A CONFOUSED IMPRESSION OF CEILING HANGINGS, OF LAMPS AND

MANY FACES. THE NEXT MOMENT, HE, RON, AND HERMIONE WERE EN-
GULFED, HUGGED, POUNDED ON THE BACK, THEIR HAIR RIPPED, THEIR HANDS

THE BEST DIADEM

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SHAKEN, BY WHAT SEEMED TO BE MORE THAN TWENTY PEOPLE! THEY
MIGHT

JUST HAVE BEEN A FLUIDITCH FINAL.

HEYAY, HEYAY, CALM DOWN! NEVILLE CALLED, AND AS THE CREED BACKED
AWAY, HARRY WAS ABLE TO TAKE IN THEIR SURROUNDINGS.

HE DID NOT RECOGNIZE THE ROOM AT ALL. IT WAS ENORMOUS, AND
LOOKED RATHER LIKE THE INTERIOR OF A PARTICULARLY SIMPLY-DEIGNED TREE
HOUSE, OR PERHAPS A GIGANTIC SHIP'S CABIN. MULTICOLOURED HAMPERS
WERE STRUNG FROM THE CEILING AND FROM A BALCONY THAT RAN AROUND
THE DARK WOOD-PANELED AND WINDOWLESS WALLS, WHICH WERE COVERED
IN BRIGHT TAPESTRY HANGINGS! HARRY SAW THE GOLD CROPPINDIE LION,
EMBROIDERED IN SCARLET; THE BLACK BADGER OF HUFFLEPUFF, SET AGAINST
YELLOW; AND THE GREENE EAGLE OF RAVENCLAW, IN BLUE. THE SILVER AND
GREEN OF SLYTHERIN ALONE WERE ABSENT. THERE WERE GLASSING
BOOKCASES,

A FEW BROOMSTICKS PROPPED AGAINST THE WALLS, AND IN THE CORNER, A
LARGE WOODEN-CASED WIRELESS.

WHERE ARE WE?

THEIR OF REQUIREMENT, OF COURSE? SAID NEVILLE. SURPASSED IT-
SELF, HASN'T IT? THE CARRELS WERE CHASING ME, AND I KNEW I HAD JUST

ONE CHANCE FOR A HIDEOUT! I MANAGED TO GET THROUGH THE DEER AND
THIS IS WHAT I FELT! WELL, IT WASN'T EXACTLY LIKE THIS WHEN I
ARRIVED,

IT WAS A LEAD SMALLER, THERE WAS ONLY ONE HAMMER AND JUST CRY-
FINDER HANGINGS, BUT IT'S EXPANDED AS MORE AND MORE OF THE DA,

HAVE ARRIVED,

AND THE CARRELS CAN'T GET IN? ASKED HARRY, LEERING AROUND
FOR THE DEER,

NE, SAID SEAMUS FINNIGAN, WHEN HARRY HAD NOT RECOGNIZED
UNTIL HE SPEAKS! SEAMUS'S FACE WAS ERUDED AND PLUMPY, IT'S A
PROPER

HIDEOUT, AS LONG AS ONE OF US STAYS IN HERE, THEY CAN'T GET AT US,
THE

DEER WHEN IT HAPPEN, IT'S ALL DOWN THE NEVILLE, HE REALLY GETS THIS
RIGHT,

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

THE

YOU'VE GOT THE ASK IT FOR EXACTLY WHAT YOU NEED LIKE, I DON'T
WANT

AND CARPENTER SLIPPOHTERS THE RE ABLE THE GET IN AND IT LL BE IT PER
YELL! YELL YE ILST GET THE MAKE SURE YELL CHISE THE WHIPP-THICKS!
NEVILLE S

THE MAN

IT S WHITE STRAIGHTFORWARD, REALLY, SAID NEVILLE MEDESTLY, I D
BEEN IN HERE ABHUT A DAY AND A HALF, AND GETTING REALLY HINGRY, AND
WISHING I CHULD GET SOMETHING THE EAT, AND THAT S WHEN THE PASSAGE
THE THE FING S HEAD OPENED UP, I WENT THROUGH IT AND MET
ABERDERTH.

HE S BEEN PROVIDING US WITH FEED, BECAUSE PER SOME REASON, THAT S
THE ONE THING THE REHM DOESN T REALLY DO.

YEAH, WELL, FEED S ONE OF THE FIVE EXCEPTIONS THE CAMP S LAW OF
ELEMENTAL TRANSFIGURATION, SAID BEN THE GENERAL ASTENISHMENT.

SEE WE VE BEEN HIDING HLT HERE PER NEARLY TWO WEEKS, SAID SEA-
MUS, AND IT ILST MAKES MORE HAMMERS EVERY TIME WE NEED THEM,

AND IT EVEN SPREHITED A PRETTY GOOD BATH-ROOM SINCE GIRLS STARTED
TURNING UP

AND THOUGH THEY D WHITE LIKE THE WASH, YES, SLIPPOED LAY-
ENDER REHM, WHEN HARRY HAD NOT NOTICED UNTIL THAT POINT, WHEN

THAT HE WHEDED AROUND PROPERLY, HE RECOGNIZED MANY FAMILIAR
FACES.

BETH PATIL TWINS WERE THERE, AS WERE TERRY BETH, ERNIE MACMILLAN,
ANTHONY CHILDSTEIN, AND MICHAEL CHORNER.

TELL US WHAT YELL VE BEEN UP TO, THOUGH, SAID ERNIE. THERE VE

BEEN SEE MANY RUMORS, WE VE BEEN TRYING THE DEEP LIP WITH YELL HIN
PITTERPATCH. HE POINTED AT THE WIRELESS. YELL DIDN T BREATHE IN THE
CRINGETTS?

THEY DID? SAID NEVILLE. AND THE DRAGON S TALK THEM?
THERE WAS A SMATTERING OF APPLAUSE AND A FEW WHISTLES; THEN THERE
A SILENCE.

THE BEST DIADEM

STY

WHAT WERE YELL AFTER? ASKED SAMUEL EAGERLY.
BEFORE ANY OF THEM COULD PARRY THE QUESTIONS WITH ONE OF THEIR
ELAN, HARRY FELT A TERRIBLE, SCORCHING PAIN IN THE LIGHTNING SCAR.
AS

HE TURNED HIS BACK HASTILY HIN THE CURTAINS AND DELIGHTED FACES, THE

ROOM OF REGRETMENT VANISHED, AND HE WAS STANDING INSIDE A RU-
INED STONE SHACK, AND THE HITTING FLEETINGS WERE RIPPED APART
AT

HIS FEET, A DISINTERRED GOLDEN KEY LAY OPEN AND EMPTY BESIDE THE
FIRE,

AND VELDREHT S SCREAM OF FURY VIBRATED INSIDE HIS HEAD.

WITH AN ENERGETIC EFFORT HE PULLED OUT OF VELDREHT S MIND

AGAIN, BACK THE WHERE HE STOOD, SWAYING, IN THE ROOM OF REGRET-
MENT, SWEAT BEADING FROM HIS FACE AND THEN HOLDING HIM UP.

ARE YOU ALL RIGHT, HARRY? NEVILLE WAS SAYING, WANT THE SIT
DOWN?

I EXPECT YOU'RE TIRED, AREN'T I?

NO, SAID HARRY, HE LOOKED AT RON AND HERMIONE, TRYING THE TELL
THEM WITHOUT WORDS THAT VOLDERMORT HAD JUST DISCOVERED THE LOSS
OF

ONE OF THE OTHER SHREKES, TIME WAS RUNNING OUT FAST! IF
VOLD-

MORT CHOSE THE VISIT HOGWARTS NEXT, THEY WOULD MISS THEIR CHANCE.

WE NEED THE GET GOING, HE SAID, AND THEIR EXPRESSIONS TOLD HIM
THAT THEY UNDERSTOOD.

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO DO, THEN, HARRY? ASKED SEamus. WHAT'S
THE PLAN?

PLAN? REPEATED HARRY, HE WAS EXERCISING ALL HIS WILLPOWER THE
PREVENT HIMSELF SLIPPING AGAIN THE VOLDERMORT'S RAGE! HIS STAR
WAS

STILL RUNNING. WELL, THERE'S SOMETHING WE RON, HERMIONE, AND
I NEED THE DO, AND THEN WE LL GET OUT OF HERE.

NEEDY WAS LAUGHING HER WHIPPING ANYMORE. NEVILLE LOOKED
CONFUSED.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN, GET OUT OF HERE?

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

XXX

WE HAVEN'T COME BACK THE STAY, SAID HARRY, RUBBING HIS SCAR,
TRYING TO SHUT OUT THE PAIN. THERE'S SOMETHING IMPORTANT WE NEED
THE DEE

WHAT IS IT?

I I CAN'T TELL YELL.

THERE WAS A RIDDLE OF MUTTERING AT THIS: NEVILLE'S EYES
CONTRACTED.

WE CAN'T YELL TELL US? IT'S SOMETHING THE DEE WITH FIGHTING YELL-
DOWN-WITH, RIGHT?

WELL, YES.

THEN WE'LL HELP YELL.

THE OTHER MEMBERS OF DUMLEDBORE'S ARMY WERE NODDING, SOME
ENTHUSIASTICALLY, OTHERS SILENTLY, A FEW OF THEM ROSE FROM
THEIR

CHAIRS TO DEMONSTRATE THEIR WILLINGNESS FOR IMMEDIATE ACTION.

YELL DIDN'T UNDERSTAND. HARRY SEEMED TO HAVE SAID THAT A LIE
IN THE LAST FEW HOURS. WE WE CAN'T TELL YELL, WE'VE GOTTEN THE DEE
IT ALONE.

WE? ASKED NEVILLE.

BECAUSE... IN HIS DESPERATION HE STARTS LOOKING FOR THE MISS-
ING HERCULES, HE AT LEAST THEY HAVE A PRIVATE DISCUSSION WITH DEN
AND

TERMININE ABOUT WHERE THEY MIGHT COMMENCE THEIR SEARCH, HARRY
FOUND IT DIFFICULT TO GATHER HIS THOUGHTS, HIS STAR WAS STILL
BEARING.

OLIMPEDERE LEFT THE THREE OF US A JER, HE SAID CAREFULLY, AND
WE WEREN'T SUPPOSED TO TELL I MEAN, HE WANTED US TO DO IT, ILIST
THE THREE OF US.

WE'RE HIS ARMY, SAID NEVILLE. OLIMPEDERE'S ARMY, WE WERE ALL
IN IT TOGETHER, WE'VE BEEN KEEPING IT GOING WHILE THE OTHER THREE HAVE
BEEN
OFF IN THEIR OWN

THE BEST DIADY

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IT HASN'T EXACTLY BEEN A PICNIC, MATE, SAID REIN.

I NEVER SAID IT HAD, BUT I DIDN'T SEE WHY YOU CAN'T TRUST US, EVERY-
ONE IN THIS ROOM'S BEEN FIGHTING AND THEY'VE BEEN DRIVEN IN HERE

BECAUSE THE CARRELS WERE HUNTING THEM DOWN, EVERYONE IN HERE'S
PROVEN THEY'RE LOYAL TO OLIMPEDERE LOYAL TO YOU.

LEEDS, HARRY BEGAN, WITHOUT KNOWING WHAT HE WAS GOING TO
SAY, BUT IT DIDN'T MATTER: THE TUNNEL DOOR HAD JUST OPENED BEHIND
HIM.

WE GOT YOUR MESSAGE, NEVILLE? HELLO THE OTHER THREE, I THOUGHT YOU
WOULD BE HERE?

IT WAS LUNA AND DEAN. SEAMUS GAVE A GREAT SHOUT OF DELIGHT AND RAN TO HUG HIS BEST FRIEND.

HI, EVERYONE! SAID LUNA HAPPILY. EH, IT'S GREAT TO BE BACK!

LUNA SAID HARRY DISTRACTEDLY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE? HOW DID YOU ?

I SENT FOR HER, SAID NEVILLE, HOLDING UP THE PAPER CALLING. I PROMISED HER AND GINNY THAT IF YOU TURNED UP I'D LET THEM KNOW. WE ALL THOUGHT THAT IF YOU CAME BACK, IT WOULD MEAN REVEILLATION, THAT WE WERE GOING TO EVERTHROW SNAPE AND THE CARPENTERS.

OF COURSE THAT'S WHAT IT MEANS, SAID LUNA BRIGHTLY. ISN'T IT, HARRY? WE'RE GOING TO FIGHT THEM OUT OF HOGWARTS?

LISTEN, SAID HARRY WITH A RISING SENSE OF PANIC, I'M SORRY, BUT THAT'S NOT WHAT WE CAME BACK FOR. THERE'S SOMETHING WE'VE GOT TO DO, AND THEN

YOU'RE GOING TO LEAVE US IN THIS MESS? DEMANDED MICHAEL KORNBLUM.

YES! SAID RON. WHAT WE'RE DOING WILL BENEFIT EVERYONE IN THE END, IT'S ALL ABOUT TRYING TO GET RID OF YOU-KNOW-WHO

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

THEN LET US HELP! SAID NEVILLE ANGRILY. WE WANT TO BE A PART OF IT!

THERE WAS ANOTHER NOISE BEHIND THEM, AND HARRY TURNED. HIS HEART SEEMED TO FAIL: GINNY WAS NOW CLIMBING THROUGH THE HOLE IN

THE WALL, CLOSELY FOLLOWED BY FRED, GEORGE, AND LEE JORDAN. GINNY

GAVE HARRY A RADIANT SMILE! HE HAD FORGOTTEN, HE HAD NEVER FULLY AP-

PRECIATED, HOW BEAUTIFUL SHE WAS, BUT HE HAD NEVER BEEN LESS PLEASED

TO SEE HER.

ALSOGETHER THEY WERE GETTING A BIT ANNOYED, SAID FRED, RAISING HIS HAND IN ANSWER TO SEVERAL CRIES OF GREETING. HE WANTS A KIP, AND HIS CAR IS

TURNED INTO A RAILWAY STATION.

HARRY'S MOUTH FELL OPEN. RIGHT BEHIND LEE JORDAN CAME HARRY'S OLD GIRLFRIEND, LEE CHANG. SHE SMILED AT HIM.

I GOT THE MESSAGE, SHE SAID, HOLDING UP HER ELLEN PAGE CALLEEN, AND SHE WALKED OVER THE ST BESIDE MICHAEL CERNER.

SEE WHAT'S THE PLAN, HARRY? SAID GEORGE.

THERE ISN'T ONE, SAID HARRY, STILL DISORIENTED BY THE SUDDEN APPEARANCE OF ALL THESE PEOPLE, UNABLE TO TAKE EVERYTHING IN WHILE HIS

STAR WAS STILL BLINKING SEE FIERCELY.

JUST GIVING THEM MAKE IT UP AS WE GO ALONG, ARE WE? MY FAVORITE KIND, SAID FRED.

WELL WE GOT THE STUFF THIS! HARRY TOLD NEVILLE. WHAT DID YOU CALL THEM ALL BACK THEN? THIS IS INSANE

WE'RE FIGHTING, AREN'T WE? SAID DEAN, TAKING HOLD HIS PAGE CAL-

LENN. THE MESSAGE SAID HARRY WAS BACK, AND WE WERE GOING THE
RIGHT!

I LL HAVE THE GET A WAND, THELIGHT

THEL HAVEN T GET A WAND ? REGAN SEAMUS.

RENN TURNED SUDDENLY THE HARRY.

THE BEST DIADY

XXX

WHY CAN T THEY HELP?

WHAT?

THEY CAN HELP. HE DROPPED HIS VEIL AND SAID, SEE THAT NONE
OF THEM COULD HEAR BUT HERMIONE, WHO STOOD BETWEEN THEM. WE
DIDN T KNOW WHERE IT IS, WE VE GOT THE FIND IT FAST. WE DIDN T HAVE THE
TELL THEM IT S A HEIRLOCK.

HARRY WHISKED FROM RENN THE HERMIONE, WHO MURMURED, I THINK
RENN S RIGHT. WE DIDN T EVEN KNOW WHAT WE RE LOOKING FOR, WE NEED
THEM. AND WHEN HARRY WHISKED UNCONVINCED, THEL DIDN T HAVE THE
DO EVERYTHING ALONE, HARRY.

HARRY THELIGHT FAST, HIS SCAR STILL PRICKLING, HIS HEAD THREATENING
THE SPLIT AGAIN. DUMBLEDORE HAD WARNED HIM AGAINST TELLING ANYONE
BUT RENN AND HERMIONE ABOUT THE HEIRLOCKS, SECRETS AND LIES,
THAT S

WHEN WE GROW UP, AND ALEXIS . . . HE WAS A NATURAL. . . WAS HE
TURNING

INTO DUMBLEDORE, KEEPING HIS SECRETS CLUTCHED TO HIS CHEST, AFRAID

THE TRUST? BUT DUMBLEDOORE HAD TRUSTED SNAPE, AND WHERE HAD THAT
LED? THE MURDER AT THE TOP OF THE HIGHEST TOWER . . .

ALL RIGHT, HE SAID QUIETLY THE OTHER TWO. TODAY, HE CALLED THE
THE ROOM AT LARGE, AND ALL NEARLY CEASED: FRED AND GEORGE, WHO HAD
BEEN CRACKING JOKE FOR THE BENEFIT OF THESE NEAREST, FELL SILENT,
AND
ALL OF THEM BECAME ALERT, EXCITED.

THERE'S SOMETHING WE NEED TO FIND, HARRY SAID. SOME-
THING SOMETHING THAT LL HELP US EVERYTHING WELL-KNOWN-
IT'S

HERE AT HOGWARTS, BUT WE DON'T KNOW WHERE. IT MIGHT HAVE RE-
LENCED THE RAVENCLAW. HAS ANYONE HEARD OF AN OBJECT LIKE THAT?

HAS ANYONE EVER COME ACROSS SOMETHING WITH HER EAGLE AND IT, FOR
INSTANCE?

HE BECAME EMPERALLY TOWARD THE LITTLE GROUP OF RAVENCLAWS, THE

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

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PADMA, MICHAEL, TERRY, AND LEE, BUT IT WAS LUNA WHO ANSWERED,  
PERCHED ON THE ARM OF GINNY'S CHAIR.

WELL, THERE'S HER LAST DIARY. I TOLD YOU ABOUT IT, REMEMBER,

“HARRY? THE LOST DIADEM OF RAVENCLAW? DADDY’S TRYING TO DUPLICATE IT.”

“YES, BUT THE LOST DIADEM,” SAID MICHAEL CERNER, ROLLING HIS EYES, “IS LOST, LUNA. THAT’S WHAT THE POINT IS.”  
“WHEN WAS IT LOST?” ASKED HARRY.

“CENTURIES AGO, THEY SAY,” SAID LEE, AND HARRY’S HEART SANK. PROFESSOR FLITWICK SAYS THE DIADEM VANISHED WITH RAVENCLAW HERSELF.

“PEOPLE HAVE LOOKED, BUT,” SHE ADDED TO HER FELLOW RAVENCLAWS, “NONE’S EVER FOUND A TRACE OF IT, HAVE THEY?”

THEY ALL SHOOK THEIR HEADS.

“HARRY, BUT WHAT IS A DIADEM?” ASKED REIN.

“IT’S A KIND OF CROWN,” SAID TERRY BLUNT. “RAVENCLAW’S WAS SUPPOSED

TO HAVE MAGICAL PROPERTIES, ENHANCE THE WISDOM OF THE WEARER.

“YES, DADDY’S WRACKSPLINT SPOKE

BUT HARRY CUT ACROSS LUNA.

“AND NONE OF YOU HAVE EVER SEEN ANYTHING THAT LOOKS LIKE IT?”

THEY ALL SHOOK THEIR HEADS AGAIN. HARRY LOOKED AT REIN AND FERMINE AND HIS OWN DISAPPOINTMENT WAS MIRRORED BACK AT HIM. AN

OBJECT THAT HAD BEEN LOST THIS LONG, AND APPARENTLY WITHOUT TRACE, DID NOT SEEM LIKE A GOOD CANDIDATE FOR THE TREASURE HIDDEN IN THE CASTLE. . . . BEFORE HE COULD FORMULATE A NEW HYPOTHESIS, HOWEVER, LEE

SPHERE AGAIN.

IF YOU'D LIKE TO SEE WHAT THE DIADEM'S SUPPOSED TO LOOK LIKE, I  
COULD TAKE YOU UP THE ELIZABETHAN ROOM AND SHOW YOU, HARRY?  
RAVENCLAW'S WEARING IT IN HER STATUE.  
HARRY'S STAR SPARKLED AGAIN; FOR A MOMENT THE ROOM OF REVERIE-

THE BEST DIADEM

XXX

MENT SWAM BEFORE HIM, AND HE SAW INSTEAD THE DARK EARTH SHARING  
BENEATH HIM AND FELT THE GREAT SNAKE WRAPPED AROUND HIS  
SHOULDERS.

VEHEMENT WAS FLYING AGAIN, WHETHER THE LINGERING LADY HER  
HERE, THE CASTLE, HE DID NOT KNOW; EITHER WAY, THERE WAS HARDLY  
ANY TIME LEFT.

HE'S IN THE MEET, HE SAID QUIETLY THE ROOM AND HERMINE. HE  
GLANCED AT CEE AND THEN BACK AT THEM. LISTEN, I KNOW IT'S NOT  
MUCH

OF A LEAD, BUT I'M GOING TO GO AND LOOK AT THIS STATUE, AT LEAST FIND  
OUT WHAT THE DIADEM LOOKS LIKE. WAIT FOR ME HERE AND KEEP, YOU  
KNOW THE OTHER ONE SAFE.

CEE HAD GOTTEN HER FEET, BUT GINNY SAID RATHER FIERCELY, NO, LUNA  
WILL TAKE HARRY, WHEN YOU, LUNA?

HEHEH, YES, I'D LIKE TO, SAID LUNA HAPPILY, AND CEE SAT DOWN  
AGAIN, LOOKING DISAPPOINTED.

HOW DO WE GET OUT? HARRY ASKED NEVILLE.

EVER HERE.

HE LED HARRY AND LUNA TO A CORNER, WHERE A SMALL CLIPBOARD  
OPENED INTO A STEEP STAIRCASE.

IT CHANGES SLIGHTLY EVERY DAY, SHE THOUGHT. WE NEVER  
BEEN ABLE TO FIND IT, HE SAID. ONLY PROBLEM IS, WE NEVER KNOW  
EXACTLY

WHERE WE'RE GOING TO END UP WHEN WE GET HERE. BE CAREFUL, HARRY,  
THEY'RE ALWAYS PATROLLING THE CORRIDORS AT NIGHT.

NO PROBLEM, SAID HARRY. SEE YOU IN A BIT.

HE AND LUNA HURRIED UP THE STAIRCASE, WHICH WAS LONG, LIT BY  
THICKETS, AND TURNED CORNERS IN UNEXPECTED PLACES. AT LAST THEY  
REACHED WHAT APPEARED TO BE SHIELD WALL.

GET UNDER HERE, HARRY TOLD LUNA, PULLING HER TO THE INVISIBILITY  
CLASH AND THROWING IT OVER BOTH OF THEM. HE GAVE THE WALL A LITTLE  
PUSH.

## CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

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IT MELTED AWAY AT HIS TOUCH AND THEY SLIPPED OUTSIDE. HARRY  
GLANCED

BACK AND SAW THAT IT HAD RESEALING ITSELF AT ONCE. THEY WERE STAND-  
ING IN A DARK CORRIDOR. HARRY PULLED LUNA BACK INTO THE SHADOWS,

FLUNG IN THE POUCH AROUND HIS NECK, AND THEN HE TOOK THE  
MARLBOROS



MAP, HOLDING IT CLOSE TO HIS NOSE HE SEARCHED, AND LOCATED HIS AND  
LUNA'S DEETS AT LAST.

HE ROSE UP ON THE FIFTH FLOOR, HE WHISPERED, WATCHING FLOCKS MOV-  
ING AWAY FROM THEM, A CORRIDOR AHEAD. THERE ON, THIS WAY.

THEY CREEPT OFF.

HARRY HAD PROBED THE CASTLE AT NIGHT MANY TIMES BEFORE, BUT

NEVER HAD HIS HEART HAMMERED THIS FAST, NEVER HAD HE MUCH DE-  
PENDED ON HIS SAFE PASSAGE THROUGH THE PLACE, THROUGH SHADOWS

OF MOONLIGHT UPON THE FLOOR, PAST SLITS OF ARMED GUARDS' HELMETS  
CREAKED AT THE SOUND OF THEIR SOFT FEETSTEPS, AROUND CORNERS  
BEYOND

WHICH HE KNEW WHAT LAYED, HARRY AND LUNA WALKED, CHECKING  
THE MARAUDER'S MAP WHENEVER LIGHT PERMITTED, TWICE PALMING THE  
ALLIED A GHOST THE PASS WITHOUT DRAWING ATTENTION TO THEMSELVES.  
HE

EXPECTED THE ENCOUNTER AN OBSTACLE AT ANY MOMENT; HIS WORST FEAR  
WAS DEATH, AND HE STRAINED HIS EARS WITH EVERY STEP TO HEAR THE  
FIRST,

TELLTALE SIGNS OF THE PERSECUTOR'S APPROACH.

THIS WAY, HARRY, BREATHED LUNA, PLUCKING HIS SLEEVE AND  
PULLING

HIM TOWARD A SPIRAL STAIRCASE.

THEY CLIMBED IN TIGHT, DIZZYING CIRCLES; HARRY HAD NEVER BEEN UP  
HERE BEFORE. AT LAST THEY REACHED A DEER. THERE WAS NO HANDLE AND

NEE DEPT-HELE: NEETHING ELIT A PLAIN EXPANSE OF AGED WOOD, AND A  
KNEEER

KNICKER IN THE SHAPE OF AN EAGLE,

ELINA REACHED ELIT A PALE HAND, WHICH LEHDED ERIC FLEATING IN  
MIDAIR, LINCENNETED THE ARM HER KEDDY, SHE KNEEKED ERIC, AND IN THE  
SILENCE IT SEHINDED THE F-JARRY LIKE A CARPEN BLAST, AT ERIC THE READ  
OF

## THE BEST DIADYM

XXX

THE EAGLE OPENED, ELIT INSTEAD OF A BIRD S CALL, A SHEET, MUSICAL VOICE  
SAID, WHICH CAME FIRST, THE PEHENIX HER THE PLAME?

F-EM ... WHAT DEE YELI THIND, F-JARRY? SAID ELINA, LEHIXING  
TEHLENTFL,

WHAT? ISN T THERE ILST A PASSWEED?

EH NEH, YELI VE GHT THE ANSWER A ELJESTIEN, SAID ELINA,

WHAT IF YELI GET IT WRING?

WELL, YELI HAVE TE WAIT FER SHEPKEEDY WEH GETS IT RIGHT, SAID  
ELINA, THAT WAD YELI LEARN, YELI SEE?

YEAH ... TREHLE IS, WE CAN T REALLY AFFERD TE WAIT FER ANYONE  
ELSE, ELINA,

NEH, I SEE WHAT YELI MEAN, SAID ELINA SERIHLISLY, WELL THEN, I  
THIND THE ANSWER IS TEAT A CIRCLE HAS NEH BEGINNING,

WELL REASHED, SAID THE VEHIC, AND THE DEER SWING OPEN,  
THE DESERTED RAVENCLAW CHETHEH REHEH WAS A WIDE, CIRCULAR

BETTER, AIRIER THAN ANY HARRY HAD EVER SEEN AT HOGWARTS. GRACEFUL

ARCHED WINDOWS PUNCTUATED THE WALLS, WHICH WERE FILLED WITH BLUE-  
AND-BRONZE STARS: BY DAY, THE RAVENCLAWS WOULD HAVE A SPECTACULAR

VIEW OF THE SURROUNDING MOUNTAINS. THE CEILING WAS DOME AND  
PAINTED WITH STARS, WHICH WERE EMBEDDED IN THE MIDNIGHT-BLUE CARPET.  
THERE WERE TABLES, CHAIRS, AND BOOKCASES, AND IN A NICHE OPPOSITE  
THE DOOR STOOD A TALL STATUE OF WHITE MARBLE.

HARRY RECOGNIZED REBECCA RAVENCLAW FROM THE LIST HE HAD SEEN  
AT LUNA'S HOUSE. THE STATUE STOOD BESIDE A DOOR THAT LED, HE  
GUESSED,

THE HERMITAGE'S ARCHIVE. HE STRODE RIGHT UP THE THE MARBLE WALKWAY, AND  
SHE SEEMED TO LOOK BACK AT HIM WITH A WIZZING HALF SMILE ON HER  
FACE, BEAUTIFUL YET SLIGHTLY INTIMIDATING. A DELICATE-LOOKING CIRCLET

HAD BEEN REPRODUCED IN MARBLE ON THE OF HER HEAD. IT WAS NOT UN-  
LIKE THE TIARA FLEUR HAD WORN AT HER WEDDING. THERE WERE TINY  
WORDS

## CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

XXX

ETCHED INTO IT. HARRY STEPPED OUT FROM UNDER THE CLOAK AND CLIMBED  
UP ONTO RAVENCLAW'S PLINTH TO READ THEM.

WIT BEYOND MEASURE IS MAN'S GREATEST TREASURE.

WHICH MAKES THEM PRETTY SKINT, WITLESS, SAID A CACKLING VEHIC,  
HARRY WHIRLED AROUND, SLIPPED OFF THE PLINTH, AND LANDED ON THE  
FLOOR. THE SLEEPING-SHULDERED FIGURE OF ALTHEA CARROLL WAS  
STANDING  
BEHIND HIM, AND EVEN AS HARRY RAISED HIS WAND, SHE PRESSED A STICKY  
THREDFINGER TO THE SKULL AND SNAKE BRAND ON HER FOREARM,

## CHAPTER THIRTY

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### THE SAVING OF SEVERUS Snape

HE MEMENT HER FINGER THICKENED THE MARE, HARRY'S STAR  
BLINKED SAVAGELY, THE STARRY ROOM VANISHED FROM SIGHT, AND  
HE WAS STANDING UPON AN HILLOCK OF ROCK BENEATH A CLIFF, AND THE  
SEA

WAS WASHING AROUND HIM AND THERE WAS TRIUMPH IN HIS HEART  
THEY

HAVE THE KEY.

A BLIND RANG BRIGHT HARRY BACK TO WHERE HE STOOD: DISORIENTED,  
HE RAISED HIS WAND, BUT THE WITCH BEHIND HIM WAS ALREADY FALLING  
FORWARD: SHE HIT THE GROUND SHE HAD THAT THE GLASS IN THE  
EYES  
TINKLED.

I'VE NEVER STUNNED ANYONE EXCEPT IN MY DADA LESSONS, SAID

LLINA, SEEMING MILDLY INTERESTED. THAT WAS NEARER THAN I  
THOUGHT

IT WOULD BE.

AND SURE ENOUGH, THE CEILING HAD BEGUN THE TREMBLE. SLURPING,

CRASHING FEETSTEPS WERE GROWING LOUDER FROM BEHIND THE DEER LEAD-  
ING THE THEOLOGY: LLINA'S SPELL HAD WEAKEN RAVENCLAW'S  
SLEEPING

ABOVE.

T

## CHAPTER THIRTY

THE

LLINA, WHERE ARE YOU? I NEED TO GET UNDER THE CLOAK!  
LLINA'S FEET APPEARED OUT OF NOWHERE; HE FLIPPED TO HER SIDE AND  
SHE LET THE CLOAK FALL BACK OVER THEM AS THE DEER OPENED AND A  
STREAM OF RAVENCLAWS, ALL IN THEIR NIGHTCLOTHES, FLEWED INTO THE  
COMMON ROOM. THERE WERE GASPS AND CRIES OF SURPRISE AS THEY SAW  
ALBERT LYING THERE UNCONSCIOUS. QUICKLY THEY SETTLED IN AROUND  
HER,

A SAVAGE BEAST THAT MIGHT WAKE AT ANY MOMENT AND ATTACK THEM.  
THEN ONE BRAVE LITTLE FIRST-YEAR DARTED UP TO HER AND PRESSED HER  
BACKSIDE WITH HIS BIG TAIL.

I THINK SHE MIGHT BE DEAD! HE WHISPERED WITH DELIGHT.

OH, YES, WHISPERED LLINA HAPPILY, AS THE RAVENCLAWS CRAWLED

IN ARHIND ALKTEH. THEY RE PLEASED!

YEAH... GREAT...

HARRY CLOSED HIS EYES, AND AS HIS SCAR THROBBED HE CHOSE THE SINK  
AGAIN INTO VEILDMERT'S MIND... HE WAS MOVING ALONG THE TUNNEL  
INTO THE FIRST CAVE... HE HAD CHOSEN THE MADE SURE OF THE LOCKET  
BEFORE COMING... BUT THAT WOULD NOT TAKE HIM LONG...

THERE WAS A RAP ID THE CHIMNEY ROOM DEER AND EVERY RAVENCLAW  
FREEZE, FROM THE EITHER SIDE, HARRY HEARD THE SILENT, MUSICAL VOICE  
THAT

ISSUED FROM THE EAGLE DEER DOWNER: WHERE DID VANISHED OBJECTS  
GET

I DUNNED, DID I? SILENT IT? SNARLED AN UNCHLUTY VOICE THAT HARRY  
KNEW WAS THAT OF THE CARROLL BROTHER, AMPLUS. ALKTEH? ALKTEH?  
ARE

YELL THERE? HAVE YELL GET HIM? OPEN THE DEER?

THE RAVENCLAWS WERE WHISPERING AMONGST THEMSELVES, TERRIFIED,  
THEN, WITHOUT WARNING, THERE CAME A SERIES OF LOUD RANGES, AS  
THOUGH

SOMEONE WAS FIRING A GUN INTO THE DEER.

ALKTEH? IF HE COMES, AND WE HAVEN'T GET BETTER D YELL  
WANT THE GET THE SAME WAY AS THE MALFOYS? ANSWER ME: AMPLUS

THE SAILING OF  
SEVERUS SNAPE

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REMEMBERED, SHADING THE DEER FOR ALL HE WAS WORTH, BUT STILL IT DID NOT

OPEN, THE RAVENCLAWS WERE ALL BACKING AWAY, AND SOME OF THE MOST  
FRIGHTENED BEGAN CLAMPERING BACK UP THE STAIRCASE TO THEIR BEDS.

THEN, JUST AS HARRY WAS WONDERING WHETHER HE MIGHT MEET THE  
BLAST

OPEN THE DOOR AND STUN AMPLIS BEFORE THE DEATH EATER COULD DO  
ANYTHING ELSE, A SECOND, MOST FAMILIAR VOICE RANG OUT BEHIND THE  
DOOR.

MAY I ASK WHAT YOU ARE DOING, PROFESSOR LARSEN?

TRYING TO GET THROUGH THIS DAMNED DOOR! SHELLIED  
AMPLIS. GO AND GET FLITWICK! GET HIM TO OPEN IT, NOW!

BUT ISN'T YOUR SISTER IN THERE? ASKED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

DIDN'T PROFESSOR FLITWICK LET HER IN EARLIER THIS EVENING, AT YOUR  
URGENT REQUEST? PERHAPS SHE COULD OPEN THE DOOR FOR YOU? THEN  
YOU

NEEDN'T WALK UP HALF THE CASTLE.

SHE AIN'T ANSWERING, YOU'LL HAD BETTER! YOU OPEN IT! CANN'T DO IT,  
NOW!

CERTAINLY, IF YOU WISH IT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WITH AN  
ALL CHILDNESS, THERE WAS A GENTLE TAP OF THE DOOR AND THE  
MUSICAL

VOICE ASKED AGAIN,

WHERE DO VANISHED BOOKS GO?

INTO NOTHING, WHICH IS THE SAY, EVERYTHING, REPLIED PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL.

NICELY PHRASED, REPLIED THE EAGLE DOOR DOOR, AND THE DOOR  
SWUNG OPEN.

THE FEW RAVENCLAWS WHO HAD REMAINED BEHIND SPURTED FOR THE STAIRS AS AMYLLIS BURST OVER THE THRESHOLD, BRANDISHING HIS WAND. FLINCHED LIKE HIS SISTER, HE HAD A PALID, DULGED FACE AND TINY EYES, WHICH FELL AT ONCE WHEN ALLECTE, SPRAWLED MORTUALLY IN THE FLEET, HE LET OUT A YELL OF FLURY AND FEAR.

## CHAPTER THIRTY

SIX

WHAT ARE THEY DOING, THE LITTLE WHIFLES? HE SCREAMED. I WILL CALCULATE THE LEFT OF EM TILL THEY TELL ME WHO DID IT AND WHAT'S THE DARD

LEARD GOING TO SAY? HE SHRIEKED, STANDING OVER HIS SISTER AND SMACK-

ING HIMSELF IN THE FOREHEAD WITH HIS FIST. WE HAVEN'T GOTT HIM, AND

THEY'RE GORN AND KILLED HER?

SHE'S ONLY STUNNED, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IMPATIENTLY, WHO HAD STEPPED DOWN TO EXAMINE ALLECTE. SHE'LL BE PERFECTLY ALL RIGHT.

WHEN SHE RILDERING WELL WHEN TO? REMEMBERED AMYLLIS. WHEN AFTER THE DARD LEARD GETS HOLD OF HER? SHE'S GORN AND SENT FOR HIM, I FELT ME MARK BLORN, AND HE THINKS WE'RE GOTT BETTER?

GOTT BETTER? SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SHARPLY. WHAT DO



WELL MEAN, GET BETTER?

HE THOUGHT HIS BETTER MIGHT TRY AND GET INSIDE RAVENCLAW TOWER,  
AND THEN SEND FOR HIM IF HE CAUGHT HIM?

WELL WOULD HARRY BETTER TRY TO GET INSIDE RAVENCLAW TOWER?  
BETTER BELIEVES IN MY BELIEF?

BENEATH THE DISBELIEF AND ANGER, HARRY HEARD A LITTLE STRAIN OF  
PRIDE IN HER VOICE, AND APPREHENSION FOR MINERVA MCGONAGALL GLISHED  
UP INSIDE HIM.

HE WAS THOUGHT HE MIGHT COME IN HERE? SAID CARRIE. I DUNNED  
WELL, DID I?

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL STOPPED UP AND HER READY EYES SWEEPED THE  
ROOM. TWICE THEY PASSED RIGHT OVER THE PLACE WHERE HARRY AND  
LUNA

STOPPED.

HE CAN PUSH IT OFF ON THE KIDS, SAID AMPLIS, HIS PIGEON FACE  
SUDDENLY CRABBY. YEAH, THAT'S WHAT WE'LL DO. WE'LL SAY AMPLIS WAS  
AMPLISHED BY THE KIDS, THEN KIDS WENT THERE HE WHINED UP AT THE  
STARRY CEILING TOWARD THE HERMITAGES AND WE'LL SAY THEY  
PULSED

THE SACKING OF  
SEVERUS'S SNARE

SEE

FOR THE PRESS FOR MARK, AND THAT'S WHY HE GOT A FALSE ALARM... HE  
CAN

PUNISH THEM, THOUGH IF KIDS MEAN FOR LESS, WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

ONLY THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TRUTH AND LIES, CHELRAGE AND CHELARD-  
ICE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGHENAGALL, WHO HAD TURNED PALE, A  
DIFFERENCE,

IN SHORT, WHICH YOU AND YOUR SISTER SEEM UNABLE TO APPRECIATE,  
BUT LET

ME MAKE ONE THING VERY CLEAR, YOU ARE NOT GOING TO PASS OFF YOUR  
MAD

INDEPTITLEDNESS ON THE STUDENTS OF EHEGLARTS. I SHALL NOT PERMIT IT.  
EXCUSE ME?

AMYLIS MOVED FORWARD UNTIL HE WAS OFFENSIVELY CLOSE TO PROFESS-  
SOR MCGHENAGALL, HIS FACE WITHIN INCHES OF HERS. SHE REPLIED THE  
BACK

AWAY, BUT LOOKED DEEPEN AT HIM AS IF HE WERE SOMETHING DISGUSTING  
SHE HAD FEELING STRUCK THE LAVATORY SEAT.

IT IS NOT A CASE OF WHAT YOU WILL PERMIT, MINERVA MCGHENAGALL,  
YOUR

TIME IS OVER, IT IS US WHAT IS IN CHARGE HERE NOW, AND YOU WILL BACK ME  
UP

FOR YOU WILL PAY THE PRICE.

AND HE SPAT IN HER FACE.

HARRY PULLED THE CHAIR OFF HIMSELF, RAISED HIS WAND, AND SAID,

YOU SHOULD NOT HAVE DONE THAT.

AS AMYLIS SPUN AROUND, HARRY SMILTED, CRUICER?

THE DEATH RATER WAS LIFTED OFF HIS FEET, HE WRITHED THROUGH THE

AIR LIKE A DREAMING MAN, THRASHING AND FELLING IN PAIN, AND THEN,

WITH A CRUNCH AND A SHATTERING OF GLASS, HE SMASHED INTO THE FRONT

OF A BENCHCASE AND CRUMPLED, INSENSIBLE, TO THE FLOOR.

I SEE WHAT BELLATRIX MEANT, SAID HARRY, THE BLOOD THUNDERING THROUGH HIS BRAIN, SHE'LL NEED TO REALLY MEAN IT.

PETTER! WHISPERED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, CLUTCHING HER HEART.

PETTER SHE'LL BE HERE! WHAT? SHE? SHE? SHE STRUGGLED TO PULL

HERSELF TOGETHER. PETTER, THAT WAS FISHY!

HE SPAT AT HER, SAID HARRY.

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PETTER, I THAT WAS VERY VERY CALLANT OF HER SHE'LL BUT DIDN'T SHE'LL REALIZE?

Yeah, I see, HARRY ASSURED HER. SHE'LL HER PANIC STEADIED HIM. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, VERBEMBERT SHE'LL THE WAY.

HEY, ARE WE ALLOWED TO SAY THE NAME NOW? ASKED LUNA WITH AN AIR OF INTEREST, PULLING OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. THIS APPEARANCE OF

A SECOND MENTAL SEEMED THE EVERWILKIN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WHO STAGGERED BACKWARD AND FELL INTO A NEARBY CHAIR, CLUTCHING AT THE NECK OF HER OLD TARTAN DRESSING GOWN.

I DIDN'T THINK IT MAKES ANY DIFFERENCE WHAT WE CALL HIM, HARRY

THEIR LUNA. HE ALREADY KNOWS WHERE I AM.

IN A DISTANT PART OF HARRY'S BRAIN, THAT PART CONNECTED THE THE AN-  
GER, BURNING STAR, HE COULD SEE VOLDERMORT SAILING FAST OVER THE  
DARK

LAKE IN THE GHOSTLY GREEN MIST, ... HE HAD NEARLY REACHED THE  
ISLAND

WHERE THE STONE BASIN STOOD, ...

YOU MUST FLEE, WHISPERED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. NOW, BETTER,  
AS QUICKLY AS YOU CAN!

I CAN'T, SAID HARRY. THERE'S SOMETHING I NEED THE DE, PROFESSOR,  
DO YOU KNOW WHERE THE DIadem OF RAVENCLAW IS?

THE DIadem OF RAVENCLAW? OF COURSE NOT. HASN'T IT BEEN LOST  
FOR CENTURIES? SHE SAT UP A LITTLE STRAIGHTER. BETTER, IT WAS  
MADNESS,

LITTLE MADNESS, FOR YOU THE ENTER THIS CASTLE

I HAD THE, SAID HARRY. PROFESSOR, THERE'S SOMETHING HIDDEN HERE  
THAT I'M SUPPOSED TO FIND, AND IT COULD BE THE DIadem. IF I COULD  
JUST SPEAK THE PROFESSOR FLITWICK

THERE WAS A SOUND OF MOVEMENT, OF CLINKING GLASS: AMPLIS WAS

COMING BEHIND, BEFORE HARRY OR LUNA COULD ACT, PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL

CALL RISE THE HER FEET, POINTED HER HAND AT THE GRACEY DEATH EATER,

AND SAID, IMPERIO.

THE SAVING OF  
SEVERUS Snape

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ANDREAS GET UP, WALKED OVER TO HIS SISTER, PICKED UP HER HAND,  
THEN SLIPPED EMBROIDERED THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AND HANDED IT  
OVER  
ALONG WITH HIS OWN. THEN HE LAY DOWN ON THE FLOOR BESIDE ALICE.

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL WAVED HER HAND AGAIN, AND A LENGTH OF  
SILVER

MERLIN SILVER ROPES APPEARED OUT OF THIN AIR AND SNAPPED AROUND  
THE

CARRIAGES, BINDING THEM TIGHTLY TOGETHER.

BETTER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, TURNING THE FACE HIM  
AGAIN WITH SLIGHT INDIFFERENCE TO THE CARRIAGES' PREDICAMENT, IF  
HE-HE-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED DOES INDEED KNOW THAT YOU ARE  
HERE

AS SHE SAID IT, A WRATH THAT WAS LIKE PHYSICAL PAIN BLAZED THROUGH  
HARRY, SETTING HIS SCAR ON FIRE, AND FOR A SECOND HE LUNGED DOWN  
UPON A BASIN WHERE POTION HAD TURNED CLEAR, AND SAW THAT NEW  
CHILDREN

WERE LAY SAFE BENEATH THE SURFACE

BETTER, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? SAID A VOICE, AND HARRY CAME BACK: HE  
WAS CLUTCHING LUNA'S SHOULDER THE STRAIGHT HIMSELF.

TIME IS RUNNING OUT, VOLDMORT IS GETTING NEARER. PROFESSOR, I'M

ACTING HEN DUMBLEDOORE'S ORDERS, I MUST FIND WHAT HE WANTED ME TO  
FIND! BUT WE'VE GOT TO GET THE STUDENTS OUT WHILE I'M SEARCHING THE  
CASTLE. IT'S MR. VERMOREL WHO WANTS, BUT HE DOESN'T CARE ABOUT KILLING  
A

FEW MORE HER LOSS, NOT NOW. NOT NOW HE KNOWS I'M ATTACKING  
HER-

CRUISES, HARRY FINISHED THE SENTENCE IN HIS HEAD.

YOU'RE ACTING HEN DUMBLEDOORE'S ORDERS? SHE REPEATED WITH A LITTLE  
OF

DARNING WINDER. THEN SHE DREW HERSELF UP TO HER FULLEST HEIGHT.

WE SHALL SECURE THE SCHOOL AGAINST THE-WE-MUST-NOT-RE-  
NAME WHILE YOU SEARCH FOR THIS. THIS OBJECT.

IS THAT POSSIBLE?

I THINK SHE SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DRYLY, WE TEACHERS ARE  
RATHER GOOD AT MAGIC, YOU KNOW. I AM SURE WE WILL BE ABLE TO FIND

## CHAPTER THIRTY

SHE

HIM OFF FOR A WHILE IF WE ALL PUT OUR BEST EFFORTS INTO IT. OF  
COURSE,

SOMETHING WILL HAVE TO BE DONE ABOUT PROFESSOR SNAPE

LET ME

AND IF HOGWARTS IS ABOUT TO ENTER A STATE OF SIEGE, WITH THE DARK LORD AT THE GATES, IT WOULD INDEED BE ADVISABLE TO TAKE AS MANY INNOCENT PEOPLE OUT OF THE WAY AS POSSIBLE, WITH THE FLEET NETWORK UNDER OBSERVATION, AND APPARITION IMPOSSIBLE WITHIN THE CORRIDORS

THERE IS A WAY, SAID HARRY BELICIOUSLY, AND HE EXPLAINED ABOUT THE PASSAGEWAY LEADING INTO THE HOGS HEAD.

BETTER, WE'RE TALKING ABOUT HUNDREDS OF STUDENTS

I KNOW, PROFESSOR, BUT IF VULDERMENT AND THE DEATH EATERS ARE CONCENTRATING IN THE SCHOOL BUILDINGS THEY WON'T BE INTERESTED IN

ANYONE WHO'S DISAPPEARING OUT OF THE HOGS HEAD.

THERE'S SOMETHING IN THAT, SHE AGREED. SHE POINTED HER WAND AT THE CARRIAGES, AND A SILVER NET FELL UPON THEIR BEHIND BENCHES, TIED ITSELF

AROUND THEM, AND HOISTED THEM INTO THE AIR, WHERE THEY DANGLED BENEATH THE BLUE-AND-GOLD CEILING LIKE TWO LARGE, LUCKY SEA CREATURES.

COME, WE MUST ALERT THE OTHER HEADS OF HOUSE. YOU'D BETTER PUT THAT LEAD BACK ON.

SHE MARCHED TOWARD THE DOOR, AND AS SHE DID SHE RAISED HER WAND, FROM THE TIP BURST THREE SILVER CATS WITH SPECTACLE MARKINGS

AROUND THEIR EYES. THE PATRONUSES RAN SILENTLY AHEAD, FILLING THE SPI-

RAL STAIRCASE WITH SILVER LIGHT, AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, HARRY, AND

ELINA FLURRIED BACK DOWN,

ALONG THE CORRIDORS THEY RACED, AND HERE BY HERE THE PATRONUSES  
LEFT

THEY; PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S TARTAN DRESSING GOWN RUSTLED OVER  
THE

FLOOR, AND HARRY AND ELINA HEGGED BEHIND HER UNDER THE CLOAK,

THE SACKING OF

SEVERUS Snape

577

THEY HAD DESCENDED TWO MORE FLOORS WHEN ANOTHER SET OF HOLLOTT  
FOOTSTEPS JOINED THEIRS, HARRY, WHOSE SCAR WAS STILL PRICKLING,  
HEARD

THEY FIRST! HE FELT IN THE PULCH AROUND HIS NECK FOR THE  
MARAUDER'S

MAP, BUT BEFORE HE COULD TAKE IT OUT, MCGONAGALL THEN SEEMED TO  
BECOME AWARE OF THEIR COMPANY, SHE HALTED, RAISED HER HAND READY  
TO BLUR, AND SAID, WHO'S THERE?

IT IS I, SAID A LOW VOICE,

FROM BEHIND A SLIT OF ARMOR STEPPED SEVERUS Snape,

HATRED BEILED UP IN HARRY AT THE SIGHT OF HIM! HE HAD FORGOTTEN  
THE DETAILS OF Snape'S APPEARANCE IN THE MAGNITUDE OF HIS CRIMES,  
FORGOTTEN EVEN HIS GREASY BLACK HAIR FILING IN CURTAINS AROUND HIS  
THIN

FACE, EVEN HIS BLACK EYES HAD A DEAD, CHILD-LIKE, HE WAS NOT WEARING



NIGHT-TIME, BUT WAS DRESSED IN HIS USUAL BLACK CLOAK, AND HE THEN WAS HOLDING HIS HAND READY FOR A FIGHT.

WHERE ARE THE CARRELS? HE ASKED QUIETLY.

WHEREVER YOU TELL THEM THE RE, I EXPECT, SEVERUS, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

SNAPE STEPPED NEARER, AND HIS EYES FLITTED OVER PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL

CALL INTO THE AIR AROUND HER, AS IF HE KNEW THAT HARRY WAS THERE.

HARRY HELD HIS HAND UP THEN, READY TO ATTACK.

I WAS UNDER THE IMPRESSION, SAID SNAPE, THAT ALBIE HAD APPREHENDED AN INTRUDER.

REALLY? SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. AND WHAT GAVE YOU THAT IMPRESSION?

SNAPE MADE A SLIGHT FLEXING MOVEMENT OF HIS LEFT ARM, WHERE THE DARK MARK WAS BRANDED INTO HIS SKIN.

HEH, BUT NATURALLY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. YOUR DEATH EATERS HAVE THEIR OWN PRIVATE MEANS OF COMMUNICATION, I MIGHT.

## CHAPTER THIRTY

SNAPE PRETENDED NOT TO HAVE HEARD HER, HIS EYES WERE STILL PREES-  
ING THE AIR AROUND HER, AND HE WAS MOVING GRADUALLY CLOSER,  
WITH

AN AIR OF HARDLY NOTICING WHAT HE WAS DOING.

I DID NOT KNOW THAT IT WAS YOUR NIGHT TO PATROL THE CORRIDORS,  
MINERVA.

YOU HAVE SOME OBJECTION?

I WONDER WHAT CHILD COULD HAVE BROUGHT YOU OUT OF YOUR BED AT THIS  
LATE HOUR?

I THOUGHT I HEARD A DISTURBANCE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

REALLY? BUT ALL SEEMS CALM.

SNAPE LOOKED INTO HER EYES.

HAVE YOU SEEN HARRY POTTER, MINERVA? BECAUSE IF YOU HAVE, I  
MUST INSIST

PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL MOVED FASTER THAN HARRY COULD HAVE RE-  
LIEVED: HER WAND SLASHED THROUGH THE AIR AND FOR A SPLIT SECOND  
HARRY

THOUGHT THAT SNAPE MUST CRUMPLE, UNCONSCIOUS, BUT THE SWIFTESS  
OF

HIS SHIELD CHARM WAS SUCH THAT MCGONAGALL WAS THROWN OFF BAL-  
ANCE. SHE BRANDISHED HER WAND AT A TIER IN THE WALL AND IT FLEW  
OUT

OF ITS CRACKET! HARRY, ABLE TO THE CLOSE SNAP, WAS FORCED TO PULL  
LUNA

OUT OF THE WAY OF THE DESCENDING FLAMES, WHICH BECAME A RING OF FIRE  
THAT FILLED THE CORRIDOR AND FLEW LIKE A LASER AT SNAP

THEN IT WAS NO LONGER FIRE, BUT A GREAT BLACK SERPENT THAT  
MAGNIFIED

CALL BLASTED THE SMOKE, WHICH RE-FORMED AND SOLIDIFIED IN SECONDS TO

BECOME A SWARM OF PURSUING DAGGERS! SNAP AVOIDED THEM ONLY BY  
FORCING THE SLIT OF ARMOR IN FRONT OF HIM, AND WITH EERING  
CLANGS

THE DAGGERS SANK, ONE AFTER ANOTHER, INTO ITS BREAST

MINERVA! SAID A SILENT VOICE, AND LOOKING BEHIND HIM, STILL  
SHIELDING LUNA FROM FLYING SPELLS, HARRY SAW PROFESSORS FLITWICK  
AND SPRUIT SPRINTING UP THE CORRIDOR TOWARD THEM IN THEIR  
NIGHT-

THE SAVING OF  
SEVERUS SNAP

END

CLOTHES, WITH THE ENEMY'S PROFESSOR SILENTLY PANTING ALONG  
AT THE  
REAR,

HE! SILENTLY FLITWICK, RAISING HIS WAND, YES WE SEE MORE  
MURDER AT HOGWARTS!

FLITWICK'S SPELL HIT THE SLIT HE ARMED BEHIND WHICH SNAPE HAD TAKEN SHELTER. WITH A CLATTER IT CAME THE LIFE. SNAPE STRUGGLED FREE HE THE COLLAPSING ARMS AND SENT IT FLYING BACK TOWARD HIS ATTACKERS. HARRY AND LUNA HAD THE DIVE SIDEWAYS TO AVOID IT AS IT SMASHED INTO

THE WALL AND SHATTERED. WHEN HARRY LOOKED UP AGAIN, SNAPE WAS IN

FULL FLIGHT, MCGONAGALL, FLITWICK, AND SPRUIT ALL THUNDERING AFTER HIM. HE FLIRTED THROUGH A CLASSROOM DOOR AND, MOMENTS LATER, HE HEARD MCGONAGALL CRY, 'HEARD! HEARD!'

WHAT'S HAPPENED, WHAT'S HAPPENED? ASKED LUNA.

HARRY DRAGGED HER THE HER FEET AND THEY RACED ALONG THE CORRIDOR, TRAILING THE INVISIBILITY CHARM BEHIND THEM, INTO THE DESERTED

CLASSROOM WHERE PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL, FLITWICK, AND SPRUIT WERE

STANDING AT A SMASHED WINDOW.

HE LIMPED, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AS HARRY AND LUNA RAN INTO THE ROOM.

WELL MEAN HE'S DEAD? HARRY SPRINTED TO THE WINDOW, IGNORING FLITWICK'S AND SPRUIT'S YELLS HE SEEN AT HIS SUDDEN APPEARANCE.

NO, HE'S NOT DEAD, SAID MCGONAGALL BITTERLY. UNLIKE DUMBLEDORE, HE WAS STILL CARRYING A WAND . . . AND HE SEEMS TO HAVE LEARNED

A FEW TRICKS FROM HIS MASTER.

WITH A TINGLE OF FERROR, HARRY SAW IN THE DISTANCE A FLICK,  
BATHING

SHADE FLYING THROUGH THE DARKNESS TOWARD THE PERIMETER WALL.

THERE WERE HEAVY FEETFALLS BEHIND THEM, AND A GREAT DEAL OF PLUMP-  
ING: SILENCE HAD JUST CALLED UP.

HARRY? HE PANTED, MASSAGING HIS IMMENSE CHEST BENEATH HIS

## CHAPTER THIRTY

XXXX

EMERALD-GREEN SILK PALMATS. MY DEAR KID ... WHAT A SURPRISE ...  
MINERVA, OH PLEASE EXPLAIN ... SEVERUS ... WHAT ... ?

OUR HEADMASTER IS TAKING A SHORT BREAK, SAID PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGAL-

CALL, POINTING AT THE SNARE-SHAPED FLEE IN THE WINDS.

PROFESSOR? HARRY SMILED, HIS HANDS AT HIS THREE-HEAD, HE COULD  
SEE THE INFERI-FILLED LAKE SLIDING BENEATH HIM, AND HE FELT THE  
GHOSTLY

GREEN THAT KIMP INTO THE LINGERINGLY THERE, AND VILDERMINT  
LEAPT

FROM IT WITH MURDER IN HIS HEART

PROFESSOR, WE VE GOT THE BARRICADE THE SCHEM, HE S CHIMPING NELL?

VERY WELL, HE-WITH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED IS CHIMPING, SHE TOLD

THE OTHER TEACHERS, SPRELLT AND FLITWICK GASPED, SILENTLY LET HIM  
A

WELL GREEN. PETER HAS WOUND THE DEE IN THE CASTLE AND DUMBLEDORE'S  
ORDERS. WE NEED THE PLAN IN PLACE EVERY PROTECTION OF WHICH WE ARE  
CAPABLE WHILE PETER DOES WHAT HE NEEDS THE DEE.

WE'LL REALIZE, OF COURSE, THAT NOTHING WE DO WILL BE ABLE TO KEEP  
HIM FROM COMING BACK INDEFINITELY? SILENTLY FLITWICK.

BUT WE CAN HOLD HIM UP, SAID PROFESSOR SPRELLT.

THANK YOU, PROFESSOR, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND BETWEEN

THE TWO WITCHES THERE PASSED A MOMENT OF GRIM UNDERSTANDING. I  
SHE-

FIRST WE ESTABLISH BASIC PROTECTIONS AROUND THE PLACE, THEN GATHER

OUR STUDENTS AND MEET IN THE GREAT HALL. MOST MUST BE EVACUATED,  
ALTHOUGH IF ANY OF THESE WITCHES ARE EVER AGREE WITH THE STAY AND FIGHT, I  
THINK THEY MIGHT BE GIVEN THE CHANCE.

AGREED, SAID PROFESSOR SPRELLT, ALREADY HURRYING TOWARD THE  
DEER. I SHALL MEET YOU IN THE GREAT HALL IN TWENTY MINUTES WITH  
MY FELLOW.

AND AS SHE HEGGED HIM OF SIGHT, THEY COULD HEAR HER MUTTERING,

TENTACULA, DEVIL'S SNARE, AND SNARECLOPP FEELS... YES, I'D LIKE TO  
SEE THE DEATH EATERS FIGHTING THESE.

THE SAVING OF

SEVERUS SNARE

XXXI

I CAN ACT FROM HERE, SAID FLITWICK, AND ALTHOUGH HE COULD BARELY SEE WHAT HE IT, HE POINTED HIS HAND THROUGH THE SMASHED WINDOW AND STARTED MUTTERING INCANTATIONS OF GREAT COMPLEXITY. HARRY HEARD A WEIRD RUSHING NOISE, AS THOUGH FLITWICK HAD UNLEASHED THE POWER OF THE WIND INTO THE CORRIDORS.

PROFESSOR, HARRY SAID, APPROACHING THE LITTLE CHARM MASTER, PROFESSOR, I'M SORRY TO INTERRUPT, BUT THIS IS IMPORTANT. HAVE YOU GOT ANY IDEA WHERE THE DIADEM OF RAVENCLAW IS?

PROFESSOR FLITWICK THE DIADEM OF RAVENCLAW? WELL, SAID FLITWICK, A LITTLE EXTRA WISDOM NEVER GOES AMISS, BUTTER, BUT I HARDLY THINK IT WOULD BE MUCH USE IN THIS SITUATION.

I ONLY MEANT DO YOU KNOW WHERE IT IS? HAVE YOU EVER SEEN IT?

SEEN IT? NEITHER HAS SEEN IT IN LIVING MEMORY? LONG SINCE LAST, YES?

HARRY FELT A MIXTURE OF DESPERATE DISAPPOINTMENT AND PANIC. WHAT, THEN, WAS THE PROBLEM?

WE SHALL MEET YOU AND YOUR RAVENCLAWS IN THE GREAT HALL, FILLS! SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, RECKENING THE HARRY AND LUNA

THE FOLLOWING YEAR.

THEY HAD JUST REACHED THE DOOR WHEN SILENTLY RUMPLED INTO

SPEECH.

MY LORD, HE PIPED, PALE AND SWEATY, HIS HAIR WAS MISTAKEN  
ANALYSE. WHAT A THING! I MIGHT AT ALL SURE WHETHER THIS IS WISE,  
MINERVA, HE IS BEHIND THE FIND A WAY IN, THE DARK, AND ANYONE WHO  
HAS TRIED THE DELAY HIM WILL BE IN MOST GRIEVOUS PERIL

I SHALL EXPECT THE AND THE SLOTHFUL IN THE GREAT HALL IN  
TWENTY

MINUTES, ALSO, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. IF THE WISH THE LEAVE  
WITH THEIR STUDENTS, WE SHALL NOT STOP THE, BUT IF ANY OF THE  
ATTEMPT

## CHAPTER THIRTY

~~THE~~

THE SABBATH THE RESISTANCE THE TAKE UP ARMS AGAINST US WITHIN  
THIS

CASTLE, THEN, HERACE, WE DIED THE BELL,

MINERVA! HE SAID, AGAINST,

THE TIME HAS COME FOR SLOTHFUL TO BE THE DECIDE UPON ITS Loyal-  
ties, INTERRUPTED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. GO AND MAKE THEIR STUD-  
ENTS, HERACE,

HARRY DID NOT STAY THE WATCH SILENTLY SPLITTER: HE AND LUNA  
RAN

AFTER PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WHO HAD TAKEN UP A POSITION IN THE  
MIDDLE OF THE CORRIDOR AND RAISED HER HAND,



PIERTHILLUM     HEI, FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, FILCH, MEET ME!  
THE AGED CARPENTER HAD JUST COME HURRLING INTO THE YIELD, SCREAMING,  
STUDENTS OUT OF BED! STUDENTS IN THE HALLWAYS!

THEY'RE SLIPPED THE KE, WELL-KNOWN IDIOT! SCREAMED MCGONAGALL.  
NOW GO AND DO SOMETHING CONSTRUCTIVE! FIND PERVES!

P-PERVES? STAMMERED FILCH AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER HEARD THE  
NAME BEFORE.

YES, PERVES, WELL, PERVES! HAVEN'T YOU BEEN COMPLAINING  
ABOUT HIM FOR A QUARTER OF A CENTURY? GO AND FETCH HIM, AT ONCE!  
FILCH EVIDENTLY THOUGHT PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HAD TAKEN LEAVE OF  
HER SENSES, BUT HURLED AWAY, FLINCH-SHIVERED, MUTTERING UNDER  
HIS BREATH.

AND NOW     PIERTHILLUM LEICHTMETER! CRIED PROFESSOR  
MCGONAGALL.

AND ALL ALONG THE HALLWAY THE STATUES AND SLITS OF ARMOR JUMPED  
DOWN FROM THEIR PLINTHS, AND FROM THE CRASHING CRASHES FROM THE  
FLOORS ABOVE AND BELOW, HARRY KNEW THAT THEIR FELLOWS  
THROUGHOUT

THE CASTLE HAD DONE THE SAME.

HOGWARTS IS THREATENED! SCREAMED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. MAN  
THE BOUNDARIES, PROTECT US, DO YOUR DUTY THE OLD SCHOOL!

CLATTERING AND ROLLING, THE HERD OF MOVING STATUES STAMPEDED

THE SACKING OF  
SEVERUS'S SNARE

XXX

PAST HARRY: SOME OF THEM SMALLER, OTHERS LARGER, THAN LIFE. THERE WERE

ANIMALS TOO, AND THE CLANKING SLITS OF ARMED CRANDIFIED SWORDS AND

SPIKED BALLS AND CHAINS.

NEEL PITTER, SAID MCGONAGALL, WELL AND MISS LEEVEHED HAD BETTER RETURN THE OTHER FRIENDS AND BRING THEM TO THE GREAT HALL  
I

SHALL RELEASE THE OTHER GRYPFINDERS.

THEY PARTED AT THE TOP OF THE NEXT STAIRCASE, HARRY AND LUNA

RUNNING BACK TOWARD THE CONCEALED ENTRANCE TO THE ROOM OF RE-  
QUIREMENT. AS THEY RAN, THEY MET CREDS OF STUDENTS, MOST WEARING

TRAVELING CLOAKS OVER THEIR ROBES, BEING SHEPHERDED DOWN THE  
THE

GREAT HALL BY TEACHERS AND PREFECTS.

THAT WAS PITTER?

HARRY PITTER?

IT WAS HIM, I SWEAR, I JUST SAW HIM?

BUT HARRY DID NOT LOOK BACK, AND AT LAST THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE  
TO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT. HARRY LEANED AGAINST THE ENCHANTED  
WALL, WHICH OPENED TO ADMIT THEM, AND HE AND LUNA SPED BACK  
DOWN THE STEEP STAIRCASE.

WH 7

AS THE BOMB CAME INTO VIEW, HARRY SLIPPED DOWN A FEW STAIRS IN  
SHOCK. IT WAS PACKED, FAR MORE CROWDED THAN WHEN HE HAD LAST BEEN  
IN THERE. DINGSLEY AND LUPIN WERE LEERING UP AT HIM, AS WERE  
HILVER

WEND, KATIE BELL, ANGELINA JONES AND ALICIA SPINNET, BILL AND  
FLEUR, AND MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY.

HARRY, WHAT'S HAPPENING? SAID LUPIN, MEETING HIM AT THE FOOT  
OF THE STAIRS.

VERMONT'S IN HIS WAY, THEY'RE BARRICADING THE SCHOOL  
SNAP'S

ALIN FOR IT WHAT ARE YOU DOING HERE? HOW DID YOU KNOW?

WE SENT MESSAGES TO THE REST OF DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY, FRED

## CHAPTER THIRTY

END

EXPLAINED. YOU COULDN'T EXPECT EVERYONE TO MISS THE PLAN, HARRY,  
AND THE D.A. LET THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX KNOW, AND IT ALL KIND OF  
UNRAVELLED.

WHAT FIRST, HARRY? CALLED GEORGE. WHAT'S GOING ON?

THEY'RE EVACUATING THE YOUNGER KIDS AND EVERYONE'S MEETING IN  
THE GREAT HALL THE GET ORGANIZED, HARRY SAID. WE'RE FIGHTING.

THERE WAS A GREAT BOMB AND A SLURGE TOWARD THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS;  
HE

WAS PRESSED BACK AGAINST THE WALL AS THEY RAN PAST HIM, THE  
MINGLED

MEMBERS OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX, DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY, AND

HARRY'S OLD HURDITCH TEAM, ALL WITH THEIR HANDS DRAWN, HEADING UP INTO THE MAIN CASTLE.

COME ON, LUNA, DEAN CALLED AS HE PASSED, HOLDING UP HIS FREE HAND; SHE TOOK IT AND FOLLOWED HIM BACK UP THE STAIRS.

THE CROWD WAS THINNING; ONLY A LITTLE BUNCH OF PEOPLE REMAINED BEHIND IN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, AND HARRY JOINED THEM. MRS. WEASLEY WAS STRUGGLING WITH GINNY, ASHENDING THEM STEADILY UPIN, FRED, GEORGE, BILL, AND PETER.

YOU'RE LINGERING? MRS. WEASLEY SCHELTED AT HER DAUGHTER AS HARRY

APPROACHED. I WON'T PERMIT IT! THE KIDS, YES, BUT YOU, YOU'VE GOT TO GO HOME!

I WON'T!

GINNY'S HAIR FLEW AS SHE PULLED HER ARM OUT OF HER MOTHER'S GRIP.

I'M IN DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY

A TEENAGERS GANG!

A TEENAGERS GANG THAT'S ABOUT TO TAKE HIM ON, WHICH SHE HAD ELSE

HAS DARED TO DO! SAID FRED.

SHE'S SIXTEEN! SCHELTED MRS. WEASLEY. SHE'S NOT OLD ENOUGH! WHAT YOU TWO WERE THINKING, BRINGING HER WITH YOU! FRED AND GEORGE LOOKED SLIGHTLY ABASHED OF THEMSELVES.

THE SACKING OF  
SPOOKS' SNARE

END

"MUM'S RIGHT, GINNY," SAID BILL GENTLY. "YOU CAN'T DO THIS. EVERY-  
ONE UNDERAGE WILL HAVE TO LEAVE, IT'S ONLY RIGHT."

"I CAN'T GO HOME!" GINNY SCREAMED, ANGRY TEARS SPARKLING IN HER  
EYES. "MY WHOLE FAMILY'S HERE, I CAN'T STAND WAITING THERE ALONE  
AND

NOT KNOWING AND

HER EYES MET HARRY'S FOR THE FIRST TIME. SHE LOOKED AT HIM RE-  
SPECIFICALLY, BUT HE SHOOK HIS HEAD AND SHE TURNED AWAY BITTERLY.

"FINE," SHE SAID, STARING AT THE ENTRANCE TO THE TUNNEL BACK TO THE  
BUS'S HEAD. "I'LL SAY GOOD-BYE NOW, THEN, AND

THERE WAS A SLUPLING AND A GREAT THUMP! SOMEONE ELSE HAD CLAM-  
BERED OUT OF THE TUNNEL, OVERBALANCED SLIGHTLY, AND FALLEN. HE  
PULLED

HIMSELF UP ON THE NEAREST CHAIR, LOOKED AROUND THROUGH WHIPSIDE  
HORN-RIMMED GLASSES, AND SAID, "AM I TOO LATE? HAS IT STARTED? I  
ONLY

JUST FEELING OUT, SEE I I

PERCY SPLOTTED INTO SILENCE. EVIDENTLY HE HAD NOT EXPECTED THE  
RUN

INTO MEET OF HIS FAMILY. THERE WAS A LONG MOMENT OF  
ASTONISHMENT,

FREENED BY FLEUR TURNING THE LUPIN AND SAYING, IN A WILDLY  
TRANSPARENT

ATTEMPT THE BREAD THE TENSION, SEE HOW LITTLE TEDDY?

LUPIN BLINKED AT HER, STARTLED. THE SILENCE BETWEEN THE WEASLEYS  
SEEMED TO BE SHEDDING, LIKE ICE.

I HEY YES HE'S FINE? LUPIN SAID HELDLY. YES, THERE'S IS WITH  
HIM AT HER MEET-HER'S

PERCY AND THE OTHER WEASLEYS WERE STILL STARING AT EACH ANOTHER,  
FROZEN.

HERE, I'VE GOT A PICTURE! LUPIN SMILTED, PULLING A PHOTOGRAPH  
FROM INSIDE HIS JACKET AND SHOWING IT THE FLEUR AND HARRY, WHO SAW  
A TINY BABY WITH A TUFT OF BRIGHT TURQUOISE HAIR, WAVING FAT FISTS  
AT

THE CAMERA.

I WAS A FOOL! PERCY REARED, SEE HELDLY THAT LUPIN NEARLY DROPPED

## CHAPTER THIRTY

~~END~~

HIS PHOTOGRAPH. I WAS AN IDIOT, I WAS A POMPINOUS PRAT, I WAS

\* \*

MINISTRY-LEAVING, FAMILY-DISHONORING, PHEW-FLINGING MURDER, SAID  
FRED.

PERCY SWALLOWED.

YES, I WAS!

WELL, YOU CAN'T SAY FAIRER THAN THAT, SAID FRED, HOLDING UP HIS

HAND THE PERCY,

MRS. WEASLEY BLIRST INTO TEARS. SHE RAN FORWARD, PUSHED FRED ASIDE, AND PULLED PERCY INTO A STRANGLING HUG, WHILE HE PATTED HER

THE BACK, HIS EYES ON HIS FATHER.

I'M SORRY, DAD, PERCY SAID.

MR. WEASLEY BLINKED RATHER RAPIDLY, THEN HE THEN FLURRIED THE HUG HIS SON.

WHAT MADE YOU SEE SENSE, PERCY? INQUIRED GEORGE.

IT'S BEEN COMING ON FOR A WHILE, SAID PERCY, WIPING HIS EYES UNDER HIS GLASSES WITH A CLOTH OF HIS TRAVELING CLOAK. BUT I HAD THE

FIND A WAY OUT AND IT'S NOT SO EASY AT THE MINISTRY, THEY'RE IMPRISON-

ING TRAITORS ALL THE TIME. I MANAGED TO MAKE CONTACT WITH A

AND HE TIPPED ME OFF TEN MINUTES AGO THAT FLEWELLS WAS CHING THE MAKE A FIGHT OF IT, SHE HERE I AM.

WELL, WE DO NEED THE ELIXIR PREPARE THE TAKE A LEAD AT TIMES SUCH AS THESE, SAID GEORGE IN A GOOD IMITATION OF PERCY'S MOST POMPILIS MANNER. NOW LET'S GET UPSTAIRS AND FIGHT, FOR ALL THE GOOD DEATHS EATERS WILL BE TAKEN.

SHE, YOU'RE MY SISTER-IN-LAW NOW? SAID PERCY, SHAKING HANDS WITH

FLURRIED AS THEY FLURRIED OFF TOWARD THE STAIRCASE WITH BILL, FRED, AND GEORGE.

GINNY? KARKED MRS. WEASLEY.

THE SADING OF  
SEVERAL SNAPE

NOT

GINNY HAD BEEN ATTEMPTING, UNDER COVER OF THE RECONCILIATION,  
THE SNEAK UPSTAIRS THEM.

WELL, WELL ASHET THIS, SAID LUPIN. WHY DIDN T GINNY STAY  
HERE, THEN AT LEAST SHE LL BE IN THE SCENE AND KNOW WHAT S GOING  
ON,

BLT SHE WEN T BE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE FIGHTING?

I

THAT S A GOOD IDEA, SAID MR. WEASLEY FIRMLY. GINNY, WELL STAY  
IN THIS ROOM, WELL HEAR ME?

GINNY DID NOT SEEM THE LIKE THE IDEA MUCH, BLT UNDER HER FATHER S  
UNUSUALLY STERN GAZE, SHE NEEDED. MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY AND LUPIN  
HEADED OFF FOR THE STAIRS AS WELL.

WHERE S BEN? ASKED HARRY. WHERE S HERMIONE?

THEY MUST HAVE GONE UP THE THE GREAT HALL ALREADY, MR.  
WEASLEY

CALLED OVER HIS SHOULDER.

I DIDN T SEE THEM PASS ME, SAID HARRY.

THEY SAID SOMETHING ASHET A KATHREEM, SAID GINNY, NOT LONG  
AFTER WELL LEFT.

A KATHREEM?



HARRY STRODE ACROSS THE ROOM TOWARD AN OPEN DOOR LEADING OFF THE  
ROOM OF REQUIREMENT AND CHECKED THE KITCHEN-ROOM KEYHOLE. IT WAS  
EMPTY.

WELL BE SURE THEY SAID KATH 7

BUT THEN HIS STAR SPARKED AND THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT VANISHED!  
HE WAS WALKING THROUGH THE HIGH WINDLIGHT-IRON GATES WITH  
WINGS

BEHIND HIM PILLARS AT EITHER SIDE, WALKING THROUGH THE DARK  
CORRIDORS

TOWARD THE CASTLE, WHICH WAS ABLAZE WITH LIGHTS. NAGINI WAS DRAPED  
OVER HIS SHOULDERS. HE WAS POSSESSED OF THAT CHILD, CRUEL SENSE OF  
PURPOSE THAT PRECEDED MURDER.

## CHAPTER THIRTY - END

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## THE BATTLE OF HOGWARTS

THE ENCHANTED CEILING OF THE GREAT HALL WAS DARK AND SPAT-  
TERED WITH STARS, AND BELOW IT THE PEARL LEGS OF THE TABLES

WERE LINKED WITH DISHEVELED STUDENTS, SOME IN TRAVELING CLOAKS,  
OTHERS

IN DRESSING GOWNS. HERE AND THERE SPARKED THE PEARLY WHITE FIGURES  
OF

THE SCREAMING GHOSTS, EVERY EYE, LIVING AND DEAD, WAS FIXED UPON  
PROFESSOR

SIR MCGONAGALL, WHO WAS SPEAKING FROM THE RAISED PLATFORM AT  
THE

HEAD OF THE HALL. BEHIND HER STOOD THE REMAINING TEACHERS,  
INCLUDING

THE PALMISTINE CENTAUR, FIRENZE, AND THE MEMBERS OF THE ORDER OF  
THE

PHOENIX WHO HAD ARRIVED THE NIGHT,

... EVACUATION WILL BE SUPERVISED BY MR. FILCH AND MADAM PONY-  
FREY, PROFESSORS, WHEN I GIVE THE WORD, YOU WILL ORGANIZE YOUR HOUSE  
AND

TAKE YOUR CHARGES, IN AN ORDERLY FASHION, TO THE EVACUATION  
POINT.

MANY OF THE STUDENTS WERE PETRIFIED, HOWEVER, AS HARRY SKIRTED  
THE WALLS, SCANNING THE GROSSINGHAM TABLE FOR RON AND HERMION,  
ERNE MACMILLAN STOOD UP AT THE FLUFFLEPUFF TABLE AND SHOUTED,  
AND

WHAT IF WE WANT TO STAY AND FIGHT?

T

THE BATTLE OF  
HOGWARTS

END

THERE WAS A SPATTERING OF APPLAUSE.

IF YOU ARE OF AGE, YOU MAY STAY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.  
WHAT ABOUT YOUR THINGS? CALLED A GIRL AT THE RAVENCLAW TABLE.  
YOUR TRUNKS, YOUR BELTS?

WE HAVE NO TIME TO COLLECT POSSESSIONS, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. THE IMPORTANT THING IS TO GET YOU HERE SAFELY.

WHERE IS PROFESSOR SNAP? SHELLIED A GIRL FROM THE SLYTHERIN TABLE.

HE HAS, THE USE THE CERTAIN PHRASE, BEING A BLIND, REPLIED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND A GREAT CRIER ERUPTED FROM THE GRYPFINDERS,

HUFFLEPUFFS, AND RAVENCLAWS.

HARRY MOVED UP THE HALL ALONGSIDE THE GRYPFINDER TABLE, STILL LOOKING FOR RON AND HERMIONE. AS HE PASSED, FACES TURNED IN HIS DIRECTION, AND A GREAT DEAL OF WHISPERING BROKE OUT IN HIS WAKE.

WE HAVE ALREADY PLACED PROTECTION AROUND THE CASTLE, PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL WAS SAYING, BUT IT IS UNLIKELY TO HOLD FOR VERY LONG UN-

LESS WE REINFORCE IT. I MUST ASK YOU, THEREFORE, TO MOVE QUICKLY AND

CALMLY, AND BE AS YOUR PROTECTS

BUT HER FINAL WORDS WERE OVERTAKEN AS A DIFFERENT VOICE RANGED THROUGHOUT THE HALL. IT WAS HIGH, CLEAR, AND CLEAR: THERE WAS NO

TELLING THEM WHERE IT CAME; IT SEEMED THE ISSUE FROM THE WALLS THEM-  
SELVES. LIKE THE MONSTER IT HAD ONCE DEMANDER, IT MIGHT HAVE LAIN  
DORMANT THERE FOR CENTURIES.

I KNOW THAT YOU ARE PREPARING THE FIGHT. THERE WERE SCREAMS  
AMONGST THE STUDENTS, SOME OF WHOM CLUTCHED EACH OTHER, WHIS-  
PERING AROUND IN TERROR FOR THE SILENCE OF THE SILENCE. YOUR EFFORTS  
ARE

FLUTE, YOU CANNOT FIGHT ME, I DO NOT WANT THE BLOOD YOU, I HAVE  
GREAT

RESPECT FOR THE TEACHERS OF HOGWARTS, I DO NOT WANT THE SPILL  
MAGICAL

BLOOD.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

10

THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE HALL NOW, THE KIND OF SILENCE THAT  
PRESSES

AGAINST THE EARDRUMS, THAT SEEMS TO BE LIKE THE BE CONTAINED BY  
WALLS.

GIVE ME HARRY POTTER, SAID VOLDEMORT'S VOICE, AND NONE SHALL  
BE HARMED, GIVE ME HARRY POTTER, AND I SHALL LEAVE THE SCHOOL UN-

THELCHED, GIVE ME HARRY POTTER, AND YELL WILL BE REWARDED.

YELL HAVE UNTIL MIDNIGHT.

THE SILENCE SWALLOWED THEM ALL AGAIN. EVERY HEAD TURNED, EVERY EYE IN THE PLACE SEEMED TO HAVE FOUND HARRY, THE FEEL HIM FREEZEN IN THE GLARE OF THOUSANDS OF INVISIBLE BEAMS. THEN A FIGURE ROSE FROM THE SLYTHERIN TABLE AND HE RECOGNIZED PANSY PARKINSON AS SHE

RAISED A SHAKING ARM AND SCREAMED. BUT HE'S THERE! POTTER'S THERE! SOMEONE GRAB HIM!

BEFORE HARRY COULD SPEAK, THERE WAS A MASSIVE MOVEMENT. THE GRAYFINDERS IN FRONT OF HIM HAD RISEN AND STOOD FACING, NOT HARRY,

BUT THE SLYTHERINS. THEN THE FLUFFLEPUFFS STOOD, AND ALMOST AT THE SAME MOMENT, THE RAVENCLAWS, ALL OF THEM WITH THEIR BACKS TO

HARRY, ALL OF THEM LEANING TOWARD PANSY INSTEAD, AND HARRY, ALMOST STRUCK AND OVERWHELMED, SAW HANDS EMERGING EVERYWHERE, PULLED

FROM BENEATH CHAIRS AND FROM UNDER SLEEVES.

THANK YELL, MISS PARKINSON, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IN A CLIPPED VOICE. YELL WILL LEAVE THE HALL FIRST WITH MR. FILCH. IF THE REST OF YOUR HOUSE COULD FOLLOW.

HARRY HEARD THE GRINDING OF KITCHENS AND THEN THE SOUND OF THE SLYTHERINS TREMPING OUT ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE HALL.

RAVENCLAWS, FOLLOW ME! CRIED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

SILENLY THE OTHER TABLES EMPTIED. THE SLYTHERIN TABLE WAS COMPLETELY DESERTED, BUT A NUMBER OF HIDDEN RAVENCLAWS REMAINED SEATED

WHILE THEIR FELLOWS FIRED BLITZ; EVEN MORE FLAMPELIPS STAYED BEHIND,

THE BATTLE OF  
HOGWARTS

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AND HALF OF GRYFFINDOR REMAINED IN THEIR SEATS, NECESSITATING  
PRESS-

SIR MCGONAGALL'S DESCENT FROM THE TEACHERS PLATFORM THE CHIVVY  
THE

UNDERAGE MEN THEIR WAY,

ABSELTLY NHT, CREEPY, GEE AND YEL, PEAKES!

HARRY HURRIED OVER THE THE WEASLEYS, ALL SITTING TOGETHER AT THE  
GRYFFINDOR TABLE,

WHERE ARE RON AND HERMION?

HAVEN'T YEL FELIND ? BEGAN MR. WEASLEY, LOOKING WHORIED,  
BUT HE BROKE OFF AS KINGSLEY HAD STEPPED FORWARD AND THE RAISED  
PLATFORM THE ADDRESS THESE WHO HAD REMAINED BEHIND,

WE VE ONLY GET HALF AN HOUR UNTIL MIDNIGHT, SEE WE NEED THE ACT

FAST! A BATTLE PLAN HAS BEEN AGREED BETWEEN THE TEACHERS OF HOG-  
WARTS AND THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX, PROFESSORS FLITWICK, SPRELLIT,

AND MCGONAGALL ARE GOING TO TAKE GRIPPS UP FIGHTERS UP THE THE  
TOWER

HIGHEST TOWERS RAVENCLAW, ASTORNEY, AND GRYFFINDOR  
WHERE

THEY WILL HAVE A GOOD OVERVIEW, EXCELLENT POSITIONS FROM WHICH THE  
WARRIORS

SPILLS, MEANWHILE REMUS HE INDICATED LUPIN ARTHEUR  
HE

POINTED TOWARD MR. WEASLEY, SITTING AT THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE  
AND

I WILL TAKE GRIPPS INTO THE GRILINDS, WE WILL NEED SOMEONE TO  
REORGANIZE

DEFENSE OF THE ENTRANCES OF THE PASSAGELAYS INTO THE SCHOOL

STUDENTS LIKE A THE FEARLESS, CALLED FRED, INDICATING HIMSELF AND  
GEORGE, AND KINGSLEY NEEDED HIS APPROVAL.

ALL RIGHT, LEADERS UP HERE AND WE WILL DIVIDE UP THE TROOPS!

BETTER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, HURRYING UP THE HIM, AS  
STILL-

BENTS REACHED THE PLATFORM, HEADING FOR POSITION, RECEIVING  
INSTRUCTIONS-

THESE, AREN'T YOU SUPPOSED TO BE LOOKING FOR SOMETHING?

WHAT? HE, SAID HARRY, HEY YEAH?

HE HAD ALMOST FORGOTTEN ABOUT THE TOWER, ALMOST FORGOTTEN  
THAT THE BATTLE WAS BEING FIGHTEN SEE THAT HE COULD SEARCH FOR IT!  
THE

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

12

INEXPLICABLE ABSENCE OF REIN AND HERMINE HAD MOMENTARILY DRIVEN EVERY OTHER THOUGHT FROM HIS MIND.

THEN GO, BETTER, GO

RIGHT YEAH

HE SENSED EYES FOLLOWING HIM AS HE RAN OUT OF THE GREAT HALL AGAIN, INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL STILL CROWDED WITH EVALUATING STUDENTS.

HE ALLOWED HIMSELF TO BE SWEEPED UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE WITH THEM, BUT AT THE TOP HE FLURRIED OFF ALONG A DESERTED CORRIDOR. FEAR AND PANIC WERE CLOUDING HIS THOUGHT PROCESSES. HE TRIED TO CALM HIMSELF.

TO CONCENTRATE ON FINDING THE HERCULES, BUT HIS THOUGHTS SLIPPED AS

FRANTICALLY AND FUTILITY AS WASPS TRAPPED BENEATH A GLASS. WITHOUT

REIN AND HERMINE TO HELP HIM HE COULD NOT SEE THE MARSHAL HIS IDEAS. HE SLEWED DOWN, CRYING TO A HALL HALFWAY ALONG AN EMPTY PASSAGE, WHERE HE SAT DOWN UPON THE PLINTH OF A DEPARTED STATUE AND

PULLED THE MARAUDER'S MAP OUT OF THE POCKET AROUND HIS NECK. HE COULD NOT SEE REIN'S OR HERMINE'S NAMES ANYWHERE IN IT, THOUGH THE DENSITY OF THE CROWD OF DEETS NEW MAKING ITS WAY TO THE REHEM OF REQUIREMENT MIGHT, HE THOUGHT, BE CONCEALING THEM. HE PLAT THE MAP AWAY, PRESSED HIS HANDS OVER HIS FACE, AND CLOSED HIS EYES.



TRYING TO CONCENTRATE . . .

VERMOREL THOUGHT I'D GET THE RAVENCLAW TOWER.

THERE IT WAS! A SHED FACT, THE PLACE THE START. VERMOREL HAD STATIONED ALBERT CARROLL IN THE RAVENCLAW COMMON ROOM, AND THERE

COULD ONLY BE ONE EXPLANATION: VERMOREL FEARED THAT HARRY ALREADY

KNEW HIS FATHER WAS CONNECTED TO THAT HOUSE.

BUT THE ONLY EVIDENCE ANYONE SEEMED TO ASSOCIATE WITH RAVENCLAW WAS THE LOST DIADEM . . . AND EVEN COULD THE FATHER BE THE DIADEM? EVEN WAS IT POSSIBLE THAT VERMOREL, THE SLOTHFUL, HAD FOUND THE DIADEM THAT HAD ELDED GENERATIONS OF RAVENCLAWS? WHEN COULD

THE BATTLE OF

BECHARTS

WAS

HAVE TOLD HIM WHERE THE LOST, WHEN NEITHER HAD SEEN THE DIADEM IN LIVING MEMORY?

IN LIVING MEMORY . . .

BENEATH HIS FINGERS, HARRY'S EYES FLEW OPEN AGAIN. HE LEAPT UP FROM THE PLINTH AND THERE RODE THE WAY HE HAD COME, NEW IN PURSUIT

OF HIS ONE LAST FEAR. THE SOUND OF HUNDREDS OF PEOPLE MARCHING TOWARD THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT GREW LOUDER AND LOUDER AS HE

RETURNED THE THE MARBLE STAIRS, PREFECTS WERE SHELLING  
INSTRUCTIONS,

TRYING THE KEEP TRACK OF THE STUDENTS IN THEIR OWN HOMES; THERE

WAS MUCH PUSHING AND SHEVING; HARRY SAW ZACHARIAS SMITH  
REEL-

ING EVER FIRST-YEARS THE GET THE THE FRONT OF THE HALLS; HERE AND  
THERE

YELLING STUDENTS WERE IN TEARS, WHILE ELDER MEN CALLED DESPERATELY  
FOR FRIENDS AND SIBLINGS. . . .

HARRY CAUGHT SIGHT OF A PEARLY WHITE FIGURE DRIFTING ACROSS THE  
EN-

TRANCE HALL REEL AND YELLED AS LOUDLY AS HE COULD EVER THE CLAMOR.

NICK! NICK! I NEED THE TALK THE YELL!

HE FORCED HIS WAY BACK THROUGH THE TIDE OF STUDENTS, FINALLY REACH-  
ING THE BOTTOM OF THE STAIRS, WHERE NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, GHOST  
OF

GRYFFINDOR TOWER, STOOD WAITING FOR HIM.

HARRY: MY DEAR NICK!

NICK MADE THE GRASP HARRY'S HANDS WITH BOTH OF HIS HANDS; HARRY'S  
FELT AS THOUGH THEY HAD BEEN THROWN INTO THE ILL WATER.

NICK, YELL YOU GET THE HELP ME, WHO'S THE GHOST OF RAVENCLAW  
TOWER?

NEARLY HEADLESS NICK LEDDED SURPRISED AND A LITTLE APPENDED.

THE GRAY LADY, IF CHURCH; BUT IF IT IS GHOSTLY SERVICES WILL  
REQUIRE ?

IT S GET THE RE HER D WILL KNOW WHERE SHE IS?

LET S SEE, . . .

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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NICK S HEAD WHEELED A LITTLE AND HIS BLISS AS HE TURNED HITHER AND  
THITHER, PEERING OVER THE HEADS OF THE SWARMING STUDENTS.

THAT S HER OVER THERE, JARRY, THE YELING WOMAN WITH THE LONG  
HAIR.

JARRY LEDDED IN THE DIRECTION OF NICK S TRANSPARENT, POINTING  
FINGER AND SAW A TALL GHOST WHEN CALLED TO BY JARRY LEDDING  
AT HER.

RAISED HER EYEBROWS, AND DRIFTED AWAY THROUGH A SHED WALL.

JARRY RAN AFTER HER, THENCE THROUGH THE DOOR OF THE CORRIDOR INTO

WHICH SHE HAD DISAPPEARED, HE SAW HER AT THE VERY END OF THE PAS-  
SAGE, STILL GLIDING SILENTLY AWAY FROM HIM.

HEY WAIT COME BACK!

SHE CONSENTED THE PALSE, FLEATING A FEW INCHES FROM THE GROUND.

JARRY SUPPOSED THAT SHE WAS BEAUTIFUL, WITH HER WAIST-LENGTH  
HAIR

AND FINGER-LENGTH CHAD, BUT SHE ALSO BEHELD HALICITY AND PHILID.  
WHOSE THE, HE RECOGNIZED HER AS A GHOST HE HAD PASSED SEVERAL TIMES  
IN THE CORRIDOR, BUT THE WOMAN HE HAD NEVER SPOTTED.

WELL ARE THE GRAY LADY?

SHE NEEDED BUT DID NOT SPEAK.

THE GHOST OF RAVENCLAW TOWER?

THAT IS CORRECT.

HER TONE WAS NOT ENCOURAGING.

PLEASE! I NEED SOME HELP, I NEED TO KNOW ANYTHING YOU CAN TELL  
ME ABOUT THE LOST DIADAM.

A COLD SMILE CURVED HER LIPS.

I AM AFRAID, SHE SAID, TURNING THE LEAF, THAT I CANNOT HELP  
YOU.

WAIT:

HE HAD NOT MEANT THE SILENT, BUT ANGER AND PANIC WERE THREATENING  
THE EVERLASTING HIM, HE GLANCED AT HIS WATCH AS SHE HEAVED IN  
FRONT

OF HIM: IT WAS A QUARTER THE MIDNIGHT.

THE BATTLE OF

HEGWARDS

ELS

THIS IS URGENT, HE SAID FIERCELY. IF THAT DIADAM IS AT HEGWARDS,  
I WANT YOU TO FIND IT, FAST.

YOU ARE HARDLY THE FIRST STUDENT TO HEAR THE DIADAM, SHE SAID

DISDAINFULLY, GENERATIONS OF STUDENTS HAVE BODGERED ME

THIS ISN'T ABOUT TRYING TO GET BETTER MARKS? HARRY SMILED AT HER. IT'S ABOUT VANDERHEIM DEFEATING VANDERHEIM HE'S NOT VERY

INTERESTED IN THAT?

SHE COULD NOT BLUSH, BUT HER TRANSPARENT CHEEKS BECAME MORE EMPHATIC, AND HER VOICE WAS HEATED AS SHE REPLIED, HE'LL NEVER I

DARE YOU SUGGEST ?

WELL, HELP ME, THEN?

HER COMPULSION WAS SLIPPING.

IT IT IS NOT A QUESTION OF SHE STAMMERED. MY MOTHER'S DIADEM

YOUR MOTHER'S?

SHE BREATHED ANGRY WITH HERSELF.

WHEN I LIVED, SHE SAID STIFFLY, I WAS HELENA RAVENCLAW.

YOU'RE HER DAUGHTER? BUT THEN, YOU MUST KNOW WHAT HAPPENED TO IT?

WHILE THE DIADEM BESTOWS WISDOM, SHE SAID WITH AN HEAVILY EFFORT TO PLUM HERSELF TOGETHER, I BELIEVE THAT IT WOULD GREATLY INCREASE

YOUR CHANCES OF DEFEATING THE WIZARD WHO CALLS HIMSELF LORD

HAVEN'T I JUST TOLD YOU, I'M NOT INTERESTED IN WEARING IT? HARRY SAID FIRMLY. THERE'S NO TIME TO EXPLAIN BUT IF YOU CARE ABOUT FLEGGWARTS, IF YOU WANT TO SEE VANDERHEIM FINISHED, YOU'VE GOT TO TELL

ME ANYTHING YOU KNOW ABOUT THE DIADEM?

SHE REMAINED BLINDLY STILL, FLEETING IN MIND, STARING DOWN AT HIM,

AND A SENSE OF HELPlessness ENGLISHED HARRY, HE THOUGHT, IF SHE HAD  
KNOWN ANYTHING, SHE WOULD HAVE TOLD FLITWICK OR DUMBLEDORE, WOULD

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

11

HAD SURELY ASKED HER THE SAME QUESTION, HE HAD SHAKEN HIS HEAD  
AND

MADE THE TURN AWAY WHEN SHE SPoke IN A LOW VOICE,

I STEAL THE DIADEM FROM MY MOTHER,

YES YES DID WHAT?

I STEAL THE DIADEM, REPEATED HERENA RAVENCLAW IN A WHISPER. I  
THOUGHT THE MADE MYSELF CLEVERER, MORE IMPORTANT THAN MY MOTHER,  
I RAN AWAY WITH IT,

HE DID NOT KNOW HOW HE HAD MANAGED TO GAIN HER CONFIDENCE,  
AND DID NOT ASK; HE SIMPLY LISTENED, HARD, AS SHE WENT ON;

MY MOTHER, THEY SAY, NEVER ADMITTED THAT THE DIADEM WAS GONE,

BUT PRETENDED THAT SHE HAD IT STILL. SHE CONCEALED HER LOSS, MY  
DREAD-

ALL BETRAYAL, EVEN FROM THE OTHER PRISONERS OF HOGWARTS,

THEN MY MOTHER FELL ILL FATAALLY ILL, IN SPITE OF MY PERIODS, SHE  
WAS DESPERATE TO SEE ME HAVE MORE TIME. SHE SENT A MAN WHO HAD  
LONG LOVED ME, THOUGH I SPURNED HIS ADVANCES, TO FIND ME. SHE  
KNEW

THAT HE WOULD NOT REST UNTIL HE HAD SEEN ME,

HARRY WAITED. SHE DREW A DEEP BREATH AND THREW BACK HER HEAD.

HE TRACKED ME THRU THE FOREST WHERE I WAS HIDING. WHEN I REFUSED TO RETURN WITH HIM, HE BECAME VIOLENT. THE BAREN WAS ALWAYS A HOT-TEMPERED MAN. FURTHERS AT MY REFUSAL, IRATELY OF MY FREEDOM, HE STABBED ME.

THE BAREN? YOU MEAN ?

THE BLEEDY BAREN, YES, SAID THE GRAY LADY, AND SHE LIFTED ASIDE THE CLOAK SHE WORE TO REVEAL A SINGLE DARK WOUND IN HER WHITE CHEST.

WHEN HE SAW WHAT HE HAD DONE, HE WAS OVERCOME WITH REMORSE. HE THREW THE WEAPON THAT HAD CLAIMED MY LIFE, AND USED IT TO KILL HIMSELF. ALL THESE CENTURIES LATER, HE WEARS HIS CHAINS AS AN ACT OF PENITENCE . . . AS HE SHOULD, SHE ADDED BITTERLY.

## THE BATTLE OF BEECHWARTS

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AND . . . AND THE DIADEM?

IT REMAINED WHERE I HAD HIDDEN IT WHEN I HEARD THE BAREN SLINDERING THROUGH THE FOREST TOWARD ME. CONCEALED INSIDE A HOLLOW TREE.

A HOLLOW TREE? REPEATED HARRY. WHAT TREE? WHERE WAS THIS?  
A FOREST IN ALBANIA, A LONELY PLACE I THOUGHT WAS FAR BEYOND MY MOTHER'S REACH.

ALBANIA, REPEATED HARRY, SENSE WAS EMERGING MIRACULOUSLY FROM CHINPLISHEN, AND NOW HE UNDERSTOOD WHY SHE WAS TELLING HIM WHAT SHE HAD DENIED DUMBLEDORE AND FLITWICK. SHE'VE ALREADY TOLD SOMEONE THIS STORY, HAVEN'T SHE? ANOTHER STUDENT? SHE CLOSED HER EYES AND NODDED.

I HAD ... NO IDEA, ... HE WAS ... FLATTERING, HE SEEMED TO ... TO UNDERSTAND ... TO SYMPATHIZE, ... YES, HARRY REHLIGHT, THE RIDDLE WOULD CERTAINLY HAVE UNDERSTOOD HELENA RAVENCLAW'S DESIRE TO POSSESS FAMILIAR OBJECTS TO WHICH SHE HAD LITTLE RIGHT.

WELL, SHE'VE BEEN THE FIRST PERSON RIDDLE WHISPERED THINGS INTO ME, HARRY MUTTERED. HE COULD BE CHARMING WHEN HE WANTED, ... SHE VERDMENT HAD MANAGED TO WORK OUT THE LOCATION OF THE LOST DIADEM INTO THE GRAY LADY, HE HAD TRAVELED TO THAT FAR-FLUNG FOREST AND RETRIEVED THE DIADEM FROM ITS HIDING PLACE, PERHAPS AS SOON AS HE LEFT HOGWARTS, BECAUSE HE EVEN STARTED WORK AT BORGIN AND BLOOMERS.

AND WOULDN'T THESE SECLUDED ALBANIAN WOODS HAVE SEEMED AN EXCELLENT PLACE WHEN, SHE MUCH LATER, VERDMENT HAD NEEDED A PLACE TO LIVE WELL, UNDISTURBED, FOR TEN LONG YEARS? BUT THE DIADEM, SINCE IT BECAME HIS PRECIOUS TREASURE, HAD NOT

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE



BEEN LEFT IN THAT HELLY TREE. . . . NEH, THE DIADEN HAD BEEN RETURNED  
SECRETLY TO ITS TRUE HOME, AND VERDERMERT MUST HAVE PUT IT THERE

THE NIGHT HE ASKED HER A HEK? SAID HARRY, FINISHING HIS  
TEHLIGHT.

I BEG YOUR PARDEN?

HE HID THE DIADEN IN THE CASTLE, THE NIGHT HE ASKED DUMBLE-  
DHORE TO LET HIM TRACH? SAID HARRY, SAYING IT HLT HELD ENABLED HIM

TO MAKE SENSE OF IT ALL. HE MUST VE HIDDEN THE DIADEN IN HIS WAY  
UP TO HER DEHN FROM DUMBLEDHORE'S OFFICE? BUT IT WAS STILL WORTH  
TRYING TO GET THE HEK THEN HE MIGHT VE GET THE CHANCE TO NICK  
GRYFFINDOR'S SWORD AS WELL THANKS YELL, THANKS?

HARRY LEFT HER FLEATING THERE, BLEEDING LITTERLY BEMILDERED, AS HE  
REHLINED THE CORNER BACK INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL, HE CHECKED HIS  
WATCH.

IT WAS FIVE MINUTES UNTIL MIDNIGHT, AND TEHLICH HE NEHL KNEW WHAT  
THE

LAST FHEERCLIX WAS, HE WAS NEH CLESER TO DISCOVERING WHERE IT WAS. . .

,

GENERATIONS OF STUDENTS HAD FAILED TO FIND THE DIADEN; THAT SUG-  
GESTED THAT IT WAS NEHT IN RAVENCLAW TOWER BUT IF NEHT THERE,  
WHERE?

WHAT HIDING PLACE HAD THEY RIDDLE DISCOVERED INSIDE FHEGLHARTS  
CASTLE, THAT HE BELIEVED WOULD REMAIN SECRET FOREVER?

LEFT IN DESPERATE SPECULATION, HARRY TURNED A CORNER, BUT HE HAD  
TAKEN ONLY A FEW STEPS DOWN THE NEW CORRIDOR WHEN THE WINDS THE  
HIS LEFT KNEE OPEN WITH A DEAFENING, SHATTERING CRASH. AS HE  
LEAPT

ASIDE, A GIGANTIC BODY FLEW IN THROUGH THE WINDS AND HIT THE OP-  
POSITE WALL. SOMETHING LARGE AND FLIRRY DETACHED ITSELF,  
WHIMPERING,

FROM THE NEW ARRIVAL AND FLYING ITSELF AT HARRY,

HAGRID: HARRY BELLEVED, FIGHTING OFF FANG THE BARKHILL S  
ATTENTIONS AS THE ENORMOUS BEARDED FIGURE CLAMBERED THE HIS FEET,

WHAT THE ?

HARRY, YER HERE? YER HERE?

THE BATTLE OF  
HOGWARTS

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HAGRID STEPPED DOWN, BELLEVED UPON HARRY A CLASH AND RIK-  
CRACKING FLEW, THEN RAN BACK THE THE SHATTERED WINDS,

GOOD KID, GRADY? HE BELLEVED THROUGH THE FLEE IN THE WIN-  
DOW. I LL SEE YER IN A MOMENT, THERE S A GOOD LAD?

BEYOND HAGRID, HLT IN THE DARK NIGHT, HARRY SAW BURSTS OF LIGHT

IN THE DISTANCE AND HEARD A WEIRD, DEENING SCREAM. HE LEANED DOWN  
AT HIS WATCH: IT WAS MIDNIGHT. THE BATTLE HAD BEGUN.

BLIMPY, HARRY, PANTED HAGRID, THIS IS IT, EN TIME TER FIGHT?

HAGRID, WHERE HAVE YEH BEEN LUMP FREET?

HEARD YEH-KNEEL-WITH FREET LIP IN ELIR CAVE, SAID HAGRID  
GRIMLY, YEH CARRIED, DIDN IT? YEH GET TILL MIDNIGHT TER GIMME  
PHTTER, DNEW YEH MJS BE HERE, DNEW WHAT MJS BE HAPPENIN,  
GET DOWN, FANG, SEE WE LUMP TER IHIN IN, ME AN GRALPY AN FANG,  
SMASHED ELIR WAY THROUGH THE BILINDARY BY THE FHEST, GRALPY  
WAS

CARRYIN LIS, FANG AN ME, THELD HIM TER LET ME DOWN AT THE CASTLE, SEE  
HE SHEVED ME THROUGH THE WINDHES, BLESS HIM, NEET EXAC LY WHAT I  
MEANT, EW WHERE S BEEN AN HERMINNE?

THAT, SAID HARRY, IS A REALLY GOOD ELJESTHEN, LUMP EN.

THEY FLURIED TOGETHER ALONG THE CHRIDER, FANG LUMHPING BESIDE  
THEM, HARRY COULD HEAR MOVEMENT THROUGH THE CHRIDERS ALL  
ARHLND:

RUNNING PHTSTEPS, SHELTS; THROUGH THE WINDHES, HE COULD SEE  
MERE

FLASHES OF LIGHT IN THE DARK GREHLNDS.

WHERE RE WE GHIN? PLIPPED HAGRID, PHLNDING ALONG AT HARRY S  
HEELS, MAKING THE PLHREHARDS BLADE.

I BLINNE EXACTLY, SAID HARRY, MAKING ANOTHER RANDEM TURN,

BLT BEEN AND HERMINNE MJS BE ARHLND HERE SHMLW-HERE. . .

THE FIRST CASUALTIES OF THE BATTLE WERE ALREADY STREWN ACROSS THE  
PASSAGE AHEAD: THE TWE STENE GARGOYLES THAT USUALLY GLARDED THE  
ENTRANCE THE THE STAFFRHEM HAD BEEN SMASHED APART BY A IINX THAT

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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HAD SAILED THROUGH ANOTHER BREKEN WINDEN. THEIR REMAINS STIRRED  
FEELY IN THE FLEET, AND AS HARRY LEAPT OVER ONE OF THEIR  
DISMEMBERED

HEADS, IT MOANED FAINTLY, ~~HE~~ DEN'T MIND ME . . . I LL ILST LIE HERE  
AND CRUMBLE. . . .

ITS LGLY STONE FACE MADE HARRY THINK SLIDENLY OF THE MARBLE ELIST  
OF RHEENA RAVENCLAW AT XENOPHILIUS S HELISE, WEARING THAT MAD  
HEADRESS AND THEN OF THE STATUE IN RAVENCLAW TOWER, WITH THE  
STONE DIADAM LIPEN HER WHITE CURLS. . . .

AND AS HE REACHED THE END OF THE PASSAGE, THE MEMERY OF A THIRD  
STONE EFFIGY CAME BACK TEE HIM: THAT OF AN LGLY ELD WARLOCK, HENTE  
WHOSE HEAD HARRY HIMSELF HAD PLACED A WIG AND A RATTERED ELD TIARA.  
THE SHOCK SENT THROUGH HARRY WITH THE HEAT OF FIREWHISKY, AND HE  
NEARLY STIMBLED.

HE KNEW, AT LAST, WHERE THE FHERLOCK SAT WAITING FOR HIM. . . .

THEM RIDDLE, WHEN CHNVIDED IN NEH ONE AND OPERATED ALONE, MIGHT  
HAVE BEEN ARREGCANT ENOUGH TEE ASSUME THAT HE, AND ONLY HE, HAD  
PENETRATED THE DEEPEST MYSTERIES OF HEGWARTS CASTLE. OF COURSE,  
DUMBLEDORE AND FLITWICK, THESE MEEEL PLIPILS, HAD NEVER SET SEET IN  
THAT PARTILLAR PLACE, BUT HE, HARRY, HAD STRAYED OFF THE BEATEN  
TRACK

IN HIS TIME AT SCHOOL HERE AT LAST WAS A SECRET HE AND  
VHEDEMENT

KNOW, THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD NEVER DISCOVERED

HE WAS REUSED BY PROFESSOR SPRUIT, WHO WAS THUNDERING PAST  
FOLLOWED BY NEVILLE AND HALF A DOZEN OTHERS, ALL OF THEM WEARING  
EARMUFFS AND CARRYING WHAT APPEARED TO BE LARGE POTTED PLANTS,

MANDRAKES! NEVILLE BELLEWD AT HARRY OVER HIS SHOULDER AS HE  
RAN, SEEING THE LOOK THEM OVER THE WALLS THEY WENT LIKE THIS!  
HARRY KNEW NOW WHERE THE GO! HE SPED OFF, WITH HAGRID AND FANG  
GALLOPING BEHIND HIM, THEY PASSED PORTRAIT AFTER PORTRAIT, AND  
THE

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PAINTED FIGURES RACED ALONGSIDE THEM, WIZARDS AND WITCHES IN ROBES  
AND KRECKLES, IN ARMOR AND CHAINS, CRAMPING THEMSELVES INTO EACH  
OTHERS CANVASES, SCREAMING NEWS FROM EITHER PARTS OF THE CASTLE,  
AS

THEY REACHED THE END OF THIS CORRIDOR, THE WHOLE CASTLE SHOOK, AND  
HARRY KNEW, AS A GIGANTIC VASE BLEW OFF ITS PLINTH WITH EXPLOSIVE  
FORCE, THAT IT WAS IN THE GRIP OF ENCHANTMENTS MORE SINISTER THAN  
THOSE OF THE TEACHERS AND THE ORDER,

IT'S ALL RIGHT, FANG IT'S ALL RIGHT! YELLED HAGRID, BUT THE GREAT  
REAR-ROLLING HAD TAKEN FLIGHT AS SLIVERS OF CHINA FLEW LIKE SHRAPNEL  
THROUGH THE AIR, AND HAGRID PHUNDED OFF AFTER THE TERRIFIED DEER,  
LEAVING HARRY ALONE,

HE FORGED ON THROUGH THE TREMBLING PASSAGES, HIS HAND AT THE  
READY, AND AFTER THE LENGTH OF ONE CORRIDOR THE LITTLE PAINTED  
KNIGHT,

SIR CADWGAN, RUSHED FROM PAINTING THE PAINTING BESIDE HIM, CLANDER-  
ING ALONG IN HIS ARMOR, SCREAMING ENCOURAGEMENT, HIS FAT LITTLE  
PENNY

CANTERING BEHIND HIM,

BRAGGARTS AND REGLIES, DEES AND SCHLINDRELS, DRIVE THEM HILT,  
HARRY PETER, SEE THEM OFF!

HARRY FLUTTERED AROUND A CORNER AND FOUND FRED AND A SMALL GROUP  
OF STUDENTS, INCLUDING LEE JORDAN AND HANNAH ARKETT, STANDING  
BESIDE ANOTHER EMPTY PLINTH, WHOSE STATUE HAD CONCEALED A SECRET  
PASSAGEWAY. THEIR HANDS WERE DRAWN AND THEY WERE LISTENING AT THE

CONCEALED PLACE.

NICE NIGHT FOR IT! FRED SMILTED AS THE CASTLE BELABED AGAIN, AND  
HARRY SPRINTED BY, ELATED AND TERRIFIED IN EQUAL MEASURE, ALONG  
YET

ANOTHER CORRIDOR HE DASHED, AND THEN THERE WERE HILLS EVERYWHERE,  
AND MRS. DERRIS WAS HISSING AND TRYING TO BAT THEM WITH HER  
PAILS,

NEE DEELET THE RETURN THEM TO THEIR PROPER PLACE. . . .

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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PETTER?

AKERBERTH DUMBLEDORE STEPPED BLOCKING THE CORRIDOR AHEAD, HIS  
WAND HELD READY.

I'VE HAD HUNDREDS OF KIDS THUNDERING THROUGH MY FLK, PETTER?

I KNOW, WE'RE EVALUATING, HARRY SAID, VOLDMORT'S

ATTACKING BECAUSE THEY HAVEN'T HANDED YETL EVER, YEAH, SAID  
AKERBERTH, I'M NOT DEAD, THE WAY HE OF HESPERADE HEARD HIM, AND  
IT NEVER OCCURRED TO ANY OF YETL THE DEEP A FEW SLYTHERINS HOSTAGE?  
THERE ARE KIDS OF DEATH EATERS YETL YOU JUST SENT THE SAFETY,  
WELL, DON'T

IT HAVE BEEN A BIT SMARTER THE DEEP IN HERE?

IT WOULD NOT STOP VOLDMORT, SAID HARRY, AND YETL BROTHER  
WOULD NEVER HAVE DONE IT.

AKERBERTH GLANCED AND THERE AHEAD IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION,  
YETL BROTHER WOULD NEVER HAVE DONE IT. . . . WELL, IT WAS THE TRUTH,  
HARRY THOUGHT AS HE RAN ON AGAIN; DUMBLEDORE, WHO HAD DEFENDED  
SNAPE FOR SOME TIME, WOULD NEVER HAVE HELD STUDENTS RANSOM. . . .  
AND THEN HE SWERVED AROUND A FINAL CORNER AND WITH A PELL OF  
MINGLED RELIEF AND FURY HE SAW THEM: RON AND HERMIONE, BOTH  
WITH THEIR ARMS FULL OF LARGE, CLAYED, DIRTY YELLOW BRICKS, RON  
WITH

A BROOMSTICK UNDER HIS ARM.

WHERE THE HELL HAVE YETL BEEN? HARRY SHOUTED,

CHAMBER OF SECRETS, SAID RON,

CHAMBER WHAT? SAID HARRY, CHEMING THE AND UNSTEADY PAUSE  
BEFORE THEM.

IT WAS REIN, ALL REIN'S IDEA! SAID HERMINE KEEPELESSLY. WASN'T IT ABSOLUTELY BRILLIANT? THERE WE WERE, AFTER YELI LEFT, AND I SAID THE REIN, EVEN IF WE FIND THE EITHER ONE, WE'LL ARE WE GOING TO GET RID OF IT? WE STILL HADN'T GET RID OF THE CLIP! AND THEN HE THOUGHT OF IT! THE BASILISK!

THE BATTLE OF  
HIGHLANDS

XXX

WHAT THE ?

SOMETHING TO GET RID OF HERCULES, SAID REIN SIMPLY.

HARRY'S EYES DROPPED THE THE OBJECTS CLUTCHED IN REIN AND HERMINE'S ARMS: GREAT CLYVED FANGES, THEN, HE NEEL REALIZED, FROM THE SKULL

OF A DEAD BASILISK.

BUT WE'LL DID YELI GET IN THERE? HE ASKED, STARING FROM THE FANGES THE REIN. YELI NEEED THE SPEAK PARSELTUNGUE?

HE DID! WHISPERED HERMINE. SHELL HIM, REIN!

REIN MADE A HORRIBLE STRANGLED HISsing noise.

IT'S WHAT YELI DID THE WHEN THE LOCKET, HE TOLD HARRY APPELHETTIALLY. I HAD THE HAVE A FEW CHES TO GET IT RIGHT, BUT, HE SHRUGGED



MODESTLY, WE GET THERE IN THE END.

HE WAS AMAZING, SAID HERMIONE, AMAZING!

SHE... HARRY WAS STRUGGLING THE DEEP LIP, SHE...

SHE WAS ANOTHER FIERCELY DEHN, SAID RON, AND FROM UNDER HIS JACKET HE PULLED THE MANGLED REMAINS OF FLUFFLEPUFF'S CLIP, HERMIONE

STARRING IT, THE LIGHT SHE SHOULD, SHE HADN'T HAD THE PLEASURE YET.

GENIUS! YELLED HARRY.

IT WAS NOTHING, SAID RON, THOUGH HE LOOKED DELIGHTED WITH HIMSELF, SHE WAS A NEW WITH YELLY

AS HE SAID IT, THERE WAS AN EXPLOSION FROM OVERHEAD! ALL THREE OF THEM LOOKED UP AS DUST FELL FROM THE CEILING AND THEY HEARD A DISTANT SCREAM.

I KNOW WHAT THE DIADEM LOOKS LIKE, AND I KNOW WHERE IT IS, SAID HARRY, TALKING FAST. HE HAD IT EXACTLY WHERE I HAD MY OLD PENTHUS ROOM, WHERE EVERYONE'S BEEN HIDING STUFF FOR CENTURIES, HE THOUGHT

HE WAS THE ONLY ONE TO FIND IT, CAME ON.

AS THE WALLS TREMBLED AGAIN, HE LED THE OTHER TWO BACK THROUGH THE CONCEALED ENTRANCE AND DOWN THE STAIRCASE INTO THE ROOM OF

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

RM

REQUIREMENT, IT WAS EMPTY EXCEPT FOR THREE WOMEN: GINNY, TENDS,

AND AN ELDERLY LITTLE LADY WEARING A MOUTH-EATEN HAT, WHICH HARRY RECOGNIZED IMMEDIATELY AS NEVILLE'S GRANDMOTHER.

AH, BETTER, SHE SAID CRISPLY AS IF SHE HAD BEEN WAITING FOR HIM.  
YOU CAN TELL US WHAT'S GOING ON.

IS EVERYONE READY? SAID CINDY AND TENDS TOGETHER.

AS FAR AS WE KNOW, SAID HARRY, ARE THERE STILL PEOPLE IN THE PAS-

SAGE THE THE KING'S HEAD?

HE KNEW THAT THE ROOM WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO TRANSFORM WHILE THERE WERE STILL WISERS INSIDE IT.

I WAS THE LAST TO COME THROUGH, SAID MRS. LINGBETTER. I SEALED IT, I THINK IT WOULD BE WISE TO LEAVE IT OPEN NOW ASKERTH HAS LEFT HIS PLACE.

HAVE YOU SEEN MY GRANDSON?

HE'S FIGHTING, SAID HARRY.

NATURALLY, SAID THE OLD LADY FRIENDLY. EXCUSE ME, I MUST GO AND ASSIST HIM.

WITH SURPRISING SPEED SHE TROTTED OFF TOWARD THE STONE STEPS.

HARRY LOOKED AT TENDS.

I THOUGHT YOU WERE SUPPOSED TO BE WITH TEDDY AT YOUR MOTHER'S?

I COULDN'T STAND NOT KNOWING TENDS LOOKED ANGUISHED.

SHE'LL BE BACK AFTER HIM HAVE YOU SEEN REMLIS?

HE WAS PLANNING TO LEAD A GROUP OF FIGHTERS INTO THE  
GRANDS

WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD, TENDS SPED OFF.

GINDY, SAID HARRY, I'M SORRY, BUT WE NEED YOU TO LEAVE THEM.  
JUST FOR A BIT. THEN YOU CAN COME BACK IN.  
GINDY LOOKED SIMPLY DELIGHTED TO LEAVE HER SANCTUARY.

## THE BATTLE OF HOGWARTS

ENDS

AND THEN YOU CAN COME BACK IN! HE SHOUTED AFTER HER AS SHE RAN  
UP THE STEPS AFTER TENDS. YOU'VE GOT TO COME BACK IN!

HANG ON A MOMENT! SAID REIN SHARPLY. WE'VE FORGOTTEN  
SOMEONE!

WHO? ASKED HERMIONE.

THE HOUSE-ELVES, THEY'LL ALL BE DOWN IN THE KITCHEN, WHEN THEY  
THEY?

YOU MEAN WE SHOULD GET THEM FIGHTING? ASKED HARRY.

NO, SAID REIN SERIOUSLY. I MEAN WE SHOULD TELL THEM TO GET OUT.  
WE DON'T WANT ANY MORE DEATHS, DO WE? WE CAN'T ORDER THEM TO  
DIE FOR US

THERE WAS A CLATTER AS THE BASTARD FACES CASCADING OUT OF HERMI-  
ON'S ARMS, RUNNING AT REIN, SHE PULLING THEM AROUND HIS NECK AND

KISSED HIM FULL ON THE MOUTH. RON THREW AWAY THE FANGS AND  
KREEM-

STICK HE WAS HOLDING AND RESPONDED WITH SUCH ENTHUSIASM THAT HE  
LIFTED HERMIONE OFF HER FEET.

IS THIS THE MOMENT? HARRY ASKED WEABLY, AND WHEN NOTHING  
HAPPENED EXCEPT THAT RON AND HERMIONE GRIPPED EACH OTHER STILL  
MORE FIRMLY AND SLAYED HIM THE SPEET, HE RAISED HIS VOICE. HE:  
THERE S

A WAR GOING ON HERE!

RON AND HERMIONE BROKE APART, THEIR ARMS STILL AROUND EACH  
OTHER.

I KNOW, MATE, SAID RON, WHO LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD RECENTLY  
BEEN HIT ON THE BACK OF THE HEAD WITH A BLDGER. SEE IT S NOW OR  
NEVER, LEN T IT?

NEVER MIND THAT, WHAT ABOUT THE HERCULES? HARRY SHELTERED.

D YOU THINK YOU COULD LIST LIST HOLD IT IN UNTIL WE VE GOTT THE  
DIADEM?

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

WE

Yeah RIGHT SHRY SAID RON, AND HE AND HERMIONE SET  
ABOUT GATHERING UP FANGS, BOTH PINK IN THE FACE.

IT WAS CLEAR, AS THE THREE OF THEM STEPPED BACK INTO THE CORRIDOR  
UPSTAIRS, THAT IN THE MINUTES THAT THEY HAD SPENT IN THE ROOM OF

REQUIREMENT THE SITUATION WITHIN THE CASTLE HAD DETERIORATED SEVERELY! THE WALLS AND CEILING WERE SHAKING WORSE THAN EVER, DUST

FILLED THE AIR, AND THROUGH THE NEAREST WINDOW, HARRY SAW FLURTS OF

GREEN AND RED LIGHT SEE CLOSE TO THE FRONT OF THE CASTLE THAT HE KNEW

THE DEATH EATERS MUST BE VERY NEAR TO ENTERING THE PLACE. LEAVING  
HIS OWN, HARRY SAW GRAB THE GIANT MEANDERING PAST, SWINGING

WHAT LOOKED LIKE A STEEL GARGOYLE THROU FROM THE REAR AND  
REARING

HIS DISPLEASURE.

LET'S HOPE HE STOPS HIM SOME OF THEM! SAID RON AS MORE SCREAMS  
ECHOED FROM CLOSE BY.

AS LONG AS IT'S NOT ANY OF OURS! SAID A VOICE! HARRY TURNED  
AND

SAW GINNY AND TENDS, BOTH WITH THEIR HANDS DRAGN AT THE NEXT  
WIN-

DOW, WHICH WAS MISSING SEVERAL PANE. EVEN AS HE WATCHED, GINNY

SENT A WELL-AIMED LIX INTO A CROWD OF FIGHTERS REBEL.

GOOD GIRL! REARED A FIGURE RUNNING THROUGH THE DUST TOWARD  
THEM, AND HARRY SAW ABERNETHY AGAIN, HIS GRAY HAIR FLYING AS HE  
LED A

SMALL GROUP OF STUDENTS PAST. THEY WERE LIKE THEY MIGHT BE  
REACH-

ING THE NORTH BATTLEMENTS, THEY WERE BRIGHT GIANTS OF THEIR OWN

HAVE YOU SEEN REMUS? THOMAS CALLED AFTER HIM.

HE WAS DRIVING DEEPER, SHOUTED ABRUPTLY, HAVEN'T SEEN HIM  
SINCE?

THOMAS, SAID GINNY, THOMAS, I'M SURE HE'S DEAD  
BUT THOMAS HAD RUN OFF INTO THE DISTANCE AFTER ABRUPTLY.  
GINNY TURNED, HELPLESS, TO HARRY, RON, AND HERMION.

THEY'LL BE ALL RIGHT, SAID HARRY, THOUGH HE KNEW THEY WERE

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HOGWARTS

END

EMPTY WORDS. GINNY, WE'LL BE BACK IN A MOMENT, JUST KEEP HOLD  
OF THE WAY, KEEP SAFE. COME ON! HE SAID TO RON AND HERMION,  
AND THEY RAN BACK TO THE STRETCH OF WALL BEYOND WHICH THE ROOM  
OF

REQUIREMENT WAS WAITING TO BE THE RIDING OF THE NEXT ENTRANT.

I NEED THE PLACE WHERE EVERYTHING IS HIDDEN, HARRY BEGGED OF IT IN-  
SIDE HIS HEAD, AND THE OTHER MATERIALIZED IN THEIR THIRD RUN PAST.

THE FLAME OF THE BATTLE DIED THE MOMENT THEY CROSSED THE THRESH-

HOLD AND CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND THEM: ALL WAS SILENT. THEY WERE

IN A PLACE THE SIZE OF A CATHEDRAL WITH THE APPEARANCE OF A CITY, ITS  
THEWERING WALLS KLILT OF BRICKS HIDDEN BY THOUSANDS OF MENG-CHINE  
STUDENTS.

AND HE NEVER REALIZED ANYONE COULD GET IN? SAID RICH, HIS VEHICLE  
RUMBLING IN THE SILENCE.

HE THOUGHT HE WAS THE ONLY ONE, SAID HARRY. THEN RICH ASKED HIM  
I VE HAD THE HIDE STUFF IN MY TIME ... THIS WAY, HE ADDED, I THINK  
IT S BEEN HERE. ...

HE PASSED THE STUFFED TRELL AND THE VANISHING CABINET DRACH  
MALPHEZ HAD MENDED LAST YEAR WITH SUCH DISASTROUS CONSEQUENCES,  
THEN HESITATED, LEEKING UP AND DOWN AISLES OF ILIND: HE COULD NOT  
REMEMBER WHERE THE GO NEXT. ...

ACUTE DIABETES? CRIED FERMINE IN DESPERATION, BUT NOTHING FLEW

THROUGH THE AIR TOWARD THEM. IT SEEMED THAT, LIKE THE VALLEY AT  
GRIN-

CHITS, THE ROOM WOULD NOT YIELD ITS HIDDEN BRICKS THAT EASILY.

LET S SPLIT UP, HARRY TOLD THE OTHER TWO. LEED AS A STONE  
LIST

OF AN OLD MAN WEARING A WIG AND A TIARA? IT S STANDING IN A  
CLIPBOARD

AND IT S DEFINITELY SOMEWHERE NEAR HERE. ...

THEY SPED OFF UP ADJACENT AISLES: HARRY COULD HEAR THE OTHERS  
FEETSTEPS RUMBLING THROUGH THE THEWERING PILLS OF ILIND, OF BOTTLES,  
HATS, CRATES, CHAIRS, KEYS, WEAPONS, BRIMSTICKS, RATS. ...

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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SOMEWHERE NEAR HERE, HARRY MUTTERED TO HIMSELF. SOME-  
WHERE . . . SOMEWHERE . . .

DEEPER AND DEEPER INTO THE LABYRINTH HE WENT, LOOKING FOR OBJECTS  
HE RECOGNIZED FROM HIS MORE PREVIOUS TRIP INTO THE ROOM. HIS  
BREATH

WAS HELD IN HIS EARS, AND THEN HIS VERY SKIN SEEMED TO SHIVER:  
THERE

IT WAS, RIGHT AHEAD, THE BLISTERED OLD CLIPBOARD IN WHICH HE HAD HID-  
DEN HIS OLD PENTHUS KEY, AND WHEN HE SAW IT, THE FICKERMARKED STONE

WARRIOR WEARING A DUSTY OLD WIG AND WHAT LOOKED LIKE AN ANCIENT,  
DISCHIEFED TIARA.

HE HAD ALREADY STRETCHED OUT HIS HAND, THOUGH HE REMAINED TEN  
FEET AWAY, WHEN A VOICE BEHIND HIM SAID, HOLD IT, PETER.

HE SKIDDED TO A HALT AND TURNED AROUND. CRABBE AND GOYLE WERE  
STANDING BEHIND HIM, SHOULDER TO SHOULDER, WANDS POINTING RIGHT  
AT HARRY. THROUGH THE SMALL SPACE BETWEEN THEIR IRKING FACES HE  
SAW DRACE MALFOY.

THAT'S MY WAND YOU'RE HOLDING, PETER, SAID MALFOY, POINTING  
HIS ELBOW THROUGH THE GAP BETWEEN CRABBE AND GOYLE.



NEET ANYMORE, PARTED HARRY, TIGHTENING HIS GRIP ON THE HAL-  
TERRN LEAD. WINNERS, DEEPERS, MALFOY, WHEN I LEET YOU THEIRS?

MY MOTHER, SAID DRACO,

HARRY LAUGHED, THOUGH THERE WAS NOTHING VERY HUMOROUS ABOUT  
THE SITUATION. HE COULD NOT HEAR WHEN HER FATHERSOME ANYMORE,  
THEY

SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN LEFT IN DARKNESS, SEARCHING FOR THE DIADEM,

SEE HOW COME YOU THREE AREN'T WITH VANDERBILT? ASKED HARRY,

WE'RE CHINA BE REWARDED, SAID CRABBE: HIS VOICE WAS SURPRIS-  
INGLY SOFT FOR SUCH AN ENORMOUS PERSON; HARRY HAD HARDLY EVER  
HEARD

HIM SPEAK BEFORE. CRABBE WAS SMILING LIKE A SMALL CHILD PROMISED  
A LARGE BAG OF SWEETS. WE LONG BACK, BETTER, WE DECIDED NOT TO GO,  
DECIDED TO BRING YOU THE IM,

THE BATTLE OF  
HOGWARTS

END

GOOD PLAN, SAID HARRY IN MUCH ADMIRATION. HE COULD NOT RE-  
LIEVE THAT HE WAS THIS CLOSE, AND WAS GOING TO BE THREATENED BY  
MALFOY,

CRABBE AND CHDLE. HE BEGAN EDGING SLOWLY BACKWARD TOWARD THE PLACE WHERE THE FIERCELY SAT UPSIDED UPON THE LIST. IF HE COULD LIST

GET HIS HANDS ON IT BEFORE THE FIGHT BROKE OUT . . .

THE FELLOW DID YELL GET IN HERE? HE ASKED, TRYING TO DISTRACT THEM. I VIRTUALLY LIVED IN THE ROOM OF HIDDEN THINGS ALL LAST YEAR, SAID MALPHY, HIS VOICE BRITTLE. I KNOW FELLOW GET IN.

WE WAS HIDING IN THE CORRIDOR OUTSIDE, GRIINTED CHDLE. WE CAN BE DIS-LISTEN CLARMS NOW! AND THEN, HIS FACE SPLIT INTO A GRIMACE

GRIN. YELL TURNED UP RIGHT IN FRONT OF LIS AND SAID YELL WAS LEAVING

AH A DICK-CLIP! WHAT A DICK-CLIP!

HARRY? THEN A VOICE CAME SLIDING FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE WALL THE HARRY IS RIGHT. ARE YELL TALKING TO SOMEONE?

WITH A WHIPLIKE MOVEMENT, CRABBE POINTED HIS HAND AT THE FIFTY-FOOT MOUNTAIN OF OLD FURNITURE, OF BROKEN TABLES, OF OLD CHAIRS

AND BOOKS AND UNIDENTIFIABLE IRON, AND SHOUTED, DESCENDING

THE WALL BEGAN TO TRETTLE, THEN THE TOP THIRD CRUMPLED INTO THE AISLE NEXT DOOR WHERE THEN STOOD.

THEN! HARRY BELLEWED, AS SOMEWHERE OUT OF SIGHT FERMINE SCREAMED, AND HARRY HEARD INNUMERABLE OBJECTS CRASHING TO THE FLOOR ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE DESTABILIZED WALL! HE POINTED HIS HAND

AT THE RAMPART, CRIED, FINITE! AND IT STABILIZED.

NOW! SHOUTED MALPHY, STAYING CRABBE'S ARM AS THE LATTER MADE TO REPEAT HIS SPELL. IF YELL WRECK THE ROOM YELL MIGHT KIDNAP THIS

DIADEM THING?

WHAT'S THAT MATTER? SAID CRABBE, TUGGING HIMSELF FREE. IT'S  
BETTER THE DARK LORD WANTS, WE'VE CARES ABOUT A DICK-OLLY

BETTER CAME IN HERE TO GET IT, SAID MALFOY WITH ILL-DISGUISED

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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IMPATIENCE AT THE SLOW-WITTEDNESS OF HIS COLLEAGUES, SHE THAT MUST  
MEAN

MUST MEAN? CRABBE TURNED TO MALFOY WITH UNDISGUISED RE-  
SENTMENT. WE'VE CARES WHAT YOU THINK? I DON'T TAKE YOUR ORDERS ANY  
MORE,

DRAGON, YOU AND YOUR DAD ARE FINISHED,

HARRY? SHELLIED BEEN AGAIN, FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ILAND  
WALL. WHAT'S GOING ON?

HARRY? MIMICKED CRABBE. WHAT'S GOING ON, PETER?  
[CRACKING]

HARRY HAD LUNGED FOR THE TIARA; CRABBE'S CLASP MISSED HIM BUT HIT  
THE STONE SLIT, WHICH FLEW INTO THE AIR; THE DIADEM SHARED UPWARD  
AND THEN DROPPED OUT OF SIGHT IN THE MASS OF BRICKS AND WHICH THE  
SLIT HAD RESTED,

STEED? MALFOY SHELLIED AT CRABBE, HIS VOICE ECHOING THROUGH  
THE ENORMOUS ROOM. THE DARK LORD WANTS HIM ALIVE

SEE I'M NOT KILLING HIM, AM I? YELLED CRABBE, THROWING OFF  
MALFOY'S RESTRAINING ARM. BUT IF I CAN, I WILL, THE DARK LORD  
WANTS

HIM DEAD ANYWAY, WHAT'S THE DIFF?

AS IF THE SCARLET LIGHT SHEET PAST HARRY BY INCHES! HERMIONIE HAD  
RUN

AROUND THE CORNER BEHIND HIM AND SENT A STUNNING SPELL STRAIGHT  
AT CRABBE'S HEAD. IT ONLY MISSED BECAUSE MALFOY PULLED HIM OUT OF  
THE WAY.

IT'S THAT MURDERER! AVADA KEDAVRA!

HARRY SAW HERMIONIE DIVE ASIDE, AND HIS FLURRY THAT CRABBE HAD  
AIMED THE KILL WIPED ALL ELSE FROM HIS MIND. HE SENT A STUNNING  
SPELL

AT CRABBE, WHO LURCHED OUT OF THE WAY, BRUISING MALFOY'S HAND  
OUT OF HIS HAND. IT REELLED OUT OF SIGHT BENEATH A MOUNTAIN OF  
BROKEN

FURNITURE AND BOOKS.

DON'T KILL HIM! DON'T KILL HIM! MALFOY YELLED AT CRABBE

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HOGWARTS

RR1

AND CRABBE, WHO WERE BOTH AIMING AT HARRY! THEIR SPLIT SECOND'S  
HESITATION WAS ALL HARRY NEEDED.

EXPPELLIARMUS!

CEHLE'S WAND FLEW OUT OF HIS HAND AND DISAPPEARED INTO THE BLIND-  
WARD OF BRICKS BESIDE HIM; CEHLE LEAPT FORTHWILLY IN THE SPOT,  
TRYING

TO RETRIEVE IT; MALPHY JUMPED OUT OF RANGE OF FERMINE'S SECOND  
STUNNING SPELL, AND REN, APPEARING SUDDENLY AT THE END OF THE  
AISLE,

SHOT A FLAMING-RED CURSE AT CRACK, WHICH NARROWLY MISSED.  
CRACK WHEELED AROUND AND SCREAMED, AVADA KEDAVRA! AGAIN.

REN LEAPT OUT OF SIGHT THROUGH THE JET OF GREEN LIGHT. THE WAND-  
LESS MALPHY COWERED BEHIND A THREE-LEGGED WARDROBE AS FERMINE

CHARGED TOWARD THEM, HITTING CEHLE WITH A STUNNING SPELL AS SHE  
CAME.

IT'S SOMEWHERE HERE! HARRY YELLED AT HER, POINTING AT THE PILE  
OF ILIND INTO WHICH THE GOLD TIARA HAD FALLEN. SEARCH FOR IT WHILE I  
GO

AND HELP R

HARRY! SHE SCREAMED.

A REHARING, KILLING NEISE BEHIND HIM GAVE HIM A MOMENT'S  
WARNING. HE TURNED AND SAW BOTH REN AND CRACK RUNNING AS HARD  
AS THEY COULD UP THE AISLE TOWARD THEM.

LIKE IT HET, SLIP? REHARD CRACK AS HE RAN.

BUT HE SEEMED TO HAVE NO CONCERN OVER WHAT HE HAD DONE. FLAMES  
OF ABNORMAL SIZE WERE PURSUING THEM, LICKING UP THE SIDES OF THE  
ILIND

BLINDARDS, WHICH WERE CRUMBLING THE SHEET AT THEIR THICK.

ACQUAINTI: HARRY RAN, BUT THE ICE OF WATER THAT SPARED THEM  
THE TIP OF HIS WAND EVAPORATED IN THE AIR.

AND

MALFOY GRABBED THE STUNNED GOYLE AND DRAGGED HIM ALONG;

CRABBE HILTSTRIPPED ALL OF THEM, NEEL BEHOLDING TERRIFIED; HARRY, RON,

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AND

AND HERMIONA PELTED ALONG IN HIS WAKE, AND THE FIRE PURSUED THEM.

IT WAS NOT NORMAL FIRE; CRABBE HAD USED A CURSE OF WHICH HARRY  
HAD

NO KNOWLEDGE: AS THEY TURNED A CORNER THE FLAMES CHASED THEM AS  
THOUGH THEY WERE ALIVE, SENTIENT, INTENT UPON KILLING THEM. NEEL  
THE

FIRE WAS MUTATING, FORMING A GIGANTIC PACK OF FIERY BEASTS:  
FLAMING

SERPENTS, CHIMÆRAS, AND DRAGONS RISE AND FALL AND RISE AGAIN, AND  
THE DETRITUS OF CENTURIES IN WHICH THEY WERE FEEDING WAS THROWN  
UP IN THE AIR INTO THEIR FANGED MOUTHS, THESSED HIGH IN CLAWED FEET,  
BEFORE BEING CONSUMED BY THE INFERNO.

MALFOY, CRABBE, AND GOYLE HAD VANISHED FROM VIEW: HARRY, RON,  
AND HERMIONA STOPPED DEAD; THE FIERY MONSTERS WERE CIRCLING THEM,  
DRAWING CLOSER AND CLOSER, CLAWS AND FIBERS AND TAILS LASHED, AND  
THE

HEAT WAS SUCH AS A WALL AROUND THEM.

WHAT CAN WE DO? HERMIONA SCREAMED OVER THE DRAGGING REARS

OF THE FIRE. WHAT CAN WE DO?

HERE!

HARRY SEIZED A PAIR OF HEAVY-LOOKING BROOMSTICKS FROM THE NEAREST

PILE OF ILDS AND THREW ONE THE REIN, WHICH PULLED HERMIONE INTO IT BEHIND HIM. HARRY SWUNG HIS LEG OVER THE SECOND BROOM AND, WITH HARD KICKS TO THE GRIND, THEY SPARED UP INTO THE AIR, MISSING BY FEET

THE HORNED HEAD OF A FLAMING RAPTOR THAT SNAPPED ITS JAWS AT THEM.

THE SMOKE AND HEAT WERE BECOMING OVERWHELMING! BEFORE THEM THE CLOSED FIRE WAS CONSUMING THE CENTRALS OF GENERATIONS OF FLINTED

STUDENTS, THE GLIMTY MENTHES OF A THOUSAND BANNED EXPERIMENTS, THE SECRETS OF THE ENDLESS SELLS WHICH HAD SELIGHT REPOSE IN THE REIN.

HARRY COULD NOT SEE A TRACE OF MALFOY, CRABBE, OR GOYLE ANYWHERE!

HE SWERVED AS LOW AS HE DARED OVER THE MARAUDING MINISTERS OF FLAME THE TRY THE FIND THEM, BUT THERE WAS NOTHING BUT FIRE! WHAT A TERRIBLE WAY TO DIE. . . . HE HAD NEVER WANTED THIS. . . .

THE BATTLE OF

BECHWARTS

XXX

HARRY, LET'S GET OUT, LET'S GET OUT! BELLEVED REIN, THOUGH IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE TO SEE WHERE THE DEER WAS THROUGH THE BLACK SMOKE.

AND THEN HARRY HEARD A THIN, PITHELI'S FLIMMAM SCREAM FROM AMIDST THE TERRIBLE CHOMPETHEN, THE THUNDER OF DEVILRING FLAME,

IT'S THE DANGEROUS ! REIN YELLED, BUT HARRY WHEELED IN THE AIR, HIS GLASSES GIVING HIS EYES SOME SMALL PROTECTION FROM THE

SMOKE, HE RAN THE FIRESTORM KEEHL, SEEKING A SIGN OF LIFE, A LINK FOR A FACE THAT WAS NOT YET CHARRED LIKE WHITE. . . .

AND HE SAW THEM: MALPHY WITH HIS ARMS AROUND THE LINCENSTHELS CHILD, THE PAIR OF THEM PERCHED ON A FRAGILE TOWER OF CHARRED BRICKS,

AND HARRY DIVED. MALPHY SAW HIM COMING AND RAISED ONE ARM, BUT EVEN AS HARRY GRASPED IT HE KNEW AT ONCE THAT IT WAS NOT GOOD: CHILD

WAS TOO HEAVY AND MALPHY'S HAND, COVERED IN SWEAT, SLID INSTANTLY OUT OF HARRY'S

IF WE DIE FOR THEM, I'LL KILL YOU, HARRY! REARED REIN'S VOICE, AND, AS A GREAT FLAMING CHIMERA BEHE BEGAN UPON THEM,

HE AND HERMIONE DRAGGED CHILD INTO THEIR ARMS AND RISE, REELING AND PITCHING, INTO THE AIR FROM WHERE AS MALPHY CLAMBERED UP BEHIND HARRY,

THE DEER, GET THE DEER, THE DEER! SCREAMED MALPHY IN HARRY'S EAR, AND HARRY SPED UP, FOLLOWING REIN, HERMIONE, AND CHILD

THROUGH THE KILLING BLACK SMOKE, HARDLY ABLE TO BREATHE: AND ALL



AROUND THEM THE LAST FEW SPIKES UNWOUND BY THE DEVOURING FLAMES  
WERE FLUNG INTO THE AIR, AS THE CREATURES OF THE CURSED FIRE CAST  
THEM

HIGH IN CELEBRATION: CLIPS AND SHIELDS, A SPARKLING NECKLACE, AND AN  
ELEGANT, DISHELOURED TIARA

WHAT ARE YOU DOING, WHAT ARE YOU DOING, THE DEER & THAT WAY  
SCREAMED MALPHY, BUT HARRY MADE A HAIRPIN SWERVE AND DIVED. THE  
DIADEM SEEMED TO FALL IN SLOW MOTION, TURNING AND GLITTERING AS IT

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

XXX

DROPPED TOWARD THE MAN IN A PALMING SERPENT, AND THEN HE HAD IT,  
CATCHING IT AROUND HIS WRIST

HARRY SWERVED AGAIN AS THE SERPENT LUNGED AT HIM; HE SWUNG  
UPWARD AND STRAIGHT TOWARD THE PLACE WHERE, HE PRAYED, THE DEER  
STOOD OPEN: REEN, HERMINE, AND GEORGE HAD VANISHED; MALPHY WAS  
SCREAMING AND HOLDING HARRY SO TIGHTLY IT HURT, THEN, THROUGH  
THE

SMOKE, HARRY SAW A RECTANGULAR PATCH IN THE WALL AND STEERED THE  
KREEM AT IT, AND MOMENTS LATER CLEAN AIR FILLED HIS LUNGS AND THEY  
COLLIDED WITH THE WALL IN THE CORRIDOR BEYOND.

MALPHY FELL OFF THE KREEM AND LAY FACEDOWN, GASPING, CHUCKLING,  
AND RETCHING. HARRY REELLED OVER AND SAT UP: THE DEER THE THE  
KREEM

OF RECREATION HAD VANISHED, AND REEN AND HERMINE SAT PANTING  
IN THE FLEET BESIDE GEORGE, WHO WAS STILL UNCONSCIOUS.

CRACK, CRACK MALPHY AS SEEN AS HE WOULD SPEAK. CRACK ...

HE IS DEAD, SAID RENN HARSHLY.

THERE WAS SILENCE, APART FROM PANTING AND CHUCKLING. THEN A

ROW OF FLYING BANGS STRUCK THE CASTLE, AND A GREAT CAVALLADE OF TRANS-  
PARENT FIGURES GALLOPED PAST HIM HORSES, THEIR HEADS SCREAMING  
WITH

BLOODLUST UNDER THEIR ARMS. HARRY STAGGERED ON HIS FEET WHEN THE  
HEADLESS FLINT HAD PASSED AND LUNCHED AROUND! THE BATTLE WAS STILL  
GOING ON ALL AROUND HIM. HE COULD HEAR MORE SCREAMS THAN THERE  
WAS THE RETREATING GHOSTS, PANIC FLARED WITHIN HIM.

WHERE IS GINNY? HE SAID SHARPLY. SHE WAS HERE, SHE WAS SLIP-  
PESSED THE BE GOING BACK INTO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT.

BLIMPY, D YOU REMEMBER IT IS STILL WINDY AFTER THAT FIRE? ASKED RENN,  
BUT HE THEN GOT ON HIS FEET, RUBBING HIS CHEST AND LUNGING LEFT AND  
RIGHT. SHALL WE SPLIT UP AND LOOK ?

NO, SAID HERMIONE, GETTING ON HER FEET THEN, MALPHY AND GINNY

THE BATTLE OF  
HOGWARTS

EEKS

REMAINED SLUMPED HAPLESSLY IN THE CORRIDOR FLOOR, NEITHER OF THEM

HAD HANDS. LET'S STICK TOGETHER, I SAY WE GO HARRY, WHAT'S THAT

IN YOUR ARM?

WHAT? EH? YES

HE PULLED THE DIADEM FROM HIS WRIST AND HELD IT UP. IT WAS STILL HOT, BLACKENED WITH SMOOT, BUT AS HE LOOKED AT IT CLOSELY HE WAS INSTANTLY

ABLE TO MAKE OUT THE TINY WORDS ETCHED UPON IT: BUT KNOWING MEASURE IS MAN'S GREATEST TREASURE.

A BLINDLIKE SUBSTANCE, DARK AND TARRY, SEEMED TO BE LEADING FROM THE DIADEM. SUDDENLY HARRY FELT THE THING VIBRATE VIOLENTLY, THEN BREAK APART IN HIS HANDS, AND AS IT DID SO, HE THOUGHT HE HEARD THE FAINTEST, MOST DISTANT SCREAM OF PAIN, COMING NOT FROM THE GREENLANDS

FROM THE CASTLE, BUT FROM THE THING THAT HAD JUST FRAGMENTED IN HIS FINGERS.

IT MUST HAVE BEEN FIENDFIRE! WHIMPERED HERMIONE, HER EYES IN THE BURNING PIERCES.

SHRILL?

FIENDFIRE CLASSED FIRE IT'S ONE OF THE SUBSTANCES THAT DESTROY

HERCULES, BUT I WOULD NEVER, EVER HAVE DARED USE IT, IT'S SO DANGEROUS-

HELS      HOW DID CRACK KNOW HOW THE      ?

MUST WE LEARNED FROM THE CARROLLS, SAID HARRY CRIMLY,

STAMP HE WASN'T CONCENTRATING WHEN THEY MENTIONED HOW THE  
STEP IT, REALLY, SAID RON, WHOSE HAIR, LIKE HERMIONE'S, WAS SINGED,  
AND WHOSE FACE WAS BLACKENED. IF HE HADN'T TRIED THE DRILL LIS ALL, I'D  
BE WHITE SHERO HE WAS DEAD.

BUT DON'T YOU REALIZE? WHISPERED HERMIONE. THIS MEANS, IF WE  
CAN JUST GET THE SNAKE

BUT SHE BROKE OFF AS YELLS AND SCREAMS AND THE UNMISTAKABLE NOISES  
OF BURNING FILLED THE CORRIDOR. HARRY WHISKED AROUND AND HIS HEART

## CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

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SEEMED THE FALL: DEATH EATERS HAD PENETRATED HOGWARTS. FRED AND  
PERCY HAD JUST BACKED INTO THE WALL, BOTH OF THEM BURNING MASKED AND  
BURNED MEN.

HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE RAN FORWARD THE HELP: LETS GO LIGHT  
FLY IN EVERY DIRECTION AND THE MAN BURNING PERCY BACKED OFF, FAST!  
THEN HIS FEET SLIPPED AND THEY SAW A HIGH THREE-HEAD AND STREAKED  
HAIR

HELLO, MINISTER! BELIEVED PERCY, SENDING A NEAT LINE STRAIGHT  
AT THE THICKNESS, WHO DROPPED HIS HAND AND CLAWED AT THE FRONT OF

HIS REEKS, APPARENTLY IN AWFUL DISCOMFORT. DID I MENTION I'M  
RESIGNING?

YELL ARE DIEDING, PERCE? SEEMED FRED AS THE DEATH EATER HE WAS  
BATTING COLLAPSED UNDER THE WEIGHT OF THREE SEPARATE STUNNING

SPELLS. THICKNESS HAD FALLEN THE THE GRIMING WITH TINY SPIKES  
ERUPT-

ING ALL OVER HIM; HE SEEMED THE BE TURNING INTO SOME FORM OF SEA

WITCHIN, FRED LOOKED AT PERCY WITH GLEE.

YELL ACTUALLY ARE DIEDING, PERCE. . . . I DONT THINK I VE HEARD YELL  
DIE SINCE YELL WERE

THE AIR EXPLODED. THEY HAD BEEN GRIMING TOGETHER, HARRY, RON,  
HERMIONE, FRED, AND PERCY, THE TWO DEATH EATERS AT THEIR FEET, ONE  
STUNNED, THE OTHER TRANSFIGURED; AND IN THAT FRAGMENT OF A  
MOMENT,

WHEN DANGER SEEMED TEMPORARILY AT BAY, THE WORLD WAS RENT APART.  
HARRY FELT HIMSELF FLYING THROUGH THE AIR, AND ALL HE COULD DO WAS  
HOLD AS TIGHTLY AS POSSIBLE THE THAT THIN STICK HE KNEW THAT WAS HIS  
ONE AND ONLY WEAPON, AND SHIELD HIS HEAD IN HIS ARMS; HE HEARD  
THE SCREAMS AND YELLS OF HIS COMPANIONS WITHOUT A HOPE OF  
KNOWING

WHAT HAD HAPPENED TO THEM

AND THEN THE WORLD RESOLVED ITSELF INTO PAIN AND SEMIDARKNESS;  
HE WAS HALF BURIED IN THE WRECKAGE OF A CORRIDOR THAT HAD BEEN

THE BATTLE OF

BEGLIARTS

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SUBJECTED TO A TERRIBLE ATTACK. CHILD AIR TOLD HIM THAT THE SIDE OF THE CASTLE HAD BEEN BLOWN AWAY, AND THE STICKINESS ON HIS CHEEK TOLD HIM THAT HE WAS BLEEDING HEAVILY. THEN HE HEARD A TERRIBLE CRY THAT

PULLED AT HIS INSIDES, THAT EXPRESSED AGONY OF A KIND NEITHER FLAME NOR COLD CHILD COULD, AND HE STOOD UP, SWAYING, MORE FRIGHTENED THAN HE HAD BEEN THAT DAY, MORE FRIGHTENED, PERHAPS, THAN HE HAD BEEN IN HIS LIFE. . . .

AND HERMIENE WAS STRUGGLING TO HER FEET IN THE WRECKAGE, AND THREE RED-HEADED MEN WERE GRIPPING HER IN THE GRIND WHERE THE WALL HAD BLASTED APART. HARRY GRABBED HERMIENE'S HAND AS THEY STAGGERED

AND STUMBLER OVER STONE AND WOOD.

NH NH NH! SOMEONE WAS SCREAMING. NH! FRED! NH! AND PERCY WAS SHAKING HIS BROTHER, AND RON WAS KNEELING BESIDE THEM, AND FRED'S EYES STARED WITHELT SEEING, THE GHOST OF HIS LAST LAUGH STILL ETCHED UPON HIS FACE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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THE ELDER WARD

THE WORLD HAD ENDED, SHE KNEW HAD THE BATTLE NOT CEASED, THE  
CASTLE FALLEN SILENT IN FUROR, AND EVERY COMBATANT LAID DOWN  
THEIR ARMS? HARRY'S MIND WAS IN FREE FALL, SPINNING OUT OF  
CONTROL,  
UNABLE TO GRASP THE IMPOSSIBILITY, BECAUSE FRED WEASLEY COULD NOT  
BE DEAD, THE EVIDENCE OF ALL HIS SENSES MUST BE LYING  
AND THEN A BODY FELL PAST THE FLEEING BLOOD INTO THE SIDE OF THE  
STREET, AND CLERGS FLEW IN AT THEM FROM THE DARKNESS, HITTING THE  
WALL BEHIND THEIR HEADS.

GET DOWN! HARRY SHOUTED, AS MORE CLERGS FLEW THROUGH THE  
NIGHT! HE AND RON HAD BOTH GRABBED HERMION AND PULLED HER

THE THE FLEEING, BUT PERCY LAY ACROSS FRED'S BODY, SHIELDING IT FROM  
FLY-

THEIR FURY, AND WHEN HARRY SHOUTED, PERCY, COME ON, WE'RE GETTING

MOVING! HE SHOOK HIS HEAD.

PERCY! HARRY SAW TEAR TRACKS STREAMING THE GRIME CHATING  
RON'S

FACE AS HE SEIZED HIS ELDER BROTHER'S SHOULDERS AND PULLED, BUT PERCY  
T

THE ELDER WARD

WAS

WOULD NOT BUDGE. PERCY, YOU CAN'T DO ANYTHING FOR HIM! WE'RE GETTING  
THE

HERMIONIE SCREAMED, AND HARRY, TURNING, DID NOT NEED TO ASK WHY. A MINISTREL'S SPIDER THE SIZE OF A SMALL CAR WAS TRYING TO CLIMB THROUGH THE HUGER HOLE IN THE WALL: ONE OF ARACHNE'S DESCENDANTS HAD JOINED THE FIGHT.

RON AND HARRY SHELTED TOGETHER; THEIR SPELLS COLLIDED AND THE MINISTREL WAS BLOWN BACKWARD, ITS LEGS TRODING FURRIEPLY, AND VANISHED INTO THE DARKNESS.

IT BRIGHT FRIENDS! HARRY CALLED TO THE OTHERS, GLANCING OVER THE

EDGE OF THE CASTLE THROUGH THE HOLE IN THE WALL THE CURSES HAD BLASTED:

MORE GIANT SPIDERS WERE CLIMBING THE SIDE OF THE BUILDING, LIBERATED FROM THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, INTO WHICH THE DEATH EATERS MUST HAVE

PENETRATED. HARRY FIRED STUNNING SPELLS DOWN UPON THEM, DROPPING THE LEAD MINISTREL INTO ITS PELLEWS, SEE THAT THEY ROLLED BACK DOWN

THE BUILDING AND FELL TO SIGHT. THEN MORE CURSES CAME SHARING OVER

HARRY'S HEAD, SEE CLEAR HE FELT THE FORCE OF THEM BLOW HIS HAIR.

LET'S MOVE, NOW!

PUSHING HERMIONIE AHEAD OF HIM WITH RON, HARRY STEPPED TO SEIZE FRED'S KIDNEY UNDER THE ARMPIES. PERCY, REALIZING WHAT HARRY WAS TRYING TO DO, STEPPED CLINGING TO THE KIDNEY AND HELPED; TOGETHER,



CRASHING WHEN THEY AVOID THE CLASSES FLYING AT THEM FROM THE  
CORRIDORS,

THEY HALLUCINATED FRED HURT BY THE WAY,

HERE, SAID HARRY, AND THEY PLACED HIM IN A NICHE WHERE A SLIT

OF ARMOR HAD STOOD EARLIER, HE COULD NOT HEAR THE WHISPER AT FRED'S  
FEET-

AND LONGER THAN HE HAD THE, AND AFTER MAKING SURE THAT THE BODY  
WAS

WELL HIDDEN, HE THREW OFF AFTER RON AND HERMION, MALFOY AND  
GRIFF

HAD VANISHED, BUT AT THE END OF THE CORRIDOR, WHICH WAS NOW FULL

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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OF BLIST AND FALLING MASTERY, GLASS BEING GONE FROM THE WINDOWS, HE  
SAW MANY PEOPLE RUNNING BACKWARD AND FORWARD, WHETHER FRIENDS

OR NOT HE COULD NOT TELL. ROUNDBY THE CORNER, PERCY LET OUT A  
SHOUT-

LIKE THAT: CRASH! AND SPRINTED OFF IN THE DIRECTION OF A

TALL MAN, WHO WAS PURSUING A GROUP OF STUDENTS,

HARRY, IN HERE! HERMION SCREAMED,

SHE HAD PULLED RON BEHIND A TAPESTRY! THEY SEEMED TO BE WRESTLING TOGETHER, AND HER MIND HAD SEENED HARRY THOUGHT THAT THEY WERE

EMBRACING AGAIN! THEN HE SAW THAT HERMIONE WAS TRYING TO RESTRAIN

RON, TO STOP HIM RUNNING AFTER PEROY.

LISTEN TO ME LISTEN, RON!

I WANNA HELP I WANNA KILL DEATH EATERS

HIS FACE WAS CONTORTED, SMEARED WITH DIRT AND SMOKE, AND HE WAS SHAKING WITH RAGE AND GRIEF.

RON, WE ARE THE ONLY ONES WHO CAN END IT! PLEASE RON WE NEED THE SNARE, WE'VE GOT TO KILL THE SNARE! SAID HERMIONE. BUT HARRY KNEW HOW RON FELT! PURSUING ANOTHER HERCULES CHALLENGE BRING THE SATISFACTION OF REVENGE! HE THEM WANTED THE FIGHT, TO FINISH THEM, THE PEOPLE WHO HAD KILLED FRED, AND HE WANTED TO FIND THE OTHER WEASLEYS, AND ABOVE ALL MAKE SURE, MAKE WHITE SURE, THAT GINNY WAS SAFE BUT HE COULD NOT PERMIT THAT IDEA TO FORM IN HIS MIND

WE WILL FIGHT! HERMIONE SAID. WE'LL HAVE TO REACH THE SNARE!

BUT LET'S NOT LOSE SIGHT NOW OF WHAT WE'RE SUPPOSED TO BE DOING! WE ARE THE ONLY ONES WHO CAN END IT!

SHE WAS CRYING THEN, AND SHE WIPED HER FACE ON HER TIE AND SINGED SILENTLY AS SHE SPOKE, BUT SHE TOOK GREAT HEAVING BREATHS TO CALM HERSELF

AS, STILL KEEPING A TIGHT HOLD ON RON, SHE TURNED TO HARRY.

## THE ELDER WARD

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THEY NEED TO FIND HIM WHERE VERDERMONT IS, BECAUSE HE WILL HAVE THE  
SNAKE WITH HIM, WHEN THEY SEE IT, HARRY      LEANS INSIDE HIM?

WHY WAS IT SO EASY? BECAUSE HIS SCAR HAD BEEN BURNING FOR HOURS,  
BURNING THE SKIN HIM VERDERMONT'S TIGHTLY? HE CLOSED HIS EYES  
AND

HIS COMMAND, AND AT ONCE, THE SCREAMS AND THE RAGES AND ALL THE  
DISCHORDANT SOUNDS OF THE BATTLE WERE DREINED UNTIL THEY BECAME  
DISTANT, AS THOUGH HE STOOD FAR, FAR AWAY FROM THEM, . . .

HE WAS STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF A DESOLATE HILL STRANGELY FAMILIAR  
TO HIM, WITH PEELING PAPEL ON THE WALLS AND ALL THE WINDOWS SHARDED  
EXCEPT FOR ONE. THE SOUNDS OF THE ASSAULT ON THE CASTLE WERE  
MUFFLED

AND DISTANT. THE SINGLE UNSHUTTED WINDOW REVEALED DISTANT FLICKS  
OF

LIGHT WHERE THE CASTLE STOOD, BUT INSIDE THE ROOM IT WAS DARK  
EXCEPT

FOR A SOLITARY OIL LAMP,

HE WAS REELING HIS HAND BETWEEN HIS FINGERS, WATCHING IT, HIS  
THOUGHTS ON THE ROOM IN THE CASTLE, THE SECRET ROOM ONLY HE HAD  
EVER

BEEN, THE ROOM, LIKE THE CHAMBER, THAT THEY HAD BEEN SO CLEVER AND  
CUNNING AND INHIBITIVE TO DISCOVER. . . . HE WAS CONFIDENT THAT THE  
KING WOULD NOT FIND THE DIADEM . . . ALTHOUGH OLIVERMORE'S PLOT  
HAD COME MUCH FARTHER THAN HE HAD EVER EXPECTED . . . THEN FAR, . . .

MY LORD, SAID A VOICE, DESPERATE AND CRACKED, HE TURNED: THERE WAS LUKILIS MALPHY SITTING IN THE DARKEST CORNER, RAGGED AND STILL BEARING THE MARKS OF THE PUNISHMENT HE HAD RECEIVED AFTER THE

LAST ESCAPE, EVEN IF HIS EYES REMAINED CLOSED AND PLUMP. MY LORD ... PLEASE ... MY SON ...

IF YELIR SHIN IS DEAD, LUKILIS, IT IS NOT MY FAULT. HE DID NOT COME AND JOIN ME, LIKE THE REST OF THE SLOTHERINS. PERHAPS HE HAS DECIDED THE FRIEND HARRY PETER?

HE NEVER, WHISPERED MALPHY.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

END

YELI MUST HAVE NOT.

AREN'T AREN'T YELI AFRAID, MY LORD, THAT PETER MIGHT DIE AT AN-

EITHER HAND BUT YELIRS? ASKED MALPHY, HIS VOICE SHAKING. WHELDON T

IT BE ... FORGIVE ME ... MORE PRUDENT THE CALL OFF THIS BATTLE, ENTER THE CASTLE, AND SEEK HIM Y-YELIRSELF?

DO NOT PRETEND, LUKILIS, YELI WISH THE BATTLE THE CASE SEE THAT YELI CAN DISCOVER WHAT HAS HAPPENED TO YELIR SHIN, AND I DO NOT NEED THE SEEK

PETER, BEFORE THE NIGHT IS OUT, PETER WILL HAVE COME TO FIND ME.

Voldemort dropped his gaze once more to the wand in his fingers. It troubled him . . . and these things that troubled Lord Voldemort needed to be rearranged. . . .

Go and fetch Snape.

Snape, m-my Lord?

Snape, well, I need him. There is a service I require from him. Go.

Frightened, stumbling a little through the gleam, Sirius left the room. Voldemort continued to stand there, twirling the wand between his fingers, staring at it.

It is the only way, Nagini, he whispered, and he looked around,

and there was the great thick snake, well suspended in midair, twist-

ing gracefully within the enchanted, protected space he had made

for her, a starry, transparent sphere shimmering between glittering

lace and tape.

With a gasp, Harry pulled back and opened his eyes; at the same moment his ears were assaulted with the screams and cries, the smashes and bangs of battle.

He is in the shrieking shack. The snake is with him, it is getting

short of magical protection around it, he is just sent Sirius Malfoy

to find Snape.

THE ELDER WARD

WAZ

WHERHEART S SITTING IN THE SHRIKING SHACK? SAID HERMIONE,  
ELTRAGED, HE S NEET HE S NEET EVEN FIGHTING?

HE DOESN T THINK HE NEEDS THE FIGHT, SAID HARRY, HE THINKS I M  
GOING TO GET HIM,

BUT WHY?

HE KNOWS I M AFTER HERCULES HE S KEEPING NAGINI CLOSE BE-  
SIDE HIM HOWEVER I M GOING TO HAVE TO GET HIM TO GET NEAR

THE THING

RIGHT, SAID RON, SHAKING HIS SHOULDERS, SHE WILL CAN T GET  
THAT S

WHAT HE WANTS, WHAT HE S EXPECTING, WILL STAY HERE AND WATCH AFTER  
HERMIONE, AND I LL GO AND GET IT

HARRY CUT ACROSS RON,

WILL YOU STAY HERE, I LL GO UNDER THE CHAIR AND I LL BE BACK AS  
SOON AS I

NO, SAID HERMIONE, IT MAKES MUCH MORE SENSE IF I TAKE THE  
CHAIR AND

DON T EVEN THINK ABOUT IT, RON SNARLED AT HER,

BEFORE HERMIONE COULD GET FARTHER THAN RON, I M JUST AS CAPA-

BUT THE TAPESTRY AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRCASE IN WHICH THEY  
STOOD

WAS RIPPED OPEN,

PETTER:

TWO MASKED DEATH EATERS STOOD THERE, BUT EVEN BEFORE THEIR  
HANDS WERE FULLY RAISED, HERMINE SHOUTED, CLASSED:

THE STAIRS BENEATH THEIR FEET FLATTENED INTO A FLAT AND SHE,  
HARRY,

AND BEN FLURLED DOWN IT, UNABLE TO CONTROL THEIR SPEED BUT SHE FAST  
THAT THE DEATH EATERS STUNNING SPELLS FLEW FAR OVER THEIR HEADS.

THEY SHEET THROUGH THE CONCEALING TAPESTRY AT THE BOTTOM AND  
SPIN

ENTER THE HALL, HITTING THE OPPOSITE WALL.

DOWN! CRIED HERMINE, POINTING HER WAND AT THE TAPESTRY, AND

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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THERE WERE TWO MORE, SICKENING CRUNCHES AS THE TAPESTRY TURNED THE  
STONE AND THE DEATH EATERS PURSUING THEM CRUMPLED AGAINST IT.

GET BACK! SHOUTED BEN, AND HE, HARRY, AND HERMINE FLAT-  
TENED THEMSELVES AGAINST A DOOR AS A HERD OF GALLIPEING DEERS  
THIN-

DERED PAST, SHEPHERDED BY A SPRINTING PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. SHE

APPEARED NEXT THE NOTICE THEM: HER HAIR HAD COME DOWN AND THERE WAS A GASH IN HER CHEEK. AS SHE TURNED THE CORNER, THEY HEARD HER

SCREAM. ~~CLANG!~~

HARRY, WHO GOT THE CLASH IN, SAID HERMIONE, NEVER MIND US

BUT HE THREW IT OVER ALL THREE OF THEM; LARGE THOUGH THEY WERE, HE

DELETED ANYONE WHOULD SEE THEIR DISMEMBERED FEET THOUGH THE DUST THAT CLOGGED THE AIR, THE FALLING STONE, THE SHIMMER OF SPELLS,

THEY RAN DOWN THE NEXT STAIRCASE AND FEELING THEMSELVES IN A CORRIDOR FULL OF DIZELERS, THE PORTRAITS ON EITHER SIDE OF THE FIGHTERS WERE

CRAMMED WITH FIGURES SCREAMING ADVICE AND ENCOURAGEMENT, WHILE DEATH EATERS, BOTH MASKED AND UNMASKED, DIZELED STUDENTS AND TEACHERS. DEAN HAD WHIP HIMSELF A WAND, FOR HE WAS FACE-TO-FACE WITH DUMBLEDOY, PARVATI WITH TRAVERS, HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE RAISED THEIR WANDS AT ONCE, READY TO STRIKE, BUT THE DIZELERS WERE

WEAVING AND DARTING AROUND SO QUICK THAT THERE WAS A STRENGTH LIKE-

NESS OF FLIRTING ONE OF THEIR OWN SIDE IF THEY LAST CLASHES. EVEN AS

THEY STEAD BRACED, LEARNING FOR THE OPPORTUNITY THE ACT, THERE CAME A



GREAT WHISPERING! AND, LEERLING UP, HARRY SAW PEEVES  
ZEEHNING

EVER THEM, DREPPING SNAREBALLS PEEBS DEHN ENTEH THE DEATH EATERS,  
WHESSE HEADS WERE SLUDENLY ENGLWED IN WRIGGLING GREEN TWERS LIKE  
PAT WHERMS.

ARGH!

A FISTFUL OF TWERS HAD HIT THE CHEAD EVER BEEN S HEAD; THE SLIMP

THE ELDER WAND

WAS

GREEN WHITS WERE SUSPENDE IMPREHABLY IN MIDAIR AS BEEN TRIED THE  
SHADE THEM WHESSE.

SHEMENE S INVISIBLE THERE! SHELITED A MASKED DEATH EATER,  
PHINTING.

DEAN MADE THE MEET OF THE DEATH EATER S MEEMENTARY DISTRACTION,  
KNICKING HIM HILT WITH A STURNING SPELL; DEHNENY  
ATTEMPTED

THE RETALIATE AND PARVATI SEHT A BODY-KIND CURSE AT HIM.

LET S GEE! HARRY YELLED, AND HE, BEEN, AND HERMENE CATH-  
ERED THE CHEAD TIGHTLY AREHND THEMSELVES AND PELTED, HEADS DEHN,

THREHGH THE MIDST OF THE FIGHTERS, SLIPPING A LITTLE IN PEEHLS OF  
SNAR-

GALLYF ILICE, THELARD THE THEP OF THE MARBLE STAIRCASE INTO THE ENTRANCE

HALL.

I M DRACH MALTHEY, I M DRACH, I M HEN YELIR SIDE?

DRACH WAS HEN THE UPPER LANDING, PLEADING WITH ANOTHER MASKED

DEATH LATER. HARRY STUNNED THE DEATH LATER AS THEY PASSED: MALTHEY WHIPPED AROUND, BEATING, FOR HIS SAVIOR, AND REIN PUNCHED HIM

FROM UNDER THE CHAIR. MALTHEY FELL BACKWARD HEN THEP OF THE DEATH LATER, HIS MOUTH BLEEDING, LITTERLY KILLED.

AND THAT S THE SECOND TIME WE VE SAVED YELIR LIFE TONIGHT, YELI TWO-FACED KASTARD? REIN YELLED.

THERE WERE MORE DIZELERS ALL OVER THE STAIRS AND IN THE HALL, DEATH LATERE EVERYWHERE HARRY WHIPPED: YAWLEY, CLOSE TO THE FRONT DOORS, IN COMBAT WITH FLITWICK, A MASKED DEATH LATER DIZELING KINGSELY RIGHT BESIDE THEM. STUDENTS RAN IN EVERY DIRECTION, SOME CARRYING HER

DROGGING INJURED FRIENDS. HARRY DIRECTED A STUNNING SPELL THELARD THE MASKED DEATH LATER; IT MISSED BUT NEARLY HIT NEVILLE, WHO HAD

EMERGED FROM NOWHERE BRANDISHING ARMOILS OF VERHEMELIS TENTACULA, WHICH WHIPPED ITSELF HAPPILY AROUND THE NEAREST DEATH LATER AND

BEGAN REELING HIM IN.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE SPED DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE! GLASS SHATTERED TO THEIR LEFT, AND THE SLYTHERIN HELLINGLASS THAT HAD RECORDED

HELLISH PRINCE'S SPILLED ITS EMERALDS EVERYWHERE, SEE THAT PEOPLE SLIPPED

AND STAGGERED AS THEY RAN. THE KIDIES FELL FROM THE BALCONY OVER-HEAD AS THEY REACHED THE GRILLING, AND A GRAY KILLER THAT HARRY THREW

FOR AN ANIMAL SPED HELL-LEGGED ACROSS THE HALL THE SINK ITS TEETH INTO

THEIR OF THE FALLEN.

NEE! SHRIEKED HERMIONE, AND WITH A DEAFENING BLAST FROM HER

WAND, PENTON GREYBACK WAS THROWN BACKWARD FROM THE FEELY STIR-RING BODY OF LAVENDER BROWN. HE HIT THE MARBLE BANISTERS AND

STRUGGLED TO RETURN TO HIS FEET. THEN, WITH A BRIGHT WHITE FLASH AND

A CRACK, A CRYSTAL BALL FELL FROM THE TOP OF HIS HEAD, AND HE CRUMPLED TO THE GRILLING AND DID NOT MOVE.

I HAVE MORE! SHRIEKED PROFESSOR TRILAWNEY FROM OVER THE BAN-ISTERS. MORE FOR ANY WHO WANT THEM! HERE

AND WITH A MOVEMENT LIKE A TENNIS SERVE, SHE HEAVED ANOTHER ENORMOUS CRYSTAL SPHERE FROM HER BAG, WAIVED HER HAND THROUGH THE

AIR, AND CAUSED THE BALL THE SPEED ACROSS THE HALL AND SMASH THROUGH

A WINDOW. AT THE SAME MOMENT, THE HEAVY WOODEN FRONT DOORS BURST OPEN, AND MORE OF THE GIGANTIC SPIDERS FORCED THEIR WAY INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL.

SCREAMS OF TERROR RENT THE AIR: THE FIGHTERS SCATTERED, DEATH EATERS AND HIGWARTIANS ALIKE, AND RED AND GREEN FLITS OF LIGHT FLEW INTO

THE MIST OF THE HURCHING MONSTERS, WHICH SLIDDERED AND REARED, MORE TERRIFYING THAN EVER.

"HOW DO WE GET OUT?" YELLED RONN EVER ALL THE SCREAMING, BUT BEFORE EITHER HARRY OR HERMIONE COULD ANSWER THEY WERE SWALLOWED ASIDE: LACRID HAD COME THUNDERING DOWN THE STAIRS, BRANDISHING HIS FLEWERY PINK UMBRELLA.

THE ELDER WARD

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"DON'T FLIRT EM, DON'T FLIRT EM!" HE YELLED.

LACRID, NOW!

HARRY FORGOT EVERYTHING ELSE: HE SPRINTED OUT FROM UNDER THE CLOAK, RUNNING KENT DELIBERATE TO AVOID THE CLAWS ILLUMINATING THE

WHEEL HALL,

HAGRID, CHEER BACK:

BUT HE WAS NOT EVEN HALFWAY THE HAGRID WHEN HE SAW IT HAPPEN:

HAGRID VANISHED AMONGST THE SPIDERS, AND WITH A GREAT SWIRLING,  
A FULL SWARMING MOVEMENT, THEY RETREATED UNDER THE UNSALIENT OF  
SPELLS, HAGRID ELIRED IN THEIR MIDST,

HAGRID:

HARRY HEARD SOMEONE CALLING HIS OWN NAME, WHETHER FRIEND OR  
FEE HE DID NOT CARE: HE WAS SPRINTING DOWN THE FRONT STEPS INTO  
THE

DARK GREENLANDS, AND THE SPIDERS WERE SWARMING AWAY WITH THEIR  
PREY,

AND HE COULD SEE NOTHING OF HAGRID AT ALL,

HAGRID:

HE THOUGHT HE COULD MAKE OUT AN ENORMOUS ARM LAYING FROM  
THE MIDST OF THE SPIDER SWARM, BUT AS HE MADE THE CHASE AFTER THEM,  
HIS WAY WAS IMPEDED BY A MENDEMENTAL FEELT, WHICH SWUNG DOWN

OUT OF THE DARKNESS AND MADE THE GREENLAND MEN WHICH HE STOOD STIL-  
DER, HE WHEDD LIP: A GIANT STOOD BEFORE HIM, TWENTY FEET HIGH,

ITS HEAD HIDDEN IN SHADEW, NOTHING BUT ITS TREELIKE, HAIRY SHINS  
ILLUMINATED BY LIGHT FROM THE CASTLE DEERS, WITH ONE ERLTAL, ALLID  
MOVEMENT, IT SMASHED A MASSIVE FIST THROUGH AN UPPER WINDOW,  
AND

GLASS RAINED DOWN UPON HARRY, PERKING HIM BACK UNDER THE  
SHELTER

OF THE DEERWAY,

HARRY : STRIPPED HERMIONE, AS SHE AND RON CALIGHT UP WITH  
HARRY AND GAZED UPWARD AT THE GIANT MEN TRYING TO SEIZE PEOPLE  
THROUGH THE WINDOWS ABOVE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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DOWN TO: RON YELLED, GRABBING HERMIONE'S HAND AS SHE RAISED  
HER HAND. STILL HIM AND HE TO CRUSH HALF THE CASTLE

HARRY

GRASP CAME LURCHING AROUND THE CORNER OF THE CASTLE; ONLY NOW  
DID HARRY REALIZE THAT GRASP WAS, INDEED, AN UNDERSIZED GIANT.

THE GARGANTUAN MONSTER TRYING TO CRUSH PEOPLE IN THE UPPER  
FLOORS

LEAPED AROUND AND LET HIT A REAR. THE STONE STEPS TREMBLED AS HE  
STOMPED TOWARD HIS SMALLER SON, AND GRASP'S LEFTHAND FEET FELL  
OPEN, REVEALING YELLOW, HALF-BRICK-SIZED TEETH; AND THEN THEY  
LAUNCHED

THEMSELVES AT EACH OTHER WITH THE SAVAGERY OF LIONS.

DOWN: HARRY REARED; THE NIGHT WAS FULL OF HIDEOUS YELLS AND  
SCREAMS

AS THE GIANTS WRESTLED, AND HE SEIZED HERMIONE'S HAND AND THERE  
DOWN

THE STEPS INTO THE GROUND, RON BRINGING UP THE REAR. HARRY HAD  
NOT

BEST THEM OF FINDING AND SAYING HARRY; HE RAN SO FAST THAT THEY  
WERE

HALFWAY TOWARD THE FOREST BEFORE THEY WERE BRIGHT UP AGAIN.  
AGAIN.

THE AIR AROUND THEM HAD FROZEN: HARRY'S BREATH CALLED AND STAGGERED IN HIS CHEST. SHAPES MOVED SILENT IN THE DARKNESS, SWIRLING

FIGURES OF CONCENTRATED DARKNESS, MOVING IN A GREAT WAVE TOWARD THE CASTLE, THEIR FACES BLANDED AND THEIR BREATH RATTLING. . . .

RON AND HERMIONA CAME IN BESIDE HIM AS THE SHADOWS OF FIGHTING BEHIND THEM GREW SUDDENLY MUTE, DEADENED, BECAUSE A SILENCE ONLY DEMENTORS COULD BRING WAS FALLING THICKLY THROUGH THE NIGHT, AND FRED WAS GONE, AND HAGRID WAS SURELY DYING OR ALREADY DEAD. . . .

COME ON, HARRY! SAID HERMIONA'S VOICE FROM A VERY LONG WAY AWAY. PATRONUSES, HARRY, COME ON!

HE RAISED HIS HAND, BUT A DULL HEPPLESSNESS WAS SPREADING THROUGH

HIM: FEEL MANY MORE LAY DEAD THAT HE DID NOT YET KNOW ABOUT; HE FELT AS THOUGH HIS SOUL HAD ALREADY HALF LEFT HIS BODY. . . .

HARRY, COME ON! SCREAMED HERMIONA.

THE ELDER WARD

899

A HUNDRED DEMENTORS WERE ADVANCING, GLIDING TOWARD THEM,

SLIDING THEIR WAY CLOSER TO HARRY'S DESPAIR, WHICH WAS LIKE A PRISM-

ISE ~~HE~~ A FEAST, . . .

HE SAW ~~THE~~ S SILVER TERRIER BLIST INTO THE AIR, FLICKER FEELY, AND  
~~EX-~~

PIRE; HE SAW ~~HERMINE~~ S BITTER TWIST IN MIDAIR AND FAD; AND HIS  
ELWN

WAND TREMBLED IN HIS HAND, AND HE ALMOST WELCHMED THE ENCHMING  
ERLIVTEN, THE PREMISE ~~OF~~ NEETHING, ~~OF~~ NE FEELING, . . .

AND THEN A SILVER HARE, A SHAR, AND A ~~THE~~ SHARED PAST ~~ELARRY~~, ~~THE~~,

AND ~~HERMINE~~ S HEADS: THE DEMENTERS FELL BACK BEYERE THE CREA-  
TURES APPROACH, THREE MORE PEOPLE HAD ARRIVED ELIT ~~OF~~ THE  
DARKNESS

THE STAND BESIDE THEM, THEIR WANDS ELITSTRETCHED, CONTINLING THE LAST  
THEIR PATRENLSSES: LLINA, ERNIE, AND SEAMLS.

THAT S RIGHT, SAID LLINA ENCHLRAGINGLY, AS IF THEY WERE BACK IN  
THE ~~THE~~ ~~OF~~ ~~REQUIREMENT~~ AND THIS WAS SIMPLY SPELL PRACTICE ~~THE~~  
THE D.A. THAT S RIGHT, ~~ELARRY~~ . . . ~~COME~~ ~~EN~~, THINK ~~OF~~ SOMETHING  
HAPPY, . . .

SOMETHING HAPPY? HE SAID, HIS VEICE CRACKED.

WE RE ALL STILL HERE, SHE WHISPERED, WE RE STILL FIGHTING, ~~COME~~  
~~EN~~, ~~NEEN~~, . . .

THERE WAS A SILVER SPARK, THEN A WAVERING LIGHT, AND THEN, WITH  
THE GREATEST EFFERT IT HAD EVER LEST HIM, THE STAG BLIST FREEM THE  
END



OF HARRY'S HAND. IT CANTERED FORWARD, AND WHEN THE DEMENTERS SCATTERED IN FURRY, AND IMMEDIATELY THE NIGHT WAS MILD AGAIN, BUT THE

SOUNDS OF THE SWIRLING BATTLE WERE HEARD IN HIS EARS.

CAN'T STAND WELL ENOUGH, SAID RON STABLY, TURNING THE LUNA, ERNIE, AND SEAMUS, WELL JUST SAVED

WITH A BEEP AND AN EARTH-SHAKING TREMBLE, ANOTHER GIANT CAME

SLURPING OUT OF THE DARKNESS FROM THE DIRECTION OF THE FOREST, BRAN-

DISHING A CLUE TALLER THAN ANY OF THEM.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

END

RON: HARRY STUTTERED AGAIN, BUT THE OTHERS NEEDED NO TELLING: THEY ALL SCATTERED, AND MET A SECOND TIME WHEN, FOR NEXT MOMENT THE

CREATURE'S VAST FEET HAD FALLEN EXACTLY WHERE THEY HAD BEEN STANDING.

HARRY LEANED BACK: RON AND HERMIONE WERE FOLLOWING HIM, BUT THE OTHER THREE HAD VANISHED BACK INTO THE BATTLE.

LET'S GET OUT OF RANGE! YELLED RON AS THE GIANT SWUNG ITS CLUE AGAIN

AND ITS BELLEWS ECHOED THROUGH THE NIGHT, ACROSS THE GROUNDS WHERE

BLASTS OF RED AND GREEN LIGHT CONTINUED TO ILLUMINATE THE DARKNESS.

THE WEEMING WILLIWS, SAID HARRY, CHE?  
SHEPHEW HE WALLED IT ALL UP IN HIS MIND, CRAMPED IT INTO A SMALL SPACE INTO WHICH HE COULD NOT LEED NOW: THELIGHTS OF FIRE AND FLARE, AND HIS TERROR FOR ALL THE PEOPLE HE LOVED, SCATTERED IN AND OUTSIDE THE CASTLE, MUST ALL WAIT, BECAUSE THEY HAD THE RIN, HAD THE REACH THE SNARE AND VEILMENT, BECAUSE THAT WAS, AS HERMIONE SAID, THE ONLY WAY TO END IT

HE SPRINTED, HALF BELIEVING HE COULD OUTDISTANCE DEATH ITSELF, IGNORING THE ITS OF LIGHT FLYING IN THE DARKNESS ALL AROUND HIM, AND

THE SOUND OF THE LAKE CRASHING LIKE THE SEA, AND THE CREAKING OF THE

FERRIDEN FOREST THROUGH THE NIGHT WAS WINDLESS; THROUGH GREENINGS

THAT SEEMED THEMSELVES TO HAVE RISEN IN REBELLION, HE RAN FASTER THAN

HE HAD EVER MOVED IN HIS LIFE, AND IT WAS HE WHEN SAW THE GREAT TREE FIRST, THE WILLIWS THAT PROTECTED THE SECRET AT ITS ROOTS WITH WHIPLIKE,

SLASHING BRANCHES.

PANTING AND GASPING, HARRY SLEWED DOWN, SWIRTING THE WILLIWS S SWIPING BRANCHES, PEERING THROUGH THE DARKNESS TOWARD ITS THICK TRUNK, TRYING TO SEE THE SINGLE KNIGHT IN THE BARK OF THE OLD TREE THAT

WOULD PARALYZE IT. RON AND HERMIONE CALLED UP, HERMIONE SHE HLT

HER BREATH SHE COULD NOT SPEAK.

THE ELDER WARD

SS1

HEW HEW ARE WE GOING TO GET IN? PANTED REIN. I CAN SEE  
THE PLACE IF WE JUST HAD CRIBSTANDS AGAIN

CRIBSTANDS? WHIPPED HERMINE, BENT DOUBLE, CLUTCHING HER  
CHEST. ARE YOU A WIZARD, OR WHAT?

EH RIGHT YEAH

REIN WHIPPED AROUND, THEN DIRECTED HIS WAND AT A TWIG IN THE  
GRASS AND SAID, WINGARDIUM LEVIOSA! THE TWIG FLEW UP FROM  
THE GRASS, SPUN THROUGH THE AIR AS IF CATCHED BY A GUST OF WIND,  
THEN ZOOMED DIRECTLY AT THE TRUNK THROUGH THE WILLOW'S  
HINDERS

SWAYING BRANCHES. IT LAKED AT A PLACE NEAR THE ROOTS, AND AT ONCE,  
THE WHIRLING TREE BECAME STILL.

PERFECT! PANTED HERMINE.

WAIT,

FOR ONE TEETERING SECOND, WHILE THE CRASHES AND RUMORS OF THE  
BATTLE FILLED THE AIR, HARRY HESITATED. VOLDMORT WANTED HIM THE DEE  
THIS, WANTED HIM THE TIME, . . . WAS HE LEADING REIN AND HERMINE  
INTO A TRAP?

BUT THEN THE REALITY SEEMED THE CLOSEST TO HIM, CRUEL AND PLAIN:

THE ONLY WAY FORWARD WAS THE BELL THE SNARE, AND THE SNARE WAS  
WHERE

YELDERBERT WAS, AND YELDERBERT WAS AT THE END OF THIS TUNNEL. . . .

HARRY, WE'RE CRAWLING, JUST GET IN THERE! SAID RON, PUSHING HIM FORWARD.

HARRY WRIGGLED INTO THE EARTHY PASSAGE HIDDEN IN THE TREE'S ROOTS.

IT WAS A MUCH TIGHTER SQUEEZE THAN IT HAD BEEN THE LAST TIME THEY HAD

ENTERED IT. THE TUNNEL WAS LOW-CEILINGED! THEY HAD HAD TO DELIBERATELY CRAWL THROUGH IT NEARLY SEVEN YEARS PREVIOUSLY; NOW THERE WAS

NOTHING FOR IT BUT TO CRAWL. HARRY WENT FIRST, HIS WAND ILLUMINATED,

EXPECTING AT ANY MOMENT TO MEET BARRIERS, BUT NONE CAME. THEY

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

END

MOVED IN SILENCE, HARRY'S GAZE FIXED UPON THE SWINGING BEAM OF THE WAND HELD IN HIS FIST.

AT LAST THE TUNNEL BEGAN TO SLOPE UPWARD AND HARRY SAW A SLIVER OF LIGHT AHEAD. HERMIONNE TUGGED AT HIS ANKLE.

THE CLIMAX! SHE WHISPERED. PUT THE CLIMAX ON! HE CRAWLED BEHIND HIM AND SHE FORCED THE BUNDLE OF SLIPPERY CLOTHS INTO HIS FREE HAND. WITH DIFFICULTY HE DRAGGED IT OVER HIMSELF, MURMURED, NOW, EXTINGUISHING HIS WANDLIGHT, AND CONTINUED ON HIS HANDS AND KNEES, AS SILENTLY AS POSSIBLE, ALL HIS SENSES STRAINING.

EXPECTING EVERY SECOND THE RE DISCOVERED, THE HEAR A CHILD CLEAR VOICE,  
SEE A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT,

AND THEN HE HEARD VOICES COMING FROM THE ROOM DIRECTLY AHEAD OF  
THEM, ONLY SLIGHTLY MUFFLED BY THE FACT THAT THE OPENING AT THE END  
OF THE TUNNEL HAD BEEN BLOCKED UP BY WHAT LOOKED LIKE AN OLD CRATE,  
HARDLY DARING THE BREATH, HARRY EDGED RIGHT UP TO THE OPENING  
AND

PEERED THROUGH A TINY GAP LEFT BETWEEN CRATE AND WALL,

THE ROOM BEYOND WAS DIMLY LIT, BUT HE COULD SEE NAGINI, SWIRLING  
AND COILING LIKE A SERPENT UNDERWATER, SAFE IN HER ENCHANTED,  
STARRY

SPHERE, WHICH FLEATED UNSLIPPERED IN MIDAIR, HE COULD SEE THE EDGE  
OF A TABLE, AND A LONG-FINGERED WHITE HAND TAPPING WITH A WAND,  
THEN

SNAPE SPEAK, AND HARRY'S HEART LURCHED: SNAPE WAS INCHES AWAY  
FROM

WHERE HE CROUCHED, HIDDEN,

... MY LORD, THEIR RESISTANCE IS CRUMBLING

AND IT IS BEING SEEN WITHOUT YOUR HELP, SAID VERDERBERT IN HIS  
HIGH, CLEAR VOICE. SKILLED WIZARD THROUGH YOU ARE, SEVERUS, I DO  
NOT

THINK YOU WILL MAKE MUCH DIFFERENCE NOW, WE ARE ALMOST THERE ...  
ALMOST,

LET ME FIND THE KEY, LET ME BRING YOU BETTER, I KNOW I CAN FIND  
HIM, MY LORD, PLEASE,

THE ELDER LORD

XXX

SNAPE STRODE PAST THE GAP, AND HARRY DREW BACK A LITTLE, KEEPING HIS EYES FIXED UPON NAGINI, WONDERING WHETHER THERE WAS ANY SPELL

THAT MIGHT PENETRATE THE PROTECTION SURROUNDING HER, BUT HE COULD

NOT THINK OF ANYTHING, ONE FAILED ATTEMPT, AND HE WOULD GIVE UP

HIS POSITION. . .

VERMOREL STOOD UP, HARRY COULD SEE HIM NOW, SEE THE RED EYES, THE FLATTENED, SERPENTINE FACE, THE PALOR OF HIM GLEAMING SLIGHTLY IN THE SEMIDARKNESS.

I HAVE A PROBLEM, SEVERUS, SAID VERMOREL SERIOUSLY.

MY LORD? SAID SNAPE.

VERMOREL RAISED THE ELDER WAND, HOLDING IT AS DELICATELY AND PRECISELY AS A CANDLESTICKER'S KATHEN.

WHY DOESN'T IT WORK FOR ME, SEVERUS?

IN THE SILENCE HARRY IMAGINED HE COULD HEAR THE SNAKE HISsing SLIGHTLY AS IT COILED AND UNCOILED. WAS IT VERMOREL'S STRIDENT SIGH LINGERING IN THE AIR?

MY MY LORD? SAID SNAPE BLANDLY. I DO NOT UNDERSTAND.

WELL WELL HAVE PERFORMED EXTRAORDINARY MAGIC WITH THAT WAND.

NEH, SAID VERMOREL. I HAVE PERFORMED MY USUAL MAGIC. I AM EXTRAORDINARY, BUT THIS WAND . . . NEH, IT HAS NOT REVEALED THE WONDERS

IT HAS PROMISED. I FEEL NO DIFFERENCE BETWEEN THIS WAND AND THE ONE

I PRELUDED FROM HILLIVANDER ALL THESE YEARS AGO.

VEHDEMENT I THINK WAS MISSING, CALM, BUT HARRY I STAR HAD BEEN THE THREE AND FOUR: PAIN WAS BUILDING IN HIS HEAD, AND HE COULD

FEEL THAT CENTRALED SENSE OF FLURY BUILDING INSIDE VEHDEMENT.

NO DIFFERENCE, SAID VEHDEMENT AGAIN.

SNAPE DID NOT SPEAK, HARRY COULD NOT SEE HIS FACE: HE WONDERED WHETHER SNAPE SENSED DANGER, WAS TRYING TO FIND THE RIGHT WORDS TO REASSURE HIS MASTER.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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VEHDEMENT STARTED TO MOVE AROUND THE ROOM: HARRY LOST SIGHT OF HIM FOR SECONDS AS HE PRELUDED, SPEAKING IN THAT SAME MEASURED VOICE, WHILE THE PAIN AND FLURY MELTING IN HARRY.

I HAVE THOUGHT LONG AND HARD, SEVERUS, . . . DO YOU KNOW WHY I HAVE CALLED YOU BACK FROM THE BATTLE?  
AND FOR A MOMENT HARRY SAW SNAPE'S PROFILE: HIS EYES WERE FIXED UPON THE CHILING SNAPE IN ITS ENCHANTED CAGE.

NO, MY LORD, BUT I SEE YOU WILL LET ME RETURN. LET ME FIND PEPPER.

YOU SOUND LIKE LILIES. NEITHER OF YOU UNDERSTANDS PEPPER AS I DO. HE DOES NOT NEED FINDING. PEPPER WILL COME TO ME. I KNOW HIS WEAKNESS, YOU SEE, HIS ONE GREAT FLAW. HE WILL HATE WATCHING THE

ETHERS STRUCK DOWN AROUND HIM, KNOWING THAT IT IS FOR HIM THAT  
IT

HAPPENS, HE WILL WANT THE STAFF IT AT ANY COST, HE WILL CHASE,

BUT MY LORD, HE MIGHT BE KILLED ACCIDENTALLY BY SOME OTHER THAN  
HIMSELF

MY INSTRUCTIONS THE MY DEATH LATER HAVE BEEN PERFECTLY CLEAR,  
CAPTURE PETER, KILL HIS FRIENDS THE MORE, THE BETTER BUT DO  
NOT KILL HIM.

BUT IT IS MY WILL THAT I WISHED THE SPREAD, SEVERUS, NOT HARRY  
PETER.

WILL HAVE BEEN VERY VALUABLE THE MR. VERY VALUABLE.

MY LORD KNOWS I SEEK ONLY TO SERVE HIM, BUT LET ME GO  
AND FIND THE KEY, MY LORD, LET ME BRING HIM THE WILL, I KNOW I  
CAN

I HAVE TOLD WILL, NE? SAID VERDEMEERT, AND HARRY CALLED THE GLINT  
HE RED IN HIS EYES AS HE TURNED AGAIN, AND THE SLIPPING OF HIS  
CLASH

WAS LIKE THE SLITHERING OF A SNAKE, AND HE FELT VERDEMEERT'S  
IMPATIENCE

IN HIS BURNING STAR, MY CONCERN AT THE MOMENT, SEVERUS, IS WHAT  
WILL HAPPEN WHEN I FINALLY MEET THE KEY?

THE ELDER LORD

ESS

MY LORD, THERE CAN BE NO MISTAKE, SLAREY ?

BUT THERE IS A MISTAKE, SEVERUS, THERE IS.



VEHDEMENT HALTED, AND HARRY COULD SEE HIM PLAINLY AGAIN AS HE  
SLID THE ELDER WAND THROUGH HIS WHITE FINGERS, STARING AT SNAPE.

WHY DID BOTH THE WANDS I HAVE USED FAIL WHEN DIRECTED AT HARRY  
POTTER?

I I CANNOT ANSWER THAT, MY LORD.

CAN'T YOU?

THE STAR OF RAGE FELT LIKE A SPIKE DRIVEN THROUGH HARRY'S HEAD:  
HE

FORCED HIS ELBOW FIRST INTO HIS MOUTH, THEN STOPPED HIMSELF FROM CRYING  
OUT.

IN PAIN, HE CLOSED HIS EYES, AND SUDDENLY HE WAS VEHDEMENT, LEER-  
ING INTO SNAPE'S PALE FACE.

MY WAND OF YEW DID EVERYTHING OF WHICH I ASKED IT, SEVERUS,  
EXCEPT TO KILL HARRY POTTER. TWICE IT FAILED. HELLIVANDER TOLD ME  
LINDER

THIRTLIKE OF THE TWIN CHIRS, TOLD ME TO TAKE ANOTHER'S WAND, I DID SEE  
BLIT LILILIS'S WAND SHATTERED UPON MEETING POTTER'S.

I I HAVE NO EXPLANATION, MY LORD.

SNAPE WAS NOT LEERING AT VEHDEMENT NOW, HIS DARK EYES WERE  
STILL

FIXED UPON THE CHILING SERPENT IN ITS PROTECTIVE SPHERE.

I SEELIGHT A THIRD WAND, SEVERUS, THE ELDER WAND, THE WAND OF  
DESTINY, THE DEATHSTICK, I THREW IT FROM ITS PREVIOUS MASTER, I THREW  
IT

FROM THE GRAVE OF ALILIS DUMBLEDORE.

AND NOW SNAPE LEERED AT VEHDEMENT, AND SNAPE'S FACE WAS LIKE A

DEATH MASK. IT WAS MARBLE WHITE AND SHE STILL THAT WHEN HE SPOKE, IT WAS AS SILENT THE SEE THAT ANYONE LIVED BEHIND THE BLANK EYES.

MY LORD LET ME SEE THE KEY

ALL THIS LONG NIGHT, WHEN I AM IN THE BRIND OF VICTORY, I HAVE SAT HERE, SAID VOLDERMERT, HIS VOICE BARELY LOUDER THAN A WHISPER, WANDERING, WANDERING, WHY THE ELDER WAND REFUSES THE KEY WHAT IT

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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BRIGHT THE KEY, REFUSES THE PERFORM AS LEGEND SAYS IT MUST PERFORM FOR ITS RIGHTFUL OWNER . . . AND I THINK I HAVE THE ANSWER.

SNAPE DID NOT SPEAK.

PERHAPS YOU ALREADY KNOW IT? YOU ARE A CLEVER MAN, AFTER ALL, SEVERUS. YOU HAVE BEEN A GOOD AND FAITHFUL SERVANT, AND I REGRET WHAT MUST HAPPEN.

MY LORD

THE ELDER WAND CANNOT SERVE ME PROPERLY, SEVERUS, BECAUSE I AM NOT ITS TRUE MASTER. THE ELDER WAND BELONGS TO THE WIZARD WHO KILLED ITS LAST OWNER. YOU KILLED ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. WHILE YOU LIVE, SEVERUS, THE ELDER WAND CANNOT BE TRULY MINE.

MY LORD! SNAPE PRETESTED, RAISING HIS WAND.

IT CANNOT BE ANY OTHER WAY, SAID VOLDERMERT. I MUST MASTER THE WAND, SEVERUS, MASTER THE WAND, AND I MASTER BETTER AT LAST.

AND VOLDERMERT SWIPED THE AIR WITH THE ELDER WAND. IT DID NOTHING

ING THE SNAKE, WHICH FOR A SPLIT SECOND SEEMED THE THING HE HAD BEEN

REPRIEVED; BUT THEN VERMOREL'S INTENTION BECAME CLEAR. THE  
SNAKE'S

LACE WAS REELING THROUGH THE AIR, AND BEFORE SNAKE COULD DO ANY-  
THING MORE THAN YELL, IT HAD ENCASED HIM, HEAD AND SHOULDERS, AND

VERMOREL SPoke IN PARSELTONGUE.

DIE.

THERE WAS A TERRIBLE SCREAM. HARRY SAW SNAKE'S FACE BEHIND THE  
LITTLE CIRCLE IT HAD LEFT; IT WHITENED AS HIS BLACK EYES WIDENED, AS THE  
SNAKE'S FANGS PIERCED HIS NECK, AS HE FAILED THE PLUSH THE ENCHANTED  
LACE OFF HIMSELF, AS HIS KNEES GAVE WAY AND HE FELL TO THE FLOOR.

I REGRET IT, SAID VERMOREL COLDLY.

HE TURNED AWAY; THERE WAS NO SADNESS IN HIM, NO REMORSE. IT WAS  
TIME TO LEAVE THIS STAGE AND TAKE CHARGE, WITH A WAND THAT WOULD

THE BLOOD WAND

END

NOW BE HIS FULL KIDDING. HE POINTED IT AT THE STARRY LACE BEHIND  
THE

SNAKE, WHICH DRIFTED UPWARD, OFF SNAKE, WHICH FELL SIDEWAYS BENEATH THE  
FLOOR, BLEED GUSHING FROM THE WOUNDS IN HIS NECK. VERMOREL  
SWEPT

FROM THE ROOM WITHOUT A BACKWARD GLANCE, AND THE GREAT SERPENT

ALHATED AFTER HIM IN ITS FLICE PROTECTIVE SPHERE.

BACK IN THE TUNNEL AND HIS HEIN MIND, HARRY OPENED HIS EYES: HE  
HAD DRAWN BLEED BITING DOWN ON HIS KNICKLES IN THE EFFORT NOT TO  
SEEMT HEIT. NOW HE WAS BLEEDING THROUGH THE TINY CRACK BETWEEN  
CRATE

AND WALL, WATCHING A FEET IN A BLACK SHEET TREMBLING ON THE FLOOR.

HARRY? BREATHED HERMIONE BEHIND HIM, BUT HE HAD ALREADY  
PRINTED HIS HAND AT THE CRATE BLOCKING HIS VIEW. IT LIFTED AN INCH  
INTO THE AIR AND DRIFTED SIDELWAYS SILENTLY. AS QUIETLY AS HE COULD,  
HE

PULLED HIMSELF UP INTO THE ROOM.

HE DID NOT KNOW WHY HE WAS DOING IT, WHY HE WAS APPROACHING  
THE DYING MAN: HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT HE FELT AS HE SAW SNAPE'S  
WHITE FACE, AND THE FINGERS TRYING TO STALINCH THE BLEEDY WOUND AT  
HIS NECK. HARRY THREW OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND BLEEDED DOWN  
UPON THE MAN HE HATED, WHOSE WIDENING BLACK EYES FELL ON HARRY AS  
HE TRIED TO SPEAK. HARRY KENT EVER HIM, AND SNAPE SEIZED THE FRONT  
OF HIS REEKS AND PULLED HIM CLOSER.

A TERRIBLE RASPING, CLINGING NOISE ISSUED FROM SNAPE'S THROAT.

TAKE ... IT ... TAKE ... IT ...

SOMETHING MORE THAN BLEED WAS LEAKING FROM SNAPE. SILVERY  
BLUR, NEITHER GAS NOR LIQUID, IT GLISHED FROM HIS MOUTH AND HIS  
EARS

AND HIS EYES, AND HARRY KNOW WHAT IT WAS, BUT DID NOT KNOW WHAT  
TO DO

A FLASH, CENILURED FROM THEIN AIR, WAS THIRST INTO HIS SHADING  
HANDS

BY HERMIONE, HARRY LIFTED THE SILVERY SUBSTANCE INTO IT WITH HIS

## CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

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WAND. WHEN THE FLASH WAS FLIT THE THE BRIM, AND SNAPE LEANED AS  
THOUGH THERE WAS NO BLEED LEFT IN HIM, HIS GRIP ON HARRY'S WRISTS  
SLACKENED.

LEEDS ... AT ... ME ... HE WHISPERED.

THE GREEN EYES BEHIND THE BLACK, BUT AFTER A SECOND, SOMETHING IN  
THE DEPTHS OF THE DARK PAIR SEEMED TO VANISH, LEAVING THEM FIXED,  
BLANK, AND EMPTY. THE HAND HOLDING HARRY THRODDED THE THE FLESH,  
AND SNAPE MOVED NO MORE.

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

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### THE PRINCE'S TALL

ARRY REMAINED KNEELING AT SNAPE'S SIDE, SIMPLY STARING  
DOWN AT HIM, UNTIL SUDDENLY A HIGH, CHILD VOICE SPEAKED  
SEE CLOSE THE THEM THAT HARRY LIMPED THE HIS FEET, THE FLASH GRIPPED  
TIGHTLY

IN HIS HANDS, THINKING THAT VERDEMERHART HAD REENTERED THE ROOM.

VERDEMERHART'S VOICE REVERBERATED FROM THE WALLS AND FLESH, AND

HARRY REALIZED THAT HE WAS TALKING THE ENGLIANTS AND THE ALL THE  
SUR-

ROUNDING AREA, THAT THE RESIDENTS OF HESMER AND ALL THESE STILL

FIGHTING IN THE CASTLE WOULD HEAR HIM AS CLEARLY AS IF HE STOOD  
BEHIND

THEM, HIS BREATH AND THE RAGE OF THEIR NEEDS, A DEATH-SCREAM ALOUD,

THEY HAVE REACHED, SAID THE HIGH, CHILD VICE, VALIANTLY, LORD  
THE-

DEMENT KNELLS THE VALLE BRAYERS,

BUT THEY HAVE SUSTAINED HEAVY LOSSES, IF THEY CONTINUE THE RESIST  
ME,

THEY WILL ALL DIE, ONE BY ONE, I DO NOT WISH THIS TO HAPPEN, EVERY  
DROPP

OF MAGICAL BLOOD SPILLED IS A LOSS AND A WASTE,

LORD VHEMENT IS MERCIFUL, I COMMAND MY FORCES THE RETREAT  
IMMEDIATELY,

THE

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

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THEY HAVE BEEN KILLED, DISPOSE OF THEIR DEAD WITH DIGNITY, TREAT  
THEIR INJURED,

I SPEAK NOW, HARRY BETTER, DIRECTLY THE THEY, THEY HAVE PERMITTED

THEIR FRIENDS TO DIE FOR THEM RATHER THAN FACE ME THEMSELVES, I SHALL  
WAIT

FOR ONE HOUR IN THE FOREBIDDEN FOREST. IF, AT THE END OF THAT HOUR,  
THEY HAVE NOT COME TO ME, HAVE NOT GIVEN THEMSELVES UP, THEN BATTLE  
RECOMMENCES. THIS TIME, I SHALL ENTER THE FAY MYSELF, HARRY  
POTTER,

AND I SHALL FIND THEM, AND I SHALL FINISH EVERY LAST MAN, WOMAN,  
AND

CHILD WHO HAS TRIED TO CHEAT THEM FROM ME, ONE HOUR,

RETH RENN AND HERMIONE SHOOK THEIR HEADS FRANTICALLY, WHISKING  
AT HARRY,

DON'T LISTEN TO HIM, SAID RENN,

IT WILL BE ALL RIGHT, SAID HERMIONE WILDLY. LET'S LET'S GET BACK  
TO THE CASTLE, IF HE'S GOING TO THE FOREST WE WILL NEED THE THINGS OF A  
NEW  
PLAN

SHE GLANCED AT SNAPE'S BODY, THEN FLURRIED BACK TO THE TUNNEL EN-  
TRANCE. RENN FOLLOWED HER. HARRY GATHERED UP THE INVISIBILITY  
CLOAK,

THEN WHISKED DOWN AT SNAPE. HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT TO FEEL, EXCEPT  
SHOCK AT THE WAY SNAPE HAD BEEN KILLED, AND THE REASON FOR WHICH  
IT HAD BEEN DONE. . . .

THEY CRAWLED BACK THROUGH THE TUNNEL, NONE OF THEM TALKING,  
AND HARRY WONDERED WHETHER RENN AND HERMIONE COULD STILL HEAR  
VIBRANT RINGING IN THEIR HEADS, AS HE COULD.

YELL HAVE PERMITTED YOUR FRIENDS TO DIE AND YELL RATHER THAN FACE  
ME

YOURSELF, I SHALL WAIT AND HUNT FOR YOU IN THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, . . .  
FINE

FOR YOU, . . .

SMALL BLINDLES SEEMED TO LITTER THE LAWN AT THE FRONT OF THE CASTLE.  
IT COULD ONLY BE AN FLOOR FOR SEE FROM DOWN, YET IT WAS PITCH-BLACK.  
THE THREE OF THEM HURRIED TOWARD THE STONE STEPS, A LONG CREEP,  
THE

THE PRINCE & TALL

END

SIZE OF A SMALL BROT, LAY ABANDONED IN FRONT OF THEM. THERE WAS NO  
OTHER SIGN OF GRAVE OR OF HIS ATTACKER.

THE CASTLE WAS UNUSUALLY SILENT. THERE WERE NO FLASHES OF LIGHT  
NOW, NO RAGES OR SCREAMS OR SHOUTS. THE FLAGSTONES OF THE  
DESERTED

ENTRANCE HALL WERE STAINED WITH BLOOD. EMERALDS WERE STILL SCATTERED  
ALL OVER THE FLOOR, ALONG WITH PIECES OF MARBLE AND SPLINTERED  
WOOD.

PART OF THE BANISTERS HAD BEEN BLOWN AWAY.

WHERE IS EVERYONE? WHISPERED HERMINE.

DOWN THE WAY TO THE GREAT HALL, HARRY STEPPED IN THE  
DARKWAY.

THE FOLLY TABLES WERE GONE AND THE ROOM WAS CROWDED. THE  
SURVIVORS STOOD IN GROUPS, THEIR ARMS AROUND EACH OTHER'S NECKS.



THE INJURED WERE BEING TREATED UPON THE RAISED PLATFORM BY MADAM  
POPMOREY AND A GROUP OF HELPERS. FIRENZE WAS AMONGST THE INJURED;  
HIS

FLANKS WERE BLEEDING AND HIS SHOULDERS WERE HIS LAY, UNABLE TO STAND.

THE DEAD LAY IN A ROW IN THE MIDDLE OF THE HALL. HARRY COULD NOT  
SEE FRED & REDDY, BECAUSE HIS FAMILY SURROUNDED HIM. GEORGE WAS  
KNEELING AT HIS HEAD; MRS. WEASLEY WAS LYING ACROSS FRED'S CHEST,  
HER

HEAD SHAKING, MR. WEASLEY STROKING HER HAIR WHILE TEARS FALLEN  
DOWN HIS CHEEKS.

WITHOUT A WORD TO HARRY, RON AND HERMIONIE WALKED AWAY.

HARRY SAW HERMIONIE APPROACH GINNY, WHOSE FACE WAS SWOLLEN  
AND

SWITCHY, AND HUG HER. RON JOINED BILL, FLEUR, AND PERCY, WHO WERE ALL  
AND

ARM AROUND RON'S SHOULDERS. AS GINNY AND HERMIONIE MOVED  
CLOSER

TO THE REST OF THE FAMILY, HARRY HAD A CLEAR VIEW OF THE BODIES  
LYING

NEXT TO FRED: REMUS AND TONKS, PALE AND STILL AND PEACEFULLY-  
LIEING,

APPARENTLY ASLEEP BENEATH THE DARK, ENCHANTED CEILING.

THE GREAT HALL SEEMED TO FLY AWAY, BECOMING SMALLER, SHRINKING,

AS HARRY REELED BACKWARD FROM THE DEERLAW, HE COULD NOT DRAW

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

END

BREATH, HE COULD NOT BEAR THE WEIGHT AT ANY OF THE OTHER ENDERS, THE  
SEE

WHEN ELSE HAD DIED FOR HIM, HE COULD NOT BEAR THE WEIGHT THE WEIGHTS,  
COULD NOT BEAR INTO THEIR EYES, WHEN IF HE HAD GIVEN HIMSELF UP IN  
THE FIRST PLACE, FRED MIGHT NEVER HAVE DIED, ...

HE TURNED AWAY AND RAN UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE, SLIPING, THRODS ...

HE FEARED NOT THE FEEL, ... HE WISHED HE COULD RIP OUT HIS HEART,  
HIS

INNARDS, EVERYTHING THAT WAS SCREAMING INSIDE HIM, ...

THE CASTLE WAS COMPLETELY EMPTY; EVEN THE GHOSTS SEEMED TO HAVE  
FINISHED THE MASS MEETING IN THE GREAT HALL, HARRY RAN WITHOUT  
STOPPING, CLUTCHING THE CRYSTAL FLASK OF SNAPE'S LAST TRICKS,  
AND

HE DID NOT STOP UNTIL HE REACHED THE STONE GARGOYLE  
GUARDING

THE HEADMASTER'S OFFICE.

PASSWORD?

OLIMPEDE? SAID HARRY WITHOUT THINKING, BECAUSE IT WAS HE  
WHOM HE FEARED TO SEE, AND TO HIS SURPRISE THE GARGOYLE SLID  
ASIDE,

REVEALING THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE BEHIND.

BUT WHEN HARRY CLIMBED INTO THE CIRCULAR OFFICE HE FELT A CHANGE.

THE PORTRAITS THAT HUNG ALL AROUND THE WALLS WERE EMPTY, NOT A  
SINGLE

HEADMASTER OR HEADMISTRESS REMAINED TO SEE HIM; ALL, IT SEEMED, HAD  
FLITTED AWAY, CHARGING THROUGH THE PAINTINGS THAT LINED THE  
CASTLE, SEE

THAT THEY COULD HAVE A CLEAR VIEW OF WHAT WAS GOING ON.

HARRY GLANCED HOPELESSLY AT OLIMPEDE'S DESERTED FRAME, WHICH

FLING DIRECTLY BEHIND THE HEADMASTER'S CHAIR, THEN TURNED HIS BACK  
ON IT. THE STONE PENDULUM LAY IN THE CABINET WHERE IT HAD ALWAYS  
BEEN:

HARRY HEAVED IT INTO THE DESK AND PULLED SNAPE'S MEMORIES INTO  
THE WIDE BASIN WITH ITS BLIND MARKINGS AROUND THE EDGE. THE ESCAPE  
INTO SOMETHING ELSE'S HEAD WOULD BE A BLESSED RELIEF. . . . NOTHING THAT  
EVEN SNAPE HAD LEFT HIM COULD BE WORSE THAN HIS OWN THOUGHTS.  
THE

MEMORIES SWIRLED, SILVER WHITE AND STRANGE, AND WITHOUT  
HESITATING,

## THE PRINCE'S TALL

WAS

WITH A FEELING OF RECKLESS ABANDONMENT, AS THOUGH THIS WOULD AS-  
SUAGE HIS THROTLING GRIEF, HARRY DIVERGED,

HE FELL HEADLONG INTO SLINKLIGHT, AND HIS FEET FELT WARM GRASS.  
WHEN HE STRAIGHTENED UP, HE SAW THAT HE WAS IN A NEARLY DESERTED  
PLAYGROUND. A SINGLE HUGE CHIMNEY DOMINATED THE DISTANT SKYLINE.  
TWO GIRLS WERE SWINGING BACKWARD AND FORWARD, AND A SKINNY BOY  
WAS WATCHING THEM FROM BEHIND A CLUMP OF BUSHES. HIS BLACK HAIR  
WAS EVERYWHERE AND HIS CLOTHES WERE SO MISMATCHED THAT IT LOOKED  
DELIBERATE: THE SHORT JEANS, A SLEAZY, OVERLARGE COAT THAT MIGHT  
HAVE

BELONGED TO A GREEN MAN, AN OLD SMOCKLIKE SHIRT,

HARRY MOVED CLOSER TO THE BOY. SNAPE LOOKED NO MORE THAN NINE

HER TEN YEARS OLD, SALLER, SMALL, STRINGY. THERE WAS UNDISGUISED GRIED

IN HIS THIN FACE AS HE WATCHED THE SWINGER OF THE TWO GIRLS SWINGING

HIGHER AND HIGHER THAN HER SISTER.

LILY, HEN T BE IT? SHRIEKED THE ELDER OF THE TWO.

BUT THE GIRL HAD LET GO OF THE SWING AT THE VERY HEIGHT OF ITS ARC

AND FLEW INTO THE AIR, ELITE LITERALLY FLEW, LAUNCHED HERSELF SKY-

WARD WITH A GREAT SHEET OF LALIGHTER, AND INSTEAD OF CRUMPLING HER

THE PLAYGROUND ASPHALT, SHE SHARED LIKE A TRAPEZE ARTIST THROUGH THE

AIR, STAYING UP FAR TOO LONG, LANDING FAR TOO LIGHTLY,

MUMMY THEN FELT NEET THE

PETLINIA STOPPED HER SWING BY DRAGGING THE HEELS OF HER SANDALS  
ON THE GRINDING, MAKING A CRUNCHING, GRINDING SOUND, THEN LEAPT  
UP, HANDS ON HIPS.

MUMMY SAID WHY WEREN T ALLOWED, LILY?

BUT I M FINE, SAID LILY, STILL GIGGLING. TILLY, LEED AT THIS,  
WATCH

WHAT I CAN BE.

PETLINIA GLANCED AROUND. THE PLAYGROUND WAS DESERTED APART FROM  
THEMSELVES AND, THOUGH THE GIRLS DID NOT KNOW IT, SNAPE. LILY HAD

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PICKED UP A FALLEN FLEWER FROM THE BLISH BEHIND WHICH SNAPE  
LURKED.

PETLINIA ADVANCED, EVIDENTLY TORN BETWEEN CURIOSITY AND  
DISAPPROVAL.

LILY WAITED UNTIL PETLINIA WAS NEAR ENOUGH TO HAVE A CLEAR VIEW,  
THEN

HELD OUT HER PALM. THE FLEWER SAT THERE, OPENING AND CLOSING ITS  
PET-

ALS, LIKE SOME BIZARRE, MAND-LIPPED HYSTER.

STEP IT? SHRIEKED PETLINIA.

IT S NEET FLIRTING YELL, SAID LILY, BUT SHE CLOSED HER HAND AND THE  
BLESSEM AND THREW IT BACK TO THE GROELING.

IT S NEET RIGHT, SAID PETLINIA, BUT HER EYES HAD FOLLOWED THE  
FLEWER S

FLIGHT TO THE GROELING AND LINGERED UPON IT. F-HEW DEH YELW DEH IT?  
SHE

ADDED, AND THERE WAS DEFINITE LINGING IN HER VOICE.

IT S HEYIELIS, ISN T IT? SNAPE COULD NEH LINGERER CONTAIN HIMSELF,  
BUT HAD LIMPED OUT FROM BEHIND THE BLISHES. PETLINIA SHRIEKED AND  
RAN BACKWARD TOWARD THE SWINGS, BUT LILY, THOUGH CLEARLY STARTLED,  
REMAINED WHERE SHE WAS. SNAPE SEEMED TO REGRET HIS APPEARANCE.  
A BULL BLISH OF CHIEF MELINTED THE SALLER CHIEFS AS HE LOOKED AT  
LILY.

WHAT S HEYIELIS? ASKED LILY.

SNAPE HAD AN AIR OF NERVOUS EXCITEMENT. WITH A GLANCE AT THE DISTANT PETLUNIA, NOW FEEVERING BESIDE THE SWINGS, HE LEANED HIS VEHICLE

AND SAID, I KNOW WHAT YOU ARE.

WHAT DO YOU MEAN?

YOU ARE . . . YOU ARE A WITCH, WHISPERED SNAPE.

SHE LOOKED APPREHENDED.

THAT IS NOT A VERY NICE THING TO SAY TO SOMEONE!

SHE TURNED, NOSE IN THE AIR, AND MARCHED OFF TOWARD HER SISTER.

NO! SAID SNAPE. HE WAS HIGHLY CHARMED NOW, AND HARRY WONDERED WHY HE DID NOT TAKE OFF THE RIDICULOUSLY LARGE COAT, UNLESS IT WAS BECAUSE HE DID NOT WANT TO REVEAL THE SPECKS BENEATH IT. HE

THE PRINCE'S TALL

WAS

FLAPPED AFTER THE GIRLS, LOOKING LUDICROUSLY KATLIKE, LIKE HIS ELDER SELF.

THE SISTERS CONSIDERED HIM, LIMITED IN DISAPPROVAL, BOTH HOLDING ON THE END OF THE SWING PULKS AS THOUGH IT WAS THE SAFE PLACE IN TAG.

THEY ARE, SAID SNAPE TO LILY, THEY ARE A WITCH. I'VE BEEN WATCH-  
ING THEM FOR A WHILE, BUT THERE'S SOMETHING WRONG WITH THAT, MY  
MUM'S

HERE, AND I'M A WIZARD.

PETUNIA'S LAUGH WAS LIKE COLD WATER.

WIZARD? SHE SHRIEKED, HER COURAGE RETURNED NOW THAT SHE HAD  
RECOVERED FROM THE SHOCK OF HIS UNEXPECTED APPEARANCE. I KNOW  
WHERE THEY ARE, THEY'RE THAT SNAPE BOY? THEY LIVE DOWN SPINNER'S  
END

BY THE RIVER, SHE TOLD LILY, AND IT WAS EVIDENT FROM HER TONE THAT  
SHE CONSIDERED THE ADDRESS A FIRM RECOMMENDATION. WHY HAVE THEY  
BEEN SPYING ON US?

HAVEN'T BEEN SPYING, SAID SNAPE, HOT AND UNCOMFORTABLE AND  
DIRTY-FAired IN THE BRIGHT SUNLIGHT. WOULDNT SPY ON THEM,  
ANYWAY,

HE ADDED SPITEFULLY, THEY'RE A MISCLE.

THOUGH PETUNIA EVIDENTLY DID NOT UNDERSTAND THE WORD, SHE COULD  
HARDLY MISTAKE THE TONE.

LILY, COME ON, WE'RE LEAVING! SHE SAID SHRILLY, LILY KEPT HER  
SISTER AT BAY, GLARING AT SNAPE AS SHE LEFT, HE STOOD WATCHING  
THEM

AS THEY MARCHED THROUGH THE PLAYGROUND GATE, AND HARRY, THE  
ONLY

ONE LEFT TO HERSELF HIM, RECOGNIZED SNAPE'S BITTER DISAPPOINTMENT,  
AND UNDERSTOOD THAT SNAPE HAD BEEN PLANNING THIS MEETING FOR A  
WHILE, AND THAT IT HAD ALL BEEN WRONG. . . .

THE SCENE DISSOLVED, AND BEFORE HARRY KNEW IT, RE-APPEARED AROUND

HIM. HE WAS NEAR IN A SMALL THICKET OF TREES. HE COULD SEE A SLINKIT RIVER GLITTERING THROUGH THEIR TWIGS. THE SHADELS CAST BY THE TREES

MADE A BASIN OF DEEP GREEN SHADE. TWO CHILDREN SAT FACING EACH OTHER,

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

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CROSS-LEGGED ON THE GRASS. SNAPE HAD REMOVED HIS CHEAT NECK; HIS RED SPOT WAS LESS PECULIAR IN THE HALF LIGHT.

... AND THE MINISTRY CAN PUNISH YOU IF YOU DO MAGIC HILTSIDE SCHOOL. YOU GET LETTERS.

BUT I HAVE DONE MAGIC HILTSIDE SCHOOL!

WE'RE ALL RIGHT. WE HAVEN'T GOT WANDS YET. THEY LET YOU OFF WHEN

YOU'RE A KID AND YOU CAN'T HELP IT. BUT SINCE YOU'RE ELEVEN, HE NEED-

ED IMPORTANTLY, AND THEY START TRAINING YOU, THEN YOU'VE GOT THE

OH CAREFUL.

THERE WAS A LITTLE SILENCE. LILY HAD PICKED UP A FALLEN TWIG AND TWIRLED IT IN THE AIR, AND HARRY KNEW THAT SHE WAS IMAGINING SPARKS

TRAILING FROM IT. THEN SHE DROPPED THE TWIG, LEANED IN TOWARD THE KEY, AND SAID, IT IS REAL, ISN'T IT? IT'S NOT A JIBE? PETUNIA SAYS YOU'RE



LYING TO ME. PETLUNIA SAYS THERE ISN'T A FLEGGWARTS. IT IS REAL, ISN'T IT?

IT'S REAL FOR US, SAID SNAPE. MEET HER HER, BUT WE'LL GET THE LETTER,

YELL AND ME,

REALLY? WHISPERED LILY,

DEFINITELY, SAID SNAPE, AND EVEN WITH HIS POORLY CUT HAIR AND HIS OLD CLOTHES, HE STRUCK AN EASILY IMPRESSIVE FIGURE STRAIDED IN FRONT OF HER, BRIMMING WITH CONFIDENCE IN HIS DESTINY,

AND WILL IT REALLY COME BY ME? LILY WHISPERED,

NORMALLY, SAID SNAPE, BUT YELL BE MUGGLE-BORN, SHE SOMETHING FROM THE SCHOOL WILL HAVE TO COME AND EXPLAIN THE YELLER PARENTS,

DID IT MAKE A DIFFERENCE, BEING MUGGLE-BORN?

SNAPE HESITATED, HIS BLACK EYES, RAGER IN THE GREENISH GLEAM, MOVED OVER THE PALE FACE, THE DARK RED HAIR,

NO, HE SAID, IT DOESN'T MAKE ANY DIFFERENCE,

THE PRINCE'S TALL

END

GOOD, SAID LILY, RELAXING: IT WAS CLEAR THAT SHE HAD BEEN WHIRRYING,

YELL WE GET LEADS OF MAGIC, SAID SNAPE. I SAW THAT, ALL THE TIME I WAS WATCHING YELL...

HIS VEHICLE TRAILED AWAY; SHE WAS NOT LISTENING, BUT HAD STRETCHED

HELT HER THE LEAFY GREENS AND WAS LEEKING UP AT THE CANOPY OF  
LEAVES

EVERYHEAD, HE WATCHED HER AS GREEDILY AS HE HAD WATCHED HER IN THE  
PLAYGROUND.

THEY ARE THINGS AT YOUR FEET? LILY ASKED.

A LITTLE CREASE APPEARED BETWEEN HIS EYES.

FINE, HE SAID.

THEY ARE NOT ARGUING ANYMORE?

YES, THEY ARE ARGUING, SAID SNAPE. HE PICKED UP A FISTFUL OF  
LEAVES AND BEGAN TEARING THEM APART, APPARENTLY UNWARE OF  
WHAT

HE WAS DOING, BUT IT WASN'T THAT LONG AND I'LL BE GONE.

DON'T YOU DAD LIKE MAGIC?

HE DON'T LIKE ANYTHING, MUCH, SAID SNAPE.

SEVERUS?

A LITTLE SMILE TWISTED SNAPE'S MOUTH WHEN SHE SAID HIS NAME.

YES?

TELL ME ABOUT THE DEMENTORS AGAIN.

WHAT DO YOU WANT TO KNOW ABOUT THEM ANY?

IF I USE MAGIC OUTSIDE SCHOOL

THEY WON'T GIVE YOU THE DEMENTORS FOR THAT! DEMENT-  
TORS ARE FOR PEOPLE WHO DO REALLY BAD STUFF. THEY GUARD THE WIZARD

PRISON, AZKABAN. YOU'RE NOT GOING TO END UP IN AZKABAN, YOU'RE  
THE

HE TURNED RED AGAIN AND SHREDDED MORE LEAVES. THEN A SMALL

## CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

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RLISTLING NOISE BEHIND HARRY MADE HIM TURN! PETLONIA, HIDING  
BEHIND

A TREE, HAD LOST HER FEETING.

TURNEY? SAID LILY, SURPRISE AND WELCOME IN HER VOICE, BUT SNAPE  
HAD LUMPED THE HIS FEET.

WHAT IS SPYING NEIGH? HE STHELTED, WHAT D YELL WANT?  
PETLONIA WAS BREATHELESS, ALARMED AT BEING CALIGHT. HARRY COULD SEE  
HER STRUGGLING FOR SOMETHING FLIRTAL THE SAY.

WHAT IS THAT YELL RE WEARING, ANDWAY? SHE SAID, POINTING AT  
SNAPE S CHEST. YELLR MUM S BHELISE?

THERE WAS A CRACK! A BRANCH OVER PETLONIA S HEAD HAD FALLEN. LILY

SCREAMED! THE BRANCH CALIGHT PETLONIA BEN THE STHLDER, AND SHE  
STAG-

GERED BACKWARD AND BURST INTO TEARS.

TURNEY?

BUT PETLONIA WAS RUNNING AWAY, LILY REHLNDED BEN SNAPE.

DID YELL MAKE THAT HAPPEN?

NEH. HE LEMBED BOTH DEFIANT AND SCARED.

YELL DID? SHE WAS BACKING AWAY FROM HIM. YELL DID? YELL FLIRT  
HER?

NEH NEH I DIDN'T!

BUT THE LIE DID NOT CONVINCER LILY: AFTER HER LAST BLINNING LEER,  
SHE RAN FROM THE LITTLE THicket, EFF AFTER HER SISTER, AND SNAPE  
LEERED

MISERABLE AND CHINUPSED, . . .

AND THE SCENE RE-APPEARED, HARRY LEERED AROUND: HE WAS IN PLAT-  
FORM NINE AND THREE-QUARTERS, AND SNAPE STOOD BESIDE HIM, SLIGHTLY

BLINCHED, NEXT TO A THIN, SALLLOW-FACED, SHLUR-LEERING WHIMAN WHO  
GREATLY RESEMBLED HIM. SNAPE WAS STARING AT A FAMILY OF FOUR A  
SHORT

DISTANCE AWAY. THE TWO GIRLS STOOD A LITTLE APART FROM THEIR  
PARENTS.

LILY SEEMED TO BE PLEADING WITH HER SISTER: HARRY MOVED CLOSER TO  
LISTEN.

THE PRINCE'S TALK

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. . . I'M SORRY, TUNED, I'M SORRY! LISTEN SHE CALLED HER
SISTER'S

HAND AND HELD TIGHT TO IT, EVEN THOUGH PETLONIA TRIED TO PULL IT
AWAY.

MAYBE SINCE I'M THERE NEH, LISTEN, TUNED? MAYBE SINCE I'M THERE,
I'LL BE ABLE TO GET THE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE AND PERSUADE HIM TO
CHANGE HIS MIND!

I DIDN'T WANT THE CH? SAID PETLINIA, AND SHE DRAGGED HER HAND BACK HEUT HP HER SISTER S GRASP, YELL THINK I WANT THE CH THE SHMP

STUPID CASTLE AND LEARN THE EE A A

HER PALE EYES REVED HYER THE PLATFORM, HYER THE CATS MEOWING IN THEIR HUNTERS ARMS, HYER THE HENS FLUTTERING AND FLEETING AT EACH OTHER IN CAGES, HYER THE STUDENTS, SOME ALREADY IN THEIR LEUNG BLACK ROBES, LEADING TROLNDS HENTH THE SCARLET STEAM ENGINE HP ELSE GREETING

HENK ANOTHER WITH GLAD CRIES AFTER A SLIMPER APART,

YELL THINK I WANT THE EE A A FREAK?

LILY S EYES FILLED WITH TEARS AS PETLINIA SLICKEDED IN TUGGING HER HAND AWAY,

I M NOT A FREAK, SAID LILY, THAT S A TERRIBLE THING THE SAY,

THAT S WHERE YELL RE CHING, SAID PETLINIA WITH RELISH, A SPECIAL SCHEEL FOR FREAKS, YELL AND THAT SNAPE REY . . . WEIRDOS, THAT S WHAT

YELL TWEE ARE, IT S CHED YELL RE BEING SEPARATED FROM NORMAL PEOPLE, IT S FOR HLIR SAFETY,

LILY GLANCED TOWARD HER PARENTS, WHEE WERE LEEDING AROUND THE PLATFORM WITH AN AIR HP WHEELHEARTED ENJOYMENT, DRINKING IN THE SCENE, THEN SHE LOOKED BACK AT HER SISTER, AND HER VOICE WAS LEL AND FIERCE,

YELL DIDN T THINK IT WAS SUCH A FREAK S SCHEEL WHEN YELL WROTE THE THE HEADMASTER AND BEGGED HIM THE TAKE YELL,

PETLINIA TURNED SCARLET,

REG? I DIDN T REG?

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AND

I SAW HIS REPLY. IT WAS VERY KIND.

THEY SHOULDNT HAVE READ WHISPERED PETLUNIA, THAT WAS MY
PRIVATE CHILD THEY ?

LILY GAVE HERSELF AWAY BY HALF-GLANCING TOWARD WHERE SNAPE STOOD
NEARBY. PETLUNIA GASPED.

THAT THEY FELT IT! THEY AND THAT THEY HAVE BEEN SNEAKING IN MY
ROOM!

THEY WERE SNEAKING WHEN LILY WAS IN THE DEFENSIVE.
SEVERUS

SAW THE ENVELOPE, AND HE COULDNT BELIEVE A MISCLE CHILD HAD
GIVEN-

TAKED THE ENVELOPE, THAT S ALL! HE SAYS THERE MUST BE WIZARDS
WHISKING

UNDERCOVER IN THE POSTAL SERVICE WHEN TAKE CARE OF

APPARENTLY WIZARDS FEEL THEIR NEEDS IN EVERYWHERE! SAID
PETLUNIA,

WHEN AS PALE AS SHE HAD BEEN FLUSHED. FREAK! SHE SPAT AT HER
SISTER,

AND SHE PULLED OFF THE WHERE HER PARENTS STOOD. . . .

THE SCENE DISSOLVED AGAIN. SNAPE WAS HURRYING ALONG THE
CORRIDOR

OF THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS AS IT CLATTERED THROUGH THE COUNTRYSIDE.
HE

HAD ALREADY CHANGED INTO HIS SCHOOL REEKS, HAD PERHAPS TAKEN THE FIRST OPPORTUNITY TO TAKE OFF HIS DREADFUL MUGGLE CLOTHES. AT LAST HE

STEPPED OUTSIDE A COMPARTMENT IN WHICH A GROUP OF REBELS WHO'S WERE TALKING. FLINCHED IN A CORNER SEAT BESIDE THE WINDOW WAS LILY, HER FACE PRESSED AGAINST THE WINDOWPANE.

SNAPE SLID OPEN THE COMPARTMENT DOOR AND SAT DOWN OPPOSITE LILY. SHE GLANCED AT HIM AND THEN LOOKED BACK OUT OF THE WINDOW. SHE HAD BEEN CRYING.

I DON'T WANT TO TALK TO YOU, SHE SAID IN A CONSTRICTED VOICE.
WHY NOT?

TURNER HATES ME, BECAUSE WE SAW THAT LETTER FROM DUMBLE-
DORE.

SEE WHAT?

THE PRINCE'S TALL

BY

SHE THREW HIM A LOOK OF DEEP DISLIKE.

SEE SHE'S MY SISTER?

SHE'S ONLY A HE CALLED HIMSELF EVILLY; LILY, THEN BLISS
TRYING

THE WIFE HER EYES WITHOUT BEING NOTICED, DID NOT HEAR HIM.

BUT WE'RE GOING! HE SAID, UNABLE TO SUPPRESS THE EXHILARATION
IN

HIS VOICE. THIS IS IT! WE'RE OFF TO THE HOGWARTS!

SHE NEEDED, SQUINTING HER EYES, BUT IN SPITE OF HERSELF, SHE HALF SMILED.

YELL'D BETTER BE IN SLYTHERIN, SAID SNAPE, ENCOURAGED THAT SHE HAD BRIGHTENED A LITTLE.

SLYTHERIN?

ONE OF THE BOYS SHARING THE COMPARTMENT, WHO HAD SEEMED NO INTEREST AT ALL IN LILY HER SNAPE UNTIL THAT POINT, WHEEZED AROUND AT

THE WORD, AND HARRY, WHOSE ATTENTION HAD BEEN FOCUSED ENTIRELY ON THE TWO BESIDE THE WINDOW, SAW HIS FATHER: SLIGHT, BLACK-HAired LIKE SNAPE, BUT WITH THAT INDISTINGUISHABLE AIR OF HAVING BEEN WELL-CARED-FOR, EVEN ADDED, THAT SNAPE SHE CONSPICUOUSLY LACKED.

WHO WANTS TO BE IN SLYTHERIN? I THINK I'D LEAVE, WHEEZED HE. YELL? JAMES ASKED THE BOY BEHINDING HIM THE SEAT'S OPPOSITE HIM, AND WITH A HEAT, HARRY REALIZED THAT IT WAS SIRILIS. SIRILIS DID NOT SMILE.

MY WHOLE FAMILY HAVE BEEN IN SLYTHERIN, HE SAID.

BLIMEY, SAID JAMES, AND I THOUGHT YELL SEEMED ALL RIGHT?

SIRILIS GRINNED.

MAYBE I'LL REPEAL THE TRADITION, WHERE ARE YELL HEADING, IF YELL VE GOT THE CHOICE?

JAMES LISTED AN INVISIBLE SWORD.

GROFFINDOR, WHERE'D YOU THE BRAVE AT HEART? LIKE MY DAD.

SNAPE MADE A SMALL, DISPARAGING NOISE. JAMES TURNED ON HIM.

GET A PROBLEM WITH THAT?

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

WTF

NEH, SAID SNAPE, THOUGH HIS SLIGHT SNEER SAID OTHERWISE. IF
YELL D

RATHER BE BRAINNY THAN BRAINY

WHERE RE YELL KEEPING THE CH, SEEING AS YELL RE NEITHER?
INTERJECTED

SIRILIS.

JAMES REARED WITH LAUGHTER, LILY SAT UP, RATHER FLUSHED, AND
WHISKED

FROM JAMES THE SIRILIS IN DISLIKE.

COME ON, SEVERUS, LET S FIND ANOTHER COMPARTMENT.

HEHEHEHE ...

JAMES AND SIRILIS IMITATED HER LEISY VOICE; JAMES TRIED THE TRIP
SNAPE AS HE PASSED.

SEE YA, SNIPELLIS! A VOICE CALLED, AS THE COMPARTMENT DOOR
SLAMMED, ...

AND THE SCENE DISSOLVED HENCE MORE, ...

HARRY WAS STANDING RIGHT BEHIND SNAPE AS THEY FACED THE CANDLELIT
FELTSE TABLES, LINED WITH RAPT FACES. THEN PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL
SAID, EVANS, LILY?

HE WATCHED HIS MOTHER WALK FORWARD ON TREMBLING LEGS AND SIT
DOWN UPON THE RICKETY STEEL. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DROPPED THE
SHIRTING HAT BENTH HER HEAD, AND BARELY A SECOND AFTER IT HAD
THICKED

THE DARK RED HAIR, THE HAT CRIED, GRYFFINDOR!

HARRY HEARD SNAPE LET OUT A TINY GRIN. LILY THREW OFF THE HAT,
HANDING IT BACK THE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, THEN FLURRIED TOWARD THE

CHEERING GRYPFINDERS, BUT AS SHE WENT SHE GLANCED BACK AT SNAPE,
AND

THERE WAS A SAD LITTLE SMILE ON HER FACE. HARRY SAW SIRILUS MOVE UP
THE KITCHEN MADE ROOM FOR HER. SHE THEN LOOKED AT HIM, SEEMED
TO RECOGNIZE HIM FROM THE TRAIN, HELD HER ARMS, AND FIRMLY TURNED
HER BACK ON HIM.

THE RELL CALL CONTINUED. HARRY WATCHED KLIPIN, PETTIGREW, AND
HIS FATHER JOIN LILY AND SIRILUS AT THE GRYPFINDER TABLE. AT LAST,
WHEN

THE PRINCE'S TALL

FOR

ONLY A DOZEN STUDENTS REMAINED THE RE SHIRTED, PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL

CALLED SNAPE.

HARRY WALKED WITH HIM THE THE STEEL, WATCHED HIM PLACE THE HAT
UPON HIS HEAD. SLYTHERIN'S CRIED THE SHIRTING HAT.

AND SEVERUS SNAPE MOVED OFF THE THE EITHER SIDE OF THE HALL, AWAY
FROM LILY, THE WHERE THE SLYTHERINS WERE CHEERING HIM, THE WHERE
LUCILUS MALFOY, A PERFECT BADGE GLEAMING UPON HIS CHEST, PATTED
SNAPE ON THE BACK AS HE SAT DOWN BESIDE HIM. . . .

AND THE SCENE CHANGED. . . .

LILY AND SNAPE WERE WALKING ACROSS THE CASTLE CHLIRTYARD,
EVIDENTLY

ARGUING. HARRY HURRIED THE CATCH UP WITH THEM, THE LISTEN IN. AS HE
REACHED THEM, HE REALIZED HOW MUCH TALLER THEY BOTH WERE: A FEW

YEARS SEEMED TO HAVE PASSED SINCE THEIR SPLITTING.

... TWILIGHT WE WERE SUPPOSED TO BE FRIENDS? SNAPE WAS SAYING,
BEST FRIENDS?

WE ARE, SEV, BUT I DON'T LIKE SOME OF THE PEOPLE YOU'RE HANGING
AROUND WITH? I'M SURE, BUT I DETEST AVERY AND MULLIKER? MULLIKER?
WHAT DO YOU SEE IN HIM, SEV, HE'S CREEPY? DO YOU KNOW WHAT HE
TRIED

TO DO THE MARY MACDONALD THE OTHER DAY?

LILY HAD REACHED A PILLAR AND LEANED AGAINST IT, LEERING UP INTO
THE THIN, SALLIED FACE.

THAT WAS NOTHING, SAID SNAPE. IT WAS A LAUGH, THAT'S ALL
IT WAS DARK MAGIC, AND IF YOU THINK THAT'S FUNNY

WHAT ABOUT THE STUFF PETER AND HIS MATES GET UP TO? DEMANDED
SNAPE. HIS CHEER ROSE AGAIN AS HE SAID IT, UNABLE, IT SEEMED, TO HOLD
IN HIS RESENTMENT.

WHAT'S PETER GET TO DO WITH ANYTHING? SAID LILY.

THEY SNEAK OUT AT NIGHT, THERE'S SOMETHING WEIRD ABOUT THAT
SLIPIN, WHERE DOES HE KEEP GOING?

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

HE'S ILL, SAID LILY, THEY SAY HE'S ILL

EVERY MONTH AT THE FULL MOON? SAID SNAPE.

I KNOW YOUR THEORY, SAID LILY, AND SHE SHOOKED HER HEAD. WHY ARE
YOU SO OBSESSED WITH THEM ANYWAY? WHY DO YOU CARE WHAT THEY'RE
DOING AT NIGHT?

I M ILJST TRYING TH SEHH VELL THEY RE NEET AS WHENDFUL AS
EVERYTHNG

SEEMS TH THINDX THEY ARE.

THE INTENSITY HP HIS GAZE MADE HER BLISH.

THEY DEEN T LSE DARK MAGIC, THLLGH. SHE DRHPED HER VEIL.

AND VELL RE BEING REALLY LINGERATEFUL. I HEARD WHAT HAPPENED THE
ETHER

NIGHT. VELL WENT SNEAKING DEEN THAT TLNNEL BY THE WHIMPING
WIL-

LEH, AND JAMES PITTER SAVED VELL FROM WHATEVER S DEEN THERE

SNAPE S WHLE FACE CHENTERTED AND HE SPOLLTERED. SAVED? SAVED?

VELL THINDX HE WAS PLAYING THE HEREE? HE WAS SAYING HIS NEEDS AND
HIS

FRIENDS THEE! VELL RE NEET GHING TH I WHN T LET VELL

LET ME? LET ME?

LILY S BRIGHT GREEN EYES WERE SLITS. SNAPE BACKTRACKED AT HENCE.

I DIDN T MEAN I ILJST DEEN T WANT TH SEE VELL MADE A FHEL HP HE
FANKIES VELL, JAMES PITTER FANKIES VELL! THE WHRDS SEEMED WRENCH-ED
FROM HIM AGAINST HIS WILL. AND HE S NEET ... EVERYTHNG THINDS ...

BIG BLIDITCH HERH SNAPE S KITTERNESS AND DISLIKE WERE RENDER-
ING HIM INCHERENT, AND LILY S EYERHWS WERE TRAVELING FARTHER
AND

FARTHER UP HER FHEE-HEAD.

I DEEN JAMES PITTER S AN ARREGCANT THEEAC, SHE SAID, CLITTING

ACROSS SNAPE. I DIDN'T NEED YOU TO TELL ME THAT, BUT MULCIBER'S AND
AVERY'S IDEA OF FILMER IS JUST EVIL, EVIL, SEV, I DIDN'T UNDERSTAND
HOW
YOU CAN BE FRIENDS WITH THEM.

HARRY REALISED THAT SNAPE HAD EVEN HEARD HER STRUTURES AND MUL-
CIBER AND AVERY. THE MOMENT SHE HAD INSULTED JAMES POTTER, HIS
THE PRINCE'S TALL

WAS

WHILE REDDY HAD RELAXED, AND AS THEY WALKED AWAY THERE WAS A NEW
SPRING IN SNAPE'S STEP, ...
AND THE SCENE DISSOLVED, ...

HARRY WATCHED AGAIN AS SNAPE LEFT THE GREAT HALL AFTER SITTING
HIS

ELLEN, IN DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, WATCHED AS HE WANDERED

AWAY FROM THE CASTLE AND STRAYED INADVERTENTLY CLOSE TO THE PLACE
BE-

NEATH THE BEECH TREE WHERE JAMES, SIRILIS, LUPIN, AND PETTIGREW SAT

TOGETHER, BUT HARRY KEPT HIS DISTANCE THIS TIME, BECAUSE HE KNEW
WHAT

HAPPENED AFTER JAMES HAD HEISTED SEVERUS INTO THE AIR AND
TALKED

HIM; HE KNEW WHAT HAD BEEN DONE AND SAID, AND IT GAVE HIM THE PLEASURE
TO HEAR IT AGAIN, . . . HE WATCHED AS LILY THREW THE CRUEL AND

WENT TO SNAPPE'S DEFENSE. DISTANTLY HE HEARD SNAPPE SPEAK AT HER IN
HIS

HUMILIATION AND HIS FLURY, THE UNFORGETTABLE WORD: MURDERED.

THE SCENE CHANGED, . . .

I'M SORRY,

I'M NOT INTERESTED,

I'M SORRY?

SAVE YOUR BREATH.

IT WAS NIGHTTIME. LILY, WHO WAS WEARING A DRESSING GOWN, STOOD
WITH HER ARMS FOLDED IN FRONT OF THE PORTRAIT OF THE FAT LADY, AT THE

ENTRANCE TO GRYFFINDOR TOWER.

I ONLY CAME HERE BECAUSE MARY TOLD ME THEY WERE THREATENING THE
SLEEP HERE.

I WAS, I WOULD HAVE DONE, I NEVER MEANT TO CALL THEM MURDERED,
IT JUST

SLIPPED OUT? THERE WAS NO PITY IN LILY'S VOICE. IT'S TOO LATE,
I'VE

MADE EXCUSES FOR THEM FOR YEARS, NONE OF MY FRIENDS CAN UNDERSTAND
WHY I EVEN TALK TO THEM, THEY AND THEIR PRECIOUS LITTLE DEATH-LATER
FRIENDS THEY SEE, THEY DON'T EVEN DENY IT? THEY DON'T EVEN DENY
THAT'S

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

XXX

WHAT YOU'RE ALL AIMING THE RE? YOU CAN'T WAIT THE WHIN YOU-KNEW-
WITH.

CAN YOU?

HE OPENED HIS MOUTH, BUT CLOSED IT WITHOUT SPEAKING.

I CAN'T PRETEND ANYMORE. YOU'VE CHOSEN YOUR WAY, I'VE CHOSEN
MINE.

NE LISTEN, I DIDN'T MEAN

THE CALL ME MURDERER? BUT YOU CALL EVERYONE OF MY BIRTH
MURDERER, SEVERUS. WHY SHOULD I BE ANY DIFFERENT?

HE STRUGGLED IN THE VERGE OF SPEECH, BUT WITH A CONTEMPTUOUS
LOOK HE TURNED AND CLIMBED BACK THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE. . . .

THE CORRIDOR DISAPPEARED, AND THE SCENE TOOK A LITTLE LONGER TO RE-
FORM: HARRY SEEMED TO FLY THROUGH SHIFTING SHAPES AND CHEERS
UNTIL

HIS SURROUNDINGS SOLIDIFIED AGAIN AND HE STOOD IN A HILLTOP,
PERHAPS

AND CHILD IN THE DARKNESS, THE WIND WHISTLING THROUGH THE
BRANCHES

OF A FEW LEAFLESS TREES. THE ADULT SNAKE WAS PANTING, TURNING IN
THE

SPOT, HIS HAND GRIPPED TIGHTLY IN HIS HAND, WAITING FOR SOMETHING
FOR SOMETHING. . . . HIS FEAR INFECTED HARRY TOO, EVEN THOUGH HE
KNEW THAT HE COULD NOT BE HARMED, AND HE LOOKED OVER HIS
SHOULDER,

WONDERING WHAT IT WAS THAT SNAPE WAS WAITING FOR

THEN A BLINDING, JAGGED IET OF WHITE LIGHT FLEW THROUGH THE AIR:

HARRY FELT LIGHT OF LIGHTNING, BUT SNAPE HAD DROPPED TO HIS KNEES
AND HIS HAND HAD FLEW TO HIS HEAD.

DON'T KILL ME!

THAT WAS NOT MY INTENTION.

AND FEELING OF DUMBLEDORE APPARATING HAD BEEN DROWNED BY
THE SOUND OF THE WIND IN THE BRANCHES. HE STOOD BEFORE SNAPE WITH
HIS REEKS WHIPPING AROUND HIM, AND HIS FACE WAS ILLUMINATED FROM
BEHIND IN THE LIGHT CAST BY HIS HAND.

THE PRINCE'S TALL

???

WELL, SEVERUS? WHAT MESSAGE DOES LORD VOLDEMORT HAVE FOR
ME?

NO MESSAGE I'M HERE AND MY HEAVEN ACCIDENT!

SNAPE WAS WRINGING HIS HANDS: HE LOOKED A LITTLE MAD, WITH HIS
STRAGGLING BLACK HAIR FLYING AROUND HIM.

I I CAME WITH A WARNING NO, A REQUEST PLEASE
DUMBLEDORE PLUCKED HIS HAND, THROUGH LEAVES AND BRANCHES STILL
FLEW THROUGH THE NIGHT AIR AROUND THEM, SILENCE FELL ON THE SPOT
WHERE HE AND SNAPE FACED EACH OTHER.

WHAT REQUEST COULD A DEATH EATER MAKE OF ME?

THE THE PROPHECY ... THE PREDICTION ... THE LALINEY ...

AH, YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HOW MUCH DID YOU RELAY THE LORD

VEHDEMENT?

EVERYTHING EVERYTHING I HEARD? SAID SNAPE. THAT IS WHY
IT IS HER THAT REASON HE THINKS IT MEANS LILY EVANS?

THE PROPHETCY DID NOT REFER TO A WOMAN, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IT
SPoke OF A BOY BORN AT THE END OF JULY

YELL KNOW WHAT I MEAN? HE THINKS IT MEANS HER SON, HE IS GOING
TO KILL HER DOWN KILL THEM ALL

IF SHE MEANS SHE MURDER THE YELL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SURELY LORD
VEHDEMENT WILL SPARE HER? (WILL YELL NOT ASK HER MERCY FOR THE
MOTHER, IN EXCHANGE FOR THE SON?

I HAVE I HAVE ASKED HIM

YELL DISLIST ME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD
SHE MURDER IN HIS VOICE, SNAPE SEEMED TO SHRINK A LITTLE.
YELL

DO NOT CARE, THEN, ABOUT THE DEATHS OF HER HUSBAND AND CHILD? THEY
CAN DIE, AS LONG AS YELL HAVE WHAT YELL WANT?
SNAPE SAID NOTHING, BUT MERELY LINED UP AT DUMBLEDORE.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

HIDE THEM ALL, THEN, HE CREAMED, KEEP HER THEM SAFE,
PLEASE.

AND WHAT WILL YELL GIVE ME IN RETURN, SEVERUS?

IN IN RETURN? SNAPE GAZED AT DUMBLEDORE, AND HARRY
EXPECTED

HIM THE PRETEST, BUT AFTER A LONG MOMENT HE SAID, ANYTHING.
THE HILLTOP FADED, AND HARRY STOOD IN DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE, AND
SOMETHING WAS MAKING A TERRIBLE SOUND, LIKE A WHEELED ANIMAL.

SNAPE WAS SLUMPED FORWARD IN A CHAIR AND DUMBLEDORE WAS STAND-
ING OVER HIM, BREATHING GRIM. AFTER A MOMENT OR TWO, SNAPE RAISED

HIS FACE, AND HE BREATHED LIKE A MAN WHO HAD LIVED A HUNDRED YEARS
OF MISERY SINCE LEAVING THE WILD HILLTOP.

I THOUGHT ... THEY WERE GOING ... TO KEEP HER ... SAFE ...

SHE AND JAMES PUT THEIR FAITH IN THE WRONG PERSON, SAID DUM-
BLEDORE. RATHER LIKE THEY, SEVERUS. WEREN'T THEY HOPING THAT LORD

VOLDEMORT WOULD SPARE HER?

SNAPE'S BREATHING WAS SHALLOWS.

HER BODY SURVIVES, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

WITH A TINY TICK OF THE HEAD, SNAPE SEEMED TO FLICK OFF AN INDI-
SCERNIBLE FLY.

HER SHIN LIVES, HE HAS HER EYES, PRECISELY HER EYES, THEY REMEMBER
THE SHAPE AND COLOR OF LILY EVANS'S EYES, I AM SURE?

DEEN T? REMEMBERED SNAPE. GONE ... DEAD ...

IS THIS REMORSE, SEVERUS?

I WISH ... I WISH I WERE DEAD ...

AND WHAT USE WOULD THAT BE TO ANYONE? SAID DUMBLEDORE

CHILDLY. IF YOU LOVED LILY EVANS, IF YOU TRULY LOVED HER, THEN YOUR
WAY FORWARD IS CLEAR.

SNAPE SEEMED TO PEER THROUGH A HAZE OF PAIN, AND DUMBLEDORE'S
WORDS APPEARED TO TAKE A LONG TIME TO REACH HIM.

THE PRINCE'S TALE

WHAT WHAT DO YOU MEAN?

YOU KNOW HOW AND WHY SHE DIED, MAKE SURE IT WAS NOT IN VAIN.
HELP ME PROTECT LILY'S SON.

HE DOES NOT NEED PROTECTION. THE DARK LORD HAS GONE

THE DARK LORD WILL RETURN, AND HARRY POTTER WILL BE IN TERRIBLE
DANGER WHEN HE DOES.

THERE WAS A LONG PAUSE, AND SILENTLY SNAPE REGAINED CONTROL OF
HIMSELF,

MASTERED HIS OWN BREATHING. AT LAST HE SAID, VERY WELL. VERY

WELL, BUT NEVER NEVER TELL DUMBLEDORE! THIS MUST BE BETWEEN
US! SWEAR IT! I CANNOT BEAR ... ESPECIALLY POTTER'S SON ... I WANT
YOUR

WORD!

MY WORD, SEVERUS, THAT I SHALL NEVER REVEAL THE REST OF YOUR
DUMBLEDORE SIGHED, LEANING BACK INTO SNAPE'S PERECUTELIS,
ANGELISHED

FACE. IF YOU INSIST ...

THE OFFICE DISSOLVED BUT RE-APPEARED INSTANTLY. SNAPE WAS PACING

LIP AND DEEN IN FRONT OF DUMKEDDRE.

MEDDRE, ARRECANANT AS HIS FATHER, A DETERMINED RULE-
BREAKER, DELIGHTED TO FIND HIMSELF FAMOUS, ATTENTION-SEEKING AND
IMPERTINENT

YOU SEE WHAT YOU EXPECT TO SEE, SEVERUS, SAID DUMKEDDRE, WITH-
OUT RAISING HIS EYES FROM A COPY OF TRANSLUCRATION TODAY,
EITHER

TEACHERS REPORT THAT THE BOY IS MODEST, LIKEABLE, AND REASONABLY TAL-
ENTED. PERSONALLY, I FIND HIM AN ENGAGING CHILD.

DUMKEDDRE TURNED A PAGE, AND SAID, WITHOUT LOOKING UP, KEEP
AN EYE ON ELLIOT, WHEN T YOU?

A WHIRL OF COLOR, AND THEN EVERYTHING DARKENED, AND SNAP AND
DUMKEDDRE STOOD A LITTLE APART IN THE ENTRANCE HALL, WHILE THE
LAST

STRAGGLERS FROM THE BLUE BALL PASSED THEM ON THEIR WAY TO THE
WELL? MURMURED DUMKEDDRE.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

XXX

BARBARUS'S MARK IS BECOMING DARKER THEN, HE IS PANICKING, HE

FEARS RETRIIBUTION; YELL KNOWS FEEL MUCH HELP HE GAVE THE MINIS-
TRY AFTER THE DARK LORD FELL. SNAPE LEERED SIDELAYS AT DUMBLE-
DHIRE S CREEPED-NEESED PROFILE. KARDAREH? INTENDS THE FLEE IF THE
MARD

KLIRNS.

DEES HE? SAID DUMBLEDHIRE SHFTLY, AS FLELR DELACHLR AND REGER
DAVIES CAME GIGGLING IN FROM THE GREENHDS. AND ARE YELL TEMPTED
THE IHIN HIN?

NEH, SAID SNAPE, HIS BLACK EYES HEN FLELR S AND REGER S RETREATING
FIGURES. I AM NOT SLICK A CHLWARD.

NEH, AGREED DUMBLEDHIRE. YELL ARE A KRAVER MAN BY FAR THAN ICHH
KARDAREH?, YELL KNOW, I SOMETIMES THINK WE SHRT THEE SEHN. ...
HE WALKED AWAY, LEAVING SNAPE LEERDING STRICKEN. ...

AND WHEN HARRY STEHD IN THE HEADMASTER S OFFICE YET AGAIN, IT
WAS NIGHTTIME, AND DUMBLEDHIRE SAGGED SIDELAYS IN THE THERNELLIKE
CHAIR BEHIND THE DESK, APPARENTLY SEMICHNUSCHLIS, HIS RIGHT HAND
DANGLED HYER THE SIDE, BLACKENED AND KLIRNED. SNAPE WAS MLITTERING
INCANTATIENS, PHINTING HIS WAND AT THE WRIST OF THE HAND, WHILE
WITH

HIS LEFT HAND HE TIPPED A CHERLET FLIL OF THICK GELDEN PHTIEN DHWN
DUMBLEDHIRE S THERAT. AFTER A MEHMENT HR TWEE, DUMBLEDHIRE S EYELIDS
FLITTERED AND HPENED.

WHY, SAID SNAPE, WITHHUT PREAMBLE, WHY DID YELL PLIT HEN
THAT RING? IT CARRIES A CURSE, SLIRLY YELL REALIZED TH-AT, WHY EVEN
THELICH IT?

MARVELLUS GALINT S RING LAY IN THE DESK BESIDE DUMBLEDORE. IT WAS
CRACKED; THE SWORD OF GRYPFINDER LAY BESIDE IT.

DUMBLEDORE GRIMACED.

I . . . WAS A FOOL. SHRELY TEMPTED . . .

TEMPTED BY WHAT?

THE PRINCE S TALK

XXXI

DUMBLEDORE DID NOT ANSWER.

IT IS A MIRACLE YELL MANAGED THE RETURN HERE? SNAPE SEEMED FLI-
RHELS. THAT RING CARRIED A CLUSE OF EXTRAORDINARY POWER, THE
CERTAIN

IT IS ALL WE CAN HOPE FOR; I HAVE TRAPPED THE CLUSE IN ONE HAND FOR
THE TIME BEING

DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS BLACKENED, LIFELESS HAND, AND EXAMINED IT
WITH THE EXPRESSION OF ONE BEING SHOWN AN INTERESTING CURIO.

YELL HAVE DONE VERY WELL, SEVERUS, HOW LONG DO YELL THINK I
HAVE?

DUMBLEDORE S TONE WAS CONVERSATIONAL; HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN ASKING
FOR A WEATHER FORECAST. SNAPE HESITATED, AND THEN SAID, I CANNOT
TELL.

MAYBE A YEAR, THERE IS NO HALTING SUCH A SPELL ANYMORE, IT WILL
SPREAD

EVENTUALLY, IT IS THE SEED OF CLUSE THAT STRENGTHENS EVERY TIME.

DUMBLEDORE SMILED, THE NEWS THAT HE HAD LESS THAN A YEAR TO LIVE

SEEMED A MATTER OF LITTLE OR NO CONCERN TO HIM.

I AM FORTUNATE, EXTREMELY FORTUNATE, THAT I HAVE YOU, SEVERUS.
IF YOU HAD ONLY SLIPPED ME A LITTLE EARLIER, I MIGHT HAVE
BEEN ABLE TO DO MORE, BUT YOU WERE TIME? SAID SNAPE FLIRTUOUSLY.
HE LOOKED DOWN AT THE BROKEN RING AND THE SWORD. DID YOU THINK
THAT BREAKING THE RING WOULD BREAK THE CURSE?

SOMETHING LIKE THAT . . . I WAS DELIRIOUS, NOT DELICIOUS. . . . SAID
DUMBLEDORE, WITH AN EFFORT HE STRAIGHTENED HIMSELF IN HIS CHAIR.
WELL, REALLY, THIS MAKES MATTERS MUCH MORE STRAIGHTFORWARD.
SNAPE LOOKED LITTERALLY PERPLEXED. DUMBLEDORE SMILED.

I REPEAT TO THE PLAN LORD VOLDEMORT IS REVEALING AROUND ME. HIS
PLAN TO HAVE THE PRINCE MALFOY KILL ME.

SNAPE SAT DOWN IN THE CHAIR HARRY HAD SO OFTEN OCCUPIED, ACROSS
THE DESK FROM DUMBLEDORE. HARRY COULD TELL THAT HE WANTED TO SAY
MORE BUT THE SUBJECT OF DUMBLEDORE'S CLOSED HAND, BUT THE OTHER

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

HELD IT UP IN POLITE REFUSAL TO DISCUSS THE MATTER FURTHER.
STELLING,

SNAPE SAID, THE DARK LORD DOES NOT EXPECT DRACO TO SUCCEED. THIS
IS MERELY PUNISHMENT FOR LUCIUS'S RECENT FAILURES. SUCH THREATS
FOR

DRACO'S PARENTS, WHILE THEY WATCH HIM FAIL AND PAY THE PRICE.

IN SHORT, THE BOY HAS HAD A DEATH SENTENCE PREDICTED UPON HIM

AS SURELY AS I HAVE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NOW, I SHOULD HAVE
THOUGHT

THE NATURAL SUCCESSOR TO THE JOB, SINCE DRACO FAILS, IS YOURSELF?
THERE WAS A SHORT PAUSE.

THAT, I THINK, IS THE DARK LORD'S PLAN.

LORD VOLDEMORT ANTICIPATES A MOMENT IN THE NEAR FUTURE WHEN HE
WILL NOT NEED A SPY AT HOGWARTS?

HE BELIEVES THE SCHEME WILL BRING HIM IN HIS GRASP, YES.

AND IF IT DOES FALL INTO HIS GRASP, SAID DUMBLEDORE, ALMOST, IT
SEEMED, AS AN ASIDE, I HAVE HEARD WORD THAT YOU WILL DO ALL IN YOUR
POWER TO PROTECT THE STUDENTS OF HOGWARTS?

SNAPE GAVE A STIFF NOD.

GOOD, NOW THEN, YOUR FIRST PRIORITY WILL BE TO DISCOVER WHAT
DRACO IS UP TO. A FRIGHTENED TEENAGE BOY IS A DANGER TO OTHERS AS
WELL AS TO HIMSELF. OFFER HIM HELP AND GUIDANCE, HE MIGHT THEN
ACCEPT.

HE LIKES YOU

MUCH LESS SINCE HIS FATHER HAS LEFT FAVER, DRACO BLAMES ME,
HE THINKS I HAVE USURPED LILIAS'S POSITION.

ALL THE SAME, TRY, I AM CONCERNED LESS FOR MYSELF THAN FOR ACCIDENTAL
VICTIMS OF WHATEVER SCHEMES MIGHT BEHIND THE BOY.
ULTIMATELY,

OF COURSE, THERE IS ONLY ONE THING TO BE DONE IF WE ARE TO SAVE HIM
FROM LORD VOLDEMORT'S WRATH.

SNAPE RAISED HIS EYEBROWS AND HIS TONE WAS SARCASTIC AS HE ASKED,

ARE YOU INTENDING TO LET HIM KILL YOU?

CERTAINLY NOT, YOU MUST KILL ME.

THE PRINCE S TALK

THERE WAS A LONG SILENCE, BROKEN ONLY BY AN EDD CLICKING NOISE.
FALDRE THE PHENIX WAS GRABING A BIT OF CLITTERING.

WOULD YOU LIKE ME TO DO IT NOW? ASKED SNAPE, HIS VOICE HEAVY
WITH IRONY. HER WOULD YOU LIKE A FEW MOMENTS TO COMPOSE AN
EPITAPH?

HE, NOT WHITE YET, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING. I DARE SAY THE
MOMENT WILL PRESENT ITSELF IN DUE COURSE. GIVEN WHAT HAS
HAPPENED

TONIGHT, HE INDICATED HIS WITHERED HAND, WE CAN BE SURE THAT IT
WILL HAPPEN WITHIN A YEAR.

IF YOU DON'T MIND DYING, SAID SNAPE RELEGALLY, WHY NOT LET
DRACH DO IT?

THAT KEY S SELL IS NOT YET SO DAMAGED, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I
WOULD NOT HAVE IT RIPPED APART BY MY ACCIDENT.

AND MY SELL, DUMBLEDORE? MINE?

YOU ALONE KNOW WHETHER IT WILL HARM YOUR SELL THE HELP AND HELP
MAN AVOID PAIN AND HUMILIATION, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I ASK THIS HERE
GREAT FATHER OF YOU, SEVERAL, BECAUSE DEATH IS COMING FOR ME AS
SURELY

AS THE CHILDRY CANNONS WILL FINISH BETWEEN OF THIS YEAR S LEAGUE. I
KNOW I SHOULD PREFER A QUICK, PAINLESS EXIT TO THE PROTRACTED
AND

MESSY AFFAIR IT WILL BE IF, FOR INSTANCE, CROOKS IS INVOLVED I
FEAR

VERBODEN HAT RECRUITED HIM? HER DEAR BELLATRIX, WHO LIKES THE PLAY
WITH HER FEED BEFORE SHE EATS IT.

HIS THERE WAS LIGHT, BUT HIS BLUE EYES PIERCED SNAPE AS THEY HAD
FREQUENTLY PIERCED HARRY, AS THOUGH THE SKIN THEY DISCUSSED WAS
VISIBLE TO HIM. AT LAST SNAPE GAVE ANOTHER CLUT NOD.

DUMBLEDORE SEEMED SATISFIED.

THANK YOU, SEVERUS . . .

THE OFFICE DISAPPEARED, AND NOW SNAPE AND DUMBLEDORE WERE
STROLLING TOGETHER IN THE DESERTED CASTLE GROUNDS BY TWILIGHT.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

WHAT ARE YOU DOING WITH PETER, ALL THESE EVENINGS YOU ARE
CHAS-

ING TOGETHER? SNAPE ASKED ABRUPTLY.

DUMBLEDORE SMILED WEARY.

WHY? YOU AREN'T TRYING TO GIVE HIM MORE DETENTIONS, SEVERUS?
THE BOY WILL SOON HAVE SPENT MORE TIME IN DETENTION THAN HE.

HE IS HIS FATHER EVER AGAIN

IN WORDS, PERHAPS, BUT HIS DEEPEST NATURE IS MUCH MORE LIKE HIS
MOTHER'S. I SPEND TIME WITH HARRY BECAUSE I HAVE THINGS TO DISCUSS
WITH HIM, INFORMATION I MUST GIVE HIM BEFORE IT IS TOO LATE.

INFORMATION, REPEATED SNAPE. YOU TRUST HIM... YOU DO NOT TRUST ME.

IT IS NOT A QUESTION OF TRUST. I HAVE, AS WE BOTH KNOW, LIMITED TIME. IT IS ESSENTIAL THAT I GIVE THE KEY ENOUGH INFORMATION FOR HIM

TO DO WHAT HE NEEDS TO DO.

AND WHY MAY I NOT HAVE THE SAME INFORMATION?

I PREFER NOT TO PUT ALL OF MY SECRETS IN ONE BASKET, PARTICULARLY NOT A BASKET THAT SPENDS SO MUCH TIME DANGLING ON THE ARM OF LORD

VERMOREL.

WHICH I DO FOR YOUR ORDERS?

AND YOU DO IT EXTREMELY WELL. DO NOT THINK THAT I UNDERESTIMATE THE CONSTANT DANGER IN WHICH YOU PLACE YOURSELF, SEVERUS.

TO GIVE VERMOREL WHAT APPEARS TO BE VALUABLE INFORMATION WHILE

WITHHOLDING THE ESSENTIALS IS A RISK I WOULD ENTRUST THE NECESSARY RISK TO YOU.

LET YOU CONSIDER MUCH MORE IN A RISK WHICH IS INCAPABLE OF ESTIMATION, WHERE MAGIC IS MEDICINE, AND WHICH HAS A DIRECT CONNECTION

WITH THE DARK LORD'S MIND?

VERMOREL FEARS THAT CONNECTION, SAID DUMBLEDORE. NOT SEEING AGEE HE HAD SOME SMALL TASTE OF WHAT TRULY SHARING HARRY'S MIND

THE PRINCE'S TALK

XXX

MEANS THE HIM, IT WAS PAIN SUCH AS HE HAS NEVER EXPERIENCED, HE
WILL

NEET TRY THE PRINCESS E-LARRY AGAIN, I AM SURE OF IT, NEET IN THAT WAY,
I DONT UNDERSTAND,

LORD VERDEMERT'S SHELL, MAIMED AS IT IS, CANNOT REAR CLOSE CONTACT
WITH A SHELL LIKE E-LARRY'S, LIKE A THING LIKE FROZEN STEEL, LIKE FLESH
IN

FLAME

SHELLS? WE WERE TALKING OF MINDS?

IN THE CASE OF E-LARRY AND LORD VERDEMERT, THE SPREAD OF MIND IS THE
SPREAD OF THE EITHER,

BLUMLEDERE GLANCED AROUND THE MADE SURE THAT THEY WERE ALONE,

THEY WERE CLOSE BY THE FORBIDDEN FOREST HILL, BUT THERE WAS NO
SIGN

OF ANYONE NEAR THEM,

AFTER SHELL HAVE KILLED ME, SEVERALS

SHELL REFUSE THE TELL ME EVERYTHING, YET SHELL EXPECT THAT SMALL SER-
VICE OF ME? SHARLED SNARE, AND REAL ANGER FLARED IN THE THIN FACE

NEED, SHELL TAKE A GREAT DEAL FOR GRANTED, BLUMLEDERE? PERHAPS I
HAVE

CHANGED MY MIND?

YELL GAVE ME YOUR WORD, SEVERUS, AND WHILE WE ARE TALKING ABOUT SERVICES YOU OWE ME, I THOUGHT YOU AGREED TO KEEP A CLOSE EYE ON YOUR YOUNG SLOTHFUL FRIEND?

SNAPE LOOKED ANGRY, MULTINELLIS, DUMBLEDOORE SIGHED.

COME TO MY OFFICE TONIGHT, SEVERUS, AT ELEVEN, AND YOU SHALL NOT COMPLAIN THAT I HAVE NO CONFIDENCE IN YOU, . . .

THEY WERE BACK IN DUMBLEDOORE'S OFFICE, THE WINDOWS DARK, AND FALLOWS SAT SILENT AS SNAPE SAT BLITHE STILL, AS DUMBLEDOORE WALKED AROUND HIM, TALKING.

HARRY MUST NOT DROWN, NOT UNTIL THE LAST MOMENT, NOT UNTIL IT IS NECESSARY, OTHERWISE HOW COULD HE HAVE THE STRENGTH TO DO WHAT

MUST BE DONE?

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

BUT WHAT MUST HE DO?

THAT IS BETWEEN HARRY AND ME, NOW LISTEN CLOSELY, SEVERUS, THERE WILL COME A TIME AFTER MY DEATH DO NOT ARGUE, DO NOT INTERRUPT! THERE WILL COME A TIME WHEN LORD VOLDEMORT WILL FEEL THE FEAR FOR THE LIFE OF HIS SON,

FOR NAGINI? SNAPE LOOKED ASTONISHED.

PRECISELY, IF THERE COMES A TIME WHEN LORD VOLDEMORT FEELS SURE-

ING THAT SNAPE MIGHT BE HIS KIDDING, BUT KEEPS IT SAFE BESIDE HIM
LON-

DER MAGICAL PROTECTION, THEN, I THINK, IT WILL BE SAFE TO TELL HARRY,

TELL HIM WHAT?

OLIMPELDER TOOK A DEEP BREATH AND CLOSED HIS EYES.

TELL HIM THAT ON THE NIGHT LORD VOLDEMORT TRIED TO KILL HIM,
WHEN LILY CAST HER OWN LIFE BETWEEN THEM AS A SHIELD, THE KILLING

CURSE REBOUNDED UPON LORD VOLDEMORT, AND A FRAGMENT OF VOLDE-
MORT'S SHELL WAS BLASTED APART FROM THE WHOLE, AND LATCHED ITSELF
ONTO

THE ONLY LIVING SHELL LEFT IN THAT COLLAPSING BUILDING, PART OF LORD
VOL-

DEMORT LIVES INSIDE HARRY, AND IT IS THAT WHICH GIVES HIM THE
POWER

OF SPEECH WITH SNAKES, AND A CONNECTION WITH LORD VOLDEMORT'S
MIND THAT HE HAS NEVER UNDERSTOOD, AND WHILE THAT FRAGMENT OF
SHELL, UNMISSED BY VOLDEMORT, REMAINS ATTACHED TO AND PROTECTED
BY HARRY, LORD VOLDEMORT CANNOT DIE.

HARRY SEEMED TO BE WATCHING THE TWO MEN FROM ONE END OF A
LONG TUNNEL, THEY WERE SO FAR AWAY FROM HIM, THEIR VEHICLES ECHOING
STRANGELY IN HIS EARS.

SEE THE KEY . . . THE KEY MUST DIE? ASKED SNAPE QUIETLY CALMLY,

AND VOLDEMORT HIMSELF MUST DO IT, SEVERUS, THAT IS ESSENTIAL.
ANOTHER LONG SILENCE, THEN SNAPE SAID, I THOUGHT . . . ALL THESE

YEARS . . . THAT WE WERE PROTECTING HIM FOR HER, FOR LILY,

THE PRINCE'S TALK

WE HAVE PROTECTED HIM BECAUSE IT HAS BEEN ESSENTIAL TO TEACH HIM, TO RAISE HIM, TO LET HIM TRY HIS STRENGTH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HIS EYES STILL TIGHT SHUT. MEANWHILE, THE CONNECTION BETWEEN THEM

GROWS EVER STRONGER, A PARASITIC GROWTH: SOMETIMES I HAVE THOUGHT

HE SUSPECTS IT HIMSELF. IF I KNOW HIM, HE WILL HAVE ARRANGED MATTERS

SO THAT WHEN HE DOES SET FOOT TO MEET HIS DEATH, IT WILL TRULY MEAN THE END OF VILDEMEHT.

DUMBLEDORE OPENED HIS EYES, SNAPE BREATHED FERRIFIED,

WHY HAVE KEPT HIM ALIVE SO THAT HE CAN DIE AT THE RIGHT MOMENT?

DON'T BE SHOCKED, SEVERUS, FEW MANY MEN AND WOMEN HAVE BEEN WATCHED DIE?

LATELY, ONLY THOSE WHOM I COULD NOT SAVE, SAID SNAPE, HE STOOD UP, WHY HAVE LIVED ME,

MEANING?

I HAVE SPIED FOR YOU AND LIED FOR YOU, PUT MYSELF IN MENTAL DAN-

GER FOR YOU. EVERYTHING WAS SUPPOSED TO BE THE DEEP LILY PATTERN &

SEEN SAFE. NOW YOU TELL ME YOU HAVE BEEN RAISING HIM LIKE A PIG FOR
SLAUGHTER

BUT THIS IS THE ONLY ONE, SEVERUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE SERIOUSLY. HAVE
YOU GIVEN THE CARE FOR THE BIRD, AFTER ALL?

FOR HIM? SNEEZED SNAPE. EXPECTED PATIENCE!

FROM THE TIP OF HIS WAND BURST THE SILVER DEER! SHE LANDED IN THE
OFFICE FLOOR, ROLLED ONCE ACROSS THE OFFICE, AND SHARED HALF OF THE
WINDING. DUMBLEDORE WATCHED HER FLY AWAY, AND AS HER SILVER GLOW
FADED HE TURNED BACK THE SNAPE, AND HIS EYES WERE FULL OF TEARS.

AFTER ALL THIS TIME?

ALWAYS, SAID SNAPE.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

AND THE SCENE SHIFTED. NOW, HARRY SAW SNAPE TALKING TO THE
PORTRAIT OF DUMBLEDORE BEHIND HIS DESK.

YOU WILL HAVE TO GIVE VERMOREL THE CORRECT DATE OF HARRY'S DE-
PARTURE FROM HIS AUNT AND UNCLE'S, SAID DUMBLEDORE. NEXT THE DE-
SEE

WILL RAISE SUSPICION, WHEN VERMOREL BELIEVES YOU SEE WELL
INFORMED.

HOWEVER, YOU MUST PLANT THE IDEA OF DECEITS; THAT, I THINK, MIGHT
THE

ENSURE HARRY'S SAFETY. TRY CONVINCE MUNDUNGUS FLETCHER, AND
SEVERUS, IF YOU ARE FORCED TO TAKE PART IN THE CHASE, BE SURE TO ACT
YOUR PART CONVINCINGLY. . . . I AM COUNTING UPON YOU TO REMAIN IN
LORD VOLDEMORT'S GOOD GRACES AS LONG AS POSSIBLE, FOR FLECHARTS
WILL

BE LEFT TO THE MERCY OF THE CARRELS. . . .

WHEN SNAPE WAS HEAD TO HEAD WITH MUNDUNGUS IN AN UNFAMILIAR
TAVERN, MUNDUNGUS'S FACE LOOKING CURIOUSLY BLANK, SNAPE
FROWNED
IN CONCENTRATION.

YOU WILL SUGGEST THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX, SNAPE
MURMURED.

THAT THEY USE DECEITS, POLYLICK POTION, IDENTICAL PETERS, IT IS
THE

ONLY THING THAT MIGHT WORK, YOU WILL FORGET THAT I HAVE
SUGGESTED

THIS, YOU WILL PRESENT IT AS YOUR OWN IDEA, YOU UNDERSTAND?

I UNDERSTAND, MURMURED MUNDUNGUS, HIS EYES WINKING. . . .

WHEN HARRY WAS FLYING ALONGSIDE SNAPE IN A CRUMBLY THROUGH
A

CLEAR DARK NIGHT! HE WAS ACCOMPANIED BY EITHER THREE DEATH EAT-
ERS, AND AHEAD WERE LUPIN AND A HARRY WHO WAS REALLY GEORGE. . . .

A DEATH EATER MOVED AHEAD OF SNAPE AND RAISED HIS WAND, POINTING
IT DIRECTLY AT LUPIN'S BACK

SECTUMSEMPRA! STRUCK SNAPE.

BUT THE SPELL, INTENDED FOR THE DEATH EATER'S WAND HAND, MISSED
AND HIT GEORGE INSTEAD
AND NEXT, SNAPE WAS KNEELING IN SIRIUS'S BEDROOM. TEARS WERE
THE PRINCE'S TALK

XXX

DRIPPING FROM THE END OF HIS FINGERED NOSE AS HE READ THE OLD LETTER
FROM LILY. THE SECOND PAGE CARRIED ONLY A FEW WORDS:
CHILD EVER HAVE BEEN FRIENDS WITH GELLERT GRINDWALD. I THINK
HER MIND IS GOING, PERSONALLY!
LET'S BE LEVE,

SNAPE THREW THE PAGE BEARING LILY'S SIGNATURE, AND HER LEVE, AND
TUCKED IT INSIDE HIS REEKS. THEN HE RIPPED IN TWO THE PHOTOGRAPH
HE

WAS ALSO HOLDING, SEE THAT HE KEPT THE PART FROM WHICH LILY
LAUGHED,

THROWING THE PHOTOGRAPH SHOWING JAMES AND HARRY BACK BENTON THE
FLOOR,

UNDER THE CHEST OF DRAWERS, . . .

AND NOW SNAPE STOOD AGAIN IN THE HEADMASTER'S STUDY AS PHINEAS
NIGELLUS CAME FLYING INTO HIS PORTRAIT.

HEADMASTER! THEY ARE CAMPING IN THE FOREST OF DEATH! THE
MURDERER

DO NOT USE THAT WORD!

THE GRANGER GIRL, THEN, MENTIONED THE PLACE AS SHE OPENED

HER EAG AND I HEARD HER!

GOOD, VERY GOOD! TRIED THE PORTRAIT OF DUMBLEDORE BEHIND THE HEADMASTER'S CHAIR. NOW, SEVERUS, THE SWORD! DO NOT FORGET THAT IT

MUST BE TAKEN UNDER CONDITIONS OF NEED AND VALOR AND HE MUST NOT KNOW THAT YOU GIVE IT! IF VOLDEMORT SHOULD READ HARRY'S MIND

AND SEE YOU ACTING FOR HIM

I KNOW, SAID SNAPE CLUTLY, HE APPROACHED THE PORTRAIT OF DUMBLEDORE AND PULLED AT ITS SIDE. IT SWUNG FORWARD, REVEALING A HIDDEN

CAVITY BEHIND IT FROM WHICH HE TOOK THE SWORD OF GRAYFINDER.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

AND YOU STILL AREN'T GOING TO TELL ME WHY IT'S SO IMPORTANT TO GIVE PETER THE SWORD? SAID SNAPE AS HE SWUNG A TRAVELING CLOAK OVER HIS SHOULDERS.

NO, I DON'T THINK SHE SAID DUMBLEDORE'S PORTRAIT. HE WILL KNOW WHAT TO DO WITH IT. AND SEVERUS, BE VERY CAREFUL, THEY MAY NOT TAKE

KINDLY TO YOUR APPEARANCE AFTER GEORGE WEASLEY'S MISTAKE

SNAPE TURNED AT THE DOOR.

DON'T WORRY, DUMBLEDORE, HE SAID CHEERFULLY. I HAVE A PLAN... AND SNAPE LEFT THE ROOM. HARRY ROSE UP OUT OF THE PENSIVE, AND

MOMENTS LATER HE LAY ON THE CARPETED FLOOR IN EXACTLY THE SAME
POSITION:

SNAPE MIGHT JUST HAVE KILLED THE DEER.

CHAPTER THIRTY - FELLER

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THE FELLEST AGAIN

FINALLY, THE TRUTH. LYING WITH HIS FACE PRESSED INTO THE BLISTY

CARPET OF THE OFFICE WHERE HE HAD SINCE THE LIGHT HE WAS LEARN-
ING THE SECRETS OF VICTORY, HARRY UNDERSTOOD AT LAST THAT HE WAS

NOT SLIPPED THE SURVIVE. HIS LIFE WAS THE WALK CALMLY INTO DEATH &
WELCOMING ARMS. ALONG THE WAY, HE WAS THE DISPOSE OF VERBEMERT &
REMAINING LINDS THE LIFE, SEE THAT WHEN AT LAST HE FELLING HIMSELF
ACROSS

VERBEMERT & PATH, AND DID NOT RAISE A HAND TO DEFEND HIMSELF, THE
END WOULD BE CLEAR, AND THE LIFE THAT LIGHT THE HAVE BEEN DONE
IN GEDRIC & FELLER WOULD BE FINISHED! NEITHER WOULD LIVE, NEITHER
COULD SURVIVE.

HE FELT HIS HEART POUNDING FIRMLY IN HIS CHEST, FELL STRANGE
THAT

IN HIS DREAD OF DEATH, IT PLUMPTED ALL THE HARDER, VALIANTLY KEEPING

HIM ALIVE, BUT IT WOULD HAVE THE STEEP, AND SEEN, ITS BEATS WERE ALM-

BEFORE, HOW MANY WOULD THERE BE TIME FOR, AS HE RISE AND WALKED

THROUGH THE CASTLE FOR THE LAST TIME, HEIT INTO THE GREENS AND
INTO

THE FOREST?

P

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

BY

TERROR WASHED OVER HIM AS HE LAY IN THE FLEET, WITH THAT FLINERAL
DRUM POUNDING INSIDE HIM, WOULD IT HURT THE DIRT? ALL THESE TIMES
HE HAD THOUGHT THAT IT WAS ABOUT TO HAPPEN AND ESCAPED, HE HAD
NEVER REALLY THOUGHT OF THE THING ITSELF! HIS WILL THE LIVE HAD
ALWAYS

BEEN SO MUCH STRONGER THAN HIS FEAR OF DEATH, YET IT DID NOT KILL
THE HIM WHEN THE TRY THE ESCAPE, THE HOLTERIN VERDERMERT, IT WAS OVER,
HE

KNEW IT, AND ALL THAT WAS LEFT WAS THE THING ITSELF: DYING.

IF HE COULD ONLY HAVE DIED IN THAT SLUMBER S NIGHT WHEN HE HAD
LEFT NIMMER FOR, PRIVET DRIVE, FOR THE LAST TIME, WHEN THE NECKLE
PHEENIX-FEATHER WAND HAD SAVED HIM? IF HE COULD ONLY HAVE DIED
LIKE FREDRIC, SHE KNEW HE WOULD NOT HAVE KNOWN IT HAD
HAPPENED?

FOR IF HE COULD HAVE BALANCED HIMSELF IN FRONT OF A WAND THE SAVE
SOMEONE HE LIVED, ... HE ENVIED EVEN HIS PARENTS' DEATHS NOW, THIS
CHILD-BLENDING WAND THE HIS OWN DESTRUCTION WOULD REQUIRE A DIFFERENT

DURING HIS PRAYERS, HE FELT HIS FINGERS TREMBLING SLIGHTLY AND MADE AN EFFORT TO CONTAIN THEM, ALTHOUGH NOW HE COULD SEE HIM; THE PORTRAITS

AND THE WALLS WERE ALL EMPTY.

SLOWLY, VERY SLOWLY, HE SAT UP, AND AS HE DID SO HE FELT MORE ALIVE AND MORE AWARE OF HIS OWN LIVING BODY THAN EVER BEFORE. WHY HAD HE NEVER APPRECIATED WHAT A MIRACLE HE WAS, BRAIN AND NERVE AND BEATING HEART? IT WOULD ALL BE GONE . . . BUT AT LEAST, HE WOULD BE GONE FROM IT. HIS BREATH CAME SLOW AND DEEP, AND HIS MOUTH AND THROAT WERE COMPLETELY DRY, BUT SO WERE HIS EYES.

DUMBLEDORE'S BETRAYAL WAS ALMOST NOTHING. OF COURSE THERE HAD BEEN A BIGGER PLAN; HARRY HAD SIMPLY BEEN TOO FOOLISH TO SEE IT. HE REALIZED THAT NOW, HE HAD NEVER QUESTIONED HIS OWN ASSUMPTION THAT DUMBLEDORE WANTED HIM ALIVE. NOW HE SAW THAT HIS LIFE SPAN HAD ALWAYS BEEN DETERMINED BY HIS BEING IT THEM TO ELIMINATE ALL THE

HERCULES. DUMBLEDORE HAD PASSED THE JOB OF DESTROYING THEM TO

THE FURST AGAIN

THE

HIM, AND IMMEDIATELY HE HAD CONTINUED THE CHIP AWAY AT THE REINS TRYING NOT ONLY TO HOLD HIM, BUT HIMSELF, THE LIFE? THE NEAT, THE ELEGANT,

NOT THE WASTE AND MORE LIVES, BUT THE GIVE THE DANGEROUS TASK THE THE

KNOW WE'VE HAD ALREADY BEEN MARKED FOR SLAUGHTER, AND WE'VE DEATH
WOULD NOT BE A CALAMITY, BUT ANOTHER BLOW AGAINST VERDICT,
AND DUMKEDERE HAD KNOWN THAT FARRY WOULD NOT BLINK EYE,
THAT HE WOULD KEEP GOING TO THE END, EVEN THOUGH IT WAS HIS END,

BECAUSE HE HAD TAKEN TRIABLE TO GET TO KNOW HIM, HADN'T HE?
DUMKED-

HERE KNOW, AS VERDICT KNOW, THAT FARRY WOULD NOT LET ANYTHING
ELSE

DIE FOR HIM WHEN THAT HE HAD DISCOVERED IT WAS IN HIS POWER TO STOP
IT. THE IMAGES OF FRED, LUPIN, AND THOMAS LYING DEAD IN THE GREAT
HALL FORCED THEIR WAY BACK INTO HIS MIND'S EYE, AND FOR A MOMENT
HE COULD HARDLY BREATHE: DEATH WAS IMPATIENT. . . .

BUT DUMKEDERE HAD OVERESTIMATED HIM. HE HAD FAILED: THE
SNAKE SURVIVED. FOR FURTHERMORE REMAINED THE KING VERDICT TO THE
EARTH, EVEN AFTER FARRY HAD BEEN KILLED. TRUE, THAT WOULD MEAN AN
EASIER JOB FOR SOMEONE. HE WONDERED WHY WOULD BE IT. . . . THEN
AND FURTHERMORE WOULD KNOW WHAT NEEDED TO BE DONE, HE COULD. . . .

THAT WOULD HAVE BEEN WHY DUMKEDERE WANTED HIM TO CHARGE IN
TWO OTHERS . . . SEE THAT IF HE FULFILLED HIS TRUE DESTINY A LITTLE EARLY,
THEY COULD CARRY ON. . . .

LIKE RAIN ON A CHILD WINDMILL, THESE THOUGHTS PATTERNED AGAINST THE
HARD SURFACE OF THE INCHANGIBLE TRUTH, WHICH WAS THAT HE
MUST

DIE. I MUST DIE. IT MUST END.

THEN AND FURTHERMORE SEEMED A LONG WAY AWAY, IN A FAR-OFF COUNTRY;
HE FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD PARTED FROM THEM LONG AGO. THERE WOULD

BE NEW CHILD-EYES AND NEW EXPLANATIONS, HE WAS DETERMINED IF THAT,

THIS WAS A JOURNEY THEY COULD NOT TAKE TOGETHER, AND THE
ATTEMPTS

THEY WOULD MAKE THE STEP HIM WOULD WASTE VALUABLE TIME. HE WISHED

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

DOWN AT THE BATTERED CHILD WATCH HE HAD RECEIVED FOR HIS
SEVENTEENTH

BIRTHDAY. NEARLY HALF OF THE FELLOWS ADMITTED BY VERDUGO FOR HIS
SLUR-

RENDER HAD ELAPSED.

HE STOOD UP, HIS HEART WAS LEAPING AGAINST HIS RIBS LIKE A FRANTIC

BIRD, PERHAPS IT KNEW IT HAD LITTLE TIME LEFT, PERHAPS IT WAS DETER-
MINED TO FULFILL A LIFETIME'S BEATS BEFORE THE END. HE DID NOT WISH

BACK AS HE CLOSED THE OFFICE DOOR.

THE CASTLE WAS EMPTY. HE FELT GHOSTLY STRIDING THROUGH IT ALONE,
AS

IF HE HAD ALREADY DIED. THE PORTRAIT PEOPLE WERE STILL MISSING FROM
THEIR FRAMES; THE WHOLE PLACE WAS ERILY STILL, AS IF ALL ITS
REMAINING

LIFELINES WERE CONCENTRATED IN THE GREAT HALL WHERE THE DEAD AND

THE MILLINERS WERE CRAMPED.

HARRY PULLED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK OVER HIMSELF AND DESCENDED THROUGH THE FLUERS, AT LAST WALKING DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE INTO

THE ENTRANCE HALL. PERHAPS SOME TINY PART OF HIM FELT THE HE SENSED,

THE HE SEEN, THE HE STEPPED, BUT THE CLOAK WAS, AS EVER, IMPENETRABLE, PERFECT, AND HE REACHED THE FRONT DOORS EASILY.

THEN NEVILLE NEARLY WALKED INTO HIM. HE WAS ONE HALF OF A PAIR THAT WAS CARRYING A BODY IN FROM THE GREENHOUSES. HARRY GLANCED DOWN

AND FELT ANOTHER BULL BULL THE HIS STOMACH! CECILY CREEPY, THROUGH LINGERAGE, MUST HAVE SNEAKED BACK JUST AS MALTHEY, CRABBE, AND GRYFFINDOR HAD BEEN. HE WAS TINY IN DEATH.

WELL DONE WHAT? I CAN MANAGE HIM ALONE, NEVILLE, SAID FELTHER WOOD, AND HE HEAVED CECILY OVER HIS SHOULDER IN A FIREMAN'S LIFT AND

CARRIED HIM INTO THE GREAT HALL.

NEVILLE LEANED AGAINST THE DOOR FRAME FOR A MOMENT AND WIPED HIS FOREHEAD WITH THE BACK OF HIS HAND. HE LOOKED LIKE AN OLD MAN.

THEN HE SET OFF DOWN THE STEPS AGAIN INTO THE DARKNESS THE RECEIVER

MORE BODIES.

THE FEELING AGAIN

END

HARRY THEN HAD GLANCE BACK AT THE ENTRANCE OF THE GREAT HALL.

PEOPLE WERE MOVING AROUND, TRYING TO COMFORT EACH OTHER,
BRINDING,

KNEELING BESIDE THE DEAD, BUT HE COULD NOT SEE ANY OF THE PEOPLE HE

LOVED, NO HINT OF HERMIONE, RON, GINNY, HER AND OF THE OTHER
WAS-

LEDS, NO LUNA. HE FELT HE WOULD HAVE GIVEN ALL THE TIME REMAINING

TO HIM FOR JUST ONE LAST LOOK AT THEM; BUT THEN, WOULD HE EVER
HAVE

THE STRENGTH TO STOP LOOKING? IT WAS BETTER LIKE THIS.

HE MOVED DOWN THE STEPS AND HELT INTO THE DARKNESS. IT WAS NEARLY
MIDNIGHT IN THE MORNING, AND THE DEATHLY STILLNESS OF THE GRIELANDS FELT
AS

THOUGH THEY WERE HOLDING THEIR BREATH, WAITING TO SEE WHETHER HE
COULD DO WHAT HE MUST.

HARRY MOVED TOWARD NEVILLE, WHO WAS KENDING EVER ANOTHER
BODY,

NEVILLE.

BLIMEY, HARRY, YOU NEARLY GAVE ME HEART FAILURE!

HARRY HAD PULLED OFF THE CHIEF: THE IDEA HAD COME TO HIM HELT
OF NOWHERE, BEING HELT OF A DESIRE TO MAKE ABSOLUTELY SURE.

WHERE ARE YOU GOING, ALONE? NEVILLE ASKED SUSPICIOUSLY.

IT'S ALL PART OF THE PLAN, SAID HARRY. THERE'S SOMETHING I'VE
GOT

TO DO. LISTEN NEVILLE

HARRY? NEVILLE LOOKED SUDDENLY SCARED. HARRY, YOU'RE NOT

THINKING OF HAVING HIMSELF KILLED?

NO, HARRY LIED EASILY. CHURCH NOT ... THIS IS SOMETHING ELSE.
BUT I MIGHT BE HELD UP SLIGHT FOR A WHILE. YOU KNOW VERMOREL'S
SNAKE,

NEVILLE? HE'S GOT A HUGE SNAKE, ... CALLS IT NAGINI ...

I'VE HEARD, YES, ... WHAT ABOUT IT?

IT'S GOT THE BE DRILLED. RON AND HERMION KNOW THAT, BUT JUST IN
CASE THEY

THE AWARENESS OF THAT POSSIBILITY SMOOTHED HIM FOR A MOMENT,

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

MADE IT IMPOSSIBLE TO KEEP TALKING. BUT HE PULLED HIMSELF TOGETHER
AGAIN: THIS WAS CRUCIAL, HE MUST BE LIKE DUMBLEDORE, KEEP A COOL
HEAD, MAKE SURE THERE WERE BACKUPS, EITHER THE LARRY MEN,
DUMBLEDORE

HAD DIED KNOWING THAT THREE PEOPLE STILL KNEW ABOUT THE
SECRET:

NOW NEVILLE WOULD TAKE HARRY'S PLACE: THERE WOULD STILL BE THREE
IN THE SECRET,

JUST IN CASE THEY'RE KIDS AND YOU GET THE CHANCE
KILL THE SNAKE?

KILL THE SNAKE, HARRY REPEATED,

ALL RIGHT, HARRY, YOU'RE HEARD, ARE YOU?

I'M FINE, THANKS, NEVILLE,

BUT NEVILLE SEIZED HIS WRIST AS HARRY MADE THE MOVE TO

WE'RE ALL GOING TO KEEP FIGHTING, HARRY, YOU KNOW THAT?

Yeah, I

THE SUPPLICATING FEELING EXTINGUISHED THE END OF THE SENTENCE; HE COULD NOT GO ON. NEVILLE DID NOT SEEM TO FIND IT STRANGE. HE PATTED HARRY ON THE SHOULDER, RELEASED HIM, AND WALKED AWAY THE LEADER FOR MORE KIDNAPS.

HARRY SWUNG THE LEADER BACK OVER HIMSELF AND WALKED ON. SOMETHING ELSE WAS MOVING NOT FAR AWAY, STEERING OVER ANOTHER PRISON

FIGURE ON THE GROUND. HE WAS FEET AWAY FROM HER WHEN HE REALIZED IT WAS GINNY.

HE STOPPED IN HIS TRACKS. SHE WAS CRAWLING OVER A GIRL WHO WAS WHISPERING FOR HER MOTHER.

IT'S ALL RIGHT, GINNY WAS SAYING. IT'S OKAY. WE'RE GOING TO GET YOU INSIDE.

BUT I WANT TO GO HOME, WHISPERED THE GIRL. I DON'T WANT TO FIGHT ANYMORE?

THE FOREST AGAIN

???

I KNOW, SAID GINNY, AND HER VOICE RANG. IT'S GOING TO BE ALL RIGHT.

RIPPLES OF COLD UNDULATED OVER HARRY'S SKIN. HE WANTED THE SILENT BELT THE THE NIGHT, HE WANTED GINNY TO KNOW THAT HE WAS THERE, HE

WANTED HER THE MOMENT WHERE HE WAS GOING. HE WANTED THE BE STOPPED,
THE BE DRAGGED BACK, THE BE SENT BACK HOME. . . .

BUT HE WAS HOME. FROGLANTS WAS THE FIRST AND BEST HOME HE HAD
KNOWN. HE AND VERMONT AND SNARE, THE ABANDONED KIDS, HAD ALL
GROWN HOME HERE. . . .

GINDY WAS KNEELING BESIDE THE INJURED GIRL NOW, HOLDING HER HAND.
WITH A FLICK EFFORT HARRY FORCED HIMSELF UP. HE THOUGHT HE SAW
GINDY LOOK AROUND AS HE PASSED, AND WONDERED WHETHER SHE HAD
SENSED SOMETHING WALKING NEARBY, BUT HE DID NOT SPEAK, AND HE DID
NOT LOOK BACK.

HARRY'S FEET MOVED OUT OF THE DARKNESS. THERE WERE NO LIGHTS,
NO

FEELING OF FANG SCRATCHING AT THE SKIN, HIS HAND REACHING IN WELCOME.
ALL THESE VISITS THE HARRY, AND THE GLEAM OF THE CHOPPER KETTLE IN
THE

FIRE, AND REDD LACES AND GIANT GRIGS, AND HIS GREAT BEARDED FACE, AND
JOHN WHISTLING SONGS, AND VERMONT HELPING HIM SAVE NINEBERT . . .
HE MOVED ON, AND NOW HE REACHED THE EDGE OF THE FOREST, AND
HE STOPPED.

A SWARM OF DEMONSTERS WAS GLIDING AMONGST THE TREES; HE COULD
FEEL THEIR CHILL, AND HE WAS NOT SURE HE WOULD BE ABLE TO PASS SAFELY
THROUGH IT. HE HAD NO STRENGTH LEFT FOR A PATRONUS. HE COULD NO
LONGER CONTROL HIS OWN TROUBLE. IT WAS NOT, AFTER ALL, SO EASY TO
DIE. EVERY SECOND HE BREATHE, THE SMELL OF THE GRASS, THE COLD AIR
ON HIS FACE, WAS SO PRECIOUS! HE THOUGHT THAT PEOPLE HAD YEARS AND
YEARS, TIME TO WASTE, SO MUCH TIME IT DRAGGED, AND HE WAS CLINGING

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

THE EACH SECOND, AT THE SAME TIME HE THOUGHT THAT HE WOULD NOT BE
ABLE TO GET IN, AND KNEW THAT HE MUST. THE LONG GAME WAS ENDED,
THE SNITCH HAD BEEN CALLED, IT WAS TIME TO LEAVE THE AIR. . . .

THE SNITCH, HIS NERVELESS FINGERS FUMBLING FOR A MOMENT WITH THE
PILCH AT HIS NECK AND HE PULLED IT OUT.

I OPEN AT THE CLOSE.

BREATHING FAST AND HARD, HE STARED DOWN AT IT, KNEW THAT HE WANTED

TIME TO MOVE AS QUICKLY AS POSSIBLE, IT SEEMED TO HAVE SPED UP, AND
LON-

DERSTANDING WAS COMING SO FAST IT SEEMED TO HAVE BYPASSED
THOUGHT.

THIS WAS THE CLOSE, THIS WAS THE MOMENT.

HE PRESSED THE GOLDEN METAL TO HIS LIPS AND WHISPERED, I AM
ABOUT TO DIE.

THE METAL SHELL CRACK OPEN, HE LOWERED HIS SHAKING HAND, RAISED
BRACE S HAND BENEATH THE CHAIR, AND MURMURED, SLIPPER.

THE BLACK STONE WITH ITS JAGGED CRACK RUNNING DOWN THE CENTER
SAT

IN THE TWO HALVES OF THE SNITCH, THE RESURRECTION STONE HAD
CRACKED

BENEATH THE VERTICAL LINE REPRESENTING THE ELDER LAND, THE TRIANGLE
AND

CIRCLE REPRESENTING THE CROWN AND THE STONE WERE STILL DISCERNIBLE,
AND AGAIN HARRY UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT HAVING TO THINK. IT DID NOT
MATTER ABOUT BRINGING THEM BACK, FOR HE WAS ABOUT TO JOIN THEM.
HE

WAS NOT REALLY FETCHING THEM: THEY WERE FETCHING HIM.

HE CLOSED HIS EYES AND TURNED THE STONE OVER IN HIS HAND THREE
TIMES.

HE KNEW IT HAD HAPPENED, BECAUSE HE HEARD SLIGHT MOVEMENTS
AROUND HIM THAT SUGGESTED PAIR KIDIES SHIFTING THEIR POSITION ON
THE

EARTH, TWIG-STRAWN GRASS THAT MARKED THE OUTER EDGE OF THE
FOREST.

HE OPENED HIS EYES AND LOOKED AROUND.

THEY WERE NEITHER GHOST NOR TRULY FLESH, HE COULD SEE THAT. THEY

WERE THE SAME AGAIN

AND

RESEMBLED MOST CLOSELY THE RIDDLE THAT HAD ESCAPED FROM THE DIARY

THE LONG AGO, AND HE HAD BEEN PREVIOUSLY MADE NEARLY SURE, LESS SUB-
STANTIAL THAN LIVING KIDIES, BUT MUCH MORE THAN GHOSTS, THEY
MOVED

THROUGH HIM, AND ON EACH FACE, THERE WAS THE SAME LIVING SMILE.

JAMES WAS EXACTLY THE SAME HEIGHT AS HARRY. HE WAS WEARING THE
CLOTHES IN WHICH HE HAD DIED, AND HIS HAIR WAS UNTOUCHED AND RUFFLED,

AND HIS GLASSES WERE A LITTLE WEDGED, LIKE MR. WEASLEY'S.

SIRILUS WAS TALL AND HANDSOME, AND YELINGER BY FAR THAN HARRY HAD SEEN HIM IN LIFE. HE MOVED WITH AN EASY GRACE, HIS HANDS IN HIS POCKETS AND A GRIN ON HIS FACE.

LUPIN WAS YELINGER THEN, AND MUCH LESS STARKY, AND HIS HAIR WAS THICKER AND DARKER. HE MOVED HAPPY THE HE WAS IN THIS FAMILIAR PLACE, SCENE OF SO MANY ADOLESCENT WANDERINGS.

LILY'S SMILE WAS WIDEST OF ALL. SHE PULSED HER LONG HAIR BACK AS SHE DREW CLOSER TO HIM, AND HER GREEN EYES, SO LIKE HIS, SEARCHED HIS FACE HUNGRILY, AS THOUGH SHE WOULD NEVER BE ABLE TO LOOK AT HIM ENOUGH.

WELL WE BEEN SO CRAVE.

HE COULD NOT SPEAK. HIS EYES FEASTED ON HER, AND HE THOUGHT THAT HE WOULD LIKE TO STAND AND LOOK AT HER FOREVER, AND THAT WOULD BE ENOUGH.

WELL ARE NEARLY THERE, SAID JAMES. VERY CLOSE. WE ARE . . . SO CLOSE TO WELL.

DID IT HURT?

THE CHILDISH QUESTION HAD FALLEN FROM HARRY'S LIPS BEFORE HE COULD

STOP IT.

DYING? NOT AT ALL, SAID SIRILUS. EASIER AND EASIER THAN FALLING ASLEEP.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

AND HE WILL WANT IT THE RE HEELIX, F-HR WANTS IT EYER, SAID LLUPIN,
I DIDN T WANT YELL THE DIZ, F-HARRY SAID, THESE WEHDS CAME WITHHELT
HIS YELLITHEN, AND HF YELL, I M SHERRY
F-HR ADDRESSED LLUPIN MORE THAN AND HF THEM, RESPECTING HIM,

RIGHT AFTER YELL D HAD YELLIR SHEN . . . REMUS, I M SHERRY
I AM SHERRY THEE, SAID LLUPIN, SHERRY I WILL NEVER KNOW HIM . . .
BUT HE WILL KNOW WHY I DIED AND I HOPE HE WILL UNDERSTAND, I WAS
TRYING THE MAKE A WORLD IN WHICH HE COULD LIVE A HAPPIER LIFE,

A CHILLY BREEZE THAT SEEMED THE EMANATE FROM THE HEART OF THE FERR-
EST LIFTED THE HAIR AT F-HARRY S EYEL, F-HR KNOW THAT THEY WOULD NOT
TELL

HIM THE GEE, THAT IT WOULD HAVE THE RE HIS DECISION,

YELL LL STAY WITH ME?

UNTIL THE VERY END, SAID JAMES,

THEY WEN T RE ABLE THE SEE YELL? ASKED F-HARRY,

WE ARE PART OF YELL, SAID SIRIUS, INVISIBLE THE ANYONE ELSE,

F-HARRY LOOKED AT HIS MOTHER,

STAY CLOSE THE ME, HE SAID EULIETLY,

AND HE SET OFF, THE DEMENTHES CHILL DID NOT OVERCOME HIM;

HE PASSED THROUGH IT WITH HIS COMPANIONS, AND THEY ACTED LIKE
PATRONISES THE HIM, AND TOGETHER THEY MARCHED THROUGH THE OLD
TREES THAT GREW CLOSELY TOGETHER, THEIR BRANCHES TANGLED, THEIR
ROOTS

ENARLED AND TWISTED UNDERNEATH, F-HARRY CLUTCHED THE CHAD TIGHTLY

AROUND HIM IN THE DARKNESS, TRAVELING DEEPER AND DEEPER INTO THE
FOREST, WITH NO IDEA WHERE EXACTLY VERDEMERT WAS, BUT SURE THAT
HE WOULD FIND HIM. BESIDE HIM, MAKING SCARCELY A SOUND, WALKED

JAMES, SIRILIS, LUPIN, AND LILY, AND THEIR PRESENCE WAS HIS COM-
FORT, AND THE REASON HE WAS ABLE TO KEEP PUTTING ONE FOOT IN FRONT

OF THE OTHER.

HIS BODY AND MIND FELT HOBBY DISCONNECTED NOW, HIS LIMBS WERE-

THE FOREST AGAIN

THE

ING WITHOUT CONSCIOUS INSTRUCTION, AS IF HE WERE PASSENGER, NOT
DRIVER,

IN THE BODY HE WAS ABLE TO LEAVE. THE DEAD WHO WALKED BESIDE HIM
THROUGH THE FOREST WERE MUCH MORE REAL TO HIM NOW THAN THE
LIVING

BACK AT THE CASTLE: ROSE, HERMINE, GINNY, AND ALL THE OTHERS WERE
THE ONES WHO FELT LIKE GHOSTS AS HE STUMBLER AND SLIPPED TOWARD
THE

END OF HIS LIFE, TOWARD VERDEMERT. . . .

A THUD AND A WHISPER: SOME OTHER LIVING CREATURE HAD STIRRED
CLOSE

BY, HARRY STOPPED UNDER THE CHAIR, PEERING AROUND, LISTENING, AND
HIS MOTHER AND FATHER, LUPIN AND SIRILIS STOPPED TOO.

SOMEONE THERE, CAME A MILD WHISPER CLOSE AT HAND. HE WAS

AN INVISIBILITY CHARM, COULD IT BE ?

TWO FIGURES EMERGED FROM BEHIND A NEARBY TREE: THEIR HANDS

FLARED, AND HARRY SAW YAKLEY AND DEEMHEEY PEERING INTO THE DARK-
NESS, DIRECTLY AT THE PLACE HARRY, HIS MOTHER AND FATHER AND SIRILIS

AND ELIPIN STOOD. APPARENTLY THEY COULD NOT SEE ANYTHING,

DEFINITELY HEARD SOMETHING, SAID YAKLEY. ANIMAL, I WOULD
RECKON?

THAT HEAD CASE HAGRID KEPT A LITTLE KITCHEN STUFF IN HERE, SAID
DEEMHEEY, GLANCING OVER HIS SHOULDER.

YAKLEY LOOKED DOWN AT HIS WATCH.

TIME IS NEARLY UP, BETTER I HAD HIS FEELER, HE IS NOT CHIMING,

AND HE WAS SURE HE WOULD BE WHEN IT BE HAPPY,

BETTER GET BACK, SAID YAKLEY. FIND OUT WHAT THE PLAN IS NOW.

HE AND DEEMHEEY TURNED AND WALKED DEEPER INTO THE FOREST, HARRY
FOLLOWED THEM, KNOWING THAT THEY WOULD LEAD HIM EXACTLY WHERE HE
WANTED THEM. HE GLANCED SIDELWAYS, AND HIS MOTHER SMILED AT HIM,
AND HIS FATHER NEEDED ENCOURAGEMENT.

THEY HAD TRAVELED FOR FEW MINUTES WHEN HARRY SAW LIGHT AHEAD,
AND YAKLEY AND DEEMHEEY STOPPED JUST INTO A CLEARING THAT HARRY

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

THE

KNOW HAD BEEN THE PLACE WHERE THE MENSTRELS DRAGON HAD BEEN

LIVED. THE REMNANTS OF HIS YAST WER WERE THERE STILL, BUT THE SWARM
OF DESCENDANTS HE HAD SPAWNED HAD BEEN DRIVEN HURT BY THE DEATH-
EATERS, THE FIGHT FOR THEIR CAUSE.

A FIRE BURNED IN THE MIDDLE OF THE CLEARING, AND ITS FLICKERING LIGHT
FELL OVER A CIRCLE OF COMPLETELY SILENT, WATCHFUL DEATH-EATERS. SOME
OF THEM WERE STILL MASKED AND HEEDED; OTHERS SHOWED THEIR FACES.

TWO GIANTS SAT ON THE ELTSHIRTS OF THE GRIFF, CASTING MASSIVE
SHAD-

OWS OVER THE SCENE, THEIR FACES COLD, REILIGHT-FLOWN LIKE REED.
HARRY

SAW FENRIR, SLOWING, CHEWING HIS LONG NAILS; THE GREAT BLEND
RHELE

WAS DAKING AT HIS BLEEDING LIP, HE SAW LILILIS MALTHEY, WHO WHINED
DEFEATED AND TERRIFIED, AND NARCISSA, WHOSE EYES WERE SLIDEN AND
FULL OF APPREHENSION.

EVERY EYE WAS FIXED UPON VERDERMERT, WHO STOOD WITH HIS HEAD
BOWED, AND HIS WHITE HANDS HELD OVER THE ELDER WAND IN FRONT OF
HIM. HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN PRAYING, OR ELSE CHINTING SILENTLY IN HIS
MIND, AND HARRY, STANDING STILL ON THE EDGE OF THE SCENE, THOUGHT
ABSURDLY OF A CHILD CHINTING IN A GAME OF HIDE-AND-SEEK. BEHIND
HIS HEAD, STILL SWIRLING AND CHILING, THE GREAT SNAKE NAGINI FLEATED
IN HER GLITTERING, CHARMED CAGE, LIKE A MINSTREL'S FALIE.

WHEN DEHEHEY AND PAXLEY REHINED THE CIRCLE, VERDERMERT
BEEDED LIP.

NO SIGN OF HIM, MY LORD, SAID DEHEHEY.

VERDERMERT'S EXPRESSION DID NOT CHANGE. THE RED EYES SEEMED THE

ELIOT IN THE FIRELIGHT, SILENTLY HE DREW THE ELDER HAND BETWEEN HIS
LONG FINGERS,

MY LORD

BELLATRIX HAD SPOKEN: SHE SAT CLOSEST THE VEILDETHART, DISCOVERED,
HER FACE A LITTLE BLEEDY BUT OTHERWISE UNHARMED,

THE FEELING AGAIN

THE

VEILDETHART RAISED HIS HAND THE SILENCE HER, AND SHE DID NOT SPEAK
ANOTHER WORD, BUT EYES HIM IN DEEPER FASCINATION,

I THOUGHT HE WOULD COME, SAID VEILDETHART IN HIS HIGH, CLEAR
VOICE, HIS EYES ON THE LEAPING FLAMES. I EXPECTED HIM TO COME,
NEEDY SPEAK. THEY SEEMED AS SCARED AS HARRY, WHOSE HEART WAS
NOW THROBING ITSELF AGAINST HIS RIBS AS THOUGH DETERMINED THE
ESCAPE

THE END HE WAS ABLE TO LAST ASIDE, HIS HANDS WERE SWEATING AS HE
PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND STUFFED IT BENEATH HIS ARMS,
WITH HIS HAND, HE DID NOT WANT TO BE TEMPTED THE FIGHT,

I WAS, IT SEEMS . . . MISTAKEN, SAID VEILDETHART,

THEY WERE NOT,

HARRY SAID IT AS BOLDLY AS HE COULD, WITH ALL THE FORCE HE COULD
MUSTER: HE DID NOT WANT TO BE SEEN AFRAID. THE RESURRECTION STONE
SLIPPED FROM BETWEEN HIS LONG FINGERS, AND HE TOOK THE CORNER OF
HIS EYES HE SAW HIS PARENTS, SIRIUS, AND LUPIN VANISH AS HE
STEPPED

FORWARD INTO THE FIRELIGHT. AT THAT MOMENT HE FELT THAT SOMETHING
MAY-

TERED BUT VERDERBERT. IT WAS JUST THE TWO OF THEM.

THE ILLUSION WAS GONE AS SOON AS IT HAD COME. THE GIANTS REARED
AS THE DEATH EATERS RESE TOGETHER, AND THERE WERE MANY CRIES,
GASPS,

EVEN LAUGHTER. VERDERBERT HAD FREEZEN WHERE HE STOOD, BUT HIS RED
EYES HAD FOUND HARRY, AND HE STARED AS HARRY MOVED TOWARD HIM,
WITH NOTHING BUT THE FIRE BETWEEN THEM.

THEN A VOICE YELLED: HARRY! NEE!

HE TURNED: HAGRID WAS BEHIND AND TRAPPED, TIED TO A TREE NEARBY.
HIS MASSIVE BODY STRUCK THE BRANCHES OVERHEAD AS HE STRUGGLED,
DESPERATE.

NEE! NEE! HARRY, WHAT ARE YOU DOING ?

ELIJAH: SILENT RUMBLE, AND WITH A FLICK OF HIS WAND HAGRID
WAS SILENT.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

BELLATRIX, WHO HAD LEAPT TO HER FEET, WAS LOOKING EAGERLY FROM
VER-

DERBERT TO HARRY, HER BREAST HEAVING. THE ONLY THINGS THAT MOVED

WERE THE FLAMES AND THE SNAKE, CHILLING AND UNCHILLING IN THE
GLITTER-

ING LACK BEHIND VERDERBERT'S HEAD,

HARRY COULD FEEL HIS HAND AGAINST HIS CHEST, BUT HE MADE NO AT-
TEMPT TO DRAW IT. HE KNEW THAT THE SNAKE WAS THEN WELL PROTECTED,

KNEW THAT IF HE MANAGED TO POINT THE HAND AT NAGINI, FIFTY CLAWS
WOULD HIT HIM FIRST, AND STILL, VERDERBERT AND HARRY LOOKED AT
EACH

OTHER, AND NOW VERDERBERT TILTED HIS HEAD A LITTLE TO THE SIDE,
CHIN UP-

ERING THE SNAKE STANDING BEFORE HIM, AND A SINGULARLY MIRTHLESS
SMILE

CURLED THE LIPLESS MOUTH.

HARRY BETTER, HE SAID VERY SHORTLY, HIS VEHICLE MIGHT HAVE BEEN
PART OF THE SPITTING FIRE. THE SNAKE WOULD LIVE,

NEVER OF THE DEATH EATERS MOVED, THEY WERE WAITING; EVERYTHING
WAS WAITING, Hagrid was struggling, and Bellatrix was panting,
AND

HARRY THOUGHT INEXPLICABLY OF GINNY, AND HER BLAZING HAIR, AND THE

FEEL OF HER LIPS ON HIS

VERDERBERT HAD RAISED HIS HAND, HIS HEAD WAS STILL TILTED TO THE

SIDE, LIKE A CURIOUS CHILD, WONDERING WHAT WOULD HAPPEN IF HE PRE-

CEDED, HARRY LOOKED BACK INTO THE RED EYES, AND WANTED IT TO HAPPEN NOW, QUICKLY, WHILE HE COULD STILL STAND, BEFORE HE LOST CONTROL,

BEFORE HE BETRAYED FEAR

HE SAW THE MOUTH MOVE AND A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT, AND EVERYTHING WAS GONE.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

THE

DING DRESS

HE LAY FACEDOWN, LISTENING TO THE SILENCE. HE WAS PERFECTLY ALONE. NOBODY WAS WATCHING. NOBODY ELSE WAS THERE.

HE WAS NOT PERFECTLY SURE THAT HE WAS THERE HIMSELF.

A LONG TIME LATER, HE MAYBE NO TIME AT ALL, IT CAME TO HIM THAT HE MUST EXIST, MUST BE MORE THAN DISMEMBERED TWILIGHT, BECAUSE HE WAS LYING, DEFINITELY LYING, ON SOME SURFACE. THEREFORE HE HAD A SENSE OF

THICK, AND THE THING AGAINST WHICH HE LAY EXISTED TOO.

ALMOST AS SOON AS HE HAD REACHED THIS CONCLUSION, HARRY BECAME

CONSCIOUS THAT HE WAS NAKED, CONVINCED AS HE WAS OF HIS TOTAL SHL-

THAT, THIS DID NOT CONCERN HIM, BUT IT DID INTRIGUE HIM SLIGHTLY. HE

WONDERED WHETHER, AS HE COULD FEEL, HE WOULD BE ABLE TO SEE. IN
OPENING THEM, HE DISCOVERED THAT HE HAD EYES.

HE WAS IN A BRIGHT MIST, THOUGH IT WAS NOT LIKE MIST HE HAD
EVER EXPERIENCED BEFORE. HIS SURROUNDINGS WERE NOT HIDDEN BY

THICK VAPOR; RATHER THE THICK VAPOR HAD NOT YET FORMED INTO
SIL-

SHADOWS. THE FLOOR ON WHICH HE LAY SEEMED TO BE WHITE, NEITHER

—

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

WARM NEW CHILD, BUT SIMPLY THERE, A FLAT, BLANK SOMETHING ON WHICH
THEY

HE SAT UP. HIS BODY APPEARED UNSCATHED. HE TOUCHED HIS FACE.

HE WAS NOT WEARING GLASSES ANYMORE.

THEN A NOISE REACHED HIM THROUGH THE UNIFORM NOTHINGNESS
THAT SURROUNDED HIM: THE SMALL SOFT THUMPING OF SOMETHING THAT
FLAPPED, FLAILED, AND STRUGGLED. IT WAS A PITIFUL NOISE, YET ALSO
SLIGHTLY

INDICENT. HE HAD THE UNCOMFORTABLE FEELING THAT HE WAS EYESORE—

PING HEN SOMETHING FLIRTIVE, SHAMEFUL.

FOR THE FIRST TIME, HE WISHED HE WERE CLEVERED.

RARELY HAD THE WISH FORMED IN HIS HEAD THAN REEKS APPEARED A
SHORT DISTANCE AWAY. HE THREW THEM AND PULLED THEM IN: THEY WERE
SOFT, CLEAN, AND WARM. IT WAS EXTRAORDINARY FEEL THEY HAD
APPEARED.

JUST LIKE THAT, THE MOMENT HE HAD WANTED THEM. . . .

HE STOOD UP, LOOKING AROUND. WAS HE IN SOME GREAT ROOM OF
REQUIREMENT? THE LONGER HE LOOKED, THE MORE THERE WAS TO SEE. A

GREAT DOME GLASS ROOF GLITTERED HIGH ABOVE HIM IN SUNLIGHT. PER-
HAPS IT WAS A PALACE. ALL WAS QUIET AND STILL, EXCEPT FOR THESE TWO

THUMPING AND WHIMPERING NOISES COMING FROM SOMEWHERE CLOSE
BY IN THE MIST. . . .

HARRY TURNED SILENTLY IN THE SPOT, AND HIS SURROUNDINGS SEEMED
TO INVENT THEMSELVES BEFORE HIS EYES. A WIDE-OPEN SPACE, BRIGHT AND
CLEAN, A HALL LARGER BY FAR THAN THE GREAT HALL, WITH THAT CLEAR,
DOME GLASS CEILING. IT WAS WHITE EMPTY. HE WAS THE ONLY PERSON
THERE, EXCEPT FOR

HE RECOILED. HE HAD SPOTTED THE THING THAT WAS MAKING THE NOISES.
IT HAD THE FORM OF A SMALL, NAKED CHILD, CRAWLED IN THE GROUND, ITS
SKIN RAW AND REDDISH, FLAYED-LOOKING, AND IT LAY SLIDDERING UNDER A

DINE & DRESS

NOT

SEAT WHERE IT HAD BEEN LEFT, UNWANTED, STUPPED FELT OF SIGHT, STRUG-
GLING FOR BREATH.

HE WAS AFRAID OF IT, SMALL AND FRAGILE AND WHEEDED THOUGH IT WAS,
HE DID NOT WANT TO APPROACH IT, NEVERTHELESS HE DREW SLOWLY
NEARER,

READY TO JUMP BACK AT ANY MOMENT, THEN HE STOOD NEAR ENOUGH TO

THOUGH IT, YET HE COULD NOT BRING HIMSELF TO DO IT, HE FELT LIKE A CHILD-
AND, HE FELT THE COMFORT IT, BUT IT REPLIED HIM,

HE CAN NOT HELP,

HE SPUN AROUND, ALAS DUMBLEDORE WAS WALKING TOWARD HIM,
SPRIGHTLY AND UPRIGHT, WEARING SLEEPING ROBES OF MIDNIGHT BLUE,

HARRY, HE SPREAD HIS ARMS WIDE, AND HIS HANDS WERE BOTH WHITE
AND WHITE AND UNDAUNTED, HE WAS WONDERFUL, HE WAS BRAVE, BRAVE
MAN, LET US WALK,

STUNNED, HARRY FOLLOWED AS DUMBLEDORE STRIDE AWAY FROM WHERE
THE PLAYED CHILD LAY WHIMPERING, LEADING HIM TO THE SEATS THAT
HARRY

HAD NOT PREVIOUSLY NOTICED, SET SOME DISTANCE AWAY UNDER THAT
HIGH,

SPARKLING CEILING, DUMBLEDORE SAT DOWN IN ONE OF THEM, AND HARRY
FELL INTO THE OTHER, STARING AT HIS OLD HEADMASTER'S FACE,
DUMBLEDORE'S

LONG SILVER HAIR AND BEARD, THE PIERCINGLY BLUE EYES BEHIND HALF-
MOON

SPECTACLES, THE CRINKLED NECK: EVERYTHING WAS AS HE HAD REMEMBERED
IT, AND YET...

BUT YOU'RE DEAD, SAID HARRY,

YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE MATTER-OF-FACTLY,

THEN... I'M DEAD THEN?

AH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING STILL MORE BROADLY. THAT IS THE
QUESTIONS, ISN'T IT? EVEN THE WHILE, DEAR BOY, I THINK NOT.

THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, THE OLD MAN STILL BEAMING.

NOT? REPEATED HARRY.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

NOT, SAID DUMBLEDORE.

BUT... HARRY RAISED HIS HAND INSTINCTIVELY TOWARD THE
LIGHTNING

SCAR. IT DID NOT SEEM TO BE THERE. BUT I SHOULD HAVE DIED I DIDN'T
DEFEND MYSELF? I MEANT TO LET HIM KILL ME?

AND THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WILL, I THINK, HAVE MADE ALL THE
DIFFERENCE.

HAPPINESS SEEMED TO RADIATE FROM DUMBLEDORE LIKE LIGHT, LIKE
FIRE: HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN THE MAN SO LITTERLY, SO PALPABLY
CONTENT.

EXPLAIN, SAID HARRY.

BUT YOU ALREADY KNOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HE TWIDDED HIS
THUMBS TOGETHER.

I LET HIM KILL ME, SAID HARRY, DIDN'T I?

YELL'D, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NODDING. CEE HEN?

SEE THE PART OF HIS SELL THAT WAS IN ME ...

DUMBLEDORE NODDED STILL MORE ENTHUSIASTICALLY, WAGGING HARRY
FORWARD, A BROAD SMILE OF ENCOURAGEMENT ON HIS FACE.

... HAS IT GONE?

HE YES! SAID DUMBLEDORE. YES, HE DESTROYED IT, YOUR SELL IS
WEAK, AND COMPLETELY YOUR OWN, HARRY,

BUT THEN ...

HARRY GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER THE WHERE THE SMALL, MAIMED
CREATURE TREMBLED UNDER THE CHAIR.

WHAT IS THAT, PROFESSOR?

SOMETHING THAT IS BEYOND EITHER OF OUR HELP, SAID DUMBLE-
DORE.

BUT IF VERBEMINT USED THE KILLING CURSE, HARRY STARTED AGAIN,
AND NEKKED DIED FOR ME THIS TIME HOW CAN I BE ALIVE?

I THINK YOU KNOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE. THINK BACK, REMEMBER
WHAT HE DID, IN HIS IGNORANCE, IN HIS GREED AND HIS CRUELTY.

DING S CRESS

XXX

HARRY TWELIGHT, HE LET HIS GAZE DRIFT OVER HIS SLIPPERBINDINGS. IF
IT WAS INDEED A PALACE IN WHICH THEY SAT, IT WAS AN HIDE HENK, WITH-

CHAIRS SET IN LITTLE ROWS AND KITS OF RAILING HERE AND THERE, AND STILL,

HE AND DUMBLEDORE AND THE STUNTED CREATURE UNDER THE CHAIR WERE

THE ONLY BEINGS THERE. THEN THE ANSWER RESE THE HIS LIPS EASILY, WITH-

BEST EFFORT,

HE THOUGHT MY BLEED, SAID HARRY,

PRECISELY? SAID DUMBLEDORE, HE THOUGHT YOUR BLEED AND REQUIR

HIS LIVING BODY WITH IT? YOUR BLEED IN HIS VEINS, HARRY, LIKE A
PUNCTURE-

THEN INSIDE BOTH OF YOU? HE TETHERED YOUR THE LIFE WHILE HE LIVES?

I LIVE ... WHILE HE LIVES? BUT I THOUGHT ... I THOUGHT IT WAS THE
EITHER WAY BEHIND? I THOUGHT WE BOTH HAD TO DIE? BUT IS IT THE SAME
THING?

HE WAS DISTRACTED BY THE WHIMPERING AND THUMPING OF THE AGES-
NIZED CREATURE BEHIND THEM AND GLANCED BACK AT IT YET AGAIN,

ARE YOU SURE WE CAN'T DO ANYTHING?

THERE IS NO HELP POSSIBLE.

THEN EXPLAIN ... MORE, SAID HARRY, AND DUMBLEDORE SMILED,

YOU WERE THE SEVENTH FURROW, HARRY, THE FURROW HE NEVER
MEANT TO MAKE, HE HAD RENDERED HIS SELF SO UNSTABLE THAT IT BROKE

APART WHEN HE COMMITTED THESE ACTS OF UNSPEAKABLE EVIL, THE
MURDER

OF YELIA'S PARENTS, THE ATTEMPTED KILLING OF A CHILD, BUT WHAT ESCAPED
FROM THAT DEED WAS EVEN LESS THAN HE KNEL, HE LEFT MORE THAN HIS
BLOOD BEHIND, HE LEFT PART OF HIMSELF LATCHED TO YELIA, THE WOULD-BE
VICTIM WHO HAD SURVIVED,

AND HIS KNOWLEDGE REMAINED WHOLLY INCOMPLETE, HARRY: THAT

WHICH VERDERMERT DEES NOT VALUE, HE TAKES NO TRIABLE THE COMPRE-
HEND, OF FEELER-ELVES AND CHILDREN'S TALES, OF LOVE, LOYALTY, AND IN-
NOCENCE, VERDERMERT KNOWS AND UNDERSTANDS NOTHING, NOTHING,
THAT

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

THEY ALL HAVE A FEELER BEYOND HIS BELLY, A FEELER BEYOND THE REACH
OF

AND MAGIC, IS A TRUTH HE HAS NEVER GRASPED,

HE THOUGHT YELIA BELIEVED BELIEVING IT WOULD STRENGTHEN HIM, HE THOUGHT
INTO HIS BLOOD A TINY PART OF THE ENCHANTMENT YELIA MOTHER LAID
UPON

YELIA WHEN SHE DIED FOR YELIA, HIS BLOOD KEEPS HER SACRIFICE ALIVE, AND
WHILE THAT ENCHANTMENT SURVIVES, SHE SEE YELIA AND SHE DEES
VERDERMERT'S

HIS LAST FEELER FOR HIMSELF,

BLUMLEBERG SMILED AT HARRY, AND HARRY STARED AT HIM,

AND YELL KNEW THIS? YELL KNEW ALL ALONG?

I GUESSED, BUT MY GUESSES HAVE USUALLY BEEN GOOD, SAID DUMBLE-
DORE HAPPILY, AND THEY SAT IN SILENCE FOR WHAT SEEMED LIKE A LONG
TIME,

WHILE THE CREATURE BEHIND THEM CONTINUED THE WHIMPER AND TREMBLE.

THERE'S MORE, SAID HARRY. THERE'S MORE TO IT. WHY DID MY WAND
BREAK THE WAND HE SHRIELED?

AS TO THAT, I CANNOT BE SURE.

HAVE A GUESS, THEN, SAID HARRY, AND DUMBLEDORE LAUGHED.

WHAT YELL MUST UNDERSTAND, HARRY, IS THAT YELL AND LORD VOL-
DEMORT HAVE JOURNEYED TOGETHER INTO REALMS OF MAGIC HITHERTO
UNKNOWN

UNKNOWN AND UNTESTED, BUT HERE IS WHAT I THINK HAPPENED, AND IT IS

UNPRECEDENTED, AND NO WANDMAKER CHILD, I THINK, EVER HAVE PRE-
DICTED IT OR EXPLAINED IT TO THE VOLDEMORT.

WITHOUT MEANING TO, AS YELL NOW KNOWS, LORD VOLDEMORT BELIEVED
THE BOND BETWEEN YELL WHEN HE RETURNED THE A FILIPAN FORM, A PART
OF HIS SELL WAS STILL ATTACHED TO THE YELLERS, AND, THINKING THE
STRENGTHEN

HIMSELF, HE THREW A PART OF YELLER MEET-ER'S SACRIFICE INTO HIMSELF. IF
HE

CHILD ONLY HAVE UNDERSTOOD THE PRECISE AND TERRIBLE POWER OF THAT

SACRIFICE, HE WOULD NOT, PERHAPS, HAVE DARED THE THING YELLER BLEED. . .

BUT THEN, IF HE HAD BEEN ABLE TO UNDERSTAND, HE COULD NOT BE LORD VERDEMENT, AND MIGHT NEVER HAVE MURDERED AT ALL.

DING STREET

911

HAVING ENSURED THIS TWO-FOLD CONNECTION, HAVING WRAPPED YELLER DESTINIES TOGETHER MORE SECURELY THAN EVER THE WIZARDS WERE MIND

IN HISTORY, VERDEMENT PROCEEDED TO ATTACK YELL WITH A WAND THAT

SHARED A CORE WITH YELLER'S, AND WHEN SOMETHING VERY STRANGE HAPPENED, AS WE KNOW, THE CORES REACTED IN A WAY THAT LORD VERDEMENT, WHO NEVER KNEW THAT YELLER WAND WAS TWIN OF HIS, HAD NEVER

EXPECTED.

HE WAS MORE AFRAID THAN YELL WERE THAT NIGHT, HARRY. YELL HAD ACCEPTED, EVEN EMBRACED, THE POSSIBILITY OF DEATH, SOMETHING LORD

VERDEMENT HAS NEVER BEEN ABLE TO DO. YELLER COLLAPSE WHEN YELLER WAND EVERPOWERED HIS, AND IN DOING SO, SOMETHING HAPPENED BETWEEN

THESE WANDS, SOMETHING THAT REINED THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THEIR MASTERS.

I BELIEVE THAT YELIA WAND IMBIBED SOME OF THE POWER AND ALIANTIES OF VERDEMERT'S WAND THAT NIGHT, WHICH IS THE SAY THAT IT CONTAINED

A LITTLE OF VERDEMERT HIMSELF. SHE YELIA WAND RECOGNIZED HIM WHEN HE PURSUED YELI, RECOGNIZED A MAN WHO WAS BOTH DIN AND MENTAL ENEMY, AND IT RECALCITATED SOME OF HIS OWN MAGIC AGAINST HIM, MAGIC MUCH MORE POWERFUL THAN ANYTHING LUCILIS'S WAND HAD EVER PERFORMED. YELIA WAND NOW CONTAINED THE POWER OF YELIA ENTHRONE'S

COURAGE AND OF VERDEMERT'S OWN DEADLY SKILL: WHAT CHANCE DID THAT POWER STICK OF LUCILIS MALTHE'S STAND?

BUT IF MY WAND WAS SHE POWERFUL, HOW COME FERMINE WAS ABLE TO BREAK IT? ASKED FARRY.

MY DEAR KEY, ITS REMARKABLE EFFECTS WERE DIRECTED ONLY AT VERDEMERT, WHO HAD TAMPERED SHE ILL-ADVISEDLY WITH THE DEEPEST LAWS

OF MAGIC. ONLY TOWARD HIM WAS THAT WAND ABNORMALLY POWERFUL. OTHERWISE IT WAS A WAND LIKE ANY OTHER . . . THOUGH A CHILD HERE, I AM SURE. DUMKEDERE FINISHED KINDLY.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

HARRY SAT IN THE LIGHT FOR A LONG TIME, FOR PERHAPS SECONDS. IT WAS VERY HARD TO BE SURE OF THINGS LIKE TIME, HERE.

HE KILLED ME WITH YOUR WAND.

HE FAILED TO KILL YOU WITH MY WAND. DUMBLEDORE CORRECTED HARRY. I THINK WE CAN AGREE THAT YOU ARE NOT DEAD THOUGH, OF COURSE, HE ADDED, AS IF FEARING HE HAD BEEN MISUNDERSTOOD, I DO NOT MINIMIZE YOUR SUFFERINGS, WHICH I AM SURE WERE SEVERE.

I FEEL GREAT AT THE MOMENT, THOUGH, SAID HARRY, LOOKING DOWN AT HIS CLEAN, UNBLESSED HANDS. WHERE ARE WE, EXACTLY?

WELL, I WAS GOING TO ASK YOU THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, LOOKING AROUND. WHERE WOULD YOU SAY THAT WE ARE?

UNTIL DUMBLEDORE HAD ASKED, HARRY HAD NOT KNOWN. NOW, HOWEVER, HE FELT THAT HE HAD AN ANSWER READY TO GIVE.

IT LOOKS, HE SAID SLEELY, LIKE KING'S CROSS STATION, EXCEPT A LITTLE CLEANER AND EMPTY, AND THERE ARE NO TRAINS AS FAR AS I CAN SEE.

KING'S CROSS STATION? DUMBLEDORE WAS CHUCKLING IMPUDENTLY. GOOD GRACEFULS, REALLY?

WELL, WHERE DO YOU THINK WE ARE? ASKED HARRY, A LITTLE DEFENSIVELY.

MY DEAR BOY, I HAVE NO IDEA. THIS IS, AS THEY SAY, YOUR PARTY.

“HARRY HAD NO IDEA WHAT THIS MEANT; DUMKLEBREE WAS BEING INFLU-
ENCING, HE GLARED AT HIM, THEN REMEMBERED A MUCH MORE PRESSING

QUESTIONS THAN THAT OF THEIR CURRENT LOCATION.

“THE DEATHLY EMBLEMS, HE SAID, AND HE WAS GLAD TO SEE THAT THE
WORDS WIPED THE SMILE FROM DUMKLEBREE’S FACE.

“AH, YES, HE SAID, HE EVEN LOOKED A LITTLE WORRIED.

“WELL?

“FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE HARRY HAD MET DUMKLEBREE, HE LOOKED

DOWNSTRESS

“HE

LESS THAN AN OLD MAN, MUCH LESS, HE LOOKED FLEETINGLY LIKE A SMALL
BOY CALLED IN WINDING.

“CAN YOU FORGIVE ME? HE SAID, CAN YOU FORGIVE ME FOR NOT TRUST-
ING YOU? FOR NOT TELLING YOU? HARRY, I ONLY FEARED THAT YOU
WOULD FAIL

“AS I HAD FAILED, I ONLY DREADED THAT YOU WOULD MAKE MY MISTAKES.
I CRAVE YOUR PARDON, HARRY, I HAVE KNOWN, FOR SOME TIME NOW,
THAT

“YOU ARE THE BETTER MAN,

“WHAT ARE YOU TALKING ABOUT? ASKED HARRY, STARTLED BY DUMKLE-

HERE S THERE, BY THE SUDDEN TEARS IN HIS EYES.

THE FALLENS, THE FALLENS, MURMURED OLMKEDEHE. A DESPER-
ATE MAN S DREAM?

BUT THEY RE REAL?

REAL, AND DANGEROUS, AND A LURE FOR FEELS, SAID OLMKEDEHE.

AND I WAS SUCH A FEEL, BUT YOU KNOW, DONT YOU? I HAVE NO
SECRETS

FROM YOU ANYMORE, YOU KNOW.

WHAT DO I KNOW?

OLMKEDEHE TURNED HIS WHITE RIND THE FACE FARRY, AND TEARS STILL
SPARKLED IN THE BRILLIANTLY BLUE EYES.

MASTER OF DEATH, FARRY, MASTER OF DEATH? WAS I BETTER, ULTI-
MATELY, THAN VILDEMENT?

OF COURSE YOU WERE, SAID FARRY. OF COURSE HOW CAN YOU
ASK THAT? YOU NEVER KILLED IF YOU COULD AVOID IT?

TRUE, TRUE, SAID OLMKEDEHE, AND HE WAS LIKE A CHILD SEEKING
REASSURANCE. YET I THEE SIGHT A WAY THE CHEVNIER DEATH, FARRY.

NOT THE WAY HE DID, SAID FARRY, AFTER ALL HIS ANGER AT OLMKE-
DEHE, HOW HAD IT WAS THE SIT HERE, BENEATH THE HIGH, VAULTED CEILING,

AND DEFEND OLMKEDEHE FROM HIMSELF, FALLENS, NOT FERRICKES,

FALLENS, MURMURED OLMKEDEHE, NOT FERRICKES, PRECISELY.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

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THERE WAS A PALSE. THE CREATURE BEHIND THEM WHIMPERED, BUT HARRY NEITHER WHINED NOR ARIELING.

GRINDLEWALD WAS WHISKING AROUND THEM THEN? HE ASKED. DUMBLEDORE CLOSED HIS EYES FOR A MOMENT AND NODDED.

IT WAS THE THING, ABOVE ALL, THAT DREW US TOGETHER, HE SAID BRIEFLY.

TWO CLEVER, ARROGANT BOYS WITH A SHARED OBSESSION. HE WANTED TO RECREATE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS, AS I AM SURE YOU HAVE GUESSED, BECAUSE OF THE GRAVE OF IGNATIUS PEVERELL. HE WANTED TO EXPLORE THE PLACE THE THIRD BROTHER HAD DIED.

IS IT TRUE? ASKED HARRY. ALL OF IT? THE PEVERELL BROTHERS

WERE THE THREE BROTHERS OF THE TALE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NOTHING. YES, I THINK SEE, WHETHER THEY MET DEATH IN A MERE

REAR ... I THINK IT MORE LIKELY THAT THE PEVERELL BROTHERS WERE SIMPLY

GIFTED, DANGEROUS WIZARDS WHO SUCCEEDED IN CREATING THESE PERMANENT MONSTERS. THE STORY OF THEM BEING DEATH'S OWN FALLENS SEEMS

THE ME THE SHIRT OF LEGEND THAT MIGHT HAVE SPRUNG UP AROUND SUCH
CREATIONS.

THE CLOAK, AS YELL DREW NEAR, TRAVELED DOWN THROUGH THE AGES,

FATHER THE SON, MOTHER THE DAUGHTER, RIGHT DOWN THE IGNEITUS'S LAST
LIV-

ING DESCENDANT, WHO WAS BORN, AS IGNEITUS WAS, IN THE VILLAGE OF

CHORIC & HILLMAN.

DUMKLEBERG SMILED AT HARRY.

MR?

YELL, YOU HAVE GUESSED, I KNOW, WHY THE CLOAK WAS IN MY POSSES-
SION ON THE NIGHT YOUR PARENTS DIED. JAMES HAD STOLEN IT THE ME
JUST

A FEW DAYS PREVIOUSLY, IT EXPLAINED MUCH OF HIS UNDETECTED WRENG-
ING AT SCHEER! I COULD HARDLY BELIEVE WHAT I WAS SEEING. I ASKED

THE BROTHERS IT, THE EXAMINE IT. I HAD LONG SINCE GIVEN UP MY DREAM OF
UNITING THE FAMILIES, BUT I COULD NOT RESIST, COULD NOT HELP TAKING
A

DING & CRESS

ALL

CLOSER LOOKS, . . . IT WAS A CLOAK THE LIKE OF WHICH I HAD NEVER SEEN,

IMMENSELY OLD, PERFECT IN EVERY RESPECT . . . AND THEN YOUR FATHER
DIED, AND I HAD TWO FALLS AT LAST, ALL THE MYSELF.
HIS TONE WAS LINEARLY BITTER.

THE CHAD WOULDNT HAVE HELPED THEM SURVIVE, THOUGH, HARRY
SAID BLINDLY. VERMONT KNEW WHERE MY MOM AND DAD WERE, THE
CHAD CHLDN T HAVE MADE THEM CLUSE-PROOF.

TRUE, SIGHED DUMBLEDORE. TRUE.
HARRY WAITED, BUT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT SPEAK, SO HE PROMPTED
HIM.

DO YOU D GIVEN UP LOOKING FOR THE FALLS WHEN YOU SAW THE
CHAD?

HE YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE FAINTLY. IT SEEMED THAT HE FORCED HIM-
SELF TO MEET HARRY S EYES. YOU KNOW WHAT HAPPENED, YOU KNOW.

YOU CANNOT DESPISE ME MORE THAN I DESPISE MYSELF.

BUT I DONT DESPISE YOU

THEN YOU SHOULD, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HE DREW A DEEP BREATH.

YOU KNOW THE SECRET OF MY SISTER S ILL HEALTH, WHAT THESE
MURKERS

DID, WHAT SHE BECAME, YOU KNOW HOW MY POOR FATHER SOUGHT RE-
VENGE, AND PAID THE PRICE, DIED IN AZKABAN, YOU KNOW HOW MY

MOTHER CAME UP HER OWN LIFE TO CARE FOR ARIANA.

I RESENTED IT, HARRY.

DUMBLEDORE STATED IT CALDLY, CHLDLY, HE WAS LOOKING NEARLY OVER THE

THEO HE HARRY S HEAD, INTO THE DISTANCE.

I WAS GIFTED, I WAS BRILLIANT, I WANTED THE ESCAPE, I WANTED THE
SHINE, I WANTED GLORY.

HE NOT MISUNDERSTAND ME, HE SAID, AND PAIN CROSSED THE FACE
SEE THAT HE WISHED ANKENT AGAIN. I LOVED THEM, I LOVED MY PARENTS,
I LOVED MY BROTHER AND MY SISTER, BUT I WAS SELFISH, HARRY, MORE

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

SELFISH THAN YELL, WHEN ARE A REMARKABLY SELFLESS PERSON, COULD POSS-
IBLY IMAGINE.

SEE THAT, WHEN MY BROTHER DIED, AND I WAS LEFT THE RESPONSIBILITY
OF A DAMAGED SISTER AND A WAYWARD BROTHER, I RETURNED TO MY
VILLAGE

IN ANGER AND BITTERNESS. TRAPPED AND LOST, I TRIUMPHED! AND THEN,
HE CHURCH, HE CAME. . . .

GRINDLEWALD WISHED DIRECTLY INTO HARRY S EYES AGAIN.

GRINDLEWALD, WHO CANNOT IMAGINE HOW HIS IDEAS CALLED ME,
HARRY, INFLAMED ME. MUGGLES PERCEIVED INTO SUBSERVIENT, WE WIZARDS
TRIUMPHANT, GRINDLEWALD AND I, THE GLORIOUS YOUNG LEADERS OF THE
REVOLUTION.

HE, I HAD A FEW STRUGGLES, I ASSUAGED MY CONSCIENCE WITH EMPTY
WORDS, IT WOULD ALL BE FOR THE GREATER GOOD, AND ANY HARM DONE
WOULD BE REPAYED A HUNDREDFOLD IN BENEFITS FOR WIZARDS, DID I KNOW,

IN MY HEART OF HEARTS, WHAT GELLERT GRINDELWALD WAS? I THINK I DID,
BUT I CLOSED MY EYES. IF THE PLANS WE WERE MAKING CAME TO FRUITION,
ALL MY DREAMS WOULD COME TRUE.

AND AT THE HEART OF HIS SCHEMES, THE DEATHLY EMBLEMS: EVEN
THEY FASCINATED HIM, EVEN THEY FASCINATED BOTH OF US. THE
UNBREAKABLE

WAND, THE WEAPON THAT WOULD LEAD US TO POWER. THE RESURRECTION
STONE. THE HIM, THOUGH I PRETENDED NOT TO KNOW IT, IT MEANT AN
ARMY OF DEATH. THE ME, I CONFESS, IT MEANT THE RETURN OF MY
PARENTS,

AND THE LIFTING OF ALL RESPONSIBILITY FROM MY SHOULDERS.

AND THE CLOAK . . . SURELY, WE NEVER DISCUSSED THE CLOAK MUCH,
HARRY. BOTH OF US COULD CONCEAL OURSELVES WELL ENOUGH WITHOUT THE
THE

CLOAK, THE TRUE MAGIC OF WHICH, OF COURSE, IS THAT IT CAN BE USED TO
PROTECT AND SHIELD OTHERS AS WELL AS ITS OWNER. I THOUGHT THAT, IF
WE

EVER FELT IT, IT MIGHT BE USEFUL IN HIDING ARIANA, BUT HIS
INTEREST

IN THE CLOAK WAS MAINLY THAT IT COMPLETED THE TRIUMPH, FOR THE LEGEND

OF THE THREE

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SAID THAT THE MAN WHO UNITED ALL THREE MARKS WOULD THEN BE TRULY
MASTER OF DEATH, WHICH WAS THE MEAN INVINCIBLE.

INVINCIBLE MASTERS OF DEATH, GRINDELWALD AND DUMBLEDORE?

TWO MONTHS OF INSANITY, OF CRAZY DREAMS, AND NEGLECT OF THE ONLY
TWO MEMBERS OF MY FAMILY LEFT THE ME.

AND THEN . . . WELL KNEW WHAT HAPPENED, REALITY RETURNED IN
THE FORM OF MY BRIGHT, UNLETTERED, AND INFINITELY MORE ADMIRABLE
BROTHER, I DID NOT WANT TO HEAR THE TRUTHS HE SPELLED AT ME, I DID
NOT WANT TO HEAR THAT I COULD NOT SET FORTH THE SEED FALLEES WITH
A

FRAGILE AND UNSTABLE SISTER IN THEM.

THE ARGUMENT BECAME A FIGHT, GRINDWALD LOST CONTROL, THAT
WHICH I HAD ALWAYS SENSED IN HIM, THOUGH I PRETENDED NOT TO, NOW
SPRANG INTO TERRIBLE KING, AND ARIANA . . . AFTER ALL MY BROTHER'S
CARE

AND CALITHEN . . . LAY DEAD UPON THE FLOOR.

BLINKEDHEE GAVE A LITTLE GASP AND BEGAN TO CRY IN EARNEST, HARRY
REACHED OUT AND WAS GLAD TO FIND THAT HE COULD TOUCH HIM; HE
GRIPPED

HIS ARM TIGHTLY AND BLINKEDHEE GRADUALLY REGAINED CONTROL.

WELL, GRINDWALD FLED, AS ANYONE KNEW I COULD HAVE PREDICTED,
HE VANISHED, WITH HIS PLANS FOR SEIZING POWER, AND HIS SCHEMES FOR
MUGGLE THIRTY, AND HIS DREAMS OF THE DEATHLY FALLEES, DREAMS IN
WHICH I HAD ENCOURAGED HIM AND HELPED HIM, HE RAN, WHILE I WAS
LEFT TO KISS MY SISTER, AND LEARN TO LIVE WITH MY GUILT AND MY
TERRIBLE

GRIEF, THE PRICE OF MY SHAME.

YEARS PASSED, THERE WERE RUMORS ABOUT HIM, THEY SAID HE HAD
ACQUIRED A LAND OF IMMENSE POWER, I, MEANWHILE, WAS OFFERED THE
POST OF MINISTER OF MAGIC, NOT ONCE, BUT SEVERAL TIMES, NATURALLY,
I

REFUSED, I HAD LEARNED THAT I WAS NOT THE BEST TRUSTED WITH POWER.

BUT THEY'D HAVE BEEN BETTER, MUCH BETTER, THAN FUDGE OR SCRIMP-
GHEUR! FIRST MET HARRY.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

WHEN I ASKED DUMBLEDORE HEAVILY, I AM NOT SURE, I HAD
PROVEN, AS A VERY YOUNG MAN, THAT POWER WAS MY WEAKNESS AND MY
TEMPTATION. IT IS A CURIOUS THING, HARRY, BUT PERHAPS THESE WHO
ARE BEST SUITED TO POWER ARE THOSE WHO HAVE NEVER SEEN IT,
THESE

WHO, LIKE YOU, HAVE LEADERSHIP INSTILLED UPON THEM, AND TAKE UP THE
MANTLE BECAUSE THEY MUST, AND FIND THE THEIR OWN SURPRISE THAT
THEY

WEAR IT WELL.

I WAS SAFER AT HOGWARTS, I THINK I WAS A GOOD TEACHER

THEY WERE THE BEST

THEY ARE VERY KIND, HARRY, BUT WHILE I BUSIED MYSELF WITH
THE TRAINING OF YOUNG WIZARDS, GRINDWALD WAS RAISING AN ARMY.
THEY SAY HE FEARED ME, AND PERHAPS HE DID, BUT LESS, I THINK, THAN I
FEARED HIM.

HE, NOT DEATH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, IN ANSWER TO HARRY'S HESIT-
TATING WORDS. NOT WHAT HE COULD DO TO ME MAGICALLY, I KNEW THAT

WE WERE EVENLY MATCHED, PERHAPS THAT I WAS A SHADE MORE SKILLFUL.
IT WAS THE TRUTH I FEARED. YELL SEE, I NEVER KNEW WHICH HE WAS, IN
THAT

LAST, TERRIFIC FIGHT, HAD ACTUALLY LOST THE CLUSE THAT KILLED MY
SISTER.

YELL MAY CALL ME CHELARDLY: YELL WOULD BE RIGHT. HARRY, I DREADED
REVEALING ALL THINGS THE KNOWLEDGE THAT IT HAD BEEN I WHO KNEIGHT
KILLED HER DEATH, NOT MERELY THROUGH MY ARROGANCE AND STUPIDITY,
BUT THAT I ACTUALLY STRUCK THE BLOW THAT SNIPPED HER LIFE.

I THINK HE KNEW IT, I THINK HE KNEW WHAT FRIGHTENED ME. I DE-
LAYED MEETING HIM UNTIL FINALLY, IT WOULD HAVE BEEN THE SHAMEFUL

THE RESIST AND HINDER, PEOPLE WERE DYING AND HE SEEMED
UNSTOPPABLE,

AND I HAD TO SEE WHAT I COULD,

WELL, YELL KNEW WHAT HAPPENED NEXT, I WHEN THE DUEL, I WHEN THE
WAND,

DURING S CRIES

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ANOTHER SILENCE, HARRY DID NOT ASK WHETHER DUMBLEDORE HAD
EVER FEELING HER WHO STRUCK ARIANA DEAD, HE DID NOT WANT TO KNOW,
AND EVEN LESS DID HE WANT DUMBLEDORE TO HAVE TO TELL HIM. AT LAST
HE KNEW WHAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE SEEN WHEN HE WALKED IN THE

MIRROR HE TRIED, AND WHY DUMBLEDORE HAD BEEN SHE UNDERSTANDING
OF THE FASCINATION IT HAD EXERCISED OVER HARRY.

THEY SAT IN SILENCE FOR A LONG TIME, AND THE WHIMPERING OF THE
CREATURE BEHIND THEM BARELY DISTURBED HARRY ANYMORE.

AT LAST HE SAID, GRINDLEWALD TRIED THE STEEP VEILMENT GOING AFTER
THE WAND, HE LIED, HE'D KNOWN, PRETENDED HE HAD NEVER HAD IT.

DUMBLEDORE NODDED, LEANING BACK AT HIS LAP, TEARS STILL GLITTER-
ING IN THE CREASED NECK.

THEY SAY HE SHOWED REMORSE IN LATER YEARS, ALONE IN HIS CELL AT
AZKABAN. I HOPE THAT IT IS TRUE, I WOULD LIKE TO THINK HE DID
FEEL

THE HORROR AND SHAME OF WHAT HE HAD DONE, PERHAPS THAT LIKE THE
VEIL-

MENT WAS HIS ATTEMPT TO MAKE AMENDS . . . TO PREVENT VEILMENT

FROM TAKING THE FALLS . . .

. . . HER MOTHER FROM BREAKING INTO THEIR TOWER? SUGGESTED HARRY,
AND DUMBLEDORE BARKED HIS EYES.

AFTER ANOTHER SHORT PAUSE HARRY SAID, HE'D TRIED THE LIKE THE RES-
URRECTION STONE.

DUMBLEDORE NODDED.

WHEN I DISCOVERED IT, AFTER ALL THESE YEARS, CLIMBED IN THE ARAN-
DINED HOLE OF THE GALINTS THE FALLING I HAD CRAVED MOST OF ALL,

THOUGH IN MY YOUTH I HAD WANTED IT FOR VERY DIFFERENT REASONS
I

HEAT MY HEAD, HARRY, I BLITHE FORGET THAT IT WAS NEAR A FIERCELY,
THAT

THE RING WAS SLIKE THE CARRY A CLUSE, I PICKED IT UP, AND I PUT IT ON,
AND FOR A SECOND I IMAGINED THAT I WAS ABOUT TO SEE ARIANA, AND

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

THE

MY MOTHER, AND MY FATHER, AND THE TELL THEM HOW VERY, VERY SORRY I
WAS. . .

I WAS SUCH A FOOL, HARRY, AFTER ALL THESE YEARS I HAD LEARNED
NOTHING

ING, I WAS UNWORTHY TO WRITE THE DEATHLY FALLS, I HAD PROVED IT

TIME AND AGAIN, AND HERE WAS FINAL PROOF.

WHY? SAID HARRY, IT WAS NATURAL! YOU WANTED TO SEE THEM
AGAIN, WHAT'S WRONG WITH THAT?

MAYBE A MAN IN A MILLION COULD WRITE THE FALLS, HARRY, I
WAS FIT ONLY TO POSSESS THE MEANEST OF THEM, THE LEAST
EXTRAORDINARY.

I WAS FIT TO BEYOND THE ELDER WARD, AND NOT THE BEST OF IT, AND NOT THE

KILL WITH IT, I WAS PERMITTED THE TAME AND THE WISE IT, BECAUSE I THREW
IT,

NIGHT FOR GAIN, BUT THE SAVE OTHERS FROM IT,

BUT THE CLASH, I THREW BUT MY VAIN CURIOSITY, AND SEE IT COULD NEVER
HAVE WORKED FOR ME AS IT WORKS FOR YOU, ITS TRUE POWER, THE
STRENGTH I

WOULD HAVE USED IN AN ATTEMPT THE DRAG BACK THESE WHEELS ARE AT
PEACE,

RATHER THAN THE ENABLE MY SELF-SACRIFICE, AS YOU DID, YOU ARE THE
WORTHY

POSSESSOR OF THE FALLOWS,

OLIVERED PATTED HARRY'S HAND, AND HARRY WHEEZED UP AT THE OLD
MAN AND SMILED; HE COULD NOT HELP HIMSELF, HOW COULD HE REMAIN
ANGRY WITH OLIVERED NOW?

WHY DID YOU HAVE TO MAKE IT SO DIFFICULT?

OLIVERED'S SMILE WAS TREMBLING,

I AM AFRAID I CHLINTED MY MISS GRANGER THE SAME YOU UP, HARRY,
I WAS AFRAID THAT YOUR FEET HEAD MIGHT DOMINATE YOUR GOOD HEART,
I WAS SCARED THAT, IF PRESENTED HLITRIGHT WITH THE FACTS ABOUT THESE
TEMPTING WHEELS, YOU MIGHT SEIZE THE FALLOWS AS I DID, AT THE
WRONG

TIME, FOR THE WRONG REASONS, IF YOU LAID HANDS ON THEM, I WANTED
YOU

THE POSSESS THEM SAFELY, YOU ARE THE TRUE MASTER OF DEATH, BECAUSE
THE

TRUE MASTER DEES NOT SEEK THE RUN AWAY FROM DEATH, HE ACCEPTS
THAT

DING'S CROSS

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HE MUST DIE, AND UNDERSTANDS THAT THERE ARE FAR, FAR WORSER THINGS
IN

THE LIVING WORLD THAN DYING.

AND VEHEMENT NEVER KNEW ABOUT THE FALLEN?

I DO NOT THINK SHE, BECAUSE HE DID NOT RECOGNIZE THE RESURRECTION
STONE HE TURNED INTO A FIERCELY, BUT EVEN IF HE HAD KNOWN ABOUT

THEM, HARRY, I DOUBT THAT HE WOULD HAVE BEEN INTERESTED IN ANY EX-
CEPT THE FIRST. HE WOULD NOT THINK THAT HE NEEDED THE CLASH, AND AS

FOR THE STONE, WHY WOULD HE WANT TO BRING BACK FROM THE DEAD?
HE FEARS THE DEAD, HE DOES NOT LIVE.

BUT WHY EXPECTED HIM TO GO AFTER THE WAND?

I HAVE BEEN SURE THAT HE WOULD TRY, EVER SINCE PHILIP WAND BEAT
VEHEMENT IN THE GRAVEYARD OF LITTLE FANGLETHEN. AT FIRST, HE
WAS

AFRAID THAT PHILIP HAD OVERPOWERED HIM BY SUPERIOR SKILL. SINCE HE HAD
KIDNAPPED HILYARDER, HOWEVER, HE DISCOVERED THE EXISTENCE OF THE
TWIN CHIEFS. HE THOUGHT THAT EXPLAINED EVERYTHING. YET THE
REVEALED

WAND DID NOT BETTER AGAINST PHILIP? SEE VEHEMENT, INSTEAD OF ASKING
HIMSELF WHAT QUALITY IT WAS IN PHILIP THAT HAD MADE PHILIP WAND SEE
STRONG, WHAT GIFT PHILIP POSSESSED THAT HE DID NOT, NATURALLY SET HIM
TO

FIND THE ONE WAND THAT, THEY SAID, WOULD BEAT ANY OTHER, FOR HIM,

THE ELDER WAND HAS BECOME AN HERESITHEN THE RIVAL HIS HERESITHEN
WITH

YELL, HE BELIEVES THAT THE ELDER WAND REMOVES HIS LAST WEAKNESS
AND

MAKES HIM TRULY INVINCIBLE. PETER SEVERUS ...

IF YELL PLANNED YELL'S DEATH WITH SNAPE, YELL MEANT HIM THE END
OF THE ELDER WAND, DIDN'T YELL?

I ADMIT THAT WAS MY INTENTION, SAID DUMBLEDORE, BUT IT DID
NOT WORK AS I INTENDED, DID IT?

NO, SAID HARRY, THAT IT DIDN'T WORK OUT.

THE CREATURE BEHIND THEM HISSED AND MEANED, AND HARRY AND
DUMBLEDORE SAT WITHOUT TALKING FOR THE LONGEST TIME YET. THE

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

REALIZATION OF WHAT WOULD HAPPEN NEXT SETTLED GRADUALLY OVER
HARRY

IN THE LONG MINUTES, LIKE SILENTLY FALLING SNOW.

I'VE GOT THE GO BACK, HAVEN'T I?

THAT IS UP THE YELL.

I'VE GOT A CHOICE?

YES, DUMBLEDORE SMILED AT HIM. WE ARE IN KING'S CROSS,
YELL SAID? I THINK THAT IF YELL DECIDED NOT TO GO BACK, YELL WOULD BE
ABLE TO ... LET'S SAY ... HEARD A TRAIN.

AND WHERE WOULD IT TAKE ME?

NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE SIMPLY.

SILENCE AGAIN.

VEHEMENTLY I GET THE ELDER LORD.

TRUE, VEHEMENTLY HAS THE ELDER LORD.

BUT THEY WANT ME TO GO BACK?

I THINK, SAID DUMBLEDORE, THAT IF THEY CHOOSE TO RETURN, THERE IS A CHANCE THAT HE MAY BE FINISHED FOR GOOD. I CANNOT PROMISE IT.

BUT I KNOW THIS, HARRY, THAT THEY HAVE LESS THE FEAR FROM RETURNING

HERE THAN HE DOES.

HARRY GLANCED AGAIN AT THE RAW-LOOKING THING THAT TREMBLED AND CRAWLED IN THE SHADOWS BENEATH THE DISTANT CHAIR.

DO NOT PITY THE DEAD, HARRY, PITY THE LIVING, AND, ABOVE ALL, THOSE WHO LIVE WITHOUT LOVE. BY RETURNING, THEY MAY ENSURE THAT FEWER SIBLINGS

ARE MAIMED, FEWER FAMILIES ARE TORN APART. IF THAT SEEMS TO THEM A WORTHY DEAL, THEN WE SAY GOOD-BYE FOR THE PRESENT.

HARRY NODDED AND SIGHED. LEAVING THIS PLACE WOULD NOT BE NEARLY AS HARD AS WALKING INTO THE FOREST HAD BEEN, BUT IT WAS WARM AND LIGHT

AND PEACEFUL HERE, AND HE KNEW THAT HE WAS LEAVING BACK THE PAIN AND

THE FEAR HE HAD LESS. HE STOOD UP, AND DUMBLEDORE DID THE SAME, AND THEY LOOKED FOR A LONG MOMENT INTO EACH OTHER'S EYES.

DOING SO FIRST

THE

TELL ME ONE LAST THING, SAID HARRY, IS THIS REAL? HE HAS THIS BEEN HAPPENING INSIDE MY HEAD?

BUMBLEBEE BEAMED AT HIM, AND HIS VOICE SEEMED LIVED AND STRUNG IN HARRY'S EARS EVEN THOUGH THE BRIGHT MIST WAS DESCENDING

AGAIN, EXCLUDING HIS FIGURE.

HE CHUCKLE IT IS HAPPENING INSIDE YOUR HEAD, HARRY, BUT WHY WOULD EARTH SHOULD THAT MEAN THAT IT IS NOT REAL?

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

HE WAS LYING FACEDOWN ON THE GROUND AGAIN. THE SMELL OF THE FUREST FILLED HIS NOSTRILS. HE COULD FEEL THE HARD GROUND BENEATH HIS CHEEK, AND THE HINGE OF HIS GLASSES, WHICH HAD BEEN BENT SIDWAYS BY THE FALL, CUTTING INTO HIS TEMPLE. EVERY INCH OF HIM ACHED, AND THE PLACE WHERE THE KILLING CURSE HAD HIT HIM FELT LIKE THE BLOW OF AN IRON-CLAD PLUNGE. HE DID NOT STIR, BUT REMAINED EXACTLY WHERE HE HAD FALLEN, WITH HIS LEFT ARM BENT UP AT AN UNNATURAL ANGLE AND HIS MOUTH GAPPING.

HE HAD EXPECTED TO HEAR CHEERS OF TRIUMPH AND EXULTATION AT HIS

DEATH, BUT INSTEAD HEARD FEETSTEPS, WHISPERS, AND SILENTLY MURMURS FILLED THE AIR.

MY LORD . . . MY LORD . . .

IT WAS BELLATRIX'S VEHICLE, AND SHE SPoke AS IF THE A LEVER. HARRY DID NOT DARE OPEN HIS EYES, BUT ALLOWED HIS OTHER SENSES TO EXPLORE HIS

PREDICAMENT. HE KNEW THAT HIS WAND WAS STILL STEELED BENEATH HIS FEET BECAUSE HE COULD FEEL IT PRESSED BETWEEN HIS CHEST AND THE

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

YES

GRINDING, A SLIGHT CLUSHING EFFECT IN THE AREA OF HIS STOMACH TOLD HIM THAT THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK WAS ALSO THERE, STOPPED OUT OF SIGHT.

MY LORD . . .

THAT WILL DO, SAID VOLDERMORT'S VEHICLE.

MORE FEETSTEPS: SEVERAL PEOPLE WERE RACING AWAY FROM THE SAME SPOT. DESPERATE TO SEE WHAT WAS HAPPENING AND WHY, HARRY OPENED

HIS EYES BY A MILLIMETER.

VOLDERMORT SEEMED TO BE GETTING TO HIS FEET. VARIOUS DEATH EATERS WERE FLIRTING AWAY FROM HIM, RETURNING TO THE CROWD LINING

THE CLEARING. BELLATRIX ALONE REMAINED BEHIND, KNEELING BESIDE VOLDERMORT.

HARRY CLOSED HIS EYES AGAIN AND CONSIDERED WHAT HE HAD SEEN. THE DEATH EATERS HAD BEEN FLOODED AROUND VERDMEERT, WHO SEEMED TO HAVE FALLEN TO THE GROUND. SOMETHING HAD HAPPENED WHEN HE HAD HIT HARRY WITH THE KILLING CURSE. HAD VERDMEERT THEN COLLAPSED? IT SEEMED LIKE IT. AND BOTH OF THEM HAD FALLEN BRIEFLY UNCONSCIOUS AND BOTH OF THEM HAD NOW RETURNED. . . .

MY LORD, LET ME

I DO NOT REQUIRE ASSISTANCE, SAID VERDMEERT COLDLY, AND THOUGH HE COULD NOT SEE IT, HARRY PICTURED BELLATRIX WITHDRAWING A HELPFUL

HAND. THE KEY . . . IS HE DEAD?

THERE WAS COMPLETE SILENCE IN THE CLEARING. NERVOUSLY APPROACHED HARRY, BUT HE FELT THEIR CONCENTRATED GAZE; IT SEEMED TO PRESS HIM HARDER INTO THE GROUND, AND HE WAS TERRIFIED A FINGER OR AN EYELID MIGHT TWITCH.

YES, SAID VERDMEERT, AND THERE WAS A RANG AND A SMALL SERIES OF PAIN. EXAMINE HIM, TELL ME WHETHER HE IS DEAD.

HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHO HAD BEEN SENT TO VERIFY. HE COULD ONLY LIE THERE, WITH HIS HEART THUMPING TRAITOROUSLY, AND WAIT THE

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

EXAMINED, BUT AT THE SAME TIME NOTHING. SMALL VERDMEERT THOUGH IT WAS, THAT VERDMEERT WAS AWARE OF APPROACHING HIM, THAT VERDMEERT

SUSPECTED THAT ALL HAD NOT GONE THE PLAN, . . .

HANDS, SOFTER THAN HE HAD BEEN EXPECTING, TOUCHED HARRY'S FACE, PULLED BACK AN EYELID, CREEPT BENEATH HIS SHIRT, DOWN THE HIS CHEST, AND FELT HIS HEART. HE COULD HEAR THE WOMAN'S FAST BREATHING, HER LONG HAIR TICKLED HIS FACE. HE KNEW THAT SHE COULD FEEL THE STEADY POUNDING OF LIFE AGAINST HIS RIBS.

IS DRACHE ALIVE? IS HE IN THE CASTLE?

THE WHISPER WAS BARELY AUDIBLE; HER LIPS WERE AN INCH FROM HIS EAR, HER HEAD BENT SHE KNEW THAT HER LONG HAIR SHIELDED HIS FACE FROM THE ENLIGHTENERS.

YES, HE BREATHED BACK.

HE FELT THE HAND ON HIS CHEST CONTRACT; HER NAILS PIERCED HIM.

THEN IT WAS WITHDRAWN. SHE HAD SAT UP.

HE IS DEAD! NARCISSA MALFOY CALLED THE THE WATCHERS.

AND WHEN THEY SHILTED, WHEN THEY YELLED IN TRIUMPH AND STAMPED THEIR FEET, AND THROUGH HIS EYELIDS, HARRY SAW BURSTS OF RED AND SILVER

LIGHT SHEET INTO THE AIR IN CELEBRATION.

STILL FRIGHTENING DEATH ON THE GROUND, HE UNDERSTOOD. NARCISSA KNEW THAT THE ONLY WAY SHE WOULD BE PERMITTED TO ENTER HOGWARTS, AND FIND HER SON, WAS AS PART OF THE CHERYLING ARMY. SHE NO LONGER CARED

WHETHER VILDEMEHT LIVED.

WELL SEE? SCREAMED VILDEMEHT OVER THE TUMULT. HARRY PETER IS

DEAD BY MY HAND, AND NO MAN ALIVE CAN THREATEN ME NOW! WATCH! CRYING!

HARRY HAD BEEN EXPECTING IT, KNEW HIS BODY WOULD NOT BE ALLOWED

THEY REMAIN UNBOWLED WHEN THE FIRST FLEW; IT MUST BE SUBJECT TO THE
HUMILIATION THE PRIDE VENDORMENT & VICTORY. HE WAS LIFTED INTO THE

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

THEY

AIR, AND IT THREW ALL HIS DETERMINATION THEY REMAIN LIMP, YET THE PAIN
HE EXPECTED DID NOT COME. HE WAS THROWN BACK, TWICE, THREE TIMES
INTO THE AIR: HIS GLASSES FLEW OFF AND HE FELT HIS HAND SLIDE A LITTLE
BENEATH HIS REEKS, BUT HE KEPT HIMSELF FLEET AND LIFELESS, AND
WHEN

HE FELL TO THE GROUND FOR THE LAST TIME, THE CLEARING ECHOED WITH
JEERS

AND STRIDES OF LAUGHTER.

NEED, SAID VENDORMENT, WE GO TO THE CASTLE, AND SHOW
THEM WHAT HAS BECOME OF THEIR HERO. WE SHALL DRAG THE BODY?
NEED WAIT

THERE WAS A FRESH EMBLEM OF LAUGHTER, AND AFTER A FEW MOMENTS
HARRY FELT THE GROUND TREMLING BENEATH HIM.

WELL CARRY HIM, VENDORMENT SAID. HE WILL BE NICE AND VISIBLE IN
YOUR ARMS, WILL HE NOT? PICK UP YOUR LITTLE FRIEND, HAGRID, AND
THE

GLASSES PUT ON THE GLASSES HE MUST BE RECOGNIZABLE

SOMEONE SLAMMED HARRY'S GLASSES BACK INTO HIS FACE WITH DELIBER-
ATE FORCE, BUT THE ENORMOUS HANDS THAT LIFTED HIM INTO THE AIR
WERE

EXCEEDINGLY GENTLE. HARRY COULD FEEL HAGRID'S ARMS TREMBLING WITH THE FORCE OF HIS HEAVING SNEES; GREAT TEARS SPLASHED DOWN UPON HIM AS

HAGRID CRADLED HARRY IN HIS ARMS, AND HARRY DID NOT DARE, BY MOVEMENT OR WORD, THE INTIMATE THE HAGRID THAT ALL WAS NOT, YET, LOST.

MOVE, SAID VERBEMERT, AND HAGRID STUMBLERD FORWARD, PERCING HIS WAY THROUGH THE CLUMP-GROWING TREES, BACK THROUGH THE FOREST.

BRANCHES CALIGHT AT HARRY'S HAIR AND REEKS, BUT HE WAS ELUSIVE, HIS

MOUTH BEHINDING OPEN, HIS EYES SHUT, AND IN THE DARKNESS, WHILE THE DEATH EATERS CRAWLED ALL AROUND THEM, AND WHILE HAGRID STARED BLINDLY, NOBODY WISHED TO SEE WHETHER A PULSE BEAT IN THE EXPOSED NECK OF HARRY POTTER. . . .

THE TWO GIANTS CRASHED ALONG BEHIND THE DEATH EATERS; HARRY COULD HEAR TREES CREAKING AND FALLING AS THEY PASSED; THEY MADE SEE

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

MUCH DIN THAT BIRDS WERE STARTLING INTO THE SKY, AND EVEN THE FEARS OF

THE DEATH EATERS WERE DROWNED. THE VICTORIOUS PROCESSION MARCHED

HEW TOWARD THE OPEN GRADING, AND AFTER A WHILE HARRY COULD TELL, BY THE LIGHTENING OF THE DARKNESS THROUGH HIS CLOSED EYELIDS, THAT THE

TREES WERE BEGINNING TO THIN.

RANK:

HAGRID'S UNEXPECTED KILLEN NEARLY FORCED HARRY'S EYES OPEN.

HARRY NEW, ARE YOU, THAT YOU DIDN'T FIGHT, YOU CHIVALROUSLY CLINCH IN NAGS? ARE YOU HAPPY HARRY POTTER'S D-DEAD . . . ?

HAGRID COULD NOT CONTINUE, BUT BROKE DOWN IN FRESH TEARS, HARRY WHISPERED HOW MANY CENTAURS WERE WATCHING THEIR PROCESSION PASS:

HE DARED NOT OPEN HIS EYES TO CHECK. SOME OF THE DEATH EATERS CALLED INSULTS AT THE CENTAURS AS THEY LEFT THEM BEHIND. A LITTLE LATER, HARRY

SENSED, BY A FRESHENING OF THE AIR, THAT THEY HAD REACHED THE EDGE OF THE FOREST.

STEP.

HARRY THOUGHT THAT HAGRID MUST HAVE BEEN FORCED THE HEAVY VEHICLE-MOUNT'S CHAMPION, BECAUSE HE LURCHED A LITTLE, AND NEW A CHILL SETTLED

OVER THEM WHERE THEY STOOD, AND HARRY HEARD THE RASPING BREATH OF

THE DEMENTORS THAT PATROLLED THE ELTER TREES. THEY WOULD NOT AFFECT

HIM NEW. THE FACT OF HIS OWN SURVIVAL CLUNKED INSIDE HIM, A TALISMAN

AGAINST THEM, AS THOUGH HIS FATHER'S STAG KEPT GUARDIAN IN HIS HEART.

SHEPHERD PASSED CLOSE BY HARRY, AND HE KNEW THAT IT WAS VERDER-
MERT HIMSELF BECAUSE HE SPENT A MOMENT LATER, HIS VEHICLE MAGICALLY
MAGNIFIED SO THAT IT SKIPPED THROUGH THE GREENS, CRASHING UPON
HARRY'S CARTRIDGE.

HARRY PETER IS DEAD. HE WAS KILLED AS HE RAN AWAY, TRYING TO
SAVE HIMSELF WHILE THEY LAY DOWN THEIR LIVES FOR HIM. WE BRING THEM
HIS BODY AS PROOF THAT THEIR HERO IS GONE.

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

~*~

THE BATTLE IS WON. THEY HAVE LOST HALF OF THEIR FIGHTERS. MY DEATH
EATERS MOUNTAIN THEM, AND THE BODY WHICH LIVED IS FINISHED. THERE
MUST BE NO MORE WAR. ANYONE WHO CONTINUES TO RESIST, MAN,
WOMAN,

HER CHILD, WILL BE SLAUGHTERED, AS WILL EVERY MEMBER OF THEIR FAM-
ILY. COME OUT OF THE CASTLE NOW, KNEEL BEFORE ME, AND THEY SHALL BE

SPARED. THEIR PARENTS AND CHILDREN, THEIR BROTHERS AND SISTERS WILL
LIVE

AND BE FORGIVEN, AND THEY WILL JOIN ME IN THE NEW WORLD WE SHALL
BUILD TOGETHER.

THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE GREENS AND FROM THE CASTLE. VERDERMERT

WAS SHE CLOSE TO HIM THAT HARRY DID NOT DARE OPEN HIS EYES AGAIN.

THAT, SAID VOLDMORT, AND HARRY HEARD HIM MOVE AHEAD, AND HAGRID WAS FORCED TO FOLLOW. WHEN HARRY OPENED HIS EYES A FRACTION,

AND SAW VOLDMORT STRIDING IN FRONT OF THEM, WEARING THE GREAT SNARL

NAGINI AROUND HIS SHOULDERS, WHEN FREE OF HER ENCHANTED CAGE, BUT HARRY HAD NO POSSIBILITY OF EXTRACTING THE WAND CONCEALED UNDER HIS

ROBES WITHOUT BEING NOTICED BY THE DEATH EATERS, WHO MARCHED ON EITHER SIDE OF THEM THROUGH THE SILENTLY LIGHTENING DARKNESS. . . .

HARRY, HEARD HAGRID. HE, HARRY . . . HARRY . . .

HARRY SHUT HIS EYES TIGHT AGAIN. HE KNEW THAT THEY WERE APPROACHING THE CASTLE AND STRAINED HIS EARS TO DISTINGUISH, ABOVE THE

GLEEPY VOICES OF THE DEATH EATERS AND THEIR TRAMPING FEETSTEPS, SIGNS

OF LIFE FROM THOSE WITHIN.

STEP,

THE DEATH EATERS CAME TO A HALT: HARRY HEARD THEM SPREADING OUT IN A LINE FACING THE OPEN FRONT DOORS OF THE SCHOOL. HE COULD SEE, EVEN THROUGH HIS CLOSED LIDS, THE REDDISH GLOW THAT MEANT LIGHT

STREAMED UPON HIM FROM THE ENTRANCE HALL. HE WAITED, AND MEANTIME, THE PEOPLE FOR WHOM HE HAD TRIED TO DIE WOULD SEE HIM, LYING

APPARENTLY DEAD, IN HAGRID'S ARMS.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

THE

THE SCREAM WAS THE MORE TERRIBLE BECAUSE HE HAD NEVER EXPECTED
HE DREAMED THAT PROFESSOR McGONAGALL COULD MAKE SUCH A SOUND.
HE HEARD ANOTHER WOMAN LAUGHING NEARBY, AND KNEW THAT
BELLATRIX

CHIRPED IN MCGONAGALL'S DESPAIR, HE FELT AGAIN FOR A SINGLE
SEC-

END AND SAW THE OPEN DOORWAY FILLING WITH PEOPLE, AS THE
SURVIVORS

HE THE BATTLE CAME UP TO THE FRONT STEPS THE FACE THEIR
VANDERBILT'S

AND SEE THE TRUTH OF HARRY'S DEATH FOR THEMSELVES, HE SAW
VANDERBILT

STANDING A LITTLE IN FRONT OF HIM, STRIKING NAGINI'S HEAD WITH A
SINGLE

WHITE FINGER, HE CLOSED HIS EYES AGAIN.

THE

THE

HARRY! HARRY!

RHEN'S, HERMIONE'S, AND GINNY'S VEHICLES WERE WORSER THAN MCGONAGALL'S; HARRY WANTED NOTHING MORE THAN TO CALL BACK, YET HE MADE

HIMSELF BE SILENT, AND THEIR CRIES ACTED LIKE A TRIGGER; THE CRIES OF SURVIVORS THEN LIFTED THE CALISE, SCREAMING AND YELLING ABLISK AT THE DEATH EATERS, UNTIL

SILENCE! CRIED VELDERT, AND THERE WAS A BANG AND A FLASH OF BRIGHT LIGHT, AND SILENCE WAS FORCED UPON THEM ALL. IT IS OVER! SET

HIM DOWN, HAGRID, AT MY FEET, WHERE HE BELONGS!

HARRY FELT HIMSELF WHIRLED BENTH THE GRASS.

WELL SEE? SAID VELDERT, AND HARRY FELT HIM STRIDING BACKWARD AND FORWARD RIGHT BESIDE THE PLACE WHERE HE LAY. HARRY PUTTER IS DEAD! OH WELL UNDERSTAND NOW, DELETED HENES? HE WAS NOTHING, EVER, BUT A KID WHO RELIED ON OTHERS TO SACRIFICE THEMSELVES FOR HIM!

HE BEAT WELL! YELLED RHEN, AND THE CHARM BOMB, AND THE DEFENDERS OF HOGWARTS WERE SHOUTING AND SCREAMING AGAIN UNTIL A SECOND,

THE POWERFUL BANG EXTINGUISHED THEIR VEHICLES ENCE MORE.

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

OK1

HE WAS KILLED WHILE TRYING THE SNAKE BOLT OF THE CASTLE GRRLINDS,
SAID VEHLDEMENT, AND THERE WAS RELISH IN HIS VOICE FOR THE LIE,
KILLED

WHILE TRYING TO SAVE HIMSELF

BUT VEHLDEMENT KNEW BETTER: HARRY HEARD A SCUFFLE AND A SCHELT, THEN
ANOTHER RANG, A FLASH OF LIGHT, AND A GRUNT OF PAIN; HE OPENED HIS
EYES AN INFINITESIMAL AMOUNT. SOMEONE HAD BROKEN FREE OF THE
GRRLIND

AND CHARGED AT VEHLDEMENT! HARRY SAW THE FIGURE HIT THE GRRLIND,
DISARMED, VEHLDEMENT THREWING THE CHALLENGER S LAND ASIDE AND
LAUGHING.

AND WHO IS THIS? HE SAID IN HIS SNEAKY S MISE. WHO HAS VEHL-
DEMENTED THE DEMONSTRATE WHAT HAPPENS TO THESE WHO CONTINUE THE
FIGHT WHEN THE BATTLE IS LOST?

BELLATRIX GAVE A DELIGHTED LAUGH.

IT IS NEVILLE LONGBOTTOM, MY LORD! THE WHO WHO HAS BEEN GIVING
THE CARROLLS SHE MUCH TROUBLE! THE SON OF THE ALPHAS, REMEMBER?

AH, YES, I REMEMBER, SAID VEHLDEMENT, LEERING DOWN AT NEVILLE,
WHO WAS STRUGGLING BACK ON HIS FEET, UNARMED AND UNPROTECTED,
STANDING IN THE RED-MAN S-LAND BETWEEN THE SURVIVORS AND THE
DEATH

LATER, BUT WHO ARE A PLEASANT, AREN'T YOU, MY BRAVE WHO?
VEHLDE-

MENT ASKED NEVILLE, WHO STOOD FACING HIM, HIS EMPTY HANDS CLUTCHING

IN FISTS.

SEE WHAT IF I AM? SAID NEVILLE BOLDLY.

YELL STEEL SPIRIT AND BRAVERY, AND YELL CHIEF OF BOLD STEED, YELL
WILL MAKE A VERY VALLIABLE DEATH LATER. WE NEED YOUR KING, NEVILLE
LONGSHOTTEN.

I AM WITH YOU WHEN HELL FREEZES OVER, SAID NEVILLE. DUMBLE-
DORE'S ARMY? HE SMILED, AND THERE WAS AN ANSWERING CHIEF FROM

THE CRUEL, WITH VILDEMEHT'S SILENCING CHARMS SEEMED LIKELY THE
FIELD.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

VERY WELL, SAID VILDEMEHT, AND HARRY HEARD MORE DANGER IN
THE SILENCE OF HIS VOICE THAN IN THE MOST POWERFUL CURSE. IF
THAT IS

YOUR CHIEF, LONGSHOTTEN, WE REVERT TO THE ORIGINAL PLAN, FOR
YOUR

HEAD, HE SAID BOLDLY, BE IT.

STILL WATCHING THROUGH HIS LASHES, HARRY SAW VILDEMEHT WAVE
HIS

WAND. SECONDS LATER, OUT OF ONE OF THE CASTLE'S SHATTERED WINDOWS,
SOMETHING THAT LOOKED LIKE A MISTAKEN BIRD FLEW THROUGH THE
HALL

LIGHT AND LANDED IN VERDEMERT'S HAND. HE SEIZED THE MILDRED HE-
RICT BY ITS POINTED END AND IT DANGLED, EMPTY AND RAGGED: THE SHIRT-
ING HAT.

THERE WILL BE NO MORE SHIRTING AT FIEGLARTS SCHEHL, SAID VER-
DEMERT. THERE WILL BE NO MORE FIEGLISES. THE EMBLEM, SHIELD, AND

CHILDERS OF MY NECKLE ANCESTER, SALAZAR SLOTHERIN, WILL SUFFICE FOR
EVERY-

HEN. WHEN THEY, NEVILLE LONGBOTTEN?

HE POINTED HIS HAND AT NEVILLE, WHO GREW RIGID AND STILL, THEN
FORCED THE HAT INTO NEVILLE'S HEAD, SEE THAT IT SLIPPED DOWN BEHIND
HIS

EYES. THERE WERE MOVEMENTS FROM THE WATCHING CREW IN FRONT OF
THE CASTLE, AND AS HEN, THE DEATH EATERS RAISED THEIR HANDS, FEELING
THE FIGHTERS OF FIEGLARTS AT BAY.

NEVILLE HERE IS NOW GOING TO DEMONSTRATE WHAT HAPPENS THE AND-
HEN FIEGLISH ENOUGH THE CONTINUE THE HYPHOSIS ME, SAID VERDEMERT,
AND

WITH A FLICK OF HIS HAND, HE CALLED THE SHIRTING HAT THE BLIST INTO
FLAMES.

SCREAMS SPLIT THE DALIN, AND NEVILLE WAS ABLAZE, REEHTED THE THE SPENT,
LINABLE THE MOVE, AND FARRY CHILD NOT REAR IT! HE MUST ACT
AND THEN MANY THINGS HAPPENED AT THE SAME MOMENT.

THEY HEARD WHISPER FROM THE DISTANT BOUNDARY OF THE SCHEHL AS

WHAT SEEMED LIKE HUNDREDS OF PEOPLE CAME SWARMING OVER THE
HILT-

OF-SIGHT WALLS AND PELTED TOWARD THE CASTLE, LITTERING BEHIND WAR
CRIES.

THE FLAW IN THE PLAN

AT THE SAME TIME, GRALP CAME LIMPING AROUND THE SIDE OF THE
CASTLE AND YELLED, HAGGER! HIS CRY WAS ANSWERED BY REARS FROM
VEHEMENT'S GIANTS! THEY RAN AT GRALP LIKE BULL ELEPHANTS,
MAKING

THE EARTH TREMBLE. THEN CAME FIBBLES AND THE TANGLES OF REELS, AND
ARRAYS WERE SUDDENLY FALLING AMONGST THE DEATH EATERS, WHO KNEW
RANX, FEELING THEIR SURPRISE. HARRY PULLED THE INVISIBILITY
CLOAK

FROM INSIDE HIS REARS, SWUNG IT OVER HIMSELF, AND SPRANG THE HIS
FEET,

AS NEVILLE MOVED THEM.

IN ONE SWIFT, FLUID MOTION, NEVILLE KNEW FREE OF THE BODY-KIND
CURSE UPON HIM; THE FLAMING HAT FELL OFF HIM AND HE DREW FROM ITS
DEPTH SOMETHING SILVER, WITH A GLITTERING, BLISKED HANDLE

THE SLASH OF THE SILVER BLADE COULD NOT BE HEARD OVER THE REAR OF
THE ENCHURING CREED FOR THE SHUNDS OF THE CLASHING GIANTS FOR OF
THE

STAMPEDING CENTALIRS, AND YET IT SEEMED THE DRAW EVERY EYE, WITH A

SINGLE STROKE NEVILLE SLICED OFF THE GREAT SNAKE'S HEAD, WHICH SPUN HIGH INTO THE AIR, GLAMING IN THE LIGHT FLEEING FROM THE ENTRANCE

HALL, AND VERDERBERT'S MOUTH WAS OPEN IN A SCREAM OF FURY THAT NOBODY COULD HEAR, AND THE SNAKE'S BODY THRODDED THE THE GROUND AT HIS FEET

HIDDEN BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HARRY CAST A SHIELD CHARM BETWEEN NEVILLE AND VERDERBERT BEFORE THE LATTER COULD RAISE HIS WAND. THEN, OVER THE SCREAMS AND THE RHEARS AND THE THUNDEROUS STAMPS OF THE BATTING GIANTS, HAGRID'S YELL CAME LOUDEST OF ALL.

HARRY! HAGRID SCHELTED. HARRY WE'RE S HARRY? CHAOS REIGNED. THE CHARGING CENTAURS WERE SCATTERING THE DEATH EATERS, EVERYONE WAS FLEEING THE GIANTS STAMPING FEET, AND NEARER AND NEARER THUNDERED THE REINFORCEMENTS THAT HAD COME FROM WHERE KNOWN WHERE. HARRY SAW GREAT WINGED CREATURES SHARING AROUND THE

HEADS OF VERDERBERT'S GIANTS, THESTRALS AND BUCKBEAKS THE HIPPOGRIPS

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

SCRATCHING AT THEIR EYES WHILE GRABP PUNCHED AND PLUMPELLED THEM, AND NOW THE WIZARDS, DEFENDERS OF HOGWARTS AND DEATH EATERS ALIKE, WERE BEING FORCED BACK INTO THE CASTLE. HARRY WAS SPEECHING INJURIES AND CURSES AT ANY DEATH EATER HE COULD SEE, AND THEY CRUMPLED, NOT

KNOWING WHAT HE WERE HAD HIT THEM, AND THEIR BODIES WERE
TRAMPLED

BY THE RETREATING CREED.

STILL HIDDEN BEHIND THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HARRY WAS SLIPPED
INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL: HE WAS SEARCHING FOR VERDERBERT AND SAW
HIM ACROSS THE ROOM, FIRING SPELLS FROM HIS WAND AS HE BACKED INTO
THE GREAT HALL, STILL SCREAMING INSTRUCTIONS TO HIS FOLLOWERS AS HE

SENT CURSES FLYING LEFT AND RIGHT: HARRY CAST MORE SHIELD CHARMS,
AND VERDERBERT'S WOULD-BE VICTIMS, SEAMUS FINNIGAN AND FANDRAGH
ABRETT, DARTED PAST HIM INTO THE GREAT HALL, WHERE THEY JOINED THE
FIGHT ALREADY FLOURISHING INSIDE IT.

AND THEN THERE WERE MORE, EVEN MORE PEOPLE STREAMING UP THE
FRONT STEPS, AND HARRY SAW CHARLIE WEASLEY OVERTAKING HERALD
SLUGGEBORN, WHO WAS STILL WEARING HIS EMERALD PALMERS. THEY SEEMED
TO HAVE RETURNED AT THE HEAD OF WHAT LOOKED LIKE THE FAMILIES AND
FRIENDS OF EVERY HOGWARTS STUDENT WHO HAD REMAINED THE FIGHT,
ALONG

WITH THE SHEPHERDS AND FARMHANDS OF HOGSMOOR. THE
CENTAURS

BANE, RHEVAN, AND MACHIRIAN FIRST INTO THE HALL WITH A GREAT
CLATTER

OF BEEHIVES, AS BEHIND HARRY THE DOOR THAT LED TO THE KITCHENS WAS
BLASTED OFF ITS HINGES.

THE HOUSE-ELVES OF HOGWARTS SWARMED INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL,
SCREAMING AND WAVING CARVING KNIVES AND CLEAVERS, AND AT THEIR
HEAD,

THE WIDEST OF REGILL'S BLACK BEHINDING HIM HIS CHEST, WAS DRACONER,

HIS KILLING & WHILE ALDIE EVEN ABOVE THIS DIN: FIGHT! FIGHT!
FIGHT

FOR MY MASTER, DEFENDER OF HILLS-ELVES! FIGHT THE DARK LORD, IN THE
NAME OF BRAVE REGLIST! FIGHT!

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

YES

THEY WERE HACKING AND STABBING AT THE ANKLES AND SHINS OF DEATH-
EATERS, THEIR TINY FACES ALIVE WITH MALICE, AND EVERYWHERE HARRY
HEADED DEATH-EATERS WERE FALDING UNDER SHEER WEIGHT OF NUMBERS,
EVERCHOME BY SPELLS, DRAGGING ARROWS FROM WOUNDS, STABBED IN THE
LEG BY ELVES, HER ELSE SIMPLY ATTEMPTING THE ESCAPE, BUT SWALLOWED BY
THE ENCHURING HERD.

BUT IT WAS NOT EVER YET: HARRY SPED BETWEEN DIZELERS, PAST STRUG-
GLING PRISONERS, AND INTO THE GREAT FALL.

VEHDEMENT WAS IN THE CENTER OF THE BATTLE, AND HE WAS STRIKING
AND SMITING ALL WITHIN REACH, HARRY COULD NOT GET A CLEAR SHEET,
BUT

ALIGHT HIS WAY NEARER, STILL INVISIBLE, AND THE GREAT FALL BECAME
MORE AND MORE CRUELLED AS EVERYONE WITH CHILD WOULD FORCED THEIR
WAY INSIDE.

HARRY SAW PAXLEY SLAMMED THE THE FLOOR BY GEORGE AND LEE IHR-

DAN, SAW DEHN FALL WITH A SCREAM AT FLITWICK'S HANDS, SAW
WALDEN

MALFLOY THREW ACROSS THE ROOM BY FLITWICK, HIT THE STONE WALL
HARD-

PHOEBE, AND SLIDE UNDERSTOOLS TO THE CORNER. HE SAW DEHN AND
NEVILLE

BRINGING DEHN FROM CRAYBACK, ABERNETHY STUNNING RHEEDWELL,
ARTHUR AND PERCY FLEEING THICKNESS, AND LUCIUS AND NARCISSE
MALFLOY RUNNING THROUGH THE CORNER, NOT EVEN ATTEMPTING THE
FIGHT,

SCREAMING FOR THEIR SONS.

VEHEMENT WAS NOW DRIVING MCGONAGALL, SILVERHORN, AND KINGS-
LEY ALL AT ONCE, AND THERE WAS CHILD HATRED IN HIS FACE AS THEY WERE

AND DRIVED AROUND HIM, UNABLE TO FINISH HIM

BELLATRIX WAS STILL FIGHTING THEM, FIFTY YARDS AWAY FROM VEHEMENT,
AND LIKE HER MASTER SHE DRIVED THREE AT ONCE: HERMION, GINNY,
AND

LUNA, ALL BATTLING THEIR HARDEST, BUT BELLATRIX WAS EQUAL TO THEM,
AND HARRY'S ATTENTION WAS DIVERTED AS A KILLING CURSE SET SHE
FREE

THE GINNY THAT SHE MISSED DEATH BY AN INCH

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

HE CHANGED COURSE, RUNNING AT BELLATRIX RATHER THAN VERDEMORE,
BUT BEFORE HE HAD GONE A FEW STEPS HE WAS DOWNED SIDWAYS.

NEET MY DALIGHTER, YELL KITCH!

MRS. WEASLEY THREW OFF HER CLOAK AS SHE RAN, FREEING HER ARMS,
BELLATRIX SPUN ON THE SPOT, REARING WITH LAUGHTER AT THE SIGHT
OF HER

NEW CHALLENGER.

HELT OFF MY WAY! SCHELTED MRS. WEASLEY TO THE THREE GIRLS,
AND WITH A SWIPE OF HER WAND SHE BEGAN THE DUEL. HARRY WATCHED
WITH

TERROR AND FLATNESS AS MELLY WEASLEY'S WAND SLASHED AND TWIRLED,
AND

BELLATRIX LESTRANGE'S SMILE FALTERED AND BECAME A SNARL. LETS OF
LIGHT

FLY FROM BOTH WANDS, THE FLEET ARROUND THE WITCHES FEET BECAME
HEAT AND CRACKED; BOTH WOMEN WERE FIGHTING THE BULL.

NEE! MRS. WEASLEY CRIED AS A FEW STUDENTS RAN FORWARD, TRYING
TO HELP HER. GET BACK! GET BACK! SHE IS MINE!

HUNDREDS OF PEOPLE NOW LINED THE WALLS, WATCHING THE TWO FIGHTS,
VERDEMORE AND HIS THREE HYPHONENTS, BELLATRIX AND MELLY, AND
HARRY

STOOD, INVISIBLE, THROU BETWEEN BOTH, WANTING TO ATTACK AND YET TO
PROTECT, UNABLE TO BE SURE THAT HE WOULD NOT HIT THE INNOCENT.

WHAT WILL HAPPEN TO YOUR CHILDREN WHEN I VE KILLED YOUR
TALANTED

BELLATRIX, AS MAD AS HER MASTER, LAVERING AS MELLY'S CURSES DANCED

AROUND HER. WHEN MUMMY'S GONE THE SAME WAY AS FREDDIE?

THEY WILL NEVER THINK OUR CHILDREN AGAIN!
SCREAMED MRS. LEASLEY.

BELLATRIX LAUGHED, THE SAME EXHILARATED LAUGH HER CHELSEA STRIPS
HAD GIVEN AS HE THROPPED BACKWARD THROUGH THE VEIL, AND SUDDENLY
HARRY KNEW WHAT WAS GOING TO HAPPEN BEFORE IT DID.

MELLY'S CLASP SEIZED BENEATH BELLATRIX'S ELONG-STRETCHED ARM AND HIT
HER SQUARELY IN THE CHEST, DIRECTLY OVER HER HEART.

BELLATRIX'S GLEATING SMILE FREEZE, HER EYES SEEMED TO GLAZE: HER

THE FLAW IN THE PLAN

???

THE TINIEST SPACE OF TIME SHE KNEW WHAT HAD HAPPENED, AND THEN
SHE THROPPED, AND THE WATCHING CROWD REARED, AND VERDERMERT
SCREAMED.

HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE TURNED IN SHELL MENTHER; HE SAW MCCORMA-
CALL, KINGSLEY, AND SILVERMAN BLASTED BACKWARD, FLAILING AND WRITH-
ING THROUGH THE AIR, AS VERDERMERT'S FLURY AT THE FALL OF HIS LAST,
BEST

LIEUTENANT EXPLODED WITH THE FORCE OF A BOMB. VERDERMERT RAISED HIS
HAND AND DIRECTED IT AT MELLY LEASLEY.

PROTECTOR REARED HARRY, AND THE SHIELD CHARM EXPANDED IN THE
MIDDLE OF THE FALL, AND VERDERMERT STARED AROUND FOR THE SEELICE AS

HARRY PULLED OFF THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AT LAST.

THE YELL HE HEARD, THE CHIEFS, THE SCREAMS ON EVERY SIDE OF
HARRY:

HE'S ALIVE! WERE STUCK AT HOME. THE CHILD WAS AFRAID, AND SI-
LENCE FELL ABRUPTLY AND COMPLETELY AS VERDERBERT AND HARRY LOOKED AT
AT

EACH OTHER, AND BEGAN, AT THE SAME MOMENT, TO CIRCLE EACH OTHER.

I DON'T WANT ANYONE ELSE TO TRY TO HELP, HARRY SAID BOLDLY, AND
IN THE TOTAL SILENCE HIS VOICE CARRIED LIKE A TRUMPET CALL. IT'S GOTT
THE

BE LIKE THIS. IT'S GOTT THE BE ME.

VERDERBERT HISSED.

BETTER DOESN'T MEAN THAT, HE SAID, HIS RED EYES WIDE. THAT ISN'T
HOW HE WORKS, IS IT? WE'RE ARE YOU GOING TO USE AS A SHIELD TODAY,
BETTER?

NEEDY, SAID HARRY SIMPLY. THERE ARE NO MORE HERCULES. IT'S
JUST YOU AND ME. NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE OTHER SURVIVES, AND
HENCE

HE'LL BE ABLE TO LEAVE FOR GOOD, ...

HENCE HE'LL? IRRATED VERDERBERT, AND HIS WHITE BODY WAS TIGHT AND
HIS RED EYES STARED, A SNAKE THAT WAS ABLE TO STRIKE. YOU THINK
IT

WILL BE YOU, BE YOU, THE BODY WHICH HAS SURVIVED BY ACCIDENT, AND RE-
CALISE OLIMPEDEHE WAS PULLING THE STRINGS?

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

ACCIDENT, WAS IT, WHEN MY MOTHER DIED THE SAME NIGHT? ASKED HARRY, THEY WERE STILL MOVING SIDEWAYS, BOTH OF THEM, IN THAT PERFECT CIRCLE,

MAINTAINING THE SAME DISTANCE FROM EACH OTHER, AND FOR HARRY THE FACT EXISTED BUT VERDAMPT. ACCIDENT, WHEN I DECIDED THE FIGHT IN THAT GRAVEYARD? ACCIDENT, THAT I DIDN'T DEFEND MYSELF THENIGHT, AND STILL SURVIVED, AND RETURNED THE FIGHT AGAIN?

ACCIDENTS? SCREAMED VERDAMPT, BUT STILL HE DID NOT STRIKE, AND THE WATCHING CROWD WAS FROZEN AS IF PETRIFIED, AND OF THE HUNDREDS IN THE HALL, NONE SEEMED TO BREATHE BUT THEY TALKED. ACCIDENT AND CHANCE AND THE FACT THAT YELL CRAWLED AND SNIPELED BEHIND THE SKIRTS OF GREATER MEN AND WOMEN, AND PERMITTED ME TO KILL THEM FOR YELL?

YELL WHEN I AM KILLING ANYONE ELSE THENIGHT, SAID HARRY AS THEY CIRCLED, AND STARED INTO EACH OTHER'S EYES, GREEN INTO RED. YELL WHEN I

AM ABLE TO KILL ANY OF THEM EVER AGAIN, THEN I YELL GET IT? I WAS READY

TO DIE THE SAME YELL FROM FLIRTING THESE PEOPLE

BUT YELL DID NOT?

I MEANT THE, AND THAT IS WHAT DID IT, I'VE DONE WHAT MY MOTHER DID, THEY ARE PROTECTED FROM YELL, I'VE NOT YELL NOTICED HOW NONE OF THE SPELLS YELL PUT ON THEM ARE BINDING? YELL CAN'T TORTURE THEM,

YELL CAN'T THINK THEM, YELL DEEN'T LEARN FROM YELLER MISTAKES,
RIDDLE,

DIE YELL?

YELL DARE

YES, I DARE, SAID HARRY. I KNOW THINGS YELL DEEN'T KNOW, THEM
RIDDLE, I KNOW LETS ME IMPORTANT THINGS THAT YELL DEEN'T WANT THE
HEAR SOME, BEFORE YELL MAKE ANOTHER BIG MISTAKE?

YELDMERT DID NOT SPEAK, BUT PRELLED IN A CIRCLE, AND HARRY
KNEW THAT HE KEPT HIM TEMPORARILY MESMERIZED AND AT LAST, FIELD

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

TRY

BACK BY THE FAINTEST POSSIBILITY THAT HARRY MIGHT INDEED KNOW A
FINAL SECRET. . . .

IS IT LEVE AGAIN? SAID YELDMERT, HIS SNAKE'S FACE IRKING. DUM-
BLEDORE'S FAVORITE SPELLTHER, LEVE, WHICH HE CLAIMED CHENELERED
DEATH,

THOUGH LEVE DID NOT STOP HIM FALLING FROM THE TOWER AND BREAKING
LIKE AN OLD WAXWORK? LEVE, WHICH DID NOT PREVENT ME STAMPING
HIT

YELLER MUDLEND MOTHER LIKE A CHECKREACH, PITTER AND NEKEDY
SEEMS THE LEVE YELL KNOWS THE PLAN FORWARD THIS TIME AND TAKE MY
CURSE, SEE WHAT WILL STOP YELL DYING NOW WHEN I STRIKE?

JUST ONE THING, SAID HARRY, AND STILL THEY CIRCLED EACH OTHER,

WRAPPED IN EACH OTHER, HELD APART BY NOTHING BUT THE LAST SECRET.

IF IT IS NOT LOVE THAT WILL SAVE YOU THIS TIME, SAID VERDEMENT,
YOU

MUST BELIEVE THAT YOU HAVE MAGIC THAT I DO NOT, OR ELSE A WEAPON
MORE POWERFUL THAN MINE?

I BELIEVE BOTH, SAID HARRY, AND HE SAW SOMETHING FLIT ACROSS THE
SNARLING FACE, THOUGH IT WAS INSTANTLY DISPELLED; VERDEMENT BEGAN
THE LAUGH, AND THE SOUND WAS MORE FRIGHTENING THAN HIS SCREAMS;
FLIMMERLESS AND INSANE, IT ECHOED AROUND THE SILENT HALL.

YOU THINK YOU KNOW MORE MAGIC THAN I DO? HE SAID, THAN I,
THAN LORD VERDEMENT, WHO HAS PERFORMED MAGIC THAT DUMBLEDORE
HIMSELF NEVER DREAMED OF?

HE, HE DREAMED OF IT, SAID HARRY, BUT HE KNOWS MORE THAN YOU,
KNOWS ENOUGH NOT TO DO WHAT YOU WERE DOING.

YOU MEAN HE WAS DEAD? SCREAMED VERDEMENT. THE DEAD THE
DARE, THE DEAD THE TAKE WHAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN HIS, WHAT WILL BE
MINE?

NO, HE WAS CLEVERER THAN YOU, SAID HARRY, A BETTER WIZARD, A
BETTER MAN.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

I REMEMBER ABOUT THE DEATH OF ALBUS DUMBLEDORE?

YOU REMEMBER YOU DID, SAID HARRY, BUT YOU WERE LYING.
FOR THE FIRST TIME, THE WATCHING CREW STIRRED AS THE HUNDREDS OF

PEOPLE ARELIND THE WALLS DREW BREATH AS HENZ.

OLIMPLEDHRE IS DEAD? VELDERTH FURLED THE LHERDS AT FARRY AS
TEHLEH THEY WELLD CALISE HIM UNENDURABLE PAIN. HIS BODY DECAYS

IN THE MARKLE THEM IN THE GREHLNDS OF THIS CASTLE, I HAVE SEEN IT,
PHT-

TER, AND HE WILL NEET RETLRN?

YES, OLIMPLEDHRE S DEAD, SAID FARRY CALMLY, KLIT YELI DIDN T
HAVE HIM KILLED, HE CHOSE HIS OWN MANNER OF DYING, CHOSE IT
MENTHIS

BEFORE HE DIED, ARRANGED THE WHOLE THING WITH THE MAN YELI
TEHLEHIT

WAS YELI'S SERVANT.

WHAT CHILDISH DREAM IS THIS? SAID VELDERTH, KLIT STILL HE DID
NEET STRIKE, AND HIS RED EYES DID NEET WAYER FROM FARRY S.

SEVERUS Snape WASN T YELI'S, SAID FARRY, Snape WAS OLIMPLE-
DHRE S, OLIMPLEDHRE S FROM THE MOMENT YELI STARTED FLINTING DOWN

MY MEETHER, AND YELI NEVER REALIZED IT, BECAUSE OF THE THING YELI
CAN T UNDERSTAND, YELI NEVER SAW Snape LAST A PATRENLIS, DID YELI,
RIDDLE?

VELDERTH DID NEET ANSWER, THEY CONTINUED THE CIRCLE EACH EITHER
LIKE WHILVES ARELIT THE TEAR EACH EITHER APART.

Snape S PATRENLIS WAS A DEER, SAID FARRY, THE SAME AS MY MEET-

ER S, BECAUSE HE LOVED HER FOR NEARLY ALL OF HIS LIFE, FROM THE TIME WHEN

THEY WERE CHILDREN. YELL SHOULD HAVE REALIZED, HE SAID AS HE SAW YELL-

DEMENT S NEEDLE'S FLARE, HE ASKED YELL THE SPARE HER LIFE, DIDN T HE?

HE DESIRED HER, THAT WAS ALL, SNEERED VELDMENT, BUT WHEN SHE HAD GONE, HE AGREED THAT THERE WERE EITHER WOMEN, AND HE PLURED

BLIND, WORTHIER OF HIM

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

991

HE CHOOSE HE THOUGHT YELL THAT, SAID HARRY, BUT HE WAS DUMBLE-
DHRE S SPY FROM THE MOMENT YELL THREATENED HER, AND HE S BEEN
WHERE-

ING AGAINST YELL EVER SINCE? DUMBLEDHRE WAS ALREADY DYING WHEN

SNAPE FINISHED HIM?

IT MATTERS NOT? SHRIEKED VELDMENT, WHO HAD FOLLOWED EVERY
WORD WITH RAPT ATTENTION, BUT WHEN LET HEUT A CACKLE OF MAD
LAUGHTER.

IT MATTERS NOT WHETHER SNAPE WAS MINE OR DUMBLEDHRE S, HE WHAT
PETTY OBSTACLES THEY TRIED TO PUT IN MY PATH? I CRUSHED THEM AS I
CRUSHED YELL'S MOTHER, SNAPE S SUPPOSED GREAT LOVE? HEY, BUT IT ALL

MAKES SENSE, PETER, AND IN WAYS THAT YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND:

OLMEDIER WAS TRYING TO KEEP THE ELDER LAND FROM ME: HE
INTENDED THAT SNAPE SHOULD BE THE TRUE MASTER OF THE LAND: BUT I
CAME THERE BEFORE HIM, LITTLE KID. I REACHED THE LAND BEFORE YOU
COULD GET YOUR HANDS ON IT, I UNDERSTOOD THE TRUTH: BEFORE YOU
CALLED IT

WELL, I KILLED SEVERUS SNAPE THREE YEARS AGO, AND THE ELDER LAND,
THE

DEATH-THIRD, THE LAND OF DESTINY IS TRULY MINE: OLMEDIER'S LAST
PLAN WENT WRONG, HARRY PETER:

YES, IT DID, SAID HARRY. YOU'RE RIGHT, BUT BEFORE YOU TRY TO
KILL

ME, I'D ADVISE YOU TO THINK ABOUT WHAT YOU'RE DOING, ... THINK, AND
TRY FOR SOME REMORSE, RIDDLE, ...

WHAT IS THIS?

OF ALL THE THINGS THAT HARRY HAD SAID TO HIM, REMORSE AND REVE-
LATIONS OF TALENT, NOTHING HAD SHOCKED VOLDEMORT LIKE THIS.
HARRY

SAW HIS PUPILS CONTRACT TO THIN SLITS, SAW THE SKIN AROUND HIS
EYES

WHITEN,

IT'S YOUR ONE LAST CHANCE, SAID HARRY, IT'S ALL YOU'VE GOT LEFT, ...
,

I'VE SEEN WHAT YOU'LL BE OTHERWISE, ... BE A MAN ... TRY ... TRY FOR
SOME REMORSE, ...

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

“YES.”

“YES, I DARE,” SAID HARRY, BECAUSE DUMBLEDORE’S LAST PLAN HADN’T

BACKFIRED ON ME AT ALL. IT’S BACKFIRED ON YOU, RIDDLE.

Voldemort’s hand was trembling on the Elder Wand, and Harry gripped Draco’s very tightly. The moment, he knew, was seconds away.

“THAT WAND STILL ISN’T WORKING PROPERLY FOR YOU BECAUSE YOU

ORDERED THE WRONG PERSON. SEVERUS Snape WAS NEVER THE TRUE MASTER

OF THE ELDER WAND. HE NEVER DEFEATED DUMBLEDORE.

HE KILLED

AREN’T YOU LISTENING? Snape NEVER BEAT DUMBLEDORE! DUMBLEDORE’S DEATH WAS PLANNED BETWEEN THEM! DUMBLEDORE INTENDED TO DIE UNDEFEATED, THE WAND’S LAST TRUE MASTER! IF ALL HAD GONE AS PLANNED, THE WAND’S POWER WOULD HAVE DIED WITH HIM, BECAUSE IT HAD NEVER BEEN WITH ANYONE ELSE!

BUT THEN, BETTER, DUMBLEDORE AS GOOD AS GAVE ME THE WAND!

Voldemort’s voice sounded with malicious pleasure. I STEAL THE WAND

FROM ITS LAST MASTER’S HAND! I REMOVED IT AGAINST ITS LAST MASTER’S WISHES! ITS POWER IS MINE!

“YOU STILL DON’T GET IT, RIDDLE, BUT YOU? POSSESSING THE WAND ISN’T

ENLIGHTENED? HOLDING IT, LISTENING IT, DOESN'T MAKE IT REALLY THEIRS. DIDN'T
THEY LISTEN TO HELLIVANDER? THE WAND CHOOSES THE WIZARD. . . . THE
ELDER

WAND RECOGNIZED A NEW MASTER BEFORE OLIMPEDERE DIED, SOMEONE
WHO NEVER EVEN LAID A HAND ON IT. THE NEW MASTER REMOVED THE
WAND

FROM OLIMPEDERE AGAINST HIS WILL, NEVER REALIZING EXACTLY WHAT HE
HAD DONE, OR THAT THE WORLD'S MOST DANGEROUS WAND HAD GIVEN HIM
ITS ALLEGIANCE. . . .

VEHEMENT'S CHEST ROSE AND FELL RAPIDLY, AND HARRY COULD FEEL THE
CLOSE CUPING, FEEL IT BUILDING INSIDE THE WAND POINTED AT HIS FACE.

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

THE

THE TRUE MASTER OF THE ELDER WAND WAS DRACHE MALFOY.
BLAND SMILED SLOWLY IN VEHEMENT'S FACE FOR A MOMENT, BUT THEN
IT WAS GONE.

BUT WHAT DOES IT MATTER? HE SAID SLEETLY. EVEN IF THEY ARE RIGHT,
BETTER, IT MAKES NO DIFFERENCE TO THEM AND ME. THEY NO LONGER HAVE
THE PHOENIX WAND! WE LIVE ON STILL ALIVE . . . AND AFTER I HAVE
KILLED

THEY, I CAN ATTEND TO DRACHE MALFOY. . . .

BUT THEY'RE TOO LATE, SAID HARRY. THEY'VE MISSED THEIR CHANCE. I
GET THERE FIRST. I OVERPOWERED DRACHE WEEKS AGO. I TOOK THIS WAND
FROM HIM.

HARRY TWITCHED THE FLAME-HERN WAND, AND HE FELT THE EYES OF EVERYONE IN THE HALL WIDEN IT.

SEE IT ALL COMES DOWN THE THIS, DOESN'T IT? WHISPERED HARRY, DOES THE WAND IN YOUR HAND KNOW ITS LAST MASTER WAS DISARMED? BECAUSE IF IT DOES . . . I AM THE TRUE MASTER OF THE ELDER WAND.

A RED-GOLD GLEW BURST SUDDENLY ACROSS THE ENCHANTED SKY ABOVE

THEM AS AN EDGE OF DAZZLING SUN APPEARED OVER THE SILL OF THE NEAR-

EAST WINDOW. THE LIGHT HIT BOTH OF THEIR FACES AT THE SAME TIME, SEE

THAT VERDERBERT WAS SUDDENLY A FLAMING BLUR. HARRY HEARD THE HIGH

WHISK SHRIEK AS HE THEN YELLED HIS BEST BEEP THE THE HEAVENS, PHINTINE

DRACH S WAND!

AVADA KEDAVRA!

EXPPELLIARMUS!

THE BANG WAS LIKE A CANNON BLAST, AND THE GOLDEN FLAMES THAT ERUPTED BETWEEN THEM, AT THE DEAD CENTER OF THE CIRCLE THEY HAD BEEN TREADING, MARKED THE POINT WHERE THE SPELLS COLLIDED. HARRY SAW VERDERBERT S GREEN IET MEET HIS OWN SPELL, SAW THE ELDER WAND FLY HIGH, DARK AGAINST THE SUNRISE, SPINNING ACROSS THE ENCHANTED CEILING

LIKE THE HEAD OF NAEGINI, SPINNING THROUGH THE AIR TOWARD THE MASTER

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

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IT WOULD NOT KILL, WHEN HAD COME TO TAKE FULL POSSESSION OF IT AT LAST.

AND HARRY, WITH THE LINERRING SKILL OF THE SEEKER, CAUGHT THE WAND

IN HIS FREE HAND AS VILDEMERT FELL BACKWARD, ARMS SPLORED, THE SLIT PUPILS OF THE SCARLET EYES REELING UPWARD, THEN RIDDLE HIT THE FLOOR

WITH A MUNDANE FINALITY, HIS KNEES FEEBLE AND SPRLINDEN, THE WHITE HANDS EMPTY, THE SNARKLIKE FACE VACANT AND LINDREHLING, VILDEMERT

WAS DEAD, KILLED BY HIS ELIN REELING CLUSE, AND HARRY STOOD WITH TWO WANDS IN HIS HAND, STARING DOWN AT HIS ENEMY'S SKULL.

THE SHIVERING SECOND OF SILENCE, THE SHECK OF THE MOMENT SUSPENDED! AND THEN THE TLMILT KROCK ARIELND HARRY AS THE SCREAMS

AND THE CHERS AND THE REHARS OF THE WATCHERS RENT THE AIR, THE FIERCE

NEW SUN DAZZLED THE WINDHILLS AS THEY THUNDERED TOWARD HIM, AND THE FIRST TO REACH HIM WERE REEN AND HERMIENE, AND IT WAS THEIR ARMS

THAT WERE WRAPPED ARIELND HIM, THEIR INCHMPREHENSIBLE SHEETS THAT

DRAINED HIM, THEN GINNY, NEVILLE, AND LUNA WERE THERE, AND THEN ALL THE WEASLEYS AND FLAGRID, AND KINGSLEY AND MCHENAGALL AND

FLITWICK AND SPRINKLE, AND HARRY COULD NOT HEAR A WORD THAT ANYONE

WAS SAYING, NOR TELL WHOSE HANDS WERE SEIZING HIM, PULLING HIM, TRYING TO HOLD SOME PART OF HIM, HUNDREDS OF THEM PRESSING IN, ALL OF THEM DETERMINED TO THICKEN THE WEB WHICH LIVED, THE REASON IT WAS NEVER AT LAST

THE SUN ROSE STEADILY OVER HOGWARTS, AND THE GREAT HALL BLAZED WITH LIFE AND LIGHT, HARRY WAS AN INDISPENSABLE PART OF THE MINGLED

WHISPERRINGS OF ILKILATION AND MELIORING, OF GRIEF AND CELEBRATION, THEY WANTED HIM THERE WITH THEM, THEIR LEADER AND SYMBOL, THEIR SAVIOUR AND THEIR GUIDE, AND THAT HE HAD NOT SLEPT, THAT HE CRAVED THE

COMPANY OF ONLY A FEW OF THEM, SEEMED THE ONLY THING HE MUST SPREAD THE MESSAGE, CLASP THEIR HANDS, WITNESS THEIR TEARS, RECEIVE

THEIR THANKS, HEAR THE NEWS NEWS CREEPING IN FROM EVERY QUARTER AS

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

YES

THE MORNING DREW ON; THAT THE IMPERILED LIP AND DEEDS THE COUNTRY

HAD COME BACK TO THEMSELVES, THAT DEATH EATERS WERE FLEEING OR ELSE BEING CAPTURED, THAT THE INHABITANTS OF AZKABAN WERE BEING RELEASED AT

THE VERY MOMENT, AND THAT KINGSLEY SHACKLEBOLT HAD BEEN NAMED

TEMPERARY MINISTER OF MAGIC. . .

THEY MOVED VERDREHT'S BODY AND LAID IT IN A CHAMBER OFF THE  
HALL, AWAY FROM THE BODIES OF FRED, THENDS, KLIPIN, CELIN CREEVER,

AND FIFTY OTHERS WHO HAD DIED FIGHTING HIM. MCGINNAGALL HAD RE-  
PLACED THE FUELISH TABLES, BUT NOBODY WAS SITTING ACCORDING THE  
FUELISH

ANYMORE! ALL WERE LIMBED TOGETHER, TEACHERS AND PUPILS, GHOSTS  
AND PARENTS, CENTALIRS AND FUELISH-ELVES, AND FIRENZE LAY RECOVERING  
IN A CORNER, AND GRAMP PEERED IN THROUGH A SMASHED WINDOW, AND  
PEOPLE WERE THRILLING AHEAD INTO HIS LAUGHING MOUTH. AFTER A  
WHILE,

EXHAUSTED AND DRAINED, HARRY FOUND HIMSELF SITTING ON A BENCH  
BEHIND LUNA.

I'D WANT SOME PEACE AND QUIET, IF IT WERE ME, SHE SAID.

I'D LOVE SOME, HE REPLIED.

I'LL DISTRACT THEM ALL, SHE SAID, USE YOUR CHARM.

AND BEFORE HE COULD SAY A WORD SHE HAD CRIED, HHHH, HHHH, A  
CLICKING FLUMDINGER! AND POINTED HIM TO THE WINDOW. EVERYONE

WHO HEARD HEEDED AHEAD, AND HARRY SLID THE CHARM UP OVER HIM-  
SELF, AND GOT TO HIS FEET.

NOW HE COULD MOVE THROUGH THE HALL WITHOUT INTERFERENCE. HE  
SPUNTED GINNY TWO TABLES AWAY; SHE WAS SITTING WITH HER HEAD ON  
HER MOTHER'S SHOULDER. THERE WOULD BE TIME TO TALK LATER, FUELISH

AND DAYS AND MANY YEARS IN WHICH THE TALK, HE SAW NEVILLE, THE  
SHARD OF GRYFFINDOR LYING BESIDE HIS PLATE AS HE ATE, SURROUNDED  
BY A HOST OF PERVAZ ADIRERS, ALONG THE AISLE BETWEEN THE TABLES  
HE WALKED, AND HE SPOTTED THE THREE MALFOYS, Huddled TOGETHER AS

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

THOUGH UNSURE WHETHER HE MET THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO BE THERE,  
BUT

NOBODY WAS PAYING THEM ANY ATTENTION, EVERYWHERE HE LOOKED HE  
SAW FAMILIES REUNITED, AND FINALLY, HE SAW THE TWO WHOSE COMPANY  
HE CRAVED MOST.

IT WAS HE, HE MUTTERED, CREEPING DOWN BETWEEN THEM. WILL  
HE COME WITH ME?

THEY STOOD UP AT ONCE, AND TOGETHER HE, RON, AND HERMION  
LEFT THE GREAT HALL. GREAT CHANDS WERE MISSING FROM THE MARBLE  
STAIRCASE, PART OF THE BALLISTRAD CHAIR, AND RUBBLE AND BLEEDSTAINS  
HIGHLIGHTED EVERY FEW STEPS AS THEY CLIMBED.

SOMEWHERE IN THE DISTANCE THEY COULD HEAR PEEVES ZEEHING  
THROUGH

THE CORRIDORS SINGING A VICTORY SONG OF HIS OWN COMPOSITION:

WE DID IT, WE BASHED THEM, WE PUTTER D THE END,

AND YELLO D CHINE MELLO, SEE NOW LET D HAVE FLIN!

REALLY GIVES A FEELING FOR THE SCENE AND TRAGEDY OF THE THING,

DEEREN T IT? SAID REEN, PUSHING OPEN A DEER THE LET FARRY AND  
F-HERMI-

ENE THROUGH.

HAPPINESS WOULD CURE, FARRY THOUGHT, BUT AT THE MOMENT IT WAS  
MULLED BY EXHAUSTION, AND THE PAIN OF MISSING FRED AND LUPIN AND  
THEIRS PIERCED HIM LIKE A PHYSICAL WOUND EVERY FEW STEPS. MOST OF  
ALL

HE FELT THE MOST STUPIDOUS RELIEF, AND A LONGING TO SLEEP, BUT  
FIRST HE

WANTED AN EXPLANATION THE REEN AND F-HERMINE, WHO HAD STUCK WITH  
HIM

AFTER SHE LEAVE, AND WHO DESERVED THE TRUTH. PAINSTAKINGLY HE  
RECALLED

WHAT HE HAD SEEN IN THE PENSIVE AND WHAT HAD HAPPENED IN THE  
ARREST,

AND THEY HAD NOT EVEN REGAIN THE EXPRESS ALL THEIR STRESS AND  
AMAZEMENT

WHEN AT LAST THEY ARRIVED AT THE PLACE THE WHICH THEY HAD BEEN  
WALKING,

THOUGH NONE OF THEM HAD MENTIONED THEIR DESTINATION.

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

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SINCE HE HAD LAST SEEN IT, THE GARGOYLE GUARDING THE ENTRANCE THE  
THE HEADMASTER'S STUDY HAD BEEN BENT OVER ASIDE; IT STOOD UPSIDE,

WHISKING A LITTLE PUNCH-DRINK, AND HARRY WONDERED WHETHER IT  
WOULD

BE ABLE TO DISTINGUISH PASSWORDS ANYMORE.

CAN WE GO UP? HE ASKED THE GARGOYLE.

FEEL FREE, GRANTED THE STATUE.

THEY CLAMBERED OVER HIM AND ENTERED THE SPIRAL STONE STAIRCASE THAT  
MOVED SILENTLY UPWARD LIKE AN ESCALATOR. HARRY PUSHED OPEN THE  
DOOR AT THE TOP.

HE HAD HAD A BRIEF GLIMPSE OF THE STONE PENDENT IN THE DESK WHERE  
HE HAD LEFT IT, AND THEN AN EARSPLITTING NOISE MADE HIM CRY OUT,  
THINKING OF CURSES AND RETURNING DEATH EATERS AND THE REBIRTH OF  
Voldemort

BUT IT WAS APPLAUSE. ALL AROUND THE WALLS, THE HEADMASTERS AND  
HEADMISTRESSES OF HOGWARTS WERE GIVING HIM A STANDING OVATION;  
THEY WAVED THEIR HATS AND IN SOME CASES THEIR WIGS, THEY REACHED  
THROUGH THEIR FRAMES TO GRIP EACH OTHER'S HANDS; THEY DANCED UP  
AND

DOWN IN THE CHAIRS IN WHICH THEY HAD BEEN PAINTED; DOLLS DERRICK  
SHOOK LINEN-DRYINGLY; DEXTER FORTESCUE WAS WAVING HIS CAR-  
TRUMPET;

AND PHINEAS NIGELLUS CALLED, IN HIS HIGH, REEDY VOICE, AND LET IT BE  
NOTED THAT SLOTHFULNESS PLAYED ITS PART; LET HIS  
CONTRIBUTION BE

BE FORGOTTEN!

BUT HARRY HAD EYES ONLY FOR THE MAN WHO STOOD IN THE LARGEST  
PORTRAIT DIRECTLY BEHIND THE HEADMASTER'S CHAIR. TEARS WERE SLIDING  
DOWN FROM BEHIND THE HALF-MOON SPECTACLES INTO THE LONG SILVER  
BEARD, AND THE PRIDE AND THE GRATITUDE EMANATING FROM HIM FILLED



HARRY WITH THE SAME CALM AS PHOENIX SHING,

AT LAST, HARRY HELD UP HIS HANDS, AND THE PORTRAITS FELL  
RESPECTFULLY

SILENT, BEAMING AND MEPPING THEIR EYES AND WAITING EAGERLY FOR  
HIM

## CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

THE

THE SPREAD, HE DIRECTED HIS WORDS AT DUMBLEDORE, HOWEVER, AND CHOSE  
THEM WITH ENTHUSIASM CARE, EXHAUSTED AND BLEAR-EYED THOUGH HE  
WAS, HE MUST MAKE ONE LAST EFFORT, SENDING ONE LAST PIECE OF ADVICE.

THE THING THAT WAS HIDDEN IN THE SNITCH, HE BEGAN, I DROPPED  
IT IN THE FOREST, I DON'T KNOW EXACTLY WHERE, BUT I'M NOT GOING TO  
SEE

LOOKING FOR IT AGAIN, DO YOU AGREE?

MY DEAR BOY, I DO, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WHILE HIS FELLOW PICTURES  
LOOKED CHINLED AND CLIMBLIS, A WISE AND COURAGEOUS DECISION, BUT  
NOT LESS THAN I WOULD HAVE EXPECTED OF YOU, DOES ANYONE ELSE KNOW  
WHERE IT FELL?

NO ONE, SAID HARRY, AND DUMBLEDORE NEEDED HIS SATISFACTION.

I'M GOING TO KEEP IT GENTLY & PRESENT, THOUGH, SAID HARRY, AND  
DUMBLEDORE BEAMED.

BUT HE CHURSE, HARRY, IT IS YOURS FOREVER, UNTIL YOU PASS IT ON;

AND THEN THERE'S THIS.

HARRY HELD UP THE ELDER WAND, AND RON AND HERMION LOOKED  
AT IT WITH A REVERENCE THAT, EVEN IN HIS REVERED AND SLEEP-DEPRIVED

STATE, F-JARRY DID NOT LIKE THE SEE.

I DIDN'T WANT IT, SAID F-JARRY.

WHAT? SAID REHN HELDLY. ARE YOU MENTAL?

I KNOW IT'S PHEWELK, SAID F-JARRY WEARILY. BUT I WAS HAPPIER WITH MINE, SEE . . .

HE SLIPPED IN THE PHELIH HING AROUND HIS NECK, AND PULLED OUT THE TWO HALVES OF PHELIH STILL JUST CONNECTED BY THE FINEST THREAD

OF PHEWELK FEATHER. F-JERMINE HAD SAID THAT THEY COULD NOT BE REPAIRED, THAT THE DAMAGE WAS TOO SEVERE. ALL HE KNOW WAS THAT IF THIS

DID NOT WORK, NOTHING WOULD.

HE LAID THE KNEEDEN WAND UPON THE HEADMASTER'S DESK, TOUCHED IT WITH THE VERY TIP OF THE ELDER WAND, AND SAID, REPAIR.

THE PLAN IN THE PLAN

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AS HIS WAND RESEALD, RED SPARKS FLEW OUT OF ITS END. F-JARRY KNEW THAT HE HAD SUCCEEDED. HE PICKED UP THE PHELIH AND PHEWELK WAND AND FELT A SUDDEN WARMTH IN HIS FINGERS, AS THE ELDER WAND AND HAND WERE REJOINING AT THEIR REJOINING.

I'M PLOTTING THE ELDER WAND. HE THOUGHT DUMKEDDRE, WHO WAS WATCHING HIM WITH ENTHUSIASM AND ADMIRATION, BACK THERE

IT CAME FROM. IT CAN STAY THERE. IF I DIE A NATURAL DEATH LIKE  
GENTLY,

ITS POWER WILL BE BROKEN, WHEN T IT? THE PREVIOUS MASTER WILL  
NEVER

HAVE BEEN DEFEATED, THAT LL BE THE END OF IT.

BLINKED HERE NEEDED, THEY SMILED AT EACH OTHER.

ARE YOU SURE? SAID BEN, THERE WAS THE FAINTEST TRACE OF  
HANGING

IN HIS VOICE AS HE LOOKED AT THE ELDER LORD.

I THINK HARRY S RIGHT, SAID HERMIONE QUIETLY.

THAT LORD S MORE TERRIBLE THAN IT S WORTH, SAID HARRY, AND

ELITE HESITANTLY, HE TURNED AWAY FROM THE PAINTED PORTRAITS,  
THINK-

ING NEW ONLY OF THE FLOOR-POSTER RED LYING WAITING FOR HIM IN  
GRAY-

FINDER TOWER, AND WONDERING WHETHER KREACHER MIGHT BRING HIM A

SANDWICH THERE, I VE HAD ENOUGH TROUBLE FOR A LIFETIME.

NINETEEN YEARS LATER

EPILOGUE

THE

NINETEEN YEARS LATER

LITTLE SEEMED TO ARRIVE SUDDENLY THAT YEAR. THE MORNING  
OF THE FIRST OF SEPTEMBER WAS CRISP AND COLDEN AS AN APPLE,  
AND AS THE LITTLE FAMILY BEGGED ACROSS THE RUMBLING ROAD TOWARD  
THE GREAT STREET STATION, THE FLAMES OF CAR EXHAUSTS AND THE BREATH  
OF

PEDESTRIANS SPARKLED LIKE CHEEKS IN THE COLD AIR. THE LARGE CAGES  
RATTLED AND THE OF THE LOADED TRAMWAYS THE PARENTS WERE PUSHING;  
THE

HEELS INSIDE THEM BEHEATED INDIGNANTLY, AND THE RED-HEADED GIRL TRAILED  
TEARFULLY BEHIND HER BROTHERS, CLUTCHING HER FATHER'S ARM.

IT WON'T BE LONG, AND YOU'LL BE GOING TOO, FARRY TOLD HER.

TWO YEARS, SNIFFED LILY. I WANT TO GO NOW!

THE CONDUCTORS STARED CURIOUSLY AT THE HEELS AS THE FAMILY WHEELED  
ITS WAY TOWARD THE BARRIER BETWEEN PLATFORMS NINE AND TEN.  
A LITTLE

VEHICLE DRIFTED BACK TO FARRY OVER THE SURROUNDING CLAMOR; HIS  
SHOES

HAD RESUMED THE ARGUMENT THEY HAD STARTED IN THE CAR.

I WON'T! I WON'T BE IN SLOTHFULNESS!

JAMES, GIVE IT A REST! SAID GINNY.

☆

EPilogue

Q59

I ONLY SAID HE MIGHT BE, SAID JAMES, GRINNING AT HIS YOUNGER  
BROTHER. THERE'S NOTHING WRONG WITH THAT. HE MIGHT BE IN

SLOTH

BUT JAMES CAUGHT HIS MOTHER'S EYE AND FELL SILENT. THE FIVE PETERS  
APPROACHED THE BARRIER, WITH A SLIGHTLY CHECKY LEER OVER HIS  
SHOULDER

AT HIS YOUNGER BROTHER, JAMES THREW THE TRILLY FROM HIS MOTHER  
AND

BROKE INTO A RUN. A MOMENT LATER, HE HAD VANISHED.

WELL I WRITE THE ME, WHEN T YOU? ALKIS ASKED HIS PARENTS IMEDI-  
ATELY, CAPITALIZING ON THE MOMENTARY ABSENCE OF HIS BROTHER.

EVERY DAY, IF YOU WANT LIS THE, SAID CINDY.

NOT EVERY DAY, SAID ALKIS ELLIGELY. JAMES SAYS MOST PEOPLE ONLY  
GET LETTERS FROM HOME ABOUT ONCE A MONTH.

WE WRITE THE JAMES THREE TIMES A WEEK LAST YEAR, SAID CINDY.

AND YOU DON'T WANT THE BELIEVE EVERYTHING HE TELLS YOU ABOUT  
BEGGARS, BARRY PUT IN. HE LIKES A LAUGH, YOUR BROTHER.

SIDE BY SIDE, THEY PUSHED THE SECOND TRILLY FORWARD, GATHERING  
SPEED. AS THEY REACHED THE BARRIER, ALKIS WINKED, BUT NOT COLLIDING

CAME. INSTEAD, THE FAMILY EMERGED BENTH PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-  
QUARTERS, WHICH WAS ENCLOSED BY THICK WHITE STEAM THAT WAS  
PELLING

FROM THE SCARLET BEGGARS EXPRESS. INDISTINCT FIGURES WERE  
SWARMING

THROUGH THE MIST, INTO WHICH JAMES HAD ALREADY DISAPPEARED.

WHERE ARE THEY? ASKED ALKIS ANXIOUSLY, PEEKING AT THE FAZY

THEMS THEY PASSED AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY DOWN THE PLATFORM.

WE'LL FIND THEM, SAID GINNY REASSURINGLY.

BUT THE VAPOR WAS DENSE, AND IT WAS DIFFICULT TO MAKE OUT ANY-  
BODY'S FACES, DETACHED FROM THEIR OWNERS, VEHICLES SEEMED LINGUISTI-  
CALLY HELD, HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD PERCY DISCUSSING HELDLY HIS

EMPHATIC RELATIONS, AND WAS WHITE GLAD IF THE EXLISE MET THE  
STEP

AND SAY HELLO. . . .

NINETEEN YEARS LATER

YES

I THINK THAT'S THEM, AL, SAID GINNY SLIDENLY.

A GROUP OF FOUR PEOPLE EMERGED FROM THE MIST, STANDING ALONGSIDE  
THE VERY LAST CARRIAGE. THEIR FACES ONLY CAME INTO VIEW WHEN  
HARRY,

GINNY, LILY, AND ALBUS HAD DRIVEN RIGHT UP TO THEM.

HI, SAID ALBUS, SEEMING IMMENSELY RELIEVED.

THESE, WHO WAS ALREADY WEARING HER BRAND-NEW HOGWARTS ROBES,  
BEAMED AT HIM.

PARKED ALL RIGHT, THEN? THEN ASKED HARRY, I DID, HERMIONE  
DIDN'T BELIEVE I COULD PASS A MUGGLE DRIVING TEST, DID SHE? SHE  
THOUGHT I'D HAVE THE CHAMPION THE EXAMINER.

NO, I DIDN'T, SAID HERMIONE, I HAD COMPLETE FAITH IN YOU.

AS A MATTER OF FACT, I DID CONVINCE HIM. RON WHISPERED TO  
HARRY, AS TOGETHER THEY LIFTED ALBUS'S TRUNK AND HEAVENTH THE  
TRAIN.

I ONLY FORGET THE LENS IN THE WING MIRROR, AND LET'S FACE IT, I CAN  
LIVE

A SUPERSENSITIVE CLAMOR FOR THAT.

BACK ON THE PLATFORM, THEY FOUND LILY AND HUGH, ROSE'S YOUNGER  
BROTHER, HAVING AN ANIMATED DISCUSSION ABOUT WHICH FEELER THEY  
WOULD BE SORTED INTO WHEN THEY FINALLY WENT TO HOGWARTS.

IF YOU'RE NOT IN GRYFFINDOR, WE'LL DISINTEGRATE YOU, SAID RON, BUT  
NOT PRESSURE.

RON:

LILY AND HUGH LAUGHED, BUT ALBUS AND ROSE LOOKED SERIOUS.

HE DOESN'T MEAN IT, SAID HERMION AND GINNY, BUT RON WAS NO  
LONGER PAYING ATTENTION. CATCHING HARRY'S EYE, HE NODDED CHEERFULLY  
TO

A POINT SOME FIFTY YARDS AWAY. THE STEAM HAD THINNED FOR A  
MOMENT,

AND THREE PEOPLE STOOD IN SHARP RELIEF AGAINST THE SHIFTING MIST.

LOOK WHO IT IS.

DRACO MALFOY WAS STANDING THERE WITH HIS WIFE AND SON, A DARK  
CHAT BRIGHTENED UP THE HIS TROUSERS. HIS HAIR WAS RECEDING SIGNIFICANTLY,

ESPECIALLY

THE

WHICH EMPHASIZED THE POINTED CHIN. THE NEW BOY RESEMBLED DRACO

AS MUCH AS ALEXIS RESEMBLED HARRY, DRACHE CALIGHT SIGHT OF HARRY, RENN, HERMIONE, AND GINNY STARING AT HIM, NEEDED CLUTLY, AND TURNED AWAY AGAIN.

SEE THAT S LITTLE SCORPILUS, SAID RENN UNDER HIS BREATH. MAKE SURE

YELL BEAT HIM IN EVERY TEST, RUSIE. THANK GOD YELL INHERITED YOUR MOTHER S BRAINS.

RENN, FOR HEAVEN S SAKE, SAID HERMIONE, HALF STERN, HALF AMUSED. DONT TRY TO TURN THEM AGAINST EACH OTHER BEFORE THEY VE EVEN STARTED SCHEMING!

YELL RE RIGHT, SHIRRY, SAID RENN, BUT UNABLE TO HELP HIMSELF, HE ADDED, DONT GET TOO FRIENDLY WITH HIM, TELLING RUSIE, GRANDDAD LEASLEY WOULD NEVER FORGIVE YELL IF YELL MARRIED A PURPLEHEED. Hey!

JAMES HAD REAPPEARED; HE HAD DIVESTED HIMSELF OF HIS TROUSERS, BELT, AND TIE, AND WAS EVIDENTLY KLUTTING WITH NEWS.

TEDDY S BACK THERE, HE SAID BREATHLESSLY, POINTING BACK OVER HIS SHOULDER INTO THE KILLING CHILDS OF STREAM. JUST SEEN HIM? AND GUESS WHAT HE S DOING? SNEGGING VICTIMS! HE GAZED UP AT THE ADULTS, EVIDENTLY DISAPPOINTED BY THE LACK OF REACTION.

HELLO TEDDY! TEDDY LUPIN! SNEGGING HELLO VICTIMS! HELLO CHILDS! AND I ASKED TEDDY WHAT HE WAS DOING

YELL INTERRUPTED THEM SAID GINNY. YELL ARE SEE LIKE RENN

AND HE SAID HE D CARE TO SEE HER HET? AND THEN HE TOLD ME TO GO AWAY, HE S SNEGGING HER! JAMES ADDED AS THOUGH WHORING HE HAD



NETT MADE HIMSELF CLEAR.

HEH, IT WOULD BE BEVELY IF THEY GET MARRIED! WHISPERED LILY EC-  
STATICALLY. TEDDY WOULD REALLY BE PART OF THE FAMILY THEN!

NINETEEN YEARS LATER

???

HE ALREADY CHOMES REELING AFTER DINNER ABOUT THEIR TIMES A WEEK,  
SAID HARRY. WHY DONT WE JUST INVITE HIM TO LIVE WITH US AND  
HAVE

DINE WITH IT?

YES! SAID JAMES ENTHUSIASTICALLY. I DONT MIND SHARING WITH  
AL TEDDY COULD HAVE MY ROOM!

NOH, SAID HARRY FIRMLY, YELL AND AL WILL SHARE A ROOM ONLY  
WHEN

I WANT THE HOUSE DEMOLISHED.

HE CHECKED THE BATTERED OLD WATCH THAT HAD ONCE BEEN FARIAN  
PREWITT S.

IT S NEARLY ELEVEN, YELL D BETTER GET HIM READY.

DONT FORGET TO GIVE NEVILLE YOUR LOVE! GINNY THOUGHT JAMES AS SHE  
HUGGED HIM.

MUM? I CAN T GIVE A PROFESSOR LOVE!

BUT YELL KNOW NEVILLE

JAMES REELLED HIS EYES.

HELLO, YES, BUT AT SCHOOL HE S PROFESSOR LONGWORTHEN, ISN T  
HE?

I CAN'T WALK INTO HERKLELEY AND GIVE HIM LEVE, . . .

SHAKING HIS HEAD AT HIS MOTHER'S FEEBLENESS, HE VENTED HIS FEELINGS BY AIMING A KICK AT ARLIS.

SEE YELL LATER, AL, WATCH ELLIT FOR THE THESTRALS.

I THOUGHT THEY WERE INVISIBLE? YELL SAID THEY WERE INVISIBLE?  
BUT JAMES MERELY LAUGHED, PERMITTED HIS MOTHER TO KISS HIM,  
GAVE HIS FATHER A FLEETING GLANCE, THEN LEAPT BENTHE THE RAPIDLY FILLING  
TRAIN. THEY SAW HIM GO, THEN SPRINT AWAY UP THE CORRIDOR TO  
FIND  
HIS FRIENDS.

THESTRALS ARE NOTHING TO WORRY ABOUT, HARRY TOLD ARLIS.

THEY'RE GENTLE THINGS, THERE'S NOTHING SCARY ABOUT THEM,  
ANDYDAD,

YELL WON'T BE GOING UP THE STAIRS IN THE CARRIAGES, YELL WILL BE GOING  
IN

THE KITCHEN.

PROBABLY

THE

GIRL KISSED ARLIS GOOD-BYE.

SEE YELL AT CHRISTMAS.

BYE, AL, SAID HARRY AS HIS SON FLEGGED HIM. DON'T FORGET  
HARRY'S INVITED YELL TO TEA NEXT FRIDAY. DON'T MESS WITH PEEVES.  
DON'T DRINK ANYWHERE TILL YELL'S LEARNED WELL. AND DON'T LET JAMES  
WIND

WELL LIP,

WHAT IF I'M IN SLYTHERIN?

THE WHISPER WAS FOR HIS FATHER ALONE, AND HARRY KNEW THAT ONLY THE MOMENT OF DEPARTURE COULD HAVE FORCED ALBUS TO REVEAL HOW GREAT AND SINCERE THAT FEAR WAS.

HARRY CRICKLED DOWN SEE THAT ALBUS'S FACE WAS SLIGHTLY ABOVE HIS EYES. ALONE OF HARRY'S THREE CHILDREN, ALBUS HAD INHERITED LILY'S EYES.

ALBUS SEVERUS, HARRY SAID QUIETLY, SEE THAT NEITHER BUT CINDY COULD HEAR, AND SHE WAS TACTFUL ENOUGH TO PRETEND TO BE LAYING THE

HOUSE, WHICH WAS WHEN IN THE TRAIN, THEY WERE NAMED FOR THE HEADMAS-

TERS OF HOGWARTS. ONE OF THEM WAS A SLYTHERIN AND HE WAS PROBABLY

THE CRAVEST MAN I EVER KNEW.

BUT I JUST SAY

THEN SLYTHERIN HOUSE WILL HAVE GAINED AN EXCELLENT STUDENT, WHEN DOES IT? IT DOESN'T MATTER THE LESS, AL, BUT IF IT MATTERS TO YOU, YOU'LL

BE ABLE TO CHOOSE GRYFFINDOR OVER SLYTHERIN. THE SORTING HAT TAKES

YOUR CHOICE INTO ACCOUNT.

REALLY?

IT DID FOR ME, SAID HARRY.

HE HAD NEVER TOLD ANY OF HIS CHILDREN THAT BEFORE, AND HE SAW THE GLEAM IN ALBUS'S FACE WHEN HE SAID IT. BUT WHEN THE DOORS WERE

SLAMMING ALL ALONG THE SCARLET TRAIN, AND THE BLURRED HORIZONS OF  
PAR-

ENTS WERE SWARMING FORWARD FOR FINAL KISSES, LAST-MINUTE  
REMINDERS.

NINETEEN YEARS LATER

???

ALBUS LIMPED INTO THE CARRIAGE AND GINNY CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND  
HIM. STUDENTS WERE HANGING FROM THE WINDOWS NEAREST THEM. A  
GREAT

NUMBER OF FACES, BOTH IN THE TRAIN AND OFF, SEEMED TO BE TURNED  
TOWARD HARRY.

WHY ARE THEY ALL STARING? DEMANDED ALBUS AS HE AND PENE  
CRANED AROUND THE CORNER AT THE OTHER STUDENTS.

DON'T LET IT WORRY YOU, SAID PENE. IT'S ME. I'M EXTREMELY  
FAMOUS.

ALBUS, PENE, FLICK, AND LILY LAUGHED. THE TRAIN BEGAN TO MOVE,

AND HARRY WALKED ALONGSIDE IT, WATCHING HIS SHINING THIN FACE, AL-  
READY ABLAZE WITH EXCITEMENT. HARRY KEPT SMILING AND WAVING, EVEN

THOUGH IT WAS LIKE A LITTLE RECREATION, WATCHING HIS SHINING GLIDE  
AWAY

FROM HIM. . . .

THE LAST TRACE OF STEAM EVAPORATED IN THE ALPINE AIR. THE TRAIN

REMOVED A CORNER, HARRY'S HAND WAS STILL RAISED IN FAREWELL.

HE'LL BE ALL RIGHT, MURMURED GINNY.

AS HARRY LOOKED AT HER, HE HELDER HIS HAND ASSENTMENTEDLY AND  
THOUGHT THE LIGHTNING SCAR HAD HIS FURROWHEAD.

I KNOW HE WILL.

THE SCAR HAD NOT PAINED HARRY FOR NINETEEN YEARS. ALL WAS WELL.

THIS

BOOK WAS

ART DIRECTED BY DAVID

SAYLER. THE ART FOR BOTH THE JACKET

AND THE INTERIOR WAS CREATED USING PASTELS ON

THICK PRINTMAKING PAPER. THE TEXT WAS SET IN 12-POINT

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